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ILLUMINATING MODERNITY



JOHN DUNS SCOTUS

Introduction to his fundamental Positions

ÉTIENNE GILSON

TRANSLATED BY JAMES COLBERT

SERIES EDITORS: FRANCESCA ARAN MURPHY, BALÁZS M. MEZEI AND KENNETH OAKES

BLOOMSBURY

John Duns Scotus

Illuminating Modernity

Illuminating Modernity is dedicated to the renewal of faith in a world that is both Godless and idolatrous. This renewal takes the legacy of faith seriously and explores the tradition in the hope that the means of its contemporary development are to be found within it. This approach takes the historical crisis of faith seriously and makes sincere efforts to receive the strength necessary for a renewal. We call our way the Franciscan option. And yet, one of the greatest resources upon which we hope to build is Thomism, especially those hidden treasures of modern Thomistic thought to be found in Continental and phenomenological philosophy and theology.

The Franciscan option takes the history of faith seriously both in its continuity and in its change. It takes seriously the tragic experiences of the history of faith since the Wars of Religion and especially in late modernity. But it also takes seriously the rich heritage of faith. As Michael Polanyi argued, faith has become the fundamental act of human persons. Faith involves the whole of the person in his or her absolute openness to the Absolute. As Hegel saw, the logic of history is prefigured in the story of the Gospels, and the great and transforming experience of humanity has remained the experience of resurrection in the aftermath of a dramatic death.

The series editors are boundlessly grateful to Anna Turton, whose support for this series made a hope into a reality. We also owe a huge debt of gratitude to Notre Dame's Nanovic Institute for European Studies for giving us financial and moral support at the outset of our project. Many thanks to Anthony Monta and James McAdams for caring about the 'Hidden Treasures'.

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Foreword: Étienne Gilson and Jean Duns Scot

Robert Trent Pomplun

Étienne Gilson needs no introduction. Arguably the most influential medievalist in the twentieth century, he might well have also been—especially at the height of his powers—one of its most influential philosophers. Henri Bergson's star had faded by the 1950s. Heidegger had eclipsed Husserl—who was too technical for the general reader anyway—but Heidegger's own influence would not extend beyond the continent until the 1960s. Jacques Derrida and Michel Foucault, of course, were *arrivistes.* Beyond Jean-Paul Sartre and Gilson's own friend Jacques Maritain, one is hard pressed to find a serious competitor for the title. Gilson owed his dominance from the 1920s through the 1960s to a steady stream of elegantly written masterpieces, ranging from definitive treatments of Augustine, Thomas Aquinas, and Bonaventure to monumental surveys of medieval, modern, and contemporary philosophy. Gilson's works were revised and enlarged, reprinted vigorously, and translated swiftly. By the end of his career Gilson's volumes were, like those of Flannery O'Connor, Thomas Merton, or Teilhard de Chardin, on the bookshelves of any educated Catholic—and more than a few educated non-Catholics. Mortimer Adler, Lionel Trilling, and Alfred North Whitehead considered themselves lucky to be his correspondents.

Yet, few are familiar with Gilson's monumental work on John Duns Scotus

(c. 1266–1308). Published in 1952, when Gilson was sixty-seven years old, *Jean Duns Scot: introduction à ses positions fondamentales* was in many respects his crowning achievement.[1] Since the second revised and enlarged edition of *Le thomisme: introduction au système de. S. Thomas d'Aquin* (1922), Gilson had written—and Joseph Vrin had published—the fruits of his seminars on several great medieval thinkers during the 1920s and early 1930s. For many, *La philosophie de Saint Bonaventure* (1924), *Introduction à l'étude de Saint Augustin* (1929), *La théologie mystique de Saint Bernard* (1934), *Héloïse et Abélard* (1938), and *Dante et la philosophie* (1939) form the backbone of any study of medieval philosophy.[2] With *L'esprit de la philosophie médiévale* (1932), however, Gilson expanded his expertise to encompass more general philosophical issues. In the French works of the 1930s and 1940s—*Christianisme et philosophie* (1936), *Réalisme thomiste et critique de la conaissance* (1939), *L'être et l'essence* (1948)—and in the English—*The Unity of Philosophical Experience* (1937), *God and Philosophy* (1941), and *Being and Some Philosophers* (1949)—Gilson developed the interpretation of Thomas Aquinas's metaphysics for which he is best known today. He came to see the history of philosophy—indeed the history of *being*—as a contest between the dynamic, person-oriented existentialism of Thomas Aquinas and the static, concept-driven essentialism of Augustine, Scotus, Descartes, and Kant. In *Jean Duns Scot,* these two currents in Gilson's career join in a single river, reflective of the whole. It was Gilson's last, largest, fully original monograph devoted to a major medieval philosopher. It was the crucible in which he put his so-called philosophical history of philosophy to the test. *Jean Duns Scot* is also—among the dozen or more classic studies authored by Gilson—the only one not translated into English.

* * *

Étienne Gilson (1884–1978) did not begin his career as a medievalist.[3] He learned Latin and catechism in primary school with the Christian Brothers at Ste-Clotilde's, and attended the best Catholic secondary school in Paris,

Notre-Dame-des-Champs, but he transferred to the Lycée Henri IV to complete his secondary education and eventually became a student at the Sorbonne. In this respect, Gilson's earliest inspirations were far removed from the scholastic revival that followed *Aeterni Patris.* At the University of Paris, the lectures from which Gilson drew sustenance were given by Émile Durkheim (1858–1917), Lucien Lévy-Bruhl (1857–1939), and Henri Bergson (1859–1941). Already, though, we see the seeds of dialectic that defined Gilson's life as a scholar: Lévy-Bruhl, who directed Gilson's dissertation, forbade him from pursuing philosophy, but agreed to let Gilson study the *history* of philosophy, which Lévy-Bruhl judged a sufficiently scientific subject for "positive" study. So Gilson's primary thesis, *La doctrine cartésienne et la liberté et la théologie* (1913), outlined the scholastic influence on René Descartes, and his secondary thesis, *Index scolastico-cartésien* (1913), provided a healthy sampling of the scholastic texts that influenced Descartes arranged in an index of relevant technical terms. Duns Scotus makes an appearance in *La doctrine cartésienne et la liberté et la théologie,* but Gilson's treatment of the Subtle Doctor, while significant, is derived largely from secondary works.[4] None of Scotus's texts appear in the *Index scolastico-cartésien,* which instead comprises passages from Francisco Suárez, Francisco Toledo, Antonio Rubio, Eustache de Saint-Paul, the Conimbricenses, and (of course) Thomas Aquinas. Gilson's first article also mentions the Subtle Doctor, but only once, as an Augustinian whose theses had impregnated later Thomists, but here, too, he cites a single secondary source for this information.[5] It would be a quarter century before Gilson would develop his particular understanding of Thomas's metaphysics, but one thing in his interpretation of Duns Scotus will remain constant over his career: the Subtle Doctor was an heir to the Augustinian tradition that included Bonaventure, Descartes, and Kant. Sometimes the Subtle Doctor will draw closer to Thomas Aquinas, and other times he will fall farther away, but in this Scotus, for Gilson, will be no different from any other thinker: he will be measured against Thomas, and Thomas alone.

Gilson only began to see himself as a specialist in medieval philosophy at

the University of Strasbourg, where he taught from 1919 to 1921, but he was well aware of the Thomistic revival. Gilson had exchanged letters with Antoine-Gilbert Sertillanges (1863–1948); he knew the pioneering work of Désiré-Joseph Cardinal Mercier (1851–1926), Pierre Mandonnet (1858–1936), and Martin Grabmann (1875–1949); and Maurice de Wulf (1867–1947) had even attended Gilson's dissertation defense. Gilson published *Le thomisme: introduction au système de. S. Thomas d'Aquin* (1919) during his first year at Strasbourg, and his lectures quickly became his first two medieval works, *Études de philosophie médiévale* (1921) and *La philosophie au moyen âge* (1922), but his chief interlocutors were still Lucien Febvre (1878–1956), Marc Bloch (1886–1944), and Sylvain Lévi (1863–1935).[6] This fact cannot be stressed enough: Gilson's formation as an historian lay well outside the normal Catholic circles, and he was not immediately accepted into them. He presented no papers, for example, at the major conferences devoted to the six-hundredth anniversary of Thomas's canonization or Pius XI's *Studiorum ducem,* which declared Thomas Aquinas the Common and Universal Doctor of the Church. For the celebrations at Le Saulchoir, Cardinal Mercier was the chief ecclesiastical presence and Ambroise Gardeil (1859–1931) delivered the keynote; in Rome, the honors went to Martin Grabmann and Louis Cardinal Billot (1846–1931). Gilson was not even the most important lay interpreter of Thomas Aquinas at this point: Jacques Maritain (1882–1973) spoke at the Academy of St. Thomas Aquinas that year and, with Mandonnet, founded the Société Thomiste de Saint Thomas d'Aquin without Gilson. In fact, Gilson still considered himself chiefly a historian at this point in his career and was more involved with the more university-oriented Société Française de Philosophie.

Gilson began to study Duns Scotus in earnest after accepting a position at the University of Paris, teaching at the Sorbonne in 1921 and at the École pratique des hautes-études when it reopened in 1922. He also began to attract attention. Seminars in the Section des sciences religieuses averaged between four and twenty students during these years: in 1923, Gilson had thirty-one; in 1924, fifty-one; in 1925, sixty-four; and, by 1929, ninety-five.[7] Many of

the books for which Gilson is now famous followed in swift succession: the Parisian publisher Joseph Vrin (1884–1957) allowed Gilson to revise and enlarge *Le thomisme*, whose first edition had been somewhat hastily assembled, for a second edition in 1922. Gilson's 1922 seminar on the Franciscan spirit in medieval philosophy became *La philosophie de Saint Bonaventure* (1924), and his paired seminars from 1922 and 1923 on Augustinian illumination became "Pourquoi saint Thomas a critiqué saint Augustine" and later *Introduction à l'étude de Saint Augustine* (1929).[8] Even the seminars that did not become books often became lengthy articles: Gilson published the fruits of his paired seminars on Avicenna and Duns Scotus as the celebrated article "Avicenne et le point de départ de Duns Scot."[9] Gilson developed a distaste for the slanders that neo-Thomists directed against Duns Scotus in these seminars, and—as we shall see—Gilson would spend his life, both public and private, defending Duns Scotus against them.[10] But Gilson also struggled to understand Scotus. In fact, the Subtle Doctor was the only thinker to whom Gilson devoted three seminars while teaching at the University of Paris, and the only seminar Gilson repeated during his time there was on Scotus's philosophy.[11] That said, in the books of the 1920s, Gilson consistently treats Scotus as an heir to the Augustinian tradition, only to except him (along with Thomas Aquinas) as critics of previous Augustinian notions of illumination and *rationes seminales*.[12] Even so, while Gilson's seminars on Augustine, Bonaventure, Bernard of Clairvaux, and René Descartes became monographs, no book on Scotus was forthcoming.

If Gilson made his reputation as a professor at the University of Paris during the 1920s, he laid the foundation of his legacy in the 1930s. Gilson was elected to the Collège de France in 1932 and, after almost a decade in the works, Gilson's Institute of Mediaeval Studies in Toronto offered its first full program in 1935. Gilson reprised many of his previous seminars at both the Collège and the Institute, while adding several seminars devoted to themes rather than thinkers—on medieval morality, epistemology, realism, and humanism, for example.[13] The first fruits of this more general medievalism were the Gifford Lectures in 1931–32, which were published as *L'esprit de la*

philosophie médiévale almost immediately after Gilson gave them. Neither Gilson nor his public had forgotten *La philosophie au moyen âge*—Payot had reprinted it in 1925 and 1930—but one cannot but feel new life in Gilson's elegant and erudite lectures. In them, one finds perhaps his most sensitive treatment of John Duns Scotus, whom Gilson honored, with Thomas Aquinas and Bonaventure alike, as an embodiment of the spirit of medieval philosophy, even as he carefully explained the differences in each man's metaphysics. Gilson, in fact, had prepared his portions on Scotus with great care: he devoted one seminar at Toronto in 1931 to Scotus's philosophy and one of his final seminars at the École pratique des hautes-études in 1932 to Scotus's natural theology. It is sometimes forgotten, too, that in the Gifford Lectures Gilson turned not to Thomas Aquinas to illustrate what he often called "the metaphysics of Exodus," but to the opening lines of Scotus's *De Primo Principio*:

> O Lord our God, when Moses asked of you as a most true doctor, what name he should give you before the children of Israel. knowing what mortal understanding could conceive of you and revealing to him your blessed name, you replied: *Ego sum qui sum.* you are true Being, total Being. This I believe, but if it be possible, I want to understand. Help me, O Lord, to seek such knowledge of the true Being that you are as my natural reason might attain, starting with the being that you have attributed to yourself.[14]

"Nothing," Gilson says, "can surpass the fullness of such a text, because it gives us both the method of Christian philosophy and the first truth from which all others derive."[15] Extremely lucid explanations of Scotus's metaphysics of infinite being, univocity, the divine ideas, the natural object of the intellect, the efficacy of secondary causes, and so forth, follow without the slightest judgment and, indeed, as consistent illustrations of the great difference between medieval and modern philosophy with—it must be added—Gilson always placing Scotus on the side of Thomas Aquinas and Bonaventure. Gilson criticized Ockham for his theologism—the only appearance of the Venerable Inceptor in the entire body of the text—but, at

this point in his career, he reserved his strongest rhetoric for the schools: "The spirit of mediaeval philosophy," he wrote, "was one with the spirit of Christian philosophy. It was fruitful and creative insofar as it was incorporated voluntarily into a Wisdom that lived itself by faith and charity. . . . It died primarily of its own dissensions, and these dissensions multiplied as soon as it took itself for an end in itself, rather than directing itself toward that Wisdom which was at the same time its end and principle. Albertists, Thomists, Scotists, and Occamists contributed to the ruin of medieval philosophy in the exact measure in which they neglected the search for truth and exhausted themselves in sterile controversies over the meaning of the formulae that express it."[16]

Even so, Gilson was not always confident in his interpretations of Scotus, and he actively sought the help of Franciscan scholars during these years. When he couldn't lure the Canadian Scotist Ephrem Longpré (1890–1965) to the Institute of Mediaeval Studies, he brought in the German Ockhamist Philotheus Boehner (1901–1955).[17] Lawrence Shook does not hesitate to attribute much of Gilson's knowledge of Scotus's metaphysics and theology to Boehner, Gilson's "best German friend," even remarking that Gilson's inquiries into Scotus "were neither as deep nor of quite the same nature" as Boehner himself had indicated in his translations of Gilson's work or his own articles.[18] Boehner's stay at the Institute was brief; after only a year, he departed for Saint Bonaventure University, depriving the Institute of his vast personal library. To be fair, Gilson was honest enough about the difficulties he had interpreting Scotus. In March 1935, in the midst of teaching a seminar on Scotus's metaphysics at the Collège de France, Gilson wrote Gerard Phelan (1892–1965), "My Toronto course, which will begin with Duns Scotus, will probably not get much beyond him because I am in the process of discovering him—at long last! I have such unexpected and, I think, important results that they ought to be presented at the Institute."[19] Gilson devoted both his lecture and seminar courses at Toronto to Duns Scotus that Fall. His "important results," which concerned the alleged authenticity of Scotus's first sixteen *Theoremata*, were not accepted by most Franciscans.[20]

By the late 1930s, however, Gilson had developed a passion for existentialism which was to shape his overall conception of the history of philosophy. In the lectures delivered at Harvard in the Fall of 1936, Gilson explained the breakdown of medieval philosophy as a series of failed attempts to find the proper balance between theologism and skepticism. Although Gilson measured the rise of modern skepticism in direct proportion to the degree in which a thinker fell away from Thomas Aquinas, John Duns Scotus seems to have been lost in the shuffle. Gilson casts the Subtle Doctor as a supporter of Thomas against the previous tradition of Franciscan illuminationism (represented by Bonaventure, Roger Marston, and Matthew of Aquasparta), but it isn't clear whether he thinks that Scotus supports Aquinas against Islamic theologism (represented by al-Ghazālī) or set the stage for William of Ockham.[21] We might gather from this that Gilson was not entirely confident in his ascription of the first sixteen *Theoremata* to Scotus, or—at the very least—was unsure how to incorporate them into his larger account of theologism.[22] Rather than blame Scotus in this early genealogy, he maintained the interpretation of the Subtle Doctor's relationship to the Islamic tradition that he had advanced a decade earlier in opposition to neo-Thomist caricatures. One thing is absolutely clear in *The Unity of Philosophical Experience,* however; at Harvard, as at Aberdeen, Ockham was the culprit.

Gilson was involved in more strictly methodological debates with other Thomists during these years as well. He'd entered the fray in 1930 by criticizing Cardinal Mercier and Léon Noël (1878–1952) with an article, "Le réalisme méthodique," which he followed with "Réalisme et méthode" and "La méthode réaliste."[23] These articles became *Le réalisme méthodique* (1936) and— for the *coup de grâce—Réalisme thomiste et critique de la connaissance* (1939). In 1941, Gilson published *God and Philosophy*,which he considered the "decisive stage" in his interpretation of Thomas Aquinas. In it, we see a slightly more polemical treatment of the so-called primacy of essence he found in Scotus, which Gilson considered a remnant of the Platonism anterior to Thomas Aquinas.[24] Writing to Marie-Dominique

Chenu, Gilson explained, "If one forgets *esse*, he condemns himself to a metaphysics of the pure concept (Scotus, Suárez, Descoqs). If one forgets *habens*, he is led, with Kierkegaard in his prestigious *Post Scriptum*, then with Jaspers, to condemn the whole of philosophy as such."[25] Gilson shows his hand by mentioning Pedro Descoqs (1877–1946), a Jesuit philosopher who had recently published a series of controversial articles about the distinction between essence and existence.[26] As it turns out, Gilson had devoted his 1941 seminar at the Collège de France to refuting Descoqs. Although titled "*Quaestiones disputatae* sur saint Thomas d'Aquin," it was really a point-by-point analysis of Descoqs's teaching on *esse, ens inquantum ens*, and the object of metaphysics. During the war, Gilson devoted himself to solidifying his new existentialist interpretation of *esse*, most notably in the fourth and fifth editions of *Le thomisme* (1942, 1944).[27] According to Lawrence Shook, Gilson's courses at both the Collège de France and the Institute of Mediaeval Studies during this time "dwelt heavily on Augustinianism and contemporary existentialism."[28] Upon election to the Académie Française, Gilson proclaimed, "University, idealist philosophy, represented by Brunschvicg and Alain is dead. . . . Thomism is bursting with life. It is the philosophy of the future. Thomism—which, by the way, is an existentialism: I myself have rediscovered the importance of existence in St. Thomas—starts from the notion of the human person."[29] As it turns out, Gilson's heavily existentialist understanding of the distinction between *esse* and *essentia* would give him the theme to organize his studies on John Duns Scotus and bring them to completion.

He did not do so easily; in fact, *Jean Duns Scot* was written during the most difficult period of Gilson's life. In 1947, his wife Thérèse was severely ill; his son Bernard had left for France; and his daughter Jacqueline was living in Spain as the nation held its referendum on the Law of Succession. Both Jacqueline and his other daughter Cécile also remained unmarried, a matter of no small importance for Gilson, who was now sixty-three. Alone in America, he worried that Europe might become the chief theater in a war between the United States and Russia. For all intents and purposes, Gilson staved off

depression with work, the majority of which was on Duns Scotus. Early that year, Carolus Balić (1899–1977), who had been chosen over Ephrem Longpré to head the team working on the new critical edition of Duns Scotus, sent Gilson sixteen pages of what was soon to be the critical edition's first volume, and Gilson devoted both of his Fall courses at the Institute of Mediaeval Studies to Duns Scotus. He did likewise in 1948, with both courses devoted to Scotus's understanding of infinite being. Later that year, Gilson completed *L'être et l'essence*, followed quickly by the quite similar (but not identical) *Being and Some Philosophers* in 1949. In these two works, we see a more polemical treatment of Scotus's understanding of essence and existence; although Gilson continues to distinguish Scotus from Avicenna on every point (except his definition of essence), he still struggles with the relationship of Scotus to his commentators.[30] Here, though, we see clearly Gilson's insistence upon two opposed—if not warring—metaphysics of being. That same year, Gilson lectured on applications of *esse* in St. Thomas Aquinas, but devoted his seminar to Scotus's seventh *Quodlibetal* question.[31] Emboldened by his habitual study of the Subtle Doctor, Gilson published much of the material that would become the first three chapters of *Jean Duns Scot* in advance of the book.[32]

Gilson became more critical of Scotus as he prepared his monograph. In a letter to Fernand van Steenberghen (1904–1993), he wrote,

> I do not believe that Avicenna himself has really made esse a "logical" accident. Averroes accused him of this, but that's not true. Even if it were true, it would be the logical [accident] of a real essence, which is the essence of Avicenna. This is certainly not true of St. Thomas. I expect one day or another the first copies of my book *L'être et l'essence*. . . . I'll send you one and you will see the direction I've sought to make my way. Avicenna seems to me the predecessor of Duns Scotus more than St. Thomas: Scotus qui genuit Suarezium, qui genuit Wolffium, qui genuit Kantium.[33]

If we see here Gilson's genealogy in its most lapidary form, we should not forget his next sentence: "Tout cela est bien compliqué." Indeed, it *was* all

very complicated. At the same time, Gilson could also write to his friend Anton Pegis (1905–1978): “How can a Franciscan be both an occamist and a scotist? The *de* [*sic*] *potentia absoluta* has nothing to do with it. The *visio intuitiva rei non existentis* is to Duns Scotus a contradiction in terms!”[34] Gilson, of course, would never have been so naïve as to think Scotus a nominalist and was justly frustrated by the charge, but we can see him in the 1940s pulling away from the more irenic tone of *L’esprit de la philosophie médiévale*. Still, the genealogy for which Gilson is most famous was determined as much—if not more—by his controversies with Thomists like Mercier, Noël, and Descoqs as it was by the study of Duns Scotus’s texts.

Tragedy struck amid this flurry of academic activity. Try as he might, Gilson could not convince Thérèse to accompany him to Toronto in 1949. With their son Bernard in France for good, Thérèse insisted upon staying in Europe, even though she was in poor health. Thérèse’s doctors were confident that her condition was not as serious as Gilson feared; in August, he wrote Pegis: “I would be reassured if only people who live together in intimacy didn’t sometimes know such things better than doctors do.”[35] Gilson returned to Toronto alone. In October, he received a telegram signed by his children informing him that Thérèse was dying. He left for Paris immediately and arrived in time to see his wife, only to learn that the treatment that could save her could be obtained solely in America. She died at 5:30am on November 12, 1949. Two weeks later, he wrote Pegis:

> I am writing to you from the new desert and wasteland wherein I now have to live, but don’t imagine that such affection as yours brings me no comfort. . . . Common tragedy is tragedy. And now, the best I can do is to say nothing more about it. Deep sorrow is a slow discovery and one feels ashamed to discover it at sixty-six, while it is as commonplace, but as important, as the sun and the moon or day and night.[36]

Gilson continued his work on Scotus in the midst of severe depression.[37] On January 8, 1950, he wrote Pegis: “I still have three chapters of my ‘Duns Scotus’ to write. The title, I believe, will be ‘Duns Scot et la philosophie’

though in fact it should be ‘Duns Scot et les philosophes.’ I think it will take a few years for its conclusions to sink into Franciscan minds. Scotism is indeed very different from Scotus.”[38] Gilson, it appears, was confident not merely that his new work on Duns Scotus would correct the neo-Thomists who had not read the Subtle Doctor, but Scotists whom he believed had made Scotus into something that he was not. If Gilson hoped the book to be a blockbuster, he still seems to have been nagged by doubts about its worth. He wrote Pegis six weeks later with a more modest assessment: “The Duns Scotus is done, a slow and meandering book, the least constructed and conducted of all those I have ever written. I think, however, that it expresses a most sincere effort to understand him as he was. What the result is worth I don’t know. At any rate it has helped me through the worst months (at least, I hope so) of my life.”[39]

* * *

Gilson had the opportunity to present his new interpretation of Scotus at the International Scholastic Congress in September. Organized by Carolus Balić and held at the Antonianum, the conference was meant to demonstrate the diverse ways that scholastic theology could be faithful to the Magisterium after *Aeterni Patris* and *Humani generis.* Gilson admired Balić, whom he described to Pegis as “straight, perfectly honest, sincerely friendly, and a great scholar,” but he had become irritated by the Franciscan’s repeated attempts to enlist him in the cause of Scotus’s beatification. Gilson was not opposed to Scotus’s beatification; he just couldn’t stand the constant bickering of Thomists and Scotists: “I am now reading the consultation of the Roman congregation on the possible canonization of Duns Scotus,” he wrote Pegis in the same February letter, “It is theological libel, just garbage. Personally I wholly disagree with Duns Scotus. His is a climate of thought in which I cannot live. But I cannot understand what there is against him from the point of view of faith. Not even of ethics. The trouble is that scotists are, in their controversies, no more honest than the thomists.”[40] Gilson attempted to beg off, but knew his debts to Balić required him to attend the conference.

It promised to be tense. Gilson informed Pegis that Summer that he planned his paper to be an "H-Bomb."[41] He also wrote Michel Labourdette (1908–1990) to announce the coming completion of *Jean Duns Scot*: "I have completed the bulk of a book on Duns Scotus. There is no one less Scotist than I am. His philosophy, especially his metaphysics, which is a metaphysics of quiddities, is exactly contrary to what I take to be true."[42] Still, Gilson complained about unjust attacks on Scotus:

> *Theologically*, I do not see how Scotism is an interpretation of the Christian faith any less satisfactory than Thomism. . . . Perhaps you'd have an idea if I asked why so many criticisms against Duns Scotus are directed and rigged precisely to impute to him errors against the faith such as pantheism, Spinozism, and so forth? . . . Were Scotism a theology false from the point of view of the faith, it would be condemned. But it is not.[43]

Even so, Gilson confided to Labourdette, "You and I both know that being is either analogous or univocal, and cannot be both at once. There is thus one of two theologies that is false in its philosophical structure, but it is still tolerated."[44] In the face of an academic public, Gilson maintained—at least to a degree—the consistent view that the plurality of medieval philosophies, while different in their metaphysical structures, were equally Christian. Privately, however, at least to Thomist friends, Gilson was more candid in his belief that there was one—and only one—true metaphysics of being. The two positions are not inconsistent, of course. Gilson never believed Scotus to be "modern" and defended Scotists' right to argue for univocity. By his own account, which we will see repeated in *Jean Duns Scot,* it was Scotus's essentialism, not his doctrine of univocity, that stood in opposition to Thomist metaphysics as he conceived it.

Gilson presented two papers at the conference, "Duns Scot à la lumière des recherches historico-critiques" and "Les recherches historico-critiques et l'avenir de la scolastique."[45] The first was in effect an introduction to and justification of *Jean Duns Scot.* While Gilson presented a very different face for Carolus Balić and the Franciscans, defending Scotus, for example, from

the charges of Avicennan necessitarianism, he announced—with no small exaggeration—that historical-critical methods would save Duns Scotus less from his Dominican critics than from his own Franciscan supporters. He took aim accordingly at the Scotist commentators, much as he had in *L'être et l'essence.* Gilson's second paper, which concluded the conference, was the H-Bomb he promised Pegis. Fernand van Steenberghen had opened the conference by recounting the history of the modern study of medieval philosophy as a competition between two schools, rationalist and Catholic, whose fortunes he traced for the century leading up to the conference. Canon van Steenberghen's paper concluded, however, with the claim that Gilson himself had reconciled the two schools. If, after thirty years, Gilson was now to be welcomed into the Catholic world of professional medievalists, van Steenberghen would not let his rival, nor the assembled ecclesiastics, forget Gilson's own "rationalist" training at the University of Paris. Not to be outdone, Gilson concluded the conference with his own provocation. Rehearsing the same history of medieval studies as van Steenberghen, Gilson attacked the modern dissociation of scholastic philosophy from theology, and called for the return of scholasticism, which had been covered by "five centuries of dust," to theology. The future of scholasticism, he claimed, "would not consist in adapting the medieval metaphysics of being and its causes to the ceaseless variations in science and philosophy; its future will rather consist in integrating to it the positive acquisitions made by science and philosophy in order to correct and purify them."[46]

Gilson's papers did not sit well with his critics; in fact, they irritated many of his friends. The Franciscans in attendance at the Antonianum did not need to be told about the historical-critical method, especially with the announcement of the first volume of the new critical edition, which appeared that year.[47] Nor did they need to be told of variations in the Scotist commentarial tradition. Truth be told, Gilson was never really comfortable in this literature. He read the commentators included in the Wadding edition and the Scotist manuals that had been reprinted in the early twentieth century, but he was largely ignorant of the great Scotist commentators of the seventeenth

century, such as Juan de Rada, Bonaventura Belluti, and Bartholomeo Mastri—to say nothing of theologians such as Carolus del Moral or Salvator Montalbanus—who were increasingly being read by Scotists at the time. Gilson also resisted corrections offered by younger Franciscan scholars. After reading Allan Wolter's *The Transcendentals and Their Function in the Metaphysics of Duns Scotus,* Gilson wrote to Maritain: "I started the day by talking of you in my lecture this morning on Duns Scotus, because we have both been accused by an American Franciscan of committing an 'inexcusable error' concerning the Subtle Doctor. But let's get serious."[48] By 1950, however, Gilson's Franciscan critics possessed both superior historical-critical skills and a far better knowledge of their own theological tradition than Gilson.

Nor were Gilson's Thomist friends particularly pleased. When Gilson claimed that Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus were not great theologians because they were great philosophers, but rather that they were great philosophers because they were great theologians, he ran afoul of both the philosophers who were not theologians and those, of course, who were. Gilson's own friend Gerard Phelan protested that to learn philosophy through the study of theology would be to deny the importance of the historical-critical method.[49] It must have seemed especially rich to theologians of the Holy Office like Réginald Garrigou-Lagrange (1877–1964) and Charles Boyer (1884–1965) to hear that they had neglected Thomas Aquinas's theology—and that from a layman who was not even permitted by canon law to study theology. It appeared to many, in other words, that Gilson wanted to have it both ways. He argued against both Thomists and Scotists for the necessity of the historical-critical method, but happily ignored its strictures in order to advance his own idiosyncratic conception of Thomistic metaphysics. It was not just that Scotus was now an "essentialist" who opposed the exemplary "existentialism" of Thomas—Gilson had been developing this position for almost a decade—but that Gilson seemed to demand that everyone share his own crisis. Lacking any way to *demonstrate* the superiority of his understanding of *esse* to Scotus's, Gilson asked his

audience—with increasing stridency—to *choose* between them.

* * *

Jean Duns Scot appeared in 1952. In it, the tensions of Gilson's career came to a head. He criticized Scotists for distorting the thought of their master, of course, but equally set out to defend the Subtle Doctor against three centuries of false accusations. More than anything else, Gilson hewed closely to the texts of Scotus, even if on occasion he sacrificed his customary elegance to the cause of exhaustive summary. Gilson presents the work not as an "historical" study of Duns Scotus, but as a "philosophical" one, which serves him as an excuse to compare Scotus consistently to Thomas Aquinas rather than his actual historical interlocutors. Be that as it may, *Jean Duns Scot* holds up quite well as a comprehensive introduction to the fundamental positions of Duns Scotus, even after sixty-five years. Specialists who desire a more critical and up-to-date understanding of the Subtle Doctor will need to supplement Gilson's monograph, of course, but those who appeal to it to support the now-common genealogy of modernity, which sees the history of the West in terms of Scotus's teaching on univocity, would do well to heed the counsel of *Jean Duns Scot,* for no one who appeals to it can with a straight face summon the old bogeymen of univocity, formalism, and voluntarism that it takes such pains to banish.[50] Nowhere in it does Gilson claim that Scotus shattered a unified patristic witness that Aquinas faithfully preserved. He instead goes out of his way to interpret Scotus's so-called formalism in light of the earlier Augustinian tradition that Aquinas himself rejected, and happily concedes that Aquinas's attempts to claim the mantle of Augustine were far more forced than Scotus's. Nowhere does Gilson charge the Subtle Doctor with Kantianism; in fact, he notes that the two philosophers have nothing in common. So, too, Scotus's voluntarism, according to Gilson, is no more than the emphasis on God's freedom and charity that makes any philosophy truly Christian. What is perhaps more shocking, at least to readers today, Gilson states explicitly and without any ambiguity early in *Jean Duns Scot,* that Scotist univocity does not contradict the Thomist analogy of being.

It appears, however, that he had changed his mind by the time he had finished his masterpiece, which ends with the rousing existential demand that the reader *choose* between the metaphysics of analogy and the metaphysics of univocity.

Reviews of *Jean Duns Scot* were mixed. To be sure, everyone praised it as a great work: no one, however, agreed upon what made it great. Historians of the Middle Ages, such as the young George Lindbeck (b. 1923), rightly recognized its studied refutation of the standard charges against Scotus, but wondered aloud why Gilson would compare Scotus at every turn to Thomas Aquinas rather than Henry of Ghent.[51] Thomists were drawn to Gilson's final *cri de couer* for the analogy of being, upon which they happily seized for their own ends.[52] Franciscans routinely praised *Jean Duns Scot* as the fitting end of an age in Scotus studies that was now superseded by their own labors, not least by the new critical edition.[53] Carolus Balić wrote a magisterial review that was appreciative, but he did not hesitate to offer critical rereadings of many of Scotus's texts.[54] Truth be told, Gilson himself was not entirely satisfied with *Jean Duns Scot.* If he had successfully defended Duns Scotus against his critics, he still knew that his presentation of Duns Scotus's thought in light of Thomas Aquinas's rather than Henry of Ghent's was true neither to Scotus nor to history. Gilson admitted to Armand Maurer (1915–2008) that he regretted his negligence in this regard and even confessed that he had not realized the extent of Henry of Ghent's influence until Balić published the first volume of the critical edition.[55]

If the work of the Scotistic Commission surpassed and, in many respects, challenged Gilson's conclusions, it does not seem to have altered the course of Gilson and Balić's friendship.[56] Balić continued to hound Gilson, and Gilson continued to struggle with the Subtle Doctor. Everything seemed just as it ever was when Gilson wrote to Pegis almost a decade later:

> Father Balić is all taken up with the cause of the beatification of John Duns Scotus and he wanted to enlist my good will. Personally, I am in favor. I do like Scotus very much. I hope the new attempt will prove successful. I shall do my utmost to help the Franciscans, but they are so clumsy that I doubt

> that they will succeed. . . . In my mind, the *only* problem is: Does the holy servant of God, John Duns Scotus, deserve to be beatified? And my answer is: Yes. Will they succeed? They will to the extent that they approach the problem with a pure heart, that is, without trying to get the doctrine canonized along with the man. . . . Besides, I like him, and have been praying to him myself for many years.[57]

How did Gilson believe that *Aeterni Patris* had no intention of excluding Scotism, even as he insisted that no doctrine could oppose St. Thomas's? In a letter to Henri de Lubac (1896–1991), he explained: "I believe you can be Scotist, Suarezian, even Cajetanian, without infringing on pontifical directives, because all other theologies can be contained in the Thomism of St. Thomas." Still, he continued, "What I waste so much time explaining to my friends who insist upon other theologies is that they should never support them *against* St. Thomas. But they all do. And they are, no less than certain Thomists, fanatics. They want to prove, not just that Duns Scotus was right, but that Thomas was wrong."[58] Gilson was moved deeply, too, by Pope Paul VI's words at the Sixth International Thomistic Congress in 1965:

> The pope spoke French. He was obviously laying down the law for the council. . . . Thomas is, was, and always will be the Doctor Communis . . . the master of all and for all. Then [the pope] said what I have always been waiting for: that by making him the Common Doctor, the church did not intend to exclude other doctors whose teachings are theologically sound. . . . Milk and honey to Father Balić: he was beaming.[59]

Still, Gilson resisted his Franciscan friend's invitation to the congress celebrating the six-hundredth anniversary of Scotus's birth the following year, and he presented a somewhat different face to Armand Maurer:

> I have done all the fighting I can for Scotus. Now that suffering scotism has been succeeded by triumphing scotism, I have no more interest. I want scotists to be free within the church: I have been disgusted by the calumnies against them and him. Now all this is in the past. Scotism now is simply a doctrinal position in opposition to the true metaphysics of being of St. Thomas. Since I have to choose between *ens*without *esse* and *ens habens*

> *esse*, I choose the latter. I now foresee a Scotus era that is philosophically and theologically anti-Thomas, so I prefer to abstain.[60]

Much of how one interprets this letter depends on its tone. It is, on its face, entirely consistent with Gilson's repeated demands that Scotus's orthodoxy and Thomas's status as the Common Doctor be respected equally. It is hard, however, not to see some bitterness in it or—at the very least—resignation. We do not know what Gilson thought such an era of Scotus might look like apart from its supposed anti-Thomism, but few Catholics in 1966 had much of an idea of what the future would bring. If Gilson imagined a Scotism triumphant, he was, of course, wrong. In the fifty years since Gilson wrote, however much historical-critical studies of Scotus and his works have progressed, scholasticism as a living tradition in the church—and the knowledge of Latin upon which it depends—have withered. If Thomism is making a fitful return today, it seems to derive much of its rhetorical energy by ritually repeating the very myths about Scotus that *Jean Duns Scot* was meant to combat. In 1966, though, Scotism might well have seemed ascendant.[61] The International Scholastic Congress that year was devoted entirely to John Duns Scotus. In *Alma parens*, the apostolic letter written for the Congress, Pope Paul VI described the Subtle Doctor as the "perfector" of Bonaventure and "the most distinguished representative of the Franciscan School."[62] The conference itself was a changing of the guard. Fernand van Steenberghen led off the conference, and Balić, Bettoni, and Gilson contributed papers, but we also see the next generation of Scotus scholars—Allan Wolter, Camille Bérubé, Gabriele Giamberardini—stepping into their shoes.

John Paul II beatified John Duns Scotus on March 20, 1993, without (we may presume) beatifying the doctrine along with the man. I think it fair to say that Gilson, despite his reticence to become involved in Scotus's cause, would have felt vindicated by the beatification. He would, in all likelihood, have had more mixed feelings about John Paul II's encyclical *Fides et ratio* (1998). The pope praised Gilson and his "courageous research" as a model of

the process by which philosophical reasoning is enriched by faith, but only at the expense of the one, true metaphysics of being for which Gilson had spent the latter half of his career arguing.[63] The encyclical names Gilson, after all, with a series of modern thinkers—Antonio Rosmini-Serbati (1797–1855), John Henry Newman (1801–1890), Edith Stein (1891–1942), and Gilson's own friend Jacques Maritain (in the West) and Pyotr Chaadaev (1794–1856), Vladimir Soloviev (1853–1900), Pavel Florensky (1882–1937), and Vladimir Lossky (1903–1958) (in the East)—who would never have subscribed to Gilson's metaphysics. In fact, *Fides et ratio* goes on to proclaim that the church neither possesses a philosophy of its own, nor canonizes any in preference to others. It promotes the Common Doctor as a model for all who seek the truth, but—to drive the point home—steadfastly refuses to present him as anything else and eschews to demand adherence to any particular theses, Thomistic or otherwise. In fact, the encyclical goes out of its way to state that no historical form of philosophy can legitimately claim to embrace the totality of truth, and that the rational pursuit of truth cannot be limited to a single thinker or school.[64]

What does this mean for the reader of *Jean Duns Scot*? One may remove the red thread of Thomist exceptionalism that runs through it without harm to the whole. Indeed, without Gilson's insistence upon *esse* and the existential crisis that precipitated it, the metaphysical genius of Duns Scotus shines all the more clearly. In fact, the Subtle Doctor is returned to the position he enjoyed alongside St. Bonaventure and St. Thomas Aquinas in *L'esprit de la philosophie médiévale*, and Gilson's career is enriched with a unity that it previously lacked. Of course, none of this is necessary to justify Gilson's last great monograph. At the end of the day, the chief and lasting value of *Jean Duns Scot* is that it allows us to better understand Étienne Gilson himself. In it, we find the master at a crossroads. We see his trials, professional and private, but what is more we see him—maybe for the only time in his career—struggle with the mind of a master he does not fully understand.

Notes

1 Étienne Gilson, *Jean Duns Scot: introduction à ses positions fondamentales* (Paris: Vrin, 1952). German translation by Werner Dettlof, *Johannes Duns Scotus: Einführung in die Grundgedanken* (Dusseldorf: Schwann, 1959). Italian translation by Davide Riserbato, *Giovanni Duns Scoto: Introduzione alle sue posizioni fondamentali* (Milan: Editoriale Jaca Book, 2007). Costante Marabelli's introduction to the Italian translation, "Gilson e il suo lento e meandrico Jean Duns Scot," is indispensable for understanding Gilson's knowledge of Scotist studies up to his writing of *Jean Duns Scot.*

2 Margaret McGrath, *Etienne Gilson: A Bibliography* (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies, 1982).

3 Two biographies are essential in taking the measure of the man: Laurence Shook, *Etienne Gilson* (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies, 1984) and Francesca Aran Murphy, *Art and Intellect in the Philosophy of Étienne Gilson* (Columbia and London: University of Missouri Press, 2004). These may be fruitfully compared to Gilson's own recollections: Étienne Gilson, *Le philosophe et la théologie* (Paris: A. Fayard, 1960).

4 Gilson, *La doctrine cartésienne et la liberté et la théologie* (Paris: Librairie Félix Alcan, 1913), pp. 128–49. Gilson seems to have taken most of his primary texts from Wilhelm Kahl, *Die Lehre von Primat des Willens, bei Augustinus, Duns Scotus, und Descartes* (Strassburg: Verlag von K.J. Trübner, 1886), although he also read Émile Pluzanski, *Essai sur la philosophie de Duns Scot* (Paris: E. Thorin, 1887) and Parthenius Minges, *Ist Duns Scotus Indeterminist?* (Münster: Aschendorff, 1905).

5 Gilson, "L'innéisme cartésien et la théologie," *Revue de métaphysique et de morale* 22 (1914), pp. 456–99, at 472, 477–78. Gilson cites Matthias Lechner, "Die Erkenntnislehre des Suarez," *Philosophisches Jahrbuch* 25 (1912), pp. 125–50. Gilson's remarks remained unchanged when he reprinted "L'innéisme" in both *Études de philosophie médiévale* and *Études sur le role de la pensée médiévale dans la formation du système cartésien,* but he wisely distanced Scotus from Descartes's understanding of God as *causa sui* in the second half of the latter book. Compare Gilson, *Études de philosophie médiévale* (Strasbourg: Commission des Publications de la Faculté des Lettres, 1921), pp. 163, 169, and Gilson, *Études sur le role de la pensée médiévale dans la formation du système cartésien* (Paris: Vrin, 1930 [repr. 1951]), pp. 30, 225–26, 229.

6 Gilson only mentions Scotus once in the first edition of *Le thomisme.* After mentioning that students of philosophy knew Descartes, Leibniz, Kant, and Comte, but had never heard of Thomas Aquinas, Bonaventure, Scotus, and Ockham, he says, "Thomas d'Aquin et Duns Scot, pour ne choisir que des exemples peu discutables, appartiennent à la race des penseurs véritablement dignes de ce nom. Ce sont de grand philosophes, c'est-à-dire des philosophes grands pour tous les temps, et qui apparaissent tels même aux esprits les plus fermement résolus à ne se rendre ni à leur autorité ni à leurs raisons." This remained the only mention of Scotus even in the third edition. Cf. Gilson, *Le thomisme: introduction au système de. S. Thomas d'Aquin* (Paris: Vrin, 1927), p. 6. (See note 27, however.) Gilson had made real progress in his studies of Scotus since the *Index,* however. In *La philosophie au moyen âge,* he not only devoted a section to Scotus, he had read Parthenius Minges, *Ioannis Duns Scoti doctrina philosophica et theologica,* 2 vols. (Ad Claras Aquas: Collegium S. Bonaventurae, 1908). See Gilson, *La philosophie au moyen âge* (Paris: Payot, 1922), vol. II, pp. 67–84.

7 Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 107.

8 Étienne Gilson, "Pourquoi saint Thomas a critiqué saint Augustine," *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* 1 (1926), pp. 5–127. For Gilson's description of these classes, see *Annuaire de l'École pratique des hautes-études. Section des sciences religieuses*

(1922–23), pp. 67–68; (1923–24), pp. 54–56. For an English translation, see Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, pp. 395–97.

9 Étienne Gilson, "Avicenne et le point de départ de Duns Scot," *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* 2 (1927), pp. 89–149.

10 Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, p. 147.

11 Compare *Annuaire de l'École pratique des hautes-études. Section des sciences religieuses* (1924–25), pp. 62–63; (1926–27), pp. 51–52; (1932–33), pp. 64–65.

12 Gilson, *La philosophie de Saint Bonaventure* (Paris: Vrin, 1924), p. 159: "C'est là s'éloigner du théorétisme de saint Thomas pour entrer dans la voie où s'engagera Duns Scot, celle d'un Dieu qui produit déterminément les essences, en attendant qu'avec Descartes il en arrive à les créer librement." Compare *Introduction à l'étude de Saint Augustin* (Paris: Vrin, 1929), p. 29. "Cette tendance profonde à trouver en Dieu seul la raison suffisante de l'idée que nous avons de lui est le lien qui rattache à la métaphysique augustienne celles de saint Anselme, de saint Bonaventure, de Duns Scot, et de Descartes." However, note this, on illumination and seminal reasons: "Sur aucun de ces deux points saint Thomas ni Duns Scot ne seront des augustiniens; saint Bonaventure, Roger Bacon, Raymond Lulle et Malebranche sont au contraire des représentants authentiques de cette tradition" (300).

13 For a list of the courses Gilson offered at the Collège in the 30s, see Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, p. 208.

14 Gilson, *L'esprit de la philosophie médiévale* (Paris: Vrin, 1932), vol. I, p. 55: "Seigneur notre Dieu, lorsque Moïse vous demanda, comme au Docteur très véridique, quel nom il devrait vous donner devant les enfants d'Israël; sachant ce que peut concevoir de vous l'entendement des mortels et lui dévoilant votre nom béni, vous avez répondu: *Ego sum qui sum*: vous êtes donc l'Être véritable; vous êtes l'Être total. Cela, je le crois; mais c'est cela aussi, s'il m'était possible, que je voudrais savoir. Aidez-moi, Seigneur, à chercher quelle connaissance de l'être vrai que vous êtes ma raison naturelle atteindra, en commençant par l'être que vous vous êtes vous-même attribué." This is Gilson's French translation.

15 Gilson, *L'esprit de la philosophie médiévale*, vol. I, p. 55: "Rien ne peut dépasser la plénitude d'un tel texte, puisqu'il nous livre à la fois la méthode de la philosophie chrétienne et la vérité première dont toutes les autres découlent." Most associate the "Metaphysics of Exodus" with Gilson's later program, especially as expressed in the works of the 1940s, especially the enlarged 1942 edition of *Le thomisme*. For perceptive comments on this (and the "classic" fifth edition that followed in 1944), see Murphy, *Art and Intellect*, pp. 197–201.

16 Gilson, *L'esprit de la philosophie médiévale*, vol. II, p. 200: "L'esprit de la philosophie médiévale ne fait qu'un avec celui de la philosophie chrétienne. Elle a été féconde, créatrice, tant qu'elle s'est volontairement incorporée à une Sagesse, qui vivait elle-même de foi et de charité. . . . Elle est morte d'abord de ses propres dissensions, et ses dissensions elles-mêmes se multiplièrent, dès qu'elle se prit pour une fin au lieu de s'ordonner vers cette Sagesse qui était en même temps sa fin et son principe. Albertistes, thomistes, scotistes, occamistes ont contribué à la ruine de la philosophie médiévale, dans la mesure exacte où ils ont négligé la recherche de la vérité pour s'épuiser en luttes stériles sur le sens des formules qui l'expriment."

17 Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, pp. 194, 212. Gilson had been quite taken by Longpré upon meeting him on his first trip to Canada in 1926, and—with Jacques Maritain—Longpré was among the very first scholars considered for the fledgling Institute of Mediaeval Studies. (For the record, Gilson had his doubts about Maritain, but not about Longpré.) On Longpré, see Camille Bérubé, "Ephrem Longpré et Charles Balić éditeurs de Duns Scot," *Collectanea Franciscana* 56 (1986), pp. 249–78.

18 Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 280. Cf. Philotheus Böhner, trans., *Der heilige Bonaventura* (Leipzig: Hegner, 1929), and "Metaphysik und Theologie nach Duns Scotus," *Franziskanische Studien* 22 (1935), pp. 209–31.

19 Gilson to Gerard Phelan (March 8, 1935) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 226. (The translation is Shook's.).

20 Gilson, "Les seize premiers *theoremata* et la pensée de Duns Scot," *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* 12–13 (1937–38), pp. 5–86. For an account of Gilson's struggles with the *Theoremata,* see Costante Marabelli, "Gilson e il suo lento e meandrico Jean Duns Scot," in Riserbato, *Giovanni Duns Scoto,* pp. xxvii–xxix.

21 Gilson, *The Unity of Philosophical Experience* (New York: Scribner's, 1937), pp. 59, 65–66.

22 See the pertinent remarks on this problem by Allan Wolter, "The 'Theologism' of Duns Scotus," *Franciscan Studies* 7 (1947), pp. 257–73, 367–98.

23 Gilson, "Le réalisme méthodique," in *Philosophia perennis: Abhandlungen zu ihrer Vergangenheit und Gegenwart: Festgabe Joseph Geyser zum 60. Geburtstag* (Regensburg: J. Habbel, 1930), vol. I, pp. 743–55; "Réalisme et méthode," *Revue des sciences philosophiques et théologiques* 21 (1932), pp. 161–86; "La méthode réaliste," *Revue de Philosophie* (new series) 5 (1935), pp. 97–108.

24 Gilson returns to Scotus's account of Being as the very name God gave to Moses in *God and Philosophy*. He grants that Scotus stressed the "existential character of being," but contrasts Scotus's essentialism more forcefully with Thomas's existentialism. While he doesn't use the word "theologism," he still notes that Scotus was far more skeptical about the capacity of philosophy to know the Christian God *qua* Christian than Thomas. Cf. Gilson, *God and Philosophy* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1941), pp. 68–69.

25 Gilson to Chenu (February 5, 1942) in Francesca Murphy, "Correspondance entre Marie-Dominique Chenu et Étienne Gilson," *Revue thomiste* 105 (2005), pp. 25–87, at 48: "Si l'on oublie l'*esse,* on se condamne à des métaphysiques du pur concept (Scot, Suárez, Descoqs); si l'on oublie l'*habens,* on aboutit, avec Kirkegaard dans son prestigieux Post Scriptum, puis avec Jaspers, à condamner toute philosophie comme telle."

26 Descoqs's chief works on metaphysics were *Institutiones metaphysicae generalis* (1925), *Thomisme et scolastique* (1927), and *Praelectiones theologiae naturalis* (1932–1935), but three articles of the late 1930s and early 1940s seem to have spurred Gilson to refute Descoqs: "Sur la division de l'être en acte et en puissance d'après S. Thomas," *Revue de philosophie* 38 (1938), pp. 410–29; "Sur la division de l'être en acte et en puissance d'après S. Thomas: Nouvelles précisions," *Revue de philosophie* 39 (1939), pp. 233–52, 361–70; and "La division de l'être en acte et en puissance d'après Saint Thomas," *Divus Thomas* 43 (1940), pp. 463–97. Cornelio Fabro responded with "Circa la divisione dell'essere in atto e potenza secondo San Tommaso," *Divus Thomas* 42 (1939), pp. 529–52, and (more pointedly) "Neotomismo e Suarezismo," *Divus Thomas* 44 (1941), pp. 167–215, 420–98.

27 Gilson added two passages on Scotus that were not found in previous editions. The first merely noted that Avicenna anticipated Scotus's essentialism much more than he did Thomas's existentialism; the second says, in contrast to Thomas, "Pour Duns Scot, chez qui l'ontologie de l'*esse* s'efface devant celle de l'*ens*. . . ." Cf. *Le thomisme: introduction à la philosophie de. S. Thomas d'Aquin,* 5th rev. et aug. (Paris: Vrin, 1944), pp. 83, 177.

28 Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 265.

29 Ibid., pp. 268–69.

30 For his discussion of Scotus, see *L'être et l'essence* (Paris: Vrin, 1948), pp. 130–40. Compare

Being and Some Philosophers (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies, 1949), pp. 83–95.

31 Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 280.

32 Gilson, "L'object de la métaphysique selon Duns Scot," *Mediaeval Studies* 10 (1948), pp. 21–92; "L'existence de Dieu selon Duns Scot," *Mediaeval Studies* 11 (1949), pp. 23–61; "Simplicité divine et attributs divins selon Duns Scot," *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* 17 (1949), pp. 9–43; "Nature and portée des preuves scotistes de l'existence de Dieu," in *Mélanges Joseph Maréchal,* 2 vols. (Bruxelles: Édition universelle, 1950), vol. I, pp. 378–95.

33 Gilson to van Steenberghen (March 23, 1948) in Fernand van Steenberghen, "Correspondance avec Étienne Gilson," *Revue philosophique de Louvain* (fourth series) 87 (1989), pp. 612–25, at 613: "Je ne crois pas qu'Avicenne lui-même ait vraiment fait l'*esse* un accident "logique." C'est ce qu'Averroès lui reproche, mais ce n'est pas vrai. Même si c'était vrai, ce ne le serait que du "logique de l'essence réelle," qui est l'essence d'Avicenne. Ce n'est certainement pas vrai de saint Thomas. J'attends d'un jour à l'autre les premiers exemplaires de mon livre sur *L'être et l'essence*. . . . Je vous en ferai envoyer un et vous y verrez dans quelle direction je cherche ma voie. Avicenne me semble le prédécesseur de Duns Scot plus que de saint Thomas: Scotus qui genuit Suarezium, qui genuit Wolffium, qui genuit Kantium."

34 Gilson to Pegis (November 26, 1949) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 281. For a contemporary treatment of Scotus and realism, see Gilson, *La philosophie au moyen âge,* 2nd revised and enlarged edition (Paris: Payot, 1947), pp. 591–608. Gilson's treatment of Scotus in this edition differs principally from the 1922 version in that Gilson incorporated his own findings about the *Theoremata.*

35 Gilson to Pegis (August 24, 1949) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 291.

36 Gilson to Pegis (November 26, 1949) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 292.

37 Shook devotes a chapter to Gilson's activities during his depression. Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* pp. 293–310.

38 Gilson to Pegis (January 8, 1950) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 281.

39 Gilson to Pegis (February 25, 1950) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 281.

40 Ibid., p. 297. For the Franciscans' attempts to canonize Scotus in the twentieth century, see Barnaba Hechich, "Il contributo della Commissione Scotista nella causa e nello studio del B. Giovanni Duns Scoto," in *Via Scoti. Atti del Congresso Scotistico Internazionale Roma 1993* (Rome: Edizioni Antonianum, 1995), vol. I, pp. 33–47. Cf. Willibrord Lampen, *Bl. Ioannes Duns Scotus et Sancta Sedes* (Ad Claras Aquas: Ex Typographia Collegii S. Bonaventurae, 1929); Franz Pelster, "The Authority of St. Thomas in Catholic Schools and Sacred Sciences," *Franciscan Studies* 13 (1953), pp. 1–26.

41 Gilson to Pegis (June 1, 1950) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 299.

42 Gilson to Labourdette (July 28, 1950) in Henry Donneaud, "Correspondance Étienne Gilson – Michel Labourdette," *Revue Thomiste* 94 (1994), pp. 479–529, at 482: "Je viens d'achever le gros d'un livre sur Duns Scot. Il n'y a pas moins scotiste que moi. Sa philosophie, surtout sa *metaphysica quae est de quidditatibus,* est exactement le contraire de ce que je tiens pour vrai."

43 Donneaud, "Correspondance," p. 483: "*Theologiquement,* bien que je sorte là de ma compétence, je ne vois pas en quoi le scotisme est une interprétation de la foi chrétienne moins satisfaisante que le thomisme. . . . Peut-être en aurez-vous une idée si je vous demande pourquoi tant de critiques truquées dirigées contre Duns Scot ont précisément pour objet de lui imputer des erreurs contre la foi? (panthéisme, spinozisme, etc.). . . . Si le scotisme était une théologie fausse du point de vue de

la foi, il serait condamné. Or il ne l'est pas."

44 Donneaud, "Correspondance," p. 483: "Pourtant, vous et moi savons que l'être est soit analogue soit univoque, mais qu'il ne peut être les deux à la fois. Il y a donc une des deux théologies qui est fausse dans sa structure philosophique, et pourtant tolérée."

45 Acta Congressus Scholastici Internationalis, *Scholastica ratione historica-critica instauranda* (Rome: Pontificium Athenaeum Antonianum), pp. 131–42, 503–16. The printed version mutes the drama between Gilson and van Steenberghen. If one looks at the "Notitia congressus" on pp. xiii–xvi, one can see that the conference began with Steenberghen's paper on the evening of September 6 and ended with Gilson's response on the evening of September 10.

46 This is Gilson's own English text, which was published as "Historical Research and the Future of Scholasticism," *The Modern Schoolman* 29 (1951), pp. 1–10, at 8.

47 John Duns Scotus, *Opera omnia studio et cura Commissionis Scotisticae ad fidem codicum edita praeside Carolo Balic* (Vatican City: Typis Polyglottis Vaticanis, 1950).

48 Gilson to Maritain (February 25, 1947) in Géry Prouvost, ed., *Étienne Gilson – Jacques Maritain, Deux approches de l'être. Correspondance 1923–1971* (Paris: Vrin, 1991), p. 159: "J'ai commencé la journée en parlant de vous, dans ma leçon ce matin sur Duns Scot, car nous venons tous deux d'être accusés par un Franciscain américain d'avoir commis un 'inexcusable error' sur le Docteur Subtil. Mais passons aux choses sérieuses." For Wolter's criticism of Maritain and (to a lesser degree) Gilson, see Allan Wolter, *The Transcendentals and Their Function in the Metaphysics of Duns Scotus* (St. Bonaventure, NY: Franciscan Institute, 1946), pp. 65–71. At 69, Wolter refers to Maritain's reading as an "inexcusable perversion of the conception Scotus had of being."

49 Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 299. For an account of the tensions that followed upon the International Thomistic Congress later that month, see Murphy, *Art and Intellect,* pp. 234–41.

50 For a small bibliography of sources that see the history of the West in terms of Scotus's doctrine of univocity, see Catherine Pickstock, "Duns Scotus: His Historical and Contemporary Significance," *Modern Theology* 21 (2005), pp. 543–74, at 569–70. Pickstock judges this genealogy, which she traces to Gilson's *Jean Duns Scot,* to be "scarcely controversial."

51 George Lindbeck, "A Great Scotist Study," *The Review of Metaphysics* 7 (1954), pp. 422–35.

52 Compare, for example, Charles Boyer, "Recensio Bibliographica," *Doctor Communis* 6 (1953), pp. 146–47; Michel Labourdette, "Livres de théologie et d'histoire: une présentation de Duns Scot," *Revue thomiste* 53 (1953), pp. 566–76; Linus Thro, "Professors Gilson's Study of the Doctrine of Duns Scotus," *The New Scholasticism* 27 (1953), pp. 198–204; and André Hayen, "Deux théologiens: Jean Duns Scot et Thomas d'Aquin," *Revue philosophique de Louvain* (third series) 51 (1953), pp. 233–94. Maritain congratulated Gilson personally on this aspect of Jean Duns Scot, although it is difficult to tell what he thought Gilson had accomplished in writing it. Cf. Maritain to Gilson (January 3, 1953) in Prouvost, ed., *Étienne Gilson – Jacques Maritain, Deux approches de l'être. Correspondance 1923–1971,* p. 179: "Votre Duns Scot est un chef d'oeuvre de lucidité et de 'sagesse de l'histoire.' Ce que vous expliquez sur l'univocité de l'être dans votre chapitre sur l'être commun me semble définitif. Enfin on y voit clair!"

53 Efrem Bettoni, "Il 'Duns Scoto' di Stefano Gilson," *Rivista di Fliosofia Neo-Scolastica* 46 (1954), pp. 178–92.

54 Garolus Balić, "Circa positiones fundamentales I. Duns Scoti," *Antonianum* 28 (1953), pp. 261–306. Other reviewers immediately took up Balić's criticisms. See, for example, Paul Vignaux, "*Jean Duns Scot* by Etienne Gilson," *The Modern Schoolman* 31 (1954), pp. 131–37.

55 Shook, *Etienne Gilson,* p. 281.

56 For Gilson's review of the critical edition, see "Doctoris Subtilis et Mariani Joannis Duns Scoti, *Opera Omnia*," *Bulletin thomiste* 8 (1953), pp. 107–15.

57 Gilson to Pegis (December 1, 1959) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, p. 350.

58 Gilson to de Lubac (May 21, 1960) in *Lettres de M. Étienne Gilson adressées au P. Henri de Lubac et commentées par celui-ci* (Paris: Cerf, 1986), p. 32: "Je crois qu'on peut être scotiste, suarézien, et même cajétanien sans enfreindre les directives pontificales, car toutes les autres théologies peuvent tenir à l'intérieur du Thomisme de saint Thomas. . . . Ce que je perds mon temps à expliquer à mes amis qui se réclament de théologies différentes, c'est qu'ils ne devraient jamais les soutenir *contre* celle de saint Thomas. Tous le font. Ce sont, eux aussi, et non moins que certains thomistes, des fanatiques. Il veulent prouver, non seulement que Scot a raison, mais que Thomas a tort." Gilson's French is significantly less snarky than it appears in Mary Emily Hamilton, trans., *Letters of Étienne Gilson to Henri de Lubac annotated by Father de Lubac* (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 1988), pp. 39–40.

59 Gilson to Pegis (September 17, 1965) in Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, p. 370.

60 Gilson to Maurer (October 3, 1966), in Shook, *Etienne Gilson*, p. 373.

61 Cf. Charles Balić, "Duns Scotus in the Present Moment of the Church," in *Scotus Speaks Today: 1266–1966: Seventh Centenary Symposium* (Southfield, MI: Duns Scotus College, 1966), pp. 21–62.

62 Pope Paul VI, Apostolic Letter *Alma Parens* (July 14, 1966). Pope John Paul II quoted Pope Paul VI to this effect in his address to the members of the Scotistic Commission of February 16, 2002, even going so far to say that Duns Scotus "even today a pillar of Catholic theology, an original teacher, full of ideas and incentives for an ever more complete knowledge of the truth of the faith."

63 Pope John Paul II, Encyclical *Fides et ratio* (September 14, 1998), n. 72.

64 Compare John Paul II, encyclical letter *Veritatis splendor* (August 6, 1993), n. 29: "Certainly the Church's Magisterium does not intend to impose upon the faithful any particular theological system, still less a philosophical one."

Translator's Preface

I have undertaken to translate *Jean Duns Scot* (after completing translations of other works by Gilson), because I find Gilson enlightening, important, and enjoyable. It is difficult for me to contemplate the possibility that someone might choose to translate a 680 page book under other conditions. My endeavor assumes that Scotus is also important and enlightening, if not always quite as elegant a writer. I cannot claim the distance from Gilson that might be necessary to judge his place among neo-scholastic writings of the 1950s or settle the question of the accuracy of his interpretation of Scotus, especially as the Scotist Commission's critical edition becomes available. An elegant writer with deep historical sensitivity, Gilson was untypical in the neo-Scholastic world. Francesca Aran Murphy has admirably situated Gilson within twentieth-century Catholic philosophical thought in *Art and Intellect in the Philosophy of Étienne Gilson*.

After *Jean Duns Scot* was completed, Gilson had access to the first volume of the critical edition of the works of Duns Scotus (published by Typis Polyglottis Vaticanis in 1950), containing the Prologue of the *Ordinatio* or *Opus Oxoniense*. I think Gilson would regard it as completely appropriate to review the texts he used in support of his interpretation of Scotus and see whether the critical edition requires modification. Given the massive amount of textual material that Gilson marshals, my sense is that such modification would be minor.

Gilson almost always refers to Scotus's most important work as *Opus Oxoniense*, as opposed to *Ordinatio*. For *Opus Oxoniense* books I and II, he used a manual edition of *Opus Oxoniense* following the Wadding (and Vivès) organization. In a few cases I observed that the manual edition Gilson uses seems to diverge from the numbering of Vivès, and I corrected to Vivès. In

Chapter 9, Gilson alludes to the critical edition of the *Ordinatio* Prologue. By way of testing the waters and to reassure myself, I located, checked, and indicated the source of quotations and references from the *Ordinatio* or *Opus Oxoniense* in volumes I, II, III, IV, V, VI, VII, VIII, and XI of the critical edition. When I could not find a quotation, I indicated that. Where applicable, I indicated the fact that an interpolation or notation had been relegated to notes or an appendix, and occasionally I mentioned differences in wording. I have also checked Gilson's references to current American editions of *De Primo Principio*,[1] *The Quodlibetal Questions*,[2] and *Quaestiones Subtillisimae in Metaphysicam*.[3] Klaus Rodler's *Die Prologe der Reportata Parisiensia*[4] contains critical editions of the prologues to different versions of what are now referred to as *Reportatio 1-A, Reportatio 1-B, Reportatio 1-C*, and *Additiones Magnae*. Allan Wolter and Oleg Bychkov have edited and translated a critical edition of the examined version of the Paris lecture, Reportatio 1-A. Since the Wadding-Vivès book I of *Reportata Parisiensia* is now known to be William of Alnwick's *Additiones Magnae*, an excerpt or summary of a longer version of the Paris lectures, I have checked Gilson's *Reportata*, book 1 references against the first volume of *Reportatio* 1-A.[5]

Latin in the body of the text has been translated, where Gilson had not already done so. The term *esse* deserves special mention. Special difficulties arise with the most central term of *metaphysics*. The normal French or Spanish way of translating both is Latin *ens* and *esse* is with the infinitive (which ought to only translate *esse*). To make matters worse, the obvious English way of translating both *ens* and *esse* would be the participle. Moreover, students of Gilson will recall that *esse* is not apprehended by a concept but in judgment. Therefore, I have left the Latin *esse* except in some cases where English seemed to demand *is*. Likewise, *esse essentiae* and *esse existentiae* stay instead of *being of essence* and *being of existence.*

I cannot begin to express my thanks for the help I have received on this massive project. Without making the book longer than it is already, I need to mention (in alphabetical order) at least Stephen Brown, Ana Colbert, John Milbank, Balazs Mesei, Francesca Murphy, and Trent Pomplun. Words are

not enough to express my gratitude.

Notes

1 The De Primo Principio of John Duns Scotus, Evan Roche, O.F.M. (St. Bonaventure, NY: Franciscan Institute, 1949).

2 John Duns Scotus, *God and Creatures: The Quodlibetal Questions*, translated with introduction, notes, and glossary by Félix Alluntis, O.F.M. and Allan B. Wolter, O.F.M. (Washington DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1981).

3 John Duns Scotus, *Questions on the Metaphysics of Aristotle*, translated by Girard J. Eizkorn and Allan B. Wolter, O.F.M. (St. Bonaventure, NY: Franciscan Institute, vol. I, books one-five, 1997; vol. II, books six-nine, 1998).

4 Klaus Rodler, *Die Prologe der Reportata Parisiensia des Johannes Duns Scotus: Untersuchungen zu Textüberlieferung und kritische Edition* (Innsbruck: Institute für Christliche Philosophie, 2005). Hereafter, KR 1-A, page and lines.

5 John Duns Scotus, *The Examined Report of the Paris Lecture, Reportatio I-A*, Allan B. Wolter, O.F.M., and Oleg V. Bychkov, Latin Text and English translation (St. Bonaventure, NY: The Franciscan Institute, vol. I, 2004, and vol. II, 2008). Hereafter *Reportatio 1-A* I and *Reportatio 1-A* II.

Preface

Since 1913, when we discussed Duns Scotus in *Theology and the Cartesian Doctrine of Freedom*, we have frequently returned to Scotus in our study and teaching. We thereby accumulated notes taken from different editions of the texts produced during the comings and goings of a wandering life, from Jehan Petit's gothic version to the first volumes of the long-awaited critical edition, and including Wadding, García, and others. These notes did not form a continuous body. Since each series represented a new effort blazing another trail through the forest of texts, it was impossible to blend them. This at least showed us how many different books on Duns Scotus are possible, and that new ones could be endlessly conceived, none of which would be the sum of the others. Consequently, the only point of view we could still attempt was the absence of a point of view. In this spirit, I offer this book, which is primarily based upon Duns Scotus's commentaries on Peter Lombard. The reflections found in it belong to one who reread Duns Scotus, pen in hand, solely concerned with understanding him.

That explains the present work's peculiar limitations. It does not consist of scholarly reflections on the sources of Scotus's doctrine or on the environment in which the doctrine arose. Incitements to such reflections appear on each page of Scotus's writing, and they are all tempting, but only a genius could enter upon detailed research of this kind without losing sight of the basic positions that he was trying to bring out. No system is identified in Duns Scotus, but this time the only reason for that is that we have not found one. Accordingly, we have limited ourselves to watch this theologian at work, asking ourselves what he was doing and, in our private ambition but one that is authentically primary here, *who* he was. To a certain extent, this is only possible under the condition of listening for a long time before speaking.

We hope to have done that. We hope that there will be readers with the same patience, which is much to ask. We know well the book on Duns Scotus that we would have liked to read. But, to reverse usual expression, not finding that book ready-made, we have not written it. The more we reread Duns Scotus, the more it seemed impossible, without betraying him, to give him a doctrinal synthesis in philosophy or even theology, in which everything would be set out in order starting from a few principles. Such a book may be legitimate in itself and perhaps would not betray the master's thought. However, at the very least, it would not give a faithful image of his work. The meaning of the principles employed by Duns Scotus is only understood in the uses he puts them to. It is always imprudent to extract in Scotus's name consequences that he has not deduced. As Duns Scotus understood it, truth does not depend on principles alone, but also on the nature of the things that the philosopher interprets in the light of the principles. This idea, we hope, has kept us from making Scotus more abstract and systematic than he is.

Still, Duns Scotus is a difficult author. The effort required to understand him is such that we cannot hope to grasp his fundamental positions without neglecting certain factual limitations that we admit are inseparable from the positions. Therefore, we are in danger of becoming schematic, not only from the historical viewpoint, but also from that of doctrine and, by doing so, in danger of deforming the very perspectives we aspire to bring out. The present book's subtitle clearly says that, even limiting oneself to Duns Scotus's fundamental positions, it only proposes to introduce the reader to them. Like Scotus, we have repeated many times that there are different problems to resolve in the light of the same principles, but not once have we exhausted the details of their discussion. Consequently, the master is not responsible for the mutilations to which his historian has submitted him. The master is still less responsible for the doctrinal observations made about him by a reader musing about what he has read and who, although he may have eliminated many remarks in rereading, has not been able to bring himself to suppress them all. Such comments really do not come under historical research. Their author only suggests that when we discuss them we should try not to detach

them from their context. The long years of dealing with Duns Scotus that inspire this book do not guarantee its conclusion, but they invite us not to discard too quickly the image of the Subtle Doctor that the book offers. The image has taken shape slowly, and time is required to get used to it. The book's author does not presume to know in what measure the image is true. Still, thanks to the theologian of infinite being, the author seems to perceive a kind of light upon the common labor of Christian theology as it was once. Theology could play a similar role today, if the inevitable debates that accompany all doctrinal freedom, instead of feeding on themselves, were again brought to bear on the substance of their object.

A few words are in order about the composition of the present book. It was completely finished by December 1949, before the publication of the first volumes of the critical edition produced by the Scotist Commission in Rome. Viewing this magnificent instrument, the author of a book on Duns Scotus can take stock at a single glance of the extent of the loss his book has undergone. But a finished work cannot be retouched because, as often as we dive into the Subtle Doctor's texts, it is necessary to revisit everything again, even at the cost of an effort equal to the previous one. We have had to be satisfied with extracting from this treasure as much as possible, envying those who would have everything at their disposition by coming later. Our quotations for *Opus Oxoniense* books I and II are taken from the García edition. We have sometimes checked them against parts of the critical edition already published. For all the other works of Duns Scotus, except Evan Roche's edition of *De Primo Principio*, we have chosen not to indicate volume and page of either Wadding or the Vivès reprint, since we have not had one of those editions always at our disposition. Moreover, the references will allow the texts to be retrieved. We have always indicated the place of publication of isolated fragments that appeared in different books, annuals, or journals. Lastly, it should be observed that the sometimes long passages reproduced in notes often contain more than our text. Duns Scotus, whose thinking ordinarily is synthetic, simultaneously introduces more doctrinal themes than analysis can consider at one time. However painstakingly Duns

Scotus is translated, he remains clearer in Latin than in the vernacular. If we have introduced some of Scotus's expressions into our own text, it is because there is often in them *nescio quid latentis energia,* about which an ancient commentator speaks. In the context of one of those especially arduous passages from which not a word can be deleted without destroying its sense, that same commentator remarked: *profecto dum haec scribebat, calamum in mente tingebat*. Duns Scotus wrote to express his thinking rather than to make it understood. We look in vain in Scotus for the constant concern with which Thomas Aquinas showers his readers. Yet, the abrupt and slightly haughty manner has at least one advantage: it makes it difficult for the reader to have the illusion, so dangerous for St. Thomas's reader, that he easily reaches the depths of his master's thought. With Duns Scotus we immediately perceive what we do not understand. Those who, after somehow attaining a certain understanding of Scotus's doctrine, struggle to go beyond easily repeatable formulae and recapture the original intuitions from which they flow, will doubtlessly see that Scotus speaks of something to be *seen* rather than *comprehended*. That, at least, is our personal experience. However full of errors made in good faith that experience may be, we hope that this book will be perceived to spring from the desire to communicate it.

We owe Duns Scotus and the reader one last clarification. To try to understand the Subtle Doctor's fundamental positions is not at all to situate him historically. Philosophical concerns cannot help but crowd out historical truth here. Duns Scotus dialogued with several other theologians, among whom Henry of Ghent can be called his preferred interlocutor. Henry was more important for Scotus than St. Thomas. The opposite is true for us and in absolute terms. A pure work of history on Duns Scotus would allot Henry of Ghent, Giles of Rome, and Godfrey of Fontaines an important place, whereas they have only a small one in ours. On the contrary, we will compare Duns Scotus and Thomas Aquinas each time that Duns Scotus calls St. Thomas into question on an important point or one whose importance we perceive. An unintentional error of perspective may result from that, but we risk creating others, and our readers should protect themselves from it. Our Duns Scotus,

whose principal interlocutor is Thomas Aquinas, is not a historical reality, but his dialogue with Thomas Aquinas is one. Of all his philosophical interlocutors, Thomas Aquinas is the principal one philosophically. He is that in and of himself, and also for us.

If we are granted time, we would like to follow closely another book on Scotus's conversation with Henry of Ghent or even Giles of Rome. Those who undertake this labor will teach us a great deal about Duns Scotus, but it is doubtful that we can expect a more instructive doctrinal confrontation than that between the two great metaphysicians of being conceived as *essentia* and being conceived as *esse*. Here again, let us avoid any misunderstanding. This comparison is not the only object of our book, but we have undertaken it each time it presents itself in order to bring out what is characteristic of Duns Scotus's philosophical position. Perhaps we will even see that sometimes understanding Duns Scotus better is useful to understand Thomas Aquinas well.

1

The Object of Metaphysics

In the prologue of the *Opus Oxoniense* Duns Scotus already encounters a theological problem whose importance is decisive in the establishment of boundaries between philosophers and theologians. Consequently, we must begin with this question ourselves.

A The limits of metaphysics

For a theologian metaphysics is not paradigmatic wisdom. Theology is above the highest natural knowledge, and any precise definition of either theology or metaphysics implies the definition of their relations.[1] The most complete discussion of the problem by Duns Scotus is found in the prologue of the *Opus Oxoniense*. This work is a commentary on Peter Lombard's *Book of Sentences*.[2] Peter Lombard did not use the word *theology* in the introduction that precedes the first book of his *Sentences*, except in the derived form "to open the concealed things of theological investigations," *theologicarum inquisitionum abdita aperire*. Likewise, even in the *Summa Theologiae*, St. Thomas Aquinas does not normally use the word *theologia* to designate the *sacra doctrina* that the theologian professes.[3] By contrast, in Duns Scotus, *theologia* is the usual term in similar cases. It has become the proper noun that designates the knowledge human beings need to let them achieve their end.

Moreover, the Scotist formulation of the problem deserves to hold our

attention: “In the state in which human beings are, is it necessary that a special doctrine be supernaturally produced of a kind that they could not attain by the natural light of the intellect?”[4] The question is posed *pro statu isto*, which is to say, in the present state of human beings as it results from original sin. The mere fact that the problem is explicitly posed seems significant. St. Bonaventure, who commented on Peter Lombard toward 1250, did not deem it necessary to devote a special article to the question.[5] By contrast, in 1254–55, if the text we possess goes back to that date,[6] in his commentary on the *Sentences*, St. Thomas Aquinas deemed it appropriate to establish the necessity of a kind of knowledge higher than philosophy. In one of the objections that Thomas raises against his position, the sufficiency of philosophy is maintained hypothetically but clearly: *for human perfection the knowledge suffices that can be had from our natural intellect; therefore, no other doctrine beyond philosophy is necessary*.[7] In Duns Scotus’s commentary, that is to say, around 1300, the conflict is no longer between theses, but between persons. *In this question, there seems to be a controversy between philosophers and theologians*.[8] This change of perspective is surely significant.

Whatever the date of the text now known as the *Opus Oxoniense*, its theses are posterior to the 1277 condemnation,[9] which implies the existence of a conflict between philosophers and theologians as well as the existence of purely philosophical wisdom. By condemning the scandalously bold proposition that *the wise men of the world are philosophers alone*,[10] or the proposition *that the intellectual and moral virtues of which Aristotle speaks suffice for human beings to be assured of eternal happiness*,[11] Étienne Tempier certainly intended to denounce contemporary errors, actually maintained by persons who lived in his time. It is not necessary to admit that Duns Scotus primarily has particular contemporaries in mind. To be sure, he speaks of philosophers, not of philosophy. By the way he speaks, we see that his thinking moves rather on the quite classical level of the distinction between *sancti* and *philosophi*. The philosophers of whom he is thinking seem to be chiefly ancients, particularly Aristotle. Such persons never had the

occasion to maintain the sufficiency of philosophy against a Jewish religion unknown to them nor against an unforeseen Christian revelation. Duns Scotus's position indicates the moment when, under the pressure of contemporary Averroism and its claims, Christian wisdom asks whether philosophy is really capable of justifying in principle the sufficiency of which it is proud. So, for Duns Scotus the issue is to find out whether philosophical knowledge alone, without the contribution of a supernaturally revealed knowledge, suffices for human beings to attain their end.

If anything can make supernatural revelation necessary, it is the insufficiency of nature. Duns Scotus reduces the debate primarily to a fundamental divergence regarding the perfection or imperfection of human nature: "The philosophers maintain the perfection of nature and deny supernatural perfection. By contrast, the theologians recognize the deficiency of nature, the necessity of grace, and supernatural perfection."[12] The very terms Duns Scotus uses, *defect of nature*, (*defectum naturae*) suggest that he is thinking here not about nature taken in the state in which human beings were created, *in statu hominis instituti*, but about human nature in our present state, *pro isto statu*, that is to say the state in which it is found as a consequence of original sin. Scotus wonders what a philosopher would say if he heard it maintained that supernatural revelation is necessary for human beings to attain their end: "A philosopher would say that no supernatural knowledge is necessary to human beings in the state in which they are (*pro statu isto*), but that by the simple play of natural causes, they can acquire all the knowledge they need."[13] Therefore, Duns Scotus asks himself about the necessity of revelation primarily in function of original sin.

It is immediately evident that his way of presenting the problem is not only theological, as it must be, but supposes that another theological problem had been resolved, one Aristotle could not conceive, namely the problem of the present condition of human beings in the state of fallen nature, *in statu naturae lapsae*. This fact is remarkable, because at first sight nothing imposes this approach to the problem on theologians as such. It is not *a priori* evident or necessary that the state of fallen nature must be involved in the discussion.

The necessity only occurs in a theology according to which we can at least ask whether human beings could have known their end distinctly without it having been revealed to them in the case in which original sin had not been committed. Allowing for possible later confirmations, the Scotist way of posing the question invites us to anticipate that the first state of the human intellect is no longer its present state and that the intellect's field of vision may be reduced as a result of Adam's fall. If this hypothesis were confirmed, the theory of knowledge and epistemology of philosophers would be criticized here from the standpoint of prior conclusions concerning the scope of the human intellect *pro statu isto*. However, let us add that Duns Scotus himself does not begin by defining the state of fallen nature. He does not immediately tell us how precisely the state can affect the solution of his first problem. No doubt, the clarification is not immediately necessary, and, with Scotus, we can await the moment to formulate it.

Therefore, let us say that a philosopher, that is to say a person disposing of natural reason alone, wonders whether revelation is necessary to human beings. What would he respond? First, that it is useless for them. Next, that the notion itself is contradictory and impossible.

In a text that first St. Thomas Aquinas and then Duns Scotus continually quote, Avicenna says that the concepts of *being* and *thing* are the first ones that fall within the grasp of the human understanding.[14] Therefore, being is the first object of our intellect. Every faculty of knowledge whose first object is a common object, namely, one that includes other objects in itself, naturally grasps all that enters within that object and attains it as included ipso facto in its natural object. For example, sight not only attains it first object, which is color, but all that falls within its grasp by being colored. The same goes for the other faculties and certainly for reason. Normally, the *first* object of a faculty is also its *adequate* object. An object of a faculty is called *adequate* when it includes all that the faculty can know and that it can know completely. In other words, the adequate object of a faculty is exactly coextensive with it; their respective areas are not distinguished in any way, either by something left over or something left out. If the first and adequate

object of the human intellect is being, human beings naturally know everything that in any sense whatsoever deserves the label *being*. Now, everything knowable is being. Consequently, no supernatural revelation could be necessary to human beings, since what is revealed would still be being, which is the first, natural, and adequate object of our intellect.[15]

As is evident, the argument is based on the necessity of exact proportion between the faculty of knowing and its object. That is why the concept of a *supernatural* knowledge received by a *natural* faculty can be rejected not only as superfluous but also as contradictory. For the revelation of a supernatural knowledge to be possible, the human intellect would have to be disproportionate to the object of the knowledge in what is purely natural, *in puris naturalibus*, and in one way or another the proportion would have to be restored. But it cannot be, because if what is added to it is natural like itself, the sum will remain disproportionate to the supernatural object. Accordingly, something will still have to be added to it, in which connection the same problem arises and so on indefinitely. To avoid going to the infinite in this way, it is necessary to stop at the start. Let us say that the human intellect of itself is proportionate to every object knowable according to any mode of knowledge. It follows that it is neither necessary nor possible that the intellect should possess inspired supernatural knowledge.[16]

It is always risky to make a philosopher say what he would have said if he posed a problem he did not pose. At first sight it seems completely legitimate to make a philosopher deny the necessity of revelation in the name of Aristotle. Duns Scotus himself might easily have gathered the wherewithal in *De Anima* and the *Metaphysics* to prove the intellect's sufficiency to know its object naturally.[17] Yet, upon reflection, the thesis is not at all certain, and perhaps it is not by chance that here our theologian starts from Avicenna rather than Aristotle. In fact, what Scotus criticizes is a thesis that invokes Avicenna and tries to justify itself with the help of arguments taken from Aristotle's writings. The Philosopher certainly never taught that supernatural revelation was necessary for human beings to attain their good, but he also did not claim that the human intellect was adequate to being as being and

naturally capable of grasping it. He even maintained quite the opposite since, according to him, being is only accessible to us through sensible expression, and the only being that fully deserves that name, the intelligible, escapes us by its very purity. Therefore, in Aristotle's world, there would be material for revelation, and this is why, in carrying out the necessary Platonic adjustments in order to relieve the soul of its body, Alfarabi and Avicenna made a great current of intelligible illuminations circulate in the soul. They are not supernatural revelations, but they can be regarded as superhuman and, in any case, they certainly intervene in order to expand the human intellect to the measure of what is its adequate object in principle in these doctrines, namely *being*. Aristotle never seemed to have hoped for this complete human salvation through philosophy. By contrast, it seems that Avicenna's neo-Platonism grants it to us. We would have to ask ourselves whether Duns Scotus was not clearly aware of this difference and even whether one of his concerns was not to reduce Avicenna to Aristotle by denying pure philosophy certain knowledge to which it wrongly laid claim.

Though expressed in Aristotelian terms, the first argument that Duns Scotus opposes to the thesis he is criticizing is still not totally Aristotelian: in order to act in view of an end, it is necessary to desire the end; to desire it, it is necessary to know it; now, human beings can have no distinct knowledge of their end by their natural abilities; it is therefore necessary that they be given supernatural knowledge.[18] The whole weight of the argument obviously lies in the major premise: human beings are naturally incapable of distinctly knowing their proper end, a proposition that is only meaningful if the person who formulates it already possesses that distinct knowledge and judges that it is due to Christian revelation.

This is precisely the case of Duns Scotus. He does not dispute that Aristotle, Averroes, or Avicenna had some knowledge of the authentic last end of humankind, but he denies that this knowledge was sufficient to ensure salvation. In other words, he reproaches philosophy in general for is radical incapacity to discover by itself what we only know by the Gospel message. He does not reproach it *qua* philosophy. As such, philosophy has done what it

could, and it could not be expected that philosophy would do what is not able by nature to do. The God of the Gospels is not its object. Here Duns Scotus argues as a Christian who knows that the last end of human beings is not simple speculative, abstract knowledge of the divine nature but a direct, beatifying vision of God. Accordingly, he reasons as a theologian who is grounded upon his faith, and his intention is not to reproach philosophers for not having known what philosophy cannot know, but rather to establish that philosophy was and remains incapable of knowing by itself that about which revelation alone can inform us.

Even reading only Wadding's text, we might think that that such was really the attitude of Duns Scotus, but it is impossible to doubt it since the new editions of the *Opus Oxoniense* have given us the key "note" omitted by Wadding, where the Subtle Doctor expresses the core of his thinking.

> There is nothing supernatural that could be shown by natural reason to be in sojourning human beings or to be required for their perfections. He who possesses it cannot even know that it is in him. Therefore, it is impossible to appeal to natural reason against Aristotle. If we argue starting from what we believe, the argument will not impact him, because he will not concede a premise taken as the object of faith. In the reasons cited here, one premise is an object of faith or proven starting from an object of faith. Therefore, they are only theological convictions that go from what we believe (*ideo non sunt nisi persuasiones theologicae ex creditis ad creditum*).[19]

Duns Scotus's position is that of a theologian who has undertaken to fix the limits that Aristotle's philosophy never exceeded. He does this for theological reasons, some of whose premises are objects of faith. What Aristotle knew de facto is merged for Scotus with what philosophy can know. But precisely for this reason, the Subtle Doctor does not for an instant imagine proving that philosophy could or ought to know it. Scotus's exposure of the insufficiency of philosophy is based on a purely religious motive: the insufficiency of natural knowledge to achieve human salvation.

To prove that, let us first observe that everything that acts by itself, acts with a view to an end. This is also the case of natural agents, who necessarily

desire the end for which they must act. It is also the case of beings whose action is guided by knowledge, with this difference however, that to act, the latter must know the end with a view to which they act. Let us add that this knowledge must be distinct, because nobody could attain an end concerning which he had only confused knowledge. As beings endowed with reasons, human beings can desire nothing that they fail to know and can attain nothing that they fail to desire. Therefore, for us, the problem is clearly to find out whether human beings are naturally capable of knowing that their last end is to see God face to face and enjoy his beatitude eternally.

Duns Scotus establishes that human beings are not capable of that. His argument presents the notable peculiarity that it directly goes against Aristotle as if proving that Aristotle did not know that the last end of human beings is equivalent to proving that philosophy itself is incapable of knowing it. The Philosopher, who follows natural reason (*Philosophus sequens naturalem rationem*), seems to say in certain texts that human happiness consists in the acquired knowledge of separated substances.[20] In any case, even if he does not explicitly affirm that such is the highest happiness available to human beings, he concludes nothing precise on the subject by natural reason. Therefore, either he is mistaken, or he remains in uncertainty.[21] In either case, he does not "know."

Besides, how could a philosophy prove that knowledge of separated substances, for example God, correspond to a nature like ours? A being's end is measured by its acts. *In statu isto*, we know and experience within ourselves no act from which we could conclude that the vision of separated substances is accessible to us and corresponds to what we are. In other words, a being all of whose knowledge in its present state presupposes sense experience cannot naturally have distinct knowledge that its end is to know purely intelligible substances. Even if we agree that natural reason suffices to prove that the direct vision and enjoyment of God are the end of human beings, natural reason would never prove that this end ought to be eternally possessed by them in body and soul. That this good must be eternal and that it must belong to human beings in their complete nature, not to their soul

alone, are two conditions that only make it more desirable.[22] Other things may be cited whose discovery would be no less impossible to natural reason and that only an inspired supernatural doctrine could reveal to us.

Two comments are necessary in this regard. First, here Duns Scotus merely establishes against Aristotle what Augustine had previously established against Plotinus, namely that natural reason alone never dared to hope for the Good News that constitutes the essence of the Gospel message. The philosophical scenery has changed since the fifth century, but the play being staged is always the same, and, moreover, that is why the arguments Duns Scotus uses are confirmed several times by authorities drawn from St. Augustine.[23] Next, as we have said, Duns Scotus argues against Aristotle as if that which Aristotle did not know is automatically inaccessible to philosophical knowledge. Everything takes place as if Scotus implicitly accepts Averroes's identification of Aristotle and philosophy. From there comes the long-range inference that what Aristotle did not know human reason cannot know, and that it is enough that Aristotle did not know some metaphysical truth to establish that natural reason cannot attain it by its own efforts. This state of mind, which certain commentators of Duns Scotus have expressed picturesquely,[24] implies the important consequence that instead of considering philosophy as an ever perfectible human endeavor, notably perfectible thanks to suggestions from revelation, philosophy is treated as a completed discipline or rather one that is finished in every sense of the word. Duns Scotus does not seem to have ever asked what the relations of "philosophy" and "theology" would be in the future. He did not ask himself, in this completely general manner, if philosophy might not enter into a new phase of its history, thanks to its association with theology, which perhaps would be a phase of progress. Nor, to our knowledge at least, did he write that theology would dispense with philosophy hereafter. What we try to describe is less a doctrine than an attitude, and Duns Scotus thinks less in terms of "philosophy" and "theology" than in terms of "philosophers" and "theologians." Once there was the Philosopher, who, having said nearly all philosophy can say, hardly left anything more to say than what he had

already said. At present, there are theologians who say what no philosophy could have or ever will be able to say and do not allow that philosophy should henceforth claim to be capable of saying it or presume to ever have said it.

The same spirit inspires a second argument against the pretended sufficiency of philosophy. First, it is not enough to know the end distinctly. To attain the end, the means must also be known. The philosophers teach that everything that comes immediately from God comes from him necessarily. But the salvation of each human being depends on two decisions of God, each of which is free: to admit certain acts as meritorious with a view to salvation, and to admit them as deserving. Here again, we are faced with a total conflict of two irreconcilable worlds: the world of natural necessity that belongs to philosophy and the world of divine freedom that belongs to Christian theology. Only one nuance is introduced into the debate, it seems, *ut videtur*. Apparently, the notion of divine freedom escapes philosophy, because the philosophers do not know it.[25]

Thus human beings cannot naturally know either their last end or the means to attain it. The conclusion is doubly damaging to philosophy, especially Avicenna's philosophy that claims to know that our last end is to know the Separated Intelligences and to know the means to come to that knowledge. The opposition that sets Duns Scotus in conflict with philosophy is so important, so decisive it might even be said, that it is useful to pause over it.

The philosophical thesis that Duns Scotus attacks can be broken down into three moments. First, "human nature is naturally knowable by human beings because it is not disproportionate to their faculty of knowing." Second, if human nature is knowable by human beings, human beings must know the end that they desire naturally; therefore they must have natural knowledge of it.[26] Third, "according to Avicenna it is naturally knowable that God possesses being perfectly. Now, the end of any faculty is the best of what falls within its first object, since it can find joy and rest in that alone. Therefore, it can be naturally known that, as regards their intellect, human beings are ordered to God as their end." If this conclusion is accepted,

another will have to be accepted. To know human nature and to know the end of that nature starting from the science that we have about what it is, is at the same time to know the necessary relation of this nature to its end, and therefore it is also to know the means that connect the nature to its end.[27] The sufficiency of philosophy seems reestablished thereby. It is the whole problem that is put into doubt.

That the human soul is naturally capable of apprehending purely spiritual natures and apprehending them in a direct intuition resembles Avicenna's position more than any other.[28] That the first object naturally knowable by the intellect is *being* is a thesis that Duns Scotus himself explicitly connects here with Avicenna. The Subtle Doctor opposes memorable responses to these two positions, at least a part of which ought to be retained by us as affecting Scotus's notion of philosophy.

Duns Scotus denies that the knowledge we have of the soul's nature allows us to form a precise notion of our last end. It particularly does not let us guess that our nature is capable of a supreme grace like the beatific vision. What matters the most is the reason he gives: "*Pro statu isto* our soul, like our nature, is only known to us by a very general concept such as can be abstracted from sensible things," which does not suffice to make us know that its most perfect object is God.[29] Consequently, this argument implies that the present state of human beings affects the action and the range of their intellects. In another state, the soul would perhaps know its nature. Perhaps the soul would grasp itself, as Avicenna claims, in immediate awareness of its pure intelligibility, and the problem of the natural knowledge that it can have of its end could be posed differently. However, disposing only of the knowledge of the soul presently accessible to us, we cannot conclude that it is essentially capable of seeing God.

A similar reservation is necessary regarding the object of the intellect: "What is assumed here must be denied, namely, that we naturally know that being is the first object of our intellect, and that it is known with total indifference to the sensible and the intelligible, and that, Avicenna says, it is known naturally. Indeed, Avicenna has mixed his religion, which is the

religion of Mohammed, with philosophical matters and has said certain things as if philosophically proven by reason and others as corresponding to his religion. That is why he himself explicitly says in his *Metaphysics*, book IX [chapter 7] that the separate soul knows the immaterial substance in itself and that is why it is necessary for him to maintain that immaterial substance falls within the first object of our intellect. This is not what Aristotle says, according to whom the first object of our intellect seems to be the quiddity of sensible things, known either in the sensible itself or what is derived from it, that is to say, in the quiddity that can be abstracted from the sensible."[30]

As we have translated the text following the critical edition, it differs from previous texts on one point. The Vivès edition gives, "and so says Avicenna, he does not conclude that it is naturally known," *et sic quod dicit Avicenna, non concludit quod sit naturaliter notum*, which provides an easily understandable text. Other editions prefer, "and what Avicenna says does not conclude that it is naturally known," *et hoc quod dicit Avicenna non concludit quod sit naturaliter notum*, which gives an equally understandable text, furthermore the same. In both cases Duns Scotus would not have denied that Avicenna held this thesis, but that, given the way in which he held it, by mixing religion and philosophy, what he says does not prove that his thesis is naturally known by reason. The same holds if we accept another reading that was also proposed, "and what Avicenna says, that it is naturally known," *et hoc quod dicit Avicenna quod sit naturaliter notum*, which means: what Avicenna says must be denied, namely that this is naturally known. The immediate meaning becomes different if the text that the new editors propose is admitted, because the issue is then no longer to deny that what Avicenna said is true, but that he said it: *et quod hoc dicit Avicenna quod sit naturaliter notum*, which signifies, "it must be denied also that Avicenna said this, that it is naturally known." The choice of this last reading is justified by the completely objective critical rules that the editors of Duns Scotus accepted.[31] Consequently, they were completely right to prefer it to others, and we in turn ought to bow to their decision, provided only that the text thus restored offers, perhaps, an intelligible meaning, as in fact happens.

Let us turn to the objection to which these lines reply: “Likewise it is naturally knowable that the intellect’s first object is being, according to Avicenna, and it is naturally knowable that the essence of being[*rationem entis*] has its highest degree of perfection in God.” it will be noted that only the first of these two propositions is explicitly attributed to Avicenna. Thus, it is quite possible that Duns Scotus might have written in his reply: “It must be denied that it is naturally knowable that being is the intellect’s first object, and that it is so according the complete indifference of being the sensible and the intelligible, and also that Avicenna says that this is naturally known.” That is possible from the standpoint of the objection, but difficult from the standpoint of the response, because, if the text is like this, the reply denies something the objection does not affirm. In the objection, Avicenna’s name covers only the first thesis: “It is naturally knowable that the intellect’s first object is being.” In the response, the two theses are merged into one: “It is naturally knowable that our intellect’s first object is one, and that is so according to the complete indifference of being to the sensible and the intelligible.” If we admit that the reply must correspond to the objection, it is difficult to doubt that the objection holds Avicenna responsible for the whole thesis for which he will be held responsible in the response. Accordingly, the text cannot mean that Avicenna maintains that it is naturally knowable that the intellect’s first object is being but does not maintain that God is included in the object of that concept.

There remains another interpretation: Avicenna would have maintained these two theses, but he did not maintain that they are naturally known. At least this is not impossible. Indeed, neither in the objection, nor in the reply does Duns Scotus cite any text where Avicenna maintains the thesis. Let us add that if a text of this kind exists, we do not know of it. Therefore it is literally exact to say: Avicenna did not write that we naturally know that being, whether intelligible or sensible, is our intellect’s first object.

But is this what Duns Scotus means? It can be doubted, because he himself explains how Avicenna arrived at this conclusion, that is to say, by mixing religion and philosophy. The only sense that remains possible is, therefore,

that Avicenna did not say that we know this proposition *naturally*. Of course, since Avicenna did not formulate this proposition explicitly, we are only dealing with what Duns Scotus constructed under the form of an objection starting from Avicenna's texts. Once this sense is admitted, we still must choose between two different interpretations.

The first is that Avicenna himself did not say that it is naturally known. Indeed, when he expresses himself on this point, he speaks rather as a person who is inspired by his religion. Thus, in his *Metaphysics*, tractate IX, chapter 7, Avicenna explicitly holds that the separated soul knows the immaterial substance in itself. This thesis, which involves the state of the soul after death, falls under religion. Yet, it is in maintaining it that Avicenna had "to include the immaterial substance within the intellect's first object." Duns Scotus, therefore, does not doubt that Avicenna taught this doctrine, because he himself explains why the Arab philosopher had to teach it. What Duns Scotus denies is that Avicenna taught this thesis as something known by natural reason, because since he held it under the inspiration of a religious belief, it completely depends on religion.

That Avicenna did so is likely, but that he did so consciously or wanted to do so is very difficult to believe. If we refer to the text of the *Metaphysics* cited by Duns Scotus, we find only one phrase to justify this interpretation. In the chapter about the divine promise, *Capitulum de promissione divina*, Avicenna states, regarding his own doctrine on the last end of human beings, that the Koran approves it (*prophetia approbat*). Perhaps Duns Scotus alludes to this phrase, when he writes that Avicenna said certain things as in conformity with his sect, *consona suae sectae*. Nothing would be more correct, because when Avicenna declares that his thesis is approved by revelation, he certainly calls it in agreement with his religion. Therefore, it is not impossible that, seizing upon this phrase to exploit it to the fullest, Duns Scotus meant: you see clearly that Avicenna is inspired here by a religious theme, because he himself says so. Therefore, it must be denied that Avicenna holds his thesis to be *naturaliter nota*, because he himself presents it as confirmed by revelation.

Whether this was indeed the thought of Duns Scotus, the contrary will never be proven. But, before showing what difficulties this interpretation raises, let us first observe that, whatever is the preferred reading, it will ultimately lead to the same meaning. Whatever Avicenna himself thought, Duns Scotus himself answers that here we can legitimately base ourselves on Avicenna to maintain that being, including the pure intelligible, *in statu isto* is naturally known as the first object of the intellect. Either Avicenna denied it or, if he maintained it, he unconsciously mixed religion with philosophy, and taught as a philosopher what he had to maintain to satisfy the requirements of his faith. The proof is that Aristotle, who knew nothing about the Muslim religion, did not commit the error. Thus, whatever is preferred, the choice in no way changes the interpretation of Duns Scotus's own thinking. His thesis is and remains that by natural knowledge we do not know that being, including the pure intelligible, is the first object of our intellect. Those who affirm the contrary speak de facto in the name of revelation.

A last question remains, which has some importance in choosing between the different readings that Duns Scotus's editors propose. Did Avicenna consider the thesis in question to be naturally known or not? Duns Scotus himself remits to Avicenna's *Metaphysics* book IX, chapter 7. What do we read there? In this *Capitulum de promissione divina*, Avicenna distinguishes two promises: first that of the Prophet, which is directed to faith and promises bodily joys and sufferings; then, "and there is another promise, *which is grasped in the understanding and through demonstrative argument and prophecy approves*, and this is the happiness of souls, *which is proved by arguments*, although our imaginations are too weak to imagine them now for reasons that I will show." However much the Prophet approves this second happiness in Avicenna's eyes, it is no less knowable by natural reason alone and demonstrable by the pure powers of the intellect. The "theologians" who investigate it are theologians in the Aristotelian and philosophical sense of the word which hold *theology* to be one of the names of first philosophy or *Metaphysics*. We can see this by reading what immediately follows the passage, where a purely philosophical method of obtaining happiness is

described in detail. Thus it is certain that, according to Duns Scotus, the reasons why Avicenna was led to include the intelligible in our concept of being as the first object of the intellect is, in Avicenna's own view, an essentially philosophical and natural conception of happiness. In order to admit that Duns Scotus made Avicenna hold the opposite, it is necessary to admit also that the Subtle Doctor was mistaken about the obvious meaning of the chapter in Avicenna to which he remits.[32] This is not impossible but ordinarily we put his level of subtlety higher. This is why, without disputing that *et quod hoc dicit* is a good critical reading, there is at least a philosophical reason to judge that the reading *et hoc quod dicit* is preferable. Duns Scotus can hardly have written in the same passage that Avicenna did not say that it is naturally known that being, including the intelligible, is the first object of our intellect, and cite in support of his saying so a passage from Avicenna where everything implies that the intelligible being is naturally accessible to our intellect. We can believe that all the less since, according to Duns Scotus himself, the reason why Avicenna must have held this last thesis is taken from a chapter of his *Metaphysics*. There, speaking purely philosophically Avicenna establishes that the separated soul knows the immaterial substance in itself by a method that owes nothing to faith and revelation, although it is in agreement with them.

On the other hand, Duns Scotus's text is coherent in itself and with the facts, if he has simply said that Avicenna, believing he spoke purely as a philosopher, was still influenced by his religion. If he had not learned from the Koran that the soul is personally immaterial, and that rewards and punishment await it in the next life, would he have ever thought that the soul finds its last end and its happiness in the intelligible union with a separated substance?[33] As a pure philosopher, Aristotle thought nothing of the sort, and this is also why, speaking of human beings in the particular state in which they are, he concluded that the quiddity of the sensible being is the natural object of our intellect.

Duns Scotus did not confuse Avicenna's doctrine with the teaching of the Koran,[34] but he thought Avicenna's religion had marked his philosophy.

Perhaps Avicenna would not have defended himself too much from that judgment.[35] In any case, Duns Scotus's thinking is clear, and as it would be equally dangerous to exaggerate its significance and to restrict it, we would like to try to measure it.[36]

It is quite evident that Duns Scotus's immediate objective here is to proceed to a theological critique of the limits of philosophy. For Christianity this is absolutely crucial, because, if it is true that human beings can see God naturally, as Avicenna thought, it follows that philosophy suffices for human salvation, all divine revelation becomes superfluous, the Gospel is useless, and the Christian religion is taught in vain. In this regard, the Arab philosophers were much more dangerous than Aristotle who could be reproached for not having offered any doctrine of salvation, but not for having invented a false one. It seems equally certain that Duns Scotus bases himself on the soul's ignorance about its true nature and true powers in order to deny that human beings can naturally know that they are capable of knowing the intelligible directly. It is certainly also to be admitted that, for Duns Scotus, this ignorance of the soul about itself is connected to its present state, which is the state of fallen nature. Finally, everyone will probably agree in summing up Duns Scotus's position on this point: "All our knowledge of essences is abstractive. It is therefore impossible for us to rise to the hope, still less the certainty, of knowing separated essences by intuition."[37] We could do so if we at least had intuitive knowledge of our soul's essence, but since we only know it by its acts, which are acts of abstractive knowledge, we cannot do so.

That said, the question remains to know whether or not Duns Scotus teaches that our incapacity to know the intelligible intuitively is a consequence of original sin. The answer is that Duns Scotus hesitates on this point, and that his hesitation or imprecision is significant since it means that "the Subtle Doctor regarded this question as of secondary importance."[38] Let us move forward, expecting to come back to the matter in due time, but let us at least say that just this would be very important for us. In order to appreciate Duns Scotus's attitude toward philosophy, it would be extremely

interesting, to know whether he regarded a question as secondary that is indeed secondary theologically speaking, but philosophically speaking primary, fundamental, and urgent. The issue is nothing less than to know whether our intellect, considered in its natural condition, was so wounded by original sin that what was included within the intellect's natural object before the fall has become too completely inaccessible for the intellect to know that it is naturally capable of knowing the object. The issue ultimately is whether, in the case in which its object is itself the object of metaphysics, the knowledge we have of it de facto is what we ought to have. All these problems hang together, and even supposing that Duns Scotus only attached secondary importance to the first, he certainly would not be uninterested in the others. We would thus be led to conclude that Duns Scotus is more concerned with defining the competence of philosophy than in extending its limits, which is not at all unreasonable and would be historically important.

A second, much more precise, point deserves to catch our attention. Whatever Duns Scotus's ultimate position on the total problem to which we will have to return, the position he adopts toward Avicenna in the prologue to the *Opus Oxoniense* remains the same. To desire to interpret it in function of the totality of the problem, as has been done, is certainly a wise decision, but more difficult to observe than it seems. It is true that "a philosophical doctrine must issue from the totality of the thought of a given master,"[39] yet, the totality of the thought of a given master also issues from the particular doctrines that he teaches. Something completely different stands between the two: the commonly accepted ideas about what the totality of a master's thought is. For the historian, that is what is at stake. At the beginning of the historian's research, he will not accept that idea as true but as an idea about whose truth he wonders. It is an essential rule that no idea about the totality of a doctrine is true if it is in conflict with a single particular thesis that has been properly established. The thesis we are discussing here is philosophically fundamental, because it concerns the natural, first, and adequate object of the human intellect. In a passage whose authenticity has never been challenged so far, Duns Scotus speaks in terms so clear that we

can only repeat them after him: “It is to be denied . . . that we naturally know that being is the first object of our intellect and know this completely indifferently in regard to sensible and non-sensible being.” *negandum est . . . quod naturaliter cognoscimus ens esse primum objectum intellectus nostri, et hoc secundum totam indifferentiam entis ad sensibilia et insensibilia*. We only know what “the totality of Duns Scotus’s thought” is when we have reconstructed a doctrinal totality capable of integrating this thesis, as Duns Scotus himself formulated it.

It is difficult to dispute what this thesis implies regarding the totality of Duns Scotus’s texts on this point. If being taken in its indifference to the intelligible and the sensible is the first object of the intellect, and if it cannot be known by natural reason alone that being thus conceived is the first object of the intellect, it cannot be known by natural reason alone what the intellect’s first object is. The minor premise is established by the passage from Duns Scotus himself that was just quoted. The major follows precisely from the totality of his thought, because, if this is not what Duns Scotus thinks, what is meant by his criticisms of the Thomist thesis according to which the first object of the intellect is the quiddity of the sensible being? What does Duns Scotus’s own doctrine of univocity mean? For the latter does not mean that we naturally have intuitive knowledge of intelligible being as Avicenna thinks. But an intellect incapable of abstract, univocal knowledge of being would be incapable, in Duns Scotus’s view, of intuitively knowing intelligible being in whatever state it may be. Therefore, it would not be a human being. Here, Duns Scotus reaffirms the rights of nature against Thomas Aquinas. How can God himself make the intellect capable of intelligible intuition, if the intellect is *naturally* incapable of it? How does it come about that the intellect was capable of it formerly and could become so again? But, if the intellect is naturally capable of that intuition, to such a degree that it would still be so, absent the fall, how will the intellect’s abstract knowledge of being not be extended to all being in virtue of its very nature?

We could challenge the conclusion and say that here Duns Scotus specifies that the issue is “total” indifference to the point that it includes God himself.

Nothing would be truer, but if Duns Scotus denies that the human intellect, placed in its present state and without the help of revelation, can know itself capable of seeing God, he emphatically affirms that the intellect is capable of it, if God wishes. For the human intellect to be capable of that, it is necessary precisely that God should fall within its first object. All that is contained of itself within the first object of a faculty is knowable by this faculty. Let us recall that the first object of a faculty is also the object adequate to its total grasp. There is no doubt that according to Duns Scotus, God is included within the human intellect's first object. "Not only limited being but also unlimited being is an object naturally capable of moving the created intellect. Consequently, being *qua* indifferent to one or the other will be the intellect's adequate natural object."[40] What is the being indifferent to being limited and to being unlimited, but being indifferent to creature and creator? It would be hard to imagine more "complete indifference."

Here is an even more explicit statement: "Everything that is contained per se within a faculty's first and natural object can be naturally attained by this faculty. Otherwise, the first object would not be natural to the faculty, but would transcend it *qua* object. Being, which is the first natural object of the intellect, corresponds with complete truth to God himself."[41] What more do we want? If God is included under the intellect's first and natural object, and if we cannot *naturaliter* know that he is so included, we can no longer know naturally what the intellect's first and natural object is. Duns Scotus says this explicitly. About this, we would simply ask: what results from that for our metaphysics? The science of being as being, metaphysics cannot know *naturaliter* the exact nature of all beings that fall within its first and natural object. To see that this is so, it is enough to look at Aristotle and all those deceived by him who restrict the power of the human intellect taken in itself to the power of the intellect in *statu naturae lapsae*. Whatever way we turn the problem around, the same conclusion is forced on us. We cannot know what the intellect is naturally capable of, if we are not blessed by the lights of revelation.

The third argument directed by the Subtle Doctor against the so-called

sufficiency of philosophy further strengthens the general hypothesis that the first two suggest. There again Duns Scotus seems to consider philosophy as an experiment already tried, finished, and whose accounts can be settled because we know the results.

Since the knowledge of separated substances, that is to say purely intelligible substances, is naturally accessible to us, it pertains to metaphysics to give it to us. Now, Aristotle himself recognizes that our knowledge of separated substances is very imperfect because it is obtained from their sensible effects a posteriori. Duns Scotus adds, for his own part, that we can prove that it is thus. The first proof that he offers implies no metaphysical problem, because it consists in observing that since we only know the First Immaterial Substance from its effects, we are irremediably ignorant of this property that, however, belongs to its nature: to be communicable to three (*quod sit communicabilis tribus*). The effects produced by God do not show this property, because they do not come from God as "triune." On the contrary, if we argued from the effects to the cause here, they would rather lead us into error, because every numerically one nature caused by God is the nature of a single subject.

The following proof, on the other hand, invites us to a properly philosophical reflection. Anticipating one of the controlling themes of his theology, Duns Scotus makes us observe that another property of the divine nature, this time a property *ad extra*, is exercising contingent causal action (*causare contingenter*). No one will ever insist more vigorously than Duns Scotus on the radical freedom of God's own divine action outward. He adds that reasoning from divine effects rather leads to error, "as we see in the opinions of philosophers who maintain that *the First* causes necessarily."[42] In an expression like this, *Primus* is an unmistakable mark of the source: the philosophers in question are Arab philosophers. The thesis in question is one of those Étienne Tempier had condemned in 1277,[43] and that Giles of Rome had classified among the "errors of the philosophers."[44] Duns Scotus himself certainly regards this proposition in this way. It is a philosopher's error, that is to say, one of those to which natural reason is exposed when it tries to

know God from his effects. Let us not say that reason is condemned to error, but the divine effects lead it rather to error than to truth: *magis . . . effectus in errorem*. The experiment carried out in philosophy testifies to this. Reasoning about the properties of created substances, we naturally come to conclude that they are perpetual, eternal, and necessary, "rather than" contingent and new in being: "This same thing is also clear regarding the properties of other substances, since the effects lead rather to their sempiternity and eternity and necessity that to contingency and newness."[45]

Who would not recognize these theses immediately? That it is impossible to refute Aristotle's arguments in favor of the eternity of the world and that everything that happens is necessary—these are two errors condemned in 1277.[46] Here we are at the very origins of what Giles of Rome had just called "errors of the philosophers," *errores philosophorum*, at least if it is true to say that the doctrine of the eternity of the world is everywhere present in Aristotle's work and, as it were, at the foundation of everything he teaches.[47] Duns Scotus moves in familiar ground, and he continues to do so when he denounces, as something suggested by observation of the sensible, the error of philosophers who conclude from the movements of heavenly bodies, that there are as many separated substances as celestial movements: "Similarly, the philosophers seem to conclude from motion that the number of these separated substances is according to the number of celestial movements."[48] Here again, we follow in the footsteps of Giles of Rome, or more exactly, on a path known to everyone. Did not Aristotle say in his *Metaphysics* that here are as many angels or intelligences as there are celestial spheres? Basing himself on this principle Aristotle counts fifty-five or fifty-seven. Avicenna counts around ten intelligences for nine spheres, while every theologian knows by faith in Scripture that the angels are innumerable.[49] Finally, what should we say of the theses likewise maintained by the philosophers that the separated substances are naturally happy and free from sin?[50]

While understanding that Duns Scotus concludes all this is perfectly absurd, it is difficult to resist attributing such a simple view of the situation to him. The philosophers did not know that the present state of human is a state of

fallen nature. They thus thought that the abstractive mode of human thought *pro statu isto* is also the only mode of knowing of which human beings are capable. From here to describing intelligible being starting from its sensible effects is only a step. The philosophers took it, and from that point on they have gone from error to error. What must be known to avoid the errors, absolutely speaking, is that the human intellect is capable of intelligible intuition, but that is also something human beings cannot become aware of in their present condition. Religion alone makes them aware by revealing to them their last end, which is the face-to-face vision of God, and if some philosopher claims to have found it himself, he is flattering himself. Unbeknownst to that philosopher, theology has just injected itself into his metaphysics, and he has learned about the last end from theology.

Nothing authorizes us to hold these first impressions as definitive certainties, but for the moment they are irresistible, and provisionally, we can accept them, under the condition of rectifying them later, if the occasion arises. Supposing that they are at least partially correct, then according to Duns Scotus, philosophy's insufficiency to show us our last end stems from our present incapacity to grasp directly an intelligible essence as such and from our necessity to substitute abstractions for the intellectual intuitions that we lack.[51] Supposing that there are no others, this reason would be enough to prove the necessity of a supernatural revelation. In any case, it is the fundamental reason that Duns Scotus offers against this exact thesis: human beings do not need supernatural revelation, *because philosophical knowledge is enough for them to attain their end*. Indeed, this is the position against which Duns Scotus levels his attack and in view of which he constructs it. However, it remains to be seen whether the revelation that is affirmed to be necessary is, furthermore, possible. To establish that, we will have to define the relation between natural and supernatural, and first of all, the concept of supernatural itself.

Everything that absolutely transcends any natural faculty is supernatural. A receptive faculty can be considered in relation either to the act it receives or to the agent from which it receives the act.

In the first case, the faculty can be naturally inclined to this act, that is to say, inclined by virtue of its own nature. It is then a *natural* receptive potency. But the act the faculty receives can be contrary to its nature; that is to say, it only receives it because it undergoes it. Then, it is a *violent* receptive faculty. Lastly, the act the faculty receives can be indifferent to its nature; that is to say, neither desired nor refused by its nature. Then it is a *neutral* receptive faculty. Whether the faculty is in a natural, violent, or neutral state, it is not at all in a state of supernaturalness. But things change if we define the relation to the agent from which the faculty receives its form.

Either the faculty in question undergoes the action of an agent that imparts a certain form, in a natural manner, or else this faculty undergoes the action of an agent that is not its active cause *naturally*, In the first case the agent acts on the faculty as a nature upon a nature, in which case we are in the order of *naturalness*. In the second case we are in the order of *supernaturalness*.[52] In short, the supernaturalness of an action stems from the fact that the agent is not the natural cause destined to exercise this action in virtue of its very essence.[53]

Let us apply this conclusion to the problem of supernatural knowledge. The philosophers say that the possible intellect is capable of becoming everything, therefore also of knowing everything. That is right. From that it follows that if we speak about instances of actual knowledge that the possible intellect receives, none of them are supernatural for it. Indeed, it is a nature, and those instances of actual knowledge are in it. Therefore, they are *natural* insofar as they belong to the intellect, because it is natural for the possible intellect to be activated by any knowledge in general, and its natural inclination leads it toward all of them. The same does not hold if we are talking about the cause of this knowledge. From this second point of view, an instance of knowledge is supernatural "when it is engendered by an agent to which it does not correspond to move the possible intellect to the knowledge *naturally*." Here Duns Scotus adds a remark whose importance cannot escape us: "In the present state (*pro statu isto*), according to the philosopher, it belongs to the possible intellect to be moved to know by the agent intellect and the

phantasm; therefore, only the knowledge these agents can impart is natural."[54]

We see how Duns Scotus demonstrates perfect continuity of purpose. The point for him is to refute certain philosophers who, though basing themselves in mere natural knowledge, nonetheless claim to be capable of assigning human beings their last end. Some of them, notably Avicenna, presume to prove that this end consists in knowing those purely intelligible substances that are the Separated Intelligences. What Duns Scotus argues against them is precisely that all knowledge of the pure intelligible must be natural for us. It cannot be so *pro statu isto*, the only state Aristotle knew and that he described correctly. Here the central thesis Duns Scotus opposes appears in the full light of day. It is that there is no possible philosophical salvation, or in other words, that philosophy alone is incapable of leading human beings to their last end, because, *pro statu isto*, it is not even capable of discovering it. Here again, more than ever, his adversary is Avicenna, the philosopher who was commonly reproached for having taught this pair of connected errors: "That our beatitude depends on our works" and "our beatitude consists in the knowledge of the last intelligence."[55] So, the point is to exclude the naturalness of beatitude and the naturalness of salvation, at least if we want to establish the necessity of a revelation. On the one hand, Avicenna was mistaken in designating as the human last end the vision of an intelligible creature and consequently of an intelligible other than God. On the other hand, Avicenna was right to posit the human intellect as capable of pure intelligible intuition. However, since nothing suggests that pure intelligible intuition is possible in the human understanding's present state Avicenna himself must have taken revelation for philosophy. Everything looks as if, in Avicenna's eyes, what a philosopher knows beyond what Aristotle knew regarding the last end of human beings, could only come from revelation.

Consequently, what is called revelation is the communication to human beings of some teaching whose source is other than the natural sources *pro statu isto*, which is to say, their agent intellects and phantasms.[56] This amounts to saying that revelation is knowledge caused by a supernatural

object, or an agent that takes its place and substitutes for it to make us know it. For example, the proposition, “God is one and three at the same time,” could be known by us perfectly if we had direct knowledge of the divine essence, which is a supernatural object for our intellect. But every agent causing the knowledge in us of truths that would be evident, if we knew such an object, performs the function of the object for us. Thus, in the present case, he who reveals the proposition, “God is three,” performs the function of God’s essence, the sight of which escapes us. He clearly causes a certain knowledge in us that is obscure and imperfect in regard to the truth, but is nevertheless revealed about God’s essence: first of all, because the truth is eminently included as the imperfect under the perfect, in this knowledge of a supernatural object that escapes us; next, because none of the objects that are naturally knowable for us virtually includes such a truth.

Thus, by gradually going deeper, Duns Scotus comes to add the supernaturality of the object of our knowledge to the supernaturality of its cause. There can be supernatural revelation of natural knowledge. For example, if some supernatural agent revealed geometry to human beings it would be supernatural as to its cause but not as to its object. But if it revealed this proposition, “God is three,” or anything else of the same order, the knowledge of that would be supernatural in both senses—for the object’s supernaturalness implies its cause’s supernaturalness, whereas the cause’s supernaturalness does not necessarily imply that of the object.[57]

When the philosophers’ optimistic propositions about the human intellect’s universal competence in the question of being are viewed from this standpoint, they suffer great restrictions. Their principal defect is that they neglect the object’s activity. It is true that the possible intellect could receive anything, and the agent intellect produce anything as regards the intellect itself, but the object still must act for the intellect to have something to produce and to receive. In other words, they would include everything it needs to be a soul, as an active and passive principle. However, on the one hand, its agent intellect is not capable of actualizing its possible intellect by itself. On the other hand, its possible intellect, thanks to its proper excellence

as an intellect, is naturally capable of receiving a perfection so eminent that no *natural* agent is capable of bestowing this perfection on the possible intellect. Still, its passive power does not exist in vain, because in the absence of a natural agent capable of perfecting it, a supernatural agent can actualize it voluntarily and thus freely.

Perhaps it will be objected that requiring a supernatural agent to lead the intellect to perfection is to debase the intellect. The opposite is true:

> If our happiness consists in the highest speculative knowledge to which we can naturally attain here below, the Philosopher would not say that nature lacks what is necessary. Now, I not only grant that this happiness is naturally accessible to us, but I furthermore add that human beings can naturally receive another still more eminent happiness, in which there is more honor for nature than if this natural happiness of which we have spoken were also the highest happiness accessible to human beings.[58]

Here, the supernatural determination from its cause takes on a completely different meaning. The exact formula Duns Scotus uses leaves no doubt: "And beside this I say that another higher [happiness] can be obtained naturally," *et ultra hoc dico aliam eminentiorem* [*felicitatem*] *posse naturaliter recipi*. In other words, the passive power of the human intellect *naturally* extends well beyond its active causality. For, if human beings have received an "inorganic" faculty knowing in the sense that its operation is not linked to any corporeal organ, they have not received at the same time everything that cooperates with the production of the act, beyond this faculty itself. So, it appears that Duns Scotus rejects the dichotomy between natural happiness and supernatural blessedness and substitutes this more supple possibility: blessedness that is supernatural in its cause and still natural for the intellect that receives it. Therefore, we cannot consider impossible that human beings might naturally receive a certain happiness in one state that was naturally inaccessible to them in another given state. Thanks to the complementary notion of *state* the notions of *natural* and *nature* here involve a flexibility that we will see is characteristic of Scotism, and that presents a

certain looseness in its applications.

Here, we must proceed with prudence and not hasten to deduce conclusions, for example, the following: that the Subtle Doctor tends to naturalize supernatural knowledge. The opposite is true. If we envisage the problem from his point of view, he intends to completely supernaturalize knowledge, in fact, much more than other theologians had done before him, except that he supernaturalizes knowledge primarily from the point of view of its cause. In this way, Duns Scotus gets a science that is natural in the subject possessing it, but supernatural by its cause and therefore also by its object. The immediate result of this position is not to confuse supernatural theology and metaphysics, but rather to accentuate their distinction.

This is easy to see in the objections Scotus directs against the Thomist approach to the problem. The objections set us at the heart of a historical circumstance whose facets are successively presented to us, but which has unity and is fundamental for the philosopher. The issue is the object of metaphysics insofar as it is also natural theology or claims to be. Ultimately, the problem is to know whether God is or is not included in the object of metaphysics. Here we are forced to choose between two great Arab traditions, whose underlying presence dominates the debates, the tradition of Avicenna and that of Averroes. There will soon be an opportunity to clarify them, but the scope of the incidental question posed by Duns Scotus would completely slip away, if we did not at least say that their influence dominates it.

According to St. Thomas, whom the Subtle Doctor opposes on this point, it is not contradictory that two distinct sciences, metaphysics and theology for example, deal with the same object, provided that they consider it under two distinct formal reasons.[59] Therefore, it is not impossible for both metaphysics and theology to deal with God, provided that metaphysics considers him as knowable by natural reason alone, while theology considers him insofar as he is knowable through revelation. There is one object, but the object has two formal reasons. Consequently, there are two sciences. Regarding this, Thomas Aquinas recurs to an example he made famous about the ways in

which the astronomer and the physicist prove the world is round. The astronomer does it by mathematics, which is abstract. The physicist does it by recurring to particular proofs drawn from the matter itself. They are certainly still two different sciences speaking of the same thing. From there comes the conclusion: “Accordingly, nothing forbids that what philosophical disciplines treat as knowable by the light of natural reason, another science should treat insofar as known by the light of divine revelation.”[60]

Duns Scotus quotes this text explicitly.[61] He had it in front of him, whether in the original or quoted by another at the very moment when he put his own solution to the problem to the test. His criticism is very valuable for anyone who wants to understand exactly Scotus’s idea of theology. What Duns Scotus intends to define is a theological knowledge that is exclusively such, that is to say, whose object is reserved to theology alone: “If the knowledge of what can be known in theology can be or actually is obtained through other sciences although under a different light, his theological knowledge of that is not necessary.”[62] To take up St. Thomas’s example, it is true that someone who knows the earth is round by the physicist’s method can also know it by the mathematician’s method, but this second method is not strictly necessary to him. This is not the theologian’s situation, as Duns Scotus conceives it. He is not someone who would speak of an object about which the representative of another discipline could also speak by another method. The theologian is someone who speaks of an object about which he alone can speak from the point of view in which he envisages it. There is no possible doubt about the point that Scotus proposes to establish here. Even while admitting, as philosophers would have it, that metaphysics, whose object is being, is competent in principle to deal with everything that is, we are not bound to admit that metaphysics is competent to deal with the objects of all sciences insofar as they are *their proper objects*.[63] Obviously, the point here is to assure the distinct specificity of theology’s proper object. Duns Scotus’s opposition to Thomas Aquinas on this point expresses the refusal to admit that there is a space that is partly shared by metaphysics and theology. Making allowance for later confirmation, that opposition suggests that if

metaphysics is the science of being, theology alone is competent to treat directly of God considered precisely as God.

The operation that consists in proving the necessity of theology founded upon revelation therefore implies another operation that consists, if we can state it thus, in putting metaphysics in its place, because the radical insufficiency of metaphysics to allow us to know God by strict knowledge is the surest proof that revelation is necessary for human beings to achieve their end. As metaphysics appears to us, at least provisionally from the angle of this problem, it is a science whose scope is universal only thanks to the indetermination of its object. Concerning the subject common to all the other things with which metaphysics deals, we can only affirm predicates common to all that is. No doubt there are such predicates, but particular beings have many others, so that it is impossible to deduce general properties of being as being: "Therefore, there are many knowable truths that are not included in the first principles," *ergo sunt multae veritates scibiles quae non includuntur in primis principiis*. Nothing is more obvious, if we think, for example, on the scope of the principle of noncontradiction, because it certainly teaches us that of two contradictions, one is true and the other false. What it does not say is which is true. That it is or is not characteristic of human beings to laugh does not prove that it is.[64] With even more reason, matters stand thus when it is a question of knowing God. Avicenna was right to say that being is what first falls within the grasp of our intellect, if he understood by this that being is the object which our intellect tends by a natural tendency, but that does not prove that our intellect naturally knows all that is—nor even that it is capable of knowing by itself alone. Whatever may be the case on this point, the fact remains that nothing in the objects of our natural knowledge allows us to deduce the science of the determinate being that is God from our science of being in general. It is necessary for God himself to teach it to us, necessary for this supernatural object to make itself known by a supernatural revelation. Since the object of this revelation is disproportionate to our faculty of knowledge by exceeding it, it is necessary that God should make our intellect capable of the revelation by himself causing assent to this truth in the

intellect.[65]

B Theology and metaphysics

In defining the area of metaphysical knowledge in relation to the area of theology, it is better to establish the object of the latter discipline first. If we are giving a nominal definition, there will be no difficulty. By its very name, theology is the discipline that speaks of God.[66] Moreover, this is what St. Augustine already observed: "Theology . . . by which word we understand that the reason or word about divinity is meant in Greek," *theologiam . . . quo verbo graece significari intelligimus de divinitate rationem sive sermonem.* Duns Scotus sums up this expression by saying: "Theology is the word or reason about God."[67]

However, this definition does not designate a simple object. Augustine himself had observed that there are many ways of speaking about God, for example, that of the philosophers and that of the poets. Both differ from the way Christians speak. Thus, there is a *theologia naturalis*, and even if we confine ourselves to what the philosophers say about God, the Christian must confront the problem of how his own theology differs from that of thinkers like Plato, for example, who only disposed of the resources of natural reason to establish their theology. The difficulty has always been present in the minds of the great Christian thinkers, and the principle of its solution has always been the same, but it seems to have been posed quite starkly in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries when professional theologians deeply versed in the knowledge of ancient philosophies attempted to formulate a solution with rigorous technical perfection. Difference of personal tendency inevitably affected the discussion of the problem because everyone granted that Christian theology is a kind of knowledge whose origin is strictly supernatural, but some judged that revelation de facto includes knowledge that is de jure naturally accessible to human beings, which by implication gives philosophers as such citizenship in theology. By contrast, others insist on excluding what is philosophical as such from what is theological as such.

Lastly, others, timidly at first but with a boldness that will break out in the fifteenth century, prepared a sort of rationalization of revealed knowledge whose endpoint would be to make the areas of reason and revelation coextensive someday. Corresponding variations are observable in the theologians' attitudes toward philosophy. In the first case, the attitude was more indulgent. In the second, it was sterner. In the third, the attitude took on the appearance of complete surrender. We forget today how far certain theologians would ultimately push indifference to Scripture. Writing much later, a Scotist commentator left us unimpeachable testimony.[68] Coming from Scotus's school, this gloomy testimony warns us that Duns Scotus himself had probably set out in a completely different direction.

As we have seen, Scotus speaks of a theology that is knowledge about God that we possess through supernatural revelation. Despite its divine origin, it is still human knowledge. It is exactly the knowledge about God that human beings can acquire thanks to the divine teaching of Scripture. Another knowledge about God, and perhaps several of them, can be conceived that is different and superior, which amounts to saying that we can distinguish with Duns Scotus several supernatural theologies, each of which corresponds to a supernatural knowledge of God.

The first of these distinctions is between theology "in itself" and theology "in us," that is to say, we distinguish between the knowledge God has of himself and the knowledge we have about him. Let us call "knowledge in itself" the knowledge of an object such that is available to an intellect proportioned to it. Let us call "knowledge in us" what our intellect can know about the same object. For example, a person incapable of understanding geometrical demonstrations might, nevertheless, believe their conclusions. For him, geometry could be *faith* not *science*, which does not keep geometry itself from being a science, because the object of geometry is of a kind that it engenders science in an understanding proportionate to the object.

The object (*objectum*) of a kind of knowledge is the real subject (*subjectum*) of that knowledge but apprehended as known. A knowable subject becomes an object thanks to the possession by an intellect of an

acquired knowledge (*habitus*), related to this object.[69] Just as the first subject of a science, that is to say the real thing, contains within itself all its predicates, so likewise the science's first object, that is to say the first subject *qua* known, contains all the immediate or mediate propositions that can be formulated about it. Therefore, it is of the essence of the first subject of a science to contain itself virtually all the truths of the science of which it is the object. It only contains them virtually, but fully (*primo*), that is to say, of itself and by itself alone, in such a way that, setting aside anything else, the knowledge the intellect has of this object is enough to include those truths. Lastly, let us observe that a subject or object that is first in this way is at the same time *adequate*, because it is the object that causes the science. If it contains the science totally, by itself alone and fully, it is the science's adequate cause. Consequently, *qua* first with a primacy thus understood, the first object is the adequate object.[70] Let us note, lastly, since we are dealing with this definite science: the theology includes two definite parts. One contains truths that relate to God's essence itself, that is necessary truths. The other contains truths relative to God's action outside himself (*ad extra*), which are contingent truths. "God is triune," "The Son is engendered by the Father," are necessary truths. "God creates," and "The Son was incarnated" are contingent truths. All these truths alike are theological. They are theological by equal right, because they do not depend on any natural knowledge. Necessary truths and contingent truths related to God thus make up the two parts of theology.[71]

It follows that the first and adequate subject of theology can only be God. This proposition is true of theology in itself and theology in us, of theology about the necessary and theology about the contingent, but it does not apply to all cases in exactly the same way.

The proposition is evident regarding theology in itself. To be first, an object must virtually contain all the truths included in the science of this object. God alone virtually contains all theological truths. As the absolutely first subject, he is not predicable of any other. He is the subject to which everything else is attributable, but he is not attributable to anything himself. Accordingly, he is

also the only cause of the truths related to himself that he himself can know. Furthermore, since theology "in itself" deals with the object of theology grasped by natural knowledge, its object can only be God. Indeed, God alone naturally knows God. Consequently, here we are certainly dealing with theology that deals with an object that is naturally knowable for the divine intellect alone, that is to say that is naturally known only by God, and as only God is such, this theology's object can only be God. In short, "the uncreated essence is naturally known to the uncreated intellect alone."[72] This amounts to saying that theology "in itself" is the science that God himself has naturally about God insofar as he is the first known object.

Such is the theology that Duns Scotus calls "divine"; it is nothing other than the knowledge God naturally has of God *theologia divina, theologia Dei*]. For God, knowing means knowing his essence, and since there is nothing that God is not, at the same time, it is to know everything knowable. Let us add that God does not know his essence first, and then everything else because of that knowledge. "God's theology" is not caused in the divine understanding by the essences, as if the quiddities as such were causing in God all the knowledge that forms his theology. God is actually the totality of his being, and virtually the totality of the possible, and because his essence grounds the possible, it suffices to cause the knowledge God has of the possible. From there comes this conclusion:

> God's theology bears on everything knowable, because the first object of his theology makes everything else be naturally known in his understanding. Accordingly, his knowledge attains his essence first, immediately known in his understanding. Secondly, he attains the quiddities, which enclose their proper truths. Then, thirdly, he knows the same truths virtually included in these quiddities. The relation of the second and third moment is not a relation of causality, as if the quiddity caused something in God's understanding. Their order is only the order of effects essentially ordered in relation to the same cause. In other words, God's essence naturally causes these quiddities that he knows, so to speak, before the truths that are related to them become known.[73]

It is not very easy to translate our theologian here. He speaks as he can, but his thought is nonetheless clear. The apprehension of everything knowable, as God apprehends it in his own essence, is global and simultaneous. Still, it involves a certain order. To use an example that belongs to Duns Scotus himself, let us suppose that the sun illuminates two objects that are spread out from it in space, the first of which is opaque. The illumination of the first will not cause the illumination of the second, and yet the sun will illuminate them according to a certain order, first the closest, then the furthest away. Between two effects of the same cause, there will be an order here that will not be the order of cause to effect.

Likewise, in divine knowledge, God's essence produces actual knowledge of other essences in God's understanding, in such a way that the truths that depend on their quiddities are naturally known to God's understanding after these essences in some manner. Still, these quiddities have no power to act upon the divine understanding nor consequently of becoming known by it, because it is infinite and they are finite, so that they are not the natural objects of such an understanding. "The infinite in no way is perfected by the finite." *Infinitum a finito nullo modo perficitur*. In this ideal genesis, which our analysis distinguishes as successive stages—three moments that are in fact simultaneous, there is first of all the divine essence, then all possible quiddities, and there would be no third moment, if the divine nature itself did not put the divine understanding in possession of truths included in these quiddities, because nothing other than the divine essence can cause any knowledge whatsoever in the divine understanding.

Let us conclude on this point. The only knowledge God has of all knowables is theological, because he only has it in virtue of the first theological object (scilicet, *haec essentia Dei*) actualizing his understanding. God's theology not only bears upon everything, but also is all the knowledge that God can have of everything. Absolutely speaking, it is all knowledge of everything, and of itself it includes no imperfection, because alone among all knowables, God's essence, which is his object, includes no limit. All other knowledge, by contrast, necessarily includes some limitation, because its

cause itself is limited.[74] That is to say that there is only one single "divine theology," God's, because in God alone an infinite object finds a naturally infinite understanding capable of receiving it. Outside of God there are only creatures and created understandings. Consequently, there can be other theologies, some more or less perfect than others, none of which will be God's theology."

The first and highest among these imperfect theologies is what Duns Scotus calls *theologia beatorum,* the theology of the blessed. Every theology that is not God's theology is distinguished from it, because a mean is interposed between the knowledge of God and God. The blessed see God. However, their intellects remain created intellects. The subject of their theology is exactly the same as that of divine theology, that is to say God himself, known, if we can say so, in the singularity of his essence or to speak in Duns Scotus's more technical but more exact knowledge, it is God "under the reason by which he is this essence."[75]

Unlike our intellects, the intellects of the blessed do not grasp God through a concept that is common to his essence and to others. They no longer know him starting from effects that are accidental to his essence, and this applies to theology of necessaries as well as to theology of contingents. It is even why the theology of the blessed, whether it is of necessaries or contingents, is a perfect science. Still, even the sight of God face to face supposes a spiritual light, the cause of this supernatural vision from which their theological science follows. For the vision of God face to face is not itself theology, but its source.[76] From this it follows that the theology of the blessed is not a science about everything knowable. Only God's theology is that. Surely, in principle, the blessed could know everything, since they see God's essence in which all knowables are included. But according to the interesting specification that Duns Scotus offers here, the number of knowables is finite for the blessed, *scibilia omnia non sunt infinita*. All the same, the divine essence remains a supernatural object for the intellects of the blessed. From there come two restrictions. First, the blessed only know those knowables in God's essence that God's will makes them know. Next, and so to speak

inversely, the blesseds' created intellects remain naturally subject to the action of created quiddities, so that if, on the one hand, they do not have total theological knowledge, on the other hand, they can have natural knowledge, and therefore, also nontheological knowledge. In the blessed, their theology is not a total or exclusive science.[77] The only total and exclusive science is God's theology.

Below these two theologies comes ours, *theologia nostra*, whose means is not even the beatific vision but revelation. It is still more limited than the previous theology. Indeed this third theology does not even extend to everything that we would be capable of knowing about God *pro statu isto*, if he revealed it to us like the theology of the blessed. It stops at the limit set by God, who has revealed it. In fact, our theology is limited to what God makes us know about himself in Scripture and to what can be derived from what he has revealed to us. From there comes our theology's two limits. First, it cannot make us know all that is knowable, because at present our intellect is restricted to drawing its knowledge from the sensible. According to the common law, that is, excepting certain extraordinary states like St. Paul's mystical rapture, revelation only directly involves propositions whose terms can be naturally known by an intellect like ours.[78] The second limit stems from the fact that, according to some authors, our theological knowledge of an object is incompatible with evident knowledge of the same object. We have recalled that for St. Thomas Aquinas, something naturally knowable can be revealed. Duns Scotus seems to think differently: "Our revealed theology cannot be about things naturally known to us" *de naturaliter nobis cognita non potest stare theologia nostra revelata*]. Here again, any inference would be premature, but, without being reckless, we can at least anticipate that the distinction between what is philosophical and what is theological will be very strict in Duns Scotus.[79] Whatever may be the case on his point, the fact remains that our theology only extends to all that is knowable insofar as all essences are related to the essence of God as such. Still, in this life this essence as such *haec essentia ut haec*] is not naturally accessible to us, which confirms our first conclusion about our impossibility of knowing naturally

that the created intellect as such is capable of intelligible intuition of God as such. How do we know the soul's proper end? To know a relation, its terms must be known. In this case, the term that escapes us is precisely the essence of God.[80]

If this is the case, the subject of *our* theology in principle can very well be the same as that of higher theologies. In fact, we can only grasp it under the highest concept accessible to us here below. Here, the human intellect's limitation opposes a barrier that is normally impassable *pro statu isto*. The real subject, which would be the object God, is an infinite intelligible essence. Is it not true that as an intelligible, it would only be known *ut haec essentia* by the mode of an intellectual intuition? Revelation itself does not give us this intuition. It speaks to us only in terms of designating concepts abstracted from the sensible, so that it could not give us an abstract concept taken in its singularity, a kind of knowledge whose very notion is contradictory. The *subject* of our theology thus remains God, *ut haec essentia*, whether we are dealing with the theology of contingents or of necessaries, but its object is not the essence of God taken in itself. In other words, while God's essence is the cause of the evidence for theology of the blessed, it is only revelation that causes the evidence of our theology. We have said that revelation speaks to human beings in the human language of the abstract concept. The first object of our theology, precisely *qua* ours, can only be the first of the abstractly known objects starting from which the first truths can be immediately known. This first thing is the concept of *infinite being*. In short, the *subject* of *our theology* is the same as that of *theology in itself*. But the *object of our theology*, even if we are dealing with theology of necessaries, is not this subject. It is only the concept of infinite being, which is the most perfect concept that we can have about this subject "since this is the most perfect concept that we can have about that which is the first subject in itself."[81]

This concept of infinite being is doubly imperfect. In itself, it does not contain our theology virtually, and still less does it contain it, as we know it. In other words, neither in itself nor in us can everything revelation makes us

know about God be deduced from the concept of infinite being.[82] Still, imperfect because it is only a concept, it is the most perfect of the concepts at our disposal, because it is the simplest. Many other concepts are properly applied only to God. Indeed, such are the concepts of all perfections taken absolutely and in the highest degree, like the concepts of supremely true being or supremely good being. However, concepts of this kind are formed out of two others, those of *being* and those of the determination *true* or *good*, which is attributed to being. The concept of *infinite being* is completely different, because infinity is not an attribute of the being about which we affirm it, it is an "intrinsic mode." The concept of *infinite being* is thus not one with that unity by accident that corresponds to concepts formed out of two others, one of which is subject and the other attribute. It is one by a subject's unity of itself, because it is simply the concept of this subject *in a certain degree of perfection*. The infinite being is not being plus infinity; it is being pure and simply taken in the modality of the infinite.

The notion of *intrinsic mode* plays an important role in Duns Scotus's doctrine. It always designates an intrinsic determination of essence, that is to say, what signifies solely the manner in which the object is what it is. If I say that a being is three, or that it is good, I attribute certain transcendental properties to the being, which, although they belong to it fully by virtue of what it is, are distinguished from it. Being, taken as being, is neither the true as such, nor the good as such. True and good are attributes of being, but infinity is not one of the attributes. Whether being is infinite or not, it is always a being, taken in different degrees of perfection. To use an example offered by Duns Scotus himself, the concept of *visible whiteness* has no unity of itself, because it is accidental to a white color to be visible, but the concept of *intense whiteness* is a simple concept, because the intensity of a color is only an intrinsic degree of this same color, that is to say a certain way of being white. The same goes for being. The concept of infinite being is simple, because it signifies only being in its highest degree of intensity.[83]

Therefore, infinity is not an attribute but the modality of a concept, and it is the concept of being thus modified that forms the object of our theology. This

affirmation is surely of the utmost importance, and yet, once more, we will take care not to deduce anything from it. The greatest

prudence is necessary when we are dealing with as keen a mind as Duns Scotus and with relations as complex as those of different sorts of knowledge that deal with the same subject, but do not all attain it, as the same kind of object and if they do attain it as the same kind of object, they do not attain it in the same way. Still, repeating is not deducing. Consequently, let us underline the fact that seems to be too often forgotten, that the *object* of our theology, that is to say the object of Duns Scotus's own theology, is God himself, *ens infinitum*. Certainly, this theology speaks of God himself, but it judges that the first object under which this subject becomes known to us, that is to say the object to which all the concepts by which it becomes known to us, can be reduced, is *infinite being*.

We will have to return to the possibility and meaning of the concept. For the moment, what interests us is its nature itself, and we must try to clarify that, although it is quite difficult to grasp. On the one hand, we cannot doubt that this concept is accessible to pure natural reason. Duns Scotus's disciples ordinarily understood it in this way.[84] For them, the most perfect concept of God that human beings can form by natural reason alone is the *conceptus entis infiniti*. Moreover, it is clear that if this concept were not accessible to natural reason, there would be no rational proofs of God's existence, at least for Duns Scotus, in whose eyes it is one and the same thing to prove the existence of the Infinite Being and to prove that God exists. That said, it remains true that the subject of our theology is God known under the notion of infinite being. Therefore, this concept must be at the same time accessible to natural reason and included in our theology as representing God under the most perfect aspect that is accessible to our reason.

Does it follow from this that human beings owe the concept of *infinite being* to revelation? To our knowledge, the expression *infinite being* does not appear in Scripture, and Duns Scotus never said that it was there, nor consequently that God revealed the corresponding idea to us. It could have been revealed to us, and the fact that the concept of *being* and *infinite*, taken

separately, are naturally known to us, does not prove by itself alone that the human intellect is capable of achieving their combination. Duns Scotus explicitly points out that revelation does not provide any concepts to human beings that, taken separately, might not be drawn from sense experience. We know *one* and *three* naturally, but we do not know that there is a *Trinity*.[85] However, the case of infinite being differs from the previous case, because unlike the concept of one God in three persons, the concept of infinite being is directly accessible to us. Therefore, we are dealing with a concept accessible to reason here. Nothing authorizes us to say it has been revealed; but it still falls under theology, because it applies fully to the Christian God and to him alone. In fact, Duns Scotus seems to consider that it expresses that which, in concepts accessible to natural reason, is most perfect and corresponds to God, certain of whose attributes, like absolute omnipotence, for example, are known to us by Christian revelation. If we are not mistaken about his intentions, Duns Scotus here uses the concepts of infinite being, not as a directly revealed concept, but as one of the most perfect intelligible concepts that corresponds to the Christian God.[86]

The same problem reappears in another guise, when we ask Duns Scotus what the object of philosophy is and especially that of metaphysics. This time the philosophers have the capacity to answer, and if their answers need not always be accepted unreservedly, it is good to understand them at least. Now, precisely on this point, their testimony turns out to be nearly unanimous: the proper object of metaphysics is “being *qua* being,” that is to say, what a *being* is and what the properties are that belong to it precisely insofar as it *is*. When this is set forth and admitted, everything remains to be said, because it is all too clear that metaphysics can only speak of being as we know it, and the point is to learn what we know about it or, perhaps even first of all, how we know it. On this key problem, whose presence is felt in all of Duns Scotus’s work, we unhappily find no definite conclusion. Let us at least try to assemble some precise indications on this subject.

The question of discovering how we know being depends on another question: what being do we know? Ordinarily, Duns Scotus takes his position

on this problem starting from the one Thomas Aquinas adopted, and here again he demonstrates such objectivity in reporting the position of his adversary that we could set it out equally well from the *Opus Oxoniense* or the *Summa Theologiae*. In fact, Duns Scotus's discussion certainly envisages in the first place two passages from the *Summa Theologiae* whose text he had in front of him when writing or dictating his own.

According to the Thomist thesis that Scotus opposes, the first object of the human intellect would be the quiddity of material things. The indication that proves the thesis rests on the general principle that there is a proportion between the faculty of knowledge and the knowable. There are three faculties of knowledge, and consequently, there must be three knowables that are proportioned to them. First, there are faculties of knowledge separated from matter in their being as in their operation; their object is the intelligible quiddity entirely separated from matter. Second, there are faculties of knowledge conjoined to matter in their being as in their operation, like the sensible faculties linked to organs; their object is the singular material object. Third, there are faculties conjoined to matter in their being but not in their operation; their corresponding object is the quiddity of the material being that, though it exists in matter, is not however known by this faculty of knowledge as being in singular matter.[87] In short, between the angelic intellect that has direct knowledge of the intelligible quiddity and human or animal sensibility that grasps the quiddity of material things in individual material things, there is interposed the human intellect that knows the quiddity of material objects abstracting from this thing itself and from its singularity.

Duns Scotus always opposes this doctrine, but it is important to specify the point to which he is opposed. Thomas Aquinas maintains that, since our intellect is tied to the body, it is impossible for it to exercise any act of intellectual knowledge without recurring to the phantasm.[88] Duns Scotus unhesitatingly agrees for every act of natural knowledge in our present state. There is no opposition between Thomas Aquinas and Scotus on this point. What Scotus disputes is that this de facto situation is also a de jure situation.

In other words, the fact that the quiddity abstracted from the sensible is the only naturally accessible object for the human intellect *pro statu isto* does not allow us to conclude that it is the intellect's first object.

Duns Scotus's argument on this point generally develops in two moments, that of the theologian and that of the philosopher. Let us consider the philosopher first.

The harmonious correspondence Thomas Aquinas establishes between knowing subjects and the objects of their knowledge has not moved Duns Scotus. On the contrary, he judges it to be worthless. "Also, that consistency, which is put forward for that opinion, is nothing." *Congruentia etiam illa, quae adducitur pro illa opinione, nulla est.* Indeed, the relation of a faculty of knowledge to its object is reduced to this: that the object can move this faculty and that the faculty can be moved by it. Accordingly, there is a relation of *motivum et mobile*, nothing else. Now, a relation of this kind in no way implies that there is resemblance between the degree of being of a knowing subject and that of the known object. Of course, a certain proportion between them is required, but the terms of this proportion can be dissimilar. They are even necessarily dissimilar, because one of them is act, the other potency. We have no reason to conclude from the mode of being of the knowing subject to that of its object. If similarity is required between the faculty of knowledge and its object, it is only what is established in the act of knowledge itself, because all knowledge consists precisely in this assimilation, but it does not extend to the knowing subject. It is a pure sophism to maintain the contrary. The eye that sees an object is assimilated to it by the sensible species. It does not follow that the sight's mode of being is similar to its object's mode of being. Even more evidently, the idea of a stone in the divine thought is a likeness of its object. However, the stone is material; its idea in God is immaterial. The correspondence Thomas Aquinas demands is thus unnecessary. In any case, it cannot oblige us to bind the intellect to the sensible object alone. At least it does not oblige us to bind the intellect to the object by reason of its nature as a faculty of knowledge,[89] although for reasons that we will have to determine, perhaps the intellect

cannot in fact exceed the limits of the sensible.

From the viewpoint of Duns Scotus's philosophy, the problem is of vital importance, because at stake is the very possibility of metaphysics, as he conceives it of course, that is to say, as the science of common being. Since Duns Scotus excludes the analogy of being in metaphysics, as we will see, he cannot admit that our intellect is incapable of rising from material being to being known under the formal perspective of immaterial being. Otherwise, we would not have metaphysics but only physics. In short, "Nothing more particular than being can be the first object of our intellect, or otherwise being taken in itself would not be known to us in any way."[90] The very possibility of metaphysical proofs—as they must be—of God's existence is at stake here, along with the object of metaphysics. The doctrine is rigorously coherent. We can only accept it or reject it as a whole.

But if our intellect can go beyond the sensible "by nature of the potency," *ex natura potentiae*, why is it limited in fact? We will find that out by examining the massive theological argument that resolves the question against Thomas Aquinas. It is important to examine it closely because it necessarily affects the notion that Duns Scotus himself formed of metaphysics, its limits, and the knowledge we have about its object.

The question of discovering what is the natural, first object of our intellect, is philosophical. It is one of the questions Plato and Aristotle had posed and each of them resolved it in his fashion. Moreover, it is not clear how the solution of a problem that deals with the natural relation of a natural faculty of knowledge to its natural object necessarily requires a supernatural revelation. Nonetheless, Duns Scotus first opposes a theological veto: "This cannot be held by a theologian," *istud non potest sustineri a theologo*. Indeed, theology teaches that the same intellect that currently only knows by abstraction starting from the sensible, later will naturally know the quiddity of immaterial substances. This clearly springs from what faith teaches regarding the mode of knowledge of the blessed souls. Now, without changing its nature, a faculty of knowledge cannot apprehend something that is not contained in its first object. Therefore, it is theologically untenable that

the quiddity of material things should be the intellect's first object.[91]

This answer is rich in implications, most of which are characteristic of Duns Scotus's theology. Indeed, the point is to make a beatific vision conceivable in which *the same intellect* that here below only knows the sensible naturally, will know the pure intelligibles in the future life. To get there, Duns Scotus must maintain that in principle, if not in fact, the human intellect does not have the sensible quiddity as its first object. If its first object were the sensible quiddity, either the nature of the human intellect would have to be changed in order for it to enjoy the beatific vision, or the beatific vision would have to be denied it. We have not yet found out what the natural first object of the human intellect is, but it is already certain that it cannot be either the quiddity of the sensible nor, *pro statue isto*, the quiddity of the universal and intelligible substance.[92]

The first theological criticism of philosophy, which we already noted in Duns Scotus's doctrine, takes that shape. Up to the point where we have followed this critique, it seems to be inspired by concern for the theological problem of the beatific vision, that is to say, for the Christian problem of salvation. Duns Scotus does not think that human beings could have discovered naturally that the beatific vision is their last end. We do not owe this knowledge to reason but to revelation. On the other hand, once our reason is informed by revelation that the beatific vision is our last end, it must conceive the human intellect in such a way that the beatific vision should be possible for it. Duns Scotus opposes Thomas Aquinas here in order to safeguard this possibility, and the fundamental error for which he reproaches Thomism on this point is precisely that of conceiving the human intellect in such a way that the beatific vision becomes inconceivable. For to say that God can raise the human intellect to the knowledge of purely intelligible substances is to say nothing. Evidently, the "light of glory" can do that, but if *the very essence* of the human intellect is to know the intelligibles by abstraction starting from the sensible, God himself could not raise it to the intuition of the intelligible. He could only replace it by another faculty of knowing.[93] This amounts to saying that for the human intellect as it is, the

beatific vision would effectively be impossible. That is why, while agreeing with Thomas Aquinas that, in fact, human beings have no knowledge that fails to be abstracted from the sensible, Duns Scotus firmly maintains that abstractive knowledge is not required by the very nature of the human intellect. It is not as if knowledge necessarily had to be abstractive *ex natura potentiae*, rather it is imposed on us solely de facto and in a way that can only be provisional. The human intellect is not condemned by its nature to the abstract mode of knowing that it possesses here below, but *propter statum alium*, that is to say—and the expression's very vagueness is fraught with meaning—by reason of a certain state.[94]

Let us try to clarify the reasons for this state and, first of all, what a *state* is. By this term Duns Scotus designates a stable continuity guaranteed by the laws of divine wisdom: "State seems to be simply a stable permanence confirmed by the laws of divine wisdom," *status non videtur esse nisi stabilis permanentia legibus divinae sapientiae firmata*. To say that our knowledge of being is determined by a certain state is therefore to say that God in his wisdom has submitted our intellectual knowledge to a stable law. That we should know being according to this law, therefore, not only stems from the nature of the human intellect, but also from conditions imposed by God to regulate the exercise of the intellect. The existence of such conditions and, consequently, the existence of the states they determine lets us understand that the first and adequate object of a faculty of knowledge taken in itself does not coincide with the first and adequate object of this faculty taken in a determined state. In the case of the intellect, it is correct to say that its first object is being taken under its most common reason, but it is no less exact to add that not everything that falls under being is suited to move our intellect naturally. In other words, and as we have already suggested, the word *natural* can designate two related yet distinct objects: first, what corresponds to a nature by reason of its very essence; next, what corresponds to a nature by reason of its "state." The second meaning never contradicts the first, because nothing can be in a state incompatible with its nature. (On the contrary, every state is the state of a nature.) But the state specifies the measure according to

which a given nature actualizes its virtualities de facto. From the standpoint of this second sense, what is natural in a certain state may not be natural in another. Clearly, the divine will could not impose conditions opposed to a faculty's essence on the faculty, but it can freely impose all those conditions that respect this essence, so that the naturalness defined by the state is added to the naturalness defined by the essence. Therefore, it is compatible with the nature of the blessed soul to have a direct intuition of intelligible reality, as it is "natural" in this life for human beings to grasp about being only what their intellect can abstract from the sensible. By assigning the intellect the quiddity of material things as its first object Thomas Aquinas has taken as the first object of this human faculty what is really only the object capable of acting upon it in its present "state."[95]

What is the reason for this state? This is a question of the greatest importance. Duns Scotus does not dodge question, but he conceives a string of possibilities that might answer it.

> The laws of divine wisdom have established that our intellect should only conceive those things whose species shine forth in the phantasm, and that whether as a punishment for original sin or because of the natural solidarity of the faculties of the soul when they operate, since we see the higher faculty occupy itself with the same thing as the lower faculty when the operations of both are perfect. In fact, things take place in such a way that whatever universal our intellect conceives, our imagination simultaneously represents it a singular. In any case this solidarity that exists in our present state in fact, does not stem from the nature of our intellect as intellect, not even insofar as it is in a body, since if the latter were the case, the same solidarity would bind it to the glorious body, which is false.[96]

This passage is remarkable in many ways. First, we see once more the theologian appropriate a problem that others would reserve to the philosopher. To tell the truth, this becomes inevitable, once the description of human knowledge is given as a *state* whose proximate cause escapes philosophical knowledge. It will be noted how far the theologian pushes his involvement here: even if the necessity of abstractive knowledge in us were

explained by a “natural harmony of the soul’s powers in operation,” *naturalis concordia potentiarum animae in operando*, the nature of our intellect as such would not require this natural solidarity, since, as theology teaches, in order to know, the resurrected human intellect will not depend on the glorious body to which it will be reunited. Here religious dogma acts in the fashion of a critical experiment that irrevocably settles a problem that others would consider essentially philosophical. However, let us observe, Scotus does not claim at all to speak as a philosopher here, but as a theologian. If the philosophers are wrong on this point, they have excuses, and we should not be surprised that philosophy expresses itself according to the lights that it possesses. By contrast, the theologian has no excuse if he is wrong on this point, unless we find an excuse in the seduction philosophers exercise upon him. The intellect’s independence in regard to the glorious body establishes beyond all possible question that the de facto cooperation that presently holds between this intellect and its body is not required by the intellect’s nature itself.[97]

But the most remarkable thing is not that. Faced with this problem, which he himself had provoked, Duns Scotus proposes two solutions that are not exactly comparable, or at least do not seem so to us, and that appear, however, to be constructed on the same level according to Scotus. There is no doubt that in his mind they are indeed of the same order. In whatever way we conceive it, the point remains to explain a *state*, and the explanation of a state cannot be found in the essence of beings placed in the state, but in the will of God that puts them there.

The first of the two solutions envisaged sees the subjection of the intellect to abstractive knowledge as a punishment imposed by God as a consequence of original sin: *propter poenam originalis peccati*. We therefore are dealing with a mere decree of punitive justice, *ex mera justitia punitiva*. This solution obviously supposes that, in Duns Scotus’s mind, the human intellect is capable of intellectual intuition and that perhaps it would still exercise it today, if God had not taken the power away as a consequence of Adam’s fall. The answer to the question posed is completely satisfactory, because what

Duns Scotus intends is precisely to safeguard the human intellect's aptitude for intellectual intuition without which human beings would be incapable of the beatific vision, in which their last end consists. Moreover, the solution is recommended to Scotus by the theological authority that is highest in his view, St. Augustine. The importance of this fact can hardly be exaggerated for the formation of Scotist theology. Though what remains of neo-Platonism in St. Augustine may be repressed in Duns Scotus, it retains some influence; just as it was limited by the influence of medieval Aristotelianism, it in turn limited that influence. From Plato to Plotinus and from Plotinus to St. Augustine, the idea is transmitted that the body prevents the human understanding from knowing, and that human sin is at the origin of this fact. Duns Scotus holds a different position, because he does not think that the body is necessarily an obstacle for the intellect, but he at least quotes St. Augustine to explain that the body has become an obstacle for the understanding in its present state.[98]

The second possible explanation of this "state" appeals purely and simply to God's will: *ex mera voluntate Dei*. In principle, which is to say by virtue of its nature, the human intellect could intuitively know purely intelligible beings. In fact, God willed that here below our intellect should be capable of abstractive knowledge, and that is why naturally (although not by reason of its nature as intellect, but by reason of the nature of its state) in this life the intellect can only know by cooperating with sensibility. Moreover, it is important to note that the two explanations are not incompatible. What original sin can explain is that after the fall, abstractive knowledge should be the only knowledge of which human beings still dispose. However, before the fall, human beings already disposed of this mode of knowledge. If human beings were not compelled as we are, they could already exercise abstractive knowledge, but even then, they would not exercise it by virtue of the nature of their intellect, because it is in the nature of an intellect to know directly without passing through the sensible. If there is a constant element in Duns Scotus's doctrine, it is the nature of the intellect that remains one and the same throughout the whole doctrine in all particular conditions and in all the

“states” through which it passes. A reader used to Thomas Aquinas may have the impression that the Scotist intellect continually changes nature, but the opposite is true, because the Scotist intellect never loses the naturalness of its essence, despite different naturalnesses that it owes to its successive states.

Of itself, our intellect has more or less the same object as angelic intelligence. Therefore, it is a faculty of intelligible intuition, and *essentially* it is only that. Before the fall, if human beings also disposed of abstractive knowledge, that could not be as a punishment for original sin that they had not committed, nor in virtue of an intrinsic requirement of their nature that, being the nature of an intellect, does not involve any inclination toward the sensible. Therefore, it could only be through God’s mere will that, having united this intellect to a body in order to create human beings, he willed that the body might contribute to human knowledge with a view to human perfections. If the natural solidarity of the soul’s powers continues to function, that is in consequence of the divine will that established it for human good before the fall. Accordingly, it is not a consequence of original sin. What is a consequence of original sin is that henceforth human beings can no longer know without recurring to their bodies. Through their fault, they are condemned to use only abstractive knowledge now. Still, let us observe that even while undergoing this limitation, the human intellect has not changed nature. It always remains this intellect, a little lower than the angels, whose normal act, if we may say so, would be intelligible intuition. Human beings first exercise this power in virtue of their nature alone, together with the faculty of knowing by abstraction starting from the sensible, which is simply compatible with their nature and was added to it by God’s will. Since original sin, tied up the first power, human beings can only exercise the second now, but the nature of their intellect remains the same, and this is precisely why the intellect again finds itself capable of intelligible intuition at the death of the body without its nature having undergone the slightest deterioration as it passes through these different states.

The two explanations that Duns Scotus offers about our present state are less alternatives than complementary. God willed the *naturalis concordia*

potentiarum animae at the creation of mankind, and it still remains an effect of God's will today. What the punishment for original sin adds is the present human incapacity for intellectual intuition. That the necessity of abstracting is accidental to the nature of the human intellect is a fact whose repercussions can be felt in many parts of the doctrine. Whether the issue is our knowledge of essences in general, of common being, or of the infinite being itself, Scotist abstraction always remains the work of an intellect whose normal mode of knowing would be intelligible intuition. The abstraction in which the Thomist intellect delights as its normal state is clearly a burden for the Scotist intellect, from which it constantly tends to liberate itself. If it cannot do so completely, Scotus at least refuses to make the burden heavier than it is. Even if it is granted that the intellect's object is no longer the intelligible essence, Scotus cannot be made to believe that the intellect's object is the quiddity of the sensible object. Its nature, nobility, and dignity as an intellect forbid it to be content with that.

Whether we accept this interpretation of the doctrine or not, the effect of the divine will was to establish its *concordia* between the intellect and sensibility that we observe in fact through introspection. As Duns Scotus says, it appears clearly when the operations of the two faculties are perfect, because they are perfect in all cases when their operations are cooperative. We only conceive well in thought what we imagine at the same time that we think it, just as inversely, we only perceive well what we conceive by the intellect at the same time that we perceive it with the senses. Therefore, Duns Scotus has retained both answers. Still, let us repeat, the object of the two solutions is not to resolve the same part of a problem for whose complete solution both are necessary. The recourse to original sin is inspired in Augustine, and its object is to explain that abstractive knowledge is the only knowledge we can use now. The recourse to God's simple will has the object of explaining that, though our intellect is naturally capable of intelligible intuition, it, however, recurs to abstraction. It seems that God first willed his recourse to abstraction in the interest of human beings themselves, so that they, formed out of soul and body, could have the advantage of using their bodies to know better. In

any case, the idea of the *concordia potentiarum animae*, which is not peculiar to Duns Scotus,[99] represents a state of fact that is not tied to the essence of our intellect *qua* intellect. This position serves Duns Scotus's principal intention perfectly: it saves the *essential* aptitude of the human intellect for intelligible intuitions, while permitting Scotus to posit abstractive knowledge as *natural* for human beings with a naturalness connected, if not to their essence, at least to their state. Why does the present natural state of knowing human beings result from the *pure* will God has of establishing this state or from his *pure* punitive justice? Sin can be this state's cause, without being its total cause.[100] In other words, our present mode of knowing can have been first willed by God in the interest of human beings but have become the means of punishment for human beings through their own fall.[101]

This problem is so important that we cannot leave it without having gotten as clear an answer as possible from Duns Scotus. The value of our present mode of knowledge is at stake. Indeed, the issue is nothing less than finding out whether the exclusively abstractive character of our knowledge of the intelligible is linked to the very essence of our intellect, or if it is an accidental consequence of original sin. According to whether we admit one or the other of these answers, metaphysics will appear as the science of being accessible to an intellect whose change of state does not keep it from still functioning according to its original nature, or else as the science of being accessible to an intellect that sin now renders incapable of functioning according to all the power of its original nature. In other words—and may we be excused for insisting on the point, but once again the present limits of philosophy are involved—the issue is to find out whether without original sin our intellectual knowledge would be what it has become today, knowledge of being acquired *exclusively* in an abstractive mode.

The *Opus Oxoniense*'s answers to this question led us to think that God originally willed, as suitable to human nature, the harmony of the powers of the soul, *concordantia potentiarum animae*, whose unbreakable rigor we experience in excess today. In fact, this solidarity is only a particular case of the union of soul and body. On several occasions Duns Scotus returned to

this idea that God willed the union of soul and body, not for the good of the body or that of the soul, but for the good of the human being. The Subtle Doctor makes his stand here no less firmly than the Angelic Doctor on a ground that is not Platonic but Christian. If we are not mistaken about his intention, this is precisely why he never eliminated the doctrine of the *concordia*. The mutual aid that intellect and sensibility still lend each other, even in the state of fallen nature in which we are, testifies that their solidarity is inscribed in human nature because nature was established in this way, *prout natura isto modo instituta est*. When Duns Scotus spoke of the *causa naturalis* of that solidarity, why did he still add that perhaps it is not *absolute naturalis*? It is because, if this solidarity is natural, the manner in which it operates after original sin is no longer natural. It no longer operates exclusively in benefit of human beings but also to their detriment. An authentic rebellion of sensibility against the intellect seems to have occurred, which now prevents the intellect from knowing without a phantasm and reduces the intellect to the abstractive mode of knowledge alone, which belongs to it today in this life. There we have its present state of infirmity, and to repeat with Augustine: what is the cause of this infirmity but iniquity?

If this is Duns Scotus's thinking, all knowledge accessible to a being that only the quiddity of natural things is now capable of moving is certainly a "fallen" knowledge in regard to itself. The metaphysics elaborated by such a knowing subject must also differ as profoundly from what the subject would in principle be capable of knowing as intellectual intuition itself differs from abstraction. This is how Scotism interpreted Duns Scotus.[102] Historians are reluctant to consider authentic the *Quaestiones de Anima* traditionally attributed to Duns Scotus. The early Scotists at least never hesitated to acknowledge his thinking there and, at least for the moment, the literary critics themselves seems to become favorable to their authenticity again. Let us wait for the judgment of the critics. Whatever the verdict turns out to be ultimately, we cannot help seeing in this composition the expression of doctrine so similar to that of Duns Scotus that it is practically identical to it. Like Duns Scotus, the author considers the solution of the problem to be

possible that makes original sin responsible for the purely abstractive mode of our intellectual knowledge in this present state of humanity. (Moreover, he does not pretend to have invented the solution.) To know without recurring to the phantasm is still not incompatible with the nature of the human intellect, since the soul separated from the body can do that. Nor is it incompatible with the union of the soul and body, since the intellect will be able to do so once reunited with its now glorious body. Finally, and above all, it is not even incompatible with the state of *homo viator*, since without original sin, human beings would have retained complete mastery of soul over body and intellect over senses, that is to say, they would have remained capable of knowing intellectually, with or without the phantasm as might have seemed good to them. Consequently, it is a punishment for sin that human beings must now pass through the phantasm. On this our author adds the suggestive remark:

> Knowing nothing of original sin and finding nature in such a state, Aristotle took his point of departure from the senses and believed that this use of the intellect was normal for us. This is why he affirmed unrestrictedly that intellectual knowledge requires the recourse to the phantasm.[103]

The last shaft aims at Aristotle, but if we think that Aristotle's only excuse here is his invincible ignorance of original sin, how much more cruelly would the shaft strike at Christian theologians who maintain the same theses without the same excuse! In any case, it remains absolutely certain that Duns Scotus himself, speaking in his own name, expressly indicated original sin as one of the possible causes of the exclusively abstractive mode of knowing that has now been imposed upon the human intellect.[104]In short, the one who knows the factual condition in which our philosophy is elaborated is not the philosopher but the theologian.

Such a position could not help having deep and broad repercussions on the very content of the first philosophy that it controls. We will have the opportunity to observe a certain number of the repercussions as they come up, but for now we can anticipate that this thesis will exercise its influence in two different ways. On the one hand, it will restrict the claims of metaphysics

taken in its present state, and on the other, by contrast, it will remind the intellect of the nobility of its true nature. Duns Scotus will never cease reminding natural reason of its present limits in order to forbid it to encroach upon the ground of faith and revelation. When he expresses himself in this sense, metaphysics is and remains for him the science of being as we know it *pro statu isto*, with the hypothetical burden that restricts our knowledge in consequence of original sin. In short it is a metaphysics that would even be ignorant of the state in which it is, were it not for revelation. On the other hand, he will never accept the limitations that some gratuitously and furthermore mistakenly, impose upon the intellect, because they take its present condition as its natural state. As limited as our metaphysics is, it is the work of an intellect, whose proper object, *qua* intellect, is no less extensive than the object of the angelic intellect. Even our fallen metaphysics retains a trace of this essential nobility and perfection, and if it forgets them, it is good to recall them to it. This metaphysical knowledge must be both kept in check and encouraged, and this dual necessity derives from the same source: our metaphysics, as we can conceive it here below, is the work of an intellect submitted to de facto limitations, about which, because it is naturally unaware of them, either it forgets their presence, or else it imagines them essential to its nature and hence that they are limitations in principle.

From here springs a general characteristic of Scotist thought that we will see progressively clarified, but which it is practically impossible to overlook from now on. Perhaps the best way of anticipating it in a vague form that is appropriate only at the point we have reached now is to resort to a comparison. So, to abbreviate, let us say that if Thomist metaphysics is the metaphysics of an intellect whose nature and functioning are unaltered by original sin, for Scotus, metaphysics is constrained by being the work of an intellect whose functioning has been profoundly altered by original sin, but whose original nature, always intact, is perceived in the manner in which it functions even though wounded. In other words, the abstraction with which the Scotist intellect has to be satisfied de facto, still remains the operation of an intellect that is naturally capable of intellectual intuition, and that fact is

felt so deeply in Duns Scotus's metaphysics that many of the differences that distinguish him from Thomas Aquinas seem to us to come from there. Behind Duns Scotus's human being is Augustine's, for whom "you made him a little less than the angels," *paulo minuisti eum ab angelis*, has adapted itself to a strong dose of Platonism and of that same residual Platonism that the Subtle Doctor so readily finds again in Avicenna. Obviously, even before the fall, Duns Scotus's human being was not an angel, but a human being composed of soul and body. Scotist metaphysics suffer nonetheless from being the work of an intellect deprived of aptitudes that it once partially shared with angels and whose latent presence it continues to feel, even when it can no longer exercise them.

What indeed is metaphysics? As first science, metaphysics ought to have the first knowable as its object: *prima scientia scibilis primi*.[105] The knowable is first, because, since it falls into the grasp of the intellect first, it is involved in all the intellect's other objects. With Avicenna, we have already recalled that this first object is being, and that is precisely why metaphysics, as the first science of the first knowable, is the science of being, as well as of all the properties that belong to being as such.[106] For the same reason, metaphysics appears as the science about what must be known and what is known before everything else, because if we do not know it, nothing can be known. In short, transcending all particular objects, metaphysics is concerned only with objects that are universally "common to all others, those things that Duns Scotus calls the *communissima*."[107] In itself, such a science ought to be able to define everything by its essence and demonstrate everything by its first essential causes, that is to say, the highest and most evident causes. In fact, we do not possess metaphysics in this way, nor does Aristotle teach it to us, and we would search his whole *Metaphysics* in vain for a single demonstration by the cause, that is to say, deduced *a priori* from an intelligible essence. Furthermore, we know why this is so. Our intellect's impotence forces us to work back toward the intelligible starting from the sensible, instead of returning down from the intelligible to the sensible, as it should.[108] Thus, the object of metaphysics, as our intellect allows us to know

it *pro statu isto*, is *ens commune* in the precise sense of this term that we will have to determine later.

Understood in this way, metaphysical knowledge is both last and first. It is last in the order of confused knowledge, which is the order of nominal definition. It is first in the order of distinct knowledge, which is that of real definition.

It is certain that the intellect does not begin by distinctly grasping the common concept of being taken in its total indeterminations. Knowledge begins with confused concepts, each of which represents one of the objects of experience to which we give names. These objects themselves are individuals, "singular" beings, whose sensible species acts upon hearing, sight, or touch. If their action on the sense is strong enough, their *species* immediately makes the intellect recognize it. Then a concept of the individual in question is produced in us, because the singular is knowable for us. But this concept remains confused, because we do not know the singular—*pro statu isto*—under its proper *ratio* of singular. What comes first in the order of acquisition of knowledge is, therefore, certainly the singular confusedly known.

With that we understand why, although Avicenna says that common being is what first falls within the grasp of the intellect, he also teaches that metaphysics, the science of being thus understood, comes last in the order of teaching.[109] Indeed, before reaching the distinct conception of common being, the principles and terms of previous sciences must have been conceived first confusedly, then distinctly. If it were otherwise, we would spontaneously begin by what is most common like *being* and *thing*, and other notions of this kind, to go back down from there toward the particular, and the teaching of the sciences would begin with metaphysics, which is exactly the opposite of what Avicenna says must be done and of what is done.

Besides, if we conceived first what is most common, the general pace of our knowledge would be quite different from what it is. We do not choose the order at will according to which we form our concepts. The intensity with which the sensation imposes a given object is what makes us conceive the

latter before a certain other.[110] It would be completely different if instead of going from the singular to the common, our intellect went from the common to the singular. Our concepts are natural effects determined by the cooperation of these two natural causes, the singular object and the intellect. This is why our first concepts are of singular objects, known in the order where sensation itself imposes them on us, and if such concepts contain this "common element" that will form the metaphysician's distinct knowledge, that is not what is given to us in the first place.

Things proceed in quite the opposite way in the actual knowledge of distinctly known concepts. What is first in the order of distinct knowledge is "the most common." Other concepts are arrayed as prior and posterior according to whether they are more or less close to being, the most common of the distinctly known concepts.

For a concept to be known distinctly everything included in the notion of its essence must be known. *Being* is included in the notion of everything that is, as an essential element. For whatever object there may be, there does not exist a single concept in whose notion the common concept of being is not included. That common concept itself can be conceived apart from anything else, but nothing else can be conceived without it. In other words, being is the object of an absolutely simple, distinct concept, and it is the only such concept. Accordingly, being is the first distinctly conceivable and distinctly known concept. Moreover, here, we find again the same confirmation by Avicenna's authority, because, if this philosophy teaches that one of the functions of metaphysics is to establish the principles of other sciences, it is precisely because the objects with which this science deals are the first that are distinctly known. The absolutely first knowledge in the order of distinction, metaphysics is also the last knowledge in the order of certainty and teaching, because metaphysics alone attains distinct knowledge of essences signified by terms whose confused knowledge suffices for other sciences. We can know all geometry without knowing what exactly *size* is, or even what a *solid* or a *line* is. To know metaphysics is to possess distinct knowledge of the object about which confused knowledge suffices for the

geometer, and in this sense, though last acquired, metaphysics is the first known.

From that, we see the general order that thought follows in acquiring knowledge. Knowledge begins neither with ignorance nor distinct knowledge, but with confusion, a sort of middle term between the two. Knowledge directs itself toward perfection from there, and this is why all distinct knowledge of a concept supposed confused knowledge of it. Whether the issue is actual direct knowledge of a concept's universality or distinct knowledge of the totality of an essence, what is confused always comes first.

A completely different viewpoint is that of habitual knowledge and virtual knowledge.[111] Then the issue is already acquired knowledge, habitually present to the intellect (like knowledge that we possess even in moments when we do not think about it), or knowledge virtually included in other knowledge. In such cases, the most common concepts precede others. The reason for that is the same as in the previous case: in going from the less perfect to the more perfect, the intellect starts from more common and less determined concepts to proceed from there, by degrees, as it were, to concepts that determine them or that they include. Here, the concept of *being* goes first, since we can only know anything as a particular determination of being or as included in the concept of being.[112]

A third and final point of view of the object of knowledge is from its perfection. What is most perfectly knowable in itself is not necessarily the most perfectly knowable for us. Thus, the sun is eminently visible of itself. However, we see it less easily than a candle, whose light, though less visible in itself than the sun's, is better proportioned to our sight. The same goes here: God is the most perfect and first knowable in himself. It is important to note that this is true even in the order of natural knowledge, and this is even why the Philosopher placed our natural happiness in the knowledge of God.[113] After God, the first knowables in perfection are the individuals of the most perfect species that there is in the universe; then those of the following species in order of perfection, and so on until we come to the individuals of the least perfect species. After the individuals come the species, then the

proximate genera that the intellect can abstract from the species, beginning again with the most proximate genus that the intellect can abstract from the most perfect species and descending back down toward those it can abstract from the least perfect species. But the issue there is only the priority of perfection that belongs to the knowable taken in itself. In relation to us, the same does not hold. We know more perfectly what is in itself less perfectly knowable, and that is why, as the science of being *qua* being, our metaphysics cannot elevate itself to an object of knowledge that is more perfect than common being conceived under the modal determinations of which it is susceptible.

This means that, although metaphysics as we know it is inferior to metaphysics in itself, metaphysics as we know it is much more inferior still to our theology, whose object is God known by us thanks to revelation, and it is infinitely more inferior to theology in itself, the science that God has about God. By settling the question this way, Duns Scotus takes part in a controversy well known to him and to his contemporaries. Averroes had conducted it against Avicenna regarding the object of theology. Nothing can sum it up better than the title of Duns Scotus's first question on metaphysics: "Is the subject of metaphysics being *qua* being, as Avicenna maintained, or is it God and the Intelligences as the Commentator Averroes maintained?"[114] Two metaphysics and in truth two irreconcilable conceptions of the universe[115] confront each other on this problem that appears to be purely academic. For Averroes, God and the separate substances, who are so many divinities, are part of the universe. The keystone of the arch of the cosmos, the First himself, is inserted in the arch, that is to say the cosmos. In such a universe, the divinity is the metaphysical cause of physical order. It is therefore natural that physical science should demonstrate the existence of God and of all other divine beings, who thus become the proper object of metaphysics. Conceived in this way, God is included in the world and the science of God, and metaphysics is necessarily the supreme science beyond which there is no other. Avicenna's universe is completely different. There, unlike the universe of Averroes, God is not the first of the Motor

Intelligences who move the universe, that is, one among them, although the first. Avicenna's God is transcendent and situated beyond the Motor Intelligences, the highest of which is God's first and only emanation. Necessarily, two different concepts of metaphysics and its object correspond to these two conceptions of the world. If God is the Motor Intelligence of the first sphere, as Averroes would have it, the proof of the existence of a first unmoved mover, as Aristotle grounds it in the analysis of movement in book VIII of his *Physics*, is a proof of God's existence. If, as Avicenna would have it, on the contrary, God transcends the Motor Intelligence of the first sphere, the proof of this Intelligence's existence is not a proof of God's existence. In Averroes, the proofs of God's existence are physical. In Avicenna, since the physics only attains the first unmoved mover, the proof of God's existence belongs to a posterior science, namely metaphysics.

Two important consequences follow, the first touching upon the object of metaphysics, the other concerning the object of theology. Averroes and Avicenna alike agree that no science can prove the existence of its own object. It receives the object from an immediately prior science that proves its existence. According to Averroes, physics proves God's existence. Metaphysics, the science that follows physics has God's nature for its object, and as there is no object above God, there is no science above metaphysics. Accordingly, it can be said indifferently either that metaphysics is theology or that theology is metaphysics. In any case, when the metaphysician stops speaking about God, nobody has anything to say after him. This is not the case in Avicenna's doctrine, where that philosopher of nature proves the existence of a simple Motor Intelligence, leaving the task of proving God's existence to the metaphysician. If metaphysics proves God's existence and to a certain degree can know God's nature insofar as God is being, it still leaves room for knowledge of God as God that comes under either revelation or even mysticism. So, while the Averroist proofs of God's existence are physical, Avicenna's proofs are metaphysical. While Averroes's metaphysics is a science of God beyond which there is no science, Avicenna's metaphysics is a science of being *qua* being,[116] beyond which there can be

room for other ways of knowing God.

It is necessary to choose between these two worlds. To know what the Subtle Doctor's choice is, it is enough to recall his cutting dictum: "Avicenna was right, and Averroes was wrong."[117] With this opinion Duns Scotus commits himself to the path of a metaphysics where being is conceived in such a way that attaining it is not immediately attaining God, but where we can attain God starting from being *qua* being. The Subtle Doctor has taken the option clearly aware of the consequences that such a philosophical commitment entails. Averroes's fundamental objection asks how would we prove God's existence other than as natural philosophers, that is to say, a posteriori and starting from his effects? Duns Scotus answered often, yes, we will prove God a posteriori and starting from his effects, but starting from his metaphysical effects, which are the metaphysical properties of being. Thus, God can be demonstrated as the necessary cause of the properties that belong to every being necessarily, just insofar as this being is.[118]

The impact of this discussion should not escape anyone who really cares about the spirit of Scotism. For a metaphysics thus conceived to be possible, being, which is its subject, must be posited by it as a common nature whose essence will be just that of being *qua* being, and that, furthermore, we can attribute properties or determinations to this nature, like one or many, prior or posterior, act or potency, that are not necessarily included in the essence of quiddity of being precisely *qua* being.[119] Let us go further. The decision that is to be taken here will have incalculable repercussions for philosophy and for several centuries of its history. Actual existence itself must be one of those properties. Evidently, to attribute any properties at all to an object, it is necessary to attribute being to it first; how are we going to attribute whatever it may be to nothing? Yet, as Duns Scotus himself says in an expression whose precision leaves nothing to be desired, the *being* from which the metaphysician starts and with which all metaphysics deals in fact, is not existence; it is essence. "If we presuppose that the subject *is*, we are not dealing with its actual existence, but with its quidditative existence, which consists in its notion not being false in itself. That *is* is what the

metaphysician demonstrates of the first being starting from his effects, because he demonstrates that there is a being for whom *first* is appropriate."[120] The being that the metaphysician's intellect necessarily conceives as first, is what the theologian will call God. There is a being that the intellect conceives necessarily as first, because there is being, and because if there were no being that was first, there would be nothing.

Known as the science of being and its properties, metaphysics thereby finds its proper subject defined by its proper status *qua* science defined by its proper object, and it finds its distinct place between physics, which it transcends, and theology, which transcends it.

The proper subject of metaphysics is *ens commune*, that is, being taken in its complete indetermination as predicable of everything that is. There is metaphysics because being is conceivable for us in this form.[121] Because metaphysics has for its object being as such, it is required, above and beyond physics, to establish the subject of theology. For physics has being in movement as its proper object. If then physics establishes, as it can, the essence of a first cause, it will necessarily stop at "the first cause of being in movement," which is precisely the First Mover of Aristotle and Averroes. Now, being first by reason of *mover* is a completely relative perfection. However high the perfection may be, it is still not the primacy in the order of being that alone is required for the perfect and infinity proper to God's essence.[122] Evidently, the First Mover is de facto the First Being. But God is only the First Mover because he created the world, which is contingent to his essence. We would never conclude at the First Being starting from the First Mover by way of necessary inference, because the First Being could be without the First Mover.[123] Also, as Duns Scotus says in one of those pithy phrases for which he has a knack, when the philosopher of nature proves that a certain mover is *first*, how would he do so, unless he were "more metaphysician for the predicate than naturalist for the subject"?[124] In short, metaphysics transcends physics as the science of being *qua* being transcends the science of being in movement. This is why, in transcending physics, it is metaphysics and not physics that must establish the existence of the First

Being.

On the other hand, this First Being whose existence metaphysics establishes is not its proper subject but the subject of theology.[125] For, if it pertains to theology to treat God as its proper subject, metaphysics can thereby be viewed as being denied the right to claim God as *its* subject. Metaphysics only attains God indirectly. Metaphysics is the highest natural science for human beings, because the subject it treats is the highest subject accessible to the human intellect here below, but this subject is not God, it is being. Two consequences follow: no natural human knowledge can speak of God known under any concept that is proper to him,[126] and metaphysics is a knowledge that tends toward the object of theology as its terminus. Such are the dignity and the limit of this highest natural knowledge, because this knowledge tends toward knowledge of God as toward its final cause, and as science of being *qua* being, this knowledge constitutes the highest knowledge of God naturally accessible to human beings, inasmuch as God is the First Being and therefore "a certain being."[127] There is misery because, incapable of passing beyond the limits of its proper object, metaphysics cannot conceive God *qua* God, but only *qua* being. If we can say so, metaphysics revolves around God.[128] By attempting to delimit God starting from the most common concept accessible to us here below, the first science attains the peak of natural human knowledge, but also its limit.[129] On this point, metaphysics is distinguished from theology, as the confused concept of first, necessary being is distinguished from the knowledge of necessary being, which is Christian theology's own God.

Such are the authentically Scotist relations of metaphysics to theology. They are clearly determined by the mutual delimitation of their respective objects. Let us add that these relations are perfectly straightforward in regard to their principles, although the interplay of their possible combinations necessarily injects a certain complexity. Still, they are nonetheless firm enough for them to remain intact, even in the de facto combinations in which they are involved. As the work of an intellect reduced to abstractive knowledge, our metaphysics is a science composed of demonstrations *quia*,

that is to say a posteriori, from effects to causes. We have no other science of being than this, and whatever the object of which it speaks it never speaks of it except neither as being nor in a different way from what has just been defined. Inversely, once we speak of God, we emerge from metaphysics to enter into theology. We are in theology, even if the metaphysician is the one who speaks about God, because he speaks then with the help of an a posteriori method that is not theology's, about an object that is not the metaphysician's; for the object of theology is God. All truths related to God, which in themselves are knowable *propter quid*, by the cause, consider the source, which deals with God taken in himself, under the very reason of divinity. Duns Scotus says explicitly that this is why all the truths that the metaphysician proves on the subject of God fall under theology absolutely speaking. They fall under theology *simpliciter*, because God is the object of theology, and, for example, once we establish the existence of a first, necessary, independent, or infinite being, since what we are discussing can only be God, we are talking about theology, even if we do it as metaphysicians.

Why do we do it as metaphysicians? Because, the kind of demonstrations that we give is not *propter quid*, by the cause, which is appropriate for theological science by virtue of the very nature of its subject. In their present state, human beings can only attain these conclusions relative to God by demonstrations *quia* that go from effects to cause. Someone who argues thus about the first, independent, necessary or even infinite being is therefore, a theologian who speak of theology while using the metaphysician's method. Thus, *absolutely* theological, because they deal with the object of theology, all the knowledge about God that we prove starting from his effects is *relatively* metaphysical, because it deals with its mode of demonstration from metaphysics.[130] Duns Scotus took the classical definition of theology, "discourse about God," s*ermo de Deo*, completely literally.

C Common being

The proper object of Scotist metaphysics is being, which would pose no special problem if the being with which we are dealing here were not being as Duns Scotus conceives it. Nobody is unaware that *univocity* constitutes the distinctive character by which we recognize this being among others. To understand the Scotist doctrine of being is to give a precise sense to the concept of univocity of being. In order to arrive at that, we propose to take a detour and to pass first through the Avicennist doctrine of the essence. The latter in any case, is much too necessary for the understanding of Scotism for the time devoted to studying it to be completely wasted.[131]

For Avicenna the essence is reality itself, and logic is the science that teaches us to formulate the essence correctly in order to make it be known as it is.[132] We meet essences in two states, in things or in the intellect, but they really offer three aspects, because the intellect itself can conceive them in two different ways, either in their pure essentiality, without relation to anything else, or with the characters of universality or singularity that logical predication confers on them.[133] To sum up, the essence can be considered in the thing itself, because "all that which is has an essence by which it is what it is."[134] The essence can be considered in the intellect with the determination of universality that thought attributes to it and which are accidental to it, since it is not itself either universal or singular. Lastly, it can be considered in itself, in which case all that can be said about it is that it is just what it is.

Under this last aspect, the essence deserves to hold our attention, not only because it is characteristic of Avicenna's ontology, but also because it has profoundly influenced Duns Scotus's ontology. Conceived in this way, the essence indeed presents itself as neutral in regard to all possible determination. We recognize it with this indication; it forms a distinct object of thought whose definition is self-sufficient and which can be conceived separately. Let us take a genus at random. *Animal* in itself is something that remains the same whether we are dealing with a sensible animal or with the animal intellectually known in the soul. Taken in itself, *animal* is neither universal nor singular. Indeed, if it were universal in itself, in such a way that animality were universal as animality, no animal could be singular, and every

animal would be universal. If, on the contrary, *animal* were singular *qua* animal, it would be impossible for there to be more than one singular, namely this same singular to which animal belongs in principle, and it would be impossible for another singular to be animal. So *animal* in itself is something that thought conceives as animal, and insofar as it is known as being animal, it is nothing other than animal (*non est nisi animal tantum*). But, if beyond that, it is conceived as being universal or singular, or some other thing, we then conceive something else beyond that same *being animal*, something that, as an accident, is adventitious to animality.[135]

Avicenna did not tire of going back over that notion of essence conceived as indifferent in itself to the logical determinations of thought. The essence of the horse taken in itself is "equinity" and nothing else: *ipsa equinitas non est aliquid nisi equinitas tantum*.[136] Roughly, we can say that this tripartite division of states of the Avicennist essence prefigures the three Scotist states of being: the essence in the real singular constitutes its physical state; the essence conceived by thought as universal or singular constitutes its logical state; the essence taken in itself and without any other determination constitutes its metaphysical state. If that is correct, we can foresee hereafter, at least as a working hypothesis, that the being that Duns Scotus makes the object of his metaphysics, although perhaps it is not exactly an essence, is nevertheless known by the intellect as if it were one: *being* taken as such without any determination.

Let us forget this hypothesis to approach the problem from another angle, that of the notion of *univocity*.[137] No part of Scotist doctrine has been more studied. A large number of these studies set out less to expound the doctrine for its own sake than to attack or defend it. Let us, therefore, try to grasp it as it is. The notion of *synonym* is at the origin of the concept of *univocal*. As Aristotle defines it at the beginning of the *Categories*,[138] the synonym is not a word but a thing. Things are synonyms when they have the same name taken in the same sense. Thus, all *animals* are synonyms, and even all *human beings* or all *oxen*, because the name is applied uniformly within each of these classes, with the same meaning that emerges from its definition. For the

class to be univocal in the Aristotelian sense of the term, it would be necessary that everything that bears the name of being should be in the same sense and in virtue of the same definition. In other words, just as an *animal* is not distinguished in any way from another *animal*, at least in as much as both belong to the genus *animal*, or just as a *human being* taken as human differs in no way from another individual of the same species, likewise a being must not differ in anything from another being, precisely insofar as both have the right to this name.

It is well known that Duns Scotus taught the univocity of being, and we also know how many controversies this doctrine has provoked. Here again, Avicenna can be of service. Almost all these controversies seem to presuppose that the being in question is Aristotle's being. We ask ourselves first of all which philosophical species of being we are dealing with. To cite only one famous example, Thomists and Scotists engage in endless dialectical sparring matches about the univocity of being, without pondering, at least most of the time, that the being they are talking about is not the same, it may therefore be that one being is analogous and the other univocal, because one is Aristotle's being elaborated by Thomas Aquinas and the other Avicenna's. We would like to attempt another hypothesis here. Let us suppose that Duns Scotus conceived the being about which he spoke as one of those essences about which Avicenna says that, taken in themselves, they only are what they are.[139] If this is the case, being taken precisely as being will not be either singular or universal, finite or infinite, first or second, perfect or imperfect. In short, it will not possess any of the determinations that are *accidental* to its essence and that define it as this or that being. Will this being that is nothing other than being be very similar to Duns Scotus's univocal being? *A priori* nothing seems more plausible, at least if we admit, allowing a reservation about verification, that in Duns Scotus as in Avicenna the quiddity is the peculiar reality with which metaphysics deals.[140] Duns Scotus does not dispute at all that the being of the essence involved in different singulars is and can only be analogous. In other words, Scotist univocity of being does not contradict Thomist analogy of being. As

Aristotle, Averroes, and Thomas Aquinas conceive it, being is indeed analogous, and it will remain so for Duns Scotus himself, at least each time that this being is also the being about which the natural philosopher speaks. The real problem for Scotus will be knowing whether beyond its physical state of analogy, being does not involve a metaphysical state of *univocity*, which would precisely be its state of *being qua being*, that state in which, to speak the language of Averroes, we can say of *ens* what the Arab philosopher said of *equinitas*: "Being itself is nothing but being," *ipsum ens non est aliquid nisi ens tantum*. There, it seems, is how the problem is posed in Duns Scotus. It is posed in a terrain that is no longer that of Aristotle or Thomas Aquinas. For, to reach that terrain, it is first necessary to escape the dilemma that Aristotelianism imposes between the singular and the universal, the *first* and the *second*. It is necessary to escape simultaneously from having to choose between the analogous and the univocal, which can only be done by obtaining a concept of being that in same fashion is metaphysically free from all determinations.[141]

Let us first recall the occasion on which Duns Scotus takes up the problem in the longest passage he devoted to it. As a theologian commenting on Peter Lombard, Scotus asks whether God exists. However, the object of *our* theology is not directly God known in his deity itself, but God known under the most perfect concept of him that is accessible to us here below, namely the concept of *infinite being*. From there comes the peculiarly Scotist formulation of the problem of God's existence: "Whether among beings there is something existing and infinite in act?"[142] The point is to find out whether there exists already among beings one that is actually infinite. To this, Scotus immediately adds a second question: is the existence of an infinite, that is God, known of itself? His general position on this point rests on two quotations, one from Scripture (Ps. 12:11), "The fool says in his heart there is no God," which the fool could not say if the opposite were evident. The other quotation is from Avicenna, "The existence of God is known neither of itself, nor is it such that we must despair of knowing it."[143] We will look for how God's existence can be established later. The problem that ought to receive

our attention is what Duns Scotus himself will pose immediately after proving the existence of an infinite being: is God knowable for us, how, and under what conditions? By responding to these questions Scotus is led to define his peculiar concept of being, which deserves to remain linked to his name in the history of philosophy.

Every philosophical element integrated into a theological problem raises the same difficulty for historians: which of these two disciplines conditions the other? The strongest temptation is normally to attribute preponderant influence to theology. But the more we reflect, the less we yield to the temptation, because, if it is true that a theologian worthy of the name is always theologian first of all, we cannot help acknowledging at the same time that if there are different Scholasticisms, it is in great measure because the authors used different philosophical techniques. That is the case here. To attain its object, which is *infinite being*, our theology must dispose of two philosophical concepts, that of the infinite and that of being, and since being is the object of metaphysics, everything proceeds as if our theology presupposed a particular metaphysics. We must not forget, any more than Duns Scotus did, that if theology alone has God as its object, it must at least use a metaphysical method to establish the existence of a first, necessary, independent, and even infinite being. Therefore we need two things, and we need them with a similar necessity: a metaphysics of being that is oriented toward the object of theology and a theology that takes over or annexes the metaphysics of being. Scholastic metaphysics and theology, precisely *qua* Scholastic, are both distinct and complementary.

To justify his own conception of being, Duns Scotus will sometimes invoke philosophical reasons, at least one of which is sufficient and decisive by itself. We have already encountered it, but now is the moment to recall it. Being, our intellect's first object, must be something more than the quiddity of material things, not only because if it were that, the theologian would have to confess that the beatific vision is impossible, but also because in such a case, the philosopher would have physics at his disposition, but not metaphysics. The proper object that the natural philosopher studies is

certainly the *quidditas rei materialis*, but to make it the metaphysician's proper object as well would be to admit that metaphysics has no proper object. Evidently, we could escape this predicament with some artifice such as recurring to a metaphysics of analogy, but it would then become necessary to accept all the consequences that flow from it. The first of these consequences is that metaphysics deals with an object that the human intellect is incapable of attaining. From that consequence would come incurable metaphysical agnosticism, since this science teaches at the same time that it deals with *being qua being* and that since the only being accessible to our intellect is sensible being, metaphysics never attains the First in itself but must be content with speaking of it by analogy to the second. Furthermore, that is why, after such a metaphysics tackles purely intelligible being, it takes refuge in what is called *negative knowledge*, as if to say that what a thing is not might confer any knowledge of what it is. Duns Scotus always stood resolutely against such an attitude.[144] In Scotus, philosopher and theologian combine here because, if metaphysics is the science of being, the philosopher will have no metaphysics unless he has a legitimate concept of being as being; and, if the theology that we can attain is the science of infinite being, then the theologian will have no theology, if there is not also a metaphysics of being. We must know being to be able to know God.

Do we know it? Yes, without doubt, but with reservations that must be specified. Let us first establish the fact, subject to formulating the reservations later.

For Duns Scotus to establish it is to observe it. There is a concept of being, but how do we know we possess it? Using a method that is inspired directly in Avicenna and that strangely foreshadows the method Descartes will use later, Duns Scotus proposes this general rule to assure the existence of any distinct concept: any concept is distinct from any other concept, if we can be certain of the first without being certain of the other.[145] What is not immediately included in the certainty that we have of a concept's content does not belong to this concept. Since the concept attains the essence directly

here, let us add that what is not included in the concept that we have of a being does not belong to its essence.

To guarantee that we have a concept of being itself, it is enough to apply this rule to it. We have such a concept if, in fact, it is possible for us to conceive *being* without the addition of any determination whatever. We can do so. "We experience in ourselves that we can conceive being without conceiving it as a being in itself or a being in another."[146] This subjective experience, moreover, is coupled with an objective experience: there is a science of being *qua* being, which is metaphysics: Aristotle himself acknowledged it.[147] How would it exist, if we did not conceive being *qua* being independently of any determination?

How do we conceive it? When Duns Scotus sets out his response to this question, he argues as if what is true of essences were true of being itself.[148] Taken as such, that is to say as what falls first within the grasp of the intellect, being is prior to any conceivable determination. It is therefore also what is most common. Indeed

> the first things to be known are the most common, because what is most common is always known first, and we cannot go to the infinite in intelligibles. What is absolutely the first intelligible is therefore also what is most common. Nothing is such except being, because none of the ten genera of being is absolutely the most common, since none of them is predicable of another genus (quantity is not predicable of quality, etc.). A common concept of being is, therefore, possible.

This is precisely what we have. Being is the intellect's first object, because the most common and even the only absolutely common to all is that by which and in which we know all the rest.[149] Such is *being qua being* in metaphysics, the first science, because it is the science of the first knowable. What is proper to being thus conceived is that it is *unius rationis*,[150] which Avicenna had said by affirming in his *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapters 2 and 6, that being is said in a single sense of all that it is said: *ens dicitur per unam rationem de omnibus de quibus dicitur*.[151] Duns Scotus in turn repeats this

under Avicenna's authority, by positing metaphysical being as a concept that is one, first, and most common of all (*communissimum*), because there is only one of them that is more common than the categories themselves, and it is it.[152]

The idea of *common being*, supported by the authority of Avicenna, is fundamental in Duns Scotus's doctrine, so that it is important to measure its scope and limits. The best way of doing both is to specify the character of *first* object of the human intellect, which has just been attributed to this idea.

The *first* object of a cognitive faculty is thereby its proper object, and when this proper object is taken in its total indetermination, without any restrictive condition, it is its adequate object.[153] In the case at issue, if being is the first object of the human intellect, its intellect must naturally be capable of knowing everything that *is*, at least insofar as it is. For such an object to exist it still must be one, that is, it must be just *the same object* that the intellect conceives in whatever being that it is. To say that the intellect always conceives the same object when thinking about being is to say that the existence of a first, proper, and adequate object of the intellect requires that our knowledge of being should be *univocal*. It remains to be seen in what sense and in what measure it is univocal.

We call *univocal* a concept that is sufficiently one for it to be contradictory to affirm and deny it of the same thing, or again sufficiently one, if we take it as the middle term of a syllogism, for the two other terms to be connected without sophistical equivocation.[154] In short, a term is univocal when it really means the same thing in all the usages made of it. How far does the univocity of being extend?

It extends to absolutely everything that is, in whatever sense being can be attributed to it, but not to everything in the same way. All that is intelligible includes being, but it can include being in two different ways, either directly, by virtue of *the primacy of community* of being, or indirectly by virtue of the *primacy of virtuality* of being. This amounts to saying that being is the first not only in relation to everything to which it is common, but also to what it implies. It is common to everything that is in whatever degree and whatever

sense that it is, insofar as that degree or sense is precisely of being. Such are individuals, species, and genera. When we attribute being to them, we attribute it *in quid*, that is, as belonging to their essence. On the other hand, there are denominations of being that taken in themselves are not, but qualify it in the sense that what is implies necessarily one or the other of them. Thus, *act* and *potency* are not beings but every being is in act or in potency. Determination of this kind includes both ultimate differences of being like those we have just designated (*differentiae ultimae*) and its ultimate properties (*propriae passones entis*) that, again, we call *transcendentals*, like the good, the true, or the beautiful. Being is univocal to every intelligible in one of these two ways, but it is only univocal with a univocity of community to all that of which it is said *in quid*, as designating an essence that is. As for the ultimate differences and transcendentals, which determine the essence of being by qualifying it, it is only univocal to them by a primacy of virtuality, because it implies them, although they themselves taken precisely as such *are* not.[155]

Being is not univocally predicable of its ultimate differences because, if it were, they could not be its *differences*. That is evident. Being *qua* being could not serve to differentiate being *qua* being. If the ultimate differences of being were themselves essentially being, it would be necessary to add further determinations to them, which, since they were not themselves being, might serve to differentiate it. Unless we regress infinitely this way, which would amount to denying any ultimate determination and consequently to forbidding ourselves to predicate anything at all of it, it must be admitted that there is something intelligible that is not directly being but its qualification or its determination.

This is what Duns Scotus expresses by pointing out that to be univocal with being, the differences would have to be at the same time different from being and identical to it. We would thus have *different identical beings*, which is absurd.[156] Moreover, supposing that we admit this absurdity, it would lead to our no longer being able to say anything about being except that it is being. To escape this total indetermination, a concept must be used that is not

simple like being but composed. Such a concept will be formed out of two concepts. For this concept to be nonetheless endowed with unity itself, it is necessary that the union of two concepts of which it is formed would be the union of two elements, one of which stands to the other in the relation of potency to act. In other words, one of the two concepts in question will have to play the role of determinable and the other of determinant. The concept that is only determinable here is precisely that of being, which, by virtue of its universal commonality, includes no determination of itself. Being corresponds to absolute potentiality in the order of concept. For this pure determination to cease to be pure determination, it must necessarily be composed by pure determinants that are immediately acts, as it is immediately potency. Thus, in the order of concepts, every concept that is not absolutely simple [*simpliciter simplex*] but is still a per se [that is to say, not *per accidens*]

> must be resolved into a determinable concept and a determinant concept. This resolution must stop at absolutely simple concepts, namely a concept that is solely determinable and includes nothing determinant and a concept that is solely determinant and includes no determinable concept. The solely determinable concept is the concept of being, and the solely determinant concept is that of its last difference. These two concepts will be immediately distinct [*primo diversi*], so that one includes nothing of the other.[157]

In short, as Duns Scotus puts it perfectly: no absolutely ultimate difference includes being quidditatively, since it is absolutely simple."[158] Thanks to this first reservation about the understanding of univocity, the metaphysician can obtain concepts of being that are simple, although not absolutely simple, and still distinct.

Let us pose the same question in regard to the transcendental properties of being.[159] Every time we want to define one of them, for example, the one or the true, we are obliged to add being to formulate the definition. If being is then added to the transcendentals, it follows that it is not included

immediately and of itself in this transcendental's essence or quiddity. The one is *one being*, that is to say, being itself plus something else that is precisely unity. Moreover, if *one* or *true* essentially include being, we ought to meet them again, as necessarily included in one of the essential divisions of being. Being is divided insofar as we are dealing with what is essentially (*quidditative*) included in uncreated being and created being. Yet, this transcendental, the *true*, does not of itself belong to uncreated being, because there is the created being, which is true. Nor does it belong of itself and by its essence to the created being, because, if it were so, it would be one of the ten genera of being, which it is not. Of itself, it is not even the specific difference in any genus of created being because, if it were so, it would be of itself the limitative determination of being and could no longer be applied to infinite being. Nothing is more false than this last conclusion, because all transcendentals by the very fact that they express pure and simple perfections, not only correspond to God, but also correspond to him in the highest degree.[160]

This dual restriction is of great importance to interpret Scotist metaphysics of being correctly. Indeed it follows from the restriction that the *commonality* to which being owes its *univocal* character is applied to every essence whatsoever, but not directly to its determinations. If we seek a concept designating a first object of our intellect that is quidditatively common to every intelligible, there is not one, because nothing is the intellect's first object in this sense.[161] Consequently, metaphysics must be satisfied with less if it wants to safeguard the existence of the intellect's first object *in some manner*,[162] and, it absolutely must do so, because its very existence is at stake.[163] If there is no first knowledge, there is no first science. In the absence of an intellectual intuition of infinite being, which we lack, and in which furthermore we would only know everything else as *virtually* contained, we must either renounce positing first object or else posit it in its role of *common* object and only as such.[164]

We can at least affirm that as such, being is really first, because it belongs to the essence of everything that is in whatever sense it is. Therefore, it is

essentially or, what amounts to the same thing, quidditatively contained, that is to say that we can predicate it *in quid*, because indeed, it is essentially a being. The connotation holds for every finite being and for all that belongs to it as a constitutive part: the individual, the species, and even the genus are being, because there is always a sense in which it is true to say that it is. The same holds, as we will soon see, regarding uncreated being, because if it is, it is being. Such are the *prima intelligibilia*: genera, species, individuals, with the essential parts of all beings and God. As for the ultimate differences, like act or potency, caused or uncaused, contingent or necessary, for example, they are not essentially included in common being, but they are all essentially included in certain of these beings: *necessary* in the uncreated being, *caused* in the created being. Therefore, those differences are said *essentially*. There remain the transcendentals, like *one* or *true*. If they are not predicted *essentially* or quidditatively of anything and if they are not themselves being, they are properties of being (*passiones entis*) and, in this capacity, virtually included under being. So, Duns Scotus observes, "that for which being is not quidditatively univocal is included in that for which being is quidditatively univocal."[165] In short, if we take being in its absolute commonality, it is said in the same sense of the essence of every being. As for the ultimate differences and transcendentals that define being, they are not directly included in its univocity, but the first are always essentially included and the second virtually included in a being that itself comes under univocity.

If the doctrine of *communitas entis in quid* only holds for the realm of finite being, it would doubtless have only incidental importance; at most it would be a curiosity in the history of medieval philosophy. However, we see that it extends to divine being itself, and that it cannot do so without committing theology to a path that several thinkers have hesitated to follow. Duns Scotus himself only embarked upon it clearly aware of the universal aspect of his move,[166] but we cannot doubt that he was decided to do so.[167]

To prove that univocity of being extends even to uncreated being here, as in the case of all concepts, is to prove that there is such a concept and, thereby, to prove, that is, to make it be seen. Let us recall that a concept exists when it

can be conceived, starting from another, and such a concept only includes that about which the intellect is certain in conceiving it, while it remains ignorant or uncertain of the rest. A subject that is distinctly conceivable without a predicate does not include this predicate, and such a predicate thus does not belong to the concept of such a subject. Now, the human intellect in its present condition can conceive being without conceiving it as finite or infinite, as created or uncreated. Therefore, the concept of being is distinct from the latter concepts. No doubt, the concept of being is included in one and the other, but neither the one nor the other is included in it. By itself, it is neither one nor the other, *et illa neutra ex se,* or as we would say, it is neutral in their regard. In short it is univocal.[168]

An impersonal and objective experience can come to the aid of personal subjective experience here. Duns Scotus excels at using this proof by philosophers, from which modern philosophy is far from taking full advantage. In fact, Scotus observes, certain philosophers admitted that the first principle of things is fire, others water, but all were certain that at least it was a being. Yet, they could not be certain at the same time that this being was created or uncreated, first or not. They could not be certain that it is the first, because neither water nor fire are the First Being. That is false and, as false, it cannot be the object of knowledge and still less of certainty. Nor can they be any more certain that fire or water is not the First Being, because if they had been, the philosophers would have maintained the opposite. So, out of this philosophical disagreement, it develops that we can be certain that the First Being is being without thereby having any certainty regarding the nature of the being in question.[169] Therefore, there exists a concept of being as such that, by reason of its commonality to all that exists, holds for uncreated beings as well as for the rest.

The second argument that justifies the extension of univocity to divine being is of the utmost historical importance, because it introduces us to the inner dialogue Duns Scotus maintains with Thomas Aquinas. Indeed, the objection he puts to himself amounts to asking why posit the concept of *being* as univocal to the created and uncreated since it would be enough to posit it

as analogous.

What allows philosophical dialogues to be prolonged, with each party remaining satisfied with itself but surprised by the adversary's ostentation, is that the interlocutors do not speak the same language. The Thomist doctrine of analogy is before all else a doctrine of the *judgment* of analogy. Indeed, it is thanks to the judgment of proportion that, without altering the concept's nature, we can make use of the concept whether equivocally or analogically or univocally. In such a noetics, where the concept remains inseparable from the sense experience from which the human intellect abstracts it, there is no hope that any manipulation might make it *represent* intelligible being. The Thomist use of such concepts in judgment does not envisage in any way producing an analogy that would be a *resemblance* of image to object. We never think without an image, even when we think what cannot have an image, and that is why the judgment of analogy seeks to posit, starting from the sensible that is representable, corresponding relations between intelligibles that are not representable. Duns Scotus thinks of an analogy that is much more an analogy of *concept*. On the level of the concept and the representation, analogy merges with resemblance. The point is no longer finding out whether two terms play an analogous role in a judgment of proportion, but whether the concept designated by a term is or is not the same as the concept designated by the other term. In a doctrine where knowledge of being necessarily includes the relation of an essence to an existing individual, since every existing individual is by definition *an other*, the real being is always known as analogous. But in a doctrine where being is defined by the concept, being is necessarily univocal within the limits of this concept since, otherwise, there would be no concept. That is why when Duns Scotus encounters Thomas's analogy, he cannot exactly be said to refute it. Rather we might say that he cannot believe it. If we say that the concept of a being is *analogous* to the concept of another being, because these two concepts are indeed quite close, will it not be necessary to say that *no* concept is univocal? For, if we say that *just one* concept of human exists, which is the same for Socrates and for Plato, that will be denied. The answer will be that there are

two, but that they have an air of only being one, because of their great resemblance.[170] Evidently, it would be a waste of Scotus's time to want to reconcile the two doctrines and just as much to refute one through the other. The origin of their divergence is prior to the conflict that puts them at odds. Surely, Duns Scotus would have been very surprised if he were told that Thomist analogy is not reduced to formal resemblance, that two concepts that resemble each other might in fact only be analogous, and that analogy can be found, by contrast, between concepts that designate infinitely different objects, as is the case when we extend the notion of being to God.

A misunderstanding well comprehended can be a source of clarity, a least in history, and this one lets us assign their full meaning to certain arguments Duns Scotus uses against Thomas Aquinas's position. They are so intimately tied to his own doctrine that they clarify it, although they rather cloud the doctrine of his adversary. What Duns Scotus plans to prove is indeed that a concept of being, which would only be *analogous* to the one we have of being, is an impossible concept. To establish that, Scotus makes us see that a concept of being that would only be analogous to ours would be *a different concept*. Now, we cannot form a different concept of being, and if we have only one, it is necessarily univocal. Nothing is more certain than that we cannot form a different concept of being. It is a fact, and St Thomas recalls unceasingly that all our concepts are abstracted by the agent intellect from the phantasm or from the object known in the phantasm. Our concept of being is not outside this law, because it is such and such, and we do not have a different one of it. With that we already draw the conclusion. If we can only grasp being in the concept drawn from the sensible, how could we form *a different concept* of being analogous to the first, which would be applied to God's being.[171] Patently, our two philosophers are not talking about the same thing. Thomas Aquinas speaks here to analogous uses of one and the same concept that he himself does not cease to repeat is the only one we possess of being, as long as our soul is united to its body, while Duns Scotus wants to make him form a second concept before declaring it *analogous* to the first one.

The third and last argument in favor of univocity could be omitted as expressing rather a theologian's concern, if it did not in some measure involve the possibility of all of natural theology. If we refuse to extend the concept of being to God univocally, Duns Scotus observes, we will have to similarly refuse to apply any of our concepts to him, because they are all formed in the same way.

> Every metaphysical investigation about God proceeds in the following manner: we consider something's formal reasons. We take away from this formal reason the imperfection it would have in creatures. We posit this formal reason separately by attributing to it the absolutely highest perfection. And we attribute it to God under this form.

This is what the metaphysician does when attributing wisdom, intelligence, or will to God. The metaphysician first considers each of them in itself and for itself, which suffices to purify them of the imperfections they have in creatures, since taken in themselves they do not include imperfection or limits formally. We thus obtain a wisdom, and intelligence, and will, each of which is only that very thing that it is and nothing else. It remains only to attribute it to God, by taking it to the highest degree of perfection. "Every investigation about God, therefore, supposes that the intellect has therein the same univocal concept that it draws from creatures." If we challenge Scotus, it would be necessary to conclude that none of the concepts that we draw from creatures is genuinely applied to God or, if we prefer, that any concept whatsoever drawn from creatures can be applied to God. For if we are dealing with univocal concepts, God is *wise*, but God is not *stone*. It is true to say the first, but not the second, because the formal reasons of wisdom and stone, as we conceive them, are certainly in question there. If, by contrast, we are dealing now only with analogical concepts, it may be that there is something analogous in God to what we call wisdom, but there may well be also in him something analogous to what we call stone, its idea in God, for example. In this same sense, why would we not say, "God is stone," as we say, "God is wisdom"?[172] On the level of pure analogy we cannot say anything about God

from creatures, or we can attribute everything indifferently to God starting from creatures.

Consequently, theology and metaphysics are connected in their very possibility to the possibility of conceiving being as univocal and consequently as *common*. Still, this conclusion gives rise to a last problem: that of knowing whether being thus conceived is or is not a *genus*. No one can fail to see the importance of this question in a doctrine where being is posited as univocal. On the one hand, Duns Scotus cannot admit that being is a genus, because this would include the created and uncreated, finite being and infinite being, in the same genus. On the other hand, Aristotle seems to avoid this difficulty by resorting to the device of analogy. Several of those who appeal to his doctrine attribute this thesis at least to him, and in fact it seems to resolve the problem, since, if we admit that being is only said analogically of everything, it can be said of all things without strictly being their genus. By rejecting the analogy of being, Duns Scotus denies himself this easy way out. Accordingly, he must elaborate a concept of being that is absolutely *common* to all beings, that is so in a *univocal* sense, and that, however, is not their genus. How is the response to this question to be found?

The Subtle Doctor finds the response in precisely that commonality of being from which the difficulty arouse. Being cannot be posited as a genus, because it is common. To the contrary, it is too common to be a genus.[173] No genus is predicated of its differences; otherwise they could not determine it. A soul can be rational, but it is not rationality. If it were, we would add nothing to the soul by predicating rationality of it. It is true that the ultimate differences do not included being, since they are precisely its differences, but this is the only case where that is so. Whatever the other differences are about which we speak, they include being and they include it exactly in the same sense as the genus they specify. The commonality of being is, therefore, such that it overflows and, so to speak, inundates, the entire realm of the intellect. Everything soaks in being, and, since the intellect knows everything as *being*, it cannot treat as a genus that outside of which nothing remains to determine it. We cannot raise the objection here of these ultimate differences of which

being is not predicated. What matters is that *these are differences of which being is directly predicable, as it is of their genus,* because that alone is enough to prove that being is not a genus.[174] If there are cases where being cannot be a genus, then the fact is that being is not a genus.

Since a being that constitutes the object of metaphysics is thus, it remains to situate it in the immense realm of what is, or more exactly, in relation to being or to the modes of being that do not directly fall under the metaphysician's jurisdiction.

The first distinction of being is between real being and thought being, or to use Duns Scotus's own language (since the term *real* can have many senses in him), between being outside the soul and being in the soul. The being outside the soul can be in act or in potency, being of essence or being of existence. Whatever it is, all being outside the soul can also be in the soul on account of being known. We are still dealing there with two distinct beings, and to such a point that we could never validly conclude from being in the soul to being outside the soul.[175]Being outside the soul is that which, placed outside its cause, possesses all the determination required to be, or participates in being as one of its determinations. Thus, every complete composite existing by itself or every part of this composite existing by and in this composite is real being.[176] Where must we situate metaphysical being, and first of all, will it be situated in our thought?

Here one must distinguish. In a first completely general sense, everything conceivable by thought is thought being, even if, as it happens, what is thus thought cannot exist in reality. In this sense, even genera are being, but simple *beings of reason,* incapable of actually existing *extra animam*. The only thing that cannot exist even in the soul is what is contradictory,[177] about which we can certainly say that since it is incapable of existing either in the soul or outside the soul, it is absolute nothing. Being is evidently not of this sort, because it is the very type of possibility. Therefore, it exists in the soul as something that can exist in reality.

What relations are there between being in thought and being outside thought? We have said that everything that is outside thought can also be in

thought under the form *of being of reason*. A science exists that deals with the being of reason as such; it is logic. By *being of reason as such*, we understand the object of thought that, whatever else its relations to reality may be, it is only considered precisely as object of thought. Logic has in common with grammar and rhetoric to speculate, not about the real as mathematics, physics and metaphysics do, but about simple contents of reason.[178] Indeed, logic deals with *universals*, that is to say with what can be predicated of many individuals. The universal thus understood is above all *unum de multis*. Evidently, in order for us to be able to be say *unum de multis*, the *unum* must first be *in multis*, but it is not for the logicians to say how it is there. The logician's universal consists essentially in its predicability. The universals are five in number: genus, species, difference, accident, and proprium. This amounts to saying that whatever the particular concept the logician may be dealing with, he considers it exclusively insofar as predicable under one of these five headings. We have said that the common being with which metaphysics deals is not a genus. It is also not a being of reason of the kind studied by logic. In other words, the metaphysician's being is not a *logical universal*.

Interpreters of Duns Scotus who talk about this doctrine as historians, are entirely right to protest against those who would attribute any confusion between metaphysics and logic to the Subtle Doctor. Nothing was more opposed to his intention than to make *ens rationis* the subject of metaphysics. He himself clearly affirmed that, although in a sense the logician considers the whole of being as much as the metaphysician, the logician and metaphysician do not speak of the same being, because the logician only speaks of the *ens rationis*, while the metaphysician speaks of the *ens reale*. Thus, not only does Duns Scotus not confuse the two orders, he forbids them to be confused.[179] Still, it does not follow from this that those who speak as philosophers and not historians necessarily commit an unpardonable error when they reproach Scotus with having done so. If they are mistaken, it is as philosophers, not as historians. What they say is not that Duns Scotus himself considered metaphysical being identical to logical being, but that from the

point of view of a philosophy that they themselves hold to be true and that is different from that of Scotus, metaphysical being as Duns Scotus conceives it is nothing but logical being, whatever the intentions of Scotus were. There are two different points of view here. The point of view of history, which is ours, envisages Duns Scotus's doctrine as he himself conceived it. It would be historically false to say that in his doctrine the being of which the metaphysician speaks is a being of reason. But the object of philosophy is philosophical truth, which is independent of history, and if a philosopher judges that the being of Scotist metaphysics is, in fact, a being of reason, he can be reproached for a philosophical error, but not "an inexcusable perversion of Duns Scotus's conception of being." We know very well how Duns Scotus himself conceived metaphysical being, and we do not say that he conceived it otherwise. We say that to succeed in distinguishing effectively metaphysical being from logical being, it would have been necessary to conceive it differently.

For Duns Scotus himself to have conceived *ens commune* as real and not logical, he obviously must have admitted a commonality different from a commonality of a logical order, or, in other words, obvious that the *common* for Scotus can be real at the same time. This is why in his doctrine there is room for a distinction between the generality properly speaking of the concept (universality) and the real commonality of essence. Everything metaphysically *common* is universally predicable, but not everything universally predicable is metaphysically and really common. The metaphysically common is certainly a being in reason like the logical universal, but it is not a *being of reason*, because metaphysics does not consider it in this way, but as a real object. The metaphysically common is what is actually common in reality. It is a real commonality grasped by an act of the intellect.

This is why metaphysics itself is a science of the real, much more similar in that to physics than to logic, although it risks degenerating precisely into logic each time it turns away from the *common* reality and toward the *universal* of predictability. The temptation is constant, and sometimes almost

irresistible, because logic and metaphysics often work on the same concepts: the genus *animal* or the species *human*, for example, without there being more distinction than the two aspects under which metaphysics and logic consider them and the uses they make of them.

As Duns Scotus understood it, here the truth, which can lead into error if misunderstood, is that metaphysics is knowledge that is both real and abstract. Furthermore, this is why, being general knowledge by concepts, it is genuine science. But it is appropriate to put existence in the first rank of all those things from which metaphysics abstracts. Intuition grasps the real only as existing. In their present state human beings only have sensible intuitions, the same as those upon which the natural philosopher works. As for intellectual intuitions of immaterial being, although our intellect is capable of them by its nature, it is a fact that it is no longer capable of them at present, whether in consequence of original sin or for any other reason. From there it follows that our abstract knowledge is concerned with what does not exist as well as with what exists, to the point that even if its object exists, our abstract knowledge does not represent it to us as existing. “Every science is concerned with an object,” Duns Scotus says, “but not taken precisely as existing.” As Scotus’s disciples will say later, science *prescinds from* existence. In other words, “existence itself, although it is a notion (*ratio*) knowable in or starting from the object, is however not necessarily required as actually belonging to the object insofar as it is a knowable object.” Still more concisely, *existentia non est per se ratio objecti, ut scibile est*.[180]

In its capacity as an abstractive science, the only science to which we can aspire in our present state, metaphysics abstracts from existence in the determination of its objects. *Metaphysica quae est de quidditatibus*, “metaphysics, which is about quiddities,” Duns Scotus says. Its universe is the universe of essence. In that universe, it is at home in its own realm, and feels completely competent to deal with essence—except, we must not hastily conclude from this that metaphysics’ objects are only beings of reason for Duns Scotus himself. Though correct in other philosophies, this conclusion would be wrong in Scotus’s, because the quiddity, taken as such, is not

necessarily known there either as included in sense experience, or as a simple logical universal whose generality is reduced to its predicability.

Nor is it necessary to commit any error about the reality of which the metaphysician speaks. In order to conceive it exactly, it is enough to ask what confers its unity on it, and, first of all, what kind of unity it possesses. To go straight to what is essential, let us say that the common enjoys real unity in the thing itself that belongs to it *outside of any operation of the understanding*. This is how the *common* or *metaphysical universal* is immediately distinguished from the logical universal, whose predicatability, even if it must be founded in reality to be valid, nonetheless remains the work of the intellect. "The intellect is what makes universality in things." *Intellectus est qui facit universalitatem in rebus*, says Averroes's frequently quoted expression. Yes, without a doubt, in logic or even in the metaphysics of Avicenna and those who follow him, but not in Duns Scotus's metaphysics, where the first thing to be understood regarding its object is that, if it confers logical generality upon it, *it is not the intellect that confers its real commonality on it*.[181] That is in things, and the intellect finds it there. The intellect does not produce it.

In what we have found so far, what is there that can be conceived as common yet is endowed with a proper unity that owes nothing to the intellect? There seems to be only one thing like that, Avicenna's common nature, taken in its essential indifference to universality and singularity alike. There is little room for doubt that Duns Scotus has just this in mind here, as he refers explicitly to Avicenna to support his thesis: "How this is to be understood can equally be seen by Avicenna's words in *Metaphysica*, book V, where he insists that equinity is only equinity, neither one nor many of itself, neither universal nor particular."[182] Such indeed is the *natura*. It is not a singular being endowed with numerical unity or a universal without other unity than its predicatability, but an intermediate that is not confused with either. Considered under the heading of being, *nature* is not *a being* existing separately like the singulars, but neither is it a simple *being of reason*, like the logical universal. It is not a singular in the full sense of the term, but an

entity, a *reality*, or also, and there will be an opportunity to recall this, a *formality*. To choose, let us say that here we are dealing with this *entity* of the nature (*entitas naturae*) that the intellect apprehends but does not produce.[183] When this entity is considered from the point of view of the unity it involves, it will be judged *less one* than the individual but *more one* than the universal,[184] and above all judged to express a unity different from the universal's unity, precisely because we are dealing with a real universal and not a simple being of reason. Duns Scotus insisted on this point so strongly that we cannot doubt the importance he attributed to it. I will prove it, he says, in "five or six ways," and he keeps his word.[185]

What is this unity of which Aristotle said that it serves as a measure in each genus for everything that falls within the genus? Real beings are not measured by a being of reason. Consequently, it is a real unity: "Therefore, it is real, since things measured are real and really measured; however, real being cannot be measure by being of reason." *Ergo est realis quia mensurata sunt realia et realiter mensurata; ens autem reale non potest realiter mensurari ab enti rationis*.—Secondly, we will consider the concept of genus. It has a certain unity, but this unity cannot be simply of reason, because we see that it belongs to the genus as proper to it, like the unity of the species' concept with its species. The proof is that a single concept, that of the genus, can be attributed to many species.—Thirdly, what is the resemblance that relates individuals of the same genus or species, if the common nature fails to enjoy a unity, not numerical (because nothing resembles itself), but real?—Fourthly, how do we explain the real opposition of contraries otherwise? In all real *contrariety*, the opposition is itself real and the reality is not the work of the intellect. We do not make white become the contrary of black; it is that. How would these terms be really opposed, if they themselves had no real unity?—Fifthly, each sensitive faculty possesses a different object from that of other sensitive faculties, color or sound, for example. The sensitive faculty knows this object as distinct from the others. The object, thus, has unity. But this unity is not numerical, since the object of a faculty of sensation is not this numerically distinct color or sound, but color

as such, sound as such, and so on. Accordingly, this unity must be a real unity different from numerical unity: “The sense of one action is one object according to some real unity, but not numerical; therefore, there is another real unity beside numerical unity.” *Unius actionis sensus est unum objectum secundum aliquam unitatem realem; sed non numeralem; ergo est aliqua alia unitas realis quam unitas numeralis*. This is proven in the following way: the object of each sense is one, at least with a certain unity. Still, sight does not perceive such and such a color as distinct from such and such other and that is so true that if God had created two identical white colors, sight would be incapable of distinguishing them. Therefore, color, sound, and the other objects of the senses must have real unity, which is not, however, numerical unity.[186]—Sixthly, if every real unity were numerical, every real diversity would be numerical, which is false, because all numerical diversities, insofar as they are purely numerical, are of the same nature. If this were so, we could abstract only one single, same concept from any two individuals. Indeed, if Plato and Socrates, or two lines only differ numerically, we could not abstract the concept of human from Plato and Socrates or the concept of line from those two limes. In other words, there are species, and one single reality must respond to each species, a reality that justifies this corresponding concept. Since the unity of the species cannot be numerical, we are left with the conclusion that a non-numerical unity must exist in reality.[187]

Under Avicenna’s influence, Duns Scotus obviously assimilated a stronger dose of Platonic realism than Aristotle or Thomas Aquinas. It does not seem impossible to him that a species, let us say a *nature*, should enjoy a unity and reality that are proper to it. If we consider this nature as a first substance, it is evident that it cannot be at the same time and in the same regard itself and the substance of Socrates or Plato. Here Aristotle would be right against Plato, if Plato had really taught such a chimera. It is true that Aristotle attributed it to Plato, but Duns Scotus doubts that this is legitimate. Whatever the case may be on this point, we always return to Avicenna’s position in his *Metaphysics*, tractate V, chapter 1: of itself nature is neither numerically one nor numerically multiple. The species human is, therefore, neither Socrates’s nor

Plato's substance, because it is not suited to either one of itself. It is of its very essence to be common in this way: "No cause of communality is to be sought other than the nature itself" *non quaerenda causa communitatis alia ab ipsa natura*.[188]

When nature is conceived thus, in the unity of its indifference to any further determination and as being neither singular nor universal, it is the proper object of the intellect. Consequently, it is also the metaphysician's proper object, equidistant from the natural philosopher, who considers the nature of its particular determinations, and the logician, who considers it as determined to universality. Moreover, this is why true metaphysical prepositions are true *primo modo*, that is to say, immediately, with a truth founded on the essence of the natures taken in themselves and independently of any later determinations:

> However, not only is the nature itself inherently indifferent to *esse* in the intellect and in the particular, and by that to universal or singular *esse*, but the nature itself that has *esse* in the intellect does not first have universality of itself, although it is understood through universality, as through the mode of understanding the nature. Nevertheless, universality is not part of its first concept, since it is not the Metaphysician's but the Logician's concept. For, the Logician considers second intentions applied to the first, according to Avicenna himself.[189]

What is true about the nature in the intellect is true of the same nature in the particular individual, *in re extra*. The nature is there with singularity, but it is not singular. As it were, it is prior by nature to the singularity that contracts it. In short, whether the nature is in thought or outside thought, it possesses a proper *esse*, corresponding to each of these two manners of being (*entitas*). In the intellect, the nature has a *verum esse intelligibile*. Outside the intellect and "also in nature," according to that entity, it has true and real *esse* "outside the soul," *etiam in rerum natura, secundum illam entitatem, habet verum esse extra animam reale*. Such is the entity to which a unity corresponds that is proper to it; it is that something is, *quod quid est*, prior to all its

determinations; it is what the metaphysician continues and expresses by the definition.[190] This commonality belongs to the nature as such. There is no need to seek a cause of the commonality; we need to seek the cause of the singularity.[191]

It seems to us that this is also the simplest manner of conceiving the proper object of Scotist metaphysics, with the sense of univocal being. The species is univocal to being, and it can be so by virtue of its very commonality that subsists intact under the determinations that it receives. If being is the first intelligible, it is what is most common, but nothing is such but being: *Illud quod est primum intelligibile simpliciter, est communissimum simpliciter; sed nullum est tale nisi ens*. As metaphysical commonality of nature but not physical commonality of substance or logical commonality of predication, Duns Scotus's univocal being, which the *Questions on the Metaphysics* place explicitly under the patronage of Avicenna, appears first of all as characterized by the Avicennist nature's indifference to actual or potential determinations. Therefore it appears to be only the most common and most *indifferent* of all. But a thought experiment suffices to prove that its concept is not a chimera.

> We experience within ourselves that we can conceive being without conceiving it such and such a substance or such and such an accident in front of us, because when we conceive being, we do not know whether we are dealing with a being in itself or in another. . . . Therefore we initially conceive something indifferent to both, and we next find that both are immediately included in a term such that the first concept, that of being, is included in it.[192]

When the controversies between Scotists and Thomists are viewed from this angle, the majority of them seem pointless. We would even call them frivolous, if they were more amusing. When people do not agree about the nature of being, what will they agree about? They need to understand each other first on this fundamental point, not only to reach agreement, but even if only to refute each other. If being is what Duns Scotus claims, we will never

prove that it must be conceived as analogous. If it is what Thomas Aquinas claims, we will never prove that it must be conceived as univocal. According to whether we admit one or the other, we will prefer a metaphysical point of departure for the proofs of God's existence, or, on the contrary, we will judge it necessary to support them on physical grounds. If the first object of knowledge is not the same in the two doctrines, their noetics will necessarily be different. In short, it will become impossible to refute any point whatsoever of one of the doctrines starting from the reciprocal point corresponding to it in the other doctrine. The initial discrepancy owing to the different ontologies upon which the doctrines rest, keeps them from ever meeting. *Principiis obsta* . . . One of them can and must be chosen by reason of its principles, but philosophy alone can choose, not history, whose only function here is to help us understand in order to permit the choice.

Notes

1 We have already touched upon this question in "Metaphysik und Theologie nach Duns Scotus," pp. 209–231 in *Franziskanische Studien*, vol. 22 (1935). Among the numerous contributions of old-school Scotists to the study of this problem, it is helpful to consult Claudius Frassen, O.F.M. (1620–1711), *Scotus Academicus*, revised edition following the author's corrections (Rome: Typographia Sallustiana, 1900), vol. I, pp. 1–94. Hieronymus de Montefortino, *Venerabilis J. Duns Scoti Summa Theologica ex universis operibus ejus concinnata juxta ordinem et dispositionem Summae Angelici Doctoris Sancti Thomae Aquinatis*, new edition (Rome: Typographia Sallustiana, 1900), part I, question 1, vol. I, pp. 5–73 (first edition, 1737). Unfortunately, it is sometimes difficult to identify this work's exact sources in Duns Scotus, but it is, nevertheless, very useful to compare the Scotist and Thomist positions point by point.—In the modern period, see Parthenius Minges, O.F.M., *Joannis Duns Scoti doctrina philosophica et theologica quoad res praecipuas proposita et exposita* (Quaracchi, 1930), vol. I, pp. 501–21. Déodat de Basly, O.F.M., "Scotus Docens," supplement to *La France Franciscaine*, XVII (1934), pp. 111–37. For an overview, see Cyril L. Shircel, O.F.M., *The Univocity of the Concept of Being in the Philosophy of Duns Scotus* (Washington DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1942). This study is very precise, exact, and excellent for everything about Duns Scotus's own thought.

2 The text of the *Book of Sentences* is reproduced along with most of the commentaries upon it that have been published, for instance, those of St. Bonaventure, St. Thomas Aquinas, or Duns Scotus. An excellent edition of the *Sentences* that identifies the sources of the text is *Petri Lombardi Libri IV Sententiarum*, ed. Fathers of the College of St. Bonaventure, second edition (Quaracchi, 1916), 2 vols.

3 For the development that culminates in the thirteenth century to posit theology as a science or at least a discipline distinct from Holy Scripture, on which, however, it is based, see Marie-Dominique Chenu, *La théologie comme science au XIII*e *siècle*, second edition (Paris: J. Vrin,

1943). The term *theology* was slow to take hold. Although St. Thomas Aquinas does not hesitate to use it, *In I Sententiarum*, prologue, question 1, body of article, he is far from employing it as often as the modern interpreters of his doctrine. By contrast, in Duns Scotus, *theologia* is the established term to designate *sacra doctrina* as distinct from philosophy. We will meet many examples of this.

4 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, 2 [CE I, p. 1. In CE this question is the sole question of part I]: "Utrum homini pro statu isto sit necessarium aliquam doctrinam specialem supernaturaliter inspirari, ad quam videlicit non posset attingere lumine naturali intellectus?"—we will quote the *Opus Oxoniense* according to the re-edition of Mariano Fernández García, O.F.M, Quaracchi, 1912 and 1914, 4 vols., though we retain the numeration of articles adopted by Wadding and correcting it according to the parts of the critical edition already published. Sometimes we will add the number of the paragraph at the end of the reference. For example, "(35)" signifies Scotist Commission edition, paragraph 35. (Translator: Gilson did not carry this out. He uses the Wadding-Vivès section numbers, although not always. However, I have checked his references in volumes I–VIII, and XI of the critical edition *Ordinatio* [*Opus Oxoniense*]. In square brackets I indicate the critical edition, henceforth CE, volume and page numbers.)

5 The four questions in St. Bonaventure's prologue deal with the material, formal, final, and efficient causes of theology, Bonaventure, *In I Sententiarum*, proemium *editio minor* (Quaracchi: Typographia Collegii Sancti Bonaventurae, 1934), vol. I, pp. 6–12. Bonaventure does not seem to be aware that the necessity of theology might be challenged in the name of the sufficiency of philosophy. On St. Bonaventure's attitude toward Aristotle, see Gilson, *La philosophie de saint Bonaventure*, first edition, pp. 12–13 (*The Philosophy of St. Bonaventure*, trans. Illtyd Trethowan and Frank Sheed [Paterson, NJ: St Anthony Guild Press, 1965]). In the opposite sense, see Ferdinand Van Steenberghen, *Siger dans l'histoire de l'aristotelisme* (Louvain: Institut Supérieur de Philosophie, 1942), chapter 2, p. 446 ff, and, by the same author, *Aristote en Occident* (Louvain: Institut Supérieur de Philosophie, 1946), chapter 6, pp. 131–47 (*Aristotle in the West: The Origins of Latin Aristotelianism*, trans. Leonard Johnson [Louvain: Nauwelaerts, 1956, 1970]).

6 The date is uncertain. We know that Thomas Aquinas composed his commentary on book I of the *Sentences* a second time around 1264. What we read in his complete works is probably the second version. It would be interesting to know whether he took the position as clearly ten years earlier.

7 Thomas Aquinas, *In I Sententiarum*, prologue, question 1, article 1, objection 3: "ad perfectionem hominis sufficit illa cognitio quae ex naturali intellectu potest haberi; ergo praeter philosophiam non est necessaria alia doctrina."

8 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 1, number 3, vol. I, p. 5 [CE I, p. 4]: "*In ista quaestione videtur esse controversia inter philosophos et theologos.*"

9 André Callebaut, "Le bienheureux Jean Duns Scot à Cambridge vers 1297–1300," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* 21 (1938), pp. 608–11.

10 Denifle-Chatelain, *Chartularium Universitatis Parisiensis*, (Paris: Frères Delalain, 1889), vol. I, p. 552, proposition 154: "quod sapientes mundi sunt philosophi tantum."

11 Denifle-Chatelain, *Chartularium Universitatis Parisiensis*, I, p. 552, proposition 157: "Quod homo ordinatus quantum ad intellectum et affectu, sicut potest sufficienter esse per virtutes intellectuales et alias morales, de quibus loquitur philosophus in Ethicis, est sufficienter dispositus ad felicitatem aetermam."

12 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 1, number 3 [CE I, p. 4]: "In ista questione videtur controversia inter philosophos et theologos. Et tentent philosophi perfectionem naturas et

negant perfectionem supernaturalem; theologi vero cognoscunt defectum naturae et necessitatem gratiae et perfectionem supernaturalem."

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 1, 3 [CE I, p. 5]: "Diceret ergo philosophia quod nulla est cognitio supernaturalis homini necessaria pro statu isto, sed quod omnem cognitionem sibi necessariam posset acquirere ex actione causarum naturalium. Ad hoc adducitur simul auctoritas et ratio Philosophi ex diversis locis."—Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 13 [CE I, p. 21]: "Ad primum requireret dici qualis fuerit cognitio hominis instituti, quod usque alias differatur, saltem respectu viatoris pro statu isto est dicta *cognitio supernaturalis*, quia facultatem ejus naturalem excedens: *naturalem* dico secundum statum naturae lapsae."—We interpret the first *pro statu isto* as designating the state of fallen nature. The context seems to suggest that. However, neither Duns Scotus nor Lychetus in his commentary on this passage say so, surely because they judge it to be evident.

14 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 6, folio 72 recto b in *Opera*, Venice, 1508: "Dicemus igitur quod *ens* et *res* et *necesse* talia sunt quae statim imprimuntur in anima prima impressione, quae non acquiritur ex aliis notioribus se."

15 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, 1, vol. I, p. 3 [CE I, pp. 1–4]. See the felicitously corrected text in *Relatio a Commissione Scotistica exhibita Capitulo Generali Fratrum Minorum Assisii A.D. 1939 celebrando* (Rome, 1939), pp. 11–18.—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, article 5, number 35, vol. II, p. 475 [CE VIII, pp. 135–37]. A second, a fortiori argument is, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 1, number 1 [CE I, p. 3]: "Sensus non indiget aliqua cognitione supernaturali pro statu isto, ergo nec intellectus."

16 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, 2 [CE I, p. 3]. Lychet comments thus the expression: "secundum omnem modum cognoscibilis; scilicet abstractive, intuitive, intense remisse et hujusmodi."

17 In *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 1, number 3 [CE I, p. 5], Duns Scotus cites Aristotle, *De Anima* book III, chapter 5, to conclude from it that, since the possible intellect can become all intelligibles, and the agent intellect can produce them all, human beings are naturally capable of knowing everything. In paragraph four, which follows immediately, Scotus quotes *Metaphysics* E, 1, 1026 a 19 (cf. *Metaphysics* K, 7, 1064 b 2), where Aristotle divides speculative science into mathematical, physical, and metaphysical. In fact, Aristotle does not say *metaphysical* but *theological*, and it is odd that Duns Scotus did not retain this term that would have reinforced the argument. Whatever the explanation may be, Duns Scotus concludes from this division of the sciences that, since the three disciplines cover the totality of being, no place remains for any other, as revealed knowledge would be. Finally, at paragraph 5, vol. I, pp. 6–7 [CE I, p. 7], basing himself on *Posterior Analytics* I, 2, 71 b 16 ff, Duns Scotus argues that, since we naturally know the first principles, we ought to be able to know their consequences naturally.

18 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 6 [CE I, pp. 9–10]: "Omne agens per se agens suo modo appetit finem; ergo per se agens agit propter finem; ergo omne per se agens suo modo appetit finem; ergo sicut agenti naturali est necessarius appetitus finis, propter quem debet agere, ita agenti per cognitionem . . . necessarius est appetitus sui finis, propter quem debet agere, qui sequitur cognitionem. Patet ergo major. Sed homo non potest scire ex naturalibus finem suum distincte, ergo necessaria est sibi de hoc aliqua cognitio supernaturalis."

19 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, critical edition, vol. 1, article 12 [CE I, p. 9].

20 Cf. Aristotle, *Ethica Nicomachea*, book X, chapter 7, 1177, 14–16. Duns Scotus cites this again in *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 32. It will be noted that Scotus does not formally attribute this doctrine to Aristotle (*videtur*). St. Thomas denies that Aristotle taught it:

Summa Contra Gentes, book III, chapter 44.

21 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 8 [CE I, p. 10]. The text remits to Aristotle, *Ethica Nicomachea*, book I, chapter 9, 1099b 10–15. The Latin text quoted by Duns Scotus is restored as follows: "Si quod igitur et aliud aliquod deorum est donum hominibus, rationabile felicitatem quoque dei datum esse, et maxime humanorum quantum optimum."—Here our theologian rather seems to confine himself to Aristotle's uncertainty. In any case, he does not positively affirm, as he has been made to say, that Aristotle teaches this doctrine. —Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 7, numbers 2 and 3: "Respondeo quod hominem esse capacem beatitudinis planum est ex Scriptura. Sed utrum sit capax secundum intentionem philosophorum, de hoc est dubium."

22 Duns Scotus cites Augustine, *De Genesi ad Litteram* XII, 36, 69, end, *Patrologia Latina*, XXXIV, p. 484.—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 7, vol. I, p. 8 [CE I, p. 11].

23 See Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 4, number 23, vol. I, pp. 21–22 [CE I, p. 41, note 3], where, Scotus cites Augustine regarding the philosophers' ignorance of the real human end, *De Civitate Dei* XVIII, 41, 3, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, p. 602: "Quamvis nescientes ad quem finem et quonam modo essent ista omnia referenda. . ." [CE I, p. 41], has "Philosophi nescientes, ad quem finem essent ista referenda. . . ."

24 Frassen, O.F.M., *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, p. 4: "Si finis ultimus hominis ab aliquo philosophantium solo rationis lumine detegi posset, eum haud dubie Aristoteles Philosophorum Aquila et Naturae Genius, deprehendisset; sed ipsum non detexit."—This Aristotle set-up as the ultimate limit of human understanding comes directly from Averroes. To our knowledge, Duns Scotus himself never used these expressions, but Frassen can be excused, because Lychet preceded him on this path, *Opus Oxoniense*, commentary, Vivès edition, vol. VIII, p. 16: "Si ergo Aristoteles princeps omnium philosophorum non cognovit distincte ultimum finem hominis propter quem ratio agit, stat ratio Doctoris quod sit ei necessaria aliqua cognitio distincta de fine ultimo, quae via naturali haberi non potest.—For a comparable state of mind, see Dante, *De Monarchia* III, 16: ". . . quae [*scilicet*, humana ratio] per philosophos *tota* nobis innotuit."

25 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 2, number 8 [CE I, pp. 12–13]: "Istud non est naturaliter scibile, ut videtur, quia hic etiam errabant philosophi ponentes omnia quae sunt a Deo immediate esse ab eo necessario." Perhaps Duns Scotus remembers the fifty-third proposition condemned in 1277. *Chartularium Universitatis Parisiensis*, p. 546: "Quod Deum necesse est facere, quidquid immediate fit ab ipso."— Moreover, it will be noted that the concept of naturally achieved salvation through philosophy is one of the errors or which Giles of Rome reproaches Avicenna, *Errores Philosophorum*, chapter 6, article 18, Joseph Koch, introduction and notes, and John O. Riedl translation (Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 1944), p. 34. Here is the text: "Ulterius erravit circa beatitudinem nostram volens eam dependere ex operibus nostris. Et ex positione sua sequitur quod beatitudo nostra consistat in contemplando ultimam intelligentiam, ut patet ex Xo Metaphysicae suae capitulo 'De cultu Dei et utilitate ejus.'" For the hypothetical sources of this attribution to Avicenna, see p. 37, note 43.—Our incapacity to know the means of salvation naturally is confirmed in *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 23, by the authority of Augustine, *De civitate Dei* XI, 3, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, p. 318: "Profecto ea quae remota sunt a sensibus nostris, quoniam nostro testimonio scire non possumus, de his alios testes requiremus, eisque credimus. . ." [CE I, p. 42, omits *profecto* and ends *aliorum testimonio requiremus*.]

26 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 9 [CE I, p. 15]: "Item, homo naturaliter appetit finem illum quem dicis supernaturalem; igitur ad illum finem naturaliter ordinatur; igitur ex tali ordinatione potest concludi finis ille ut ex cognitione naturae ordinatae ad

ipsum."—It is difficult to resist the impression that Duns Scotus here aims the passage at the well-known Thomist thesis about "the natural desire to see God," and judges that St Thomas was too generous to philosophy.

27 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 10 [CE I, pp. 15–19].

28 See Étienne Gilson, "Les sources gréco-arabes de l'augustinisme avicennisant," *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* IV (1929), p. 40, note 1 (English translation by James G. Colbert, *Greco-Arabic Sources of Avicennist Augustinism* [New York: Global Scholarly Publications, 2003], p. 49 and pp. 77–79, note 2).—Cf. Louis Gardet, "Quelques aspects de la pensée avicennienne dans ses rapports avec l'orthodoxie musulmane," in *Revue Thomiste* 45 (1939), p. 730: "It [the soul] therefore, grasps itself, because it is in its nature to know itself."

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 11 [CE I, p. 17]: "Non enim cognoscitur anima nostra a nobis, nec natura nostra pro statu isto, nisi sub ratione aliqua generali, abstrahibili a sensibilibus, sicut patebit infra, distinctione 3. Et secundum talem generalem rationem non convenit sibi ordinari ad talem finem, nec posse capere gratiam, nec habere Deum pro objecto perfectissimo."—We will have to come back to the texts of distinction III, where the problem of the knowability of pure intelligibles is directly confronted. Let us simply observe that here the expression *pro statu isto* certainly refers to the classical theological distinction between the initial human state and the human state after the fall: *homo in statu innocentiae vel naturae institutae, homo in statu naturae lapsae*. See *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 13, vol. I, p. 13 [CE I, pp. 20–22]. What Duns Scotus envisages is exactly that power of knowing which is currently natural for our intellect: "naturalem dico secundum statum naturae lapsae," *ibidem* [CE I, p. 21].

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 12 [CE I, pp. 19–20]: "Ad aliud negandum est illud quod assumitur, quod scilicet naturaliter cognoscitur ens esse primum objectum intellectus nostri, et hoc secundum totam indifferentiam entis ad sensibilia et insensibilia, et quod hoc dicit Avicenna quod sit naturaliter notum. Miscuit enim sectam suam—quae fuit secta Mahometi—philosophicis, et quaedam dixit ut philosophica et ratione probata, alia ut consona suae sectae. Unde expresse ponit, libro IX *Metaphysicae*, capitulo 7, animam separatam cognoscere substantiam immaterialem in se; et ideo sub objecto primo intellectus habuit ponere substantiam immaterialem contineri. Non sic Aristoteles; sed secundum ipsum est vel videtur esse primum objectum intellectus nostri quidditas rei sensibilis, et hoc vel in se sensibilis vel in suo inferiori, et haec est quidditas abstrahibilis a sensibilibus."—On this text see Carolus Balić, *De critica textuali Scholasticorum scriptis accomodata* (Rome: Antonianum, 1945), p. 38, note 1; also in *Antonianum* XX, 1945, p. 302, note 1; see also "Ordinatio 33."—Cf. the reproach that Averroes directs against Avicenna, *In IV Metaphysicorum*, com. 3: "cum quorum [*scilicet*, Loquentium] admiscuit ipse suam scientiam divinam." In a word, he has mixed theology and philosophy.—Cf. Averroes, *In II Physicorum*, com. 22: "Via autem qua processit Avicenna in probando primum principium est via Loquentium, et sermo ejus semper invenitur quasi medius inter Peripatetitcos et Loquentes."

31 Balić, *De Critica Textuali*, p. 40; *Antonianum*, XX, p. 304.

32 Further on, Duns Scotus quotes the text literally, *Opus Oxoniense*, Prologue, question 2, number 8. [CE, pp. 71–72. In CE this is in sole question of part II.]

33 We have seen Giles of Rome attribute this doctrine to Avicenna, *Errores Philosophorum*, p. 34, article 48: "Ulterius erravit ponens animam nostram esse beatam in eo quod intelligit intelligentiam ultimam."—The same author, *Errores Philosophorum*, p. 42, article 12, attributes the doctrine to Algazel in the same terms, which is justified by Algazel, *Metaphysics*, ed. J. T.

Muckle (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Medieval Studies, 1933), p. 185. In Avicenna himself, see *Metaphysica*, tractate IX, chapter 7, Venice: 1508, folio 107 recto a, and the very clear passage in *Metaphysicae Compendium*, book II, tractate 1, chapter 1, number 9, ed. Nematallah Carame (Rome: Pontifical Institute of Oriental Studies, 1926), pp. 230–31.—Against this thesis of Avicenna, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction I, question 1, number 3, vol. I, pp. 128–30 [CE II, p. 5], where Duns Scotus groups Avicenna with Proclus, *Elementatio Theologiae*, 35.

34 Duns Scotus expresses himself bluntly on Mohammed's own doctrine, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 32 [CE I, p. 60], for example: "Quidam autem . . . ut Saraceni, quibus immundus Mahometus alias immunditias innumeras immiscuit." Also, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue question 2, number 8, vol. I, pp. 37–38 [CE I, pp. 71–72]: "Quid Saraceni, illius vilissimi porci, Mahometi discipuli, pro suis scripturis allegabunt, expectantes pro beatitudine quod porcis convenit scilicet gulam et coitum? Quam promissionem despiciens philosophus, qui fuit quasi illius sectae, Avicenna, IX *Metaphysicae*, capitulo 7, alium finem, quasi perfectiorem et homini magis congruentem, asserit dicens: 'Lex nostra quam dedit Mahometus, ostendit dispositionem felicitatis et miseriae quae sunt secundum corpus, et est alia promissio quae apprehenditur intellectu.' Et sequitur ibi: 'Sapientibus magis cupiditas fuit ad consequendum hanc felicitatem quam corporum, quae quamvis daretur eis, non tamen attenderunt, nec appretiati sunt eam comparatione felicitatis quae est conjucta primae Veritati.'"—A little further on, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue question 2, number 9, vol. I, pp. 39–40 [CE I, p. 77], Duns Scotus announces that in the year 1300 Islam is nearing its end! On this passage, see Étienne Gilson, "Sur un text de Duns Scot," *Revue d'histoire franciscaine* I, (1924), pp. 106–07.

35 Avicenna, *Metaphysices Compendum*, book II, tractate I, chapter 1, p. 227.

36 Efrem Bettoni, O.F.M., *L'ascesa a Dio in Duns Scotus* (Milan: Vita e Pensiero, 1943), pp. 114–17.

37 Bettoni, *L'ascesa*, p. 115.

38 Ibid., p. 119.

39 Ibid., p. 117, top.

40 After having recalled "Objectum adaequatum intellectui nostro ex natura potentiae non est specialius objecti angelici, quia quidquid postest intelligi ab uno et ab alio," Duns Scotus raises the objection against himself that, for a philosopher unaware of original sin, the sensible quiddity, the object he perceives as adequate *pro statu isto*, must appear adequate absolutely. But he answers in *Quodlibet* XIV, 13 (John Duns Scotus, *God and Creatures: The Quodlibetal Questions*, translated with introduction, notes and glossary by Félix Alluntis, O.F.M., and Allan B. Wolter, O.F.M. [Washington DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1984]; hereafter AW, p. 327): "Contra ista arguitur quod ens non tantum limitatum, sed illimitatum sit objectum naturaliter motivum intellectus creati, et ita ens, ut est indifferens ad utrumque, erit objectum natural, scilicet per actionem causae naturaliter agentis attingibile. Et arguitur primo sic; ejusdem objecti primi accepti *secundum suam totam indifferentiam*, ad potentiam quam primo respicit acceptam secundum suam totam indifferentiam, est idem modus se habendi in movendo, scilicet naturaliter vel non naturaliter."—The fact that God is not naturally present to the created intellect, whether human or angelic, does not allow him to be an object capable of moving these intellects, nor that these intellects should be susceptible of being moved by him. Therefore God is included in the object that is natural to these intellects *ex natura potentiae*.

41 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, 11; AW, p. 325: "Contra istud, quidquid per se continetur sub primo objecto naturali alicujus potentiae, ad illud potentia potest naturaliter attingere, alioquin objectum primum non esset adaequatum potentiae, sed transcendens in ratione objecti; nunc autem ens quod

est primum objectum naturale intellectus, verissime convenit Deo; igitur, etc."

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 2, number 14, vol. I, p. 15 [CE I, p. 24]: "Proprietas etiam istius naturae ad extra est causare contingenter; et ad oppositum hujus magis ducunt effectus in errorem, sicut patet per opiniones philosophorum ponentium Primum necessario causare."

43 See note 25 in this chapter.

44 Giles of Rome, *Errores Philosophorum*, XI [sic], 4, p. 36. Alkindi: "Quod omnia de necessitate contingunt."—*Errores Philosophorum*, IX, 9, p. 44. Algazel: "Quod Deus non potest facere nisi quod facit." Cf. article 7, p. 40.

45 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue question I, article 2, number 14, vol. I, p. 15 [CE I, pp. 24–25]: "de proprietatibus etiam aliarum substantiarum patet hoc idem, quia effectus magis ducunt in sempiternitatem et aeternitatem et necessitatem earum, quam in contingentiam et novitatem."

46 Chartularium Universitatis Parisiensis, I, p. 548, proposition 39: "Quod impossibile est solvere rationes Philosophi de aeternitate mundi, nisi dicamus, quod voluntas Primi implicat impossibila."—p. 545, proposition 21: "Quod nihil fit a casu, sed omnia de necessitudine eveniunt, et quod omnia futura, quae erunt, de necessitudine erunt, et quae non erunt, impossible est esse, et quod nihil fit contingenter, considerando omnes causas."

47 Giles of Rome, *Errores Philosophorum*, I, 1, p. 2 and II, p. 12. See, above all, III, p. 14. Incidentally, in *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 4, number 23, vol. I, p. 22 [CE I, pp. 41–42], Duns Scotus reproaches Aristotle with having taught polytheism, the same error that is attributed to Cicero in prologue, question 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 39 [CE I, p. 75 note, considers the explicit reference to Cicero to be an interpolation and excludes it from the text], as well as other immoral practices. Concerning polytheism, see *Politics*, book VII, chapter 9 and concerning immoral practices, see VII, chapter 16.

48 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 2, number, 14, vol. I, p. 15 [CE I, p. 25]: "Similiter videntur philosophi ex motibus concludere quod numerus istarum substantiarum separatarum sit secundum numerum motuum coelestium.

49 Giles of Rome, *Errores Philosophorum*, I, 14, p. 10, and II, 14, p. 12. On Avicenna, see VI, 15, p. 32. On Algazel, see VIII, 5, pp. 38–40.—Cf. Dan. 7:10: "Millia millium ministrabant ei et decies milies centena assistebant."

50 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 2, number 14, vol. I, p. 15 [CE I, p. 25]: "Similiter quod illae substantiae sunt naturaliter beatae et impeccabiles, sicut philosophi posuerunt. Quae omnia sunt absurda."—Compare Giles of Rome *Errores Philosophorum*: "Quod in angelis non potest esse malum" to Avicenna, VI, 15, p. 36, and VI, 12, p. 30, to which Giles opposes Job 4:18.

51 All the attempts that Duns Scotus imagines to justify the philosopher ultimately fail for this reason. It is his decisive argument against them. In regard to God, see *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 17 [CE I, p. 29]: "Non concipimus Deum nisi in conceptu generali, communi sibi et sensibilibus." In this exact sense we must say: "conceptum qui potest fieri de Deo virtute creaturae, esse imperfectum."

52 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 3, number 20, vol. I, p. 19 [CE I, p. 35].

53 Fernández García, *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. I, p. 19, note, specifies that according to Duns Scotus there exist *intrinsically supernatural* forms or *habitus*, that is to say, that are not such simply by relation to the agent that produces them. On this point, he remits notably to *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 17, question 3, number 21, vol. I, p. 815 [Seems to be CE V, pp. 200–02]. The observation is justified, but perhaps it is not necessary, First, it would be surprising for Duns

Scotus to have forgotten his point at the exact moment when he was defining the supernatural as such. Next and above all, the definition of the supernatural given implies the specification that some people desire to add to it. In the text cited, Duns Scotus teaches precisely that even when the conditions required for the perfection of an act are all fulfilled, none of those conditions suffices to make it acceptable to God. The exhaustive analysis of this act will not reveal it to be thus justified. What must be added to make it justified is a "habitus supernaturalis gratificans naturam beatificabilem." It is precisely the *habitus* that makes this act "acceptabile Deo." If it is supernatural, is not that precisely because nothing either in the nature of the power that produces the act or in any *nature* capable of making it produce the act, could require that this act should be accepted by God as meritorious. Moreover, it will be seen further on that Duns Scotus explicitly distinguishes two *supernaturalities*, that of the cause alone, and that of the object, where the second necessarily includes the first, but not inversely. That said, it is still true that, *from the point of view of the nature that receives it*, every *habitus* is natural, or otherwise it could not ever be received. From there comes the paradoxical phrase of Fr. Parthenius Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, I, 505: "Supernaturale est perfectio quaedam naturalis."

54 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 3, number 21, vol. I, pp. 19–20 [C E, I, p. 37]: "Ad propositum dico, quod comparando intellectum possibilem ad notitiam actualem in se nulla est ibi cognitio supernaturalis; quia intellectus possibilis quacumque cognitione naturaliter perficiter, et ad quamcumque naturaliter inclinatur. Sed secundo modo loquendo, sic est supernaturalis quae generatur ab aliquo agente quod non est natum movere intellectum possibilem ad talem cognitionem naturaliter. Pro statu autem isto, secundum Philosophum, intellectus possibilis natus est moveri ad cognitionem ab intellectu agente et phantasmate; igitur sola illa cognitio est ei naturalis quae ab istis agentibus imprimatur."—On the *natural* character of the intellect's capacity to give its assent to a knowledge whose cause is supernatural, see *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 5, number 34, vol. I, pp. 30–31 [CE I, pp. 57–58].

55 Giles of Rome, *Errores Philosophorum*, VII, 21 and 22, pp. 36, 38: "quod beatitudo nostra dependet ex operibus nostris and quod beatitudo nostra consistit in cognitione ultimae intelligentia*e*."—Cf. VIII, 12–13, p. 42, for the formula that Giles attributes to Algazel: "Ulterius erravit ponens animam nostram esse beatam in eo quod intelligit intelligentiam ultimam. Ulterius errabit ponens ultimam beatitudinem nostram esse naturalem. Voluit enim quod naturaliter deberetur animae talis beatitudo."—See Gardet, "Quelques aspects de la pensée avicennienne," pp. 724–38, on the elements of naturalism even in Avicenna's mysticism.

56 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 3, number 22, vol. I, pp. 20–21 [CE I, p. 37].

57 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 3, number 22, vol. I, p. 21 [CE vol. I, p. 40]: "Differentia istorum duorum modorum ponendi supernaturalitatem notitiae revelatae patet separando unum ab alio. Puta, si agens supernaturale causaret notitiam objecti naturalis, ut si infunderet geometriam alicui, illa esset supernaturalis primo modo, non secundo (hoc est utroque modo, quia secundus infert primum, licet non e converso). Ubi autem est primus tantum, ibi non est necesse quod sit supernaturalis, quia naturaliter possit haberi; ubi est secundus modus est necessitas ut supernaturaliter habeatur, quia naturaliter haberi non potest."— Cf. Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 17 [AW, p. 332]: "Essentia divina est motiva immediate sui intellectus, sed non intellectus creati, quia intellectus divinus est primum mobile omnino."—Thus, God must want to become known by us for us to know him.

58 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, number 26, vol. I, p. 24 [CE I, p. 46].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, number 26, vol. I, p. 25 [CE I, p. 46]: Needless to say, the possible intellect's natural sufficiency is not *organic* (that is to say, linked to

any organ). Scotus says so in passing and reaffirms it later. Every *organic* faculty partakes of the organ it needs, but a *non-organic* faculty does not necessarily get from nature, beyond itself, everything that might cooperate with its act.

59 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 1, article 3, reply to objection 2.

60 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 1, article 1, reply to objection 2.—Here we observe the richness of Thomist thought: a *double truth* is related to the same object, consequently two different sciences about the same object, and therefore one, revealed theology, can occasionally deal with what the other (natural theology) deals with, without thereby losing its unity. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentes*, book I, chapter 4: "Duplici igitur veritate duorum intelligibilium existente, una ad quam rationis inquisitio pertingere potest, altera quae omne ingenium humanae rationis excedit, utraque convenienter divinitus homini credenda proponuntur."—Thus, in Thomism God can be the object of metaphysical or theological knowledge and yet certain metaphysical positions can be proposed to human beings as objects of faith.

61 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 1, article 1, poses the same problem that Duns Scotus takes up at the beginning of the *Opus Oxoniense*. Thomas Aquinas asks: "Utrum sit necessarium praeter philosophicas disciplinas, aliam doctrinam haberi."—We note primarily that Duns Scotus's text is not content with summing up *Summa Theologiae* part I, question 1, article 1, reply to objection 2. It contains a direct quotation. It next discusses the text of *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia-IIae, question 54, article 2, body of the article. This instance is not unique, and we may conclude that Scotus had the *Summa Theologiae* at hand when composing the *Opus Oxoniense*. The quotation in question is found in *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, number 27, vol. I, p. 25 [CE I, pp. 47–48]: "Ad rationem tertiam quaere responsionem Thomae in *Summa*, I parte *Summae*, questione I ubi respondet sic, quod 'diversa ratio cognoscibilis. . .'"

62 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, number 27, vol. I, p. 25 [CE I, p. 48,]: "Si de cognoscibilibus in theologia est cognitio tradita vel possibilis tradi in aliis scientiis, licet in alio lumine, ergo non est necessario cognitio theologica de eisdem."

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, number 28, vol. I, p. 26: "Ideo ad argumentum respondeo, quod in illis scientiis speculativis etsi tractetur de omnibus speculabilibus, non tamen quantum ad omnia cognoscibilia de eis, quia non quantum ad propria eorum cogniscibilia de eis." [CE I, p. 50, does not *have cognoscibilia de eis*.]

64 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, numbers 30–31, vol. I, pp. 27–28 [CE I, p. 52].

65 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5 number 34, vol. I, pp. 30–31 [CE I, p. 58]. Note on p. 30 [CE I, p. 58] the appearance of the notion of *obediential potency*.—Cf. Étienne Gilson, *L'ésprit de la philosophie médièvale*, second edition (Paris: Vrin, 1944), pp. 359–64.

66 St. Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, book VIII, chapter 1, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, p. 225.

67 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 46. [CE I, p. 91; part III, question 1 according to CE's organization]: "Theologia est sermo vel ratio de Deo."

68 Mauritius de Portu, "Super D. Scoti *Theoremata* XIV, 9 in Vivès, vol. V, p. 44: "Loca autem Scripturarum, in quibus hae propositiones habentur, adducat Lector quae hic omitto, coactus temporis angustia, et ne curiosis Scholasticis sacra verba nauseam generent, quod abhorreo dicere, et magis ita esse." It is obviously superfluous to underline the importance of this compelling testimony.

69 In Duns Scotus, the term *habitus* taken absolutely often designates acquired knowledge, some science that has become the possession of an intellect. No translation has become usual in the

French language. We regret the failure of the elegant French word *ayance*, tried unsuccessfully in the seventeenth century.

70 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 2, number 4, vol. I, pp. 48–49 [CE I, pp. 96–97]. Here Duns Scotus remits to Aristotle, *Posterior Analytics*, book I, chapter 4, where the notion of first subject effectively appears at 73 b 39. With the occasion of this, we note the energetic affirmation of that passivity of knowledge in regard to its object. *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 2, number 4, vol. I, p. 49: "Objectum autem se habet ad habitum sicut causa ad effectum. . ."—*Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 2, number 5, vol. I, p. 49 [CE I, p. 100]: "Proportio objecti ad potentiam est proportio motivi ad mobile, vel activi ad passivum; proportio subjecti ad habitum est sicut proportio causae ad effectum. . ."

71 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 50 [CE I, p. 101].

72 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 3, number 7, vol. I, p. 51: "soli intellectui increato est essentia increata naturaliter nota." [In CE I, p. 103 "Solus Deus est sibi soli naturaliter notus. . . Omnis essentia creata alicui creato potest esse naturaliter nota; igitur sola essentia increata, soli intellectui increato."]

73 In the following text, whose translation is difficult, the term *signum*, which is familiar to Duns Scotus, is offered to us for the first time. Duns Scotus himself sometimes replaces it by *instans*. (Cf. a little further on: *si intentio instanti naturae*. . .). We could translate it by *moment*, understanding of course that we are not dealing with a moment of time here, but one of an essential order. Nevertheless, it is not a simply ideal, abstract order that our thought introduces into the real, but an order that is intrinsic to the very reality of the essence, which in this case is the essence of God. That said, here is the text, *Opus Oxoninese*, prologue, question 3, article 8, number 23, vol. I, p. 68 [CE I, p. 135]: "Ideo dico aliter, quod divina theologia [*scilicet* the theology of God himself], est de omnibus cognoscibilibus; quia objectum primum theologiae suae [*scilicet* Dei] facit omnia alia actu cognita in intellectu ejus ita quod si in primo signo naturae est essentia sua primo cognita intellectui suo, et in secundo signo naturae quidditates virtualiter continens veritates proprias, in tertio signo sunt istae veritates, virtualiter contentas in illis quidditatibus sibi notae. Non est ordo secundi ad tertium secundum causalitatem, quasi istae quidditates causarent aliquid in intellectu ejus; sed tantum est ordo effectuum [essentialiter] ordinatorum respectu ejusdem causae; puta quod essentia sua quasi prius natura causat illas quidditates sibi notas quam veritates de eis sunt notae." Here, the use of the term *quidditates* should be noted, which Duns Scotus prefers to *essentiae*, no doubt, because here we are dealing with God's absolute knowledge, without regard to creating, which makes the quiddity an essence properly called so.

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 8, number 23, vol. I, pp. 68–69 [CE I, p. 136].

75 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 4, number 11, vol. I, p. 55 [CE. I, p. 109]: "Concedo igitur quartum membrum, scilicet, quod Theologia est de Deo sub ratione qua scilicet est haec essentia, sicut perfectissima scientia de homine esset si esset secundum quod homo, non autem sub aliqua ratione universali vel accidentali."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 4, question 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 485 [CE IV, p. 2]: "Deitas autem est de se *haec*; ergo Deus est de se *hic*."—See also *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 4, question 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 491 [CE IV, pp. 5–7].

76 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 5, number 13, vol. I, p. 57 [CE I, p. 114]: "Ex his ad propositum dico, quod essentia divina est primum subjectum theologiae contingentis, et hoc eodem modo sumpta quo praedictum est ipsam esse subjectum primum theologiae necessariae

[cf. note 75]; et hoc tam hujus theologiae contingentis in se, quam ut est in intellectu divino, quam etiam ut est in intellectu beatorum. Totius igitur theologiae, in se et Dei et beatorum, primum subjectum est essentia divina ut haec. Cujus visio in beatis est sicut in metaphysica cognitio entis; et ideo beata visio non est theologia, sed est quasi perfecta incomplexa apprehensio subjecti, praecedens naturaliter scientiam theologiae."

77 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 8, numbers 23–24, vol. I, p. 69 [CE I, pp. 138–39].

78 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 3, number 21, vol. I, p. 20 [CE I, pp. 37–38]. Cf. prologue, question 3, article 8, number 25, vol. I, p. 70 [CE I, pp. 138–39].—Locke recalls this doctrine or a completely similar one (including St. Paul's case) in *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*, IV, p. 18, 3. Moreover, the objection is classical. St. Augustine already taught that Scripture uses human language.

79 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 8, number 25, vol. I, p. 70 [CE I, p. 138]. However, it will be noted that the text as we have it seems to imply restrictions that are not clearly formulated: "tum propter defectum theologiae nostrae, quia non potest esse cum cognitione evidenti de eisdem cognoscibilibus, secundum aliquos, et per consequens de naturaliter nobis cognitis non potest stare theologia nostra revelata."—Is the point to separate what is revealed from what is naturally knowable or what is naturally known?

80 Duns Scotus extends this conclusion to the relation of image that exists between the soul and God. We cannot naturally know that the soul is the image of the divine nature taken in itself: *sicut sancti loquuntur de imagine*. *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 8, number 25, vol. I, pp. 70–71 [CE I, p. 139].

81 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 4, number 12, vol. I, pp. 55–56 [CE I, pp. 111–12]: "Theologia nostra est habitus non habens evidentiam ex objecto; et etiam illa quae est in nobis de theologicis necessariis non magis, ut in nobis, habet evidentiam ex objecto cognito quam illa quae est de contingentibus; igniter theologiae nostrae ut nostra est, non oportet dare nisi objectum primum notum, de quo noto immediate cognoscantur primae veritates. Illud primum est ens infinitum, quia iste est conceptus perfectissimus quem possumus habere de illo quod est in se primum subjectum, quod tamen neutram praedictam conditionem habet, quis non continet virtualiter habitum nostrum in se, nec multo magis ut nobis notum continet ipsum habitum. Tamen, quia theologia nostra de necessariis est de eisdem de quibus est theologia in se, ideo sibi assignatur primum objectum quoad hoc quod est veritates continere in se, et hoc idem quod est primum subjectum theologiae in se; sed quia illud non est nobis evidens, ideo non est continens istas ut nobis notum, immo non est nobis notum."—On the identity of subject of the two theologies of contingents, see *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 5, number 13, vol. I, p. 57: "Subjectum vero. . ." [I do not find *subjectum vero* in CE I, pp. 112–14.]

82 God's essence seen intuitively *ut haec essentia* includes theological science within it, but the concept of *ens infinitum*, which is its abstract substitute, does not contain it. God as God is singular. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 2, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 141 [CE II, p. 31]: "Haec autem cognitio essentiae divinae distincta est, quia ejus objecti est quod est de se hoc."

83 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, questions 1 and 2, article 4, number 17, vol. I, pp. 313–14 [CE III, p. 40]: "Tamen conceptus perfectior et simplicior, nobis possibilis est conceptus entis simpliciter infiniti. Iste enim est simplicior quam conceptus entis boni vel entis veri, vel aliquorum similium; quia *infinitum* non est quasi attributum vel passio entis sive ejus de quo dicitur, sed dicit modum intrinsecum illius entitatis; ita quod cum dico *infinitum ens*, non habeo

conceptum quasi per accidens ex subjecto et passione, sed conceptum per se subjecti in certo gradu perfectionis, scilicet infinitatis—sicut albedo intensa non dicit conceptum per accidens sicut albedo visiblis, immo intensio dicit gradum intrinsecum albedinis in se. Et ita patet simplicitas hujus conceptus, *ens infinitum*."

84 For example, the author of *Quaestiones Miscellaneae de Formalitatibus*, traditionally attributed to Duns Scotus, question 5, number 24, Vivès edition, vol. V, pp. 396–97. In the same question, see the objections of John of Mont Saint-Eloi, p. 385, against the thesis that holds the concept of *infinite being* to be the most perfect concept of God.

85 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 3, numbers 20–21, vol. I, pp. 19–21 [CE I, pp. 38–39].

86 The strict distinction between theology and philosophy does not exclude revelation being the source of rational knowledge. The distinction only implies that even if rational, knowledge remains theological. In fact, among the marks of truth that he attributes to Holy Scripture, Duns Scotus attaches great importance to what he names "the rationality of its concept." *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 38 [CE I, p. 70; see also pp. 71–73]: "Quid rationabilius quam Deum tamquam finem ultimum super omnia debere diligi et proximum sicut seipsum. . . Ex istis quasi ex principiis practicis alia practica in Scripturis sequuntur tradita, honesta et ratione consona, sicut de eorum rationabilitate patere potest singulatim cuilibet pertractanti de praeceptis, consiliis et sacramentis, quia in omnibus videtur esse quasi quaedam explicatio legis naturae, *quae scripta est in cordibus nostris*." Christians believe in nothing that is unbelievable. Otherwise, it would be unbelievable for the world to believe in Christianity, as, however, it does. Inversely, the "unreasonable" character of paganism, Islam, and Judaism can be shown, as well as the "asinine" character of Manichaeism. Revelation can even make us see the irrational elements of certain philosophical doctrines, because even in Aristotle's politics there is irrationality.—This character of *explication* (i.e., development) of the natural laws undoubtedly lets us understand that in the theoretical order, even something *rational* can be revealed. Therefore, we would have something *rational* that was strictly theological, but still rational, as offering natural reason a satisfaction to which it confusedly aspires without being capable by itself of obtaining it. Let us not forget that *natural object* has two meanings: first, a naturally accessible object; second, an object of a faculty's natural inclination, whether it could naturally attain it or not, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 5, number 33, vol. I, p. 29 [CE I, p. 54]. Revelation can give reason rational satisfaction, by bringing it closer to an object to which it naturally tends, although reason alone cannot attain that object. In other words, rational things that revelation shows human beings fall quite properly within theology, without losing anything of their rationality.

87 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 330 [CE III, pp. 69–70]: "In ista quaestione est una opinio quae dicit quod primum objectum intellectus nostri est quidditas rei materialis, quia potentia proportionatur objecto. Triplex autem est potentia cognitiva: quaedam est omnino separata a materia, et in essendo et in operando, ut intellectus separatus; alia conjuncta materiae in essendo et in operando, ut potentia organica, quae perficit materiam et non operatur nisi mediante organo corporali, a quo in operando non separatur, sicut nec in essendo; alia est conjuncta materiae in essendo solum, sed non utitur organo materiali in operando, ut intellectus noster. Istis autem correspondent absoluta objecta proportionata; nam potentiae omnino separatae, scilicet primae potentiae, correspondere debet quidditas omnino separata a materia; secundae singulare omnino materiale; tertiae ergo correspondet quidditas rei materialis, quae etsi sit in materia, tamen cognoscitur non ut in materia singulari."—In the same sense, cf. Duns Scotus, *Quodlibetales*, XIV, 12 [AW, pp. 326–27]. Compare these texts to Thomas

Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 84, article 7, body of the article at "Hujus autem ratio est. . .," and also I, question 85, article 1, body of article. These two passages inspire Duns Scotus's summary. Cf. especially Duns Scotus, "Primum objectum intellectus nostri est quidditas rei materialis," and *Summa Theologiae* part I, question 84, article 7, body of article: "Intellectus autem humani . . . proprium objectum est quidditas sive natura in materia corporali existens." Also compare, Duns Scotus, "Ratio ponitur ad hoc, quia potentia proportionatur objecto," and *Summa Theologiae*, *ibidem*: "Hujus autem ratio est, quia potentia cognoscitiva proportionatur cognoscibili." The tripartite picture of relations faculty of knowledge-object is taken from *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 85, article 1, body of the article: "Est autem triplex gradus cognoscitivae virtutis. . ." and so on.

88 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 84, article 7, opening of body of article.

89 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, number 4, vol. I, p. 332 [CE III, p. 75].

90 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, number 3, vol. I, p. 332 [CE III, p. 73].

91 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 330 [CE III, p. 70]: "Contra: istud non potest sustineri a theologo; quia intellectus existens eadem potentia, naturaliter cognoscit per se quidditatem substantiae immaterialis, sicut patet secundum fidem de anima beata. Potentia autem manens eadem non potet habere actum circa aliquid quod non contientur sub suo primo objecto."—An object that is first and of itself an object is defined by *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 2, article 2, number 7, vol. I, p. 142 [CE II, p. 33]: "Et vocatur hic *objectum* primum totum illud ad quod terminatur actus potentiae, et *objectum* per se illud quod includitur per se unitive in objecto terminante primo."—Understood in this way, the first object of our intellect, which is being, does not include God *qua* God. This is so true that Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. I, p. 304 [CE III, p. 2], interprets Gregory the Great's gloss on Ezek. 2:3, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. LXXVI, p. 956: "Quantumcumque mens nostra in contemplatione Dei profecerit, non ad illud quod ipse est, sed ad illud quod sub ipso est attingit."—Duns Scotus concurs. Even contemplative knowledge does not penetrate beyond being. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 5, number 20, vol. I, p. 318 [CE III, p. 47]: "Contemplatio autem, de lege communi [that is to say, except in the Pauline *raptus*] stat in aliquo conceptu qui est minoris intelligibilitatis quam Deus in se ut est haec essentia. Et ideo debet intelligi ad aliquid quod est sub Deo, hoc est, ad aliquid in ratione intelligibilis cujus intelligibilitas est inferior intelligibilitate Dei in se, ut haec essentia singularis."

92 The Scotist *De Anima*, question 11, numbers 2–4, Vivès edition, vol. III, pp. 599–600, expounds the doctrine of *Opus Oxoniense* even more clearly. See article 2: "Ergo Deus saltem continetur sub objecto viatoris, non autem sub quidditate materiali; igitur etc.; articulo 3: igitur Deus non excedit potentiam intellectivam nostram."—The mere existence of metaphysics, the science of being as being, would be enough to prove this point: "Praeterea intellectus noster, etiam in via, potest cognoscere ens sub ratione entis, quae est objectum adaequatum intellectus nostri." Authentic or not, this passage, *De Anima*, article 4, p. 600, exactly expresses Duns Scotus's thinking. This is to say that we agree entirely with the note in which Cyril Louis Shircel, *The Univocity*, p. 60, believes he disagrees with us. The phrase he is discussing possesses a sense different from the one he attributes to it. It suffices that univocity, like analogy, does not permit the intellect to attain the beatific vision naturally. Doubtless, Shircel will agree with us in exonerating Duns Scotus of any suspicion of ontologism.

93 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 330 [CE III, p. 71].

94 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 330.—It

should be noted that from this moment, Duns Scotus enters onto a path that leads to his metaphysical doctrine of being. Just as the human intellect is a faculty capable both of abstraction and of intelligible intuition, being, which is its first object, must be able to be said in the same sense about sensible being and about intelligible being. The proper object of metaphysics is consequently *ens commune*, in the peculiarly Scotist sense that will be clarified below.

95 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 4, number 24, vol. I, p. 351 [CE III, pp. 112–13]: "Sed restat unum dubium. Si ens secundum rationem suam communissimam sit primum objectum intellectus, quare non potest quodcumque contentum sub ente naturaliter movere intellectum, sicut fuit argutum in prima ratione ad primam quaestionem in Prologo? Et tunc videtur quod Deus naturaliter posset cognosci a nobis, et substantiae omnes immateriales, quod negatum est; immo negatum est de omnibus substantiis et de omnibus partibus essentialibus substantiarum, quia dictum est quod non concipiuntur in aliquo conceptu quidditativo, nisi in conceptu entis. Respondeo: objectum primum potentiae assignatur illud quod adaequatur potentiae in ratione potentiae, non autem quod adaequatur potentiae ut in aliquo statu. Quemadmodum primum objectum visus non ponitur illud quod adaequatur visui existenti in medio illuminato lumine candelae praecise, sed quod natum est adaequari visiui ex se, quantum est de natura sui. Nunc autem . . . nihil potest adaequari intellectui nostro ex natura potentiae in ratione primi objecti nisi communissimum. Tamen pro isto statu ei adaequatur in ratione motivi quidditas rei sensibilis; et ideo pro statu isto non naturaliter intelliget alia quae non continentur sub illo primo motivo."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 28, pp. 422–23 [CE III, pp. 305–06.].The Scotist concept of *nature* thus combines the concepts of Augustine and Thomas Aquinas. *Natural* is both what is according to a nature and what is according to a nature given its state. The fact that the sensible has become our natural object *pro statu isto*, does not prevent the intelligible also being, in principle, the object of our intellect.

96 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 4, number 24, vol. I, pp. 351–52 [CE III, pp. 113–15]: "Stabilitum est autem illis legibus sapientiae, quod intellectus noster non intelligat pro statu isto nisi illa quorum species relucent in phantasmate, et hoc sive propter poenam originalis peccati, sive propter naturalem concordantiam potentiarum animae in operando, secundum quod videmus quod potentia superior operatur circa idem circa quod inferior, si utraque habeat operationem perfectam. Et de facto ita est in nobis, quod quodcumque universale intelligimus ejus singulare actu phantasiamur. Ista tamen concordia, quae est de facto pro statu isto, non est ex natura nostri intellectus unde intellectus est, nec etiam unde in corpore est; tunc enim in corpore glorioso necessario haberet similem concordantiam, quod falsum est."—Cf. Efrem Bettoni, *L'ascesa*, pp. 83–84.

97 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 45, question 2, number 9.

98 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 4, number 24, vol. I, p. 352 [CE III, p. 114]: "Utcumque igitur sit iste status, sive ex mera voluntate Dei, sive ex mera justitia punitiva, sive ex infirmitate [CE lacks *ex infirmitate*], quam causam Augustinus innuit XV *De Trinitate*, capitulo ultimo: *quae causa*, inquit, *cur ipsam lucem acie fixa videre non possis, nisi utique infirmitas? et quid eam tibi fecit, nisi utique iniquitas?* Sive, inquam, haec sit tota causa, sive aliqua alia; saltem non est primum objectum intellectus, unde potentia est, quidditas rei materialis, sed est aliquid commune ad omnia intelligiblia, licet primum objectum adaequatum, sibi in movendo, pro statu isto, sit quidditas rei sensibilis."—Cf. Augustine, *De Civitate* Dei, book XV, chapter 27, 50, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, p. 1097.

99 See, notably, Olivi's doctrine in Bernhard Jansen, S. J., *Die Erkenntnislehre Olivis* (Berlin: Ferd. Dümmlers Verlagsbuchhandlung, 1921), chapter 9, "Die *Colligantia* der Seelenkräfter."

100 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction [number omitted], question 4, number 2.

101 The problem is posed again for Duns Scotus in relation to the soul's knowledge of itself. He responds exactly in the same spirit on this subject: "quod anima de se intelligibilis est, et praesens sibi." But then why does the soul not always apprehend itself? There is an obstacle to that, says Augustine. Then Scotus continues, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 13, vol. II, p. 298 [CE VII, pp. 535–37]: "Sed quod est istud impedimentum? Respondeo: intellectus noster pro statu isto non est natus moveri immediate, nisi ab aliquo imaginabili vel sensibili extra prius moveatur. Et quare hoc? Forte propter peccatum sicut videtur Augustinus dicere XV *De Trinitate*, capitulo ultimo: *Hoc tibi fecit infirmitas. Et quae causa infirmitatis nisi iniquitas?* Idem dicit Commentator VI *Ethicae*, et Lincolniensis ibidem et *Super I Posterioris* similiter. Vel forte ista causa est naturalis, prout natura isto modo instituta est, non absolute naturalis: puta si ordo iste potentiarum de quo dictum est in I [cf. note 96 above in this chapter] diffuse, necessario hoc requirat, quod quodcumque universale intellectus intelligat, oportet phantasiam actu phantasiare singulare ejusdem; sed hoc non est ex natura, nec ista causa est absolute naturalis, sed est ex peccato, et non solum ex peccato, sed etiam ex natura potentiarum, pro statu isto, quidquid dicat Augustinus."—The commentator on *Ethics*, book VI, to whom Duns Scotus remits here, is identified by the text of *Quaestiones de Anima*, cited below in this chapter note 103, where the references are more complete.—Cavellus, *Commentary on De Anima*, question 18, number 11, *dubium*, Vivès edition, vol. III, p. 598, concludes that nothing can be affirmed about Duns Scotus's definitive thought: "nihil, ut certum, occurrit dicendum." Cavellus himself seems to prefer the explanation by original sin, and, as he realizes that, if this explanation is good, the Blessed Virgin must have been capable of thinking without images in virtue of her immaculate conception, Cavellus concludes without hesitating: "Cum igitur potissimos effectus justitiae originalis habuerit Beata Virgo, juxta sententiam tenentem quod in statu innocentiae non esset conversio ad phantasmata, hoc tribuendum est Virgini, cum sit perfectius, neque constet de opposito. . ."—On the position of Robert Grosseteste, see Étienne Gilson, "Pourquoi saint Thomas a critiqué saint Augustin," *Archive d'histoire littéraire et doctrinale du moyen âge* I (1926), p. 96, note 1.

102 Hieronymus de Montefortino, *Summa Theologica*, I, question 12, article *incidens*, body of article. For example: "Respondeo dicendum primo, objectum motivum nostri intellectus pro praesenti statu naturae lapsae, esse quidditatem rei materialis, vel forte specialius quidditatem rei sensibilis, intelligendo non de sensibili proprie solum, sed etiam de incluso essentialiter vel virtualiter in sensibili."

103 Scotus, *Quaestiones de Anima*, question 18, number 4: "Ideo, omissis aliis necessitatibus, dicunt alii, quod non est contra rationem actus intelligendi intellectus nostri absolute intelligere sine phantasmate, quia recursus ad phantasmata esset necessarius animae separatae ut dictum est, nec contra rationem ejus ut est corpori unitus absolute, quia hoc esset necessarium sibi unito corpori glorioso post resurrectionem, quod falsum est; nec contra rationem ejus ut viator est, vel conjunctus corpori in via, quia hoc etiam esset necessarium homini in statu innocentiae, qui tunc fuit viator; hoc autem falsum est. cum anima ejus quantum ad actum ejus proprium in nullo fuisset corpori subjecta, sed super ipsum et sensus suos, tam quod apprehensionem quam quoad appetitum, habuisset plenum dominium, ita quod potuisset intellexisse sine phantasmate vel cum phantasmate, sicut sibi placuissset. Sed dicunt quod necessitas recurrendi ad phantasmata est nobis inflicta propter peccatum. Unde sequitur ad ignorantiam nobis inflictam, et hoc juste, quia ex eo quod anima se deordinavit, dimittendo divinum dominium et se ab ejus subtrahendo subjectione, rationabile fuit in poenam hanc incidere, et amittere dominium proprium quod habebat super corpus suum et super sensum. Et haec est sententia beati Augustini in pluribus locis, et Hugonis super antiquam Hierarchiam (*Patrologia Latina*, vol. CLXXV, p. 925). Eustathii super librum

Ethicorum (*Commentaria in Aristotelem Graeca*, ed. Gustav Heylbut [Royal Literary Academy of Prussia, Berlin: Reimer, 1892], vol. XX, p. 4, 26–38) et Lincolnienis super librum *Posteriorum*, super illud verbum: Deficiente nobis uno sensu, necesse est nobis deficere scientiam secundum illum sensum [Libro I, capitulo 14, tomo 81]. Aristoteles autem, quia nihil scivit de peccato illo et invenit naturam taliter dispositam, procedens ex sensu tantum, credidit hoc nobis esse naturale sicut intelligitur; et ideo hoc posuit absolute, quia necesse est ad phantasmata recurrere volentem intelligere."—According to Duns Scotus, this is why no sacrament was necessary for human beings in the state of original innocence, because the sacraments are sensible signs. He says, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 3, number 7 [CE XI, p. 85]: "Tunc non indiget homo sensibilibus, ut cognoscat intelligibilia pertinentia ad salutem suam." Certainly, "tunc homo potuerit ex sensibilibus cognoscere intelligibilia," but human beings could also have done without them. [The second phrase is not in CE.] This position completely coincides with the text of *Quaestiones de Anima*.

104 St. Thomas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 89, article 1, body of the article, maintained that it is as natural for the soul to know by using the phantasm, as it is for it to be united to this body: "Unde modus intelligendi per conversionem ad phantasmata est animae naturalis sicut et corpori uniri; sed esse separatam a corpore est praeter rationem suae naturae et similiter intelligere sine conversione ad phantasmata est ei praeter naturam."—The intuition of the intelligibles is natural for angels, not human beings. For Duns Scotus, the opposite is true, *Quodlibet*, p. 14, 12 [AW, pp. 326–27]: "Dico igitur quod objectum naturale, hoc est naturaliter attingibile, adaeqatum intellectui nostri, etsi pro statu isto sit quidditas rei materialis, vel forte adhuc specialis quidditas rei sensibili, intelligendo non de sensibili proprie solum sed etiam de incluso essentialiter vel virtualiter in sensibili, tamen objectum adaequatum intellectui nostro ex natura potentia non est aliquid specialius objecto intellectus angelici, quia quidquid potest intelligi ab uno, et ab alio; et hoc saltem concedere debet theologus qui ponit istum statum non esse naturalem nec istam impotentiam intelligendi multorum intelligibilium esse naturalem, sed poenalem, juxta illud XV *De Trinitate*, 27. . . . Tamen Philosophus qui statum istum diceret simpliciter naturalem homini, nec alium expertus erat nec ratione conclusit, diceret forte illud esse objectum adaequatum intellectus humani simpliciter ex natura talis potentiae, quod percepit sibi esse adaequatum pro statu isto."—The same remark is made regarding the soul's aptitude to know itself, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 14, vol. II, p. 298 [CE VII, p. 537]: "Ista causa quae est ex parte angeli est sufficiens ad hoc quod essentia angeli sit sufficiens ratio intelligendi seipsam, etiam ipsa talis est ex parte animae, sed in anima sunt impedimenta, in angelo non; non enim intellectus angeli habet talem ordinem ad imaginabilia, sicut habet intellectus noster pro statu isto. Et propter istam impotentiam intelligendi immediate intelligibilia in actu, quae impotentia non est ex impossibilitate intrinseca sed extrinseca, quam etiam experiebatur Philosophus et non aliquam possibilitatem, ideo dixit Philosophus quod intellectus non est aliquod intelligibilium ante intelligere, id est: non possibile intelligi a se ante intelligere aliorum."

105 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam* (translator: the full title is *Quaestiones Subtilissimae in Metaphysicam Aristotelis*) book VII, question 4, number 3 (pp. 114–15 in Girard J. Etzkorn and Allan B. Wolter, O.F.M., *Questions on the Metaphysics of Aristotle by John Duns Scotus*, vol. II, books six–nine [St. Bonaventure, NY: Franciscan Institute Publications, 1998]). (Henceforth EW II.) Let us remember that this first knowable is *ens commune*. This is why metaphysics does not have God as its direct and first object, because the only science that deals directly with God is theology. As the science of common being and its properties, metaphysics stands in the same relation to theology as to physics. Everything true of being in general is true of physical being as being. Everything that is true of being in general is true of God insofar as he is being, plus what is

true of the first and necessary being. Therefore, metaphysics is presupposed by theology as the science of being is presupposed by every science about a particular being. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 7, number 20, vol. I, p. 65 [CE I, pp. 129–130].—Lastly, let us note that being is the first knowable in the order of knowledge. This is why metaphysics is the last of the sciences in the order of teaching, since the intellect proceeds from the most particular known confusedly to the most common known distinctly. See *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 22, vol. I, pp. 319–21 [CE III, pp. 50–51].

106 Scotus *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book II, question 3, number 21: [EW I, p. 195, number 93] "Primus habitus potentiae habet pro objecto objectum primum potentiae primi habitus; ut metaphysicae objectum primum est ens inquantum ens."—This is deciphered as follows: the first knowable acquired by a faculty has as its object the first object of the faculty under whose purview the knowable falls. So, in the present case, since metaphysics falls under the purview of the intellect, whose first object is being, the first object of metaphysics is also being.

107 They are also the *maxime scibilia*, precisely, "quia primo omnium sciunur, sine quibus non possunt alia sciri." Duns Scotus adds, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, prologue, number 5 [EW I, p. 7, number 17]: "Maxime scibilia primo modo sunt communissima, ut est ens in quantum ens et quaecumque sequuntur ens inquantum ens. Dicit enim Avicenna I *Metaphysicae*, capitulo 6, *quod ens et res imprimuntur in anima prima impressione quae non acquiritur ex aliis notioribus se*. Et infra: *quae priora sunt ad imaginandum per seipsa, sunt ea quae communia sunt omnibus sicut res et ens et unum*, et ideo non potest manifestari aliquod horum per probationem quae non sit circularis. Haec autem communissima pertinent ad considerationem metaphysicae secundum Philosophum in IV hujus in principio: *Est enim scientia quae speculatur ens inquantum est ens*. . ."

108 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, prologue number 9 [EW I, p. 10, number 27]: "Hoc est metaphysica secundum se scibilis, non tamen sic eam scimus, nec sic invenitur ab Aristotele tradita: quaere si in toto libro invenias unam demonstrationem metaphysicam propter quid, quia propter impotentiam intellectus nostri ex sensibilibus et minus notis secundum se, devenimus in cognitionem immaterialium, quae secundum se notiora sunt et tanquam principia cognoscendi, alia in metaphysica essent accipienda."—Therefore, not only in *our* theology, but also in *our* metaphysics, as we have it *pro statu isto*, our demonstrations, although necessary, are not evident. If human beings were still in their first state, the demonstrations could be evident, and they would not be demonstrations *quia*, but *propter quid*. It is simply a fact that they are not. See Charles Reginald Schiller Harris, *Duns Scotus*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1927, 2 vols. (Reprint Bristol: Thoemmes Press, 1994), vol. II, p. 379, for the distinction between *metaphysica in se* and *in nobis*. Cf. Harris, *Duns Scotus*, p. 384, "Secundo. . ."

109 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 3.

110 Without another passage, we would not suspect that Duns Scotus lets himself be guided here by Augustine, *De Libero Arbitrio*, III, 25, 74, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XXXII, p. 1307. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 17, vol. I, p. 412 [CE III, p. 234], where he quotes the "non est in potestate nostra quin visis tangamur."

111 Definition of these terms, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 28, vol. I, pp. 323–24 [CE III, p. 60]: "*Habitualem* [notitiam] voco, quando objectum sic est praesens intellectui in ratione intelligibilis actu, ut intellectus statim possit habere actum elicitum circa illud [objectum]. *Virtualem* voco, quando aliquid intelligitur in aliquo ut pars intellecti primi, non autem ut primum intellectum sive ut totale terminans intellectionem: sicut cum intelligitur *homo*, intelligitur *animal* in homine ut pars intellecti, ut non intellectum primum sive totale terminans intellectionem."

112 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 28, vol. I, pp. 323–24 [CE III, pp. 60–61]. Cf. *Quaestiones de Anima*, question 16, 3–5.

113 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 29, vol. I, p. 325 [CE III, p. 62]: "Loquendo ergo de ordine cognitionis *perfectioris simpliciter*, dico quod perfectissimum cogoscibile a nobis etiam naturaliter est Deus; unde in hoc etiam ponit Philosophus felicitatem naturalem, X *Ethicae*; et post ipsum species specialissima perfectior in universo; et deinde species proxima illi, et sic usque ad ultimam speciem; et post omnes species specialissimas genus proximum abstrahibile a specie perfectissima, et sic semper resolvendo."—The most knowable object in relation to us, *pro statu isto*, is the intelligible abstracted from the sensible, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 30, vol. I, p. 326 [CE III, p. 63].—As for God, Aristotle is right to posit him as the most perfect knowable object in himself, but that does not mean he is the *adequate* object of out intellect, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 30, p. 327 [CE III, p. 64, number 100]. See *Quaestiones de Anima*, question 16, number 6, regarding God as first knowable in the order of perfection.

114 Duns Scotus took up the overall question again in *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1. Taking the side of Avicenna against Averroes, he successively proves that no science proves the existence of its own subject; that metaphysics can prove God's existence as first being; that God is therefore not the subject of metaphysics but of theology [KR 1-A, p. 60, lines 41–42; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 77, number 219]: "Igitur nulla scientia naturaliter acquisita potest esse de Deo sub aliqua ratione propria."—For the opposing view, see Averroes, *Epitomes in libros Metaphysicae*, Venice: apud Juntas, 1574, tractate I, vol. VIII, p. 367.

115 See the remarkable observations in Harry Austryn Wolfson, "Notes on Proofs of the Existence of God in Jewish Philosophy," *Hebrew Union College Annual* I (1924), pp. 575–96.

116 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 1, folio 70 recto b: "Constat autem quod omnis scientia habet subjectum suum proprium. Inquiramus ergo quid sit subjectum hujus scientiae, et consideremus an subjectum hujus scientiae sit ipse Deus excelsus. Sed non est: imo ipse est unum de his quae quaeruntur in hac scientia. Dico ergo impossibile esse ut ipse Deus sit subjectum hujus scientiae, quoniam subjectum omnis scientiae est res quae conceditur esse et ipsa scientia non inquirit nisi dispositiones illius subjecti et hoc notum est ex aliis locis. Sed non potest concedi quod Deus sit in haec scientia ut subjectum, imo quaesitum est in ea. . . Postquam autem inquiritur in hac scientia an sit, tunc non potest esse subjectum hujus scientiae; nulla enim scientiarum debet stabilire esse sum subjectum."

117 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, I, question 3, article 1, number 3, vol. I, p. 47 [CE I, p. 93: "Idem Commentator, *I Physicorum*, ultimo commento, dicit quod Avicenna multum peccavit ponendo metaphysicam probare primam causam esse, cum genus substantiarum separatarum sit ibi subjectum, et nulla scientia probat suum subjectum esse; sed ratio illa Averrois non valeret, nisi intelligeret quod Deus esset primum subjectum ibi; ergo, etc Ad Commentatorum *I Physicorum* dico, quod Avicenna, cui contradixit, bene dixit, et commentator male." See also *Opus Oxoniense* prologue, I, question 3, article 7, number 21, vol. I, p. 65 [CE I, p. 130], and *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1: "Sed videtur mihi Avicennam melius dixisse quam Averroem." [KR 1-A, p. 59, and *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 75, number 215: "Sed Avicenna bene dicit et Averroes valde male."]

118 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 4 [EW II, p. 81, number 3]: "Contra Averroem: ex quolibet effectu ostenditur causam esse, quia impossibile est effectum esse nisi a causa tali, sive nisi talis causa sit; hujusmodi sunt multi passiones metaphysicae, *prius* et *posterius*, *unum* et *multa*, *actus* et *potentia*; quomodo haec causatis insunt, nisi sit aliquod unum

primum?”—Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, I, question 3, article 7, number 21, vol. I, p. 66 [CE I, p. 131, number 194]: “. . .omnem conditionem effectus potest demonstrari de causa quia est, quam impossibile est esse in effectu nisi causa sit; sed multae passiones considerantur in metaphysica quas impossibile est inesse nisi ab aliqua causa prima talium entium; ergo ex illis passionibus metaphysicis potest demonstrari aliquam primam causam istorum entium esse.”—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1 [KR 1-A, p. lines 53–54; *Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 75–77, numbers 214–18].

119 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, I, question 1, number 23 [EW I, p. 34, number 76]: “Ens inquantum ens potest habere passionem aliquam, quae est extra essentiam ejus inquantum est ens; sicut esse *unum* vel *multa*, *actus* vel *potentia* est essentiam cujuslibet inquantum est ens sive *quid* in se.”

120 Duns Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 4, number 3 [EW II, p. 83, number 10]: “Tenetur igitur Avicenna [*scilicet* quod metaphysica sit de ente]. Prima ratio ejus sic declaratur: si est praesupponitur de subjecto, non de actuali existentia, sed quod habet esse quidditativum, scilicet quod ratio ejus non est falsa in se. Tale *si est* ostenditur demonstratione quia a metaphysico de primo ente. Ostenditur enim, quod primum convenit enti alicui, et ita quia ille conceptus, ens primum, qui est perfectissimus subjecti, si esset hic subjectum, non includit contradictionem. Ergo si aliqua scientia supponeret istum conceptum pro subjecto, alia esset prior de ente, quae probaret praecendentem, de primo ente, quia conclusio demonstrationis illius esset prior tota scientia de primo ente.”—Cf. Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate 1, chapter 2, folio 70 verso b: “Igitur ostensum est tibi ex his omnibus quod ens inquantum ens commune est hiis omnibus [This is the text cited by the Scotists to justify the attribution of univocity of being to Avicenna.] et quod ipsum debet poni subjectum hujus magisterii, et quod non eget inquiri an sit et quid sit, quasi alia scientia praeter hanc debeat assignare dispositionem ejus, ob hoc quod inconveniens est ut stabiliat unum subjectum an sit et certificet quid sit scientia cujus ipsum est subjectum, sed potius debe concedere tantum quia est et quid est. Ideo primum subjectum hujus scientiae est ens inquantum est ens, et ea quae inquirit sunt consequentia ens inquantum est ens sine conditione aliqua.”

121 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 1, number 3, vol. I, pp. 331–32 [CE III, pp. 72–73]: “Nulla potentia potest cognoscere objectum aliquod sub ratione communiori quam sub ratione sui primi objecti. . . sed intellectus cognoscit aliquod sub ratione communiori quam sit ratio entis materialis, quia cognoscit aliquid sub ratione entis in communi, alioquin metaphysica nulla esset scientia intellectui nostro. Praeterea. . . quidquid per se cognoscitur a potentia cognitiva vel est objectum primum, vel continetur sub illo objecto: ens autem, ut est communius sensibili, per se intelligitur ab intellectu nostro, alias metaphysica non esset magis scientia transcendent quam physica; ergo non potest aliquid esse primum objectum intellectus nostri quod sit particularius ente, quia tunc ens in se nullo modo intelligeretur a nobis.”

122 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 4, number 1 [EW II, pp. 81–82, number 4]: “Item perfectior conceptus de Deo possibilis physico est primum movens, possibilis autem metaphysico, est primum ens; secundus [*scilicet* conceptus] est perfectior tum quia absolutus, tum quia requirit perfectionem infinitam: nam primum perfectissimum [because being first in the order of being is being absolutely perfect.] Sed si enti non repugnat infinitas, non est perfectissimum quod non est infinitum; sed enti non repugnat infinitas. Primum movens tantum respectum dicit et non necessario ex formali ratione sui requirit infinitatem. Qui autem habet perfectiorem conceptum de subjecto, potest perfectius de ipso ostendere, quia per illa in effectibus quae ducunt ad cognoscendum esse de tali conceptu.”—*Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 7, number 20, vol. I, p. 66 [CE I, p. 131]: “Multo etiam perfectius ostenditur prima causa esse ex

passionibus causatorum consideratis in metaphysica, quam ex passionibus naturalibus ubi ostenditur primum movens esse; perfectior enim cognitio et immediator de primo ente est cognoscere ipsum ut primum ens, vel ut necesse esse, quam cognocere ipsum ut primum movens."—Let us note once more the gradation of knowledges about God accessible to different sciences: physics, *primum movens*; metaphysics, *primum ens*; theology, *ens infinitum*.

123 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, I, question 1, number 44 [EW I, pp. 54–55, number 145; Vivès, vol. VII, p. 34]: "Nec etiam ratio ista primi moventis, ut sit de aliqua ratione ad quam pervenit naturalis, quia quamvis in eodem concurrant primitas movendi et essendi, tamen ex ratione ipsorum non includitur contradictio quod non necessario eidem inessent, et ita nunquam naturalis ostendit primum ens esse, nisi per accidens; ita quod non ostendit aliquod ens esse primum, sed aliquod movens esse primum; sic nec aliquod ens esse ultimum, sed aliquod ultimum motum."

124 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 4, number 2 [EW II, p. 82, number 5]: "Confirmetur: si metaphysicus non consideraret *esse* de Deo nisi sicut demonstratur a physico, non cognosceret nisi de primo movente et ita non haberet aliquam notitiam quod subjectum suum est, quia primum movens non est suum subjectum, non sequitur: primum movens, ergo primum ens, sicut non sequitur: prima nigredo, ergo primus color; nec physicus potest per ipsum ostendere de primo ente, amota ratione primi moventis. Quomodo autem de movente ostenderet physicus primo, nisi in hoc sit magis metaphysicus propter praedicatum, quam physicus propter subjectum?"—By not situating himself in the standpoint of the movement's very existence, as Thomas Aquinas had done, Duns Scotus has the right to admit that the *first mover* is not necessarily the *first being*.

125 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1 [KR 1-A, p. 60; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 76, number 218]: "Ideo dico quantum ad istum articulum, quod Deus non est subjectum in metaphysica, quia sicut probatum est supra quaestione I de Deo tanquam ut primo subjecto tantum est una scientia, quae non est metaphysica."—Moreover, this is why, unlike Thomas Aquinas, Duns Scotus refuses to "subalternate" metaphysics to theology. For there to be subalternation properly speaking, our metaphysical science of being would have to be deducible *a priori* from our theological knowledge of God, which is not the case. See *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 10, number 29, vol. I, p. 74 [CE I, pp. 146–147]; also *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 4. [KR 1-A, p. 70. KR does not number the *quaestionunculae*, but it is his seventh. *Reportatio 1-A* I counts it as number seven, p. 87.]

126 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1 [KR 1-A, p. 60, lines 40–42; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 77, number 219, does not have *viatoris*, but adds "in this life."]: "Sed nulla ratio propria Dei conceptibilis a nobis statim apprehenditur ab intellectu viatoris; igitur nulla scientia naturaliter acquisita potest esse de Deo sub aliqua ratione propria."—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 3 [probably KR 1-A, pp. 66–67, the first quaestionuncula; *Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 62–63, numbers 234–37].

127 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue I, question 3, article 7, number 20, vol. I, p. 65 [CE I, p. 130]: "Cum vero probatur quod scientia metaphysica est de Deo per Philosophum VI *Metaphysicae*, dico quod ratio ejus sic concludit: 'nobilisssima scientia est circa nobillisimum genus,' vel ut primum objctum, vel ut consideratum in scientia illa perfectissimo modo quo potest considerari in aliqua scientia naturaliter acquisita. Deus autem etsi non est primum subjectum in metaphysica, est tamen consideratum in illa scientia nobilissimo modo quo potest in aliqua scientia considerari naturaliter acquisita."—Even spiritual contemplation with the exception of *raptus*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, article 5, number 20, vol. I, p. 318 [CE III, p. 47]: ". . .stat in tali conceptu communi, et ideo stat in aliquo conceptu qui est minoris intelligibilitatis quam

Deus in se ut haec essentia. . .”

128 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1, regarding Aristotle’s thesis that metaphysics inquires *circa causas altissimas* [KR 1-A, p. 61, lines 52–54, has “sicut *de* causae materialis”; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 77, number 218]: “Unde *circa* proprie notat circumstantiam causae finalis sicut et causae materialis: unde metaphysica est circa altissimas causas finaliter, ad quorum cognitionem terminatur scientia metaphysicalis.”—The highest causes, not this highest cause, which is God *ut hic*.

129 Scotus *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 7, number 18 [CE I, pp. 127–28]: “. . . omne attributum ut hoc [*scilicet* as an attribute of this singular essence that is God] potest per se sciri theologice de Deo, licet aliquod ut confuse cognitum sit metaphysice cognitum de ipso; sicut enim Deus ut sic et sic, hoc est ut hic [*sicilicet* as *essentia haec ut singularis*], et ut confuse cognitum, pertinet ad theologicum et metaphysicum, sic et quodlibet attributum sic et sic sumptum [est quasi consideratio attributorum naturaliter a nobis intelligibilium est consideratio metaphysica; non sic autem attributa tantum convenientia huic essentiae ut haec, et non ei ut a nobis nunc naturaliter intelligitur, scilicet confuse—bracketed in CE].”—Let us note that this confused knowledge of God by the metaphysician really comes under metaphysics but only in a secondary way, *secundum quid*, because the proper object of metaphysics is direct *a priori* knowledge of being, not confused a posteriori acknowledgment of God, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 1, numbers 10 and 11 [Probably, KR 1-A, p. 66, lines 11–13, 22–23, and p. 67, lines 27–30; *Reportatio I-A*, p. 83, numbers 235–37]. This is why, as the science of a distinct object known in a distinct way, metaphysical knowledge does not have its *cause* in theological knowledge and is not strictly subalternated to it.

130 On this overall problem, see Fr. Joseph Owens, C. Ss.R., “Up to What Point is God Included in the Metaphysics of Duns Scotus?” *Medieval Studies* X (1948), pp. 163–77.

131 We allow ourselves to remit to “Avicenna et le point de départ de Duns Scot,” in *Archives d’histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* II (1927). On the overall question, see Cyril Louis Shircel, *The Univocity*.

132 Cf. Avicenna, *Logica*, part I, folio 2 recto b, in *Opera*, Venice, 1508.

133 Avicenna, *Logica*, part I, folio 2 recto b: “Essentiae vero rerum aut sunt in ipsis rebus aut sunt in intellectu; unde habent tres respectus.”

134 Avicenna, *Logica*, part I, folio 3 verso b: “Dicemus ergo quod omne quod est essentiam habet, qua est id quod est, et qua est ejus necessitas, et qua est ejus esse.”

135 Avicenna, *Logica*, part III, folio 12 recto a: “Animal est in se quiddam, et idem est utrum sit sensible aut sit intellectum in anima. In se autem hujus nec est universale nec est singulare. Si enim in se esset universale, ita quod animalitas, ex hoc quod est animalitas, esset universale, oporteret nullum animal esse singulare, sed omne animal esset universale. Si autem animal, ex hoc quod est animal, esset singulare, impossibile esset esse plus quam unum singulare, scilicet ipsum singulare cui debetur animalitas, et esset impossibile aliud singulare esse animal. Animal autem in se est quiddam intellectum in mente quod sit animal, et secundum hoc quod intelligitur esse animal non est nisi animal tantum. Si autem praeter hoc intelligitur esse universale aut singulare aut aliquid aliud, jam intelligitur praeter hoc quoddam, scilicet id quod est animal, quod accidit animalitati.”—Cf. Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1 folio 86 verso a: “Nam ipsum [*scilicet* animal] ex animalitate sua tantum est animal. Intentio vero animalis, ex hoc quod est animal, est praeter intentionem proprii et communis, nec sunt intrantia in suam quidditatem. Cum ergo ita sit, tunc animal ex hoc quod est animal, nec est proprium nec commune ex sua animalitate, sed est animal, non aliud aliquid a se de dispositionibus, sed consequitur ipsum esse

proprium vel commune."—In *natures* of this kind, Duns Scotus is going to see the result of an *abstractio ultima*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 5, question 1, number 7, vol. I, p. 508 [CE IV, p. 22]: "quando aliquid est abstractum ultima abstractione, ita quod est abstractum ab omni eo quod est extra rationem ejus."—See note 136.

136 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1, folio 86 verso a: "Individuum vero est hoc quod non potest intelligi posse praedicari de multis sicut substantia Platonis hujus designati. Impossibile est enim intelligi hanc esse nisi ipsius tantum. Ergo universale ex hoc quod est universale est quoddam, et ex hoc quod est quiddam cui accidit universalitas est quiddam aliud; ergo de universali ex hoc quod est universale constitutum, signatur unus praedicatorum terminorum; quia cum ipsum fuerit *homo* vel *equus*, erit haec intentio alia praeter intentionem universalitatis, quae est *humanitas* vel *equinitas*. Definitio enim equinitatis est praeter definitionem universalitatis, nec universalitas continetur in diffinitione equinitatis. Equinitas etenim habet diffinitionem quae non eget universalitate, sed est cui accidit universalitas, unde ipsa equinitas non est aliquid nisi equinitas tantum. Ipsa enim ex se nec est multa nec unum, nec est existens in his sensiblibus nec in anima, nec est aliquod horum potentia vel effectu, ita ut hoc contineatur intra essentiam equinitatis."—Cf. Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 5, number 7, vol. I, p. 389 [CE III, p. 185], where there is an allusion to that passage. See also number 13, p. 394 [CE III, p. 195], and further on, I, distinction 5, question 1, number 6, vol. I, p. 507 [CE IV, p. 20], where this concept is presented as a case of *abstractio* ultima, that is *maxima*, where the formal quiddity of the substance or nature is abstracted from its supposits.

137 On this point, consult the useful study by Timotheus Barth, O.F.M, *De Fundamento Univocationis apud Joannem Duns Scotum* (Rome: Pontificio Ateneo Antonianum, 1939). By the same author see "Zum Problem der Eindeutigkeit. Ein Beitrag zum Verständnis ihrer Entwicklung von Aristoteles über Porphyrius, Boëthius, Thomas von Aquin nach Duns Skotus," *Philosophisches Jahrbuch* LV (1942), pp. 300–21; regarding Duns Scotus himself, see pp. 310–21. The "novelty" that Barth attributes to Duns Scotus (p. 312) perhaps would appear to be a radical innovation, if it were compared to Avicenna's doctrine on the same point. Perhaps the evolution that Barth tries to uncover in Duns Scotus's thinking is more apparent than real here. If univocity is the metaphysical state of being, it is natural that univocity would hardly appear in logic where essence's determination to singularity and universality would engender rather relations of equivocity than of analogy. The object of this reservation is not to deny that Duns Scotus evolved on this point, but simply to limit the value of the argument *ex absentia* drawn from his writings on logic. We can see (Barth, "Zum Problem," pp. 314–15) how a critical edition of the texts would be necessary for it to be merely possible to pose problems of evolution.

138 Aristotle, *Categories*, chapter I, 1.

139 Avicenna clearly teaches the priority of the pure essence in the particular being itself, *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1, folio 87, recto a: "Repetemus autem ea a capite et rcolligemus ad declarandum ea alio modo, tanquam rememorantes quam prius dicta sunt. Dicemus ergo quod hoc est quiddam sensibile, quod est animal vel homo cum materia et accidentibus, et hoc est homo naturalis, et hoc est quiddam quod est animal vel homo consideratum ita seipso, secundum hoc quod est ipsum non accepto cum eo hoc quod est sibi admixtum sine conditione communis aut proprii, aut unius aut multi, nec in effectu nec in respectu etiam potentiae secundum quod est aliquid in potentia. Animal enim ex hoc quod est animal, et homo ex hoc quod est homo, scilicet quantum ad diffinitionem suam et intellectum suum absque consideratione omnium aliorum quae comitantur illum, non est nisi animal vel homo; sed animal commune, et animal individuum, et animal secundum respectum. . . quo est in his sensibilibus vel intellectum in anima, est animal et aliud non animal, consideratum in se tantum. Manifestum est autem, quod cum fuerit animal et

aliud quod non est animal, animal tunc erit in hoc quasi pars ejus; similiter et homo. Poterit autem animal per se considerari, quamvis sit cum alio a se; essentia enim ejus est cum alio a se, ergo essentia ejus est ipse per se. Ipsum vero esse cum alio a se est quiddam quod accidit ei, vel aliquid quod comitatur naturam suam, sicut haec animalitas et humanitas. Ergo haec consideratio, scilicet ex hoc quod est animal, praecedit in esse et animal quod est individuum propter accidentia sua, et universale quod est in his sensibilibus et intelligibile, sicut simplex praecedit compositum et sicut pars totum. Ex hoc enim esse nec est genus nec species nec individuum nec unum nec multa, sed ex hoc esse est tantum animal et tantum homo, nec comitatur illus sine dubio esse unum vel multa, cum impossibile sit aliquid esse et non esse alterum istorum, quamvis sit comitans ipsum extrinsecus."

140 Barth, "Zum Problem," p. 320, cites a passage from the Scotist treatise, *Quaestiones de Anima*, question 1, number 6, that encourages us to take this path: "Est enim duplex univocatio, una est logica, secundum quam plura conveniunt in uno conceptu tantum communi; alia est naturalis, secundum quam conveniunt in una natura reali. Exemplum ut in specie atoma de qua loquitur Philosophus, VII *Physicae*, textu 24. . . Praeter utramque univocationem est una metaphysica, secundum quam aliqua uniuntur in genere propinquo. Et est media inter utramque, est enim minor prima et major secunda."—When we are dealing with being, the proper object of metaphysics, the univocity at stake can only be metaphysical: it is the univocity of the pure essence. It is true, according to Duns Scotus himself, that being is not a genus, but that is why we see him have reservations about its complete univocity. Still, according to *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book I, question 1, number 23 [EW I, p. 34, number 75] everything "habet quid, tum quia habet essentiam, tum quia alias non praedicaretur de aliquo quid."—Therefore, common being has an essence, even if it does not have a definition.

141 We completely accept the position of Fr. Barth, which seems historically impeccable to us. Barth, "Zum Problem," p. 321: "While Aristotle and the Scholastics influenced by him always envisage being under the aspect of multiplicity and particularity, Duns Scotus has undertaken at least partially to elaborate a pure concept of being, the concept of purely being (*den Begriff des reinen Soseins*). In the first case, the being includes in itself its particular modes, but not in the second case. The consequence that flows from that is inevitable, and it determines the destiny of analogy and univocity. Being taken without its modes as purely being is univocal. Being with its modes is analogous."—Fr. Barth has seen, with the help of Aimé Forest, *La structure métaphysique du concret selon S. Thomas* (Paris: Vrin, 1931), p. 154, that suggestions in this direction are already found in Avicenna, "Zum Problem," p. 316, note 89. If, as we propose, the Avicennist doctrine of being is established in relation to the doctrine of essence, the suggestions at issue become less vague than they are deemed to be. Let us merely recall Avicenna's thesis cited by Scotus himself, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book IV, question 1, article 5 [EW I, p. 260, number 31]: "In ista quaestione videtur opinio Avicennae I *Metaphysicae* suae, capitulo 2 et capitulo 5, quod ens dicitur per unam rationem de omnibus de quibus dicitur. . ."—The Subtle Doctor attributes the univocity of being to Avicenna on the strength of another text that he elaborates intelligently to this end, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 22, vol. I, p. 609 [CE IV, pp. 212–13]. It cannot be denied that the doctrine agrees with the authentic spirit of Avicennism, but until now it has not been found, *ipsissimis verbis*, in Avicenna's writings. By way of curiosity, let us note that Duns Scotus chose to deduce it from certain passages in Aristotle, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 24, vol. I, p. 610. [I find no reference to Aristotle in number 24, but there is one in number 23, at CE IV, p. 215].

142 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 1, article 1, vol. I, p. 179 [CE II, p. 125]: "Utrum in entibus sit aliquid existens actu infinitum." In the formulation of the following question,

the equivalence of the two expressions is obvious.—*Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 1, article 1, vol. I, p. 180: "An aliquod infinitum sive an Deus esse sitper se nostrum." [CE vol. II, p. 128 has rather: "Utrum aliquot infinitum sit per se notum ut Deum esse."]

143 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 181. [I do not find this sentence in CE II, p. 130.] "Item, Avicenna I, *Metaphysicae* Deum esse non est per se notum nec desparatum cognosci." See Avicenna *Metaphysica*, folio 70 recto c.

144 Scotists have often criticized what is called, in modern terms, Thomist *agnosticism*, which, for them, is tied to the metaphysics of analogy. Duns Scotus himself anticipated them. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 2, number 1, vol. I, pp. 304–305 [CE III, pp. 4–5].

145 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 12, vol. I, p. 340 [CE III, p. 92]: "Ille conceptus de quo est certitudo est alius ab illis de quibus est dubius."—*Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, questions 1 and 2, article 4, number 6, vol. I, p. 309 [CE III, p. 18]: "Omnis intellectus certus de uno conceptu et dubius de diversis habet conceptum de quo est certus, alius a conceptibus de quibus est dubius."—*Ibidem*: "Nullus idem conceptus est et certus et dubius."—Two distinct concepts thus correspond to two distinct essences. Cf. Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 6, folio 72 verso a: "Dum enim dixeris. . ."

146 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book IV, question 1, number 6: "Experimur in nobis ipsis, quod possumus concipere ens, non concipiendo hoc ens in se vel in alio, quia dubitatio est, quando concipimus ens, utrum sit ens in se vel in alio." [This passage is on Vivès VII, p. 148. I do not find it at the corresponding place in EW I, p. 262.]

147 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 7, number 5: "Et hoc habemus per experientiam. . . quod est quaedam scientia, quae speculatur ens inquantum ens, quae est metaphysica."

148 Here we encounter the Avicennist notion of pure essence again. *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1, folio 87 recto b: "*Animal* enim, consideratum secundum quod est animal et secundum ejus animalitatem, non est proprium nec improprium quod est commune; utrumque enim removetur ab eo. Nam ipsum ex animalitate sua tantum est animal. Intentio vero animalis ex hoc quod est animal est praeter intentionem proprii et communis, nec sunt intrantia in suam quidditatem. Cum igitur hoc ita sit, tunc animal, ex hoc quod est animal, nec est proprium nec commune ex sua animalitate sed est animal, non aliquid aliud a se de dispositionibus, sed consequitur ipsum esse proprium vel commune."—The indifference of essence is not exclusive, or otherwise it would no longer be essence. Of itself, indifference implies neither singularity nor universality. It is precisely this fundamental indetermination of essence that permits conceiving it now as *proper* to an individual, now as *common* to individuals of the same genus or species. What is true of *animal* is true of *being*.

149 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book IV, question 1, number 5 [EW I, pp. 260–61, numbers 31–32; Vivès, vol. VII, p. 147]: "In ista quaestione videtur opinio Avicennae, I *Metaphysicae* suae, capitulis 2 et 5, quod ens dicitur per unam rationem de omnibus de quibus dicitur, sed non aeque primo, quod quaedam sunt quasi genera, sive species entis, quaedam vero passiones, etc. Ad hoc est ratio illa: quae prima sunt ad intelligendum, sunt communissima, quia semper communius prius intelligitur et non est processus in infinitum in intelligibilibus; ergo illud quod est primum intelligibile simpliciter, est communissimum simpliciter. Sed nullum est tale ens, quia nullum decem generum est communissimum simpliciter, quia nullum praedicatur de alio genere; ens ergo potest habere unum conceptum communem."

150 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book II, question 3, number 22 [EW I, p, 197, number 106].

151 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 2, folio 70 verso b: “Igitur ostensum est tibi ex his omnibus quod ens inquantum est ens commune est omnibus his, et quod ipsum debet poni subjectum hujus magisterii, et quia non eget inquiri an sit et quid sit, quasi alia scientia praeter hanc debeat assignare dispositionem ejus ob hoc quod inconveniens est ut stabiliat suum subjectum an sit et certificet quid sicut scientia cujus ipsum est subjectum, sed potius oportet concedere tantum quia est et quid est. ideo primum subjectum hujus scientiae est ens inquantum est ens, et ea quae inquirit sunt consequentia ens inquantum ens sine conditione aliqua.”—*Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 6, folio 72 recto b: “Quae autem promptiora sunt ad imaginandum per seipsa sunt ea quae communia sunt omnibus rebus, sicut res et ens et unum, etc.”—*Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 6, folio 72 verso b: “Postquam autem una intentio res secundum hoc quod assignaviumus sequuntur illud accidentialia quae ei sunt propria, sicut supra docuimus, et ideo eget aliqua scientia in qua tractate de eo, sicut omni sanative necessaria est aliqua scientia.”

152 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book IV, question 1, number 5 [EW I, p. 260, numbers 31–32].

153 Scotus, *Quaestiones Quodlibitales*, question 14, number 13 [AW, p. 328]: “Objectum proprium secundum totam suam indifferentiam est adaequatum objectum et respicit potentiam suam secundum totum genus suum ut proprium extremum.”

154 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 5, vol. I, p. 309 [CE III, p. 18]: “Et ne fiat contentio de nomine univocationis, univocum conceptum dico qui ita est unus, quod ejus unitas sufficit ad contradictionem affirmando et negando ipsum de eodem: sufficit etiam pro medio syllogistico, ut extrema unita in medio sic uno sine fallacia aequivocationis concludantur inter se uniri.”—More simply, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 14, vol. I, p. 600 [CE IV, p. 195]: “univocum est, cujus ratio est in se una, sive illa ratio sit ratio subjecti, sive denominet subjectum, sive per accidens dicatur de subjecto.”

155 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 335 [CE III, p. 81]: “Quoad primum dico quod ens non est univocum dictum in quid de omnibus per se intelligibilibus, quia non de differentiis ultimis nec passionibus propriis entis.”—*Dicere in quid* or *praedicare in quid* is to attribute its essence as such to any being whatever, on account of its being essence. By contrast, to denominate a subject by its sufficient difference or some accident is *praedicare in quale*.—Cf. Shircel, *The Univocity of the Concept of Being*, pp. 31–34; on the notion of *differentia ultima*, see Shircel, *Univocity*, pp. 75–77.

156 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 335 [CE III, p. 81]: “Si differentiae includant ens univoce dictum de eis, et non sunt omnino idem [otherwise they would not be differences], ergo sunt diversa idem entia.”

157 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 336 [CE III, p. 82].—The concept is called *simpliciter simplex* when it cannot be resolved into other concepts. Nevertheless, it is conceivable by simple intellection. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, number 21, vol. I, p. 319 [CE III, p. 49. CE does not contain the last sentence and last six words.]: “Alius est *conceptus simpliciter simplex* et alius est *conceptus simplex*, qui non est simpliciter simplex. Conceptum simpliciter simplicem voco, qui non est resolubilis in plures conceptus, ut conceptus entis vel ultimae differentiae. Conceptus simplex, sed *non simpliciter simplex*, voco quicumque potest concipi ab intellectu actu simplicis intelligentiae, licet possit resolvi in plures conceptus seorsum conceptibiles, sicut est conceptus definiti vel speciei.” Or again, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 5, vol. I, p. 187 [CE II, pp. 142–43]: “Voco autem conceptum simpliciter simplicem qui non est resolubilis in aliquos conceptus simplices, quorum quilibet possit actu simplici distincte cognosci.”

158 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, number 14, vol. I, pp. 343–44 [CE III, pp. 95–97]: “nulla differentia simpliciter ultima includit ens quidditative, quia est simpliciter simplex.”—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 47.

159 Duns Scotus distinguishes two groups of *passiones entis*. First come those that correspond to the classical transcendentals and are convertible with being; these are the *passiones convertibiles simplices*. Second are those that are only attributable to a being disjunctively, since they go by pairs of contraries; these are the *passiones disjunctae* (necessary-possible, infinite-finite, etc.). The properties of the second group are no less transcendental than those for the first because they are not generic determinations. Everything finite falls within some genus or other, but *finitude* itself is not a genus of being; it is a modality of being. This is why Duns Scotus says, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 19, vol. I, p. 606 [CE IV, p. 207]: “Utrumque membrum illius disjuncti est transcendens, quia neutrum determinat suum determinabile ad certum genus.”—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 13, vol. I, p. 1214 [Vivès, vol. X, p. 623; CE VI, p. 414 gives this as part of an interpolated text] where we see that, starting from the lower term of each of these pairs of transcendentals it is possible to demonstrate the other term, which will be Duns Scotus’s preferred method to establish God’s existence: “Si aliquid ens est finitum, ergo aliquod ens est infinitum, et si aliquod ens est contingens, ergo aliquod ens est necessarium; quia in talibus non posset enti particulariter inesse imperfectius extremum, nisi alicui enti inesset perfectius extremum a quo dependeret.”

160 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3 question 3, article 2, number 7, vol. I, pp. 336–37 [CE III, p. 84].

161 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 337 [CE III, p. 85]: “Cum nihil possit esse communius ente, et ens non possit esse commune univocum dictum in quid de omnibus per se intelligibilibus: quia non de differentiis ultimis nec de passionibus suis, sequitur quod nihil est premium objectum intellectus nostri propter communitatem ipsius in quid ad omne per se intelligibile.”

162 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 335 [CE III, p. 81]: “Quod si ens ponatur aequivocum creato et increato, substantiae et accidenti, cum omnia ista sint per se intelligibilia a nobis, nullum videtur posse poni primus objectum intellectus nostri, nec propter virtualitatem, nec propter communitatem. Sed ponendo illam positionem quam posui in prima quaestione hujus distinctionis de univocatione entis, potest aliquo modo salvari aliquod esse primum objectum intellectus nostri.”

163 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 1, number 5, vol. I, pp. 333–34 [CE, p. 80]: This radical pluralism of real being, which makes impossible the existence of a first object of the intellect in the order of quiddity, will find its justification when the relation of finite beings to the infinite intellect is treated.

164 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 335 [CE III, p. 80]: “Vel igitur nullum ponetur primum objectum, vel oportet ponere primum adaequatum propter communitatem in ipso.”

165 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 338 [CE III, pp. 85–86].

166 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 5, vol. I, p. 309: “Secundo, non asserendo, quia non consonat opinioni, dici potest, quod non tantum in conceptu analogo conceptuali creaturae concipitur Deus, qui scilicet sit omnino alius ab illo qui de creatura dicitur, sed in conceptu aliquo univoco sibi et creaturae.”—This *non assserendo* does not necessarily express real hesitation. It may be merely a flourish of style, of courtesy, we might say,

toward those who thought differently. [Unfortunately, *the non asserendo* is not in CE III, p. 80, where *non asserendo* quia non consonat opinioni, dici potest is replaced simply by dico.]

167 In the absence of a critical edition of Duns Scotus's works, it is premature to pose the problem of a possible evolution of his thinking on this point. The manuscript tradition does not always agree with Wadding's printed version (Gilson, "Avicenne et le point de départ de Duns Scot," p. 160, note 1), and the marginal notes of manuscript Z 291 of the Amploniana in Erfurt can be interpreted as attributing a change of opinion to Scotus, Barth, "Zum Problem," pp. 314–15. Two versions of book IV of *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam* would exist, one where Duns Scotus still holds analogy, the other where he teaches univocity. The text of Wadding-Vivès would have mixed them, Barth, "Zum Problem," p. 315. Personally, for reasons that are too provisional to be worth setting out, I am inclined to admit that the thinking of Duns Scotus was at least progressively clarified on this point.

168 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 6, vol. I, p. 309 [CE III, p. 18]: "Intellectus viatoris potest esse certus de Deo quod sit ens, dubitando de ente finito vel infinito, creato vel increato; ergo conceptus entis de Deo est alius [conceptus] a conceptu isto vel illo, et ita neuter ex se, sed in utroque illorum includitur; ergo univocus . . ."—Note the specification *intellectus viatoris*, because what is true in the present human state is not necessarily true in another. Lastly let us recall that finite and infinite are modalities of being, included under it as essential modes of determined being. Let us add that what is *neutral* is the concept, because really existing being is not neutral. See *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 11, vol. I, p. 598 [CE IV, pp. 189–90]. The common concept of being is formally neutral as finite and infinite being, but a real being is necessarily one or the other.

169 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 6, vol. I, pp. 309–10 [CE III, pp. 18–19].—The same argument is formulated elsewhere in more abstract terms, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 9, vol. I, p. 338 [CE III, p. 86]: "De quocumque enim praedictorum conceptuum [*scilicet*, creatum, increatum] quidditativorum contingit intellectum certum esse ipsum esse ens, dubitando de differentiis contrahentibus ens ad talem conceptum [utrum sit tale ens vel non], et ita conceptus entis, ut convenit illi conceptui, est alius ab illis conceptibus inferioribus de quibus intellectus est dubius."—We understand the passage in this way: the intellect cannot think *created* or *uncreated* without relation to being, but it can think *being*, without determining it to one or the other of these two differences. Therefore, the concept of being is different from the concepts of its differences, and it is conceivable separately. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, numbers 6–7, pp. 593–95 [CE IV, pp. 178–83]. Of course, the commonality of this concept of being entails no commonality of actual being. "Collatio 24," ed. Carolus Balić, *De Collationibus J. D. Scoti* in *Bogoslovni Vestnik*, vol. IX, 1923, p. 215.

170 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 7, vol. I, p. 310 [CE III, p. 20]: "Quod si non cures de auctoritate ista accepta ex diversitate opinionum philosophantium, sed dicas quod quilibet habet duo conceptus in intellectu suo propinquos, qui propter propinquitatem analogiae videntur esse unus conceptus, contra hoc videtur esse quia, ex ista evasione, videretur destructa omnis via probandi unitatem alicujus conceptus univocam; si enim dicis hominem habere unum conceptum ad Socratem et Platonem, negabitur et dicetur: sunt duo, sed videntur unus propter magnam similtudinem.—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 7, vol. I, pp. 594–95 [CE IV, pp. 179–83].

171 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 8, vol. I, p. 310 [CE III, pp. 21–22]. In a later passage Duns Scotus extends his critique by showing that, for the same reason, the Thomist doctrine would in fact prevent our forming a common enough notion of being

to be said in the same sense of substance and accident, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction, 3, question 3, article 2, number 9, vol. I, pp. 338–39 [CE III, p. 87], "Secundum rationem. . ."—On the impossibility of forming any concept proper to God without recurring to univocity, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 4, vol. I, p. 591 [CE IV, pp. 173–74].

172 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 10, vol. I, pp. 311–12 [CE, pp. 26–27].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 8, vol. I, p. 595–96 [I do not find these words in CE IV, pp. 184–85]: "Contra illud etiam est tertium argumentum. . ."—As we will see further on, the attributes are perfections said of God *formaliter*. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 10, vol. I, p. 597 [CE IV, p. 188]: "Attributa autem, sunt perfectiones simpliciter dictae de Deo formaliter."—This is why Duns Scotus does not admit that it is enough to attribute perfections to God considered as *cause* of created perfections. A divine attribute is only conceivable if one and the same concept according to the same formal reason is *common* to God and creatures.

173 "Collatio 24," Balić ed., p. 214: "Ens autem non est sic limitatum [*scilicet*, quod tantum sit commune ad limitata] sed indifferens, quia ex hoc habetur quod praedicatur in quid de ente limitato sicut illimitato, et ideo non est genus."

174 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 14, vol. I, p. 343 [CE III, p. 97]: ". . . sed removet [*scilicet*, argumentum] rationem generis propter nimiam communitatem qui videlicet praedicatur per se primo modo de differentia aliqua et per hoc possit concludi quod ens non sit genus."—The argument is as follows: the ultimate differences are absolutely simple, and they are the ultimate differences of *being*; therefore they cannot include it. But every other difference (e.g., the *rational* soul) is part of a thing different from the nature from which the thing takes its genus (the species rational is different from the genus soul). Such a difference is not absolutely simple (*simpliciter simplex*), and it includes being quidditatively, because, if it is true to say *anima intellectiva est ens*, it is equally true to say *rationabilitas est ens*. We use the same concept of *ens* in both cases. Conclusion, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 15, vol. I, pp. 343–44 [CE III, p. 98]: "Et ex hoc quod talis differentia est ens *in quid*, sequitur quod ens non est genus propter nimiam communitatem entis. Nullum enim genus dicitur de aliqua differentia inferiori *in quid*."

175 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 9, vol. I, p. 1176 [CE VI, p. 285]: "Prima distinctio entis videtur esse in ens extra animam et ens in anima; et illud extra animam potest distingui in actum et potentiam, essentiae et existentiae. Et quodcumque istorum esse extra animam potest habere esse in anima, et illud esse in anima aliud est ab omni esse extra animam. Et ideo de nullo ente, nec de aliquo esse sequitur, si habet esse diminutum in anima, quod propter hoc habet esse simpliciter, quia illud esse est secundum quid absolute, quod tamen accipitur simpliciter in quantum comparatur ad animam ut fundamentum illius esse in anima."—Here the expression *ens diminutum* means *the being that is only in thought*, that is to say the being of reason.

176 Scotus, *Quodlibet* IX, number 17 [AW, p. 232]: "Uno modo esse potest intelligi illud quo formaliter aliquid recedit a non esse. Primo autem receditur a non esse per illud per quod aliquid est extra intellectum et potentiam suae causae. Hoc modo cujuslibet entis extra intellectum et causam est proprium esse. Alio modo dicitur esse ultimus actus, cui scilicet non advenit aliquis alius dans esse simpliciter, et ipsum dicitur simpliciter habere esse cui primo convenit esse sic dictum; primo, inquam, sic quod non sit alicui alteri ratio essendi illo esse. Isto modo compositum perfectum in specie dicitur esse et solum illud; pars autem ejus dicitur esse per accidens tantummodo, vel magis proprie participative isto esse totius. Sic igitur solum compositum est per

se accipiendo esse secundo modo."

177 Scotus *Quodlibet* III, number 2 [AW, p. 61]: "Verissime enim illud est nihil quod includit contradictionem, et solum illud, quia illud excludit omne esse extra intellectum et in intellectu; quod enim et sic includens contradictionem, sicut non potest esse extra animam, ita non potest esse aliquid intelligibile, vel aliquod ens in anima."

178 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 34, sole question, number 8. (Translator: This seems to be a mistake because number 8, like the rest of the question deals with whether the moral virtues are in the will as their subject.)

179 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 5, number 10, vol. I, p. 393 [CE III, pp. 192–95].—Cf. the passages cited by Alan B. Wolter, *The Trascendentals and Their Function in the Metaphysics of Duns Scotus*, St. Bonaventure, NY: The Franciscan Institute, 1946, p. 69.

180 Scotus, *Quaestiones Quodlibitales*, VII, numbers 8–9 [AW, pp. 166–68].

181 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 7, vol. II, p. 228 [CE VII, p. 402]: "Aliqua est unitas in re realis, absque omni operatione intellectus, minor unitate numerali sive unitate propria singularis, quae unitas est naturae secundum se; et secundum istam unitatem propriam naturae, ut natura est, natura est indifferens ad unitatem singularem; non ergo de se est sic una unitate illa, scilicet unitate singularitatis."—Duns Scotus admits that Averroes's discourse, *In De Anima* I, Comment. 8, is true in the sense that the intellect confers its *logical* universality on a *nature*, but not its metaphysical commonality, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 1, numbers 8–9, vol. II, pp. 230–32. [I find no reference to Averroes in CE VII, pp. 169–71.]

182 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 7, vol. II, p. 228 [CE VI, pp. 402–03]: "Qualiter autem potest hoc intelligi, potest aequaliter videri per dictum Avicennae V *Metaphysicae* ubi vult quod equinitas sit tantum aequinitas, nec ex se una, nec plures, nec universalis, nec particularis."

183 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 9, vol. II, p. 264 [CE VII. p. 475].—Every metaphysical quiddity results from an *ultimate* abstraction, that is, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 5, question 1, number 6, vol. I, p. 508 [CE IV, pp. 20–21], "quidditatis absolutissime sumptae ab omni eo quod est quocumque modo extra rationem quidditatis."

184 Scotus *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 2, vol. II, p. 224 [CE VII, p. 395].

185 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 2, vol. II, p. 224 [CE VII, p. 395]. This is the sense in which we spoke of a remainder of "Platonism" in Duns Scotus. Wolter, *The Transcendentals*, pp. 67–68, prefers to see Aristotelianism there. This is not contradictory, because much of Plato remains in Aristotle himself, though less than in Avicenna and in Duns Scotus. We cannot explain by Aristotle that Duns Scotus is more Platonic than Aristotle.

186 We simplify the demonstration, which, however, it is worth reading in detail for what it teaches about the object of the senses in Scotism. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 4, volume II, p. 227 [CE VII, pp. 399–400]: "Potentia cognoscens objectum sic, inquantum scilicet hac unitate unum, cognoscit ipsum in quantum distinctum a quolibet quod non est hac unitate unum; sed sensus non cognoscit objectum in quantum est distinctum a quolibet quod non est unum ista unitate numerali; quod patet, quia nullus sensus distinguit hunc radium solis differre numeraliter ab illo radio, cum tamen sint diversi per motum solis, si circumscribantur omnia omnino per potentiam divinam, quae essent omnino similia et aquaria in albedine et quantitate, visus non distingueret ibi esse duo alba; si tamen cogosceret alterum istorum, in quantum est unum unitate numerali, cognosceret ipsum in quantum distinctum numeraliter a

quolibet alio."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 5, vol. II, pp. 227 [CE VII, p. 400]: "De uno objecto unius actus sentiendi, non videtur vere posse negari quin necessario haberet unitatem realem et minorem unitate numerali."

187 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 5, vol. II, p. 227 at *Item sexto* [*Praeterea sexto* CE VII, p. 400].—Cf. Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 10 [EW II, pp. 209–11].—On this point, Duns Scotus remits to Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1, folio 87 recto a.

188 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 10, vol. II, p. 232 [CE VII, p. 410].

189 Cf. Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 2, folio 79 verso a: "Non solum autem ipsa natura est de se indifferens ad esse in intellectu et in particulari, ac per hoc ad esse universale et singulare, sed et ipsa habens esse in intellectu, non habet primo ex se universalitatem; licet enim ipsa intelligatur sub universalitate, ut sub modi intelligendi ipsam, tamen universalitas non est pars conceptus ejus primi, quia non conceptus Metaphysici, sed Logici. Logicus enim considerat secundas intentiones applicatas primis, secundam ipsum Avicennam."

190 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1 number 7, vol. II, p. 229 [CE VII, p. 403].

191 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 10, vol. II, p. 232 [CE VII, p. 410].

192 Scotus, *Quaestiones in Metaphysicam*, IV, question 1, numbers 6–7 [EW I, pp. 261–62]. Discussions of univocity and analogy often suffer from this confusion. According to Duns Scotus, logic knows no middle term between the univocal and the equivocal. For the logician the analogous is a particular case of the equivocal. The analogous only has its proper sense in relation to real beings. There can only be a relation of analogy for real sciences, like metaphysics and physics. In fact there are some, but their existence cannot prevent the metaphysician from transcending the real diversity of the beings involved in these relations to abstract from them a concept common to all, that of being.—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 17, vol. I, p. 345 [CE III, pp. 281–84].—Moreover, Scotus observes with a touch of humor, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, number 7 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 196; note that the Latin and English texts are on facing pages with the same number]: "Hoc etiam magistri tractantes de Deo et de his quae cognoscuntur de Deo, observant univocationem in modo dicendi, licent voce hoc negent."

2

The Existence of the Infinite Being

The object of metaphysics is not God's essence as such as its object, but its method allows us to establish the existence of the being that theology calls *God*. Obviously, theology will also be able to express itself on God's nature, precisely in the measure in which God is a certain being. When Duns Scotus envisages this problem, he sees himself situated between two extremes. One, St. Thomas Aquinas, aims too low. The other, Henry of Ghent, aims too high. The former limits the human intellect to knowledge of quiddities abstracted from sensibles and consequently condemns it to purely analogical knowledge of the divine being. If we confine ourselves to a conceptual interpretation of analogy, as is the case here, God is not analogous to anything. Thomas Aquinas himself affirms many times that divine *esse* eludes our concepts. This is as much as to confess, concludes Duns Scotus, that reason has nothing to say about divine *esse*. But, "there is another opinion that grants too much to the intellect as regards knowledge of God, just as the first opinion grants the intellect too little."[1] That is the opinion of Henry of Ghent according to whom, since in himself God is the first intelligible, God is also the first knowable for us and is the cause of our knowledge of everything else.[2] Duns Scotus argues against this second error as vigorously as against the first, but the ultimate grounds of his demonstration lie well beyond the limits of philosophy. This is completely natural, because the essence of God *qua* God is at issue here. First of all, the problem involves the relation of the essence of

God *qua* God to knowledge and to an object in general.[3] Later, we find it again in relation to the problem of the essence and the possible. Accordingly, it seems all the more preferable to relegate the refutation of the principle in dispute to that moment, because, as we know, the Scotist point of departure for an investigation into the existence of a being, such as the one about which theology speaks, is already assured. The theologian will certainly end on this path or he will have to give up his undertaking. In any case, if the theologian must advance as much as possible on this road, it is the only one for him. He will never go further than where this path lets him go.

The inquiry starts from univocal being, but what goal does it propose to attain? This time the point is to reach a certain being, a definite individual, posited in actual existence. Theologians call that being *God*. Those with a taste for great philosophical classifications in historical issues will immediately observe that, by his very method, Duns Scotus necessarily sets out to prove God's existence starting from a concept. So, this would predetermine that his proof belongs to the well-known family of ontological arguments. That may be, but Duns Scotus himself would have many reservations here. Let us remember that, as he conceives it, metaphysics is a *real* science in the sense that it deals with real being grasped under one of its real aspects. Certainly, univocal being is a concept, but it is not a concept without an object, and its object is found to be precisely what is univocal in real being. If this intelligible did not really exist, there would be no intellection or concept. What exists, let us recall, is not a numerically distinct *univocal* being. What exist are real beings that still have in common all that really belongs to being, however infinitely different one can be from another. The object thus conceived is one; its unity is less than numeral entity, but still real unity. Therefore, it is itself real. Metaphysics does not have the *concept of univocal being* as its object, but *univocal being*, which is grasped by this concept.

A second determination of the point of departure is necessary. The fact of looking for something immediately implies a certain notion of what one is looking for. As the logicians say, it is necessary to start from a *nominal*

definition that provisionally formulates the object of the inquiry.[4] Here we agree that the point of departure is *being*. But what being do we propose to find? If it is the *subject* of *our* theology, it will be *infinite being*. But why that and not something else? Why does infinite being constitute the most satisfactory approximation to the Christian God that is naturally accessible to the human understanding?

We could conceive others. Duns Scotus knew Thomas Aquinas well. Scotus saw clearly that once the existence of God is established, Aquinas's first concern is to prove that God is *simple*.[5] At the point where we find ourselves, we do not yet know what the philosophical equivalent of the theological notion of God will be, but we at least know that the being designated by his name is supreme and perfect *qua* being. From this point of view, the concept of *simple being* seems less satisfying than that of *infinite being* because a certain simplicity of being can belong to creatures, whereas infinity of being is incompatible with the very essence of created being.[6]

But will there not be other determinations of being like that and, if there are, why choose *infinite being*? Surely, there are a great number of them. All have in common that they do not lead to an *absolutely simple* concept of their object. We immediately see why. If the inquiry's point of departure is common being, it is necessary to determine that, limiting it through the addition of another term to make it designate *divine being*. If we start from the good or the true instead of being, this necessity will still be forced upon us. Unless we say of being or good that it is *superior* or *infinite* or *uncreated*, neither concept will be said properly of God. In short, a metaphysics of common being cannot claim any concept of God that is absolutely simple. Whenever we conceive a perfection taken to its highest degree, we get a concept proper to God. A very satisfactory way of conceiving him would be to describe him as "all perfections taken absolutely and in the highest degree." However, another concept proper to God turns out to be no less perfect and simpler, that of infinite being.

The concept is simpler, because all the others are formed by determining the notion of *being* by some transcendental that is itself endowed with a

proper concept. We thus obtain the concepts of *good being*, *true being*, and others of the same kind, where the determinant is a genuine attribute distinct from the subject. By contrast, *infinite* is not predicated as attribute either of being or of any other thing of which it is affirmed. The infinite is an *intrinsic mode* of what it qualifies. As we have observed previously, this means it is a mode of being taken *qua* being.

> Thus, when I say *infinite being*, I do not have a concept somehow accidentally formed of a subject and an attribute, but the concept in itself of the subject taken in an infinite degree of perfection—infinity. It is like *intense whiteness*, which does not express a concept by accident like that of *visible whiteness*, because the intensity here designates rather an intrinsic degree of whiteness.[7]

Therefore, the concept of *infinite being* is certainly not absolutely simple, but as simple as a human concept of divine being can be, because it only involves a single concept taken under a certain modality. But it is at the same time more perfect than any other concept, because all others are virtually included in it. Indeed, every perfection is virtually included in being, so that to say *infinite being* is to say at the same time *infinite good*, *infinite true*, and so forth. In fact, we are going to see that we end at the concept of infinite being when we ask what the first principle of being is. The ultimate point of arrival reached by a demonstration *quia*, that is one parting from created effects, is necessarily the most perfect thing that can be perceived starting from such a foundation.[8] Accordingly, starting from finite being, our investigation certainly will have to be oriented toward infinite being. But is it certain that a proof is necessary here, and does not the very nature of the concept of *infinite being* allow us to dispense with a proof?

A That God's existence is not evident

We can use the terms *God* or *infinite being* indifferently, as Duns Scotus himself shows by example, when he asks "whether the existence of some infinite or God is something known of itself."[9]

What is a proposition that is *known of itself*? A proposition *per se nota* is one whose truth is grasped by the mere knowledge of its terms, or as Duns Scotus says, it is a proposition that exhibits truth merely by virtue of the peculiar terms it includes and insofar as they are included in it.[10] Classic examples of such propositions are “The whole is greater than the parts” or “A line is length without width.” It is easy to see that they are composed of two terms. The first is what is defined: *whole* or *line*. The second is its definition. Among propositions known of themselves, some are known starting from simple confused knowledge of their terms.[11] Notably, this is the case of the two things we have just mentioned. For, the geometer knows them of themselves, although he does not have the distinct knowledge of the concept *line*, for example, that the metaphysician has, when he defines *line* as one of the three species of continuous quantity. Every proposition known of itself starting from confused knowledge of its terms a fortiori is known of itself when it starts from the distinct knowledge of them. But the reverse is not true. From the fact that a proposition is known of itself when its terms are distinctly known, it does not follow that it would be known of itself, if its terms were only confusedly known. Whatever may be the knowledge with which we are dealing, we will say that all propositions and only those propositions are known of themselves whose truth evidently depends on the understanding of their terms.[12]

Given that, the quality of being *known of itself* belongs to propositions taken in themselves, independently of the subject who knows them. Duns Scotus refuses to distinguish between propositions *known of themselves* and propositions that are *only knowable of themselves*. For him, what is *known of itself* and what is *knowable of itself* are merged, since something can only be knowable of itself for us, because it is that inherently. What makes it knowable of itself is the very nature of its terms. A proposition is not called *knowable of itself* because it is actually known as such. Otherwise, “if no intellect actually knew it, no proposition would be knowable of itself.” that would be absurd in a doctrine where the intelligible always precedes intellection. On the contrary, Duns Scotus affirms energetically:

> A proposition is called *knowable of itself*, because by the nature of its terms, it possesses the evident truth contained in those terms, whatever the intellect that conceives them may be. If some intellect does not conceive the terms and consequently does not conceive the propositions, the proposition is nonetheless known of itself in what belongs to it, and it is in this sense that we speak of a proposition known of itself.[13]

Other distinctions must be eliminated for the same reason. Some propose to distinguish what is known of itself from that which is only known of itself for us. As has just been said, what is *known of itself* is known *in itself* and consequently, remains so for any intellect. The fact that I do not perceive the evidence of a proposition known of itself does not keep it from being one and being one *even for me*. I know that it is a proposition known of itself whose evidence escapes me, and whose nature, nevertheless, remains what it is. Again, for the same reason, we refuse to distinguish what is *known of itself by the learned* from *what is known of itself by the ignorant*. Obviously, for the person whose ignorance keeps him from understanding a proposition's terms, the proposition will not be evident either of itself or otherwise. It will simply not exist for him. The proposition exists and the question of finding out whether it is known of itself begins to be posed from the moment the terms are understood.[14] Once a proposition's terms are conceived, all minds that conceive them know the proposition of itself and know it equally.

These clarifications announce Duns Scotus's personal positions, which, it would seem, can be summed up briefly as follows: the proposition *God is* is a proposition known of itself. In virtue of the previous consideration, since the proposition is known of itself, we must say that it necessarily must be that, even for us. On the other hand, we do not conceive it as known of itself, because the manner in which we conceive its terms does not allow us to see with immediate evidence that existence belongs to God's essence. Let us try to clarify that point.

The proposition that unites these two extreme terms, *being* and *divine essence* conceived as *this determined essence*, is a proposition known of

itself. In other words, the bond that unites these two terms, *God* and *the being proper to God*, is immediately evident of itself, as God himself knows, as well as the blessed who can see God's essence in an intuitive vision. Let us not waste this first opportunity that has arisen to note that, according to Duns Scotus, God's existence is inseparable from his essence. Existence is not a predicate that must be connected to the divine essence by some other intermediary, "as if the predicate were external to the notion of the subject." This is why the proposition *God is* is directly and immediately evident starting from its terms alone. It is the most immediate proposition to which are resolved all propositions enunciating something about God somehow conceived, *immediatissima, ad quam resolvuntur omnes propositiones enunciantes aliquid de Deo qualitercumque concepto*. The expression is remarkably powerful. It is helpful to take notice of it all the more, since the concept of God will not be the object of perfect agreement within the Scotist school. Here at least no doubt is possible. "The proposition *God is*, like this other proposition *the essence is*, is known of itself, because these two terms are such that they confer evidence on the proposition for anyone who perfectly apprehends its terms, there being nothing to which being corresponds more perfectly than to this essence."[15] If this proposition is known of itself, it is necessarily known of itself for us. Although we have only confused knowledge of God, because, for us, his name designates something imperfectly known and that we do not conceive as *this very divine essence* (*hanc divinam essentiam*), the proposition *God is* remains known of itself.[16]

Still, let us add that in the absence of an intuition of the divine essence, this proposition known of itself is not evident for us. If it assures us that existence belongs to the divine essence by right, it does not suffice to assure us that God exists. Existence corresponds to God's essence precisely in so far as he is *haec essentia*, the essence of the singular being that he is. We certainly have a concept of essence in general, but not of *this very essence* that is God's essence.[17] Let us go further. There can be concepts in our understanding that are proper to God in the sense that they are not common to

God and creatures, for example, *necessary being* or *highest good*. We can attribute existence to their object. However, to the question of whether, when we attribute being to any of these objects, we can form a necessary proposition, the answer must be negative. In other words, the proposition *God is*, where the terms are only known confusedly, is known of itself. But, since it is not evident for us, it does not guarantee that God exists. The propositions, *the necessary being is* or *the infinite being is*, whose terms are distinctly conceivable for us, are not evident for us, although, as we will soon see, they permit us to prove that God exists. It is appropriate to assign this Scotist sense to Avicenna's expression that we have already quoted. God, precisely *qua* God, is not evidently known to us, but we must not despair of knowing him as God later and as infinite being in this life: that God *is* is neither known of itself nor impossible to know, *Deum esse non est per se notum nec desperatum cognosci*.

In the absence of a proper concept of the divine essence as such, in order to attain God we dispose only of the common concept of being, determined, however, in such a way as to form concepts that can only be applied to him. Examples are the concepts of *necessary being*, of *infinite being*, or *highest good*. All these concepts are such that existence can be attributed to their object, but none of them suffices to justify this attribution immediately. It cannot be demonstrated that a being exists because it is necessary or infinite or supreme. Completely the opposite: we will know that necessity and infinity exist when we have proved the existence of an essence that possesses them. We cannot go from the attributes of the divine essence to its existence, because its existence alone permits the proof of its attributes' existence. The divine essence has the role of middle term in any *a priori* demonstration of its attributes.[18] It must first be proved that the divine essence exists; it follows that none of the distinct concepts by which we conceive the Supreme Being permits us to posit its existence as evident.

Besides, it is enough to observe the movement of thought in order to be sure that matters are thus. We conceive *infinite being*. Is it immediately evident for us that such a being exists? Surely not. We can believe its

existence. We can demonstrate its existence. In no case do we grasp it as immediately evident on the basis of these terms alone. The cause of our assent to the proposition *the infinite being is* is not found solely in the terms of which it consists, but in faith or demonstration.

This fact stems from the very nature of the concepts that we *distinctly* conceive as properly applicable to God. None of them is absolutely simple. To know the existence of their object as evident, it would be necessary for us to know the link between the parts that compose it as evident. In other words, *the infinite being is* cannot be an evident proposition unless it is evident that the infinite is linked to being. On the one hand, all the concepts that we can attribute to God fully are composed of the concept of being and of a determination of being like *supreme* or *infinite*, *uncreated*, *immense*, or something else of the same kind. On the other hand, nothing can be known of itself regarding a concept that is not absolutely simple unless it is known of itself that its parts are effectively united. If the parts of a composed concept are not at least unitable, the concept is contradictory, and everything that could be concluded from it is false. To know that such a concept is possible, it is necessary to prove it, as Duns Scotus will do for the concept of *infinite being*. Once more, the existence of such a being is not known of itself; it is an object of demonstration.[19]

That said, Duns Scotus can eliminate the authorities who seem to attribute immediate evidence to the proposition *God is*, taken in the forms whose terms are distinctly accessible to us.

First of all, there is the famous remark of John Damascene at the beginning of *De Fide Orthodoxa*: “The knowledge of God’s existence is naturally innate in all men.” Thomas Aquinas had already responded that this is true if we mean God known in something common under a certain confusion, *in aliquo communi sub quadam confusione*, in the sense, for example, that all humans desire happiness without knowing that what they call *happiness* is really called *God*. Duns Scotus prefers to interpret John Damascene’s phrase as true if we are talking “about the faculty of knowing what is actually given to us, by which we can immediately (*statim*) know that God exists starting

from creatures, *saltem in rationibus generalibus,* at least [God known] in general concepts." Moreover, this doctor grants us no other knowledge of God starting from creatures than what consists "in notions common to God and creatures," posited more perfectly and more eminently in him than in them. If we mean a distinct, actual knowledge of God as God, demonstrations do not provide it. Let us say, rather, with John Damascene himself: "No one knows him, except insofar as he himself has revealed." *Nemo novit eum, nisi quantum ipse revelavit.* As we see, Duns Scotus loses no opportunity to distinguish the metaphysical knowledge of the first being from the theological knowledge of this same first being as God.

The second objection, taken from St. Anselm by Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus, is based on the celebrated argument of *Proslogion* II: the being such that no greater can be conceived is necessarily existent. Still, let us note that in presenting the argument, Thomas Aquinas does not name St. Anselm but freely interprets it, as if we could correctly assimilate it to something *per se notum*, known of itself, like *the whole is greater than the part*.[20] Duns Scotus, by contrast names St. Anselm, which authorizes him to distance his thesis from the interpretation that Thomas Aquinas had given of the *Proslogion* argument. Indeed, "Anselm does not say that this proposition is known of itself." The proof is that in order to deduce the conclusion that God exists, we need at least two syllogisms, one of which proves that the *supreme* is not non-being and the other that, since it is not non-being, it is being. Moreover, if Anselm's argument does not establish that God's existence is evident, we will see that it helps prove God's infinity.

The third objection is also common to Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus. It amounts to this: "It is known of itself that truth exists. Now, God is truth. Therefore God exists." Duns Scotus responds with Thomas Aquinas that the evidence of truth in general is a thing known of itself, but that it does not follow from this that God exists. At least, it does not follow as a proposition known of itself, because it is not at all evident either that being necessarily belongs to truth in general or that the being of this truth is the same as that of this determined essence that is God's.[21]

The last objection is completely different from those presented by Thomas Aquinas. It is highly formal in character, which allows Duns Scotus to clarify his own thought regarding the issue. The necessity of first principles, the objection declares, does not rest on the real existence of their terms but on the relation of these terms as they are in the intellect that conceives them. If these prepositions concerning concepts that have no other existence than as objects of thought are immediately known of themselves, with much greater reason, the proposition *God is*, which concerns absolutely necessary terms, must be known of itself.[22] Against this, Duns Scotus recalls once again that the character *known of itself* belongs to propositions independently of the fact that their terms exist only in the understanding or in reality. The evidence of the agreement of these terms is the evidence of the proposition's truth, even the evidence that makes it a proposition known of itself. In the proposition *the whole is greater than the part*, the relation of the terms is such that every intellect that conceives them perceives their evidence at the same time. Whatever the intrinsic necessity of these terms may be, the evidence of the propositions that unites them is neither more nor less great.[23] Certainly, in the proposition *God is*, the intrinsic necessity of its terms and their relation is infinitely greater, and no proposition would be more immediately evident than that one, if we had a distinct concept of God. But for the concepts proper to God we have only an attributive determination of the common notion of being. That is why, in the absence of a sufficient concept of God's essence, we cannot perceive the necessity, however supreme, with which existence belongs to it.

Duns Scotus's position is easier to repeat than to comprehend, because we wonder more than once precisely how it is distinguished from St. Thomas's position. Both teach that the proposition *God is* is known of itself, but that unless we conceive its terms distinctly, its evidence escapes us. They are in agreement on the essential point. However, Thomas Aquinas concludes from it that, if we take the proposition in itself, it is known of itself, but it is not known of itself for us. By contrast, Duns Scotus maintains that his proposition remains known of itself for us, as it is in itself, although it is not

presently known as that to us. In other words, the character of *being known of itself* belongs to every proposition whose truth is evident once its terms are distinctly known. The fact that the terms may not be distinctly known prevents us from grasping this evidence, but does not deprive the proposition of its evidence. This is why, although the immediate evidence of the proposition *God is* escapes us, it must be regarded as known of itself, both in itself and in us.

B The first cause

The demonstration of the existence of an infinite being involves two clearly distinct moments: the proof that a first being exists and the proof that its first being is infinite.[24]

This double demonstration is simultaneously a perfect model of what Duns Scotus understands by metaphysical knowledge. This is why a reader risks not just getting lost in Scotist metaphysics, but not even finding the entrance to it if he is not used to its style. Duns Scotus assures us that he argues from effects to their cause. We immediately think of the Thomist sort of a posteriori proofs, and since we only find abstract concepts, we are disoriented. We then try to compare the Scotist proofs to purely conceptual arguments that are found in authors like Alexander of Hales or St. Bonaventure, proofs that are drawn immediately from essential properties. But then we immediately come up against warnings by Duns Scotus that his proofs are a posteriori and only attain God from his effects. We are going in circles, and the only hope of emerging from the predicament lies in a return to the peculiar Scotist concept of the metaphysician's object.

Duns Scotus often affirmed that the proofs of the First Being's existence are a posteriori and taken from effects, not *a priori* and by the cause, and what we already know about Scotus's thought would make the opposite attitude incomprehensible. The feature that dominates his doctrine here is the absence of a proper concept of God in the human understanding. If we had such a concept of the divine essence, we could use it to demonstrate *propter quid*, by

the cause, that this nature exists. But we do not have it. Therefore, if the proof is possible, it remains for us only to base it on creatures, who are God's effects "since from our viewpoint the infinite being cannot be demonstrated to be by a demonstration by the cause, although by the nature of the terms the proposition would be demonstrable by the cause for us, but the proposition is demonstrable for us through a demonstration by effects from creatures."[25] Other texts might easily be quoted, but none could be more explicit, and this one is enough to settle the question.

If some hesitate to take Duns Scotus's declaration literally, it is because the created effects upon which his demonstration rests are not those to which Thomist metaphysics appeals. More precisely, Scotist metaphysics does not appeal to the path that St. Thomas considers the most manifest of them all, the one that uses movement. We have already seen why, and we will see it more precisely again, but it is enough to recall here what kind of being the metaphysician takes into consideration when he really speaks *qua* metaphysician. Since in fact all our knowledge derives from the sensible, sensible being is the only thing from which the metaphysician can start. But precisely *qua* metaphysician, he only considers sensible being insofar as *being*. Not only is this being something real, completely the opposite to a pure being of reason like those with which logic deals, but all the properties that thought discovers there are real just like sensible being.[26]*Common being* and its properties are nothing but the creature itself taken in its particular reality, conceived under the metaphysician's peculiar standpoint.

In created being, there are many characters that are themselves created realities, whose actual existence in being is impossible to explain unless they are considered effects of a cause. Therefore, starting from these effects, it can be demonstrated that their cause exists and that it exists actually in reality as the effects themselves exist in reality. Let us mention some: plurality, which belongs to being as we know it, dependence,[27]composition, and so many evident properties from which it is possible to start in order to demonstrate the connection to an evident cause, and to persuade, to make it clear that a simple, independent, and necessary being exists upon which everything else

depends. If being as we know it presents characteristics such that it cannot exist of itself, it must, in consequence, be possible to establish that a cause superior to all creatures exists, from which they have being.[28] We do not depart from the great debate between Averroes and Avicenna, here, and it is well known what position Duns Scotus took in it. All that can be reached starting from physical beings considered in their physical condition of changeable beings, is the *existence* of a being whose nature will be the object of the theologian's study. Again, for that, the metaphysician must prove its existence, that is, he must prove it *qua* metaphysician.

Even though purely metaphysical, such proof will not address the properties of the infinite being that can be called *absolute*, but the properties that can be called *relative*. By that we understand those properties of infinite being that explain the existence of those same effects from which we start in order to establish the existence of the infinite being, or at least that belong to it by virtue of the relations creatures have with it. Consequently, the point is exactly to prove first of all the *existence* of *relative properties* of the infinite being, which are *causality* and *eminence*. This is precisely what Duns Scotus intends by proving the existence of the *First* Being, whose *infinity* he will next prove by a subsequent dialectical move.[29]

Let us start by establishing that a first efficient cause exists, a cause such that it is not the effect of any other cause, and that produces in virtue of nothing other than its own causality.

"Some being is producible" is the initial proposition of the proof. Despite all the precautions already taken, that proposition risks appearing purely abstract, dialectical, and unreal. Indeed, it is abstract and dialectical, because it deals with a general property of common being, and posits the point of departure of an argumentation whose only content is abstract properties of this type. But it is not unreal, because the being from which it starts is not a being of reason. Let us recall again that Duns Scotus's metaphysics certainly can use a dialectical method. It is not logic. In saying "some being is producible," *aliquod ens est effectibile*, it implicitly supposes the actual existence of given beings and the actual existence of relations of cause to

effect among certain of these beings of which some produce and others are produced. Scotus does not start from the production, but because there is production, Duns Scotus calls being *producible* and speaks of *producibility*: properties endowed with a real foundation, like the being of which he speaks, but something that is universal, and which is considered here in their strictly metaphysical dimension, for reasons that Duns Scotus has asserted, instead of stopping at the physical dimension presented in the completely empirical proposition, *there are currently particular beings that are actually produced*. This is what Scotus himself calls real possible, midway between the real actual and the logical possible.[30] Either we accede to situating ourselves on the metaphysical scheme of being with Duns Scotus, and his whole proof will be constructed on the level of a real thing thus conceived, or else we read his texts as if they simply implied a dialectical consideration of *physical being*, in which case they will leave the impression of moving on the level of *conceptual generality* that is difficult to distinguish from the generality that characterizes the object of logic. In any case, let us not commit the error of criticizing the Scotist proof of God's existence in the name of an ontology that is not his. Here as elsewhere, except in the genuinely primitive level of ontology, the real drama is taking place off stage. We will have an opportunity to return to this important point.

Consequently, let us admit that the real datum from which we start is this definite fact: *producibility* of being. This property implies another, *productivity* of being, which is to say that, since we are dealing with what is real, if there is producible being, there is productive being. Moreover, we can show it. The producible or *effectibile* can only be so by nothing or by itself or by another. It cannot be so by nothing, because what is nothing is the cause of nothing. It cannot be so by itself, because no thing makes or engenders itself. Therefore the producible, *effectibile*, is made by another being, which is the *effectivum*.[31] Consequently, let there be some producer of the producible, which we will designate *A*. If it is the first in the highest definite sense, we have what we were looking for, a being that is the first efficient cause without being itself the effect of any other cause and that produces by virtue of its

causality alone. If it is not first in this sense, it is only a second cause (*posterius effectivum*), whether because it is the effect of a cause itself, or because it produces by virtue of some other. Let us admit that it is not first, and let us label its cause *B*. We will reason about *B* as we did about *A*. Accordingly, we will either continue this way to infinity, going from efficient cause to efficient cause, each one of which will be the effect of another, or we will stop at an absolutely first cause. But it is impossible to go on to infinity. So, there exists a cause that has no cause itself, which amounts to saying that the property of being from which we started, its *producibility*, implies the existence of a productivity that is itself endowed with another property, *primacy*.[32]

The demonstration seems to take as granted that regress to infinity in the series of caused causes is impossible, and indeed it is impossible. Surely, it will be conceded, first, that a *circular* causal series is inadmissible. If we admit that nothing causes itself, we must reject at the same time the hypothesis of a causal series in which one term would be at once the effect of another and the cause of all there is. Such a supposition practically amounts to admitting that a being could be cause of itself *qua* the effect of its own effect. If we reject that, it remains only to make sure that in the order of efficient causes we cannot do what Aristotle does when he admits that living beings can engender each other to infinity in a universe that, as we know, Aristotle supposes eternal, and where this takes place according to a linear order of generation where no *circular* causality can be alleged. We would thus have an indefinite line of second causes with no first cause.

That hypothesis is inadmissible. Furthermore, the philosophers themselves have condemned it, because they did not admit that an *infinity of essentially* ordered causes is possible. They only admitted it in the case of *accidentally ordered* causes, as we can see in Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, chapter 5, where he speaks of the infinity of individuals within a species.[33] This distinction does not coincide with the distinction between causes *per se* and causes *per accidens*, where we are only dealing with the relation between the two terms, the cause and its effect, while in the case of causes that are

essentially or accidentally ordered, we are dealing with the relations between two causes, in so far as they produce one effect. The *cause per se* causes according to its own nature and not according to some accidental character. In *essentially ordered* causes,[34] the second cause depends on the first in regard to its existence, for example, or in any other regard, but it does not depend on it in regard to its causality. A second difference is that in essentially ordered causes the causal relation is not of the same order or the same nature in the different degrees considered. For, from that moment there are degrees whose totality forms a scale, as they say, where the higher degree causes are more perfect than those that follow. Moreover, this second difference follows from the first, because no cause can hold its causal power from a cause of the same nature. Now, we recall, here we are dealing with the very causality of the cause. As the causality follows the nature, we must necessarily recur to a higher nature to account for causality that is itself higher. A third difference is that, when we are dealing with essentially ordered causes, the simultaneous presence of all the causes is required for the effect to be produced. This could not be more obvious, always by virtue of the fundamental reason that the *essential* ordering of causes is the ordering of their causality itself. Since the causality of the later depends on the causality of the earlier, any gap at all in the chain is enough to make the effect's existence impossible.[35] When these distinctions are admitted, we can establish first, that an infinity of essentially ordered causes is impossible; second, that an infinity of accidentally ordered causes is impossible; third, that even if we deny any essential order in the series of causes, infinite regress is still impossible.

It is proven that an infinity of essentially ordered causes is impossible. Let us consider the universality of essentially ordered effects. Since it is composed of effects, it is caused. But its cause cannot be part of the totality of effects, or else, by including its own cause, it would cause itself. Consequently, the cause of a universality of essentially ordered effect, is external to it, and since we are arguing about the totality of caused being, its cause is first.—In the second place, we have specified that in the order of

essentially ordered causes, the totality of causes must be posited simultaneously (since such causes confer their causality even on those that follow them). If there were not a first, these causes would be infinite in number. But an infinity of actually and simultaneously existent beings is impossible. Accordingly, the series of causes must stop at a first, as we require.—Third, the very notion of *prior* means *closer to the first*.[36] Thus, if there were no first cause, there could be no essentially prior or posterior cause.—Fourth, we suppose that a higher cause in the order of causality itself, is also a more perfect cause. Consequently, if there were an infinite series of essentially ordered causes, its cause would be infinitely superior to it, infinitely more perfect than it, with infinite causal perfection, and consequently, capable of causing by itself alone, without the help of any other cause. In short, it would be first in the sense we have defined.—Fifth, the trait of being able to cause (of being an *effectivum*), of itself does not necessarily imply any imperfection. Hence this trait can be found somewhere without any imperfection. But if, in any being, it is always found depending on something prior, then it is not found in any being without imperfection. Therefore, it can be found somewhere without imperfections, and where that is, it is absolutely first by virtue of its very independence. If this is so, an absolutely first causal power is possible (*ergo effectivitas simpliciter prima est possibilis*). We will see later that, if it is possible, that suffices to conclude that it exists in reality.

Supposing next that we are dealing with an infinity of accidentally ordered causes, it would be proved that infinity is impossible unless it stops at essentially ordered causes. If it is admitted by hypothesis that there is an infinity of accidentally ordered causes, that infinity is such that the causality of each of the causes does not depend on the causality of those that precede it. In a series of this kind, a posterior cause can consequently exist and act even if the prior cause has already ceased to act and exist. The moments of such a series thus exist one after another, as the son engenders in his turn when the father who has engendered him has already died. Because, if the son owes the father his having received being, he does not owe him its

conservation. In any case, even if his father is still alive, the son does not engender in his turn by virtue of the power of engendering that belongs to the father. So there is a succession of causes. Every succession supposes permanence. This permanent term cannot be a proximate cause. Otherwise, it would be involved in this succession itself. To the contrary, since the whole succession depends on this term, it must be prior by essence to what is successive and belongs to a different order. Accordingly, every series of accidental causes supposes a first term that is essentially prior to it.[37]

Lastly, it is proven that—even if we deny all essential order, whether among the terms of the series or among the totality of these terms and a first term—the regress to infinity in the series of causes remains impossible. By the first phase of our proof we know that nothing comes from nothing. From there it follows that some nature is *effective*. (It may be observed in passing that the argument shows to what point Duns Scotus is conscious of reasoning about some property that is actually existing, however abstract it may be.) If we deny that there is an essential order among agents, this productive nature, *natura effectiva*, does not cause by virtue of any other and although it may be posited itself as caused in some given singular occurrence, there is one of them in which the *natura effectiva* is not caused, which is what we proposed to establish. If we posited this nature capable of causing as itself caused in every single being where it is found, it immediately becomes contradictory to deny all essential order. Because if it is caused in all individuals, their whole series must depend causally on a cause that is external to the series, as the previous argument just established.

These three proofs focus on the same property of being, which could be called its *causality*. They contemplate this property in itself on the level of metaphysical abstraction, that is, of real being as the metaphysician grasps it *qua* metaphysician. All three proofs consist of arguments that concentrate on productivity and producibility, which we know belong to being, since in fact there are beings that produce and others that are produced. The three proofs cover the totality of conceivable relations among any beings, whether these relations are posited as essential or they are posited as accidental. All three

conclude by posing a first term, first cause of every series of causes, whatever the way we conceive them. Lastly, all three move forward starting from a relative property of being, the property being has of being able to be caused.

This last characteristic offers Duns Scotus the occasion of specifying his own conception of a metaphysical proof of the existence of a first being. He puts the objection to himself that his proof is not a demonstration properly speaking, because every demonstration focuses on the necessary. Scotus's demonstration focuses on the fact that something is *caused*, which is always contingent.[38] The Subtle Doctor answers that we can indeed argue starting from the contingent, notably as follows: a certain being undergoes mutation; the term of this mutation then begins to exist in this being, and consequently, a certain nature is encountered that is actually caused or produced. From this it follows, in virtue of the correlation of terms, that an efficient cause exists. Such an argument would be set in the order of contingency. Yet, Duns Scotus observes, when proving the first conclusion, that he does not argue thus but rather in the following manner: "Some nature is producible, therefore some nature is productive," *aliqua natura est effectibilis, ergo aliqua est effectiva*. Two errors are to be avoided on the subject. The first, already noticed, would be to transpose the argument from metaphysics to logic. The second, which Duns Scotus rejects here, would be to believe that by arguing about the real, he is arguing about the empirical existence of this real being. Once again, metaphysics stands between physics and logic. It is closer to physics because both are about the real but still distinct from it. The subject itself of the proof is not an actually given change, movement for example. It is the mobility itself of the mobile, the mutability of the mutable, the *possibility* of the *possible*. In other words, we did not start from physical existence to infer its cause, but from a real determination of metaphysical being, its *causability*, in order to infer another real determination, its *causality*, with the goal of inferring another real determination, its *first causality*. In consonance with his own notion of metaphysical being, Duns Scotus contemplates all of this from the standpoint of *quiddity*. The very essence of the causable implies that of a first cause. Perhaps it will be objected that if matters are thus, we are not in

the order of actual existence. Yes, because we argue about the metaphysical entity of common being, *ens commune*, which is the very essence of the actually existent. The possibility of being, which is real, alone permits us to attain the *necessary*, and therefore also the *demonstrated*. We have just established in three different cases (which exhaust the dimensions of the problem) that the essence of the given causable implies the essence of a first uncaused cause.[39] It remains only to show that this last essence is possible. From that we will finally see that, if it is possible, it actually exists in reality. The actual existence of such a cause, reached by this path, can only be necessary, which is precisely what Duns Scotus intends to demonstrate.[40]

Let us return to our first conclusion: a certain efficient cause is absolutely first. The first conclusion leads to this second: the absolutely first efficient cause is uncausable. It can even be said that the second conclusion immediately follows from the first, because a cause can only be absolutely first if it depends on no other cause in its existence or in its causality. This results from the previous proof that left only the choice between an impossible regress to infinity, a vicious circle, or a finite series of causes causing each other, or else stopping at a first cause that is not caused by anything. If we accept this last conclusion, it must be taken in its full scope, that is, as valid in every order of causality, not just for efficient, but also for material, formal, and final causality. Metaphorically speaking, the final cause is what moves the efficient cause itself to exert its causality. If, as has been established, the first efficient cause does not depend on anything in this efficiency, it cannot depend on an end that is outside its essence. But what does not have an extrinsic cause, no longer has any intrinsic cause, because the intrinsic cause, precisely *qua* intrinsic, is part of the causal effect. Therefore, if the first efficient cause has no extrinsic cause in its action, still less does it have one in its being, which excludes its having a material or a formal cause.[41] In short, the first efficient cause is uncausable.

There remains the proof's third and last phase, as rapid in pace as the first was slow. In it we are present at the brusque climax of this metaphysical operation:

> The third conclusion about the first producer, *primum effectivum*, is that the first producer exists in act: *primum effectivum est actu existens*, and a certain actually existent nature is the first efficient cause. Demonstration: that for whose essence it is absolutely contradictory to be by another, can be by itself, if it can be. Now, it is absolutely contradictory to the essence of the first efficient to be by another; this follows from the second conclusion. It follows from the fifth reason in favor of the first conclusion that this first efficient is possible; the reason seems not to conclude, but it concludes this. . . . An absolutely first efficient can, consequently, exist by itself. Therefore it exists by itself, because what *does not* exist by itself *cannot* exist by itself. Otherwise, non-being would lead something to being, which is impossible, or again, one and the same thing would create itself, so that it would no longer be entirely uncausable.[42]

Such a conclusion requires more commentary. In order to eliminate first all merely apparent difficulty, let us recall that if Duns Scotus proceeds here by way of the being of the essence and of the possible, he does not condemn the way that proceeds starting from empirically given existence, like the way St. Thomas Aquinas followed.[43] Scotus's proof is set up in the order of the necessary. He prefers it to the proofs that get by with the contingent.[44] Having said this, and without disputing that we must not exaggerate what distinguishes Duns Scotus from Thomas Aquinas,[45] we can add that it is necessary not to diminish what separates them either. First, Scotus never presented these proofs, whose validity he does not dispute, as *his own*. The only proofs of God's existence that Duns Scotus develops in his own name are those we are currently analyzing. Furthermore, Duns Scotus's preference for the proofs he proposes is connected to a whole series of other preferences that form an imposing whole, because they include a noetic and an ontology that differ from those of St. Thomas. Duns Scotus and St. Thomas do not share the same notion of being, of essence, of existence, of their mutual relation, or of their relation to the human intellect. It is because of these deep-seated reasons, situated at the very heart of metaphysics, that the proofs of God's existence are not the same in the two doctrines. Ultimately, even if

Duns Scotus concedes the legitimacy of the Thomist proofs of God's existence (something he does not do unreservedly, because he prefers others), we may doubt that if Thomas Aquinas had known Duns Scotus's proofs, he would have accepted them. Starting from empirically given beings in whom existence is distinct from essence and from which he works back to a first *esse* posited by a judgment of analogy, Thomas Aquinas doubtlessly would not have agreed to start from a univocal concept of being or agreed to abandon the empirical existence of effects (which alone allows him to affirm their cause's existence) in order to establish the latter's reality by virtue of its essence's intrinsic possibility. If there is this sort of difference between the two doctrines, it would be useless to impose the conclusion that they are far from or near to each other. All that can be said is that it is difficult to regard two metaphysics that are so different as a single metaphysics. Each of us will judge differently to what point they are a single metaphysics, according to his requirements on the subject of metaphysical agreement, and there is no objectively valid formula to determine that.

Let us keep to the Scotist proof itself in order to avoid certain difficulties that risk obscuring its sense. Critics have taken up the first under several forms. It amounts to saying, with one of its historians, that "the alleged demonstration *a posteriori* is transformed, without Scotus saying so, into an *a priori* demonstration," with the result that it "is exposed to his own criticism of St. Anselm."[46] Let us leave St. Anselm for later. There will be time to talk about him when Duns Scotus introduces him into the debate. Also, Anselm's presence is not necessary here. It can only be maintained that Duns Scotus proceeds *a priori* in some moment of the proof. He does not prove the first cause's existence by our concept of this cause, for the simple reason that he denies we have such a concept. His proof, it should always be recalled, turns on a proposition: *the infinite being exists*, which, though demonstrable *propter quid* in itself, is only demonstrable for us by a demonstration *quia*, from creatures, *ex creaturis*.[47] What produces the opposite illusion is that on the way we forget—that is the reader forgets, not Duns Scotus—what aspect of the creature falls within the metaphysician's consideration. The

metaphysician considers the creature's being, and it remains that even insofar as common being, *qua ens commune*. With greater reason, the being remains the creature's if what is first considered in it is its character of *causable* being, which is tied to its very condition of creature. It can be said that Duns Scotus's proof is extremely abstract, not more so, however, than the proofs of William of Auvergne, which Duns Scotus's proof recalls in certain respects.[48] But the proof keeps exactly to the level of abstraction that defines the object of metaphysics for Scotus. Based on the real properties of *causality* and *producibility* that in fact belong to the creature, the proof remains a demonstration *quia* from one and to the other, and nowhere metamorphosizes into a *propter quid demonstration*.[49]

When we pass dialectically from the given possible to the necessary that this possible implies, we do not start from God's infinite essence as from a given, but work back toward it by a demonstration *quia* in order to reach its existence, through the essence, by a demonstration *quia*. This is even to attempt to reach the infinite on the side that is least inaccessible to us: this *relative* property, its causality, that in some way it turns toward the creature. But perhaps it will be objected that even if Duns Scotus does not grant us an idea of God, he nonetheless proceeds *a priori*, because "he concludes at existence from an idea."[50] Certainly, but from what might we conclude at existence? Those who deny that we can conclude at God from an idea generally deny that there is any means of concluding at God. The issue is to find out whether this idea is a pure logical form or if it has real content taken from experience. Here, the second hypothesis is the good one. In Duns Scotus's mind, his proof has an *a posteriori* basis no less than the Thomistic proofs. What is not the same is the object of the experience. To base ourselves on the properties of common being, with which the real science that is metaphysics deals, is to attribute necessary existence to a being at which we conclude starting from the metaphysical properties of the given being.

Still, the same objection can be raised again in another form. However the proof is shown to be self-consistent, it remains true that the proof concludes existence starting from the possible, and again, would that not be an *a priori*

method of demonstration? The third phase of the proof is at issue here, in the part that is most difficult to grasp. If we reproach Duns Scotus for admitting that something whose existence must be affirmed exists necessarily, it is necessary to say with Kant that every proof of God's existence is subject to this necessity, and that the proof is *ontological* in the Kantian sense of the term. Thus, Duns Scotus's proofs are ontological from the viewpoint of critical idealism, but they are no more and no less ontological than Thomas Aquinas's proofs. The only question worth raising, unless we are involved in a general discussion of Kantianism, once the element of Avicennist realism in Scotus is acknowledged, is to find out whether the proof of God's existences abandons the realm of real being at the precise moment when it reaches this conclusion.

Let us examine this dialectical gambit more closely. At the point where it is effected in order to hasten the outcome, Duns Scotus has already established that an absolutely first aptitude for causality is possible: *ergo effectivitas simpliciter prima est possibilis*.[51] What is to be understood by that? Exactly that such a concept implies no contradiction. Of itself, the concept of causal power does not necessarily include any limit. Therefore, we can conceive it as unlimited. More precisely, we can conceive it as belonging to a subject in which the power is found with no dependence on something prior, that is, in a nature that is absolutely first, *qua* efficient cause. If there is no contradiction in that, and there is not, an absolutely first causal power is *possible*. Besides, we have already made clear that such a being is uncausable, and that it is so precisely *qua* first. Therefore, if it is possible, and we know that it is, it can only be of itself. The critical part of the argument is here: if this possible being cannot have its possibility from another, it can only have it of itself, and how would it have it, except by existing. This is why Duns Scotus says: "What does not exist of itself is not a possible being of itself, otherwise, since its possibility comes to it neither from another (since this would be contradictory), nor of itself (since it is not posited as existing or else it would create itself, which cannot happen, since it is uncausable, or else it would be created from nothing, which is absurd). In short, the only conceivable reason

why an absolutely first cause is possible is that it exists. This fundamental truth—that God's actual existence is the very root of his possibility—has never been better illuminated.

Very well, it will be said, it still remains true that existence appears suddenly here at the end of a dialectic in which only concepts have been utilized! That is an error, a quite excusable one, but we must undo it, if we want to understand Duns Scotus. Existence does not appear suddenly at the end of the proof, because what is found there is just that from which we started and that we kept in sight during our journey. *Effectibilitas* (the being's aptitude to be caused) and *effectivitas* (the being's aptitude to cause) are metaphysical properties of real being given in experience.[52] The first *effectivum* to which the proof leads is not obtained by a different dialectical development from the one that likewise leads to positing a first unmoved mover. The only difference is that, following his own path, Duns Scotus ends up closer to God as God than if he followed the path of Aristotelian physics. As to the last phase of the proof, it does not consist of decreeing that if the first cause is possible *in thought*, it exists in reality, but rather in making clear that if it is possible *in itself*, that is so because it exists. We rightly say *in itself* because the essence's possibility is that of the being, and the point is precisely to show that the existence of this essence alone can cause its possibility. The point is not to transform something possible into something real by dialectical magic, but, on the contrary, to show the only conceivable ground of possibility that we can observe, in something real whose intuition escapes us.[53]

C The last end and the supreme being

Just as it can be proved that an absolutely first cause exists, it can be proved that an absolutely ultimate end exists. It is proved firstly by recasting the arguments already proposed from the standpoint of efficiency, and now from the standpoint of finality. Here again, the point of departure is empirical observation taken to the strictly metaphysical degree of abstraction. Aristotle

teaches that every nature acts with a view to an end, which is true but less evident than when we are dealing with agents endowed with intellectual knowledge. Since humans act in view of ends, there is finality in being. We will consider finality metaphysically under the common aspect of *finitivum* and *finibile*, that which *is* end and that which *has* an end.[54]

By way of example, let us transpose the first argument by efficiency into an argument by finality. This argument was based on the complete collection of causes and effects,[55] and concluded at a first efficient cause posited as Uncausable. If everything that acts, acts with a view to an end, we can consider the universality of beings as acting with a view to essentially ordered ends, that is, so ordered that one end is end by virtue of the finality of a higher cause. If this is true, the total collection of beings engaged in their relations of finality depends on an end that is not itself included in the collection, otherwise either we would go on to infinity, or else we would go around in a circle of ends that are their own ends. Therefore, an end of the universe must be posited that is external to the universe and that, while end of everything else, has itself no other end.

This posited, we can add that the first (or ultimate) end is uncausable in the order of finality, precisely because it is not ordered to any end in itself, and even that it is uncausable in regard to any efficient cause, because what has no final cause has no efficient cause. If every efficient cause that acts by itself, not by accident as chance does, acts in view of an end, what cannot constitute the end of any action cannot be the effect of any action. In other words, in a universe where finality is coessential to efficiency, what cannot serve as an end cannot be caused. Thus, the *infinibile* is *ineffectibile* by definition.[56]

We have just proved, first, that an end possesses the character of first; next, that this first end has no cause. It remains to prove that it exists. Since finality is a property of being, and since this fact, such as we observe it, would not be possible if there did not exist an end for which nothing else is the end, then this last end certainly exists, if only it is *possible*. It is not contradictory, because there is nothing contradictory in conceiving an end that has no end

itself. We then ask from what this end can get its possibility. Not from another, since it is strictly *uncausable*; not from nothing, because nothing comes from nothing. Therefore, it is because it exists as such, that it is possible. In short, "a first orderer to ends exists in act," *primum finitivum est actu existens*. This primacy in the order of the end belongs to some actually existing nature.[57]

Besides, the same conclusion could be obtained by focusing on the efficient cause, because the end that a cause proposes to itself in acting is a being higher than the cause. It certainly must be, since this cause intends it as an end. If the First in its role as efficient cause is perfect *qua* cause, it acts with a view to an end; not with a view to an end other than itself, because then the latter would be superior to it. Consequently, it cannot act with a view to an end higher than it, which amounts to saying that it is the highest of all.[58]

The third proof intends to establish the existence of an absolutely first nature in the order of eminence. It does so by following, in the order of the formal cause, the path followed to establish the existence of a first efficient cause. The reality upon which this proof is supported is the nature itself, that is to say, the reality of the form. The relation that permits us to establish the proof is the hierarchy that reigns among the forms. This hierarchy stems from the very distinction of the forms, because each of them defines, so to speak a certain quantity of being that cannot be changed without augmenting or diminishing the form. This is why Aristotle said, in an often-quoted passage, that the forms are like numbers,[59] their distinction being the same as the hierarchy that constitutes their series. In the hierarchy of forms, a first term must be admitted and admitted for the same reasons we admit a first efficient cause, namely that the forms are essentially or accidentally ordered. Moreover, it suffices to prove it in the first case, where each term of the series owes its very formality to a higher term, since the other cases ultimately postulate an essential order of this kind. The proof consists once more in making clear that the relations of perfections that are within the totality of the forms cannot rise to infinity or cause each other in a circular manner or come from nothing. Accordingly, a nature must necessarily be

posited that is supremely eminent in the order of formality. Here, we recognize the Scotist version of the proof by degrees of perfection.

As supreme, this nature is obviously uncausable, because being superlatively good, nothing could be an end for it, and since it is supremely being, nothing could confer being on it. Moreover, to be causable it would have to be essentially ordered to another, in which case it would not be the highest. Let us add that such a nature is possible since no contradiction appears between the concepts of nature or form and that of absolute primacy in an order. Here again, the conclusion forces itself on us: a supremely eminent nature, which by definition cannot hold its possibility either from nothing or from another being, can only hold it from itself. Its existence is the only conceivable cause of its possibility.[60]

In each of the three cases contemplated, the proof leads to a first nature in the absolute sense of the term, that is, such that no nature can be posited as prior to it. Since the primacy of each of them is absolute, it can be shown that the three natures are only one, by making it clear that these three primacies mutually imply each other. Indeed, the first cause cannot act for an end that would be higher than it, because there is nothing of the kind. Nor could it act for an end other than itself without being dependent on this end. Therefore, it can only act for an ultimate end that is identical to itself, which amounts to saying that the first efficient cause and the ultimate end are only one. As for its primacy in the order of nature or form, it is equally evident by virtue of the definite causality that belongs to it.[61] The first cause is that because it is the cause of the whole collection of other causes. In this capacity, as we have seen, it is literally outside the series, which amounts to saying that it does not cause the other cause in the sense in which the latter, even essentially ordered, cause each other. Consequently, it does not produce them in the manner of a univocal cause but of an equivocal cause, as nobler and more eminent than they. Thus, supremely eminent in its capacity of efficient cause, the first producer, *primum efficiens*, is identified with the supremely eminent.[62]

From there comes its necessity and its unity. This triple primacy does not

just belong to the same nature, in such a way that whatever possesses one also possesses the others. Their identity is such that what one of them is, so also are the others. To be exact, the first efficient is singular in nature and in quiddity: “According to quiddity and nature, there is only one first producer,” *primum efficiens est tantum unum secundum quidditatem et naturam.*

Indeed, since the first efficient is uncausable, it owes its existence to nothing, that is, it is necessary of itself, *ex se necesse*. Let us understand the expression in the strong sense, as signifying that such a being is essentially indestructible. For it not to exist, it would either have to be destroyed by an internal contradiction, in which case it would not even be possible, or be destroyed by an external cause, in which case it would not be the highest nature that we have said it was. That being true, if it *is*, it cannot fail to be, and that is what is called *necessity*.

Being necessary, this nature is one. First, because if there were two of them, it is not clear how they could be distinguished. If two natures are necessary beings, each of them can only be distinguished from the other by real reasons that are proper to them. [Translator: *Reason* and its French equivalent translate the Scholastic technical term *ratio*.] So, we can make two hypotheses: these reasons are formally reasons for existing necessarily or they are not. If they are not, neither of the two beings in question is necessary. If they are, each of these two beings must possess both reasons, because both of them condition necessary existence. In the latter case, each of the two beings will be necessary by virtue of two real reasons. That is impossible, because in order for these reasons to be two, neither can include the other, and since each of them is a reason for necessary existence one of the two could be suppressed without undermining the necessity of the being. Obviously at least one is necessary, but given that it does not matter which, the being in question is necessary by virtue of a reason such that it would be no less necessary if the reason were suppressed, which is manifestly absurd.

Let us add that two necessary beings are inconceivable in any genus of cause that we choose. Species are distinguished like numbers. The idea of two natures that are distinct precisely *qua first cause* or *supremely eminent*

nature is the idea of two natures that would be distinct *qua* identical. As for the order of the final causes, to posit two supreme ends would amount to positing two systems of beings, each of which would be ordered to one of the ends, that is, to posit two universes instead of one.

In a general way, moreover, no given order would ultimately depend on two terms, because we could then suppress one of these ultimate terms, while conserving the other, without the dependence of the order in question being affected, which proves that the order envisaged does not depend on at least one of these two terms. In short, whether we are dealing with the order of efficiency, finality, or eminence of being, there cannot be two first terms closing the series of being in any of these three orders of dependence. Accordingly, there is a unique nature upon which the other beings depend in the triple order of dependence. In other words, considered in its quiddity or nature, the first efficient is the same being as the supreme being and as the supreme end.[63]

Thus ends the proof of the existence of a first being. For metaphysics to attain the subject with which theology will deal, it remains for it to prove that this first being is infinite. However, this existence of a being transcending the order of the contingent and of becoming is already definitely guaranteed. It is guaranteed by a method that consists of determining an essence to which existence belongs necessarily. Two points must be emphasized here. On the one hand, it is true that the existence of the First is attained by means of the essence, but on the other, that the thing itself is possible only because the existence is included in the essence known as absolute impossibility of not existing. We cannot follow the Scotist proofs of God's existence in their development without being surprised when we remember the appearance they acquire later in certain disciples of the Subtle Doctor. It may be that he is indirectly responsible for that because of other features of his thought. Moreover, it is difficult to believe that men as profoundly imbued with Scotus's principles as Francis of Meyronnes, for example, should have completely betrayed the spirit of his doctrine. This problem will be examined elsewhere.[64] For the moment, it is right to observe that nothing in the

dialectic of the *Opus Oxoniense* suggests the idea of a divine essence starting from which, by going through a more or less considerable number of intermediate predicates, we finally reach existence. It even seems particularly impossible to maintain that Duns Scotus situated the existence of the first essence after its infinity, since we have just observed, on the contrary, that the First's existence is definitely established before his infinity. Far from justifying the dialectical division of the divine essence that will take place in certain of his disciples, Duns Scotus's argument irresistibly invites us to conceive the First as an indissoluble identity of an essence and its existence or, if one prefers, of an essence such that it exists in principle.[65] Let us add that this perfect match of existence to essence in Duns Scotus's theology extends to all that our thought determines as a constituent of the divine essence. Between God's understanding or will and his being or nature, there is a real and complete match.[66]

D The infinite being

Starting from the relative properties of the First Being, we have just demonstrated that it exists. To prove its infinity as well, which would be to prove that the infinite being exists, Duns Scotus begins by making clear, starting from the First Being's triple primacy, that this being is endowed with intelligence and will, and moreover, that its understanding involves an infinity of distinctly grasped objects. Next, Scotus will prove that this understanding is the very essence of the being. Afterward, from that, he proves that its essence is distinctly representative of an infinity of objects, and finally that it is infinite.

These preambles suppose that the problem of the existence of the First Being is already resolved. Now, the point is no longer to prove that a first being exists, but rather to prove that this first being, whose existence is now considered established, is infinite. Perhaps it is not excessive to consider this distinction as important, or for all practical purposes, to indicate it is may be significant in our subsequent analyses. Here, Duns Scotus does not proceed

as a metaphysician who pursues metaphysical goals, but as a theologian, who uses metaphysics for the goals of theology, and not only Christian theology in general, but his particular Christian theology. Obviously, we can hold that from a sufficiently general viewpoint there exists only one Catholic theology, namely, that of all Catholic theologians, whose theology is one by the unity of their conclusions. Likewise, we can hold that there is a sort of *Franciscan* theology, whose usefulness is due to the *spiritual family resemblance* in the way it justifies similar conclusions. It is certainly a real, legitimate object of historical research to isolate the shared traits to which this resemblance is due. The fact remains that if this spiritual family exists, its members are individuals, and we can only distinguish them one by one through their individual differences. This third point of view is certainly no less legitimate than the previous ones, and it takes on special importance in a doctrinal monographic study. After all, if Duns Scotus had thought that his predecessors had succeeded perfectly in their endeavor, he would not have attempted his own. In fact, his proofs of the existence of God are not those of St. Bonaventure or Ockham, no more than they are of Thomas Aquinas, Anselm, or Augustine. Taking note of differences where they exist is not to exaggerate then, and it is simply to observe a fact when we mark the relation of metaphysics as Duns Scotus understands it to theology as he teaches it. It may be that the path followed by the proofs of God's existence is indeed significant in the sense that it lets us clarify certain difficulties that will not fail to appear later on, stemming notably from the purely philosophical scope of his proof. We will not articulate it here, because Duns Scotus himself does not articulate it there. Is it exaggerated to say that the Subtle Doctor is a theology professor here? As the God who is the subject of theology itself, the God whose existence Scotus proves, must be attained as the *object of our theology*, that is, the infinite being. Since Scotus intends to prove, he proceeds philosophically, but the path he follows has led him to a first being, transcendent to the totality of beings, the *equivocal* cause of their totality, and whose demonstration by itself constitutes the proof of the existence of some god. We can wonder whether this god in Duns Scotus's philosophy would not

be roughly the god of Aristotle and of philosophers ignorant of Christianity. It is a simple hypothesis, currently devoid of any truth value, which we can at least formulate as such, provided only that facts already known summon us to it. The scheme Duns Scotus has just assigned to himself can be understood as an invitation to do so, because ultimately, what non-Christian philosopher has ever established the existence of a first being endowed with an *infinite* intelligence, and *infinite* will, and consequently that is *infinite* in its very essence? In other words, what non-Christian philosopher has ever undertaken to prove the existence of God, as he must be conceived in order to constitute the object of *our* theology understood in the manner of Duns Scotus? We can follow the Subtle Doctor faithfully without forbidding ourselves to wonder whether, starting from the point at which we are, Scotus's metaphysics do not move on grounds that he himself knows to be specifically Christian.[67]

a Preambles to the proof

The first preamble to the proof establishes that *the first efficient is intelligent and willing*. In other words, the first efficient cause is endowed with intelligence and will.[68] Indeed, this first efficient cause acts of itself and not accidentally. Otherwise, it would not be first in the order of efficiency. Everything that acts, even in the order of simple physical natures, acts for an end. Using a remarkable argument, Duns Scotus then points out that "every natural agent considered precisely *qua* natural, if it did not act with a view to some end, would act necessarily and in the same manner as if it were an independent agent." In other words, if we understand the hypothesis correctly, a nature taken as the cause of its natural operation to the exclusion of any end external to this operation itself, behaves in its operation as if there were nothing other than itself. This is not the case, since natures act with a view to an end. Therefore, these natures have their finality also. For a nature to act with a view to an end, it must depend on an agent that loves this end. Here again, let us consider the totality of things, *tota natura*. The only thing on which it depends in the order of acting is the first efficient. Therefore, this first efficient must impress on the whole of nature the finality that is found

there. As it cannot do so unless it knows an end and loves it, it is necessarily endowed with intelligence and will.

The second argument proceeds as follows. If the first cause acts for an end, this end acts upon the first cause either as loved by an act of the will or else as loved in a merely natural manner. In the former hypothesis, the first cause is endowed with will and consequently with intelligence. In the latter hypothesis, we finish in an impossibility, because the first cause cannot love an end other than itself with the love by which a nature loves. We understand from this that the *first agent* cannot tend toward another being by virtue of a tendency by nature, as for example, matter tends toward the form or a heavy body toward the center of the earth. If it were that way, indeed, either the first agent would have an end itself, which we have demonstrated to be false, or else it would love *naturaliter* with a love by nature, itself alone, which would not explain that it is the cause of other things. The only conceivable reason for the first cause to act with a view to any other than itself is that it wills the end. Therefore, the first cause has intelligence and will. Let us note that a complete explanation of the argument would call upon Duns Scotus's fundamental distinction between *natural* and *voluntary* action. This is not the place to dwell on the distinction.

The third argument involves principles of equal scope, because it questions the whole metaphysics of causes and does so from a vantage point that is particularly important to Duns Scotus. The point of departure is an empirical observation, the very fact that there is contingent causality: "Something is caused contingently," *aliquid causatur contingenter*. For there to be contingency in the effect, there must be contingency in the cause. Every second cause causes in so far as it is moved by the first cause. Therefore, if the first cause moves by necessity, all the other causes are moved and will cause in their turn by necessity. By contrast, if a second cause exercises a contingent action, the first cause also exercises a contingent action. But we know on the other hand, that the will is the only principle of contingent operation. The first efficient cause must, consequently, be endowed with will.[69] The Scotist theme of the opposition between the natural and the

voluntary reappears in this proof linked to the rejection of the Greco-Arabic necessitarianism. If the first cause acted only by necessity of nature, the world would be completely submitted to its necessity.

Against this reasoning it could be objected that Aristotle recognized contingency in the universe without admitting on that account that the first cause's action was contingent. That is true. But what contingency did Aristotle admit? The contingency that is opposed to the necessary and to the eternal, as in the case of the accidental or of chance. God necessarily causes a uniform motion, but matter introduces deformity in its parts and thereby contingency. That is not enough to satisfy Duns Scotus, because the contingency required to account for finality cannot merely be that of chance. It must be that of a will, and to be completely explicit, of freedom. Here, the point is not to explain *contingent being*, but *contingent causality*. "Therefore I said: 'Something is caused contingently,' and I did not say, 'Something is contingent.'" *Ideo dixi: aliquid contingentur causatur, et non dixi aliquid esse contingens*. The contingent in the order of causality is "that whose contrary could happen when it happens." If this is so, Duns Scotus adds, I say that the Philosopher cannot save the contingency of effects while maintaining the necessity of the cause. The reason Scotus gives shows him to be resolutely committed to a very different universe from that of Aristotle. To what degree is he aware of that? There we have questions that it is as difficult to answer, as it would be desirable to be able to do so. In the present case, it will at least be noted that Duns Scotus does nothing to release Aristotle from the doctrinal responsibility that falls to him. Without denying in any way that Aristotle's first mover acts by necessity, Scotus simply remarks that, such being the case, the Philosopher no longer has a way of explaining that there is contingent causality and freedom in the world. If the total movement (*iste totus motus*) is necessarily and inevitably caused, when it is caused, that is, if, when it is caused nothing in it can be caused differently from the way it is, all that is caused by any part whatever of this total movement is also caused in a necessary, inevitable manner.

The response would be the same if we said that the first cause can produce

contingency without being a will itself, because things moved by natural movement can mutually hinder each other, which makes them move contrary to their nature, therefore with a *violent* movement. Here again, for Aristotle's uncreated world, Duns Scotus substitutes a created Christian world where nothing escapes the efficacy of the creative cause. *If* the First's causality is necessary, and *if* at the same time the First's efficacy attains the whole of being as in the Christian universe, causality that is necessary at its origin entails the necessity of every subsequent causal action. Everything will be subject to divine necessity there, as everything is subject to divine providence in the Christian world. This is why either nothing is produced in a contingent way, that is, nothing is caused in an avoidable manner, or else the First immediately causes in such a way that it could also not cause.[70] Nothing yet lets us see how far Duns Scotus will push his concern to safeguard the freedom of divine causality, but it is already posited as the first origin of all other freedom.[71]

Other preliminary conclusions are still required before establishing the First's infinity. All are connected with his intelligence and will, which have just been required by his absolute primacy in the order of causality.

When the first cause acts, its intelligence and its will are not other than its essence, whether the First knows and wills itself, or whether it knows and wants something other than itself. Let us first examine the case where the *first agent* wills itself. In tractate VI of Avicenna's *Metaphysics*, he says that the science that deals with the final cause is the most noble of all sciences that deal with causes. As we already had occasion to observe, the final cause precedes the efficient cause in dignity, because it moves the efficient cause to act.[72] Therefore, the causality of the first end is ultimate and completely uncausable by any action whatsoever in whatever genus of cause it might be. In short, its causality is absolutely *first*. From there, transporting the relation established by Aristotle between the first mover and the first mobile to the interior of the first cause, as it were, Duns Scotus infers that the causality of the first end consists in moving the first efficient by the love it inspires in it. To say that an object is loved by the will is to say that the will loves it.

Therefore, to say that the first end is loved by the first efficient cause is, therefore, to say that the first efficient cause loves the first end. This love is uncausable in the first efficient, because it is the first cause. Therefore, it is necessary of itself, but if it is something *ex se necesse esse*, it is identical to the first nature, which amounts to saying that the intellection and volition involved in the love the First has of itself are identical to its essence.

This conclusion is rich in corollaries. Duns Scotus enumerates four. The first's will is identical to its nature, because every volition belongs to a will. To know itself is likewise identical to the first nature, because nothing is loved that is not known, and if the love it has for itself is necessary of itself, the knowledge it has of itself is also something *ex se necesse esse*. Just as the identity of the volition and the first nature entails that of the will, likewise also the identity of the intellection with the nature entails that of the intelligence. Finally, since the reason always precedes knowledge, the reason the first has of knowing itself is also something *ex se necesse esse*, and as such this reason is identical to the first.[73]

The third conclusion preliminary to the proof of divine infinity concerns the case where the First's intellection and volition concerns something other than himself, whatever the object that is involved. Duns Scotus establishes it by proving in a completely general way that no act of intellection can be an accident of first nature. It is the absolutely first cause. Consequently, it has a way to cause every effect by itself alone and with no condition whatsoever. If it did not have knowledge, it could not cause the effect. Accordingly, knowledge of anything else whatsoever is not other than its nature. That the first nature could cause nothing else without knowing it is completely certain, because the first nature can only cause something if it wills it by love of the last end, and the first nature cannot love something without knowing it. Its intellection and its volition of something other than itself are thus certainly identical to its essence.

The same point could be established directly by arguing that the relation of all intellections to a given intellect is the same. We see this by our own intellect, where all intellections are received as coming from some object. We

already know that at least one intellection of the First is identical to its nature; therefore all of them are. But the most elegant proof starts from the fact that one act of intellection can grasp several objects ordered to each other, and the more perfect an act of intellection, the more it can apprehend at one time. Therefore, if we contemplate the case of an intellection so perfect that it is impossible to conceive one more perfect, it will suffice by itself to grasp all intelligible at once. The First's intellection is like this. Therefore, it grasps all intelligibles, and as its intellection is identical to its intellect, which in turn is identical to the First, its intellection and it are just one thing.[74]

There remains the fourth and last preliminary conclusion to the proof of the First's infinity. "The First's intellect always knows every intelligible necessarily and by a distinct act, and the knowledge it has of them naturally precedes the existence of this intelligible in itself."[75]

To begin, it is certain that the First can grasp every intelligible intellectually. The perfection of the intellect consists in being able to know every intelligible directly and in act. To be able to do so necessarily belongs to the nature of the intellect, because the intellect has as its object total being taken in its absolute commonality (*omnis intellectus est totius entis communissime sumpti*). We have just proved that the First can have no intellection that is not identical to it. Therefore, it has an intellection of every intelligible, one that is actual, distinct, and identical to itself, which means perpetual and necessary like it. It is no less certain that the knowledge that the First has of other things is prior to the being of these things themselves. Identical to the First, this knowledge is necessary like it, and since the being of no other intelligibles is necessary, their being is necessarily posterior to the knowledge the First has of them.[76] This case is unique in the doctrine of Duns Scotus, where the intellection precedes the intelligible. Moreover, it is quite precisely limited to the knowledge the First has of intelligibles *other than itself* and can be reduced to the knowledge God has of his own essence, which is prior to everything else.

Duns Scotus now has all the conditions required to establish the First's infinity. In proceeding to establish this proof, he begins by examining the

method followed in it by two of his predecessors. He is justified in taking their proofs into consideration at this precise moment since both base themselves on the First's efficacy to demonstrate its infinity. Now the first Scotist proof itself is based on efficient causality. Therefore, without precluding the possibility of looking for a new demonstration, it is natural for Scotus to find out whether the proofs offered by others are sufficient to establish this infinity.

b The path of efficiency

It is noteworthy that Duns Scotus should have thought first of weighing the value of Aristotle's arguments. He sums up Aristotle's doctrine with perfect historical exactness. The First moves with infinite movement. Therefore, it has infinite power. Duns Scotus remits to *Physics* III, 5, and *Metaphysics* XII, 7, where Aristotle affirms that the first unmoved mover cannot have size, either infinite, because the notion of infinite size is contradictory, or finite, because it moves during an infinite time and "nothing finite can have an infinite power."[77]

We immediately see how the problem interests Duns Scotus. To begin with, we are dealing with a strictly philosophical problem, the existence of a First, about which Duns Scotus himself speaks so strictly as a philosopher that, once he begins to establish its existence, he never once calls it *God*. Sometimes he uses a neuter, *Effectivum* or *Primum*, for example, and sometimes he speaks of it as *natura*, but, if we are not mistaken, he never speaks of it by calling it *Deus*, as he freely did when discussing the object of theology. Obviously, the First of philosophy is very much the same *subject* as the theologian's God, but everything transpires as if this subject presented itself in the guise of two different *objects*. Here the object of metaphysics is at stake. Duns Scotus and Aristotle are on the same ground.

Moreover, in this area, Duns Scotus has already gone beyond Aristotle, and it can even be said that he parted company from Aristotle at the start. By refusing to base his proof on the *physical* fact of movement and by basing it on causality in the order of *ens*, Scotus sets out on the path toward a First

that, if it is infinite, will be infinite other than in the cosmological order of movability. This is even why the initial choice between Avicenna and Averroes is decisive, since Thomas Aquinas always appears in Scotus's theory as a metaphysician who chooses his point of departure badly and tries to make metaphysics emerge from a natural philosophy incapable of performing the service required of it. Obviously, Duns Scotus sees clearly that Thomas Aquinas concludes as a metaphysician. Yet, precisely why does Aquinas begin as a natural philosopher? For, in any case, he needs to be more of a metaphysician to conclude at a *first* mover than a natural philosopher to prove that at a first *mover*. This is why, by situating himself straightaway in common being, Duns Scotus directly attains a First whose knowledge embraces all intelligibles and whose will can freely love them all. When Scotus turns toward Aristotle at this point, how would he not see the manner in which he had left Aristotle far behind? Starting from a cosmological problem, the Stagyrite has not yet emerged from it. Indeed, he will never emerge from it, and, on this point, Averroes is a faithful interpreter when he holds that proving God's existence pertains to natural philosophy, not metaphysics. What first principle can be attained from movement except a First Mover? What infinity can be legitimately attributed to a mover precisely as such, except the infinity of its power to move? This is what Aristotle correctly does. The First moves eternally, therefore its motor power is inexhaustible and unlimited. It is infinite. But Duns Scotus's First cannot be infinite in this limited sense, because it is already a first essence for us, whose triple causality, in the orders of efficient, final, and eminent causality, includes intelligence and will without limit, which are simply one with it. There is nothing that keeps us from allowing that this supreme energy of the cosmos moves our world eternally without asking of it the secret of an infinite about which Aristotle himself never thought.

But we are dealing with Aristotle, whose philosophical authority is great, and whenever possible, Duns Scotus utilizes authority, even if he does not surrender to it. This is what he calls making an argument apparent, touching it up, *colorare rationem*. Everyone knows that he used this method in a case

that we will encounter again soon, St. Anselm's famous argument. But Scotus treats Anselm the same as Aristotle. Scotus does well, because the argument's first premise is unacceptable to a Christian. "The First moves with infinite movement." *Primum movet motu infinito*. That would be true in Aristotle's eternal, uncreated world or in the world that Thomas Aquinas acknowledges could be created from all eternity. But it is not true in the Christian world that God created in or with time. To use Aristotle, let us start once more from the *possible*. The essence, *qua* absolutely first cause, can move by itself and without any help whatsoever. Unlimited in its power, since no external condition is required, it can produce an infinite movement. That whose effect can be infinite is infinite. The essence is therefore infinite.

This interpretation of the proof patiently implies the interpretation of the whole metaphysics of causes. Instead of the causality of movement being presented as a special case that justifies attributing limited infinity to the First, the infinity of its power—and let us not forget that Aristotle formally excludes the infinity of size, which he rejects as being inherently corporeal—it is merely presented as a particular case of an absolutely unlimited efficacy: the first mover has the power to produce all the effects that can be produced by movement. They are infinite if the movement can be infinite. Therefore, if the mover moves to the infinite, it is infinite.[78] However, even modified in this way, Aristotle's argument is not still beyond reproach, precisely because the infinity of movement does not authorize us to conclude more than an infinity of duration and of motor power, which is not yet the pure and simple infinity of essence that we seek. To succeed, an unrestricted causal infinity must be demonstrated, not one that can cause beings of the same species indefinitely, not even the one (whose possibility Aristotle would deny, furthermore) that could indefinitely cause an infinity of different species; rather, we must demonstrate a causal infinite such that it would simultaneously cause all co-possible effects, or according to its choice, whichever of those that are not co-possible. By that we understand that even if the first cause cannot cause something *white* that is *black*, it could at least simultaneously cause everything that is simultaneously causable and

separately cause every effect whose simultaneity would be contradictory.

To get there we must definitely abandon Aristotle's principle, although certainly not his conclusion, because the simple fact that the First could eternally move will never ground a conclusion of this kind. Duns Scotus thus comes to invent a final justification, which occurs to him in order to clarify Aristotle's conclusion. "The last probability, which occurs as the Philosopher's conclusion, is to be declared in this way" (*Ultima probabilitas quae occurrit pro consequentia Philosophi declaranda est ita*): everything that can cause several effects simultaneously as well as separately, each one of which requires in its cause the proper perfection characteristic of it, is more perfect if it can cause them simultaneously than separately. If it can simultaneously cause an infinity of them, it is infinite itself, and it remains so even though the nature of certain effects forbids their being simultaneously caused since in what regards this cause in itself, it would remain capable of causing an infinity of effects.[79]

In order to concede Aristotle's conclusion in this sense, much more than his principle is necessary, and it is necessary to confer a generality on it that Aristotle himself did not anticipate. What Duns Scotus proves here is no longer Aristotle's infinite; it is his own. This First, which formally and simultaneously possesses all causality of every possible cause, *omnem causalitatem omnis causae possibilis formaliter et simul*, is not yet the Omnipotent of Christian theology, which the Subtle Doctor will always make an object of faith and certainly not accessible to natural reason alone, but at least "an infinite power that, in so far as it is of itself, eminently possesses the causality required to simultaneously cause an infinity of effects, if their nature is such that they can be simultaneously caused."[80] In short, Aristotle's argument must be profoundly revised to obtain from it the infinity of divine power accessible to the philosopher, which still remains far from the absolute divine *omnipotence* that only the theologian's faith knows.

We could proceed otherwise without leaving the path of efficiency, and maintain that the creative power is infinite of itself. Indeed, in creation from noting, *ex nihilo*, whose two extremes are the creature and nothing; the

distance from nothing to the creature is infinite. Therefore, the creator has infinite power.[81] What is this argument worth?

Let us first observe that it takes the concept of creation as granted. Elsewhere Duns Scotus himself asked in what measure the concept is accessible to the philosopher.[82] For the moment he limits himself to positing it as the object of faith: “But this antecedent is posited only as believed,” *sed hoc antecedens ponitur tantum creditum*. If the First’s power of creating the world is the object of faith and not of a proof, we cannot use it to demonstrate philosophically that the First’s power is infinite. Duns Scotus bases himself on this to reject this argument *a priori*. Still, even supposing that the notion of creation is accepted unreservedly among concepts accessible to natural reason, we cannot base ourselves on it to prove that the first is infinitely powerful.

Such a position may be surprising, if we do not know how Duns Scotus justifies it. The concepts of *omnipotence* and *creation* are bound together in the memories of those who recall the Apostles’ Creed: I believe in God, the father almighty, maker of heaven and earth. *Credo in Deum patrem omnipotentem, factorem caeli et terrae*. We may be sure that Duns Scotus does not forget that. However this may be, a general reason makes our philosopher’s lack of confidence in a proof of this kind easy to understand. After all, a creature is only something physical, and how can something be found in a finite datum of this kind in order to ground an infinite power?

Moreover, the way in which Duns Scotus justifies his criticism is extremely significant. It should be examined all the more carefully in that in it we first encounter one of the most important notions of Duns Scotus’s metaphysics, namely his concept of created being, which, however, is not the easiest one to grasp.

The argument in question is based upon the idea that the distance of any being to nothing is infinite, something Duns Scotus denies absolutely. For there to be an infinite distance between two terms, one of those terms must be infinite. Between God and the most perfect creature possible, if there were one, the distance would still be infinite, not because of the distance between

the two extremes, but because of the infinity of one of the two terms. In short, the distance between two terms is all the greater in proportion as one of them is more perfect. In the case of the pair creature-nothing, the more perfect term is still finite, the distance that separates them is finite, and there is no need of an infinite power to cross it.[83] Let no one be misled on this point. Duns Scotus does not intend to maintain here that a being other than the First can create, but, as we will have a greater opportunity to see hereafter, he explicitly maintains that if creating is a divine prerogative, it is not one for this reason.[84] For the moment, let us retain a lesson that is fundamental for the ontology that emerges from this passage: the distance that separates a being from nothing is not measured by the infinite distance that separates existing from not existing, but by the finite distance that separates being something from being nothing.[85]

c The paths of intellect, will, and eminence

After establishing the First's infinity by following the path of efficiency, we can also establish its infinity by following the paths of intellection, will, and eminence.[86] The absolutely first cause's intellect simultaneously conceives the totality of intelligibles. The intelligibles are infinite, as is easily observed in relation to an intellect that never finishes apprehending them one after another.[87] This infinity of terms given successfully will be called *infinite in potency*. If the terms were given simultaneously, they would belong to *the infinite in act*.[88] If, as we have indicated by way of preamble,[89] the First's intellect always knows everything intelligible by a distinct and necessary act, we can conclude that the First always knows by a distinct and consequently unique act, the infinity of intelligibles without simultaneously including, *qua* eminent, the perfection of an infinity of intelligible essences, each of which includes the perfection corresponding to its proper reason. Those perfections, infinite and all taken at once, constitute an infinite perfection. Since they are eminently contained in the intellect that conceives them, this intellect is infinite itself.

The term *eminent* has not been surreptitiously introduced into this

demonstration, because, in its preamble, we already proved that the intelligibles are in the First's intellect before existing in themselves. Accordingly, this intellect does not result from their accumulation. It produces them. Moreover, we cannot see how their addition could constitute the intellect, because each of them, which is finite, adds something to the sum of the others, each of which is likewise finite, but none of them can add anything to this cause, which is infinite. It is because it is infinite that the first intellect simultaneously conceives an infinity of finite intelligible reasons. Since the latter suppose an infinite intellect, they could not constitute it. The only presupposition required for an intellection of this order is the *natura prima*, the first essence itself, whose mere presence in the First's intellect suffices to cause in it the knowledge of any intelligible object whatsoever, without the cooperation of any other object. That is to say, no other object can add intelligibility to the first intellection's intelligibility. The first intelligible, therefore, is not finite in any way. It is *in-finite*, and it is infinite in its very being, since each thing is in the order of being as it is in the order of intelligibility. Infinite intellection, infinite intellect, and infinite being are the three moments of one and the same reality.[90]

A similar proof can be drawn from the nature of the last end. Our will can desire and love something greater than every finite object, just as our intellect can, in what belongs to its particular nature, know something greater than every finite object.[91] Let us go further. It even seems that a natural inclination leads us to love an infinite good supremely. For, not only does our will, which is free, focus on such an object of itself (*ex se*), without a disposition acquired through prior effort (*ex habitu*), promptly and with pleasure (*prompte et delectabiliter*), but it seems that it cannot rest perfectly in anything else. This experience is important and, in its fashion, decisive, because, if it were contradictory to the good of the infinite being, the will would not tend so easily toward the infinite good as the *terminus* of its rest. Moreover, we will examine this point more closely soon in regard to the object of the intellect, but we can already say that the natural tendency of our free will toward an infinite good implies its object's infinity.[92]

On this point, Duns Scotus's argumentation is simple and clear. Nothing makes us think that he himself regards it as other than strictly philosophical. It is so in his eyes, because if he did not admit that humans have *distinct* and complete natural knowledge of their last ends, he always did teach, first, that humans are naturally ordered to God as their end and, next, that humans can know that and thereby know that God is their end.[93] Still, one must remember the limits that such knowledge must involve in virtue of principles posited by Duns Scotus himself. The most perfect concept of God naturally available to us is that of infinite being. Thus, humans can know themselves as naturally ordered to this infinite being, and as far as it is proven to be such, humans can know that there is an infinite being. This, however, does not mean that the concept of infinite being permits us to deduce that it is God precisely *qua* God. The very nature of this concept is opposed to that "since we have certain concepts of immaterial and material substances," *quia conceptus quosdam communes habemus de substantiis immaterialibus et materialibus*. Let us suppose that there is a *first* geometrical figure, and that we know it, but that it is the triangle, and we do not know that. We would be able to attribute all the properties that belong to it as a figure but not as a triangle.[94] Accordingly, humans can naturally know that the first being is infinite, because they can observe in themselves that they experience the desire for it, and about this being they can naturally know everything that belongs to a being from the fact that, since it is first in being, it is infinite at the same time.

After the paths of intellection and will, a fourth way that leads to the First's infinity is the path of *eminence*. This eminence, as we have made clear, is absolute, that is to say supreme. It is not contradictory to say that some thing is more perfect than something finite, but it is contradictory that something should be more perfect than the being that is supremely eminent in the order of being. Accordingly, if there is no contradiction between infinity and being, the First can be infinite, and since it is greater to be infinite than finite, the supremely eminent being *qua* being is necessary and infinite.

The same argument can be presented under another form, where infinity will naturally be taken in the sense of *intensive* and not only extensive

infinity, as in the case of Aristotle's first mover, moving the world indefinitely in time. Here is the argument: if it is not repugnant to its nature as infinite being, a being is not perfect unless it is infinite. Therefore, if by hypothesis it is not infinite, it is not perfect. From there, it follows that the supremely eminent and consequently all perfect being in the order of being is an infinite being.

The crucial point of this proof, as in the proof drawn from the object of will, is the compossibility that it supposes between *being* and *infinite*. On this point, Duns Scotus observes that their compossibility cannot be demonstrated *a priori* because, since the concept of being is first, it cannot be clarified by any other concept. We can at least observe that, if there is some un-compossibility between these two concepts, it is nowhere apparent. Being is known by itself, but the infinite is known by the finite. The concept we commonly have of it can be described as follows: the infinite is that which not only exceeds a given finite in any precise finite proportion, but, furthermore, surpasses it beyond any assignable proportion.[95] That, said, no uncompossibility appears between infinity and being. Let us recall that the being in question is *common*, that is completely indeterminate, and that finiteness does not belong to the essence of being thus conceived: "Finiteness does not belong to the concept of being," *de ratione entis non est finitas*. It is not even one of those trascendentals that are convertible with being. Therefore, we can think infinite being without being involved in any contradictions. To put it more strongly, we cannot associate these two terms without perceiving their remarkable agreement: "Why does the intellect whose object is being experience any repugnance in conceiving something as infinite? Why does that agreement rather seem to the intellect the most perfectly intelligible thing? It would be surprising that no intellect should perceive such a contradiction concerning its first object, when a dissonance so easily offends the ear. Indeed, if discord is immediately perceived and if it offends, how does it happen that no intellect immediately rejects an infinite intelligible as not suitable to it and even as destroying its first object?"[96] Consequently, there is compatibility between infinity and being, and if

infinity is a *possible* perfection of being, the supreme being is necessarily infinite.

Duns Scotus also describes this being that is supreme *qua* being or supremely eminent, as the "being such that a greater cannot be conceived." This is why St. Anselm's well-known argument offers itself as usable here, provided that it is made to undergo the necessary modification in order to transform what is given as a proof of the First's existence into a proof of its infinity. That Duns Scotus certainly understood it this way emerges from both his own declaration and from the place he assigns to the *Proslogion*'s argument, as revised and corrected by him, within the totality of his own argumentation.[97] Let us recall once more that at the point we have reached, the First's existence is unshakably established. Nevertheless, it could be held that here Duns Scotus appeals to a supplementary argument if only by way of probability, reinforcing proofs that are considered established.

Much has been written about the meaning of the verb *colorare* in the phrase "with that Anselm's concept of the highest thinkable thing is touched up," *per illud colorari illa ratio Anselmi de summo cogitabili*. It would be imprudent to attribute a precise sense to it at the outset in order to interpret what follows in function of the sense thus chosen. Rather we clarify the meaning of the verb when we determine exactly what it is that Duns Scotus does next. If we judge by the usage Duns Scotus himself has made of it in *coloring* an argument of Aristotle, this verb could designate such a profound modification that it is equivalent to a transposition properly speaking. But why conclude from one case to another? Each case is self-sufficient.

So, starting from the nominal definition of the word *God* that Anselm gives in *Proslogion* II, and that he sums up elsewhere in his manner as "God is that greater than which cannot be thought," *Deus est quo cogitato majus cogitari non potest*, Duns Scotus proposes to add the important clause, "without contradiction," *sine contradictione*. We call this clause important because, if the definition in question implied contradiction, it would not be thinkable. Duns Scotus has just expressed some difficulty precisely in proving that there is no contradiction between the two notions of *being* and *infinity*. The very

nature of the problem makes it difficult to resolve, and what the Subtle Doctor finally finds best, as we have seen, is to call on a kind of collective experience of the human intellect, which very far from understanding any conflict in it, rather perceives an intimate and profoundly satisfying agreement between the two terms. If Scotus appeals to St. Anselm here, it seems that he does so precisely because the *Proslogion* argument lets us establish the metaphysical possibility of the concept of infinite being. This possibility is nothing but its absence of contradiction. If we show that the concept of infinite being is not contradictory, let it be first posited in the understanding and then as realized. We will have demonstrated the complete possibility of such a being. This will not prove that an infinite being exists, but certainly that the First, whose existence has just been established, can be attained as infinite by following the path of eminence, precisely what Scotus intends to demonstrate.

The issue is to demonstrate that the highest conceivable exists in reality: "That the highest thing thinkable without contradiction is in reality," *summum cogitabile sine contradictione esse in re*. It is proven first for quidditative being (*esse quidditativum*), that is, for the being that belongs to the essence designated by the words *that which is such that nothing greater can be thought*. If the expression involves contradiction, it would be necessary to conclude that this essence, taken as essence, has no being, which amounts to saying that in the order of reality proper to the essence, it does not exist in reality. In fact, it is not contradictory at all, but how does Duns Scotus prove it? By appealing to the same experience that justifies the minor premise of his *quarta via*, namely, "The infinite is not incompatible with being," *infinitum non repugnat enti*. His reason for affirming it continues to be what he already proposed: "In this supreme object of thought (*in tali cogitabili summo*), the understanding finds supreme satisfaction (*summe quiescit intellectus*)." This same supreme object includes the reason of the intellect's first object: "Therefore in him is the highest reason of the first object of the created intellect, namely being, and it is in the highest degree," *ergo in ipso summa est ratio primi objecti intellectus creati, scilicet entis, et*

hoc in summo. Overall, this first phase of the argument certainly proves that, in speaking about the essence's reality (the essence of the infinite being), because the essence of the infinite being is possible, it exists in reality.

Let us pass from the *esse essentiae*, which is in reality but in thought alone, to *esse existentiae*, which exists in reality outside of thought. The issue then is to show that the *supremely thinkable* (*summa cogitabile*) does not exist only in the understanding that thinks it. We arrive there in two stages, neither of which is represented in St. Anselm's own argument. The first consists in noting that the supremely thinkable is possible, as has just been established. The second consists in showing that, if this *possible* being did not exist in reality, it would be contradictory, not at all because the concept of such a being that did not exist would be contradictory in itself, as Anselm maintained, but for the specifically Scotist reason that it is contradictory to the concept of such a being to exist by another cause. From there, that is to say from his own proof, Duns Scotus concludes, not that the supremely thinkable exists in reality but that what exists in reality is a *greater thinkable* than what is only in the understanding (*majus igitur cogitabile est quod est in re quam quod est tantum in intellectu*). About this he specifies: we will not understand it in the sense that this object of thought would be more thinkable if it existed, but rather in the sense that what exists is a greater thinkable that what is in the understanding alone.[98]

What has Duns Scotus done here? First, he has substituted his own proof of the existence of the First for the proof of God's existence proposed by St. Anselm. If it is contradictory that the First not exist, that is so, says the Subtle Doctor explicitly, "because to be from another cause is opposed to its concept, as was clear earlier in the second conclusion about the first producer," *quia repugnat rationi ejus esse ab alia causa, sicut patuit prius in secunda conclusione de primo effectivo*. The argument to which we are referred here sets out to show that the *primum effectivum* whose existence was already demonstrated at that point, also had to be held *uncausable*.[99] How would Duns Scotus invoke an argument here that supposes the First's existence to be already demonstrated, if he set out to demonstrate its

existence? We can believe that instead he does this: having proven in his fashion and to his own satisfaction that the First exists and even that he is infinite, Duns Scotus modifies the *Proslogion* argument in order to make it correctly prove the First's infinity. The endeavor can succeed, because, if we have already proven the existence of a first efficient cause that is itself uncausable (which is not done starting from the nominal definition of God but starting from the causality of God), we can next show that far from being contradictory and impossible, the concept of an infinite, supreme being that exists is *more* thinkable than the concept of the same being conceived as not existing. If this interpretation is correct, then the use of St. Anselm's argument certainly has the objective of proving the First's infinity.[100]

Going back over the totality of this dialectical edifice in order to clarify its outline and object, Duns Scotus recalls that he has successively proved: first, that there is an absolutely first being (*simpliciter primum*) by the triple primacy of efficacy, end, and eminence, and that this being is so absolutely first that there can be nothing before it. With that, Duns Scotus specifies, God's being is established "in regard to God's properties in relation to creatures or insofar as he determines the relation and dependence of creatures toward him."[101] Secondly, following the four paths, Scotus has proven that this First is infinite, as first efficient, as first knower of all knowables, as last end, and as supremely eminent. Now, concludes Duns Scotus, it only remains to unite the previous conclusion as follows: there exists actually among beings a triple first being. That which is triply first among beings is infinite. Therefore some infinite exists. With that, God's being is proved in regard to God's absolute perfection, the most perfect that we can conceive. Therefore, with that we have proven God's existence, achieved under the concept of God as the most perfect that is conceivable to us and that we could have of him.[102] The most perfect relative knowledge that we have of God is that he is the *first* being. The most perfect absolute knowledge that we have of him is that he is the *infinite* being. Everything that goes beyond this concept of God or that does not allow for us to draw connections by way of necessary consequence, escapes the grasp of natural knowledge, and remains unknown

to us here below, unless it has pleased God to reveal it to us.

By Duns Scotus's responses to the arguments that can be directed against him, we see how clearly he is aware of having gone beyond the limit of Greek philosophy. If there were an infinite being, he objects in name of the Ancients, how would there be room for anything beyond him in nature, and more particularly, how would there be room for evil alongside of him? The reality is, responds the Subtle Doctor, that the objection only contemplates an infinite active force acting by necessity of nature, whereas the First, whose existence has just been proven, acts freely and voluntarily. Consequently, there is room for something else outside him, provided only that he himself consents to it, and even room for evil.[103] This basic opposition between a necessary first cause and a contingent first cause, which already presents itself as the origin of many other problems, will, however, serve us as the key to resolve problems that the Ancients solved badly or that they even gave up. How can a power be infinite and yet move in time? To this question, like many others, we will see that the only new concept of First Being, conceived as the *infinite being*, permits us to offer a satisfactory reply. It is a philosophical reply, of course, as we have already said, and we will gladly repeat to those of our contemporaries who are interested in this aspect of the problem, but it will suffice to let Duns Scotus speak to see what other aspect of the problem interests him. We will refute this point later, he says arguing against the philosophers who maintain that the first necessarily does all it does itself immediately. But the argument has no difficulty for Christians, because they say that God acts in a contingent way.[104] Those who deny Duns Scotus the title of *Christian Philosopher* are not wrong, because, after all, he never attributed it to himself, but then we must go all the way and say that the only title he claims here is not *Philosopher* but *Christian*.

E Unicity of the infinite being

Once the existence of an infinite nature or quiddity is demonstrated, we can still wonder whether there is only one such nature or there are several. At the

point in Duns Scotus's commentary on Peter Lombard where Scotus poses the question, he does not hesitate to return to using the name *God*, which he had provisionally renounced while he proved the existence of the First. Accordingly, he simply and directly wonders whether there is only one God.

No hesitation about the answer is possible. The conclusion is certain: there is only one God. But some say that this conclusion is not rationally demonstrable and can only be held by faith. Notably, that is the thesis held by theologians who quote Moses Maimonides, according to whom the religious law alone assures us that God is one. What should we think of this?[105]

We will first note the form in which the problem is posed in Duns Scotus's doctrine. It is not that there is an option between two answers, one of which would exclude the other. It is possible without any contradiction, that God's unicity should be at the same time an article of faith and an object of rational demonstration. This was already the case of God's existence, which Duns Scotus regards as an article of faith but which, we have seen, he did not consider impossible to demonstrate.[106] The same holds here. Maimonides is right to say that the Mosaic Law imposes belief in God's unicity, and moreover everyone remembers the well-known text of Deut. 6:4, "Hear O Israel, the Lord thy God is one Lord," *Audi, Israel, Dominus Deus tuus Dominus unus est*. To this we may add Isa. 45:5, "There is no God beside me," *Extra me non est Deus*. Thus it is quite true that God's unicity is the object of faith, but God himself revealed it to the Jewish people because this rough people prone to idolatry needed to be instructed by the divine law. When God says in Exodus 3:14, "I am who am," *Ego sum qui sum*, or when the Apostle says in the letter to the Hebrews that he who approaches God must believe that he exists, neither God nor St. Paul intend to deny that this truth is demonstrable. It is useful that what can be demonstrated should be taught to the whole people by way of authority, because of the negligence humans demonstrate in the search for truth, of the impotence of their intellects, and of the errors committed in the demonstrations by those who mix the false with the true in the search for truth.[107] When simple people follow such demonstrations they can certainly wonder what to believe.[108] It is

good that a guaranteed, infallible authority should open a path that is easy and accessible to all.

This is why, without disputing that God's unicity is a revealed truth, we can seek demonstrative proofs that depend only on reason. All these proofs, excepting one that is based on the necessity of the First, are based on God's infinity, which has just been demonstrated. It is even why we can rightly hold them to be strictly rational. They rest on the most perfect concept of God that is naturally accessible to us. At no time do they encroach upon the area reserved to revelation alone.

Perhaps Duns Scotus could have begun by the fifth of his proofs, the one drawn directly from the First's absolute infinity, because that would eliminate the need for the four that precede it. The absolutely infinite cannot be exceeded. Since we have defined it as what exceeds any given finite, beyond any assignable proportion, its very concept implies that nothing exceeds it. Now, if there were several infinities, there would be more in their totality than in a single one among them. Consequently, by virtue of its very notion, a plurality of infinities is contradictory and impossible: "Therefore, infinity in many things cannot be numbered in any way," *ergo infinitum in pluribus omnino numerari non potest*.

Applying the same principle to the first modes of the divine being, it can be made clear, first, that a plurality of infinite intellects is impossible. The proof of this is purely dialectical and is established, if not by *A* + *B*, then by *A and B*. An infinite intellect knows perfectly all that is intelligible, precisely insofar as that is indelible of itself. Let there be given two gods, A and B. A will know B as perfectly as B is intelligible, that is, he will know B perfectly. Now, that is impossible. Indeed, A will know B by B's essence, or he will not know B in this way. If A does not know B by B's essence, but B is knowable by his essence, A will not know B as perfectly as B is knowable. But if he knows B by B's essence, A's cognitive act is posterior to B's essence, and thus A is not God. The conclusion is unavoidable, because every act of knowing that is not identical to its object is posterior to this object. If it were prior or simultaneous, it could do without the object. Since it needs it, it is

posterior to it. A being whose essence implies an infinite intellect is accordingly a unique being.[109] Dialectical objectivity could not be pushed further in the area of natural theology: “Therefore, if there are two gods, let them be A and B,” *ergo si sint duo dii, sit A et B* . . .

Next, let us proceed by the path of will. An infinite will is a sound will. It loves all that can be loved, precisely insofar as it can be loved. Let us return to our two gods. If B is another god, he is an infinite good, and on that account infinitely lovable. Therefore A’s will loves B infinitely. Now, that is impossible, because, since every being naturally loves its being more than another’s being, a sound will, as every infinite will is, rationally prefers itself to everything else. Since A prefers itself to B, A cannot love B infinitely. Furthermore, we could argue on the will itself as we have just argued on its object. Citing the classical Augustinian distinction between *uti* and *frui,* Duns Scotus reasons as follows: A enjoys B, or he uses B. If A uses B, his will is ordered to another object than itself, therefore it is not infinite. If A enjoys B, since he also enjoys himself, he enjoys two objects at the same time, each of which suffices to give him total happiness, which is impossible. The hypothesis is manifestly impossible, because it supposes that a will made totally happy by one object is made totally happy at the same time by another, whose destruction would not affect its happiness at all, since the will is already totally happy.[110]

A third path, which passes through the concept of good, leads to the same conclusion. A will that is ordered can desire one good that is greater than another and desire it more. If several infinite goods were possible, they would include more goodness than a single infinite good. In such a case, a will, without being disordered, could prefer several infinite goods to a single one. Consequently, it would not find perfect rest in any single infinite good. Since it is contradictory that an infinite good should not suffice to satisfy the will, a plurality of infinite goods is impossible.[111]

The fourth path starts from God’s infinite power. We see without much difficulty why an infinite power cannot coexist with another equally infinite power. Because each of them could cause the totality of possible effects,

unsolvable conflicts of jurisdiction could not help putting them at odds. Furthermore, Duns Scotus's unshakeable dialectical composure is instructive in itself. He does not limit himself to indicating broadly the general direction thought must follow. He is never satisfied as long as the proof's mechanism has not been adjusted and clarified in its slightest details. For example, here he first posits that two causes could not be total causes of the same effect in the same order of causes. (Doubtless, that would be granted to him without discussion, but he does not understand matters thus, and he proves his claims.) If this were the case, something would be the effect of another thing upon which, however, it would not depend. Indeed, if two total causes of the same effect are posited, we get the impression that one of these causes is sufficient. Yet here again, Duns Scotus is not satisfied with a confused acceptance of this kind, and he pursues his proof implacably. Nothing is essentially dependent upon something else, when its existence is not dependent upon that other thing. However, if C has two total causes, A and B, and if they are in the same order of causality, C would exist even in the case that either A or B ceased to exist. That is also proven because, given that A and B are both total causes of C, B would suffice to cause C without A, as A would suffice to cause C without B. With the major premise thus demonstrated, the syllogism can follow its course. Two causes cannot be total causes in the same order of causality. An infinite cause is the total cause of every effect whatsoever, and it is that as first cause. Therefore, no other power can be the first cause of any effect, which amounts to saying that no other infinite power can cause this effect.[112] The infinite power is, accordingly, unique, which is what had to be demonstrated.

As Duns Scotus himself indicates, all these proofs amount to showing that every *first* is unique by virtue of its very primacy. The argument, by which he previously established that the first in one order is identified with the first in another, again holds in the second case because the problem is the same, except simply in that instead of proving that there is only one First, we now prove that there is only one infinite. Just as nothing can be totally caused by two different causes, nothing can be ordered to two ends that would be at the

same time different ends and its ultimate ends. As the fifth argument (which we have placed ahead of the others) says, this is why there can only be one single term that exceeds all others, in all conceivable orders and beyond any given proportion. By its very nature the infinite rejects any numerical multiplicity. There cannot be several infinites that could be counted.

After having shown in five ways, at the same time combined and distinct, that the infinite's very nature implies its uniqueness, Duns Scotus proposes a completely different sixth philosophical path to justify the same conclusion. It is the *path of necessity*. It is good to pay close attention each time the Subtle Doctor involves himself in this area, because he shares it with his principal adversary, Greco-Arab necessitarianism. Because he intends to defeat it precisely there, he only enters it with extraordinary precautions.

Here he first appeals to brute necessitarianism of nature against the contrary thesis. If there could be several infinities, they would be so many individuals of the same species. By the species of corruptible beings, we can see that each is compatible with an infinity of individuals. The only difference is that, in the case of that which is necessarily, not only *could* there be, but there would necessarily be an infinity of them; *si possent esse infinita necesse esse, sunt infinita necesse esse*. Now, this consequence is false, Duns Scotus adds. Therefore the antecedent is false as well.[113] Since this is not an infinity of infinities, the infinite is not a species and there can only be one infinite. Furthermore, the same conclusion can be established by recurring once more to the detailed dialectical method through A and B. It is applied now in showing that two necessary beings would each necessarily include all that the other necessarily includes, which amounts to saying that nothing allows them be distinguished.

So, there is no doubt that the author of the *Opus Oxoniense* holds God's uniqueness to be a rationally demonstrable truth and that he sees it as a corollary of the concept of a first, infinite being, which is itself rationally justifiable. Certain arguments to the contrary, which Scotus leaves unanswered, are radically excluded here. For Scotus, either they were always mere dialectical experiments or else they pertain to an order of investigation

foreign to the *Opus Oxoniense*, or even, after letting them detain him for a while, Scotus has definitively left them behind. Whether for one of these reasons or something completely different, it is a fact that the great theological synthesis whose fundamental philosophical theses we are gathering has not retained the slightest trace of them. It is as if they never existed.

By contrast, their traces remain in *De Primo Principio*, chapter 3, conclusion 19, where Duns Scotus introduces an impudent fellow, *protervus*, who refuses to give up as long as he can formulate an objection. Indeed, after admitting the existence of a unique nature, simultaneously first in the order of efficiency, end, and eminence, we could maintain the existence of many other natures that, without being first from all these points of view, would still not be posterior in certain regards. Here, Duns Scotus thinks of Aristotle's doctrine, and says so. In Aristotle's doctrine it can be asked whether, though posterior to Pure Thought in the orders of eminence and end, the Separated Intelligences are posterior in the order of efficiency. This question can even be posed in regard to prime matter, which Aristotle perhaps did not consider to be caused by the First.

These remarks are interesting because they let us give the obstinate dialectician of *Theorema* XV, 2, his rightful name. He is a *protervus*. Recalling Aristotle's polytheism, he concludes that, since the position did not seem absurd to the Philosopher, we must be able to support it for the same reasons. Indeed, there are reasons, but they are refuted in *De Primo Principio* chapter 3, conclusion 19, which points out the irrational aspect of such a doctrine, or to put it better, incompletely rational. If the First is necessary of himself, and if he is the only one to be so, everything else is necessarily posterior to him in every regard: eminence, efficiency, and finality. If he is the highest end, and if everything has an end, everything is ordered to him as its end. If he is supremely eminent, everything else is measured in relation to him, unless we admit that some beings could have no degree. If he is the highest efficient, everything else is effected, unless it is admitted that some beings can be neither causes nor effects. In short, Duns Scotus rejects

Aristotle's cosmos, as the *protervus* describes it, for admitting the existence of beings that are neither the First nor wholly posterior to the First, that is to say, whose places are incompletely defined in the universal order. This is what Scotus cannot admit: "Also, positing some being having no order is very irrational," *Positio etiam alicujus entis nullum ordinem habentis irrationalis est valde*. This time we are certain that the theologian has considered and rejected objections of the *protervus* arguing in the name of the philosophers, but the theologian does not oppose his faith to the conclusion. Pushing the intellection of "I am who am," *Ego sum qui sum* as far as possible, the theologian rejects the philosophers' universe for its lack of rationality.

F Nature and scope of the proofs

The proof of the existence of an infinite being that is unique is one of the best examples of the technique Duns Scotus uses when he argues in the manner of the philosophers. We also see what the style of his metaphysics would have been, if he had wished to construct one, but its spirit can be even better discerned in *De Primo Principio* than in the *Opus Oxoniense*. It is not that Duns Scotus appears more as a metaphysician in *De Primo Principio* than he does in his commentary on Peter Lombard. The opposite could easily be held, because *De Primo Principio* is presented as a meditation on God's word, *Ego sum qui sum*. It begins with a prayer and ends with a doxology. Still the demonstration is very dense, and although it is substantially and sometimes literally the same as that of the *Opus Oxoniense*, the metaphysical structure is more obvious. It is not misleading to compare the work to a *Proslogion* in the mode of Anselm, whose author had mastered the resources of his time's metaphysics in addition to those of dialectic.

Moreover, *De Primo Principio* employs these resources in an original way. Aristotle is very frequently utilized, first by way of appeal to his principles, next to justify the use of a term or clarify its definition. For example in chapter one, Scotus cites *Metaphysics* book IX, chapter 8, to show the sense

in which it speaks of a priority that involves eminence and of posteriority that implies inferiority. According to Scotus, that is the type of priority that Aristotle finds in act in contrast to potency, which is correct, but Aristotle does not use the dialectic of act and potency as an occasion to soar to a general definition of the *essential order* within which the *order of eminence* is a division. Another division is the *order of dependence*, where what is essentially posterior depends on the essentially prior, and here again Duns Scotus quotes Aristotle, *Metaphysics* V, 11, in his favor, but once more, it is to clarify what Scotus himself understand by it: "The prior in nature and in eminence is what can be without the posterior, while the reverse is not true." We have general concepts there. Duns Scotus does not accept the Philosopher's proof by the First Mover, and in Aristotle we do not find any of the dialectical proofs developed by Duns Scotus. The metaphysical atmosphere of the two doctrines is palpably different.

The difference is less marked if we compare Duns Scotus's demonstration to Avicenna's demonstration by the possible and the necessary. The two masters function in complete metaphysical abstractness, without reference to any sense experience, except as a point of departure for the initial formation of the concepts. Still, it would be easier to approximate St. Thomas's "third way taken from the possible and the necessary," *tertia via sumpta ex possibili et necessario*, to Avicenna's proof, than Duns Scotus's demonstration. Here, Angelic Doctor rather than the Subtle Doctor can be said to Avicennize. However, Duns Scotus does not fail to quote Avicenna. In *De Primo Principio*, chapter two, conclusion 4, he cites the Muslim philosopher's *Metaphysics*, part VI, chapter 5, to confirm that the end is the *cause of causes*. Further on, he will refer to *Metaphysics*, part VI, chapter two with regard to the manner in which Avicenna understands the notion of creation, but we are always dealing with material loans that do not concern the demonstration's general direction.

Among Christian writers, it is necessary to acknowledge that St. Augustine is not the origin of the Scotist proof either. Like Aristotle or Avicenna, Augustine is quoted as the opportunity arises. For example, in *De Primo*

Principio, chapter two, Duns Scotus offers *Confessions*, XII, 4, on the subject of the priority of matter in relation to form, but we never see Scotus borrow one of the Augustinian proofs of God by the transcendence of truth. The same holds in regard to St. Anselm, whose argument *De Primo Principio* colors, as had the *Opus Oxoniense*, that is, it employs the argument at the point where it is useful within the overall dialectical structure, less as a proof of God's existence, than as a reason in support of his infinity.[114] Among the Christian masters whom we know, on this point, the one Duns Scotus most resembles is William of Auvergne, in whom we find many of these same pairs of correlative notions that Duns Scotus will call "the disjunctive passions of being," *passiones entis disjunctae*, and that he also employs to establish the existence or the nature of God. No doubt we could go further, because perhaps one day William of Auvergne will be seen as an intermediary between St. Anselm and Duns Scotus, at least in the sense that the essentially dialectical method is already applied in William to relations between metaphysical concepts in the way Duns Scotus's dialectical method will apply them.[115] Traces of this type of argumentation are found in St. Bonaventure,[116] who mixes it with others. It seems to us that here we are in the presence of a doctrinal tradition that has not yet been precisely identified, nor has there been an effort to follow it throughout history, but the tradition receives new form and vigor in Duns Scotus's theology.

It first presents itself as a dialectic of causality and essence, because the point is to prove God's existence starting from certain of his effects, but it gets its proper character from the objects to which it is applied. We already know that Duns Scotus's metaphysics is concerned with essences, which are the very heart of being. On the other hand, we will have to clarify the kind of reality upon which Duns Scotus works when he speaks of essences, but it would be useful to give some indications on the point now, since it is so important for the general interpretation of Scotism and, moreover, produces many misunderstandings.

Let us note in the first place that the word *being* in Duns Scotus denotes both the essence and actual existence of that which is. We will have the

opportunity later on to insist that the whole proof of infinite being presupposes the existence of being in general and tends toward the actual existence of he who is called *Qui Est*. Here, the issue is something else, precisely that the metaphysician knows very well that if being did not exist, there would be neither metaphysics nor metaphysicians, but this is precisely why existence, this general presupposition of all speculation, is not itself an object of speculation. The metaphysician does not have to demonstrate that beings exist, and consequently being, but to say *what* it *is*. Essence is precisely *what* being is. The problem is to know what kind of being belongs to essence.

Insofar as an essence belongs to an actually realized subject, placed outside its causes, it possesses its subject's existence. Therefore, it is correct to say that essences exist insofar as they are essences of actually existent beings. It is even the only kind of actual existence that they have outside of thought, because *human*, *bird*, and *tree* do not exist except by the existence of particular humans, birds, or trees. On the other hand, since it is impossible to define a particular being without saying what it is, its essence is part of its being. Therefore, it belongs to the being, and in its way, it is. Accordingly, let us state that there are twin errors to avoid here. One is to attribute an *existence* to the essence that would belong to it *qua* essence, that is to say, to imagine that essences *exist.* The other is to refuse the essence any being of its own, any *entitas* as Duns Scotus says most often, that is to say, to imagine that essences *are* not.

The only way of avoiding both these errors is to attribute to essence its proper mode of being, that is, the mode of an intelligible entity. There is such an entity each time the intellect apprehends an object by a distinct act of intellection. We must refer to this definition in order to comprehend *formalities*, *formal distinctions*, and *modal distinctions* in Duns Scotus. For the moment, it is enough to understand that, since all intellection presupposes an intelligible, each distinct intellection supposes a distinct intelligible and therefore one that is also endowed with a proper unity that defines its being. The essence's entity is not an abstract understanding of existence, but rather

the intelligible's reality as such. Metaphysics deals precisely with these entities. Even when metaphysics speaks of existents and of the existential order, as is the case in the problem of God's existence, and also each time we deal with efficient causes and effects, Duns Scotus approaches them from the viewpoint of the essence. If we want to think with him, we must never forget that since coordination of existence follows coordination of essence, it is always possible to substitute the essence, of which any existent or existential activity whatever is only a particular realization, for the existent or existential activity. We lose nothing of what a *cause* is by considering it as a particular case of the *causality of being*. This is what Duns Scotus always does, to such an extent that a passage whose author adopts this attitude can hardly be written by anyone other than Scotus or one of his disciples. The technique of the Scotist proofs of God's existence illustrates with remarkable clarity the method that consists of making the entity the essential point of support and the very object of reasoning: as metaphysician, "Blessed John Duns Scotus always speaks most formally," *formalissime semper loquitur beatus Johannes Duns Scotus*. Some have said the same of St. Thomas, but they take him for Duns Scotus.

It is understandable why the Subtle Doctor, instead of arguing about causes, effects, ends, forms, or matters taken in particular, puts the weight upon what constitutes the essence of causality, finality, formality, or materiality in beings. We still know the history of medieval theologies too poorly to dare to affirm that this attitude is peculiar to Scotus, but one fact invites us to think so. It certainly seems that, in order to define his position, Scotus must have created a personal terminology—the one that initially disconcerts all his readers. *Effectivum*, *effectibile*, and *effectum* mean, respectively, what produces as efficient cause, what can be produced by an efficient cause, and what is produced by it. *Finitum* is what is ordered to an end. *Materiatum* is what is caused starting from matter. *Formatum* is what the form causes. The natural philosopher must take interest in singular existents and say which are effects and which are causes. The metaphysician should not pose these problems, but consider what is common to all efficient causes and to all their

effects: the essence of efficiency and of effectibility, that is, the aptitude to produce or to be produced.

This transposition is required to pass from natural philosophy to metaphysics, and it calls forth another. Since the master discourses upon essence, he will stay within the framework of the *essential* order. This order is a hierarchy. The order of essences is a hierarchy as is the order of numbers. Just as for two distinct numbers, one is always larger and the other smaller, one of two distinct essences is always prior, nobler, or more effective than the other. Their distinction rests, so to speak, on their quantities of perfection. The most important part is that, by arguing from the relations of essences engaged in a hierarchical order of this kind, the metaphysician constitutes a sort of abstract replica of particular eminence and particular realities. He replicates the concrete existential realities with a corresponding order of essential relations whose terms conserve the dynamics of the first terms, because they translate them. For example, if I say that which has no efficient cause has no final cause, I merely formulate abstractly a definite relation that remains valid, whether the number of cases to which it applies is elevated or whether it is reduced to just one. In other words, because what is true of the essences is true of the corresponding existences, every demonstration founded on the abstract relations between essences will be applied to the real existent. The manner in which the essences are distributed and mutually condition each other inside the essential order, *ordo essentialis*, reveals to the intellect, with the necessity proper to metaphysics, the manner in which the particular singulars that correspond to them are distributed and are caused. In Duns Scotus's doctrine, God's sovereign freedom does not allow the order and connection of things to be the same as the order and connection of ideas, but if singulars are not deduced from the order of idea, they always conform to it. The dialectic of essences posits the general rules that contingents themselves are bound to respect, if divine freedom confers existence on them.

Precisely the proof of the existence of the infinite being sets in motion a metaphysics of causes, where the order of eminence and causal dependence of essences is the driving force of the argumentation. Despite its Aristotelian

vocabulary, this is why the philosophical style is related to the tradition of the *Elementatio Theologica* and the *Liber de Causis*. This fact is less apparent in the *Opus Oxoniense* than in *De Primo Principio*, where the master takes care to highlight the proof's presuppositions, but the doctrine is the same. It rests upon a collection of theorems whose immediately apparent aphoristic form recalls the work of those theologians from Boethius to Alan of Lille and Nicholas of Amiens, who tended toward a theology demonstrated in a geometrical fashion, *theologia more geometrico demonstrata*. At times some theorems reproduce others that were already known, but that is the exception. The reason is simple. Duns Scotus is not writing a treatise *de regulis theologic*is, about theological rules, or even a *De Causis* in general. Obviously, he possesses a metaphysics of causes that he has explained *elsewhere*,[117] but, since his object is to prove the existence of a unique cause that is the First Principle, the Subtle Doctor must have created for his own use the principles he needed for his demonstration. All bear directly or indirectly on the laws that govern the relations of beings with what he calls the *essential order*, whether of eminence or of causal dependence. This order itself springs from the entity of the essence that naturally distributes them into superior or inferior, efficient or effected, into ends or things in relation to ends. Consequently, the essential order about which Duns Scotus discourses is not a creation of the mind, but being itself in its hierarchical distribution as it ensues from its essence. Clearly, this is what Mauritius a Portu, who understood Duns Scotus so profoundly, gave us to understand when he wrote in his commentary on *De Primo Principio*, that the order with which Scotist metaphysics deals is certainly a relative property, "not however a species of predicable relation but a transcendent one, like cause and things of this sort," *non tamen species relationis praedicabilis sed transcendens, sicut causa et hujusmodi*. Again, in a completely general manner at the start of his glosses: "for the essential order seems to be a certain passion in regard to being, from which our Doctor begins," *ordo enim essentialis videtur passio quaedam respectiva ipsius entis a quo incepit Doctor*. It would be difficult to say that better, and any argumentation on Duns Scotus's theses that empties them of

their real content to turn them into a logic or that ties them to the singular existent to turn them into natural philosophy, is essentially mistaken in its object.

We might wonder what the value is of the Scotist proofs of the existence of God. That would be to consider the proofs in themselves and do the work of a philosopher. If the historian only wants to be a historian, he chooses a different question. In Duns Scotus's own view, what was the scope of his proofs? This is the only question we would like to discuss here.

First of all, what is the nature of these proofs? Do they belong to the philosopher, that is to the metaphysician, or to the theologian? Our knowledge about God is necessarily shared by these two disciplines, and the principle of the distribution of this knowledge is found in the concept of scientific knowledge that Duns Scotus develops. With Aristotle he judges that science is knowledge *a priori*, by the cause, that is, *propter quid*. This, moreover, is why we see him refuse to admit that one and the same knowledge can fall under two distinct sciences identically, for example, that the earth's roundness simultaneously falls under philosophy of nature and astronomy. It is true that the astronomer and the natural scientist can both give the proof but, like every truth, it properly belongs to the science that can demonstrate it *a priori*. Now, there has always been just one. Here, it is philosophy of nature because astronomy only demonstrates that roundness a posteriori, that is, starting from its effects.

Let us generalize the conclusion. Every truth belongs purely and simply (*simpliciter*) to the science that knows why it is true (*propter quid*). As for the science that knows only that it is true (*quia est*) without knowing why, the truth only belongs to it indirectly (*secundum quid*). Applied to our problem, the principle implies this: all truths relative to God, which are knowable by the cause (*propter quid*) taken in themselves, fall purely and simply under the science that deals with God taken under his reason of divinity, that is, the science of theology. Consequently, every truth that is demonstrable *a priori* of God by its own nature is purely theological. On the other hand, we know that the metaphysician demonstrates nothing about God *a priori* and by the

cause, but only starting from God's effects. Consequently, that which is established about God as true (*quia est*) falls first under a science that can know why it is true (*propter quid*). Accordingly, all the truths relative to God that the metaphysician demonstrates belong purely and simply to this other science which is theology. Still, since the metaphysician proves the truths starting from effects, that is, by a demonstration *quia*, they belong secondarily or relatively (*secundum quid*) to metaphysics.[118]

Duns Scotus's position is particularly clear on this point. However, lest we fear we are mistaken, Scotus undertakes to dispel any uncertainty, because he addresses the following objection: "Is not metaphysics science purely and simply? If it is, it is directly concerned with the truths that it proves on the subject of God. Therefore, these truths belong directly to what metaphysics studies." To this he responds, with a subtlety that does not lack firmness: "In everything metaphysics says about God, it is purely and simply a science *quia*. A science that is purely and simply *quia* is only indirectly *propter quid*. Therefore, these truths only belong to metaphysics indirectly."[119] Therefore, it is impossible to be in doubt about this. Every truth related to God that is demonstrated *a priori* by metaphysics belongs fully to theology, and only indirectly or relatively to metaphysics.[120]

We should not seek any intention of denigrating metaphysics here. Duns Scotus holds it to be the most perfect among the sciences that are naturally accessible to humans. For Scotus, as for Aristotle, metaphysics is the most *scientific* of our sciences. Fixed upon truths that are of themselves the most known, most common, most universal, and most certain, metaphysics is truly wisdom, insofar as it is the science of the first principles and of the first causes.[121] In consonance with his deepest philosophical thinking, Duns Scotus assigns metaphysics the goal of speculative knowledge of essences of the supreme causes and separate substances. To attain it, metaphysics uses three operations, dividing and defining by the constituent elements of the essence (the *essentialia*), and then demonstrating by the absolutely first and most known essential cases, principally by the supreme causes. That said, Duns Scotus simply observes that in fact we do not possess this ideal

metaphysics and that Aristotle himself leave us no example of a demonstration of this kind, that is, one deduced *a priori* from the essence.[122] Because the direct intuition of intelligibles is impossible for us at present, our metaphysics is a science *quia*, which infers causes starting from effects instead of deducing effects from their causes. Starting from effects, we prove that their causes exist. We do not explain why the effects exist starting from the essences of causes. By using such metaphysics for the ends of his own science, the theologian makes theology with the most perfect natural knowledge of which human reason disposes in its present state.

Accordingly, the point is not to challenge the proofs' rationality. Since the proofs take their method from metaphysics, they are rational like metaphysics itself. But there is no lack of difficulties of interpretation.

Here is the chief one. We know the controversy that sets Averroes against Avicenna. It is always present in Duns Scotus's mind when he returns to this problem. Avicenna maintains that God does not fall within the purview of metaphysics, because no science proves the existence of its own object. The metaphysician proves God's existence. Therefore, God is not included within the subject of metaphysics. By contrast, Averroes holds that God's existence is proven in natural philosophy. Consequently, he maintains that this same God whose existence has already been proven by the natural philosophers enters within the subject that metaphysics studies.

We know what Duns Scotus's position is on this point. Between Avicenna and Averroes, Scotus opts for Avicenna in the name of the principle that no science proves that its subject exists, nulla *scientia probat suum subjectum esse*. Let us admit the principle with Scotus. It obviously follows from this that the metaphysician has something by which he demonstrates the existence of a *first being*, which he does by basing himself on the disjunctive metaphysical properties of being such as the *prior* and *posterior*. Indeed, just as in natural philosophy movement presupposes a mover, in metaphysics the posterior being presupposes a prior being. The same goes for the properties that are act and potency, finitude and infinity, multiplicity and unity, and still many others, from which metaphysics can conclude that God exists or that

the first being exists.[123]

Let us follow Duns Scotus that far. What comes from that? Apparently, it follows that it pertains to metaphysics to demonstrate the existence of God, whose nature then belongs to theological study. If things are thus, should we not say that for Duns Scotus himself, the proofs of God's existence fall purely and simply under metaphysics? The answer is both simple and correct, but perhaps also a bit simplistic, because, how can we prove God's existence without having at least a nominal definition of his nature? If the theologian provides the metaphysician with this definition, how do we fail to see that theological influence runs all through his metaphysical demonstration and guides it from beginning to end? It will be difficult to maintain that he who proposes to the metaphysician the task of proving the existence of an infinite being does not exercise some influence on the metaphysician's subsequent steps. So, one more time we are drawn into the problem, which we have already discussed, of the respective objects of theology and metaphysics. Let us return to the examination stating from other data,[124] with a view to clarifying the nature of the Scotist proofs of God's existence.

Here is the problem. "The highest knowledge that we can naturally have of God is obtained in metaphysics, according to the philosophers. Accordingly, we must first find out how far the metaphysical knowledge of God extends and second, whether further knowledge is possible for us in our state."[125]

The first of these two questions interests us more directly. Scotus treats it here exactly as he always does, namely, by reducing it to the controversy between Avicenna and Averroes about whether God is the first subject in metaphysics, *An Deus sit primum subjectum in metaphysica?* Supposing that the answer is negative, it must be asked how far our knowledge of God extends in this science of which he is not the subject.

The answer to the two questions presupposes a distinction that we have already met, but that is so insistently formulated here that the historian, in his turn, feels no hesitation in underlining its importance. It is the distinction between *metaphysics in itself* and *metaphysics in us*. In other words, the point is to distinguish between the metaphysical science as it would be in principle,

by virtue of its nature alone in an intellect that possessed it as it is, and metaphysical science as we in fact possess it. The distinction posited so emphatically by the *Opus Oxoniense* between theology in itself and our theology, is paralleled here by a second distinction, which the *Opus Oxoniense* suggests but that this text imposes, namely between metaphysics in itself and metaphysics in us: "There is a certain distinction metaphysics in itself and in us . . . metaphysics as it is a science in us . . . it is obvious to what metaphysics in itself extends . . . but our metaphysics does not extend in this way."[126] These expressions as well as others remove all doubt.

However we understand metaphysics, whether *in itself* or *in us*, its subject is the same. It is being. By that we understand being as such, in its absolute transcendence, abstracting from all the determinations that species might impose on it. We cannot doubt that *metaphysica in se* is thus, but it is important to establish this for *metaphysica in nobis*. Moreover, since this concept is absolutely simple, we can only conceive it distinctly. Everything it contains in itself, immediately, and by virtue of its proper reason, is therefore contained for our intellect evidently and in a manner that is no less immediate. Consequently, in its order, abstractive metaphysics, the one that is ours, can be an *a priori* science, by the cause (*propter quid*) just as metaphysics in itself is. The concept of being, taken in itself, immediately contains certain truths about being, by means of which we can acquire others. Since this concept can be in our intellect distinctly, it contains those truths distinctly there.[127]

Naturally, it will be objected that, in fact, our knowledge of many metaphysical conclusions is knowledge *quia*, that is, it works back from effects to their cause. Here we encounter this a posteriori metaphysics that could be called second-order metaphysics, whose legitimacy Duns Scotus never denied but that he always refused to regard as the best, the most genuinely *metaphysical*. The question we were studying gave a particularly firm expression of this problem:

The metaphysics of which we speak, transcendent metaphysics, can

> certainly have some conclusions starting from effects, that is, it can know the first substance by starting from the knowledge of some sensible in order to conclude about being, something that is not an immediately evident property of being. However, the same property can be known *propter quid* by beginning with the concept of being (*a ratione entis*) and following the order of its properties.[128]

Transcendent metaphysics (conceived in Duns Scotus's fashion) is certainly what is justified here.

The subsequent considerations provide much satisfaction to the student of Duns Scotus, who sometimes asks himself with uncertainty whether our metaphysics is even competent to speak of infinite being. Let us first let the text speak: "The metaphysician descends when he conceives being taken under one of the term of a disjunctive property, starting from which, following the order, he denominates being thus contracted." For example, the metaphysician *descends* from necessary being to possible being. Or else, adds the philosopher, happily for us: "That which perhaps comes first by order of nature, infinite being, and this metaphysics is according to itself and *a priori* (*secundum se et propter quid*), because what is supposed as first subject is known in itself *a priori* and, besides, because starting from this subject known *a priori*, we can know the rest."[129]

Why are things thus? The reason given is extremely important in that it confirms with very proper precision. Duns Scotus's scattered remarks on the close relation of the two concepts, *being* and *infinite*. The second notion, so to speak, is the first as it is spontaneously offered to the mind when the mind takes it just as it is in itself, as if the infinite were only the determination of being that consists in having no determination. "The reason of being, says our text, is the reason of its co-possibility to infinity as also to its proximate intrinsic mode," *entis est ratio compossibilitatis ejus ad infinitatem, sicut ad modum ejus proximum intrinsecum*. The very nature of being grounds its compossibility with the infinite as with a proximate intrinsic mode. There is nothing, not even its infinity or its necessity, that cannot be attributed to a certain being, starting from being. Indeed, if we can descend to the first

disjunctive property, which is infinity, starting from being, it is evident that there is no other more particular property that we cannot attain in the same manner. Let us go further. It is because infinity and necessity belong to a certain being that finitude and contingency can be found in others. Therefore, it is certain that taken *secundum se*, metaphysics can know everything *a priori* and by the cause, by going from the nature of being *qua* being to all the determinations that limit it.

But how can we know that infinite being exists? In their present state, human beings cannot know it by knowledge *propter quid*. Starting from it, that is from the concept of infinite being, we can demonstrate why it is necessary and free creative cause and other properties of this kind, but as for the existence of the infinite itself, it is only known to us by its effects. In that, we are not exposed to falling back into a kind of metaphysical empiricism, because the effects in question are essential properties of being in general, taken *qua* second, caused, condition, and so on. Given the abstractive nature of our knowledge in its present state, these are the lesser terms of the disjunctive pairs of being, which we know first and starting from which we demonstrate the others by a demonstration *quia*: "What the senses teach us is always that the imperfect member of a disjunctive property belongs to a being; for example that a being is caused, possible, finite, and so on; and as this property cannot belong to a certain being unless the opposite properties, those which are perfect, belong to another, it is appropriate that the metaphysician should demonstrate *a priori* and by the effect that there exists a being that is infinite, necessary and so forth."[130]

Consequently, this text explicitly affirms that the demonstration of the infinite being's existence pertains to the metaphysician. It is all the more interesting to see the precise reason why our metaphysician cannot demonstrate these conclusions *a priori*. The reason is that in propositions like "the infinite being exists," or "the necessary being exists," we have a distinct concept of the term *being*, but not of the terms *necessary*, *infinite*, or others of the same kind.[131] In this connection, let us observe that even this metaphysics of essences ends in supreme concepts that the intellect is incapable of

enclosing within a distinct definition, precisely those by which this metaphysics transcends its object to hand it over to our theology. We are not angels, and we must be content with our metaphysics.

This infinity in being can be conceived in three ways. First, positively, that is to say as an intrinsic positive mode of being itself. For example, when I see *something whitest*, it superiority in whiteness is not known to me as a direct visual object. I positively see this superiority as an intrinsic mode of this whiteness itself. There is only a single act with a single object: the act by which I perceive such and such an object endowed with such and such perfection. This is the way that the angel sees God's essence under his proper greatness, which is infinity.

Moreover, the infinite can be conceived privatively, that is, once again as in intrinsic mode of being, but conceived starting from what is lack in another. For example, I know that the sun's brightness is greater than that of a torch, not that I positively perceive the greater luminosity of the sun as an intrinsic mode of its light, but rather because I perceive a certain lack of visibility in the torch's luminosity, a privation of luminosity that it does not have and that its light could have. Moreover, it is easier to conceive this in the intelligible order than in the sensible order, because we conceive negations better than we feel them. For example, let us take a created understanding that is capable of comprehending some finite object or other or at least of intellectually knowing everything intelligible it possesses. If this created intellect then sees God's essence without comprehending it totally, or if it knows it without showing its intelligibility it would know God's infinity through the presence of this privation in the knowledge that it had of it. Or again, if this intellect compared divinity to a finite intelligible, then to another, and so on, it would certainly see that divinity surpasses all of them, but it would not know by how much because it could not distinguish that according to any determined proportion. This would occur then as when we know the intensity of sunlight by arguing that it exceeds all possible finite light, even without knowing exactly by how much. If we perceived that a light exceeds all possible finite light, even without knowing by how much, we would know its infinitely

privatively. In this way we know God's infinity *privative*.

The third way of conceiving the infinite consists in apprehending it, whether positively or privatively, as included in a concept as a part. Examples of this kind of knowledge regarding other objects are not rare. Thus, the intellect can conceive, on the one hand, a certain essence and, on the other hand, its degree of perfection or quantity of essence as two distinct objects. It can also join these distinct objects, absolutely simple in themselves, to make a single concept of them. In the case of infinite being, the problem is a little different, because we in no way can rise above the concept of being taken in its intrinsic reason of being. However much we say *infinite being*, we really only conceive *being*, and this is even why *ens infinitum*, as we conceive it, does not give our intellect rest. Therefore, in this case, we have a total concept, a part of which, *ens*, is indeed a determined concept, but the other part of which, *infinitum*, is not the object of any positive determined concept, not even that of a mode. For, infinity is certainly a mode of being in itself, and when we say *ens infinitum*, we conceive what corresponds to the word *infinitum* as a mode of *ens*, but we only have a privative concept of this mode, the negation of finitude. In short, we attribute an intrinsic mode to being, of which we have no positive concept. At bottom, infinite being remains for us being as we know it through abstraction starting from the sensible, plus the negation of all possible limitation, which we include in its concept as a modality.[132]

These remarks bring important specifications about the subjects of our theology, our metaphysics, and their relations.

The infinite being, we were saying, is the subject of our theology. This is true, because our theology has no other subject. But this does not imply that the concept of infinite being possesses all the characteristics that make the subject of a science a perfect subject. We can expect the subject of such a science to contain virtually all the truths of which the science is comprised. As we said in its moment, the only subject that contains all the truths relative to God is his essence: *Dei essentia ut haec*. Even the infinite being's existence is not immediately evident. It must be demonstrated starting from

natural philosophy or more immediately starting from metaphysics. Therefore, we say, regarding the concept of infinite being, that it is the subject of our theology in the precise measure in which, among all the concepts that we can form, it is the closest to the concept of the first subject of theology in itself. Although for us the infinite is not the object of a concept that represents it as an intrinsic mode of being, the concept of infinite being that we do have is an intellectual approximation to the intrinsically infinite being, more immediate than our other concepts, for example, those of first being or necessary being.[133] This subject of our theology does not contain all theological truths, but it is the best one of which we dispose.

Next, the author poses to himself what for us is a fundamental objection: "If matters stand thus, our theology is subalternated to metaphysics or natural philosophy, because both of them can prove the existence of the subject of our theology." The first part of the response is obvious, because it amounts to saying that theology *in itself* does not depend on our concept of infinite being, whether metaphysical or from natural philosophy. Therefore, our theology does not need these sciences in order to prove the existence of its subject. By contrast, the second part of the response is quite remarkable: Indeed, our theology, which takes from metaphysics whether the infinite being is, does not have immediate principles, since we can have no proper positive concept containing theological truths."[134] This is not a revelation for the historian, but this thesis, which we know to be that of Duns Scotus, achieves a remarkably precise expression here. Our theology does not draw its principles from infinite being as philosophy gives infinite being to our theology. To tell the truth, our theology has no immediate principles, because we cannot have a positive concept of being that contains theological truths. Moreover, that is not necessary for our theology to be established, because our theology is grounded much more in divine revelation. It is, nonetheless, interesting to observe a certain interruption of continuity of the sciences at the very heart of our theology. Unlike what occurs between philosophy of nature and metaphysics, the object whose existence metaphysics proves by natural reason under the name of infinite being does not virtually contain all that is

known by the theologian to whom natural reason provides the concept. The theologian's infinite being is richer than that of the metaphysician.

Accordingly, returning to the determination of the first subject of metaphysics, first, we still say that whether we are dealing with metaphysics in itself or in us, the subject is still being, whether taken at the level of its universal properties or descending to what can be known about being determined by either side of its disjunctive properties. Secondly, we can see in what sense metaphysics in itself differs from our metaphysics. Metaphysics in itself can descend from being *qua* being to all the determinations that it is possible to predicate of it. Our metaphysics lacks the proper concepts of these determinations and does not permit us to know them as included in being. Of course, if truths are contained in our concept of a being determined by this or that property, for example those of the first or necessary being, our metaphysics can attain them, but it does not go further. The reason for this difference of extension between the respective areas of these two sciences is found in the manners in which they are acquired. For, metaphysics in itself is a science *propter quid*, in the sense that those who possess it can descend *a priori* and by the cause from the intellectual intuition of being to the proper, positive concept of each of its determinations. Such is not the case of our metaphysics, whose description marvelously suits Duns Scotus's metaphysics here: a sequence of argumentations, so to speak, *a priori* and by the cause, but that, however, extended it may be, always depends on knowledge *quia* in the last analysis, such as the knowledge of the being determined in a particular way or of the determinant that defines it. Indeed, we can never prove the existence of the necessary except a posteriori and starting from the possible, nor prove the existence of the perfect except by starting from that of the imperfect, nor prove that of the infinite except by starting from the infinite.[135] Everything *a priori* in our metaphysics rests on a posteriori knowledge.

Such is the reason why we said that God could not be the subject either of metaphysics in itself or our metaphysics. Both these metaphysics have being *qua* being as their subject. Theology has as its subject God under the reason

of Deity, *Deus sub ratione Deitatis*. God as God and God as being are the objects of two different concepts. Since each science has a different concept of the essence of its first object, these two different concepts cannot correspond to a single subject. But this is only an a posteriori justification of our conclusion. The ultimate reason that supports it is that the subject of metaphysics is not God, not even God known under the reason of *infinity*, which is more common than the reason of *deity*. Either God is not the subject of any science, or else he is a first subject different from being, which is the first subject of metaphysics.

It is difficult to grasp exactly what Duns Scotus says here, and having grasped it, still more difficult to not let it slip away again. Metaphysics proves the existence of the infinite being, and our theology welcomes the conclusion of this proof, but it incorporates it rather than making it its point of departure. Our theology is organized around the *ens infinitum* as much as possible, but it is not deduced from it as its principle. Indeed, as Duns Scotus has just told us, there is no such principle: *Theologia vero nostra, quae accipit a metaphysica de ente infinito si est, non habet principia immediata, quia nullum conceptum proprium positivum contentivum veritatum theologicarum possumus habere.* The real points of departure of our theology are God's words in Scripture, and although the concept of infinite being is the most perfect to which we can link the interpretation of those words, whenever that is possible, we cannot deduce them from the concept.

This rupture, which God's transcendence introduces into the rigorous continuity of the chain of the sciences, consequently entails the transcendence of theology. The infinite being that theology inherits is only introduced into it as the potential home around which all the revealed truths are going to be assembled and, if possible, be coordinated, unless we are content to simply accept them by faith. Infinite being is there for that. Otherwise, theology would leave it to metaphysics. Accordingly, it may be that we pose a pseudo question by asking whether the proofs of the existence of an infinite being belong to metaphysics or theology. For the metaphysician, it would be only philosophy. For the theologian, this is the work of an interpreter of God's

word, who uses metaphysics with a view to understanding this word. That is why metaphysics itself changes appearance in the theologian's hands. It throws away as much natural ballast as possible in order to ascend from the metaphysical heaven of essences as soon as possible. Passing beyond the order of movement, it seeks a First that is first in being, an infinite that is first in being, and whose perfection, because it is the perfection of being, implying freedom no less than intelligence, is at least compatible with the Christian God's omnipotence. This metaphysical preparation is peculiar to Duns Scotus's theology. The massive dialectic at the beginning of the *Opus Oxoniense* is not found anywhere else. It can be said of it that by having reached the summit, the one who has climbed it sees once and for all, spread out before him, the road to the theology of the Christian God. Each time that Duns Scotus proves by necessary reasons that revealed truth is *possible*, we find that the principle of the proof is long established. It will always be some link of this dialectical chain, where the primacy in being requires, along with infinity, the absolute perfection of knowledge and freedom. One must be a metaphysician to do it. One must be a theologian to think it.[136]

Moreover, this does not authorize us to say that there is the slightest confusion of genera here. The problem is not posed in the same terms, if we say *theology-metaphysics* or *theologian-metaphysician*. Further on, the author of our text makes what, to us, is an intensely interesting remark. He recalls that the subject of our theology is identical to that of theology in itself insofar as it is accessible to us,[137] given that a science that provides a demonstration *quia* of its object can then apply demonstrations *propter quid* to its essence.[138] Then, our author observes that a science does not change nature because we speak of it in a book that deals with another science. A logical argument remains logical even in a treatise on natural philosophy. The natural philosopher who seasons his book with metaphysical considerations does not thereby change them into natural philosophy. He does there what some perhaps mean when they say that some natural philosopher metamorphoses into a metaphysician, or that he assumes the metaphysician's form and dignity.[139] But if the natural philosopher can dress up as a logician, we do not

see why the theologian cannot dress up as a metaphysician. What does he do in such a case? He does metaphysics as a theologian—unless we prefer to say that he does theology, because what he does remains metaphysics *secundum quid*.

We cannot go further without anticipating the results of research still in its beginnings. But as we go along, it will be important not to lose sight of these first elements of the problem. It is tempting to do so in order to simplify everything. For example, it is certain that Duns Scotus considers metaphysics competent in any context where God can be grasped by a metaphysical concept, that is to say, not just being, but infinite being, necessary being, and so on.[140] How could he deny it? The Subtle Doctor knows very well that Aristotle, Avicenna, and Averroes spoke of God. With greater reason he knows that metaphysics can at least demonstrate God's existence. How would he otherwise have taken Avicenna's side against Averroes? Still, this is not the whole question in his eyes, because philosophers knew so much about the divine being's necessity, that perhaps his freedom escaped them. Was the infinity they acknowledge in God that of power or of being itself? In what sense is this infinity of power that is not rooted in infinity of being omnipotence? These questions and many others invite us to reserve judgment. It is impossible to argue in the abstract about the boundaries of our metaphysics and our theology, without taking into account what occurs depending on whether the metaphysician does theology or the theologian does metaphysics. The results are not the same, and this is why the theologian claims for his science all the knowledge that falls under the subject with which that science deals, whatever the method the theologian uses to obtain it. This subject contains all this knowledge at least virtually.[141] Otherwise, how could it be explained that with both using the same method and pondering the same problem, that of finite being, the first cause whose existence philosophers establish was not the same as that to which the theologian's demonstration leads?

The remarks suggested by this passage agree with what Duns Scotus's other works say, provided that we take into account the different manners in which

he can be obliged to say the same things according to the different points of view that he successively adopts in regard to one and the same problem. For example, if he envisages the problem from the viewpoint of metaphysics in itself as a human intellect still capable of intuitively knowing intelligibles would be able to know it, it is not necessary to push on to the concept of the infinite to reach the limits accessible by the philosopher's reason. Even the concept of *first being*, known precisely as such and apart from its infinity, cannot constitute the subject of any science naturally accessible to humans. Although God is something other and more than the first being, he is that. In other words, *first being* is the first concept through which God is accessible to us: *prima ratio Dei, quam concipimus de eo, est quod sit primum ens*. From this point and in this very modest form, God already escapes the grasp of our natural reason. In any natural science whatsoever, reason bases itself upon intuitive evidence of its subject to deduce its consequences. Among other sciences, this is the situation of geometry and optics. In these sciences, consequences are less known than the principles by which alone the consequences are known. Here, on the contrary, the consequences of divine efficiency are more known than their principle. Starting from its effects, what is posterior and possible, that which we experience immediacy, we work back toward him, First and Act, of whom we have no intellectual intuition. As for the *first being*, of whom we have no sensible intuition, we first need to establish that these two terms, *being* and *first*, are compatible and can be joined in a single complex concept. That can only be done by starting from effects in order to establish the necessity of positing such a being. This accomplished, we know something about what God is in relation to other beings (his primacy), but we have not yet said what he is in himself and for himself. In short, without being able to form immediately a concept of God that is adequate to him, no naturally acquired science can attain God under a simple concept that is adequate to him: "No proper reason of God conceivable by us is immediately grasped by the intellect in this life; therefore there can be no naturally acquired science of God under any proper reason." [142]

If we carry the analysis of the problem to completion, we discover the deep reason for the unevenness that keeps all natural knowledge below the level of theology. It is that the object of theology presents a characteristic that, by distinguishing it from the characteristics of other sciences, distinguishes theology itself from these sciences. There is only science about what is general. Aristotle said so, and it is true of all sciences naturally accessible to humans. Mathematics studies extended being in general. Natural philosophy studies changeable being in general. Metaphysics studies being as such in general. Theology is concerned with that unique being that we call *God*. Therefore, there is a science that is distinguished from all other sciences in this: "Its subject its singular."[143] We immediately see why Duns Scotus has always maintained the possibility of a science about the particular. To deny this possibility is to make all science about God intrinsically impossible by reason of the very nature of its object, which is the most singular of singulars. Theology would not only be impossible in this life, it would remain so in the other. Whatever might be the case here, it is not surprising that, since at present our understanding is reduced to abstractive and therefore general knowledge, it is resourceless when it undertakes the only science whose object, *Deus ut sic*, is a singular being.

By this path we return to the same solution of the problem. On the one hand, no science establishes its own object. Therefore, theology, the science about God, cannot prove his existence, which amounts to saying that the proofs of God's existence come under metaphysics, not only as to the method but even as to their object *insofar as they only consider God as being*. On the other hand, since the infinite being is the subject of our theology, everything that concerns it is theological and, even though the proofs of God's existence are metaphysical, they are the task of the theologian. Consequently, Duns Scotus is a theologian. When he assists his thought by metaphysics, he never loses sight of the theological goals of his work. This metaphysician knows that the subject of theology is the *ens infinitum.* If he did not know that, perhaps he would not notice that metaphysics can prove the infinite being's existence. But he knows it. Therefore, he notices that the proof of the infinite

being is possible, and he establishes it.

What is the scope of these proofs? We know that they are based on being, and that they consist of establishing the existence of an infinite being, by starting from properties of being that are distinct from its quiddity of being *qua* being. Therefore, they agree on the nature of being, which even metaphysics does not have to demonstrate according to Avicenna. They also take as established the existence of being *qua* being, upon whose quiddity or essence metaphysics itself has already shed light, as well as its general properties (the one and the many, the prior and the posterior, and so forth). Although the latter are outside the essence of being *qua* being (always according to the tradition of Avicenna), they still belong to it. What is the nature of a demonstration based on such elements?

The demonstration's object is to obtain an existing being,[144] but the demonstration is not constructed with a view ultimately to make existence gush forth from elements in which it is not included. To avoid this sleight of hand, Thomas Aquinas had started from sensible existence. Duns Scotus avoids it in another way, by starting from being, that is, from what is peculiarly metaphysical in the given reality. The expression *proof of real existence* has its disadvantages, precisely because it wrongly suggests that existence is suddenly introduced at the end of the demonstration. However, it has the advantage of recalling that, since the object of metaphysical abstraction is real being, we are in full reality from one end of this dialectic to the other. Duns Scotus proves that infinite being exists by proving that in existing being we must necessarily posit one that is distinguished from the others by its infinity. On the other hand, since metaphysics works on quiddities, the proof of existence presupposes the proof of the essence's possibility. Every metaphysical demonstration of the existence of God will consequently require that we first establish the reality of his proper concept, or to speak Duns Scotus's language, the reality of his *quidditative being*. Proceeding a posteriori, because our metaphysics cannot do otherwise, the theologian will first prove that the concept of *first being* is not false, that is to say contradictory and impossible. Likewise, he will prove that the concept

possesses *quidditative being*, a real essence *qua* essence. Next he will establish that, since the concept is quidditatively possible it exists, since its actuality is the only conceivable case of its possibility. Accordingly, this theologian will first ask whether *the ens primum* is a possible essence. Next, he proves it by demonstrating that *primacy* belongs to a certain being.[145] Finally, he concludes from the very possibility of this essence to its actuality.

The need to pass through the essence's possibility would suffice to impose their purely metaphysical character upon the proofs. An essence like the essence of *infinite being* precisely *qua* being can never be attained starting from empirical data taken from the sensible order. The most perfect concept that the natural philosopher attains is the concept of *first mover*. The most perfect concept that the metaphysician attains is that of *first being*. The concept of first mover is relative (because to move is a relation), while the concept of first being is absolute (because to be is to be what one is). Moreover, the concept of first mover is imperfect, because it is not impossible to be first in the order of motor causes without being first in the order of being, therefore without being infinite. By contrast, the first in the line of being is, as such, absolutely perfect, and therefore infinitely perfect, that is, infinite.[146] Let us even suppose that starting from movement, we establish the existence of a first mover that, while first in the order of motor causes, is also first in the order of being; we would still not have the proof of the existence of an infinite being that was the most powerful one there could be. Even if the First Mover is in fact the First Being, it is accidental to the First Being to be also the First Mover. If the First Being did not create anything, he would have nothing to move. He would, nonetheless, be the First Being.[147] That is the deep reason why, without rejecting the physical proofs of God's existence, Duns Scotus denounces their inferiority. Divine motion's radical contingency in relation to the divine essence prevents the metaphysician from attaining the first being by an effect that is *necessarily* linked to the first being, if the metaphysician bases himself in natural philosophy.

Accordingly, the theologian cannot attain God's existence by the

metaphysical path without passing through God's essence. The passage from one to the other must still be possible, Duns Scotus does not doubt it. The ease of the passage in question even surprises certain readers, and consequently, it is appropriate to explain it.

The first point to understand, if this problem is posed, is that in principle the problem need not to be posed. It is posed in a metaphysics where essence is really distinct from existence. It also seems to be required in Scotism, if that distinction is introduced from the outside. But Duns Scotus is not responsible for that. The problem is not posed at all in authentic Scotism, because, there, existence is not really distinct from essence, from which it is inseparable by reason of being a modality.

Esse is said properly of completely determined being, placed in actual being by the efficiency of its cause. Nothing else merits this title fully.[148] We pass over the classical distinction, maintained by Duns Scotus, between the being of reason, which only exists in the soul, and real being, which exists outside the soul. At most, it will be useful to note, in order to remove any confusion about the manner in which Scotus understood his doctrine, that the passage from the logical to the real seems impossible. We can never conclude from being-that-is-thought to really existent being.[149]

The problem is posed differently, if we pass from beings of reason to the being of essence. The latter is also distinguished from the being of existence, but in another way. There is coordination and correspondence between the order of essences and the order of existences, because every *possible* essence is susceptible of existing, if an efficient cause gives it existence. When it receives existence thus, existence is not added as one thing to another, which moreover, would have the effect of creating a being by accident. Still, even in an actually existing individual, existence is not included in the nature of the substance. In other words, an actually existing individual, this human for example, is completely defined in his substance (genus, species, and individual) independently of the fact that he exists. Therefore, although existence is really identical to real essence, the essence of a human remains formally distinct from his existence. This is why Duns Scotus, taking up

Avicenna's terminology that Scotus rather reinforces on this point, speaks of existence as an *accident* of the essence, which means that existence is added to the human essence as a complementary determination, not included in its definition.[150] Accordingly, it is true to say that since the nature of the substance is completely constituted as such outside of its relation to existence, the latter's accidentalness is what always characterizes a relation between two beings, at least one of which can be defined without the other.[151] Since the individual's substance is susceptible of complete definition, whether we conceive it as existing or not, such is the case here. Let us note well that the being of essence is not a simple being of reason whose whole reality consists in being thought, and that only exists in the soul. It is a real being outside the soul.[152] Formally distinct from its existence, but really identical to it, it is a true being, *verum esse*, not an *esse* in a limited sense or *secundum quid*, but that in its proper order of essence participates in the existent's reality.[153]

Consequently, Duns Scotus refuses to combine essence and existence formally because, for anything whatsoever, *that which it is* is not identified with the fact that it is. But he also refuses to distinguish them really in actual beings because a being's cause gives it both and jointly essence at the same time as existence. Ultimately, Scotus always maintained that a truly real being is an essence upon which the modality *existence* supervenes to make it a being in the full sense of the word. This last point is important because it situates Duns Scotus in the traditional line of those who make essence pass ahead of existence in the metaphysical structure of being. Here one must choose between two metaphysics of being. If existence is the act of essence there will be being just insofar as there is *esse*. This is the position of Thomas Aquinas.[154] If existence is a mode of essence, there will be *esse* just insofar as there are real essences. This is the position of Duns Scotus.[155] From that he concludes: "But if there are two lights, it must be that many things shine. Therefore, if there are many natures, many things are." [156] There are as many existents as there are essences or natures. Our Doctor is so firm on this point that he applies what he says about substances to the accidents themselves.

The Thomist doctrine of *esse* common to substance and accidents seems incomprehensible to Scotus: “Just as each thing has essence, so also it has *esse*.” *Sicut enim unumquodque habet essentiam, ita et esse*.[157] As the accident has its essence, so it has its *esse*.

However fragmentary these indications may be, they sufficiently determine the scheme by which the Scotist proof of the existence of the infinite being is established. It certainly proves an actual existence, and it proves it a posteriori, that is, in St. Paul’s phrase, *a creatura mundi*, by working back from effects to their cause. But unlike the proofs of St. Thomas, the Scotist proof is not based on the sensible intuition of existents, to infer from them by way of judgment another existent whose essence escapes our grasp. They are based on the real existence of common being to determine through a progressive dialectic, the real existence of this singular being that is the infinite being.

From there comes the first feature that makes them resemble St. Augustine’s *excursions*. But these are excursions within the essence of being, not across the Augustinian hierarchy of beings. By using metaphysics for his own ends, the theologian successively determines all the properties that constitute the being in its singularity that, since it is first in the distinct orders of causality and eminence, is also the perfect and eminent being. Only then, after reaching this point, will the theologian call this being *God*.

The second feature of the indications is to deal directly with an existent essence, that of being. Accordingly, they do not have to make existence gush forth from essence, as they have been unfairly accused of doing, but to establish the existence of a certain being at the heart of the existence of being. Consequently, its *actus essendi* is not what must be proved to establish the actual existence, but the reality and possibility of its essence. For, if there is such an essence *in the real being* from which we start, that essence exists. Duns Scotus’s proofs cannot be understood without penetrating into the real entity of *ens commune*, which is the proper object of metaphysics. Univocal being is not a being that exists in itself and in whose actual existence all other beings participate, but neither is it a simple being of reason. Univocal being is

the essence formally common to the really distinct beings in which alone the essence exists, and where the essence is divided in beings, however distinct they are, without losing its formal commonality. The Scotist proofs are based on the common nature of being that is given to us in particular reality. We can refuse to be interested in it, but in Duns Scotus's eyes that is to refuse to be interested in metaphysics, a science no less *real* than philosophy of nature, which is real precisely because its object itself is real. Assuredly, this science of essence is the most abstract science, but metaphysical abstraction is not empty. It does not let go of the real. On the contrary, it only holds on to what merits the name of *being*. This is why the theologian, working from the outset as a metaphysician on actually given being, does not have to add existence to the infinite being's essence when he reaches the end of the proof, once the essence's determination is completed. Duns Scotus has correctly posed his problem: *among beings* is there one that is infinite?

From there comes the third feature of Scotus's demonstration. Precisely because it is cut out of the stuff of common being as it is included in every existent, its object is to prove the existence of a certain essence at the heart of being. Duns Scotus no more grants us a concept of the divine essence as such than Thomas Aquinas does. For Scotus also, God as this, *Deus ut hic*, remains unknown to us in this life, but Scotus would not deny with St. Thomas that we do know God's *esse* more than we know his essence.[158] We do not know the *esse* of God as God or as an infinite being, but we know him as *being*. We know purely and simply that in which he is being. We do not know it by analogy with sensible being as in Thomas Aquinas, but by univocity to all that is when we retain nothing of it but being. Perhaps we can know even more, if, as we shall see, Scotist univocity extends from being to other essences and authorizes us to predicate created perfections positively, perfections univocally attributable to God as so many divine attributes.

With that we see what legitimates the method followed by Duns Scotus to establish God's existence or rather the existence of the infinite being that the name *God* designates. This proof consists of justifying the metaphysical attribution of the modality *infinite* to a certain being, because if there is one

who is infinite in being, the infinite being exists. Accordingly we are engaged from the outset in a *venatio essentiae*, whose immediate continuation will be the determination of divine attributes, and which the theologian will pursue, tirelessly exhausting the resources that the metaphysics of being puts at his disposition, up to the impassable barrier, the Christian God's free omnipotence.

Every theology that seeks to express itself rationally forms a concept of God that is inseparable from the proofs of God's existence and inversely. In other words, the proofs of existence are always adapted to the particular concept of the existent that we have formed. In St. Thomas Aquinas, the five ways of the *Summa* and still more the dialectic of *De Ente et Essentia* lead toward the *Qui est* of Exodus, understood as pure act of existing. In Duns Scotus, the dialectic of the *Opus Oxoniense* leads toward the same *Qui est* of Exodus, but understood as the essence whose proper modality is infinity, that is, an infinite wealth of being because it exceeds every being by more than any assignable quantity. It is also why, in Duns Scotus, the concept of infinite acquires new value and plays a much more important role than in Thomas Aquinas. In both doctrines we have only a negative concept of infinite, which is the concept of non-finite as that whose essence excludes limits. But in Duns Scotus, infinity itself is posited as an intensive modality, or, if we prefer, as an intensity of being itself. The negative definition that Scotus gives of infinity designates a positive reality: the modality by virtue of which Being surpasses all being beyond any given quantity or proportion. The role this concept plays in Duns Scotus's theology is as new as its content. In Thomas, infinity adds nothing to the concept of God conceived as pure act of *Esse*. We could almost say that St. Thomas does not need it. As *Summa Theologiae* I, 7, 1 says: "*Esse* is what is most formal of all. . . . Therefore, since divine *esse* is not *esse* received in anything, but he [God] is his subsistent *esse* . . . it is manifest that God himself is infinite and perfect." *Illud quod est maxime formale omnium, est ipsum esse . . . Cum igitur esse divinum non sit esse receptum in aliquo, sed ipse sit suum esse subsistens, . . . manifestum est quod ipse Deus sit infinitus et perfectus*. Here infinity flows

from *Esse* as a corollary, but in a metaphysics of essence like that of Duns Scotus, infinity must be added to being as its last determination for us to be able to attain a proper concept of God. God is not bound before we encounter infinite being. After having encountered it, we can add nothing to it. Therefore, the *infinitum* necessarily occupies a supremely important place in Duns Scotus's thinking that it does not have in Thomas Aquinas's doctrine.

Through an unexpected but all the more remarkable consequence, the simplest manner to view two so different theologies at the same time is to remember that in Scotus, *infinitas* plays a role analogous to the role *esse* plays in Thomism. The two concepts are as irreducibly different as the key of essence is from the key of the act of being, but they perform corresponding functions and their very relation to the divine essence appears so similar in the two doctrines that a sort of metaphysical necessity, enclosed within the very concept of God, seems to govern the thinking of the two theologians here. Just as God is the only being in whom essence is the same thing as his act of existing according to St. Thomas, likewise in Duns Scotus, God is that unique being about whom we could almost say that his essence is identified with infinity. It is true that the reduction is less clear in Duns Scotus than in St. Thomas. The expression that we have just used is not found in Scotus. But the tendency toward the reduction is unquestionably found there, just as if this metaphysics of *essentia* had experienced the necessity of transcending the level of essence in order to attain the object of theology. In the measure in which Scotism also aspires to get the better of the fetters of essence, its peculiar genius undoubtedly invites it to advance toward speculation upon the infinite.

Histories of doctrine can already benefit by this observation, because it is clear that Duns Scotus sought to discover how being can be individualized by infinity in the singular case of God. Let us not hold his awkward language against Scotus. St. Thomas Aquinas has his own difficulties here, and they are inevitable in speaking about God. Let us say rather that by making infinity the first and immediate mode of this most singular essence, which is God, Scotus has pushed the reduction of *essentia* to *infinitas* as far as the

language of essence, which is his language, allows him to push it. Let us not forget that a modality is not an accidental attribute or even a necessary but extrinsic attribute. The *infinite* being *is* the infinite. To make *infinita*s its proper mode, that of the individual *ut hic*, is to say that the infinite is just that which it is. In other words, as we ourselves were trying to say for him, with the hope of sharing in his deepest thinking, the metaphysician has no other terminology than that of the unique essence, but when he has just spoken of God in order to precede the theologian (or when the theologian elevates the language of the metaphysician toward his own), the essence in question becomes that about which it would be best to say that it is infinity itself. The proper modality of divine being is the infinite, which is what we call its being.[159]

From there come the particular variations of language in Duns Scotus. Sometimes he says that existence is included in the concept of essence in God, and sometimes that infinity is the proper mode of divine being as such. This leads us, along with certain of his disciples, to wonder whether, starting from essence, it would not be necessary to pass through infinity to attain existence. The answer is yes and no. Yes, verbally, no, really. For taking things quite strictly, an essence that is infinity itself, that is, an infinity of being, would necessarily have to find all these other modalities in itself. Because it is *infinitum*, it would be *That Which Is*, and through that it would also be *He Who Is*.

This last conclusion will not fail to surprise those for whom *esse* means *to exist*. But let us not mix metaphysical systems. One must distinguish in order to choose. The *esse* conditioned by infinity is not Thomism's act of being (*actus essendi*); it is the *esse* of common being, which belongs in principle to every *essentia*, which it makes an *entitas*. To whatever place divine *esse* comes, it does not make it exist. It merely qualifies it with this modality of being, which in no case could be first here, since it is universal to all that is. Therefore, let us change metaphysical climates to understand where we are. The drama of being is not played out here between existence and nothing, between finitude and infinitude, but rather, if we may say so, at the heart of

the given being. There is some, because we are. This is why, starting from the very reality of being as such, its *essentia*, we conclude from the finitude of our being to the infinity of the first being. It is self-evident that, even speaking about God, our language continues to put *essentia* first. *Essentia* is the point of departure of our investigation, but what comes last in inference is first in reality: in God, not essence, but the infinite, and in us, not essence but thisness (*haecceitas*). The final points of the real imply and possess all the rest. The Scotist proofs of God's existence necessarily pass through essence, but what they attain is this unique essence whose real human name is *Infinite*.

A passage from the attentive and intelligent Scotist Jerome of Montefortino will perhaps allow us to make a more authoritative voice than our own say what we would have wished to express better. Perhaps it will be useful even for certain Scotists, who seem to have put as much water into Duns Scotus's wine as certain Thomists mix into that of St. Thomas. We ourselves will stress several expressions whose exactness seems perfect and whose scope seems considerable:

> God is a most singular unity, in that he possesses *esse* and infinity by essence, so much so that his absolute singularity stems from nothing other than his infinity. Because, it constitutes a kind of ocean, where all the perfection of his substance is absorbed, nothing other than he is equal to him or resembles him, otherwise he would not possess all possible perfection. Consequently, God is singular and one, because he is infinite. Therefore, in a certain sense, we can conceive infinity as a mode of entity prior by essence to that which makes it be the singular being that it is [*esse hoc*]. But let us not go on to conclude that existence is not included in the quidditative reason of such a being. On the contrary, if existence did not enter into its quidditative concept, it would not be the infinite being, or the essence *per se* that possesses all perfections of itself. But if by essence it is what possesses all perfection of itself, evidently it *is* in the full sense of the word. Now, it would not be such, if it were not of its essence to exist (*nisi essentialiter existeret*), because, the others who exist by virtue of an *esse* distinct from their essence are not in the full sense of the term, but they grasp a certain measure of perfection in being when they receive it from

> their donor. Thus, what has all perfection of itself, by that very thing possesses existence [*esse*]. Accordingly, it exists by essence, in such a way that, in it, the essentia is identical to the *esse*. So, it seems that infinity must be called an *intrinsic mode* in as much as we base ourselves upon it to say *what* being God is. But, in reality, it is *what formally constitutes God's essence*, and, on account of that, we expect to see flow from it, according to a kind of order, existence [*esse*] and necessity and aseity, and then all other perfections. Likewise, inversely, the creature owes beings possible and being by another to finitude, and then the other imperfections that finitude of participated being and being by another entail, although we conceive it in the inverse order.[160]

Insofar as we can speak of these things, God is not infinite because he is. He is, because he is infinite, since infinity formally constitutes his essence and tells *what he is*. This is probably the soundest point of view from which we can perceive Duns Scotus's mental universe in its broad outline. In ascending toward God by the intellect, we ultimately arrive at infinity. Duns Scotus also sought, and he too found something beyond essence, but this time in essence, and from there, after having found him, Scotus's thinking deals with all the problems concerning God. By going through the surface of sensible being in the opposite direction in order to penetrate toward substances and form, Duns Scotus's metaphysical reflection will lead us up to this ultimate nucleus of the particular, its finitude, that which makes it be *this*. Accordingly, the infinite and the finite will be two poles of the doctrine, one marking the divine essence's highest actuality, the other the finite essence's highest actuality, that is to say, its *haecceitas*.[161]

It would be difficult to imagine a world that is more different from the world of the *philosophers*. The proof that an infinite being exists constitutes the doctrinal base upon which Duns Scotus's whole theology rests. We could almost say that it is virtually contained there, in the sense that Duns Scotus will not cease to refer to it in order to draw out the principles of his demonstrations. The God whose existence the theology proves is the very one that Scotus continually opposes to the philosophers in his discussions with

them, and yet the theology itself is free from all controversy with the philosophers. We might say rather that by quoting, mentioning, and using Aristotle so frequently, Duns Scotus wants less to contradict him, than to get his support in order to go beyond him. For example, if we recur to *De Primo Principio*, chapter IV, starting from Aristotle, the fourth conclusion proves that the First Efficient knows and wills. However, this is where Scotus posits divine freedom starting from the contingency of finite beings: "Something is contingently caused. Therefore the first cause causes contingently. Therefore, it causes willingly." *Aliquid causatur contingenter: ergo prima causa contingenter causat, igitur volens causat.* In this way, and we will have many occasions to return to the point, Duns Scotus places the very basis for all his arguments against the *philosophers'* necessitarianism. Moreover, we see the arguments already sketched. The point is not only to know whether there are contingents, which Aristotle explains very well in his fashion, but whether there is contingent causality, which he fails to explain. The point is also to know how there can be evil for which the First is not responsible, if the First does not act in a contingent manner, because to answer that *matter does not obey* is to say nothing. God could reduce matter to obedience. Lastly, the point is to know whether the First, which is that will, does not love himself as necessarily as he knows himself in Aristotle's metaphysics, by which an order of love and charity is introduced into the world, which adds a new dimension to the world, one unknown to the Philosopher. These are only examples, because for now there are merely proofs of the infinite being that we sense are loaded with consequences that the theologian seems to have to force himself to refrain from developing immediately. Still, no controversy with other theologians, no refutation of the *philosophers* could be more directly constructive than this dialectic. Duns Scotus serenely follows the path that alone can lead him to the God whose existence he intends to prove, and he worries about nothing else. An effort is also necessary for the historian in order not to develop the consequences of this fact immediately, because if Duns Scotus's theology rests on a proof of infinite being, which is practically devoid of controversy, Scotism's essentially positive character can

now be regarded as established. Criticism will come later, but starting from doctrinal positions that control it, and since the criticism springs from them, it cannot ground them. Besides, the manner in which the Subtle Doctor attains the infinity of being suffices to situate his overall doctrine in a different line from the one where certain historians believe they ought to situate it. The infinity of the First Being is not that of a will or a power to start with, but the infinity of an essence, and with the essence, of an intellect rich in the infinity of the intelligibles. Directing himself to God in chapter 4 of *De Primo Principio*, Duns Scotus asks God's permission to try this path: "Therefore, if you grant it, I will try to infer your infinity from what has been said earlier about your intellect." *Infinitatem igitur tuam, si annuas, ex dictis de intellectu tuo prio conabor inferre*. Scotus embarks on it. In a created intellect, the intelligibles are virtually infinite, whereas their infinity is actually and simultaneously known in the divine intellect: "Infinite understood things are there in act." *Ibi sunt actu infinita intellecta*. The divine intellect is not an attribute of God but his very essence, from which it follows that this essence is actually infinite, and that it is so, first of all, by virtue of the infinity of his intelligibility.[162] In this infinity all the primacies communicate and are identified under their distinct formalities. Therefore, it is true to say that what is most formal in God is his infinity, according to this doctrine.

We must go that far to understand in what sense the proof of the infinity includes virtually everything that enters into metaphysics of being in Scotist theology. Through it, God is found to be ontologically separated from everything else, and at the same time, established in a transcendence such that his essence escapes our concepts to become an object of judgment. The dialectic suited to the infinite requires that we affirm the real identity of the formally distinct. It is a singular case. Everywhere else, the distinction of formalities entails the composition of beings where the distinction is found. In God alone, what is formally other is really identical in the primordial infinity of essence. Thus, God's infinity is the very root of his simplicity.

Notes

1 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, article 4 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 191–92, numbers 22–23].

2 Duns Scotus does not name the author of this doctrine, but his commentators identified that author early on, and recent research has confirmed that identification. See Jean Paulus, "Henri de Gand et l'argument ontologique," *Archives d'histoire littéraire et doctrinale du Moyen Âge* X (1936), 265–323, especially pp. 288–97. By the same author, see Henri de Gand, *Essai sur les tendences de la métaphysique* (Paris: Vrin, 1938), pp. 60–66.

3 The *Opus Oxoniense* only sketches the solution of the problem to which is devoted the admirable *Quodlibet* XIV, number 10, Vivès, vol. XXVI, p. 39 [AW, pp. 324–325]. Still, the crucial principle is the same in both works. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 16, vol. I, p. 313 [CE III, p. 39]: "Deus ut haec essentia in se non cognoscitur naturaliter a nobis, quia sub ratione talis cognoscibilis est objectum voluntarium, et non naturale, nisi respectu sui intellectus tantum; et ideo a nullo intellectu creato potest sub ratione hujus essentiae ut haec naturaliter cognosci."

4 Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 7, number 31, vol. I, pp. 327–28 [CE III, p. 67].

5 See Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 2, *An Deus sit*, immediately followed by I, 3, *De Simplicitate* Dei. The path taken by the *Summa contra Gentes* is different, which confirms once more that, for Duns Scotus, Thomas Aquinas *is* the *Summa Theologiae*. Yet, let us specify that if in fact Duns Scotus deals here with the Thomas of the *Summa*, that is not what he first envisages. See the summary of the position he attacks in *Opus Oxoniense* I, distinction 3, question 1, article 3, number 3, vol. I, pp. 306–07 [Probably, CE III pp. 8–10, see note 1, p. 10]. The editors attribute it to Henry of Ghent.

6 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 13, vol. I, p. 314 [CE III, pp. 41–42, where it is number 16]: "Ex hoc apparet improbatio illius quod dicitur in praecedenti opinone [see previous note], quod perfectissimum quod possumus cognoscere de Deo est cognoscere attributa reducendo illa in esse divinum, propter simplicitatem divinam; cognitio enim esse divini sub ratione infiniti est perfectior cognitione ejus sub ratione simplicitatis, quia simplicitas communicatur creaturis, infinitas autem non, secundum modum quo convenit Deo."

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 5, vol. I, p. 187 [CE II, p. 142]: "Quemcumque conceptum concipimus, sive boni, sive veri, si non contrahatur per aliquid ut non sit conceptus simpliciter simplex, non est proprius conceptus Deo."

8 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 17, vol. I, pp. 313–14 [CE III, p. 41].

9 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 1, vol. I, p. 180 [CE II, p. 128]: "An aliquod infinitum sive an Deum esse sit per se notum."

10 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 182 [CE II, p. 131]: "Dicitur igitur propositio per se nota, quae per nihil aliud extra terminos proprios, qui sunt aliquid ejus, habet veritatem evidentem."

11 To know something *confusedly*, is to know it as designated by its name (nominal definition). To know it distinctly is to know its essential definition. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, number 22, p. 319, vol. I [CE III, p. 50]: "Confuse dicitur aliquid concipi quando concipitur sicut exprimitur per nomen; distincte vero quando concipitur sicut exprimitur per definitionem." To know *confusedly* is not necessarily to know something *confused*. The first confusion is in our mode of apprehending the object; the second is in the object itself [CE III, p. 49]: "Confusum enim idem est quod indistinctum." Examples of *confusion* include the essential

whole (like the essence *human*) in relation to its parts, or the universal whole (like the general concept of *human*) in regard to individual subjects of which it is predicated. The concept of the essence is confused in the sense that it includes the concepts of its essential parts in an indistinct state. The concept of the species is confused in the sense that it includes the concepts of its objective parts in an indistinct sense.

12 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 183 [CE, vol. II, p. 135]: "Est igitur omnis et sola illa propositio per se nota quae ex terminis sic conceptis ut sunt ejus termini, nata est habere evidentem veritatem complexionis." [CE inserts *habet vel* before *nata*.]

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 3, vol. I, pp. 183–84 [CE II, p. 136]: "Ex hoc patet quod non est distinguere inter propositionem esse per se notam et per se noscibilem, quia idem sunt. Nam propositio non dicitur per se nota quia ab aliquo intellectu cognoscatur per se; tunc enim si nullus intellectus actu cognosceret, nulla propositio esset per se nota; sed dicitur per se nota quia, quantum est de natura terminorum, nata est habere evidentem veritatem contentam in terminis, etiam in quocumque intellectu concipiente terminos. Si tamen aliquis intellectus non concipat terminos, et ita non concipiat propositionem, non minus est per se nota, quantum est de se; et sic loquimur de propositione per se nota."

14 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 3, vol. I, pp. 183–84 [CE II, p. 136]. Here, Duns Scotus manifestly attacks Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 2, article 1, body of article. There, St. Thomas refers to a passage in Boethius, *De Hebomadibus*, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. LXIV, p. 1311, on certain common notions of the mind that are *per se notae apud sapientes tantum*. Duns Scotus gets rid of this authority by responding, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 184 [CE II, p. 137, presents this in a footnote as canceled by Scotus]: "vel non est idem propositio per se nota et communis conceptio, vel ipse intelligit de concepta, non de conceptibili."—Once again, Scotus closely follows the text of the *Summa* not only arguing against its theses, but against the authorities it invokes. It will be observed that the three arguments offered by the *Summa* in favor of the affirmative (rejected by Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus) are also the first that *Opus Oxoniense* presents, vol. I, pp. 180–181, and in the same order. Duns Scotus adds the fourth.

15 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 4, vol. I, pp. 184–85 [CE II, p. 138]. Note the equivalence of the expressions *Deus est* and *essentia est*. The latter connects Duns Scotus to the tradition of theological essentialism. (Cf. Étienne Gilson, *Le Thomisme*, fifth edition [Paris, J. Vrin, 1945], first part, chapter I, "Les théologies de l'essence." [Translator: There are two translations of *Le Thomisme*, one from the third edition, published by Barnes and Noble, 1929, 1923, which lacks this chapter, and one from sixth edition, published by the Pontifical Institute of Medieval Studies, 2002, which includes it.])

16 The apparent ambiguity in Duns Scotus's position stems from our not distinguishing the stages of the problem as he does. The fact that the proposition *Deus est* is not *per se nota* for us, in fact, does not prevent that in principle it must remain the *per se nota* proposition that it is in itself. In other words, a proposition is *per se nota* when it is evident to the intellect that apprehends its terms. This is the case of the proposition *Deus est*. That we do not apprehend the terms intuitively does not change the proposition's nature. Frassen, *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, p. 115, put his finger on the technically correct Scotist expression of the answer by emphasizing these words of Duns Scotus: "et sic propositio per se nota in se et per se nota in nobis *non sunt membra opposita*." Hence, the Subtle Doctor agrees with Thomas Aquinas about the fact, but he refuses to transform it into opposition in principle. The intrinsic evidence of the proposition for one who comprehends its terms is in no way affected by the fact that a particular intellect does not comprehend them.

17 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 2 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p.

116, number 10]: “Secundum nullum conceptum quem nos hic de Deo concipere possumus, est aliquid de ipso nobis per se notum; nec etiam potest esse nobis notum demonstratione propter quid, quia medium illius demonstrationis propter quid, quod est ipsa deitas in se, inquantum haec deitas, non est nobis per se notum, nec est aptum per se a nobis cognosci, et ideo haec proposito, Deus est, non est [nobis] per se nota.”

18 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 5, vol. I, p. 185 [CE II, pp. 139–40].

19 See Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 5, vol. I, p. 185 [CE II, pp. 140–41]. Cf. number 6 in the same article, pp. 187–88 [CE II, p. 143], where Duns Scotus questions whether the proposition *necesse esse est* is evident. It would be evident if it were known of itself that *necesse* and *esse* are in fact united in an actually existing subject, which is the point at issue: “quia non est per se notum partes quae sunt in subjecto uniri actualiter.” It is not evident of itself that an existence corresponds to our concept of *necessary*. In fact, Duns Scotus himself felt some unwillingness to admit that the necessary had a right to existence *precisely insofar as necessary*. Being grounds necessity where it exists, but not inversely. We are not dealing with abstract methodological discussions here. The methods rejected by Duns Scotus would not lead to a supreme being such that the theologian could accept it from the metaphysician. As for those whose simple minds cannot discern the sense of the proof, it remains to them to believe that God exists, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, question 1, number 13. Cf. Heb. 11:6.

20 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 2, article 1, objection 2. The refutation offered by Thomas Aquinas in the reply to objection 2 deals with the argument’s metaphysical validity: we cannot conclude from the concept to real being. The refutation Duns Scotus presents, in consonance with his personal way of posing the problem, bears first of all upon the question of knowing whether the argument, as St. Anselm formulates it, amounts to making God’s existence a *res per se nota*, as Thomas Aquinas suggests he does. Note that Duns Scotus sets aside the other argument presented by Thomas Aquinas in *Summa contra Gentes*, book I, chapter 10. Once more Scotus considers the *Summa Theologiae*.

21 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 189 [CE I, pp. 146–47].

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 1, vol. I, p. 181 [CE II, pp. 129–30].

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 9, vol. I, p. 190 [CE II, pp. 147–48].

24 Scotus’s remarkable treatise *De Primo Principio* takes up the *Opus Oxoniense* proofs again, but in a different philosophical style, which makes it difficult to combine the two texts. We will follow *Opus Oxoniense*, which furnishes the outline of our explanation in order not to break its unity.

25 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 10, vol. I, p. 190 [CE I, p. 148]: “quia de ente infinito non potest demonstrari esse demonstratione propter quid quantum ad nos, licet ex natura terminorum propositio esset demonstrabilis propter quid quantum ad nos, sed quantum ad nos propositio est demonstrabilis demonstratione quia ex creaturi.”

26 That can be seen in the Scotist division of reality, *Quodlibetales*, prologue, number 1 [AW, p. 3]: “Res autem prima sui divisione dividi potest in rem creatam et increatam, sive in rem a se et in rem ab alio habentem esse, sive in rem necessariam et rem possibilem, sive in rem finitam et infinitam. Res autem increata, a se, infinita et necessaria Deus est; res autem creata, ab alio, possibilis et finita, communi nomine dicitur *creatura*.”—All these disjunctive determinations have the reality of that same being that they determine.

27 Dependence grounds an order of priority and posteriority, which, along with *eminence* about which we will speak later, is one of the divisions of the *ordo essentialis*, Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, revised text and translation by Evan Roche (St. Bonaventure, NY: Franciscan Institute, and Louvain: Nauwelaerts, 1949), p. 4: "Prius dicitur a quo aliquid dependet, et posterius, quod dependet."

28 Cf. the passage whose first sentence we have already quoted, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 7, number 21, vol. I, pp. 65–66 [CE I, pp. 130–31]: "Ad Commentatorem, I *Physicae*, dico quod Avicenna cui contradixit Commentator, bene dixit, et Commentator male. Quod probatur: primo, quia si aliquas substantias separatas esse esset suppositum in scientia metaphysicae et conclusum in naturali scientia, ergo physica esset simpliciter prior tota metaphysica, quia physica ostenderet de subjecto metaphysicae 'si est,' quod praesupponitur toti cognitioni scientiae metaphysicae.—Secundo, quia per omnem cognitionem effectus potest demonstrari de causa quia est, quam impossibile est esse in effectu nisi causa sit; sed multae passiones considerantur in metaphyisca, quam impossibile est inesse, nisi ab aliqua causa prima talium entium; ergo ex talibus passionibus metaphysica potest demonstrare aliquam esse causam primam istorum entium. Minor probatur: quia multitudo entium, dependentia et compositio et huiusmodi, quae sunt passiones metaphysicae, ostendunt aliquod esse simplex actu, independens omnino et necesse esse. Multo etiam perfectius ostenditur primam causam esse ex passionibus causatorum consideratis in metaphysica quam ex passionibus naturalibus, ubi ostenditur primum movens esse; perfectior etiam cognitio et immediatior de primo ente est cognoscere ipsum ut primum ens, vel ut necesse esse, quam cognoscere ipsum ut primum movens."

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 10, vol. I, p. 190 [CE II, pp. 148–49]. In number 11, p. 191 [CE II, pp. 149–50], the general plan of the argument is clearly described: "Ostendam, primo, quod aliquid est in effectu inter entia quod est simpliciter primum secundum efficientiam, et aliquid est quod etiam est simpliciter primum secundum rationem finis, et aliquid quod est simpliciter primum secundum eminentiam. Secundo principaliter ostendam quod illud quod est primum secundum unam rationem primitatis, idem est primum secundum alias primitates. Tertio ostendam quod ista triplex primitas uni solae naturae convenit, ita quod non in pluribus naturis differentibus specie vel quidditative."—The three moments correspond roughly to the three kinds of cause: efficient, final, and formal (eminence). Material causality cannot be involved here. As for exemplar causality, it is combined with efficiency, since the exemplar cause in God is only knowledge about the being whose existence God wills. The last clause of the passage deserves attention: the unicity it announces is that of species. If we take literally the terms Scotus uses there, he undertakes to prove that there only exists a single divine being. A plurality of individuals belonging to the divine species is not excluded in advance by virtue of the proof of the divine being that Scotus announces.

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 6, article 2, number 10, vol. I, p. 249 [CE II, p. 282]: "Possibile logicum est modus compositionis formatae ab intellectu, illius quidem cujus termini non includunt contradictionem. . . Sed possibile reale est quod accipitur ab aliqua potentia in re, sicut a potentia inhaerente alicui, vel terminata ad illud sicut ad terminum."

31 Cf. Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, ch. 3, p. 38.

32 Ibid., p. 40.

33 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, chapter 5, folio 94 recto.—See Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, p. 4: "Accipio ordinem essentialem, non stricte—ut quidam loquuntur, dicentes posterius ordinari sed prius vel primum esse supra ordinem—sed communiter, prout ordo est relatio aequiparantiae dicta de priori respectu posterioris, et e converso, prout scilicet ordinatum sufficienter dividitur per prius et posterius."—Regarding the adversaries at whom Scotus aims, see Efrem Bettoni, *La*

ascesa, pp. 42–45.

34 Essentially ordered causes can also be called causes ordered *per se* (= essentially), in contrast to causes ordered *per accidens* (= accidentally), but we are always dealing with the relation between two causes, not that of a cause and its effect.

35 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 12, vol. I, p. 193 [CE II, pp. 134–35].

36 Refers to Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book V, chapter 11, 1018 b, 9–11.

37 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, ch. 3, p. 46.

38 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 6, *Ad secundam instantiam* [probably *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 122, numbers 28–29]; *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 11, vol. I, p. 192 [CE II, p. 153].—See the important drafts, several of them previously unpublished, in Bettoni *L'ascesa*, pp. 49–50.

39 The natural philosopher discoursing about the efficient cause considers it as the cause of movement. The metaphysician, who abstracts from movement, considers the efficient cause as the cause of being. That is why Duns Scotus retains only the efficient cause's relation of efficient being to produced being. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 10 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 346–47, number 51]: "Metaphysicus enim considerat quatuor genera causarum et naturalis similiter, sed non eodem modo sicut metaphysicus, quia sicut metaphysicus in considerando abstrahit a naturali, ita causae ut considerantur a metaphysico abstrahuntur a seipsis ut considerantur a naturali philosopho. Philosophus enim naturalis considerat causam agentem ut est movens et transmutans, materiam ut est subjectum transmutationis, et formam ut dat esse per comparationem ad actionem et motum ei proprium, et finem ut est terminus motus et transmutationis. Sed sic a causis abstrahit metaphysicus, nam metaphysicus abstrahit causam moventem ut dat esse sine motu et transmutatione."

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 15, vol. I, p. 195 [CE II, p. 162]: "Potest tamen sic argui, probando primam conclusionem sic: haec est vera; aliqua natura est effectibilis, ergo est aliqua effectiva. Antecedens probatur: quia aliquod subjectum est mutabile, quia aliquod entium est possibile distinguendo possibile contra necessarium, et sic procedendo ex necessariis. Et tunc probatio primae conclusionis [*scilicet*, esse effectum simpliciter primum] procedit vel concludit de esse quidditativo, sive de esse possibili, non autem de existentia actuali. Sed de quo nunc ostenditur possibilitas, ultra in conclusione tertia actualis existentia ostenditur."

41 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 16, vol. I, p. 196 [CE II, pp. 162–63].

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 16, pp. 195–96 [CE II, pp. 164–65]: "Tertia conclusio de primo effectivo est ista: primum effectivum est in actu existens, et aliqua natura vere existens actu sicut est effectiva. Probatio istius: cujus rationis repugnant simpliciter esse ab alio, illud si potest esse, potest esse a se; sed rationi primi effectivi simpliciter repugnant esse ab alio, sicut patet ex secunda conclusione; similiter et ipsum potest esse. Ergo effectivum simpliciter primum potest esse a se; ergo est a se, quia quod non est a se non potest esse a se, quia tunc non ens produceret aliquid ad esse, quod est impossibile, et adhuc idem crearet se, et ita non esset incausabile omnino." [CE omits *ergo est a se, quia*]—Cf. *De Primo Principio*, chapter 3, p. 48.

43 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 7 [I have been unable to find this either in *Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 125–28 or in Vivès volume XXII]: "Illa demonstratio, sive ratio dupliciter potest fieri. Uno modo, sumendo pro antecedente propositionem contingentem de

inesse, quae nota est sensui, scilicet quod aliquid sit productum in actu, quod notum est sensui, quia aliquod est mutatum, quod nec negaret Heraclitus, est sic ex veris evidentibus, non tamen necessariis, sequitur conclusio."—On this general character of the proof, see the excellent passages in Bettoni, *L'ascesa*, pp. 13–16.

44 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 16, vol. I, p. 196 [CE II, p. 164]: "Aliae autem probationes ipsius *A* possunt tractari de existentia, quam ponit haec tertia conclusio, et sunt de contingentibus, tamen manifestis: vel accipiuntur de natura et quidditate et possibilitate, et sunt ex necessariis."—It will be noted that here *manifestis* does not characterize the proofs in question, but the empirical contingent on which they rest. Cf. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 2, article 3, body of article: "Prima autem et *manifestior* via est quae sumitur ex parte motus."

45 See Fr. Bettoni's useful and interesting remarks, *L'ascesa*, p. 36, note 6.

46 Emile Pluzanski, *Essai sur la philosophie de Duns Scot*, Paris: Thorin, 1888, p. 139.

47 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 10, vol. I, p. 190 [CE II, p. 148].

48 Duns Scotus argues gladly *per naturam correlativorum*, for example, by the pair *effectibile-effectivum*, which plays a decisive role in the proof. The use of such pairs, rather frequent in St. Bonaventure, was already familiar to William of Auvergne.

49 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 2 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 116–17, number 10]: "Hic propter ordinem quaesitorum est sciendum quod, sicut dictum est prius, secundum nullum conceptum quem nos hic de Deo concipere possumus, est aliquid de ipso nobis per se notum, nec est aptum per se a nobis cognosci, et ideo haec propositio, *Deus est*, non est per se nota; igitur potest de Deo a nobis cognosci demonstratione quia, in qua sumitur praemissa ab effectu; igitur immediatius ostendetur de Deo talis perfectio sub ratione illa qua immediatius respicit effectum; hujusmodi vero relationis sunt ad creaturas, ut causalitatis et producibilitatis; ideo ex hujusmodi rationibus est propositum ostendendum."

50 Pluzanski, *Essai*, p. 139. We combine Pluzanski's objections against the different Scotist proofs, because the objections are inspired by the same spirit. Here, he criticizes the proof from the eminence of being.

51 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 14, vol. I, p. 194 [CE II, p. 159]. Let us recall that this same thing is object of a demonstration *quia*.

52 Cf. Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, ch. 2, p 14: "Et loquor de positivis, quae sola sunt proprie effectibilia," According to Mauritius a Portu's commentary, this amounts to saying: "Debent intelligi de positivis et entibus realibus ad differentiam negationum vel non entium vel respectuum rationis."

53 The reason Duns Scotus prefers these proofs by *the necessary* is that they dispense us from proofs by the contingent, while the contrary would not be true. *De Primo Principio*, chapter 3, p. 40: "Sed malo de possibili conclusiones et praemissas proponere: illis quippe de actu concessis, istae de possibili non conceduntur, et non e converso. Illae etiam de actu contingentes sunt, licet satis manifestae; istae de possibili sunt necessariae."—The possibility of the first cause is not invoked here to ground its existence, but to guarantee that the object posited as being genuinely satisfies the fundamental requirement of being. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 16, vol. I, p. 197 [CE II, p. 164]: "ergo si potest esse, quia non contradicit entitati. . . sequitur quod potest esse a se, et ita est a se."

54 To be precise, that which is susceptible of having an end. Cf. Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, p. 10. What has an end is *finitum*. Here, the final cause is prior, what is posterior is "ordinatum ad finem

quod, ut brevius loquar, dicatur finitum."

55 Claude Frassen makes this point clear in *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, p. 122: "qui enim dicit totam collectionem entium, nulllum aliud ens supponit, quod intra ipsam collectionem non innovator, alias non esset omnium entium collectio." Moreover, it will be noted that, writing in the eighteenth century, Frassen, (vol. I, p. 129,) relegates the argument by finality to a secondary position.

56 If we had to articulate Duns Scotus's metaphysics in English, for our part we would not hesitate to say *unendable* and *uneffectible* [French *infinible* and *ineffectible*]. It is true that *unendable* and *uneffectible* are not English, but *infinibile* and *ineffectibile* are not Latin. It is the language of Duns Scotus.—Cf. the preliminary theorems of *De Primo Principio*, ch. 2, p. 14, conclusion 3: "Quod non est finitum non est effectum," and p. 16, conclusion 5: "Quod non est effectum non est finitum."

57 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 17, vol. I, p. 198 [CE II, p. 166].

58 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 8 [probably *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 123, number 31]: ". . .quia omne agens agit propter finem; sed primum efficiens est perfecte agens; igitur agit propter finem; non propter finem alium a se, quia tunc illud esset eminentius primo efficiente: quia finis, qui est alius realiter ab agente intendente finem, est ens eminentius, cum causa finalis sit nobilissima."

59 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book VIII, chapter 3, 1043 b 36 to 1044 a 2.

60 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 18, vol. I, p. 198 [CE II, pp. 167–68].—Cf. *De Primo Principio*, ch. 3, pp. 58, 60.

61 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 18, vol. I, p. 198 [CE II, pp. 168–69].

62 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 18, vol. I, pp. 198–99 [CE II, p. 169].—*Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 9, article 3, number 27, vol. I, p. 453 [CE III, p. 304] gives the definition of univocal and equivocal causes: "quando agens agit univoce, hoc est, inducit in passum formam ejusdem rationis cum illa per quam agit; . . . In agentibus autem aequivoce, id est in illis agentibus quae non agunt per formam ejusdem rationis cum illa ad quam agunt."

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 19, vol. 1, pp. 199–200 [CE II, p. 173]. See also *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 8 [possibly *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 125, numbers 35–36].

64 We note the profound remark by Mauritius a Portu in his commentary on *De Primo Principio*: "Sed salvando Francisco, dico quod hic loquitur Doctor de ordine essentiali essentiarum, qualis non est in divinis: Franciscus vero extendit ordinem essentialem ad ordinem essentialium perfectionum seu proprietatum ejusdem essentiae."

65 Scotus, *Quodlibet* I, question 1, number 4 add. [AW, p. 485]: "Ad secundum dici potest quod essentia et ejus existentia in creaturis se habent sicut quidditas et modus, ideo distinguuntur. In divinis autem existentia est de conceptu essentiae et praedicatur in primo modo dicendi per se, sic quod propositio illa per se est prima et immediata ad quam omnes aliae resolvuntur, ut patet in primo, d. 2, q. 2. Quaere in 4, 46 di, qu. 3, et primo *Reportationum*, di. 45, 2, et di. 2, parte 2, q. 2, et infra q. 5, art. 3, et 2, dist. 1, q. 2, plura ad propositum harum objectionum." This text is an addition that may not be from Duns Scotus's own hand, but it renders his thought faithfully.

66 Scotus. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, article 3, number 32, vol. I, pp. 270–71 [CE II, p. 331–32].—Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, article 4, number 34, vol. I, p. 273 [CE II, p. 334]: ". . .essentia divina et quaecumque essentialis perfectio

intrinseca sibi est indistinguiblis."—See *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, conclusion 1, p. 72.

67 We definitely say *Christian* and not *theological*. We recall that the most technically metaphysical demonstration of God's existence in Duns Scotus begins with a prayer and asks God for understanding of his words *Ego sum qui sum*. Every proof in *De Primo Principio* searches by natural reason for the truth of this word of God, *De Primo Principio*, p. 2. Cf. *De Primo Principio*, ch. 2, pp. 12, 14.

68 Intellect and will can be considered divine attributes, but only in a broad, really improper sense of the word *attribute*. Speaking properly, these are intrinsic perfections of the divine essence, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 26, sole question, number 55, vol. I, p. 1014 [CE VI, pp. 59–60 in a footnote as an interpolated text]: "Concedo igitur quod proprie vocando attributa illa sola quae quasi qualitates perficiunt in esse secundo rem praesuppositam in perfecto esse primo, scilicet quantum ad omnem perfectionem quae convenit rei ut substantia, hoc modo intellectus et voluntas non sunt proprie attributa, imo sunt quaedam perfectiones intrinsicae in essentia ut praeintelligitur omni quantitati et quasi qualitati."—Cf. a little further on [CE VI, p. 60 in a footnote]: "Vel aliter declaratur et melius: quia haec essentia ut haec essentia praecedens omnem quasi qualitatem, est intellectualis et volitiva essentia, ita quod sicut rationalitas non est attributum homini, sic nec intellectualitas huic essentiae [*scilicet*, divinae]. Istud patet per simile de infinito, quod alias negavi esse proprium attributum, qua dicit modum cujuslibet in Deo, tam substantiae quam cujuslibet attributi; ita intellectualitas dicit modum intrinsecum hujus essentiae. Proprie autem attributa sunt sapientia et charitas et alio modo transcendentia, puta veritas et bonitas."

69 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 20, vol. I, pp. 202–03 [CE II, pp. 174–77].

70 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 21, vol. I, p. 204 [CE II, pp. 176–77].

71 Duns Scotus postpones the proof that God is intelligent and endowed with will. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question [CE VI, pp. 245–70].

72 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, chapter 5, folio 24, verso a E.

73 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 22, vol. I, pp. 205–06 [CE II, pp. 180–84].

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 23, vol. I, pp. 206–08 [CE II, pp. 184–85].

75 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 24, vol. I, p. 208 [CE II, p. 187]: "Quarta conclusio principalis de intellectu et voluntate Dei ad infinitatem probandam est ista: intellectus Primi intelligit semper et distincto actu et necessario quodcumque intelligibile, prius naturaliter quam illud sit in se."[CE does not have *ad infinitatem probandam*.]—Cf. *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, conclusion 8, p. 100.

76 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 24, vol. I, p. 208 [CE II, p. 188].

77 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book XII, chapter 7, 1073 a 7. The question of whether Aristotle himself remits to his own *Physics* here (1073 a 5) is disputed. Bonitz thinks that Aristotle remits to *Physics* 267 b 17. W. D. Ross, *Aristotle's Metaphysics* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1924), reprinted with corrections 1953, vol. II, p. 382, judges that Aristotle simply remits to the demonstration he has just given in the *Metaphysics* itself. However, this may be the First Mover's infinite power is already affirmed by *Physics*, 266 a 24 to b 6, for the same reason. It moves eternally.

78 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 25, vol. I, p. 209 [CE II, pp. 189–91]. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 5 [possibly

Reportatio 1-A I, p. 134, number 66], summarizes: “Primum movens simul habet in virtute sua omnes effectus possibiles produci per motum; sed illi sunt infiniti si motus potest esse infinitus; ergo si movet in infinitum, est infinitum.”

79 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 26, vol. I, p. 210 [CE II, pp. 192–93].

80 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 27, vol. I, pp. 211–12 [CE II, p. 194]: “Licet igitur omnipotentiam proprie dictam secundum intentionem theologorum tantum creditam esse et non naturali ratione credam posse probari, sicut dicitur distinctione 42, probatur tamen infinita potentia, qua simul quantum est ex se habet omnem causalitatem, qua simul posset in infinita, si simul essent factibilia.” [CE inserts *naturaliter* between *tamen* and *infinita* and the two *qua* are *quae*.]—The objection refuted in article 28 is that, although infinite, this power is not yet the total cause, that is to say, something capable of causing its ultimate effects without the cooperation of intermediate causes. As will be seen later, an absolute causality of this kind is precisely *omnipotence*, as the theologians understand it. It is impossible for a philosopher to demonstrate it. What Aristotle’s argument proves, when modified this way, is that the First’s power, which may or may not be passed through intermediate causes that philosophers require *propter imperfectionem effectus*, *eminently* contains the total causal power of the infinity of possible second causes. This suffices to prove that this power is infinite.

81 This argument could be constructed from Thomist positions, but to our knowledge, St. Thomas Aquinas does not employ it.

82 See Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII [AW, pp. 218–35].

83 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 29, vol. I, pp. 213–14 [CE II, pp. 198–201].

84 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 4 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 132, numbers 59–60].

85 The degree proper to each being is defined by its essence’s intrinsic perfection, independently of its possible reference to other beings. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 33, vol. I, p. 218 [CE II, p. 212]: “Nam quaelibet entitas habet intrinsecum sibi gradum suae perfectionis, in quo est finitum si est finitum, et in quo infinitum, si potest esse infinitum, et non per aliquid accidens sibi.”

86 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, p. 4. The order of eminence is that division of the essential order where “prius dicitur eminens, et posterius, quod est excessum. Ut breviter dicatur, quidquid est perfectius et nobilius secundum essentiam est sic prius.”—Scotus remits to Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book IX, chapter 8, 1050 a 4. In fact, Dionysius, *De Divinibus Nominibus*, VII, inspires him.

87 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, p. 106, remits also to Augustine, *De Civitate Dei*, book XII, chapter 18, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, columns 367–68.

88 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 30, vol. I, p. 214 [CE II, p. 202]: “Quaecumque sunt infinita in potentia, ita quod in acccipiendo alterum post alterum nullum possunt habere finem, illa omnia, si simul actu sunt, sunt infinita actu: intelligibilia sunt hujusmodi respectu intellectus creati, satis patet; et in intellectu increato sunt simul omnia intellecta actu quae a creato successive sunt intellecta; ergo ibi sunt infinita actu intellecta.”

89 See above, pp. 49–50, in chapter 1.

90 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 30, vol. I, p. 215 [CE II, p. 203–05]. Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 7 [possibly *Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 135–136, numbers 69–70], and *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, pp. 100–06.

91 See *Mediaeval Studies*, X (1948), p. 54. (Translator: the reference is incomplete. My surmise is that Gilson remits to one of his articles, either "The Infinite Being According to Duns Scotus" or "Texts Relating to the Notion of Infinite Being.")

92 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 31, vol. I, p. 216 [CE II, pp. 205–06].

93 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 9, vol. I, p. 10 [CE I, p. 15]: "Item homo naturaliter appetit finem istum quem dicis supernaturalem; igitur ad illum finem naturaliter ordinatur; ergo ex tale ordinatione potest concludi iste finis ex cognitione naturae ordinatae ad ipsum."—Pronouncing himself on this objection, Duns Scotus declares further on, number 11, p. 12: "Sed in quantum adducitur [*scilicet*, auctoritas Augustini] contra illam responsionem de fine supernaturali et naturali, concedo Deum esse finem naturalem hominis, sed non naturaliter adipiscendum, sed supernaturaliter. Et hoc probat ratio sequens de desiderio naturali quam concedo."—Immediately afterward, Duns Scotus denies that Avicenna could know, without being helped by theology that "ens esse primum objectum intellectus nostri, et hoc secundum totam indifferentiam entis ad sensibilia et insensibilia."

94 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 2, number 16, vol. I, pp. 16–17 [CE, vol. I, pp. 27–28]. At the end of the article, it is anticipated that if the *common* character of the concept of the *First* is challenged, it will at least be necessary to grant its *imperfect* character, since the concept is taken from the sensible. The conclusion stays the same in both cases. Let us recall the definition natural knowledge. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question I, article 2, number 21, p. 20: "Pro statu autem isto, secundum Philosophum, intellectus possibilis natus est moveri ad cognitionem ab intellectu agente et phantasmate; igitur sola illa cognitio naturalis est quae ab istis agentibus potest imprimi."

95 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article, number 31, vol. I, p. 216 [CE II, p. 207]: "Infinitum intelligimus per finitum, et hoc vulgariter sic expono: infinitum est quod aliquod finitum datum secundum nullam habitudinem finitam praecise excedit, sed ultra omnem habitudinem assignabilem excedit adhuc."—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 1 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 129–30, number, 51]: "Infinitum est quod quodcumque finitum datum ultra omnem proportionem excedit."

96 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 32, vol. I, p. 217 [CE, vol. II, p. 208]: "Quare intellectus, cujus objectum est ens, nullam invenit repugnantiam intelligendo aliquod infinitum, immo videtur perfectissimum intelligibile? Mirum est autem si nulli intellectui talis contradictio patens fiat circa ejus primum objectum, cum discordia in sono ita faciliter offendat auditum; si enim disconveniens, statim ut percipitur offendit, cur nullus intellectus ab intelligibili infinito naturaliter refugit, sicut a non conveniente, suum ita objectum primum destruente?"—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 8 [*Reportatio 1-A*, pp. 136–38, numbers 71–75].

97 For a contrary view, see Bettoni, *L'ascesa*, chapter 2, pp. 30–31, and chapter 4, p. 79. The author, p. 31, notes 2 and 3, contradicts Belmond and Van Woestyne, who maintain that Duns Scotus *colored* the argument with a view to proving, not the existence of God, but his infinity. The two scholars base themselves on the obvious sense of Duns Scotus's own text, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 189 [CE II, p. 146]: "Quomodo autem ratio ejus [*scilicet* Anselmi] valeat, dicetur in sequenti quaestione, argumento sexto, de infinitate probanda."

98 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 32, vol. I, pp. 217–18 [CE II, pp. 209–10]. Duns Scotus, who has just dismissed this last interpretation, immediately takes it up to color again Anselm's proof differently (*vel aliter coloratur*). We then get this: what

exists is more thinkable, that is more knowable (because object of a *possible* intuition) than that which, since it does not exist, can only be known in the mode of abstraction. Now, intuitive knowledge is more perfect than abstractive knowledge. Ergo.

99 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 1, number 16, vol. I, pp. 195–96. [CE, vol. II, p. 164 has: "sed rationi primi effectivi simpliciter repugnat esse ab alio, sicut patet ex secunda conclusione."]

100 Cf. Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, pp. 122, 124.

101 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 34, vol. I, p. 219 [CE II, p. 213]: ". . .et in hoc probatum est esse de Deo quantum ad proprietates respectivas Dei ad creaturam, vel in quantum determinat respectus dependentias creaturarum ad ipsum."—We understand that the subject of *determinat* in the second clause of the sentence is an implicit *Deus*.

102 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 34, vol. I, pp. 219–20 [CE II, pp. 214–15]: "Ergo aliquod infinitum ens existit actu. Et istud est perfectissimum conceptibile et conceptus perfectissimus, absolutus, quem possumus habere de Deo naturaliter, quod sit infinitus, sicut dicetur 3 distinctione. Et sic quantum ad conceptum vel esse ejus Deum esse perfectissimum conceptibilem vel possibilem haberi a nobis de Deo." [CE has *probatum est* in the last sentence.]

103 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 3, number 35, vol. I, p. 220 [CE II, pp. 215–16].—Note how this responds to the authority: but did not the Philosophers admit that there is evil in the universe while maintaining that God acted by necessity of nature? Answer: yes, no doubt, for that, they had to recur to a device to explain that evil could occur in the universe contingently. They then conceive the First as necessarily producing opposite goods, whose causes conflict with each other, from which evil comes accidentally. This is a useless attempt at evasion, Duns Scotus has already observed, because the contingent precisely remains inevitable, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 21, vol. 1, p. 204 [CE II, pp. 178–79].

104 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 3, number 36, vol. I, p. 223 [CE II, p. 221]: "Istud improbabiliter distinctione 8, quaestione ultima, ubi in hoc arguetur contra Philosophos, qui ponunt Primum agere ex necessitate quodlibet quod immediate agit. Sed Christianis non est argumentum difficile, quia dicunt Deum contingenter agere."

105 See Moses Maimonides, *Guide des Égarés*, part one, chapter 75, trans. Salomon Munk, Paris: A. Franck, 1856, vol. I, pp. 440–50. Cf., part two, chapter 1, vol. II, pp. 42–46.

106 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 24, sole question, number 21.

107 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 7, vol. I, p. 230 [CE II, pp. 236–37]. Here Scotus remits to St. Augustine, *De Civitate Dei*, XVIII, 41, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, columns 600–02.

108 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 7, vol. I, p. 230 [CE II, p. 237]: ". . .et ideo, quia simplices sequentes tales demonstrationes bene possent dubitare cui esset assentiendum, ideo tuta est via et facilis et communis, auctoritas certa quae non potest fallere nec falli." [CE has *stabilis* instead of *facilis*.]

109 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 5, vol. I, p. 228 [CE II, pp. 232–34]. Scotus remits to St. Augustine *De Trinitate*, book VII, chapter 1, number 1, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, p. 933.—Cf. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I, question 11, article 3, body of article.

110 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, vol. I, pp. 226–27 [CE II, p. 230].—Compare this demonstrative technique to the one employed by William of Auvergne, *De Trinitate*,

chapter 6.

111 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 4, vol. I, p. 227 [CE II, p. 230].

112 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 4, vol. I, pp. 227–28 [CE II, pp. 230–32].

113 Scotus *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 3, number 5, vol. I, p. 228 [CE II, p. 232].

114 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, pp. 122, 124. (Translator: chapter 2, p. 26, note 28 for the relation to Confessions, book 12, chapter 4.)

115 On William of Auvergne and the rational pairs he uses, see Stephan Schindele, *Beiträge zur Metaphysik der Wilhelm von Auvergne*, Munich: Kastner, 1900.—Amato Masnovo, *Da Guglielmo d'Auvergne a san Tomasso d'Aquino*, Milan: Vita e pensiero, 1930, vol. I, pp. 78–75, second edition 1945–46.

116 Particularly in Bonaventure's *Itinerarium Mentis in Deum*, V, 5–6, *editio minor*, pp. 334–36. (Translator: possibly refers to *Itinerarium* in *Tria Opuscola ad Theologiam Sectantia*, Quarracchi, Collegium Sancti Bonaventurae, 1936; available electronically, published Turnhout: Brepols, 2010.)

117 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, chapter 1, p. 10 (Translator: Roche's note 11), remits to *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 3 [CE III, pp. 250–51]. Mauritius a Portu remitted to another work whose authenticity seemed sufficiently established: "Illud *alibi* posset asignari in *Theorematibus*, ubi illa tangit egregie." or again *in physicis*. In any case, it is certain that the theorems *de causis* included in the *Theoremata* that are presupposed by the propositions of *De Primo Principio* are not identical to them. All issues of authenticity apart, the two works do not have the same object.

118 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 1 [KR 1-A, p. 66, lines 17–23; and *Reportatio 1-A* I, with verbal differences]: "Omnes veritates secundum se scibiles de Deo *propter quid*, sciuntur in illa scientia quae est de Deo secundum se sub ratione divinitatis, et ideo omnes veritates, quas metaphysicus vere probat de Deo simpliciter pertinent ad illam scientiam [*scilicet*, theologiam]; sed quia metaphysica probat illas ex effectibus et demonstratione *quia sunt*, ideo secundum quid ad metaphysicam pertinent."

119 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 1 [KR 1-A, p. 66, lines 24–26; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 83, number 237]: "Respondeo, quod metaphysica, quantum ad illud quod de Deo considerat, est simpliciter scientia *quia*, sed scientia simpliciter *quia*, est secundum quid *propter quid*. Ideo ad metaphysicam secundum quid pertinent illae veritates."

120 Moreover, this is why Duns Scotus does not believe that metaphysics as such is subalternated to theology, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, quae*stionuncula* 4 [KR 1-A, p. 70, lines 221–31 in the seventh *quaestionuncula*; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 67, number 249]: "Si ulterius quaeritur: an theologia sibi subalternet aliam [*scilicet*, scientiam]? Dicendum quod non, quia non dicit *propter quid* respectu aliarum; quia aliae scientiae resolvunt suas conclusiones in principia immediata, quae primo sunt vera, etsi nihil aliud esset." *Ibidem* [KR 1-A, p. 70, lines 130–31; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 87, number 250]: "Si poneretur, per impossibile, quod Deus non esset, et quod triangulus esset, adhuc habere tres angulos resolveretur ut in naturam trianguli."—Compare Suarez's position and Descartes's opposition on this point, in Gilson, *La liberté chez Descartes et la Théologie*, Paris: Alcan, 1913, p. 35 ff. Those pages from 1913 would have to be entirely rewritten in function of this new fact. See also the sound remarks of Pierre Garin, *Thèses cartésiennes et thèses thomistes*, Paris: Desclée de Brouwer, 1931, pp. 99–100. See the passage from Suárez, quoted on p. 131, and Cajetan's objections to Duns Scotus quoted in the Appendix, pp. 169–72. Although neither Garin nor I believed it, there really was a theologian who maintained

the theses disputed by Descartes, letter to Mersenne, May 6, 1630, Adam-Tannery edition, vol. I, p. 150: “Si Deus non esset, nihilominus istae veritates essent verae.”

121 If the following passage is correct, exact knowledge of Greek does not seem to have been a factor in the environments where Duns Scotus studied. *Quaestiones Subtillissimae in Metaphysicam*, prologue, number 5 [EW I, pp. 7–8, number 18]: “Igitur necesse est esse aliquam scientiam universalem, quae per se consideret illa transcendentia, et hanc scientiam vocamus metaphysicam, quae dicitur a *meta*, quod est *trans*, et *physis*, *scientia*, quasi transcendens scientia quae est de transcendentibus.”

122 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, prologue, number 5 [EW I, p. 8, number 19].

123 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 1, article 1, scholion 1: “potest concludi in metaphysica Deum esse, sive primum ens esse.” [The scholion is not included in KR 1-A or *Reportatio 1-A* I. In Vivès, vol. XXII, it is on p. 4.] Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 7, number 20 [CE I, pp. 129–30].—The inference is possible here because the properties of being are exterior to its essence. *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 1, number 23 [EW I, p. 34, number 76]: “Ens inquantum ens potest habere passionem aliam, quae est extra essentiam ejus inquantum est ens; sicut esse unum vel multa, actus vel potentia, est extra essentiam cujuslibet inquantum est ens, sive *quid* in se.”

124 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, Merton College Manuscripts, codex XC, folios 147 recto—154 verso. The text was published by Harris, *Duns Scotus* (reproduced Bristol: Theommes Press, 1994), vol. II, pp. 379–98.

125 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, p. 379.

126 Ibid., pp. 379, 384: “Est distinctio quaedam de metaphysica in se et in nobis”; “. . .metaphysica ut est scientia in nobis. . .” “patet ad quae se extendit metaphysica in se; . . .sed metaphysica nostra non se extendit sic. . .” This insistence is not surprising. Since *Opus Oxoniense* proposed to determine the object of theology, it was natural for Duns Scotus to insist there on the distinction between the two theologies. Since the present question bears upon the extent of our metaphysical knowledge of God, it is natural that its author should insist more vigorously on the distinction between the two metaphysics.

127 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, p. 379. The text immediately specifies that, since distinctly conceived being only includes these truths virtually, it is not necessary that we conceive the truths as distinctly as being itself. We have the irresistible sensation of hearing Duns Scotus, when the text recalls in this regard the question on the unicity of being, where it is proven that being “is not quidditatively included in its properties.” Of course, to say that our science of being is *a priori* in its fashion does not contradict its being a posteriori a science of God.

128 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, p. 380.

129 Ibid.

130 Ibid.

131 Ibid., p. 381: “Respondeo: oportet concedere quod termini concipiantur a nobis et distincte, sed de illa parte disjuncti, puta infnito, necesse esse, et hujusmodi non oportet hoc concedere: qui conceptus proprius hujus non includitur in conceptu entis, cum communis est et subjectum metaphysicae nostrae; nec possumus devenire ad concept proprium infiniti per conceptum entis quem habemus, sicut de passionibus convertibilibus pervenitur per substantiam [starting from being, we can attain the convertible transcendentals, not the *passiones disjunctae*], nec aliquid aliud est motivum intellectus nostri, nec quod virtualiter contineat conceptus talis partis talis passionis disjunctae; quia sensibilia omnia, secundum totum illud quod movent sensum et intellectum nostrum, continetur sub imperfecta parte disjuncti.—Cf. *Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione*

Dei, vol. II, p. 390: “Porro: metaphysica nostra . . .”

132 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione, vol. II, p. 382: “Nos autem intelligimus infinitatem negative, scilicet per remotionem finiti, et comparando infinitatem ad ens... Et haec est ratio quia ens infinitum, ut a nobis intelligitur, non quietat intellectum nostrum, quia non concipimus ens sub perfectiori ratione intrinseca entis.”—In other words, this mode of being that is infinity cannot be the object of any other concept than that of being. Our concept of being, abstracted from the sensible does not represent infinity. Ergo...

133 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, p. 383.

134 Ibid., p. 384: “Theologia vero nostra, quae accipit a metaphysica de ente infinito si est, non habet principia immediata, quia nullum conceptum proprium positivum contentivum veritatum theologicarum possumus habere.” The continuation of the text is sometimes obscure, and we must hope that other manuscripts will let us check the text C. R. S. Harris gives us.

135 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, pp. 384–85.

136 Harris’s text, *Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei*, vol. II, p. 384, contains a difficult passage, whose final word is uncertain. It is as follows: “Unde probando de infinito si est, non exigitur metaphysica, non ulterius probando de ente infinito, sicut a nobis concipitur quidquid in ratione ejus continetur; et ideo concludo; quodcumque cognoscimus demonstratione per rationem entis infiniti pertinet etiam ad nostram.” A note to the last word says “*ad etiam* Cod.” If the text has *etiam*, that is evidently a mistake. We can admit *nostram* (or many other words), but we would like to know whether, in the event it is *nostram*, the word relates to *metaphysicam* or *theologiam*. Nothing is riskier than the exegesis of an uncertain text. The author’s overall thinking invites us to understand “ad nostram metaphysicam.”

137 Therefore, there are not so much two immediately distinct subjects, known by two irreducible concepts, than a single subject known by two hierarchically situated concepts, with the lower belonging to the same species as the higher, “quia perfectum et imperfectum non mutant speciem,” *Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei*, vol. II, pp. 385–86.

138 Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, p. 386: “Consequentia patet. . . .”

139 Ibid., pp. 386–87.

140 This is what our author says, *Doctor Subtilis de Cognitione Dei*, vol. II, p. 387: “Metaphysica in se extendit ad omnia cognoscibilia de Deo concepto aliquo conceptu metaphysico; hoc autem est, concepto non tantum in communi conceptu entis, sed concepto conceptu entis infiniti, necessarii et hujusmodi.”

141 Subtilis Doctor de Cognitione Dei, vol. II, p. 391: “Ex hoc sequitur. . .”

142 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, article 1: “nulla ratio propria Dei conceptibilis a nobis statim apprehenditur ab intellectu viatoris, igitur nulla scientia naturaliter acquisita potest esse de Deo sub aliqua ratione propria.” [KR 1-A, p. 60, lines 40–42, and *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 77, number 218. without mention of *viatoris*]. In this sense, as Aristotle has it, metaphysics is certainly concerned: “circa causas altissimas.” In fact it does not have them as its subject but as its goal, *ibidem*: “Unde *circa* proprie notat circumstantiam causae finalis, sicut et causae materialis; unde metaphysica est circa altissimas causas finaliter, ad quarum cognitionem terminatur scientia metaphysicalis.”—By its nature the human intellect could have an adequate concept of God. However, for that, God would have to create the concept infusing into the human intellect a light proportional to this object, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, numbers 8–10 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 196, number 41].

143 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 3: “subjectum illius est singulare.” [KR 1-A, p. 67, line 41; and *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 84, number 239, “est ipsa

singularitas”].

144 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 1, number 1, vol. I, p.179 [CE II, p. 125], asks: “Utrum in entibus sit aliquid actu existens infinitum.” The exact meaning is difficult to render. It could be translated: “Whether, among beings, there is an actually existent infinite being.” The stress then falls on actual existence. It could also be translated: “Whether in being, there is one that is actually infinite.” The stress then falls on actual infinity. The second translation is possible because, *aliquid actu existens infinitum* in this Latin normally means something that is actually infinite. Furthermore, it seems to us better adapted to the general line of argumentation, because, although the argument here contemplates a real existence and thus an actual existence, the argument sets out above all to establish that this real existence is an infinite. Lastly, it agrees with other versions cited by Fr. Carolus Balić, *Les Commentaires de Jean Duns Scot sur les quatre livres des Sentences*, Louvain: Bureau de la Revue, 1927, p. 63: “Utrum in entibus sit aliquod entis actu infinitum,” and again, “Utrum in entibus sit aliquod ens in actu infinitum.” Accordingly, the point is to establish the existence among beings of a certain being, the one whose formal being, which is deity, is the supremely formal entity, because it is totally form, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 4, question 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 485 [I do not find this passage in CE IV, pp. 11–13]: “Quia cuilibet entitati formali correspondet adaequate aliquod ens vel aliquid ens entitate tali. Ista autem deitas, quae est entitas formalissima, quia se tota est forma, non habet sic sibi aliquid correspondens nisi Deum.”—Duns Scotus and Thomas Aquinas agree on the primacy of act, but Duns Scotus is faithful to the traditional metaphysics of primacy of the formal act, whereas Thomas Aquinas elevates the primacy of the act of being above the act of the form.

145 Let us recall this explicit passage, Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 4, number 3 [EW II, p. 83, number 10]: “*Si est* praesupponitur de subjecto, non de actuali existentia, sed quod habet esse quidditativum scilicet quod ratio ejus non est falsa in se. Tale *si est* ostenditur demonstratione *quia* a metaphysico de primo ente. Ostenditur enim quod primum convenit enti alicui. (The French erroneously has book VII for both notes 145 and 146.)

146 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 4, number 3 [EW II, p. 83].

147 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question I, number 44 [EW I, pp. 54–55, number 145].

148 The most precise passage is found in *Quodlibet*, IX, 17 [AW, p. 232]. [Translator’s note: Gilson does not seem to have carried out his plan to return to *Quodlibet*, IX, 17.].

149 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 9, vol. I, p. 1176 [CE VI, p. 285]: “Prima distinctio entis videtur esse in ens extra animam et ens in anima; et illud extra animam potest distingui in actum et potentiam, essentiae et existentiae. Et quodcumque istorum esse extra animam potest habere esse in anima, et illud esse in anima aliud est ab omni esse extra animam. Et ideo de nullo ente nec de aliquo esse sequitur, si habet esse diminutum in anima, quod propter hoc habeat esse simpliciter, quia illud esse [*scilicet*, in anima] est *secundum quid* absolute, quod tamen accipitur simpliciter in quantum comparatur ad animam ut fundamentum illius esse in anima [*scilicet*, being in the soul is real by the reality of the soul where it is].—The expression “ens. . . extra animam potest distingui in. . . essentiae et existentiae” should be noted. Consequently, Suárez will be right to classify Duns Scotus among those who favor the distinction between essence and existence, but, as we will see, the point here is not a real distinction. Duns Scotus never admitted that the modality *existence* was an act distinct from the essence within the actually existing substance. A thing is an *ens* by its *essentia*, even including the modality of essence that is *esse*.

150 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 22, sole question, number 13: “Quando vocat [*scilicet*, Aristoteles] hominem in universali subjectum et individuum in genere substantiae

existens, hoc non arguit ex se existentiam, nam quidquid est illius coordinationis, est in genere, antequam comparetur ad existentiam. Unde *hic homo* abstrahit ab existentia sicut *homo*; hic tamen homo existens non est ens per accidens tanquam aliquid compositum ex rebus diversorum generum; sed existentia formaliter est extra rationem essentialem illius hominis et totius illius coordinationis in genere substantiae et pro tanto dicitur existentia sibi esse *accidens*. Unde existentia est conditio necessaria isti homini, ut terminet generationem. Nam *hic homo* non generatur per se et primo, sed *hic homo existens*, et eo modo existentia sequitur ipsum, ut comparatur ad generationem producentem ipsum in esse; unde sic *hoc subjectum* generatur, et non subjectum ut praecise dicit individuum in genere substantiae, secundum ordinationem illius generis."

151 Duns Scotus judges that Avicenna and Aristotle agree on this point, because he reduced the distinction of essence and existence to the relation of efficient cause to effect. The existence of an effect is always accidental to its essence, because its cause alone can give it existence, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 19 [probably *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 354, number 72]: "Hoc autem probatur, quia quod capit esse ab alio, in sua quidditate non includit esse: sed intelligere quidditatem praecise, non includentem esse, est intelligere quidditatem ut in potentia ad esse, quod non est de se habens esse, ut intelligere humanitatem praecise in quantum humanitas est intelligere ipsam ut est in potentia ad esse, quia est in potentia ad omne illud quod nondum ex se habet, possibile tamen ipsi competere. Et sic loquitur Avicenna de quidditate V *Metaphysicae*, capitulo 1, ubi dicit omne tale esse accidens essentiae, quod non est de formali conceptu ejus, et quidditatem ad omne hujusmodi esse in potentia, ut ad unum et multum et caetera hujusmodi."—Let us note that in Duns Scotus's time, Avicenna's doctrine was a platitude. In the Franciscan order itself, it had been expounded in detail, and accepted with its epistemological consequences by Matthew of Aquasparta, *Quaestiones de Cognitione*, Quaracchi: 1903, p. 227.—For protection against the excessive importance that we attribute to Avicenna in Duns Scotus's metaphysics, see René Arnou, "Autour d'Avicenne (Ibn Sina)," *Gregorianum*, XX (1929), pp. 140–47. It seems that Peter Aureolus is not of our opinion, which is certainly regrettable, but we are completely of Mauritius a Portu's opinion in his note *In IV Metaphysicae*, question 1, Wadding edition, vol. IV, p. 581: "Favet namque Avicennae inter philosophos ubique, nisi sit contra fidem, et Paulo inter apostolos, et Joanni inter evangelistas, et nimirum, quia teste Boethio, omnis similitudo appetenda est."

152 See the expression quoted above in note 149 of this chapter where, "ens extra animam" is differentiated into "essentiae et existentiae." The next article in *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 10, vol. I, p. 1176 [CE VI, p. 288], can complete this, where Duns Scotus writes: "Non quidem secundum esse essentiae vel existentiae, quod est verum esse; sed secundum esse diminutum, quod esse est secundum quid etiam entis absoluti." Again in the same question, article 11, vol. I, p. 1177 [CE VI, p. 290]: "*Ens ratum* aut appellatur illud quod habet esse firmum et verum esse, sive essentiae sive existentiae, quia unum non est sine altero, qualitercumque distinguantur; aut *ens ratum* dicitur illud quod primo distinguitur a figmentis, cui scilicet non repugnat esse verum essentiae vel existentiae."—Therefore it is not enough to establish that essence has no being of its own in Duns Scotus, which is easy, in order to prove that the being of reason has no reality of its own. To conclude from one to the other is, once again, to confuse the logical and metaphysical orders. What misleads the reader here is viewing the *esse essentiae* itself as an existence, whereas it is necessarily situated in the line of the being's essential formality, not in that of existence. Essence and existence are both distinct and always simultaneously given in any real being in the full sense of the term. This is why, after the text that has just been quoted, Duns Scotus immediately adds, p. 1177 [CE VI, p. 190]: "Si primo modo

accipitur ens ratum, dico quod *homo* non est ex se ens ratum, sed ab efficiente, a quo habet esse verum et essentiae et existentiae."

153 This is true not only of the species, but even of the genus. Of course, the issue is not the concepts of genera, which are simple beings of reason, but the objective reality that these concepts designate. *Reportata Parisiensia*, distinction 8, question 5, number 4 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 367, number 122]: "Intellectus concipiendo genus habet conceptum de aliquo quod est in re, et non loquor de secunda intentione generis, sed de eo quod concipitur objective. Sic enim propositio est vera; aliter enim concipiendo animal, quod est genus, non conciperetur aliquid quod in quid diceretur de homine: sic etiam concipiendo differentiam objective concipitur aliquid quod est in re."

154 For example, in the context of knowing whether there are two *esse* in Christ's person, Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part III, question 17, article 2, body of article: "Unumquodque secundum hoc dicitur ens, secundum quod dicitur unum, quia unum et ens convertuntur; si ergo in Christo essent duo esse, et non tantum unum, Christus esset duo, et non unum." Duns Scotus sums this up exactly, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 6, question 1, number 1: "Esse constituit ens, igitur si ibi sunt duo esse, Christus erit duo entia."

155 So, to use the same example, Duns Scotus maintains against Thomas Aquinas that in Christ there are two *esse existentiae*. Here is the reason, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 6, question 1, number 7: "Dico igitur, loquendo de esse actualis existentiae in re extra causam et extra intellectum, vel non est res in actuali existentia, vel non differt existentia a re extra causam suam nisi sola ratione. Loquendo igitur de isto esse existentiae, dico quod in Christo sunt duo esse existentiae." Cf. same question, number 8: "In Christo est duplex esse, quorum utrumque est esse Christi."—As for the principle "esse constituit ens," Duns Scotus rebuts it by saying that in particular beings, we count the beings by the number of subjects and not inversely. Here there is only one particular subject, Christ. The fact that he has two *esse* does not prevent him from being one. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 6, question 1, number 9: "Non enim sequitur iste habet duas scientias, igitur est duo scientes. Sic nec sequitur: Christus est habens duas voluntates, igitur est duo volentes; nec sequitur: habet duas existentias, igitur est duo existentes; nec valet, habet duo esse, igitur est duo entia."—Even in God where there is only a single pure and simple *esse* of the divine essence, there is an "esse incommunicabile sive hypostaticum" per divine person, *Quodlibet* IV, 30 [AW, p. 106].

156 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 6, question 1, number 9: "Sed si sint duae luces, oportet esse plura lucere, igitur si plures naturae, plura esse." By writing "sic sapientia ad sapere, ita essentia ad esse," Duns Scotus summarizes Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book VII, chapter 4, number 9, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 942: "Quemadmodum quia hoc est Deo esse quod sapere, sicut non tres essentias, ita nec tres sapientias dicimus."—In what concerns Anselm, *Monologion*, chapter 6, Bonn: Schmidt, 1929, p. 13: "Quemadmodum enim esse habent ad invicem lux et lucere et lucens, sic sunt ad se invicem essentia et esse et ens, hoc est existens sive subsistens. Ergo summa essentia et summe esse et summe ens, id est summe existens sive summe subsistens, non dissmiliter sibi covenient, quam lux et lucere et lucens."

157 Speaking of the Eucharistic accidents, Thomas Aquinas (*Summa Theologiae*, part III, question 77, article 1, reply to objection 4) says that before the consecration, the accidents of bread and wine have no *esse* of their own. Their *esse* is *inesse*, as for all accidents. By contrast, after the consecration, the accidents of bread and wine certainly must have an *esse*, because they subsist: "Post consacrationem ipsa accidentia quae remanent habent esse, unde sunt composita ex esse et quod est." The miracle is precisely there.—Duns Scotus is opposed to this, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 12, question 1, number 4: "Sed istud non capio. Sicut enim unumquodque

habet essentiam, ita et esse, quia omnis essentia est actus, sicut probatum est; sed accidens habet essentiam, et per se unam, et est alterius generis a subjecto suo, igitur, habet esse distinctum aliud ab esse subjecti."—Furthermore, the examination of the problems of creation and of immortality of the soul will permit us add some indications to the previous ones.

158 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 3, article 4, reply to objection 2.

159 We could infer this conclusion from the transformation imposed by Duns Scotus upon the Aristotelian notion of infinite, "Commutemus rationem infiniti in potentia, in quantitate, in rationem infiniti in actu, in quantitate si posset ibi esse in actu." Proceeding toward genuine metaphysical integration, Duns Scotus asks us to imagine numerical infinity as actually achieved since we conceive of infinite beings by analogy with the former, *Quodlibet* V, 3 [AW, p. 109]: "Si in entibus intelligamus aliquid infinitum in entitate in actu, illud debet intelligi proportionabiliter quantitati imaginatae in actu, sic ut ens illud dicatur infinitum quod non potest ab aliquo in entitate excedi, et ipsum vere habebit rationem totius et perfecti."—This is why we have noted: "Infinitum excedit in entitate finitum ultra omnem proportionem assignabilem." This *infinitas intensiva* is not an extrinsic attribute of being or even a transcendental like the true or the good, but a mode, so intrinsic that even abstracting from every transcendental like the true or the good, else, the being that possesses it still remains infinite, *Quodlibet* V, 4 [AW, p. 111]: "Immo infinitas intensiva dicit modum intrinsecum ilius entitatis, cujus est sic intrinsecum, quod circumscribendo quodlibet quod est proprietas vel quasi proprietas ejus, adhuc infinitas ejus non excluditur, sed includitur in ipsa entitate, quae est unica."—*Quodlibet* V, 4 [AW, p. 112]: "Substantia ergo secundum quod habet rationem omnino primi in divinis. . . est infinita et interminata; sic autem non includitur in ea nec veritas, nec bonitas, nec aliqua proprietas attributalis: ergo ipsa infinitas est magis modus intrinsecus essentiae quam aliquod attributum."—Cf. *Quodlibet* V, 17 [AW, pp. 121]: "Divinitas est formaliter infinita. . . " See also *Quodlibet* VI, 2 and VI, 10 [AW, pp. 130–31 and 138–39].

160 Hieronymus de Montefortino, *Venerabilis Joannes Duns Scoti. . . Summa Theologica*, part I, question 3, article 4, reply to objection 1.—If we want to see what happens to the thought of a master grappling with his object, when that thought itself becomes the object in the mind of a disciple, we should read the astonishing *Alphabetum Doctoris Subtilis* published by Fr. Balić in order, I think, to teach modesty to historians, in "La questione Scotista," *Rivista de filosofia neo-scolastica* XXX (1938), pp. 247–50. The author of this little text posits in God, as the first moment of nature, independent necessary being, to which he subordinates ten other principal moments. The first is his essence. Let us pass over the next three and come to the fifth: "Quintum signum entis necessarii et independentis sunt modi intrinseci qui minus distinguuntur ab essentia et attributis quam attributa ab attributis. Et istud signum habet sub se septem signa subalterna [everything counted, that makes twelve *signa* so far]: primum est realitas; secundum est existentia; tertium est actualitas' quartum est contingentia; quintum est infinitas; sextum est vita; septimum est hecceitas." Thus the modality *existence* comes as the seventh natural moment of essence, *infinity* as the tenth, and *singularity* as the twelfth. Regarding Scotists who make existence an extrinsic mode of God, see *Conciliationes Locorum Quodlibetalium*, Wadding, vol. XII, p. 548, *Conciliatio* II, numbers 1 and 2.

161 This same fundamental position is found in Frassen, *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, p. 171: "Ens infinitum radicaliter, seu infinitas radicalis, est formale constitutivum et ultimo distinctivum, essentiae divinae." Frassen bases himself on the same passage of *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 18 [CE IV, p. 205]. Thus, Frassen adds, infinity belongs to God before singularity although both of them are essential to God. Taking a position on this further on, Frassen goes as far as to say that infinity is more essential than even a mode: "Nec refert quod ibidem infinitatem modum entitatis appellet; non enim vult eam esse tantum modum divinae

essentiae, qualiter immensitas, aeternitas, etc., dicuntur modi Deitatis; sed solum quod non habeat rationem perfectae et completae differentiae, nec sit conceptus adaequate distinctus ab ente quod Deum determinat et contrahit."—Duns Scotus certainly wants to say this: finite does not determine being as rational determines animal, and in general, as differences determine the genus. Would he go so far as to say with Frassen that *infinite* is more radical in God than a simple mode? This is for Scotists to dispute. Let us retain at least that Frassen pushes the identification of divine being with the infinite to the limit. Moreover, we understand why: all attributes (*intellectualita*s, *sapientia*, etc.) are univocal to God and creatures, except in so far as they imply infinity. The infinite is not univocal. Frassen, *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, p. 174: "Ergo is conceptus essentiae divinae ultimo constitutivus dicendus est, qui omnimode eam a creatura secernit, et in quo cum ea nullatenus convenit; is autem conceptus infinitatis radicalis, ac proinde censendus est formaliter essentiae divinae constitutivus et distinctivus."—This interpretation agrees with the texts where Duns Scotus posits the infinite as what is most *actual* in God, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 4, number 10, vol. I, p. 54 [CE I, p. 108]: "Tertio, quia illud secundum suam rationem propriam videtur esse actualius in se cui magis repugnat communicabilitas ad plura ad extra; sed essentiae de se repugnat communicabilitas ad plura ad extra, et nulli proprietati attributali, nisi quatenus est istius essentiae, vel idem isti essentiae inquantum infinitae. Si dicatur quod quaelibet proprietas est infinita, et ideo incommunicabilis, contra: infinitas illa est propter infinitatem et identitatem cum essentia sicut ex radice et fundamento omnis perfectionis intrinsecae."

162 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, conclusion 9, p. 102. Naturally, this does not exclude the proof of God's infinity by the perfection of his causality, *De Primo Principio*, pp. 106–14, but this first demonstration precludes the divine essence's being an unintelligible will, the only point at issue here. Besides, we can see further on in *De Primo Principio*, p. 118, that the first three of the five ways of proving divine infinity are drawn "ex mediis sumptis de intellectu." The other two are grounded upon the essence's simplicity and upon eminence.

3

Divine Nature

What is our rational knowledge of God worth, as Duns Scotus defines it in the *Opus Oxoniense*? It is not as easy to resolve this problem as might be imagined at first. A simple criterion can certainly serve as a guide here, because nothing indicates that Duns Scotus ever retreated from on the very firm conclusion that natural reason can know everything about God that can be known about the infinite being and nothing else. It is necessary not to lose sight of it. For example, if we expect to observe a change of method to mark the moment at which Duns Scotus crosses over from what is philosophical to what is theological, we are exposed to several misunderstandings. Since Scotus, in agreement with St. Thomas, sees no difficulty in God's revealing rationally demonstrable truths, he makes no bones about quoting Scriptural authorities before proving what he intends to demonstrate rationally. After all, it is within a theological work that he undertakes to demonstrate those revealed truths that he judges rationally demonstrable. It does not matter that he cites Scripture in such a case. He does not thereby abandon the method of philosophy, since Scripture, which is sufficient in its own order, only serves here to show what the philosopher claims he can demonstrate.

Just as the presence of Scripture does not exclude philosophy, the presence of demonstration does not exclude theology. Duns Scotus does not change method at any point in his work, and the philosopher's method remains the theologian's method. It would be pointless to expect the Subtle Doctor to

declare himself incompetent before the mystery of the divine Trinity, for example. Obviously, he does not claim to comprehend it, but he does not have the impression of entering into a sphere that is hostile to rational knowledge or totally alien to it. Even the notion of a "single essence in three persons" does not seem contradictory to him,[1] because it does not involve one and the same thing being one and three at the same time and in the same regard. No contradiction appears between unity of essence and Trinity of persons, and that is why Duns Scotus's dialectic retains its rigor when he decides to apply it here. Moreover, rigor is certainly necessary, since Duns Scotus intends to establish his own theses against Aristotle and Averroes, that is, against arguments in their philosophies that would make Christian theology impossible. Whether the issue is proving the First's existence or proving that there can be and there is internal activity within the divine essence, or that these infinite activities are and can only be two, or that there are and can only be three persons in the divine essence, Scotus's technical vocabulary and demonstrative methods remain exactly the same: "I argue in this way, proof of the antecedent, the major of the prosyllogism is proved," *arguo sic, probatio antecedentis, probatur major prosyllogismi*. Duns Scotus never loses sight of the fact that he may be read by unbelievers as well as believers, and his argumentation takes both into account: "These reasons do not clarify the assertion by what is more manifest either for the faithful or the infidel," *istae rationes non declarant propositum per manifestius, neque fideli, neque infideli*. With unflagging patience and industry, our theologian continues to weave the thread of syllogisms to enlighten the believer and, if possible, persuade the infidel, *persuadere infideli*. Through this splendid continuity, one sign and one alone informs us that the scheme within which we move is no longer the same. Unlike the metaphysician's conclusions, the theologian's are not exhaustively and exclusively justified by recourse to the concept of *infinite being*. Here, two distinct sciences cooperate in the same task, and they do so under the leadership of one of them, but the closeness of their cooperation does not cause them to be confused, because the distinction of their objects always keeps them from that. If the philosopher directs his

attention to the object of theology, he attains it under the concept of infinite being. If the theologian employs metaphysics with a view to his own ends, he tries to clarify what revelation tells us about God by means of the philosophical concept of infinite being.

The highest service that theology can expect from metaphysics is to inform theology as completely as it can about those attributes of God that reason can attain starting from the concept of infinite being. Reason does not attain all the attributes, and it corresponds to natural reason to acknowledge its limits here by forbidding itself to exceed the limits of its object. However, before reason commits itself to this path, it must proceed to a critique of a much more general scope and determine the value of our concepts insofar as they claim to express God.

A The plurality of divine names

God can be named, as he can be known. That is to say, for us, the possibility of naming him depends first of all on the possibility of knowing him. We cannot attain the divine essence in itself, at least not in this life. The only way to know God that is available to us starts from creatures, as we have done to demonstrate his existence, and in this way forms concepts, which a kind of metaphysical purification lets us then attribute to God. If matters are thus, since no distinct concepts in us correspond to the divine essence, it seems that we do not dispose of any names to designate God.

In principle at least, Duns Scotus does not dispute that a being can only be named insofar as it is known, but he limits the scope of this observation, since beings can be named more distinctly than they are known. Common experience confirms that. For example, we frequently employ the word *substance*, and we know very well that there are indeed substances. We even know that this or that object is a substance. However, what concept do we possess of the substance? None that is proper to it. Everything we know about it remains in the common concept of *being* for us, which we qualify and determine in such a way as to make it represent the definite genus of

being that we call substances. By saying that a being is a substance, we name it as such distinctly; we distinctly know it is such, although no concept of *substance* distinct from that of being corresponds to this word in the understanding. In fact, almost all the names of substances designate some accidental property of what they name. Therefore, what is not distinctly known can be distinctly named.[2]

In that case, the fact that God is not conceivable by us in the singularity of his essence, as this essence, *haec essentia*, does not keep us from being able to name him by one or several names that designate this singular essence taken in its very singularity. Without explicitly affirming it, Duns Scotus holds this position to be at least plausible. Accordingly, it is at least plausible that several of the names claimed for himself by God in Scripture or taught to humans by an angel who knows God himself directly, or even found by humans, distinctly signify the singular essence that is in fact God's. One such name is the *tetragrammaton*, which is the name the Jews attribute to God. Consequently, one such name is He Who Is, *Qui Est*, which is God's name for eternity there, as God himself one day told Moses (Exod. 3:14-15). Lastly, one such name is *Adonai*, which God himself said is his (Exod. 6:3).

The problem's solution thus ultimately depends on a semantic issue, the question of *imposition of names*. Can we name more distinctly that we can know? Duns Scotus is clearly inclined to admit that because, in fact, we do so continually, but even supposing that Scotus refused to admit it, it would still be certain that we can distinctly *use* a name whose attributions are not justified by any correspondingly distinct concept. What God designates as *Qui Est* can escape our understanding, but *Qui Est* designates God's essence just the same. Therefore, certain names signify God's essence more distinctly than we can grasp it.[3] Or if we prefer, God is ineffable in the sense that no name expresses him, but not in the sense that none can designate him.

So far, we are only dealing with names that are proper names in some way,[4] to which no definite essence responds within the understanding. However, the problem appears quite different when we ask whether certain common names that humans attribute to God are validly predicated of his essence or

substance, and consequently if they signify it.[5] Duns Scotus took a completely clear position on this question, understood in this definite sense, by first describing the answer that would be satisfied with purely negative knowledge of the divine essence. Here, the issue is naturally not to attribute to the human intellect the distinct concept of God's essence that Scotus has so far denied. The only question is to know whether the human knowledge that we have of God, whatever its limits may be otherwise, applies to God's essence. What Duns Scotus vigorously rejects is any admission that *negative* knowledge of the divine essence is conceivable. Furthermore, the problem transcends this particular case, because the issue is, first of all, to discover whether, generally speaking, knowing what an object is not is knowing the object.

The very clumsiness of the expression is enough to reveal how confused and almost contradictory such a concept is. Any negation has meaning only as the reverse of an affirmation. We cannot deny that God is a body without affirming that he is incorporeal. Indeed, all negations about God that we hold to be true suppose as many affirmations that support them. To deny all composition in God is, first of all, to affirm that he is simple. Generally speaking, thought never holds a negation as ultimate: "Also, we do not like negations very much," *negationes etiam non summe amamus*, Duns Scotus says.[6] Affirmation is what thought loves above all and at which alone it ultimately stops.

The reason for this preference is simple. Taken in itself, apart from any determined subject, a negation can signify anything at all by virtue of its very indetermination, which amounts to saying it means nothing. What does *non-stone* mean? We do not even know whether we are dealing with something or nothing, because nothing is not stone. A chimera is not stone either, any more than God is. In short, a pure negation holds alike for being and nothing. If the negation is offered as connected to a determined subject, we are no longer dealing with a pure negation. For example, if we say that x is not stone, the problem is posed of knowing what sort of concept x represents. If it is an affirmative concept, it is what gives sense to the proposition, including the

negation that it involves. If it is a negative concept, we again ask whether this negation must be understood absolutely or relative to an object. In the first case, it will correspond to nothingness as well as to God. In the second case, the subject of which it is understood gives it meaning. In short, let us pile up as many negations as we please about the subject of God. If the concept of God is negative itself, we will have said nothing. For such negations to have definite meaning, they must be applied to a first concept that is affirmative: "And insofar as one proceeds by negation, either God is not understood more than nothing, or he is established in some affirmative concept which is first."[7] It is already easy to foresee that everything we could say about the divine essence in Scotism will presuppose that the positive concept of *being* is applied univocally to God.

Moreover, this is what Duns Scotus himself establishes through a series of progressive determinations that successively eliminate any other interpretation.

First, Scotus refuses to admit that we can distinguish here between knowledge of whether something is, *si est*, and knowledge of what it is, *quid est*. Some authors judge that the human understanding can have positive knowledge of God while having only negative knowledge of his essence, but that is only a subterfuge to avoid the difficulty. How does someone know that a thing exists unless he has a concept of the thing whose existence he knows? The possibility of the concept itself is at stake here. Even if only to know that God is, we must have a simple concept applicable to the God that we know exists.

Duns Scotus goes further. Specifying the point at which he diverges from an adversary whose identity is hardly in doubt, he refuses to distinguish between knowing the truth of the proposition *si est* and knowing what the being of the thing in question is. To know the truth of the proposition *God is* is to know that the predicate *is* corresponds to the subject *God*, and how do we know that this proposition is true unless we first understand its terms? Consequently, it is impossible to be satisfied with knowing that the proposition *God is* is true, because it cannot be known if we do not first have

a simple concept of the subject *God*. Whether such a concept is naturally available to human beings and is available in our present state is precisely the issue.[8]

Lastly, let us add that for such a concept to be knowledge worthy of the name, it must make us know God not simply in his creatures but in himself. Certainly, and we have seen it well enough while proving his existence, God is only accessible to us through creatures, *per creaturam*, but this is not to know him except by knowing him in the creature, *in creatura*. Even if our discursive knowledge must begin with creatures, it will only be knowledge of God if it finishes in a concept of God known in himself. Otherwise, since the end of our dialectic is the same as its point of departure, we ultimately would have no knowledge of God. The issue here is to know whether humans in this life can naturally form a simple concept by which they conceive God.[9]

Scotus's response to this question signifies a reaction against Dionysius the Areopagite's negative theology, and if Scotus was not satisfied even with analogy, it is because negation ultimately carries him on to affirmation. No medieval thinker made a more determined effort to guarantee knowledge about the divine essence by the human intellect, which is both natural and positive. This does not necessarily mean that Duns Scotus attributes an especially extensive knowledge of God to us, and the occasions to mark our knowledge's limits does not fail to arise. Moreover, we already know the principal one, since God coincides with *infinite being* for natural knowledge. On the other hand, within these limits, Duns Scotus certainly intends to attain concepts such that they guarantee us positive knowledge of the divine essence, *in so far as the divine essence is knowable by metaphysics as being*. Now, it is knowable in this way, and how could we doubt that since Aristotle himself affirms that metaphysics is theology and situates human happiness in the contemplation of the separated substances?[10] What was possible for Aristotle must still be possible for us, and we must attempt to reach precisely this knowledge of the First that is both positive and rational.

The classical problem of the *divine attributes* presents itself necessarily here, but its solution supposes that we have found the solution of another

problem that we have already discussed. Every attribute is affirmed of a subject, and the union of an attribute and its subject engenders a concept *by accident*, which grasps the subject's essence insofar as determined by this attribute. What is a concept of this kind worth? Certainly, its value partly depends on the value of the concept of the attribute it includes, but in the first place it also obviously depends on the value of the concept of its object. Accordingly, knowledge of God's attributes will only be positive knowledge of God if we can affirm positively known attributes of an essence of God that is positively known itself. Take for example the attribute *wise*. In itself it designates a property or something like a property that perfects a nature as a second act. Consequently, we cannot understand *wise* without presupposing something that, so to speak, is a subject to which the sort of property that is wisdom pertains. In short, the concept of any attribute presupposes a *quidditative concept*, that is to say, the concept of a certain quiddity or essence to which this attribute belongs. Here, the concept can only be a quidditative concept of God without which no positive knowledge of God would be possible, and we know what this concept is. It is the univocal concept of being thanks to which the existence of infinite being has already been demonstrated.[11]

We no longer have to define the Scotist concept of univocity for itself.[12] It suffices to recall the criterion by which we recognize the univocal concept's of univocity in order to observe immediately that the notion of being is indeed applied to God's essence univocally. A concept only contains what its definition includes distinctly, or as Duns Scotus prefers to say, "Every intellect that is certain about one concept and uncertain about several others, possesses a concept of that about which it is certain that is other than the concepts about which it hesitates." This is why the concept of *being*, taken in itself, is applied in the same sense to all that is, even to God. This is only true in the measure in which our knowledge of God accepts being limited to knowledge of God considered *qua being*. But within these limits it is absolutely true because, precisely insofar as God is *being*, everything that is true of *being* is true of God. Now, even in the human intellect's present state,

it can be certain of what the word *being* signifies, although, provisionally, it remains uncertain about whether the being in question is finite or infinite, created or uncreated. By virtue of the rule we have posited, it follows that the concept of being is sufficient and that, since it is separately conceivable, it is a separate concept. So, it is a concept distinct from the concepts of *finite* or *infinite*, *created* or *uncreated*. It is distinct from them, because it does not include them, even if they include it. Conceivable separately from everything else, without any added determination, the concept of being is, thus, univocal to everything that is, provided solely that we only consider being in it, independently of any determination.[13]

When the rule of univocity is understood in this way, it guarantees that, the metaphysician will have a positive concept of the divine essence from the beginning of his investigation, which, insofar as God is being, permits the theologian to attain God directly. Surely, it is unnecessary to recall that this thesis would be strictly impossible in a doctrine where the quiddity of natural substance is not conceivable under its metaphysical aspect of common nature separate from any physical or logical determination. The quiddity is conceivable in this way in Duns Scotus's doctrine, and that is why univocity does not merely guarantee us positive knowledge of divine being itself, but no less positive knowledge of its attributes. Like the concept of being, the concept of every attribute does not necessarily imply anything other than that of the common essence that it signifies, and it signifies the common essence in itself, without any added modality. What counts in such cases is the *formal reason* of the object in question and it alone. It is true that all our concepts are taken from creatures and even from material creatures, but the fact becomes completely unimportant from the moment when the quiddity alone is taken into consideration. To the contrary, to consider only the formal reason of an attribute is to strip it of the imperfection that accompanies it in creatures and thereby render it attributable to God. Let us go further. Since we know that God is the infinite being, it will be enough to take to the infinite each attribute considered to thereby make it attributable to God alone. If we consider the formal reasons of *wisdom*, *intellect*, or *will*, precisely in themselves and

independently of any adventitious determination, they are univocal by reason of their very *commonality*. Originally taken from creatures, they nevertheless hold for all wisdom, every intellect, and every will, including God's. Though they may be conceived as infinite and perfect there, they will conserve their validity as univocal knowledge, and yet they will be conceived as attributes of God.[14]

Accordingly, the doctrine of univocity extends beyond the realm of being to the totality of divine attributes taken in the proper formal reasons: "Every inquiry about God supposes that the intellect has some univocal concept that it gets from creatures," *omnis inquisitio de Deo supponit intellectum habere conceptum eumdem univocum quem accipit ex creaturis*. The very possibility of such univocal predications is connected to the use Duns Scotus makes of modality. If a concept can be univocally predicated of the infinite being and finite beings, then this concept does not change nature when changing modality. Everything takes place as if the essence's neutrality were in no way affected by a determination of this kind. Indeed, in the expression *finite intellect*, we distinctly conceive *intellect*, *finite*, and *finite intellect*. However, in *infinite intellect*, the fact is that such an intellect escapes us, but it escapes us because we do not grasp *infinite*, not because we do not grasp *intellect*. Avicenna's golden rule holds here as elsewhere: intellect is just intellect, *intellectus est intellectus tantum*, which means that there can certainly be an infinite difference between a finite intellect and an infinite intellect, but that a variation of intensity in the essence's being, although it be infinite itself, does not affect the formal reason as such. This is even why the distance between an infinite intellect and a finite intellect is infinite, because it can only be known as such if we remain in the same order, that is, if we are talking about an intellect as such in both cases, whether finite or infinite. Hypothetically, let us suppress univocity. We are left only with a finite intellect and an infinite x, which we call intellect, but of which we have no concept. From that instant it is no longer possible to speak of any distinction between the two terms. Since the second term is missing, the very possibility of relation disappears with it.

This doctrine of divine attributes is obviously original and characteristic of Scotist philosophy, but it is no less true that it represents the new philosophical expression of a very ancient tradition. The use Duns Scotus makes of the quiditative *commonness* of Avicennist essences belongs only to Scotus. As far as we know, he gets it exclusively from his own reflection. On the other hand, at the core of the doctrine, it certainly seems that Duns Scotus himself only saw fidelity to Augustinianism, though the errors of perspective inseparable from history would make us believe in a rejection of Thomism. Something like Augustine's phrase in *De Trinitate*, VII, 4, would seem definitive to Scotus: "Essence is so-called from the fact that it is *esse*, on account of which God himself, to whom *esse* corresponds most strictly and truly, is most truly called essence." *Ab eo quod est esse, appellatur essentia, propter quod Deus ipse, cui propriissime et verissime convenit esse, verissime dicitur essentia*. Nobody claims that Augustine teaches the doctrine of univocity here, but one would need still more imagination yet to read the doctrine of analogy into the phrase. If one of the two doctrines can legitimately appeal to the obvious sense of this text, it is the first. Now, what is true of being, is true of attributes in general, because *essentia* is to *esse* as *sapientia* is to *sapere*, *potentia* to *posse*, and *justitia* to *justum esse*. If someone needs a laborious exegesis of Augustine's texts to achieve agreement with them, it is not Duns Scotus, and between him and Thomas Aquinas, we would not think about the Subtle Doctor here. If Duns Scotus begins by excluding as insufficient knowledge of God that would be satisfied with knowing God *in creatura*, it is precisely because he has in mind the article in the *Summa Theologiae*, where Thomas Aquinas, so Thomist and so un-Augustinian on this point, still looks for an acceptable exegesis of the passages from St. Augustine. Whatever the path by which he comes to them, Thomas's conclusion is formal: in this life we cannot know God's essence as it is in itself, "but we know it according to how it is represented in the perfections of creatures, and so they signify it through the name we assign."[15] Duns Scotus concedes the first part of this conclusion, but not the second, because in God, *being*, *power*, *wisdom*, and *simplicity* do not represent for us

what these words represent in creatures. They represent exactly and only what they signify: being, power, simplicity, and wisdom. Where do we go, asks Duns Scotus, if we adopt another position? If the *formal reason* of *wisdom* is the same in God as in humans, then we understand it univocally. If it is not the same, let us state sincerely that it is impossible to conclude what any formal reason whatever that we can consider in creatures might be in regard to any attribute of God. As we have already said, God would then be neither more nor less wise that he is stone, since neither concept would really any longer mean anything applied to God.

If there is a point where Duns Scotus's profound faithfulness to the tradition of Augustine is manifest, it is certainly the concept he forms of God and his concept of our knowledge of God. It is not as though Augustine was a Scotist before Duns Scotus. When we think of Augustine's God, the attribute that comes first is not *infinity* but rather *immutability*.[16] On the other hand, like infinity in Duns Scotus, at bottom immutability in Augustine is certainly attributed to the same thing, namely *essentia*. Several times Augustine affirms that God is above all *essentia*, in passages that caught the attention of Duns Scotus.[17] Of course, God *is*, not because he is essence; he is essence, because he *is*. But, since he is immutably and eternally, he is essence in the highest degree and, so to speak, archetypically. That is exactly what God is first of all in Duns Scotus's mind. To use Scotus's own language, if we only consider the *formal reason* of essence, Scotus's God is much closer to Augustinian *essentia* than to Thomist *esse*. What Scotus thinks of when he speaks about God is not so much the highest act of existing as a real entity, that is, from the nature of the thing, and one in actual existence, *entitas realis, sive ex natura rei, et hoc in existentia actuali*. For him, this actual real entity, *entitas realis actualis*, is exactly what Augustine was thinking of when he designated God by the name of *essentia*. Here we are not dealing with a historical hypothesis but with a fact:

> Since this real entity that is God is the first reason of being absolutely, the saints reasonably call it *essence*. Therefore, in *De Trinitate*, book VII, at the

> end of chapter one, Augustine says: “What is being-wise to wisdom and what is being-able to power and being-eternal to eternity and being-just to justice, so also is *esse* itself to essence.” Further on, in chapter four, he says: “Essence is named from the fact that it is *esse*, on account of which God himself, to whom *esse* corresponds most strictly and truly is called *essence* most truly.” In chapter five of the same book, Augustine says this: “It is manifest that God is wrongly called substance in order to understand *essence* (which is said truly and strictly) by a more customary name, so that perhaps God alone must be called *essence*. For truly it is he alone, since he is immutable, and he declared his name to his servant Moses, when he said, ‘I am who am.”’[18]

With regret for cutting this web of passages off too soon, it was necessary to quote it where Augustine’s *essentia* is so clearly presented as *that which* Duns Scotus’s univocal *essentia* sets out to interpret in its turn. It is because of the latter that the consideration in Scotist theology of the bare essence, which is the essence taken *as an absolute and absolutely first entity*, must precede any other consideration.[19] The *formal reason* of essence demands its rights here so rigorously that in order to introduce something other than essence, for example the divine persons, it will be necessary to appeal to other *formal reasons* than that of essence. This holds likewise and even more for the divine attributes, because although all the attributes are included in the unity and identity of the divine essence, that essence taken precisely as essence does not include all the divine perfections *formaliter*. In the essence, the divine perfections remain distinct *a natura rei et formaliter* within the core of its unity.

B Simplicity of the divine essence

The very structure of the Scotus proofs of the First’s existence testifies to the absolute unity of his essence. If we can establish, by the path followed by Duns Scotus, that the infinite being exists, then in such a being existence belongs to the concept of essence, *existentia est de conceptu essentiae*. The First is the being such that, if he is possible, he exists. As for the

determinations involved in the proof, they are always immediately reduced by Duns Scotus to the unity of the divine essence, as in the case of the intellect or the will, unless, like infinity, they are directly posited as simple modes of their essence. So far, nothing permits us to anticipate that the problem must raise any particularly thorny difficulty. Still, there is at least one, which entails others in its turn, to such a degree that we can ask whether here we have not entered the area in which the important division will take place within the Scotist school that will split it until the end of the Middle Ages. In the measure that Duns Scotus takes God's unity for granted, he posits it as absolute, and of course he never allows the smallest fissure to be introduced there. But things change a bit from the moment when Scotus, not satisfied with affirming the divine essence's perfect internal unity, undertakes to demonstrate it.

The problem forces itself upon the theologian's attention even at the level of natural knowledge, as soon as he considers the relation of the divine attributes to God's essence. For the divine essence to be absolutely one, it must be absolutely *simple*. Consequently, simplicity is an attribute of God. There would be no difficulty in this, if this attribute meant that the divine essence has no attributes. However, the difficulty is extraordinary if it means that the perfect simplicity of the divine essence is the perfect unity of a multiplicity of different attributes, as is the case for every Christian philosopher. Either these attributes are distinct, and the essence is not one, or else they are not distinct, and the essence has no attributes. This problem is not peculiar to Scotism, but we will have to consider it under the particular guise it takes in a metaphysics where the concept of being is what it is in Duns Scotus.

The first phase of the discussion involves the fewest new difficulties. Really, it does not involve any because the point is to establish that God is supremely and perfectly simple without bringing in the subsequent problem of the predictability of attributes. In other words, considering the concept of infinite being taken alone and it itself, can we prove the First's perfect simplicity? We can, and Duns Scotus could, even do so immediately starting

from this concept alone, but he begins by eliminating certain complications from the divine essence, which we might be tempted to introduce into it, after which he will prove directly that the First is simple by virtue of his infinity and his necessity.

The first composition to be eliminated is that of matter and form. Matter and form are two of the four kinds of causes, but these kinds of causality are such that they necessarily imply some imperfections, because they are only causes *qua* essential parts of the being that they constitute. The same does not hold for efficient causality or final causality, whose concepts imply no imperfection. On the contrary, an efficient cause is necessary to produce the composition of matter and form. If the First were composed of matter and form, an efficient cause of this composition would be required. This could not be itself, because nothing produces itself by uniting its matter to its form. Consequently, there would be a previous efficient cause. But then the First would not be the first efficient cause, which we have proved it is. Accordingly, the First is not composed of matter and form.[20]

Nor is the First composed of quantitative parts. Moreover, in Aristotle's *Physics* and *Metaphysics*, he himself seems to have already seen that an *infinite* power could not be a *magnitude*.[21] Indeed, an *infinite magnitude* is impossible. Therefore, if the First's power is infinite, it cannot be a magnitude itself nor be composed of quantitative parts as magnitude is. Still, Aristotle's argument does not seem conclusive, because it supposes that the power of a magnitude must necessarily be conceived as proportional to this magnitude. Perhaps that is not necessary. We could conceive an infinite power that is homogeneous in itself, which is completely in each part of the magnitude under consideration, as the soul is completely within each part of the body it animates. Therefore, the argument Aristotle uses must be employed differently. Let us start from the conclusion previously established by him, namely that the First Mover is an immaterial being. If that is the case, the infinity of its power is not tied to any extension in the order of magnitude or of quantity. Consequently, it is not one of those powers that, by belonging to a quantity, grow or diminish with it. In other words, the First's power is

not *extensively* finite, that is to say, its efficacy whose intensity is not linked to any finite magnitude, because it is infinite, and since there is no infinite magnitude, an *intensively* infinite power could not belong to any magnitude whatsoever. Accordingly, Duns Scotus's proof rests on the distinction between two infinites, one extensive the other intensive. Divine power is infinity in the order of *intensity*. If every magnitude is finite of itself, no power whose intensity is infinite will be linked to a magnitude. So, the First's being does not have quantitative parts, because its magnitude is not that of a quantity.[22] In short, the concept of an intensively infinite power as a *magnitude* is contradictory and impossible.

It follows from that that the First cannot be composed of subject and accident. Since it is neither material nor of the order of *quantum*, it can receive no material accidents, which correspond only to objects that are material themselves. Therefore, the First could only receive accidents that correspond to spiritual beings, intellection and volition for example. But in proving the existence of the First, we have been made to see that, in the First, intellection and will are its proper substance.[23] Therefore, they could not be accidents whose subject would be the First himself.

With these different compositions eliminated in this manner, we can prove divine simplicity directly, that is, by establishing generally that his very nature excludes any composition.

First of all, this is because the First is the necessary being. Let us suppose that the necessary being is composed. Let us designate the composite elements by the letters A and B. We first ask whether A is a necessary being formally and of itself or if it is only possible being. If A is merely possible being, the necessary being will be composed of possible and necessary, such that it will no longer be necessary of itself. If A is necessary being, it is supremely actual of itself and cannot be united to anything else to form a composite with it that is intrinsically one, *unum per se*. Let us add that if A and B were both necessary being, their composite would be twice necessary, and that it would be so in each case by virtue of a component whose omission would not change its necessity at all, which is absurd.[24]

We next prove that the First is simple because it is the infinite being. It cannot enter into the composition of another thing as a part or be composed itself. The first hypothesis is impossible, because being part is less than the whole. The infinite cannot be less than anything. Therefore, the infinite cannot play the role of a part. The second hypothesis is no less impossible, because if the finite is composed, it is composed of finite or finite components. If its components are infinite, they cannot enter into composition, as we have just proved. If they are finite, he himself will not be infinite, because there cannot be composition of the infinite in the sense of intensive infinity of perfection in being, which is the issue here.[25]

Since such simplicity is linked to the First's necessity and infinity, it does not belong to any creature. This thesis was not at all new, and in book I, distinction 8 of the *Sentences*, Peter Lombard already points it out in Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book VI, chapter 6. Before Duns Scotus, certain theologians had looked for the lack of ontological simplicity, which every creature suffers, in the composition of matter and form. St. Bonaventure can be cited among the representatives of this school. Taking an entirely different path, Thomas Aquinas reduced the fundamental composition of created being to that of its essence and its existence. It is remarkable that in the *Opus Oxoniense* Duns Scotus neglects both of these solutions. He does not even speak of them to refute them. It is understandable that he passed over the doctrine of hylemorphic composition of spiritual creatures in silence. No doubt it seemed philosophically obsolete to him.[26] But we may lament the lack of a direct critique of the composition of essence and existence, because it would have been highly instructive regarding the Scotist doctrine of the existent. There is something mysterious in Duns Scotus's attitude about this point, and we do not know how to explain it. Did he see the key role of the concept of *esse* in Thomism, and did he attribute such importance to it that he postponed the moment of giving a thorough explanation about it? Or, as is probable, did Duns Scotus calmly follow his own path with no care for a position that seemed unintelligible to him? One hesitates between these two hypotheses but perhaps the question is beyond the limits of history and stems

from the thinker's individual psychology, about which we can suppose anything, because we do not know it.

In any case, it is certain that Duns Scotus implicitly eliminates the Thomist solution of the problem by rejecting the composition of potency and act in the created as insufficient. Indeed, in the measure in which the Thomist composition of essence and existence is a particular case of the composition of potency and act, we can say that the former is involved in the elimination of the latter. It is a fact that Duns Scotus does not situate the fundamental composition of created being in the composition of act and potency, unless we understand the composition, as he states it himself, as the fundamental composition of created being. That to which Duns Scotus is attached here is precisely a composition of act and potency known, to use the terminology of one of his interpreters, as of beings really distinct from each other, *tanquam entitatibus inter se realiter distinctis*.[27] By that we should understand that in every creature there are not necessarily two distinct realities, one of which is potency and the other act. For example, a certain light can be perfectly pure, *qua* act of lighting, although it has limited intensity. Its actuality is not impure in the sense that some positive entity other than light is mixed into it. Consequently, it does not suffer from an impurity of essence, but a lack of intensity, which is only a variation of modality.[28] If Duns Scotus understood the Thomist conception of essence and existence as a particular case of composition of potency and act, itself understood as a composition of two distinct entities, it could be maintained that he implicitly eliminated it here.

However this may be, Duns Scotus's own position is clear. He admits unreservedly that the First alone is pure act, but he does not thereby admit that every creature is *composed of things*. Certain creatures are simple, in the sense that they themselves are not things composed of several other *things*. The difference that separates finite things from the First is that no creature is perfectly simple, because they are all composed or suited to enter into composition with others: composed or composable, *composita* or *composibilis*.[29] Here Duns Scotus follows exactly along the axis of his metaphysics. The infinite alone is essentially simple, because it is

uncombinable, and not just uncombined. It excludes the very possibility of an addition. Every finite can be added to another, and something can always be added to it. The accident combines with the substance. In corporeal substance, matter combines with forms, and the immaterial substance itself combines with an accident. It needs that for its proper perfection as we see in the case of the most perfect Separate Intelligences, who only enjoy their beatitude because they are capable of beatifying intellection and volition. This intellection and this volition are not their substance; otherwise they would be formally beatific by themselves. Therefore, they are accidents in those Separated Intelligences.

Not only does every creature combine with others, but also it is open to composition by its very finitude. As we have said, creatures do not always combine actually with another created thing, but certainly with the being the creature lacks *qua* finite, or in other words, with the privation within it: therefore it is not composed of two positive things but of a positive thing and a privation, *componitur igitur, non ex re et re positivis, sed ex re positiva et privatione*. Let us understand the Subtle Doctor here. No creature possesses being in the total perfection of which being itself is capable. The creature always lacks certain perfection compatible with being, which amounts to saying that it is deficient precisely insofar as we consider it in the line of being. An example from Aristotle can clarify this specification. We say that the mole is blind, because it could have sight as animal, although it may not have it *qua* mole.[30] In the same way, every finite being, even if it suffers no privation, *qua* being of a determined species, nevertheless *qua* being remains lacking of all the being it is not. Therefore, it is not composed of two things but of the positive thing it is and of the lack of a certain degree of perfection of being. This particular being is not capable of that further degree of perfection that it lacks, but being itself is capable of it, just as the mole cannot see *qua* mole, but could see *qua* animal. This composition of positive *being* and *privation of being* entails no composition in the thing's essence itself, because privation is not a constituent of the essence of any being, but it entails a composition of act and *objective potency*. Indeed, every being

lacking a certain perfection in the order of being is simply *possible* in regard to the being that it is not. Consequently, just as finite being is composed of being and privation, so also it is composed of act and objective potency. This objective potency corresponds to the lack of *entitative* perfection (i.e., to the lack of being) which makes it a finite being. Indeed, *if we take it precisely insofar as being*, not insofar as *such being*, its actuality is composed of the possible it could be and that it is not.[31]

We cannot help being struck by the personal and, as far as we know, solitary character of the road taken by Duns Scotus, but the parallel between his approach and St. Thomas's is striking. Scotus's God, who is infinite being, *ens infinitum*, takes his simplicity from his infinity, as Thomas's God, who is *Esse*, owes his simplicity to the purity of his act of being. Just as Thomas Aquinas did not yield to the easy options of hylemorphism, Duns Scotus does not yield to what for him would have been the easy option of the Thomist distinction of essence and existence. He rejects any radical composition of created being other than what he can find in the finitude of that being as he conceives it. If we may say so, there is a certain quantity of real essence or, if one prefers, a certain quantity of being, which would change real essence if being were added to it or subtracted from it. Some of these beings include matter, but others do not. Accordingly, the composition of matter and form does not constitute the finite as such. In so far as they are real, all these beings exist, but their existence is only a modality of their essence. Therefore, we cannot situate what characterizes finite being as such in a real composition of essence and existence. If a composition of the finite exists that is linked to its very nature of finite, it is, consequently, what could be called in Platonic terms the composition of the same and the other. The limit that the essence posits by defining what it is always implies the corresponding privation of what it is not. Let us observe that it is precisely this privation that makes the finite essence a pure *possible*. For, when there is not privation, there is no limit. Then we enter into the infinite and at the same time into the necessary, because, as it is the totality of being, no place remains in it for any possibility.[32]

However, the very manner in which Duns Scotus contrasts the inner complexity of created being with the pure simplicity of the First Being makes difficult, not to say impossible at first sight, any predication related to God's essence. This is not a frivolously contrived aporia, because the Subtle Doctor formulated it himself, and it could hardly have escaped him. From the instant when he established the univocity of being, he foresaw and said that if being ought to be held univocal to God and creatures, all divine attributes must be likewise univocal for the same reason. But if the First's being is absolutely simple, not only is it hard to see how the different attributes can be predicated of it, but also we no longer see how it is at all possible to attribute being to him. God, we say, is superlatively simple, in which we know he is radically different from every creature. If he is at once simple in himself and radically different from the rest, how will we find in him anything *common* with creatures? But if no concept *common* to God and creatures can be found, not only do any divine attributes become inconceivable in this doctrine, but the First's perfect simplicity puts the very univocity of being in question.[33]

From Duns Scotus's own point of view, this difficulty is only an illusion. Despite the specifications he has untiringly multiplied, the Subtle Doctor sees the same mistake about the meaning of his doctrine reappear each time he applies it anew. Perhaps that simply expresses the spontaneous resistance of thought to the effort of reaching the superlative level of abstraction that a metaphysics of *common nature* requires. Conceiving *natures* as such is to conceive pure *formal reasons* taken in themselves, whereas thought consistently tends to conceive them in the individuals where they exist. For example, when Duns Scotus affirms that the concept of being is *formally neutral* and consequently that it is indifferent to the concepts of *created* or *uncreated*, he faces the objection that being itself is not neutral, since it is necessarily created or uncreated. That could not be truer, and it is what Duns Scotus teaches explicitly. Every existing *animal* is endowed with reason or is not endowed with reason, which does not prevent the concept *animal* from not including *formally* either the concept of *rational* or the concept of *irrational*. Let us add that it does not exclude them either. Let us repeat that it

is *neutral* with regard to them, and in exactly the same way the concept of being is both common and neutral to the created as to the uncreated, although every real being is creature or creator.[34] Accordingly, it cannot be held that concepts *common* to the creator and the creature are incompatible with God's perfect simplicity, because it is quite true that God and creature are immediately and irreducibly different, to such a degree that the reality of one has nothing in common with the reality of the other, but that does not prevent the concept of being from designating a formal reason common to these beings that *really* have nothing in common.[35]

The very possibility of the divine attributes depends directly on this point. In order to establish it definitively, Dun Scotus must eliminate any possible confusion regarding the meaning of univocity. That being is not a genus was a commonplace among thirteenth-century theologians. The proposition could invoke Aristotle,[36] and it was enough to recall it to establish that, although God is being, he is not himself one of the genera of being. Duns Scotus cites Avicenna on this point both because of his authority, and because of the reason upon which he based his thesis. Avicenna had explicitly denied that God was being in the sense that he was included within the genus *being*. Indeed, the genus of a being is an essential part of that being, the very thing that the specific difference and then the individuality will determine. But God is simple. Thus, he has no part or, consequently, genus. If we can say he has being, it cannot be attributed to him as a genus.[37]

Accordingly, Duns Scotus did not have to pose a new problem here or to find a new solution, but he at least had to seek a new justification for this old answer. Finding it was indispensable to him, because, if a doctrine of analogy cannot be accused of situating God in the common being of a genus, by contrast, the doctrine of univocity of being provokes this objection almost irresistibly. How is being not a *common* genus in a doctrine where being is said in the same sense of everything that is?

If we look closely, however, the objection brings us back to something difficult to distinguish from the objection we just rejected. It confuses the common concept of being with the real subjects of which it is predicated.

Moreover, this is what Duns Scotus already suggested by saying, from the very instant when he proved the univocity of being, that this concept cannot designate a genus, because it is too *common* for that. We understand him instantly here. By virtue of its total *commonality*, being is posited prior to the order of this particular being, which is in the genus and about which, consequently, a genus can be predicated. At the moment when the metaphysician's intellect conceives being, he still does not know whether there are genera or whether there are not. If he knows, he does not think about it. How could being be a genus, even though it does not itself include the notion?

It is enough to see the moment at which *genus* appears to be assured that this is certainly how things stand. As Avicenna said, every genus is in a being as a part. Consequently, there is only *genus* where there is composition, that is, in the order of finite being. From the instant we are in the finite, we have left *common* being, whose perfect commonality itself makes it neutral and, as it were, indifferent to the finite and the infinite. In other words, the common notion of being is indifferent to the notion of finite, which itself cannot be indifferent to the notion of genus. A concept indifferent to something to which the concept of genus is not indifferent cannot be the concept of a genus. Such, precisely, is the notion of *being*. If it is applied to God's being, it is no longer the concept of being but the concept of *infinite* being. If it is applied to *created being*, it is no longer the concept of being, but the concept of *finite* being, which, indeed, inters into a genus. Accordingly, to be applied to God and creature in common, to the finite as to the finite, this concept must be limited strictly to *being* as such, in request to which the problem of genus cannot yet be posed.[38]

The argument's eminently Scotist character shines out before our eyes. What makes it impossible that being should be a genus is that it is susceptible of *infinity*. Without the compatibility, or better the deep affinity, of the notions of *infinite* and *being*, we do not see why being is not a genus. But God is infinite. Like *esse* in Thomas Aquinas, in Duns Scotus *infinitas* tends to consume the divine essence. It is so coessential and singularly

characteristic of the divine essence that to name one is practically to name the other. All essential reality in God is *formally* infinite, and, since no reality in God is in potency in regard to another, no composition is possible in God, not even the composition of potency and act, which, though the least of all, would be enough to ground a composition of genus and species.[39] No place remains for the *genus* in an essence whose very singularity stems from its infinity.

The solution Duns Scotus proposes holds for the attribution of being, but does it resolve the problem in what concerns attributes predicated of the divine being itself? We may wonder. Moreover, the Subtle Doctor posed the question. Granting that *being* is not said of God as a genus, is it agreed that the same goes for attributes like *good*, *wise*, and so on? Yes, it does and for the same reason, however it may seem at first. Since all genera are included in finite being, being is divided into finite and infinite before being involved in the division into genera. Everything that is said of being prior to the first of its divisions thus corresponds to it insofar as indifferent to the finite and the infinite, and, therefore, for the same reason, insofar as transcendent and *outside any genus*. This is precisely the *transcendence* that we have already recognized in the divine attributes. Everything that corresponds to being *qua* indifferent to the finite and the infinite is common to God and to creatures. *Goodness* and *wisdom* belong to this order. Insofar as they correspond to God, they are infinite. Insofar as they correspond to creatures, they are finite. Accordingly, they correspond to being prior to its division into the Aristotle's ten genera. In short, all the attributes of this order are transcendent.[40]

Doubtless we thereby see better to what extent Duns Scotus's theology implies the *commonality* of being. This commonality permits our intellect, using only the natural concepts of which it disposes, to find a certain number of concepts that are applied properly and directly to God, although none of them is the proper concept of God. Let us not forget that Duns Scotus's natural theology begins by being assigned precise limits. It deals with the subject *God*, grasped under the species of the object *infinite being*, which itself is attained at the end of a metaphysics of common being. But the natural

theology has assigned those limits in order to provide a foundation, because within these limits, it is the most resolutely positive thing that could be conceived.[41]

By elevating these essential attributes of God to the level of the transcendent, this theology ultimately assures the possibility of maintaining a plurality of such attribute without endangering the perfect simplicity of the divine essence. At first glance, it could seem that univocity must make the undertaking impossible. For, to become *common* to God and the creature, a concept would first have to draw out the *common* part from God's essence, which has no parts, and it is clear that, thanks precisely to univocity, the attributes are pushed back beyond the point where their concept would be applied in a determined way to God or creatures. Since the only commonality that the attributes possess is the commonality of their primitive indifference, it implies no withdrawal of a part performed upon an essence to which the attributes have not yet been applied. Goodness is only goodness. Wisdom is only wisdom. When it becomes necessary to determine these attributes in order to apply them to God or creatures they will not be treated as genera determinable from the outside, but as formal entities determinable from within by their proper modality.

When we are dealing with the divine essence, its proper modality is infinity. Since certain developments within the Scotist school force the problem upon the historian's attention to the point where soon we will have to ask what can explain them in Duns Scotus's own body of work, the moment has come to cite all those passages from Scotus where the intense sense of divine unity that move Scotus is perhaps best expressed with the abstract vehemence that characterizes him. Asking whether it can be said that in *infinite being*, despite everything, being is in potency in regard to the infinite and whether it is not necessary at least to conceive it as this being, *hoc ens*, before conceiving it as *infinitum*, Scotus responds:

> When some being is of itself the being that it is and is not merely capable of receiving this being, it also has, of itself, all the conditions necessarily

> required to be. Now such being corresponds to God; that is, by essence he is the infinite being itself and not that to which it only corresponds to be infinite. This is why, since he, of himself, is what he is, he is infinite of himself, almost as if we ought to conceive infinity as a mode of being by essence before conceiving it itself as that which it is. Therefore, it is not necessary to ask why the being is infinity, as if simplicity corresponded to it before infinity.[42]

In short, concludes Duns Scotus, if we are dealing with a being that is by essence and not by participation, then it is of himself both that he is this way by essence, that is infinite, and that he is this very individual that he is.

The passage is admirably vigorous. Yet, the abstract passion that inspires it also makes it somewhat mysterious. We can wonder whether, alongside the firmest profession of faith in the divine essence's indestructible unity that Duns Scotus bequeathed to us, the text does not also contain a temptation, which will later attract the minds of some of Scotus's disciples. The intention that guides Scotus is perfectly clear. So to speak, he does not want us to conceive the divine essence as receiving two complementary determinations from outside, namely singularity and infinity. In particular, he does not want God the individual to be conceived as a subject upon whom infinity would supervene in his essence, even if it were eternally. On the contrary, with an "as if," *quasi* and an "in some way," *aliquo modo*, Scotus makes infinity precede singularity to reestablish the divine essence's endangered simplicity, not in order to substitute another order for the order of divine modalities that he refuses to accept.[43] If Duns Scotus does not admit that singularity belongs to the divine essence before infinity (unless we force the text), we cannot make him maintain that infinity belongs to this essence before singularity. In any case, he does not say so, and the actual conclusion of his text implies rather the contrary. It is of itself that such a being is by essence, that he is infinite, and that he is this peculiar being that he is. Still, when everything is said and done, the fact remains that Duns Scotus suggested conceiving infinity of essence in God before his singularity. If we wanted at all costs to imagine an order among divine modalities, Scotus seems to tell his adversary,

it would be *rather* that one.

Who would dream of being surprised? In a doctrine in which infinity is the properly divine modality of being, we can see nothing that could precede infinity in God's essence. Evidently, what Duns Scotus himself thinks is that nothing precedes anything in this perfectly simple essence, but he does not foresee that he would have disciples, or that a Scotist school would be born out of a teaching as personal as his. We see him advance step by step through the *Opus Oxoniense*; he prudently proposes solutions of whose novelty he is aware;[44] he obtains confirmation in the measure in which he puts the solutions to the test and weighs the objections that arise between two lectures during his actual teaching.[45] This tireless seeker, whose course notes seem to be before us, became the prey of a posterity for which he was not writing, because he did not foresee it.

There has been no lack of serious thinkers among those who have invoked Scotus's doctrine, except that, as is the rule with all schools, the master's disciples take his doctrine itself as their object of study and no longer the problem the doctrine attempted to resolve. From that point on, they think about his thought rather than thinking about the relation of this thought to what is real. A given solution proposed by the master becomes a problem in its turn, and certain of them are endlessly discussed for their own sakes, forgetting almost completely the problem whose solutions they were. For the historian who prophesizes infallibly about the past, it is an almost irresistible temptation to prove that the school had to emerge from the doctrine. At least it could emerge, since it did, and it does not exceed the limitations of history to observe that.

C The doctrine of divine attributes

Perhaps the easiest way to see how the Scotist school came out of Duns Scotus can best be seen by examining the long deferred but ultimately inevitable problem of the possible basis of the distinction of the divine attributes. Let us grant the Subtle Doctor that we can univocally attribute

being to God without endangering the divine essence's simplicity. Moreover, let us likewise grant, as Scotus's principles demand, that every essential attribute transcends the order of genus and consequently transcends the order of finite being. It still remains for us to ask how the essential attributes can be distinct from each other and nevertheless find a basis for their distinction in the perfectly simple essence of which they are predicated. The problem is posed with an urgency it did not have in Thomas Aquinas's doctrine. There, it was impossible for anything to be predicated univocally of God and creatures, and the only manner of communality, *modus communitatis* acknowledged between creator and creature was that of analogy.[46] To ground the distinction of divine attributes it sufficed to admit that they signify the first principle of things itself, insofar as that which each of them signifies *preexists in it* in a mode too eminent for us to be able to conceive it or express it.[47] The problem of their unity in God is swamped in the very wave of the knowledge we have of it. By contrast, here in Scotism, the problem is posed with rigorous precision. From the very fact that each attribute is a transcendental, each attribute designates a distinct *quiddity* whose *formal reason* is separately conceivable. On the other hand, Duns Scotus teaches that each attribute is univocally and positively predicated of the divine essence. Therefore, it is certainly necessary to admit that the formal reason of the distinct attributes here are distinctly present in this essence. In other words, it is no longer enough to admit with Thomas Aquinas that the distinction of attributes has a *fundamentum in re* in the eminent perfection of the divine being. It must be admitted that each distinct attribute finds this real foundation in a distinct formal reason within the core of God's very essence. Henceforth, the question is how to save the simplicity of this essence.

The concept of *formal distinction* through which Scotus obtains the whole answer, appears for the first time tentatively and allowing for a better answer, *sine assertione et praejudicio sententiae melioris,* in order to explain that the divine essence, which is one, is not *made plural* by the Trinity of persons. With a view to resolving this purely theological problem, Duns Scotus proposes to admit a distinction between the *essentia* and the three *supposita*,

or more exactly between the formal reason of the divine essence and the formal reason of the three *supposita* in question. For the distinction contemplated to be capable of rendering expected service, it is necessary that "there should be some distinction between the reason by which the complete subject or *suppositum* is formally incommunicable and the reason of the essence *qua* essence, which precedes every act of the created and uncreated intellect."[48] The sentence is remarkable in every way, but particularly in its last clause. There is formal distinction only if it can be conceived as preceding every act of the created and uncreated intellects, *praecedens omnem actum intellectus creati et increati*. Obviously, we are not dealing with temporal priority here, but Duns Scotus means that the formally distinct is not formally distinct by virtue of an act of knowledge that sets it apart from the rest. It is distinct of itself. Accordingly, it does not have to be distinguished by thought to become distinct.

Duns Scotus first introduces this distinction in the context of a problem that does not come under philosophy, but the distinction does not change its nature by being extended to the realm of metaphysics from which, furthermore, it is clear that it emerges.[49] Of what does it consist? Let us consider any formal object, for example, the concept *human*. It can be conceived in two different ways from the grammatical point of view: human being, of the human being, *homo*, *hominis*. Consequently, there is a first distinction in the intellect insofar as two grammatical forms of the same name are conceived as distinct. If the logician conceives the same distinction, it will take the form human being-humanity, *homo-humanitas*, it will always be two ways of conceiving the same object. The formal object is more emphatic than the previous one, because it only exists in the understanding when it distinguishes, through two acts, *two formal objects*. It may be that two distinct beings correspond to two acts in the case where I conceive human and donkey,[50] but we are going to see that this is not necessary, since the presence of two distinct formal reasons in the same object is enough to ground this distinction.

Whatever the case may be on this past point, it is clear that the formal

distinction is based on the distinction of formal objects, and since the formal distinction *precedes every act of the intellect* it can only be a real distinction. It is indeed that, but it is the smallest distinction of this kind: minimal in its order, that is among everything that precedes intellection, *minima in suo ordine, id est inter omnes que praecedunt intellectionem*.[51] Scotus finds no accepted type of distinction whose name exactly fits what he wants to define here. We can call it a real distinction, but it is not a real distinction strictly speaking, because the latter ordinarily supposes that at least one of its terms designates an actually existing being separate from what the other term designates. It can be called a distinction of reason, provided that *ratio* here designates the thing's quiddity itself, in which case we are rather dealing with a distinction of *reasons*. This is why, asking up the problem at its root, Duns Scotus prefers to start from a general classification of the degrees of unity in the hope that an exact determination of the unity that grounds formal identify as such will allow him to measure the difference that springs from the lack of unity.

The first and lowest degree of unity is that which comes out of the *group*, for example, the unity of objects put in a pile and simply collected (*unitas aggregationis*). It supposes that the collection is not pure and simple juxtaposition but that each of the parts in it occupies a place that is explicable by virtue of a certain principle. Higher still comes the unity by accident (*unitas per accidens*). Now we are no longer dealing with a simple relation of order but with the unity of something determined and of the form that determines it. If its form is accidental, we obtain the unity by accident of which we are speaking. If this form is substantial, we obtain higher unity than the previous one, which stems from the essential principles of being. It is strict unity (*unitas per se*). Above this last unity that is to say, beyond the unity of composition as unity of order, comes the unity of what is simple (*unitas simplicitatis*). Here we are dealing with genuine identity, because within what is simple anything is the same thing as anything. We might think we have reached the end of this hierarchy, but not at all. Beyond all these unities, Duns Scotus adds, *formal identity* is found, where the identity

includes the identical in its formal reason itself, that is to say, immediately, intrinsically.[52] It suffices to reverse this formal distinction, because where the first is missing, we have the second. What is formally distinct from something is not "identical to it by inclusion in its formal reason." So, there is certainly *formal distinction*, or as Duns Scotus sometimes prefers to put it, *formal non-identity*, everywhere that two quiddities are found whose formal reasons are irreducible to each other. Thereafter, our problem is to know whether a formal distinction thus understood can be reconciled with God's simplicity.

Duns Scotus experiences no doubt as to the existence of formally distinct essential perfections in God. Let us say more: he is not even convinced that those who affirm the opposite really think so. Some of them certainly think that relations between divine attributes are not more than relations of reason. Still, Duns Scotus observes with humor:

> What good is it to fill so many books in order to deduce attributes from each other, if their relations are reduced to simple distinctions of reason? If that were the case, God would also have to be perfectly known, in regard to every real knowledge or every real concept that we can have of him, whether he is known under just one of his attributes or he is known under all his attributes, because knowing more relations of reason, regarding any subject, does not make the real knowledge we have of it more perfect.[53]

Whatever philosophical significance we give it, the psychological value of the jest is considerable. It is sometimes said that certain people, who are Thomists when they teach, are Molinists when they preach. In any case, it is certain in Duns Scotus's view that those who teach that the divine attributes are analogous imagine them as univocal.

Here Duns Scotus has the merit of imagining as he thinks. He absolutely refuses to admit that there is any other distinction between the divine attributes than what stems from different manners of conceiving one and the same formal object. The essential perfections of God are not simply the same divine essence conceived by us according to different modes. Let us say

more; they are not distinguished only as formal objects *distinct in our understanding*. For, if it were so, the fact that we distinguish God's attributes in our thoughts would not prevent their really being merged in God and being interchangeable there or formally identical. They would be synonyms, something however that is denied.[54] We must affirm more. God is the absolutely perfect being, or else he would not be the being such that nothing greater can be conceived. If God is absolutely perfect, he possesses all perfections, and they are infinite in him. For them to be that in him, they must not be in him only as objects of knowledge, but as existing objects. Accordingly, unless we suppose that there really exist perfections in an imperfect creature, which would only exist ideally in the supremely perfect being, it must be admitted that everything that is finite perfection in the creature, is infinite perfection in God.[55] Let us understand by this that these perfections are really there in themselves, because any other way of understanding that they are there practically amounts to saying that they are not there. If wisdom is in God, it is there as wisdom. If goodness is in God, it is there as goodness. Real wisdom is not *formally* real goodness. Accordingly, it must be admitted that wisdom, goodness, and all the other essential attributes, since they *are* in God, are there in the only way they could be there; that is to say, as formally distinct.

Perhaps it will be objected that, since everything in God is infinite and since the divine attributes are infinite, everything will be equally merged into a single thing that is infinity itself. That would be to forget that infinity is not an attribute of God but the peculiar mode (properly speaking) of the divine essence. What the essence's infinity entails is that everything that belongs to this essence is infinite. Therefore, God's wisdom is infinite; God's goodness is likewise infinite; and both are so by virtue of the infinity of the divine essence itself. It still does not follow that infinite wisdom is *formally* infinite goodness. As Duns Scotus says very clearly: "Infinity does not destroy the formal reason of that to which it is added, because in whatever degree we consider a perfection, provided that it is a degree of the same perfection, the formal reason of the perfection is not removed by the degree."[56] In other

words, infinity does not belong to the formal reason of any attribute as such. If it did, it would be included in the definition of each of them, and then there would only be infinite wisdom or infinite goodness, which is manifestly false. Accordingly, the fact that wisdom like God's is infinite cannot make infinity be included in wisdom's formal reason. The *formal non-identity* of wisdom, goodness, and other attributes therefore subsists intact in the divine essence despite their infinity.[57]

The thorniest point remains. How is this distinction, or if we prefer, this formal *non-identity*, compatible with divine simplicity? At the moment when Duns Scotus poses the problem in relation to the divine attributes, he has already solved it in regard to the Father's properties when studying the dogma of the Trinity. The fact that Scotus takes refuge here behind that previous demonstration, which undoubtedly falls under theology, shows well to what point the same method holds for Scotus in both realms. Consequently, let us first note that, if we were expounding Duns Scotus's theology here for its own sake, we would simply say that the compatibility of the divine simplicity with the formal distinction of the Father's two *properties*, *unbegottennness* and *paternity*, guarantees a fortiori the compatibility of the divine essence's simplicity with the formal distinction of its attributes.[58]

We seem to find a solution by posing the same question in a slightly different form: how do God's attributes come to be *formally* distinct if they are *really* identical by virtue of God's absolute simplicity? Duns Scotus develops his response to this question while eliminating the formidable objection that could be drawn from a famous passage of Augustine: "Wisdom and justice are two qualities in creatures, but not in God, because what is justice itself in him is also goodness."[59] Indeed, this is the chief argument that Scotus must eliminate and it is a weighty argument, less by reason of Augustine's authority than for the certain truth it contains, explicitly taught by Duns Scotus himself: everything in God is identically one and the same being, God's being.

The Subtle Doctor proposes a solution that perhaps may be ranked among

the deepest and most original creations of this powerful mind. Here, he can only create or retreat before a problem that his metaphysics of being renders both inevitable and, it seemed, unsolvable. Two apparently contradictory truths, but both certainties, have to be harmonized because, on Scotus's view, it is equally certain that to predicate anything of God is to predicate the identical of the identical, and that to predicate any two essential attributes of God is to attribute two formally distinct attributes to him. How can both these, whose own truths are beyond doubt, be true?

The fact is, Duns Scotus thinks, that our understanding only disposes of one logic, that of formal identity. It is the logic of created being that is appropriate to speak of created beings. Formal identity is the only kind we know, and we cannot know any other, because we only know finite beings, whose identity is indeed tied to that of their proper formal reasons. As we are going to see, the same does not hold for God. Two logics of predication are unheard of in the order of creatures, one that would be true in the formal order (*alia formaliter vera*), while the other that would be true *by identity* (*et alia per identitatem*). What we have to show is that in divine things (*in divinis*) there can be a predication that is true by identity, which, however, is not formal predication.

"In my opinion, the reason for this difference is the following." The *ut puto* certainly seems to warn us that the Subtle Doctor enters into uncharted territory that he himself has not fully explored. However that may be, here is that reason. Let us conceive anything abstract. Taken in the last degree of abstraction,[60] it is conceived as a quiddity without relation to anything but what its proper formal reason of quiddity includes. Let us recall the adage: humanity is just humanity, *humanitas est humanitas tantum*. In a metaphysical world where essences, understood in this way rule, the mind inevitably comes up against the problem of their relations. Separated one from the others by their very purity, they are incapable of communicating or, rather, the fact that they are themselves and nothing else prevents them from doing so. This is what Duns Scotus saw and stated admirably:

> If the terms [of propositions] are conceived in this manner, there will never be truth in their union unless, to be exact, the quiddity of one of the two is the same as the quiddity of the other term. Now, this does not happen in creatures, because when we abstract the realities that are in the same subject, for instance those of genus and difference, and if we consider them with complete precision, each of them is finite and neither of the two is perfectly identical to the other. At present they are not found to be identical among themselves, except by reason of a third term to which they are identical This is even why, when we abstract from this third term, no reason remains to hold them to be identical, and the cause of the truth of the proposition that united the two terms disappears.[61]

In other words, such essences taken under the abstract formal reason of pure quiddities cannot directly communicate because of the *finite* character of each of them. In a finite being, the essence has the unique function of distinguishing the quantity of perfection that specifies it as such. On account of that, we said, every finite being is composed of act and privation, and the formal reason that makes it be what it is just by that prevents it from being something else. That can be verified here since, if every definition is given by genus and difference, that is precisely because the genus *is not* the difference and inversely. It is true that humans are rational animals, but *animality* is not rationality. When we push formal abstraction as far as possible, we end in terms that are not really identical, one of which can no longer be predicated of the other. That could only be, if one if the two terms were held to be identical among themselves as being identical to a third *from which they are abstracted*. In the example used, they are abstracted from the term *human*, and it is certainly necessary to abstract them from it to obtain ultimate formal quiddities, but the very abstraction that liberates them into this pure state suppresses the cause of the affirmative truth that unites them.

Consequently, the finite nature of the created makes it inevitable that any true predicate relative to creatures should be simultaneously true in the formal *order* and in the order of identity. It is quite different in God, because the divine essence is infinite, and everything that participates in this essence

participates in its infinity. In Scotism, at the level of the divine essence, the role of link for essences, which *esse* plays in Thomism, will once again belong to *infinity*. Let us note, furthermore, that here Duns Scotus in no way contradicts what he teaches elsewhere regarding the purely *modal* character of infinity. On the contrary, it is this very characteristic that allows infinity to untangle the metaphysical situation that might well be said to have no solution otherwise. Because *infinity* is a modality of being, it can be communicable to quidditatively irreducible formal reasons and confer *identity in being* upon them without suppressing their *distinction in formality*. This is why the simultaneous usage of two logics will be necessary here, one where the predication of identity will be true of being, whereas the other will attribute to this being, with complete truthfulness, quiddities as formally distinct that we otherwise know to be *ontologically* identical.

Let us take an example. If we abstract wisdom and goodness in the created, we obtain two ultimate essences, neither of which can communicate with any other, because, since each of them is ontologically finite, it cannot be anything other than what its formal reason makes it be. If we abstract wisdom and goodness in God, the situation is completely distinct. “Abstracting from everything that is alien to the formal reason of each of them, each of these quiddities, taken precisely as such remains formally infinite.” It is formally infinite *qua* being and by virtue of the divine essence’s infinity, although, “since infinity is the reason of the identity of the two terms, their identity persists despite their state of total abstraction. For their identity was not precisely because of identity to a third term from which they had been abstracted, but rather because of the formal unity of each of them.”[62] Thus, it is still true to say with St. Augustine that God’s wisdom *is* his justice, but it is no less true to say with Duns Scotus that *what is* God’s wisdom is not what is his justice, because God’s justice is not formally identical to his wisdom, but since justice and wisdom are infinite, each of them *is* identically what the other is. By virtue of the previously achieved conclusion, that two infinite beings are incompossible, the essence’s infinity guarantees divine being’s real simplicity in formal distinction of the attributes.

Accordingly, Duns Scotus does not want to limit himself to distinguishing divine attributes based on the knowledge God has of himself as variously imitable by creatures.[63] The quiddities are in creatures, and since all perfection that there is in creatures is first in God, these quiddities are first in God. What keeps some people from admitting this is that they do not manage to distinguish the *formal reason* from the *mode of the essence*. They do not see that the perfection of being that defies a formal reason is neither finite nor infinite of itself, but finite in a finite essence and infinite in an infinite essence. Therefore, it is true that in a finite being, quiddity limits being at the same time that it specifies it. But from this quiddity let us set aside limitation that is not included in its essence. What remains is a certain *perfection* of being. Let us take this perfection precisely *qua* perfection, to the infinite. *Qua* infinite perfection, it contains all possible perfection. Such precisely are the divine attributes, each of which, by reason of its very infinity, contains the whole divine essence with all the formal reasons to which its proper reason is not identical.[64] Consequently, the perfect simplicity of the divine essence is not only safeguarded, but also confirmed more strongly than ever. We see that it is not endangered for a single instant in Duns Scotus's mind. It is possible that it may have been endangered later in the doctrine of certain *formalizantes*, who appealed to Scotus's principles. If that happened, it is at least plausible that it occurred by reason of the nature of these same principles, but since every doctrine is a balance, it implies a possibility of rupture of balance. Knowing who is responsible for such raptures clearly exceeds the competence of history. All the historian as such can do is to indicate the point in a doctrine at which the rupture could happen and to wait until it has happened before commenting on it.

In Duns Scotus's own work, there is no trace of such a rupture for a reason that perhaps suggests the only way of avoiding it. His thinking is different from Thomas Aquinas's. Close to Anselm and Augustine, he situates the heart of reality in the *essentia*, but he too must explain the coexistence of essences in the divine being's unity. Since he cannot do so by identifying God's *essentia* with his *esse*, he does so by a dialectic of infinity. The formal

distinction of essence does not prevent the perfect ontological unity of the infinite. Everything in the infinite that is formally distinct of itself and remains so, nevertheless, becomes one by virtue of the infinity of being that is common to it. How would it be otherwise? A metaphysics of essences can only seek this solution in the essence itself. Duns Scotus finds the solution of his problem in the properly divine modality of the First Being, namely infinity. The double predication of identity stemming from that demands a truly supreme degree of abstraction, because it cannot be realized without attributing the same *being* identically to everything that belongs to the divine essence, all this while only attributing their particular essence or quiddity to this essence's determinations taken one by one. In other words, while the limitation of finite being only permits attributing to it in the mode of identity what its essence includes, the formal distinction of God's attributes determines no limitation of being in him. This is why the formally real distinction of attributes does no harm to their ontological identity, since all that is God is as infinitely *being* as he.

If we lose sight, even a little, of the fact that the object of our theology is *ens infinitum*, all the modalities of formalities of divine being lose the connection that unites them in the simplicity of the divine essence. It is then that we begin separating them in order to arrange them hierarchically and sometimes even to count them. Duns Scotus resolutely directs points in the opposite direction. We must follow him with docility, if we do not wish the unity of his doctrine to shatter into fragments that can never be reassembled.

D Divine immutability

In Duns Scotus's view although God's infinity is the archetypal mark of the divine essence, God's immutability must not be neglected; first, because according to St. Augustine it was God's essence itself; next, because it is important to establish God's immutability in order to be assured of the important consequence that God alone is immutable. This undertaking holds no special difficulty for Duns Scotus, himself, but it presents rather thorny

difficulties for someone who wants to write history because, once more, it involves the relation of philosophers to the theologian.

Following the path of Augustine, Peter Lombard spoke of God's immutability before speaking of his simplicity. Duns Scotus does the opposite, because immutability seems to Scotus to be deduced from divine simplicity rather than the reverse. Although the word *immutability* is negative, we are dealing with an eminently positive perfection here, as we see, moreover, in the proof that Duns Scotus proposes for it. It has already been established that God is infinite, and by virtue of his very infinity, that he is simple. Since God is simple, he can receive no new form that would add to his essence, which is equivalent to saying that God can undergo no change in the order of formal causality. With greater reason, God can undergo no change in the order of accidental determination. In short, God cannot become other than he is in any way. We see how this absence of mutability is presented as a positive characteristic in Duns Scotus's view. Though an indirect expression, it translates the plentitude of an absolutely infinite essence, whose actuality itself renders absurd the hypothesis that it *is* not enough, so as still to be able to *become*.

Still less could God change in order to cease being. There, we have the most radical change, which John Damascene named *versio*, and which consisted of passing from nothing to being or from being to nothing by way of creation or annihilation. No such thing can happen in God, whom we have proven first in the order of efficacy and necessary by virtue of this primacy. The necessary being cannot pass from non-being to being or the reverse, because he cannot not be. This is why, free from any substantial, formal, or accidental modification, God enjoys complete immutability by essence.[65]

The thesis is certain in itself, and the difficulties it meets come from an extrinsic and thus accidental cause that does not affect its certainty at all. Let us not forget that among theologians the question is not to know whether God is immutable, because all theologians are in agreement, but not all of them justify this thesis in the same way, and, here as elsewhere, the controversies that divide them concern the best way of justifying it. Duns Scotus

particularly thinks of certain among them who gladly content themselves with arguments that can be drawn from Aristotle's *Physics*, where the Philosopher proves that the First Mover is immobile, because a First Immobile and a First Immutable are the same thing. But is Aristotle's demonstration fully satisfactory? For Duns Scotus that is the question, and it is related to our topic because it is connected to another issue whose philosophical importance is considerable: the difference between the immobility of Aristotle's First and the immutability of Duns Scotus's God exactly corresponds to the difference between two first principles whose existence they prove and the difference of the methods they use to demonstrate it.

To develop this critique was not easy in a theological work like the *Opus Oxoniense*. It was all the less easy because, in order to undertake the dialogue with the Philosopher usefully, it was first to confront another problem: can God's immutability be reconciled with his freedom? Duns Scotus nonetheless gives some summary indications about the proofs of divine immutability contained in Aristotle's *Physics*. The first, rather external, reservation is that these proofs ought to be expounded at greater length for their conclusive value to appear (*indigent majori expositione ad hoc ut rationes illae ostendantur valere*). Moreover, we can wonder whether this reservation bears upon Aristotle's own demonstration or on the succinct summary that Scotus himself has just given of it. We would lean toward this second interpretation except for the way in which Duns Scotus formulates the next reservation: and even if they are found to be valid (*et si forte valeant*), they have only limited scope (*tamen diminute concludunt*), as we will be made to see elsewhere. Indeed, perhaps the proofs only conclude that the First cannot be moved in the sense in which either bodies are moved, or forces situated in bodies, or even souls that are moved by accident when their bodies are moved.[66] However we interpret the first of these two reservations, the second one certainly bears upon the heart of the proof as it is read in Aristotle's *Physics*. Since the Philosopher has not demonstrated divine immutability by the metaphysical path of infinity, but by the completely physical path of the

motor cause, Duns Scotus doubts that the First Mover's immobility is more than simple exemption from local movement and also doubts that it is the positive immutability of a first essence in being itself. The problem clearly reveals itself here as what it is. It is the prototypal problem upon which Duns Scotus's mind is unceasingly fixed.

We can formulate the problem in several ways. Historically, the issue once more is to choose between Avicenna and Averroes. Philosophically, it is necessary to choose between physicism and metaphysicism, that is, to decide once and for all whether metaphysical science possesses or does not possess a proper object and is distinguished or not from natural philosophy. From this point of view, the very existence of metaphysics as a distinct science is at stake. Theologically, it is necessary to choose between having the support of a metaphysics of first abstraction starting from the sensible, as Thomas Aquinas does, or having the support of a metaphysics of ultimate abstraction (*abstractio ultima*), as Duns Scotus does. From Scotus's point of view, this amounts to extending either Averroes's technique or Avicenna's technique. On both cases we succeed, but less profoundly in the first case than in the second. For, by using an empiricist metaphysics that is only an immediate development of natural philosophy, it is difficult to reach a God other than Aristotle's, who is the keystone of the cosmos rather than its transcendent cause, and less its free creator than the first in a long chain of necessity.

The problem's omnipresence in Duns Scotus's work dispenses him from taking up its detailed discussion each time that the occasion to do so offers itself, but he frequently reaffirms the problems that govern its solution. Let us recall the principal moments of Aristotle's proof, as it is found in his *Physics* and again almost identically in his *Metaphysics*. There is movement, and this fact includes the existence of a mover who is first, which is to say not moved and consequently immobile. Since movement is eternal and infinite, this immobile mover's power is eternal and infinite itself. But the concept of infinite corporeal magnitude is contradictory, because an actual infinite quantity is impossible. Thus, it is demonstrated that the immobile First Mover is not a body.[67]

We cannot insist enough on the fact that Duns Scotus does not blame Aristotle's conclusions here, but the method Aristotle uses to justify them. The problem of God's existence dominates this whole debate, because the way of conceiving God depends on the paths we follow to demonstrate his existence. If we think we have proven God's existence by establishing the existence of a First Mover, his immutability will always only be immobility, that is, exemption from any corporeal movement suffered either directly or indirectly in conjunction with the movement he causes. Duns Scotus says this: Aristotle certainly proves that the First is not moved after the fashion of a body, because he is incorporeal. He even proves that God is not moved by accident, as are the forces that are put into effect in bodies or in the souls that move them, because, since God is absolutely first, he is *separated*. Nothing further is needed to justify Averroes, because in the last analysis his God is only the first and highest of the Separated Intelligences, each of which presides over the movement of the sphere of which the Intelligence has charge.[68] But this immutability, which is real, still remains simple physical immunity in regard to any movement suffered directly or indirectly.

Duns Scotus often expressed the same reservations about the method that consists in demonstrating metaphysical conclusions by essentially physical paths. To attain the immutability of being, it is necessary to argue directly from being *qua* being, the object of metaphysics, and not from being *qua* movable, object of natural philosophy. We cannot conclude legitimately about being starting from what is inferior to being. On the other hand, as we have already said, *our* metaphysics is knowledge a posteriori. Accordingly, here we must base ourselves on a property of being such that it authorizes us to conclude, not to some highest perfection in a genus of being, as movement does, but to the highest perfection of being. This is why the point of departure must not be physical but *transcendental* in regard to natural philosophy, that is, it must be metaphysical. We can legitimately conclude from truth or goodness to being because, taken absolutely, truth and goodness are univocal transcendentals prior to the involvement of being in the finitude of the genera. Likewise, we can start from the relations of priority or posteriority in

causality or in eminence to conclude at being *qua* being. By contrast, to argue from local movement is to shut ourselves up in the finite category of quantity, and if the deduction leads to assigning it an infinite cause since the motion itself is of infinite duration, we will have the right to posit it as an infinite power in the order of motor causality, but not as infinite in the order of being.[69] Likewise, by proving that the First is immobile by virtue of its primacy in the order of motor causes, the Philosopher does not prove that God is immutable in the order of being. We will never reach this last conclusion by working back from cause to cause in the physical series of motors and moved, but by establishing the existence of a being that is necessary, infinite, and simple precisely *qua* being, from which this time its essential immutability follows with no possible misunderstanding. Let us note that it is necessary to reach his precise conclusion if we want to reach what old Scotists called immutability of God in entity, *immutabilitas Dei secundum entitatem*, and immutability of God with respect to form, *immutabilitas Dei ad formam*, as Duns Scotus undertakes to do. It is not enough to know that God does not move to have the right to conclude that he cannot acquire being or lose it, or change by the arrival or departure of some accidental or substantial form. This is a point where we see most clearly how faithful Duns Scotus remains to the direction he has chosen with an eye to achieving his own end, even when he uses Aristotle's language.

If we are content with the divine immobility Aristotle discusses, it is to be feared that what depends on the First Immobile is necessary like him. A cosmos eternally moved by a first motor whose power alone is infinite is ruled by absolute necessity, excluding all contingency. The immobile's necessity naturally extends to what depends on the immobile, and then contingency and novelty become difficult to explain rather than permanence, uniformity, and necessity. Now, there is contingency and novelty in the world. Therefore, it is necessary to assign a cause to the immobile such that the presence of contingency and novelty is explicable. Since this cause is immutable, the problem is to discover how this immutability can be absolute without its effects being determined necessarily. In other words, the principle

that is first in a universe like ours must be both necessary in itself and free in regard to everything else; a problem that is unsolvable from Aristotle's standpoint. But the problem admits a solution if this principle's immutability is based on its simplicity, which itself flows from its infinity. The issue then is no longer physical movement or its first cause, but metaphysical being and its First Principle. In infinite being *qua* being, the immutability of essence implies no limitation, because since it is total infinity of the possible at the same time, it is not a God that is unable to do anything new without changing. On the contrary, he is a God who can eternally produce an infinity of new beings without being able to change himself, whatever he might do. The actual infinite is such that the concept of change and limit are abolished by its very transcendence. This is why, since the infinite essence's immutability leaves the way open to the finite's contingency, or rather since it alone is able to make it occur, Duns Scotus prefers to link the concept to his proof of the existence of an *ens infinitum*.

Understood thus, the concept of divine immutability is one of the essential elements of the problem of God's freedom and, thereby, of the problem of freedom pure and simple. It leads us to admit that freedom and necessity are not incompatible in all connections. The proof of this is that God loves himself necessarily, because the will necessarily desires its proper object, and by virtue of its own perfection, God's infinite will cannot fail to live the infinite good that he is. As Duns Scotus says in Quodlibet XVI, 2 [AW, p. 370], "There is simple necessity in the act of the divine will." *In actu voluntatis divinae est necessitas simpliciter*. And again, "God is necessarily happy; therefore he necessarily beholds and also loves the beatific object." *Deus necessario est beatus, igitur necessario videt et etiam diligit objectum beatificum*. Let us go further: if God wants what is not himself, he is bound by *necessity of immutability*, which excludes his wanting the opposite, and by his *necessity of inevitability* which excludes that the opposite of what God wants can happen.

These remarks are important. They immediately introduce another observation, which will describe once and for all what will be stated and

restated about the Scotist opposition between the order of nature and necessity and the order of will with freedom inherent in it.[70] This opposition is real, and it is absolute on one point but not on all points, and freedom is compatible with certain necessities, provided that it is the basis of these necessities. In regard to the will's proper object, the will itself behaves in the manner of a nature. How could it be otherwise? As the desire for good in general, the will cannot fail to want, and if absolute good is given to it, to want it. Yet, the will is free. Why? Because the will is the single case whose nature is to be spontaneity,[71] or rather, as Duns Scotus says, a choice, an option whose source is the will itself. That is why, after having recalled in *Quodlibet* XVI, 11 [AW, pp. 380–381], that there is a quadruple order of necessity in God (he sees necessarily, he knows necessarily, he necessarily *breathes* the Holy Spirit, and he loves himself necessarily), Duns Scotus asks in what the freedom of willing consists: *In quo igitur est libertas volendi?* Here is the answer: "I respond that it elicits an act pleasurably and deliberately and remains in act." *Respondeo quia delectabiliter et diligibiliter elicit actum et permanet in actu*. God's freedom resides in his act's radical eligibility, whose lasting quality is to be a choice, because God freely elects to be immutable, or if we prefer, whose mutability is only the perfection itself of his choice.

The conclusion's dialectical rigor forces assent to the thesis, but a new effort allows it to be understood. By not making the effort, adversaries and sometimes even defenders of Scotism entered an inextricable labyrinth on account of the controversy *de auxiliis gratiae* or of the freedom of the blessed. All necessities, including that of immutability, are compatible with freedom with the sole exception of necessity of coercion, *necessitas coactionis*. Once the latter is eliminated as contradicting the very essence of the will, the only problem is to find out whether the object of the will is given to it necessarily or not. If it is, the will wants it necessarily, but by a necessity of the object, not of the will. This is the case of God. As necessary, his being is necessarily given to his will. Therefore, it is necessary that God should will or love himself: "The act occurs by necessity of nature," *necessitate naturae*

habetur actus, Duns Scotus says. However, he adds, “but he does not want the object by necessity of nature,” *sed non vult objectum necessitate naturae*. The object’s nature is such that the act of willing it is made necessary, the act is not willed by a necessity of nature. It is willed by a delectable, free, and freely immutable election of God’s will.

Whatever the manner in which God’s immutability is understood, it is commonly admitted, and moreover, can be demonstrated that *nothing other than God is immutable*, but this is neither universally recognized nor easily demonstrated. Indeed, it is enough to recall Aristotle’s world, where other movers than the First are immobile to see that there have been different solutions to the problem. Besides, here Duns Scotus differs from his adversaries unambiguously: “On this part of the problem, the Philosophers disagree with the theologians, and the reverse.”[72] In other words, philosophers and theologians are in agreement about God’s immutability, but only the theologians maintain that this perfection is reserved exclusively to God. It goes without saying that Duns Scotus ranges himself with the theologians and that his whole argument will be theological. How could it be otherwise? To prove that the infinite alone is immutable is to speak of the proper object of our theology. But precisely because theology is defined from the point of view of its object, it does not exclude the use of philosophical methods. Once more, this is why the controversy will not be carried out on the level of philosophy versus theology, but between philosophers and a theologian speaking the philosophers' own language to them and consequently qualified to converse with them.

In a general way, the philosophers are all those who grant the universe a proper necessity and just because of that a certain immutability. Their principal representatives are Aristotle and Avicenna, whose thought, moreover, has perhaps not always been interpreted correctly by some of their critics. Here, Duns Scotus adopts a remarkably objective attitude in regard to the philosophers that theologians have not always adopted toward him. Far from attributing to philosophers those positions least acceptable to Christian theology, Scotus begins by showing that errors on this particular point have

sometimes been attributed to them that they have not really committed.[73] He is careful not to fall into this mistake:

> I know nothing about the intention of these philosophers, Aristotle and Avicenna, but I do not want to make them say more absurdities than they did say or ones that do not necessarily follow from what they said. I intend to take their words in the most reasonable sense.

This does not mean that Scotus will say Aristotle and Avicenna are right, but that, instead of refuting errors, he plans to oppose those errors, about which, on the strength of their writings, there can be no doubt that they really did commit them.

> Therefore, I respond: Aristotle and Avicenna have both maintained that the relation of God to beings other than himself and outside him is a necessary relation. From that it follows that everything else is a necessary relation in regard to God, when he relates to it in a manner that is somehow immediate, in other words without intermediary movement. Because, at the same time that they posit the totality of movable being, they admit deformity in its parts, so that beings that are generated and corrupted are not connected to God by uniform motion.[74]

Here we see clearly how the *philosophers'* universe appears to Duns Scotus. At the summit is God, who is necessary and immobile. Below comes what God immediately produces, which by virtue of this immediacy is necessary and immutable like God. Still further down is being in becoming, whose movement as the effect of a necessary, immobile cause, naturally presents an overall uniformity but also irregularities of detail due to matter. These accidental deformities are the only kind of contingency that such a world tolerates and the only exception to the rule of conformity.[75] Accordingly, even in exonerating the philosophers of any other errors, the fact remains that two of them, who are close to representing all philosophy, agree in that, whose importance is obvious, because it deals with divine causality. The point is to find out whether, as Aristotle and Avicenna held, the relation of God to things other than he is necessary. For, they maintained that God

relates necessarily to other things outside himself. *Posuerunt Deum necessario se habere ad alia extra se*. And so it is certainly necessary, because if we admit with them that the First is a *necessary cause*, we are inevitably led to maintain that his immediate effects are likewise caused and necessary. How would what stems from a cause obeying its proper necessity not be submitted to necessity? But the necessity is immutable, so that in such a case the cause's immutability naturally extends to its effects.

What necessity is at issue here? A being other than God but immediately caused by him, for example, a Separated Intelligence and most especially the First of them all, can be necessary in three different senses. First, it can be *formally necessary* but be *causally* through another. Secondly, if we pass from the order of causality to the order of essences, it can be *formally necessary* but *dependent* in regard to another, as occurs when it is contradictory that a later being should be without an earlier being upon which it depends in the essential order, but not inversely. Thirdly, the being can be *formally possible by itself* but *necessary by another*, if its cause's efficacy is itself necessary. The point is to discover which one or ones of these necessities are involved in the metaphysics of Aristotle and Avicenna and what sort of immutability they entail for the universe they describe.

In what concerns Aristotle, the situation is clear. Starting from the principle that the First's causality is necessary, he does not contradict himself at all by positing the First's effects as equally necessary, although that has been claimed.[76] Consequently, Aristotle certainly admits the first of the three necessities that we have distinguished, that which is formally necessary in itself and is necessary at the same time by the necessity of its cause. A Separated Intelligence can be at once caused and yet necessary. But Aristotle admits no less certainly the second kind of necessity, which corresponds to what is later in the order of essence, because he teaches that "the principles of the eternal beings are necessarily true in the highest degree."[77] Therefore, there are eternal beings that have principles upon which they depend in the order of the essence's truth and to which these beings are subordinated, even though they are immutable. On these two points, Avicenna agrees with

Aristotle, and also on the third point, about which we can even say that it is more visible in Avicenna than in the Philosopher. There exists what is possible of itself but made necessary by the causality of its cause, in short, "the necessary is caused by another," *necessarium ab alio causaliter*. Neither of these philosophers saw any contradiction in these theses, and so far, it does not seem that there is any.

By contrast, we can legitimately ask whether Avicenna did not contradict himself by adding that what is necessary by another in this third sense nevertheless can remain possible intrinsically. As Avicenna in fact says, the thing would be *possible-by-itself-necessary-by-another*. But is a concept like this possible? That is not certain, because if a being is possible of itself, it can, of itself, fail to exist. Therefore we cannot go on to claim that its cause is necessary, because the cause of a possible effect is itself possible. Nor might the cause produce the being necessarily, because what is necessarily produced cannot fail to exist. Since Scotus is unable to pronounce himself on Avicenna's intention, this is precisely the point where he wants to interpret Avicenna's doctrine in the most reasonable sense he can give it. It can be admitted that when Avicenna refers to his general doctrine of being and essence, he means to say this: in being by another, existence is not included in the concept of essence. Accordingly, in what is of itself, the thing is indifferent to be or not to be, in the same way, for example, that *humanitas* is indifferent to singularity or plurality. Thus understood, Avicenna's position contains no contradiction. It does not say, as it is made to say, that an effect could be necessary by virtue of its cause and nevertheless might not exist, which would be absurd. It signifies that even while an effect exists necessarily by virtue of its cause, the effect remains possible of itself, if it does not include its existence in its essence. Possible of itself, it is thus necessary by another.[78]

Let us note once again the perceptiveness Duns Scotus demonstrates in doctrinal interpretation. This historical and philosophical care to uncover what makes a thesis intelligible and true in its author's mind, in other words to understand before disputing, was something rare in the Middle Ages. It has

not become frequent in our time. However that may be, the Subtle Doctor is right. The first two theses are common to Aristotle and Avicenna, the third, in the sense that has just been defined, is only found in Avicenna, because it is tied to the peculiarly Avicennist doctrine of the essence's existential neutrality, where we can see a legitimate interpretation of Aristotelianism, but not something that can be attributed to it. Furthermore, it is not important. Whether this last thesis of Avicenna is contradictory or not, it agrees with Aristotle on the false principle that God is a necessary cause and on the equally false conclusion that everything that depends on God (whether immediately or by an intermediary that is as immutable as God) is in a relation of necessity to God.[79]

This apparently indirect way of approaching the problem of mutability of creatures is eminently Scotist. Others would be satisfied with the empirical evidence in this regard: things change; therefore their nature is not immutable. But Duns Scotus was too familiar with Aristotle and Avicenna to fail to know that a world can be imagined where everything changes unceasingly and where, however, there is never anything new. If the combination of the first cause and the totality of effects forms a block of necessity such that, except for the wastage due to chance, no initiative is possible within it, we can say that movement and change itself are immutable there. In other words, to return to a distinction that is familiar to Duns Scotus, something contingent is found there, but nothing acts in a contingent way. In a universe where we can go from the first to the last causes of an uninterrupted succession of necessary causal relations, everything happens according to the requirements of strict immutability.

This whole view of the world is tied to a single thesis: the first cause produces the first caused thing with the necessity of a nature.[80] Accordingly, the problem of creatures' mutability evidently combines with another problem in Duns Scotus's thinking, which also pitted *philosophers* against *Catholics* or *theologians*: How does the First exercise its causality? Is it in the manner of a nature or in the manner of a will? The memory of the 1277 condemnations still dominates the debate here, when it can be said that

everything is at stake, because the issue is to choose between Greek necessitarianism and Christian freedom. Two contradictory conceptions are in conflict with their possible consequences: one seeks necessity everywhere to ground rational intelligibility everywhere; the other holds that the real, just as it is, postulates freedom as cause of that necessity, and this similarly is a requirement for intelligibility. As Duns Scotus perceptively grasped, the point is to find out whether it is true to say that necessity is everywhere superior to contingency: "Necessity is more perfect than contingency in every difference of being."[81] The answer will be *yes*, if the First's causality is that of a nature, and *no*, if it is the causality of a will, because, if the First causes in the fashion of a nature, it is not only immobile, but we can certainly say that everything else is immobile with it.

To begin with, it might seem that the problem was resolved at the moment when Duns Scotus proved that the First is intellect and will. That is true, but not completely, because the proof of an infinite being's existence involved no dialogue with philosophers. It happens that Avicenna also conceived the First as endowed with intelligence and will. Bowing to the suggestion of the *Timaeus*, this philosopher even added that the First acts outside himself with entire liberality, expecting no advantage from the effects he causes, because he has no end to achieve, even himself; he is the end.[82] Accordingly, we can say that Avicenna's God is free, at least in the sense in which Plotinus's One is free, from which everything emanates and on which everything depends, without it depending on anything. His freedom is the liberality of absolute ontological transcendence, but it is not liberality of a choice, because it is exercised with the necessity of a nature.[83] Therefore, it is not enough to prove that the First knows and wills to establish that his causality is not necessarily determined to produce its effects. When we discuss this problem further on, we will have to find out whether it is true to say with Avicenna that God's understanding determines his will, because the intellect is a nature, and if divine liberality is infallibly directed by the necessary determinations of the divine understanding, that will does not escape necessity.

Henry of Ghent, whose reasons Duns Scotus adopted and reinforced here,[84]

had already demonstrated that God does not act in the fashion of a nature. First, all natural production adds some perfection to its cause, and since nothing can be added to the First, who is perfect, he cannot produce beings other than himself *qua* nature. Next, a will, even one that is fixed necessarily upon a certain end, only wills the means necessary to this end. But God only wills himself necessarily, and since no creature can add anything to him, no creature is imposed on his choice as a necessary means.[85] As Duns Scotus puts it more technically:

> This is what we see each time the will is concerned with the end itself. Because this end does not determine the will to any being that is related to it, unless we can conclude by a practical syllogism that such and such a being is necessary to this end. Now, the divine intellect knows nothing other than God that is in any way necessary to its last end. Therefore, the divine will, *qua* necessary will of its end, necessarily wants nothing other than this end.[86]

To these arguments of Henry of Ghent that Duns Scotus has somewhat reinforced, he adds his own five arguments. The first is based on divine necessity:

> If a being is perfectly necessary of itself, that is, as necessary as we can conceive that a being may be, it cannot fail to exist, even if no other being than it exists. Now, God is superlatively necessary, in the sense that has just been defined, so that even if nothing other than he existed, it would not follow that he himself did not exist. But if there were a necessary relation to his first effect, God would not exist if that first effect did not exist. Therefore, the relation of God to effect is not necessary.[87]

In short, the argument amounts to saying that, since a necessary being, in the sense in which God is necessary, is more necessary than everything that can proceed from him, then the non-being of the rest is always less impossible than his non-being. From that it follows that since God's being is completely independent of the existence of any other whatsoever, it cannot depend necessarily on the existence of his effects.[88] We observe that here Duns

Scotus argues about the relation of God to the first of his effects, which decides all the others. If God does not will necessarily the existence of even the first of the Separate Intelligences, then he does not will necessarily any other. Moreover, let us observe that if Duns Scotus can use Aristotle's logic here against Aristotle's metaphysics, it is not because he is a more skilled logician than his master, but rather because the concept of necessary being about which they argue is not the same. The First's necessity no longer stems from total, finished intelligibility of being as it did for Aristotle, but from necessity that implies infinity of essence and perfection that follows from his infinity. Consequently, necessary being conceived thus is fully sufficient. There is one God, and this God is sufficient, Leibniz will say. Yes, Duns Scotus would add, but first he is self-sufficient. How could one pretend to doubt that there is something other than he, because we prove his existence starting from his effects? It remains no less true that if the First is necessary and infinite *in the order of being*, nothing would change for him if the rest did not exist. Radical ontological contingency separates what is not God from God. If God causes a being other than himself, the relation of such a being to such a cause must also be radically contingent, and since every nature causes by virtue of its essential necessity, the relation of God's effects to God does not fall under the order of natural causality; it is not subject to his necessity.[89]

The second argument presupposes an empirical observation, which Duns Scotus does not hesitate to make, provided that the empirical moment is immediately left behind. *Aliquid fit contingenter in rebus*; there are contingent events in reality. The Subtle Doctor often argued starting from this fact, because the philosophers against whom he argued admitted it themselves. Consequently, the metaphysical element that this fact includes, namely contingency, can be abstracted from it, and this question can be put to Aristotle: how does it happen that events are produced contingently in a universe whose origin itself is necessary? *Antecedens concedunt philosophi*, it is true, but it is equally true that the *philosophers* grant the other antecedent, and it is not clear how to harmonize them:

> Let us suppose that the relation of the first cause to the next cause is necessary [and it certainly must be, if it causes in the manner of a nature], and let this next cause be B. Then B will be made in a necessary way by the first cause. But B moves the cause that follows it, as it is moved itself by the first cause. Therefore, B moves in a necessary manner when it moves C, and so does C when it moves D—. We can go through all the causes in this way. Nothing will be produced in a contingent manner there, if the first cause acts in a necessary way.[90]

The argument is already familiar. Duns Scotus had used it to establish that the First is a will. Indeed, this is the whole problem, because this choice is only between two types of causality, that of *natures*, which always engenders necessity, and that of *wills*, which always engenders contingency in regard to the end. From that instant, Duns Scotus had started from the same fact, *aliquid causatur contingenter*, to conclude from it that, if there is contingency somewhere in the world, then there must be contingency at its origin. As "there is no principle of operation except the will or something accompanying the will" (*nullum est principium operandi nisi voluntas, vel aliquid concomitans voluntatem*), it is certainly necessary that the world's existence depends not on a nature but on a will.[91] The empirical character of the starting point does not take away the proof's metaphysical scope, because we are dealing with Scotist empiricism here. The fact that there is something contingent summons the understanding to form one of the pairs of *correlatives* that correspond to being's *passiones disjunctae*. Finite-infinite, effect-cause, contingent-necessary are so many properties of being where one or the other belongs to it necessarily. Accordingly, the empirical observation is immediately translated into a purely metaphysical principle: being is necessary *or* contingent. It is a principle, we say, because it cannot be demonstrated that being must be one or the other, and because we are certainly dealing with immediate properties of being. Thus understood, the proposition *aliquod est contingens* signifies less "This being is contingent" than "There is being to which contingency corresponds." It remains no less true that the existence of contingency is itself contingent. If God had not

created the world freely, no contingency would exist, and since this supreme act cannot be deduced from a necessary cause, we cannot demonstrate *a priori* why there is contingency: “And therefore, it seems that some being is contingent is first true, but not demonstrable by the cause.”[92]

Once again we see that the debate between *theologians* and *philosophers* concerns something other than an issue of dialectical correctness. As Aristotle conceives the First, he can act necessarily without contingency being thereby excluded from a universe whose matter that the First has not created is the source of what is accidental and of what is against nature. Such a universe can also involve chance, because no creative providences watches so that encounters of causal series, each of which is ordered to an end, should themselves be ordered to an end. There is no chance in a Christian universe where *everything* has an end. In short, the First’s being itself differs in these two metaphysics, and their difference in the order of being entails the difference of their respective causalities. Duns Scotus’s universe is not justified by the dialectical refutation of Aristotle’s universe, but by the dialectical justification of a concept of God that Aristotle did not conceive. Aristotle’s nature God is the keystone of a metaphysics conceived as the endpoint of a philosophy of nature. Duns Scotus’s infinite God is the hinge of a metaphysics and a theology.

The third argument brings back a theme that is no less familiar in Scotist metaphysics and is only an application of the previous argument to the case where the *contingent* to be explained is found to be something *evil*. “Something evil happens in the universe; therefore God does not cause necessarily.” *Aliquod malum fit in universo, ergo Deus non necessario causat*. Evil is produced in the world, the *philosophers* agree, and Duns Scotus assumes the responsibility of proving that, if this is so, God cannot cause in a necessary fashion. So, this time, we are dealing with a problem of *theodicy*. We could not exonerate God of all responsibility for the existence of evil, if everything were produced necessarily starting from him. If a First whom we know to be good acted necessarily, he would necessarily make each thing as good as it can be. Therefore, there would be no evil in the

universe.[93] It is true that Aristotle can still evade the difficulty here by explaining evil, as he has just explained the contingent, as *deformity* due to matter.[94] This *evasion*, which frequently caught Duns Scotus's attention, seems to have helped Scotus distinguish his own position from Aristotle's. For the Greek philosopher, contingency is an empirically given fact whose cause we can describe as being reduced to the absence of cause. Consequently, there is no room to ask what causes contingency. The pure and simple absence of final causes suffices to explain it. The contingency about which Duns Scotus thinks is completely different. It is a willed contingency, which resides in the cause before being met again in the effect. A Scotist contingent is not only something non-eternal and non-necessary like an Aristotelian contingent, it is that whose opposite can happen when it happens, *id cujus oppositum potest fieri quando illud fit*.[95] Scotus's contingency springs from a choice. Therefore the Philosopher's *evasion* fails inevitably, if we understand the contingency of which he speaks differently from the way he understands it. A Christian universe, like that of Duns Scotus has no room for absolute chance, as St. Augustine had already said. Without exception everything there depends on divine causality, and if this causality were causality of a nature, the First, which is the highest Good, could only cause good. But *aliquid malum fit in universo, ergo Deus non necessario causat*. Besides, even admitting that the presence of evil in nature could be explained, as Aristotle wants, that is to say, that there is evil, we will not have explained it in so far as it is worrisome. Moral evil takes place before our eyes, and it happens in a contingent way. So, unless we admit that the contingent can result from the necessary, we must acknowledge that the first cause does not cause *necessario*.[96]

The third argument appeals to another aspect of natural causality, its *potency*. Every natural cause acts in a necessary fashion and is totally applied in its action. It acts *secundum ultimum potentiae suae*, Duns Scotus says, that is, with all its power. Since it is not a voluntary cause, it has no choice. Likewise, it does not depend on the natural cause to act or not act. But, of itself, the first cause can cause everything causable. If, therefore, it causes all

it can cause, it will cause all that is causable, and no second cause will cause anything.

The proof is interesting in that, once again, it shows that there is hardly one *mental universe* that fails to be offered at least once to a metaphysician's thought. The cosmic hypothesis with which Duns Scotus's imagination plays for an instant is not at all contradictory. If Scotus had taken it seriously, that would have been enough to lead him to construct a universe like Spinoza's. Now, that is precisely what Duns Scotus wants to make impossible. By the first proposition of the *Liber de Causis* Scotus knows that the cause of a cause is the cause of the latter cause's effects: *causa causae est causa causati*. If the first cause acts according to its total power, it must necessarily cause everything that the second cause seems to cause, which amounts to saying that the second cause causes nothing, and since what is true of the second cause is likewise true of the subsequent causes, in such a universe there would not be any other causality than the First's. It is true that certain philosophers see no difficulty in denying all efficacy to second causes, but, even if we resign ourselves to that denial, a still more impossible consequence would follow from this position, because the very plurality of beings would then be lost in absolute monism. Since the totality of effects produced by the First constitutes a single effect, everything is one. We then arrive at the absurdity that, on the one hand, the First can cause all possible effects, and on the other hand, it can only cause one. At bottom, Duns Scotus does not lose sight of the Christian God, who is his own. What Scotus pictures here is not a First whose omnipotence could engender all possible effects, some of them through others and according to an uninterrupted chain of essentially ordered causes. Such a universe would be the universe of the *Liber de Causis*, but it is not Scotus's universe, because the First about whom Scotus thinks is omnipotent in a different sense from the First about whom the philosophers thought. Duns Scotus's First, we will see, can cause all possible effects of himself and by himself alone, with or without the cooperation of second causes. If we situate such a First at the origin of everything, and if we should conceive him as acting in the manner of a

nature, what place would remain for causality other than his?[97] We would then witness the eternally total realization of an infinite cause, positing a single effect in being at one single stroke.

This fourth argument differs from the previous ones in that it implies a concept of divine omnipotence that belongs to the strictly theological order, as Duns Scotus himself proves. Furthermore, it drives the philosophers to impossibilities that for some of them would not be contradictory at all. Scotus knew of Arab philosophers for whom the First alone was a cause. But against what Scotus rejected as still more unsustainable, namely the thesis that God caused both everything and one thing alone, *omnia et unum solum*, the *philosophers* retorted that from the One only one could emerge. The Subtle Doctor took notice of them. Reviewing his arguments before concluding, he will note, "Although certain of them perhaps would not persuade the philosophers to the point of leaving them without a response, they are more probable than those that are invoked in favor of the philosophers, and perhaps some of them are even necessary."[98] Their probability will only become certainty if God's absolute omnipotence can be demonstrated.

The fifth and last reason alleged by Duns Scotus against the *philosophers* requires this kind of reservation. It is founded upon the same principle: "By the same means, drawn from the total causality of a cause submitted to necessity, we end by concluding that the cause would not move in time or, at the very least, that the heavens will not be moved in time, which amounts to saying that the heavens are not moved, properly speaking." Duns Scotus means that, given a First whose infinite power possesses the perfection of efficient causality to such a degree that he alone could produce what he can produce with the cooperation of second causes, then the First can cause immediately in the celestial spheres the totality of the effects he causes there through the Separated Intelligences. Accordingly, if we suppose that the First, conceived as all-powerful in this absolute sense, nevertheless acts in the fashion of a *nature*, he will produce the totality of his effects at one stroke and by himself alone. If he produces at one stroke, he does not produce in time or by movement. But it cannot be admitted that the First produces at one

stroke in the heavenly spheres everything that can be produced there because if that were so, there would not be any successive generations and corruptions in the sublunary world. The philosophers acknowledge that there are some of these successive generations and corruptions. So, according to the philosophers themselves, the hypothesis from which such consequences follow must be regarded as false.[99]

Consequently, it is certain that according to Duns Scotus, God alone is immutable, because, nothing other than God is formally necessary, that is, necessary by virtue of just what he is. Obviously here is negative immutability that stems from the fact that things do not exist enough to be able to change themselves or become the subject of any change, but we are speaking here of positive immutability precisely due to the perfection of that which as immutable being is actually and in reality. If outside of God there were a single immutable being by virtue of its own perfection, it would be the first of the Intelligences. But even the latter changes from intellection to intellection, because, although it can know all intelligible, something of which our own intellect is capable in principle, it cannot grasp them all at once in a single intellection, which would suppose that it was an infinite Intelligence. Even the highest of the Intelligences passes from one intellection to another; therefore it is subject to mutability.

It would be imprudent to specify more than Duns Scotus does what falls under philosophical argument here and what depends on theological truth. At least it is certain that what God's omnipotence (in the absolute theological sense of the expression) implies goes beyond the level of philosophy properly speaking. However, this does not mean that the immutability exclusive to God is not metaphysically demonstrable. It is metaphysically demonstrable insofar as it flows from a metaphysically demonstrable concept of God. But Duns Scotus's First is not only necessary; he is also, *qua* infinite, an intellect and a will. This is why his necessity does not entail the impossibilities to which the necessity of the philosophers' God leads, because if the philosophers' First is necessary with the necessity of a nature, everything else is necessary, and not only is he immutable himself, but everything else is

immutable with him. Let us observe that this consequence, valid for the immutability of a nature, is no longer valid if we are dealing with the immutability of a will. Without altering my own will, I can wish that the effects foreseen by me be produced at the moment in which I foresaw that they must be produced. This is still more evident in the case of the divine will. “God willed from all eternity that something other than he should exist at a determined time, and then he created it when he wanted it to exist.”

Averroes’ objections against this thesis are unimpressive, because they rest on confusion between God’s will and human will. A perfect will *is* not in time. Therefore, it does not have to *wait for* the moment to come when the effect is produced, as is objected. It will outside of time, both time and the moment of time in which the event in question will be produced. Likewise, one who objects that the mutability of effects presupposes the indetermination and mutability of their causes forgets that the issue here is a will, not a nature. Even in us, the will’s indetermination is not an imperfection. It is not the passive indetermination of matter determinable from the outside, but active indetermination capable of choosing between opposites. In God’s case, this active indetermination is unlimited. It can choose among the contraries by virtue of its perfect freedom. It is not appropriate to pose the question why God’s will chooses one of the contraries rather than another. The divine will is a first principle for all that is not God, and Aristotle says it is the sign of bad philosophical training to seek demonstrations and causes for everything. There is no demonstration of the principles of demonstration. There is no cause of the principle of every cause. Heat heats. This is a fact, and no middle term intervenes between this effect and its cause. The will wills. This is another fact, and this second relation is no less immediate than the previous one. Only the first is a relation of nature; the second is a relation of freedom. From the fact that the divine will wanted this, no other reason is to be given but that the will is the will.[100] In short, the fact that God’s will wants something is both the contingent and immediate cause of his effect, because from the necessary only the necessary come, and the contingent can only come from the contingent.[101]

As the Scotist universe appears in terms of this analysis, it is the contingent, mutable effect of a contingent but immutable volition. It is important to note that this radical contingency affects not only the world's first origin, it penetrates and, if it may be put this way, impregnates all its parts. In a universe where the relation of the first effect to the first cause is contingent "no relation of effect to cause is absolutely necessary; it is only relatively necessary." If we think about it, any second cause only causes because the first cause has already caused. Depending upon the First's causality, which is absolutely contingent, the second cause can only cause *contingenter*. It will be objected that at least the conditional causality of the second cause is itself necessary, once the contingent volition of God, which causes it, is posited. Yes, answers Duns Scotus, but even this conditional necessity is not absolute, because it certainly implies that the second cause cannot fail to cause in what regards it and as to its particular part, but God's part remains. Heat cannot fail to heat in what concerns it. However, absolutely speaking, it can fail to heat if God does not cooperate with its action, "as is perfectly obvious regarding the three young men in the fiery furnace."[102]

Therefore, here, we have double contingency in the second causality: a theological contingency due to the ever-present possibility of miracles and a philosophical contingency due to the first cause's freedom that reduces the necessity of second causes to the state of conditional necessity. We would rightly (or at least by a somewhat justifiable anachronism) speak of *radical contingency of the laws of nature* in the Scotist universe and *radical* would be the correct word here, since there is free will at the very root of nature. This is why the problem of divine immutability in Duns Scotus leads to unexpected results that we have just observed. It is not enough to know that God is immutable. If we do not also know that he alone is immutable, we form a very inadequate idea of his immutability. To be mutable is to be mutable in one's very being. *Vertibilitas*, a notion that Duns Scotus takes from John Damascene, in Scotus's thinking emphasizes above all the absolute possibility of not existing. The empirical fact of the existence of change by itself does not let us conclude anything. If all natures necessarily follow from

a first nature that causes them *qua* nature, the totality of effects produced by these natures will be *inevitable*. Neither in the course of their development in time nor of their origin, in a word, nowhere, do we discover this possibility of not being, which is essential to contingency properly so called; and the pseudo-contingency of the accidental with which Aristotle and Averroes were satisfied would not even be possible, since nothing there would let us conceive that what has happened could have failed to happen. The dialectic where this possibility's justification is sought is complex, but Duns Scotus's metaphysical intuition is simple: if there is contingency in nature, it is necessary first that there is contingency in its cause, to put it as the Catholics conceive it: "No causation of any cause can save contingency unless it is posited that the first cause immediately causes contingency and unless we posit perfect causality in the first cause as Catholics do."[103]

Notes

1 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 1, number 1, vol. I, p. 236 [CE II, p. 249].

2 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 22, sole question, number 2, vol. I, pp. 925 [CE V, pp. 343–45].

3 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 22, sole question, number 4, vol. I, pp. 926–27 [CE V, pp. 346–47]. See Maimonides, *Guide des egarés*, I, 61, on the *tetragrammaton*. Cf. *Guide*, I, 63.

4 The name God is itself of this sort, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 4, question 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 490 [CE IV, p. 4]: "*Deus* autem signficat naturam divinam et est nata praedicari de supposito."

5 A passage in St. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XV, chapter 5, number 7, suggested the problem to Duns Scotus. There, *spiritus* is presented as signifying God's substance, while *justus*, *immortalis*, *aeternus*, *bonus*, and *beatus* would designate qualities of the substance. See *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, columns 1061–62.—Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* part I, question 13, article 2, *sed contra*, who also admits that certain names specify God's substance remits to another passage of *De Trinitate*, book VI, chapter 4, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, columns 927–28: "Deo hoc est esse quod fortem esse, vel sapientem esse, et si quid de illa simplicitate dixeris, qua ejus substantia significatur."

6 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, article 2, number 1, vol. I, p. 305 [CE III, p. 3, where this phrase is in question 2, number 2].

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, article 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 305 [CE III. p. 5]: "et quantumcumque procederetur in negationibus, vel non intelligeretur Deus magis quam nihil, vel stabitur in aliquo conceptu affirmativo, qui est primus."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 9, vol. I, p. 596 [CE IV, pp. 185–87].

8 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3 question 1, article 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 305

[CE III, p. 6].

9 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3 question 1, article 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 306 [CE III, p. 7].

10 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, number 1, vol. I, p. 304, *contra* [CE III, p. 3].

11 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, article 4, number 5, vol. I, p. 309 [CE III, p. 18].—Frassen, *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, pp. 176–77, clearly defines the distinction of divine modes and divine attributes: "Modus seu perfectio modificans essentiam divinam, est praedicatum intime et soli essentiae conveniens, per quid abs ea removentur omnes creaturarum imperfectiones, et sine quo divina essentia concipi nequit conceptu quidditativo adaequato."—The divine essence cannot be conceived without its modes, but it can be conceived without its attributes: "Attributum divinum est perfectio simpliciter simplex, quam a creaturis vel univoce vel analogice participatam et in eis relucentem, Deo tribuimos; ipsique formaliter et intrinsece convenire judicamus per modum proprietatis afficientis divinam essentiam jam adaequate in ratione essentiae constitutum." Frassen remits to *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, questions 3 and 4 [CE IV, pp. 169–277].—All that is genuinely Scotist. The only difficulty that might occur for us is that *intellectus* and *voluntas* in God, strictly speaking, are neither attributes nor modes. But when speaking of *intellectus divinus*, Duns Scotus thinks of the real infinite essence, where everything is really identified by virtue of infinity. God's *intellectus* is God. It is not an attribute. But *intellectualitas* is an attribute because it is a formality that is univocal with respect to God and creatures.

12 See above, pp. 84–85, in chapter 1.

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 1, article 4, number 6, vol. I, pp. 309–10 [CE III, p. 18].

14 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 10, vol. I, pp. 311–12 [CE III, pp. 26–27]: "Omnis inquisitio metaphysica de Deo sic procedit: scilicet considerando formalem rationem alicujus, et auferendo ab illa ratione formali imperfectionem quam habet in creaturis, et reservando illam rationem formalem, et attribuendo sibi omnino summam perfectionem, et sic attribuendo illud Deo. Exemplum de formali ratione sapientiae, vel intellectus, vel voluntatis. Consideratur primo in se et secundum se; et ex hoc quod ista ratio non includit formaliter imperfectionem aliquam nec limitationem, removeantur ab ipsa imperfectiones quae concomitantur eam in creaturis, et reservata eadem ratione sapientiae et voluntatis, attribuuntur ista Deo perfectissime. Ergo omnis inquisitio de Deo supponit habere conceptum eundem, univocum, quem accipit ex creaturis." [CE has *concludit* instead of *includit*.]

15 Cf, Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 13, article 2, reply to objection 3: "sed cognoscimus eam secundum quod repraesentatur in perfectionibus creaturarum, et sic nomine a nobis imposita eam significant." The *sed contra* is taken from Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book VI, chapter 4, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, columns 927–28.

16 At *Confessions*, book I, chapter 4, number 4, infinity is not even mentioned among the other attributes. Accordingly, it would be exaggerated to regard Duns Scotus's theology, dominated by the concept of infinite being, as a merely a new exposition of Augustine's theology, where it is difficult to discover infinity, although it is an attribute of God.

17 Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book V, chapter 2, number 3, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 912; see also *De Civitate Dei*, book XII, chapter 2, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, column 350.

18 Scotus, *Quodlibet* I, number 3 [AW, p. 7]: "Ista realis entitas quae est in Deo, cum sit prima ratio essendi simpliciter, rationabiliter a sanctis vocatur *essentia*. Unde Augustinus 7 *De Trinitate*

capitulo 1 in fine: *quod est sapientiae sapere, et quod est potentiae posse et aeternitati aeternum esse et justitiae justum esse, hoc est essentiae ipsum esse*; et infra capitulo 4: *ab eo quod est esse appellatur essentia, propter quod Deus ipse, cui propriissime et verissime convenit esse, verissime dicitur essentia*; et hoc primo dicente Augustino ibidem capitulo 5; *manifestum est Deum abusive vocari substantiam, ut nomine usitatiori intelligatur essentia, quod vere ac proprie dicitur, ita ut fortasse solum Deum oporteat dici essentiam. Est enim vere solus, quia incommutabiliis, idque nomen suum suo famulo enuntiavit Moysi, cum dixit, Ego sum qui sum*." Duns Scotus interprets the well-known passage of Exodus like Augustine, but he translates this interpretation in his own language. *Quodlibet* I, 3 [AW, pp. 6–7]: "In divinis necessaria est aliqua entitas realis, sive ex natura rei, et hoc in existentia actuali, alioquin nihil esset ibi reale in actu."—*Quodlibet* V, number 25 [AW, p. 127]: "Primum omnino in divinis . . . est essentia, ut essentia."—He immediately comments on this using the classical passage from Damascene, who follows Gregory of Nazianzen; the commentary is enriched by the Scotist concept of intensive infinite: "Essentia . . . est pelagus propter comprehensionem omnim perfectionum divinarum; ita est infinita non tantum intensive in se, sed etiam virtualiter primo, et per se continens omnia intrinseca . . ."

19 In an important passage, Duns Scotus addresses an objection based on the authority of Exodus, where God calls himself *Qui Est*. From this passage quoted by Augustine and Damascene, does it not follow that "existentia est prima entitas, et non essentia, ut essentia"? Unfortunately, we have the response only in an addition, but a very valuable one, which specifies that if existence is to its essence in creatures in the same relation as the mode to quiddity (which implies a certain distinction between them), the same does not hold for God, where existence is immediately and of itself included in the concept of the essence, of which it is predicated, *Quodlibet* I, 4 [AW, p. 9]. Cf. *Quodlibet* V, 25 [AW, pp. 127–28]. Consequently, Duns Scotus does not grant that God is first of all existence, but he specifies that God is the essence to which existence belongs immediately and by right. This is why *esse* is often the synonym of *essentia*. It is the same thing, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 46, question 3, numbers 4–5.

20 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 580 [CE IV, pp. 154–56]. The following argument (*ibidem*) is only another expression of the same point: an efficient cause is required to submit matter to its form. A third argument, pp. 580–81, proves that the *unity* of such a concept would require a cause that, once again, is the efficient cause.

21 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book XII, chapter 7, 1073 a 5–11. Cf. *Physics*, book III, chapter 5, 204 a 9–12. The interpretation of these passages, which are among those upon which Duns Scotus reflected most deeply, merits a separate study.

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 1, number 4, vol. I, p. 582 [CE IV, pp. 157–58]: "Ex hoc sequitur quod omnis talis potentia extensa per accidens . . . quamdiu est in magnitudine finita est intensive finita et non infinita, quia infinitas intensive non potest esse sine infinitate in efficacia. Et ex hoc sequitur quod potentia infinita in efficacia non est in magnitudine finita; nec etiam potentia infinita intensive. Et tunc ultra, cum not sit aliqua magnitudo infinita, patet quod non est aliqua talis potentia infinita in magnitudine."

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 1, number 4, vol. I, p. 582 [CE IV, pp. 157–59].

24 Doubtlessly, here Duns Scotus recalls Aristotle's thesis according to which the necessary in the absolute, first sense is identified with the simple.—Cf. Aristotle, *Metaphysic*s, book V, chapter 5, 1015 b 11–12.

25 Scotus *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 1, number 5, vol. I, p. 583 [CE IV, pp. 160–61].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 26, sole question, number 56, vol. I, p. 1015

[CE VI, p. 60, in a footnote as interpolated]: “Ex infinitate sequitur simplicitas, quia infinitum nulli est componibile ut pars parti.”

26 In any case, that alone serves to shake the thesis of the historians who attribute this doctrine to him, trusting in the apocryphal *De Rerum Principio*. The question will be examined in due time.

27 Hieronymus De Montefortino, *Summa Theologica*, part I, question 3, *articulus incidens*, objection 2. Let us recall that St. Thomas also does not understand it in this sense, although his adversaries and sometimes his partisans too often interpret it thus.

28 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 588 [CE IV, p. 167]: “Non enim est actus purus qui caret aliquo gradu actualitatis, sicut non est lux pura quae caret aliquo gradu lucis, licet cum illa luce impura non misceatur aliqua alia entitas positiva, sed tantum carentia perfectioris gradus lucis.”

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 2, number 2, vol. I, p. 586 [CE IV, p. 165]. Duns Scotus does not admit that every thing is composed of other things, because, if one of the components is simple, it is false that everything is composed, and if both elements are composed, we would go on to the infinite that way.

30 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book V, chapter 22, 1022 b 25.

31 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 2, number 2, vol. I, pp. 586–87 [CE IV, pp. 165–67].—Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 2, number 3, p. 588 [CE IV, pp. 167–68], eliminates the argument based on the fact that every creature is *ens per participationem*, because participant and participated are not really composed.

32 Since God’s individuating modality is infinity, which involves simplicity in identity, the modality proper to what is not God must be finitude, which entails composition in difference. The doctrine’s metaphysical consistency is irreproachable.

33 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 590 [CE IV, p. 172]: “Item tertio sic: quia primo diversa in nullo conveniunt; sed Deus est primo diversus a quacumque creatura, alioquin haberet quo conveniret et quo differret, et ita non esset simpliciter simplex; ergo Deus in nullo convenit cum creatura, et ita nec in conceptu communi.”—This objection is cited by Duns Scotus in support of the thesis that he opposes, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 590 [CE IV, p. 171]: “Cum simplicitate divina non stat quod aliquis sit conceptus communis univocus Deo et creaturae . . .”—We see that this issue is to find out whether divine simplicity is compatible with univocity in general, whether we are dealing with being or its attributes.

34 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 11, vol. I, p. 598 [CE IV, p. 190]: “Ad confirmationem de neutro dico, quod conceptus communis duobus est neuter formaliter, et ita concedo conclusionem, quod conceptus entis non est formaliter conceptus creati nec increati. Si autem intelligatur quod iste conceptus est ita neuter quod neutrum contradictoriorum dicatur de eo, falsum est. Ita est in rationali et irrationali, quod conceptus animalis neuter est formaliter, et tamen illud quod conciptur non est neutrum, sed vere est alterum istorum; alterum enim contradictoriorum dicitur de quolibet, et tamen oportet quemlibet conceptum esse formaliter alterum conceptum contradictoriorum.”—We speak of *superlative abstraction* here, thinking of the phrase Duns Scotus himself sometimes uses to designate to abstraction required to conceive natures taken in themselves, *abstractio ultima*.

35 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 11, vol. I, p. 598 [CE IV, p. 190]: “Deus et creatura non sunt primo diversa in conceptibus; tamen sunt primo diversa in realitate, quia in nulla realitate conveniunt; et quodmodo esse possit conceptus communis sine convenientia in re vel in realitate in sequenti dicatur.”—The arguments announced

by Duns Scotus will be examined further on.

36 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book III, chapter 3, 998 b 32. Cf. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 3, article 5, body of the article.

37 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 603 [CE IV, pp. 198–202]. Scotus remits to Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VIII, chapter 4.

38 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 603 [CE IV, pp. 199–202].—The concept of being, Duns Scotus will say further on, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 3, number 28, vol. I, p. 615 [CE IV, p. 224]: " non est de se infinitus positive, ita quod de se includat infinitatem . . . nec est de se finitus positive, ita quod de se includat finitatem . . . sed est de se indifferens ad finitum et infinitum." In short, although our concept of being is finite of itself, it is "finitus negative, id est, non ponens infinitatem."

39 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 604 [CE IV, p. 202]: "Ista autem compositio. . ."—In number 17, p. 604 [CE IV, pp. 202–04], which follows immediately; Duns Scotus points out that, just as being is not a genus, *finite* and *infinite* are not specific differences, but, as we have already said, *intrinsic modes* of one, same reality. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 3, number 26, vol. I, p. 613 [CE IV, p. 221].—On the formal infinity of all that is said of God, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 18, p. 605 [CE IV, p. 205].

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 18, vol. I, p. 605 [CE IV, p. 205].

41 Let us recall that a concept's univocity depends on its *commonality*, which itself stems from its imperfection. The very possibility of positive knowledge is therefore connected *pro statu isto* with the imperfection (which here might be called fertile) of the initial concept of being. Moreover, this is why the existence of concepts common to God and to creatures does not necessarily imply that there is a reality of the same *genus* in God and in creatures, which this concept would designate. The concept applied to God is not distinguished by a specific difference from the same concept applied to creatures, but as the concept of one and the same reality taken under a more or less perfect mode. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 3, number 27, vol. I, p, 614 [CE IV, pp. 222–23]: "Respondeo quod quando intelligitur aliqua realitas cum modo intrinseco suo, ille conceptus non est ita simpliciter simplex quin possit concipi illa realitas absque modo illo; sed tunc est conceptus imperfectus illius rei. Potest etiam concipi sub illo modo, et tunc est conceptus perfectus illius rei. Requiritur igitur distinctio inter illud a quo accipitur conceptus communis et illud a quo accipitur conceptus proprius: non ut distinctio realitatis et realitatis, sed ut distinctio realitatis et modi proprii et intrinseci ejusdem; quae distinctio sufficit ad habendum perfectum conceptum vel imperfectum de eodem, quorum imperfectus sit commuis et perfectus sit proprius. Sed conceptus generis et differentiae requirunt distinctionem realitatum non tantum ejusdem realitatis perfecte et imperfecte conceptae."

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 3, number 29, vol. I, p. 616 [CE IV, p. 227]: "Sed saltem quaeres: quare entitas non habet proprium individuum in re quod sit in potentia ad individuum determinantis, ut primo intelligatur hoc ens quam infinitum.—Respondeo, quod quando aliquid est de se esse, et non tantum capax illius esse, tunc etiam est de se habens quamlibet conditionem necessario requisitam ad esse; ens autem ut convenit Deo, scilicet ens per essentiam, est ipsum esse infinitum, et non aliquid cui tantum convenit ipsum esse; et ideo ex se est hoc, et ex se infinitum, ut quasi per prius intelligatur aliquo modo infinitas esse modus entitatis per essentiam, quam ipsum intelligatur hoc esse; et ideo non oportet quaerere quomodo hoc ens sit infinitum, quasi per prius conveniat sibi singularitas quam infinitas. Et ita est universaliter in his

qua possunt esse entia per essentiam, non per participationem; tale primo determinatur ex se ut sit tale per essentiam, et ut sit infinitum tale, et ut sit hoc de se."—This passage is surely one of the origins of the speculation of Francis of Meyronnes and other Scotists that led them to count and to classify the modalities of divine essence, even if it means attributing existence to it only in third or fourth place.—Cf. Étienne Gilson, *L'être et l'essence* (Paris: J. Vrin, 1958), pp. 134–40 (English translation, *Being and Some Philosophers* [Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Medieval Studies, second edition, 1952, 1961], pp. 94–96).

43 This passage seems to us to confirm strongly the position of Hieronymus of Montefortino that we reported with approval above toward the end of chapter 2, pp. 176–77.

44 We have noted this fact as regards the univocity of being, which Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 2, article 4, number 5, vol. I, p. 309 [I have not found this in CE II, pp, 15–18], initially proposes, "non asserendo, quia non consonat opinioni communi . . ." The same goes for the formal distinction, which Duns Scotus initially introduces, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 5, number 41, vol. I, p. 279 [CE II, p. 349], "sine assertione et praejudicio sententiae melioris."—Let us keep in mind the conventional element that may be present in these phrases characteristic of the epoch. Nevertheless, it would be difficult to cite Scotists who have not dared *to affirm* the formal distinction and univocity. Furthermore, Duns Scotus himself seems to admit these theses more and more firmly in the measure that he defended them, and it is natural that his school should defend them so resolutely, but the nuance we indicate remains a fact.

45 For example, it seems that in returning to the problem of univocity Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 590 [CE IV, p. 171], takes new objections into account: "Ad hoc ponuntur quaedam rationes prius non tactae." Doubtless he might have imagined these objections himself, but as a *professor*, it is impossible to read this question without thinking that Duns Scotus was delighted to seize the opportunity presented to him to go back to the overall problem of univocity that he had treated at length in distinction 3, question 3, To resolve the new problem presented by this repeat encounter (*Utrum cum simplicitate divina sit quod aliquis sit conceptus communis univocus Deo et creaturae*), it would have sufficed to respond to the third of the four objections raised against univocity here, p. 590, CE IV, p. 172, *Item tertio sic* . . . All this is said with the reservation that a critical edition could enlighten us about this passage, because after all, an irresistible impression is still only an impression.

46 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 13, article 5, body of article.

47 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 13, article 2, body of article.

48 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 5, number 41, vol. I, p. 279 [CE II, p. 348, where this is in part 2, question 4, of distinction 2]. With Francis of Meyronnes, *In I Sententiarum*, distinction 8, question 1, the Scotist school will distinguish four degrees of stronger and weaker distinctions: *distinctio essentialis* between two actually existing essences (for example, God and creatures); *distinctio realis*, between two separable things (for example, cause and effect, a wall and its color); *distinctio formalis* between two objects whose quidditative concepts are different; *distinctio modalis* between the quiddidty and its mode or degree (for example, finite wisdom and infinite wisdom). Claude Frassen, *Scotus Academicus*, vol. I, p. 184, observes that the formal distinction "inter duas formalitates seu conceptus objectivos seorsim conceptibiles" is less than the real distinction between beings that can exist separately and more than the modal distinction: "Modus enim non variat rationem formalem rei, sed eam auget vel minuit intra eamdem rationem formalem." Therefore, he concludes, p. 199, in agreement with Duns Scotus: "Divina attributa invicem distinguuntur formaliter, et actu ex natura rei et seclusa intellectus consideratione." Consequently, we are certainly dealing with a kind of distinction that is different

from nominal distinction, but one where distinct existence is not implied.

49 However, let us note that the theological problem of the Trinity and the philosophical problem of the formal distinction overlap because the distinction of the two modes *intellect* and *will* are at the beginning of the distinction of the *emanations of the persons*, since the Son is conceived in the intellect and the Holy Spirit in the will. Without an inner distinction of God's intellect and will, the modes of emanation of the divine persons could not themselves be distinguished. See *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 1, number 7, vol. I, p. 624 [probably CE IV, pp. 241–42]: "Item tertio sic . . ." Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 1, number 8, vol. I, p. 625 [CE IV, p. 243]: "Item contra minorem . . ." and *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 2, number 10, p. 627 [CE IV, p. 246]: "Primo per tertiam . . ."

50 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 5, number 42, vol. I, p. 280 [CE II, p. 351].

51 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 5, number 43, vol. I, p. 282 [CE II, p. 354].

52 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 5, number 44, vol. I, p. 283 [CE II, pp. 356–57]: "In quinto [*scilicet* gradu] est unitas simplicitatis, quae est vere identitas quidquid enim est ibi est realiter idem cuilibet, et non tantum est unum illi unitate unionis, sicut in aliis modis). Ita adhuc ultra omnes est identitas formalis. Voco autem identitatem formalem, ubi illud quod dicitur sic idem, includit illud cui sic est idem, in ratione sua formali et quidditativa et [per consequens] per se primo modo."—Further on, Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 4, article 5, number 45, p. 284 [CE II, p. 358], clarifies through an example that *real* identity does not always and necessarily entail formal identity.

53 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 19, vol. I, p. 634 [CE IV, p. 267].

54 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 2, number 14, vol. I, p. 631 [CE IV, pp. 256–57], notably: "Et tunc ultra, cum nulla sit distinctio in re, sive secundum opinionem, sive secundum expositionem opinantium, sequitur quod bonitas et veritas sint formaliter synonyma, quod ipsi negant . . ."—It is not impossible that here Duns Scotus has in mind Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 13, article 4, body of article.—Duns Scotus's principal argument seems theological. God knows himself intuitively. Now, intellectual intuition perceives no distinction in its object unless the distinction exists. Therefore, it must be admitted that God acknowledges no attributes in himself or, if he knows them, they are really in him. See *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 2, number 15, vol. I, p. 631 [CE IV, pp. 257–58], to which *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 17, vol. I, p. 633 [CE IV, pp. 260–61] remits.—Since humans have no intuitive knowledge *pro statu isto*, the argument cannot be considered philosophically valid, unless of course we hold that it is philosophically demonstrable that God has intuitive intellectual knowledge of his attributes grasped under their proper formal reasons, which perhaps Duns Scotus would not refuse to maintain.

55 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 2, number 13, vol. I, p. 630 [CE IV, pp. 252–53].

56 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 17, vol. I, p. 633 [CE IV, p. 261].

57 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 18, vol. I, pp. 633–34 [CE IV, pp. 261–64].

58 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 21, vol. I, p. 636

[CE IV, p. 269]. We said a fortiori because, as we shall see, the infinity of divine perfection (which does not *formally* belong to the Father's properties) guarantees their compatibility with the simplicity of God's essence.

59 Augustine, *De Trinitate* book XV, chapter 5, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. 42, columns 1061–62, quoted by Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 1, number 1, vol. I, p. 618 [CE IV, p. 230].

60 For the meaning of *abstractio ultima*, see above, chapter one, note 183.

61 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 25, vol. I, p. 639 [CE IV, pp. 274–75].

62 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 26, vol. I, p. 639 [CE IV, pp. 275–77].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 23, p. 638 [CE IV, p. 273 has "bonitas and sapientia]: "Bonitas et magnitudo et caetera hujusmodi sunt eadem quasi identitate mutua, quia utrumque est formaliter infinitum, propter quam infinitatem utrumque est idem alteri."—See also, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 3, number 6, vol. I, p. 624 [CE IV, pp. 240–41]: "Quodlibet attributum continet essentiam divinam secundum omnem rationem perfectionis idealis. . . quia ratio idealis correspondet perfectionis creaturae, in quantum ea perficitur in esse quidditative, et per consequens sub ratione illa qua essentia est limitata. Unde et secundum diversos gradus limitationis distinguuntur, non autem in quantum ista essentia est perfecta simpliciter, quia sic correpondet omnibus unum attributum in Deo, ut bonitas aut perfectio simpliciter."

63 Cf. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 15, article 2 body of article: "Sic igitur inquantum Deus cognoscit suam essentiam ut sic imitabilem a tali creatura, cognoscit eam et propriam rationem et ideam hujus creaturae."

64 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 1, number 6, vol. I, pp. 623–24 [CE IV, pp. 239–41].

65 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 642 [CE IV, pp. 233–34].

66 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 642 [CE IV, pp. 280–81].

67 Aristotle, *Metaphysic*s, book XII, chapter 7, 1073, a 7–13. Cf. *Physics*, book VIII, chapter 10, 267 b 17 ff.—On the impossibility of an infinite *magnitude*, see *Physics*, book III, chapter 5, 205 a 7 to b 1. We can add *De Caelo*, book III, chapter 5, where Aristotle proves that the world is finite: first, because a spatially infinite circular movement is impossible; next, because an infinite rectilinear movement is impossible; from which it follows that an infinite body is impossible.

68 On this point see above the Scotist critique of the proofs of God's existence drawn from movement, chapter 2, pp. 135–36.

69 Here it seems that we can use completely general principles posited elsewhere by Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, article 2, number 21, vol. I, p. 608 [CE IV, pp. 210–11]: "Respondeo nunquam ad summum in inferiori sequitur summum in superiori, nisi illud inferius sit nobilissimum contentum sub illo superiori . . . Igitur non sequitur optimum sive perfectissimum ens ad perfectissimum aliquid eorum qua continentur sub ente, nisi illud sit simpliciter perfectissimum sub ente: quantitas autem non est tale, nec aliquid alicujus generis, quia quodlibet est limitatum, imo nihil est tale nisi quod est perfectio simpliciter, quod ex se potest esse infinitum; et ideo non sequitur: perfectissima quantitas, ergo perfectissimum ens, nec etiam sequitur de aliqua re alicujus generis; sed tantum sequitur: perfectissima veritas vel bonitas, ergo perfectissimum ens. Ita ergo et cum infinito, quod non tantum dicit perfectionem summam, sed

etiam non possibilem excedi, non sequitur infinitum ens, nisi praecise ad infinitum tale quod est perfectissimum, in quo est ratio entis, quod scilicet dicit perfectionem simpliciter."—The remark is applied to the position of Aristotle, who, in his exposition of the doctrine, deduces God's impassiblity and immutability from his immobility, *Metaphysics*, book XII, chapter 7, 1073 a 11.

70 The Scotist distinction between *natura* and *voluntas* covers Aristotle's distinctions between *secundum propositum* and *non secundum propositum*, cf. *Physics*, book II, 196 b 18) and then the distinction between *ab intellectu* and *a natura*, *Metaphysics*, book IX, chapter 2, 1046, b 1–2. But Duns Scotus specifies that the intellect stands fast on the side of nature, whereas "Voluntas semper habet suum modum causandi proprium, scilicet libere, et ideo quando concurrit cum intellectu in productione artificialium, totum dicitur produci libere et a proposito, quia propositum est principale et immediatum principium illius productionis extrinsece." This is why Duns Scotus, *Quodlibet* XVI, 13 [AW, pp. 382–83], reduces these distinctions to the distinction between natural and voluntary.

71 The expression is authentically Scotist, because in the broad sense in which nature extends to everything that is, we can speak of a *natura voluntatis*. *Quodlibet* XVI, 13 and 15 [AW, pp. 382 and 384]: "Sic enim extensive loquendo necessitas in ente quocumque posset dici necessitas naturalis, et tunc cum voluntas saltem divina ex sua perfecta libertate habet necessario aliquid velle, ista necessitas perfectae libertatis potest dici isto modo necessitas naturalis." But this does not exclude the distinction of two orders between *natura* in the strict sense and *libertas*, or again between what happens *a per se causa* and what happens *per propositum*. In this strict sense: "Voluntas per se loquendo nunquam est principium activum naturaliter, quia esse naturaliter activum et esse libere activum sunt primae differentiae principii activi." In short, "Non magis igitur potest voluntas esse naturaliter activa, quam natura ut est principium distinctum contra voluntatem potest esse libere activa."

72 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 643 [CE IV, p. 282]: "Sed pars negativa illius exclusivae, scilicet quod nihil aliud a Deo habeat immutabilitatem, habet majorem difficultatem. Circa istam partem philosophi a theologis discordant et e converso. Ad quod considerandum primo oportet videre quae fuerit intentio philosophorum, et quae motiva pro eis, et quae sunt rationes contra eos."—We will see below that we are dealing with not *some* but *the* philosophers, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 13, p. 650 [CE IV, p. 302]: "Contra istam conclusionem in qua communiter concordant philosophi, quod prima causa necessario et naturaliter causat primum causatum, arguitur sic . . ."

73 The Scotist discussion of certain interpretations of Aristotle would require some detailed exegesis, whose conclusions would not affect our analysis of Duns Scotus. After recalling certain arguments taken from Aristotle, Philoponus, and Avicenna, that would exonerate the Philosopher from the accusation of necessitarianism, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, numbers 3–4, vol. I, pp. 643–44 [CE IV, pp. 280–83], subsequently, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, numbers 6–7, vol. I, pp. 655–46 [CE IV, pp. 288–94], establishes that these arguments do not agree with the thinking of either Aristotle or Avicenna. Even if he does not want to burden the philosopher with more errors than he committed, Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, numbers 10–11, pp. 647–49 [CE IV, pp. 298–300], regards his doctrine as a metaphysics of necessity.

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 647 [CE IV, pp. 294–95].

75 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 643 [CE IV, p. 283]: "Potest enim aliquid aliud a Deo, puta intelligentia alia a prima, tripliciter poni esse

immutabilis et necessaria: uno modo, quod ex se formaliter sit necesse esse, sed ab alio causaliter; secundo modo, quod ex se formaliter sit necesse, sed ab alio dependenter sic quod propter ordinerm essentialem contradictio esset secundum esse sine primo, et non e converso, et est ordo inter perfectius et minus perfectum, non inter causam et causatam; tertio modo aliquid habet esse ex se formaliter possibile, necessario autem ab alio est, quia illud aliud necessario causat."

76 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 647 [CE IV, p. 295]. remits to *Metaphysics*, book V, chapter 5, 1015 b 10, where Aristotle distinguishes among necessary things between those that have the cause of their necessity outside themselves and those that having their necessity in themselves are causes of the necessity of other beings. According to this interpretation, for Aristotle there is certainly *that which is necessary by another*. *Quodlibet* XXI, number 15 [AW, p. 483]: "Dicemus ergo secundum Aristotelem quod agens omnino immutabile non habens causas medias activas vel receptivas diversae dispositionis, non potest causare aliquid novum alterius rationis; sed aliqua istarum conditionum deficiente non habebimus secundum Aristotelem unde concludamos aliquam novitatem in Deo."

77 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book II, chapter 1, 993 b 28–29. This is the passage where Aristotle formulates the famous adage: "As each thing is in respect of being, so it is in respect of truth," *Metaphysics*, book II, chapter 1, lines 30–31, *The Basic Works of Aristotle*, ed. Richard McKeon (New York: Random House, 1941), p. 713.

78 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 7, vol. I, p. 646 [CE IV, pp. 293–94], remits to Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI: "ubi dicit quod causatum, quantum ex se inest ei ut non sit; quantum vero ad suam causam est ei ut sit. Quod autem est ei ex se, apud intellectum prius est, non duratione, eo quod est ei ex alio. Et hoc apud sapientes vocatur creatio, dare scilicet esse rei post non esse absolute. Contra ipsum arguitur, quia iste modus includit contradictionem; quia si, per impossibile, ponitur non esse, sequitur non tantum falsum sed etiam impossibile secundum ipsum, scilicet causam necessariam non necessario causare et dare esse."

79 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 9, vol. I, p. 647 [CE IV, pp. 296–97].

80 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 13, vol. I, p. 650 [CE IV, p. 302]: "Contra istam conclusionem in qua communiter concordant philosophi, quod prima causa necessario et naturaliter causat primum causatum, arguitur sic. . ." We may doubt between translating *communiter* as *jointly* or as *commonly* (in the weak sense of *ordinarily*). At bottom there would be little difference here because, *the* philosophers are primarily Aristotle and Avicenna for Scotus.

81 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 12, vol. I, p. 649 [CE IV, p. 300]: "in omni differentia entis necessitas est perfectior contingentia."

82 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 13, p. 650 [CE IV, p. 302], remits to Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, last chapter. Scotus already put forward the concept of *liberal* production, basing himself on that same text in Avicenna to justify the production *within* the divine essence in the dogma of the Trinity, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 6, article 2, number 4, vol. I, p. 243. [The corresponding question in CE II, ends at number 2 on p. 255.]—*Liberal* production corresponds to an agent moved solely by the plenitude of his own perfection, who consequently does not expect any personal advantage from his productive activity.

83 The breach in Avicenna's necessitarianism due to divine freedom will be studied in chapter 4, pp. 261 ff. In itself, this necessitarianism is not doubtful. Jean Paulus, *Henri de Gand, essai sur les*

tendances de sa métaphysique, Paris: J. Vrin, 1938, p. 262: “It certainly must be noted that in Avicenna’s eyes emanation from the Principle is carried out in the same necessary, intemporal manner that Plotinus conceived. For God, as for each of the Intelligences, *to create* is nothing but *to think*, accepting that the very thing that is thought is born into being by the simple fact of being thought. There is no place for freedom or voluntary initiative in this unfolding of divine thought.”—The author then notes, just as aptly, how this *return to Hellenism* departs from Koranic conceptions. Philosophers writing in *Arabic* must not be confused with *Muslim* philosophers.

84 This is what Scotus will do at the point where he proposes his own arguments. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 17, vol. I, p. 653 [CE IV, p. 310]: “Istis rationibus cujusdam doctoris aliqualiter sic fortificatis, addo alias rationes.”—Cf. Paulus, *Henri de Gand*, pp. 295–98.

85 This is proved by induction. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 14, vol. I, pp. 651–52 [CE IV, pp. 304–05]: “Omne agens naturale aut actione sua perficitur in se [like the intellect when it knows], aut in suo simili [like fire when it burns], aut in toto [as the sun, when it engenders imperfect animals, benefits by this growth of perfection in the universe of which it is part], aut per suam perfectionem natura ejus accipit esse in alio [as in God himself the Father engenders the Son] . . . Sed si Deus naturaliter produceret creaturam, nullum istorum contingeret: nec enim perficeretur in se ex tali productione, nec in simili, nec in toto, nec natura sua acciperet esse in producto [this time, by hypothesis, the effect being not a divine person but a creature]; ergo nec creatura naturaliter producetur.”—In short the concept of natural production of a *creature* is contradictory when the producing nature is the nature of a perfect God.

86 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 653 [CE IV, pp. 307–08].

87 Opus Oxoniense, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 17. vol. I, p. 653 [CE IV, p. 310].

88 Each of these propositions is demonstrated separately. Lest it be believed that the Subtle Doctor has simply usurped his nickname, let us give the demonstration of the major premise here (which might seem almost evident to some), namely, what is perfectly necessary cannot fail to exist even if nothing else exists. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 17, p. 654 [CE IV, p. 310]: “Majorem probo, qui ex minus impossibili non sequitur impossibilius, sicut nec ex minus falso sequitur falsius. Et hoc probo, quia si falsius habeat duplicem rationem falsitatis, et minus falsum tantum unicam, circumscribamus a falsiori illam rationem falsitatis in qua excedit minus falsum, stante alia, et a minus falso illam quam habet; tunc falsius erit falsum, et minus falsum non erit falsum, quia cicumscripta est ratio falsitatis minus falsi; ergo, hoc posito, falsius erit falsum, et minus falsum erit verum, et tunc ex vero sequitur falsum. Ex hoc etiam patet tunc quod ex minus impossibili non sequitur impossibilius.”—Let us attempt this: if what is more impossible has two reasons for being and the less impossible only one, let us remove from the less impossible the only reason of impossibility that it has. Then, the more impossible becomes impossible and the less impossible ceases to be impossible. Therefore, if we maintain that the more impossible stems from the less impossible, we would then maintain that the impossible stems from the possible, which is absurd. Therefore, however necessary an effect of the First may be, it is less necessary than the First, and it could fail to exist without the First’s existence, becoming impossible thereby.

89 Duns Scotus very correctly perceived that in his metaphysics (perhaps he would say rather *theology*) the relation of effect to cause is a relation of *being*, which is not the relation of consequence to principle. A conclusion is of a *partial truth*, that is to say, a part of the principle’s truth. The case of the relation of effect to cause is completely different. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I,

distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 17, p. 654 [CE IV, p. 311]: “In entibus autem ens causatum non est quaedam entitas quasi partialis causae, sed est omnino alia entitas dependens ab entitate causae.”—Accordingly, Scotus’s thought moves in a completely different universe from that of Avicennist being, where the relations of causality are like transcriptions in terms of being of intelligible relations of principle to consequence, which are eternally bound together in the First’s intellect.

90 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 19, vol. I, p. 655 [CE IV, pp. 313–14].

91 In fact, we will have the opportunity to see that, since the intellect behaves like a *nature*, the source of contingency can only be a will.—Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 14, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, p. 416, in an appendix]: “Oportet ergo contingentiam istam quaerere in voluntate divina, vel in intellectu divino; non autem in intellectu ut habet actum primum ante omnem actum voluntatis, quia quidquid intellectus intelligit hoc modo intelligit mere naturaliter et necessitate naturali, et ita nulla contingentia potest esse in sciendo aliquid quod non scit, vel in intelligendo aliquid quod non intelligit tali intellectione prima: primam ergo contingentiam oportet quaerere in voluntate divina.”

92 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 13, vol. I, pp. 1214–15 [CE VI, p. 415, in an appendix]: “et ideo videtur ista, aliquod ens est contingens, esse vera primo et non demonstrabilis propter quid.”

93 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 20, vol. I, p. 202 [This should be at CE II, pp. 174–77].

94 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 21, vol. I, p. 203 [CE II, p. 177, has reference to deformity but not matter].

95 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 2, article 2, number 21, vol. I, p. 204 [CE II, p. 178].

96 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 19, vol. pp. 655–56 [CE IV, p. 314].

97 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 20, vol. I, pp. 656–57 [CE IV, pp. 316–17]: “Primum habens in se causalitatem omnem causae secundae, quantum ad quodlibet quod est perfectionis, potest immediate causare ex se omne causabile, sicut et cum causa secunda. Et si consequens ultimum, quod scilicet causae secundae priventur actionibus suis, non habeatur pro inconvenienti, duco ad majus inconveniens: quod causabit et omnia et unum solum, ita quod omnia erunt tantum unum; quia si etiam in quacumque causatione causabit quantum potest causare, et ita perfectissimum et ita omnia illa erunt unum causatum, et tunc omnia erunt unum.”—Such a universe would follow from Avicennist intellectualist necessitarianism, if the First acted in it in the manner of a nature endowed with the Christian God’s absolute omnipotence. An infinitely powerful intelligible nature cannot fail to accomplish everything at the same time.

98 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 22, vol. I, p. 657 [CE IV, p. 321]: “Ad quaestionem, quantum ad exponentem negativam istius exclusivae, respondeo concedendo conclusiones istarum rationum, quantum licet forte aliquae non convincerent philosophos, quin possent respondere, sunt tamen probabiliores illis quae adducuntur pro philosophis et forte aliquae necessariae.”

99 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 21, vol. I, p. 657 [CE IV, p. 317 says only that the heavens will not be moved or changed in time].

100 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 3, number 24, vol. I, p. 659 [CE IV, p. 325]: “Immediatum autem principium est voluntatem velle hoc, ita quod non est aliqua

causa media inter ista: sicut immediatum est calorem esse calefactivum, licet hic sit naturalitas, ibi autem libertas; et ideo hujusmodi, quare voluntas voluit hoc, nulla est causa, nisi quia voluntas est voluntas: sicut hujus, quare calor est calefactivus, nulla est causa, quia nulla est prior causa."

101 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 3, number 24, vol. I, p. 659 [CE IV, p. 326]. Avicenna would object that the First acts *per essentiam* and that his actions cannot be accidental. To this Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 3, number 24, vol. I, p. 660 [CE IV, p. 326] concedes: "Verum est quia suum velle est sua essentia; tamen contingenter transit supra hoc objectum vel illud, sicut infra de futuris contingentibus dicetur."—Duns Scotus perfectly sums up his position in the following manner: "Cum necessitate Dei stat quod illud ad quod immediate se habet sit mutabile; quia immediate ab immutabili est mutabile, sine mutatione immutabilis, quia contingens habitudo est immutabilis ad proximum sibi, et ideo extremum illius habitudinis est contingens et mutabile, licet fundamentum sit immutabile."

102 Daniel 3:50; Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 3, number 25, vol. I, pp. 660–61 [CE IV, p. 328, gives the Vivès number as 26]: "sicut perfecte apparuit de tribus pueris in camino ignis."

103 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 38, *questio unica*, article 3, number 14, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, p. 416, in an appendix]: "nulla causatio alicujus causae potest salvare contingentiam, nisi prima causa ponatur immediate contingenter causare, et hoc ponendo in prima causa perfectam causalitatem, sicut Catholici ponunt."

4

Origin of the Contingent

A The divine ideas

Duns Scotus identified too much with St. Augustine to fail to have room for the divine ideas in his doctrine. As in St. Bonaventure, Matthew of Aquasparta, and St. Thomas Aquinas, reflections on this matter are inspired by the fundamental passage of the Book of *Eighty Three Diverse Questions*: "The ideas are certain fundamental principles or stable and immutable reasons of things, which, since they are not forms, are eternal, always remaining in the same state and contained in the divine intelligence."[1] Adopting this definition as his own and strengthening it with what Augustine added in his comments on it, Duns Scotus sums it up in the following technical formula: "In divine thought the idea is an eternal reason according to which something can be formed outside this thought, according to its own proper reason."[2]

Let us justify this expression. God causes everything or can cause everything. He does not do so irrationally but rationally. Therefore, God always has a *reason* according to which he forms. On the other hand, since different things require different reasons, God forms each thing according to his proper intelligible reason. Besides, since God needs nothing other than himself to act, these *reasons* cannot be outside him. Consequently, he forms things according to intelligible *reasons* included in his thought. Since what is

in his thought is immutable like him, God can form every formable thing according to a *reason* that is both proper to each thing formed and eternal in God's thought. This *reason* is precisely what is called *idea*.[3]

So far, Duns Scotus follows Augustine literally, but once he begins to introduce his own comments, many questions arise whose answers it would be useless to seek in the Bishop of Hippo's writings, because he does not even pose them. "Thus, it seems," says Duns Scotus, "that the stone known by the intellect can be called *idea*." Let us note this point carefully; it has its importance, and it is not evident that Augustine would have granted it unreservedly. To say that the idea of stone is "the stone insofar as known by the intellect," perhaps is not exactly the same thing as to say that the idea of stone is the reason according to which the stone is formed, if God creates it. We may ask whether, by an inflection of genuine Augustinianism, intentional or not, Duns Scotus here does not begin to accentuate the relation of the idea to the object more than St. Augustine did.

The question seems legitimate to us, and Duns Scotus is so visibly concerned with what Augustine said on the issue that it is hardly possible to avoid comparing the two doctrines continually. But this is a further reason to keep ourselves from the error of perspective to which we are exposed in comparing them. What formally interests Duns Scotus is not the exegesis of what Plato and Augustine said on this point before him. It is the nature of divine knowledge and the nature of its objects insofar as they represent finite possible beings. Through Augustine, Scotus knows that Plato designated these objects with the name of ideas, and since the term has entered theology, it might as well be retained. But that is not necessary, and a theologian could deal with the issue without using this philosophical term. We have just quoted Scotus's own remark in chapter 4 of *De Primo Principio*:

> Many things are said about the ideas, but even if they were never said, nay, even if the ideas were not mentioned (*immo nec nominatis ideis*), no less will be known about thy perfection. This is established, that thy essence is the perfect reason of knowing ever knowable whatsoever under every reason of the knowable. Let him who wishes call it an idea. I do not intend

here to delay over that Greek and Platonic word.

Everything essential is there, and we must never forget that the only objective that Duns Scotus proposes, when he discusses the nature of the ideas, is to understand how, in what sense, the divine essence is the sole and sufficient cause of its knowledge of objects. The point is important in that it settles a fundamental question at the outset: whatever Duns Scotus says, everything that he will say about the ideas will have to be interpreted in the sense that what the philosophers call *idea* is, in the last analysis, only God's essence.[4] He may sometimes seem to say something else in order to cast light on certain aspects of the problem. In fact, he will never say anything but that. As important as the Augustinian doctrine of the ideas may be in Scotus's mind, and however closely he comments on its texts, this is also why the object of Scotus's commentary is not the Augustinian doctrine but the truth about the question. Insofar as we see the degree to which Scotus remains faithful to the Augustinian doctrine we must declare it. But this will not be in order to judge his fidelity to authentic Augustinianism, which Scotus does not make an end in itself. These comparisons will only have the object of defining more precisely the meaning of Scotus's own doctrine by keeping in mind that, since Duns Scotus could have said all he had to say about divine knowledge without uttering the word *idea* a single time, the heart of the problem in his view cannot be this term's authentic sense in the writings of Augustine.

Therefore, it is not surprising that the Subtle Doctor immediately embarks on a personal path. The expression Scotus has just used, *the idea of stone*, that is, *lapis intellectus*, is going to be justified in his thinking by a meticulous metaphysical dissection of the act by which God knows the idea. In a first moment (not of time but of nature and metaphysical order), God knows his essence under a purely absolute reason. In the second moment, he produces the stone in intelligible being and knows the stone intellectual. In the intellectually known stone, there is already relation to the divine intellection. But there is still no relation in divine intellection to the stone, because the divine intellection is the terminus of the relation of the known

stone to the relation itself. The stone is intellectually known, and that is all. A third moment comes then, because the divine intellect can compare its intellection to any intelligible to which we might compare one of our intellections, and in thus being compared to the intellectually known stone, the divine intellect would cause in itself the relation of reason that exists between the knowing subject and the known object. Finally, in a fourth moment, the divine intellect can in some manner, reflect on this relation caused by the third moment, and only then will this relation be known. With this we see in what sense the idea is the object of God's understanding. There is a relation between the idea and the understanding, but this relation is not the basis of the object, it presupposes it. First, there is the knowledge God has of himself. Next, there is the knowledge he has of the stone or of every other idea. Then, there is the relation of reason of the divine intellect to the object. Finally, there is the knowledge God has of this relation. Neither this relation of reason nor the knowledge that God has of it is formally required for God to know the stone *qua* object. The idea appears as soon as the divine understanding produces the stone in its intelligible being,[5] and nothing else is required for it to be.

Scotus has no doubt that this description of the idea is faithful to Augustine's thinking. The stone known by the intellect (*lapis intellectus*) satisfies all the conditions required by the Augustinian definition of *idea*. It is the *reason* of a thing that can be made by God outside himself. This *reason* is proper to that thing in the sense that it can be said that the carpenter's conceptual chest is the *reason* of the wooden chest that he will make. Moreover, this reason is eternal in divine thought, because it exists by virtue of an act of the divine intellect, and nothing new occurs in God from an act of his intellect.[6] It seems that we are even in agreement with Plato from whom St. Augustine took the term *idea*, but Duns Scotus is not certain of this, because he is not sure about Plato's thought. If, as Aristotle maintained, Plato viewed Ideas as quiddities subsisting in themselves, he was wrong. But if, as St. Augustine has it, he posited them in divine thought, he was right. This intelligible world, of which we sometimes speak following Plato, is exactly

there. Whatever Plato thought himself, the ideas are certainly things' essences, existing as known objects in the divine intellect.[7]

Simple as this manner of conceiving the divine ideas may be, it nevertheless presupposes a decision whose scope will be clearer when we see why Scotus's analysis places the divine idea after the divine essence but *before* the relation that the idea enters into next with the divine intellect that conceives it. To posit the idea as an *objectum cognitum* terminating the act of the intellect that produces it is to admit that the idea is not directly and immediately knowledge of the divine essence as such.[8] There is more. By positing the idea as known by God's intellect *before* (metaphysically speaking) its relation to the act that knows it is known, Duns Scotus refuses to include this relation in the intelligible reason that constitutes the idea itself. If, as is the case in Thomas Aquinas, the idea here were the knowledge God has of his essence insofar as imitable by a possible creature, Duns Scotus could not define the idea of stone by the simple, direct expression *lapis intellectus*. It would no longer be the intelligible stone but the divine essence *qua* imitable by the stone's essence, which would be the divine intellect's object. In short, between the knowledge God has of his essence and the knowledge he has of the idea, there would not be the sharp distinction that Duns Scotus introduces between the first and second instants of his analysis, which he signals with this expression pregnant with meaning: "In the second instant [God] produces the stone in intelligible *esse* and understands the stone," *in secundo instanti producit* [*Deus*] *lapidem in esse intelligibili, et intelligit lapidem*. We cannot read these words without remembering so many controversies about the origin of the divine ideas and wondering whether with this *production* of the ideas we are not witnessing a rectification of the doctrine of the production of ideas in God, whose literal expression was condemned several times but whose spirit remained alive in the fourteenth century.[9]

Let us first say that Duns Scotus never proposed the doctrine of the creation of the divine ideas, not even as a defensible hypothesis. In this regard he remains outside the tradition that is inspired in Dionysius the Areopagite and

passes through Scotus Eriugena and the doctrines condemned in the thirteenth century and then in the fourteenth century.[10] With greater reason Scotus has nothing in common with a voluntarism like that of Descartes, for example, where God's intellect, will, and power are just one thing. There is no possible doubt on this point, because if Descartes denied that God creates the eternal truths by an act of will prior the act of knowledge of them (since in God the two acts are combined), Duns Scotus many times explicitly denied that divine knowledge of the idea depends on an act of divine will. Produced by God's intellect, the ideas and their truth are independent of the divine will in such a way that if, by an impossibility, God had no will, the divine ideas and their truths would remain exactly what they are.[11] Consequently, the so-called *primacy of the will over the understanding* that some thought they found in Duns Scotus is a legend, at least on the level of speculative knowledge where we are situated.

A second more delicate issue is the relation of the problem's Scotist solution to its Thomist solution. Here the point is not an abstract comparison of the two doctrines, but what Duns Scotus himself thought of the doctrine St. Thomas taught about ideas, because Scotus knew, discussed, and criticized it. Here again, whatever their divergences ultimately were, we ought to begin by underlining their agreement on a fundamental point. It is not permissible to say that any object other than the divine essence itself moves God's intellect, in Scotism any more than in Thomism. The number of moments Duns Scotus distinguishes in his analysis changes nothing. Nor does the more important thing, that Duns Scotus opposes Thomas Aquinas about the way to conceive the idea's relation to God, change anything either. Here we are in an area where Christian dogma imposes unity on all speculation about divine knowledge. Nothing exists that fails to have its intelligibility and its being from God; therefore, nothing exists outside God that might naturally determine any act of his intellect.[12]

Within this fundamental agreement differences are manifested that, however secondary they may be, nevertheless give rise to two distinct doctrines of the ideas. Among the doctrines that Duns Scotus criticized, one

closely resembles the Thomist position. Knowledge of the idea would be knowledge of the divine essence itself known as imitable by a creature. Expressing this doctrine in his own language, Duns Scotus says that this manner of conceiving the ideas amounts, if not to making the ideas relations of reason, at least to subordinating God's knowledge of each idea to knowledge of a relation of reason. Here, these relations, Scotus specifies, would be in the divine essence insofar as it is known object. In God's absolutely first intellection, this essence would be apprehended by the intellect in a global way. For the creature to be known subsequently, the divine intellect would have to compare God's essence thus known to the creature, and conceive the essence as imitable by the creature. Then, conceiving his essence as imitable, God would conceive the creature. Accordingly, the creature would certainly be known in the divine essence (which remains the first object of the divine intellect) but in that essence known as imitable, which is to say, in this essence known under this relation of reason that is imitability.[13]

There is no reason to doubt that Scotus here envisages a doctrine similar to that of St. Thomas, although he formulates it in a language calculated to make evident what he considers to be its weak point. If a divine idea is the divine essence known as imitable, the relation of imitability is intrinsic to the idea, so that divine knowledge of the idea necessarily implies (we could almost say *presupposes*) knowledge of this relation. Such a doctrine could not satisfy Duns Scotus. If the ideas are knowable by the divine intellect, they themselves, and not any relations, must close this act of knowledge. The ideas, not some relations, must be the object of this divine knowledge. It is not clear how relations of reason could determine the divine essence, which is formally infinite. As such, the divine essence always remains infinite, whatever the aspect under which we may conceive it. Consequently, it is impossible that any relation should limit it to the representation of a finite essence. Besides, if the finite essences were not directly conceived by God but only by intelligible reasons that determine them, these reasons themselves would presuppose others, and so on to infinity. God would never know them,

unless it is admitted that before knowing each essence and in order to know, he must know an infinity of others. What Duns Scotus wants to make us understand is that the divine essence is always the proper and sufficient reason of all knowledge that the divine intellect has. Taken by itself, the divine essence causes, *qua* first object, the knowledge God has of himself, and it again causes the knowledge God has of the ideas or essences of things known *qua* secondary objects of his intellect. Let us not say that the essences cause knowledge that God has of them, which would be to diminish the divine intellect by submitting it to finite objects, but let us not deny either that God cannot know both himself and the essences of finite beings by his own essence completely denuded in some manner.[14]

Here we see the exact point upon which Duns Scotus's criticism bears. He fears a certain interpretation of the Thomist thesis, and for that very reason he prefers another thesis where this erroneous interpretation is impossible. Is God imitable by creatures? Very well, but here just as everywhere, the essence is the basis of the relation. Imitability is in the divine essence; so to speak the divine intellect relates the divine essence to what can imitate it. Let us go further; because, if it is true that God's essence known by his intellect is that by which God achieves knowledge of the stone, he seems no less capable of knowing the stone in itself, without having to compare his own essence to it. Aren't we ourselves capable of doing so? Cannot we know the stone without relating it to something else?[15] Therefore, God can do so. Obviously, Duns Scotus wants the idea, secondary object of divine knowledge, to be known by God directly, independently of any relations and prior to them. The relations presuppose the idea. They cannot be its foundations.

So, we are led to this conclusion: when the divine intellect produces an idea, there is first a relation between this idea and the divine intellect, not between the divine intellect and the idea. This unilateral relation, if we may call it that, is completely different from the relation that unites a finite intellect with its object. In this second case, a relation of coexistence unites the two terms, which is a mutual relation. That does not hold in the act by

which the divine intellect knows something other than the divine essence itself. There is no mutual relation in such a case. The object alone, insofar as known, is in a relation of dependence in regard to the divine intellect.[16] In short, within God there exist eternal relations to the objects that he knows, but they are not in him naturally prior to these objects. On the contrary, these relations are first established naturally between these objects and him, being only relations of dependence of objects known to the divine intellect that knows them.

The analysis of the different metaphysical moments in divine knowledge achieves its full meaning here. At the first moment, Duns Scotus says, God knows his essence absolutely and in itself. At the second moment, he produces the stone into intelligible being, the only relation existing there being what in the idea of the stone relates it to the divine intellection. Only then can God, if he so wills, compare his intellection to that of this intelligible, and know the relation of reason that is thereby established between his intellect and the known object. Evidently, the second moment of the analysis is decisive in what concerns the idea: “In the second instant [God] produces the stone in intelligible *esse* and understands the stone.” For it to be produced, it is doubtlessly necessary for the idea to have a certain entity of its own, a certain reality, a certain being, but how can Duns Scotus teach that God produces the ideas’ being without returning to the frequently condemned doctrine of the creation of ideas, which Scotus never admitted either directly or indirectly?

Duns Scotus is considered a *realist*, and his realism has sometimes been labeled excessive, but that would have surprised him, because he is being compared here to Thomas Aquinas, while he compared himself to Henry of Ghent. According to the latter, God is the first formal cause in the order of essence, as he is the first efficient cause in the order of existences. As formal cause, God eternally produces the Ideas endowed with formal being of essence that entails no existence of their own. This position was somewhat tempting for Duns Scotus, because it is inspired by Avicenna. It is all the more remarkable to see Scotus reject, not the legitimacy of the concept of

esse essentiae because he also admits a formal entity of essence, but rather that the divine ideas have this kind of being. Indeed because essence has real being in its order, Scotus refuses to attribute real being to the ideas in order not to introduce real being into God that is distinct from God. On this issue we cannot situate Duns Scotus without using two references: Thomas Aquinas, on the one hand, and, on the other, Henry of Ghent, who attributed to essences a *reality qua* exemplar eternally produced by God and *existence qua* efficiently caused by God in time.[17] It is in relation to this doctrine that Duns Scotus asks whether, *qua* known by God, the idea possesses genuine being of essence.[18] His answer is negative, because, if God creates existents according to ideas already endowed with being of essence of their own, Scotus does not see how we can still speak of *creatio ex nihilo*.[19] For the stone to be created from nothing, the understood stone, *lapis intellectus*, must not already be something. Evidently, we could maintain with John Scotus Eriugena that the ideas in a certain sense are already creatures. However, then we would fall into the impossibilities with which the concept of eternally created ideas collides, and since Henry of Ghent himself refuses to admit this, there is no refuge in this quarter.[20] Accordingly, we are a choice between two theses: God creates beings from nothing, or he creates them according to ideas already provided with a being of their own. If we want to maintain the concept of creation, the second of these theses must be abandoned. Consequently, Duns Scotus abandons it. Still, unless God *qua* idea is not distinguished in some way from God *qua* God, the idea in God certainly must possess, for God also, the minimal formal entity of its own without which it would be nothing itself. This is the kind of being attributable to the idea that Scotus is going to try to define.

Naturally, here is no question of a being of existence, which even Henry of Ghent denied to it. So far, we are in the order of knowledge properly speaking, that is, of pure divine intellection, taken in itself and before any intervention of the will. The will does not have to intervene as long as God does not choose among ideas to decide which of them will be imitated by existents fully created outside of him. Accordingly, the act by which the

divine intellect produces the idea's intelligible being does not have the effect of positing the known object in a real entity other than that of the divine essence. It simply makes it present to the divine intellect as the known is to the knower. Consequently, the divine idea as such is prior to the order of existential possibility properly speaking because, since a possible being is always other than God who alone is necessary, the divine will is required to determine it.[21] So, God's intellect behaves toward intelligibles other than himself differently from the way God's will behaves in regard to objects other than himself that he may wish. The divine intellect can grasp all intelligible necessarily insofar as they are present to it, without anything other than God being thereby necessarily posited in real being.[22] Thus, the idea produced by the divine act of intellection has no reality of its own outside the divine essence, which amounts to saying once more that its production is not creation.

Granted, but what kind of being can be attributed to the idea, which is neither being of a creature nor being of an essence eternally subsisting in the divine understanding,[23] nor directly being of the divine essence as such? Duns Scotus has seen the difficulty very clearly, and no one has formulated it better:

> The first production is not merely that of some relation, because there is only relation for the absolute. Having granted in the previous question that God produces things in intelligible being, according to which the thing known is said to be an idea, it is consequently necessary in a second moment to posit some absolute entity of the thing produced, in order to ground the produced thing's relation to what produces it.

In short, if the idea's relation to God is posterior to the idea, it is not possible that the idea itself should be absolutely nothing.

The problem would have been unsolvable in any other doctrine than Duns Scotus's, where every object of a distinct concept possesses being of its own, whatever degree this being may be. Scotus attributes *esse* in a restricted sense, *secundum quid*, to the divine idea, which is to say, a relative being, or

as he also says, *ens diminutum*,[24] a reduced being. It is pardonable to hesitate about the meaning of these expressions against which Duns Scotus's interpreters have bumped their heads since the Middle Ages, but Scotus paid attention to them only because they express his thought, and he takes the trouble to explain them several times. The idea is only insofar as it is known. This is what is expressed by attributing a being *secundum quid* to it, namely, that its only reality is the link of dependency that unites it to its cause. The cause here is divine intellection, whose reality is that of a being pure and simple, and in this sense, the *ens* in a restricted sense, *secundum quid*, of the idea has no other absolute being (*ens simpliciter*) than that of the intellection to which it can be reduced. This remark is applied to the order of being properly so called, but it leaves another question open: while the divine idea has no other real being than the being of the intellection and the infinite essence that cause the divine idea, it has its own formal entity, which this intellection as such does not suffice to explain. It is equally true of all the divine ideas that they have no other being than the being of God who knows them. However, they are distinct. What one represents is not what another represents. In short, their suchness, *talitas*, is not the same. It is no longer enough to invoke the reality of divine being here, because if divine intellection (identical to God's *essentia*) is the idea's whole real being, it is not that *formally*, in the sense that the divine intellection is not what makes it be *such and such an idea*. In the unity of divine being, this *talitas* belongs by right to the idea itself. The relative being of the latter has no other real being than the real being of the divine intellection, but insofar as *object* of this intellection, the idea of stone must possess the minimum of formal entity and formal distinction to be *such and such an object*.[25]

Two errors must be avoided: first, by granting real being to the idea independently of the divine intellect's real being, and concluding that the idea does not possess formal identity fully. This second error would consist in saying that the idea's aptitude to represent would be pure nothing. This would be a real error. Obviously, of itself the idea is neither an existence nor even an essence. Therefore, it is not an actual reality in any sense but *qua* object of

an intellect, it is not nothing. Let us remember that it is at least enough to be the basis of a relation. In other words, since it is the basis of a relating of known object to knowing intellect, it must have the relative being that is appropriate to the term of a relation.

This is what Duns Scotus means when he qualifies a being of this kind as reduced, *diminutive* (*diminutum*). Let us take an example. We have Caesar and a statue that represents him. If Caesar is annihilated, his statue remains and continues to represent Caesar. Therefore, Caesar continues to be represented. Let us consider this *represented being* (*esse repraesentativum*) formally and in itself. It is different in nature from any being properly speaking, whether of essence or of existence. It is not even Caesar's reduced being, in other words, a part of what Caesar was minus the rest. If we say that an Ethiopian is white in a restricted sense (*diminute blancus*), it is because he has only white teeth; consequently he is white as to his teeth, although he is not white as to his skin. By contrast, the fact of being represented by Caesar's statue was not part of either Caesar's essence or existence when he was still alive, and we certainly see that by the fact that he continues to be represented after his death. Caesar's *esse represntativum* is consequently neither nothing nor a real being distinct from Caesar's being; it is the representation's being, which is completely relative to what it represents; that is to say, it is the being of the term of a relation to its principle. The being itself of this term is *diminutive*, because in fact it is only the being that belongs to the representative as such in its relation to what is represented. What is true of Caesar's statue in relation to Caesar is much truer still of the divine ideas in relation to the divine intellect, because Caesar's representation exists outside of Caesar, whereas the idea's restricted being is totally included, *qua* object, in the intellect that knows it.[26]

Let us recall once more that in Duns Scotus's doctrine, all that a separately conceivable intelligible entity possesses, a corresponding formal entity possesses. Can we conceive the *known* as such? Obviously we can, because known or not, the object taken in itself remains what it is. As the basis of the relation of known to knower, the object is distinguished from the relation.

Therefore, the relation is distinguished from the object. This being known is not the full being of the known object itself. It is only a relation. But this being in relation is sufficient in its order and of itself does not require the full reality of the absolute being.[27] To understand Duns Scotus's position, we must understand that even if we are dealing with a relation, the object of the definition has its own entity, independently of the existence of what is defined.

There is hardly a facet of Scotus's doctrine that it is more necessary to understand. Scotus himself knows very well what is a real being, fully constituted as such. In a broad sense, we can attribute genuine being to everything that is not contradictory and impossible of itself, but in the strict sense, real being (*ens ratum*) is what possesses the being of an essence or of an existence. Moreover, it does not matter which, because they are inseparable however we distinguish them. No doubt essence only possesses *ens ratum* when it exists actually by virtue of its efficient cause, but that implies neither that essence taken in itself has an existence of its own lower than the existence of *ens ratum*, nor that it has no entity and that there can only be definition of what exists. The definition is the "distinct knowledge of the defined according to all its essential parts," and the knowledge of an object can be equally distinct whether it does or does not exist.[28] Accordingly, the idea, which is produced by the divine intellect, can eternally possess in the divine intellect a being of known object, taken in itself and as such, without any creature resulting from it or its production being a creature in any way.[29]

Furthermore, as Duns Scotus explicitly notes, this is also the only point of view from which his own version of Augustinian illumination becomes intelligible. All Augustinians, in whatever degree they are Augustinians, admit with their master that humans know the truth in the eternal reasons, *in rationibus aeternis*, but since not all conceive these eternal reasons or divine ideas in exactly the same way, they do not agree about the nature of the illumination. In Duns Scotus God moves our intellect to know pure truths by the objective being, *ens objectivum*, of his ideas. Of course, since they only

have relative being, God's absolute being is what moves our intellect by them, but it still moves our intellect to know the truth according to their relative being.[30]

There is no reason to think that Duns Scotus attributed this kind of being to ideas in order to give a satisfactory answer to the problem of divine illumination. Reasons drawn from his own doctrine led him to this conclusion, but we may doubt that he accepted it with pleasure, when he wondered in what sense it was true to say with Augustine that the intellect knows infallible truths *in* the eternal reasons. Because, Augustine had said it, it was better to admit it.[31] But, if the ideas' *ens diminutum* had not come just in time to remove the difficulty, it would have been less clear in what sense it could be maintained.

The problem's history is known, at least in its basic outlines. All thirteenth-century doctors including Thomas Aquinas admitted that the human intellect knows the truth thanks to divine light and even, in a certain sense, in this light. Some of them, particularly in the Franciscan school, were even inclined to think that all knowledge of necessary truth by the human intellect requires a *special illumination*, distinct from the general action God exercises upon his creatures and from the intellect's proper light with which God has endowed humans in creating them. The responses of each doctor had its nuances, but all appeal alike to the authority of St. Augustine, whose theory of knowledge is an apple of discord among historians on this precise point.[32]

Duns Scotus must have found it difficult to take sides against this doctrine, first of all because as a Franciscan, he would have had to contradict his Order's "elders," but above all because they had apparently managed to get St. Augustine on their side, and Scotus himself had the greatest respect for Augustine's authority. So it is not surprising to see him establishing, through an exegesis into whose detail it is not necessary to enter in order to understand Scotus's own doctrine, that no passage of St. Augustine invites us to attribute this type of doctrine to him, that is to say, the doctrine that a special illumination is needed to know necessary truths. General illumination is enough.[33]

However, it remains to be seen in what sense it is true to say that we see these truths *in regulis aeternis*, because if Augustine said nothing else, he at least said this. Moreover, it is comprehensible that he should have said it, because all intelligibles have their intelligible being from an act of the divine intellect, and since all truths that are related there shine in them, the intellect that has them also knows through them all necessary truths that are related there. Consequently, that intellect sees these necessary truths in them as in objects. These intelligibles themselves, *qua* secondary objects of the divine intellect,[34] are *truths*, because they conform to their model, which is the divine intellect. They are *light* because they make something seen. Lastly, they are *immutable* and *necessary* like divine intellection itself. Therefore, their characteristics are certainly the ones that Augustine attributes to the ideas, including *eternity*. Still, let us note that a being's eternity is one of its proper conditions linked to its nature and measured by it. Since the divine ideas only have existence in a restricted sense, *secundum quid*, their eternity is only eternity *secundum quid*. There we have a first acceptable sense of the expression *see in the eternal light*, which now means: see in the secondary object of the divine intellect, which is the truth or eternal light thus understood.

But sometimes Augustine expresses himself differently. In a famous passage of *De Trinitate*, XIV, 15, 21, he speaks of eternal rules written *in the book of that light called truth*." This is a second way of saying the same thing. The book of eternal light is the divine intellect itself, insofar as it contains the truth. We do not see the book itself (which would be to see God in a beatific vision) but certainly the *quiddities* or truths that are written there. Still, here again, it can be said that our intellect sees the truths *in the eternal light*, that is to say, in this book insofar as it contains the object that we see there because, without seeing the book, we read what is written there.[35] In other words, these quiddities are in the divine truth, and we see them. Therefore we see *in* the divine truth, as St. Augustine justifiably says.

So, there are two acceptable senses of the Augustinian expression *see*. It might be said that this is playing with words because, in the last analysis, we

cannot read a book we do not see. More precisely, if we do not see the divine intellect where these truths are, how can we see them in the uncreated life itself?

However minimal the formal distinction that Duns Scotus introduces may be between God's ideas and God's essence taken as object of his intellect, the distinction's importance becomes apparent here. Since the ideas are only second objects of the divine intellect, these ideas have only relative being (*secundum quid*). No relative being exercises any operations directly and as such. It only exercises operations by virtue of the absolute being upon which it depends. Here these secondary objects of the divine intellect only move our intellect precisely by virtue of the divine intellect, which is an absolute being. Accordingly, we see what the ideas are *in the relative eternal light* as in a proximate *object*, but we see in the uncreated light as in the proximate *cause* by virtue of which the proximate *object* moves our intellect.[36]

Those are rather strong expressions. Taking them literally, we would attribute a distinct enough being to the divine ideas for them to be able to be the *proximate objects* of our intellect without the divine intellect itself being yet known. To know in the idea as in a proximate object is really to travel a long way down the Bonaventurian path of illumination. There is no reason to minimize these passages, but it is also necessary to remember that we are talking about formal distinctions of objects here. The knowledge of a divine idea by our intellect is not at all knowledge of the divine essence for us, precisely because, in God himself, the idea is a product of his intellect, not a view of his essence known in a certain relation. If God produces the idea as known object, it is precisely because the idea's object is not directly God's essence. Consequently, the human intellect can know the stone, object of the divine idea, without in any way knowing the essence of God or of the divine intellect. We know in God insofar as he is the cause of the object of our knowledge. However, he himself is not that object.

Duns Scotus's position on this point is not identified with any other, but it represents the most attenuated distinction conceivable between God's ideas and his essence. We mean that Duns Scotus distinguishes them as little as it is

possible to do when it is still desired to distinguish them. Their formal *suchness*, *qua* object of knowledge, distinguishes them both from each other and from God himself. This suchness also confers this reason of object on things by which they directly move our intellect to such and such certain knowledge.[37] For that again, it is necessary that the divine intellect should produce the formal *suchness* of the objects, in which their intelligible being consists. If the suchness were nothing, it would no more be produced as object (as it is), than the divine essence itself. Accordingly, there is certainly a distinction that is both minimal and irreducible between the divine essence as object and the divine ideas as object, a distinction that corresponds to terms all of whose being is reduced to *being-of-objects*.

Here Duns Scotus distances himself from some of his Franciscan predecessors in resolutely denying that *special illumination* is required to know in the eternal rules.[38] Against other doctors whose identity we do not know, Scotus does not admit that the divine will intervenes in the production of ideas, not even in order that our intellect may conceive the necessity of their relations when it knows them. So to speak, the divine intellect produces the ideas prior to the divine will. Through God's ideas and without involvement of his will, his intellect also cooperates in us to produce this natural effect that is the human intellect's conformity to the ideas that it apprehends. Evidently, God voluntarily cooperates or does not cooperate in our arranging the ideas among themselves. But if God does cooperate and we form the ideas, then their arrangement in us is determined by the nature of their terms, as God naturally causes them in us in their intelligible being.[39] Let us repeat that it is even why all this stems from God's *general influence*, and not from some particular action, but Scotus remains certain that the relating of the idea to God is that of effect to cause. Here we also observe a *double causality of the divine intellect*, which is the true uncreated light: first, insofar as it produces its secondary object in intelligible being, then because, by virtue of it, the secondary objects thus produced move our intellect actually.[40] If we like we can say that this double causality defines a third way of justifying the Augustinian phrase *see in the eternal light*. It would be

equally incorrect to ascribe these interpretations to St. Augustine himself and to say that his ideas are not present in Duns Scotus's at all.

Although the Subtle Doctor uses a different technique, he stays well within the line of what can be called Franciscan Augustinianism, at least if we really want to admit that this Augustinianism itself is not a simple repetition of St Augustine. In fact, to return to Scotus's own expression, he stays within the line of St. Bonaventure. This is why, beyond the Seraphic Doctor, Scotus rejoins the Augustinian and Plotinian tradition of the *intelligible world* understood as the totality of the Ideas eternally subsisting in God. Admitting all the nuances or difference proper to each of these philosophers and theologians, the fact remains that, according to them, ideas possess an entity that is more distinct from the divine essence than is the case in St. Thomas Aquinas, for example.[41]Let us not forget that for Duns Scotus, Augustine conceived the divine idea as a known object,[42] hence its nature, as we have just defined it and also the principal characteristics that Duns Scotus acknowledges in it.

Indeed, by that we can determine about what there is an idea in God. Everything that is doable, whether it is a substance, an accident, or a relation, in short, everything that is something other than God, is a distinct object for the divine intellect. It is natural that Duns Scotus should reason about the divine knowledge according to what he knows about human knowledge. In our intellects, that is to say, in a created intellect, everything that can be made constitutes a distinct knowable object, and therefore a positive reality expressible by a distinct idea: "Every knowable distinct positive thing has a distinct idea," *omne positivum distinctum cognoscibile habet distinctam ideam*.[43] The *intelligible world* produced by God's intellect is certainly the model of the world. Possessing its *esse* or its proper entity, *entitas*, everything that is, in whatever degree it is, has its idea there. Naturally, first of all are the substances, but also everything that is not a simple privation. Like evil, which is only a particular case of privation, privation has no form of its own, therefore, no proper idea. God knows privation by the idea of the positive form whose absence privation is. God has no distinct idea of what is, of itself,

a lack of being,[44] but he knows distinctly, in the mode of an idea everything that is distinctly.

Thus, matter has its idea in God, because in Duns Scotus's doctrine, matter possesses a proper being in its proper degree. It is no use to object that we can only conceive matter by analogy to form, because that is true, but the relation of matter to form is completely different from that of privation to being. Matter is not a privation of form. Taken in itself, matter is what receives form, that is to say, it is a reality. Obviously, our intellect cannot conceive matter without form, but how do we conceive a substance except by relation to its accidents?[45] And how do we conceive the form itself except by relation to its operation? We distinguish forms from each other according to the proper operations they exercise. The same goes for matter. Our intellect knows only by starting from the sensible. Seeing that certain beings undergo mutations from one contrary or another, without it being possible for the beings themselves to be totally transformed into their contraries, we conclude that something must subsist under this mutation in order to receive the two contraries successively. That is what is called *matter*. Our intellect knows matter through its relation to the contrary forms that succeed each other in it, but it does not know matter relative to form more than form to matter. In both cases, the intellect knows what are certainly distinct entities. Matter is the permanent subject in which formal mutations occur from one contrary to the other. If we know matter according to its proper entity, with how much greater reason does not the divine intellect know it this way? Therefore, God knows matter by a particular idea of matter.[46]

The same principle—that every distinct object has a distinct idea in God—obliges us to conclude in the same sense in regard to the parts of any whole. Here, we are not in the Thomist world of *esse*, the first act conferring the unity on the totality of each being at the same time as its existence. Rather we are in the Scotist world of essence, where what is separately conceivable possesses formal entity separately. Each part of a whole can be known in itself. Consequently, it has a distinct idea in God. There is no use objecting that, since the part is inseparable from the whole, it is now necessary that

God should have two ideas of the part, one representing it in itself, the other representing it as included in the whole, because this is indeed the case. God has an idea of the part represented distinctly and adequately in itself and another idea of the whole that also represents the part, no longer adequately or distinctly in itself, but as included in the whole.[47] Therefore, there are two ideas of the same part in God, because God knows the part under two different formal reasons as object and in this sense as two formal objects.

For the same reason, God has two distinct ideas of the genera, not that they could exist apart from the species and individual, but that they are part of them. When the artist produces a whole, he not only has a distinct idea of the whole but of each part as such. Otherwise, God would produce each thing without knowing it, which would be absurd to say, speaking about the supreme and perfect artisan.[48] The same goes for accidents inseparable from the substance, because God knows them directly, and therefore by a distinct idea. This would not necessarily be true for a human artisan who can fabricate an object without knowing all these properties. A carpenter, for example, can make a chest without knowing whether it can float. All he needs to know is what is necessary to make a chest. By contrast, God knows in advance all that an object can be, overall and in all its parts, as substance and with all its accidents. He would not be the total efficient cause if he did not know exhaustively all the elements that constitute it. Therefore, God has ideas of everything, even of accidents.[49]

Needless to say, God has ideas of individuals taken in their singularity. Sometimes it is objected that a proper idea does not correspond to the individual because the latter is individuated by matter, for which, it is claimed, there is not a distinct idea in God; also, because the intention of the nature is terminated in the species, which is more perfect than the individual. The first reason does not hold, because we know that matter has its distinct idea in God. As to the second, Duns Scotus does not hold back his answer. We cannot hold both that the intention of the nature is terminated in the species, and that divine providence looks out for individuals above all,[50] because if the nature only acts under God’s direction, it cannot terminate its

intention in species but in individuals for which providence cares. Such a position is even less defensible in that individuals, as first substances, are eminently substances. Therefore, each of them has a real being and real unity proper to it, which is not the case for the species, whose unity and entity, whatever the way in which they are understood do not have the same degree of reality. Since nature always tends to the maximum reality and perfection, it would be surprising that its intention should be limited to the species without pushing on to the individual.[51] Indeed the opposite is true, because nature tends to the species as more perfect than the genus and to the individual as more perfect and more real than the species.[52]

Perhaps some have refused to admit that there are ideas of individuals in God or distinct ideas of parts contained in the whole in order to avoid positing an infinity of ideas in him. If that was the case, it was a mistake, because it should rather be admitted with “old doctor” Bonaventure that there is an infinity of ideas in God. Those thinkers themselves cannot avoid this consequence, because they agree that God knows an infinity of objects because his intellection is infinite. No reason appears why this infinity of objects should not be known by an infinity of ideas. Moreover, the number of individuals can be infinite. Therefore, if each of them must have its idea in God, the number of divine ideas must itself be infinite. For that, it is not necessary that God has produced them; it is enough that God could produce them for him to have their ideas. Lastly, let us add that, by comprehending his essence, which is infinite, God comprehends an infinity of infinite objects, and as the idea is a known object, there must be an infinity of ideas in his thought. If we reduce the ideas to the relation of the divine essence to these known objects, since God knows an infinity of objects, his ideas will still be infinite. The infinity that God knows by knowing himself is the most perfect of all, since it is the infinity of an essence. How would God fail to know at the same time this other lower and derived infinity of which his essence is the cause? Consequently, there is no reason to fail to posit an infinity of ideas in the divine essence.[53]

As knowledge of makeable beings, the ideas are directly oriented toward

possible production. Doubtless, this is why in *De Trinitate*, book VI, chapter 10, St. Augustine says that in God there is a certain art (*ars quaedam*), which can only be these same ideas about which he speaks elsewhere as models according to which everything is formed.[54] Insofar as God's science concerns the idea of things to make, it is ultimately practical science. By practical science we understand not only the knowledge that immediately precedes the operation and prescribes the manner in which a thing must be done, but also the knowledge of practical principles that virtually includes this immediate knowledge and even the formal knowledge of the essences or quiddities that the terms included in these principles designate. Obviously, many artisans know what must be done and how to do it without knowing why it is necessary to proceed precisely in this way. They would not be able to justify their technique by the principles that govern it, nor comprehend the terms of which the principles consist. But we are not speaking about them here. We are dealing with God, the infinite and perfect artisan, who cannot be deemed to fail to know any reason of his possible acts. Therefore, we certainly must attribute to God complete knowledge of all the intelligible conditions of production.[55] The ideas are part of it, at least in the degree of precision that has just been defined. As secondary objects of divine knowledge that are the model upon which God forms beings other than himself, the ideas are the essences or quiddities included in the very principles of the divine operations *ad extra*.[56] It is another matter, however, to know whether the science God has of them is a practical science primarily, immediately, and in itself.

We even must deny that this is so, because the idea is included in the practical science only as a necessary element of the knowledge of the things to be produced. As for the direct knowledge that God has of them for and in itself, that is to say *qua* simply known object, it is not practical but speculative science. In order to be included in God's practical science, it is necessary for his will to intervene first. God has the idea of an infinity of creatures that he will never produce. For those that he will produce, his intellectual knowledge of their ideas is not what he moves to produce those creatures. Of themselves, they are not the terms of necessary practical

principles that God had to form and to which he would then have to conform his action. That would be the case in Avicenna's world. Once again, we must choose between Avicenna's world and the Christian world, and we are speaking of the Christian world here.

God's knowledge of himself as first object and of the ideas as secondary objects of his intellect precedes any act of the will in him. Therefore, the knowledge is purely natural and consequently necessary. It follows that if the divine knowledge of the ideas, along with the knowledge of the principles whose terms are the ideas and that their quiddities determine, were practical science fully, God would know necessarily that this or that ought to be done. Consequently, in his knowledge, there would be determining rules that his will could not escape without guilt. His will would not do that, it will be said. That is certain, but a perfectly righteous will like God's is not only such that it never contradicts reason; it cannot contradict it. However we look at the question, it is impossible to conceive a perfect and infinite God whom science would naturally inform about the necessity of doing certain things and who still would not do them. This is impossible, we say, unless we accept that everything is controlled by strict necessity.[57] We are thus led to the fundamental problem of divine freedom in regard to the possibles, the dividing line between the Christian universe of contingency and the Greco-Arabic world of necessity.

B The possible and the contingent

Duns Scotus's whole theology is centered on the concept of infinite being, *ens infinitum*. On the other hand, in this doctrine where distinctions of being are always translated into distinct concepts, one and the same concept, that of univocal being, *ens univocum*, holds for both God and creatures. This is even why *esse* cannot be distinguished from *essentia* in this doctrine, because if each essence possessed a distant *esse* that was proper to it, there could not be two essences whose being was the same, and therefore univocally predicable. We would be completely within Thomistic analogy and in an epistemology of

judgment rather than concept.

We are not there, but we still remain in a Christian universe, where each creature is a finite being and consequently infinitely distant from God. To guarantee this distinction within the univocity of being, we do not dispose of the Thomist distinction between *esse* and *essentia* here. Since each creature is an essence indistinct from its existence, the gap that must separate it from its creator will not stem from *esse* being contingent in relation to essence within the created being. Consequently, we must look for another dividing line among beings, another cause that posits the creature outside God and radically distinct from God.

According to St. Thomas, *Esse* itself, *Ipsum Esse*, is at the summit of being. If there are other beings, the supreme act of existing creates them, since creation consists precisely in the free gift of *esse* in Thomism. So the creature's radical contingency is guaranteed from its very origin, because God, who is the infinite act of existing, produces these finite *esse*s, whose existence adds nothing to his and which he could annihilate without being diminished. In Duns Scotus we are at the level of essence. Consequently, there, the highest essence, *summa essentia*, creates *essentias*, but since *esse* is inseparable from *essentia*, the dividing line between creator and creature is not in the creature's contingency. This is so true that to give *esse* to any being is not the creator's privilege, as we will see. If God alone can create, this is not the reason why he alone is able to produce an *esse*, being *ipsissimum esse* himself. On the contrary, when any finite cause produces any effect, it confers *esse* on it. Otherwise, not producing something, it would not be a cause. The gap must be situated elsewhere. In Duns Scotus, the distinction of nature and will, *natura* and *voluntas*, often compensates for the Thomist distinction of *essentia* and *esse*.[58] On the level of causality, the will is going to hold the separating role that *esse* cannot play on the level of being, and since the distinction of the creature and the creator must be radical, this divine freedom must affect and condition finite being in its very essence. Its essence depends first of all on the knowledge God has of it. Consequently, divine freedom must be at the origin of created essences and of God's

knowledge of them in another sense. Let us observe that here we are dealing with an absolute metaphysical requirement. In a universe of existents, the contingency of beings is explained there by the contingency of their acts of existing. In a universe of real essence, if the nature of their contingency cannot be in their essence, it must be in the free choice that the creator's will makes.

Here we should deflate the pretext seized by so many historians to speak of Duns Scotus's *voluntarism*. No single epithet has ever sufficed to characterize any doctrine exactly, the present one, no less than the rest. It is not surprising that there have been protests against the imprudent use that some have made of the term. One of Scotus's disciples says:

> In no way does Duns Scotus intend to teach that God's arbitrary will can fabricate all truth at pleasure, for example, logical, metaphysical, and mathematical laws and principles, or that God at whim can make these or those attributes and accidents belong or not to things or substances. But Scotus wants to emphasize exactly that God's knowledge, insofar as it is not purely speculative but practical (that is to say, insofar as it is the cause of things' existence), is not necessary but free. Or again, Scotus wants to emphasize if we are dealing with actual existence of particular things with all their attributes, God knows it by virtue of the decrees of his will and not by virtue of necessary ideas, because otherwise, things would not be contingent, and no contingency would even be possible in the world.[59]

This approach to the problem is clear, but we immediately see the difficulty it contains. Here, the point is to save contingency against those who put it in doubt, without thereby placing God's will at the origin of the ideas. Even in a doctrine where existence is not really distinct from essence, God's will can exercise his freedom in the choice of essences to be realized through the creative act. Accordingly, there will really be contingency, but it will be rather in the extrinsic cause of beings than in the beings themselves, because it will not stem from their essence being distinct from their own acts of existence, but from the divine free decree that confers actual existence on them. From this moment on, the problem of the possibility of future

contingents is going to be posed with special urgency, because *the root of their contingency* will no longer be primarily within them but outside them. Without claiming to distinguish these two problems more than their nature allows, we will examine in turn the divine knowledge of the contingents and the conditions of their existence.

In Duns Scotus's view, the important point is to know whether the divine knowledge of the contingents can be explained by the divine intellect alone or whether, as he himself thinks, it is necessary to make the divine will intervene to understand that this knowledge is possible. In order to justify his own position, the Subtle Doctor begins by criticizing two others according to which divine intellection would be enough to solve the problem.

A first solution looks within the divine ideas themselves, or more precisely within their perfection, for the root of the divine science's certainty regarding possible existents and all their conditions of existence. This perfection is their aptitude to represent existents (*propter perfectionem earum in repraesentando*). According to this doctrine, the divine ideas represent their object not only in the totality of what they are, but also in all these relations in which they can be a term. The divine intellect would be the sufficient reason for the knowledge God has, not only of the simple apprehension of these ideas, but also of their association with all the combinations required for them to exist.[60]

This has been identified as being St. Bonaventure's doctrine, at least in its sense, if not in its letter.[61] Duns Scotus may be thinking of St. Bonaventure here, because he considers the divine ideas as expressing their objects, not only in the highest degree (*summe*) but also according to all conditions, *secundum omnes conditiones*. For St. Bonaventure, we are dealing with an expression in minute detail (*discretissimam expressionem*).[62] Whoever the author of this thesis may be, Duns Scotus rejects it. For, his question bears upon the knowledge of contingents, that is to say, of particular events whose realization always involves complex wholes, for example, a given individual making a given choice in given circumstances at a determined moment. Since we are dealing with contingents by hypothesis, it is not enough that the terms

of a possible combination should be given for the combination to result necessarily. If that were so, that is to say, if the complex thing necessarily followed from the totality of the terms that compose it, it would not be contingent but necessary. That is why the perfection of the divine ideas does not settle the problem. Not the divine intellect, but the very nature of the object is opposed to it. However perfect the divine knowledge of the elements of a complex contingent may be, it does not explain that God should know it, because this complex itself does not follow *necessarily* from its elements.[63]

A second argument drawn from one of the most typically Scotist principles is based on the purely natural character of knowledge by ideas. Here *natural* is opposed to *voluntary* and not to *supernatural*. What Duns Scotus means is that if the ideas are taken precisely as objects of possible intellectual knowledge, they do not depend on God's will at all, but only on his intellect. It follows that even if God knows the infinity of possible combinations of his ideas, he cannot know by simple inspection which of these combinations will be realized in preference to others. In fact, from the viewpoint of mere intellectual knowledge there is no preference. Let us take any two terms, for example, human being and white, *homo* and *albus*. If, of themselves, they had to be composed, God could not know them apart from each other. If, of themselves, they must be separated, God could not know them as united. If they included both at the same time, they would include contradiction, and would be impossible even for God. The only purely intellectual knowledge of the complex *homo albus* that can be conceived is, therefore, that which apprehends it as a combination of possible terms, not as a combination that will be realized.

This brings us to the third reason that such a doctrine does not let us distinguish between simple possibles and future possibles. But let us recall that, in Duns Scotus's thinking, as in Avicenna's science abstracts from existence.[64] This is the case here, since the idea of *homo albus* is known identically whether a white man exists or does not exist. The same holds in all other cases:

> The ideas of possibles that do not have to be realized are the same as the ideas of possibles that have to be realized, because the only difference that there is between non-future possibles and future possibles comes from an act of the divine will. Consequently, the idea of a future possible no more represents it as having to take place than the idea of a possible that will not take place.[65]

This is all the more true in that, in order to represent a possible as having to be realized, its idea would have to include not just the time but some particular moment in time rather than some other particular moment. Since nothing of all that is included in the idea of any possible being, *qua* purely possible, we cannot require that the representative perfection of divine ideas should be the basis of the knowledge of future contingents in God.

Another way of basing this knowledge on the divine intellect alone consists in saying that God knows the future contingent with certainty, because the entire course of time is present to his eternity with all that it contains. This time it is impossible to doubt about which doctrine is envisaged; it is that of St. Thomas,[66] but it satisfies Duns Scotus no more than the previous one. If we were dealing with a simple possible, the explanation would be sufficient. God knows me with certainty from all eternity, just as I can be, for example, seated or standing. Since this knowledge is purely speculative, the intellect is sufficient for it. But matters are quite different in this question: is the divine intellect also sufficient to know that I will exist one day and that at some determined moment of my existence I will be seated? We are dealing with future contingents then, no longer in their abstract being as possible, but in regard to their *esse* of existence, *quantum ad esse existentiae*, and that is why the Thomist solution is no longer sufficient this time. For future contingents to be present to God's eternity in *esse existentiae*, his will would have had to have chosen, wanted, and produced them. Then they would no longer be future but present. Unless perhaps, we admit that after having produced them into existence once in eternity, God reproduces them a second time into existence in time, which is to say he makes them exist twice.[67]

Moreover, let us suppose that the future contingent is present to God, no

longer as a present existent but as a future existent. Even that is useless. It is not the finite object that causes the certainty of divine knowledge. The divine essence is the sole object of the divine intellect, and the latter cannot turn toward another object without being debased. For example, I am seated and God knows it, but the fact that I am seated does not make God know it: *non enim movet sessio intellectum ejus*. So, even if we all agreed that all future contingents were eternally present to divine knowledge and were eternally present *qua* future existents, they would not be what gives certainty to the knowledge that the divine intellect would have of them. Accordingly, the reason of this certainty must be elsewhere than in any presence of its objects to God's eternal intellect.[68]

Next, Duns Scotus examines a third position that he himself connects to Boethius, but that again can be said to be a Thomist position in its essence. Moreover, in that we see the sign that what matters to Scotus is not the doctors but the doctrines. In fact, in *De Consolatione Philosophiae*, book V, prose 6, Boethius says that the same future that appears necessary from the point of view of God's knowledge of it, can appear devoid of necessity if it is considered in its own nature. Returning to the same idea in more precise terms, St. Thomas observes that the futures known by God "are contingent by virtue of their proximate cause, although the science of God, which is the first cause, is necessary."[69] In his turn Duns Scotus says exactly the same in different words: "Although certain things are necessary in regard to the divine science, it does not follow that they may not be contingent in regard to their proximate causes." Here we have another example, out of a hundred, of the precision with which Duns Scotus reproduces the theses he combats.[70]

We have reached a crucial point because, here, the Subtle Doctor confronts the thesis that he most heartily desires to eliminate: the first cause of futures is divine science; this divine science is necessary; although it is a necessary cause, contingent effects result from it. Who fails to see that this is impossible? If you put necessity at the start of the series, you will never find contingency at the end. There can be no contingency in the manner in which a cause produces its effect, unless the first cause behaves in a contingent

manner in regard to the cause that follows it immediately, and which is its effect. It is clear why. Let us consider any intermediate cause. *Qua* intermediate, it moves insofar as it is moved. If it is necessarily moved, it moves necessarily. Therefore, if a second cause is moved necessarily by the first cause, it is going to move necessarily in its turn and produce its effect necessarily. This reason, which holds for a cause, holds for the whole series of causes. The entire order of causes, up to the last effect, would produce necessarily, if the relation of the first cause to the following cause were necessary.[71]

In addition, the series of causes does not necessarily have to intervene in the argument. God, who is all-powerful, could immediately produce what he produces through the intermediary of a series of causes, which amounts to saying that, if the first cause—God's science—is necessary, it will have to be able create necessarily a contingent effect! But it is useless to make any supposition. Indeed, God could actually create any effect whatsoever without any intermediate cause. Even more, he does so, because today he immediately creates souls as he once created the world, in a contingent way. If God knows futures in the necessary science he possesses about them, and if this science is their first cause, how can we understand that in each soul God creates, this necessary cause produces a contingent effect?[72] It would be better to renounce any explanation of this kind completely and bring contingency back to the origin of a world of future contingents.

With what precedes, we anticipate that Duns Scotus is going to seek and find the principle of his own answers to the question, but we can only comprehend this answer if we grasp the sense of the question exactly. The issue is not to find out that there is contingency. There is contingency, and this is an observable fact, not a consequence of any principle. In fact *necessarium* and *contingens* are disjunctive passions of being, *passiones disjunctae entis*, and we already know that in all cases of this kind we can infer the higher member starting from the lower, but not the reverse. If there is a finite being, there is infinite being. If there is contingent being, there is necessary being, but the reverse inference is never good. In every case, the

imperfect assumes the perfect. The perfect never assumes the imperfect, unless, of course, we are dealing with two correlatives like cause and effect. But this is not the case for *necessary* and *contingent*, the first of which in no way assumes the second. If this is true, the proposition, "Some being is contingent," is a fact that cannot be demonstrated *a priori*. We can always make its evidence manifest, without demonstrating it. If someone denies it, he must be submitted to the oriental treatment recommended by Avicenna to bring to their senses those who argue against the principle of noncontradiction, that is to strike them or roast their feet until they recognize that striking or not striking, burning and not burning, are not one and the same thing, at the same time, and in the same regard. Those who deny contingency are submitted to torture until they admit that it is possible that they not be tortured.[73]

Only after this point is the question put: "Admitting as an evident truth that there is contingent being, how—we ask—can the presence of contingency in things be explained?" There is only one answer to the question posed thus, and it is simple: "The action of any cause cannot respect contingency unless it posits the action of the first cause as immediately contingent, and does so by attributing perfect causality to the first cause, as Catholics do."[74]

Let us note this central point from which each of us will draw the conclusion that he pleases, according to the idea he wishes to form of Duns Scotus's doctrine. Why isn't there some contingency, even in these matters? Here at least are the consequences that seem legitimate to draw. According to the Subtle Doctor, contingency is a fact that everyone observes, or that the recalcitrant can be brought to observe with a little dexterity. But if the issue is to know how this fact is possible, it is necessary to go back to a conception of the first cause that itself presupposes the Catholic faith. So, there is no purely metaphysical contingency, a position that agrees with the fact we have already noted and to which we will return, that Greek metaphysical doctrines are philosophies of necessity. Everything transpires as if we lived in a universe of contingency, whose structure would be inexplicable on any other understanding than the Christian one.

This is precisely the reason Duns Scotus puts forward against theology in the intellectualist spirit. How can those who maintain it fail to see that in so doing they reduce the true God of Christianity to the Greek god? Ultimately, when we deal with makeables, *factibilia*, God's science is practical science. If the divine intellect could have certain knowledge of them before any act of his will, he would have it in a purely natural and necessary manner. Accordingly, God would know necessarily that he must do this or that, and since a righteous will could not stray from practical reason in any way, God's will would necessarily act according to his knowledge. In place of the Christian God, we see Avicenna's God reconstituted before our eyes. An intellect necessarily predetermining a will with purely natural necessity and a will that necessarily conforms to intellect inevitably mean the suppression of all contingency in the world.[75] To avoid this danger we must return to the perfect causality of the first cause—as Catholics affirm, *sicut Catholici ponunt*.

With that we see how difficult it is for the historian to interpret Duns Scotus correctly. Obviously, prudence dictates inserting oneself as little as possible, but at the extreme, this abstention would lead to no longer interpreting at all. In the issue at hand, the slightest interpretation involves the whole sense of Scotism. If contingency, which is an indisputable fact of experience, can only be intelligibly justified by positing the perfect causality of the God of Catholics, and if the proof of this causality is included in the proof of God's existence, we must see in this, the proof of the existence of the God of Catholics. In Duns Scotus *Catholici* naturally designates those who profess the Christian faith, as opposed to *philosophi*, who only appeal to natural reason. Accordingly, we must admit that the God whose existence the *Opus Oxoniense* demonstrates is certainly the God of the theologians, not of the philosophers, which, moreover, would confirm our conclusions that, although the proofs of God's existence use a metaphysical technique, they fall directly under theology here. Should we say come under *natural theology*? Duns Scotus does not speak of it, and, furthermore, if the perfect cause whose existence he demonstrates falls under *natural theology*, how would it be

particularly the God of Catholics?

When we turn to God's effects, the situation is no less complex, because we immediately see how God's perfect causality is combined with his absolute omnipotence, which is the object of faith, not of demonstration. So, we are in the Christian universe, that of freedom, as opposed to the philosophers' universe, that of necessity. If we admit that this is really Duns Scotus's thinking, the theology of Christian faith alone holds the intelligible justification of the world of nature. Included in the universe itself, there will be a transcendent secret; rational exploration of nature is not enough to decipher that secret. More than ever, we would be involved in a completely theological task, not a philosophical one. We would be fixed upon the *ens infinitum* and its freedom, not upon nature, the consideration of which, says Duns Scotus, rather leads in the opposite direction, *ducit in oppositum*. If things are this way, we have no right to conclude that there is no *Scotist philosophy* in Duns Scotus himself or that we have no right to construct one, and still less that there is no philosophy in Duns Scotus's theology. But we must at least observe that, if there is a *philosophy* in Scotus, not everything the *Opus Oxoniense* says about God is necessarily part of it in Scotus's own view, even when we distinguish theses demonstrable by natural reason alone, because there are truths about which Catholics think, although the Philosophers seem to have never thought about them.

C Selection of contingents

The existence of an infinite being cannot be established without proving in the course of the demonstration that the first efficient case is endowed with intellect and will. If there were no will, the First could desire no end. Consequently, he could not act, which amounts to saying that it would not be a cause.[76] Moreover, certain philosophers, Avicenna among others, assent without difficulty to this conclusion. The disagreement only begins at the moment when we ask how God's will behaves in regard to different possible objects, and on this precise point, there is serious, although not absolute,

disagreement.

The first problem is to find out whether the universe is submitted to absolute necessity, in the sense that no contingency may be found there. It is certain that it is not, although, as we have said, that is not demonstrable *a priori*. The contingent is a possible, and the possible is one term of the pair *possible-necessary*. If these were convertible properties of being, in order for there to be necessary and possible, it would suffice that there should be being. Their belonging to being would be as evident as being itself. But pairs of disjunctive properties are very different, because they are composed, like this one, of two terms. One is strong, the other weak, and they are such that, if we posit the weak term, we can infer the strong term, but not the reverse. For example, if there is contingent being, there is necessary being, but from necessary being, we cannot conclude that there is contingent being. In other words, the imperfect supposes the perfect, but the perfect does not suppose the imperfect.

That is to say that no middle term exists, with whose help, starting from necessary being, we might prove that there is contingent being. If it is certain that there is contingent being, it is by this first immediate truth, indemonstrable *a priori*, which belongs among factual evidence. This is why, when Aristotle wants to prove that not all futures are necessary, he does not establish this by recurring to a demonstrable impossibility in principle, but to a factual impossibility that is obvious to us. For example, if the future were necessary, it would be useful to calculate our actions. This is why, we would say, if anyone denies there is contingency, to prove the contrary to him, it is enough to submit him to torture, until he admits it is possible that we cease torturing him.[77]

Therefore, there is contingency. It is a fact. The second question, then, is to find out how there can be. We can only respond by coming back to our fundamental position. It is impossible that any cause should produce any contingent effect, unless the first cause itself acts in a contingent manner, whether toward the cause that follows it immediately or toward its effect. If the second cause is moved necessarily by the first, the third will be

necessarily moved by the second so that, if the relation of the first cause to the second is necessary, the whole sequence of causes and effects will be so likewise.[78]

Consequently, the presence of contingent effects in reality supposes that the first cause acts in an immediately contingent manner. This involves attributing perfect causality to the first cause, just as Catholics understand (we said), which means infinite, just, free causal efficacy, because it does not require any condition to be exercised. We can situate God's causality only in his intellect or will. It cannot be found in the intellect, whose first act prior to any act of the will, is purely natural and naturally necessary. Since the first divine intellection knows everything intelligible in one act, no place is left for contingency, because God would have to learn some fact of which he is still unaware for that, or else he would finally have understood an intelligible that would have escaped his first intellection. Therefore, the divine will is certainly the source of all contingency.[79] Only necessaries would be in the world, if God himself, in his freedom, did not cause contingency.

Only part of the problem is there, however, because there can only be contingents if there are possibles. Yet, to say God is free to cause the contingent does not tell us what the possible itself consists of. From this second point of view we must first turn to the divine intellect to get an answer. The stone is possible of itself and formally. As the term of an act of divine power, the possible must fulfill two conditions: that existence is not repugnant to its nature and that, inherently, it does not exist necessarily. Therefore, if we put it this way, the possible is halfway between the impossible and the necessary. The stone produced into intelligible being by the divine intellect is located exactly there. It is not necessary, and existence is not repugnant to it of itself. Therefore, it is possible formally and of itself, by virtue of the mere act of the divine intellect that knows it. The divine will intervenes next, if God wants to give existence to this possible, "but the thing has possible *esse* before any production of it outside [God]," *sed ante omnem productionem rei ad extra res habet esse possibilem*.[80] In short, the first reason of possibility is the divine intellect alone.

We might want to refine more and find out why the stone or human are of such a nature that existence is not repugnant to them. This would be a false quest, because every conceived object is a possible being. Otherwise, being contradictory, it could not be conceived.[81] Thus the nature of the possible as opposed to the impossible is explained, but the nature of the possible as opposed to the necessary remains to be explained. Using language different from that of Duns Scotus, we could call the first a *possible of essence* and the second a *possible of existence*. However we name them, we are dealing with two different orders of possibility, because the concept of a being that is impossible because contradictory does not exist strictly speaking. Like the concept of *chimera*, for instance, the concept of an impossible being is dissected into two other concepts plus perception of their incompossibility. Where the possibility of existence is lacking. no contingent existence is possible. But the essence's possibility is not enough to be the basis for the possibility of the existence, because we could admit, as certain philosophers have in fact admitted, that the existence of very possible essence is necessary from a certain point of view. This is the case in Avicenna, not in the doctrine of Duns Scotus. As we have seen, the first motion of all is necessarily natural in beings, because every voluntary motion presupposes a natural one, and presupposes that if there is a motion in beings that is not natural, it is eminently the motion of the will. The first being that we could consider as a movable moved by a natural motor cause, in the broad sense, is the divine intellect, whose first natural mover is the divine essence, first object of this intellect: *essentia divina est motiva immediate sui intellectus*.[82] This first action is followed, not in time but in the order of nature, by a second motion, that of the divine will. Just as God's intellect knows necessarily his essence and expresses it necessarily, so also the divine will loves necessarily its essence and breathes out its love. We see to what theological truths the double observation leads: God engenders the Word in knowing his essence; he breathes out the Holy Spirit in loving him.

So, an eternal love is the origin and cause of every communication of the divine essence, and although this act is not *natural*, because it is an act of

will, it is necessary. The Holy Spirit is produced by the divine will, the principle capable of loving an infinite object with an infinite love. Accordingly, the divine will can produce an infinite love, and as the divine essence alone is infinite, this love is the divine essence. Produced by it, it is distinguished from it personally, because nothing produces itself.[83] Therefore, this subsistent love is truly a subsistent divine person, eternally produced by God's will. Still, we say, this production is necessary, something astonishing, at least if it is true that freedom follows the will as necessity follows nature. However, this is not contradictory, because we are dealing with an adequate love of an infinite will for an infinite good. An infinite will is necessarily righteous because every will tends toward the good, and it is impossible to see how an infinite will could fail to want the infinite good necessarily. Even more, an infinite will cannot fail to be in act, because otherwise it would be in potency and therefore finite. Thus, it necessarily wills in act the infinite good that the intellect presents to it. But the same necessity is inevitable if we pass from the divine will to its object, because this object is the divine essence, which being an infinite good is of itself infinitely worthy of being loved.[84] Given an absolute good and a will eternally in act of wanting the good, how could this will fail to want this good and fail to breathe out its love for it? We have the perfect proportion between the will, its object, and the love with which it loves it, which *is* only another way of saying that although God's will loves his essence freely, his love's inevitably is equivalent to a necessity.[85]

God's will behaves completely differently when its object is a finite good. Here its eternal necessity of loving the good continues to determine its act, but there is no longer any necessity on the side of the object. Since the object is only possible, there is no necessity for the divine will to want it.[86] Therefore, a second order of acts begins, which presupposes the first act, but is not presupposed by it. The infinite cannot have as its condition the finite, which rather presupposes the infinite.

We know that the divine essence moves the divine intellect to the simple intellection of the intelligibles, that is the ideas, eternally produced into

intelligible being by the very knowledge that God's understanding has of them. They are *secondary objects* of his knowledge, the first object being his essence. This simple intellection of ideas is the term of what might be called God's natural knowledge, which is *necessary with a necessity of nature*. God's essence alone does not move his intellect determinately to the distinct knowledge of all truths relative to contingent events that are produced in the created world. This can be affirmed with certainty because there is contingency in the world, and there would not be if the divine essence determined the intellect to the distinct knowledge of the truth of particular combinations of the ideas when determining the intellect to produce the ideas. If that were the case, these finite combinations would be necessary by virtue of the divine essence, so that they and they alone would be necessarily realized. For example, let us suppose that the divine intellect is eternally moved to know as true one of two possible propositions regarding a future contingent, for example, to happen or not to happen. Either the divine will is necessitated to want it, which would destroy the event's contingency, or the divine will is not necessitated, which would save this contingent's contingency, but would expose the divine intellect to being mistaken.[87] On either side, we run into an impossible consequence, therefore we must give up the principle itself.

How far does God's knowledge reach by virtue of his intellect alone? In the first place, it includes the infinity of possible ideas and, next, all true and necessary propositions whose terms are these ideas. But it stops there. That is, it stops at the threshold of existence. Taken precisely as intellect and before any intervention of the divine will, the divine intellect does not know the truth of any proposition related to the existence of any contingent whatsoever. Taken in itself, such a proposition concerning a contingent does not imply any determined truth.[88] Obviously, this intellect inherently is capable of knowing that on a given date there will be or not be a naval battle, but that is not to know which of the two disjunctive propositions is true. Consequently, it is to know nothing of the truth of one or the other. If one of these two propositions were determinately true, the corresponding event

would no longer be contingent. It would take place necessarily.

So, at the end of the order of necessary motions, contingent motion commences and, since its cause cannot be a nature (whose motions would be necessary), its cause can only be the will. There must be first of all will as a free motion of God by which the will determines itself to want one of the two disjunctive propositions to be true. Without this decision to create the contingent existence of one of the two possibles, neither of the two propositions will ever be true, because nothing will ever come to pass. The divine will first determines itself to want a particular contingent event to be produced. Secondly, seeing this infallible determination of the will, the intellect knows that this event will be produced. The contingent, therefore, follows an order that is the reverse of necessary motion. In necessary motion, the first principle is nature, and this is why it is determined. In contingent motion, the first principle is the will and only in consequence of its free act is the intellect's natural action produced.

The internal contingent motion produced in this way precedes the external motion by the power. The latter, accordingly, is completely contingent and immediately depends on the will as its principle. At this juncture we are at the critical point of the Scotist doctrine of possibles insofar as it allows us to understand contingency present in the world. For Duns Scotus, the point above all is to forbid that any truth about the actual existence of any possible should be imposed on the divine intellection of itself and as if by rights. For Scotus, to yield on this point would be to condemn himself to a world of Greco-Arabic necessity because if the contingent's truth could only be observed by the divine intellect without God himself being its cause, the possible would determine the divine intellect, which in turn would determine the divine will. This would be Avicenna's universe. To shatter that universe's necessity, God's will must dispose at its pleasure of the truth of the contingent. God's will must be the master of deciding between the possibles that are called or not called to be realized.[89] Therefore, a contingent truth is never what moves the divine essence as such to know the truth by virtue of a natural motion. It is the divine will, cause of this contingent truth, which first

proposes it to the divine understanding. In divine knowledge there is no necessary succession of contents to which the will would be bound to consent.

This point decides everything. Duns Scotus knows that he has the philosophers against him, particularly the two he regards as the most illustrious, Aristotle and Avicenna.[90] When we just asked whether there is contingency at the world's origins, "philosophers disagree with theologians and the reverse," *philosophi a theologi discordant et e converso*.[91] For the philosophers, God's immutability and necessity make no more difficulty than for the theologians. It is mutability and contingency of finite things that embarrass them. Duns Scotus knew well their doctrine and the interpretations that had been proposed before him, but refusing once again to heap more absurdities upon them than they had really held or that must necessarily be deduced from their writings, Scotus proposed the interpretations that seemed most reasonable to him,[92] although even reduced to these terms, they were still unacceptable for a theologian. We will successively set out the doctrine of the philosophers and the reasons that compel its rejection.

Let us first note that Duns Scotus considers that Aristotle and Avicenna agree on this fundamental point: something can be possible of itself and yet necessary by another insofar as necessarily caused by it. Scotus judges that Aristotle attributed this mode of being to all the Separated Intelligences after the First Intelligence and judges that, when Avicenna took same the same position again, he explained Aristotle without contradicting him.[93] Accordingly, we can start from the Avicennist doctrine in the confidence certain of not being mistaken about Duns Scotus's adversary.

According to Avicenna, the necessary is a being whose nonexistence implies contradiction. The possible, by contrast, is that whose existence or nonexistence does not imply contradiction. So far there is nothing particularly remarkable, but what follows is more noteworthy, because Avicenna adds that a being that is only possible of itself can be necessary by its cause at the same time, if that cause itself is necessary in its being and produces the effect necessarily. Avicenna sees no contradiction in this, because being, as he

conceives it, is entirely defined by its essence. If by its essence it is not such that its existence is necessary, it is possible, and even if an external cause would necessarily have to cause it, it remains no less what it is, that is to say, a simply possible being. The necessity of its existence can be absolute; it still does not belong to it in any way because in no way does it stem from its essence. Such a being, even while it exists necessarily by virtue of a necessity that is not its own, is therefore certainly *a being possible by itself necessary by another*, *possibile per se necesse ex alio*.

This is not all, because if what is only necessary through another always remains intrinsically possible, when something intrinsically possible comes into existence, it is certain that it is only necessary by another. If it were intrinsically impossible, nothing could make it exist. If it remained a mere possible intrinsically, it could exist, but it would not exist, and nothing would distinguish the possibles that exist from those that do not exist. The only new disposition that is found in it then is existence, and since nothing would be changed for it, if we were only dealing with possible existence, we can only explain it by the act of a necessary cause. Since Avicenna did not imagine the cause that is both necessary of itself and free toward the rest (which was to be Duns Scotus's God), for Avicenna only necessity of its cause can explain the actual existence of the realized possible.

Duns Scotus gives an interpretation of this doctrine that once more testifies to his remarkable perceptiveness. He rightly sees its core in the Avicennist concept of essence to which so many different paths always lead us. Taken in itself, the essence is uniquely what it is, as its definition fixes it in its proper quiddity, independently of any other determination. Of itself, consequently, the essence is neither one nor multiple, neither singular nor universal, but existence is the most remarkable among all the accidental determinations to which the essence is and always remains indifferent. An essence remains exactly what it is whether it exists or does not exist. This is why it is the very type of the possible; but it is also why, even when it exists under the necessary action of a necessary cause, it remains a possibility of itself. The existence that it receives remains alien to it insofar as it is essence. The

Avicennist accidentalness of existence certainly is what justifies this doctrine of the necessary possible, and it is what Duns Scotus magisterially expounds in the justification he proposes of Avicenna's thesis, before refuting it, of course.

> What receives existence from another does not include existence in its quiddity. To conceive the quiddity precisely as not including existence, is to conceive it in potency with respect to existence, that is to say, as not existing of itself. For example, to conceive humanity precisely[94] *qua* humanity is to conceive of it as being in potency in respect to existence, as it is in respect to everything that it does not have and of which it is susceptible. Avicenna speaks thus of the quiddity when he says in his *Metaphysics*, tractate V, chapter 1, that for every being of this kind, existence is an accident of essence, because existence is not included in the essence's formal concept, and because the quiddity is in potency to all determinations of this kind, like the one and the many, and so on. Therefore, I say that Aristotle posited every Intelligence other than the First Intelligence as being possible inherently in this sense and in potency in regard to existence, because none of them includes existence in its formal concept. Thus Aristotle and Avicenna are in agreement.[95]

Let us clarify: they agree with perfect consistency about the consequences of the false principle about which they agreed initially, namely, God behaves in a necessary manner in regard to everything outside him that his action affects immediately or mediately.[96]

This discussion leads to one of those foundational divergences between philosophers and theologians, where no reconciliation is possible, because there are conflicting principles. Why do Aristotle and Avicenna judge that God acts necessarily? Clearly, it is because in their view necessity is a more perfect mode than contingency, from which it follows that the most perfect cause must act with necessity. Let us add, because Duns Scotus know it, that the argument he has just used in favor of contingency seems capable of being twisted around in favor of necessity. There is contingency in the world, we said. Therefore there must be contingency in the first cause. No doubt there

is, but there is also necessity in the world. Therefore, we can say, the first cause must cause its effect with necessity. To convince oneself that there is necessity in the world, it is enough to see natural causes act. The causes are essentially ordered, and in an order of this kind, what comes later can only be necessary if what comes first is necessary too. Since the connections of effects to their causes are necessarily ordered, none of them can be necessary unless the connection of the first effect to its cause is already necessary.[97]

Duns Scotus's response is instructive, because it makes clear that, since the philosophers' position is tied to a certain concept of the highest cause, this conception is what must be transformed if we wish to avoid the consequences the philosophers draw from it. They argue by going back to God's natural causality, as if what is true of second causes is also true of the first cause, that is, to forget that modes of causality always depend on the mode of being of causes. A second natural agent only acts because it needs to produce or needs what it produces. In a certain sense, its causality is necessary for its own perfection, but the same does not hold for the first cause, which obtains no benefit from its effects.[98] So the new idea of an infinite being, perfect *in the order of being itself*, is really what separates the two conceptions of the universe.

It is true, and Duns Scotus is aware of it, that Avicenna itself interprets the First's causality as *liberality*. The Platonic fecundity of the Good reappears in Scotus's doctrine. The First's effect is not the goal of his act as if causing perfection in another stems from the First's being; the perfection the First causes adds nothing to his own; it only stems from his own perfection.[99] Accordingly, it does not seem impossible that the First causes necessarily and by pure liberality at the same time, which would allow us to understand that the world is at the same time the work of a perfect cause and necessarily caused.[100] In a universe conceived in this way, it remains true to say that the First acts with a view to an end, which is himself, not because he needs the end, but because he is it.

To answer this objection we must narrow down even more the point where the two doctrines part company, that is to say the relation of the first cause to

the possibles. According to Avicenna, the intelligibles flow necessarily from God in the sense that his intellect knows their necessity both in themselves and in the order of their necessary connections. The totality of the possible is offered to God in a state of complete determination, and his liberality, which is only another name for his will, has nothing to do but give them existence according to the same order in which his intellect knows them. Here, there is no trace of a will of God that by choosing freely among the infinity of creatable essences, as in Duns Scotus, decrees which of them will be effectively realized. Avicenna's First has no choice. A possible that will never be called to be realized in the course of an infinite duration would be a de facto impossible. That is why every possible necessarily exists once by virtue of the First.

We see better than ever how important the demonstration of the existence of an *ens infinitum* is for Duns Scotus, because, if God is truly infinite *in being* and not only in power or intelligence, he is thereby infinitely perfect, so that nothing that can be outside him fails to be bound to him by a necessary relation. Because his essence is perfect good, his will cannot fail to want it, but there is nothing else that it wants with a necessary will, because nothing else is a good such that it must be necessarily wanted. A will fixed on an essence that is necessary and per se is not bound to want what only has an accidental relation to this object. Creatures have no essential relation to God whose essence is self-sufficient. Therefore he does not have to want them for himself as if they were means essentially ordered to the end that is himself. They add nothing to him. He does not need them either to be or to know himself.[101] Consequently, they do not impose themselves on his will necessarily.

At the same time, we see why, though Duns Scotus attributed to the ideas a *diminutive* being of known object, he always refused to make a subjectively real being out of this *esse objectivum*. If he had attributed its own subjective reality to the idea instead of positing it as an object whose complete entity resides in the fact of *being known*, he would have made divine intellection into a creator of beings that were eternal and necessary like it. Accordingly,

God's will must freely intervene in the choice of possible to be realized in order for God alone to be necessary.[102] Again, it is useful to note that even this voluntary choice is not the creator of being. Just as the divine intellect produces the idea into known *esse*, *esse cognitum*, the divine will produces the possible into willed *esse*, *esse volitum*. These two operations, which are eternal, do not cause any existence of themselves. This is even why God's freedom in respect to the contingent resides primarily and inherently, not in the process of producing an act that is identified with its essence but in transforming a willable *esse*, *esse volibile* into *esse volitum*. When the wantable is produced as wanted, the divine will attains its term in that.[103] For the wanted to become an existence in its turn, God's executive power must intervene. The creation of contingents by God's power finishes what their election by his will began.

D Creation of the contingents

A relation of necessity between things and God is declared impossible not on the side of the thing but on God's side. A supremely necessary being is a self-sufficient being, that is, one who can exist just as he is, even if nothing else exists. To posit that a possible should be connected to him by a necessary bond, if we take *necessary* in the full meaning of the term, is not only to admit that the effect cannot exist without its cause, but that its cause is itself necessarily determined to produce it. It is as much as to say that the cause could no more exist without the effect than the effect without the cause. Consequently, it would not be necessary. For the cause to be necessary, it is necessary that it can exist without the effect, and that if it causes the effect, it causes it freely.[104]

To cause freely possible beings whose existence is in no way necessary is to create them. Evidently, in the thinking of philosophers the concept of creation meets difficulties that we have already indicated. The difficulties are exactly the same, or rather, the difficulty is the same. We have to choose between a universe of immutability, necessity, and eternity, and a universe of

novelty, contingency, and temporality. Creation only poses the same problem under an extreme form, because for God to create the world from nothing, we must admit that he does something he had never done, that is to say, that God is subject to mutability. This is all the more true in that it is hard to see why God would suddenly take this decision. It could not be by chance, since God acts for himself, being the highest end. It could not be by nature, because what acts by nature has no choice about time. It could not be by will, because having the power to produce the world at any moment, we cannot see why one time would seem better to God than another. Yet, Genesis says so: "In the beginning God created heaven and earth." *In principio creavit Deus coelum et terram*. Not only does Scripture affirm it, but also reason approves, because there is contingency in the world, and that can only be so if the world is created.

What is understood by creating *ex nihilo*? Since nothing is not anything, we must not understand that nothing is a matter out of which the world as made, as a chest is made from wood. The only possible sense of the expression is that before creation there is nothing, and after creation contingent being exists. We are dealing with an order of succession here and, if we may say so, of duration. It is still necessary to clarify the meaning of this, because it is not immediately clear how something could come after nothing or nonbeing could precede being.

To find a positive meaning for this expression, we return to the concept of *nature* yet again. Taken in itself, nature includes no determination, not even existence. Nor does nature exclude existence. It can receive existence, but it does not include existence, because it will only have existence if its efficient cause gives existence to it. Of itself nature is in nothing of existence, and in this sense, we can say that the absence of existence *precedes* its existence. Air is not luminous of itself. However, let us suppose it is eternally illuminated. That would not keep it from being dark by nature *before* being luminous in fact, because if one abstracts from the cause from which air gets its light, we find it as it is in itself, that is, nonluminous. In short, indifferent of itself to light or obscurity air remains essentially devoid of both. The same

holds here. Creatable essence, as God himself knows it, is without any essence of itself, so that in some way its own nothing of *esse* precedes it.[105] To create a nature from nothing is to confer existence on it after the nothing of existence, which precisely *qua* nature it permanently endures, and in this sense, we ask whether creation is possible.

It is important to establish exactly what Duns Scotus thinks of the philosophers' position on this point. It would be hard to imagine that he could have attributed the doctrine of creation *ex nihilo* to Aristotle, less because of the difficulty of finding texts to support the thesis than because to make Aristotle's God a creator in the strict sense would have been to approximate him oddly to the God of Christian theology. So, Duns Scotus does not say that Aristotle's God creates the world *ex nihilo*, but he very clearly says that nothing prevented Aristotle from maintaining it on the basis of his own principles.[106] After all, that is the only thing that matters, because even if the Philosopher had to refuse to assent to the consequences that can be deduced from his principles, it remains true to say that he ought to have demonstrated by natural reason the possibility of creation.[107]

Indeed, according to Aristotle himself it is certain that God can immediately cause an effect in the sense of there being no other effect interposed between him an it. An immediate effect of God is totally caused by him. Accordingly, God can cause an effect totally, which is exactly to create it. It is evident that God could immediately create an effect, because, to deny that, it would be necessary to admit that before the first effect there must be another, then another before the latter, and so on to infinity, which amounts to saying that God cannot cause anything at all. That the first effect is caused in the totality of its being is no less evident. For, since there is nothing between a cause and its immediate effect, the cause causes the entire effect. In Aristotle's doctrine, this is how the first Separate Intelligence, the Heavens, and (as Aristotle says himself) all nature depend on God.[108] Moreover, the consequence is inevitable, because the universe is made of parts that are essentially ordered among themselves and to the first cause. Everything that is essentially ordered to the first cause, precisely because it depends on the first cause in its

essence, only exists through the first cause. Thus the entire universe depends on a first, immediate effect that itself depends totally on the first cause and that we can rightly say is created, since it receives being after its own nonbeing without presupposing any other cause than God alone.[109]

So far, the issue is the immediate creation of separate substances that are formally necessary and eternal. Duns Scotus chose a case where matter is not taken into account. He was right to do so, because his intention was limited to proving that in Aristotle's doctrine, we find at least one case of total production of a being by God, namely, the production of the First Separate Intelligence. That is enough to establish that the concept of creation is rationally justifiable, which was what had to be demonstrated.

On the other hand, we find nothing in Aristotle that suggests that the creation of this world in time is philosophically demonstrable. This second thesis does not obviously follow from the first, because now the issue is no longer to prove that the existence of contingent nature is metaphysically subsequent to God, but rather that it is subsequent to him in the order of duration in the sense that after an eternity of nonexistence this nature begins to exist. Aristotle said nothing of the sort, adds Duns Scotus, but this does not prove that it is not demonstrable by natural reason, because we can know many things by natural reason of which the philosophers have said nothing, just as inversely, they affirm many things that are rationally undemonstrable. We will examine in turn the problem of creation and the problem of creation in time.[110]

In defining creation as "to produce something *from* nothing as an effect, "aliquid *de* nihilo producere in effectum," Duns Scotus points out that *from*, *de*, can be understood as indicating either priority of nature or temporal priority. It is clear that the philosophers admit the possibility of creation in the first sense. We can convince ourselves of that by reading Avicenna,[111] because this philosopher quite evidently taught a particular doctrine of creation that later drew Averroes's criticism and even sarcasm. That even makes it difficult to interpret Duns Scotus's thinking here. Averroes certainly saw what modifications Avicenna has imposed on Aristotle's doctrine, and he

correctly denounced their general cause. Avicenna, says Averroes, listened to the Muslim theologians and mixed his theology and theirs.[112] We are sure that Duns Scotus was aware of the reproach, because he took it from Averroes to direct it in his turn toward another doctrine of Avicenna. If there is a point where the reproach hits home, it is certainly in our present issue. Here, Duns Scotus invokes the example of a man whom he knows whose metaphysics betrays the influence of a certain theology in establishing that creation in time can be rationally demonstrated. Surely Scotus thought that if reason can find proofs in favor of a conclusion, it matters little who suggested them first, provided that they are authentic proofs. This is only a plausible hypothesis, but it has a fact in its favor: in the case of creation (which is not the same as the case of the intellect's first natural object), the proof Duns Scotus takes from Avicenna rests on a principle that Scotus himself never doubted was accessible through reason alone.

The issue, of course, is the Avicennist distinction between essence and existence in finite being, or more exactly, essence's existential neutrality that Scotus inherited from Avicenna. We may even say that Scotus reinforced it, because in Avicenna the possible always ends by existing, and the existence that the possible essence does not include in its notion sooner or later is bestowed on it by the Cause that is necessary inherently, On the other hand, by virtue of his very freedom, Duns Scotus's God, can eternally leave an infinity of possibles in nothing. Accordingly, there is no directly or indirectly necessary connection between essence as Duns Scotus conceives it and its actual existence.

That said, here is the argument Duns Scotus takes from Avicenna: "Considered *ex se* [of itself] the effect's nature does not have a reason to exist. Now, for the intellect, what is of itself [*ex se*] is prior [although not with a priority of duration], because its nature is to be by another. And this is what the Sages call *creation*," namely, to give being to a thing that was absolutely nothing.[113] In other words, in the order of duration, essence can have nothing itself, before its being is created, because up to that point it is nothing. But in the order of nature for the intellect that conceives the essence

in itself, it does not have something that makes it exist, because existence is not included in its concept. Still, let us specify that, of itself, the essence's quiddity does not imply that it exists or does not exist. The quiddity does not contain these determinations together or separately. Not to include being is different from including nonbeing. What Avicenna means, according to Duns Scotus and in reality, is that precisely as such "the creature would have no way of existing if an extrinsic cause did not confer existence upon it," or to put it better, "if an extrinsic cause did not exclude its non-being by giving it being." Consequently, let us not say that the creature's nature is to not exist but that (taken formally and in itself) its nature is not to exist.[114] In short, if essences exist that do not have their own reason of being within them, their existence can only come from a creation.

Duns Scotus's position in regard to Aristotle and Avicenna here is worthy of attention. For Scotus these two philosophers are equally in error in that both conceive as necessary God's relation to everything that comes from him either immediately or by an immutable intermediary. The only contingency they acknowledge is that of chance and evil, which is explained by the insertion of matter between the first cause and its ultimate effects. They are wrong in that, but Avicenna is not wrong to maintain, despite Averroes, that an effect that is only possible of itself might become necessary by its cause. Whatever we say about that, there is no contradiction, precisely because, according to Avicenna, of itself a possible is neither necessarily existent nor necessarily nonexistent. Since the possible implies neither of these determinations in any sense, it is difficult to see why it would not receive one or the other indifferently or even one and the other successively.[115]

Let us retain simply that, according to Duns Scotus, the finite essence's existential neutrality has the necessary consequence that, if it exists, its existence must have been given it by another, and given completely, integrally, and absolutely. That is certainly necessary; since its essence strictly includes nothing that permits it to exist, it exists truly *from nothing* in what it is of itself. Caused *from nothing*, it is created. Consequently, every finite actual existence presupposes its creation.

The argument is clear, but we can ask once more whether we are dealing with a *philosopher's* proof or a *theologian's* proof. Obviously, the proof invokes Avicenna, but beside the fact that Avicenna is not free of all theology, his position is not identical to Duns Scotus's. Avicenna admits that an angel can create *ex nihilo*, although it was created itself. Duns Scotus does not admit that, because in his mind, the concept of creation is inseparable from that of immediate causality, while the angel is a mediate cause, whose being at least must have been created before it creates in its turn. The authentically Scotist proof of the possibility of the creative act, the one he offers as his after having rejected the others, is that God can *cause and make something immediately*. This is so true that if God could not cause certain beings immediately, that is to say without intermediate causes, he could cause no effect, even mediately, because he would not be the cause of the cause. It is impossible to doubt the doctrine's meaning. To say that God creates is as much as to say: "He produces immediately without any act being presupposed," *immediate producit nullo acto praesupposito*.[116] Moreover, we know that this power of immediate production without intermediary cause being necessarily required is the very thing that Duns Scotus calls divine omnipotence, understood in the sense in which we see that *the Catholics* believe it without being able to demonstrate it. If the Scotist proof of creation presupposes a gift of faith, can we regard it as a proof in philosophy?

It is necessary to distinguish. Duns Scotus does not doubt that Avicenna[117] and perhaps even Aristotle taught the *immediate production* of the First Separate Intelligence by God. Accordingly, in the doctrine of the philosophers, there is at least one being whom God created. It seems to follow that the concept of creation is naturally demonstrable. Duns Scotus's position differs from that of the *philosophers* in other points. First, divine omnipotence, as the Catholics conceive it, is free. Duns Scotus never claimed that the *philosophers* conceived the production of the first created being by the creator as free. Next, the creation that the *philosophers* discuss stops at the first caused thing, because it is the only being *immediately* caused. If we admit with Duns Scotus that to create is to cause all beings *ex nihilo*,

immediately and without intermediary causes, the concept of creation requires the concept of omnipotence as the *Catholici* understand it; for them God created everything at once, directly and immediately, without the humblest and least of his effects owing what it is to another cause than God's creative omnipotence. This is why, in reading Duns Scotus, we would not be wrong to think that here the theologian overtakes the philosopher. In Scotus's view, the facts prove that the concept of creation is naturally accessible to reason up to the point that the philosophers effectively reach. Beyond that point, the concept receives a much more absolute meaning than natural reason approves, certainly, but also one which natural reason was unable to discover and could not demonstrate.

Perhaps this will be seen better by examining the second part of the problem: does reason prove that the world was created from all eternity or that it began in time? Naturally, the *philosophers'* block stands solidly united against the *theologians'* block here. If creation is understood as implying a finite duration of time at least in the past, "creation is generally denied by philosophers," *negatur communiter creatio a philosophis*. That was inevitable. Since the *philosophers* taught that God necessarily produces what he produces immediately, and since it is still God who produces what he produces mediately, that is, through the intervention of second causes, we can say that not a single one of God's effects, immediate or not, is produced in a contingent way,[118] from which it follows that creation exists from all eternity.

Obviously, a God whose action is thus necessary, and naturally necessary, could not produce anything that would be new. But at the point we have reached, Duns Scotus has already proven that God causes every effect external to himself in a contingent manner. When the discussion of divine immutability offers him the opportunity to do so, he immediately seized it. Accordingly, the question is no longer to know whether God can cause a contingent effect, but rather, a contingent effect that is new. There appears to be no reason why this is impossible. Since God's will is immutable, we cannot admit that, after willing contingent A's existence, God should change his mind and wish that A not exist. Consequently, we do not admit that there

might be something new in relation to the divine volition itself. But if we are dealing with the *production* of a new effect and no longer with a new *volition*, the problem is different. The product can be new without the producer's volition ceasing to be immutable. Let us take an imaginary and imperfect example, but one that will suggest the meaning of this thesis. We can admit that the sun is always equally luminous and always casts its light equally around itself. Let us suppose that a transparent medium is created to carry the sun's rays. The sun is going to illuminate it without thereby modifying its proper action in any way. But let us suppose that solar energy also has something that conserves this medium in being. The sun would conserve the medium by continuing to act as it acts. What would be true of the sun would be even truer of God. Producing demands no effort from the creator, and if he creates, something happens to the creature, not to him. Eternal or temporal creation does not bind the divine essence at all. In this regard, it is completely unimportant whether what God produces is eternal or new. What is true is that *if God caused necessarily*, his causality would be exercised eternally, and its effects would be necessarily eternal. In this sense, it is natural that, having conceived God's action as necessary, the philosophers should maintain the eternity of the world. But since God causes in a contingent manner, he can cause something new, as he could cause something eternal.[119] For that, it is enough that his free will should eternally want the existence of a temporal being.

Therefore, the creation of a temporal being by a free first cause is naturally *possible*, but we cannot climb beyond that and say why this possible is actually realized. In other words, since our first principle of explanation here is a free will, the question of knowing what could have been its cause is meaningless. This will is the cause here; it has no cause itself. Aristotle said that there is no demonstration of the principle of demonstration.[120] That remains true even of contingents, because, since contingents cannot result from the necessary, we must stop at a first contingent or go on to the infinite in the series of causes. Thus,

> It is God's will itself, by which he wants *this* effect and produces it *at a given moment*, that is the immediate and first cause for which another cause is not to be sought. Just as there is no reason for God to have willed that human nature should exist in a particular individual, and that it should be possible and contingent in him, so also there is no reason for God to have willed that such and such a thing was now and not later. It is only because he wanted the thing to be that it was good that the thing was, and to seek the cause of this proposition, although it is immediately contingent, is to seek for the cause or reason of what has no cause or reason to seek.[121]

Here, Duns Scotus seems to remember that in the book of Genesis God first creates beings and only then says that they are *valde bona*.

This last point has its importance. Ridiculing the idea of creation of the world in time, Averroes asked what God was waiting so long for, before he made up his mind to create. Evidently nothing! In a sense, Averroes was right, but not as he thought, because his ironic question supposes that God's will gets its goodness from the object he wants, which is only the case for our will. When our will is righteous, and if what it wants is good, it does it immediately unless it has some reason to prefer another thing, in which case it will wait for a more propitious moment to accomplish its first object. Accordingly, in regard to a human being, it is licit to ask why he or she has to wait to act. But here we speak about God. His will does not owe its goodness to its object. Completely to the contrary, the object has its goodness from the goodness of God's will. There is no necessary reason why God should wish anything new. Absolutely speaking, there is not even a necessary reason why God should wish anything. In short, God can find no occasion for *waiting* within the nature of what he wishes.[122]

The thesis's purity, one might almost say, its harshness, is impressive. But to understand it, it is necessary to place oneself on its level, which is that of a theologian who speaks to the philosopher in the only language the philosopher understands. What does Duns Scotus do here? Against Averroes, Avicenna, and Aristotle, he establishes the *possibility* of the creation of the world in time. To be valid, his proof must be purely rational and the

principle, upon which it rests, is that the infinite being can know only itself as the necessary object of its will. So, in relation to the *ens infinitum*, everything else is contingent. But, to say that the rest is contingent is equivalent to saying that nothing in the rest has a way of moving the divine will with enough force to motivate its choice. However much we pile up all the *reasons for willing* in our imagination, they will never explain that God should will anything other than himself, because the distance between anything else and him is infinite. Moreover, until God wills it, there is not *anything else but him*, and how are we to find reasons *for willing something* that can have nothing good in it, because it still has no being? Strictly speaking, God's pure will is the only conceivable cause of the creation of the world in which we are with the beginning in time that it entails. But the theologian gives reasons to the philosopher starting from a concept of infinite being, which transcend the level of metaphysical speculations and that the philosopher, *qua* philosopher, does not attain. Even when the theologian talks about will, he thinks *charity* and *love*. Nowhere more than here is the historian who studies Duns Scotus's rational speculation aware of the error of perspective to which he exposes his reader, even when he protects himself from it. There is no *metaphysical synthesis* in Duns Scotus, or, if there is one, it does not represent his total view of the world. The only complete synthesis that Duns Scotus knew is a theological synthesis, whose nucleus is found in the phrase of St. John: "God is love," *Deus caritas est* (I John 4:16). It has been rightly said that from there all the fundamental thesis regarding God's relations *ad extra* are clarified,[123] including the only conceivable reason for the creation of the world and the motive for the Incarnation. It would be an injustice and an absurdity to narrow what to begin with was primarily a theologian's view of the world down to the dimensions of metaphysics.

Duns Scotus's position remains to be situated in relation to the positions of his predecessors, which he did himself several times. His own conclusion comes down to saying, first of all, that God can produce *ad extra* and do so in a contingent way. Next, that nothing necessitates his producing the world from all eternity.[124] Accordingly, if revelation teaches that the created world

had a beginning, there are metaphysical proofs that it is not *impossible*. There are even necessary proofs of the possibility of this fact. Here theology can expect nothing else from dialectic. However, certain theologians adopt more extreme positions. One claims creation in time is only true by faith and fears lest Christian belief be ridiculed in the eyes of the infidels by justifying creation in time by sophistical arguments.[125] Another maintains, to the contrary, that we can demonstrate the impossibility of an eternal creation, which implies that there was a beginning, since the world exists.[126]

On the first point, Duns Scotus is in complete agreement with St. Thomas that it is wrong and even harmful to faith to invoke sophistical reasons to defend faith. But Duns Scotus maintains that it is good to invoke necessary reasons, if there are any. In any case, it is not dangerous for anyone, whether they are faithful or infidels. It is not harmful to the faithful, because by using reasons to rediscover the truth of what they believe, Catholic theologians do not intend to strip faith of its merit. Like Anselm and Augustine, who furthermore follow the command of Isa. 7:9, all their effort aims at understanding what they believe. How can we blame a Christian for seeking comprehension of his faith? But it is not dangerous for infidels either, because we do not claim to prove the article of faith itself to them by necessary reasons, but simply its possibility. This is of interest because, by establishing these reasons, the person who puts them forward at least persuades the unbeliever that he does not have to reject the articles of faith under the sole pretext that they are rationally impossible.[127] If the unbeliever resists the article of faith for that reason, we at least will have eliminated this obstacle, and in that measure contributed to persuading him.

Duns Scotus's position is less in conflict with St. Thomas's than it seems at first glance. They use two different languages to say almost the same thing. The necessary reasons, *rationes necessariae*, and true demonstrations, *verae demonstrationes*,[128] of which Duns Scotus speaks here simply seek to prove that, since God is free, he might as well have created the world eternal as limited in time. This, in brief, is what St. Thomas says, for whom faith alone guaranteed that the world did not always exist. As to the so-called

demonstrations of those who believe that they can prove that the world had a beginning, Duns Scotus is satisfied to establish against them that the reasons are not at all necessary. A fairly good indicating is that the philosophers could have taught the eternity of the world without seeing any contradiction in it.[129] Reasons are not lacking. First, we have said that there is no way of finding a cause of God's will, which is without cause. Therefore, we cannot prove that he must have wanted to create the world temporal rather than eternal. This is the fundamental reason and the one to which Duns Scotus himself resorts: necessarily true, *verum necessarium*, settles the question. Other reasons are dialectical in the sense that they add a varnish of probability to the possibility of the eternity of the world, but there are also probabilities in the opposite direction, and this is completely natural, since we know that God *could have* created the world eternal as he created it temporal. Whether he did it or not, the reasons stay the same. We will never find a necessary reason to justify a contingent act *a priori*.

On the one hand, a creature's duration adds nothing to its perfection. A man who lives ten years is not more perfect than one who lives one day. Consequently, an eternal creation would not be more perfect or less perfect than one that began in time. Let us add that what makes the creature as such is its failure to possess its existence of itself. It is said that left to itself the creature tends to nothingness: *tendit in non esse . . . quia est ex nihilo*. This is true, but it would also be true of an eternal creation. If there were one, it would eternally tend toward nothingness of itself. Moreover, this is the case of the angels and souls that never will cease either to depend on God in their being and yet they will never cease to exist. Accordingly, there is no contradiction between being an eternal universe and being a universe that, in what is of itself, would tend toward nothingness.[130] As for the well-known objection that if an infinite number of days had gone by (which would be the case in the hypothesis of an eternal world) God must have already created infinity of souls, it is excessively naive. God is represented as creating a soul each day, whence the conclusion that an infinite number of days would entail an infinite number of souls, although an actual infinite number is impossible.

But how can one fail to see that the problem is the same for a world that only lasts one day? For a day consists of an infinity of instants. Even a single hour is composed of an infinity of instants, in each of which God can create a soul, as he could have done in each day of an infinite past, if there were one. Obviously, the actual existence of an infinity of souls is impossible. To create this infinity of souls is not something feasible in itself, because actual infinity in number implies contradiction. This is why God does not create an infinity of souls in a day. But for the same reason, he could not have created this infinity of souls if there had been an infinity of days in the eternity of the past.[131]

On the other hand, we can argue in order to establish that the concept of *creation without beginning* is a contradictory concept. For example, we would say that in an eternal universe conservation and creation by God would be identical. In other words, there would be no place for creation, only conservation.—Or again, we might say that the creature was possible for all eternity, and for this reason capable of being or not being. For the creature to have being, it must have received it, acquired it. Therefore, its nonbeing must have preceded in duration the new being it acquired after creation.—Or again, as we just said, if the world had not begun, there would be an infinity of souls.[132] It is true that the argument is refutable and even that we have refuted it, but that does not prevent the possibility that the thesis in question might be true of itself.—This alone matters to us: it is rationally possible that the world had a beginning. So, Duns Scotus dismisses, back to back, the defenders of these two opposed positions, because they pursue the same phantom, the necessary cause of a contingent effect.

E The production of being

Theologians commonly agree that to be created inserts the finite being into a relation with God, but they do not reach an agreement about the nature of this relation. Here we understand the word *creation* not in the somewhat active sense of the term when it designates the creative act, but in the passive sense

that it is given when it designates in the creature the fact that it is created. We easily see what justifies this acceptation of the term. Even if the fact of being created is only a relation to God, the nature of this relation poses problems. It can be considered real or as a being of reason. If it is posited as real, we can again posit it as really distinct from the creature's being or as identical to it, as long as it is distinguished abstractly in one way or the other. Since the decision taken necessarily affects the finite's ontological status in its totality, it is interesting to know what Duns Scotus thinks on the issue.

In this relation, the creature plays the role of basis, because the problem of its relation to God is posed from the moment in which it exists. According to Duns Scotus, the relation is the same for all creatures, and it is really identical to its basis. Consequently, creation is only the creature itself in its relation of dependence on God. However, since we speak of creation, the word must be distinguished from the creature in some sense. Duns Scotus grants this. In his view, creation is not formally the creature. Accordingly, creation is not adequately identical to the creature. To be exact, creation is the creature formally taken as the basis of its relation to God.

Let us start by establishing the first point. We can consider as really identical to its subject that which is united to it in such a way that this subject could not exist without it. In other words, if it would be contradictory that a being should exist without a certain relation, the latter is identical to it. This is the case of a creature, for example, a stone. The relation to God is strictly inherent in the stone, and without the relation to God it would be contradictory for the stone to exist. Therefore, this relation is identical to the stone. But let us go further. What is strictly inherent in a being as a relation is found there as in its basis. The basis is naturally prior to the relation whose basis it is. If the basis cannot exist without the relation whose basis it is, as in the case here, then the basis is really identical to the relation. Indeed, just as it is contradictory to the status of creature that the stone should exist without God, it is contradictory that the stone should exist without dependence in regard to God. Therefore, we cannot introduce a real distinction between the creature and the necessary relation to God, namely creation, of which the

creature is the basis.[133]

We can establish the same conclusion differently. A relation to God that can be uniformly affirmed of everything that is not God cannot be accidental. What we call *creation* is a relation common to every creature and is said uniformly in regard to God of everything that is not God. That could not be an accident in any creature. The relation has its basis in the creature's essence. Therefore, it is really identical to its basis. Furthermore, we can be sure this is the case. Let us suppose that the relation of effect to cause is accidental in the stone. The stone would have its proper being as an accident. (Let us not forget that in Duns Scotus the accident has its being as the substance has its being.) Therefore, the relation would be something other than the stone and as such it would have to have itself a relation of effect to cause in regard to God. But in its turn, this relation would be an accident whose being would require another relation and so on to infinity. Consequently, in the relation of creature to creator the relation must necessarily be identical to its basis.[134]

But we also said that the relation of creature to God is not formally identical to its basis. Why this formal distinction?

Let us first note that the formal distinction introduces no real difference between the terms that it distinguishes. There is formal distinction between two terms, or rather these terms are formally two, when the intellect apprehends them under two different reasons. By contrast, everything that the intellect apprehends under one and the same reason is formally identical. Here, the intellect first apprehends the creature in itself and as an absolute. Then it apprehends the relation of effect to cause that binds the creature to God. Evidently, the creature cannot exist without this relation, and this is why they are really identical, but the formal reason of the absolute is self-sufficient without the formal reason of the relation, and, if we think about it, the formal reason of the relation does not include the formal reason of the absolute, which requires a distinct intellection to be grasped in itself. Let us go further. Even if we grasp the absolute term as *basis*, it still is not the relation strictly, because the basis of a relation is not a relation, any more than

one relation can be the basis of another.[135] With that we see how there can be both real identity and formal distinction between the basis and the relation. In being, creature is identical to creation, without which it would be nothing. In our thought, the creation by which the creature exists is a formal distinct object from the being that serves as the basis for this relation.

Perhaps this time it seems that Duns Scotus is unnecessarily subtle, but let us remember that the theologian who is so keen on metaphysics is on his own ground here. What interests him is the connection of the relation to its real basis. What he intends to establish is that in this connection the basis really includes the relation. This is obviously so where the relation between divine persons is identical to its basis, not by virtue of the relation's perfection, as if it contained the essence in the mode of identity, but by virtue of the essence's formal infinity, which makes the essence contain the relation within itself in the mode of identity. At its moment, we scrutinized this dialectic, proper to God by reason of his infinity. However, even in God, that which contains is not formally the contained.[136] The essence precisely as such is not the relation precisely as such. This is so in creatures with greater reason. What contains is not the contained there, but as it is the subject that is the basis for the relation, it is as perfect as if the contained were external to it and had been added to it. Let us say rather that its reality is only more perfect this way, because it is by virtue of its perfection that it contains all other entity. The basis in the case in question is like this. The relation whose basis it is is identical to it, because it contains the relation so perfectly in its substance that the relation cannot be an accident for it. Therefore, this identity is grounded in the perfection of the created subject. Essence is first in the creature as in God.

But what is the creative act itself? Is the creature, which is the term something there of itself, or must we say that this act is wholly and exclusively God's work.

Theologians generally grant this second conclusion, and perhaps it must be admitted, but not all the reasons that are given for it are valid. *Esse* pure and simple (*simpliciter*) is God's proper effect, some say. Pure and simple being

is the proper term of creation, which consists in giving being. Therefore, God alone can be creator. Here we immediately realize St. Thomas Aquinas's "doctrine about the mode of emanation of things from the first principle," *doctrina de modo emanationis rerum a primo principio*.[137] The heart of the problem is finding out whether it is true to say "*esse* in the strict sense is God's proper effect," *esse simpliciter est proprius effectus Dei*, which is necessary in Thomism, or since God is absolute *Esse*, his proper effect can only be *esse*. But Scotism is not a doctrine of *esse* in the sense of *actus essendi*. Instead of being its act of existing, what Scotus calls the thing's *esse* is everything that it is. In a Scotist perspective, every cause that produces any effect whatsoever necessarily produces *esse*. Duns Scotus calmly objects this against Thomas Aquinas, as if the argument and the response were not posited in two mutually alien metaphysical universes: "By whatever efficient cause the composite is engendered, that same thing causes the composite's *esse* effectively. Now, there are composites engendered by created causes." Therefore, a created cause can cause *esse*, and this is not the proper effect of God.[138] What Thomas Aquinas said of the *esse* whose essence is to exist is not refuted. Everything transpires as if it had not been said.

But there is something more interesting yet, because Duns Scotus certainly saw what an equivocation is hidden in the words *universal* or *more universal*. St. Thomas himself, moreover, denounced it by warning his readers not to confuse causal universality, which stems from the cause's perfection, with universality of predication, which is only simple generality. Duns Scotus saw very clearly that for Thomas Aquinas's argument to have sense, universality had to be understood in a causal sense, that is to say, as the universality of the cause's very efficacy. Only (and here is the misunderstanding that is extraordinarily interesting), Duns Scotus denies that the universality of *esse* can be understood in this sense. Let us not lose this privileged opportunity to confront these two metaphysics of being in the central point of their opposition. Duns Scotus sees a major premise in the Thomist argument: God is the universal cause where the cause's universality can only be the universality of its perfection. Duns Scotus sees a minor premise next: now,

being is the most perfect universal effect, here in order for the argument not to be equivocal, it would be necessary for the effect's universality to be equally its perfection's universality. This is precisely what Duns Scotus considers impossible. "Indeed, *esse* is not the most perfect effect, because what is included in many others cannot be more perfect than any one of those in which it is included." It is impossible to escape this. God is the universal cause in perfection. Therefore, we cannot attribute to him as something proper an effect that is universal in predication. Or else, if *esse* were a universal effect, with universality of predication, it would be necessary that the universality of its cause, who is God, should also be of the order of predication. In short, if the major is true, the minor is false; if the minor is true, the major is false. We are in a circle.[139]

This whole dialectic is excellent in itself, but it hides the nucleus of the debate. The point is exactly to find out whether, because *esse* is included in many other things, it is true to say "*esse* is not the most perfect effect," *non enim esse est perfectissimus effectus*. We are no longer dealing with dialectics, but with a metaphysical option. Everything depends on the sense we give the word *esse*. For Thomas Aquinas, as for Duns Scotus, "esse is included in many," *esse includitur in multis*, but each being has its own *esse*, precisely by virtue of which it is a being, and it is that which is most intimate in it: *illud quod est magis intimum cuilibet et quod profundius omnibus inest*.[140] This is certainly why God alone can be the cause and his omnipresence at the heart of his effects can be rationally demonstrated! Everything is linked: "And since the thing's form is within the thing, it is all the more considered prior and more universal; and God himself is properly the cause of universal *esse* itself in all things, which is what is most intimate to all things."[141] Accordingly, there is the thing. In the thing, there is the form. In the form, there is *esse*, which is the most universal effect, not simply in the order of predication, but in the order of perfection, because there is an *esse* in each being, and because it is what is most perfect in its being, since it is the act of all the rest. This whole dialectic is excellent, but if we substitute Scotist *esse* for Thomist *esse* in the dialectic, nothing works anymore,

because Duns Scotus's *esse* is nothing but univocal being, that common being, *ens commune*, whose very indetermination is the basis of the predication's generality. What Thomas Aquinas thinks has no role in the business, something all too natural, because a philosopher who reads another translates the other philosopher's language into his own. In fact, for Duns Scotus, Thomas Aquinas has no right to attribute any other universality to create *esse* than that of predication.

We have not successfully reached the end of these instructive misunderstandings, because Thomas Aquinas proposes a second principal reason in favor of his conclusion, as follows. An efficient cause's efficacy is not measured only in the substance of what it produces, but in its manner of producing it. More intense heat does not only heat more but more quickly. In the case of creation, we might maintain that to create a finite effect does not require infinite power, but an infinite power is necessary to create it *ex nihilo*. The productive cause must be all the more powerful in the measure that what it produces is further from being in act. In the case of natural production, the cause always has only to make its effect pass from potency to act, and as the distance of an act from its potency is always finite, a finite cause can suffice for it. But in the case of creation, the issue is to make a being pass from nothing to act, and since from any act to its own nothingness, there is no proportion, only infinite power can produce in this way. Since no creation has infinite power, God alone can create.[142]

The argument perfectly corresponds to Duns Scotus's critique, because it comes down to this: from nothing to existence the distance is infinite, so that however impoverished the substance may be, provided only that it is, a being starting from nothing can only receive existence by virtue of God's infinite power. This reasoning makes sense only if we take Thomist *esse* into consideration, that is to say, an *actus essendi* between which and nothing no middle term is conceived. But if we suppress this *esse*, what becomes of the argument?

We speak of infinite distance in the argument. From God's viewpoint, it is clear that the distance between him and the most perfect creature possible is

always infinite, but this stems only from God's own infinity. The distance between God and any creature is measured by the amount of being by which God exceeds creature, and as the quantity is infinite, the distance between them is necessarily infinite. Therefore, God's own greatness, not the creature's smallness, puts this distance between them, and the problem is not changed by substituting the nothingness for a creature as the argument's starting point. For since nothingness only differs from being by defect, a nothing cannot lack more being than the being (whose nothing it is) contains. In other words, the distance of a being to nothing is always proportional to what it is. In God, the distance is infinite because he himself is infinite. In the creature the distance is finite, like the being of the creature itself. That is the principal reason that governs this reply: "However, *nothing* is not further from a being than what this being posits."[143] If a nothing of being cannot lack more being than there would be in this being (and the proof is that between one nothing and another there is no distance), the creation of the finite does not require an infinite power, or in any case, not for this reason. The conclusion is logical in a doctrine where, since the real substance of the being consists above all in what it is, we do not have to set apart the problem of existence. There is an infinite distance between existing and not existing, but the distance from something's being something to nothing is exactly measured by the quantity of finite being that something is.

In fact, the philosophers admitted that a created being could create in its turn. This is the case of Avicenna, who teaches that the Second Intelligence produces the Third Intelligence, which in turn produces the Fourth, and so on.[144] By the way Avicenna speaks, we see that he views the Second Intelligence as a creator, and that these productions are certainly by creatures, that is, productions "from nothing, that is, after nothing, not in the order of duration, but of nature."[145] We have production without any presupposition. Moreover, we know how things happen in Avicenna's doctrine, where, since a cause that is absolutely one can immediately produce only one effect, a plurality of Intelligences cannot emanate immediately from the unique simple cause that is God. Thomas Aquinas intends to refute Avicenna by objecting

that what shares a certain nature can only communicate it in its turn by introducing it into some particular matter. God alone is his own *esse*. Therefore, no creature can give *esse* pure and simple, which is to say, create. This is particularly evident where we are dealing with Intelligences that are pure forms and, in the absence of matter to which they could be applied, cannot be produced without being created. Accordingly, Thomas Aquinas says that we can admit that an Intelligence acts upon another to perfect it, but not to produce it.[146]

Having arrived at this point, Duns Scotus himself feels that the dialogue becomes impossible. Thomas Aquinas reasons as if humans were individuated by matter, which is false; as if the Separated Intelligence were individuated by its form, which is false; and as if something that participates in being could only produce it in turn by transmitting it to something else. For Scotus the very concept of *possible participation* in being is contradictory because, in order to participate in being, it is necessary to be, that is, it is necessary to have being in order to be in a position to receive it. Finally (because this is where we must always return), what is this *esse* they tell us about? In the first interpretation, nothing proves that a finite being could not create, because, if *esse* presupposes an essence that receives it, the essence itself presupposes nothing, so that, although the effect is not created as to existence, it would be created at any rate as to essence. In the second hypothesis, it is all too clear that it is possible for a creature to create being, because each time one of them produces another, it makes it exist. Each individual participates in the nature of the species, but the species can be the origin of generation in one individual and the term in another. In each singular it is both participated and the productive cause of another singular. Matter plays no role in this business, because matter is not required for the production of a being to be possible; matter is required because the form that is part of the participated nature is the form of a material being.[147]

Accordingly, Duns Scotus does not admit that Thomas Aquinas successfully refuted Avicenna, but he does not conclude from this that Avicenna was right. It just remains to refute Avicenna better, which,

moreover, can be done by preparing a direct solution to the problem. For, when Avicenna says that an Intelligence produces the following one, he thinks that the prior Intelligence produces the next one by two acts, one of his intelligence, and the other of his will, which are accidents of the angelic substance. The accident is inferior to the substance, and since the less perfect cannot produce the more perfect, it is impossible to admit that the accidents of a Separated Intelligence should produce the substance of another Separated Intelligence: "However, nothing is the formal principle of producing something more perfect than itself. For if it produces univocally, it is equally perfect; if equivocally, it must be more perfect."[148] For this argument to be effective in Duns Scotus's view, the concept of creation must signify the act of producing the subject. Evidently, only a cause acting by its substance is capable of producing the substance taken in its very substantiality. An angel does not know by its substance, otherwise it would be infinite as would be the objects of its knowledge.[149] Neither its will nor its power is identical to its substance, which is true only in God himself. We see now not only that a substance alone can produce another being's substance, but even that it can only do so if it is infinite itself. The strictly Scotist reason that God can create is that he is the *infinite being*, not the pure act of existing.

What is creating in the full and strict sense of the word? It is to produce a being as principle and first cause, that is, by an action independent of any other cause higher than it. In other words, the creative cause is absolutely first, independent, sufficient, and capable of producing directly and alone its effect's very substance. It is immediately clear, and all theologians agree, that God alone can exercise creative action.[150] Therefore, God's exclusive privilege of creating must not be situated in the perfection of his *esse*, but in his essence's infinity. Let us not forget what the proofs of God's existence taught us: because God is first in being, he is also first in causality.

Consequently, let us admit that in the absolute sense, God alone causes being *qua principle*, but if we understand *principaliter* in a less absolute sense, opinions may very again. We can agree to call *principal cause* that which is not an instrumental cause but acts by itself in virtue of its proper,

intrinsic form, although its action is subordinated to the action of a superior cause. We ask then if it is possible to prove that a second cause thus understood, that is, which presupposes a first cause, is incapable of totally producing the totality of a being without presupposing anything *on the part of the effect*. In this precise sense, the creature would produce such an effect from this effect's nothingness, which would be to exercise a strictly creative activity, although by divine delegation. Why not? For that, it would suffice that a natural cause should contain eminently, and therefore virtually and actively, its effect's total perfection. As we will see further on, if there can be several angels of the same species, why could an angel not produce another angel, as fire lights another fire? Certain theologians even judge that if this is possible, it cannot be demonstrated but only believed. Others are content to say that every second cause requires a matter upon which it can act, while God's creative action does not presuppose any, which is true, but hardly helps us. To say that a cause requires matter to produce is to say that its efficacy is limited. We ask exactly whether it is impossible for a second cause to have enough efficacy to produce an effect without preexisting matter. To simply answer *no* is to suppose that the question is solved.[151] We must also look for the principle of the solution.

No principle is valid for all cases, and we must use several according to the different natures with which we are dealing. We will say, "No purely intellectual created nature can create a substance." Why? In refuting Avicenna, we just said that between such a nature and its effect, an accident always intervenes, such as its intellect or its will. "The same does not hold for God, whose intellection and will are his essence. That is why God can produce a substance by his intellection and his will, which a creature cannot do." Let us pass on to the material form. The answer will be the same, but for another reason. For, by nature, a created form is produced by its cause before (not necessarily in duration) it informs its matter or actualizes its potency. Otherwise, there would be *information* not creation. But no creature can produce a material form outside its matter. Otherwise, being capable of producing it separately, it could conserve it separately, which conflicts with

the very concept of material form, whose nature necessarily tends to being the substantial or accidental act of a matter. Thus, no material form can create anything, because the term of an action cannot be more dependent of matter than the form is, and because, if the existence of a form presupposes the matter in which it is, this action necessarily supposes the matter upon which it acts.[152]

Here is a first conclusion: *Nulla creatura potest principaliter creare*. But could not a creature create *qua* instrumental cause? We know Peter Lombard thought so. However, Duns Scotus does not admit it to be possible. First, it is not certain that every instrumental cause is active in the strict sense of the word, because an instrument only acts in virtue of a predisposition that foresees its employment with a view to the term to which its action tends. Creation does not presuppose any prior disposition. Nor does it presuppose anything that might help the efficacy of the active form to achieve its goal and realize its object. Therefore, no creature can be both instrumental and creative cause, because there is a contradiction between the terms there.[153] Consequently, a creature cannot create in general in any sense whatsoever in any capacity.

Unquestionably, this concept of creation coincides perfectly with the general spirit of Scotism and the metaphysics of substance that Scotism practices everywhere. When it comes to problems of efficacy, all solutions presuppose the involvement of causes, each of which, since they act within the limits of an essence, can only give what this essence has. The divine essence alone is per se, by virtue of its infinity. Therefore, the divine essence alone can be the unique and total cause of participated being. As participated being is only through God, who creates and conserves it, God alone can annihilate it by ceasing to conserve it.[154] On the other hand, while God conserves what is created, what is created can act of itself according to its nature and the efficacy appropriate to its degree of being. No new influence created by God is needed in the second cause for it to be able to exercise its action and produce its effects. Obviously, everything the second cause does, it certainly does more by virtue of the first cause than by virtue of itself,

because its own virtue comes to it from the first cause. But the first cause, which can dispense with the second cause, cannot make the second cause produce the effects that its particular nature fails to enable it to produce in some way. Within the limits of its nature, the second cause possesses a proper efficacy that the creative cause's general influence precisely permits it to exercise.

These conclusions draw our attention to an important point. The more we reflect upon Duns Scotus's doctrine, the more we are persuaded about two principles. The first is that every entity, reality, or substantiality falls within the order of the essence's quiddity. The next is that every production of existence ultimately falls within the order of causality, freedom, and will. In Scotus, the cause's efficacy does not flow from the act of being, *actus essendi*, which did not enter into the structure of being as distinct *esse*. Causality no longer goes back to the *Qui est* of Exodus, understood in the pure existential sense, as to its source. Where should it be situated then? Evidently in God's infinite essence, but within this essence everything is necessary, even love of free volition by which God loves himself. Consequently, insofar as the creature presupposes the free choice of contingents to which nothing necessitates the divine essence, in Duns Scotus creation calls for another mode of separation than what is introduced from the outset in Thomas Aquinas by the mere fact of something not being the *esse* that it has. In a theology whose metaphysics rests upon essences, the separation must go back to some relation between essences, which indeed occurs in Duns Scotus between the infinite essence and finite essences. It is their very finitude that, since it prevents them from necessitating the infinite will of the infinite good, is the basis of the radical contingency of their relation to the divine willing and being.

So far, we have spoken about creation exclusively from the viewpoint of the divine will, but its execution remains to be considered. The problem is equally important if we are interested in delimiting the competence of the philosophers. We have just seen what they lack in order to conceive creation as the Christians conceive it. The failure is not in conceiving the total

production of a being by another, but in understanding how the contingency of its production must be. The same problem is going to be posed regarding the mode of production itself. What God's will wishes, his power executes, and to create, the power must be omnipotence. "The active power of God is his omnipotence." Obviously, the intrinsic possibility of the essences escapes it. As we have said, these fall under neither the power nor the will of God but his understanding. Only existence falls directly under the domain of divine omnipotence. "Divine omnipotence is not the principle of anything, except according to its *esse* of existence."[155]

F Divine omnipotence

Christians believe God is all-powerful. It is an article of faith for them to such a degree that they cannot repeat the apostle's creed, *Credo in Deum patrem omnipotentem*,[156] without affirming that they believe it. Yet, does it follow that omnipotence is a truth demonstrable by natural reason? The simplest manner of clarifying the problem is to ask whether the philosophers have demonstrated that God is all-powerful, and first of all, whether they know it. We already know this customary posture of Duns Scotus. The usage that might be called *proof by the philosophers* is habitual in him. It is often a proof by absence, which is the case here. "No philosopher using natural reason, however perfectly he considers God from the point of view of his efficiency, admitted that God is all-powerful in the sense in which Catholics understand it."[157] Accordingly, there is a strictly Christian concept of divine omnipotence, which seems inaccessible to the natural reason of philosophers who pose the problem *qua* philosophers.

What is this concept? First, it is the notion of an active power, not a passive one, and more exactly, an active causal power. One who possesses it cannot exercise it in regard to himself or in regard to another whose essence is not causable. Consequently, it is not defined in the first place in relation to the possible in general, that is, in relation to what is simply opposed to the contradictory and the impossible. Nor does opposition to the necessary in

itself define it, that is to say to that whose *being* is but cannot be produced. This power extends to everything possible only in the sense of the *causable*, and if it is called *all*-powerful, it is in order to mark its character of universality in that order. There is nothing causable, that it is not capable of causing. Next, on the other hand, since *possible* is a *synonym* of causable (*prout possibile idem est quod causabile*), and since the point here is to cause being, we will also say that omnipotence extends to the totality of the creatable, *omnipotentia est ipsa potentia activa respectu cujuscumque creabilis*. Let us add a final specification: a causal power can exercise its action mediately or immediately, that is, either by the intermediary of other causes or by producing its effect, however remote it might be, without intermediary causes.[158] Absolute omnipotence, as Christians understand it, is the power of immediately creating all the creatable without passing through intermediate causes, and it is precisely what they attribute to God.

To the question of finding out whether the divine omnipotence thus understood is demonstrable, we cannot simply answer yes or no. Three different answers are legitimate from the viewpoint of the demonstration by the cause (*propter quid*), and two others are legitimate in the order of the demonstration from effects (*demonstratio quia*). Let us examine these five conclusions separately.

Concerning the demonstration by the cause, we can ask first whether the proposition is demonstrable in itself, or if its nature is not rather such that, once its terms are known, the truth imposes itself upon the intellect as evident. Let us recall that something known true of itself, *verum notum per se*, is that in itself and that it remains so in the doctrine of Duns Scotus independently of the limitations of the intellect that knows it. If this intellect is incapable of perceiving its evidence, the proposition in itself remains no less a truth known per se. This is what it is in the theology of God. In the theology of the blessed, God’s omnipotence, mediate and immediate, is at least reducible to the evidence of a principle. For every intellect that knows God’s essence intuitively, that is, God as this, *Deus ut hic*, there is no real distinction of powers in God, but they possess a formal order in him.

Accordingly, in a certain sense, we can say that the divine nature precedes the intellect, that the power follows next and the will to act outside God last. If this formal order were an order of real distinctions in God, his nature would have a certain intellect, therefore a certain will, and therefore a certain power; and since his essence is absolutely infinite, his power would be all-powerful in every sense of the term. Since the order of knowledge always follows the real order of knowability, the direct apprehension of the divine essence, as it is, entails the mediate knowledge of its abstract omnipotence, as corresponds to God's intellect and to his will. In this sense, the intellect of one of the blessed, for example, can know *propter quid*, that is to say, by the divine essence *qua* the cause, that God's absolute omnipotence necessarily follows from his essence. Perhaps someone might wonder about the *mediate* character of this knowledge, but that would be a mistake, because the divine omnipotence implies a relation to something other than God (*respectum ad extra*). As such, it does not correspond absolutely immediately either to God or to any divine person. Therefore, it is a truth known by itself and in virtue of its terms, including the order according to which the first, which is the essence, implies the absolute omnipotence, which is last here.

Let us go down a step to ask whether in the present state of humans, that is, outside the beatific vision or any supernatural rapture like that of St. Paul, divine omnipotence is demonstrable *by the cause*. Duns Scotus answers that it is, at least in theology and for the theologians. Here, he is certainly speaking of *our* theology, taken as *we* know it. Even under this form, it is science. It is true that our theology does not rest upon any intuitive knowledge of God, but intuition is not necessarily for there to be science. Abstraction is enough. The fact that we have no intuitive knowledge of God here below does not keep us from having a scientific knowledge of him. It would be different if existence were included in principle in the object of the science, because then we could have no science of God here below, except of course in the exceptional cases of mystical rapture. But since scientific knowledge abstracts from existence, theological science remains possible without the intuition of its object. Abstractive knowledge, like all the

knowledge that we have here below in the state in which we are, only requires sufficiently precise concepts to define its object, not intuition of its object's existence.[159] The proof of this is that, according to Aristotle's observation in *Metaphysics* VII, 13, every demonstration remains immutably that, without ever ceasing to be true. The objects of the demonstration can be corruptible and cease to exist without either their definition or the demonstration that concerns them being effected. For scientific knowledge to subsist in the soul when its objects no longer have actual existence, existence must not have of itself the reason of knowable object, or more exactly, existence must not enter into the reason of the object precisely insofar as it is knowable. This is why we say that the knowable remains immutable in knowledge and under its very reason of knowable, when it has ceased to exist in reality. In short, since the science abstracts from existence and since existence is not included in the scientifically knowable,[160] the fact that our theology does not involve any intuition of God as existing, does not keep it from being science, if not in the perfect sense, at least in the strict sense of the word.

If this point is granted, it is clear that the theology of the pilgrim sojourner can justify the possibility of divine omnipotence by necessary reasons. Where could its impossibility come from? An intellect capable of a concept virtually including all the necessary truths that depend on the concept, taken in the order in which they depend on it, can have the complete science of this object. Let us recall that the subject of our theology, which is God, is known to us by a very distinct concept, that of *ens infinitum*. This concept is accessible to us apart from any intuitive knowledge. It virtually and evidently contains all the necessary truths that depend on its subject. As to the contingent truths, since their very contingency excludes their being included in a subject, they cannot be known in this manner, but we can at least have necessary knowledge regarding their possibility. The concept of God does not necessarily include that he creates or that he resurrects the dead, because nothing necessitates God to do this, and even if he does it, that is by virtue of a contingent will. But at least the concept necessarily includes that God could

create, resurrect, and give beatitude to certain of his creatures, and so on for all the articles of faith regarding his contingent acts. In this life a person would be a perfect theologian if, conceiving God under the most perfect concept we can have of him outside any intuitive knowledge, he also knows all the necessary truths that follow from this concept, according to their order.[161] Since absolute omnipotence is one of those necessary truths, the theologian can justify it.

The same does not hold if we pass from theological knowledge based on revelation to purely natural knowledge. The metaphysician who disposes only of the light of reason and philosophical knowledge cannot demonstrate this proposition by cause: *God is omnipotent*. For a proposition to be demonstrable it must be mediate, that is justifiable starting from a prior proposition that is itself immediately evident by virtue of the terms of which it is composed. In this life we have no natural concept in which we can see with evidence the necessary relation that connects in fact omnipotence to God's essence.

The first reason for the impossibility is the nature of the concept of God that humans can form with the aid of their natural lights alone and in their present state. That concept is produced by the agent intellect and sensible species or phantasms, the only objects that can naturally act on the human intellect according to the common law. The phantasm and the agent intellect cannot cause a concept of God in us such that it includes virtually and with evidence all the truths that lead from the divine essence to the conclusion that God is absolutely omnipotent. The most perfect simple concept that humans can have of God in this life, thanks to the simple resources of their natural light, does not go beyond the most perfect simple knowledge available to the metaphysician. Moreover, we know that the knowledge of faith itself does not provide new simple concepts that would be added to our natural knowledge. The knowledge of faith only inclines us to give our assent to certain propositions that we would not dream of forming without it, since the connection of the terms of which those propositions are composed is not evident to reason. Consequently, faith does not provide any simple concept

that would be added to our natural knowledge. The knowledge of faith only inclines us to give our assent to certain propositions that we would not dream of forming without it, since the connection of the terms that compose these propositions is not evident to reason. Consequently, faith does not provide any simple concept beyond those naturally available to the metaphysician. Furthermore, this is evident because when a believing and an unbelieving metaphysician contradict each other about God, one of them affirms what the other denies about him. They do not merely dispute about a word, but about a concept. They have exactly the same concept, without which they could not contradict each other.

Granted this point, no concept of God that is naturally accessible to humans allows us to deduce divine omnipotence from it *a priori*. By hypothesis, we will admit that many philosophers must have naturally achieved the most perfect concepts of God possible. However, they have never attained their truth starting from these concepts. Therefore, they never had a simple concept from which absolute divine omnipotence could be deduced. Otherwise, they would have seen it as quasi-immediately evident, even if they had to retrace their steps in order to justify it as a mediate truth by means of necessary reasons. Thus, once again, employing the *experiment* by philosophy, Duns Scotus argues as if he held to be practically indemonstrable by mere natural reason that which the greatest philosophical geniuses never demonstrated in fact.

Furthermore, there is a reason of principle in this, because we speak of demonstration *propter quid*, in other words, demonstration by the cause. Now, the metaphysician can demonstrate no property of God, not even his existence except by a demonstration *quia*, that is, by starting from effects. His first move is to form a particular proposition that particularly affirms a predicate of being that corresponds to created being, from which premise, the metaphysician concludes particularly about being with a predicate proper to God. Here are some examples of such reasoning: some being is caused; therefore some being is an uncaused cause. Or, some being is finite; therefore, some being is infinite. Or, some being is possible, therefore some

being is necessary. All these consequences are justified by the principle that an imperfect condition cannot be found in any being, unless it is found more perfectly in another, because the imperfect depends on the perfect. It is evident that there are demonstrations *quia*, from effect to cause.[162] Consequently, the metaphysician can never demonstrate anything about God by the cause, his omnipotence no more than anything else.

So, let us fall back on the demonstration *quia* and ask whether it is possible to prove this conclusion in philosophy by this path. Let us recall that we are dealing with absolute omnipotence, that is, with a cause capable of producing immediately and by itself alone any effect whatsoever. We even should clarify, because a cause's immediacy in regard to this effect can be understood in two senses. Between a cause and its effect there can be intermediate effects, which are not causes of this effect. Accordingly, to say that an efficient cause produces its effect immediately can mean that its action excludes every intermediary efficient cause, or that it excludes every intermediary effect prior to the one it produces itself. Duns Scotus thinks that not only the philosophers, but also even the theologians, would deny that God could be all-powerful with omnipotence excluding both every intermediate cause and every intermediate effect. The principle of contradiction itself is opposed to it, because the concept of effect implies relation to some term prior to it, whether in nature or in time. To say that God produces an effect that *nothing* precedes in being in any sense, would be to say that he produces the relation of effect to cause without first producing the cause that is its basis. Therefore, it would be contradictory to maintain that God could immediately produce any effect without any other caused effect preceding it. That would no longer be to *cause*, but to *create ex nihilo*. Obviously, creation is possible for God, but that is another problem. What is denied here is precisely that in the universe, as it exists, God could produce an effect that is not the effect of a cause. The very notion is absurd, so it is necessary to eliminate it at once. For the moment, the point is precisely and solely this: can it be demonstrated a posteriori that God could cause any effect without the intermediary of one or several elements of the causal series naturally

required to produce it, that is to say, either of an intermediary cause or an effect that is prior or preparatory to the effect in question?

Let us return once again to the collective experience represented by the philosophers. They demonstrated the existence of a first efficient cause by natural reason. From the fact that it is first, it necessarily follows that its power extends to the total series of proximate or remote causes. Consequently, the cause is omnipotent in his sense, that it can do everything, either immediately or mediately. By contrast, the problem becomes completely different if we are dealing with omnipotence in the theological sense of the term, which is to be capable of immediately producing every possible effect while suppressing this intermediary cause or that intermediate effect. To say that the first efficient, considered *qua* first, has infinite power does not serve to resolve the problem, because the existence of an infinite being is like the last term that natural reason can attain in the knowledge of God, and starting from there we cannot prove this absolute omnipotence of God. It is true that a first cause eminently contains in itself the efficacy of the total series of second causes and their effects—"the Cause of the cause is the cause of what is caused," *Causa causae est causa causati*—but it does not follow that the first cause could immediately produce the immediate effect of the second cause. The hierarchical order of higher and lower causes does not permit it, because even if we admit that the sun, for example, possesses a more eminent causality than the ox or any other animal, we would not be compelled to admit that the sun could engender an ox. No ox would be engendered if there were no sun, but the generation of an ox requires another ox.[163]

So, it is not surprising that far from attributing to God omnipotence understood in this way, the philosophers maintained that it is impossible. Everything indicates that their position rests entirely upon the following principle: a necessary and absolutely perfect principle produces nothing in a contingent manner (*principium necessarium et omnino perfectum ad nihil contingenter se habet*). Once more the philosophers are identified in Duns Scotus's mind with the Greco-Arabic doctrines of necessity condemned in

1277. How would there be contingency in such a world? Where would it come from? Its first principle is absolutely necessary. Therefore, there is no reason for change to be introduced into its causal action. On the other hand, it is perfect. Nothing is lacking for it to act. Nothing can prevent it from acting. Nothing other than itself is required for its action to be exercised. Consequently, there is nothing outside it that could modify its capability.[164] The philosophers' world is such that the first cause's efficacy cannot avoid any intermediate step in it; divine omnipotence—in the sense in which Catholic theology understands it—is impossible there. No reconciliation can be expected between the Christian universe of contingency and the philosophical universe of necessity.[165]

The root of the divergence between these two conceptions of the world is certainly here. Aristotle and Avicenna always maintained that the actions of God *ad extra* are necessary, because the necessity is both in him and in the things themselves. Now, if God could cause any effect whatever without a second cause, he could make any second cause lack its proper action. But if beings have no proper actions, they have no proper essences, and as Aristotle teaches that there are formally necessary beings outside of God, it is contradictory to admit that these essences could be destroyed, even by God.[166] Not only the necessity of certain essences is at issue here, but also their order, because if God could cause any effect without taking into account the order of causes in the universe, there would no longer be necessary order, nor, consequently, the essential order in the series of causes, something the philosophers refuse to accept.[167]

Many other obstacles keep the philosophers from imagining that omnipotence conceived in the Christian way is attributable to God. Between the pure thought that Aristotle places at the origin of the world and the multiplicity of effects that follow from its efficacy, a philosopher must necessarily introduce intermediaries. For example, an infinite power cannot immediately move a body in time, or otherwise a finite power endowed with sufficient motor force could move this body at the same time as the infinite power. Evidently, Aristotle would not admit that God, who is outside time,

would immediately cause a moment that necessarily unfolds in time, because it is successive.[168]

What is true about movement is true of every material effect because, in order to cause it, a prior material transformation is necessary. Let us recall Aristotle's arguments against Plato proving the causal inefficacy of the Ideas that, being separated from matter, could not act directly upon it. The arguments hold equally against the hypothesis of a God who acts immediately upon bodies to produce any act in them directly.[169]

To understand the philosophers' attitude on this point, the role of secondary causes must be represented as the philosophers represented them. If the philosophers teach that secondary causes must necessarily contribute to the divine action, it is not to explain the effect's perfection but rather its imperfection. In a universe like that of the Greeks, where a perfect first principle acts in a necessary manner, imperfection is what is difficult to explain. The effects of a perfect being, who necessarily acts according to his perfection, could only be perfect themselves. To explain that they are not perfect, the philosophers recur to the second causes. Since the First Cause's immediate causality, which is perfect, cannot produce an imperfect effect, they make another cause, which is imperfect, contribute to his act. So, in place of God's power acting directly and directly producing an effect that, since it only depended on the First Cause, would be perfect like it, God's power limits itself to moving an imperfect cause by which it produces an imperfect and limited effect.[170] We come to the odd conclusion that, in the Greco-Arabic world of necessity, it is not for want of power that God cannot immediately produce any effect whatsoever. It is rather for lack of freedom. Like a nature that cannot act without involving itself completely in its act, God cannot channel his power or limit its effect at his pleasure. Second causes alone can do that and, since they do so for God, how can he dispense with them? We cannot demonstrate that a perfect and necessary cause could immediately produce any finite effect as long as the assistance of mediate causes is required precisely for the perfect cause to be able to produce such effects.

Duns Scotus clearly perceives his own position's importance and that it controls many other positions.

> By that we see that this proposition, *everything that the first efficient cause can do with a second cause it can immediately do by itself*, is not known either by virtue of its terms or by natural reason alone, but only by faith. For, if we knew omnipotence, upon which the position depends, by natural reason, it would be easy to prove to the philosophers many truths and propositions that they deny. It would even be easy to prove to them at least the possibility of many things that we believe and they likewise deny.[171]

The dividing line between philosophers and theologians follows the line traced by divine freedom. If divine freedom were rigorously demonstrable, God's omnipotence in the Catholic sense of the term would be demonstrable as well, but since the first truth is not demonstrable, we can only believe the second truth. Divine freedom with all its consequences remains knowledge exclusively reserved to Christians. They can only believe it in the exact sense that they cannot provide any sufficiently rational demonstration for a philosopher who only uses natural reason to be constrained to accept it. However, Duns Scotus does not stop there. First, if absolute divine omnipotence is true, it is possible that arguments directed against it by philosophers should be conclusive. If we cannot rationally prove that this thesis is true, we are even less able to prove it false. From that comes this first task for the theologian, to establish that the contrary conclusions of philosophers are not demonstrated necessarily. That is not all, but we cannot say what remains to be done better than by yielding the floor to Duns Scotus: "Although omnipotence taken in this sense is not sufficiently demonstrable, it can however be proven with probability as something true and necessary; more probably even than certain other objects of belief, because nothing prevents certain of them being more evident than others."[172] Let us not take *evident* in the strong sense that involves no decrees. It is easy to understand that, among the articles of faith, the divine Trinity, for example, is further from complete rational justification than omnipotence. What is more

surprising at first sight is that Duns Scotus admits that we can prove it is probable that a certain truth is necessary. Yet, he admits this, and if we desire to follow the development of his doctrine, we must admit it with him.

Let us first answer the philosopher's arguments, notably the one that is based on the impossibility of depriving the second cause of its causality without depriving it of its being. The theologian would agree that we cannot do one without doing the other, but he would add that God can do both, because he can annihilate being. Furthermore, it is not certain that in order for God to deprive a second cause of its action and to exercise it himself in its place, he has to annihilate its being also. In such a case, beings subsist without causing their effects. A piece of wood burns. If a screen will not allow another piece of wood near it to be put into the fire, that does not keep either the first piece from burning or the other one from being able to burn. The fire could cause the effect it does not cause. When Averroes writes that if beings no longer have their proper action, they will no longer have their proper essences, he does not intend to speak about a particular, accidental case. He means that, since causal efficacy is inseparable from the essence, we cannot conceive that a being should be stripped of its virtual aptitude to carrying out certain actions, whether it actually carries them out or not. So, when God substitutes his efficacy for the cause's efficacy, he respects this cause's aptitude to exercise its own efficacy.[173] Moreover, let us not forget that here we are dealing with exceptional interventions of divine omnipotence. Averroes argues against some moderns who maintained that God, the unique cause, produces everything by himself alone and without intermediaries. According to Augustine, that is not the Christian God; the Christian God "administers things that he has created in such a manner that he lets them cause their own movements" (De *Civitate Dei*, book VII, chapter 30). By doing this, God would not destroy the beings he created. He would simply leave them otiose and inefficacious. Furthermore, we observe that, to the contrary, God preferred to attribute active virtue and a proper action to them at the same time as he gave them being. God did not deny the totality of things the perfection of which they were capable,[174] and he continues to do

so, even in the case where his omnipotence accidentally suspends the exercise of their actions. This whole response has the object of retaining the possibility of miracles. It is valid against the Greek philosopher and his Commentator if we substitute the Christian world's temporal, contingent *entitas* for the Greek world's eternal, necessary *entitas*, and substitute the theologian's infinite being for the philosopher's necessary being.

The theologian will deny that God is unable to act directly on matter to transform it. Moreover, it is not certain that Aristotle himself would fail to deny it. It is Averroes who does so in order to refute the doctrine of Creation, who makes Aristotle say that every motor cause of matter is necessarily a body itself. When we have a choice between a passage in Aristotle that can be taken in an acceptable sense, and a commentary by Averroes, whose sense is unacceptable, why choose Averroes?

It would be all the more wrong to do that in the case in question, in that we are dealing with a passage where Aristotle establishes against Plato that the Ideas are not necessary for generation because an individual suffices to engender an individual, and that the Ideas could not engender individuals because only another individual can do so. The argument is excellent, and we can accept it, because Plato's Ideas are not individuals. If they engendered, their effects would be univocal, that is, specifically identical to each other. Consequently, Aristotle is right to say that the Ideas are not necessary for the production of composite material beings. To produce them, composite material beings that are like their effects are sufficient. As to the second point, it is equally true that the Ideas cannot engender. But we are not talking about ideas; we are talking about God, who is not a species that has been realized, but a singular. To that, let us add that God does not cause the generation of beings as a univocal cause, but as the highest equivocal cause, upon which everything depends in any order whatsoever. Accordingly, nothing prevents us from admitting that God, a spiritual being, is the eminent cause of natural effects. He does not cause fire as a body, in the way flames make another thing inflamed. Rather, it is certainly he who causes these bodies and the fire that consumes them. We are dealing with a completely

different order of causality here. Therefore, the theologians must reject in their turn Aristotle and Averroes's philosophical positions denying that God could move a body immediately.

The general thesis remains, which confirms the three previous positions: Aristotle teaches that God causes in an absolutely necessary way all that he can cause immediately.[175] To this we must reply that it is not quite true. What is true is that according to Aristotle, God does necessarily all he can do immediately, that is, with no efficient cause or any preparatory condition being required on his part or on the effect's part. The reason given is that if God produced an effect in a contingent way, the novelty of this effect would finally be explained only by some novelty in himself, where there can be no novelty. But if the point is that God can cause immediately and without intermediary *efficient* causes, although preparatory causes or at the very least prior effects may be required for a certain effect, Aristotle will no longer say that God could cause in an absolutely necessary way, but only with a necessity of inevitability, that is, in an inevitable way once those conditions are posited.

In neither of these two cases will the theologian be in agreement with Aristotle. For the theologian, God acts by his will, freely and in a contingent way in regard to everything that he can cause outside himself. No necessity binds him, neither necessity from the inevitably of things nor that from his own immutability. Faithful to his own principles, Aristotle would deny on his part that God could immediately cause a multitude of things whose production involves any contingency. Even taking account of the theologian's reservations, it thus remains true to say that we cannot demonstrate starting from effects that God's omnipotence extends immediately to everything that can be caused, even though that is true.[176]

What, then, can the philosopher prove? He can prove that God is omnipotent in the sense that he can produce all that can be caused either immediately or by the intermediary of some means itself subject to his causality. This is demonstrable from his effects, that is, by a demonstration *quia*. This time the issue is not the Christian God's absolute omnipotence,

capable of producing any effect whatsoever, but that of a God capable of producing all possible effects, some immediately, others mediately.[177]

Thus we return to a universe similar to Aristotle's where all possible effects are produced, the first immediately, the others by a continuous chain of causes entirely subject to God's causality, but necessary for its exercise. Accordingly, Scotus naturally borrows his first demonstration from the Philosopher. The universality of effects has a cause that cannot itself be part of this universality, otherwise it would be its own cause. Therefore, it is obviously outside this universality. If there is a cause of the universe outside the universe, it is not only each particular effect but also their totality that is caused by a principle external to it. In other words, it is impossible to go back to the infinite in the series of causes, but it is necessary to stop at a first cause upon which the effects depend.

The conclusion can be proved differently. An efficient cause is higher in the measure that it is more perfect in causality. Therefore, if we posit another cause above it that is infinitely higher in efficacy, it will be infinitely superior in causality, which amounts to saying that it will have an infinitely perfect causality. A causality that is caused itself, that is to say, dependent in its causal efficacy, is not infinitely perfect, because it is imperfect in regard to the causality upon which it depends. Consequently, if we go back to infinity in the series of causes, we arrive at a cause that is infinite, entirely uncaused, and independent in its causal efficacy. It will be necessary to stop at this cause, and since it will cause everything without depending itself on any other, every other causality will be caused in it, or at least will be exercised by virtue of its causality. Everything that an infinite cause can do immediately or mediately, the higher cause can also do, precisely through the intermediary of the lower causes. It does and can do everything they do and can do. Therefore, the first cause is all-powerful in the limited sense discussed here.[178]

`We see that Duns Scotus does not reproach philosophy as such at all. He has no quarrel with it. Rather the contrary is true, because he regularly defends Aristotle against those who gratuitously burden the Greek

philosopher with errors that it is unclear he committed.[179] This is a question of fact for Scotus: What can philosophy demonstrate? And, after what point is the necessarily true eclipsed before the probable? Here for example, the Subtle Doctor opposes the restrictive interpretations that, according to him, arbitrarily diminish the scope of Aristotle's conclusions. Some, says Scotus, claim that the power of the Aristotelian God is not infinite intensively, *intensive*, but only extensively, *extensive*. In other words the divine power would be infinite in the sense that it is inexhaustible and capable of eternally producing a movement whose duration in time is infinite. In short, the divine power's infinity would be capable of producing everything possible immediately or mediately.

If he had the intent of belittling philosophy as much as possible, nothing prevented Duns Scotus from accepting this interpretation of Aristotle. In fact he fought it vigorously. Aristotle, he says, admitted that a body was capable of an infinite duration and of motor power that was infinite like the duration. This is particularly the case of heaven, which, although endowed with dimensions like a body, moves the rest of the world during an infinite duration. In Aristotle, everything eternal is formally necessary, so that, if it is endowed with an active power, its power must be infinite in duration. Aristotle's God is a completely different being, superior to the order of bodies. It is because God has infinite power that Aristotle concludes that he cannot either be in extension nor have an extension, whether infinite because an infinite extension is impossible, or finite because a power in a finite extension would not be infinite. In short, Aristotle conceives the infinitely powerful being as much more powerful than would be enough for him to move the world of bodies eternally. Above this power that extends infinitely in duration, only one other is conceived, which is an infinite in intensity before being infinite in extension. The question whether Aristotle himself conclusively demonstrated his thesis is another problem. Whether he succeeded or not, the meaning of his doctrine is not in doubt. The power Aristotle attributes to the First Cause is certainly infinite in efficacy, capable of producing everything possible immediately or mediately.[180]

It remains to be seen how Aristotle proved it. Everyone knows that in Aristotle's doctrine God moves the world eternally, because the world itself is eternal in the past and in the future. The theologians deny that, because they hold as an article of faith that, since God created the world out of nothing, *ex nihilo*, it had a beginning. Nevertheless, many of them admit that God could have moved it with an infinite movement before, as all admit that he could move it with an infinite movement afterward. In other words, they deny God created the world from all eternity, but recognize that God could have created it and consequently moved it from all eternity. What separates them from the philosophers is that the latter consider such a power as necessitated to exercise its act. What an immutable and necessary being can do, it does necessarily. The theologians deny that. They do not think that the relation between two extremes, both immutable, God and heaven, for example, must possess the character of necessity. First of all, because, when God is posited, the heavens are not necessarily posited. Next, because, even once God posits the heavens, it does not follow that God must necessarily move them. Aristotle himself only concludes in *De Coelo* that God could move them during an infinite time, but that suffices to establish the divine power's infinity. Even if God does not do so, it suffices that he could move the world eternally in both past and future, *a parte ante* and *a parte post*, for him to be infinitely powerful.[181]

But then, are we dealing with a power that is infinite in intensity or only by its duration's extension? Here Duns Scotus poses the same problem that Averroes and after him St. Thomas Aquinas had discussed, when they asked whether Aristotle's God must be regarded as the cause of the very substance of beings or only of their movement. Both chose the first answer. Duns Scotus has no further hesitation in acknowledging that Aristotle's God has the highest causal power that can be attributed to him without making him a creator properly speaking. Here as elsewhere, he tends to give the Philosopher the greatest credit possible. On what does Aristotle base himself to attribute infinite power to the First Mover? On the fact that, since he is first in the order of causes, moves by himself a universe where everything is

moved by another. If that is so, we certainly must attribute omnipotence in the intensive sense to the First Mover, because, if he is cause per se, he is being per se. Possessing per se the perfection of being and of being able to act, nothing within him or outside him can limit him in either of these two orders, which amount to saying that his power is not only infinite by its efficacy's perpetuity, but first of all in intensity.[182]

Here it seems that Duns Scotus's personal position is totally clear. The Greek God's active power is infinite, and everyone grants that in at least once sense: the infinite duration of its efficacy. Moreover, the most objectively scrupulous history cannot dispute that. But Duns Scotus himself goes further, because he regards the power as genuine *omnipotence*, at least insofar as *intensive* infinite. An infinite power cannot be exceeded, and it is not even conceivable that it should be. If no power that can be exceeded is omnipotence, what cannot be exceeded is omnipotence. Therefore, it is true to say that an infinite active potency is genuine omnipotence. Still, although the infinite active power is true omnipotence, *licet infinita potentia activa sit vera omnipotentia*, we cannot conclude by natural reason alone that we are dealing there with complete omnipotence in regard to everything possible as Christians admit. Aristotle himself would deny that such a consequence could be validly deduced from his principles. No doubt he would say that the concept of one single being whose omnipotence would immediately extend to everything possible would imply contradiction as destroying the essential order of causes.[183] Once again, what the Greek God lacks in order to be all-powerful in the Christian sense of the term is not power; it is freedom.

It is remarkable that the principal obstacle that makes rational demonstration impossible here is the presence in the Greco-Arabic universe of substances lower than the First Cause but eternal and necessary like it. In Duns Scotus Christian world, everything that is not God is voluntarily caused by God, so that he alone is necessary, since all the rest is contingent in its very origin. This is why certain thinkers hold the proposition *An angel can have a cause* to be indemonstrable and simply the object of faith. As Aristotle ordinarily understands it and, moreover, as he sees it in *Metaphysics* book

XII,[184] he conceives the Separated Intelligences (which are angels for Christians) as eternal, immutable, and necessary beings. Therefore, it is said, he cannot have simultaneously admitted these two contradictory propositions: *The Intelligences are necessary* (which he clearly affirmed), and, *They are caused by something else*. They are even endowed, it is added, with infinite power, from which it follows still more obviously that they are beings per se, whose very nature excludes their being caused.

Duns Scotus does not interpret Aristotle in this way. Once again, he refuses to attribute a false or absurd opinion to Aristotle unless Aristotle professed it explicitly or it can be evidently deduced from his words. Now, it is false that an angel is a being per se. The opposite can be proven, and far from denying that, Aristotle agreed. Duns Scotus has proved that there is only one God, which is to say, a single being that is infinite and per se. Consequently, it is impossible that the angels are also infinite and per se, and since they are, they can only be because they are causable and caused. Moreover, we say that Aristotle conceded this. In *Metaphysics*, book XII,[185] Aristotle says that all things have an essential order among themselves, and still more in regard to a first being. We know that since the First Being is per se and infinite in the intensive sense. Therefore, it cannot be essentially subordinated to anything else. On the contrary, other things are subordinated to it as to their principle and their end. If it is objected that they depend on it in their order, as number in a series but not as effects depending on their cause, Duns Scotus will again refuse to admit that this was Aristotle's authentic thinking. In the Philosopher's world, ontological dependency in regard to the First subordinates all beings to him. Duns Scotus again finds the proof in *Metaphysics* book XII, chapter 4, where Aristotle says that God moves the closest Intelligence. The intellectual act of knowing is the very substance of the Intelligence. To say that God moves the Intelligence to know amounts to saying that he produces it.[186]

This interpretation will meet resistance in some modern interpreters of Aristotle, but it would be wrong to attribute it to an influence of Christian thought tending to approximate the Aristotelian universe to the theologians'

universe. We know how carefully Averroes excluded all religion from his philosophy. But Averroes did not understood Aristotle otherwise, and after St. Thomas, Duns Scotus followed Averroes on this point. In chapter two of his *De Substantia Orbis*, the Commentator wrote: “The heavenly body not only needs a force that moves it locally, but also one that gives it being, its substance, and eternal permanence.” He adds: “Some have said that the cause of the heavens was motor, not efficient, but that is absurd to the ultimate degree.” With greater reason, matters stand thus according to Avicenna, as can be seen in tractate IX, chapter 4, of his *Metaphysica*, where he explicitly says that every Intelligence is caused by the First. Not only does Avicenna not contradict Aristotle here, but he explains also the nature and order of the production that Aristotle did not explain. Even if we admit that Aristotle rejected the order proposed by Avicenna and maintained that the production of Intelligences by God is immediate, the disagreement does not prevent them from being in agreement on the fact that these Intelligences are produced. Furthermore, Avicenna never conceived the mode of its production as some movement or change presenting a character of novelty. The total being of the Intelligence, with its distinct essence, always exists for Avicenna by virtue of the First, as the Son always subsists for us in his proper essence by virtue of the Father, or as for Aristotle, the sun always causes its light in the diaphanous bodies that never have any shadow.[187]

Duns Scotus belongs to a time when Aristotle’s works were well know, along with different possible interpretations of them. For example, Scotus knew that the separated substances of which the Philosopher spoke are formally necessary, but he denies, supported by texts, that it is contradictory in Aristotle’s view for a being to be necessary and yet caused.[188] In short, in Scotus’s eyes, the universe of natural reason is the work of a first efficient cause, whose infinite power genuinely deserves the label *omnipotent*, but which necessarily follows from a necessity instead of being the work of liberty as in the world of Christian faith.

At the same time, we see what the real attitude of Duns Scotus is in regard to what we usually call *philosophy* today. The word is unavoidable for us but

Scotus himself does not use it here. He only speaks of *philosophers*. They are the ones who posed the problem from natural reason alone, so that what they knew and did not know rather precisely delimit the area of what is knowable by natural reason alone. We should not press Duns Scotus's expressions too much, because none of them ever articulates his whole thought with all its nuances in a single phrase. But we should observe that the mere fact that the philosophers could not prove God's immediate omnipotence by reason alone and even the fact that reason led them rather to the opposite conclusion, in Scotus's eyes is a *proof* that this thesis is the object of faith. "However, that this is thus only believed and that it cannot be proved by natural reason is proved, since the philosophers supported only by natural reason could not posit this according to their principles, since they posited that the first cause acts necessarily."[189] Duns Scotus does not say that the philosophers did demonstrate the opposite, but that, given their principles, they naturally reached their own conclusions.[190] It is necessary to start from different principles to avoid these conclusions, or rather from propositions that are really principles and from which we can achieve the truth for that very reason.

G Omnipresence and providence

The supra-rational character of Christian belief in divine omnipotence entails a series of important consequences concerning God's immensity, omnipresence, and providence. It is at least their immediate cause, because the group of these theses itself depends on a certain notion of finite being conceived as substantial essence rather than as manifestation of an act of existing.

If God's omnipresence could be necessarily inferred from his omnipotence, it would not always be a rationally demonstrable truth, because what is deduced from an article of faith essentially stems from faith. But in fact we cannot deduce it from them. This ought to catch our attention, because its explanation leads to instructive remarks about Duns Scotus's general attitude

toward philosophy.

Let us first distinguish the concept of omnipresence from the concept of *immensity*, which is so close to it that they are often confused. By *immensity* we understand the attribute by which God, who is the infinite being, is necessarily there where there is something. *Omnipresence* is a more precise concept. It not only means that God is everywhere (which is his immensity), but that he is *present* in everything that exists.

We said that these are two different, although related, concepts. God can be in things in four different ways. First, as an efficient and conserving cause of all things: we say then that he is present in all things by power, *per potentiam*. Second, as knowing everything laid bare and open to his infinite science. In this sense, everything is present to him, and since things are present to him by his own ideas, we can say that God, in his turn, is in them by presence, *per praesentiam*. Thirdly, by reason of his immensity as the infinite being, God is in all things by essence, *per essentiam*, because, says Duns Scotus, "[he] flows into everything by reason of his unlimited immensity," *omni rei illabitur ratione suae illimitatae immensitatis*. Fourth and last, insofar as God confers their supernatural form on the human operations and acts of which God is the term, God is present in humans by grace and charity, *per gratiam et charitatem*.

As Duns Scotus poses the question, it is to find out whether we can prove that God is everywhere by virtue of his immensity, but more particularly whether God is present in everything *per potentiam* and *per essentiam*. For a theologian who thinks of the Greeks when he talks about philosophers, the undertaking's success looks doubtful, because ultimately for this intimate presence of God in things to be demonstrable, it is necessary to be able to base oneself on a doctrine of creation and divine omnipotence, which they lack insofar as these concepts imply freedom, By contrast, certain theologians fortified by these beliefs, imagine themselves to be capable of proving divine omnipotence, but the problem is precisely knowing whether they honor their commitments.

St. Thomas Aquinas is a good representative of these theologians. Duns

Scotus certainly has him in mind here, since the refutation of the thesis that Scotus offers adapts itself so exactly to the arguments of *Summa Theologiae* (part I, question 8, article 1) that we can hardly doubt it. The philosophical principal of argumentation that Duns Scotus cites at the beginning of his question is taken from Aristotle: "Every agent is present to what is affected," *omne agens est praesens passo*. It is exactly the point of departure of St. Thomas's argument: "God is in all things, not certainly as part of their essence or as an accident, but as the agent is present in that upon which it acts. Every agent must be connected to that in which it acts immediately and touches it with its active virtue. From that comes the proof in *Physics*, book VII, that what moves and what is moved must be simultaneous."[191] Starting from there, St. Thomas directly returns to his own principle: By essence God is his own *esse* (*cum autem Deus sit ipsum esse per suam essentiam . . .*). Thomas immediately infers that created being (*esse creatum*) is the proper effect of God as burning is the proper effect of fire. God does not cause the effect in things only at the moment when they begin to exist, but also for as long as he conserves them and, since their *esse* is what is most intimate in them, God is intimately present in them insofar as he causes their act of existing in them. Consequently, it is true that the presence of God in beings is based on his creative power here. Obviously, Thomas Aquinas, like Duns Scotus afterward, admits that an omnipresence of knowledge exists in God: "He is in all things by presence in so far as all things are; they are laid bare and open to his eyes." But God is in all things in the mode of power, because nothing escapes him, and he is there by the mode of essence, because he is in every being *qua* cause: "He is in all things by power insofar as all things are subject to his power. He is in all things by essence, in so far as he is present to all things as the cause of being."[192]

The demonstration presupposes that we hold to be true the proposition, Esse est proprius Dei. It is one of the pillars of Thomism, at least insofar as it implies that God is conceived as the pure act of esse. But here we touch upon one of the points where Scotism's divergence from Thomism appears as primordial, fundamental, and decisive, because it is concerned with the

concept of being itself. When we reread St Thomas, we see the sense in which he sees his comparison between the causality of God and that of fire. *Esse* produces *esse* as fire produces fire. In Aquinas's mind that implies that a fire does not produce the *esse* of the fire it ignites, because its essence is not *to b*e but *to be fire*. Duns Scotus seizes the reverse of the comparison to turn it against its author. Since the fire engenders fire, it engenders the being of the fire, whose being it causes. Therefore, it is not only God whose action causes being, which amounts to saying that to be (*esse*) is not God's *proper* effect.

One risks a kind of intellectual vertigo by trying to view the two theses simultaneously. That would be to look at two universes at once. Duns Scotus's answer is only meaningful if the term *esse* no longer connotes the act of existing primarily but rather the being of the substance defined by its quiddity. Obviously, even in Scotus's doctrine, creating remains God's prerogative, because then we are dealing with causing *ex nihilo* and *de nihilo*. But, the fact of producing being is not what is unique here—all causes produce it—it is the manner of producing it. Therefore, we can locate the source of this doctrinal difference precisely and situate it in the concept of *esse*. In St. Thomas no creature ever causes the *esse* of any effect. Accordingly, in the sense where *esse* designates not the substance's being, but the act of existing, the *esse* is really God's proper effect, that which God alone can produce. In Duns Scotus, the concept of a cause that acts without producing the effect's *esse* is contradictory and absurd. Consequently, we verify once more that Scotus's thinking moves on a level where the relations of being to being include existence rather than supposing it. The being produced by God is univocal with the being produced by God's effect.

Moreover, this is evidently why Duns Scotus does not know what to make of the theses he criticizes, and they never surprise him more deeply than when he seeks their possible justification. For example, we could say that God causes the *esse* of beings and that the second causes add the rest, or inversely, but that is meaningless. If God causes the fire's *esse*, the fire exists. Therefore, the second cause no longer has anything to do. "I do not

understand how the created agent would cause the substance that God would then cover (*supervestiret*) with the accident that is being according to them."[193] Who indeed would understand it? But it is necessary to recall that, for the adversary whom Duns Scotus contemplates, *esse* is the highest act of the substance and therefore the contrary of an accident.

The adversary maintains that, in any case, God certainly causes the *esse* of things as long as he conserves them.[194] Yes, but this is not the issue. The problem is to know whether God is in the world *by virtue of his power*. Nothing proves that God could not conserve this world without being present to the world as the cause is to the effect. Here Aristotle's authority is bereft of value, because it is true that the motor and mobile are always together and connected, but it is only true in the order of natural causes. Once again these causes only act upon each other by their qualities. They touch, so to speak. But some causes are not in others by their essences. Now, God's *esse* certainly ought to have to be present to the essences of things for him to be in them as the ultimate cause that is claimed. Therefore God can act on things and even cause them without being in them.[195] He surely is in them, and the Christian knows it, but no philosopher can demonstrate it to him. We can even argue the reverse by keeping to the point of view of the cause. The more powerful an agent is, the more it can act at a distance, like the sun that engenders animals from far away without being in these animals. God is a much more perfect cause than the sun, and if his perfection proves anything, it is that he can act upon things without being inside them.[196]

Duns Scotus rarely lacks arguments, but here he has a surfeit of them. Someone who acts by will can produce an effect without his will being present where the effect is produced. For example, if God were seated on a throne in heaven—*ut vetulae imaginantur*—he could produce everything without moving away. Besides, before creation, God was no more present here, where there is a universe, than he is present today outside the universe where there is nothing. So when God created the universe, he was not there where the universe is. If he did not need to be there to create it, he does not need to be there today to conserve it.—Lastly, what is nothing cannot be

present to God. It follows that God created it before it was present to him and consequently, God's action in a being does not imply that he is present to it.[197] We must conclude with Duns Scotus: "It does not seem to me that it can be proved demonstratively that God is everywhere by essence, but for me it is only believed and not proved."[198]

It is useless to strive to find a position common to the doctors somewhere beyond metaphysics. They come together in faith and do so completely. They cannot even be compared historically, that is to say, in the manner of a narrator who does not enter into their texts. From the Thomist viewpoint, Duns Scotus lacks a doctrine of *actus essendi*, whose absence reduces metaphysics of being to metaphysics of substance, that is, to a philosophy of nature (something unreasonable for Duns Scotus). From the Scotist viewpoint, in St Thomas there is too much unreal metaphysics of *esse* as act of existing, imaginary appendix of a being to which the act always comes either too early because nothing is there to receive it, or too late because the being does not need it to exit. This is why Duns Scotus only sees individualized essences in the universe accessible to philosophers, acting upon other individualized essences by causal virtues whose exercise respects the separation of the essences. For a philosopher, that remains evident even in the case of God. The philosopher's God does not intrude into his effects just as no other cause intrudes. The proof is that God "can cause something outside the universe, and still he is not there in his essence,"[199] because there is nothing outside the universe, and God himself cannot be present to what is nothing.

This parallel would be irrelevant if Duns Scotus's resistance to Thomism did not instruct us on the meaning of Scotus's own position. When we neglect the metaphysical sense of Thomist *esse* with Scotus, what rational meaning can this proposition, *God is in this being by his power*, have? None. In order to maintain it still, one must recur to the magic of the imagination. In other words, in place of affirming with the intellect that each finite *actus essendi*, in every instant of time is a participation in the supreme *esse* of *Qui Est*, we picture God as *being somewhere* in order to be able to exercise his

powers there. Nothing remains then but to laugh: “We should not imagine an infinite void before creation, as if God were present there according to his essence before producing the universe. Completely to the contrary, God has the power to produce the world without being present anywhere according to his essence.”[200] What was true then is still true of God today. God does not need to be anywhere to act there. Therefore, we cannot infer his omnipresence from his power, or from the effects that his power produces before our eyes.

Is this Duns Scotus’s own mental universe? No, let us repeat once more. But this universe, where God’s power does not imply his intimate presence within beings, in Scotus’s view, is the solution of philosophers who are only philosophers. We should not be surprised to see him argue like them to establish that, from their viewpoint, their conclusions can go no further. Observe the relations of cause to effect as we can observe them. Natural causes are really in direct or indirect contact with their effects, like the torpedo fish that numbs the fisherman’s hand by contact with the line (although the nerve itself feels nothing). But the cause’s active power only requires intermediaries by reason of its imperfection, and we can imagine a perfect enough power to dispense with it. The power would then act at a distance, being present in the ultimate effect no more than it is in the proximate effect upon which it acts. It suffices to see the heavenly bodies engender minerals within the earth, or even certain inanimate or animate mixed bodies, to be assured that in created bodies, the more perfect a form is, the more it can act at a distance.[201]

What does all this have to do with St. Thomas Aquinas? Nothing or a great deal according to the perspective we take. For, if Thomistic metaphysics claims to be purely metaphysical, it must conceive being as philosophers conceive it, and its causality and the relation of *presence* to power as they are conceived in philosophy. A philosopher never thinks that a cause must be *in* its effect in order to be able to produce it. Certainly, there is this *esse* about which we hear, but who will tell us what it is?

It is extraordinarily important not to forget this point if we want to avoid

consequences that damage our understanding of the doctrine. When Duns Scotus criticizes Thomist doctrine, he can only do so as he understands it, and the way a philosopher understands the philosophy of others always depends on the way he understands philosophy himself. We will never know what Scotus would have thought of Thomistic metaphysics if he had worked out the meaning of *esse* in it. We do know, because Scotus said so, that when someone speaks to him about the distinction of essence and existence, he responds, *non capio*. Consequently, it is useless to insist, and we can only try to see by way of Scotus's theology how he perceives the universe of philosophers, which is what would have been his universe if he had not possessed the grace to be Christian and the honor to be a theologian.

Thereafter, we can expect that after having reserved to faith the certainty about an omnipotent God in the absolute sense of the Credo, and therefore God's most intimate presence in beings, Scotus leaves to theology the concern to guarantee divine providence. Obviously, we find abundant *necessary* demonstrations in Scotus's work, but if they presuppose classic omnipotence in the sense in which it is only guaranteed by faith, then the concept of providence in its turn remains a *dogma fidei* and cannot become the object of metaphysical demonstration.

The issue of divine providence is not presented like those of omnipotence and omnipresence. We do not know a passage where Duns Scotus explicitly says that this truth is not demonstrable by reason without the support of faith. A single text seems to say it in *De Primo Principio*, where providence is listed among the attributes that Catholics acknowledge in God beyond what the Philosophers demonstrate regarding him.[202] But this treatise's text is not very trustworthy, and all that can be concluded from it is that in Duns Scotus's immediate circle, some held it to be unquestionable that divine providence was a certainty of faith in the master's eyes. The information has some value, but it is not decisive.

In the absence of explicit statements upon which the historian might base a definite conclusion, he can only proceed by successive judgments here. The problem is as complex as that of divine omnipotence, and it may be that

reason can demonstrate some kind of providence without thereby justifying the concept of providence that Catholics hold by faith. For example, one may distinguish between general providence by which God governs the world and special providence according to which he justifies humans. The latter involves an *election* as a consequence of which God foresees every human according to his present and future merits, which, moreover, are always present for God. These judgments and these merits are hidden for us, and it may be doubted whether their existence in general is accessible to natural reason alone, because they are linked to the last end of humans. The whole prologue to the *Opus Oxoniense* famously teaches that this supernatural order is only knowable for us by revelation. It seems contrary to what we know best about Duns Scotus's doctrine to claim that the fact that God freely decides to predestine some humans to beatitude is an object of metaphysical demonstration. Furthermore, Duns Scotus's interpreters in closest harmony with his thought generally admit this. They can even interpret in this sense the expression from *De Primo Principio* that we have quoted: "Catholics praise you . . . watching over all creatures and especially the intelligent ones," *Catholici te laudant . . . cunctis creaturis et specialiter intelligibilibus providentem*. Only Catholics celebrate the providence that God especially exercises toward intelligible beings, because the mystery of the election of the just is revealed to them alone, not to the philosophers.[203]

There remains God's general providence toward the world, including humans known as purely natural beings. To establish that providence, it is not enough to recall that we can rationally demonstrate that God is creator and conserver of the world according to Duns Scotus. It is not even enough that nothing is done without God's cooperation. Scotus grants that Aristotle, to whom it would be difficult to attribute a doctrine of divine providence with regard to individuals, knows these things. But making all possible concessions in this direction, let us admit that Aristotle's God creates, conserves, and knows all the effects that come forth from him in his way. No doubt we could speak of a certain kind of providence—but in what order? In the philosophers' rational, natural world, necessity governs everything.

Supposing that the philosophers' God exercises this kind of providence, it would not involve any free choice on his part, any intention of any kind toward nature. As the philosophers understand it, the dialogue between God and the world follows a law that is somewhat mechanical, since the first cause's general action always remains identical to itself and produces different effects according to the different disposition of the different matter that receive it. On the one hand, there is divine energy that is eternally in act; on the other, eternally passive matter in which God never foresees in particular, because the matter at any moment always undergoes what it can capture of the divine energy. We can grant to this interpretation of Aristotle that there is production, conservation, divine cooperation in the generation of all beings here, but we must doubt whether the issue is Christian providence even in its general, natural form. Not a single sparrow can be born in this philosophical world without the first unmoved mover's energy, but it is only in the world of the gospel that not a sparrow "is forgotten before God."[204]

These general considerations would lack historical interest, if they were not supported by the interpretation of Aristotle's philosophy that Duns Scotus constantly proposes. There is a beautiful passage that exactly establishes the relation of this conception of the world and the idea of providence.

> According to Aristotle, God uniformly influences every being in the complete measure of his power, and because one is disposed, while another is not, God impels with a certain plan from which it will draw advantage, If God does not impel another, because he does not find in it the disposition of which we have spoken. Aristotle's position in *De Bona Fortuna* thus agrees with his position in *Physics,* book VIII, namely that God cannot cause a new world or a new heaven and a new movement by virtue of his causality. But according to faith and truth, it must be said that God exercises providence upon everything and that he governs things as it belongs to their nature to be governed.[205]

There is no text that cannot be debated, and in the last analysis, the personal judgment of each will decide its sense. So, Fr. Parthenius Minges declares: "Natural knowledge even seems to be expressed in correct terms, but

according to faith *and truth* (sed secundum fidem *et veritatem*) . . .”[206] Accordingly, *et veritatem* seems to him to explicitly designate the truth of natural reason. This is not impossible. But we cannot prove either it or the contrary. First of all, there is hardly a more natural expression from the pen of a theologian than *according to faith and truth*, that is, as we believe and as is true. Here, truth of faith, *veritatem fidei*, seems to be transformed into truth of reason, *veritatem rationis*. If we grant the translation, what do we make Duns Scotus say? He would be saying that God’s general providence is knowable by reason since, according to Aristotle, God’s action is always exercised uniformly upon things and since God’s action affects some rather than others according as they are or are not disposed to receive it. This proves that providence is philosophically knowable by presenting a philosophy that did not know providence.

Someone might insist saying “Scotus does not reproach Aristotle for teaching that God influences things, but only for affirming that God cannot cause anything new.”[207] This is not completely true. Duns Scotus’s reply points out that Aristotle’s position in the apocryphal *De Bona Fortuna* agrees with the position he takes in *Physics*, book VII, where he teaches that God cannot cause a new world. That is certainly the issue.[208] There is no doubt that that the Aristotelian world is penetrated with reason and order through the influence of the First Mover. But precisely because Aristotle’s God can do nothing new, he has not chosen or reconsidered, and he has provided for nothing. It is impossible to maintain simultaneously that Aristotle’s God is provident and that he obeys his own necessity in his productive and conserving action. Yet, this is what Duns Scotus would maintain if he offered Aristotle as an example of a philosopher demonstrating providence in a passage where the philosopher explicitly teaches that God does not adapt his general action to any particular nature, but that different dispositions of these natures diversify the effect of God’s action. We do not understand providence in this fashion: “But according to faith and truth, it must be said that God, who has general providence over all things, rules over things according to the way that it is natural for them to be ruled,” *sed secundum fidem et veritatem*

dicendum est quod Deus habens providentiam generalem de omnibus, regit res secundum quod natae sunt regi.

This seems to us by far the least forced interpretation of the text of Duns Scotus. We can always argue a historical case, but it is generally wiser to accept what our author says, as he says it, because, although he may still have defenders and adversaries, none of them have an interest either in glorifying a doctrine under his name that is not his or, on the other hand, of fighting against someone who never existed. As we see it, allowing for future revision, *salvo meliori judicio*, Duns Scotus would have admitted unhesitatingly that philosophers can demonstrate the existence of a first creative and conserving cause of being and order, but he does not seem to have admitted that the divine action merits the name of *providence* in the Christian sense of the word. After all, Aristotle's case really is evidence in favor of this thesis, and if the God of the *Physics* and *Metaphysics*, enclosed in his own necessity, is roughly the philosophers' God, we cannot be surprised if he does not exercise all the privileges of the Christian God.

We can compare Scotism to Thomism here only from this point of view, because the number and extent of satisfactions offered to theology is not a criterion of its value as philosophy. Clearly, theology cannot tolerate philosophical contradiction. Every philosophy that contradicts revelation is ipso facto condemned as false by the theologian delivering his verdict in the name of faith. Later, this same theologian can use metaphysics to establish that, from the point of view of philosophy and natural reason, the thesis is rationally false. Finally, as Duns Scotus always does systematically at every point of his doctrine, the theologian can demonstrate by necessary reasons that the truth of faith is at least rationally possible, perhaps probable, and sometimes more probably than the contrary. We can say that all great medieval theologians share this cluster of positions.

This theological agreement permits differences in detail, but it will be noticed that the agreement does not cover another question. We can go still further in the same direction and ask whether in the content of revelation there exist truths common to philosophy and theology, what they are, and to

what extent philosophy knows them by its own method. The criterion is no longer theological but philosophical on this point, because if in principle we prefer the philosophy that prides itself on demonstrating the most revealed truths, we make a wager that our funds do not cover. The real problem then is to know whether reason genuinely demonstrates what it claims to prove. In a word, for the theologian just as for the philosophy, the truth of a philosophical proof, is what gives it value. The best philosophy whose cooperation he can take up for his own ends is the philosophy that genuinely demonstrates everything that can be demonstrated, to the point that it can be demonstrated, and does not claim to demonstrate, even as an extra flourish, what is beyond the grasp of natural reason.

This must be said in order that the historian not be suspected of making himself the judge in a debate that is outside his area of competence, when he attempts to compare Scotism and Thomism on this point. As a historian he does not know whether Duns Scotus or St. Thomas is right in granting more or less to the light of natural reason, but he can legitimately ask why (that is to say, by reason of what philosophical knowledge) one of them permits more and the other one less.

For complex reasons (both of early education and personal thought) that escape us, Duns Scotus did not follow Thomas Aquinas on the path of a metaphysics of *esse*. We meet Scotus in the great tradition of *essentia*, with St. Augustine and St. Anselm, and so in good company. Moreover, Avicenna's teaching on *natura communis* nourishes Scotus's thinking; he not only assimilates that teaching, but reinforces in his own sense. For, although Avicenna is *the* philosopher for Duns Scotus, along with Aristotle, Scotus did not completely follow Avicenna on the crucial point of the relation of essence to existence. Avicenna considers existence an appendix to essence, something that according to the convention of the Latins was called an accident. For Duns Scotus, existence is rather a modality of essence, so that real being is essence under the mode of existent. If his theology uses philosophy to build itself, it will doubly be a doctrine of *essentia*.

In order that his God-*essentia* not be identified with an ordinary nature,

Duns Scotus must find a proper formal act for it. As we have seen, that is *infinitas*, which our thought grasps as an intrinsic mode of the divine essence —because our thought goes from the essence to modal determination—but which in reality is the proper formality, *formalitas*, of the divine essence as such. Within Duns Scotus's theology, infinity, *infinitas*, in God plays an analogous role to *esse* in Thomas Aquinas. Intelligence and will, freedom, omnipotence, omnipresence, providence, and everything that the notion of the divine essence comprises for us, spring from infinity as from a center. In Scotus, *infinitas* identifies God as God and separates him from any other being, exactly as God is set apart in his pure act of existing within Thomism.

It seems that certain differences in the way our two doctors employ philosophy come from there. If we start from the empirically given act of existing with Thomas Aquinas, everything that has *esse* for whatever reason and in whatever measure requires God's *esse* as its cause. Conversely, positing God as the absolute *esse* we can be certain that everything that is, in whatever degree it may be, only exists *qua* proper immediate effect of He Who Is, *Qui Est*. The number of causes, intermediaries in duration or in the hierarchy of being, changes nothing. It counts for nothing because substantial dependences can be innumerable, they can even by infinite in an eternal world, without the existential dependence of the cosmos and all its parts becoming less immediate. Accordingly, it is true for the philosopher as for the theologian that in him we love and move and have our being, *in ipso vivimus et movemur et sumus*. Obviously, the philosopher does not know everything, even in Thomism. The order of grace escapes him, and God transcends the philosopher's highest concept. Yet, however ignorant the philosopher is about what divine *esse* is, he at least knows that it penetrates all being in its very intimacy. Divine omnipresence is implied in the proof of God's existence. However, if we start from the finitude of being with Duns Scotus, or rather even from its *finibility*, we find ourselves closer to God in one sense, because we develop our argument upon a concept of being univocal to God and his creatures. But when we infer the infinite starting from the finite in this way, they must be separated at the very heart of being,

in order that the univocity of being does not lead us to join them in a single existent. Thus, we know that the existence of the finite presupposes the existence of the Infinite being as its cause, but natural reason alone does not see why or how the Infinite is in the finite. Here is where Duns Scotus's objection to the empirical foundation of the proofs of God's existence attains its full meaning. Since, for reasons tied to his own philosophy, Scotus does not admit that the proofs have the object of capturing the metaphysical act of existing at their outset, it seems to him that they gratuitously establish themselves in contingency. But by establishing himself in the necessity of essences, he is involved in an order of relations of cause to effect, where the cause's presence in the effect, although possible in itself, is not recognizable. The case of the Philosophers assumes considerable importance in Scotus's view and quite rightly, because Aristotle's God acts upon the world without being in it and because the universe is presented as consisting of substances closely linked by relations of causality, though always outside each other. However informed this world is, from beginning to end, by one and the same Wisdom, it is not maintained outside nothingness by the intimate presence, in all things that compose the world, of one, single, act of existing.

We beg leave to recall yet again that *philosophy* is the issue here for the historian. There must be a reason why, in Duns Scotus, philosophy does not know what it knows or what it believes it knows in Thomas Aquinas. The articles of faith are identical in the two theologians. The point is simply to find out what the philosopher can know, in this case, how two different philosophies can connect the particular individual to God. In what we seek to understand, the infinite being's presence to the finite being cannot be deduced or inferred, because reason only discovers relations either of cause to effects or of effects to causes, in which, since *esse* is not at stake, the relation is not necessarily immediate. It can be immediate, but how do we prove that it is? It has been certainly observed that from here comes Duns Scotus's insistence on the fact that, in philosophy, the first cause immediately affects only the first effect, which is the highest Separated Intelligence. It affects the other Separated Intelligences through the First. From the

perspective of the *philosophically known* being, there is nothing that implies the cause's intimate presence in the existent that it produces. The absence of *esse* prevents demonstrable certainty about the immediateness without which we cannot rationally establish omnipotence, omnipresence, or even God's general providence understood in the Christian sense.

We obviously do not thereby lose the omnipotent, omnipresent God that provides for each creature according to what it is. The theologian can still show that the philosophers advanced toward him by reason alone, for example, when they proved the divine power's infinity and God's general influence upon the production and conservation of the cosmos, which is a kind of providence. He may even make us see that the articles of faith do not come up against any rational impossibility. Finally, and above all, theology takes over that before which philosophy surrenders. Consequently, the debate is limited here to the opposition between metaphysics of essences and metaphysics of acts of existing.

Notes

1 St. Augustine *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 46, 1–2, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, columns 29–30.—However, this curious passage in *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, p. 146, should be noted: "Multa de ideis dicuntur, quibus tamen nunquam dicis, imo nec nominatis ideis, non minus de tua perfectione sciretur. Hic constat, quia tua essentia est perfecta ratio cognoscendi quodcumque cognoscibile, sub quacumque ratione cognoscibili. Appellet ideam qui vult; hic non intendo circa graecum illud et platonicum vocabulum immorari."—Duns Scotus is capable of making fun of the philosophers, but if he really wrote this text as it stands, we can see in it the expression of the very lively feeling he always had of the transcendence of theology in regard to philosophy. What matters in Scotus's view is to realize that God knows *by his essence alone* both his own essence and those of all possibles (see note 5 in this chapter). This is the truth, and, in order to express it, it is well to do without the word *idea* that the philosophers have burdened with too many quarrels. Perhaps in Duns Scotus's mind, *In Metaphysicam*, VII, question 18, number 3 [EW II, pp. 292–93], this remark is bound up with criticism of Plato's ideas, as Aristotle understands them. Moreover, if by *Idea*, we understand a substance "separated from movement and accidents, not containing anything in itself but the separated specific nature, as perfect as it can be," there is nothing to improve: even in God the Idea's identity is certainly nearly that. In fact, Aristotle does not maintain that the Ideas are impossible, but that it is not necessary to posit them, because they do not serve to account either for beings or for our science of them.

2 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, *questione unica*, number 12, vol. I, p. 1160 [CE VI, p. 260].

3 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, *questione unica*, number 12, vol. I, p. 1160 [CE

VI, pp. 261–62].—See *Quodlibet* III, article 2 [AW, pp. 64–69] on the different sense of the term *ratio*. Here, it is taken in the sense of intelligible principle defining the nature of a possible being.

4 Duns Scotus expresses this fact in an indirect but striking form by saying that the knowledge God has of the ideas adds nothing to the knowability of his essence. *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, conclusion 9, addition, p. 110: “Si igitur intellectionem intuitivam habet Deus de lapide, ipse nullo modo causante, oportet quod lapis in cognoscibilitate etiam propria nihil addat cognoscibilitati essentiae Primi per quam lapis sic cognoscitur.” (The extract in the text is from chapter 4, p. 146.)

5 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 10, vol. I, p. 1158 [CE VI, p. 258]: “Deus in primo instanti intelligit essentiam sub ratione mere absoluta. In secundo instanti producit lapidem in esse intelligibili, et intelligit lapidem, ita quod ibi est relatio in lapide intellecto ad intellectionem divinam, sed nulla adhuc in intellectione divina ad lapidem, sed intellectio divina terminat relationem lapidis intellecti ad ipsam. In tertio instanti forte intellectus divinus potest comparare suam intellectionem ad quodcumque intelligibile ad quod nos possumus comparare, et tunc comparando se ad lapidem intellectum potest causare in se relationem rationis. Et in quarto instanti potest quasi reflecti super istam relationem casusatam in tertio instanti, et tunc illa relatio rationis cognita erit. Sic igitur non est relatio rationis necessaria ad intelligendum lapidem tamquam prior lapide ut objectum, imo ipsa ut causata est posterior, quia in tertio instanti et adhuc posterior erit ipsa ut cognita, quia in quarto instanti.”—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 2, number 34.

6 On this point, see Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 30, questions 1 and 2, number 9, vol. I, p. 1090 [presumably CE VI, pp. 181–83].

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 12, vol. I, p. 1160 [CE VI, p. 262]: “quidditates rerum . . . habentes esse cognitum in intellectu divino”—As we will see, in order to respect St. Augustine’s doctrine scrupulously, Duns Scotus will maintain that divine intellection of objects other than the divine intellect itself requires different relations between these different intelligibles and the divine intellect that knows them. To those who maintain the contrary, Scotus responds, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 2, number 31: “Videtur quod haec dicta destruant sententiam Augustini de ideis.”—As to what concerns Plato, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 2, number 33: “Hoc etiam probatur per Platonem, qui primo induxit nomen *ideae*; posuit enim mundum sensibilem extra et mundum intelligibilem in mente divina; et mundum intelligibilem in mente divina vocavit ideam mundi sensibilis in re extra; mundus autem intelligibilis non est nisi mundus extra, ut est objective in esse cognito in mente divina; idea igitur mundi in re extra non est nisi mundus intelligibilis, sive mundus in esse cognito, nec est curandum ad propositum, si mundo in re extra correspondeat una idea vel duae. Item hoc patet ex alio, quia sicut Plato induxit nomen et rationem idea, sic Augustinus imitatur ipsum. Nunc autem Plato vere posuit ideam in mente divina, non eo modo quo Arisoteles falso sibi imponit eas posuisse in re extra, ut per Commentatorem patet supra primo *Ethicorum*.”

8 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 2, number 31.

9 On this point see the remarkable work by André Combes, *Un inédit de saint Anselme? Le traité “De Unitate Divinae Essentiae et Pluralitate Creaturarum” d’après Jean de Ripa* (Paris: J. Vrin, 1944).

10 For a brief history of this doctrine as it involves John Scotus Eriugena, see Étienne Gilson, *La philosophie au moyen âge* (Paris: Payot, 1944), pp. 207–14.—For its continuation see G. Catherine Capelle, *Autour du décret de 1210: III—Amaury de Bène. Étude sur son panthéisme formel*, Bibliothèque Thomiste (Paris: J. Vrin, 1932), vol. XVI, especially pp. 89–111.—An

unexpected development in this history has been revealed by Fr. André Combes, *Un inédit de Saint Anselme?* Whatever we think of the Anselmian authorship of the treatise, this admirable study proves that an evolved version of Eriugenism still lived on in the fourteenth century, which is very important in order to situate Duns Scotus within this overall history. Let us repeat that the Subtle Doctor does not teach the creation of the divine ideas either directly or indirectly. However, (as we will see below), just as an *esse intelligibile* is situated between existing being and simple being of reason in Scotus's doctrine, Scotus's thesis of the ideas' *production* in intelligible being is inserted between the doctrine of the creation of the divine ideas and the doctrine that absolutely identifies them with the divine essence as such. Here the historian is guaranteed against any error in interpretation by the criticism of this doctrine that we read in a disciple of Duns Scotus, Fr. Guillelmus Alnwick, O.F.M., *Quaestiones Disputatae de Esse Intelligibile et de Quodlibet*, ed. Athanase Ledoux, O.F.M. (Firenze-Quaracchi: Collegii Sanctae Bonaventurae, 1937). Just as Alnwick labors to prove that there is no intermediary between real being and being of reason, he establishes that, if the idea's intelligible being is real, its *production* is a creation. Inversely, if the production is not an act of efficient causality, the idea can have no being of its own distinct from the divine essence in any degree whatsoever, Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, pp. 111–13. However, this intermediate position is held by Duns Scotus and according to Fr. Ledoux, Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 120, note 1 is even the position of "fere omnium scotistarum quorum nomina habentur apud Mastrium, *Disputationibus Theologicis*, disputatione 3, quaestione 2, p. 180." Alnwick himself holds the opposite position. According to him, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 124, if *esse intelligibile* belongs to real being, however slightly this may be, its production can only be a creation, which it is heretical to maintain. From there comes Alnwick's own conclusion, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 136: "Respondeo igitur ad quaestionem quod esse intelligibile conveniens creaturae ab aeterno non est productum ab intellecto divino." By maintaining both that God *institutes* creatures' intelligible being and that, however, his essence is sufficient to represent all the rest, Duns Scotus contradicts himself, Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 137: "Unde Johannes Duns . . . dicit expresse opposita." It corresponds to the philosopher to say whether these positions are contradictory, but in Alnwick, the historian finds a trustworthy guarantee that Duns Scotus indeed maintained them. This is also Fr. Ledoux's opinion, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 162: "Revera hae duae assertiones inveniuntur apud Scotum." In any case, Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 162, rejects any production of intelligible being and does so in the name of the opinion "omnium loquentium de ideis," *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 429. Alnwick's worthy editor, Fr. Ledoux, presents him as a *Scotista indepens*. To know that, it would be necessary to know at what degree of independence one ceases to be a Scotist.

11 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 2, number 7, vol. I, p. 1209 [CE VI, p. 407 in appendix]: "Ideae mere naturaliter repraesentant illud quod repraesentant et sub ratione sub qua aliquid repraesentant. Quod probatur ex hoc, quia ideae sunt in intellectu divino ante omnem actum voluntatis divinae, ita quod nullo modo sunt ibi per actum voluntatis divinae; sed quidquid naturaliter praecedit actum voluntatis est mere naturale."—Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 23, vol. I, p. 1224 [CE VI, pp. 428–29 in appendix]: "Hoc autem existente determinate vero, essentia est ratio intellectui divino intelligendi istum verum; et hoc naturaliter quantum est ex parte essentiae, ita quod sicut naturaliter intelligit omni principia necessaria, quasi ante actum voluntatis divinae, quin eorum veritas non esset quia tunc sunt vera: non quidem quod illa vera moveat intellectum divinum, nec etiam termini eorum ad apprehendendum talem veritatem, quia tunc intellectus divinus vilesceret, quia pateretur ab alio ab essentia sua, sed sicut essentia divina est ratio cognoscendi simplicia, ita et complexa talia."—The thesis of Wilhelm Kahl, *Die Lehre vom Primat des Willens bei Augustinus, Scotus und*

Descartes (Strasbourg: Karl J. Trübner, 1886), is interesting, but it can set us off on a false trail. In what concerns Descartes, we attempted to offer a rectification in *Liberté chez Descartes et la théologie* (Paris: Félix Alcan, 1913), pp. 137–49. Its conclusions still seem true to us. When we study the human will below, we will say at what point and within what limits there is a primacy of the will in humans. In God, the only conceivable primacy is the primacy of the infinite essence, which is at once intellect and will.

12 Let us recall that in defining the object of *divine theology* (knowledge that God has of himself) Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 4, number 11, vol. I, pp. 54–55 [CE I, pp. 108–09], posits God's essence as the first object of divine knowledge. This first object includes the totality of all the intelligibles known in act, simultaneously, and distinctly. From this instant, the problem of the ideas is resolved.—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, questions 1 and 2, article 2, number 24, vol. I, p. 208 [CE II, pp. 187–88]: "Intellectus Primi intelligit semper et distincto actu et necessario quaecumque intelligibile, prius naturaliter quam illud sit in se." The theses are recalled in *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1152 [CE VI, pp. 246–47].

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 4, vol. I, p. 1153 [CE VI, pp. 248–49, and 400–01 is found in and appendix as an interpolated text].

14 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 5, vol. I, p. 1154 [CE VI, pp. 249–51]. This is why the idea, tied to God's essence, offers him an object in which he may take pleasure but that leaves his will free. *Quodlibet* XVI, 7 [AW, p. 377]: "Licet necessario voluntas divina habeat actum complacientiae respectu cujuscumque intelligibilis, inquantum in illo ostenditur quaedam partipatio bonitatis propriae, tamen non necessario vult quodcumque creatum volitione efficaci sive determinativa illius ad existendum."

15 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 8, vol. I, p. 1157 [CE VI, pp. 254–55].

16 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 35, sole question, number 9, vol. I, p. 1158 [CE VI, pp. 256–57]: "Non oportet igitur propter intellectionem alicujus objecti praecise quaerere relationem nec in utroque extremo nec in altro. Ergo oportet aliquid aliud addere propter quod sit relatio in utroque extremorum vel in altero; illud autem non video esse nisi vel mutua coexistentia, si est relatio mutua, vel dependentia in altero extremo, si non est mutua. Hic autem quando Deus intelligit aliquid aliud a se, non potest per mutua coexistentia in utroque extremo, ut videtur; ergo praecise sufficit ponere relationem in altero extremo, ubi est dependentia: illud est objectum ut cognitum."

17 Henry of Ghent, *Summa Quaestionum Ordinarium Theologiae* (Paris, 1520), vol. XXI, p. 4, article 9: "Essentia enim, ut dictum est, dicitur res ex respectu ad Deum, inquantum ab ipso exemplata est ab aeterno. Dicitur autem existens ex respectu ad Deum, inquantum ipsa est effectus ejus ex tempore."—Likewise, Henry does not admit that the ideas have being of their own outside God, but they have a being in God. *Quodlibeta Magistri Henrici Goethals a Gandavo* (Paris, 1519), *Quodlibet* VIII, question 1: "Sed sciendum est quod secundum rationes ideales Deus *alia a se* intelligit dupliciter. Uno modo secundum quod sunt essentiae vel existentiae quaedam in se. Alio modo secundum quod sunt quaedam operabilia a Deo."—Cf. Gilson, *La liberté chez Descartes et la théologie*, pp. 39–40, and above all Paulus, *Henri de Gand*, p. 285: "In his eyes, *esse essentiae* represents something no less objective, resistant, and solid than existential being." Compare this with what follows on the necessity in which Henry finds himself consequently of deducing it from God. To avoid having to deduce from God a being distinct from God's, even though it be within God, Duns Scotus is going to substitute the idea's being of reason for the being of essence that Henry of Ghent attributed to it.

18 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 1, vol. I, p. 1169 [CE, p. 272]: “Utrum creatura in quantum est fundamentum relationis aeternae ad Deum ut cognoscentem habeat vere esse essentiae, ex hoc quod est sub tali respectu?” [CE omits the words *creatura in quantum est*.]

19 Dealing with Duns Scotus on this point, historians sometimes have disrupted the balance of his doctrine. Pluzanski, *Essai sur la philosophie de Duns Scot*, p. 184, says: “Existences are created by God and, for Scotus, the possibles are created *qua* possibles before existents.”—This is not faithful to Scotus’s thought. Every creation has an actual existence as its effect. Neither the ideas nor the possibles have actual being of their own. Therefore, they are not created. The divine understanding produces the Ideas, as the artist produces the projects of his possible works. The divine will chooses certain of these possibles, and makes a creatable from the possible, as the artist decides to execute this project rather than that other one. Creation intervenes only when the power executes the will’s order, but its effect is an actual finite being, not its idea or this possibility. Once more, we give way to the illusion that transforms the formal distinctions of being familiar to Duns Scotus into distinctions of real beings. Even a real distinction in the order of formality of itself entails no distinction of real being, particularly in God, where infinity of essence requires that everything that the essence is should be really identical. Strictly speaking, there is no *real, actual* distinction between formalities. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, number 43, vol. I, p. 282 [CE II, p. 355]: “Sed numquid haec distinctio dicitur realis? Respondeo: non est proprie actualis realis, intelligendo sicut communiter dicitur, realis actualis illa quae est differentia rerum in actu . . .” This is why a *realis actualis* distinction cannot be introduced between the Idea’s being and God’s being without making the Idea a creature and rendering any other creation *ex nihilo* impossible. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 3, vol. I, p. 1171 [CE VI, p. 276]: “Primo quia creatio est productio ex nihili: sed si lapis praehabuit esse verum reale, igitur quando producitur ab efficiente non producitur ex nihilo.” [CE inserts *ab aeterno* before *praehabuit*.] For the historical background of this controversy, see Paulus, *Henri de Gant*, pp. 293–98. Note, p. 296, that Henri of Ghent’s doctrine, from which Duns Scotus distances himself, is already a reform of Avicenna.

20 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 3, vol. I, p. 1171 [CE VI, p. 277]: “Et quinto, secundum idem medium de creatione: quia productio rei secundum illud esse essentiae verissime est creatio; ipsa enim est mere de nihilo ut de termino a quo, et ad verum ens ut ad terminum ad quem: et productio ista, secundum eos est aeterna; ergo et creatio est aeterna; cujus oppositum nititur ostendere, et dicit se habere demonstrationes.”

21 This is why Duns Scotus contradicts Henry of Ghent. The idea only has a being of reason. Besides, since *esse essentiae* in his doctrine is not really separable from *esse existentiae*, we cannot admit that the idea has any real *esse* without assimilating this production to creation.—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 7, vol. II, p. 29 [CE VII, pp. 43–45].

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 653 [CE IV, pp. 308–09]: “Quod instatur de intellectu non est simile; quia intellectum esse necessario respectu alicujus objecti non ponit illud esse aliquid in entitate reali aliud a primo objecto, quia esse cognitum ab intellectu divino non ponit illud esse aliquid in entitate reali aliud a primo objecto, quia esse cognitum ab intellectu divino non ponit illud habens ad intelligibilia alia a se sicut voluntas ad alia volibilia, quia ille intellectus potest esse necessario omnium intelligibilium, quatenus sunt sibi praesentia; nec per hoc ponitur aliquid aliud a Deo formaliter necessarium in esse reali. Voluntas autem non posset esse necessario aliquorum aliorum volibilium, nisi illa alia essent aliquando necessaria in aliquo alio esse reali, alio ab esse divino.”—If God had chosen eternally to create nothing, his knowledge of the ideas would be exactly what it is.

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 7, vol. I, p. 1174 [CE VI, p. 283].—In a word, the issue is to conceive the difficult to grasp intermediate being in order to grasp what is *debilius esse reali et majus esse rationis*. This Scotist *esse intelligibile* would remain an apple of discord in the school. In any case, it is an essential element of the doctrine, inseparable from Duns Scotus's ontology. We can accept it or reject it, but it is not possible to reject it and call oneself Duns Scotus's disciple.

24 See Armand Maurer, "*Ens Diminutum*: A Note on Its Origin and Meaning," *Mediaeval Studies*, Toronto, XII, 1950, pp. 216–22. The expression goes back to a Latin translation of an Arabic translation of Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book VI, chapter 4, 1027 b 33. In the broad sense, Maurer, "*Ens Diminutum*," p. 221, note 26, Duns Scotus identifies *ens diminutum* with *ens rationis*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 2, number 3 [CE XI, p. 64]. It is an *ens logicum proprie*, *In Metaphysicam*, book VI, question 3, number 15 [EW II, pp. 79–80, number 71] (Maurer, "*Ens Diminutum*," p. 221, note 27). Let us add that in the case of the divine ideas, which are the issue here, the proper *entitas* of the being of reason, which is the *entitas* of being as object, is not a pure nothing of real being. It is an entity of intelligible being, which formally places it apart in the perfect unity of divine being. William of Alnwick's closely argued critique of this entity of the Idea guarantees that Duns Scotus's position certainly was this. But there were other *realists* beside him in this period. See Henry of Harclay's texts in his questions *De Ideis* cited by Ledoux in Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 29, note 1.

25 Scotus, Opus Oxoniense, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 10, vol. I, p. 1177 [CE VI, p. 289]: "Et si velis quaerere aliquod esse verum hujus objecti ut sic, nullum est quaerere nisi secundum quid, nisi dicatur quod istud esse secundum quid reducitur ad aliquod esse simpliciter, quod est esse hujus intellectionis; sed istud esse simpliciter non est esse formaliter ejus quod dicitur esse secundum quid, sed est ejus terminative vel principative, ita quod ad istud verum esse illud esse secundum quid reducitur, ita quod sine isto vero esse istius non esset illud esse secundum quid."

26 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 10, vol. I, p. 1176 [CE VI, pp. 288–89].—For the contrary view, see Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*. Duns Scotus's student, but not exactly his disciple, Alnwick refuses to distinguish the represented being from the form that represents it. *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 15: "Esse repraesentatum alicujus objecti non est res distincta a forma repraesentante, sicut esse repraesentatum Caesaris et statuam repraesentantem non differt a statua repraesentante nisi in modo significandi."—In a word, in agreement with the Anselmian tradition followed by St. Thomas Aquinas, Alnwick returns to the strict classical thesis, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 16: "Sicut igitur res creata aut creabilis prout continetur in essentia divina perfectionaliter et eminenter non est aliud ab essentia divina et pout continetur virtualiter in Deo non est aliud quam potentia, sic prout habet esse repraesentatum in essentia divina non est aliud quam essentia divina repreasentans et prout habet esse scitum sive cognitum in scientia Dei non et aliud quam scientia Dei."—Cf. Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputate*, pp. 44, 67.

27 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 12, vol. I, p. 1179 [CE VI, pp. 292–94]. See Alnwick's relentless criticism against the concept of esse *secundum quid*, understood in this way, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, pp. 41–43.

28 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 1, vol. I, p. 1169, and number 11, p. 1177 [CE VI, pp. 271–72, 191–92].

29 Alnwick consequently is not fighting phantoms, and his editor Fr. Ledoux says, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 6, note 1: "quia secundum Scotum esse repraesentatum mediat inter esse reale et esse rationis."—Indeed it does, for Duns Scotus would maintain unhesitatingly that the idea is

being of reason and that such a being is not a pure *nihil*.

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 36, sole question, number 10, vol. I, p. 1177 [CE VI, pp. 289–90]: “Ex hoc autem apparet quoddam dictum superius distinctione 3 de cognitione in regulis aeternis, videlicet quod motio intellectus nostri a quidditatibus intelligibilibus reducitur ad ipsum intellectum divinum, per cujus esse simpliciter ista objecta habent esse secundum quid, scilicet esse objectivum, secundum quod esse movent intellectum nostrum ad cognoscendum veritates sinceras, et propter motionem earum dicitur intellectus ille movere, sicut ista habent suum esse secundum quid propter simplicitatem esse illius.”

31 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 18, vol. I, p. 376 [CE III, p. 160]: “Propter verba Augustini oportet concedere quod veritates infallibiles videntur aut intelliguntur aut cognoscuntur in regulis aeternis.” [CE omits *aut intelliguntur aut cognoscuntur*.]

32 See Gilson, *Introduction à l’étude de saint Augustin*, first edition, chapter 5, section 2, pp. 103–25 (English translation by L. E. M. Lynch, *The Christian Philosophy of St. Augustine* [New York: Random House, 1960]).—Étienne Gilson, *La philosophie de saint Bonaventure* (Paris: Vrin, 1943), chapter 12, pp. 304–24 (English translation by Trethowan and Sheed, *The Philosophy of St. Bonaventure*).—For different interpretations of Augustinian illumination, see Johannes Hessen, *Augustins Metaphysik der Erkenntniss* (Berlin: Bümmler, 1931), pp. 98–113 (second edition, Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1960).

33 Upon Augustine’s authority (as they understood it), Scotus’s predecessors admitted an illumination that was natural although special. As we see in Matthew of Aquasparta, that was even one of their principal difficulties. Duns Scotus did not understand illumination thus. By citing passages of *De Trinitate* book IV, chapter 15, book IV, chapter 16, and book IX, chapter 6, where Augustine says that the pagan philosophers know many truths thanks to the divine light and the eternal wisdom, Scotus gives us to understand that this illumination common to all humans cannot have been *special*. This implies that a special illumination, and therefore one different from the natural light, would be fully supernatural, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 21, vol. I, p. 379 [CE III, p. 168]. Note the conclusion: “Ibi maxime removetur illustratio specialis et sufficit sola generalis.”

34 “Inquantum sunt objecta secundaria intellectus divini,” since the divine essence itself is the first object of the divine intellect.

35 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 18, vol. I, pp. 376–77 [CE III, pp. 160–61].—Cf. St. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XIV, chapter 15, number 21, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. 42, column 1052.

36 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 19, vol. I, p. 377 [CE III, p. 162]: “Sic ergo in luce aeterna secundum quid sicut in objecto proximo videmus, sed in luce increata videmus secundum tertium modum, sicut scilicet in causa proxima cujus virtute objectum proximum movet.”

37 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 19, vol. I, p. 377 [CE III, p. 162]: “Videmus in luce aeterna sicut in causa proxima objecti in se; nam intellectus divinus producit ista actu suo in *esse intelligibili*, et actu suo dat huic objecto *esse* tale, et illi tale, et per consequens dat eis talem rationem objecti, per quam rationem primo movent intellectum ad cognitionem talem certam.” [EC has *post* instead of *primo* here.]—Duns Scotus does not speak of *talitas*, *suchness* here. We introduce this term here, which was well known in the Scotist school, in order to express the viewpoint of the *such*, in which Duns Scotus situates himself here.

38 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 20, vol. I, pp. 378–79 [CE III, p. 164]: “Ex isto apparet . . .”

39 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 20, vol. I, pp. 378–79 [CE III, p. 163, "*Et si obiciatur* . . .] "Et si objicias . . ."

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 19, vol. I, pp. 378 [CE III, p. 163]: "Ista igitur duplex causalitas intellectus divini, qui est vera lux increata, videlicet, quod producit objecta secundaria in esse intelligibili, et quod est illud virtute cujus objecta secundaria etiam producta movent actualiter intellectum, potest quasi integrare unum tertium membrum de causa propter quam dicamur vere videre in luce aeterna." [CE omits *de causa*.]

41 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 20: "Respondeo ergo ad quaestionem, primo sequendo alium Doctorem antiquum, scilicet Bonaventuram, et dico quod idea, sive accipiatur ut ratio et principium cognoscendi, sive ut exemplar et principium operandi, quasi quaelibet idea, ut credo, utroque modo potest accipi, ipsa est cujuslibet alterius positivi a Deo, sive sit factibile in se, sive in altero, sive sit absolutum, sive respectivum, ita quod cujuslibet istorum est propria idea in Deo."—St. Augustine's influence is much stronger in Henry of Harclay, who, because the Bishop of Hippo had said of the ideas, "non enim formatae sunt," concludes that his ideas have a real entity distinct *a parte rei*, *non per operationem intellectus*, within the divine intellect. See the selections from his question, *De Ideis*, in Alnwick, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, p. 29 note 1.

42 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 20.

43 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 20.

44 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 23.

45 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 10: "Et mirum est quod aliqui intelligentes ex hoc concludant quod materia secundum se non sit cognoscibilis, quia non est cognoscibilis a nobis nisi per analogiam ad formam . . . Unde et perfectionis esset in intellectu nostro si posset cognoscere materiam, sicut perfectionis est in sensu quod potest cognoscere minimum sensibile."

46 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 23.—At bottom the decisive reason that settles everything here is that matter is creatable and consequently has an idea. Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 9: "Materia secundum se est ens. Agitur per se factibilis; igitur per se habet ideam."—According to St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 15, article 3, response to objection 3, matter has its idea in God, but not separate from the idea of composite, because matter can neither exist nor be known in itself.

47 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 23.—At the beginning of this question, Duns Scotus takes Thomas Aquinas to task (*Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 15, article 3).—See *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 6.

48 Reportata Parisiensia, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 11.

49 Reportata Parisiensia, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 12. This is entirely in agreement with another thesis that the accident has an *esse* of its own, distinct from its substance's *esse*.—By contrast, according to St. Thomas, in God there is not an idea of a genus distinct from the idea of the species or ideas of inseparable accident that are distinct from the ideas of their substances, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 15, article 3, reply to objection 4.

50 This seems to aim directly at St. Thomas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 15, article 3, reply to objection 4, end.

51 Reportata Parisiensia, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 14.—According to St. Thomas Aquinas, God knows in their very singularity because he is their cause and because his knowledge extends as far as his causality. God knows singulars even in their principle of individuation, which

is their matter, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 14, article 11, body of article, without needing, on account of that, an idea of their matter distinct from the idea of their form.

52 Reportata Parisiensia, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 25: "Intentio naturae in specie sistit, tanquam in perfectiore quam sit genus, et sistit in individuo, tanquam in entitate perfectiori et realiori quam sit entitas speciei."—Here the controversy aims directly at St. Thomas Aquinas, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 14: "Quando enim dicit quod individuum non est de intentione naturae, et tamen providentia est primo circa individua, videtur esse contradictio, quia natura non est agens propter finem, nisi quatenus dirigitur a cognoscente finem; igitur natura agens propter finem non intendit finem nisi ut directa in finem a cognoscente et providente; igitur si natura producit individuum in quantum dirigitur a Deo et Dei providentia, et non solum sistit in speciebus, sed principaliter est circa individua, oportet ut intentio naturae non solum sistat in natura specie, sed etiam per se in individuo.—*Ibidem*: "Item individua sunt maxime substantiae, quia sunt primae substantiae. Unde de illis non est dubitatio quin quodlibet eorum dicat unitatem realem et entitatem . . . cum igitur natura maxime intendat illud quod est maximae entitatis et perfectionis, mirum videtur quod natura solum intendat de specie et non de individuo."—The position is perfectly coherent. If the individual's ultimate reality stems from the *essence's coordination*, nothing but a distinct idea can represent it in God. All the possible resources of Thomist *esse* stem from another perspective, and reality cannot be viewed in the two perspectives at once.

53 Reportata Parisiensia, book I, distinction 36, question 4, numbers 26–27. Here, Duns Scotus explicitly appeals to the doctrine of his Order and more precisely to his "elder," Bonaventure. First, regarding the definition of the idea, let it be understood "sequendo alium doctorem antiquum, scilicet Bonaventuram," whether as "ratio et principium cognoscendi," or as "exempla et principium operandi," there is an idea in God for everything God can do, which is to say, for everything that is "factibile in se" or "in altero," *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 20. Next, regarding the infinity of ideas: "Dicendum est cum antiquo doctore Bonaventura, quod in Deo sunt infinitae ideae. Propter tamen infinitatem vitandam forte negaverunt alias esse ideas esse individuorum et partium in toto; sed frustra hoc intendunt vitare, quia concedunt in Deo esse infinita cognita, quia infinita intelligit, sed non est ratio quare Deo magis repugnat infinitas idearum quam cognitorum, quia non arguit compositionem una infinitas, sicut nec alia, nec sequitur aliqua imperfectio magis ex infinitate idearum, quam ex infinitate cognitorum," *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 36, question 4, number 26. References are found in Gilson, *La philosophie de saint Bonaventure*, p. 131, note 1.—Beyond St. Bonaventure, Duns Scotus goes back to Augustine here, *De Primo Principio*, chapter 4, conclusion 9, p. 106: "Item: infinitas intelligibilium specie confirmatur ex numeris et figuris per Augustinum XII *De Civitate Dei*, capitulo 18."—So, behind Augustine, Scotus's doctrine of the infinite being goes back to Plotinus in the measure in which the infinity of the intelligibles allows him to affirm the infinity of God.

54 Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book VI, chapter 10, article 11, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, column 931: ". . . tanquam Verbum perfectum cui non desit aliquid, et ars quaedam omnipotentis atque sapientis Dei, plena omnium rationum viventium incommutabilium; et omnes unum in eo, sicut ipsa unum de uno, cum quo unum."—Cf. Augustine, *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 46, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, columns 29–31.

55 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 38, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1199 [CE VI, pp. 304–05].

56 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 38, sole question, number 5, vol. I, p. 1201 [CE VI, pp. 307–08 and p. 404 in appendix for interpolated material].

57 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 38, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1199 [CE VI, p. 305].

58 Like the intellect, the will is also an absolute perfection. Therefore, God possesses it, and in him it is identical to his essence and infinite like his essence. Yet, between the will and the divine essence or between the will and the other divine perfections, there is a distinction that is not simply of reason, because the will as such is not the intellect as such. Therefore, we must admit within this essential identity, *aliqua distinctio ex parte rei secundum quid*, that is to say, a nonformal nonidentity between the intellect, will, and essence. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 45, question 2, number 9: "Et intelligo per *non identitatem formalem* aliquorum, quando unum non est de formali ratione alterius, ita quod si definiretur, non pertineret ad definitionem ejus; igitur per *non identitatem formalem* intelligo non identitatem quidditativam non pertinentem ad definitionem alterius, si definiretur."—In the context of the soul's relation to its powers, we will have to return to the compatibility of the formal, and even real, distinction with the real unity of being but let us recall that infinity is the cause of identity in God. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 45, question 2, number 16: "Deitas non esset realiter infinita, nisi esset realiter eadem sapientiae et voluntati: ergo si deitas sit formaliter infinita, est eadem formaliter voluntati."

59 Minges, *J. Duns Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 101.

60 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 7, vol. I, pp. 1208–09 [CE VI, p. 406 in appendix].

61 Minges, *J. Duns Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 102.

62 Bonaventure, *In I Sententiarum*, distinction 35, *articulus unicus*, question 2, reply to objection 3, vol. I, p. 483.—*In I Sententiarum*, distinction 35, *articulus unicus*, question 4, body of article, vol. I, p. 486: God has the ideas of all individuals.—*In I Sententiarum*, distinction 39, article 2, question 3, body of article, vol. I, p. 553: God knows the ideas of all future things as present and simultaneous.

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 7, vol. I, p. 1209 [CE VI, pp. 406–07 in appendix]. Cf. book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 11, vol. II, pp. 342–43 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 not included in CE VII].

64 Duns Scotus did not put this fundamental thesis of Avicenna into circulation among the Latins. It is already found in Matthew of Aquasparta, where, as in Avicenna, it justifies the possibility of knowing what does not exist. The consequence is self-evident, because abstractive intellection does not know the existent as existent. Abstractive knowledge always has as its term, along with a being of essence, a nonbeing of existence. Matthew, *Quaestiones Disputatae de Fide et Cognitione*, Quaracchi, 1903, p. 230, refers to Avicenna, who in *Metaphysics*, V, 2, and V, 8, *et in multis locis* says: "In omni creato differt quidditas et esse, nec esse est de intellectu quidditatis, immo indifferenter se habet ad esse et non esse; et ideo nihil refert intelligere quidditatem rei absque eo, quod res sit in actu. Hoc explicata, non respicit hominis existentiam vel non existentiam, imo nullo homine existente, ista est vera: homo est animal."—*Quaestiones Disputatae de Fide et Cognitione*, p. 231: "Nam, nec re existente, quidditas, ut est in rebus, est intellectus objectum."—We see that Duns Scotus had at least one predecessor in his own Order, and that he is situated within a tradition.

65 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 7, vol. I, p. 1209 [CE VI, p. 407; the material given as an extract does not seem to be a literal quotation].

66 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 14, article 3, body of article: "Et licet contingentia fiant in actu succesive, non tamen Deus successive cognoscit contingentia prout sunt in suo esse,

sicut nos, sed simul: quia sua cognitio mensuratur aeternitate, sicut etiam suum esse: aeternitas autem tota simul existens ambit totum tempus . . . Unde manifestum est, quod contingentia infallibiliter a Deo cognoscuntur, in quantum subduntur divino conspectui secundum suam praesentialitatem; et tamen sunt futura contingentia suis causis proximis comparata."—Cf. Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 8, vol. I, p. 1210 [CE VI, p. 407 in appendix]: "Aliter ponitur quod certam notitiam habet Deus de futuris contingentibus, per hoc quod totus fluxus temporis praesens est aeternitati et omnia quae sunt in tempore."

67 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, *questio unica*, number 9, vol. I, p. 1211 [CE VI, pp. 409–10 in appendix].

68 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 10, vol. I, p. 1212 [CE VI, pp. 410–11 in appendix].

69 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 14, article 13, reply to objection 1.

70 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 12, vol. I, p. 1213 [CE VI, pp. 412–13].

71 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 12, vol. I, p. 1213 [CE VI, pp. 412–13].—Consequently, the philosophers admitted an implicitly contradictory position by maintaining both that there is contingency in the world and that the first cause causes necessarily, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 16, vol. II, p. 44 [CE VII, pp. 77–79].

72 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, *ibidem*.—Cf. Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 39, question 2, numbers 2–5. (Translator: my surmise is that *ibidem* refers to Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 12.)

73 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 13, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, p. 415 in appendix].—Therefore contingency can be proven a posteriori, but not *a priori*, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 40, number 6.

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 14, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, p. 416 in appendix]: "Nulla causatio alicujus causae potest salvare contingentiam, nisi prima causa ponatur immediate contingenter causare, et hoc ponendo in prima causa perfectam causalitatem, sicut *Catholici ponunt*." This *perfect causality*, as the Catholics understand it, will be clarified further on in the context of divine omnipotence, whose concept, since every argument of Duns Scotus presupposes that God could cause *immediate* whatsoever effect, is henceforth at work in what has just been said. The Catholics' *perfecta causalitas* and *omnipotentia* are the same thing.

75 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 38, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1199 [CE VI, pp. 304–05].—Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 14, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, p. 416 in appendix]: "Primum autem est causans per intellectum et voluntatem, et si ponatur tertia potentia executiva alia ab istis, non juvat ad propositum, quia si necessario intelligat et velit, necessario producit. Oportet ergo contingentiam istam quaerere in voluntate divina, vel in intellectu divino; non autem in intellectu ut habet actum primum ante omnem actum voluntatis, quia quidquid intellectus intelligit hoc modo, intelligit mere naturaliter et necessitate naturali, et ita nulla contingentia potest esse in sciendo aliquod quod non scit, vel in intelligendo aliquid quod non intelligit tali intellectione prima: primam ergo contingentiam oportet quaerere in voluntate Divina."—Let us add, more profoundly yet, that mere knowledge can produce nothing, *Quodlibet* II, 26 [AW, p. 54]: "Essentia mere intellectualis non est principium alicujus productionis, nisi ut coincidit cum memoria et voluntate." This is true, first of all, in God himself *ad intra* and with even more reason *ad extra*.

76 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, questions 1 and 2, number 20, vol. I, p. 202 [CE II, pp. 174–77].

77 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 13, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, p. 415 in appendix].

78 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 2, number 12, vol. I, p. 1213 [CE VI, pp. 412–13 in appendix].

79 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 14, vol. I, p. 1215 [CE VI, pp. 415–16 in appendix].

80 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 43, sole question, number 3, vol. I, p. 1277 [CE VI, p. 354]: "Lapis est possibilis esse ex se formaliter; ergo reducendo quasi ad primum principium extrinsecum, intellectus divinus erit illud a quo est prima ratio possibilitatis in lapide."

81 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 16; "Sed unde habet homo quod sit talis natura, cui non repugnat esse? Dico quod ab intellectu divino, quia est tale intelligibile."—Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 43, sole question, number 5, vol. I, p. 1279 [CE VI, p. 358]: "Res producta ab intellectu divino in esse tali, scilicet intelligibili, in primo instanti naturae, habet seipsa formaliter esse possibile in secundo instanti naturae, quia seipsa formaliter non repugnat sibi esse, et seipsa formaliter repugnat sibi habere esse necessarium ex se, in quibus duobus stat tota ratio possibilis . . ." [CE has *omnipotentiae* instead of *possibilis*.].

82 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 17 [AW, p. 332].—Cf. *Quodlibet* XIV, number 14 [AW, p. 329]: "Omnino primum mobile motione naturali, extensive loquendo, est intellectus divinus, et ideo primum motivum motione naturali est essentia divina, ut est primum objectum intellectus sui; igitur omnino prima motio est naturalis motio intellectus divini a suo objecto."

83 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 10, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 679 [CE II, pp. 341–42].

84 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 10, sole question, number 11, vol. I, p. 6 86–87 [CE IV, pp. 359–61].—In God, the word *natura* primarily signifies the divine essence itself, in which there are three persons. In a second sense *natura* means the natural active principle, and understood in this way, the nature is a force that produces like from like, for example, the power that the Father has of engendering. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 10, number 3, vol. I, p. 680 [CE IV, p. 345]: "Tertio modo dicitur natura quaelibet vis naturaliter existens in natura prima modo dicta, quae scilicet vis etsi sit libera tamen hoc modo potest dici natura; et sic voluntas in Deo dicitur natura, quia scilicet est naturaliter potentia existens in natura divina naturaliter." Cf. *Quodlibet* XIV, number 14 [AW, pp. 329–30].

85 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XVI, number 9 [AW, p. 379]: "Et si quaeras, quomodo stat libertas cum necessitate? Respondeo secundum Philosophum quarto *Metaphysicae*, non est quaerenda ratio eorum quorum non est ratio: 'Demonstrationis enim principii non est demonstratio.' Ita dico hic quod sicut ista est immediata et necessaria: voluntas divina vult bonitatem divinam, nec est alia ratio nisi quia haec est talis voluntas et illa talis bonitas; sic voluntas divina contingenter vult bonitatem seu existentiam alterius, et hoc quia est talis voluntas et illud est tale bonum, nisi addamus generaliter unum breve, quod voluntas infinita necessario habet actum circa objectum infinitum, quia hoc est perfectionis; et pari ratione non necessario habet actum circa objectum infinitum, quia hoc esset imperfectionis, nam imperfectionis est necessario determinari ad posterius, et perfectionis requisitae est sic determinari ad prius, et perfectionis concomitantis ad illud quod est simul natura."—A will does not cease to be free because it so perfect that it cannot err in regard to its object. To maintain the contrary, it would be necessary to claim that freedom is incompatible with the will's act by reason of the very perfection of this act, *Quodibet* XVI, number 8. In short, the divine will wants necessarily, only because it is perfectly will, which is to say freedom. Cf. *Ordinatio*, II, p. 88, number 132 [*Sic*, translator].

86 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 10, number 11, vol. I, 687 [CE IV, p. 361]: “Non est autem ita quando voluntas infinita respicit bonum amabile finitum; quia licet ibi actus sit infinitus quantum est ex parte voluntatis divinae, non tamen est infinitus quantum est ex parte objecti.” Cf. *Quodlibet* XVI, number 7 [AW, pp. 376–77].

87 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 15 [AW, p. 331]: “Completo autem toto isto processu originis respectu primi termini scilicet essentiae divinae communicandae, sequitur ordo alius respectu termini secundi essentiae, scilicet creabilis; et quidem essentia ipsa divina in isto secundo ordine movet primo ad intellectionem simplicem omnis intelligibilis, et haec intelligentia ut jam est in tribus suppositis; non autem movet ad distinctam notitam veritatis cujuscumque complexionis, quasi moveret determinante ad cognoscendum alteram partem in futuris contingentibus, cum naturale movens necessario moveat, sequitur quod intellectus divinus necessario intelligeret hanc partem contradictionis fore veram, et ita vel posset errare, vel oppositum non posset evenire, et tunc non esset contingens sed necessarium, illud quod ponitur esse contingens.”

88 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 16 [AW, p. 331]: “[Primum intelligibile] naturaliter movet, et per consequens necessario ad cognitionem cujuscumque quod est possibile naturaliter et necessario cognosci; hujusmodi est quodcumque objectum simplex et etiam quodcumque complexum verum necessarium; non autem tale est aliquod complexum de existentia contingentis, quia non est datum esse determinatum ad veritatem.”

89 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 16 [AW, pp. 331–32].

90 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 4 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 341, number 37]: “Primo inquiretur intentio philosophorum in hac quaestione, scilicet Aristotelis et Avicennae, qui magis sunt famosi inter philosophos.”

91 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 3, vol. I, pp. 642–43 [CE IV, p. 282].

92 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 8, pp. 646–47 [CE IV, p. 294]: “De intentione istorum philosophorum Aristotelis et Avicennae, nescio: sed nolo eis imponere absurdiora quam ipsi dicant, vel quam ex dictis eorum necessaria sequitur, et ex dictis eorum volo rationabiliorem intellectum accipere quem possum.”—For the interpretations of Aristotle and Avicenna’s necessitarianism that Scotus deems arbitrary and for which he refuses in consequence to attribute responsibility to Aristotle and Avicenna, see numbers 6–7, pp. 644–46, and number 10, pp. 647–48 [CE IV, pp. 288–94 and 298–99].

93 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 19 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 353, number 70, and p. 354, number 72].—On Avicenna’s position, see Gerard Smith, S.J., “Avicenna and the Possibles,” *The New Scholasticism*, XVII (October 1943), pp. 340–57.

94 It is hardly necessary to observe that *praecise* has technical value here. It means *to conceive humanity* prescinding from any determination that is accidental to the essence.

95 Scotus, *Reportata, Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 3, number 19 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 354, numbers 72–73].

96 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 9, vol. I, p. 647 [CE IV, pp. 296–97]. In what immediately precedes this, see [CE IV, pp. 294–95]: “Respondeo igitur, quod Aristoteles simul et Avicenna posuerunt Deum necessario se habere ad alia extra se; et ex hoc sequitur quod quodlibet aliud necessaro se habere ad illum ipsum quod qui immediate comparatur ad ipsum, vel non mediante motu . . . Tenendo illud falsum fundamentum, scilicet Aristoteles, ponendo ipsum esse causam necessarium, non videtur contradicere sibi ponendo causatum necessarium.”—Cf. Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1, 1508 edition, folio 86 verso.

97 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 12, vol. I, pp. 649–50 [CE IV, pp. 300–02].

98 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 13, vol. I, p. 650 [CE IV, p. 302].

99 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 13, vol. I, pp. 650–51 [CE IV, pp. 302–03]. Cf. Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, chapter 5.

100 Duns Scotus himself uses the concept of liberality to express the fecundity of a being whose action gushes forth from the plenitude of his perfection, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, article 2, number 4, vol. I, p. 243 [CE II, p. 268].

101 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 15, vol. I, p. 652 [CE IV, p. 305–07].—Pluzanski, *Essai sur la philosophie de Duns Scot*, p. 188, has seen the importance of this point very clearly.

102 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 16, vol. I, p. 653 [CE IV, pp. 288–90].

103 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, numbers 21–22, vol. I, pp. 1222–23 [CE VI, pp. 425–28 in appendix]. The conciliation of divine science, which is infallible, with the contingency of being is not impossible. God's intellect offers his will simple terms whose different modes of compositions are objects of purely speculative knowledge. His will chooses one of these possible arrangements and by wishing it, *facit illud determinate esse verum: hoc erit pro A*. So, at the same time, God knows the truth of future contingents infallibly, and he knows it by his essence, as he knows the truth of the ideas. At the same time, *stat contingentia objecti cogniti, quia voluntas volens hoc determinate, contingenter vult hoc*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, number 24, vol. I, pp. 1224–25 [CE VI, p. 430 in appendix].—Predestination strictly speaking is a particular act of the divine will choosing an angel or human for heavenly glory, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 40, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1240 [CE VI, p. 215]. It is infallible because, since God is immutable, he cannot successively fail to predestine a creature after having predestined it. Nor, because it is contradictory, can he fail to predestine someone predestined. But the predestination remains contingent, because God could damn the one he predestined, and the damned person could be predestined to glory. A contingent decree's immutability takes nothing away from its intrinsic contingency. It remains immutably and eternally contingent. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 40, sole question, vol. I, pp. 1240–42 [CE VI, pp. 309–13]. This conception of freedom will be revisited later on in more detail in the context of the human will.

104 Scotus *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 17, vol. I, p. 653 [CE IV, pp. 310–11].

105 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 3.

106 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 8: "Dico ergo ad istum articulum, quod, etiam ex mente Philosophi, Deus potest sic creare, hoc est, quod potest creare aliquid post nihil ordine naturae, sine aliquo praesupposito quod sit pars causati, et non solum sicut forma causatur de novo, quia licet nihil ejus praeexistebat, tamen aliquid praesupponebatur, quod recipit formam. Sic non est in creatione, quia nihil praesupponitur, nec tanquam pars nec tanquam recipiens, sed post non esse totale ordine naturae, dantur esse."

107 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 9: "Patet ergo per rationem naturalem quod etsi Philosophus hoc non diceret, quod possit probari aliquid esse a Deo causabile hoc modo."

108 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book XII, chapter 7, 1072 b 14.

109 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction I, question 3, number 8.

110 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 11: “Secundum membrum principale est de creatione, secundum quod est de nihilo, sive post nihil ordine durationis. Et dico quod Aristoteles non dixit Deum aliquid creare isto modo; nec propter hoc sequitur quod contrarium non possit esse notum per rationem naturalem; nec sequitur, Philosophi hoc posuerunt, igitur est notum demonstratione per rationem naturalem. Multa enim non posuerunt philosophi, quae tamen possunt cognosci per naturalem rationem; et multa ponunt quae non possunt demonstrari, quia per nihil, quod nobis apparet, potest demonstrari quod sint plures motores orbium, quando sufficeret Deus tantum.”—Note once again that Scotus speaks of *philosophers* and not of *philosophy*. As we see in the section of the text immediately following, the debate goes on between *philosophi* and *Catholici*, conceived as sometimes agreeing and sometimes disagreeing. Even when the *philosopher* and the *Catholic* both use pure natural reason, they do not stop being what they are. On the other hand, this text encourages us to limit the scope of an observation we have made several times: at least at the level of critique of doctrines. The theologian can still create something new in the philosophical order. Since the theologian must establish by reason that the object of faith is not *impossible*, he is naturally led to expand the field of philosophical possibilities considerably. There are many of them of which the philosophers never thought.

111 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, number 2, folio 92, recto c.

112 Averroes, *In IV Metaphysicae*, 3, Venice: 1552, vol. III, folio 32, recto: “Avicenna autem peccavit multum in hoc, quod existimavit quod unum et ens significant dispositiones additas essentiae rei. Et mirum est de isto homine, quomodo erravit tali errore; et iste audivit Loquentes in nostra Lege, cum quorum sermonibus admiscuit ipse suam scientiam divinam.”—Creation is not the issue there, but the remark is general in its scope, and since the Avicennist distinction of *esse* and *essentia* is explained in Averroes’s mind by the fact that Avicenna borrowed the concept of creation from the Muslim theologians, we are exactly at the heart of the matter. This point can be confirmed in Averroes, *Destructio Destructionis*, disputation VIII, vol. IX, folio 43 verso: “Et debes scire quod innovatio, quam Lex declaravit de hoc mundo, est ejusdem spcciei cum innovatione quae apparet hic . . . Quod vero existimat secta Assaria quod natura possibilis sit innovata, et creata ex nihilo, est id in quod certant cum eis philosophi . . .”—The Averroist opposition between philosophy and theology left its traces. The 1277 condemnation gave it a specific meaning.

113 This passage from Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, chapter 2, is quoted by Duns Scotus in *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 7, vol. I, p. 646 [CE IV, p. 293], and again in *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 3, vol. II, p. 24 [CE VII, p. 34].

114 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction I, question 2, number 3, vol. II, p. 25 [CE VII, pp. 35–36].

115 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8 question 5, article 2, section 1, number 8, vol. I, p. 647 [CE IV, pp. 294–95].

116 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 4, vol. II, p. 26 [CE VII, p. 37].

117 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 4, vol. II, p. 26 [CE VII, pp. 37–38].

118 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 5, vol. II, p. 26 [CE VII, p. 38]. Furthermore, let us note that even created from all eternity, the world would not be eternal in the sense in which Duns Scotus understands eternity, namely, as excluding all succession, *Quodlibet*

VI, 14 [AW, pp. 141–42].

119 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 5, vol. II, pp. 26–27 [CE VII, pp. 38–40].

120 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book IV, chapter 6, 1011 a 8–10.

121 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 9, vol. II, p. 31 [CE VII, p. 48]. Let us specify that here, divine freedom makes the existence of a particular contingent be good, but divine freedom does not make its essence be what it is.

122 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 10, vol. II, pp. 31–32 [CE VII, p. 48].

123 See Reinhold Seeberg's observation in *Die Theologie des Johannes Duns Scotus; eine dogmeneschichtliche Untersuchung* (Leipzig: Deiterich, 1900), pp. 169–72, and Ephrem Longpré's approval of it in *La philosophie du bienheureux Duns Scot*, Paris: Societé et Librairie S. François d'Assise, 1924, p. 140, note 1. Longpré's book, pp. 140–47, offers a long sketch of this theological synthesis. Fr. Longpré's irritation upon reading Bernard Landry, *Duns Scot* (Paris: Alcan, 1922), is understandable. But in defense of Landry, it must be remembered that in its author's mind, and moreover in the usual title, the undertaking was entitled *La philosophie de Duns Scot*. It is arbitrary to judge Duns Scotus's thinking by what he accepted for purely philosophical reasons, and Landry sometimes incurred in this failing. But it is also arbitrary (although less harmful to Scotus's thinking) to attribute conclusions to him as philosophical that he himself regarded as theological. Areas for patient research are still available to those who would like to confront this last problem in detail. So far everyone has gone a little hastily. We do not need to attack or to defend, but to observe and reflect.

124 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 11.

125 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 46, article 2. Duns Scotus discusses St. Thomas on this point in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 4, number 18.

126 Gilson, *La philosophie de saint Bonaventure*, first edition, 1924, chapter 6, pp. 183–89.

127 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 10, vol. II, pp. 40–41 [CE VII, pp. 69–71].

128 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 10, vol. II, p. 41 [CE VII, pp. 70–71].

129 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 5, vol. II, p. 36 [CE VII, p. 57]: "Confirmatur etiam, quia non videtur probabile quod tam praeclari philosophi, et tam diligenter veritatem inquirentes, et tam perspicaciter rationem terminorum concipientes, non vidissent contradicionem inclusam, si fuisset inclusa in terminis."—Note that there is not a proof here but a *confirmatur*. Furthermore, Scotus himself does not hesitate to say that the *philosophers* contradicted themselves, when he thinks of taking them up on the issue.

130 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 4, vol. II, pp. 35–36 [CE VII, p. 56].

131 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 20, vol. II, p. 48–49 [CE VII, pp. 85–87].—However, Duns Scotus notes that the point indeed is that certain philosophers do not regard an infinity of *accidentally ordered* beings as impossible. But he adds the following argument. An eternally created universe would be in time or in the *aevum*? Before wondering whether an infinite succession of beings would be possible, it would be necessary to know if there was succession in it.

132 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, numbers 6–7, vol. II, pp. 36–38 [CE

VII, pp. 58–63].

133 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 5, number 21, vol. II, pp. 69–70 [CE VII, pp. 129–30].

134 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 5, number 23, vol. II, pp. 70–71 [CE VII, pp. 132–33].

135 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 5, number 17, vol. II, p. 66 [CE VII. pp. 120–22].

136 In the passage let us note Duns Scotus's scruple in speaking about *formal distinction* in the divine essence. He prefers to talk about formal *nonidentity*. In regard to Duns Scotus's formal distinction, we observe a phenomenon similar to what occurs in the context of analogy in St Thomas. These two doctrines are everywhere in their author's work, more as tools than as a matter for speculation. They become objects in themselves in the disciples. We do not mean that their authors did not define them. Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7 [CE II, pp. 255–377]. Rather we mean that their disciples wrote treatises *De Formalitatibus*. On the doctrine's history, see the excellent articles by Bernard Jansen, S. J., "Beiträge zur geschichtlichen Entwicklung der *Distinctio Formalis*," *Zeitschrift für Katolische Theologie* LIII (1929), pp. 317–44 and 517–44. For Duns Scotus in particular, see pp. 321–32.

137 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 45, article 5, body of article: "Oportet enim universaliores effectus in universaliores et priores causas reducere. Inter omnes autem effectus universalissimum est ipsum esse. Unde oportet quod sit proprius effectus primae et universalissimae causae, quae est Deus. Unde etiam dicitur libro *De Causis* (propositione 31) quod neque Intelligentia, vel anima nobilis dat esse, nisi inquantum operatur operatione divina."—Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 5 [CE XI, p. 10]: "Prima ratio sumitur ex parte termini creationis, quae talis est: effectus universaliores oportet in causas universaliores reducere; sed inter omnes effectus universalissimus est ipsum esse; ergo est proprius effectus causae universalissimae. Unde dicitur in libro *De Causis*, quod nec Intelligentia, nec anima rationalis dat esse, nisi inquantum operatur operatione divina."—Further on, number 8 [CE XI, pp. 17–19], Duns Scotus will respond that the text of *De Causis* implies, to the contrary, that the Intelligence could give *esse* (which is right), and he will even add that we are mistaken about the meaning of the well-known proposition 4, *prima rerum creatarum est esse*, at least if, as certain authors affirm, the proposition does not mean that *esse* is the immediate term of the creation, but that the first creature is the Intelligence that comes immediately after God. Every historian will acknowledge that this is good exegesis. Roger Bacon had already said so, still more firmly than Duns Scotus.

138 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 7 [CE XI, pp. 14–16]. Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 5.—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 7: "Esse non est nobilissimus effectus Dei, sed imperfectissimus, quia per se includitur in effectu ejus imperfectissimo; nihil enim est in universo ita imperfectum quin includat esse, et omne agens quodcumque potens super aliquod, potest super esse; commune enim est secundum se perfectis et imperfectis."

139 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 7 [CE XI, pp. 15–16].

140 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 8, article 1, body of article. In the opposite sense, Scotus *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 2, number 3: "Nullum esse dicit aliquid additum essentiae, quia si sic, quaerendum esset de isto addito, cum ipsum sit ens, an suum esse dicit additum supra essentiam, et sic esset processus in infinitum."

141 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 105, article 5, body of article: "Et quia forma rei est

intra rem, et tanto magis quanto consideratur ut prior et universalior; et ipse Deus est proprie causa ipsius esse universalis in rebus omnibus, quod inter omnia est magis intimum rebus; sequitur quod Deus in omnibus intime operetur."

142 Aquinas, *Summa Theologia*e, part I, question 45, article 5, reply to objection 3.

143 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 11 [CE XI, p. 22]: "non plus autem deficit nihil ab ente, quam ens illud ponit." For example, *ibidem* [CE XI, p. 23]: "Terminus ad quem creationis est finitus; ergo non potest concludi ex hoc quin super ipsum possit virtus finita."—Again. *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 13 [CE XI, p. 25]: "Positivi autem ad non positivum nulla est proportio, sicut nec entis ad nihil . . ." and so on.—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 10: "Ergo tanta est distantia inter contradictoria quantum est extremum nobilius; ut inter terminos creationis *esse* et *non esse*, gratiae et non gratiae, extremum nobilius, ut *esse* gratiae, est finitum; ergo et distantia inter illa est finita."

144 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate IX, chapter 4, folios 104–05.

145 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate VI, chapter 2, folio 92 recto c: "*ex nihilo, id est post nihil, non ordine durationis, sed naturae*."

146 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 45, article 5, reply to objection 1. Duns Scotus completely dissected this article and left almost nothing in it unanswered.

147 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 17 [CE XI. pp. 29–31].—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 12: "Alio modo accipitur creatio solum excludendo causam materialem concausantem, et isto modo creatio est productio alicujus de nihilo, quia de nulla materia, et hoc modo accipiendo eam, difficile est prohibere quin possit creatio competere agenti creato respectu multorum, ut respectu formarum per se subsistentium, cujus modi sunt angeli, si sunt formae simplices, et etiam respectu formarum quae non educuntur de potentia materiae ut animae intellectivae . . . De primis autem formis ponit. Avicenna IX *Metaphysicae*, capitulo 4, quod Intelligentia superior creavit aliam Intelligentiam sibi proximam, non quod omnes Intelligentiae sint a Primo immediate productae vel creatae . . . Et si Aristoteles concors sit cum eo in istis duabus propositionibus, scilicet quod Intelligentiae sint productae, et non ex se, et quod ab aliquo non possit esse nisi unum, idem poneret ipse, quod una scilicet Intelligentia crearetur ab alia, accipiendo creationem prout esse ipsius producti est per creationem et sequitur suum non esse, natura et non duratione, ut Avicenna loquitur de creatione."

148 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 18 [CE XI, p. 32]: "Nihil autem est formale principium producendi aliquid perfectius seipso; si enim univoce producat, est aeque perfectum; si aequivoce, oportet quod sit perfectius."

149 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 22 [CE XI, pp. 39–40].—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 12: "Et sic creatio est productio alicujus in esse since quacumque alia causa concreante primo creanti, excepta causalitate finis. Finis enim ut dictum est, movet efficientem ad agendum, et non potest ab ejus actione excludit. Et isto modo concedo quod Deus solus creat."

150 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 5, *Ad propositum* . . . [CE XI, pp. 9–11. I find no *propositum* there.]—Naturally, Duns Scotus thinks that the creature's relation to God's conserving action is the same as to his creative action, *Quodlibet* XII, numbers 2–3 [AW, pp. 272–73].

151 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 27 [CE XI, pp. 46–47].

152 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 28 [CE XI, pp. 47–50].

153 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 31 [CE XI, pp. 54–55].

154 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 33 [CE XI, pp. 68–69].

155 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 43, question 1, number 7: "Potentia activa Dei est sua omnipotentia . . . Omnipotentia divina non est principium alicujus, nisi secundum esse existentiae." Obviously, God's free will causes the creature's contingency in St. Thomas also, but not *per se et primo* as in Duns Scotus. The line of separation between the Thomist infinity of *esse* and the finite *esse* produces the same effect as the separation between Scotist infinity of *essentia* and finitude of *ens creatum*, but the metaphysical bases of the two doctrines are different.

156 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 3.

157 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 1, vol. I, p. 1266 [CE VI, p. 342]: "Nulli philosophi utentes naturaliratione, etiam quantumcumque perfecte considerarent Deum sub ratione efficientis, concesserunt Deum esse omnipotentem secundum intellectum catholicorum."—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 1, number 1: "Philosophi utentes ratione naturali, non concesserunt Deum esse omnipotentem, quia non concesserunt ipsum esse causam alicujus contingentis; igitur etc. Item non posuerunt quod aliquid posset fieri de nihilo, quod requiritur ad omnipotentiam secundum nos." It will be noted that according to this passage, creation would be found in the same order of knowledge as divine omnipotence of which creation is a particular case. See, likewise *Opus Oxoniense*, book 1, distinction 2, question 1, section 2, article 2, number 29, vol. I, p. 213. (Translator: this seems to refer to CE II, p. 197, where the material referring to philosophers is placed in the notes to question 2, number 28.) However, Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 11, gives a demonstration of it by natural reason, specifying that the philosophers have not demonstrated everything demonstrable. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 2 [CE VII, pp. 32–50], and book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 11 [CE XI, 21–23]. Evidently an infinite power suffices to create, although it is not yet omnipotence in the absolute sense of the word.

158 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, 4 [AW, p. 161–64].—This is what Duns Scotus calls omnipotence understood in the theological sense (*theologice*), *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1266 [CE VI, p. 343]. He adds, "Et hoc modo omnipotentia videtur esse credita de primo efficiente et non demonstrata."—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 3: "Habere potentiam ad omnia quae significantur per omnipotentiam, potest intelligi dupliciter vel ad quaedam immediate et ad quaedam mediate, vel ad omnia possibilia immediate. Primo modo verum est quod potest probari ratione naturali omnipotentiam esse. Sed non sequitur ex hoc quod potest immediate movere lapidem, quamvis sit potentiae infinitae, quia non est possibile secundum philosophos nisi quod est possibile secundum ordinem causarum . . . Secundo modo omnipotentia conceditur a Catholicis, et sic est tantum credita; unde dicitur in Symbolo: *Credo in Deum patrem omnipotentem*."

159 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, 8 [AW, p. 167]: "Etsi cognitio abstractiva possit esse rei non existentis aeque sicut et existentis, tamen intuitiva non est nisi existentis ut existens est; cognitio autem hominis abstractiva et definitiva potest esse non existentis et existentis . . . Et patet ex se, quia ita habetur si res non existat, sicut si existat; ergo illa cognitio definitiva est citra cognitionem intuitivam objecti definiti universalis."—We will revisit this distinction.

160 Quodlibet VII, 8 [AW, p. 167]: "Omnis scientia est de re non praecise ut existens est, quod intelligo sic, quod ipsa existentia, etsi sit ratio intellecta in objecto, vel citra objectum, tamen non necessario requiritur ut actualiter conveniens objecto, inquantum objectum est scibile."—*Quodlibet* VII, 9 [AW, p. 168]: "Ex hoc ergo habeo istam propositionem, quod cum ratio in anima possit manere non manente existentia actuali objecti, sequitur quod existentia non est per se ratio objecti ut scibile est, quia ratio scientifica non potest manere eadem in anima, non

manente illo eodem quod est per se ratio scibilis, ut scibile est; sive autem scibile possit existere in re, sive non, saltem ratione ejus, ut scibile est, potest manere eadem in anima non manente existentia; abstrahit ergo scientia ab existentia, ita quod non includit eam in ratione scibilis."—It is superfluous to note how strongly these passages underline the *essentialist* character of metaphysical knowledge in Duns Scotus, "metaphysica quae est de quidditatibus."

161 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, 10 [AW, pp. 168–69].

162 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 11–12 [AW, pp. 169–71].

163 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 2, vol. I, pp. 1266–67 [CE VI, p. 344].

164 Scotus, *Quodlibe*t VII, number 16 [AW, p. 173].

165 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 3, vol. I, p. 1267 [CE VI, p. 344–45]: "Praeterea, si philosophi non potuerunt per rationem naturalem concludere Deum posse contingenter causare, quanto magis nec posse immediate in quemcumque effecum vel in quodcumque quod potest producere mediantibus aliis causis secundis?"—The philosophers here are above all Aristotle and Avicenna, who both taught, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 8, vol. I, p. 647 [CE IV, p. 294]: "Deum necessario se habet ad alia extra se."—In *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 3, [CE V, p. 345] at "Praeterea si Philosophi posuerunt . . ." Duns Scotus asks what would happen if we admitted a God who acts necessarily like the philosophers' God and who was omnipotent like the theologians' God. This God would produce everything possible by himself and necessarily. There would be no room in the world for any other cause but him.—By contrast, *Quodlibet* XII, number 14 [AW, p. 280]: "Theologi autem non concedunt Deum agere naturali necessitate circa creaturam."

166 Duns Scotus bases this interpretation of Aristotle on Averroes, *In Metaphysicam*, book IX, chapter 4, comment 7: "Moderni autem ponunt unum agens omnia entia sine medio, scilicet Deum, et contingit istis, ut nullum ens habeat actionem propriam naturaliter, et cum entia non habuerint actiones proprias, non habebunt essentias proprias. Actiones enim non diversantur nisi per essentias diversas. Et ista opinio est valde extranea a natura hominis, et qui recipiunt hujusmodi, non habent cerebrum habilitatum naturaliter ad bonum."

167 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 17 [AW, p. 173–74].

168 Cf. Aristotle, *Metaphysic*s, book VI (Z), chapter 8, 1033 b 26–28; and Averroes, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, chapter 8, number 28.

169 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 18 [AW, p. 174].

170 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 2, vol. I, p. 1267 [CE VI, p. 344].—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 5.

171 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 3, vol. I, p. 1268 [CE VI, p. 346].

172 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 3, vol. I, p. 1268 [CE VI, p. 346]: "Omnipotentia tamen hoc modo sumpta, licet non sufficienter demonstretur, probabiliter tamen potest probari sicut verum et necessarium, et probabilius quam quaedam alia credita; quia non est inconveniens quaedem credita esse evidentiora quam alia."

173 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 23 [AW, pp. 177–78].

174 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 24 [AW, pp. 178–79].

175 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 41, question 2, number 4.

176 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 26 [AW, pp. 180–81]: "Concedo ergo quod Aristoteles secundum

sua principia negaret Deum multa posse immediate causare, puta omnia illa, in quorum productione est simpliciter contingentia, absque utraque necessitate praedicta; sed in hoc theologus contradicit sibi, sicut dictum est. Est ergo de demonstratione, conclusio principalis et ordine quarta, ista, scilicet quod Deum habere omnipotentiam immediate, respectu cujuscumque causabilis, licet sit verum, non tamen est nobis demonstrabile, demonstratione quia."

177 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 27 [AW, p. 181]: "Quinta conclusio principalis est ista, quod demonstrabile est viatori demonstratione quia, Deum esse omnipotentem mediate vel immediate, hoc est, quod possit causare quodcumque causabile, vel immediate vel per aliquod medium, quod subsit causalitati ejus."

178 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 27 [AW, pp. 181–82]. In number 28, Scotus formulates two objections. 1) The first efficient cause is not necessarily God but the Motor Intelligence of the first heaven, beyond which God only moves as final cause. 2) The first efficient cause only has power over the series of causes that depend on it. To prove it can cause all possibles, it would be necessary to establish that no other system of possibles exists outside of it.—Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 28 [AW, p. 182], eliminates the objection by answering that there is only one being per se, and therefore a single efficient cause that is independent in its action.

179 Examples of this concern are *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, article 2, number 8, vol. I, pp. 646–47 [CE IV, p. 295].—Cf. *Quodlibet* VII, number 38 [AW, p. 189].

180 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 29 [AW, pp. 182–83].—Cf. Aristotle, *Ethica Nicomachea* book Z, chapter 3, 1139 b 23–24; *De Coelo*, book A, chapter 12, 282, a 21 to b 9.

181 Scotus, *Quodlibe*t VII, number 30 [AW, pp. 183–84].

182 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 31 [AW, pp. 184–85].

183 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 32, which concludes [AW, p. 185]: "Verum est ergo quod suprema potentia activa, sive potentia infinita est omnipotentia, sed non est notum per rationem naturalem, quod suprema potentia possibilis etiam intensive infinita, sit omnipotentia proprie dicta, quae scilicet potest in quodcumque possibile immediate."

184 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book XII, chapter 7, 1073 a 5–10 and chapter 8, 1073 a 14 to b 1.

185 Ibid.

186 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 40 [AW, pp. 190–91]. Duns Scotus next rejects the objection that here *to move* is not really *to cause*, because the object is really the intellection's efficient cause.

187 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 42 [AW, pp. 193–94].—Cf. Averroes, *De Substantia Orbis*, chapter 2, and Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate IX, chapter 4, folio 104 verso b.

188 Scotus, *Quodlibet* VII, number 43 AW, p. 194. He remits to Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book II, chapter 1, 993 b 26–31 and book V, chapter 5, 1015 b 9–15.

189 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 4. Cf. number 7: "Quod autem sic sit tantum credita, et quod non possit probari per rationem naturalem, probatur, quia philosophi solum innitentes rationi naturali non potuerunt secundum principia sua hoc ponere, quia posuerunt causam primam necessario agere. Licet suppositis principiis philosophorum, non ... possit probari Deum posse producere immediate quidquid est possibile produci, tamen aliter dicendum est secundum fidem."

190 In fact, the philosophers would judge God's immediate omnipotence to be contradictory. Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 6: "Imo philosophi dicerent quod omnipotentia secundo modo dicta, non posset concipi sine contradictione."

191 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 8, article 1, body of article. The passage from Aristotle is in *Physics*, book VII, chapter 2, 243 a 4. Upon it rests the principal argument criticized

by Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 37, sole question, number 1, vol. I, p. 1191 [CE VI, p. 299]: "Omne agens est praesens passo, secundum Philosophum VII *Physica*, et hoc immediate, si immediate posset agere in illud, vel mediate si agat in illud mediate: omnipotens autem potest agere in quodlibet immediate; ergo est praesens cuilibet immediate."

192 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 8, article 3, body of article: "Est in omnibus per potentiam inquantum omnia ejus potentiae subduntur. Est per praesentiam in omnibus inquantum omnia nuda sunt et aperta oculis ejus Est in omnibus per esentiam inquantum adest omnibus ut causa essendi."—Compare that to Scotus's summary, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 37, question 2, number 3. We encounter the same problem in the context of the angels present in a place in *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. II, distinction 2, question 6, number 3, vol. II, pp. 135–36.

193 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 4.

194 Cf, Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 8, article 1, body of article: "Sed quamdiu in esse conservator."

195 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 5.

196 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, number 6.

197 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, numbers 7–8.

198 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 37, question 2, number 10: "Non videtur mihi quod possit demonstrative probari Deum esse ubique per essentiam, sed ipsum tantum est mihi creditum et non probatum."

199 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 37, sole question, number 1, p. 1191 [CE VI, p. 299].

200 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 37, sole question, number 4, vol. I, p. 1193 [CE VI, p. 302].

201 We enormously simplify a very complex argument. See Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 37, sole question, number 2, vol. I, pp. 1191–92 [CE, pp. 299–300].

202 Scotus, *De Primo Principio*, Roche edition, p. 146 (in the edition of Mariano Fernández García, Quaracchi, 1910, pp. 699–700): "Praeter praedicta de te, a philosophis probata, saepe Catholici te laudant omnipotentem, immensum, ubique praesentem, verum, justum et misericordem, cunctis creaturis, et specialiter intelligibilibus providentem, quae ad tractatum alium proximum differentur." [Gilson and presumably Fernández García's *probata* emend a second *praedicta* in Roche.]

203 Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 280, article 2. We completely agree with the author on this point. As for the others, it would be as difficult to prove that divine providence is rationally demonstrable in Duns Scotus, as it would be for us to quote a clear passage establishing that it is not. He is aware of that himself. "Scotus videtur tenere etiam conservationem et gubernationem mundi generalem a parte Dei ex naturalibus posse cognosci," p. 281. Further on, p. 283: "Scotus ergo non videtur negare cognoscibilitatem naturalem concursus et providentiae generalis, sed non nisi concursus et providentiae specialis, seu talis, quam Thomistae profidentur." In a word, we have physical premotion. The fairly general arguments presented by the author in favor of his thesis can be seen on p. 281, articles 1–4. Once again, no specific passage of Duns Scotus is cited to establish it, except *Quodlibet* XXI, number 15 [AW, pp. 483–84], whose meaning will be discussed a little further on.

204 Luke 12:6.

205 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XXI, number 15 [AW, p. 484]. He probably has in mind *Physics*, book VIII, chapter 6, 258 b 10 to 259 20 from which this consequence can be inferred.

206 Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 282, article 4.

207 Ibid.

208 Quodlibet XXI [AW, pp. 469–84] is a remarkable example of the care with which Duns Scotus precisely limits his criticism of Aristotle. Scotus asks whether the Philosopher contradicted himself by supposing that God eternally moves the world *qua* unmoved mover, and that, yet, he inspires conduct that comes to fruition in certain humans, born with *good fortune*. For theologians this *bene fortunatus . . . sine ratione habens impetum ad bona, et haec adipiscens*, is inspired by special divine providence, which Aristotle seems not to have known. However, the Philosopher does not contradict himself, because, if it is true that his Unmoved First can cause no new effect immediately, he can cause it mediately, through the intermediary of active and passive causes, whose diversity points to the diversity of the effects, and in consequence, certain novelty. As the sun melts ice and solidifies mud without varying its own action, God exercises his action uniformly upon matters whose diversity varies God's effects: "Ita secundum Aristotelem, hoc corpore organisato Deus necessitate immutabilitatis causat hanc animam, et prius non, quia materia non erat disposita . . . sic in proposito Deus influit uniformiter in quodlibet inquantum potest secundum Aristotlem, et quia iste est dispositus, ille non, ideo Deus impellit istum ad tale propositum, ad quod consequitur commodum, illum autem non impellit, quia non invenit in eo dispositionem illam quam diximus prius."—Consequently, there is no contradiction between *Physics*, Book VIII, where Aristotle says that God cannot cause a new heaven or a new world, and *De Bona Fortuna*, where he says that God can guide a human being by felicitous inspiration. Duns Scotus goes as far as possible to justify Aristotle as having taught a kind of general and impersonal providence that in fact Aristotle did not teach. Scotus invents a limited providence for Aristotle, compatible with his physics. Moreover, then Duns Scotus adds, in an expression that we will meet again: "Sed secundum fidem et veritatem dicendum est quod Deus, habens providentiam generalem de omnibus, regit res secundum quod natae sunt regi, secundum quod dicitur VII *De Civitate Dei*, capitulo 30: *Sic Deus res quas condidit*, etc."—Duns Scotus notes the limitations of philosophy in relation to theology. He does not look for contradiction.

5

Angels

Obviously, the topic of angels is philosophical, at least in some measure, because Duns Scotus knew that Aristotle, Avicenna, Averroes, and many other philosophers spoke of it before him. They were philosophers. What are the Separated Intelligences but angels? Without angels, how can we explain the structure of the universe and the movement of the heavenly bodies with the generations and corruptions that result from them? So, angels cannot be omitted from a study of what, for Duns Scotus, is the philosophical interpretation of the world where we live. Moreover, along with matter, angels are one of the two poles of creation: they are near God, matter near nothingness. This phrase of Augustine, which we will meet again in Duns Scotus's writings, is an invitation first of all to define these two extremes, between which it becomes easier to situate human beings.

A Nature of angels

To define and describe beings of which humans have no intuitive experience, the comparative method is necessary. If such separated substances exist, they are kinds of souls without bodies, subsisting in themselves and provided with what is necessary to be and to act. Consequently, the best thing to do is to situate them in the hierarchy of beings, starting from the human soul, about which we likewise have no intuitive knowledge, but whose operations we know indirectly in view of their effects.

Is there a specific difference between the angel and the soul? To Scotus's mind, the question is more complex than for certain other theologians. We know that the human intellect's natural object, as Duns Scotus conceives it, is not inferior to that of the angel. Their end is the same, and the distance that separates them in the perfection of being must be kept within limits such that they permit this common destiny. Like the angels, humans can be elevated to the privilege of seeing God. Consequently, humans must be incomparably closer to angels than irrational animals are to rational animals. Indeed, it is not evident that a given angel is more perfect than a given soul, for instance the Virgin Mary's soul. The contrary is even less evident. Still it would be necessary if there were a specific difference between soul and angel; between individuals of different species, superiority and inferiority will always lie on the same side.

Whatever the weight of this argument may be, it does not get to the bottom of the problem, because, if angels are different from souls, they can only be specifically different. In a general way, it can be said that the more noble a being is, the more its structure implies degrees of perfection that make up its nobility. So the mixture involves more forms than the element, the animate more forms than the inanimate, and probably, animals more than plants. Accordingly, a pure intellectual nature must involve in its turn more than the form animating a body. Moreover, the decisive proof is there. Forms of the same degree exercise their acts in the same manner, or rather they exercise the same acts. The intellectual soul is naturally the act of an organized body, whose form it is. By contrast, the angel is not the act of any matter. Consequently, soul and angel are not in the same species.[1]

Still, it remains to be seen what the basis of this difference is in the angel's own being. Some situate the difference in the fact that the angelic nature cannot be united to matter, while the soul can be. However, this unitability, *unibilitas,* of the soul would specify the soul in relation to matter. Forms are not specified with a view to matter; rather, the distinction about matter is there in view of the form's distinction. The bodily parts of the deer differ from those of the lion because the deer's soul is different from the lion's.

Therefore, there must be a primitive specific difference between these two different acts that are a soul and an angel. The nature of one must differ in itself from the nature of the other, and we must find out how to define this primitive difference.[2]

It is also said that a higher degree of intellectuality is what distinguishes angels from souls. We distinguish different sensitive souls in animals according to different degrees in their aptitudes for sensing. We are certainly dealing with specific difference here. Why would there not be a specific difference between two degrees of perfection in intellects. For our intellectual knowledge is naturally discursive and that of the angel is not. Thus, there certainly seem to be two specifically distinct intellectual modes here.

This thesis neglects some facts. First, it is not true that our knowledge is discursive. Knowledge of conclusions is discursive, but knowledge of principles is not. Accordingly, if distinct intellectuality corresponds to each of these modes of intellection, there will be two specifically distinct intellectualities in each human soul: one for knowledge of principles, the other for knowledge of conclusions.[3] Above all, it is not true that angelic knowledge is never discursive. Knowing principles, would an angel be incapable of deducing conclusions from them? We should not believe that all conclusions are simultaneously present to the angel in the apprehension of principles. But what would it matter if they were? If God wanted to, along with the knowledge of all principles, he could impress upon the human intellect, the knowledge of all conclusions that flow from them. This intellect would no longer have matter for discourse, and that would be due not to lack of power but rather excess. The only reason on account of which this intellect could acquire new knowledge would be that it had it already. However, the nature would remain the same. It would not be an angelic intelligence, but a human intellect. One asks what is proven by this hypothesis that no fact verifies.[4] It is enough for it to be possible, that is to say, not in contradiction with the nature of the human intellect, in order to prove that the specific distinction between angel and human does not rest upon degrees of intellectuality.

The defect of any explanation of this kind is that it rests on an operation. Before the second act, which is the operation, there is always a first act from which it flows. The analogy of the role played by *haecceitas* in Scotism with the role played by *esse* in Thomism is apparent here. In Thomas Aquinas, it is always necessary to go back to *esse* to account for operations. Being (*ens*) taken as a whole is not their first origin. That is, the *esse* that constitutes *ens*. Likewise, in Duns Scotus the source of operations is not found in the undetermined *natura*. Obviously, like Thomist *esse*, Scotist *natura* is the principle of the second acts that are operations, but the being's first entity is not the undetermined nature from which its operations follow. It is this individual nature, *natura sua ut in se est haec*. Consequently, to get at a being in itself, we must go back beyond the operations and even the nature from which they flow. The nature itself is certainly the first act of the being and principle of its operations, but it is *qua* individuated that the nature is this being whose operations it exercises.[5]

Accordingly, the distinction between the angel and the soul does not rest upon the relation of their faculties to their essences. Duns Scotus does not admit real distinction between the soul and its faculties, either in the case of the angel or of the rational soul. What situates these two types of beings in their two different species is that their natures themselves are different. Because one is *haec natura*, it is the principle of a given operation and not the reverse. We know that the sun has the power to engender many mixtures in this world here below—for example, plants. However, the power to engender plants is not what distinguishes the sun from them, because, if its power were communicated to another being, that being would not become the sun, and it would not be distinguished thereby from the soul as plants are distinguished. The real cause of their distinction is that the sun's form is not the plant's form, and this difference entails the difference of their operations.[6]

It remains for us to find out how the angel's form differs from the soul's form, taken precisely in themselves. Duns Scotus's answer may be surprising, because, in proposing to establish a specific distinction between angel and soul, he first says that they are not distinguished to begin with as *two species*.

We immediately see why. In fact, the problem approached in this way is badly posed, because there is no correspondence between the two terms. An angel is a being, but a soul is only a being as part of the human being. To compare them, even in order to distinguish them, is to correlate a species, the angel, with part of a species, the soul. This is precisely what distinguishes them. The soul is the first reason for the distinction between angels and humans—that is, between the angel's species and the species of which the soul is part. In other words, since the soul is the first reason for the distinction of its species, the principle of its distinction is certainly in it.[7] The same reasoning is not necessary in the case of the angel, a species complete in itself, and therefore, specifically distinct from the semi-species that is the soul. Unless we grant that a species is specifically identical to a semi-species, this distinction must be admitted.

We might initially believe that Duns Scotus comes back here to the solution of *unibilitas* that he discarded, because it might seem that the soul is only a semi-species because it is unitable and even united to a body. But this would be an error of perspective on Scotus's doctrine. Duns Scotus does not doubt that the soul is unitable to its body, or that it is distinguished in this way from an angel, a being that subsists by itself,[8] but in this cause for distinction he only sees the consequence of another prior cause of distinction. Because the angelic spiritual substance is a complete species of itself, it is inconceivable as the form of a body. But its substantial perfection is what specifies it, not the completely negative absence of *unibilitas* that flows from it. Inversely, its *unibilitas* is not what specifies the soul. It is its condition as a part of the species *human* that requires its unity with a body. Perhaps it will be said that this reversal of the position has little importance, but that would really mean that we are not interested in metaphysics.

Another, much more pertinent objection is what we have been announcing since the start of this analysis. When Duns Scotus speaks of the first natural object of the human intellect, he strongly insists on the fact that, since it is intellect by nature, its object will not be inferior to the object of any other intellectual nature, even an angelic one. If humans are bound to abstraction, it

is not that their intellect's nature wishes it so, not even the natural bond that unites it to the body. In principle, we ought to be able to know the intelligibles intuitively, as the angels do. In short, when Duns Scotus compares human knowledge to angelic knowledge, everything proceeds as if he were pushing their possible approximation to the extreme limit: "you made him a little lower than the angels," *paulo minuisiti eum ab angelis* (Heb. 2:7, Ps. 8:5). Here we have the reverse tendency. Having to situate angels in relation to humans, Duns Scotus makes two different species of them, and even goes so far as to hold that the human intellect (that he still refuses to make inherently subservient to the sensible) be a simple part of the species. How can these two opposite moves be reconciled?

Scotus saw the difficulty clearly himself, and he resolved it by saying that angel and soul can differ specifically without one's intellectuality differing specifically from the other's taken precisely *qua* intellectuality. In other words, angel and soul belong to two different species if we consider them as first acts—that is, absolutely and in themselves. However, this does not imply that the cognitive perfection that they virtually include and through which they are principles of second acts falls into two different species. Quite the contrary, we recognize that angelic intellect and human intellect belong to the same species in the fact that they are concerned with the same objects. An example will convey this: the soul of an ox and the soul of an eagle do not belong to the same species, but that does not prove that one's faculty of sight is specifically different from the other's. There is sight in both cases.

We are not dealing with an expedient calculated to resolve a particular case. Containers of different species can contain contents of the same species. There are innumerable species of beings, all of which possess the transcendental properties of being without those properties thereby becoming specifically distinct. *Human* and *stone* are different species, but a human's unity is not specifically different in him from the unity in the stone. These two unities, in truth, only differ numerically.

Here we see the answer's meaning clearly. There is no contradiction in attributing an intellect of the same species to angel and human while making

two species of them. As we have said, beings are distinguished neither by their operations nor their operative faculties but by the first constituent acts of their substances. The fact that angel and human have intellectuality in common, consequently, has no role to play in their specific difference. They are two different species, both endowed with intellect. Unequal in substantial perfection, they share no less univocally the common nature of intellectualness, *intellectualitas*.[9] This is Duns Scotus's constant teaching, which allows him to affirm that our intellect's first object is being taken in its total indifference to any determination: "the adequate object for our intellect by nature of its power is not more special than [that of] the angelic intellect," *objectum adaequatum intellectui nostro ex natura potentiae non est specialius intellectus angelici, quia quidquid potest intelligi ab uno, et ab alio*.[10]

This position implies a new problem concerning the relation of individual to species in the angelic substance and even in the human species. Let us set aside the latter case, whose discussion is unnecessary here. As for the angel, it is immediately evident that having no matter and not being the form of any matter, it does not owe its individuation to matter. Thomas Aquinas agreed, but from that he inferred that each angel constituted a species. According to Thomas whereas beings of the same species but numerically distinct agree in form and are distinguished by matter, a being that is only form is necessarily unique. Accordingly, there cannot be two angels of the same species.[11]

By contrast, according to Duns Scotus, every quiddity is communicable of itself—whether God's, which is perfect, or the quiddity of corruptible substances, which is imperfect. The difference is that the divine quiddity alone is communicable in numerical identity, because it is infinite, whereas all others are communicable in numerical distinction because they are finite. Consequently, the angel is numerically multipliable as are all finite beings.[12]

Furthermore, let us recall the nature's primitive indifference in regard to indistinction. We can conceive the nature as universal, which would be contradictory if it were *haec* of itself. Therefore, we cannot claim that the angelic quiddity implies universality of itself, or consequently, that the

existence of several angels of the same species is impossible.

By far the most interesting arguments that Duns Scotus employs, however, is drawn from the comparison of angels and rational souls. For, although the latter are acts of matter, they are pure forms in Scotus's view: *sunt formae purae licet perfectivae materiae*. There are several souls in the human species. Therefore, it is not impossible that pure forms are numerically distinct within the same species, because every argument that proves this for angels will also prove it for souls, about whom, however, we know that it is false. Nothing could make us anticipate better how the relation of soul to body becomes different in Scotism from what it is in Thomism. Certainly, Duns Scotus does not deny that there is a natural inclination in the soul to perfect the matter of a body, but the inclination is not an absolute entity in the soul, because every inclination belongs to something or someone: that is, to some absolute distinct entity. Because it is *this soul here*, a soul has such an inclination and not the reverse. So, it is not its inclination to a body that individuates the soul. On the contrary, the nature of this inclination follows from individuality.[13]

The problem of the angel's individuation and the problem of its relation to the species are thus solved at one stroke, and once again the root of the solution is the indetermination of the essence in regard to both singular and universal. The concept of matter plays no role in the discussion of this question, and Duns Scotus only introduces it in order to exclude it by showing that the problem is posed for the soul as for the angel because the angel, like the soul, is a common nature that can only be individuated by its own principle of individuation.

With this we see what defines Duns Scotus's position in regard to St. Thomas's. Starting from the angelic substance's common and undetermined *quidditas*, Scotus considers the quiddity as always determinable by a principle of individuation that makes it singular. Accordingly, we cannot conceive of any case where an angel would be individual *qua angel* in such a way that its nature's actualization would make the existence of other angels impossible. This is why, in this doctrine where individuation does not have

matter as its cause, the species angel is as multipliable in individuals as the species human. This point is clear, but there are two difficulties.

The first comes from Aristotle. Not his authority but his thought intervenes in the discussion, all the more importantly in that Duns Scotus considers Aristotle right on this point. Scotus recognizes unhesitatingly that, in Aristotle's doctrine, every being into whose composition matter does not enter is immediately identical to its essence and consequently individual by right: *omne tale quod quid est ponit per se hoc*.[14] Duns Scotus does not dispute for an instant that if he proposed to follow Aristotle in everything, he would have to admit the identity of species and individual in immaterial substances. But that is not Scotus's intention, because the real reason why the Philosopher believed he had to maintain the doctrine is different in Scotus's opinion. Directing us to the heart of Aristotle's doctrine, Scotus profoundly observes that Aristotle conceived every immaterial substance as *formally necessary*. In a formally necessary nature, everything that composes it is necessarily given with it. The power is not distinguished from the act in it. Consequently, if several individuals of the same species as this substance were possible, they would exist necessarily, and so their number would be unlimited, there would be an infinity of them. In short, Aristotle does not see how the multiplication of species would encounter an obstacle, except for the beings whose individuation by matter limits their number. There can only be one or an infinity of them, and as an actual infinity of the same nature is impossible, every immaterial substance is necessarily unique in Aristotle's doctrine. But, replies Duns Scotus:

> We are not in agreement with him on the principle that every quiddity without matter is formally necessary, and that is why we are not in agreement about the conclusion. When a theologian is not in agreement with a philosopher about a principle, because this theologian maintains a certain conclusion it is more reasonable on the theologian's part to reject the philosopher's conclusion than to be mistaken with him on the conclusion, and more reasonable to be in disagreement with him on the principle that leads him to that error. To agree with him thus would be neither to

> philosophize nor to think as a theologian. Indeed, someone who would do so would have no reason to do so that would be valid according to a philosopher, since the philosopher himself only grants this conclusion by virtue of this principle. Nor does the philosopher any longer have a theological principle for his conclusion precisely since the conclusion has a philosophical principle that he denies.[15]

In other words, if the theologian is sure that there can be several angels of the same species, he would be theologically wrong to admit that this is impossible. Also he would not be philosophically right in any sense, because Aristotle only holds that to be impossible in virtue of a particular philosophical principle. If his principle is judged to be philosophically false, Aristotle himself would not admit that in denying its principle, its conclusion should be conceded.

On this point, everything is clear, because we know that God's freedom in regard to creatures (a topic where Duns Scotus always opposed Greek necessitarianism) justifies our Doctor's position. The same does not hold when we no longer ask how the species *angel* can contain more than one individual but how it contains subspecies in Duns Scotus's doctrine, like Archangels, Powers, Dominions, and so forth. It cannot be doubted that Duns Scotus speaks of different species of angels. When he writes, for example, "that no *species* of angels totally parish in all its *individuals*," "quod nulla *species* angelorum quantum ad omnia *individua* totaliter perierat,"[16] his language supposes that he classifies angels in different species. Accordingly, we cannot maintain that Duns Scotus thought the contrary, but we have noticed no passage where he explains his position on this issue, and we know nobody who has cited one.[17] With a little imagination we can fill this gap. If Duns Scotus were here to answer us, perhaps he would say that the substances that form the angelic hierarchy are distinguished in nature and dignity by their functions. After all, these *species* are properly *orders*, and perhaps they are only species improperly so-called, *improprie dicta*. But in the history of ideas, it is useless to try to substitute oneself for the thinking of another who is not oneself.

B Angels and duration

The angel's duration is studied in the same spirit as its nature, that is to say, in relation to its substance.[18] Moreover, that is necessary because each being perdures according to what it is: humans in time, angels in eons (*aevum*), and God in eternity. But this way of speaking raises a problem because we might wonder whether beings in their duration are measured by it, or whether their duration is combined with their being so that it is their proper manner of existing. In God's case, we already know the answer: God's eternity is God, but we can wonder about the angel. Hence Duns Scotus poses the question: in an actually existing angel, must something be posited that measures its existence or its duration, which is really distinct from its existence?[19]

Since the eon is the measure of the proper duration of the pure Intelligence, the problem comes down to finding out whether this duration is an external measure to which the Intelligence's being must be related. Duns Scotus thinks that the opposite is true, because if the eon is really distinct from the angel, by what will the eon subsist? Perhaps someone will reply, "by itself." But this way, won't the angel's existence formally perdure by itself? Whatever else might be imagined would not be more perfect in anything than this existence, which is a property of the angel's being itself. Besides, if we posit the eon as endowed with being of its own, it would be necessary to say what measures its being, and then what measures this being, and so on to infinity.[20] So, the measure of angelic existence is not really distinct from it.

This answer is connected to Duns Scotus's answer about the relation of *creation* to created being. Let us recall the principle: everything that would be posterior by nature to a being, if it were distinct from the being, is necessarily identical to the being, if the being cannot be without that thing. For, we were saying, the relation of *creation* is both posterior to and inseparable from the created thing; the relation is identical to it. The same holds here. If it were impossible for an angel to exist without something extrinsic that is the measure of its actual existence, this extrinsic thing would be naturally posterior to the angel's actual existence and consequently would be other

than it. By contrast, if we wanted to posit the extrinsic thing both as other and posterior, it would not be contradictory for the actual existence to be without it, and there would consequently be no necessity to posit it.

With this we see what conditions are required in this doctrine for there to be distinction between two beings. These beings must be actually separated or potentially separable. Or their relationship must be analogous to the relationship of two other beings, one of which is separable from the other. This third condition is important. Let us suppose, for example, that no human exists without flesh, and that all circles are made of bronze. We could still prove by the definition of triangle and wood that a geometrical figure is separable from bronze and that therefore the circle is distinct from it. But this is not the case of the eon and the angel, because they are not actually separated, and no one claims they are either separable or in a relationship analogous to that of two separable beings. On the contrary, it is enough for an angel to exist for the eon to exist with him. Therefore, it is impossible to distinguish them.[21]

It remains for us to discover whether the angel's actual existence is not measurable by some *intrinsic* measure that is still distinct from what is measured. But first, what is *measuring*? It is to ascertain an unknown quantity with the help of a known quantity. The operation can be mental and be done by imagination, *imaginatione*, as Duns Scotus says. For example, a worker can often measure some quantity by sight, thanks to the measure he has in his imagination. But the operation can also be real, that is to say, compare the unknown quantity to another really existing quantity, whether larger, smaller, or equal. The first of these real methods is the one we use to measure quiddities, where the greater is always the measure of the other, such as whiteness in the order of color, or God the first measure of everything contained in any genus. The second is commonly employed every time a smaller size is better known than the one we want to measure. For example, we can use a brief movement by repeating it as many times as is necessary to measure a long movement. The third measure, which consists in superposing two equal sizes, requires that the one serving as measure be naturally more

known than that of the measured and that their equality stems from this nature itself. Still, let us note that the size of the measure does not necessarily have to be more known in itself, that is to say, by virtue of its nature. It might be better known only by accident. For example, if I know the length of a face, I can use it to measure the length of a fabric, not that one is naturally more known than the other, but because I find that I know the first and am ignorant of the second.

All four methods have in common that the measure is always distinct from the measured. That is enough to settle the question. In the angel, we already know that there is no measure extrinsic to what is measured. So, on the one hand, the angel's duration has no extrinsic measure, on the other hand, every measure is extrinsic. Accordingly, there cannot be any measure of the angel's duration that is both intrinsic to the angel and other than it. If there is measure of the angel's duration, it can only be of the last kind, where measures and measured are equal. Consequently, the angel's own existence must be what serves to measure it, as quantity serves to measure itself when we apply a known length to an unknown length. But (and this specification is valuable for us) the angel's existence is not an extension in duration but an indivisible (*cum ista existentia sit indivisibilis*). Therefore, we cannot conceive parts of length confusedly or clearly, because the angel's existence has none.[22]

So, the angel's indivisible existence is the measure of its actual existence, and the latter is only the act (ultimate in its order, which is to say, outside of the coordination of essences) that puts the angel outside its causes. There is no multiplicity without necessity. *Non est pluralitas sine necessitate*. To add a superfluous measure to existence would be to violate this rule. There is neither a measure that is an absolute being, nor even a measure that would be some sort of relation. There is already a relation there, the angel's relation to the cause that creates and conserves it. We have established that the relation is identified with the angel itself, who is the basis of this relation. Moreover, this is why we cannot say whether there is or is not succession in a being of this kind, because there is certainly plurality in its operations. But since they are carried out in the permanent *nunc* of an indivisible existence, and

consequently one free of any quantity properly so-called, we have no concept that might signify a change that abstracts from the distinction of *before* and *after*.

This still does not imply that there are as many distinct eons as eternal beings. Some authors imagine that there are as many eons as angels: *quot sunt angeli, tot sunt aeva*. But this is an illusion; and at bottom, it is the same illusion that consisted in imagining the angel's eon as measured by a rule distinct from the angel itself. Language is deceptive here, but however we express ourselves, the fact is that no aeviternal has its eon and that the highest aeviternal or highest angel does not have a peculiar eon by which we can measure the others, since it has no such thing in itself, *quia nihil tale habet in se*.[23]

So far we have spoken of the angel's being, but what are we to say about its operations? The problem is no longer the same, because if the angel is not measured by anything in its existence, the existence, which is the eon itself, can measure its operations. Certain authors judge that, to the contrary, some of the angel's operations can unfold in a kind of time, one quite different from ours, which they call discontinuous time. This time would be a variety of discontinuous quantity, like number, but different from it in that its parts would be destroyed in the measure that they succeed each other, which is not necessarily the case with numbers, or similarly with words, whose parts are also destroyed in the measure that they succeed each other, but different from words in that each part of the word is continued in the next before being destroyed. So, this discontinuous time would be ready-made to be adapted to the angelic being's operations. That is certainly necessary because the measure ought to be adapted to the measured, permanent if the measured is permanent, fluid if it is fluid. The knowledge of angels is transitory, because angels do not have one single knowledge of everything that is the only knowledge they may have, but many instances of knowledge that flow and pass away according to an order, one after another. Still, as we are assured, these instances of knowledge are without connection because the angels do not move discursively from one to another. They are even without

succession, at least in the interior of each one, because the angel is never in the process of acquiring them or losing them, but insofar as the knowledge is there, each instance of knowledge is both entire and indivisible. That is why some imagine the *discretum tempus*, itself composed of parts that are transitory, ordered, indivisible, and without connection among themselves.[24]

But that is a waste of time, because the concept of any time cannot be adapted to permanent being. Let us consider any instance of knowledge that an angel can have. It is certain that the knowledge will change and that consequently the angel's existence will last longer than the existence of this knowledge. Nevertheless, *as long as the knowledge lasts,* it has the same mode of being as the angel's existence, by which alone the knowledge exists. Thus, although this knowledge does not last as long as the angel itself, its measure is of the same nature as that of the angel's existence. The eon measures it, not time. Even if an angel were to be annihilated ultimately, the measure of its existence would, nonetheless, be the measure of its operations, as long as it existed to carry them out.[25] Moreover, let us add that this discontinuous time is very difficult to conceive, because in the end we will admit that an angel can know by acts of distinct knowledge all the natural objects that succeed each other in the course of one of our days, for example, stones, wood, iron, water, and so on, in the order in which they succeed each other. Since the angel's time corresponds to this day, it will consequently be composed of as many parts as our time, which succeed each other in the same order and yet without any determined position in relation to the time that is called its time, which is absurd.[26]

Let us conclude with Duns Scotus on this point that an angel's intellections have the eon as their measure and not only its intellection but in general all actual existence whose nature must be invariable, that is to say, such that it does not intrinsically involve any becoming. As we have said, their transitory character does not come into consideration. As long as they are, only their mode of being matters. Without progress or decadence, completely alien to the order of time, as long as angelic intellects are, they are *aeviternal*.[27]

The preceding arguments only have meaning if we correctly understand the

nature of the aeviternal, and particularly the kind of permanence that distinguishes it. It is not a permanence of state or condition, many examples of which are offered in the temporal itself, but permanence of being. We cannot even compare the transitory character of an aeviternal act with the transitory character of a temporal act, because the two characters are ontologically incommeasurable. Suppose that we attempt that meaningless operation, a human intellection would not last *for a longer time* in any way than an instantaneous aeviternal intellection, because the latter participates in the duration of the eon, which is the pure Intellect's actual existence. These are two worlds whose rhythms of duration often intersect, but never really accompany each other. We would seek in vain for a way to get their events to correspond one to one on two parallel lines.[28]

The general condition of the Scotist aeviternal is revealed here with a naked clarity that delights the understanding. What is first offered to our view is the very flow of the form (*fluxus formae*), which is essentially measured by time, because its formal reason excludes its permanence and, by forbidding it to remain the same, wills that one part should always succeed another in it. Immediately afterward the form presents itself insofar as it is the source of this flow by the act of movement. We are still in time. In the third place, comes the form itself, insofar as it can cause such a flow of successive parts, but in the act of rest. Although the form does not cause this flow then, since it is of such a nature as to be able to cause it, its duration is always the duration of time. In the fourth place come those entirely different forms that are not measurable by time in themselves and consequently cannot be said to be either in movement or at rest, like the Motor Intelligences, but which necessarily follow forms subject to movement, like the forms of the heavenly bodies. Of the former we say that they are in the eon of themselves, but at rest by accident in comparison with the moving forms that are connected to them. In the fifth and last place, that is to say, unlike the flow of the form, we find that whose essence excludes all beginning and whose existence itself does not presuppose any. That form remains invariably the same as long as it remains. Consequently, it is not measured by time at all, either as a whole or

in part or even by accident.[29] Such a being's *esse invariabile* is what makes it aeviternal.

C Angels and place

Angels are not in time, but they are in place. If they are, in what sense are they? On this point, Duns Scotus opposes two adversaries, one of whom teaches that the angel is in a place by its operation in the place, and the other that the angel is in the place in the mode of application to this place.

The first of the two doctrines invokes passages in St. John Damascene, *De Fide Orthodoxa*, chapters 13 and 16, which do not maintain it explicitly, but about which the Subtle Doctor rightly says that the presence of the angel in a place always seems to be associated with some operation "as if for the angel being in a place was the same as operating in the place." Scotus's first reaction against this thesis is theological. The thesis, he says, seems to be condemned

> in the form of an article condemned and excommunicated by the bishop of Paris. We may try to say that excommunication does not cross the sea or the limits of a diocese. When an article has been condemned as heretical, it is condemned as heretical everywhere and not only by the diocesan authority but by the Pope's authority. At the very least, an opinion is suspect when it has been solemnly condemned in some university.[30]

Furthermore, that is certainly why in their concern to avoid the suspect term *operation*, others say the angel is in a place by application to the place. But this is to disguise the same idea under another term. Indeed, this *application* can only be a second act, not a first act. But, if it is a second act, it is an operation. It is not even an immanent operation, because the angel's immanent operation is as independent of place as its essence. In fact, if an angel is applied to a place, it performs a transitive operation upon a body.[31] Therefore, there is only a verbal difference between maintaining that an angel is in a place because he operates there or because he is applied to it. If the first is condemned or at least suspect, so is the other.

However that may be, Duns Scotus contents himself with refuting the first expression as if nothing more were necessary to destroy the second, about which, however, he continues to think, as we see by his arguments. His criticism is interesting since it is connected to certain fundamental positions, because the case of the angel's presence is comparable to God's omnipresence. Resting on the Aristotelian principle that the mover is always together with the moved, St. Thomas concluded that God is present everywhere, because he is cause everywhere. If the point were simply to say that God is present everywhere he causes, there would be no difficulty. It is rather a tautology. But if we intend to prove that God is present *everywhere*, because he causes *somewhere*, it is another matter. Really, the immensity by virtue of which God is present everywhere is what explains that he can act everywhere. Consequently, he is present as immense by priority of nature before being present as cause.[32] This is also the case for an angel, whose existence must be present in any place before (by priority of nature) it can carry out any operation there. This is even more necessary for the angel than for God, because it seems that an infinitely powerful cause like God ought to be able to act at any distance, whereas a cause without finite power like an angel must not be too far away to exercise his action efficaciously. Accordingly, it is more necessary in the angel's case that presence is required before the operation than in God's.[33]

So, Duns Scotus literally interprets this thesis against which he argues, as if the operations were invoked not *qua* sign of a presence but *qua* condition. Understood in this sense, the thesis in question entails many curious consequences. The first is that an angel who does nothing in a place is nowhere; since the empyrean heaven is immutable and immobile, the angel will be nowhere. Again, an angel who crossed the distance from heaven to earth without finding anything to do during the trip would not be in the heaven he has already left, or on earth where it has not yet arrived, or in between the two because, unless it is the motor intelligence of one of the spheres, he does nothing there. Many other impossibilities of this kind are conceivable, but they present only dialectical interest. The heart of the matter

is elsewhere. It lies in the very nature of place.

Place is not a simple concept such that we would say without further specification that the angel is or is not there. In the first sense, everybody other than the outermost covering of the universe is in a place, that is to say, in its immediate immobile container.[34] Therefore, place is not a *form* but quite precisely a *container*. We call it immobile insofar as immobility is opposed to local movement, but not to indestructibility, because each time a body changes place, the place it occupied ceases to exist. In short, a body is always in a place but, by passing into a new one, it destroys the old one.[35] Secondly, a corporeal quantity can only be in a place if it actually exists, so that it presses upon the walls of the containing body and stretches them to lodge itself there.[36] Thirdly, since their quantity is the same, the body requires a place of equal size to its own. Fourthly, and for the same reason, the body is communicable to its place, so that one part of the contained corresponds to one part of the container, and the whole body to the whole place. Fifthly, each body has a determined place that lodges it. Sixthly, its place belongs to it insofar as this body is a natural body because insofar as this body has a determined substantial form and determined qualities, the body can be conserved by one place and corrupted by another. We say that a body is in its *natural place* when it is in its natural container, and it is in the environment most suitable to conserving it. Still, the natural place's *naturalness* is quite accidental to the place, which is always a place, whether it is natural or not.

Let us consider successively the angel's relation to each of these properties of place. Firstly, angels are not necessarily in a place. It is very easy to conceive of angels being created without there being any corporeal creation, or that after bodies were created, angels should have had no relation with them. However, let us add that even then, angels would be in passive potency in regard to place, in the sense that they *could* be there. That is a natural possibility for them, which stems either from their substance or from the fact that an angel is an actually existing limited nature or from some extrinsic cause. Therefore, we should not seek some intrinsic reason for which angels

must necessarily be in a place because there is none, and let us simply say that there is a completely passive possibility in angels to be in a place, because it does not contradict their nature.

Secondly, if an angel is in a place, it can fail to be there in act, because it is not there as something contained exerting lateral pressure that distends the walls of the container.

By contrast, the third point causes a problem. We say that the containing place is always equal to its content. It is commonly but not unanimously admitted that an angel cannot be in a place of any size whatsoever, because that is proper to God. It follows that an angel neither could be in a place of any smallness whatever, as can be established by proposition 35 of Euclid, book I, where Euclid demonstrates that since each *placeable* has a determined place, everything that exists in a place can be in another equal place, provided that the container's configuration allows it.[37] Starting from that point, the argument is as follows: everything that can be in a place can be in another equal place, provided that the container's configuration is not in conflict with the configuration of the contained. But an angel has no configuration that could conflict with the configuration of a place. Therefore, if an angel can be in either of two equal places, it can be in the other. On the other hand, if we admit that an angel can be in a place of any dimensions at all, it would be necessary to admit also that it can be in a square as small and narrow as we please. But if we admit that, a new consequence follows, that an angel could be in a quadrangle as long as we please, provided that the quadrangle is equal to the little square in which the angel can be. The reasoning would not hold if we were dealing with water, for example, which is not indefinitely extendible in length, but since angels have no quantitative dimensions, nothing prevents them from filling an infinitely narrow quadrangle whose side would extend to infinity.[38] Accordingly, the possibility of occupying an infinitely small place would entail the possibility of occupying an infinitely large place, which, as we said, is proper to God and consequently impossible for an angel. To conclude on this point, it seems that an angel has a determined place, but within undetermined limits, in the sense that there is a limit to the largeness

or smallness of the place that the angel can occupy. Let us at least say a limit to the largeness or smallness of the *continuous* place, because it is not impossible that the angel might be at a point.[39]

There is no difficulty about the fourth issue. The angel cannot be in a *commeasurative* place, because the angel has no parts that could correspond one by one with the parts of its place.

Fifthly, to the question of finding out whether the angel is in a place by virtue of what contains it, we will answer that it is necessarily in this or that place, because it is not everywhere. In other words, we are dealing with an undermined determination. Not being endowed with ubiquity, an angel is always in a place, but as a surface always has a color. The surface is not necessarily white, black, or any determined color, and likewise the angel is not necessarily in this place rather than that other place. In short, it is only determined to place in general.[40]

On the sixth and last issue (that place corresponds to body *qua* natural body), angels will be said never to be in a place by reason of their nature, because the nature of an immaterial substance implies no relation to place. Angels would be compelled to place only against their nature and in a *violent* state. Moreover, for that, it would be necessary to suppose that one body *qua* an angel's natural place had the power to conserve it and that another body had the power to destroy it, which is absurd.

In conclusion, angels can only be in a place according to their essence, but the passive potency of being in a place that is founded within them is neither natural (in the sense that their nature compels them of itself to some place as the stone to its place), or violent (in the sense that to be in place would contradict their nature). Their nature is neutral, exactly as a surface is to white or black.[41]

D Angels and movement

Consequently, angels are in a place, not just indirectly and by their efficacy but, if we can say so, in person and *secundum essentiam*. Likewise, the angel

can move in the place. Angels are never in a place that they are determined to have by their form. Really present in a definite place, angels are never circumscribed by the place. On the other hand, angels are not unlimited beings, whose immensity exempts them from moving. Accordingly, they can move, that is to say change places, and they must move to change place.

Let us add that the angels move with continuous movement, because there are infinite intermediate positions between two positions in a place (*inter duo ubi sunt infinita ubi media*). We will prove it by demonstrating that bodies pass through all these successive positions with a continuous movement. Angels could not pass through them either, unless they move with continuous movement.[42]

The heart of the proof is the certainty that it is impossible for a mobile whose movement is not continuous to traverse infinite positions. If the moment of this mobile is discontinuous, it would have to go successively from place to place, or as Duns Scotus says, from one *where* to the next *where*, and as their number is infinite by hypothesis, it will never get across any space. Continuous movement does not encounter this difficulty, because indivisibility does not exist for it. It literally passes over.

Evidently, the difficulty is proving that continuous movement is possible, because if it is as essentially divisible as space, the problem will be unsolvable in both cases and for the same reason. In the case of movement, the difficulty seems even more serious than in the case of place, because all movement is successive, and it is not clear how what is successive might be composed of anything but indivisibles. The point here is not something successive that is simply a vision of the mind, but an actually existing successive. If it exists, that can only be successively. But for there to be real succession, its moments must flow one after the other—that is, when one of them appears, the previous one has ceased to exist. Let us suppose that one moment lasts, however little it may be, as long as two moments for example, then there is no longer succession but continuity, and the movement is no longer successive but continuous. Consequently, it seems necessary that all successive moment is composed of indivisibles and therefore that it is

impossible for angels' movement to be successive.[43]

At bottom, the argument rests on the conviction that everything successive is composed of minima, that is to say of points completely devoid of quantity, each of which is something nonquantitative, a *non quantum*. Evidently, a succession of *non quanta* cannot be continuous. This is a tenable position. Thus, every movement has a beginning, and this beginning can only be an indivisible, because if there could be something that was smaller, this smaller would be the beginning, which in turn would have another, and so on to infinity. But, we can also argue starting from the generation of forms. When movement introduces a form into matter, there is a moment when it is not yet. This is the last instance of the previous form. And there is a moment when the new form begins to exist. It is the first moment of the following form. There is nothing between the two, because there is no middle term between two contradictories, and a middle term would be both forms at the same time. Therefore, the second form must have a first movement, and as we have said, it can only be first if it is indivisible.[44]

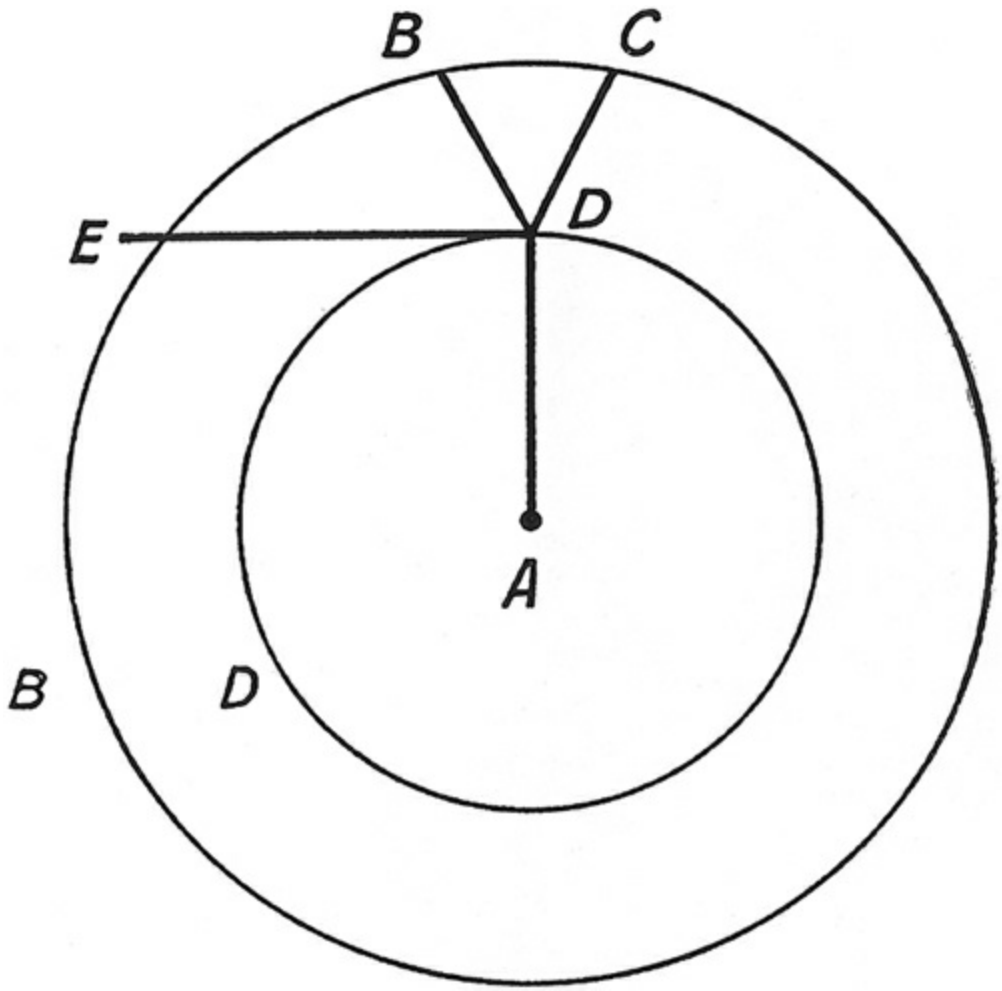
Against this position Duns Scotus again adopts Aristotle's hypothesis according to which movement, size, and time are composed of indivisibles for the same reasons.[45] A line cannot be composed of indivisibles because indivisible points would be discontinuous. But, if size were composed of indivisibles, the movement that traverses it would necessarily be composed of indivisible movements that would correspond to them. Let there be a line ABC formed of three indivisibles, the movement DEF of object O that traverses them necessarily will likewise be formed of three indivisibles. By hypothesis, these are indivisibles of movement, instantaneous, and therefore at rest, which leads to the absurdity that movement is rest, or that movement is not made of movements.[46] The same goes for time as for size and movement, because if all size is divisible, as a mobile whose velocity remains equal traverses a minimum length in a minimum time, it will have to traverse an indivisible unit of length in an indivisible unit of time—that is, once again, to be instantaneous time, which leads to the absurdity that time does not last or that duration is not composed of duration.[47] Aristotle's conclusion is that

every dimension is divided into dimensions, every movement into movements, every duration into durations. In short, every continuum is divided into continuums, that is to say, into parts that are always divisible.

In this way we get the genuinely demonstrative reason *a causa*, to which Duns Scotus refers.[48] At bottom it comes down to observing that we cannot make the continuous with the discontinuous even if we are dealing with an immobile continuum like a line, because if there is nothing between two points, there are not points but a *linear* element. But the conclusion remains valid for a mobile continuum, because if there is never anything between two elements of a continuum, the mobile that traverses it is itself never between one instant or another, but always is a movement whose elements are continued one in another. We can say indifferently then either that the end of one is united to the beginning of another or that none of them have beginning or end.

Accordingly, Duns Scotus, always along with Aristotle, holds that if the permanent is continuous, the successive is permanent as well, but he judges that the proof is easier to grasp in the case of the permanent (size) than in the case of the successive (movement or time). Consequently, he likes to demonstrate the continuity of size and does so with the help of two geometrical demonstrations.

Here is the first. Starting from any center A, we draw a large circle B, which is always possible to do under the second postulate of the first book of Euclid. Then starting from the same center a smaller circle D is inscribed in the first. Let us now suppose that the circumference of the large circle B is composed of points and let us choose two contiguous points B and C on it. By the first postulate of the first book of Euclid, a straight line can always be drawn from one point to the other. Let us now draw two straight lines, one from the center A to point B, the other from the center A to point C. These straight lines will cut the circumference of the smaller circle D. Here, two hypotheses are possible. These straight lines will cut circle D at the same point or at different points.



If they cut it at different points there will be as many points in the smaller circle as in the larger, because what is true of two straight lines is true of any number drawn from the center A to the circle B cutting the circle D. Now it is impossible that two unequal circles should be composed of parts equal in size and number. Points are equal by definition, and as there will be as many of them in the circumference of the smaller circle as the larger, then the smaller will be equal to the larger, and the part to the whole, which is impossible. But let us suppose that the two straight lines AB and AC cut the smaller circumference at the same point, and let this point be D. On the line AB we raise a perpendicular line that will cut it at the same point and that will be the tangent to the small circle (by virtue of theorem 15 of the first book of Euclid). The latter will form two right angles with line AB and also line AC, or angles equal to two right angles (by virtue of theorem 13 of the first book

of Euclid). Therefore, if the angle ADE and the angle BDE equal two right angles, the angle ADE and the angle CDE equal two right angles for the same reason. But any two right angles are equal to any two other right angles (by virtue of the third postulate of the first book of Euclid). Therefore, if we remove the common angle ADE, the remainders will be equal, so that the angle BDE will be completely equal to the angle CDE, which is impossible.[49]

The second demonstration is based on propositions 5 and 7 of Euclid, book X, from which it follows that the diagonal of a square is incommensurable with the side. Now, continues Duns Scotus, if these lines were composed of points, they would not be incommensurable because there would be a numerical proportion between the number of points in one line and the number of points in the other. These lines would not only fail to be incommensurable, they would be equal, a patently false consequence whose necessity, however, we prove as follows.

Let us take two contiguous points on one of the sides and the two corresponding points on the other side. If we join them by two parallel straight lines, the lines will cut the diameter at two points. We ask whether these points will be contiguous or not. If they are contiguous as the origins of the two straight lines are, then the diagonal will not be larger than the side. If they are not contiguous, let us take an intermediary point on the diagonal, and let us draw from it a straight line parallel and equidistant to the other two lines. This line must cut the sides between the origins of the first two straight lines and at equal distance from the two points. Thus, between these two points that are said to be contiguous, there is room for a third, which is absurd. Therefore, we must renounce the hypothesis from which this contradiction follows. In fact, there can be no intermediate point between these points where our two lines cut the diagonal. Furthermore, Euclid's entire book X destroys the hypothesis that a line is composed of points, because, if that were so, there would be none of those irrational lines whose many species are studied by geometers.[50]

That shows in a general way why it is false to say that the successive is composed of indivisible *minima*. That is false of quantity, which is divisible

to the infinite as such, and it remains false whether this quantity is taken in itself or reduced to unity by its form.[51] A book would be necessary to analyze in detail the many discussions to which Duns Scotus devotes himself on this point, mere extracts of which are given here. We ought at least to indicate their existence, because they are an excellent example of how a theologian could use philosophy in Duns Scotus's time. He does so *ad abundantiam* in a way, as a luxury that he allows himself and for the pleasure of exercising his dialectic on problems that, from a strictly theological point of view, nothing requires him to treat. Even the way he uses Aristotle is interesting, because this whole discourse rests on book VI of the *Physics*, but Duns Scotus does not expound it or sum it up. Supposing it to be known by his hearers or readers, as indeed it was for the best of them, our theologian argues in the context of the text by taking a major premise here, a minor premise there, or even a conclusion. But he justifies them in his fashion and by his own means, or if needed by Euclid, utilized in the same manner as the *Physics*. A modern philosopher feels the presence of Zeno's arguments all during this whole discussion. We do not name him, because Duns Scotus does not name him here. Scotus knows Zeno, because Aristotle refutes him by name in *Physics*, book VI, chapter 2. But Duns Scotus is interested in the problem, not in its history. Again, Scotus is interested in the problem in Aristotle, not in Aristotle. The notion we have of argument by authority in the Middle Ages is distorted by our historicism, at least in a doctor of the stature of Duns Scotus. For us Aristotle is a man. For Duns Scotus Aristotle is what he said or rather the meaning of what he said. The same holds for Avicenna and Averroes, whose commentary Duns Scotus uses here. We get the impression of a philosophical interlude inserted into theology. Who would dare to assure that the survey of this speculation about the infinite did not influence the history of philosophy? When this speculation proliferates in the fifteenth century, it is not created from nothing.

We should not forget that the point is to know whether an angel can move in a place. We have examined the problem from the standpoint of place.[52] But the problem remains to be discussed from the angel's viewpoint, because

if space is not composed of indivisibles, the angel himself is one. But can an indivisible move? That will be the question now.

Duns Scotus's answer illustrates even better than the previous one this dialectic's gratuitousness, because, in reality, there is no problem. Not only is there no theological problem, because we know by Scripture that these *messengers* who are the angels *come* toward humans to whom God sends them. But there is no philosophical problem, because the angel's indivisibility is the indivisibility of a purely spiritual form, which is not circumscribed by a place, even in the place. Therefore, we should not imagine the length of a continuum as a quantitative point in movement. Except that, Duns Scotus adds, since there is no reason that an indivisible of quantity cannot move with a continuous movement, we can demonstrate that an angel could still move with continuous movement even if it were always in a point. In short, an angel is not a point or enclosed in a point, but if it were, continuous movement would still remain possible to it.

An example will make this clear. Let us put a sphere on a plane, and let us displace it on the lane. It traces a straight line, and still, it only touches the plane at a single point. Accordingly, the point traverses the whole line, and yet, this line thus traversed is not composed of points. The same would hold if this point existed by itself and traced this line by itself, and the same again if the angel, present in the point, traversed the line with the point. But we can make a simpler supposition. Let us take a first point on the line, and let us suppose that another line moves on the first. This point will describe the whole line in movement, because just as each point of the line in movement does not cease to pass from one point of the lower line to another, so also each point of the lower line does not cease to pass under all the successive points of the line in movement. The movement's continuity is not altered, however, from which it follows that an indivisible that existed by itself could move by itself with continuous moment without the distance traversed being composed of indivisibles.[53]

The real difficulty is not there, because what is surprising is not that an indivisible, like an angel, can traverse a continuum, but that it needs a

successive movement to traverse it. The only reason that makes the succession in movement necessary is the resistance that the mobile opposes to the motor. For there to be movement, the mover must be able to overcome the mobile's resistance, but the mobile need not tend naturally to a contrary movement, in which case the movement that the mover imparts to it would do it violence. There must be a resistance of the mobile such that it prevents the mover from immediately achieving its end. Obviously, an infinite power could immediately bring the mobile to its term, but a finite power encounters this resistance of the mobile and of the environment. The environment's resistance against the mobile is precisely what causes the mobile's resistance against the mover.[54]

Consequently, the reason for this succession is partly in the angel itself. Its active force is not infinite. There are many environments between heaven and earth, and when an angel passes from a celestial *ubi* to a terrestrial *ubi*, its motor virtue is not such that it can traverse time instantaneously. Each environment must be crossed by the angel before it attains its term, and therein is all the resistance required for there to be succession in movement. So even, if we represent an angel as present in an indivisible point, it can only move this part in space successively.[55]

But can an angel move *itself* in space? Obviously, because we just said that it can move in space. A body does not cause its movement, and the movement can be produced other than just by virtue of a divine miracle. The angel itself produces it.[56]

We have seen that such movement is possible for an angel, but it is equally possible that this spiritual nature should have the active power of acquiring successive positions in place in regard to which the spiritual nature is in potency. This is not an imperfection in it. Quite the contrary, for it would rather be imperfection on its part to find itself in potency to anything, without having a way to acquire it.[57] Accordingly, an angel is in the same condition as all finite beings. Heavy or light beings have an inclination in them to achieve their natural places.[58] Animals have senses, active powers of experiencing sensations, for which they are in passive potency. An angel has

the faculty of moving in space in order to reach successively the different places that its nature permits it to occupy there.

E Angels and intellection

"In Duns Scotus's questions on angelic knowledge," says Fr. Parthenius Minges, "he primarily proposes to make it clear that the opinion of others on this point, especially the opinion of St. Thomas, is not as certain and solid as they think."[59] If the observation is accurate, and in great part it is, we must expect a primarily critical position from Duns Scotus. But we will see that, even in this part of his doctrine, positive answers are not completely absent.

Firstly, how does an angel know itself? Thomas Aquinas admits, "An angel knows itself by its form, which is its substance." Just as the species of the thing seen is the formal principle of vision in the eye, so also the angel's essence is the formal principle of the intellection it has of itself in the intellect[60] Duns Scotus does not deny that, and this thesis is not what he opposes. In any case, if he has St. Thomas (whom he does not name) in mind, his interpretation supposes an error on his part, which is unusual for him and inexplicable for anyone who knows Scotus's habits. Summing up, Scotus says: "This opinion, it seems (*ut videatur*), maintains that the intellect is in essential potency to the operation or intellection that the opinion declares is immanent, and that the whole reason for the operation is the object that is united to it in its operation, as heat in wood is the whole reason for its warming up."[61] It is true that the example of heat in wood is found in the text of St. Thomas and that the angel's intellection is posited as immanent, but we do not find there that an angel's essence, its form, is *tota ratio* of its intellection. On the other hand, it is true that Duns Scotus is conscious that he is interpreting this opinion, because he writes: "this opinion holds, as it seems," *Haec opinio ponit, ut videtur* . . . but it is enough for him to go back to the question to observe that Thomas taught the opposite.[62] However that might be, Duns Scotus denies that an angel's essence is the act of its intellect or rather that its intellect is in act by its essence. Indeed, taken as subsistent in

itself, an angel's essence does not inform its intellect and confers no activity on its intellect. Accordingly, it is not enough that a particular essence exists and is presented to an angel's intellect for the intellect to have an operation whose reason would be the essence or a likeness of the essence. The very example used helps us see this, because if heat were a separated form, it could not be a principle of an immanent operation in the wood, the operation of warming up.[63] Evidently, Duns Scotus does not understand the relation of the intellect to the angelic essence as Thomas Aquinas does, but neither teaches that the essence is the *total* reason of intellection, or that an angel knows itself directly by its essence, which would amount to confusing it with God.

A philosopher would see no drawback to identifying the angel's intellection with its substance, because each separate substance would no doubt appear to him as receiving its intelligible knowledge from higher substances that the separated substance itself does not know. But, Duns Scotus points out, our theologians must refuse this identification. For the lower angel does not only know itself; it knows the higher angel; it knows God. The intellection it has of itself could be identical to its essence, because in this case the object's perfection is the same as the intellection's perfection. But how could an angel know an essence higher than it, by its essence, for example God's essence? Moreover, Duns Scotus is not concerned by this disagreement. As he has just said in regard to another problem: "the fact that the Philosopher does not see this has no importance, because there are many things he did not see, and that theologians must grant."[64]

Moreover, this does not mean that angels do not know themselves by their essence at all, but that essence and intellection are not identical in them. In fact, the essence of angels is the partial cause of their intellection. Indeed knowing themselves or knowing their essences is the same, but such an act requires two causes: a knowing intellect and a known object. Insofar as the object is intelligible, it exercises partial causality in regard to intellection, and the intellect exercises its part of the causality in regard to the same act by cooperating with the object to produce the act.[65] Furthermore, of itself the

angelic essence is united to its intellect. Therefore, *qua* partial cause and in conjunction with the intellect that is the other partial cause, the angelic essence can immediately exercise a complete act of intellection of itself.[66] Accordingly, angels can know themselves by their essence in the sense that they only need their essence and their intellect to know themselves. Two causes cooperate there, neither of which is the total motor cause of the act, and both of which move equally, *ex aequo*, in some fashion. Not that we could not maintain here as elsewhere that the intelligible naturally precedes the intellection and that, from this point of view, the angelic essence is only the first cause of the knowledge it has of itself. But the relations of object to intellection are as complex in the angels as they appear to be in humans, and we can see there that in spite of the priority of nature in regard to intellection, the soul is simply a cooperating cause in the production of this common effect—the knowledge of itself that it receives insofar as it produces it.[67]

When the angelic intellect looks above itself, the only object it finds is God. As a theologian, Duns Scotus knows that the good angels enjoy the vision of God face to face, but this intuitive knowledge is only possible for them because God raises them to it. In a word, it is supernatural knowledge. This is precisely why Duns Scotus poses the other question whose disinterested character is indisputable: Is abstract knowledge of God possible for angels? Speaking absolutely, the question is interesting, because we cannot discuss it fully without defining the concept of pure natural knowledge. This is why Duns Scotus immediately sets out to do so by distinguishing two kinds of intellectual knowledge, abstraction and intuition. We have already met it, but the distinction is provided so clearly that it will be useful to examine it again.[68]

It is remarkable that, in order to define abstractive knowledge (*cognitio abstractiva*) Duns Scotus presents it as abstracting from all actual existence: *cognitio objecti secundum quod abstrahit ab omni existentia actuali*. Let us take this expression literally: for knowledge, being abstract is not including the existence of the object of knowledge. Inversely, intuitive knowledge grasps the object *qua* existing and present in actual existence: *secundum quod*

existens et secundum quod praesens in aliqua existentia actuali. We cannot insist too much on this point in a time of confusion like ours, where we see certain representatives of medieval tradition appeal both to Duns Scotus and Ockham. The latter, as we know, maintained that it is possible to have an intuition of what does not exist. From the point of view of his absolute power, *de potentia absoluta,* if God pleases, he can give us this kind of intuition. It is certainly necessary to say that from Duns Scotus's viewpoint, and moreover from Thomas Aquinas's viewpoint, this thesis of Ockham is absurd. Since intuitive knowledge is defined as knowledge of an object grasped *secundum quod existens et secundum quod praesens in aliqua existentia actuali*, the concept of an *intuition of what does not exist* is contradictory and impossible. We are free to choose between Ockham and Duns Scotus, but we cannot defend both at the same time. Furthermore, we see in this how dangerous it is to write history as a history of philosophical formulas, because Duns Scotus has been declared Ockham's predecessor on this point. In fact, Ockham inherits the terms *intuitive* and *abstract* knowledge, *cognitio intutiva* and *cognitio abstractiva*, from Scotus, but far from having received the concept of intuitive knowledge from Scotus, Ockham destroys it and with it the distinction by proposing what was a monstrosity in Duns Scotus's eyes, the intuition of the existence of something that does not exist.

Whatever the case may be on this issue, to which we shall return, Duns Scotus's own position is clear. He knows very well that we can have knowledge about something that does not exist, provided that this knowledge is not an intuition. Scientific knowledge belongs to this type. Dealing with quiddities, "there is science of the object insofar as we abstract from actual existence," *scientia est objecti secundum quod abstrahit ab existentia actuali*. Moreover, his is a classic position connected to another, namely, that there is only one science of the general because, since all scientific knowledge is necessary, its truth cannot depend on the existence of nonexistence of its object. Accordingly, science proves that abstractive knowledge is possible, but, on the other hand, sensation proves that intuitive knowledge is possible,

because the senses attain an object as existing and as present through its existence. If we admit that a higher faculty contains at least as much perfection as a lower faculty of the same kind, we will recognize that it must be possible for the intellect, the highest cognitive faculty, to perceive its object's existence in an intuition.

Two complimentary observations are necessary. First, by cognitio *intuitive*, Duns Scotus does not understand the direct vision of any object of thought whosoever. We already noted that the simple apprehension of a quiddity by the intellect is an intuition in its fashion. It is the intuition of an abstraction whose typical case is the intuitive knowledge of a principle. By contrast, the present distinction means that intuitive knowledge, properly so-called and in the absolute sense of the term, is concerned with the existent as existent.[69] Next, these two modes of knowledge differ in perfection as they differ in nature, and intuitive knowledge is more perfect because it not only attains the intelligible species of the essence, as abstraction does,[70] but a present object as present.[71]

That said, let us recall that angels can only have intuitive knowledge of God if they dispose of their natural faculties of knowledge. At least that is the common opinion of theologians. Nevertheless, angels might have abstract natural knowledge about God—that is, they might conceive the divine presence distinctly by means of an intelligible species that would represent it. Obviously, this species would not represent the divine essence as presently existing, but the angel could have distinct, though abstract, knowledge of it. There is even no reason not to admit that such a representative species of the divine essence might be innate in angels from the start. An angel is a very noble essence, because it is the most perfect created intellect that there is. Therefore, nothing in its nature is opposed to its being created with an innate intelligible species, of which, after all, any created intellect would be capable, since it does not exceed its perfection.[72]

Such a creature would naturally dispose of this distinct concept of God; the metaphysical notion of *infinite being* is the highest possible approximation to that concept. This knowledge *per speciem* would be analogous to our

knowledge, in the sense that the angel would not necessarily be fixed upon it, but would dispose of the species as it pleased in the same way that we think about our concept of infinite being when we wish. This is even why knowledge *per speciem* is worth more than an intellection of God directly caused in an angel by God himself. Since an angel can only have one intellection at a time, it cannot think about anything else; or once it thought about anything else, God would have to recreate the intellection in the angel to bring the intellection back to the angel.[73] As for knowing what such a concept would be, that is impossible for us, precisely because we do not have it. Evidently, it would be the most perfect conceptual representation of God to which our finite intellect can aspire. In short, it would be the *perfect concept of God* accessible to intellectual creatures, but it would always be only a concept.[74]

For the present, let us suppose that angelic intellects turn toward creatures other than themselves? How do they know those creatures? Certainly by cognitive reasons—that is, by intelligible species distinct from the essences they represent, each of which corresponds to a distinct quiddity.[75] Duns Scotus gives great importance to this last point. Let us recall that we are dealing with intelligible species, which are therefore finite, which makes it impossible for one of them to represent infinity of distinct objects by itself. Indeed, the more an intelligible species allows us to know different objects, the more perfect it is. A species that would allow us to know an infinity of objects would be infinite itself, which is the case of God, not angels. Let us add that no created intelligible species by itself allows several essences to be known *distinctly*. Here again, God's case is different, because, since the divine essence includes all knowables perfectly, it is enough for God to know himself to know them all directly. By contrast, in the case of angels, each distinct reason of knowing conceives a distinct object to which it is adequate, but none of which includes all created objects in itself. Accordingly, a distinct intelligible species will make it know one essence distinctly and several others confusedly, but not all essences distinctly.[76]

So, let us admit that angels know other beings by intelligible species

created with them and therefore innate, each of which corresponds to a distinct essence. This does not explain angels' whole knowledge, because they know individuals, not just essences. They do not have innate species of individuals: "they are not created with likenesses of individuals," *similitudo singularis non est sibi concreata*. This is very easy to understand, because there can be an infinity of individuals, and for an angel to know them, it would suppose an infinity of intelligible species. Since the actual infinite is impossible, the hypothesis is absurd, but for angels to be able to acquire knowledge they do not have, they must be able to get it from things themselves. Thus, angels can progress by extracting the knowledge of singulars from the singulars.[77]

Some authors, Thomas Aquinas among them, have denied that. But it can be proven starting from their own principles, because they admit that angels possess agent intellects. Humans have them, therefore angels, who are superior to humans in intellectuality, have them too. Consequently, it remains for us to find out what could be such an intellect's first object. This object must be adequate to everything an angel can know, and since our adversary admits that an angel can know singulars, the first object of its intellect must virtually include all singulars. God alone can know them by his essence. We are left with the conclusion that the angelic intellect's adequate object is something common, some community of predication or analogy in regard to everything knowable by it, including intelligibles and sensibles. But sensibles are merely intelligibles in potency. Accordingly, angels must have an agent intellect to render sensibles intelligibles in act, which was what had to be demonstrated.[78]

At any rate, it is certain that angels have possible intellects, because whatever the source of their knowledge may be, and even if it does not come to them from God, they certainly have to receive it. Their intellect's possibility in regard to the intelligible species is necessarily prior to the act by which the intellect receives the species, not in time, but in nature. If God had created our souls equipped with the species of all intelligibles, an agent intellect and a possible intellect would still be necessary, because the nature

of the human soul requires it. Since Christ was human, he possessed agent and possible intellects; and angels also would have them even if they had no need to put them to use. But they do need to do so, because since angels have nothing in themselves by which they know bodies, they depend on the agent and possible intellects for the knowledge they have of bodies. Perhaps it will be objected that their perfection excludes such dependence, but that would be a sophism. We cannot conclude: angels do not depend on the body *qua* act of the body; therefore, they do not depend on the body *qua* object of knowledge. For the angel to have no need of receiving anything from the outside, it would have to be God.[79]

This whole discussion presupposes a serious concern in Duns Scotus to avoid undervaluing nature. What our Doctor deems unbelievable is an angel who only knows anything by means of infused species that come completely from God, so much so that in the event that the knowledge had not been bestowed upon it, it would remain passive like a stone. Such a being would be no more an intellectual substance than a stone.[80] In fact, angels can know singularity in singularity itself, and as the being's singularity is not included in any universality, it must be admitted that angels are educated by proper species, each of which represents the singular in its singularity. Unless we admit that God creates an infinity of such species in them, which we know is absurd, we must conclude that angels extract their knowledge of singulars from singulars.

Furthermore, even if angels had innate species of all possible singulars, it would not be enough to make them know the singulars that exist among those numberless singulars. Let us suppose that an angel has the concept *Socrates* and the concept *running*. It would never deduce *Socrates runs* from them, because this proposition is contingent like all propositions of the same kind. To teach an angel that Socrates runs, Socrates must exist; he must be in the process of running; and the angel must see it.[81] Accordingly, there is at least one mode of knowledge of things that angels cannot acquire without things. It is intuitive knowledge of their existence because there could be abstract knowledge of things without things, but there cannot be intuition of things

without them, and “a real object or the thing itself as present necessarily accompanies intuitive knowledge.”[82] In short, like our intellect, the angelic intellect can receive species from sensibles, and to say that its perfection forbids that is to reason backward. The opposite is true. If angels need to do this to acquire all the perfection of which they are capable, angels can obviously do so, since sensitive natures can do so.[83]

This conclusion allows us to anticipate that the relation of intellect to object will be different in Duns Scotus from what it is in Thomas Aquinas. Here, matter does not individuate form, and the principle of individuation itself is not material. A world of bodies whose natures remain the same of themselves under singularity or under universality, and where the singularity of each singular, far from stemming from matter, is the last actuality of its form, is a world that does not present itself to the intellect’s scrutiny as a body that is opaque to its light. Without being abased, angels can learn by intuition or conceive by abstraction even singular existences that compose that world of bodies, because everything there possesses being, and since matter is, matter presents itself to the intellect with its own intelligibility.

Notes

1 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction I, question 6, number 2, vol. II, p. 80 [CE VII, p. 149]. This excludes the possibility of hylemorphic composition in the angel. The passages of *De Rerum Principio* supporting the attribution of this doctrine to Scotus are not by him. Fr. Parthenius Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. I, pp. 46–47, could have spared himself the trouble of glossing them. The authority of *Quaestiones de Anima*, question 15, numbers 3 ff, vol. III, p. 554 ff, is weightier, but besides the fact that it is not beyond all dispute, to say that the hylemorphic composition of the soul is a *probable* opinion does not mean that Scotus endorsed it. In any case, it does not seem to agree with the teaching of *Opus Oxoniense*, and it seems to us that if Duns Scotus admitted a thesis of its importance, we would find some undeniable trace of it in his authentic writings.

2 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 2, vol. II, p. 80 [C VII, pp. 150–51]. Cf. *Quodlibet* IX, number 4 [AW, pp. 220–21]. Of course, the angel cannot be united to matter as form. Duns Scotus simply proves that its essential difference from the soul does not reside there.

3 Theologically speaking, the beatific vision is not discursive, but intuitive. Neither angel nor soul are naturally capable of it without divine light; yet, “utraque visio essentialiter dependet ab intellectualitate naturae cujus est.” This *intellectualitas* is the same in both cases. So there is no specific difference between these two beatific visions, nor consequently between these two

intellects. If there is one, it must be for another reason, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 3, vol. II, p. 81 [CE VII, pp. 151–52]. This, philosophically speaking, is *ad abundantiam*. Cf. *Quodlibet* IX, number 7 [AW, p. 223].

4 Theologically, there is a fact, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 3, vol. II, p. 82 [CE VII, pp. 152–54]: "Hoc modo anima Christi non discurrebat, sed ipse novit habitualiter omnia principia et conclusiones in principio, et tamen ipsa non fit natura angelica."

5 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 4, vol. II, p. 82 [CE VII, p. 154]: "Dico tunc ad quaestionem, quod quicquid est potens agere est aliquod habens actum primum; et prior est sibi secundum naturam ratio actus primi secundum se quam in comparatione ad actum secundum cujus potest esse principium, ita quod licet illud quo tale ens est principium actus secundi non sit aliud a natura sua non tamen prima entitas sua est natura sua ut est principium talis actus secundi, sed natura sua ut in se est haec. Et ita prima distinctio entis non est per naturam suam in quantum est principium talis operationis, sed per naturam suam ut haec natura, licet per identitatem ipsa sit principium talis actus secundi."

6 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 4, vol. II, pp. 82–83 [CE VII, pp. 154–55].

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 5, vol. II, p. 83 [CE VII, pp. 155–57].

8 Scotus, *Quodlibet* IX, number 1 [AW, pp. 218–19].

9 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 6, number 5, vol. II, pp. 83–84 [CE VII, pp. 156–57]: "Hoc etiam declaratur per aliud: quia sicut in eodem possunt contineri per identitatem illa quorum est distinctio formalis quasi specifica, sicut in eadem anima includuntur perfectiones intellectivae et sensitivae, quae ita sunt distinctae formaliter sicut si essent duae res, ita et e converso, potest aliquid indistinctum contineri in distinctis. Et si hoc est verum, tunc planum est quod angelus et anima sic non distinguuntur specie primo per talem et talem intellectualitatem, immo nec primo nec non primo, quia talis intellectualitas in eis non distinguitur specie. Aut si istud non est verum, sed relinquatur istud modo sicut dubium, saltem primum dictum videtur satis clarum, scilicet quod per istud non est prima distinctio eorum." This last reservation cannot cast doubt on Duns Scotus's thought. His whole doctrine of the first object of the intellect proves that, for him *intellectualitas in eis non distinguitur specie*. Also, his doctrine of common nature requires it: *intellectualitas est intellectualitas tantum*. Finally, St. Augustine confirms him in this position, because at start of this question 6, number 2, vol. II, p. 79 [CE VII, p. 148, number 1 rather than 2], Duns Scotus quotes the words of *De Libero Arbitrio*, book III, chapter 11, number 32, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XXXII, column 1287: "Animae sunt enim rationales, et illis superioribus [*scilicet*, the angels] officio quibus impares, sed natura pares." The parity of nature of humans and angels is matched with the firmest assertion of superiority of angelic creatures, *ibidem*: "Tales sunt optimae, et sanctae et sublimes creaturae caelestium vel supercaelestium potestatum, quibus Deus solus imperat, universus autem mundus subjectus est."

10 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 13 [AW, p. 327].

11 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 50, article 4, body of article. In *Quodlibet* II, number 3 [AW, pp. 32–33], Duns Scotus criticized the Thomist position according to which spiritual forms are not numerically multipliable without matter. He has in mind *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 41, article 6. After maintaining that forms of the same species can be multipliable without matter and treating the contrary position as doubtful or even false according to the opinion of several authors, he invokes the condemnation of 1277 against that contrary opinion, *Quodlibet* II, number 4 [AW, pp. 33–34]: "Et articuli damnati tres videntur istum articulum prima facie

reprobare. Unus est a domino Stephano condemnatus, qui dicit sic, quod *quia Intelligentiae non habent materiam, Deus non posset ejusdem speciei facere plures; error*. Secundus, *quod Deus non potest multiplicare individua sub una specie sine materia; error*. Tertius, *quod formae non recipiunt divisionem nisi secundum divisionem materiae*, error, nisi intelligatur de formis eductis de potentia materiae; ergo de formis non eductis de potentia materiae hoc dicere, est errror." These three articles are found in *Chartularium Universitatis Parisiensis*, vol. I, p. 548, number 81; p. 549, number 96; p. 554, number 191. They are invoked against the same thesis by Henry of Ghent, *Quodlibet* II, question 8: "Unde et inter erroneos articulos nuper ab episcopo damantos . . ." To appreciate the moderation in Duns Scotus's tone, one should read this passage from Henry of Ghent in the same *Quodlibet*: "Quod mirum ergo si Philosophus dicit quod in formis separatis in una specie, id est essentia, non est nisi unium individuum? Hoc enim de necessitate sequitur, non tam ex illo quod falso posuit non esse plura individua sub eadem specie nisi per materiam, quam ex alio sacrilegio quod tanquam sacrilegus posuit, quod scilicet quaelibet earum deus quidam sit et quoddam necesse esse. Nostri ergo philosophantes si velint sequi Philosophum in hoc . . ." By contrast Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* XII, question 5, counts this thesis among those that, while condemned in 1277: "Videtur litteratis et peritis quod possit licite aliter opinari." (Translator: Gilson quotes from the Louvain edition of Godfrey's Quodlibets, published under five different titles: *Les quatre premiers Quodlibets de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Maurice de Wulf and Auguste Pelzer [Louvain: Institut supérieur de philosophie de la université; Paris: A. Picard, 1904]. *Quodlibet cinq, six et sept de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Maurice de Wulf and Jean Hoffmans [Louvain: Institut supérieur de philosophie de l'université, 1914]. *Le huitième, neuvième et dixième Quodlibet de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Jean Hoffmans [Louvain: Institut supérieur de philosophie de la université, 1924]. *Les Quodlibets once-quatorze de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Jean Hoffmans [Louvain: Institut supérieur de philosophie de la université, 1932], *Le Quodlibet XV et trois questions ordinaires de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Odon Lottin, study by Jean Hoffmans and Auguste Pelzer [Louvain: Institut supérieur de philosophie de la université, 1937]). Cf. M.-H. Laurent, "Godefroid de Fontaines et la condemnation de 1277," *Revue Thomiste* XII (1930), pp. 273–81.

12 Opus Oxoniense, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 3, vol. II, p. 279 [CE VII, pp. 498–500]. See *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 5, vol. II, pp. 280–81 [CE VII, pp. 504–05. In CE the last word of this passage is *multiplicatio*]: "Dico igitur quod omnis natura quae non est de se actus purus potest, secundum illam realitatem secundum quam est natura, esse potentialis ad realitatem illam qua est haec natura [*scilicet*, the Scotist *haecceitas*] et per consequens potest esse haec, et sicut de se non includit aliquam entitatem quasi singularem, ita non repugnant sibi quotcumque tales entitates, et ita potest in quotcumque talibus inveniri. In eo tamen quod est necesse esse ex se, est determinatio in natura ad esse haec (quia tantum est quantum potest esse), quia quicquid potest esse in natura est ibi, ita quod determinatio non potest esse per aliquod extrinsecum ad sigularitatem, si possibilitas sit in natura per se ad infinitatem; secus est in omni natura possibili, ubi potest cadere multitudo." Cf. Scotus, *Quodlibet* II, number 6 [AW, pp. 35–37], which is interesting for the comparison of the case of the angel to that of the soul.

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 4, vol. II, p. 279 [CE VII, p. 502].

14 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book VIII, chapter 6, 1031 a 15–19, where the question is why the individual is something other than its substance, or *quod quid erat esse*? In an immaterial being, substance, and individual are the same.

15 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 6, vol. II, p. 281 [CE VI, pp.

506–07]. Note on this point, *ibidem* [CE VII, pp. 507–08], that Scotus's principle leads him to distance himself from Avicenna, who sustains: "quod tantum sit unus angelus in una specie; sed propositio cui haec conclusio innititur, scilicet quod angelus superior creat inferiorem, a nullo theologo vel catholico conceditur; quare nec ejus conclusio debet concedi ab aliquo theologo." For the same reasoning, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 11 end, vol. II, p. 286 [CE VII, pp. 515–16].

16 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 5, vol. II, p. 280 [I do not find the phrase quoted in CE VII, pp. 403–05].

17 For example, in *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 285, Parthenius Minges declares against Schwane: "Falsa est assertio, omnes angelos secundum Scotum non nisi una speciem constituere." But he only gives two passages as proof, where Scotus "explicitly maintains" several species of angels. They prove that Duns Scotus used the word *species* in regard to the angelic orders, but he does not tell us in what sense. Schwane's excuse, *Dogmengeschichte der mittleren Zeit*, p. 201, vol. II of the fourth volume *Dogmengeschichte* (Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1882–1885), is that it is difficult to show that there are species of the species *angel* in Duns Scotus, but his genius disposed of resources that we do not possess.

18 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 1, number 1, vol. II, p. 89 [CE VII, p. 161], first asks whether any succession formally exists in the angel's actual existence. However his lengthy discussion of the problem leads to no solution.

19 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 2, number 1, vol. II, p. 107 [CE VII, p. 193].

20 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 2, number 1, vol. II, p. 107 [CE VII, p. 194].

21 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 2, number 3, vol. II, pp. 108–09 [CE VII, pp. 196–98].

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question, 2, numbers 10–11, vol. II, pp. 114–16 [CE VII, pp. 208–11].

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 3, number 3, vol. II p. 118 [CE VII, p. 215].

24 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 4, numbers 2–3, vol. II, pp. 121–23 [CE VII, pp. 220–22].

25 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 4, number 4, vol. II, pp. 123–24 [CE VII, pp. 222–24].

26 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 4, number 6, vol. II, p. 125 [CE VII, p. 226].

27 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 4, number 9, vol. II, p. 127 [CE VII, pp. 230–32].

28 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 4, number 14, vol. II, pp. 131–32 [Possibly CE VII, pp. 238–39]. This does not mean that the angelic intellection is always instantaneous nor that it could not last during what *we* call *a certain time*, nor that the duration of an eon could last only while our duration lasts, or *as long as* from our point of view. But we say that these two events never take place *at the same time*, because one of them is not in time at all, *ibidem*.

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 4, number 9, vol. II, p. 128 [CE VII, pp. 231–32]. Note the interesting criticism of a doctrine in the *Liber de Causis*, Scotus, *Opus*

Oxoniense, book II, distinction 2, question 4, number 1, vol. II, p. 121 [pp. 219–20] and number 14, p. 131 [CE VII, p. 238], where the response involves Avicenna in the problem.

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 1, vol. II. p. 134 [CE VII, pp. 244–45]. Scotus alludes to one of the articles condemned by Étienne Tempier, bishop of Paris, in 1277, *Chartularium Universitatis Parisiensis*, vol. I, p. 554, article 204: "Quod substantiae separatae sunt alicubi per operationem; et quod non possunt moveri ab extremo in extremum, nec in medium, nisi quia possunt velle operari aut in medio, aut in extremis. Error, si intelligatur, sine operatione substantiam non esse in loco, nec transire de locum ad locum."

31 The second thesis considered is that of Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 52, article 1, body of the article: "Per applicationem igitur virtutis angelicae ad aliquem locum qualitercumque dicitur angelus esse in loco corporeo." *Qualitercumque* ought to be taken in the strong sense, because St. Thomas has just said that, in relation to the way in which a body is in a place, the angel is there.

32 This is directed against Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 8, article 1, where the passage from Aristotle about which Duns Scotus speaks is indeed cited. It may be interesting to note that Thomas Aquinas does not use the term *immensitas* in the same way as Duns Scotus, probably because for Aquinas this is only another name for God's *intimate presence* in creatures. By contrast, immensity has a different name in Duns Scotus, because it is that in God's essence, which is the *basis of his presence* to finite being.

33 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 3, vol. II, p. 135 [CE VII, pp. 248–49]. The different climates of the metaphysics of being and metaphysics of cause can be perceived here. The idea that the angel's presence *secundum essentiam* to his effect is more necessarily required than God's is perfectly justifiable in a metaphysics where the issue is precisely *essentia*, which is more able to act at a distance, the more perfect it is. It is not justifiable in a metaphysics of *esse*, which is more necessarily present to its effect, the more perfect it is.

34 Aristotle, *Physics*, book III, chapter 5, 205 a 7–9, and book IV, chapter 4, 211 b 10–17. This is true for philosophers. But *secundum Catholicos*, God could create a stone that was not housed anywhere, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 10, vol. II, p. 141 [CE VII, p. 259].

35 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 9, vol. II, pp. 140–41 [CE VII, pp. 258–59]: "Sic dico in proposito, quod locus est immobilis per se et per accidens localiter; est tamen corruptibilis, moto subjecto localiter, quia tunc amplius non manet in eo illa relatio; et tamen non est corruptibilis in se et secundum aequivalentiam; quia necessario succedit illi corpori, in quo fuit ista ratio loci, aliud corpus in quo est alia ratio loci numero a praecedenti, et tamen eadem praecedenti secundum aequivalentiam per comparationem ad motum localem." For the doctrine about place, see *Quodlibet* XII, number 15 [AW, pp. 280–81].

36 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 10, vol. II, p. 141 [CE VII, p. 260]. This is not the case of the part in the whole, because the part is not there as what is lodged is in a place, and in this way does not actualize the surface that contains it in potency. Cf. Aristotle, *Physics*, book IV, chapter 4, 211 a 29–34.

37 See Carolus Balić, O.F.M., "Bemerkungen zur Verwendung mathematischer Beweise und zu den *Theoremata* bei den scholastischen Schriftstellern," *Wissenschaft und Weisheit* III (1936), pp. 192–93 on the Oxford mathematical tradition prior to Duns Scotus, and pp. 194–97 in Scotus himself. All the examples in Scotus recorded by Fr. Balić are taken from Euclid, books I–VII. Balić, p. 196, note 23, quotes an amusing remark of Carolus Constantius Rabbi O. S. Aug. (d. 1746): "Commentatores Principum Scholarum oportet esse etiam in mathematicis eruditos. Nos in

gratiam candidatorum theologiae ac praesertim Scotistarum, qui ageometrae sint, argumentum idem paulo fusius et maiori qua poterimus claritate exponemus." The point is precisely to find out whether in Duns Scotus an angel can occupy a place so small that it cannot occupy a still smaller place. Fr. Balić, who considers the *Theoremata* authentic at least in their doctrine, connects them to this tradition with great perceptiveness, "Bemerkungen," pp. 204–17.

38 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 12, vol. II p. 143 [CE VII, pp. 262–63]. Duns Scotus next demonstrates that, if there is a *quantitas virtutis* in an angel proportional to a certain place, the angel can exercise it in an infinitely greater or infinitely smaller place. This amounts to saying that its power is infinite, which is false. If the consequence is false, so is the antecedent.

39 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 13, volume II, p. 144 [CE VII, p. 264]. However, the following article reserves other possibilities. For example, there is the possibility that the angel has a place whose quantity is determinate and proportional to its power. Or even that the angel has a place *adequate* to its essence and power, although by its will, it could occupy a larger or smaller place, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 14, vol. II, p. 144 [CE VII, pp. 264–65]. In any case, since an angel is not *contained* in a place, it does not contradict its nature to be present in several places at the same time, at least by divine power, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 7, number 2, vol. II, p. 148 [CE VII, p. 271], or even that two angels might be simultaneously in the same place, always by divine power, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 8, number 2, vol. II p. 152 [CE VII, p. 276]. See Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 52, article 3, for the opposing view.

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 15, vol. II, p. 145 [CE VII. pp. 265–66].

41 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 6, number 16, vol. II, p. 145 [CE VII, pp. 266–67].

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 2, number 8, vol. II, p. 160 [CE VII, pp. 288–89]. He then cites some theological arguments in his favor, the third of which follows: "Similter credibile est quod frequenter missi sint [*scilicet*, Angeli] sine corpore, sicut de illo misso ad Joseph de conceptu beatae Mariae dubitantem." This angel crossed space composed of an infinity of *ubi*. Therefore, it moved with continuous movement. The reason for this consequence will become apparent. All the arguments that follow suppose that two of Aristotle's definitions are accepted: first, the continuous is that whose two extremes are one; second, the discontinuous (or successive) is that between which there is nothing of the same kind, *Physics*, book VI, chapter 1, 231 a 22–23.

43 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. II, distinction 2, question 9, article 1, number 2, vol. II, p. 155. The response, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, number 34, p. 186 [CE VII, p. 335], will be that it is not contradictory for the nonbeing of heat to precede the being of heat immediately in time. Their coexistence would be contradictory only at the same time.

44 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 1, number 4, vol. II, p. 157 [CE VII, p. 284].

45 Aristotle, *Physics*, book VI, chapter 1, 231 b 18–20. On the impossibility of size being made of indivisibles, see *Physics*, book VI, chapter 1, 231 a 21–29.

46 Aristotle, *Physics*, book VI, chapter 1, 232 a 15–17.

47 Aristotle, *Physics*, book VI, chapter 1, 232 a 18–21.

48 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 9, vol. II, p. 161 [CE VII, pp. 290–92], indicates another "de proportione sesquialtera, quae plus convincit

adversarium." But he does not seem to prefer it. It is found in Aristotle, *Physics*, book VI, chapter 2, 233 b 15–13.

49 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 10, vol. II, pp. 162–63 [CE VII, pp. 292–94]. Numbers 11 and 12, pp. 163–64 [CE VII, pp. 294–95], set out an objection that Scotus refutes, *licet videatur absurda*.

50 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 13, vol. II, pp. 164–66 [CE VII, pp. 296–98]. Number 14, pp. 166–67 [CE VII, pp. 298–300], completes this. Following Werner, C. R. S. Harris, *Duns Scotus*, vol. I, p. 137, notes that Roger Bacon inspires these demonstrations; cf. vol. II, pp. 128–29. See Roger Bacon, *Opus Tertium*, chapter 39, ed. J. S. Brewer, *Opera Omnia*, London, 1850, pp. 132–35,

51 We are dealing with quantity as such, because the quantity of natural bodies, precisely as natural bodies, is not divisible to infinity. The quantity of matter of the human body is not so divisible. In other words, the *natural* is not composed of *mathematical parts* but of natural parts, and it is divided only into the latter. However, this does not limit the scope of our conclusion in any way, because as quantity the natural remains divisible to infinity, as if the quantity that exists under a natural form existed in itself without any natural form. Thus, even the indivisibility of the form itself does not entail the indivisibility of the *quantum*. Of itself, the *quantum* remains continuous, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 18, vol. II, pp. 169–70 [CE VII, pp. 305–06]. Of course, the very concept of divisibility to infinity excludes our dealing with a division in act. When we imagine a quantity as actually divided to the infinite, we imagine we will encounter indivisible *quanta* at the end, but we only find contradiction, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 22, p. 173 [CE VII, pp. 311–13].

52 Another objection taken from the nature of place is that it is neither an act nor a perfection of the angel, whose nature is nobler than the nature of place. To move in a place, an angel would need to be in potency in regard to the place where he is not, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 1, number 1, vol. II, p. 154 [CE VII, pp. 278–79]. The response, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 1, number 9, vol. II, p. 161 [CE VII, p. 290], is that an angel is not all-perfect, and it is possible that a nobler substance should be in potency in regard to a less noble substance, whose perfection the nobler substance does not possess of itself. In any angel, nature is superior to intellection, which, however, the angel has. At a much greater distance from angelic perfection, the same holds for place.

53 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 36, and the beginning of 37, vol. II pp. 189–90 [CE VII, pp. 338–41].

54 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 40, vol. II, pp. 192–93 [CE VII, pp. 344–46]. Duns Scotus is more precise than this analysis lets us see. The environment's resistance to the mobile explains "the divisibility of the parts of the mobile, or the divisibility of the form according to which the mobile takes place or both at the same time. However, the necessity of succession is never due to this resistance, but precisely to the relation of the resistance to the agent whom the mobile resists, because of the resistance the environment offers it." The environment's resistance to the mobile explains the *possibility* of successive movement, and it is because the force of the mover cannot immediately overcome the mobile's resistance (hence by reason of their relation) that this mover can only bring the mobile to its term successively. Let us remember that according to Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 12, number 1, vol. II, p. 214 [CE VII, pp. 384–85], an angel cannot move from one end to the other without passing through the environment because this is how it is for movement. Movement is like time, no part of which flows from the future into the past except through the present. For the opposing view, see Aquinas, *Summa Theolgiae*, part I, question 53,

article 2, body of article.

55 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 9, article 3, number 41, vol. II, p. 193 [CE VII, pp. 346–47]. For the opposing view, see Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 53, article 2. This leaves open the question of finding out whether an angel can move instantaneously. Some say that an angel can move in an instant provided that it is not an instant of continuous time, but discontinuous. *Quaere a Thoma*, Duns Scotus says. In fact, in *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 53, article 3, reply to objection 3, we find that Thomas Aquinas admits that an angel's movement can be continuous or discontinuous. When an angel's movement occurs *in instanti*, it is discontinuous. Duns Scotus judges this distinction unnecessary *quia pluralitas non est ponenda sine necessitate*. To be instantaneous, a movement must be followed immediately by another instantaneous movement. This condition can be fulfilled as well in continuous time as in discontinuous time. Accordingly, ordinary continuous time suffices, and it is not necessary to invent another time to resolve the problem, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 11, number 5, vol. II, pp. 211–12 [CE VII, p. 380].

56 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 10, number 1, vol. II, p. 196 [CE VII, pp. 350–51].

57 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 10, number 2, vol. II, pp. 196–97 [CE VII, pp. 351–52].

58 A body is in potency in regard to its natural place, and it actively moves to occupy it. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 10, number 5, vol. II, p. 199 [CE VII, p. 357]: "Lapis enim movet se in quantum gravis in actu, et movetur in quantum est in potentia inferius." This is the only conceivable cause of its movement. Others have been proposed, for instance what removes an obstacle, but that would be purely passive, number 7, pp. 201–02 [CE VII, pp. 361–62]; or what gives the impulse, but that would be a *movens per accidens*, and a *movens per se* is necessary [CE VII, p. 359]: "Nec istud potest esse centrum trahens," because there is no heavenly body at the center, and if the whole earth were taken away so only the center remained, the heavy would still tend there. It is not the influence of the heavens, which is too general a cause that could be invoked to explain everything, and so forth. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 10, number 7, vol. II, p. 200 [CE VII, pp. 360–61]: "Ergo oportet dare quod sit aliquid intrinsecum ipsi gravi, vel ipsum grave per aliquid intrinsecum." Against the thesis [CE VII, p. 360] according to which "generans manet in virtute in gravi," see number 6, pp. 200–01 [CE VII, pp. 360–61]. Finally, let us note this general specification about the movement of bodies, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 10, number 9, p. 203 [CE VII, p. 364]: "Tamen propter unum verbum Philosophi addo ultra quod motus iste non est universalis in se ex hoc quod habet principium activum in se, sed solum ex hoc quod mobile habet principium intrinsecum passivum naturaliter inclinans ad motum." Cf. Aristotle, *Physics*, book II, chapter 1, 192 b 21–23, and especially 192 b 35–37, where the philosopher says that, for fire, moving upward is not *nature* but according to its nature. *Natural inclination* toward a place consists of that. Take for example, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 2, question 10, number 9, p. 203 [CE VII, p. 365]: "Naturaliter moventur in loco illa quia apta nata sunt ibi esse, id est habent naturalem inclinationem ad illud ubi." This whole doctrine of movement of bodies is inserted into angelology simply because our professor takes the occasion to deal with philosophy of movement in general. In the context of angels, he similarly is going to deal with individuation of matter, a long discussion that we reserve for the next chapter, where the very nature of matter will pose the problem of its individuation.

59 Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 291.

60 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 56, article 1, body of article.

61 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 4, vol. II, p. 289 [CE VII, p. 522].

62 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 54, article 1. Duns Scotus may have thought that, whatever St. Thomas said, in fact his thesis constrained him to maintain that the angel's intellection is its substance. But he would no less be in agreement on the particular position we are discussing: the angel's essence is not the total cause of its intellection. By contrast, Duns Scotus explicitly names Henry of Ghent and quotes his *Quodlibet* V, question 14, to attribute the thesis to him that angels know themselves *per habitum scientialem*. He refutes the doctrine as unworthy of angels, because this *habitus scientialis* would be entirely caused by God, so the angel would not be the cause of his own knowledge, while humans, less perfect than angels, are the cause of theirs, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II distinction 3, question 8, number 6, vol. II, pp. 290–91.

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 4, vol. II, p. 289.

64 Duns Scotus judges that a philosopher would think the contrary: "philosophus concederet quod intellectio angeli est essentia sua sed nos dicimus quod non," because an angel is not God. However, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 16: "Nec valet quod Philosophus hoc non vidit, quia multa non vidit quod oportet theologos concedere." Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 2, vol. II, p. 288 [CE VII, p. 519], in the objections to the thesis in general: "Item, si ita esset, tunc ista intellectio esset eadem vel idem cum angelo vel essentia sua: consequens est falsum, quia hoc proprium est soli Deo, quod sua intellectio sit idem cum essentia sua; ergo et antecedens est falsum." Cf. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 54, article 1, *sed contra*: "Plus differt actio rei a substantia ejus, quam ipsum esse ejus: sed nullius creati suum esse est sua substantia. Hoc enim solius Dei proprium est . . . ergo neque angeli, neque alterius creaturae sua actio est ejus substantia." Once again, two different techniques lead to the same conclusion.

65 This point will motivate an important objection regarding the human soul's knowledge of itself, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, numbers 13–14, vol. II, pp. 297–99 [CE VII, pp. 534–39]. We will meet it again at its place.

66 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 8, vol. II, p. 292 [CE VII, pp. 524–26]. Here we are dealing with immediate knowledge without the intermediary of intelligible species, since these are not required for the knowledge of an *intelligible act* such as the angelic essence, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 10, vol. II, p. 294 [CE VII, pp. 529–30]. Furthermore, it should be noted that Duns Scotus underlines the intellect's partial causality, because he attributes a proper activity to it, whether in regard to the species or if the object is an intelligible in act, even to the object. Finally, the angels can know themselves either intuitively, by their essence presence to their intellect, or *per speciem*, when they know themselves abstractly by means of an intelligible species representing their essence, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 10, number 15, vol. II, p. 327 [CE VII, pp. 590–92].

67 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 12, vol. II, p. 296 [CE VII, pp. 585–87]. Scotus remits to book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 2, numbers 20–21, vol. I, pp. 446–49 [probably CE III, pp. 289–95]. We will return to its problem when we study human intellectual knowledge.

68 For an overview of this problem, see Sebastian J. Day, *Intuitive Cognition: A Key to the Significance of the Later Scholastics* (St. Bonaventure, NY: The Franciscan Institute, 1947). It contains an ample, useful analysis of the texts of Duns Scotus on the problem, pp. 48–139.

69 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 9, number 6, vol. II p. 307 [CE VII, p. 353]: "Et, ut brevibus utar verbis, primam [*scilicet*, cognitionem] voco *abstractivam* quae est

ipsius quidditatis secundum quod abstrahitur ab existentia actuali et non existentia; secundam, scilicet quae est quidditatis rei secundum ejus existentiam actualem, vel quae est rei praesentis secundum talem existentiam, voco *cognitionem intuitivam* non prout intuitiva distinguitur contra discursivam, quia sic aliqua abstractiva est intuitiva, ut cognitio principii, sed simpliciter intuitiva, eo modo quo dicimur intueri rem sicut est in se."

70 Abstraction is to intuition as imagination is to sense. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 9, number 7, vol. II, p. 307 [CE VII, p. 554]: "Sensus enim particularis est objecti secundum quod est per se vel in se existens; phantasia cognoscit idem secundum quod est praesens per speciem; quae species posset esse ejus, licet non esset existens vel praesens . . ."

71 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, article 5, number 42, vol. I, p. 281 [CE II, p. 352]: "Omnis intellectio abstractiva et non intuitiva est aliquo modo imperfecta: cognitio autem intuitiva est objecti ut objectum est praesens in existentia actuali, et hoc in se vel in alio eminenter continente totam entitatem ipsius; ergo quae cognoscuntur intuitive ut objecta formalia distincta, vel unum eminenter continetur in alio, vel utrumque secundum propriam existentiam terminat actum ut est ejus." *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, article 5, number 19, vol. II, pp. 459–60 [CE VIII, pp. 164–65]: "Omne objectum cognoscibile ab inferiori potest esse cognoscibile a superiori aeque perfecte vel perfectius: nulla autem cognitio abstractiva alicujus objecti perfectior est cognitione intuitiva; quia cognitio abstractiva per speciem potest esse de re non existente in se praesentialiter, et ita non perfectissime cognoscitur, nec attingitur."

72 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 9, number 8, vol. II, p. 309 [pp. 556–57]. St. Paul's *raptus* seems to have left him with the memory of a concept of this kind, 2 Cor. 12:3-4. In numbers 9–10, pp. 309–10 [CE VII, pp. 557–60], note the philosophical exegesis of St. Augustine's doctrine on *matutina* and *vespertina* knowledge in *De Genesi ad Litteram*, book IV, chapters 23–24, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XXXIV, columns 312–13.

73 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 9, number 11, vol. II, p. 311 [CE VII, p. 560]. Cf. number 17, p. 315 [CE VII, pp. 567–69].

74 It would not even be the absolutely most perfect concept of God possible, because an *adequate* concept of God would be taken from the divine essence itself, not from a *species* representing this essence, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 9, number 13, p. 312 [CE VII, pp. 562–63]. Between a finite *species* and an infinite object the only conceivable perfection stems from the *proportion of the representative to the represented*, number 13, p. 313 [CE VII, p. 563].

75 Here Duns Scotus opposes the thesis according to which angels know other beings by virtue of a unique *habitus scientalis*. The thesis is presented at *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 10, numbers 3–5, vol. II, pp. 317–19 [CE VII, pp. 571–76], and refuted in numbers 12–13, pp. 324–26 [CE VII, pp. 585–87].

76 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 10, number 8, vol. II, pp. 321–22 [CE VII, pp. 579–81]. What is true of the species and the object is also true of the act of being, because each *ratio cognosciendi* can only have one single cognitive act that is adequate to it, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 10, number 9, vol. II, pp. 322 [CE VII, p. 582].

77 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 1, vol. II, p. 333 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 in not included in CE VII; a similar theme is found pp. 579–81]. Like Duns Scotus, Thomas Aquinas already admits that angels do not know beings by their own substance, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 55, article 1. However, contrary to Duns Scotus, Thomas denies that angels can extract any knowledge from sensibles, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 56, article 2. According to Aquinas, the species by which angels know are connatural to them. Duns Scotus certainly has in mind at least one of St. Thomas's arguments. Cf. *Summa*

Theologiae, part I, question 55, article 2, reply to objection 2, and *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 3, vol. II, p. 335 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 not included in CE VII], "Item convenit . . ." Furthermore, Duns Scotus is amazed that in maintaining this thesis, Thomas Aquinas still grants that angels know singulars, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 57, article 2, because angels have responsibility for singulars, and therefore, they know them (Aquinas, *Sed contra*; Scotus, *Quia angelus* . . .). Aquinas also affirms this, because the superior unites in itself what is dispersed in inferiors (Aquinas, *Et ideo aliter* . . . Scotus, *Item quod continetur* . . .). Another of Aquinas's reasons is that Aristotle denies against Empedocles that God is ignorant of discord (Aquinas, *Unde Aristoteles* . . .; Scotus, *Item III Metaphysica* . . .). Duns Scotus certainly had this article in front of him or an exact analysis of it, when he composed his own text.

78 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 4, vol. II, p. 336 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 is not included in CE VII].

79 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 6, vol. II, pp. 337–38 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 is not included in CE VII]. The critique of the mode of knowledge that certain authors attribute to angels "per effluxum a Deo," number 7, pp. 338–39, is aimed directly at Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 57, article 2, body of article: "Manifestum est autem . . ."

80 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 9, vol. II, p. 340 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 is not included in CE VII]: "Contra istam."

81 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 11, vol. II, p. 342 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 is not included in CE VII]. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, article 3, number 10, vol. II, pp. 451–52 [CE VIII, pp. 148–50].

82 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 12, vol. II, p. 343 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 not included in CE VII]: "cognitionem intutivam rei necessario concurrit objectum reale, vel ipsa res ut praesens." A little further on: "Ergo oportet quod angelus accipiat ipsam a re ipsa singulari, si non habet eam, vel ad hoc quod possit eam habere. Probo quod possit eam habere; quia possible est imperfectiori potentiae; ergo et perfectiori, est enim possibilis potentiae sensitivae." Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, article 5, number 34, vol. II, pp. 474–75 [CE VIII, p. 194]: "Ad ultimam . . ." and number 36, p. 476 [CE VIII, p. 198], where Duns Scotus observes that, in the order of determination to its object, "Intellectus divinus est ad determinatum singulare."

83 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 11, number 12, vol. II, p. 343 [Vivès book II, distinction 3, question 11 is not included in CE VII]. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, article 3, number 11, vol. II, p. 453 [CE VIII, pp. 151–52]: "Praeterea rationes suae." Regarding the way in which one angel speaks to another, " causando in eo conceptum immediate illius objecti de quo loquitur," see *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, article 4, number 15, vol. II, p. 456 [CE VIII, pp. 156–58], and on the way in which an angel speaks even at a distance, see number 16, p. 457 [CE VIII, pp. 158–60]. On the effects produced in an angel to whom another speaks, see number 20, pp. 460–62 [CE VIII, pp. 165–68]. On how one angel can speak to another without speaking to a third angel, see number 24, p. 464 [CE VIII, pp. 173–74].

6

Matter

While commenting upon Peter Lombard, Duns Scotus encounters the problem of the distinction between persons, which supposes that the problem of individuation has been resolved. This question interests Scotus so deeply that, without waiting for the point at which he will have to treat corporeal creatures, he immediately introduces the problem of individual distinction in material substances. Since what he says lends itself to misunderstanding if we do not first specify the nature of matter, we will examine the latter before seeking the cause of its individuation.

A The being of matter

Does matter exist? When he poses this question, Duns Scotus does not simply ask whether there is an element in corporeal beings connected to form, which can be designated by the name *matter*. He wants to know whether a positive reality (*aliqua entitas positiva*) exists in beings subject to generation and corruption that is endowed with its proper being, which is really distinct from the being of form.[1] Duns Scotus will answer affirmatively, because a composite is not worthy of the name if it does not include at least two elements, and matter would not be one of these elements if it did not have positive reality proper to it. However, this is not the opinion of all philosophers, and we must examine their reasons.

Firstly, there are those who do not hold matter to be one of the elements of

particular things, not because matter is nothing, but because it is everything. As we say nowadays, they are materialists. According to this opinion, the only positive reality that can be found in generable and corruptible being is matter. To explain the hierarchy of being, the partisans of this opinion admit that matter progresses from degree to degree in being, but they specify that the term of each progression is always intrinsic to matter, not extrinsic. We can call this term *form*, under the condition that we consider it as intrinsic to matter. In other words, the form thus understood is only matter itself under any one of its proper determinations.[2]

Duns Scotus does not name anyone, and we do not know if he had anyone in mind. But this materialism exhibits at least the spirit of a well-known tradition, that of Alexander of Aphrodisias.[3] Moreover, this thesis is not rejected here precisely for its materialism, but because, by reducing the particular to one single element, we destroy it *qua* particular. The proof of this is that its generation and corruption become inexplicable, because in natural generation, for example, the engendered term must replace a contrary term. This passage from one contrary to another can only occur in a common element, which is not either term or which, being unable to receive these contraries at the same time, receives them successively. This is what is called *matter*. At least two elements are required for generation and corruption to be possible. Furthermore, Duns Scotus points out that they would be made equally inexplicable by reducing this kind of beings to form alone. Between these two positions there is only verbal difference: *differunt opinones istae solum in voce et non in re*.[4]

Accordingly, there is matter. But what reality must be attributed to it? Obviously, we must acknowledge its reality as potency, because matter's role in generation is to be in potency in regard to form. But there are two species of potency, one *objective*, and the other *subjective*. It may be that the same potency is envisaged in these two cases in two different relations, but it may also be that one exists without the other. *Objective* potency is the term that the potency can become, as when we say that marble is a statue *in potency*. *Subjective* potency is the subject itself that is in potency in regard to a term.

In our example, the same thing is both its term in potency and the subject in potency in regard to this term, statue in potency and what can become statue. But we said that one of these potencies could exist without the other, which is the case of the *creatable*. As such, the creatable is only in *objective* potency to the being it can become, not in subjective potency, because before being created, it cannot be a subject, it is nothing.[5]

It will be noted that attributing the role of subject to the potency of matter entails acknowledging its proper reality when it plays this role. In order to be a subject, matter must be something. This is what others dispute. According to them, matter can only be *objective* potency that is to say, since it has not subjective reality in itself, it is the simple possibility of becoming something by virtue of one or several causes.

That is an error, as can be verified by returning to the point of departure of the problem. Let us remember that the intent is to explain that generations and corruptions are possible, which requires that there be at least two terms: matter and form. Moreover, this is the doctrine of Aristotle. If matter has no reality of its own, no *subjective* reality, it is nothing, which is to say that one of the two terms of the generation disappears, and the generation alone with it. There would be no more composed beings. All would be simple. And since we say that the only way that whiteness, for example, can *be in potency* is for it to exist in its cause's active potency, we do not see why all causes would not produce all their possible effects at one stroke. Is not this subjective potency of matter precisely that which limits their efficacy and that whose dispositions are required so that the effect can be produced in it? But if it is nothing real of itself, it cannot play any role, not even that of receiving and channeling the efficacy of causes. So, on the one hand, if matter were nothing subjectively real, every fire, for example, could be produced at the same time, but on the other hand, there would nothing that could burn.

It is worth noting that Duns Scotus is sure here that he interprets Aristotle's thinking exactly: Aristotelian matter is the receptacle of form. If matter were nothing, how could it receive? "And, therefore, situating matter only in objective potency and not subjective potency, he denies the Philosopher's

whole notion about matter."[6]

Here the Scotist position differs not only from the one Thomas Aquinas takes, but also from the majority of those who appealed to Aristotle. Like Duns Scotus, all agree that matter is the subject of substantial transmutation, but few would have admitted that matter was conceivable as being endowed with an entity of its own, separate from form. If we want to take matter in itself, St. Thomas said, it is not *ens aliquid actu existens*, but in potency to being in act.[7] Many others beside St. Thomas said the same thing then, and Duns Scotus does not seem to oppose Thomas personally here, but the thesis itself. Let us add that once more his doctrine connects with the Augustinian tradition on this point, and that Duns Scotus knows it because he quotes the famous passage from *Confessions* XII, 7: "You made two things, Lord, one near to you and the other near nothing." *Duo fecisti, Domine; unum prope te et aliud prope nihil*.[8] It is still necessary to be something in order to be near nothing.

Moreover, the argument is not primarily based on Augustine, but on Aristotle.[9] The philosopher attributes to matter functions that are too numerous and important for it to be possible to attribute them to nothing. Matter is intrinsically a principle of nature.[10] Intrinsically, it is one of the causes.[11] Intrinsically, it is the subject of substantial mutations,[12] and if we want to add Augustine to Aristotle, matter is the term of a creative act as we have just seen. Consequently, it is impossible that matter should be nothing more than *objective* potency. It must be in *subjective* potency, that is, it must be a subject.[13] Must we say, "a subjective potency existing in act," or "an act"? That is not important, provided that we posit it as endowed with its proper reality and existence, in the sense in which we understand that which is outside its cause as being in act or being an act. We cannot avoid doing so because, since matter is one of the causes of being, it certainly must be a being itself, unless we want being to have nothing as a cause, which is impossible.[14]

Those are absolute certainties in Duns Scotus's view. What can be engendered cannot be simple. That would be absurd. Therefore it is

composed of matter and form, but, if matter is nothing, the engenderable is composed of nothing and something, which is no less absurd. From this comes the conclusion: “Matter has a certain positive reality (*entitatem*) outside the intellect and outside of its cause. It is in virtue of this reality that matter can receive the substantial forms that are unqualifiedly acts.”[15]

Here we draw out a principle of explanation that can help us understand Duns Scotus. Substantial forms, he says, are *actus simpliciter*. On the other hand, since matter is something (*aliquid*), it is also an act. Accordingly, it must be being in a restricted sense. Indeed, of all beings it is that whose actuality is least and, consequently, that whose potency is greatest. It certainly must be that. Since matter is the receptacle of all substantial and even accidental forms, it is eminently in potency in regard to them. We would not be unfaithful to Duns Scotus’s thinking by saying that for him matter is the being whose act consists of being in potency in regard to all acts. On the other hand, its potentiality does not consist of being nothing, but of not possessing any specific determination of itself. It has no act that distinguishes it, that separates it, that it receives, or that informs it by conferring its specific being as matter upon it. “So what is it?” we will say. If we could define it, it would not be matter, but form. What is certain is that the receptive subject of the form’s act and therefore one of the causes of the composite cannot be nothing, because nothing can receive nothing.[16]

There are classic objections against this position. First, if the subject of the generation is act, there can no longer be authentic generating, but simple alteration. Everything that comes to a being in act is an accident for it. Therefore, if matter is being in act or possesses actual entity that distinguishes it from the form, everything that befalls it will constitute a unity by accident with it. Accordingly, as we were saying, there will be alteration rather than substantial change. Next, it is impossible to make something per se from two beings in act. Therefore, if matter is in act, it cannot form an intrinsic unity by being united with the form and a per se *unum* will never result from their composition.

Duns Scotus is not unaware of these difficulties, but what weight do they

have against the necessities that we have already observed? Let us remember that the issue is to explain how generations and corruptions are possible. It is a fact that there are generations and corruptions. Accordingly, we ought to be able to explain them. Once we pose the problem, we inevitably will enter into the same circle of hypotheses and answers. If the generable thing is simple *qua* form, it will be incapable of being engendered or corrupted. If it is composed of a form in act and matter lacking any actuality, that amount to saying it is composed of something and nothing, which does not make sense. In this way, we come back to the same conclusion. Every generable being must necessarily be composed of *something* and *something*, consequently of matter and form.

It will be objected that we cannot obtain something intrinsically one, an *unum* per se from the union of two acts, but the difficulty is not insurmountable. If we admit that a thing can be substantially one while being composed, nothing prevents us from admitting that it is composed of really distinct actual entities. It is even necessary because, if the elements were not distinct beings, in what sense would they be composed. It is true that some will want to deny that it is an *unum* per se, but by what right? In common being unity is the same thing as being, or in any case, being's immediate property. In other words, each being has its proper unity and possesses it fully. This is immediate evidence. It is not demonstrated, because *being* and *one* are transcendentals. Consequently, they have no definitions starting from which we might demonstrate one or the other. In any case, if *one* is a mediate property of *being*, that by which one is inherent in being is unknown to us. But what is true of common being, *ens commune*, is also true of the determined being of a species. Whether or not it is composed of really distinct elements, once it exists *qua* composed, it has its proper unity. That is our reply. To the question, "Why is this composite one by itself?" the only answer is, "Because it has such and such a form by which it is a being by itself and therefore also one by itself." No other reason is to be given for a composite. That which is being intrinsically can be simple or composed. That which, by itself possesses this immediate property of unity, can also be either

simple or composite.[17]

The heart of the position has not shifted. Duns Scotus understands the objection made against him. He knows the difference between a substantial form and an accidental form and, therefore, between something intrinsically one that causes the former and something one by accident that causes the latter. But he holds that the objection is irrelevant. If form and matter compose an *unum* per se, according to Aristotle that is because the nature of matter is to be totally receptive and the nature of the act consists essentially in informing matter. Here act and potency, form and matter, are intrinsic causes of the composite. It could not exist without each of them. A human, for example, would not be human without his soul and without the matter of his body. But he can be human without being white. Therefore, a human is not in potency in regard to whiteness intrinsically, by reason of the substance that he is, and this is why *human* and *whiteness* only for a unity by accident.[18] Accordingly, the actuality of material potency is not what can prevent it from composing an *unum* per se with the form. On the contrary, it is because material potency is pure receptiveness that it can compose something one out of them, and if it were nothing composing with nothing, it would not compose anything at all.

After that point, the discussion can continue, but it is verbal. For example, if we define act by opposition to what receives the act, it is clear that matter cannot be act, since by definition it is receptive of the act in some way. But this is a quarrel about words. Again, if we object that there can no longer be generation but only alteration, we reason as if we were saying that matter is such by reason of some form that specifies it as matter. That is what the Ancients did, whom Aristotle reproached for having transformed all generations into alterations. He was right against them, but it would be wrong to say that against us, because we do not say that matter is actualized and distinguished from everything else by a proper substantial form. On the contrary, we say that what is proper to matter is to be that which is essentially bereft of form and, with those forms that it receives, composes substances whose birth is generation.

So, Duns Scotus moves in a universe where each thing has the entity that is suited to its kind of being. Since beings can be simple or composed, unity can be simple or composed. What is intrinsically being is intrinsically one. A being by accident is one by accident. A being that is only an aggregate or a pile has the unity of an aggregate or pile. There are even things that have no other unit than that of an order. Therefore, they are a *unity* or *order* insofar as they are ordered to a term that is one itself.[19] In this same universe, it remains true to say with Aristotle that potency and act divide all being, but that does not mean that everything is *either* potency *or* act. On the contrary, that means there is nothing in particular that is not in one sense potency and in another act. How could something be without being in act? If matter is, which nobody doubts, it is the proper actuality of possibility in regard to the form.[20]

Matter and form are radically distinct: *sunt omnino alterius rationis et primo diversa*. This opposition in no way contradicts the proposition that grants actual being to matter, because Duns Scotus wants to disassociate the two concepts of *act* and *form*. He does so, not as St. Thomas did in order to extend the concept of act of the form to the act of existing, but in order to extend it from the form to real being, whatever it might be. Form remains act in Scotism as it was in Thomism, but everything that is being is actual, even if it is not form. Duns Scotus invites us to conceive to distinct entities, that of materiality and that of formality, such that nothing that appears in one belongs to the other. Obviously both are being, but materiality as such contains no trace of formality, and inversely. Their entities are mutually exclusive, as the being of that which is only determinable and the being of that which is only determinant. In order for them to be radically distinguished, and for the essential determination of one to distinguish the essential determination of the other, both must be actual being: one the being of what is purely determinable, the other the being of what is pure determinant. But, since the more two things are formally distinct, the more they are apt to be united and to constitute a unity by itself; we can say that the radical distinction of these two real elements, very far from setting them in conflict, grounds the possibility of their union.[21] Not the similarity of their

natures, but the suitability of their relation, is the basis of their aptitude to be united, and such suitability may be present between immediately diverse elements. We should conclude with Duns Scotus, “Therefore, I say that there is a contradiction for me in matter being the term of creation and part of composite without having a particular being, while it is a particular essence. Indeed, that a particular should be outside its cause without having some being by which it is essence, is a contradiction for me.”[22]

Two remarkable consequences follow from this conclusion: in Duns Scotus’s doctrine, matter is separately knowable, and matter can exist separately.

Matter is knowable separately because it possesses by itself a being distinct from the form’s being. It will be objected that, according to Aristotle, matter is only knowable in relation to the form. But Aristotle is made to say that; it is not what he actually says. In this passage, Aristotle gives us to understand that, however known or knowable matter and subject are in themselves and by themselves, they nonetheless are knowable in relation to the form.[23] Up to book V of the *Physics*, Aristotle speaks of movement in general, and what he says of matter as subject holds for alteration and generation. It is true that in all these cases, matter is not knowable by itself. It is knowable only as a subject of the change that we observe. But that does not prove that it is not knowable of itself. Indeed it is knowable, although it is not knowable by us.

Of itself, matter is knowable because it is a distinct absolute entity and because every entity of this kind is knowable in itself. However we understand the nature of the Idea—whether as object of the divine understanding (Duns Scotus), or as possible participation of the divine essence (Thomas Aquinas)—matter has its idea in God. On the other hand, it is not knowable separately, but this is not at all surprising, because form is more knowable than matter and yet we only know it by its operation. The same holds concerning matter, all the less knowable by us in that it is further away from the senses. We know it by transmutations, where, since we see a new operation appear, we conclude that there is a new form and that consequently matter subsists as the common subject of this transmutation.

Consequently, it is right to say that we know matter in its relation to form, but it is wrong to conclude that it may not be knowable in itself in another matter.[24]

Duns Scotus's allusions to a divine idea of matter along with his repeated affirmation that matter is one of the terms of the creative act lead to this last conclusion that nothing in the nature of matter is opposed to what exists separately.

To tell the truth, no new argument is necessary here, and each of those we have already seen can serve. Since there are two actual and really distinct entities in the composite (otherwise it would not be a composite), there is no contradiction in one of them being able to exist without the other. That is the case here, and it is all the clearer in that one of the two elements, matter, is in some way prior to the other, if not in time at least by nature. We see that matter receives the form, but what receives is the foundation, as it were, of what it receives, and we can say that its being is at the origin of the other. Moreover, St. Augustine's authority confirms this when he says that, although God created matter with form and at the same time, creation first attains matter by reason of its natural priority of origin.[25] From there, the conclusion follows: "A distinct absolute prior to another absolute can exist without it. Now, matter is a distinct absolute being, prior to any form, whether substantial or accidental. Therefore it can exist without the absolute other."[26] Consequently, there is no reason intrinsic to the nature of matter for it not to be able to exist separately.

Nor is there any reason why God cannot create matter separately, but from this point on, we return to a concept of creative act that implies God's absolute omnipotence in the sense in which Catholics understand it. For example, it will be said that everything God can produce mediately and through a second cause, he can produce immediately and without the second cause, provided only that the second cause is not included in the effects' essence. This is the case here. The form is a second cause that does not belong to matter's essence as such, the essence by means of which God gives existence to matter. Therefore, God can give existence directly to matter's

essence without creating the form at the same times.[27] To that, let us add that God immediately conserves what he immediately creates. Prime matter, precisely because it is first, falls immediately under the impact of creative action. If this is the case, matter is immediately conserved in being by God, which means that it is directly conserved in itself, not through some other thing without which it could not exist. Consequently, as such matter receives and possesses its being separately, so to speak, which supposes that it could be conserved in existence separately and with nothing except what belongs to its essence. Accordingly, God could cause it without causing anything else if he so willed.[28] Finally, and perhaps above all, God is free in regard to everything that is not his essence. Here, we return to the great principle. For God to have to necessarily will the form in order to will the matter, there would have to be a necessary connection between matter and form. There is no such connection. If there were one, matter would not only be determined by a form in general but a specifically defined particular form and even particular individual *haecceitas* within the species. The reason is clear: to say that matter demands the form in general without the genus being determined to the species and individual is to admit that matter can do without the form. If we prefer, let us say inversely that to posit matter without necessary determination to any particular form would be to posit it without necessary connection to any form in general. It is clear that, being in potency to every form, matter does not require any form in particular. Therefore, there is no necessary link between matter and form, so much so that God who is supremely free in regard to the contingent could create matter without creating form. He could create it in the universe, where it would be somewhere. He could create it outside the universe, and since it would be outside any locality that would define its place, it would not be anywhere. But that would not prevent it from existing.[29]

According to Duns Scotus, matter is the following: a being caused by God and produced by God with the degree of entity it possesses in divine thought, lower than the form's entity but higher than the accident's entity, since this being is part of the substance.[30] In short, it is the lowest being, but still a

being. Moreover, we should not forget about what kind being we speak. It is univocal being, that common nature that is offered to thought as one and the same, conceived in God precisely as being and in matter taken simply insofar as it is. Substance has its share of being and so does accident, but what is part of substance has more being than accident.[31]

B Matter and individuation

The actuality of matter entails a general consequence whose importance is obvious. Since matter in principle can exist separate from any form, matter must be endowed with its proper individuality. Matter cannot be the principle of individuation of matter. Therefore, matter is not the principle of individuation. The sequence of ideas seems necessary, but the problem's importance is so great in Duns Scotus's mind that he subjects it to detailed discussion—one of the most detailed discussions in any part of Scotus's doctrine. Furthermore, after having said why matter could not play this role. Scotus will have to say what the principle of individuation is.

a Is matter naturally individual?

The simplest solution to the problem of individuation is to admit that material substances are singular and fully individual. That solution was proposed.[32] Just as nature is nature formally and of itself, likewise it is singular of itself, *ex se*. From this point of view, no cause of the nature's singularity is to be sought outside the nature, as if there could be nature either in time or in the order of origin before being singular, and as if it had to be contracted by a principle coming from outside in order to be reduced to singularity.

For those who see things in this way (and passages supporting this thesis are not lacking in Aristotle), there are only two states of the real: universality and singularity. Universality does not belong to the thing as it is in itself, but only insofar as it is in the soul that knows it. Inversely, singularity does not belong to the thing as known but as it is in itself. Accordingly, there is reason to seek for what makes a thing able to become universal and to say that this cause is the intellect, but there is no reason to seek for the cause that a nature

is singular, as if we could find one in order to connect the nature to its singularity. In short, a being is singular in the same way that it is one, that is, by the mere fact that it is.[33]

Duns Scotus does not admit this solution, first because if things are singular by virtue of their very nature, our intellect conceives them in a way contrary to their nature, when it knows them as universal. How could an object which is singular of itself be apprehended as universal by the intellect?

But that is only the first skirmish, and the real Scotist argument is elsewhere, because the thesis in question supposes a very different universal from that of Duns Scotus: a universal where there is no room for anything between the universal and the singular. This, indeed, is the basis of the thesis: if material being is not a universal, it can only be a singular. By contrast, Duns Scotus thinks that between the singular's real unity, which is numerical unity, and the pure universal, there is room for unity that is less than numerical unity but still real. If that is true, the thesis in question collapses, because the fact that a material being is not a universal does not imply ipso facto that it is a singular. Without being universal or singular, such a being can be in an intermediate state where a principle of individuation is required to make it singular.

The heart of the problem is to find out whether realities exist that are endowed with a unity less than the singular's numerical unity. Duns Scotus has no doubt of this and proposes to prove it in five or six ways, *quinque vel sex viis*. In fact, he will offer seven proofs among which we will permit ourselves to choose those that are less purely dialectical and that throw the strongest light on the Scotist concept of the singular.

Let us begin with the second proof. Why can we situate two beings in the same species? Because these two individuals are of the same nature, which supposes that there is *una natura*. Consequently, there is a unity proper to the nature of the species. Perhaps it will be said that it is the unity of a being of reason, that is to say, of the concept of its species. But that is not true, because, the concept of the genus is no less one in the intellect than the concept of the species. By virtue of this entity we can even predicate a single

genus of a plurality of species because, if a concept of genus were necessary for each concept of species, there would be no genera and we could only predicate each species of itself. Therefore, we cannot compare this conceptual unity of genus, common to its species, with the real unity of the species, common to individuals. Duns Scotus is certain that this is Aristotle's intention on this point. The Philosopher conceives the nature of species as one by the unity of the specific nature. This unity cannot be the individual's numerical unity, because we do not compare two numerical unities as such, although they are comparable from the point of view of the unity of the species. Nor can this unity be the universal's abstract unity, because we have just said that the species' unity as universal does not differ at all from the genus's unity. Accordingly, the species or its nature certainly has real unity, although less strict unity than the singular's numerical unity.[34]

The third proof presented by Duns Scotus appeals to this principle posed by Aristotle: relations of identity, resemblance, and equality are based on unity. Unless these relations are purely verbal, this thing can only be identical, similar, or equal in relation to a common term that possesses unity. For a relation to be real, it must have a real basis that is endowed with real unity. The unity of this basis cannot be numerical because a single thing cannot be similar to itself or equal to itself. Therefore, this unity must be at the same time real and less than numerical, which was what had to be demonstrated.[35]

Duns Scotus's fifth argument is drawn from sense objects and, for this reason, indirectly involves noetics. Each action of the same sense possesses an object that is one, whose unity is real entity. This unity cannot be numerical. Therefore, it must be a real unity different from numerical unity. Why cannot the unity of sense objects be numerical? Because the faculty of sensing perceives its object as a whole as distinct from anything other than itself, but nothing more. In other words, each sense knows the sensible quality as endowed with a certain unity and thereby distinguishes it from all duality that is not included in the same unity. To express ourselves more specifically, sight knows that it sees *white*, and it perceives *the white* as other that the green or the red, but it does not perceive it as *a white* individual

distinct from another white individual. Or again, no sense perceives a particular ray of sunshine as numerically different from another particular ray, although they are two different effects of the sun. Accordingly, if divine power created two bodies of identical dimensions and perfectly alike in everything, notably in whiteness, sight would not distinguish two whites there, but it would certainly distinguish clearly the unity of the class *white* from the class of all the other kinds of colors. Accordingly, the unity of a class of sensibles is not numerical, but it is still real.[36]

Perhaps the seventh argument is simplest and the most direct of all, without thereby ceasing to be typically Scotist, because it is based on the pure and simple acknowledgment of the reality of species. Even if no intellect existed, fire would still cause fire. Consequently, there would still be a certain real unity of the generative cause and of what this cause engenders: namely, a unity of form that would make this generation be univocal. But the fact that there are intellects changes nothing. The knowledge that our intellect achieves of a generation is not what makes the generation univocal. The intellect knows the generation is univocal because it is.[37] We should conclude, therefore, that material substance of itself is not individual (*substantia materialis ex natura sua non est de se haec*), but that, apart from any operation of the intellect, there exists a lesser unity than the numerical unity of the singular. This is the unity of nature taken in itself, and if we consider it according to this unity that is proper to it *qua* nature, it is indifferent to the unity of the singular. In a word, nature does not possess singularity of itself.[38]

Thus Avicenna's *natura* dominates this position like so many others, and we are not dealing with a hypothesis here, because Duns Scotus immediately cites the text of the Arab philosopher's *Metaphysics*, "where he holds that equinity is only equinity," *ubi vult quod equinitas sit tantum equinitas*. We know that, but Duns Scotus only rises to its commanding position in order to get another overview. Let us yield him the floor without commentary, and he will show us with perfect clarity the entrance to the great avenues that lead from there to his doctrine of being, to the distinction of metaphysics as

science of being from logic whose object is the concept, and lastly to the nature of the metaphysical real whose indifference to either singularity or universality requires the complementary termination of a principle of individuation in order to become a possible existent. For, even the individual essence does not yet exist, since it is necessary that its cause place it in being. But, in the formal line, individuation completes the metaphysical structure required for the singular essence (the only one that is susceptible of actual existence) to be able to exist effectively.

> Nothing is such by virtue of just any real unity, which this unity itself taken precisely in itself puts into proximate potency to be predicated of some subject or other. We have in mind a predication that says of any subject whatever, "This subject is that" [Hoc est hoc]. Indeed, although it is not contradictory to anything that really exists to be in another singularity than that in which it is, we cannot truthfully say of just any inferior that it is the being in question. That can be said of this being only insofar as it becomes an indifferent object by the act of this intellect that apprehends it. On this account, it possesses the numerical unity of an object in the intellect, which lets it be predicated of any singular and to say, "This subject is that."
>
> This way we see how false it is to say that it is the intellect that causes universality in things by stripping from them the quiddity that is found in the phantasm. When we consider this being before it has being as object in the possible intellect, either in reality or in the phantasm, and when its existence is observed or deduced by reason, since it is completely understood that even outside any action of the intellect it does not contradict its nature to exist in another, the quiddity, *quod quid*, is not yet in proximate potency to be predicated of some subject or other—except, we repeat, *qua* object of the possible intellect. Accordingly, in the thing, there is a common element which of itself is not *this* and to which *failing to be this* is not contradictory. Such a common element is not universal in act, because it still lacks what can make it a universal as such, that is to say, what confers a sort of identity on it that renders it predicable of some individual or other and allows it to be said of this individual that it is this.[39]

This is the verdict, but let us return to the considerations that motivate it.

How should we understand Avicenna's statement that nature of itself is neither one nor several, neither universal nor particular? That, of course, is the heart of the matter.

> It must be understood in the sense that nature of itself is not one with numerical identity, nor is it several with plurality opposed to that unity. It is not universal in act in the manner in which something is rendered universal by the intellect. Nor is it particular of itself because, although it never really exists without one or the other of these things, of itself it is none of them, but it is naturally prior to all. In this state of natural priority, nature is that which something is, *quod quid est*, a distinct object for the intellect and precisely as such even the metaphysician's object of consideration—in a word, that which the definitions expresses. Propositions intrinsically and of the first mode are true by reason of the quiddity thus understood, because we can say nothing of a quiddity intrinsically and in the first mode that is not essentially included *qua* abstracted from all these determinations that are naturally posterior to it. Not only is it indifferent of itself to the nature to exist in the intellect or in a particular being, and therefore that it is universal or singular, but even if we take the nature as it exists in the intellect, it does not possess universality of itself and immediately. Clearly, universality belongs to it at that point by virtue of our manner of conceiving it, but the universality is not part of its first concept because of that; it is not part of the concept that the metaphysician forms of it, but the logician. The logician considers the second intentions applied to the first, as Avicenna himself says. Intellection is concerned, first of all, with the nature independently of all its modes, the mode it has in the intellect or the mode it has outside the intellect, because universality is not a mode of the known thing here, but of the knowledge that we have of it.
>
> Since the nature, taken in this being that is its own, is not universal of itself, but receives the universality that is added to it immediately when it becomes object of the intellect, likewise, this nature taken in the external reality where it possesses singularity is not determined to singularity of itself, but it is naturally prior to what restricts it to this singularity. And, insofar as it is naturally prior to this restrictive element, it is not contradictory for it to be without it. Accordingly, just as *qua* object of the intellect, the nature possesses genuine intelligible being with the entity and

> universality of such an object, so also, *qua* material reality outside the soul the nature possesses the genuine real being that corresponds to a reality of this kind (*secundum illam entitatem—in rerum natura—habet verum esse extra animam reale*). Consequently, it possesses unity of the same reality as that of this being, in other words, unity indifferent to singularity, so that being posited with some unity of singularity does not contradict this unity of nature.[40]

The doctrine of common nature is therefore like a turntable from which we can orient ourselves in all directions. From the point of view of the doctrine's noetic, it leads us to deny that the intellect is what causes universality in things: first, because universal is never in things, next because the universal that is in the intellect at least presupposes the real community of *quod quid est*.[41] From the point of view of metaphysics of being, the indifference of nature entails the consequence that the nature, determinable to universality in the understanding, just as to singularity in external reality, is of itself neither universal nor singular. Thereby, the thesis is excluded according to which the material substance would be individual by rights. By contrast, in God, what we call common, *commune* (for example the essence), is fully singular and individual.

b Is matter individuated by a positive intrinsic constituent?

It follows from what has been said that "by positing commonality in the nature itself taken with the entity and unity that corresponds to it, we must necessarily seek a cause of singularity that adds something to the nature of the singular being."[42] The conclusion is now inevitable, but it must be protected against certain objections, because it is not accepted by all.

The point is exactly to discover what there is in this stone right here that immediately grounds the impossibility of dividing it into several stones, each of which would be identical to it. In other words, I can divide a stone into several stones, but none of them would be *the same stone* as the one I have divided; and we are asking what it is in the stone that grounds the impossibility.[43] Some authors thought they could solve the problem of

individuation not by attributing a positive cause to it, but with the help of a simple negation or at most of a privation. What is it to say of a being that it is an *in-dividual*, but that it is not identical? Now being and one are inseparable, so that to be and to be one are the same thing. Accordingly, we might have to search for what causes a being to be divided, but the reason why it is not divided is simply that it is a being. A being is singular for the simple reason that insofar as it is, its substance does not admit division.[44]

Duns Scotus thinks that the response is inadequate, because a simple absence of division would perhaps suffice to make it understood that a being is not divided, but not that it is indivisible. What is at stake is the formal incompatibility of the individual with division into other individuals that possess the same individuality as that first individual. A simple absence or a simple lack of something cannot account for a property as positive as this one. Since we pose the question in regard to physical substances, let us ask in what condition it would be indivisible. It would be indivisible if it had not quantity, because it is divisible *qua* quantified. Still, even in that case, the corporeal substance of itself is not incompatible with division, because it would be incompatible with it to receive the quantity by which it is divisible.[45] The same goes in the hypothesis of indivision by the simple absence of division because, if we grant that of itself the nature is neither one nor individual, its formal incompatibility with division remains to be explained, which is our real problem. Moreover another observation will make this understood better. A well-known thesis of Aristotle at the beginning of the *Categories* holds that the paradigmatic substance is not the second intention, which only exists in thought, but the first substance, which exists in reality. The first substance is individual. We must immediately see what we commit ourselves to by explaining and including a simple negation. Simply put, we would explain by a negation that which is most possible and most perfect in being,[46] which is absurd.

Thus, the defect of this thesis is to confuse what is simply undivided with what is genuinely indivisible. Let us admit, if it is desired, that there is one or even two negations in the individual being. The real problem would remain

untouched, because we would still have to ask why these insufficiencies, privations, or negations are constitutive of the individual as such. What is there in the individual that requires them? We cannot be satisfied with answering by pointing to the negation itself, because *not being* something does not explain what it is. For example, it is not enough to say that of himself Socrates is not divided either in his matter or in his form, in order to explain that he is this very individual who is Socrates. At a minimum, we might be satisfied with that to explain that he is *an* individual, but not to make it comprehensible that he is *this* individual that in fact he is. Is Socrates individual in his matter and in his form? Obviously, but the same absences of division are found in Plato: in what way do they explain that Socrates is Socrates and Plato is Plato?[47]

We come back, therefore, to our first conclusion: it is an intrinsic element in this particular stone, and not just intrinsic but *positive*, that is the proper reason of its indivisibility into subjective parts, that is parts each of which would be the same subject that it is. If we agree to call the indivisibility or incompatibility with divisibility *individuation*, we will say this positive, intrinsic element in being of itself is the *cause of individuation*.[48] But we still have to ask what it is.

c Individuation by existence

Aristotle encumbered the freedom of thought of medieval philosophers and theologians less than is claimed, because each of them found in Aristotle what he thought himself and not always arbitrarily. This is the case here. If, as we can read in the *Categories*, the individual alone is fully real, we can infer that either every real substance is fully singular or that it is fully individual. If these two explanations are not satisfactory, there remains a third to try: since the singular is what exists in the highest degree, why is existence not the cause of its individuation?[49]

We do not know what doctrine Duns Scotus envisages here or even if he envisages some particular doctrine. In any case, it is not the doctrine commonly attributed to Thomas Aquinas, and there is no reason to think that

Scotus had Aquinas's doctrine in mind. Let us merely note as a fact that Duns Scotus bases the hypothesis of individuation by existence on principles that Thomas Aquinas would not have repudiated, although he evidently would have disavowed the consequence that Scotus wants to get out of them. According to Aristotle, the act is what determines and distinguishes.[50] Starting from there, we can infer that the last distinction must result from the last act. The last act is that act that individuals receive from *esse* of existence, *esse existentiae*, because everything else is in potency in regard to it. Accordingly, it is certainly the being of existence that causes individuation.

As seductive as this thesis is, Duns Scotus makes short work of it. If we start with him from a common univocal concept of being, we do not see how or in what sense it could become a cause of distinction. What is neither distinct nor determined of itself cannot be the first determinant of something else, that is to say, the immediate cause that distinguishes this thing from everything else. The objection strikes the adversary all the more precisely in that, by distinguishing the being of existence from the being of essence, the adversary seeks the cause of individuation only in the first being. Existence intrinsically, however, entails neither distinction nor determination. We only distinguish existences through essences, as may be easily confirmed by recurring to the tree of Porphyry. There we have a systematic coordination of essences from the essence of the individual up to that of the highest genus passing through a succession of species and intermediate genera that are increasingly universal. But we cannot construct a corresponding tree of existents along with this representation. We repeat unceasingly about all that is, in whatever degree it is, that it is. Consequently, there is no coordination of existences other than that of essences. This amounts to saying that the essences are what determine the existences and consequently, existence cannot serve to determine anything.[51] Beyond the interest of the discussion of the problem of individuation, this remark, which Duns Scotus makes several times, expresses with arresting clarity the primacy he grants essence in the structure of being. The hierarchical coordination of forms stems from what is most actual in reality.

This observation is not tangential to the problem, since Duns Scotus seizes the opportunity it offers him to clarify an important point in his metaphysics of being. It might be objected that Scotus's argument holds for the entire coordination of essences with the exception of the essence of the singular, which, by escaping from the order of genera and species, is not included in this coordination. Therefore, the fact that there is no hierarchy of the being of existence corresponding to the hierarchy of essences would not prove that existence is not the cause of individuation for the individual.

Duns Scotus's response is extremely important for the interpretation of his thinking because, although we immediately understand that he responds this way, we see nothing that makes him do so. After all, the importance he attaches to the individuality of being might have summoned him to make an exception in its favor and to extract the individual from the coordination of essence. There would have been no inconsistency on his part in doing so. But he does not. Even this individual, who we will see transcends the form in a sense, is still included in the universal coordination of forms. In Scotus's eyes this coordination embraces everything that stems from the essence from the most universal genus in this order, passing through the intermediate genera and differences down to what is lowest. We should carefully note that this *infimum* is the singular with no actual existence: *singulare absque omni existentia actuali*. So, even the singular, completely individualized essence does not of itself involve existence. In other words, "*this human being* does not formally include actual existence any more than *human being*," *hic homo non plus includit formaliter existentiam actualem quam homo*.[52] At no instant, even when the coordination of essences reaches the individual, does it imply existence. The singular's integrally individuated essence, which is Socrates, leaves actual existence outside its concept.

We know beforehand that the cause of individuation is situated somewhere in the line of essences and that it will be included in their coordination. Invoking existence to resolve the problem would be useless, because, just as we ask what determines the essence to be this particular essence, we would have to ask what determines existence to be this particular existence. It is

necessary to come back to essences, where the individual distinction is presented as the ultimate distinction within the totality of the system that the essences form. Here is the final stroke by the metaphysician of essences:

> Evidently, actual existence is an ultimate act, *but posterior to the whole coordination of categories*. Therefore, I grant that existence distinguishes in the last analysis, but with a distinction that is external to the coordination of the categories by itself. Therefore, it is an accidental distinction in some manner, although it is not truly accidental. But it follows the total distinction according to quidditative being. Therefore, it distinguishes in the manner in which it is the act, and where it is the final act, it distinguishes in the last instance.[53]

We should understand the meaning of this phrase itself: even when existence is the last act, it is not existence that individuates the nature, because the nature must be individuated by an intrinsic positive determination for the existence to make an actually existing singular of it.

d Individuation by quantity

Won't quantity be this positive, intrinsic determination of the material substance? That is said, and reasons are offered.[54] The clearest reason is drawn from the very nature of quantity whose peculiarity according to Aristotle[55] is to be divisible in parts of the same nature although being divisible in this way always pertains to a being by reason of its quantity. Accordingly, individuals are distinguished from each other by quantity, which amounts to saying that quantity is the principle of individuation. To that we can add that a fire only differs from another fire because the form of one is not the form of the other. But a form only differs from another form because they are received in different parts of matter. Now, a part of matter only differs from another because they are found under different parts of quantity. All the distinction that there is between two fires is thus reduced to quantity as the first basis of this distinction.[56]

In Duns Scotus's mind, explaining individuation by quantity comes down to basing it on an accident.[57] But no accident can be the cause of

individuation of a material substance, that is to say, the reason that makes an individual the singular being that it is. That is what we are seeking and not the cause of singularity in general.[58] But in Aristotle, it is a principle that substance is naturally prior to every accident.[59] Moreover, he understands this principle as valid for the totality of beings, because when we want to distinguish them, we must first determine their substance to which we then attribute their accidents. But if the latter are only intelligible as *accidents of the substance*, the substance is naturally prior to every accident. Consequently, it pertains to real substances to be singular by virtue of their proper natures before being determined by any accident.[60]

There is a precise and deep sense to this dialectic. It means that the Scotist principle of individuation will be directly attached to the substance itself and will not be the result of a jumble of accidental determinations like height, skin color, shape of nose, and other identifying traits of this kind. An individual's description is not what makes him; it is the principle of individuation of a being that explains the detail of its description. Therefore, in Scotism, individuation is inscribed in the heart of being, in the very substance by which it is what it is.

At bottom, the real reason why Duns Scotus judges the thesis of individuation by matter to be false is the certitude that his own solution to the problem is the genuine one. Each time he thinks about it, the coordinated series of structural elements of beings is presented first of all to his mind: genus, species, and individual. This series is complete and self-sufficient, and we should not introduce another series to explain one of the terms of that first series. No one ever thought that a species fits into its genus in virtue of another genus, and what would be the sense of a species that was not predicated of any individual? We must never lose sight of that. In the line of substance, universal being or singular being is explained exclusively by the place it occupies. Take *nature* for example: since *being common* belongs to its essence, if nature is found there, we can be certain to find it there with the common being that belongs to it. Nature can only be *common* or nothing at all. To return to the example of Socrates, we admit unreservedly that his

substance is in potency in regard to whiteness or to the form of his nose, but first there must be a Socrates for this skin and shape of nose to belong to Socrates. It is fine to accumulate accidents of this kind. They do not change the substance at all. Socrates will not be any more determinately in the genus substance than before, for he already was *this, quia prius erat hic*.[61] When accidents determine the singular substance, they arrive too late to individuate it.

A strange illusion is found at the origin of all these errors: it is believed that quantity can individuate because it is divisible. This would be true if only quantity were individual of itself: *formaliter de se haec*. It is not. Of itself, quantity is no more individual than substance is inherently individual. Since quantity has no proper singularity of itself, we cannot expect it to give the substance what it lacks itself. If this quantity is undetermined, it cannot determine anything. If this quantity is determined, it is not what determines the substance; rather it is the substance that determines it. A human body has certain dimensions only because it is a human's body, not inversely. Furthermore, quantity is a form like others, that is the quiddity of quantity. We are in a circle. The same goes for the quantity's figure. The nature of a line is common to all lines, that of a surface to all surfaces, and lines and surfaces of the same nature are found in this stone or that stone. Here we are not talking about quantity in general, but rather about designated, determined quantities: a particular line, a particular surface. It is still not clear how they can explain the individuality of the bodies they compose.[62] The misunderstanding resides at the very start of this explanation. In the division of the species, each individual is formally the nature of the species. In quantitative division, although each line segment is an individual line, none is *quantitatively* the line from which it comes, because no part of a quantitative whole is the whole from which it comes.[63]

Consequently, Aristotle's authority is wrongly invoked here. The Philosopher did not say that quantity is divisible into parts, each of which is the whole, but that the whole can be divided in as many parts as it contains, each of which being in turn a distinct individual, like the whole from which

the parts come. The part is thus of the same nature as the whole, not because the whole and the parts share in the same nature that is common to them, namely quantity. On the contrary, the species is divided into parts of the same nature, and each part (that is each individual) includes the nature of the species. Accordingly, there is multiplication of individuals in both cases, but there is only individuation in the case of multiplication of the species in individuals. In the case of quantity, the multiplication of individuals does not result from genuine individuation. After all, quantity does not individualize matter; each matter individualizes its quantity.

e The principle of individuation

Consequently, we must come back to matter because all these theses in one way or another imply that matter is the real principle of individuation. Furthermore, that is Aristotle's doctrine. The only trouble is choosing passages to support the thesis, but Duns Scotus finds no difficulty in finding many others that he can interpret in the opposite sense. Such Aristotelian exegesis cannot settle the matter because it always depends largely on the thesis that one tries to confirm. Moreover, Duns Scotus readily acknowledges that "as the solution of authorities taken from the Philosopher in the opposite sense requires the solution of the sixth question, I ask, 'Are material substances individual by some positive entity inherently determining the nature of singularity?'"[64]

We already know what the answer will be. Every inferior (in the sense of more particular) includes in itself something that is not included in the concept of the superior. Otherwise, the concept of the inferior would be as common as the concept of the superior. Therefore, the concept of the individual inherently includes something that is not included in the concept of the nature. It has been established, first, that this something is a positive entity, next, that it and the nature compose an *unum* per se. Therefore, it is certainly this element that by being added determines the nature to singularity.

Accordingly, this positive principle of individuation's existence is not in

doubt, but its nature remains to be determined. The easiest method consists in comparing numerical unit and specific unity or, more precisely, the respective causes of those two unities. This ought to be possible because what form does for the species, that entity does for the individual. We can compare the specific formal difference to what is above it, below it, or at its level. Since Bonaventure, this is the established method, and it is easy to follow.

First, let us compare the species to what is under it. It is contradictory for the species to be divided into several other species, since, being species themselves, they will be both different and belong to the same nature. On this point, the individuating entity is in exactly the same situation, because it is contradictory for an individual to be parceled out among other individuals, each of which would be both what the others are and what it is. Thus, the individual's unity is individually indivisible, as the species' unity is specifically indivisible. However, there is a difference. Because the species' unity, which is the unity of a common nature, *natura communis*, is less strict than an individual's unity, we can conceive its division into subjective parts (individuals), although it is not divisible into essential parts (other species). In the case of the individual, any division is impossible whether into essential parts or subjective parts. The individuating entity consequently produces the strictest unity that there is: numerical unity.

Next, let us compare the individuating entity with what is above it. The entity from which we get the specific difference is act in relation to the genus's reality; *rational* determines *animal* in the way act determines potency. Thus, the specific entity is determinant in relation to the genus's potentiality; otherwise all definition would be vain and the genus by itself would contain all the species contains. Therefore, the genus is normally determined by the specific form, which adds something to the genus's nature, but that is not always the case. It may happen, although rarely, that the determining concept only adds another formality of the same thing to the genus, another real concept of the same object. For example, if I say God is *infinite being*, I do not determine the genus being by a specification foreign to being. I do not even *specify* it in any sense. It would be better to say that I

individualize it, and in this case, I do so simply by raising the genus to its highest degree of actuality. I could even simplify the concept by saying that God is the actual being in such a perfect manner that he ought to be called *Being* purely and simply.

The same holds at least partially in the case of individuating difference. The latter plays the same role in relation to the species that the species plays in relation to the genus. The difference (and this is key for anyone who wants to understand Scotist individuation correctly) is that the individuating distinctive is *never* drawn from a superadded form (as in the case of *human—rational animal*), but always and precisely from the form's ultimate reality: *ista nunquam sumitur a forma addita, sed praecise ab ultima realitate formae*. It is impossible to insist on this point too much, because it is necessary to see how, philosophically speaking, even metaphysics of essence is called to transcend itself when it comes to speak of the actually existent. Whether deliberately or not, Duns Scotus placed himself from the outset on the ground of quiddity, and it is the mark of a great philosopher that, once he adopted it, he never abandoned it—not even in case of (metaphysical) distress. Although nature and form are *common*, and even if it is impossible, as it is in fact, that the individuating difference should be form, it can belong only to the form in a universe where the essence is the very heart of reality. Therefore, there will be something beyond essence within essence, but there will be something. If agreement in a sense of metaphysical necessity matters more than the way of confronting it, we must note what is manifested, and this time genuinely, in the fundamental intuitions, starting from which the philosophy of *essentia* and the philosophy of *esse* diverge.[65]

Nothing shows this more than the following remark of Duns Scotus. When the species is added to the genus, it forms a composite with the genus, which is precisely the quiddity *animal rationale*. By contrast, here the issue is not to constitute a quiddity. The union of the genus and difference already gives the quiddity. The individuating cause's effect is different, because it consists of constituting the reality in an order different from that of quiddity: *ista autem entitas individui est primo diversa ob omni entitate quidditativa*. Except in

the case of infinite being, no quiddity contains that by which it is *haec*. Therefore, what is proper to the positive individuating entity intrinsic to the singular is not to add a quiddity to another, which would only specify it instead of individuating it, but to posit the quidditative whole constituted by genus and difference in a being of a different kind: *in esse alterius rationis*. We thereby transcend the order of what is common to enter the order of the individual, which is to enter a *different* order.

Finally, let us compare these differences with differences at their level once again with specific differences but this time with those that they themselves determine. Some of these specific differences that are not ultimate (in the sense that they behave like genera) are still determinable by other differences. The cause of individuation does not belong to this kind. It only resembles ultimate specific differences that completely determine the species, such as mortal rational animal, *animal rationale mortale*. Just as an ultimate specific difference posits the species as immediately and radically distinct from any other, so also the individuating difference posits its singular as immediately and radically distinct from any other. In this order, the cause of individuation is always the last difference, *differentia ultima*.[66]

This last point is more important than it seems at first sight, because nothing makes clearer the radical character of the difference of orders implied by the transition from species to individual. Starting from singulars, we can abstract the community of species, but we can only do so from their natures, not from their singularities. There are no species of singularities: last differences are first of all different, and therefore nothing that is intrinsically common can be abstracted from them, *differentiae ultimae sunt primo diversae et ideo ab iis nihil unum per se commune potest abstrahi*. Of course, this does not mean that individuals cannot enter into classes endowed with unity, but if they enter into them, it is by reason of their common natures, not by reason of their individuating difference.[67] In short, singularities are entities as incompossible as the individuals that possess them.

Duns Scotus leaves us with this conclusion, and we can understand why. The analysis of being that Scotus has undertaken leads him to situate

metaphysically an element of the real for which the philosopher has no abstract concept, since it is not a form. The *individual entity*, cause of the *individual difference*, is neither matter, nor form, nor their composite, because neither matter, nor form, nor their composite implies any singularity of themselves. What is it then? It is the last reality of being, *ultima realitas entis*, Duns Scotus responds. It is exactly

> the last reality of the being that is matter or form or the composite, so that any common but still determinable entity whatsoever can be determined again, however much it may be one thing, in several formally distinct realities, of which the latter is not formally the former, because one is formally the entity of a singular, while the other is formally the entity of a nature.[68]

This leads to a clarification that our Doctor can only call to the reader's attention, because it is for us to internalize it if we want to understand it. All during the essential coordination, the mind goes from entities to entities. The genus has its own entity proportional to the unity that belongs to it. The species has its entity in the same conditions. Consequently, their union is the union of a thing, *res*, with another *res*, but this is no longer the case when we reach the individuating difference. The latter is not added to the quiddity as another thing (otherwise would be a quiddity itself), but as an intrinsic determination that confers singularity on it. We can distinguish the individuating difference *formaliter* from the quiddity, in other words we can posit it separately in thought, but not conceive it as a being distinct from what it individualizes. It is, we repeat, the last actuality of the form, *ultima actualitas formae*.[69]

Accordingly, here we are dealing with individuation *of* the quiddity but not *by* the quiddity. Perhaps we might say without betraying Duns Scotus that it is individuation of the form but not by the form, since at no point do we depart from the predicamental line of essence. Existence cannot be taken into consideration, because existence is the basis of a different coordination from those of quiddities and their respective entities. The order of actual existing

that Scotus keeps in mind cannot enter into the system of quidditative constituents of being that must be able to be constituted by its own resources alone from the highest genus to the most particular species. It is most important to understand that. Scotist individuation allows the complete determination of the singularity without appealing to existence. Individuation would be rather the necessarily required condition for all possible existence, the subjects are completely determined by their individual difference: in a word, individuals that alone are capable of existing. The only individuating difference that existence requires of its essence is that of the being whose *haecceitas* is its own infinity. Other individual essences only exist by virtue of their causes. Nothing is more extrinsic to these existences than their causes. By contrast, the principle of individuation is what is most intrinsic to the being whose determination it finishes.

Duns Scotus does not conceal the pitfalls that this concept prepares for our imagination. His refusal to make it a *thing* can lead us to conclude that the individuating difference has no entity. That, however, would be an error because that difference entails a supplementary composition by way of addition. The proof is that this composition is incompatible with divine simplicity, whose *essentia* is this thing, *haec*, of itself and fully. There, we find not only no composition of thing and thing, *rei* and *rei*, but not even of reality and reality, *realitatis* and *realitatis*, as if the divine essence could be determined by an actual reality of some individuation difference. As we said, in God everything that stems from his essence is identical, because in it everything is formally infinite. By contrast, in the finite, the species never includes the individual of itself, nor the opposite. Species and individual are only joined in a third term, this individual being of which they are the integrating parts and that includes them in its identity. Moreover, this is why the singular is not simple. Its composition is not even the most perfect possible, because its elements are not all things: “this totally perfect composition, which is out of thing and thing.”[70]

After all, it is not surprising that this reality is not intelligible to us at present. It is intrinsically intelligible. Why it is not intelligible for us is a

different problem. In any case, the reason does not stem from singularity itself, and it is beyond us rather by excess. Not the sun, but the owl's eye explains that the owl does not see the sun. Moreover, even if we knew the singular, we could see it, but not define it. Its nature is opposed to that. Obviously, it is being, and it adds entity to the species' entity, "but that entity, which it adds, is not quidditative entity," *sed illa entitas quam addit non est entitas quidditativa*. There is no definition, and therefore no demonstration or science.[71] We handle the individual only by way of the species. Again, here we have a metaphysics where the ultimate point of what is real defies scientific knowledge, but, after all, if it were otherwise, we would not need metaphysics; philosophy of nature would be enough for us. "The individual is irreducibly ultimate," says Heidegger about the Scotist singular,[72] and that is obviously what Duns Scotus himself wanted to demonstrate. For, although he did not represent it as a *thing*, he wondered what the individuating difference would be for it, if it existed for itself within the substance. It would be exactly the act of the quiddity: *si esset res alia, proprie esset actus quidditatis*.[73] Accordingly, it is right to attribute a keen sense of the individual to Scotus, but perhaps it would be better to say that, in his doctrine, he emphasized the supreme importance of the metaphysical act by which being is completely terminated in its fullness and capable of receiving existence. In Thomas Aquinas, the act of being is found at the core of what is real; in Duns Scotus we find *haecceitas*.

C Unity of the concrete

After having studied matter in itself, it remains for us to consider it in the particular substances of which it is an element. Let us first recall that matter enters into these particular substances *qua* component element. As we have said, matter is one principle of nature, *unum principium naturae*, one cause of the component distinct from the form. Whether we call it *act* or not, matter has its proper reality, and since it is, it must necessarily be, if not *an act*, at least *in act*. Moreover, if matter were nothing of itself, God himself could not

produce it. It would not be the term of creation, *terminus creationis*. Finally, if it were nothing, how could it receive the form? Therefore, it is impossible to put the reality of matter in doubt. From there comes the definition of matter that Duns Scotus gives: “the word *matter* designates a positive entity outside of the intellect and of its proper cause, an entity by which matter is capable of substantial forms that are acts in the full sense of the word.”[74]

These very expressions already lead us to acknowledge that the concepts of act and potency are not attributed here to irreducibly opposed realties. To be potency is not to be act, but neither is it to be nothing. Although Scotus grants matter a certain degree of actuality, he nonetheless opposes it to form as potency to act. However real matter is, its actuality is reduced to the minimum being required to receive the form, in other words, to be always in potency in regard to the form. So, despite what actuality matter possesses, it is no less immediately and radically distinct from form. To return to Duns Scotus’s own expression: “Act and potency, which are principles of being, are different from the first. Matter and form are like that. Therefore, matter and form are different from the first.”[75]

Since this is Scotus’s position, it is pointless to argue against it in the name of another position, as sometimes occurs. Nobody could ever convince Scotus that by granting matter positive entity endowed with the degree of actuality corresponding to its being, he is implicitly obliged to confuse potency and act. For Scotus, matter’s proper actuality is that of receptor; that of form is the actuality of the received or, if we prefer, the form distinguished from *matter as what gives*, as distinguished from *what receives*. This is even why we have heard Scotus say that form and matter are suited to be united to compose a singular being, because two elements are all the better made to enter into composition insofar as they are more diverse and more distinct. This composition suggests to Duns Scotus a remark that we have already recalled, but to which it is useful to return since it notably clarifies his way of conceiving the relation of real essence to existence. That is the heart of the matter, if we think about it. We posit that matter is a positive term of the creating act, from which it follows, as we have said, that matter is something,

an *essentia*, a reality, in short, the entity that it must possess to enter, *qua* part, into the composition of the substance. It is precisely on this point that Scotus opposes his *non possumus* to the real distinction of essence and existence. Thomas Aquinas certainly admits that matter is part of the composite, but he denies matter any *esse* of its own outside of what it receives by the form and in which matter participates in this sense. The doctrine is consistent with its principles, since in Thomist metaphysics no essence fully exists even as long as it exists. In Duns Scotus, it is equally true, according to Avicenna's doctrine, that essence or quiddity does not imply its existence. It can only receive its existence from its cause. However (and this is how Scotism differs from Thomism), essence no longer differs from its existence once its cause has realized it. We should not forget that *essentia* includes the meaning *reality* here. To admit that an essence thus understood is effectively produced in being by its cause and that it still is not is to admit the possibility of an unreal reality, the possibility of an *essentia* bereft of *esse* that precisely makes it *essentia*. It is, in short, to contradict oneself.[76]

By attributing its proper *esse* to matter, which is proportional to matter's degree of actuality and by maintaining it even within the actually existent composite, Duns Scotus only applies to this problem the general solution that is always his solution in similar cases. What is true of matter in the composite is true of the accident in the substance and, generally speaking, true of any component whatsoever entering into the structure of a whole. In this context, it has been maintained that according to the Subtle Doctor, all reality is "an absolute or a collection of absolutes" and that "everything in the world of ideas and the world of nature is a mosaic."[77] This is a philosophical judgment that exceeds a historian's competence. Accordingly, we do not have to approve or refute it, but we can at least point out that in Duns Scotus's own mind the world of composed substances looks different. The entities Scotus distinguishes certainly have their proper being, but they are not juxtaposed like pieces of a mosaic. From matter to God, in other words from the poorest *essentia* to infinite being, *ens infinitum*, all beings are ordered in a hierarchy

whose appearance greatly differs from a collection of fragments that, even disposed according to certain definite figures, would nonetheless all be of the same order. Besides, the most important thing is that the elements of the composite enter into each other through relations of act to potency that would weld them into the unity of the whole. Thisness, *haecceitas* is not exception to this rule. Rather, it confirms the rule, because it is certainly the *ultimate actuality of the form* that definitively seals the unity of the real composite, which in the last analysis is always an individual. It is true that there are as many individuating principles as elements in the composite.[78] Moreover, that is certainly necessary. As we saw in its moment, if it is true that even matter is individuated by a proper intrinsic determination, with greater reason that must also hold for the form and even the composite that their union constitutes. There are as many principles of composition as *essentiae*, as many *esse* as real *essentiae*, and there are as many intrinsic determinations that individuate *esse* as there are *esse*. It would be difficult to push the realism of essence further, but we must add that here substances are nonetheless strongly connected organic structures. If their elements were not actual, individual entities, there would not be beings, and if there were only nothings and therefore no components, how could there be composites? Still, these components mutually determine each other up to the individuating principle of the whole that reduces all to the unity of substance.[79] There, the higher actuality holds the lower on up to the highest intrinsic determinant that holds them all in its act. What is true is that here we are in a metaphysics of real essence, and since the *actus essendi* is excluded from it by a decision of principle there can be no question of appealing to it to ground or cast the elements together in the unity of the composite. It is necessary to seek a catalyst of essences in the essence itself, and nothing appears but the hierarchical efficacy of acts, the efficacy of the form actualizing that of matter, and the efficacy of the intrinsic individuating principle actualizing in its turn that of the form. The real problem here is to choose between a metaphysics of *essentia* and a metaphysics of *esse*.

Moreover, the structural complexity of the particular in Duns Scotus’s

doctrine must not be exaggerated. Analysis necessarily takes all the elements one by one, and by considering each in itself attributes to them each time an individuality of the same degree as their being, but it is not only a metaphor to present them as melted together in the unity of the particular. Scotus's whole habit of thought that inclines him to multiply moments in analysis, on the other hand, makes him eliminate real distinctions from the particular any time he can void them. We will have proofs of it, but none more decisive than his doctrine of natures to which we are naturally led.

The problem is vital in the sense that it cannot be resolved without answering the question that has just been posed: Do the elements subsist in the mixture? If Duns Scotus were so inclined, this would be an excellent occasion to make the mixture into a mosaic! Does he? He sees two solutions available. The first is Avicenna's that wants the elements to remain intact within the mixture, in other words, without loss of substance but with a mere weakening of their quiddities. The second is Averroes's solution that maintains them only at the cost of a weakening of their substance as well as of their qualities. We would naturally expect to see Scotus once more rally to the opinion of Avicenna against that of Averroes, but there is nothing of the kind. Instead of adhering to Avicenna's opinion, Duns Scotus rejects even that of the Commentator, because the elements still subsist too distinctly within the mixture according to Averroes. In short, both of them are courteously dismissed back to back. But let us see what is being considered:

> I answer the question by maintaining the contrary to what both say, namely that the elements do not remain in the mixture as to their substance, whether attenuated as Averroes wishes or without attenuation as Avicenna would have it. The reason is that it *is necessary not to multiply without necessity*. Nothing forces to maintain that a plurality of elements or substantial forms subsists in the mixture.[80]

The operation that is acknowledged in the form does not force us, because the mixture's operation does not belong to the same species as the elements' operation. Nor does the transmutation, because the elements' form and the

mixture's form have enough reality for the first to be the starting point, *terminus a quo*, of a corruption, and the second the point of arrival, *terminus ad quem*, of a generation. When air is corrupted to engender fire, the form of air gives way to the form of fire. Likewise, in a mixture of air and fire, the forms disappear to give way to the form of the mixture. From the point of view of their own substance, therefore, the elements are abolished in the substance of their composite.

The following remark is even more striking, because it amounts to saying that, if the elements subsisted in the mixture, the mixture would indeed only be a mosaic. Every nature includes matter and every union of a distinct matter and distinct form constitutes a distinct subject, that is to say a substance. Accordingly, if there were several elementary forms in the mixture, each of them would constitute a substance, so that every mixture would be a substance composed of several substances, of water and fire, for example, each of which could exist separately.[81] Thus we could certainly complain that beings are made of bits and pieces. What is true of the substance of elements is also true of their qualities. These remain, if we please, in the same way that the vegetative soul and the sensitive soul subsist in the intellectual soul, which as we have just seen is virtually.

This indeed is Duns Scotus's own position. The four elements remain virtually in the mixture whose substantial form virtually contains them all. Consequently, they are not there *secundum substantiam ut partes sui* (as substances included in another substance), but in the mode of virtual containment, which is what Aristotle seems to suggest by saying that the four elements remain in potency and virtue, *potentia et virtute*. Duns Scotus's world must be interpreted thus. The form of the mixture does not actualize matter by means of the element's form, but directly. Obviously, human generation supposes that matter is under the form of the elements before receiving the form of the seed, then of blood, then of flesh, then of human being, but at each successive moment of the generation there is always only one substantial form, which is the whole composite's form.[82]

However, this last argument goes beyond the problem of the simple

mixture, which ordinarily is only composed of elements. It is rare to pass from the mixture to what is organic and to what is alive without a new element intervening, which is precisely the *semen*. Accordingly, the seed is a body whose form is not there for itself but with a view to something else, namely, in order to permit the generation to produce a being similar to it.[83] We can put this differently: the finality of the *semen* is to guarantee the continuity of the species. A nature is the seat of a double process, ascending and descending, that first leads from the form of the seed to the form of blood, from the form of blood to the form of the embryo, and so on up to the form of the perfect animal. Later the perfect animal dissolves into a cadaver, and ultimately resolves into elementary forms. All nature is bound to this order and this process, whose directive force is the *semen*. The *semen* does not permit nature to remain where it is until the being achieves its completion. Therefore, we can define it: an unfinished body produced by the generator in order to lead subsequently to perfect forms that resemble it.

The word *semen* is often replaced by the expression *ratio seminalis*, which is intimately connected to it, but does not mean exactly the same thing. The *seminal reason* is in the seed. It is its form, either the substantial form or a quality that necessarily results from this form. For example, in wheat, it is the form of wheat or a quality necessarily resulting from the form of wheat.[84]

We said that the *semen* is the directing force of generation, but it is not its active principle. That is important in order to comprehend exactly what corresponds to this term in Duns Scotus's thinking. It must not be understood in terms of male and female. As Duns Scotus conceives generation, the *semen* does not yet exist at the moment when it is produced. In the case Scotus considers, which is that of male and female, the male's active *semen* has the same form as the female's passive *semen* upon which it acts. Therefore, suppose that this dual *semen uniforme* is detached from the father and mother; it only does so by virtue of the generator. It does not produce the generation. The generation produces the *semen*, and this is why we say that, since it does not exist at the moment of the generation, it is not the generation's active principle any more than the substance to which the

generation tends as its term. Neither is it the active principle starting from moment when it exists because what is the *semen's* nature except to be a body transformable into what must be engendered? To be transformable is not to be active in nature but passive. To that let us add that the less perfect cannot suffice to cause the more perfective actively, and the seed itself with all the vital spirits with which it is endowed remains less perfect than the complete being that is the term of the generation. Accordingly, the *semen* cannot be the complete being's active principle in any case.

However, it would still remain for us to suppose that at the moment when the seed is detached from the generator, the generator communicates a force to the seed by virtue of which it acts. Galen insinuates this when he attributes divine force to the seed. Perhaps there is something true in that, but not in the sense in which Galen understood it. For, if a divine force exists in the *semen*, it does not come from the generator. From the moment at which the seed is detached from the generator, everything takes place in the generator as if the generator has ceased to exist. Practically, it no longer exists, and this is even literally true every time we are not dealing with essentially ordered causes (where the cause must be there to cooperate with the effect), but with accidentally ordered causes whose presence is not necessary for the effect to be produced. A family lineage is precisely the typical cause of a series of accidental ordered causes. Socrates can beget Plato, who can beget Cicero, although Socrates has ceased to be and consequently to be a cause. Each of these accidentally ordered causes acts by its own virtue, and after its effect exists, it must no longer be its cause. Accordingly, we must conclude that, first, as we have already said, neither the seed nor anything that belongs to it is the active principle of generating or of the ultimate form that is in the term; next, that the principle is no longer the father, since at the moment when the generator is produced, the father has always ceased to exist *qua* father; lastly, and in order to leave no hypothesis untested, that the form of the heavens is not the active principle, because many living things are more perfect than it. We have three negative conclusions, the third of which eliminates a fourth, which would consist in saying that the angels are the active principles of the

semen's generative virtue. If they were, their causal action would be exercised by means of celestial moment, which has just been acknowledged to be impossible. By way of successive eliminations, we are thus led to the sole supposition that now remains conceivable. There is only one cause that could render the soul capable of giving life: God.[85]

The living organism with its well-ordered development, of all beings, is the one where the presence of a seminal reason is most evidently imposed, but Duns Scotus allows that there can be seminal reasons in other beings than animals. All mixtures can have seminal reasons that put them on the path of later and more perfect forms. A heavenly body can induce into a steer's carcass the quality necessary for bees to be born. It is a seminal reason. It is not even necessary that there should be a mixture properly speaking; a quality of this kind can be induced in a simple blend where the elements are only juxtaposed. Finally, let us recall that a single element is enough for the divine power to insert a seminal reason, for instance water, from which we read in Gen. 1:21 that God produced fish.[86]

Consequently, Duns Scotus's universe does not let itself be broken up into as many fragments as formal distinctions are necessary to analyze its structure. While maintaining a certain plurality of forms,[87] the Subtle Doctor retains the means of guaranteeing the unity of particular substances.[88] The unity of their structure is essentially quidditative, since the form itself only intervenes here in order to determine the nature to be as its essence wills it to be. Therefore, everything happens according to *reasons* that define an essence or perhaps a route, but that of themselves do not realize this essence and do not move on this route. The origin of efficacy and movement is elsewhere, perhaps higher than simple metaphysics. We should have no qualms about repeating that metaphysics is about quiddities, *metaphysica est de quidditatibus*, but neither must we imagine that there is nothing more than the quiddity in real being. To the contrary, what is fully real is always individual, and Aristotle saw this well, but did not succeed in achieving metaphysics capable of justifying being as he himself understood it.

Duns Scotus achieved this metaphysics. The individual is not only first in

fact there, but first in principle, and it is eminently first. All that is, is intelligible: intelligibility absolutely follows entity, *intelligibilitas absolute sequitur entitatem*. "The singular includes the total higher quidditative entity, and besides, a degree of actuality and of ultimate unity by reason of individuation. Far from diminishing the entity and unity, this unity adds to them, and thereby adds intelligibility."[89] In this sense, the general knowledge that is only such always allows a part of its object's intelligibility to escape, precisely the part that stems from its singularity. Therefore, it is incomplete knowledge that lacks the degree of being proper to the singular *qua* singular. By contrast, one who knows this highest degree of being that is the singular knows everything else in it, and this is why, in divine knowledge, which is perfect, "the ideas are eminently ideas of singulars because they directly represent all ineligibles other than God."[90] Consequently, the fullness of reality and intelligibility do not belong to univocal being, not even to the hierarchical structure of the formalities connected by the unitive virtue of the higher quiddity that contains them all. This fullness only belongs to the being completely determined by its individuating difference, and, even in that being, the singular does not constitute the peak of being; its singularity does.[91]

Notes

1 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 1, vol. II, p. 497 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12].

2 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 3, vol. II, pp. 498–99 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12].

3 See Gabriel Théry, O.P., *Autour du decrét de 1210:* II *Alexandre d'Aphrodise, aperçu sur l'influence de sa noëtique*, Bibliothèque Thomiste, VII, Paris: J. Vrin, 1926. See especially pp. 32–33, the passage quoted from Léopold Mabilleau, *Étude historique sur la philosophie de la Renaissance en Italie (Cesare Cremonini)* (Paris: Hachette, 1881), p. 283: "Since the individual is only the indissoluble unit of matter and form (two terms whose separation would be a contradiction) the form itself must be material."

4 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 3, vol. II, p. 498 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. Further on, Duns Scotus points out that even the concept of *degrees of being*, becomes unintelligible if we reduce things to matter because any two degrees would be identical to a third that would be precisely matter. Therefore, there would be no degrees. Lastly, and here Alexander of Aphrodisias's doctrine is definitely being considered: "It is certain that the

intellectual soul cannot be an intrinsic degree of matter, because it is the term of creation," *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 9, vol. II, pp. 502–03 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. Against the possibility of reducing corruptibility to form alone, see number 6, p. 500.

5 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 10, vol. II, p. 503 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12].

6 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 10, vol. II, p. 503 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Et ideo ponens materiam solum in potentia objectiva, et non subjectiva, negat omnem rationem Philosophi de materia."

7 Aquinas, *In VIII Metaphysicae*, *lectio* 1, number 1687; *In Metaphysicam Aristotelis Commentaria*, M.-R. Cathala (Turin: Marietti, 1915, 1935, 1980).

8 St. Augustine, *Confessions*, book XII, chapter 3, 3 (Latin text ed. and trans. Pierre de Labriole, two volumes, Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1925, vol. II, p. 331): "Nonne tu, Domine docuisti me, quod priusquam istam informem materiam formares atque distingueres, bonam erat aliquid, non color, non figura, non corpus, non spiritus? Non tamen omnino nihil; erat quaedam informitas sine ulla specie." Book XII, chapter 6, 6, p. 333: "Quiddam inter formam et nihil nec formatum nec nihil, informe prope nihil." Genesis affirms the creation of this *informis materia* under the name *terra*, book XII, chapter 7, 7, p. 334. Book XII, chapter 8, 8, p. 355: "de materia informi, quam fecisti de nulla re paene nullam rem." And so on. Again, this is a point where, under Augustine's pressure, Duns Scotus departs from the tradition of Avicenna. Cf. J. L. Muckle, ed. *Algazel's Metaphysics*, I, 1, 3 (Toronto: St. Michael's College, 1933), p. 16.

9 To be exact, Augustine's authority is instead theological here, but Duns Scotus does not refrain from basing himself upon it. If *terra* means *materia* in Genesis, it is written that God created matter. Therefore matter must exist *qua* created being. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 11, vol. II, p. 504 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Et est terminus creationis, patet, et secundum hoc est realitas distincta a forma, ex eisdem causis, et est quid positivum, quia receptivum formae."

10 Aristotle, *Physics*, book I, chapter 7, 191 a 8–14.

11 Aristotle, *Physics*, book II, chapter 3, 198 a 22–24.

12 Aristotle, *Physics*, book IV, chapter 9, 217 a 22–26.

13 Here again, Duns Scotus can appeal to passages where Aristotle says that matter is *nature* as being the immediate *subject* in everything that possesses the principle of movement and change in itself, *Physics*, book II, chapter 1, 193 a 28–31. Cf. *Physics*, book IV, chapter 2, 226, a 10–11.

14 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 11, vol. II, p. 504 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. Consequently, matter does not receive *esse* from its form; it has its own *esse*, *In Metaphysicam*, book VIII, question 3, number 5 [EW II, pp. 375–77].

15 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 13, vol. II, p. 505 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. Obviously, form is more being than matter, but matter is not matter by virtue of a form of materiality. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 10, vol. I, p. 520 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Potest dici quod forma est magis ens, nec tamen est causa constituens esse materiale, sed est causa concurrens ad esse compositi contituendi, et ideo potest separari forma a materia; sicut a converso." Of course, matter without form would be different from matter than can only exist under form. Consequently, there can be different first matters, all individual and numerically distinct, *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 15.

16 Here is the essential passage, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number

11, vol. II, p. 504 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: “Tamen dicitur ens in potentia, quia quanto aliquid habet minus de actu, tanto magis est in potentia; et quia materia est receptiva omnium formarum substantialium et accidentalium, ideo maxime est in potentia respectu earum, et ideo difinitur per esse in potentia secundum Aristotelem; non enim habet actum distinguentem, vel dividentem, vel receptum, vel informantem et dantem sibi esse specificum. Ex quo tamen est receptivum istius actus, per suppositum, et est causa compositi, non potest esse nihil, quia nihil non est alicujus receptivum.” In the opposite sense, see Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 66, article 1, reply to objection 3: “Accidens, cum sit forma, est actus quidam; materia autem, secundum id quod est, est ens in potentia. Unde magis repugnat materiae esse in actu sine forma quam accidenti sine subjecto.”

17 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 13, vol. II, pp. 505–06 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. For a harmonization of this position with the texts of Aristotle, see *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 5, numbers 4–5 [EW II, pp. 123–26].

18 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 14, vol. II, p. 506 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12].

19 Ibid.

20 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 15, vol. II, p. 507 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. Cf. number 20, vol. II, p. 511: “Ad aliud de actu, dico quod si accipis actum pro actu informante, materia non est actus; si autem accipias actum pro omni eo quod est extra causam suam, sic materia potest dici ens actu, vel actus. Sed secundum communem modum loquendi, esse actu attribuitur et appropriatur formae.”

21 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 16, vol. II, p. 508 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. In consonance with this thesis, Duns Scotus teaches that matter belongs to the species of the quiddity. Evidently, we should understand common matter, not individual and accidental matter, nor the matter of everything. In short, the quiddity of the species includes the matter required by this quiddity, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 16, number 6 [EW II, p. 276, number 40].

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 16, vol. II, p. 508 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: “Dico igitur quod nihil est contradictio quod materia sit terminus creationis et pars compositi, et quod non habeat aliquod esse, cum tamen sit aliqua essentia; quod enim aliqua essentia sit extra causam suam, et quod non habeat aliquod esse quo sit essentia, est mihi contradictio.”

23 Aristotle, *Physics*, book I, chapter 7, 191 a 7–8: “The underlying nature is an object of scientific knowledge by an analogy.” Consequently, Duns Scotus is literally right. Aristotle does not say that nature is only knowable in relation to form.

24 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 20, vol. II, p. 511 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 7, vol. II, p. 518: “Sive idea accipiatur pro objecto cognito, sive pro ratione cognoscendi, falsum est quod materia non habeat ideam; imo quocumque modo idea acccipiatur, dico quod materia ipsa habet ideam; sicut enim materia est quid creabile distinctum a forma, sic est quoddam ideale, quod habet ideam distinctam.”

25 Augustine, *Confessions*, book XII, chapter 29, number 40, vol. II, p. 360. In this we see what Duns Scotus calls priority of origin. Sound is prior *origine*, Augustine says, to song. Because song is *formed* sound, Duns Scotus adds, in an expression that is very important for those who want to understand him, that something can exist without being formed, but what is nothing cannot be formed. Therefore, sound is something real that can exist without song. Although sound does not

precede song in time, it is its condition, and in this perspective it precedes it *origine*. Matter is also like this; it is to form as sound to chant. *Confessions*, book XII, chapter 29, number 40, pp. 360–61: "Cum vero dicit primo informem, deinde formatum, non est absurdus, si modo est ideoneus discernere, quid praededat . . . orgine, sicut sonus cantum . . . sic est prior materies quam id quod ex ea fit; non ideo prior quia ipsa efficit, cum potius fiat; nec prior intervallo temporis . . . Sed prior est origine, quia non cantus formatur, ut sonus sit, sed sonus formatur, ut cantus sit." Therefore, as to the core of the thesis, Duns Scotus is situated in a genuinely Augustinian position, and he is not afraid to go further, because according to him, matter's priority of origin makes it more independent than form. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 10, vol. II, p. 520 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Potest dici uno modo quod licet entitas materiae sit minus perfecto quam formae, non tamen plus est dependens, imo minus, et ideo potest fieri sine forma et non e converso." Henry of Ghent, who similarly denies that matter is pure potency, accumulates authoritative statements from Augustine at the beginning of his *Quodlibet* I, 10.

26 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 3, vol. II, p. 514 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12].

27 Ibid.

28 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 4, vol. II, p. 515 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12].

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 5, vol. I, p. 516 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Nusquam esset localiter vel definitive; tamen esset natura quaedam absoluta." We can be certain that shortly afterward Duns Scotus directly envisages Greek necessitarianism. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 517: "Nec etiam Deus posset facere materiam sine forma, secundum Aristotelem. Sed hoc fuit pro tanto, quia ipse posuit necessariam connexionem causarum, ita quod impossibile est, secundum eum, primas causas agere sine secundis, sive causam omnino primam sine secunda causa. Sed si hoc negasset, habuisset ponere, secundum ea quae posuit de materia, quod potuisset iam Deus fecesse sine forma."

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 7, vol. I, p. 518 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: ". . . Sive etiam idea ponatur ratio imitandi essentiam divinam [as in Thomas Aquinas] in tali gradu, adhuc habet ideam, quia alium gradum imitandi habet materia essentiam divinam quam forma, vel aliud quodcumque." Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 6, vol. I, p. 517 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Ad aliud dico concedendo majorem, quia non video quin esse in alio ente sit inferius quam esse in se, et quin sit magis imperfectionis dependere quam non dependere. Et ideo dico quod omne esse cujuscumque alterius generis a substantia, scilicet accidens, est imperfectius quodcumque quod est pars substantiae sicut est materia."

31 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 2, number 8, vol. I, pp. 518–19 [CE VIII has no book II, distinction 12]: "Ad aliud de analogia, quod illud [*scilicet*, sanitas quae est realiter in animali et in urina non nisi per attributionem] recipitur tantum in uno realiter in aliis per attributionem, dico quod hoc est falsum; quia si ita est in uno exemplo, in centum est contrarium; nulla enim est major analogia quam sit creaturae ad Deum in ratione essendi, et tamen sic esse primo et principaliter convenit Deo, quod tamen realiter et univoce convenit creaturae." Even the example is not good because in a *healthy animal*, a *healthy diet*, and *healthy urine*, the concept of *health* is not the same, whereas the concept of being is the same for God and matter, for substance and for accidents.

32 Johannes Kraus, *Die Lehre des Joannes Duns Skotus O.F.M. von der Natura communis* (Freiburg: Studia Friburgensis, 1927), pp. 52–3 thinks that the reference is to Richard of Middleton, which is possible. Cf. Edgar Hocedez, S.J., *Richard de Middleton, sa vie, sa oeuvre, sa doctrine* (Louvain: Spilegium sacrum louvanense, 1925), pp. 204–08. Richard expresses himself as if the basis of individuation were the substances' individual unity: "Per suam autem unitatem individualem est in se [singulare] substantialiter indistinctum." Therefore, by that it is "ab alio subtantialiter distinctum," Hocedez, p. 206. In Godfrey of Fontaine's long discussion of the problem, for which he proposes a complex solution, he touches upon this position. *Quodlibet* VII, question 5, ed. de Wulf and Hoffmans, p. 325: "Sed si quaeratur qua differunt realiter, dicendum est quod se ipsis." Naturally, Duns Scotus simplifies the positions to reduce them to fundamental theses that he can discuss in themselves. On the overall problem, see Johannes Assenmacher, *Die Geschichte des Individuationsprinzip in der Scholastik* (Leipzig: Meiner, 1926), pp. 58–71, and Kraus, *Die Lehre des Joannes Duns Skotus*, pp. 93–99. Regarding Duns Scotus, see *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13 [EW II, p. 187], *Utrum natura lapidis de se sit haec vel per aliud intrinsecum?*

33 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 1, vol. II, p. 224 [CE VII, pp. 393–94].

34 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 3, vol. II, p. 226 [CE VII, pp. 391–93]. Here Duns Scotus interprets the passage from Aristotle, *Physics*, book VII, chapter 4, 227 b 7, that deals with another problem. Speaking about what gives unity to movement, Aristotle says that movement is one, with a specific unity, when, being one as to genus, it is also one in an indivisible species. Duns Scotus seizes upon this last expression to conclude directly from it: "In specie atoma fit comparatio, quia est una natura." Accordingly, he invests these two terms of Aristotle with the whole Avicennist doctrine of *natura communis*. The definition of the individual is, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 17 [EW II, p. 224, number 115]: "Individuum, sive unum numero, dicitur illud quod non est divisibile in multis et distinguitur ab omni alio secundum numerum."

35 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 4, vol. II, p. 226 [CE VII, pp. 398–99]. The argument interprets Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, book V, chapter 15, 1021 a 11–12. All equality is said in relation to one, but it is not said that this unity is real in the sense that Duns Scotus understands it. The fourth argument takes up the third again, applying it to contrariety. For opposition between *white* and *black* to be real, each of these two terms must have a real unity that is not an individual's real unity.

36 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 4, vol. II, p. 227 [CE VII, pp. 399–400]: "Praeterea quinto . . ."—The sixth argument has some interest, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 5, vol. II, p. 227 [CE VII, pp. 400–02]. If all unity is numerical, there are only numerical differences between beings; therefore, there are no specific differences, "et tunc sequitur quod non plus potest intellectus abstrahere a Socrate et Platone aliquod commune quam a Socrate et linea, et esset quodlibet universale purum figmentum."

37 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 6, vol. II, p. 228 [CE VII, pp. 401–02].

38 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 7, vol. II, p. 228 [CE VII, p. 402]: "Aliqua est unitas in re realis, absque omni operatione intellectus, minor unitate numerali sive unitate propria singularis, quae unitas est naturae secundum se; et secundum istam unitatem propriam naturae, ut natura est, natura est indifferens ad unitatem singularem; non ergo de se est sic una unitate illa, scilicet unitate singularitatis." Cf. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 4, number 20, vol. II, p. 256 [CE VII, pp. 456–57]: "Ad Avicennam . . ." This doctrine has been vigorously criticized, as can be seen in Johann Kraus's excellent and substantial study

"Die Universalienlehre des Oxforder Kanzlers Heinrich von Harclay," *Divus Thomas*, Freiburg, Switzerland, vol. X (1932), pp. 36–58 and pp. 475–508 and vol. XI (1933), pp. 288–314. See particularly vol. X, pp. 52–53 and vol. XI, pp. 494–95. For a similar critique of Duns Scotus by another Franciscan, see Ephrem Longpré, "Les questions disputées de Guillaume Farinier, O.F.M., ministre général de l'Ordre (1348–1357) et cardinal (1356–1361)," *La France Franciscaine* V (1922), pp. 434–37. Following these indications, Kraus examined Farinier, *Quaestiones de Ente*. See "Die Universalienlehre," vol. XI, pp. 302–04. See also pp. 307–09 on the position of Guido Terreni.

39 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, numbers 8–9, vol. II, pp. 230–31 [CE VII, pp. 405–08]. The study by Johannes Kraus just cited situates Duns Scotus in the general history of universals: (1) Universals are actual beings (Plato, Ibn Gabirol), endowed with numerical unity. (2) Universals are *entities reales*, the common natures whose very indifference to the universal and the singular allows us to universalize (Duns Scotus). (3) There is a form in the singular that can be abstracted from it by the agent intellect, which *makes* the universality that has its *fundamentum in re* (Thomas Aquinas). (4) The same thing is singular under a distinct concept and universal under a confused concept (Harclay following Abelard), which is a desperate effort to maintain metaphysical realism by purely psychological means. (5) Nothing is universal in any way or under any concept, *quia res de se singularis nullomodo nec sub aliquo conceptu est universalis* (Ockham, *In Sententiarum*, book I, distinction 2, question 7). This is even why it is contradictory to speak of *conceptualism* in regard to Ockham, unless one admits that a universal concept with *no* real basis for its universality is possible. See *In Sententiarum*, book I, distinction 2, question 8: "Hoc tamen teneo quod *nullum* universale (nisi forte sit universale per voluntariam institutionem), est aliquid existens *quocumque modo* extra animam, sed omne illud quod est universale praedicabile de pluribus, ex natura sua est in mente vel subjective vel objective, et quod nullum tale est de essentia seu quidditate cujuslibet substantiae." In short, *insofar as a concept is concerned with what is general*, the notion of *Ockhamist concept* is the notion of *concept without object*. Here Ockham achieves a pure metaphysical position. This is what constitutes his greatness, and respecting the purity of Ockham's position seems to us to be the only way to honor him. But if someone wants to be an Ockhamist without losing the real entity that this Scotist concept contains, who are we to spoil his fun?

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 7, vol. II, pp. 228–30 [CE VII, pp. 403–504].

41 What is called *universale in re* is only *commune* and *indifferens*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 8, vol. II, p. 230 [CE VII, pp. 405–07]. We can see the error of which Aristotle accuses Plato. It consists in achieving a universal under the name of Idea, that is to say, in positing as a singular external reality a universal whose being is that of an object of the intellect, number 10, p. 232. Therefore, it is right to deny that Scotus is a Platonist, if to be one it is necessary to admit a doctrine of Ideas that Scotus himself is not certain that Plato admitted. But it is possible to maintain that our Doctor Platonizes by attributing a *verum esse extra animam reale* to the common nature *etiam in rerum natura*. We just saw that Scotus says so in appropriate terms, number 7, pp. 229–30.

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 10, vol. II, p. 232 [CE VII, p. 410]: "Et ideo concedo quod quaerenda est causa universalitatis, non tamen quaerenda est causa communitatis alia ab ipsa natura; et posita communitate in ipsa natura secundum propriam entitatem et unitatem, necessario oportet quaerere causam singularitatis, quae superaddit aliquid illi naturae cujus est." Therefore Johann Kraus is right to say that the discussion of the problem does not confine itself to the logical level, "Die Lehre des Johannes Duns Scotus," p. 46. We

might add with this interpreter that we are dealing with a physical problem, p. 47, but perhaps it would be better to say *metaphysical*. For the same position, see "Die Lehre," pp. 64–65. For Henry of Harclay's interesting critique of the Scotist concept of universal, see Kraus, "Die Universalienlehre," p. 290, and for Ockham's critique of Harclay, see pp. 291–98. On Harclay, see Franz Pelster, "Heinrich von Harclay: Kanzler von Oxford, und seine Quästionen," in *Miscellanea Francesco Ehrle*, 6 vols (Rome: Bibliotheca Apostolica Vaticana, 1924), vol. I, pp. 307–56.

43 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 2, number 2, vol. II, p. 234 [CE VII, p. 413].

44 The text of *Opus Oxoniense* remits to Henry of Ghent, *Quodlibet* V, question 8, on the point, to whom Scotus attributes a doctrine of individuals by double negation. Cf. Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 8 [EW II, p. 206, number 56].

45 Opus Oxoniense, book II, distinction 3, question 2, number 2, vol. II, p. 235 [CE VII, p. 414].

46 Opus Oxoniense, book II, distinction 3, question 2, number 3, vol. II, p. 235 [CE VII. pp. 414–15].

47 Opus Oxoniense, book II, distinction 3, question 2, number 4, vol. II, pp. 235–36 [CE VII, p. 416].

48 Opus Oxoniense, book II, distinction 3, question 2, number 4, vol. II, p. 236 [CE VII, pp. 4156–417]: "Concedo igitur . . ." Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 9, vol. II, pp. 264–65 [CE VII, pp. 474–75].

49 Richard of Middleton already discussed this theme. Cf. Hocedez, *Richard de Middleton*, p. 207. Duns Scotus energetically criticizes the same doctrine in *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 2 [EW II, p. 193, number 17, and p. 194, number 19]. He sums it up in terms that Aquinas would not repudiate, but which cannot be taken in their Thomist sense, because Scotus infers from them that *esse* is the principle of individuation, which Aquinas never taught. Here we can judge that Scotus envisages Giles of Rome.

50 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book VII, chapter 3, 1029 a 20–30.

51 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 1, vol. II, p. 237 [CE VII, pp. 418–19]. The argument is immediately reproduced in another form: "Illud quod praesupponit coordinationem et distinctionem alterius non est ratio distinguendi ipsum; sed existentia ut determinata et distincta praesupponit ordinem et distinctionem essentiarum; igitur, etc." It is self-evident that, if existence is not individuating, the individuating difference does not imply existence. *Haecceitas* and existence are ultimate in two different orders.

52 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 2, vol. II, pp. 237–38 [CE VII, p. 420]. We have a simple application of a general principle, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, number 9 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 371, number 133]: "Quidquid est in genere abstrahit ab actuali existentia, quia illa tota coordinatio potest salvari in intelligendo illa coordinata, intellectione abstractiva quae non includit existentiam objecti, quia sic esset intellectio intuitiva."

53 Scotus, *Opera Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 3, vol. II, p. 238 [CE VII, pp. 420–21]: "Et ideo concedo quod existentia distinguit ultimate, sed distinctione quae est extra totam per se coordinationem praedicamentalem, quae distinctio est aliquo modo accidentalis, licet non sit vere accidentalis; tamen sequitur totam distinctionem secundum esse quidditativum. Eo ergo modo quo est actus distinguit, et in quo est ultimus actus ultimate distinguit."

54 We omit the authorities but note that they follow here in Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 4, number 1, vol. II, p. 239 [CE VII, pp. 421–23], in the same order as in Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* VII, question 5, vol. III, pp. 319–20.

55 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book V, chapter 13, 1020 a 7–8.

56 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, distinction 3, question 4, number 2, vol. II, p. 240 [CE VII, p. 424]: “Et ex hoc ultra . . .”

57 Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* VII, 5, p. 319: “Videtur ergo quod individuatio fiat per accidentia, et hoc videntur dicere philosophi et sancti doctores. Nam Porphyrius dicit quod indivdua differunt per accidentales proprietates quas nunquam contingit simul in pluribus reperiri. Et Boetius . . .” The authorities that Duns Scotus cites in favor of individuation by quantity, which is an accident, are Godfrey’s authorities in favor of individuation by accidents.

58 Duns Scotus first proposes a theological argument drawn from transubstantiation, where there is change of substance without change of quantity. Inversely, God could conserve the same substance while informing it with another quantity. It will be said that this is a miracle. Yes, but “miraculum non est respectu contradictoriorum ad quae nulla est potentia.” A possible miracle is a possible thing, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 4, numbers 3–4, vol. II, pp. 241–42 [CE VII, pp. 427–29]. Cf. *In Metaphysicam* book VII, question 13, number 5 [EW II, pp. 200–01, number 34].

59 Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, book VII, chapter 1, 1028, a 11–20.

60 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 4, number 5, vol. II, p. 243 [CE VII, pp. 429–31], and further on, number 6, vol. II, p. 244 [CE VII, p. 432]: “Praeterea eodem modo substantia est prior naturaliter omni accidente . . .” Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, numbers 5 and 16 [EW II, pp. 201–02 numbers 35 and 37, and p. 222, number 109].

61 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 4, number 8, vol. II, p. 245 [CE VII, p. 435]. Number 9 [CE VII, pp. 436–38] sums up and discusses another variety of the same thesis, due perhaps to Giles of Rome, *Quodlibet* I, question 5, article 1, which Duns Scotus rejects for reasons similar to his previous ones.

62 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 4, numbers 10–11, vol. II, pp. 247–48 [CE VII, pp. 439–32]. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 16 [EW II, p. 223, number 112]: “Forma non est proprie *haec*, sed est quod aliud est *hoc* . . . Similiter forma individualis determinat naturam specificam, ut sic *haec* vere; non tamen illa forma est proprie *haec*, sive hoc aliquid, quia si sic, tunc sequitur quod differentia esset species.”

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, vol. II, distinction 3, question 4, number 12, vol. II, p. 249 [CE VII, pp. 443–44].

64 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 1, vol. II, p. 259 [CE VII, pp. 463–64].

65 This does not imply that Scotism excludes existence from the structure of the singular. Completely the opposite is true. The singular is composed of all its determinations whatever they are, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 19 [EW II, pp. 229–30, number 131]: “Accipitur individuum, substantia et simul totum stricte, prout includit existentiam et tempus ut hic homo existens et hic lapis existens.” What is true is that once posited in actual being by its cause, its singularity individuates all these accidental determinations and not the reverse. As to singularity it is “unitively contained” within the composite’s highest form, which is inseparable from its individuating difference, without which its existence would be impossible.

66 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, numbers 11–13, pp. 266–68 [CE VII, pp. 478–81]. For the case of determination of the form by its last actuality, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 2, number 14, vol. I, pp. 342–44 [CE III, pp. 95–97].

67 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 14, vol. II, pp. 268–69 [CE VII, p. 482]. Another reason that matter is not the principle of individuation is that it is a nature. Of itself it is not *haec*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 20, vol. II, p.

273 [CE VII, p. 490]. See the objections against this doctrine raised by Guillaume Farnier, O.F.M. in Kraus, "Die Universalienlehre," p. 302, note 2.

68 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 15, vol. II, pp. 269–70 [CE VII, pp. 483–84]. The concept of specifically identical singularities, or of a species of singularities as such, has no meaning, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, numbers 21, 24–25 [EW II, pp. 232–33; 237–40]. Therefore, for us singularity is indefinable. Number 23 [EW II, pp. 235–36, number 258].

69 This is what the term *haecceitas* designates. Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 12, question 6, number 13: "Sic haec unitas minor de se est haec numero, non essentialiter, sed tantum denominative; sed haecceitas est numero haec essentialiter." Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 12, question 6, number 8: "Item, si non potest intelligi inclusum esse nisi hoc, igitur neque includens. Si enim non potest intelligi rationale sub opposito rationalis, igitur nec homo includens rationale; sed non potest intelligi haecceitas, ut universale igitur nec natura speciei includens, cum ipsa haecceitas de se sit haec; igitur impossibile est intelligere naturam specificam ut universale." See also *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, numbers 9 and 26 [EW II, pp. 209–09, and 221–24]. According to Kraus, "De Univeralienlehre," pp. 93–94, the Scotist authenticity of the term is still doubtful. While waiting for this issue to be settled by future critical editions, we can observe that the use of *haecceitas*, which in any event is rare in Duns Scotus himself, became universal in his school. It is a convenient term, whose only drawback is to suggest a *thing* rather than the ultimate point of actuality that determines each real being to singularity. On different interpretations of this doctrine, see C. R. S. Harris, *Duns Scotus*, vol. II, pp. 97–99.

70 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 16, vol. II, pp. 270–71 [CE VII, p. 485]: "et ita totaliter ista compositio perfectissima quae est ex re et re." In the absence of being like that, "its composition is at least that of a *thing* and a *reality*."

71 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 6, number 16, vol. II, p. 271 [I have not found the phrase quoted at CE VII, pp. 270–71]. Consequently, in order to find something existential in Duns Scotus, it is reasonable to look for its substitute in the individual, Béraud de Saint-Maurice, "Existential Import in the Philosophy of Duns Scotus," *Franciscan Studies* IX (1949), pp. 274–313. But it is excessive to conclude, p. 289, that it is a pseudo-problem to ask whether the philosophy of Duns Scotus is essential or existential. Naturally, we can argue about the terms, but it is a fact that in Duns Scotus there is no act of being that is the form's perfection. If there were in Duns Scotus an act of the form really distinct from the form, it would be *haecceitas*. Intrinsically, *haecceitas* is indifferent to existence or nonexistence. The opposition between two doctrines, one of which holds the quiddity to be intrinsically indifferent of itself, while the other regards it as potency whose act is existence, is certainly not imaginary. The simple *possible* is different in the two cases. There is a possibility of existence in Thomism, and a pure absence of existence in Scotism, where "a thing's possibility means no more than blindness in an eye," *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 30, question 2, number 15 [CE VI, pp. 194–95]; cf. Saint-Maurice, "Existential-Import," p. 289.

72 "Das Individuelle ist ein unzurückfuhrbar Letzes," Martin Heidegger, *Die Kategorien und Bedeutungslehre des Duns Scotus* (Tübingen: Mohr, 1916), and before him, Seeberg, *Die Theologie des Johannes Duns Scotus* (reproduced Aalen: Scientia Veri, 1971), pp. 73–74. For the justification of the thesis, see *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, numbers 18–19 [EW II, pp. 226–30].

73 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 12, question 8, number 9.

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 13, vol. II, p. 505. [CE VIII has no distinction 12.]

75 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 16, vol. II, p. 508 [CE VIII has no distinction 12]: "actus et potentia, quae sunt principia entis, sunt primo diversa; materia et forma sunt hujusmodi; ergo materia et forma sunt primo diversa."

76 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 16, vol. II, p. 508 [CE VIII has no distinction 12]: "quod enim aliqua essentia sit extra causam suam, id quod non habeat aliquod esse quo sit essentia, est mihi contradictio." Therefore intrinsically matter is knowable, although it is not knowable for us. It has its proper idea in God that corresponds to its proper being, number 20, vol. II, p. 511. Using a terminology that is not Scotus's, we could say that just as matter is directly caused and not only *co-caused*, it is directly known and not only *co-known*. In the excellent study by Timotheus Barth, O.F.M., "De Fundamento Univocationis apud Joannem Duns Scotum," *Antonianum* XIV (1939), pp. 278–87, the author compares different interpretations of Scotist *ens*. After recalling the interpretations of the old Scotists, Boyvin, Mastrius, and Rada, where *ens* equals *essentia*, Barth prefers Fackler's interpretation, *Der Seinsbegriff in seiner Bedeutung für die Gotteserkenntnis des Duns Scotus* (Friedberg-Augsburg: Bauer, 1933), p. 22. Barth, p. 286, reinforces Fackler's interpretation by attributing to *essentia* not only an aptitude to existence, which the old Scotists always did, but also a *tendentia ad existentiam*. But if essence exists, why would it tend toward existence? And how could it tend to existence, if it did not exist? Once more, the old Scotists were sounder.

77 Bernard Landry, *Duns Scot*, Paris: Alcan, 1922, p. 111. Furthermore, this historian thinks that the critique applies to nominalism as well as to Duns Scotus's realism. The mosaic imagined by nominalists is merely *finer*. In fact, the distinction of form in what is mixed is not that of pieces of a mosaic, which are essentially distinct and juxtaposed in place. That said, we acknowledge that Duns Scotus's position has flummoxed even the old Scotists. Lychetus endeavored to explain how an individual could include partial entities that must be individualized (that is, be individuals) in order to be real.

78 Scotus, *Reportata Parsiensia*, book II, distinction 12, question 1, number 8. In this curious text Duns Scotus counts six entities in the composite: universal matter, individual matter, universal form, individual form, the universal composite, and the individual composite. The terms of this enumeration suggest that we are not dealing with elements actually existent in a distinct state inside the composite, but as always in such cases with formally distinct entities in the identity of being. Duns Scotus even says so explicitly, number 8: "Et formalitas naturae non est formalitas quae est incommunicabilis, nisi denominative; tamen in composito est formalitas quae est communicabilis: igitur sex sunt entitates in composito per identitatem unitive." Here we are not dealing with "res alia sed formalitas alia, idem tamen identice." Further on, number 9: "Dico quod non sequitur quodlibet individuum esse compositum proprie, quia compositio non est proprie nisi ex actu et potentia proprie acceptis; et quod ista proprietas individualis est eadem essentia identitate, ideo ex talibus nunquam proprie fit compositio."—It is hard explain oneself better and to be understood worse. The blindness of Scotists and Suarezians to Thomist *esse* is only equaled by that of Thomists to Duns Scotus's *formalitas*. From Cajetan, *On part I*, question 76, article 1, to Norberto Del Prado, Thomas Aquinas's disciples regard the proposition *tot esse quod entitates* as an intolerable error. Scotus and his disciples, adds Cajetan, *On part I*, question 76, article 3, see neither the nature of being nor that "ex duobus existentibus in actu non potest fieri unum per se ens." But Cajetan himself does not see that Duns Scotus's formal entities precisely lack actual existence. When one comes to speak of his adversaries as does Fr. Del Prado, *De Veritate Fundamentali Philosophiae Christianae*, Freiburg, Switzerland: Ex typis Consociationis Sancti

Pauli 1911, p. 194, note: “Ita omnes, velint, nolint, coguntur dicere . . .” then there is something that has not been understood. Yet we must understand it, even to reject it.

79 This is precisely why the internal formalities contained in the composite must not be realized in the form of actual and actually distinct beings. If we committed to this error, it would indeed be necessary to compose the individual with other individuals. Duns Scotus himself is opposed to it. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 21 [EW II, p. 233]: “Non est tamen nisi una differentia individualis ultima, quae determinat formam specificam.”

80 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 15, sole question, number 3, vol. II, p. 559 [CE VIII does not have distinctions 15 through 25 inclusive].

81 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 15, sole question, number 5, vol. II, pp. 561–62. [CE VIII does not have distinction 15.] See number 6, pp. 562–63, for the way Duns Scotus analyzes Aristotle’s texts on this point. He is far less in line with the Philosopher than he says, but does he really believe he is in agreement? According to Scotus’s doctrine it may occur that a single element is enough to engender a mixture. It is written in Gen. 1:20, “Producent aquae reptile . . .” and so on. But reason confirms this because, if all elements mutually corrupt each other in the generation of the mixture, the mixture would be engendered from nothing. This would not be generation but creation. Consequently, there must be at least one element starting from which the mixture is engendered in every case, number 7, vol. II, p. 563. Still, let us note that the generation of the mixture starting from a single element as the passage of Genesis implies, is only possible “per potentiam divinam,” *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, number 11, vol. II, p. 611 [CE VIII does not have distinction 18.]

82 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 15, sole question, number 9, vol. II, p. 565. [CE VIII does not have distinction 15.]

83 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, number 8, vol. II, p. 608. [CE VIII does not have distinction 18.]

84 Ibid.—Landry, *Duns Scot*, pp. 66–67, seems to have confused two different problems by maintaining that Duns Scotus rejects the doctrine of *seminal reasons*, thereby breaking with Franciscan tradition. A distinction is necessary. Duns Scotus denies that the seminal reason is matter or passive potency of matter, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, number 3, vol. II, pp. 601–02. Likewise, he would not admit without many reservations that the seminal reason is act, and against the old Augustinian school he explicitly questions whether we are forced to posit seminal reasons to make natural causality into authentic creation, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, number 4, vol. II, p. 604, and number 6, end, p. 60. That said, the passages that we analyze establish beyond dispute that Duns Scotus maintains the doctrine of seminal reasons by interpreting them in his fashion, which is quite natural. This fashion peculiar to him consists in amputating the seminal reason from any active causality in generation, in order to reserve to it the role of a kind of directive idea. This is why he calls it *form* rather than *act*, because in his doctrine form can be, *qua* nature, as passive a principle as matter. Supposing that stones have no active principle of motion of themselves, stones nonetheless descend *naturally* if they are moved, because their descent happens according to the inclination of a form. Therefore, the Scotist seminal reason is the passive principle *according to which* the animal’s natural development is produced, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, beginning of number 6, vol. II, p. 606.

85 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, number 10, p. 610. [CE VIII does not have distinction 18.] In the same article, Duns Scotus adds that for the same reasons, the *semen* could not of itself be the cause of the alterations and developments that precede it. Here again, as

Galen and Averroes anticipated, only the presence of a divine element lets us answer the question. It is superfluous to note that these views favor the theologians' position, for whom God alone creates the human soul, and always remains free to create it or not, although all the necessary preparation has been completed, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 16, question 1, number 13.

86 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 18, sole question, number 11, vol. II, p. 611. [CE VIII does not have distinction 18.] Thereby we can explain how Pharaoh's magicians could produce frogs, as St. Augustine says, *De Trinitate*, book III, chapter 7, 12, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 875.

87 Therefore, we must avoid two opposite errors. The first would be to deny that Duns Scotus taught the plurality of forms; the second would be to understand this plurality as the plurality of actually distinct existences within the composite. The proper reality of each of them is the entity of a form. In this sense, the thesis, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 20, number 2 [EW II, pp. 330–32], is against Thomas Aquinas's thesis. See numbers 3–5 [EW II, pp. 333–37]. Duns Scotus taught the plurality of forms, but not in the sense in which Thomas Aquinas denies it. Of course, Scotism's real formal entity cannot be accommodated in Thomism. Even understood in the Scotist sense, the plurality of forms cannot be reformed into Thomas Aquinas's doctrine. To state this differently, we cannot attribute to Duns Scotus on the authortiy of the apocryphal *De Rerum Principio* a doctrine of plurality of forms as does Parthenius Minges among others, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. I, pp. 61–62. By contrast, Antonio Andrés, *Quaestiones super Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, folio 43 recto, was right to maintain that the forms of the composites "are really or specifically distinct" because it is all the same in Duns Scotus: there are as many specifically distinct partial forms in Duns Scotus as there are organs. But, according to Duns Scotus himself, it is necessary to remember that formal plurality does not entail any separation of being. Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 19 [EW II, pp. 229–30], where Duns Scotus shows that the higher degrees are never separated from the lower ones and that "in . . . unitive contentis non est separatio realis nec etiam potentialis." Real being is composed of the nature and all its determinations. Accordingly, it is the *compositum*, not the *natura*, that contains these determinations unitively, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 20 [EW II, p. 231].

88 Moreover, Bernard Landry, *quasi coactus a veritate*, saw this clearly in his *Duns Scot*, p. 79. Having seen it at the end of his development, why did he not retouch the beginning, where he reproaches Duns Scotus for making the particular into a kind of *mosaic*? A cause does not produce a mosaic of being, but a being whose actual unity includes several formalities. These formalities do not form a mosaic. They are arranged hierarchically in the unitive energy of the highest form that includes them.

89 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam* book VII, question 15, number 4 [EW II, p. 257].

90 See Scotus *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 17 [EW II, p. 226]: "Item individuum est verissime ens et unum . . ." and so on.—This does not keep being *qua* being from being the intellect's adequate object. We have noted that univocal being does not include its determinations quidditatively (not even the passions convertible with being). *Ibidem*: "Non est ergo natum intelligi singulare ut pars inclusa in primo intellecto, sed tantum in primum intellectum, in quo alia quaecumque superiora per se intelliguntur."

91 Even the substantial form is ordered *qua* part to the being of the whole. This *esse totius* is also *actus simpliciter*. Cf. *Quodlibet* IX, number 4 [AW, p. 220].

7

The Human Soul

Following the traditional path of the work of the six days, Duns Scotus encounters different problems that catch his attention. God says, “Let there be light, and there was light.” What is *lux*? What is the difference between the luminous source that the word *lux* designates and the rays (*lumen*) that emanate from it? This is an excellent opportunity to utilize optics![1] Further on, Duns Scotus will spend a long time to define the nature of the heavens and even to sum up certain astronomical knowledge for his listeners. Neither the theory of tides nor the theory of epicycles contradicts him. All this is as familiar as Euclid to Scotus, and he expounds them well, but it is not clear that he had a personal position on these questions any more than on the question of the influence of the stars, where we are not surprised that he admits their influence or that he denies that it abolishes human freedom.[2] In these matters, along with some personal nuances, the importance of Duns Scotus is little more than that of a competent witness to the science of his time. The situation becomes different when he comes to the problem of the creation of the soul, where what he says about it deserves our attention. Humans and their last end are directly affected. In cases of this kind the theologian should take a position toward the philosophers, whether to approve or criticize them, but in any case to situate himself.

A Origin and immortality of the soul

Scripture says (Gen. 2:7) that God forms man and breathes the spirit of life into his face: that is, creates his soul in his body. Accordingly, the soul's creation is an object of faith, but is it rationally demonstrable knowledge?[3]

It is certain that the creation of the soul is possible. By this we should understand that the soul can be created in itself and without the body. The soul is form. We even know at least by revelation that the soul is suited to subsist independently of its body. Therefore, we are not dealing with a form by accident, inseparable from the body and consequently such that it could only be created with the body and in the body. A form that can be by itself can be produced by itself. Scripture affirms that Adam's soul was created, and since it was possible, we can be certain that the soul was produced in itself, despite the fact that it was created in its body.

This amounts to say in that the soul was created as a form intrinsically, if it was created. But was it? This is a different question. Let us follow Duns Scotus's answer: "I say that it cannot be demonstrated that the soul is produced by itself. Indeed, it cannot be demonstrated that it is immortal, as we will see in book IV, distinction 3, question 2 [CE XI, pp. 171-189]. Accordingly, it cannot be demonstrated that it is produced in itself and through a proper production."[4] Two points deserve our attention here. The first is the generality of the question. Duns Scotus does not say that this has not been demonstrated, but that it is not demonstrable: *non potest demonstrari*. Next, comes the precise point upon which this negation bears. The soul is produced alone as a distinct created effect. This is what explains the first form of the argument because, if we could demonstrate the immortality of the soul, we would know that it could exist without the body, from which we could conclude that it was indeed created in itself and not insofar as mixed with the body.

But Duns Scotus immediately goes further:

> Even supposing that the soul is immortal and that it does depend on some natural agent to exist or not exist, a philosopher would still not posit it as created. Philosophers would say: the form of the heavens can only be produced by God, and yet we do not say it is created, because God did not

> produce the form of the heavens by a production distinct from the production of the whole heavens, so the form of the heavens was not a term of creation prior to the heavens, prior, we mean, by a priority of nature. Consequently, they would even say when the passive matter is in the required disposition, that God would necessarily create and produce the soul, by a creation whose term would not be the form but the composite. Accordingly, the philosophers would not concede that the soul is what is created, because they would not picture, as we do, that in the first moment of nature or of time God's action is terminated at the being of the soul itself; next, that in a second moment the soul is infused into the body. Rather, they would maintain that from the first instant of nature, God's action is terminated at the being of the whole.[5]

It is clear what precisely is the issue. Duns Scotus does not dispute that the philosophers' God is creator in a certain sense. On the contrary, he tells us in what sense and in what manner this God would create or produce (which here amounts to the same thing for Scotus) the soul.[6] What Duns Scotus affirms is that a philosopher would never imagine, as Christians do, that God could create the soul in itself and for itself and not as a mere part of the composite. The problem of the *moments of nature* assumes the greatest importance here, because the way divine action is conceived varies according to the way the moments are counted. In the philosophers there is a single moment. When the material mixture is suitably tempered to receive the form, God necessarily confers the form upon it. Therefore, this kind of creation of the soul is a necessary action like natural actions, and it is less the creation of a soul than the creation of a composite. For Christians there are two moments, perhaps in time, but in any case in nature. In the first moment, God creates the soul; in the second, he infuses it into the body. From there two differences spring. First, the Christian God is not necessitated in creating the soul by the simple fact that matter is ready to receive it. This creation is free. Second, the soul is thus only created in itself because it is for itself. Obviously, since the soul is part of the human, God must have created it at the same time as the body whose act it is, but nonetheless there are two passive productions there, the

production of the soul (the partial term) and the production of the whole.

Accordingly, the point at which Christians diverge from philosophers is tied to their certainty that human souls have their proper destiny and that if God created them as separate beings, it is because he wanted them to be capable of existing separately. The problems of their creation and their immortality are therefore effectively linked. We see at the same time that the opposition of the philosophers to the Christians (or rather of the Christians to the philosophers) is not posed in terms of *philosophy* and theology. Here as elsewhere, for Duns Scotus, it is the same to say that the creation of the soul for itself *non potest demonstrari* and to say that when questioned on this subject the *philosophers* would answer, as they have in fact answered, that this does not seem demonstrable to them. In the measure in which Scotus thinks about this, *the philosophers for him represent philosophy*, and what philosophy can say is represented by what they have said. Scotus does not think in any way of two orders of equally necessary, although opposed, conclusions, the first of which would be the conclusions of *philosophy* and the second those of faith or of *theology*. The opposition about which Scotus thinks is not of principle but of fact. Scotus is far from picturing the philosophers themselves as being the only ones capable of expressing rational truths, nothing but rational truth, and the whole rational truth. He does not see them in this way at all, but as perplexed minds who are often deluded about the value of their proofs, because sometimes they presume to demonstrate certain conclusions, although they are false, and sometimes they maintain true conclusions that they are incapable of demonstrating.

The problem of the immortality of the soul is a good example. Some say it is a demonstrable conclusion, because philosophers have admitted it. But what is the philosophers' authority worth? If we are talking about Aristotle himself, we do not know exactly what he thought, because he talks differently in various places, and he appeals to diverse principles, some of which imply the immortality of the soul, while others logically lead to the opposite conclusion. But the true answer is different. It is that the philosophers have not demonstrated by natural reasons everything they have

affirmed: *non omni dicta a philosophis erant ab eis probata per necessariam rationem naturalem*. They are often satisfied with defensible probabilities, or they even confine themselves to the ordinary opinions of those who preceded them: *frequenter non habebant nisi quasdam probabiles persuasiones vel vulgarem opinionem praecedentium philosophorum*. Consequently, they are often content with little by way of proofs,[7] on one side or the other. If they really hold that the soul is immortal, it would be necessary not to accept their word for it. But if they maintain the opposite, that does not prove they have demonstrated it.[8] In fact, we cannot demonstrate by the philosophers that the soul is immortal, but we can demonstrate by the philosophers that it is possible that it is immortal. Christian faith needs no more to have the path open to it, and philosophers have no serious argument here to prevail against the teaching of the theologians.

Consider Averroes, for example, he denies the rational soul's immortality for the simple reason that he denies its individual existence. How could the individual intellectual soul be immortal since it has no intellect proper to it? Those who view Duns Scotus as a kind of Averroist would do well to ponder his reply to this proposition. He calls the opinion of Averroes admitting only a single intellectual soul common to all humans: "The vilest and most unreasonable of all the errors of philosophers and, moreover, manifestly contrary to the intention of his teacher Aristotle. The opinion is very unreasonable because it debases human nature more than any other opinion and does so unnecessarily, since according to the principles of his master, all possible dignity must always be attributed to human nature."[9]

What a strange Averroist who would claim to work back to Averroes upon what the Philosopher taught! Duns Scotus has his reasons. We discover that here, because Scotus has treated the nature of souls at the same time as the nature of angels. The fact is that the problem is the same. At first sight it hardly matters whether we admit that there can be several angels of the same species, but the theologians who grant this to Averroists ought to watch out that if there can only be an angel of each species, there can only be one intellectual soul for the same reason. It is said that since angels are pure

forms, they are not numerically distinguishable into individuals, but souls are also pure forms, although they are perfective of matter. If the numerical distinction of angels were impossible from the point of view of the form, the numerical distinction of souls would be impossible for the same reason. It would be useless to object that souls have diverse inclinations to different bodies, which distinguish them numerically and individualize them. It is not because a soul has a particular inclination toward a particular body that a soul is a particular soul. It is because it is a particular soul that it inclines toward a particular body. An inclination is not an absolute entity. On the contrary, the inclination supposes a distinct, absolute entity to which it belongs.[10]Why do we say that Averroes contradicts his master here? We can read in *De Anima* what Aristotle thinks of the relation of soul to body.[11] The body parts of the deer differ from those of the lion, because the deer's soul differs from the lion's. The form is what provides itself with the body parts it needs; matter does not choose the form. Once again the theologian can select the truth among the teachings of the philosopher and say what is right among them and on what points, even when the philosopher speaks more truly than he can prove.

Accordingly, let us leave Aristotle and see which operation of the intellectual soul implies, if not its immortality, at least the possibility of its immortality. The form can only be defined here a posteriori and starting from its operations. The operation proper to humans is the act of intellectual knowledge: *intelligere*. This act corresponds to humans formally—*formaliter*—because humans can exercise it by virtue of their form. This proposition is so obvious that one would have to cease being human to deny it. It is almost a fact of experience. Each of us can observe in himself that he knows intellectually, and this is the experience of an operation in which no corporeal organ takes part. Every organ belongs to a determined kind. It involves a kind of mixture that makes it sensitive to the opposites of one kind, like white and black for sight, sweet and bitter for taste, hot and cold for touch, and so on. Consequently, every operation of sense knowledge is tied to an organ, limited to a certain kind, and is concerned with the contrary qualities of that same

kind. But we have the experience of an operation and knowledge of being under its most common and most universal reason. Accordingly, its object is broader than either the particular or commons sensible. If this were not so, the naturally known science that is metaphysics could not consider being *qua* being. In a word, lacking an object, it would not be a science, which means it would not exist.

It is necessary to go further, because a being that engages in intellectual knowledge by virtue of its form does not possess its intellections because it causes them, but because it receives them. Therefore, if humans formally exercise intellection, it is because there is something in them to receive it. For the reason just stated, this receptor cannot be the body or part of the body or some organ. It can only be the soul alone or the whole human being by reason of the soul. Consequently, if this operation is in humans by virtue of their forms (*formaliter*), the intellectual soul must be the form of humans. If the intellectual form is not in us, then the receptor of the intellection is not in us formally, that is *qua* form. The receptor would be like that of color, which is only in a body by its surface, the immediate receptor of color. If the surface were not in the body, color would not be there. If the intellectual soul were not in humans, the intellection would not be there either.[12]

That such an intellectual soul may be immortal is clear, but it is a completely different matter to demonstrate that it is. As we have said, Aristotle appeals to different principles, some of which invite us to consider the soul immortal while others would lead us rather to conclude that it is not. At bottom, Aristotle never knew clearly what the nature of the human form was, and the only immortality that he really attributed to it would be reducible to that of an operation that does not require an organ. Moreover, if Aristotle really made the soul the proper form of the body and not of the whole, he must have regarded it as corruptible like the composite whose form it was. Furthermore, the doubt that hovers over the origin of the soul in this doctrine affects the problem of its immortality. No passage in Aristotle shows that in his eyes the soul or any other form of any composite comes to it from the outside.[13] He rather seems to have admitted that the soul comes to the

human composite from within as drawn from the possibility of matter, and that consequently it is destined to be corrupted when it returns to matter. The fact that matter, principle of corruption, is not part of the soul does not prove that the soul is incorruptible. That the human composite of which the soul is part has matter suffices for the composite's corruption to entail the corruption of the soul that informs it. Thus, although the soul is neither intrinsically engendered nor intrinsically corruptible, it is corrupted by the corruption of the whole, as every accidental form is corrupted along with its subject.[14]

A master of theology could not maintain this position at the beginning of the fourteenth century (especially not in Paris) without considering Thomas Aquinas's opposing position. Duns Scotus did that in the *Reportata Parisiensia* and in one of his remarkable quodlibetic questions. The misunderstanding that divides these two philosophers of being impregnates every line and almost every word of the discussion. St. Thomas's whole argument in its peculiarly Thomist bent rests upon the concept of an act of being exercised by the soul and communicated by it to the body. In such a doctrine, which deepens the Platonic concept of the soul-as-life by pursuing it to the level of soul-as-act-of being, it is self-evident that the soul cannot lose its being when the degeneration of the body no longer permits it to receive the soul. In Duns Scotus, there is no *esse* by which an essence is a being. Now, the term *esse* simply designates the substance itself taken in its actual reality outside its cause and outside the intellect. Accordingly, it is not clear how the soul would communicate its *esse* to the body. The soul has its *esse* as part of the composite. The whole has its *esse* of whole. But nothing proves that the being-as-part that belongs to the soul allows it to subsist itself as a whole after the composite's dissolution. We would be sure if we could prove that the soul is created directly in itself and for itself, but that is what Aristotle never tried to establish, and it is not even clear how we could demonstrate it starting from the principles posited by the philosophers.[15]

The same goes for another Thomist thesis that is intimately connected to the previous one, that the soul is not an accidental but a substantial form. As such, it intrinsically has the act of being (*per se habet esse*). Consequently, it

can only be engendered or corrupted by itself, not by the generation or corruption of the body. From Duns Scotus's point of view, the argument formulated in this way rests upon a petition of principle.[16] Scotus takes for granted that the soul is a substantial form and that it possesses its proper being independently of the body, "but this proposition is believed and not known through natural reason," *sed haec propositio credita est et non per rationem naturalem nota*. We do not ask now whether it is necessary to believe it, something beyond doubt, but whether it can be known, and it certainly must be recognized that no philosopher seems capable of offering any demonstration of it. Those who follow the philosophers commit the same error of granting what they claim to demonstrate.[17]

We should situate the famous argument *by the natural desire for immortality* in the same classification. The desire to live forever exists, but it is nothing but the natural inclination to a particular act. In this sense, Aristotle says that nature in all beings always wants to be as much as corresponds to it, but that does not entail that it can always be; and we even see by the corruption of composites that it cannot be so. Furthermore, is it really certain that living beings desire immortality and incorruptibility of the soul? That is not obvious. Perhaps they would prefer to on forever being what they are.[18] But to continue, admitting that humans naturally desire that their souls should be immortal would prove nothing. Humans may want the impossible. It would first be necessary to prove that immortality is possible because this proposition "is not known by our natural light or natural reason," *non est nota lumine naturali, nec ratione naturali*. It will be replied that Aristotle certainly affirms that nature always wants what is best, and, since immortality is better than corruptibility, nature must necessarily want the soul to be immortal. Let us grant that. It does not follow from that that each intellectual soul is individually immortal. Nature can satisfy its desire for the best in the way Aristotle seems to have thought it does, by giving immortality and incorruptibility to the human species, not to individuals. Then the species is immortal by the incessant corruption and generation of individuals, and each individual soul is only indirectly corruptible or, as they say, corruptible by

accident, in so far as it is one of the moments of the eternal species.[19]

In the end, all these philosophical arguments fail because they try to prove that God had to do something that he is free to do or not do. This is why it is useless to pore over the doctrine of the philosophers to abstract an answer to the question. From their habitual viewpoint, God acts necessarily. Consequently, how would they prove anything that concerns a subject that falls within God's freedom? If souls are beings by themselves and independently of the body, God gives them the *per se esse* that characterizes substances. Accordingly, souls are not by themselves in the sense that they exist by themselves, without receiving their being from God. They are by themselves in the sense that their being is not an accident's being. It does not follow from this that souls do not depend on the body. The form of fire is not in the matter of an accident. Nevertheless, it depends on matter. All substantial forms depend on God. Nevertheless, they are not accidents of God or of the universe. "Therefore, on this point I see no demonstrable reason that justifies this conclusion necessarily. But upon this we have the Savior's manifest authority (Matthew 10:28): 'Do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. But be rather afraid of him who is able to destroy both soul and body in hell.'"[20]

The immortality of the soul is thus a proposition whose truth is possible, probable, and even more probable than the contrary proposition. If Duns Scotus does not regard it as demonstrable, that is not because he entertains any skepticism in regard to philosophy, but because the principles of philosophy, as *philosophers* conceive them, do not seem to Scotus to allow this demonstration. Everything depends on the concept of being. If, as St. Thomas has it, the intellectual soul is a spiritual form endowed with an act of being, it perdures of itself so naturally that a divine act would be required to destroy it. If, on the contrary, the soul is a real essence whose existence stems immediately from its cause and not from an act of being that the soul receives from its cause, the metaphysical analysis of the soul finds no intrinsic principle of perpetuity there. History shows amply that when a thinker, even someone so deeply Thomist as Cajetan, neglects the role of the *actus essendi*

in the problem, he necessarily comes to coincide with Duns Scotus's position.[21] The reason is simple: as Thomistic as Cajetan is and even an eminent defender of the composition of *esse* and *essentia*, Cajetan speaks on this issue as if, since *esse* was no longer the act of being, it was also not natural for the soul to exist except in the circle of full being. Initially an opponent of Trombetta in his commentary on *De Ente et Essentia*, Cajetan finishes as if he had agreed with him long since.

B The soul and the form of corporeality

Nothing makes it clearer how theological concerns prevail over philosophical ones in Duns Scotus's mind than the place where we find some of his most important metaphysical theses. In order to clarify completely the relation of the soul to souls and, even generally, to the forms that constitute the human composite, we must reach book IV, distinction 11, question 3 of the *Opus Oxoniense*: *Utrum panis convertatur in corpus Christi in Eucharistia*? There is always a theological justification for the place in which this kind of philosophical discussion is introduced, and that is apparent in the present problem. The theologian employs the metaphysician's technique at the opportune moment. The issue is to know what the sacramental words produce at the moment of the consecration. For the believer, and therefore for the theologian, transubstantiation changes bread and wine to the body and blood of Jesus Christ. But what is the body of Jesus Christ? What is human nature composed of? Philosophically speaking, different theologians respond to this question according to the way in which they represent the metaphysical structure of the human soul. Duns Scotus discusses several of these replies, for example, that of Giles of Rome and that of Henry of Ghent, but we will particularly review the examination to which Scotus submits the answer of St. Thomas Aquinas.

According to Aquinas, the answer is simple, because he holds the unity of the form in the composite. In Christ's human nature, as in that of every human, there is only prime matter and intellectual soul, and this is true for a

very simple reason: “there is one *esse* for one being; there is one *esse* from one form; therefore there is one form for one being.”[22] Furthermore, Thomas Aquinas observes that every form that is added to the substantial form can only be an accidental form. An accidental form does not give *esse*: it simply gives this being. Its advent does not determine a generation, and its departure does not determine a corruption.[23] To these reasons and others that Scotus finds unconvincing, he adds one of his own invention that impacts him much more (*plus valet omnibus praecedentibus*) because it rests upon a principle dear to him, “multiplicity is not to be assumed without necessity,” *pluralitas non est ponenda sine necessitate*. Indeed, what better occasion might there be to economize in beings? Since the more perfect form virtually contains in itself the less perfect, as the quadrilateral contains the triangle, it is superfluous to posit a lower form in humans distinct from the higher form that contains it. What happens after the consecration according to theologians who think this way? At the priest’s words, the bread is transubstantiated into a composite of matter and intellectual soul, neither *qua* intellectual nor as constituting the composite human, but *qua* giving corporeal *esse* and constituting the composite that is the body. For our theologians, one and the same soul constitutes the being (*esse*) of the human, the animal, the body, and of the substance, with real distinction of several forms, because the form of the intellectual soul, which is more perfect than the others, virtually contains them all. In that way, this form can first act so that the soul gives corporeal *esse*, *esse corporeum* without giving intellective *esse*, *esse intellectivum*.[24]

When the problem is to find out what kind of being belongs to Christ under the Eucharistic species, the historian of philosophy becomes aware of intruding into what does not concern him. The point is important, however, for someone who wants to understand what philosophical technique Duns Scotus employs. In no way do we mean that he chose it here to resolve a theological problem more easily. The opposite is evident, because he just as well could have recurred to the solution of Thomas Aquinas or that of Henry of Ghent or Giles of Rome, each of whom in his fashion achieved harmony with dogma. On the contrary, Scotus’s personal philosophical position is

what impels him to reject their answers and to propose a new one. As Scotus's answer implies taking a position on the problem of plurality of forms, his way of posing it must be considered. Duns Scotus is going to require the presence of a form of corporeality in the case *where no higher form is present*. This point's importance will become progressively apparent.

Scotus begins by granting Thomas Aquinas his first proposition: there is one *esse* for one being, *unius entis unum est esse*. There is a single *esse* where there is a single being. If Scotus agreed with the sense in which Thomas took the proposition, they would inevitably agree on all the rest, but we know that the term *esse* does not have the same meaning in Scotus as in Thomas Aquinas. Accordingly the agreement is only verbal, and as is normal when positions diverge from the start, they continue to differ. Let us first take Duns Scotus's argument in its entirety:

> I grant the first proposition that there is a single *esse* for a single being. As for the second, that a single *esse* only requires a single form, it is necessary to deny that, unless we take esse in the same sense in the major and in the minor premises. Being and one, *ens* and *unum* are divided into simple and composed. In the same way, *esse* and *unum esse* are divided into such and such being (*scilicet*, in being *esse* and being *unum esse*). Therefore, the fact of being one intrinsically (*esse per se unum*) does not confer simple *esse* precisely as such (*esse simplex praecise*).

In other words, the concept of being implies the concept of unity, but it does not imply that this unity is that of a simple being. It only requires that every being should have the unity suitable to its proper degree of simplicity or complexity. This is the place to recall the hierarchy of unities that Duns Scotus recognizes, from unity of aggregation, *unitas aggregationis*, which is only the unity of a pile, to the perfectly simple unity of the infinite being. Whatever we make of this general classification, it remains clear that the composite is one *qua* whole, but that it includes partial *esse*s, so that the whole is a single being, but is composed of several partial entities. Once again, the *esse* of which Duns Scotus speaks is that of real substance, not that of simple and indivisible *actus essendi*, by virtue of which a thing is a being

according to Thomas Aquinas. The Subtle Doctor is not unaware of this. He perceives that the *esse* of which he speaks is not the *esse* of which Thomas Aquinas spoke, but the nature of the latter seems illusory to Scotus and, as he says himself, he does not know what it is: *nescio istam fictionem*. "I do not know what this invention is, of an *esse* happening to the essence without being composed if the *esse* is composed." Let us reflect upon this term, which like so many others leads us to the heart of the debate. *Nescio istam fictionem, quod esse est quid superveniens essentiae non compositum, si essentia est composita*. Since the Thomist *actus essendi* is a fiction, the only *esse* that the whole can have is the *esse* of what the whole is, and how could it be a whole if its parts were nothing? "Thus, the *esse* of the composite whole includes the *esse* of all its parts. It includes numerous partial *esse*s of numerous parts or of numerous forms, as a total being composed of numerous forms includes these partial actualities."[25]

The doctrine of plurality of forms is thus affirmed in the context of the *forma corporeitatis*, which itself is introduced in the context of the problem of transubstantiation. We would not dream of disputing the general character of the solution or even of weakening the expression, but it is necessary to specify its meaning, and although an even more favorable occasion to do so will present itself in the context of the relation of the soul to its powers, it will be useful to orient ourselves already toward a correct interpretation of the problem. Let us remember first of all that Duns Scotus here asks what the form of a body might be, if it is not the form of corporality. But he immediately asks what the lower forms become under the higher forms of the composite whole, and we cannot grasp the meaning of his answer without giving it the necessary attention.

Duns Scotus is going to maintain both that the partial forms subsist actually, really, and distinctly in the form of the composite whole, and that they only subsist there virtually and insofar as included in this form. He will maintain it at the same time but not in the same regard, so that we can say indifferently that he admitted or rejected the doctrine of the plurality of forms, unless we prefer to say what would be truer, that Duns Scotus admits

the plurality of forms but understood in a way that does not exclude their unity on another level. This is not a question of words, but rather a question of the meaning of words, which is quite different.

Moreover, we see this in the Subtle Doctor's commentary on his own position. He agrees that the whole composite's *formal esse* comes to it from a single form that is its principle. He agrees that, thanks to this form, the whole is *hoc ens*. Lastly, he agrees that this is the last form, which comes after all previous ones: So much for the formal unity of the whole, now for the plurality of forms.

> So, the composite whole is divided into two essential parts. On the one hand we have its proper act, namely the last form by virtue of which it is what it is. One the other hand, we have the proper potency of this act, which includes prime matter with all prior forms. In this sense, I agree that this total *esse* holds its complete being from a single form that confers what it is on the whole. But it does not follow that the whole only contains precisely one form and that several forms are not included in the whole, not as conditioning this composite specifically, but as included in the composite's potential (*sed tanquam quaedam inclusa in potentiali istius compositi*).[26]

Furthermore, the example of the animal organism confirms this view, because the more perfect a living being is, the more it requires organs, and it is probable that these organs are specifically distinct by virtue of distinct substantial forms. This is what happens most frequently in composites. In the measure in which composition grows, unity and being become more true than they are in their parts, where the composition is less.

It would have been difficult for Duns Scotus to express himself more clearly, and the confusion in which his answer leaves us arises for us, not for him, who understood himself very well. We would like to know precisely what kind of being to attribute to these multiple forms whose persistence within the composite Scotus affirms. It is clear that the highest substantial form finishes the completion of the whole. In this capacity, that is to say, *completive* and insofar as it does so, this form is the total essence of the being that possesses it: "the whole substance of the thing is in a complete way, just

as the whole essence of what has the form is in a complete way by the ultimate form."[27] But it does not suppress those forms that it completes when it completes the unity of the whole, and we would like to know whether these forms retain the kind of distinction within the composite that the members of a living body have in the unity of the body. Since it would be useless to imagine a response, we may prudently wait for the moment in which Duns Scotus himself will judge it good to give it to us.

Let us return to the objection that Scotus himself raises, declaring it to be stronger than the others, and which, he repeats, looks impressive: "it has good evidence," *habet evidentiam bonam*. It is that beings must not be multiplied without necessity. Consequently, why not be satisfied with the intellectual soul. If we admit that the intellectual soul includes the vegetative and sensitive souls, and that they in turn include the form of corporeality, it would suffice to posit the intellectual soul to save ourselves all the others. Duns Scotus replies that this is precisely a case where there is need to multiply beings. Why is there a need? In a general way, there is the necessity that requires that we distinguish one thing from another, in other words, there would be a contradiction in failing to distinguish several beings within beings when they are indeed distinct. When a thing is and another is not, they are not the same being, or if we prefer, their *esse* is not the same. To acknowledge this fact is not to multiply beings without necessity, but to count as many of them as there are.

That is the case here. When an animal dies, its corpse remains. Consequently, after the departure of the vegetative soul, there must remain a form of corporeality. "Therefore, the form by virtue of which the body is a body is other than the form by which it is alive: therefore, the body, which is the other part remaining in its proper *esse* without the soul, consequently has a form by which it is a body in this way, and does not have a soul; and so that form is necessarily other than the soul." Here again, the reasoning is as clear as possible, but we continue to wonder whether the form of corporeality already subsisted under the vegetative soul in the same way as after the vegetative soul's departure. There are reasons to pose the question from Duns

Scotus's own point of view. What remains after the departure of the soul is not exactly a body, but a cadaver. A stone is a body; a human cadaver is only the bodily remains of a human as also the separated soul that has just left the body is another remains. It is only by reduction to their whole, that is to the human, that one is a body and the other is a substance.[28] The fact that the cadaver tends toward rapid decomposition makes us see that it is not a being in the full sense of the word. The form of corporeality is no longer enough to conserve it, and consequently we wonder whether it is then in the same state as when it was included under the form of the whole.

This uncertainty will be lifted by the examination of the passages where Duns Scotus defines the relation of the soul to its powers, but for now we can formulate the solution's principle. It is found in the distinction that Duns Scotus consistently makes between the order of formality and the order of actual being. The container, which is to say here the form of the composite whole, is not *formally* its content, but it is as perfect, *qua* being, as if it contained the whole reality of the lower forms that it includes.[29] Consequently, it is necessary to conceive that in the same human, the form of corporeality, the vegetative soul, the sensitive soul, and the intellectual soul are formally distinct. Sometimes Duns Scotus goes so far as to speak of real distinction in this context, provided that we understand the expression as being applied to the entity of the formality as such. It is true that if a form being is other than another form it is *really* other than it. This sign lets us recognize their distinction's reality: one can be completely known without the other. However, it does not follow that in the composite each of these forms has its proper actual existence, distinct from the actual existence that the form of the whole has. This is why the intellectual soul really animates and informs the body down to its least parts as if it were the vegetative soul, whose perfection moreover it includes. It is also for this reason that each of these souls, even each of their powers, is in the others,[30] since all are included in the highest power. In short, from the point of view of actual existence, *sensitiva anima et vegetativa in homine eadem anima est cum intellectiva*.[31] The study of the soul's powers is going to confirm this.

C Soul and faculties

We defined the rational soul when we had to define the angel,[32] but it remains for us to describe the soul's structure and first of all the relations of the soul's *powers* or faculties to the soul.[33]

With the exception of the plurality of forms, with which the question of the relation of soul to its powers is confused, there are few points of Scotist doctrine where the historian is confronted with more difficulties. The reason is that here as elsewhere, if only to situate the doctrine more easily, it is compared to that of St. Thomas. Duns Scotus himself does so, as he has a right to do, and since he involves himself in this area, his historian must follow him, but not without taking precautions ahead of time against certain misconceptions. We know that according to St. Thomas the soul's powers are really distinct from it. We also know that according to Duns Scotus, they are not really distinct from it. The conclusion is almost inevitable that Duns Scotus thinks the contrary of what Thomas thought. To begin with, we only ask that the possibility of a third hypothesis be considered because it may be that Duns Scotus thought neither the same as St. Thomas nor the opposite, but something else. If there are grounds for the supposition, it will lead us once again to acknowledge that the two doctrines are incommensurate, which would not be surprising. For them to be commensurate, the two concepts of *identity* and *distinction* would have to have the same meaning in both. We will see that they do not. It is necessary to refrain from defining Duns Scotus's thought by simple opposition to that of St. Thomas because, even when Scotus contradicts Aquinas, the affirmation and the negation seldom bear upon the same object.

Here we find again the famous formal distinction, which, after having been employed many times by Duns Scotus, will become an inexhaustible subject of speculation and often a topic of controversy among the Scotists.[34] Philosophically speaking, the distinction seems to be based on a thesis dear to Avicenna, which the Subtle Doctor often used: distinct realities correspond to

distinct concepts. Obviously then, the realities do not necessarily exist separately, but in reality there is always a distinction of being corresponding to the distinction of our concepts. Moreover, this feature of Avicenna's doctrine has been emphasized in the connection to the curiously pre-Cartesian doctrine of the flying man, where it is proven that, since a man who did not feel his body would still know he exists, the soul is a being distinct from the body. To that, let us add that in a doctrine where the quiddity possesses at least a proper entity, if not actual existence, it is easy to conceive that a distinct reality would correspond to this concept. This in fact is the first characteristic of the formal distinction in Duns Scotus: a being possesses as many distinct formalities as the intellect can form distinct concepts.[35]

Its second characteristic is to be a real distinction in the sense that it precedes in reality any act of the intellect. In other words, our concepts are not what confer their distinction on the formalities. To the contrary, by their distinction the formalities are the basis of the distinction of our concepts. For this distinction to be real, it is not necessary for it to be actual in the sense that two things exist separately,[36] but a distinct datum in reality must correspond to each of the distinction's terms in our thought. As Duns Scotus says, it is the least among the real distinctions, *minima a parte rei*, but it is real because, even when two formalities belong to just one being, they are as distinct as if they belonged to two actually distinct beings.[37]

One of the reasons that make us hesitate about the meaning of this doctrine is that we spontaneously emphasize the aspect of *distinction*, whereas we ought to stress the realities that are the basis of the distinction. The imagination seeks something in the distinction that can distinguish the realities, as if it were not rather their respective natures that posit them as distinct. Yet, Duns Scotus does his best to dispel this illusion. He often returns to the idea that for an entity to be distinct it ought first to be, and it is in the measure in which it is one. The less strict the unity is, the less distinct the being is. Let us recall that at the bottom of the ladder is *unitas aggregationis*, which is the unity of a pile of stones and is reduced to contiguity of the parts in a place. Above comes unity of order, *unitas ordinis*,

where the relation to the same term connects all the parts. Further up yet is unity by accident, *unitas per accidens*, which includes the unity of order, but adds to it the information of one being by another. Still higher is intrinsic unity, *unitas per se*, which stems from the union of essential principles intrinsically in potency and intrinsically in act in the structure of the composite. Lastly, at the top we find unity of simplicity, *unitas simplicitatis*, which is genuine identity, because all that is there is not only united to the rest but identical.

These are the most obvious types of unity. But among cases of unity of simplicity or identity, *formalis identitas* should be set apart. Duns Scotus says that there is formal identity when the identical includes the identical its formal reason and therefore intrinsically and immediately: "I say formal identity when that which is said to be down includes that say thing to which it is the same in its formal reason, and in consequence intrinsically in the first manner." *Voco autem identitatem formalem ubi illud quod dicitur sic idem includit illud, cui sic est idem, in ratione sua formali et per consequens per se primo modo*. We immediately see that what is one by virtue of this unity is fully other than what is not included in it. For example, if there is something intellectual in a being, everything that possesses the form of intellectuality in common is immediately other than what has the form of voluntary in the same being: "it ought to be called formal nonidentity rather than distinction." *Non identitas formalis potius quam distinctio dicenda*. Consequently, the best way of expressing oneself would be: *this is not formally that*, and in this sense it is distinct from it.[38] Duns Scotus makes these specifications in the context of the distinction of persons within the unity of the divine essence, and it is easy to understand how in this regard he insists on the positive aspect of the distinction. Of all the cases where we must recall that the formal distinction of itself entails no actual distinction, none demands more imperiously that we do so than the distinction of divine persons. Yet even when real identity is at its peak, it is not *formal* identity, in regard to what is said of the Father as Father and the Son as Son. In this we cannot compare finite being to God,[39] but whatever beings we are dealing with, a formal

nonidentity is always the basis of the formal distinction, whose positive element and reality it is.

This is the case here. In Aquinas two distinct substantial forms always define two really distinct beings. In Scotus, several distinct substantial forms do not always define several really distinct beings. Thus, while a Thomist being can only have one form, a Scotist being can have several without thereby ceasing to be one. There, we might say, is the famous doctrine of the plurality of forms. Yet, it is not a doctrine of plurality of Thomistic forms. The retort will be that this is evident, but in turn we will answer that what historians know in principle, they constantly loses sight of in his interpretation. It is even why so many interpreters of Duns Scotus, not only Thomists but even Scotists, do not know what to make of passages that seem to them to express contrary tendencies. To sum up this paradox briefly, let us say that the philosopher of the unity of the form continually introduces real distinctions into the substance, and that the philosopher of the plurality of forms continually rejects these distinctions. That is understandable. The only cause of finite being that is truly one and assures unity in Thomism is *esse*. As long as it is there, no distinction will break the unity of being. It is not there in Scotism. Therefore, if we introduce real distinction into finite being in Scotism, we fragment it into several beings. This is why Duns Scotus rejects distinctions of this kind, but since essences are richer in intelligibility insofar as they are nobler, he admits that we can always distinguish the perfections of each thing formally. From that come the being's formalities that never entail real distinction except between simply formal beings. Accordingly, if there is really plurality of forms in Scotism, something we do not know yet, it will express the freedom the metaphysician has to multiply forms, since they do not divide being. To begin with, this is the way we understand how the same doctor who admits at least six forms in every being, continues to repeat that beings must not be multiplied without necessity.

Initially, we hesitated to propose general interpretations, which could not convince anyone in this form. But the point is more to comprehend than to convince, and the analysis of texts will make it clear, through the study of

specific cases, what is reasonable to retain from the interpretation.

Duns Scotus studies the relation of the soul to its faculties in the context of a theological problem: what does the image of the Trinity in the soul consist of? To start his philosophical reflection on this question, Duns Scotus formulates it as follows: does the image of the Trinity in the soul consist of three really distinct faculties? These three faculties could be intellect, will, and memory, but the theologian's whole effort will fall upon the first two ("I do not speak of the memory now," *de memoria modo non loquor*), as if after Augustine, the influence of Aristotle, Avicenna, and Averroes had relegated to the background a doctrine that is difficult to fit into peripatetic philosophy. However, Scotus does not hesitate, and for want of finding a ready-made answer in Augustine to the question posed in this way, he at least takes the principle from Augustine. In *De Trinitate*, book XIII, chapter 8, 11, Augustine says: "The image must be sought in what is best in our soul." There is nothing better in the soul than the essence. Therefore, if the image resides in the intellect and will, they cannot be really distinct from the essence of the soul; otherwise, since the essence is better than them it would not be true that the image would be in what is best in the soul. Again, in *De Trinitate*, book XV, chapter 7, 12, Augustine says that memory belongs to the image and represents the Father. The same holds for the intellect, which represents the Son. He justifies this last point by observing that perfect memory is the sufficient principle of intellection. Let us say that perfect memory is intellection's first act, because the first act is the principle of operation. The intellect is also the principle of operation. Since the memory and the intellect are the first acts of the same operations, these two powers are not really distinct, and the same goes for the will.[40]

This, in fact, is the position of Duns Scotus: the powers of the soul are not actually distinct, either from each other or from the soul's essence. The general reason that Scotus gives for this, by using Aristotle's principle that nature always acts for the best thing possible,[41] is that economy of means is always preferable when it is possible: *paucitas sine multitudine est melior in natura, si sit possibilis*. So, if it were possible to obtain different acts with a

single essence, without real distinction of the soul's powers, we can be certain that nature does so.[42] The conclusion is important in itself, but the principle from which it is deduced is still more important for the general interpretation of Duns Scotus. Some will say that this is already "Ockham's razor." Really, if it is anyone's razor, it is Aristotle's. However, to keep only to the use Duns Scotus makes of it, it is especially his own.[43] It is necessary to remember always that this doctrine, which on the one hand multiplies formalities indefinitely,[44] economizes almost avariciously in beings. Like a true Scot, Duns Scotus avoids useless expenditures, except where the issue is giving, which is the case of God, who gives everything for nothing. But we are speaking of nature here, which is economical, and we must expect that its interpreter avoids superfluous division or obliterates those that others have introduced without necessity. Since the soul's essence suffices to produce, through the faculties, the different acts that the faculties carry out, there is no need to deny their existence or to make them distinct beings from which, in fact, the soul can dispense in order to act.

Nevertheless, let us suppose that a real distinction is introduced between the soul and its powers. What kind of reality would we need to attribute to them? Some say that the powers are accidents that flow from the substance,[45] and that they are really distinct from it for this reason. They assert that it is impossible that a power of the soul should be its essence, because the operation is substance only in God, whose operation is his very substance. Moreover, this is why God's power, which is the principle of his operation, is God's essence, which is not true of any creature, even an angel, because the *essentia* of the created always differs from its *esse*, while in God the *essentia* is identical to his *esse*. Therefore, in God there is identity of *esse*, *essentia*, *potentia*, and *operatio*.[46] But Duns Scotus is not convinced. There is an equivocation in the term *potentia* there, Scotus says. It sometimes means the principle of an operation, sometimes the opposite of act. St. Thomas argues as if it would be contradictory for the soul's essence, which is act, to be at the same time a power of operating. Nothing is less contradictory, because we see clearly that the soul cannot be act and potency at the same time and under

the same respect, but we do not see why the soul would not be an act endowed with power to operate. Duns Scotus immediately adds an observation that should be pondered. “Besides, in the soul, this act possesses an active virtue in regard to these powers, because flowing from the essence supposes active virtue in the essence.”[47] There is a greatness and depth in the way philosophers and sometimes theologians fail to understand each other to the point that we can rightly speak of *profound* incomprehension. Duns Scotus clearly sees that in order for the powers to flow from the essence, an active force must impel them to gush forth. There is none in the essence as he conceives it. Therefore, he does not see how the powers can be made to emerge. Obviously, in the passage he has before him and challenges, Aquinas remits to the article on the angel, where it turns out that *esse* is the active principle in *essentia*. But when Duns Scotus thinks about this *esse*, he simply declares, “I do not understand,” *non capio*. Indeed, this does not fall within his perspectives. It would be contradictory for the same mind to see two different metaphysical universes simultaneously.

In the same article of the *Summa Theologiae* (part I, question 77, body of article), Aquinas also says that, if the soul were its powers of operating, it would operate always, since it is act according to its essence. This is a sophistical conclusion, because from the fact that the soul is act according to its essence, it certainly results that it is always in act, but not that it always operates, not even that it could always operate. Here we reach a point where the misunderstanding throws the strongest light on the ultimate meaning of the two doctrines that it sets against each other. In a doctrine of *esse*, it is true that an essence that is intrinsically act is always totally everything it can be, since it is inherently efficacious by virtue of its act of existing. By contrast, in a doctrine of *essentia*, the problems of efficacy do not stem from the metaphysics of essence but from the metaphysics of causes. From the latter viewpoint, the Thomist argument is ineffective because it is no longer enough that an essence should be formally in act for it to be able to operate. When it is formally in act, it belongs to its essence to give life, not to operate; but it does give being to the living thing, *qua* formal principle, but it is principle of

operation in another order, the order of the efficient cause.[48]

These technical discussions have a theological (or rather religious) background. Duns Scotus's theology is a practical science, whose proper goal is to lead humans to eternal salvation. For humans to achieve salvation is to attain God, and how is God to be genuinely attained except by his essence? Not only does the nobility of human beings demand that, but also their very nature. We can debate to find out whether humans will ultimately enjoy God rather by the intellect or the will. It is important to know that, but much less than to decide whether the power of the soul by which humans can attain God, whichever it is, is really distinct from their essence or not. If the power is distinct, we will have to acknowledge that the soul will never be blessed by its essence but by accident, a troubling conclusion. In this hypothesis, the soul would attain God by something really distinct from itself. Would it not then be necessary to speak of a *blessed intellect* rather than a blessed soul, since the intellect, which is really distinct from the soul, would receive the beatific vision in the fashion of a Separated Intelligence?[49]

Whatever Duns Scotus's ultimate intentions are, his doctrine is what matters to us. It consists in maintaining

> the essence of the soul without real distinction or distinction of reason is the principle of a variety of actions, without there being real diversity of powers in the sense that the powers would be parts of the soul, whether its accidents or its relations. For, it is not necessary that real plurality in the effect should denote a real plurality in the cause, since plurality can proceed from unlimited unity.[50]

The true difficulty is thus not in finding out whether it is necessary to distinguish soul from powers really but rather, given that the powers are not really distinct from the soul, to find out in what sense it remains possible to distinguish them.

Duns Scotus's answer to this question must be carefully weighed, because in it we find the key to a whole series of passages where step-by-step examination of the letter does not always reveal the sense. Scotus's point of

departure is a concept of Dionysian inspiration, *continentia unitiva*. This unitive inclusion involves contents of complex but determined nature. It does not contain completely identical elements, because such elements would have no need of being united, nor does it contain elements that after union in their container would remain distinct in the same way as they were before being united in it. The unitive inclusion contains elements that, while really *one*, remain nevertheless *formally* distinct. In other words, these elements are identical with real identity and only form a single thing within which they remain formally distinct.

It is necessary to read this key text in Duns Scotus's own Latin,[51] because nothing can equal its precision or power. The contents of the *unitive containers* are really one, *unum realiter*. They are the same by real identity, *idem identitate reali*, but they are not identical in all aspects, because they remain formally distinct in their real identity. This should not surprise us, because we have known—really since our study of God's absolute simplicity—that the formal distinction involves no rupture of real unity, but we discover this principle's universal value better here. It can serve as the connecting thread in the labyrinth of texts and controversies on these texts, in which the Subtle Doctor (who truly merits his honorary title here) sometimes posits a plurality of distinct forms in the substance, but sometimes refuses to make things really distinct and reduce them to the individual's real unity. All these passages speak the truth, but each from its point of view, because there is always *unity of actual being* and *plurality of formal beings* in any substance. Each form's actual being has its basis through the modality of unity in the being of the substance, but each form preserves the being of its proper formality. This is certainly why a single form thus fed by several others can give them its actual being while exercising their operations. Furthermore, we see that it patently does exercise those operations. In humans, for example, there is not *really* a form of corporeality, but there is *formally* one, without which the soul would lack a body to love. Pluralism of formal being in the unity of actual being is the only principle in whose light we can understand the metaphysical structure of the real as Duns Scotus

conceived it.[52]

There is no doubt that this principle possesses universal explanatory scope in Scotus's doctrine. It is what lets him understand that being contains unitively (that is to say in a real unity of being) transcendentals like one, true, and good (*unum*, *verum*, and *bonum*), and still others that are formally distinct both among themselves and from being.[53] This same principle lets us understand that the soul unitively contains (i.e., in the real unity of a single being) powers as formally distinct as intellect and will: "as, therefore, being contains these three powers as one, although they are formally distinct."[54] Duns Scotus insists on this with unusual vigor, which, however, proves unable to avoid misunderstandings. Nevertheless, let us recall with Scotus that everything the understanding can grasp through a distinct concept possesses a distinct formal reality: *omni entitati formali correspondet adaequate aliquod ens*.[55] Accordingly, being and one never exist separately, but if they existed separately, the formal reason of *one* would be different from the formal reason of *being*, because there would be precisely something *one* and something *being*. This real quidditative distinction that there would be between them, if they existed apart, subsists no less for reason where they exist together. Let us go further. The order of distinct formal elements that essence contains is the same for reason within the being that contains them, as it would be in reality if they actually existed separately. For example, if being and its transcendentals could exist separately, *being* would come first, *one* second, and *true* third. Consequently, these quasi-passions of being have the same formal distinction and formal order in our thought that they would have among themselves in regard to being if they existed separately in reality. Let us repeat that intellect and will are unitively contained in the soul exactly in this way. The difficulty in understanding this position from the Thomist viewpoint is exactly the reverse of the difficulty that the Scotist has in understanding the position of St. Thomas Aquinas. The Scotist reproaches the real distinct of the powers of the soul for multiplying beings without necessity, whereas in Thomism the powers have no *esse* of their own but like all accidents only exist by the *esse* of their substance. The Thomist

reproaches Duns Scotus for identifying operation and substance here, as if the soul were God, whereas in Scotism the unity of being is the unity of a form virtually inclusive of the other forms that constitute this being.

When St. Thomas, in posing the problem in regard to the angels, derives his answer from the distinction of *esse* and *essentia*,[56] he draws the boundary line between the two doctrines in advance. An early Scotist rightly observed that Aquinas always distinguishes while Scotus always unites, but we might just as well maintain the opposite, because both distinguish and unite, but not in the same way. In Thomism, God is the only being whose essence is identical to his *esse*. In other beings, therefore, their essence and everything that flows from their essence must be really distinct from their *esse*. In Duns Scotus, there is no *esse* understood in this way, and God is separated from creature, not in this way, but by the essential modality of infinity. Absolute divine simplicity is not the simplicity of pure *esse*, but the simplicity of real identity in the infinity of being. Therefore, it is possible in Scotism to maintain real unity in creatures under formal distinction, without this unity being the unity of divine simplicity in any way. The creature's unity is not that of an *esse* to which its powers and operations are identical, but the unity of the form of the whole that by reason of its essential finitude lacks the simplicity proper to infinity.

This kind of multiplicity in unity characterizes the Scotist soul. The intellect is intellect. The will is only will. The soul is only soul. The essence of the will and the essence of the intellect are not the essence of the soul *qua* soul, which amounts to saying that they are formally distinct from it. But let us consider this whole that is the human composite. It is such by its form, which is the soul, and as the composite alone is substance, the soul alone really exists as form of this substance. This is why intellect and will have no other actual being than the soul's actual being.[57]

Confident of this position, Scotus acknowledges an acceptable sense for the Thomist position: the soul's powers emerge or flow from its essence. In fact, they emanate, since they are its operative potencies. In this sense, Augustine was right to regard the soul's unity and the trinity of its powers as an image

of the divine Trinity. It is nothing but an image because each of the powers only formally contains its peculiar perfection, while each divine person, being infinite, contains them all. Still, it is an image because the distinction of powers within this real unity is scrupulously safeguarded in it.

Notes

1 On *lux*, which is not a substance but probably an active quality connected to the substantial form of heavenly bodies, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 13, sole question, number 2, vol. II, p. 526 [CE VIII, pp. 229–30].—On *lumen*, which is neither matter nor substantial form, nor substance, but an *intentional* sensible form that directs us toward its source (*lux*), whose *sensible species* is this quality, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 13, sole question, number 3, p. 526 [CE VIII, pp. 230–33].

2 However, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 14, question 1, vol. II, number 2, pp. 536–40 [CE VIII, p. 243], presents an almost irresistible temptation to those who attribute a doctrine of double truth to Scotus: “Alia videtur responsio danda secundum theologos, alia secundum philosophos.” According to the philosophers whose thinking Averroes interprets well, the heavens are not material. According to the theologians, who think that chaos originally extended as far as the empyrean, the heavens have a matter, number 4, pp. 538–39 [CE VIII, 99, 250–51]. The same goes for the question of finding out whether the heavens are animate, about which Augustine has doubts and which St. John Damascene denies: “Breviter si coeli non sunt animati, hoc est creditum, et non ratione conclusum, quia nulla est conditio in corpore illo ita perfecto manifeste apparens repugnare animationi corporis,” number 5, p. 540 [CE VIII, p. 245].—The pair *philosophi-theologi* has been quite familiar to us, and we have learned not to substitute *philosophia-theologia* for it. Duns Scotus does not say that the philosophers’ conclusions are necessary and true, even when they contradict the theologians’ conclusions. He only says that they are conclusions to which the philosophers’ position leads in fact, but the only true conclusions are the ones that are the same as the theologians’ conclusions.—On the influence of the stars see *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 14, question 3, vol. II, pp. 548–54 [CE VIII stops at question 2, number 7].

3 Beside the passages that we will follow, on this point one can consult *Quaestiones Subtillissimae in Metaphysicam*, book II, question 2 [EW I, pp. 73–74], where, as occurs several times in this work, Duns Scotus has not yet achieved his final position. On the use he makes there of a proof from Avicenna (employed by Albert the Great and known to St. Bonaventure), see Franz Luger, *Die Unsterblichkeitsfrage bei Johann Duns Scotus* (Wien-Leipzig: Braumüller, 1933), p. 4, note 3. On the problem’s history before Scotus, see Wilhelm Gotzmann, *Die Unsterblichkeits-Beiweise, in der Väterzeit und Scholastik biz zun Eude des 13 Jahrhunderts* (Karlsruhe: F. Putsch, 1927).

4 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 17, question 1, number 3, vol. II, pp. 591–92 [CE VIII has no distinction 17].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 1, number 4, vol. I, p. 130 [CE II, p. 9]: “Alii arguunt contra rationem ejus [*scilicet*, Avicennae], quia anima immediate creatur a Deo; igitur in Deo immediate quietatur. Sed hujus rationis antecedens est tantum creditum, et negaretur ab eis, quia ipse ponit eam immediate creari ab ultima intelligentia et infima.”

5 Scotus. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 17, question 1, number 3, vol. II, p. 592 [CE VIII has no distinction 17]. Duns Scotus is thinking of the passage in Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, part X,

chapter 4, folios 104 verso to 105 recto: “Nos autem non prohibemus . . .” As for Aristotle, he would not admit a creation of the soul, but its generation. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 13: “Nam circa animae creationem ponimus duplicem mutationem, unam a non esse animae ad esse ejus, aliam a non animato corpore ad corpus animatum, secundum quam mutatur corpus organicum animatum. Primam mutationem non ponit Aristoteles, sed secundam tantum, et ideo non concederet creationem.” To this Duns Scotus, number 14, immediately adds: “Sed nos Christiani aliter ponimus; non enim ponimus unum angelum creare posse inferiorem angelum secundum viam Avicennae; sic non etiam aliquam formam substantialem infimam.”—For an overview of the question, see Luger, *Die Unsterblichkeitsfrage*, chapter 3, “Aristotle and His Position Regarding the Problem of the Immortality in the History of Philosophy,” pp. 49–59, and chapter 4, “Duns Scotus’s interpretation of Aristotle on the Problem of Immortality,” pp. 60–74.

6 Let us recall in what sense the philosophers could conceive creation. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 1, question 1, number 12: “Respondeo ergo ad quaestionem, quod creatio dupliciter potest accipi: uno modo proprie, excludendo a creante omnem aliam causam concreantem, praeter causam finalem quae movet causam efficientem et creantem ad creandum; et excludendo causam materialem, efficientem secundariam et formalem, quae est pars rei; et sic relatio est productio alicujus in esse sine quacumque alia causa concreante primo creanti, excepta causalitate finis. Finis enim, ut dictum est, movet efficientem ad agendum, et non potest ab ejus actione excludi, et isto modo concedo quod Deus solus creat. Licet enim quodcumque aliud a Deo posset aliud producere de nihilo, necessario tamen praesuponeret aliud agens in actione sua, ut primam causam, et ita non est possibile isto modo aliquam creaturam creare aliquid. Alio modo accipitur creatio solum excludendo causam materialem concausantem; et isto modo creatio est productio alicujus de nihilo, quia de nulla materia, et hoc modo accipiendo eam, difficile est prohibere, quin possit creatio competere agenti creato respectu multorum, ut respectu formarum per se subsistentium, cujusmodo sunt angeli, si sunt formae simplices; et etiam respectu formarum quae non educuntur de potentia materiae, ut animas intellectivae; sive respectu formarum accidentialium, ut sunt fides, spes, intelligere, velle et hujusmodi.”

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 16.

8 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 17: “Unde non oportet quod omne illud, quod dicit Philosophus sit demonstratio, quia multa dixerunt philosophi quae acceperunt a prioribus philosophis, persuasi per rationes probabiles eorum et non semper demonstrativas.”

9 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 6.—Number 7 establishes that this conclusion is not demonstrable *a priori* but *a posteriori*, because the forms are recognized in their operations, and we are going to see how a certain operation of the soul implies its immortality.

10 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 7, number 4, vol. II, p. 279 [CE VII, pp. 500–03]. Cf. *Quodlibet* II, number 6 [AW, p. 36]. In this last text, number 5 [AW, p. 35], we see that the problem is connected to the problem of individuation by matter, which Duns Scotus combated. The soul can be created by God separately without being united to a matter. Indeed, “anima prius naturaliter est haec, quam unitur materiae . . . Unde ista anima est haec sua propria singularitate . . . ergo distinctae sunt istae animae prius natura quam uniantur materiae; non ergo per se et primo distiguuntur sua materia.” From that it follows, number 6 [AW, p. 35] that we cannot even distinguish souls by their diverse adaptation to different bodies, “quia natura ipsa absoluta est prior natum ipsa aptitudine . . .” Cavellus and Lychetus saw correctly that the discussion derives from Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 41, article 6.

Quodlibet II, number 4 [AW, p. 34], is the occasion for Duns Scotus to invoke the condemnation of three of the articles censured by Étienne Tempier in 1277.

11 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 14, vol. II, p. 579 [CE VIII has no distinction 16].—Cf. Aristotle, *De Anima*, book I, chapter 3, 407 b 20 ff, at *sensum*; or Aquinas, *In I De Anima*, *lectio* 8, number 131, edited by Angelo M. Pirotta, Turin: Marietti, 1959. —Duns Scotus here remembers Averroes *De Anima*, book I, chapter 3, commentary 53, Venice: apud Juntas, 1574, p. 28 verso.

12 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, numbers 7–9. So, according to Duns Scotus, Aristotle would only speak of *separation*, *eternity*, and *incorruptibility* in regard to the intellect's operation, not about its substance. Luger, *Die Unsterblichkeitsfrage*, pp. 64–65, rightly says that this interpretation of Aristotle is difficult to maintain.

13 Duns Scotus admits that in Aristotle's thought, the intellectual soul's operation is extrinsic to the body and in this sense *from the outside*, but not the soul itself. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 17: "Nunquam invenitur a Philosopho, quod ipse asserat animam intellectivam esse ab intrinseco." Moreover, "si simpliciter esset ab extrinseco, non poneret Philosophus quod esset forma naturalis ipsius corporis sibi propria, quia principium apud eum est, quod de nihilo nihil fit, et quod cuilibet potentiae possitivae in natura correspondet potentia activa in natura. Et ideo, quia ponit eam formam propriam ipsius corporis organici, ut patet in multis locis 2 et 3 *De Anima*, ponit eam corrumpi ad corruptionem totius."—Aristotle would admit no other immortality than immortality of the species. Duns Scotus is right on this last point. But since he denies against Averroes that Aristotle taught the unity of the intellectual soul, it is difficult to see how he can maintain that Aristotle, who portrays the intellect as coming to humans from outside, never said that the intellectual soul is *ab extrinseco*. Cf. Aristotle, *De Generatione Animalium*, book II, chapter 3, 736 b 27–28.

14 Duns Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 16.

15 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 16.—Duns Scotus naturally noticed the passage of Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 76, article 1, reply to objection 5: "Anima illud esse, in quo subsistit, communicat corpori . . ." Scotus sums it up in number 12 and refutes it in number 19. The misunderstanding about *esse* that separates the two doctrines is clearly visible here. It is set out all through *Quodlibet* IX, number 15–17 [AW, pp. 230–32]. Duns Scotus objects that if the soul's *esse* were not identical to the *esse* of the whole, the separated soul would suffer no imperfection in its being, since nothing would be taken away from it, except that it would no longer communicate its being to something other than itself. Q*uodlibet* IX, number 15 [AW, p. 231]: "Videtur ergo ista neganda, quod esse animae est idem quod esse totius, quia anima habens esse, videtur pars totius habentis esse; consimiliter videtur esse se habere ad esse."—Once *esse* no longer means act of being but the reality of the essence placed outside its cause, everything St. Thomas says loses its meaning. Duns Scotus understands *esse* in the second sense, *Quodlibet* IX, number 17 [AW, p. 232]: "Uno modo *esse* potest intelligi illud quo primo formaliter aliquid recedit a non esse; primo autem receditur a non esse per illud per quod aliquid est extra intellectum et potentiam suae causae. Hoc modo cujuslibet entis extra intellectum et causam est proprium esse. Alio modo dicitur esse ultimus actus, cui scilicet non advenit aliquis alius dans esse simpliciter et ipsum simpliciter dicitur habere esse cui primo convenit esse sic dictum, primo inquam, sic quod non sit alicui alteri ratio essendi illo esse. Isto modo compositum perfectum in specie dicitur esse, et solum illud; pars autem ejus dicitur esse per accidens tantummodo, vel magis proprie participative isto esse totius; sic igitur solum compositum est per se ens, accipiendo esse secundo modo; anima autem intellectiva non dicitur subsistens nisi improprie et secundum quid, licit dicatur ens, et per se ens primo modo accipiendo esse."—In

short, in the broad sense, every effect actually produced by its cause is *esse*; in the strict sense, *esse* is the finished whole in whose being its parts share, which itself does not enter *qua* part into the composition of another part. In this metaphysics of essence, the individual *forma totius* completes being, like *esse* in the metaphysics of the act of being. Where this *esse* disappears, the Thomist proof of the soul's immortality disappears with it.

16 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 75, article 6, body of article: "Unde quod per se habet esse non potest generari vel corrumpi, nisi per se."—In the opposite sense, see Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, numbers 14 and 23. In another passage, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 18, Duns Scotus objects that, in any case, for those who make *esse* an accident of *essentia*, the soul that loses its *esse* could only be corrupted by accident. Scotus himself judges that the soul's *esse* does not differ from its *essentia* and that, if it cannot have one without the other, it could lose both at once. At the beginning of the fourteenth century, it was obviously more difficult to distinguish between the position of Avicenna and that of St. Thomas on the composition of essence and the act of being than it is for us today. We now know that the form's existential act is completely different from an accident in authentic Thomism.

17 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 17. This important conclusion should be added: "Ita in proposito dico quod bene verum est quod si alicubi inveniatur a philosophis dictum quod anima sit incorruptibilis, haec quidem conclusio probabilior est quam opposita."

18 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 15. It has been objected that Thomas Aquinas did not give this argument as a demonstration, but Duns Scotus would respond that his criticism envisages something else, the very object of this natural desire.

19 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, numbers 15–16. See above note 13 in this chapter.—Also, it has not been philosophically demonstrated that the generation of individuals must end someday. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 26: ". . . philosophi posuerunt generationem fieri in infinitum a parte post, sicut a parte ante, et magis; et ideo nunquam posuerunt eam finiri, nec aliquam specie. Est igitur creditum, et non demonstratum, quod generatio terminanda est aliquando."

20 Scotus, *Reportata Parisienia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 19.—For Duns Scotus's precursors on this point (Robert Grosseteste, Thomas of York, and Roger Bacon), see F. Immle, "Die Unsterblichkeit der Seele bei der Franziskanertheologien des 13 Jahrhunderts," in *Franziskanische Studien* XXIV (1937), pp. 284–94.

21 On Cajetan's uncertainties and variations, see the excellent introduction of Jean Coquelle, O.P., to his edition of *Thomas de Vio Cardinalis Cajetanus (1469–1534) Scripta Philosophorum, Commentaria in De Anima Aristotelis*, Rome: Institutum Anglelicum, 1938, vol. I, pp. vii–lii. In Cajetan's 1534 commentary on Ecclesiastes that was completed the year he died, he ends by writing in regard to 3:21 (*In Ecclesiasten*, Rome, 1542, p. 117, in Coquelle, p. xxv, note 4): "Et quamvis argumentando loquatur, dicit tamen verum negando scientiam immortalitatis nostrae. Nullus enim philosophus hactenus demonstravit animam hominis esse immortalem, nulla apparet demonstrativa ratio, sed fide hoc credimus et rationibus probabilibus consonat."—Here, the prince of Thomists speaks exactly like Duns Scotus. To evaluate his position fairly, we must remember that his most virulent opponents like Spina, see Coquelle, p. xliii, held the following two propositions to be equivalent: Aristotle did not demonstrate the immortality of the soul, and the soul's immortality is not philosophically demonstrable. Like Duns Scotus, Cajetan was right to deny that Aristotle had demonstrated the soul's immortality. After holding for a long time that it was demonstrable, Cajetan ended, as we just saw, by doubting it. Neither Duns Scotus nor Cajetan

opened to the door to Pomponazzi, whose completely different thesis is that the mortality of the soul is demonstrable. However that may be, Javelli was not wrong to write, Coquelle, p. li: “Ad viam Hervei et Scoti declinavit Gaetanus.”—Since the occasion presents itself, Coquelle, p. lii, we have been reproached for unfairly blaming Cajetan for his failure to assume the spiritual direction of the humanism of his time, as St. Thomas took the lead in the intellectual movement of his period. We take advantage of the occasion to observe that this is to misunderstand the point of our thinking. Firstly, our regret implies high praise. Secondly, and above all, it is not a response to us to object that Cajetan, on the contrary, was a humanist both in theology and in exegesis. We said precisely that it became impossible to accept humanism from the moment in which metaphysics was lost.

22 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 25: “unius entis est unum esse; unum esse est ab una forma; ergo unius entis est una forma.”—Cf. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 76, article 4, *sed contra*: “Unius rei est unum esse substantiale. Sed forma substantialis dat esse substantiale. Ergo unius rei est una tantum forma substantialis. Anima autem est forma substantialis hominis. Ergo impossibile est quod in homine sit aliqua alia forma substantialis quam anima intellectiva.”

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 26.—Cf. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, art I, question 76, article 4, body of article.—Cf. Matthias Schneid, *Die Körperlehre des Johannes Duns Skotus und ihr Verhältnisss zum Thomismus und Atomismus*, Mainz, F. Kircheim, 1879, especially chapters 2 and 3, pp. 11–24. The author still attributes *De Rerum Principio* to Scotus and consequently Ibn Gabirol’s hylemorphism.—See especially the detailed study by Bernard Badoux, O.F.M., “De Forma Corporeitatis,” *Antonianum* XIII (1938), pp. 429–74.

24 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 27.—Cf. Aristotle, *De Anima*, book II, chapter 3, 414 b 20–31.—We will see that Scotus does not find this passage easy to assimilate. On the other hand, in a kind of theological experiment, he asks what would happen under the hypothesis of unity of the substantial form, if the consecrated host had remained upon the paten for three days after the Last Supper. At Christ’s death on the cross, his intellectual soul was really separated from his body. Would it therefore be necessary to say that during that time Christ’s soul remained united to him in the consecrated host? The problem disappears if we admit a f*orma corporeitatis*. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, numbers 27 and 31: “Sic ego neuter modus . . .” Likewise see number 57: “Quantum ergo ad istud dubium . . .”

25 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 46.—From Duns Scotus’s standpoint, giving *esse* consists of giving either substantial being or accidental being. Therefore, he seeks the cause of *esse* in the order of form (substantial or accidental). Transposed into his own language, number 50, *dare esse simpliciter* normally means give substantial being in contrast to accidental being.

26 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 46. The distinct specific forms that enter into an animal’s composition are not heaped up in a pile. Nor are they absorbed into a single form. They remain formally distinct in the unifying inclusion of the whole. Once again, the whole’s unity does not necessarily exclude the distinction of the parts that compose it. See *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 20, number 3 [EW II, p. 334, number 30]: “Tertio . . .”

27 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 47: “completive est tota substantia rei, sicut a forma ultima est completive tota essentia habentis formam”—Moreover, without this unity, we cannot conceive that a human could be a *person*, that is, an individual of intellectual nature, and (what is a peculiarly Scotist characteristic) actually impendent of anything else by virtue of its very singularity. This actual independence is based on an essential

incommunicability whose profound reasons are found in the theology of the divine persons, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 1, question 1, number 10; also *Quodlibet* XIX, number 20 [AW, pp. 435–36].—Cf. Léon Seiller, O.F.M., *La notion de personne selon Duns Scot, ses principales applications en christologie* (Paris: Éditions franciscaines, no date).

28 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 11, question 3, number 54: "unde corpus, quod est altera pars manens quidem in esse suo proprio sine anima, habet per consequens formam qua est corpus isto modo, et non habet animam; et ita illa forma necessario est alia ab anima." Note particularly: "Sic in proposito, forma animae non manente, corpus manet, et ideo universaliter in quolibet animato necesse est ponere illam formam, qua corpus est corpus, aliam ab illa, qua est animatum."

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 1, question 5, number 25, vol. II, pp. 72–73 [Vivès question 5 is CE question 7, which ends at number 6]: "In omnibus istis, et maxime in creaturis, continens non est formaliter contentum; sed est ita perfecta entitas in se sicut esset contentum, si contentum esset extra se vel sibi additum; imo perfectior entitas est, quia ex perfectione sua continet omnem aliam entitatem. Unde anima intellectiva non tantum est forma substantialis, quia tunc non esset perfecta, sed est ita perfecta illa ultimam entitas quae est sibi, sicut si praesupponeret aliam entitatem a se."—Note the words "as if" in the last sentence. Therefore, the form of the whole does not presuppose them.

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 19, question 3, article 3, number 10, vol. I, p. 894 Probably [CE V, pp. 295–98].

31 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 44, question 1, number 4.—In all cases of this kind in Duns Scotus, and they are innumerable, the point is to understand how a thing can be formally distinct from another with a real unity of being like will and intellect in God, for example. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 45, question 2, number 5: "Dico autem aliquid esse in alio ex natura rei, quod non est in eo per actum intellectus negotiantis, nec per actum voluntatis comparantis, et universaliter quod est in alio non per actum alicujus potentiae comparantis. Dico autem esse formaliter tale, sive *esse in alio formaliter*, quod non est in eo potentialiter, ut album in nigro; nec virtualiter ut effectus in sua causa est; nec hoc dico formaliter esse in aliquo quod est in eo confuse et cum quadam commixtione quomodo ignis est in carne non formaliter; sed dico esse formaliter in aliquo, in quo manet secundum suam rationem formalem et quidditativam, et *esse tale formaliter* est includere ipsum secundum suam rationem formalem et quidditativam, et *esse tale formaliter* est includere ipsum secundum suam rationem formalem praecisissime acceptam." This is why in p. 444, note 2, of Fr. B. Badoux's excellent article we find the remark: "Certo decipitur E. Gilson . . ." We would be inclined to strike *certo*. In Duns Scotus there is a form of corporeality really distinct from the soul as long as the soul is not there, but in the soul, the form of corporeality has no other real distinction than what the formal distinction includes in the real unity of the whole. The same response can be given to criticism directed against Parthenius Minges in note 1 of p. 444 in Badoux's article. In other words, if the form of corporeality is really distinct in the form of the whole, this is only by the least of all real distinctions, which is the formal distinction, in which the distinctive entity is not existence. Unless we are mistaken (possible, but not certain) the form of corporeality has no more distinct actual existence in the form of the whole in Duns Scotus than in Thomas Aquinas.

32 See chapter 5, pp. 391–97 (check internal reference).

33 For an overview of the question see Agostino Fioravanti, "La distinzione fra anima e le sue facoltà nella dottrina del Ven. Giovanni Duns Scoto," *Studi Francescani* I (1914), pp. 235–44.

34 On the history of the formal distinction, see B. Jansen, "Beiträge zur geschichtlichen Entwicklung

der *distinctio formalis*."—By the same author, see "Die *distinctio formalis* bei den Serviten und Karmeliten des 17 Jahrhunderts," *Zeitschrift für Katholische Theologie* LXI (1937), pp. 595–601. —The classical argument on the doctrine remains Parthenius Minges, O.F.M., "Die *distinctio formalis* des Duns Scotus," *Theologische Quartalschrift* XC (1908), pp. 409–36.—It is immediately clear that the recourse to the formal distinction will be inevitable. Taken formally in itself, a potency of the soul is an absolute by definition. *In Metaphysicam*, book IX, question 5, number 5 [EW II. p. 509, number 17]: "Si autem per potentiam animae intelligatur illa perfectio, quae praecedit naturaliter actum sicut ratio elicitiva actus, sive receptiva motionis objecti, illa praecise dicit absolutum." Accordingly, there must be distinction between the powers, but not necessarily distinction of actual existence.

35 We should understand *distinct* in the strong sense, which is, *irreducibly distinct*. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, number 43, vol. I, p. 282 [CE II, p. 355]: "Similiter concluditur [*scilicet*, haec differentia] ex differentia objectorum formalium, quorum neutrum continetur in aliquo eminenter et ex hoc in inellectu intutive considerante, concluditur aliqua differentia, ante actum intellectus, eorum quae cognoscuntur intutive."—Note the intuition of the formality. The formality is the object of a simple apprehension or, better, an intellectual vision. Of course, this does not contradict the Scotist thesis that in this life all our knowledge is abstracted from the sensible. The intuition of the essence is always the intuition of an abstraction for us here below.

36 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, number 43, vol. I, p. 282 [CE II, p. 355]: "Sed numquid haec distinctio dicitur realis? Respondeo: non est proprie realis actualis, intelligendo, sicut communiter dicitur, realis actualis illa quae est differentia rerum et in actu . . ."—This is what makes several authors (notably Jansen, "Beiträge," p. 331) say: "Duns Scotus's realism has nothing to do with Platonic *universalism*." Obviously, the quiddity's entity is not the entity of a separated Idea. But what was it in Plato's own eyes? Is there no trace of Platonism in the doctrine that grants real entity to the essence, and a real entity before any act of the intellect?

37 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, number 42, vol. I, p. 282 end [CE I, p. 356].

38 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7, number 44, vol. I, p. 283 [CE II, pp. 356–57].—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 45, question 2: "Intelligo per *non identitatem formalem* aliquorum, quando unum non est de formali ratione alterius, ita quod, si definiuntur, non pertineret ad definitionem ejus. Igitur per *non identitatem formalem* intelligo non identitatem quidditativam non pertinentem ad definitionem alterius, si definiretur."—This is why Duns Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book V, question 6, number 3 [EW I, pp. 398–99] and book VIII, question 1, number 6 [EW II, pp. 353–54, number 34], admits a formal distinction even between categories. Quantity as such is not quality as such, and so on.

39 In the finite, formal nonidentity always belongs to a being that is inherently composed, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 2, question 7 [CE II, pp. 255–378]. In God, where the infinite guarantees absolute identity, there are no real parts of any kind, *In Metaphysicam*, book IV, question 2, number 23 [EW I, p. 306, number 136]. In other words the distinction of forms implies no real composition in divine being.

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 2, vol. II, pp. 569–70 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]. For St. Augustine's texts, see *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, columns 1044 and 1065. Duns Scotus himself establishes the equation *mens* = *essentia*, from which he draws his conclusion. His metaphysics of essence is thus inserted into St. Augustine's doctrine.—To this double argument from authority taken from Augustine, Scotus, *ibidem*, p. 570, adds an argument from authority taken from Proclus, *Elementatio Theologica*: "Omne immateriale est

supra se conversivum," This is interpreted: "et sic intelligens et intellectum sunt idem realiter in anima; ergo potentia non differt ab essentia, et sic erit de aliis; quare nec inter se."—In this regard, we should note that what is most formal in the rational soul is not the will, *Quodlibet* I, number 11 [AW, p. 16]: "Ista intellectualitas, quae per se intelligitur per rationale, est idem homini essentialiter, immo ut actualissimum et completissimum in essentia."

41 Aristotle, *De Generatione et Corruptione*, book II, chapter 10, 336 b 28.

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 15, vol. II, p. 579 [CE VIII has no distinction 16].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 5, vol. II, p. 572: "Et cum pluralitas non sit sine ratione cogente ponenda; ergo . . ." Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book VIII, question 1, number 4; EW II, p. 349, number 22, remits to *Physics*, book I, text. comm. 50, for Aristotle's thesis: "commendantis Melissum prae Anaxagoram propter paucitatem principiorem, natura enim nihil facit frustra."

43 Indeed, there is one completely non-Aristotelian case that decisively justifies the principle of economy, the case of God. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 15, vol. II, p. 580 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "Quod autem ista paucitas sit nobilitatis, patet quia aliter non competeret Enti Nobilissimo, cui competet per unicam essentiam suam operari diversa."

44 Here we again encounter the problem that has just been discussed in the context of the relation of the soul to the parts of the soul and even to the *forma corporeitatis*. To understand Duns Scotus, it is useful to follow him in the application he makes of his principle to particular cases.

45 Aquinas, Summa *Theologiae*, part I, question 76, article 4, body of article.

46 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 77, article 1, body of article.—On Duns Scotus's critique of St. Thomas's arguments, see Maurice J. Grajewski, O.F.M., *The Formal Distinction of Duns Scotus: A Study in Metaphysics* (Washington DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1944), chapter 8, pp. 155–69. The positions of Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus are set out with the same fidelity. The Scotist critique of Thomism, p. 164, which accuses the real distinction between the soul and its faculties of compromising its unity, naturally does not take into account the act of being, which in Thomism is the perfection of the soul. Once more, the misunderstanding erupts in *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 6 [CE VIII has no distinction 16], where Duns Scotus objects: "Secunda ratio non valet; non enim sequitur, anima secundum essentiam suam est actus, igitur habens ipsam semper operatur, vel potest operari semper; quia anima est principium formale, quo vivum est vivum, quia ipsa formaliter dat esse vivum."—This is the whole Scotist truth, but not the whole Thomist truth, where the soul (formal principle of the living thing as such) is also that by which the composite exercises the act of being. By virtue of that act, the composite is capable of operating. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 77, article 1, reply to objection 3: "Dicendum quod actio est compositi, sicut et esse; existentis enim est agere. Compositum autem per formam substantialem habet esse substantialiter; per virtutem autem quae consequitur formam substantialem, operatur." Therefore, if the soul's operation were not really distinct from its essence in the doctrine, the essence would not be distinct from its act of being, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 54, article 3, body of article. It would be God. But if the composite did not have its act of being, it would no longer have any unity. The points of contact between the two doctrines are often points of intersection.

47 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 5, vol. II, p. 572 [CE VIII has no distinction 16].

48 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 6, vol. II, p. 573 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "Nec est simile dare vitam et operari, quod scilicet sicut est principium vivendi per essentiam, ita est principium operandi per essentiam, etc.; quia anima est principium

formale quo vivum est vivum, quia ipsa formaliter dat esse vivum; sed anima est principium operationis secundum quod reducta ad genus causae efficientis, et sicut ars se habet ad effectum, scilicet in genere principii effectivi. Est igitur ibi [*scilicet, Summa Theologiae*, I, 77, 1, respondeo] aequivocatio quantum ad immediationem; uno enim modo est sic, et alio modo non sic; est enim anima immediatum principium formale essendi, et immediatum principium operandi; sed non similiter se habet ad causam formalem et ad effectivam; non enim oportet quod habens formam sit semper in actu secundo."

49 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 15, p. 580 [CE VIII has no distinction 16].

50 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 16, p. 580 [CE VIII has no distinction 16].

51 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 17, vol. II, p. 581 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "Secundum Dionysium 5 c. *De Divinis Nominibus*, continentia unitiva non est eorum quae omnino sunt idem, quia illa non uniuntur; nec est eorum quae manent distincta ista distinctione qua fuerunt distincta ante unionem; sed quae sunt unum realiter, manent tamen distincta formaliter, sive quae sunt idem identitate reali, distincta tamen formaliter."—This theme of unity containing diversity runs all through *De Divinis Nominibus*. See, for example, chapter 2, 11, *Patrologia Graeca*, vol. II, column 652, and chapter 4, 12, *Patrologia Graeca*, vol. III, column 710. However, we have not been able to find the expression *continentia unitiva*. We can compare *unitivam quamdam complexionem*, *Dionysiaca*, vol. I, p. 229, trans. Robert Grosseteste, with articles 7–10 in chapter 5. Perhaps Duns Scotus translated Dionysius into his own language, but it also may be that the expression is found in one of the translations of Dionysius that has escaped us. In any case, the reference to Dionysius on this point is important. It shows Duns Scotus searching in the neo-Platonic line of the *one* for the unifying metaphysical property he needs to overcome the pluralism of essence.

52 In *unitive containment*, the container first includes, *qua* content, all the higher formalities required to constitute its essence. Thus a particular whiteness essentially includes the concepts of *whiteness*, *color*, *sensible quality*, and *quality* in general, which are higher than it.—The container further contains the properties (*passiones*) that flow from its nature, and although they are posterior, because they flow from it, they are not things other than the container. For example, being is like this. Its transcendental properties are not really different, but yet are formally distinct from each other. (Formally, good is not true, and so on.) The same holds for being itself. (*Bonum* as such is not formally *ens* as such.) Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 17, vol. II, p. 582 [CE VIII has no distinction 16], goes so far as to say that the transcendentals are distinguished from being *formalitate . . . reali et quidditative*. Consequently, there is a *real formal distinction*, or if we prefer, a distinction that is real in the order of formality, which does not damage being's absolute metaphysical unity, its unitive container. That is certainly necessary, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 17, vol. II, p. 582 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "Aliter metaphysica concludens tales passiones de ente, et illas considerans, non esset scientia realis."—Thus, metaphysics is a *real* science and not mere logic, because the *passiones entis upon* which it operates are so many realities distinct from each other and from being itself by virtue of real distinction in the order of formality.

53 The dual primacy of *commonality* and *virtuality* that Duns Scotus attributes to being troubles some of his interpreters who see in this initial absence of unity a germ of the doctrine's dissolution and fragmentation, Timotheus Barth, O.F.M., "De Fundamento Univocationis apud," p. 391. That is not true. The primacy of commonality extends to all genera, species, and individuals, as well as to their parts, which is to say, the whole order of essences where everything *includit ens quidditatis*.

The primacy of virtuality encompasses everything by which being can be determined, "conceptus qualitativos differentiarum ultimarum et passionum," *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, number 8 [CE III, p. 86]. Finite being is like this, and we cannot reduce the second primacy to the first without making finite being into a kind of Parmenidean being, which it is not. From the level of transcendentals onward, differences determine being *qua* being. Differences are not deduced from being, but they are not added to it by reason of being existentially distinct entities. Their actual reality is its reality. We can reject Scotus's formalism, but we cannot be Scotists and reject it, because being precisely as such, is not one, it is being. *One* precisely as such, is not *being*; it is *one*. Because being is nothing but being, it is univocal. We can prefer a different metaphysics, but we cannot want Scotism to be something that it is not.

54 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 17, vol. II, p. 582 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "sicut ergo ens continet potentias istas unitive, quamquam sint formaliter distinctae." This applies to singularity, because the highest degree of being, which contains the others, is never really separate from the others.—*In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 19 [EW II, p. 230]: "Cuicumque enim gradui realis entitatis, correspondet realis unitas. Sicut tamen in aliis unitive contentis non est separatio realis, nec etiam potentialis, sic natura cui intellectus tribuit intentionem speciei, quae dicta est esse in re, est communis sicut commune est potentiale in re, nunquam separatur ab alia perfectione unitive secum contenta, vel ab illo gradu in quo accipitur differentia individualis. Cum etiam nunquam fiat in rerum natura nisi sub determinato gradu, nunquam est ab illa separabilis, quia ille gradus cum quo ponitur, est secum unitive contentus."

55 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 12, question 2, number 6 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 431, number 31].

56 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 54, article 3, body of article.

57 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 18, vol. II, p. 582 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "non quod sint essentia ejus formaliter, sed sunt formaliter distinctae, idem tamen identice et unitive."—Here Duns Scotus very suggestively remits to what he said about divine attributes, whose real identity in God's absolute simplicity does not prevent their being formally distinct from God and from each other. Through this we understand better how the Scotists might discourse at leisure on the hierarchy of intrinsic modes of the divine essence, whose formal distinction in no way changes their unity. Moreover, the mode of reasoning here is the same as in the analysis of *moments* of the divine nature or life. It *imagines* a succession of distinct moments according to the order in which they would be conditioned if they effectively succeeded each other in reality. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 16, sole question, number 18, vol. II, pp. 582–83 [CE VIII has no distinction 16]: "Imaginandum est ergo quod anima quasi in primo instanti naturae est natura talis, in secundo instanti est operativa, sive potens operari secundum hanc operationem vel illam, et potentiae, quae sunt principia operationum, continentur unitive in essentia."—In both cases, the imagined order follows the hierarchy of formal distinction, but the formal reality of each formality must not be confused with the reality of actual being that the substance gets from its cause.

8

Intellectual Knowledge

Scattered through Duns Scotus's writings, we find many remarks about the individual senses, common sense, imagination, and their objects. A study of Scotus's psychology pursued for its own sake would have to take such remarks into consideration. The majority are fragmentary, occasional, and do not allow us to tell whether Duns Scotus personally reflected on these questions. Often also we find a simple echo of the Aristotelianism common to the theologians of his time, so that collecting them leads us to rediscover part of the doctrine taught by *De Anima*.[1]

The same does not hold for the psychological questions to which our theologian devotes his attention while commenting upon the texts of Peter Lombard. Scotus reflects upon them at length, and each solution that he adopts is preceded by serious investigation and often by authentic general surveys, to secure the conclusions obtained by his predecessors. Scotus commits himself personally in this, and we can see clearly our theologian in the midst of the task of doctrinal elaborations, listening to the philosophers, judging their answers, and choosing among those answers, rectifying and perfecting the ones he thinks he can retain. The very order in which he approaches them has its interest. Evidently, it is not the order that a philosophical treatise would follow, but it would also be incorrect to qualify it as theological. Indeed, one might follow very different orders starting from a passage in the *Sentences*. The choice of philosophical material that might be

introduced in this commentary is practically unlimited. Ordinarily, Duns Scotus begins by elucidating the most important concepts in themselves, the concepts whose general interpretation controls the solution of the subsequent problems. As we noted in its place, in this way, the concept of infinite being, *ens infinitum*, precedes all the theological speculation whose object it defines. The same holds here. Having to say what the image of God in humans is, and having to clarify the nature of our intellectual knowledge in order to do so, Duns Scotus begins by meditating on the concept of intelligible species, *species intelligibilis*, which we are going to find at the heart of the attempts to know the human intellect.

A Intellect and intelligible species

When he deals with the image of God in humans, Duns Scotus asks, "Whether memory properly speaking is found in the intellectual taken strictly, that is to say, the intellect in possession of an intelligible species that is prior by nature."[2] Thus, memory in the strict sense boils down to the intellect properly speaking, and the problem is to discover whether from the point of view of the condition of exercise, the intelligible species must already be present for the intellect to be able to exercise its act. Duns Scotus's reply is affirmative, and he presents a justification that affects his whole noetic.[3]

This was a disputed question in Scotus's time: "There are many ways of speaking about this matter." *In ista quaestione sunt multi modi diciendi*, but the simplest way of responding was to deny the existence of intelligible species or at least to affirm that the act of intellection can be produced without them.[4] By contrast, Duns Scotus maintains the necessity of the species for intellection to be possible. In fact, the object must always precede intellection; otherwise the intellect would have nothing to know. This is true in general, but it is particularly true when the issue is knowing the universal. For the intellect to be able to know a universal, the universal must be present. The very concept of object demands it, because what is an object of

knowledge that is not real?[5] Duns Scotus will repeat this in many ways: “According to its intrinsic condition of object, the object precedes the act; the universal is an intrinsic condition of the object of the intellect.” Or again, “the universal is a condition of the object that precedes the act of understanding.” Or else, “the object according to its proper reason of object must precede the act.”[6]

The principle is confirmed by the proper nature of intellectual knowledge considered both from the viewpoint of this object and the viewpoint of its act.

Firstly, it is confirmed from the standpoint of the object, because, if the intelligible species is suppressed, we are left only with the contrast of intellect and the singular object known by its species. It has been claimed that by illuminating the singular, the intellect can see the universal in it without an intelligible species of the universal being necessary. But how can the intellect see what is not there? A single species cannot represent the singular and the universal at the same time, because every species is in the measure of its object: singular if the object is singular, universal if it is universal. Consequently, no species can represent two formally distinct objects, nor the same object under two formally opposed objective reasons. In short, the universal can only be an object of the intellect through an intelligible species that represents it. Accordingly, it is necessary to posit this doctrine for the knowledge of the universal to be possible.[7]

This is equally necessary from the point of view of the agent intellect and of the exercise of the agent intellect’s act. Making sure of this, moreover, will be the first occasion to achieve knowledge of the human intellect as Duns Scotus conceives its structure. In regard to the agent intellect’s general structure, that will remain the same in Scotism as in Aristotle’s conception. The agent intellect is an active power, capable of making everything intelligible, whose action must have a real effect as its term, because it acts like art upon matter, and no one doubts that art produces something in the matter upon which it acts. Therefore, the agent intellect *potest habere actionem realem*, whose effect, since we are dealing with a real action, is *aliquid reale*. Something must receive this real effect. It cannot be received in the agent intellect whose

nature is to produce it, not to undergo it. Neither can it be in the phantasm, because if the phantasm is tied to the singular and to extension, so that if the effect of the agent intellect were received in the phantasm, it would lose its aptitude to represent the universal. Furthermore, even the possible intellect, the faculty of the universal by virtue of its immateriality, would not be suited to receive it. The agent intellect must produce in the possible intellect a real effect that is something universal. Such is the intelligible species, and it is impossible to do without it because if we reduce the operation to the action of the agent intellect on the possible intellect without production of a species, we no longer understand how the knowledge of the universal can be effected. For the universal to be known, let us recall, it must be there. It is not in either the possible intellect or in the sensible species or in the phantasm. Therefore, it can be produced only by the agent intellect.[8]

This explanation settles two important points at one stroke, the nature of the intelligible species and the nature of abstraction. With Aristotle, Duns Scotus admits that the proper function of the intellect is to make universal what is not universal of itself, or to make known in act what is only known in potency, that is to say, what is knowable. As Averroes says,[9] and as Duns Scotus is pleased to repeat with him, if the essence of things were abstracted from matter and were universal in act in the manner of Plato's Ideas, we would have no need of an agent intellect to know them. But they are not, and it is very important to understand this if we want to limit the proper entity of *common nature* in Scotism, as we must. This entity is real, and its reality affects the way in which Duns Scotus conceives abstraction, but if the *nature* as such has a proper entity, the *universal* as such has none. To use language that is not Scotus's but is sometimes employed in order to situate his doctrine, we would say that if there is a certain *realism* of the common nature and of the essence in Duns Scotus, no *realism* of the universal is found there. The universal's whole existence is reduced to something's aptitude to represent the object under the aspect of universality. This something is the intelligible species itself. From there comes the agent intellect's proper role. To make universal what is not universal is a meaningless exercise if it does

not signify that “the agent intellect makes something representative of the universal out of what was representative of the singular.” In the expression *fecit de eo* (“made out of it”), the word *eo* can be understood materially or virtually. In whichever way it is understood, the expression signifies that the effect of the agent intellect is a “representation of the object under the reason of universal.” But, to be representative, it must *be*. The agent intellect does not produce *representation*; it causes a *representative* being. Thus, “the real action of the agent intellect has as its term a form endowed with real existence (*formam aliquam realem in existentia*), which formally represents the universal *qua* universal; otherwise the action could not be terminated in the universal under its reason of universal.” Accordingly, the act of intellection produces in the following way: the agent intellect causes a form in the possible intellect that receives the form; the form is suited to represent as universal the object that the sensible species represents as singular. This form is the intelligible species thanks to which a universal is offered to the intellect as object.[10]

It is rather difficult to specify what characterizes Duns Scotus’s peculiar position on this point without distorting it in one direction or another. Once again we find him grappling with his familiar principle that beings must not be multiplied without necessity. To this he responds: there is a necessity to posit intelligible species, because we cannot explain the agent intellect’s operation without them. If the agent intellect had nothing to do, it would not have a reason to exist, and so on. Furthermore, to deny the agent intellect one of the conditions necessary for its exercise is not to do it honor but dishonor. That alone would be enough to eviscerate the debate, because we must know how to oppose this other equally important principle to the principle of economy: “that it is always necessary to exalt the noble nature, unless there is some clearly opposing reason,” *quod necessitas est semper dignificare naturam nobilem, quando non apparet aliquid manifeste repugnans*. It would hugely diminish the intellect’s dignity to deny it the intelligible species thanks to which it can have its object present without being constrained to beg it from the lower faculties of the soul with which, *qua* power of the soul,

it has only a contingent union (*cum quibus contingenter unitur in ratione potentiae*). Would it not be inappropriate that the sense and the other lower powers had their object present and that the intellect alone could not enjoy the presence of its object? Likewise, would it not be inappropriate that the intellect's object should only be present to it in the object of the lower faculties? Consequently, we must not hesitate to say that the object of this most noble of all powers is present to it in the highest degree, and as present as it is possible to be, before the act of intellection. Only the intelligible species lets us say that,[11] and therefore when we affirm its existence, we are very far from multiplying beings without necessity.

Perhaps those remarks suggest Duns Scotus's greatest concern in discussing this problem. For him, attributing intelligible species to the agent intellect was the surest means to avoid subjugating it to sensible species and to separate the intellectual soul's being by separating its operation. When we reread Duns Scotus after the warning he has just given, he becomes clear. If the intellect is distinguished from the sensible as the power of the universal, capable of composing or divining by judgment and of connecting by syllogisms, we must attribute a proper object to the intellect, really distinct from the object of sense. Accordingly, the point is to reserve for the intellect "some operation proper to it without the lower powers," *aliquam operationem sibi propriam sine potentiis inferioribus*. The intellect would not be separated from the body as the incorruptible is separated from the corruptible "unless it could have a proper object not depending on the sensitive part," *nisi posset habere operationem propriam non dependentem a parte sensitiva*.[12] If we bind its operations to the imagination's phantasm, it will be necessary that the intellect "depend in its operation on that power to which it is contingently joined."[13] But why multiply signs? An incisive expression has already said everything: "The agent intellect exercises no causality on phantasms."[14] Consequently, here we are dealing with an operation quite different from what we ordinarily call *abstraction*, a name Duns Scotus does not utter its name here. The Scotist agent intellect does not work on the phantasm to extract something or other from it. It does not

abstract; it does not extract; nor does it transform anything. It causes and produces the intelligible by virtue of the power that its separation from the body confers on it. In this doctrine everything affirms the intelligible order's autonomy.

Consequently, there is a profound reason to connect this problem to the problem of *memory*, because an intellect like the one about which Duns Scotus speaks is both the source and the place of its intelligible. This is why, after Scotus notes that his doctrine of the intelligible species seems to respond to Aristotle's intention, he immediately and rightly adds, *Expressius tamen est ad istud intentio Augustini*.[15] The inferences to which Scotus recurs to establish that Augustine's *memoria* requires intelligible species are certainly rather unconvincing, understood in this way, because Augustine himself says nothing about this. However, Duns Scotus is unquestionably faithful to the old Augustinian inspiration. The Scotist intellectual soul works to free itself within peripatetic philosophy from the bonds that subject it to the organized body whose form it is and nothing but the form in the doctrine of Aristotle. If the Stagyrite could have read this part of Duns Scotus's work, he would have recognized some expressions, but he would, even more surely, have asked why he was mentioned there.

However clear it is in itself, this position leaves another problem open from which it is inseparable. Duns Scotus, furthermore, never attempts to avoid it. However independent from the phantasm the agent intellect is in the exercise of its act, it still needs it. What relation is there between the sensible species and the intelligible species? Do they collaborate, and why?

We again meet one of the first conclusions to which the study of Duns Scotus led us, but this time it takes on a peculiarly noetic sense. Yes, humans do not think without images, but in principle the human intellect ought to be able to dispense with them. We will not review this point, which we have already examined at length. But it is important to weight the consequences for the problem that concerns us: although humans do not know anything in general without imagining it in the singular, the way in which our agent intellect does so suggests that in principle it could do otherwise. It does not

make any sense that in an intellect inherently capable of intelligible intuition, even abstractive knowledge, should be identical to what it is in an intellect naturally incapable of such an intuition.[16]

We see the way Duns Scotus describes the role of the sensible species and the phantasm in the production of the intelligible species. It is the role of a cause whose cooperation is necessary for the act of intellection, but which remains subordinated to the intellect. Moreover, if it were otherwise, we would not understand how the sensible species, which is produced by a singular exercising a singular action, could represent something universal and intelligible to the intellect. The problem is all the more urgent for Duns Scotus in that the question for him is not about just any action of the agent intellect upon or in the intelligible species. Accordingly, in the presence of the sensible species, the intelligible species must spring from the agent intellect as from its authentic source. This, in fact, is what happens. Duns Scotus unreservedly admits that the singular object engenders in the sense a species that does not represent under the guise of a universal but as a singular. He also admits that the singular species is the partial cause of the intelligible species' production. He simply observes that the other partial cause is the agent intellect, whose role is precisely to engender a species of the same nature as itself, that is to say, intelligible and capable of universality.[17] In other words, the agent intellect is no longer actually in a position to produce the intelligible without the cooperation of the sensible, and in this sense it is only the partial cause. Nevertheless, even *pro statu isto*, the intelligible species is in the likeness of the intellect, the father that authentically produces it.

Having arrived at this point, we begin to perceive the broad outlines of the act of intellection. At its origin is the real presence of the object, capable of acting upon the senses and or engendering a species in the image of its own singularity: *in primo signo naturae est objectum in se vel in phantasmate praesens intellectui agenti*. The intelligible object would be present in itself, if we were dealing with intuitive knowledge. It is at least present in the phantasm where we are dealing with abstractive knowledge as in the case

here.[18] Since the partial causes are present to the possible intellect as the agent is to the patient, the intelligible species is engendered by the agent intellect in the possible intellect: *in secundo signo naturae, in quo illa sunt praesentia intellectui possibili ad agentia passo, gignitur species in intellectu possibili*. Finally, when the intelligible species is thus produced, the object becomes knowable to the intellect through it: *et tunc in tertio per speciem est objectum praesens sub ratione cognoscibilis*.[19] It is in this sense that the intelligible always precedes the intellection, because the latter properly speaking is not the production of the intelligible by the agent intellect, but rather, as we will see, the passive modification of the possible intellect, by the intelligible species that the agent intellect produces.

The agent intellect, thus equipped with objects of knowledge that it gives itself, is a kind of intelligible memory always ready for its act. On this point, Duns Scotus finds himself in conflict with Avicenna, whose contrary position had long been known, at least since Thomas Aquinas had refuted it in *Summa contra Gentes*, book II, chapter 74: "On the opinion of Avicenna, who held that intelligible forms are not kept in the possible intellect," *De opinione Avicennae qui posuit formas intelligibiles non conservari in intellectu possibili*. Referring his readers to Avicenna's *Liber VI Naturalium*, part V, chapters 5 and 6, Aquinas sums up the Arab philosopher's position as follows: once the intelligible species are produced, they cannot be preserved in a corporeal organ because they are immaterial. They cannot subsist in themselves because they would be Platonic ideas. Consequently, each time we exercise an act of intellection, the intelligible species must flow from the separated agent intellect into our possible intellect, and thus, acquiring knowledge is combined with acquiring the habit of turning our possible intellect toward the separated agent intellect in order to receive the corresponding intelligible species from it. Even if Duns Scotus had not delved deeply into this part of Avicenna's work, he could hardly be unaware of this doctrine. He sums it up remitting to this part of *Liber VI Naturalium*, which, of course, is Avicenna's *De Anima*. However, Duns Scotus does not say with certainty that the doctrine was Avicenna's. First, it is the same to

Scotus whether Avicenna maintained it or not: *An hoc senserit Avicennae an non, non curo*. Next, if Avicenna really maintained it, he can be excused: *Tamen posset bene excusari*. Even if we take into account the concern for fairness that Duns Scotus usually demonstrates toward philosophers, it seems that Avicenna has the right to special privileges. We insist: Avicenna himself has that privilege, and not his doctrine, which Duns Scotus completely resists. Avicenna's possible intellect devoid of intelligible species and constantly in expectation of its celestial manna could not be more different from Duns Scotus's memory-intellect bulging with intelligible species that it constantly produces and that it preserves. In this regard, we find no trace of Avicennism in Duns Scotus. This is not surprising, because agent intellect's individuality is at stake in a problem, with which human supernatural destiny is directly involved. Yet, by a curious reaction, this very point makes Duns Scotus indulgent toward the Arab philosopher, because Scotus sees that in Avicenna's fashion (which is false), he takes care to assure humans a salvation that is *philosophical* and at bottom religious.

The fact is, observes Duns Scotus, that Avicenna admits that there is an order among intelligences and says that the last intelligence sends the intelligible species to our intellect. Plato already taught that we only know a thing by turning our intellect toward the idea of that thing. In the same way, according to Avicenna, we acquire knowledge and retain the science of what the sensible impression disposes us to know by a conversion of our intellect toward the intelligence that naturally influences it. This last point is important for someone who wants to salvage Avicenna. If someone wanted to give Avicenna a second chance, *qui vellet salvare Avicennam*, he would interpret Avicenna in the following manner: in the human intellect there are two kinds of species. One is abstracted from the sensible and subsists in it even when the intellect does not perform its act. The other is due to the intelligence toward which the human intellect turns, and it does not subsist when the intellect does not exercise the act of knowing. It is not necessary, Duns Scotus adds, that the second kind of species should subsist, because the intelligence always gives it naturally to the intellect that turns toward the

intelligence in the manner in which some doctors say that the separate intellect knows, “but through the flow of species from God, not from the Intelligence,” *sed per influxum specierum a Deo, non ab Intelligentia*.[20] Therefore, Duns Scotus notes a kind of collusion in certain of his predecessors between Avicennism and the Augustinian doctrine of divine illumination. That Avicenna could have thought almost like them does not make his doctrine true, but that he was mistaken almost like certain Christians invites us at least to excuse him.

However that may be, the doctrine in question is false, because the science or wisdom of an intellect is *its* science and *its* wisdom. If the objects of our knowledge, which are the intelligible species, subsist outside of us in some Separated Intelligence, there would never be acquired knowledge in us that is truly our own. But we should closely observe the way in which the Subtle Doctor criticizes Avicenna on this point, and let us not suppose that he thereby adheres to Thomas Aquinas’s position. Our agent intellect conserves a Scotist intelligible species, not a Thomist one—that is, an intelligible species more similar to that which an intelligence would give it than to what results from the conversion to the phantasms, *conversio ad phantasmata* in Thomism.

This is not a historian’s inference. Duns Scotus sets it out, and nothing helps us better to situate his personal position on this point and his general interpretation of intellectual knowledge. What Scotus declares in the prologue of the *Opus Oxoniense* as one of the most urgent things to be said here attains its full meaning. Some claim the proper object of the intellect united to the body is the quiddity of the material thing that only exists in this or that singular. If that were so, they would be right to add that the intellect cannot attain its object without the *conversio ad phantasmata*. Since the phantasm represents the singular, and the intellect’s object is the quiddity of the singular, the intellect must necessarily turn toward the phantasm to see in it the universal nature existing in the singular. But, Duns Scotus observes, this response is worthless: *haec responsis nulla est*. The intellect can know first only the singular or the universal. It cannot be the singular, since those who

hold this thesis themselves teach that we only know it by reflection. Therefore, we know the universal first. But it is contradictory to maintain that we can know the universal in the singular. At least we cannot if we are dealing with a true universal, a universal known in its total indifference, *secundum totam suam indifferentiam*. In a singular subject, the universal is restricted to the subject's singularity. In an object like the phantasm, the universal is only represented as restricted to the singularity of the object that engenders the sensible species. It is impossible, however we understand it, that the intellect should turn toward the phantasm to view the universal in it. The universal is not there.

Here, there is a confluence of theology, metaphysics, noetic, and psychology. Theologically, the agent intellect's proper object cannot be the *quidditas rei materialis*, because the blessed souls are capable of seeing God. Metaphysically speaking, the proper object of the agent intellect cannot be that quiddity, because the object of metaphysics in itself is being taken in total indifference to the sensible and the intelligible, the first knowledge of the first knowable, *scientia prima scibilis primi*. Likewise, from the noetic point of view, we know the universal, and it is contradictory that we should know it in the sensible. Finally, psychology itself is opposed, because our agent intellect, part of the substance *human*, is intrinsically an intelligible form, univocally comparable to the angelic intellect. Do the angels who perfectly know the quiddities of material things need a phantasm to know them? The same goes for us. Quiddities only exist in singular subjects, but the intellect can know them in themselves, without knowing that they exist. Here the opposing position's error appears clearly. Once again, it consists of overlooking the essential indifference of quiddities as such to both singularity and universality. What the intellect first sees in the singular is the *natura communis*, and thanks to the latter knowledge of the universal is possible, because "it is not included in the quiddity *qua* quiddity that it should exist in the singular, although it really only exists in it."[21]

Duns Scotus overwhelms us. All the actors assemble on stage and join hands. At the beginning of the last scene each of them sums up his or her

particular role in the overall action in a final effort to make us understand it. Everyone is there: agent intellect, possible intellect, phantasm, and intelligible species. If just one is missing, the play is ruined. *Pro statu isto*, we cannot even do without the phantasm and the common nature that it conveys, because its simultaneous presence in the act of intellection is necessary in abstractive knowledge, the only kind presently available to us. Accordingly it is good to retain the common language, provided that it is interpreted correctly. We can say that the intellect *abstracts*[22] the intelligible species from the phantasm by which the imagination portrays the particular object, but in the sense that it engenders and produces it. We can even say that intellect turns toward the phantasms, but in the sense that the possible intellect receives the intelligible species both from the phantasm and the agent intellect, which allows us to know the object at the same time we imagine it. Analysis leads us once more to the fundamental question: what are the respective contributions of the sensible species and the intellect to the knowledge of the object?

B The cause of intellection

To look for the cause of an intellection or of a volition (the problem is the same) is not to inquire about the production of a substance, because these intellections subsist in the absence of their objects. It is not the production of an action, a passion, or of a relation. The intellection and the volition are qualities. More exactly, they are qualities of the first species in which, according to Duns Scotus, all perfections of spiritual substances, other than God, consist.[23] Even a quality supposes a cause that produces or engenders it, and the principle is applied to immanent operations like intellection. However, let us specify that the *intellectio* is not the *notitia*. The latter, which is *knowledge* properly so-called has not been engendered apart from the *intellection* that it accompanies. Accordingly, there is no reason to look for a different cause for it. To determine the intellection's cause is exactly to say why the intellect knows, or better yet, why humans know. For, it is always

subjects that act, *actiones sunt suppositorum*.[24] Therefore, we have totally explained knowledge, if we say why humans exercise the act of intellection.

A first solution of the problem credits the intellect alone with the total production of the intellection. We doubt that this doctrine should be associated with a single proper name, since we are dealing with a position or rather, a tendency common to several of Duns Scotus's predecessors. Pushing to the extreme, we might attribute the position to St. Augustine, according to whom, even in sensation, the soul is active. However, Duns Scotus would not easily accept that Augustine is not on his side and, in fact, he will deny that this was Augustine's doctrine. William of Auvergne is a possible hypothesis. In brief, it is certainly difficulty to find a medieval doctrine of knowledge that absolutely denies all cooperation of the object in the act of intellection. But there are reasons to think that Duns Scotus directs himself to one or several doctrines that understand the cooperation so as to practically eliminate it.

In any case, the predecessors are Augustinians who base themselves with some appearance of plausibility on *De Genesi ad Litteram*, book XII, chapter 16, and *De Trinitate*, book X, chapter 5, where the doctrine of sensation conceived as an act of the soul is expounded.[25] This thesis is genuinely Augustinian, but it acknowledges explicitly that even in Augustine there would be no knowledge if there were no object. The object plays a necessary role, which can only be that of a cause. We can demonstrate that in intellection the object behaves as a cause distinct from the intellect, because if the intellect were the total cause, since it is a natural act and an act, then it would always know. Nothing could prevent it from that, either within it (because it is always naturally in act) or outside it (because in this hypothesis the object plays no role). But things do not occur this way. It does not depend on us alone to have sensible intuitions or not, a sure sign that the presence of objects cooperates in the act of intellection.

Not all who hold this position defend it in the same way. They do not deny unreservedly that the object's presence is necessary, but they sometimes reduce its role to that of a sine qua non cause, other times to an *excitant*. In order to admit a sine qua non cause, it would be necessary to admit a fifth

kind of cause, and since the four known causes sufficiently explain any effect, we do not see what further role would be attributed to this fifth kind. Parenthetically, Duns Scotus would have no sympathy for occasionalism, one of the permanent temptations of Augustinians. As for making the object a *term*, which it is, or an *excitant*, which it also is, that would be to admit implicitly that the act of intellection is impossible without the object, and therefore that the object cooperates in it; either it does something or it is simply the passive material cause, which is still a mode of genuine causality. In any case, we will not avoid the consequence that if the object were not a partial cause of intellection, intellection would never cease.[26]

Against this thesis, which places the whole activity of intellection on the side of the intellect, Duns Scotus sets a diametrically opposed one that places the whole activity of intellection in the object. This time we can identify the adversary without hesitation. He is Godfrey of Fontaines, who might have protested against the intention imputed to him here; Duns Scotus has him in mind, and the *Opus Oxoniense* reconstitutes his doctrine as it is derived from different places expressing this opinion, *sicut colligitur ex diversis locis sic opinantis*, in order to destroy it more surely.

As Duns Scotus understands it, this thesis amounts to maintaining, "The intellectual soul, *qua* intellectual, has no activity or causality in regard to intellection." This seems evident in what concerns the possible intellect, whether denuded or informed by the intelligible species, whose existence the author of this thesis denies. When we say *possible*, we say something passive that stands on the side of matter. Will it be admitted that the possible is act and the material cause is the efficient cause? To maintain that the intellect in potency for intellection could cause intellection would amount to maintaining that the mobile can move itself, that air illuminates itself in presence of the sun, or that wood is not heated by fire but heats itself in the presence of fire.

Less evident in regard to the agent intellect, this position still maintains that the agent intellect can cause nothing effectively in the possible intellect, and remarkably for the same reason. The agent and possible intellects form only a single subject; to say that one acts upon the other would amount to holding

that the intellect can act on itself.

In reality, everything here resembles what happens in the case of light and luminous bodies. To become luminous, a body must satisfy two conditions: be *diaphanous* and be illuminated by a luminous source (*lux*). In illuminating the body, light does not make the body pass from potency to act at all. Light does not make the body undergo any transformation. Simply, the body was already diaphanous before being illuminated, and in illuminating it, the extrinsic efficient cause that is the luminous source makes this dark body into a luminous body: it brings forth a certain body into a certain *esse*, it formally perfects that body, *producit corpus tale ad esse tale, formaliter perficit illud corpus*. Accordingly, there is induction of a formal quality without any modification of the subject. The same occurs here. The agent intellect is not the efficient cause of anything in the possible intellect, and if it finds a light there, he who, in creating the soul, simultaneously created these two faculties produces the light. The object, cooperating with this light of the intellect, causes intellection. To know the object, the intellect does not have to do anything in particular. It is enough for it to be the light that it is in order for the object to become intelligible, as it suffices for the light to be itself in order for a diaphanous body that is dark without the light to become a luminous body through the light.

Consequently, it is not the intellect but the object itself that causes both intellection and volition, not as efficient cause, but as formally cooperating with it as intellect. This initially mysterious expression has a simple meaning at bottom. Let us posit two intellects and the phantasm. Under the constant light of the agent intellect, the intelligible species shines in the phantasm without having anything to do other than explain how the phantasm can move the possible intellect. But even this is understandable because, although certain powers of the soul are tied to the body and although this one is not, all are powers of the same soul. It would not be surprising that a power located in a different part of the body from the imagination should be modified by the imagination’s power. It is no more surprising that the imaginative power should act by the phantasm upon the intellect, which is neither in the

imagination nor elsewhere, but nowhere.[27]

Duns Scotus subjects the doctrine to an examination that is too exacting for him to fail to see that, in spite of everything, the agent intellect still does something. By illuminating the phantasm if only by its ordinary permanent action, the agent intellect at least makes the intelligible form shine in the phantasm. But this does not exempt Godfrey from the reproach of having suppressed the intellect's efficacy. The intellect does not cause anything that is not already formally in the phantasm. The casual action attributed to the intellect is, therefore, not the production of anything. It is reduced to a kind of *spiritual contact* of this light with the phantasm, whose sole effect is to discard the individuating conditions that prevent the phantasm from informing the possible intellect. Once this removal of obstacles, *remotio prohibentium*, is accomplished, the phantasm remains the sole cause of intellection. Certainly, the light of the agent intellect is equally necessary, but strictly speaking its efficacy is from God, who created this light in the possible intellect. It follows that, unless we admit that God immediately produces all our intellections in us, it is necessary to recognize that the phantasm alone causes all the actions of the intellectual part of the soul, whether intellections or volitions.[28]

This doctrine is unacceptable, because to attribute the whole causality of intellection to the phantasm is to make inexplicable the intellect's many operations that go far beyond the phantasm's intelligible contact, notably the judgments by which we unite or separate the quiddities. Error would become impossible, because always acting as a natural cause, according to its nature, the phantasm would never make us mistake true knowledge for false, nor false knowledge for true. It would always make itself known as it is. In a completely general way, we do not see how the impact of the phantasm on the intellect by itself could cause syllogistic reasoning, or argumentation and, least of all, second intentions as well as relations of reason. Indeed, if the phantasm causes the whole intellection, the latter will always be real knowledge, namely, *intellection immediately caused by a thing or a species immediately representing a thing in itself*. Neither second intentions nor

relations of reason involve things. Consequently, they would become impossible if the phantasm was the sole cause of intellection. Finally, how could the intellect know itself? Can the phantasm in causing intellection also cause reflection on this intellection? Since its causality is that of its nature, we would enter into a sequence of acts that would go on to infinity. After having caused intellection and then reflection on this intellection, the phantasm would likewise cause reflection on this reflection and so on. Consequently, either the phantasm cannot cause any reflection or else it must cause numberless reflections. Let us not diminish the soul by explaining the operations of such a noble nature by the phantasm alone. If the phantasm were the only cause of intellection, the intellectual soul would not be more perfect than the phantasm is.[29]

Duns Scotus directs a critique inspired by the second approach against several other solutions to the same problems. Whatever its historical interest may be, the critique does not seem indispensable for the interpretation of Scotus's personal response, which is based on the refutation of the two extreme theses rejected by him at the outset.[30] The controlling fact seems to Scotus to be the discontinuity of intellection. We know; then we cease to know in order to begin again. That is a fact of experience. Accordingly, it is within our power to know when we wish, which supposes an active cause of intellection, and supposes that in one way or the other this cause is within us. On the other hand, we have previously established that there can be intellectual knowledge without the cooperation of an intellectual soul and an object present in an intelligible species. That said, we can immediately conclude that neither the object alone nor the soul taken separately suffices to cause the acts of intellection and that their cooperation is necessary. Consequently, they must be consulted here as the two integral parts of a single cause. "Therefore, if either the soul alone nor the object alone is the total cause of actual intellection, and only these seem to be required for intellection, it follows that these two are a total cause in regard to the knowledge produced."[31] This involves a return to St. Augustine's teaching, but the nature of this *cooperation* calls for some clarification.

Causes can cooperate toward the same effect in several different ways. A first case is that of two causes that cooperate in the same way, *ex aequo*, as when two men join to pull a heavy object. A second case is that of essentially ordered causes. This case in turn is subdivided in two. First, there is the case where the inferior can only act moved by the superior, whether it receives the form that moves it or whether it receives at least the natural motion that makes it produce its effect. In the second case, without the superior conferring motion or motor force on the inferior, the superior possesses a more perfect active force than the inferior, but without the inferior cause receiving its active force from the superior with the more perfect active force. Two examples will say it best. If I strike with a stick or I throw a ball, the stick or the ball have no other motor force than my hand's motor force. Therefore, here the inferior is only moved by the superior. But here is another case. Let us admit that the mother exercises an active force in the generation of the baby. This force and the father's force are going to cooperate in procreation as two partial causes, moreover ordered ones, because one is more perfect than the other. However, the less perfect does not receive its causality from the more perfect cause. It would not even be true to say that this total causality is contained eminently in the more perfect cause. In reality, the lower cause contributes something that does not come from itself to the effect. It puts something of its own there, to such an extent that the effect itself is more perfect, being produced by two causes, than it would be if the higher cause alone produced it.

To which of these cases should we say the act of intellection corresponds? The intelligible object present in the intelligible species and the intellectual part of the soul do not cooperate *ex aequo* to produce the effect. This declaration is expected, but it certainly is a Subtle Doctor who justifies it. Let us suppose that the intellect and object cooperate *ex aequo* to produce the act of intellection. It would be necessary for each of them to exercise imperfect causality. Otherwise, the other would do nothing. However, they both do the same thing, so much so that if one of them exercised perfect efficacious causality, it could produce the effect alone. Two men tie up the same stone.

Each pulls his part of it, but a sufficiently strong man would drag it all alone. For this to be so in the case of intellection, the species would have to contribute on its side a degree of intellectuality lower than that of the intellect, *but of the same order*. It would follow that an intellect more perfect than this one would be enough to produce the same act of intellection alone without the cooperation of species or object. That is false, because if the intelligible intuition were still possible for us, it would be an act of intellection different from that by which we know the sense object.

Accordingly, the result is that the object and intellect are two essentially ordered causes, cooperating unequally in the same effort. But what does each of them do? To find out, let us go back to the different cases we have distinguished. Does the intellect confer its causality on the object or on the species? It does neither, because the object and the species contribute to producing the intellection by virtue of their own natures and not by some influence of the intellect. Will we say, on the contrary, that the intellect receives causality from the object or the object's species? Not at all, because this would make it necessary to admit that the intellect was inferior to the intelligible species, which is not true. Besides, that would lead us to deny that intellection is the proper perfection of the intellect, to make it into a simple accidental perfection, whose real principle would be the intelligible species. Finally, the facts invite us to think the opposite, because both in sensible knowledge and in intellectual knowledge, the same object is more perfectly known if the effort of attention assists the act's exercise. We see the same object better at the same distance and in the same light when we look at it attentively. In certain cases, the intensity of the gaze can even come to harm sight. The same goes for an intelligible object that we know all the better insofar as we make a greater effort to know it.[32] Consequently, it is impossible either to deny the species the causality that is specifically its own, which devolves to it in the act of intellection or to deny the intellect that which belongs to it as peculiarly its own. We are dealing with the cooperation of two essentially ordered causes in the last sense that we have previously distinguished. Absolutely speaking, one of them, the intellect, is more perfect

than the other. However, each of them is perfect and independent of the other in the order of partial causality that it exercises: “One is absolutely more perfect than the other, however, in such a way that each is perfect in is partial causality, not depending on the other.”[33]

Duns Scotus’s central preoccupation appears clearly here. Once more it involves his concern with maintaining each order of being and each order of causality in its rightful pace. Real being and formal being each have their rights. They do not belong to the same order. If I want to cut something, I pick up a knife, and this knife cuts by virtue of my hand’s motor force, but my hand cuts by virtue of the previously sharpened blade of the knife. Both causes are necessary for the effect. Yet the knife’s *acuties*, sharpness, does not confer any movement on it, and the knife’s movement confers no *acuties* on it. Even if the hand had a cutting edge, it would be accidental to it, insofar as it is the motor force. The proof is that the hand can certainly move itself without the knife as well as with it, and the knife remains as sharp on a table as in my hand. The knife acts as a motor cause, and therefore efficient cause. The knife’s blade, its sharpness, acts as a formal cause. Therefore, there are certainly two distinct and complementary acts of being and causality.

The same goes for intellection. All the production and efficiency that intellection involves is the work of the intellect, but since intellection represents the object, the species possesses the unity and entity proper to the form. The species does not confer or exercise active causality upon the intellect. But it is in the intellect *qua* form, and it determines the content of intellection by its formal causality. In other words, the intellect causes the act of intellection, and the species make that act the intellection a given object. The intellect can only know with a species, as the hand can only cut with a knife. It might be objected that the intellection considered in this way lacks unity, but this is wrong. Intellection cannot be explained by a single cause; it needs two. But since they are essentially ordered and cooperate in the same act, there is a unity of order between them. The case is not unique, and it is wrong to claim that a single effect never has more than a single cause. In the generation of a being, the sun is partial cause in its order, as the father is

partial cause in its order. We cannot unite sun and father in the unity of a third being, which would be the total cause. Each of these two causes acts by exercising its particular causality, and their only unity is certainly a unity or order, *unitas ordinis*. Accordingly, there is no reason to reject ordered cooperation of the two causes in the act of intellection.[34]

This conclusion implies a definite concept of intellect, whose significance greatly transcends the structure of our problem. Duns Scotus feels he remains faithful to Augustine's teaching, and he does so in great measure, but not as much as he believes. Regarding the problem of sensation, Duns Scotus admits an action by the sensible upon the soul, whereas Augustine, faithful to Plotinus, admits an action of the object upon the body, followed by an act of the soul that produces sensible knowledge from its own substance. Duns Scotus can gloss well-known passages where the Bishop of Hippo formulates his doctrine, but he does not entirely succeed in reconciling himself to them.[35] On the other hand, if we compare Scotus's position to Thomas Aquinas's, for example, it seems that Scotus is closer to Augustine, because despite the causality Scotus assigns to the object, we see in him a strong concern to guarantee the intellect's spontaneity and causal efficacy. In this sense, Duns Scotus's argumentation moves completely between the outer limits posted by the first two theses, that of total activity and that of the total passivity of the intellect. We have seen that both of them are inadmissible, because the intellect is capable of all being, and in order to cause the knowledge of all being by itself, it would be necessary that the intellect should be all being.[36] But inversely, if the object exercises no causality, even a simple formal one, we do not conceive how the intellect is not continuously in act and how, in order to know, it needs the object's direct or indirect presence.[37]

The main difficulty for Scotus comes from Aristotle who, as is well known, held intellection to be a passion. It is easy to reconcile this classical position with the object's causality. The difficulty is to reconcile it with the activity of the intellect. Duns Scotus is able to succeed by using his distinction between the orders of efficient and formal causality. The intellect is active as efficient

cause and passive formally.[38] Scotus does not hesitate to recur to this argument, but its properly Scotist sense must be clarified. As agent, the will produces absolutely nothing but its action, which is the last term and has no other term itself. The single and unique function of the agent intellect is, therefore, to cause the intellection. This is why another cause is necessary to assimilate the possible intellect to the known object. But this other cause cannot affect the agent as such or the production of its act. Thus, the formal casualty required for knowledge to be formally similar to the known in no way affects the intellect's active causality.

Duns Scotus makes us see this with equal clarity and vigor, when, he responds to the difficulty that, since an agent cannot produce a determined action without undergoing the action of a cause that determines the agent to it, the intelligible species must act on it as determinative principle.[39] The ambiguity that must be avoided lies precisely there, because there can be a formal determinative principle of intellection, but not of the act that produces it. When we speak of an indetermination of the intellect to different acts and different objects, we distinguish between material indetermination through a deficit in the act and indetermination of an agent whose active virtue is unlimited. In this second sense, the sun's active virtue is not determined to the generation of this or that being, but it can engender a great number of beings indeterminately. It is indetermination by excess not defect. In the first sense, the undetermined cannot act without being determined to it by an act, because since it is in potency itself, it is incapable of activating itself alone. However, the undetermined in the second sense (by excess of actuality) is not determined by any other form than itself. Of itself, it determines itself to produce any effect in regard to which it is naturally undetermined, provided only that the passive receiver of this effect is there to receive it. When the appropriately tempered material mixture is present, the sun engenders the kind of being that can come out of it. The same occurs in the case of intellection: "The indetermination of the intellect is not that of a passive potentiality in the order of causality, but the indetermination of a quasi-unlimited actuality. Therefore, it is not determined by a form that is its reason

for acting determinately, but only by the presence of a determinate object, from which it is natural that the intellection is determined."[40] Duns Scotus does not even admit that the lower determining cause acts on the higher determined cause, except formally, *formaliter* and as its reason of acting, *ratio agendi*. The *notitia* is what the lower cause formally determines to be *this knowledge*, not the agent intellect itself. The causality of the latter is not any more determined by the intellection than the causality of the sun is by the various beings it engenders. Since both have only to be and to shine for their efficacy to be diversified by the formal diversity of the patients that are subject to their action,[41] it is certain that the intellect is always the principal cause of intellection.[42]

Perhaps this description of the *intellectio* will leave uncertainty in the minds of those accustomed to another doctrine of *abstractio*. The two causalities distinguished and united by Duns Scotus respect so completely the specificity of their different causalities in their acts that some will ask how they can cooperate, since each only contributes to the common effect by being what it is, one an efficient cause, the other a formal cause. But now is the time to recall that the object to be known in Duns Scotus is not what it was in Thomas Aquinas. The same object is already endowed with a proper, sui generis unity, independent of sense knowledge and naturally prior to it. It is the unity of a *quod quid est*, the white for example. With greater reason this holds for the object of the intellect, that is to say, for the real singular known by the senses, which, however, offers a quiddity or nature to the intellect, something indifferent of itself to existence and nonexistence, to universality and singularity.

Important consequences follow. With his peripatetic predecessors, Duns Scotus admits that the intellect causes the universal, because *natura communis* of itself is not more universal that singular, but, in Duns Scotus, the intellect has less to do to cause the universal than in Thomas Aquinas. If the intellect does not find the ready-made universal in things, it does not come up against the singular there. The matter of the operation is the *natura* or *quidditas* taken in its natural indetermination, which the intellect does not

have to desingularize first in order to be able to universalize it later: “Therefore, the agent intellect, cooperating in some way with the nature that is undetermined of itself, is the whole active cause of the object in the possible intellect according to the universal’s complete indetermination.”[43] The function of the intellect is to universalize the common nature as the individuating difference has the function of singularizing it. The intellect makes it by producing a universalized intelligible species in the possible intellect. Accordingly, this universalization is not an abstraction in the Thomist sense of the term. Obviously, the intellect does not find the universal ready-made in the real, but it finds it directly there in potency to be universalized. The *abstractio* is not required to *lay bare* the quiddity that is found in the phantasm, where it is always bared, as it is in the thing itself. No purification or denuding is necessary to strip its singular marks from an object that of itself does not entail them. Consequently, we must avoid two contrary errors here. One would be to believe that the agent intellect does nothing in universalizing the quiddity. The other error would be to believe that the agent intellect first has to transform something *singular* into *common* in order net to be able to universalize it.[44]

Universalization is a definite positive operation and a causal action whose effect is observable. The *indifferent* is not universal. Strictly, in the *common*, we can see what is universal in its virtual state but not in act. It is something to which it is not repugnant to be predicated of several beings in the sense that nothing in its nature is opposed to that, but the intellect alone can consider this *common* in such a way that, by taking advantage of its indifference, it makes it into an object of predication.[45]

On the other hand, the agent intellect does not produce the universal in things by striping the quiddity of the singular marks that it carries in the phantasm. Everywhere the *natura* is found, whether in the thing before being in the phantasm or in the intellect at the moment of intellection, it remains what it is, namely, “a nature such that of itself it is not opposed to being in another,” *talis natura ex se cui non repugnet esse in alio*, but it is in proximate potency to be predicated of every singular of the same species only

in the intellect.[46] In other words, the quiddity is not in proximate potency to be produced either in the thing or in the phantasm. It only becomes predicable by the possible intellect's action under the agent intellect's act.[47] Only then does the nature's indifference become complete to the point that it is predicable of a plurality of distinct individuals, each one of which is identically what the nature is.

Accordingly, Duns Scotus's personal position on the question is not doubtful, but it is interesting to note that, *qua* theologian, he does not consider positions other than his to be impossible. Since the problem comes down to choosing between Augustine and Aristotle, we can naturally include different doses of active and passive elements in the act of intellection. We can even try to be fair to Aristotle himself, as well as to those who start from his doctrine but sometimes seem to stress this act's passivity excessively. This is what Duns Scotus wants to do in his remarkable *Quodlibet* XV [AW, pp. 344–68], where, without abandoning the positions just defended, he explains the reasons why Aristotle and Augustine took the different positions that their interpreters find difficult to reconcile.[48]

It must be acknowledged that Aristotle speaks most often of the object's activity and the passivity of our faculty of knowing. But this is explicable, because he ordinarily envisages the powers of the soul as that by which we can operate formally. For example, in Aristotle the faculty of feeling is that by which we can formally feel in fact, and the faulty of knowing is that by which we can exercise formally acts of intellection. Duns Scotus observes that, although the intellect actively causes intellection in us, we would not say that it knows insofar as it causes, for, if God caused intellection in us, we would not say that God knows. The intellect in which God would cause this intellection would be the knowing intellect. The same holds for us: "Therefore and in some manner, the intellect is said to understand, not because it causes, but because it receives the intellection and thus it is true that to understand is to undergo something, since to understand what is understood is nothing but receiving the intellection," *igitur et modo intellectus dicitur intelligere, non quia causat, sed quia recipit*

intellectionem; et sic verum est quod intelligere est quoddam pati, quia intellectum intelligere non est nisi ipsum recipere intellectionem. Once more, we see how scrupulous Duns Scotus is in his interpretations of the philosophers. This time he explains that Aristotle may have been led to stress intellection's passive aspect, but without forgetting that the intellection is an act. Inversely, Augustine generally insists on the intellect's causality and does so starting from the level of sensation, but without ever forgetting that the object cooperates in the act of knowing, as he says in *De Trinitate*, book IX (among other passages in his works). Consequently, Duns Scotus admits that their cooperation is necessary, since the intellect is the intrinsic principle of the act of knowledge, and the object is its extrinsic formal principle. Intellection essentially depends on both, on the intellect even to be an intellection and on the object in order for the intellection to relate to it.

On the matter of finding out which intellect causes intellection, our theologian again wonders how Aristotle must be interpreted to put him in agreement with what Augustine says about memory insofar as it constitutes part of the image of the Trinity in us. In Aristotle we can consider either the agent intellect or the possible intellect as the active principle of intellection. It is evident that the agent intellect could be this principle, since Aristotle defines it as being able to do everything in contrast to the possible intellect that can become everything. Yet, it can also be the possible intellect because, according to Aristotle, all the agent intellect does is to produce the intelligible. As we have just seen, the one who knows the intelligible is not the one who causes it, but the one who receives it. The indications given by Aristotle himself amount to so little that we cannot count on his texts to decide between those who hold the two interpretations. As for Duns Scotus, everything transpires as though the only question that really interests him is to discover which of the two is adapted more easily to what we read about the image of God, *imago Dei*, in St. Augustine. In Scotus's eyes, this theological problem dominates the controversy, and in order to resolve it Scotus successively develops the two solutions in *Quodlibet* XV.

According to the first solution, which deems the agent intellect the active

cause of intellection, this intellect exercises two ordered actions: one that makes the intelligible in potency intelligible in act (or the universal in potency the universal in act), the other that makes the knowable in potency known in act. The intelligible's actualization can be conceived as follows: by virtue of the agent intellect, an intelligible species is engendered in the intellect starting from the phantasm that is in the imagination (*phantasia*). We are dealing with a reason of knowing (*ratio*) where the intelligible illuminates in act, which is abbreviated as an *intelligible species*. This real generation of an intelligible representation starting from a sensible representative is accompanied by the metaphorical generation of an intelligible object starting from an imaginable object. It is reasonable to speak this way because, as the representative being of the object is, so is its objective being in the representation (*tale esse objectivum habet objectum in repraesentari quale habet reprasesentativum correspondens*). If we admit that the representative undergoes a real transfer when something spiritual is generated from something corporeal, or a universal representative (the intelligible species) is generated from a singular representative (the phantasm), it is certainly necessary to admit a parallel transfer from the corporeal to the spiritual or from the singular to the universal. A second action is added to this first action of the agent intellect. By the second action, the knowable in potency, becomes knowable in act. Actual intellection really follows the intelligible species. This is why, when the intellect really produces the intelligible species from the corporeal phantasm and metaphorically produces an intelligible object from a sensible object, it turns the latter from intelligible in potency to intellectually known in act. In other words, the intellect exercises a real action, which is the transfer of the species from one order to another, and also a first metaphorical action, the production of an intelligible action, followed by a second metaphorical action, the intellection.

This complicated language expresses a simple idea. Duns Scotus says that we can attribute the intellection to the agent intellect, if we think that it is the agent intellect that produces the intelligible species, from which ipso facto result the intelligible object and the act of knowing. The agent intellect only

really produces the first, but we can attribute to it the two consequences resulting from that because an intelligible species is an intelligible object, and to cause an intelligible object in an intellect is, in fact, to cause an intellection. Perhaps we will see this better by placing ourselves in the standpoint of the possible intellect, where a double passion corresponds to this double action. By the first passion the possible intellect receives the intelligible species produced from the phantasm by the agent intellect; by the second action, it receives the intellection caused in it by the intelligible object that the agent intellect causes. From the viewpoint of this second operation, the agent intellect could be included in the *memoria* of which Augustine speaks because, although the memory does not have to produce anything new, for example something intelligible from something sensible, it produces intellections and actual knowledge by leading them from potency to act, which the agent intellect does in the possible intellect. As for the possible intellect, by undergoing the agent intellect's first action, that is to say, by receiving the intelligible now present, the possible intellect is memory. We would thus call the second reception intelligence (*intelligentia*), which is the reception of the intellection.

That is the first way of inserting the Aristotelian doctrine of abstraction into the Augustinian doctrine of *imago* by attributing the intellection to the agent intellect. However, we would succeed at least as well by attributing intellection to the possible intellect. In this last hypothesis, the agent intellect does not belong to memory at all, since its action is limited to abstracting the intelligible object, but this action is terminated at the memory, since its term is the form in which the intelligible object illuminates the intellect. Once in possession of this form, the intellect is memory in the full sense of the word. If the issue were to know pure intelligibles, for example, spiritual substances, the agent intellect would have nothing to do, because there would be no abstraction to carry out. With or without species, these objects would suffice to cause their knowledge in the possible intellect. The possible intellect would then respond to memory in two ways: retaining the representative reason of the intelligible object and actively expressing actual knowledge. In

short, the problem of rejoining the Augustinian *imago* admits a solution in both cases.

These analyses call for several observations. To begin with the most external aspect, we observe that at no time does Scotus envisage the possibility of knowledge without species, except hypothetically for the intuition of pure intelligibles, which does not apply to the present human state. These passages do not favor the hypothesis according to which Duns Scotus would admit intuitive knowledge without intelligible species, even when a present object is known as present. Next and more importantly, the two positions contain common elements about which Duns Scotus shows no reservation: distinction of the two intellects, production of an intelligible species, the transfer of order implied by this production, and the act of intellection exercised by the possible intellect in possession of the species-object caused by the agent intellect, which the possible intellect would be capable of exercising alone, if the pure intelligible were offered directly to it.

The totality of these characteristics confers the general tendency of Duns Scotus to place the principal cause of intellection in the possible intellect, something furthermore that agrees well with a doctrine in which it is not essential for human intellectual knowledge to be abstractive. The agent intellect is there to make intellection possible, but in principle there could be intellection without abstraction, in which case the possible intellect would undergo knowledge without agent intellect. Along with Duns Scotus we see this again, along, by comparing the Aristotelian distinction between the two intellects and the distinction that Duns Scotus introduces in *De Trinitate*, book X, chapter 11, between memory, intelligence, and will (*memoria*, *intelligentia*, and *voluntas*). The possible intellect corresponds to Augustinian *intelligentia*, since it alone receives the act of knowing. The possible intellect also corresponds to *memoria*, since memory receives habitual knowledge according to St. Augustine, and the possible intellect plays the same role in Aristotle. Even the act of engendering actual knowledge belongs to the possible intellect, at least accidentally, because even though this intellect knows through the species, it is certainly the intellect that knows. We say no

less correctly that the possible intellect knows when it is in possession of the intelligible species-object. We note the tendency without emphasizing it more than Duns Scotus does. After all, the answer to the question depends on the degree of distinction that is introduced between these powers of the soul. If we only admitted a single principle of absolute and unlimited knowledge (one therefore capable of producing a multitude of different acts, but called *agent* in relation to some and *possible* in relation to others), it would be equally plausible to hold the agent intellect to be the principal cause of intellection.

C Knowledge of the singular

We have seen that the first object of the intellect is being taken in its indetermination to the intelligible and the sensible. For the reasons stated, we have seen that in fact *pro statu isto*, the intellect only knows the abstract quiddities of the sensible. Lastly, we see that the sensible beings known by us are singular existents. Accordingly, it is inevitable to wonder whether and how the human intellect knows the singular *pro statu isto*.

The problem is complex, but not more or less than all problems that concern intellectual knowledge in Duns Scotus's doctrine. Let us note, however, that it is first posed in the context of the knowledge that angels can have of their own essences, which are singulars. From this moment, there are theologians who claim that, since the singular is not intelligible in itself, the angel's essence cannot cause intellection in its intellect. Therefore, matter does not immediately come into question. The only obstacle to intelligibility in the singular at issue here is its singularity.[49]

This way of posing the question is legitimate, because we already know that individuation is independent of matter in Duns Scotus. Accordingly, the problem can be formulated about any finite essences. Just as it belongs to the essence of a material quiddity to exist in a singular, it belongs to the essence of an angelic quiddity to exist in a subject or *supposit*, which is also the subject or *supposit* of a singular.[50] Consequently, the issue is to find out firstly whether singularity as such by nature is opposed to being an object of

intellection. Then supposing that singularity is intelligible in itself, we must find out whether it is knowable by us.

Duns Scotus rejects the first conclusion, at least insofar as we are dealing with angels, because it is not impossible that the singular escapes the grasp of an intellect like ours, but that is not the case of the angelic intellect. The latter knows itself in its essence, so it knows its essence, and it knows its essence as singular through a direct intelligible intuition. To establish this point is to prove at the same time that the singular is intelligible of itself, because it certainly is that, if it is intellectually known.

Let us return to the distinction between the two kinds of intellection. First, there is scientific, abstractive intellection, the intellection that constitutes science precisely because it abstracts from the existence of its object. As existing objects are variable, our science would vary with them, if it included their existence. What we know about Socrates would change according to whether he is alive or dead, or whether he sits or stands. In short, the contingency of existence would be incompatible with the necessity that scientific knowledge owes to its object's necessity. On the other hand, there is intuitive knowledge, which is a vision, this time a vision of the thing itself: *cognitio intuitiva, seu visiva, quae est rei in se*. For the intellect, this second kind of intellection is analogous to the direct sight of an object in sense knowledge, because we can imagine an object or remember it, knowing it in its image, which is a kind of abstraction where knowledge is independent of the object's existence. But we also see it in its actual being as an existent, and since every higher faculty can do in its order what the lower faculty can do, the intellect certainly must enjoy two kinds of intellection corresponding to these kinds of sensible knowledge. In what concerns abstractive knowledge, no uncertainty is possible. We experience it continually, because it constitutes science. That we are capable of intellectual intuition is certain for the reason we just stated. Moreover, St. Paul says in 1 Cor. 13:12, "At present, we are looking at a confused reflection in a mirror; then we will see face to face." For this direct view to be promised to our intellect, it is necessary that our intellect be capable of it. With greater reason this is so for

the angels, because not only are they capable of it, but they also have it, particularly in regard to their own essences. The latter are intelligibles in act and always present to the respective angelic intellects immediately and without intermediary. As we said in its moment, angels do not know themselves immediately and by their essences, knowledge that is a prerogative of God, but their respective essences are immediately intelligible to them, and consequently nothing prevents there being an intuition of it.[51] How would an angel see its essence in itself, without seeing it in its singularity?

The singular is intelligible by nature. More than that, as we have just said it is superlatively intelligible; otherwise our intellect could not be beatified by God seen face to face and known in his singularity.[52] It is legitimate to argue from angels to humans by virtue of the principle that we are dealing with an intellect in both cases. We can even argue from God to men, because in both cases we are dealing with intellect taken univocally, as must be when we speak of intellect as such. "Everything is intelligible for the divine intellect, both singular and universal. Therefore everything is intelligible for any intellect absolutely speaking, since inherently it deals with the totality of being, although it is impeded in this fallen state of ours (*licet impediatur secundum istum statum lapsum*)."[53] Abstracting from this accidental obstacle, it remains true to say that of itself and in principle, the singular as such is intelligible for our intellect.

Yet, it is a fact that we have no science of the singular. Intrinsically intelligible and knowable (*intelligibile* and *scibile*) in itself, the singular is not intelligible or knowable for us at present. Duns Scotus has just suggested the reason for that, which we already know. In its intact nature, our intellect, precisely as intellect, is capable of all being and even of God. However in the state of fallen nature, *secundum istum statum lapsum*, it is not apt for intelligible intuition. Obviously, we know the intelligible, but *ut natura*, not *ut hoc*. We already know that neither the individuating difference nor the singularity that results from it is included in a nature as such. Even more, if there is only science of the general, the singular cannot be the object of

science. Irreducible to the quiddity, the singular cannot be universalized. Singularity is an object of knowing, but of a knowing different from what we call *science*. It is knowing that is not formulated in definitions, because definitions only express the essences of species, and the individual is more than the species: *individuum exprimit plus quam quidditatem*. In short, the individuating difference is such that it must be seen in order to be known. In our present state, the individuating difference cannot be seen. We do not lack the intellectual capacity to see it, but we have temporarily lost the power to exercise that capacity, as if humans had lost their sight, while retaining their eyes, something that would be possible.

This is Duns Scotus's constant position on the subject. What complicates the question, besides the desire some of his interpreters have of discovering the position there, is that Duns Scotus himself attributes certain knowledge of the singular to us. He does not do so forgetfully or in passing but often and fully aware of what he is writing. We simply must be careful about the meaning he gives his expressions. Like all the doctors of his time, including Thomas Aquinas, Duns Scotus grants us some knowledge of the singular and of its singularity. How could he do otherwise, if only individuals exist? But our intellect attains the singular in sensation, and since the senses themselves do not perceive the singular in its individuating difference but as a *nature*, the senses only reveal the existence of the existing singular to the intellect. Perceiving this being's indifferent *nature* the senses permit the intellect to know this singular nature abstractly and its existence intuitively. Since I see Socrates, I know he exists, and I know that what I know is a singular existent. But beyond its existence, which sensation reveals to me, I only know its nature obstructively. In other words, I know intellectually, thanks to the sense perception and the phantasm that an individual endowed with a given nature exists. Therefore, the intellect prevails over the senses, because they only know singulars, but the intellect only abstractively knows the common nature, which it endows with universality. In this life and in its present state, the intellect does not have an intuition of the individuating principle that circumscribes the common nature to the existent's singularity.[54]

Therefore, Duns Scotus grants us no intellectual intuition of singularity under any form. Since the knowledge that the intellect achieves does not go beyond the *natura indeterminata*, it is necessarily abstract.[55] When we have the sensible intuition of an existent, our intellect knows that its quiddity belongs to a singular, but the immediate knowledge the intellect has of this quiddity, as the phantasm conveys it, is knowledge in the mode of abstraction. The difficulty we find in understanding it perhaps stems from our displacing what was the heart of the question in our view. What the concept of intuitive knowledge immediately invokes in his mind is the object's existence. It does not at all evoke that singularity is existence. An intellect more perfect than ours, which had an intelligible intuition of individuating differences, would not know only the existence of the corresponding singulars by that intuition.[56] However, there is a vision of the intellect that does attain existing natures without seeing their singularity,[57] so that intuitive knowledge as such is not only knowledge of the singular, but also knowledge of the existing nature, precisely as existing.[58] What condition is necessarily required for there to be intuition if not precisely the existence of the object presently known? The intuition of what does not exist is a contradictory concept.[59] But again, in our present condition, in our weakened state (*pro statu isto*, *pro statu miseriae*), what other than sensation is the necessarily required condition for an existent nature to be known to us in its very existence? Presently, a nature only moves our intellect by the phantasm. Consequently, we only know the singular thing as existent by a nature's phantasm, which not being intrinsically singular cannot cause the knowledge of singularity in the intellect. In other words, the singularity of a nature does not move our intellect; it *accompanies* the nature that moves the intellect by the phantasm. If, when undergoing the motion of the phantasm, we know that that our knowledge is the intuition of an existent, our intellect can only know its nature abstractly, without thereby grasping this thing as this thing, *hoc ut hoc*.[60] These analyses lead to the following equivalences: everything that actually exists is singular; the intuition always bears upon an existent; therefore, intuition always bears upon a singular, so that all intuitive

knowledge is knowledge of a singular. However, *pro statu isto*, the singular only acts upon our intellect by its nature and the phantasm, abstracting from the singularity that only accompanies it without acting. Therefore, we only intuitively know the singular, as the existent that causes our intuition. As Klug's expresses it, perfectly in our opinion, "The intellect knows whether a nature exists by intuition," because it possesses knowledge of the sensible act that grasps the existing nature by intuition.[61] This is Duns Scotus's own doctrine without any interpretation.

The divergences that clutter the history of Duns Scotus's thought on this point, and those that we think are observed in his texts, are perhaps explained by the lack of attention to an elementary distinction. When the intellect has the intuition of an object, it knows it both as object and as existent. It is perfectly true that the intelligible species plays no role in our knowledge of the object *precisely* as existing in this sense, in other words, precisely as *cognitio existentis ut existens est*, the intuition owes nothing to the species. Not the species but the sole presence of the object is what makes, thanks to sensation, *cognitio intuitiva* out of the knowledge we have of the object. However, it does not follow that intuitive knowledge occurs without species, because if there were none, there would be no known object. Through the species, Duns Scotus will say,[62] the object is present to us under the reason of knowable or represented, *sub ratione cognoscibilis sive repraesentati*. Unless we take it to be knowledge of the existence of nothing, it certainly is necessary that the intellectual intuition itself has an object. In consequence, we need the species, moreover the same species that will allow abstractive knowledge in the absence of the same object. Intuition must be conceived as resulting from a single object, but caused by it in two ways: insofar as present, it makes its existence be seen; insofar as acting by the species, the object makes itself *knowable* and *represented*.

If we may be permitted to insert into this analysis a gloss that emphatically proclaims itself to be a gloss and that we would be free to discard without the above conclusion being affected, we would say that Duns Scotus offers a solution to the important problem of knowledge of existence, a solution that

essentially agrees with that of St. Thomas Aquinas. The two doctrines hold that existence is an intuitive intellectual evidence grasped in the sensible. St. Thomas's solution immediately situates this vision of existence in judgment. Duns Scotus's solution, where existence and essence do not enter into the composition of being as distinct elements, simply attributes to the object the power of making itself known directly as existent. From this point of view and for this reason, the Scotist distinction between *cognitio intuitiva* and *cognitio abstractiva* has real importance. Its correct interpretation is that it reveals existing. It should not be an occasion to attribute to Duns Scotus a doctrine of intellectual intuition of essence that he always denies us *pro statu isto*.

It seems to us that in Duns Scotus we ought to interpret the intuitive knowledge of our psychological acts in the same manner. There again, intuition as such bears precisely upon their existence. Duns Scotus returns to this point several times when posing the problem, connected to the previous one, of discovering whether we have an intelligible intuition of our soul. Our soul is also a singular, even an immaterial singular, and therefore eminently knowable of itself. In principle, it ought to be able to know its own essence intuitively, as we have seen that the angel knows its existence. In fact, the situation is analogous to what has just been described regarding the knowledge of material singulars. In both cases, an intrinsically intelligible essence presently escapes intellectual intuition, but intellectual intuition sees the acts produced by this essence, and by them knows that the essence exists. What is true of the soul is also true of its powers: we go from the act to the power, and from the power to the *nature*, which is the soul, not inversely.[63]

Why is this knowledge indirect? Always for the same reason: "the soul is intelligible in act of itself and present to itself; and from this it follows that it could understand itself, if it were not impeded."[64] The nature of the *impedimentum* is known: "In our present condition our intellect is not capable of being immediately moved, unless it is first moved by something imaginable or an external sensible."[65] Let us observe the expression's generality: in our present state, only a sensible or an imaginable acting on the

intellect from the outside can move the intellect. No restriction is made regarding the acts of the soul itself. Whatever the cause, this difficulty is general.[66] The problem is to discover how it plays out.

No doubt is possible in regard to the soul's own *nature*. Duns Scotus grants us general and abstractive knowledge starting from the sensible: "For our soul and our nature are not known by us in our present condition, except under some general reason that is abstractable by the senses."[67] This general concept is the concept of being.[68] Speaking generally, we know that our soul is *a being*, and that its faculties are of the order of *being* that is proper to them. Moreover, that is what we meant by saying that we have a soul and faculties; our knowledge about them is certain, but that certainty does not go beyond the existence of these faculties and of this soul and about what they must be in order to be causes of such acts.

The problem is more complex when we pose it in regard to these acts themselves. How do we know them? The complexity of the answer stems from its bearing upon two distinct levels at the same time: the cognitive acts and the knowledge we have of them. Let us recall that even in knowledge of the sensible, the intellectual soul intuitively knows the nature in its quiddity, but as an existent to which the senses testify.[69] The novelty added here is that the intellectual soul also knows its act of knowing. In sensation, it not only sees the existence of the nature abstractly known, but also sees the sensation itself. Its knowledge of the sensation is intuitive, as everyone can be assured by observing himself, because we have the intuition of our sensations as of all other acts exercised by the intellectual soul, and we continually experience these intuitions.

Therefore, the nature of this experience occasions no difficulty. We are dealing with an intuition and therefore with a *vision*, that is to say, a kind of internal sense that perceives our acts as the external senses perceive their objects. By saying "in a certain sense, that is, we experience by inner perception,"[70] Duns Scotus stays within the tradition of St. Augustine, but above all he intends to articulate an indisputable fact, for, with someone who claimed to lack this *visio interior*, we would not even need to argue. Upon

what would this interior vision bear? Solely upon the soul's operations, that are themselves immaterial, although their objects all presuppose the phantasm and sensation.[71]

It is enough to follow his argumentation to be sure of it. What Duns Scotus intends to prove is not at all that intuitive knowledge is the only justification of the introspective method in psychology, but rather we have in us a certain knowledge of the object, whose nature is such that it cannot be explained by any sensitive knowledge. Here are the proofs. We learn by experience that we know the universal, that we know being and quality under a more common reason that that of the first sensible known by the highest sensitive faculty. We know that we know relations of reason and all the second intentions that logic deals with. We find that we know the acts by which we know these things and we can exercise a reflective act upon those acts. We know that we give our assent to the first principles without fear of error of being contradicted. Lastly, we know that we proceed from known to unknown without being able to escape the evidence of reasoning or of the conclusion. *Experimur*, repeats Duns Scotus each time to designate the kind of knowledge that we achieve of these acts and that we thus know by experience, by a kind of internal sense, by inner perception, or by a view from within. These are the acts of the intellect that it is impossible to attribute to any sensitive faculty. Ergo, there is really an incorporeal faculty of knowing within us. Our soul is immortal, which was what had to be demonstrated.[72]

Such a passage is obviously very interesting, but to see what concerns Duns Scotus in it is clearly not to minimize that interest. He is so far from intending to define a certain kind of intuition in the passage that he does not use the term even once, although, if he had been asked to give a name to those acts, he certainly would have called them *intuitions*. What is an act of *visio* other than intuition? However, what concerns Duns Scotus is not the internal experience he invokes; it is the immateriality of the act's content, which proves the immateriality of the intellectual soul itself. In relation to the problem of the knowledge of the soul, which is our problem, this analysis

establishes that the intellectual soul can infer its own immateriality by reflecting on the nature of a great number of operations that internal experience make it aware that it carries out. This intuition of its acts and operations furnishes the soul with a variety of experiences upon which its reflection must then be exercised to conclude the immortality of the soul from them. Accordingly, there is no reason to modify the general conclusions already reached. *Pro statu isto*, Duns Scotus does not attribute to us any intuition of our soul's essence; he attributes consciousness to us (which we could call an *intuition* of the internal sense and of the acts and operations of the soul), but like all operations of the intellectual soul, even those that deal with the metaphysician's intelligible or the logician's second intentions presuppose sensations and are accompanied by phantasms. Here as elsewhere, the situation testifies to the existence of the resent object that causes it.[73] The understanding alone is competent to define the natures of the existents that intuitive intellection apprehends and we do not even have an intuition of the immateriality of our acts. We have only the intuition of acts. Intellectual analysis of them allows us to conclude that, since their nature transcends the power of sense knowledge, their cause must be immaterial. Here below there is not intuitive knowledge of the singular, whether intelligible or sensible, except knowledge of its existence. As for knowledge of its nature, our intellectual soul is intrinsically capable of it, but the time has not yet come for the soul to exercise it. That said, we should not conclude that we have no knowledge of singulars. Although intuition is the most perfect mode of knowledge, it is not the only one, and even reduced to abstractive knowledge of natures, our intellect is not so cut off from its first source that it cannot draw treasures of intelligibility from the sensible.

D Knowledge and divine illumination

The general problem of the value of our intellectual knowledge is posed in Duns Scotus under a form that can be called classical in the Franciscan school by that date: "Can a certain truth without mixture of error (*sincera*) be

known by the human intellect in this life naturally and without illumination by the uncreated light?"[74] Two points must be noted. Duns Scotus generalizes a question that in the passage of St. Augustine, from which it derives, only bears directly upon the value of sense knowledge.[75] Moreover, by specifying that this issue in his mind is special *illumination*, Scotus poses the problem in its most precise form, that is to say, by setting aside from the outset the question of the universally accepted necessity of a general illumination of our intellect in order that knowledge of truth should be possible for it.[76] What interests Duns Scotus is not the problem of illumination taken in itself but rather its impact upon natural knowledge, whose certainty and validity Scotus intends to safeguard. From that comes his choice of the well-known passage of St. Paul, Rom. 1:20, to validate his response: "For, since the creation of the world, his invisible attributes are clearly seen . . . being understood through the things that are made," *Invisibilia Dei a creatura mundi per ea quae facta sunt intellecta conspiciuntur*. Contrary to normal usage, Duns Scotus does not argue to establish that God's existence and attributes can be demonstrated starting from the sensible. He would accept that proposition, clarifying it, but he argues rather to guarantee his own conclusion in advance. Are not the *eternal reasons* of which St. Augustine spoke those *invisibilia Dei*? If we know the eternal reasons from creatures according to St. Paul, then we can know the creature without the eternal reasons. Accordingly, it is possible to have sure knowledge of sensible things before knowing the divine ideas, certain proof that no special action is required on the part of the divine ideas for us to know them.[77]

Here, as often, the adversary contemplated by Duns Scotus is Henry of Ghent,[78] whose three principal arguments are drawn from the nature of the known object, the nature of the knowing subject, and the nature of the species that represents the object to the subject.

Consequently, since the objects from which the species are abstracted are changing and variable, how will the species that represent them not be like them? By reason of this mutability, Augustine denies that we can attain the

pure truth by the senses and, with this motive he urges us to turn away from the world of bodies in order to turn ourselves toward God.

The human soul itself is changeable and subject to error. Again, Augustine says so. Something whose uncertainty and changeability equals the soul's and that, like the soul is exposed to deviating from the truth, cannot bring order to the soul. The source of guaranteed knowledge can only be above the soul and its subject. That source is God in the supreme law that is Truth. Our thought judges everything by Truth, which our thought cannot judge.[79]

The species itself remains. We have already said that the species shares in the variability of objects. But there is something more. We have images in dreams as well as when we are awake. Someone who loses his reason has the same images as the sleeper and as the person who is awake, so that the latter judges things by the same phantasm as the person who dreams or has lost his reason. Therefore, it is impossible to tell true from false with the help of images alone. To achieve the truth, humans must turn their thoughts away from species of this kind and, as Augustine says, turn it toward the truth.[80] The truth is not found in the intellect's conformity to the created model but in its conformity to the uncreated model.

Henry of Ghent, like the Franciscan masters on whose side he places himself, confronts an objection whose urgency those masters are the first to acknowledge: how can thought turn toward the uncreated model that is the Idea, without thereby seeing God? The idea of God is God. Therefore, how can this model be the *reason of knowing* without God being known along with it? Henry answers that we see in light of God without seeing God, as we sometimes see in the sunlight without seeing the sun. God produces three effects by his light. The light sharpens our sight, modifies the species, and impresses the seal on our soul that makes it conform to the divine model. According to Henry of Ghent, there is certainly a special illumination there, and it does not misrepresent his doctrine to say so. He admits that these eternal essences are not naturally visible to us in themselves and that two species cooperate in thought as exemplar models in every instance of perfect knowledge of truth. One is internal and caused in thought by the object. The

other descends into thought and illuminates without being caused by the object. From the union of these two species, a single cognitive reason is formed by which thought conceives the object in the perfection of its truth.[81]

Obviously, this is an appealing doctrine, but Duns Scotus holds that it ultimately leads to skepticism, and he judges that it does not even agree with Augustine's deep intention. Indeed, such reasons seem to conclude that no certain natural knowledge is possible, which shares the opinion of the *Academics*, to employ a terminology that our theologian owes to St. Augustine. This characteristic is worth noting since it was enough for Duns Scotus to have read the *Contra Academicos* to be convinced that one cannot be both a faithful disciple of Augustine and a defender of skepticism. Accordingly, Scotus felt comfortable in separating his master from any involvement with a doctrine that his master had abundantly and eloquently refuted.

Whatever the case may be with Augustine, Duns Scotus judges that the position adopted by Henry of Ghent amounts to destroying all certainty. It is said that an immutable light is necessary for us to be able to draw certain truth from a changing object. But, if the object of knowledge in itself is such that it escapes all certain knowledge, our intellect can have no science of it with or without illumination. Furthermore, if divine illumination made us recognize as certain objects that are uncertain in themselves, it would lead us into error by representing them as other than they are. Consequently, Duns Scotus definitely intends to assure the possibility of a science of the sensible or rather a science of a sensible whose nature is such that it may be the object of science. Here Aristotle wins in Duns Scotus as in Thomas Aquinas.

On the other hand, it is claimed that the *exemplar* that is in the soul is as changeable as the object that causes it, so that science is no more possible from the angle of the phantasm than from the angle of the object. That may be, but what would divine intellection do there? All that is in the soul subjectively is mutable like the soul. Since the soul is created, its act of being is itself variable and will remain so. If the cause of its error is in its variability, we can say that unless it changes its nature, no divine illumination

will keep it from error.

Finally, it will be said that the species or sensible images are the same in wakefulness and dreams, in sanity and madness, without anything in them allowing us to discern the state in which we are. Whether we admit it or not, divine illumination changes nothing. If the sensible species is not intrinsically true or false, it does not bear within itself any character that allows its validity to be recognized, no special cooperation of the divine light will ever permit us to discern within it the true from the false or even the plausible. In short, the species will never become what it is not, and if the only reason that we have to admit a special illumination is the desire to avoid skepticism, it would be better to give it up.

Moreover, Duns Scotus has texts to prove that Augustine cannot be invoked in support of this thesis. Such texts exist, because Augustine always teaches that scientific truth is accessible to humans, that our senses tell us the truth regarding heaven and earth, that we have the certainty of our own acts, so that he who wills knows that he wills, knows that he knows it, and so on to infinity.[82] All this is true, but it is less certain whether Henry of Ghent may not represent the authentic Augustinian spirit here. What Duns Scotus wants to prove against Henry is that the nature of the sense object is not such that it introduces a cause of permanent and almost inevitable error, something to which St. Augustine consented in advance precisely under the proviso that there is collaboration of the divine light in our intellect's judgments about sense objects. Consequently, the two arguments move in opposite directions. "No genuine truth is to be expected from sensibles." *Nulla est veritas sincera expectanda a sensibilibus,* says Augustine. Yet, despite that, there is science. Therefore science comes to us not from the sensible but from eternal light. Augustine acknowledges that there is science, Duns Scotus says. There would not be science if the nature of the sensible were not such that it could be the object of science. Therefore, Augustine cannot have maintained the doctrine of special illumination under the pretext "that from sensibles no genuine truth is to be expected," *quod a sensibilibus non sit expectanda sincera veritas*. If they had heard Duns Scotus appeal to Augustine on this

point, Bonaventure, Matthew of Aquasparta, Roger Marston, John Peckham, and several others would have felt very legitimately surprised.

That does not mean that Duns Scotus has passed with all his equipment over to Aristotle's band, or that nothing in his noetic recalls Augustine's remembering. Against the error of the Academics, Scotus begins by evoking our certainty about first principles. The terms of first principles, known by themselves, are identical so that to know one is to know the other. That is why, when we apprehend these terms, our intellect finds in their composition in fact a necessary reason to unite them in its act. Since the composition of these terms is inscribed in their content, it is impossible for us to conceive them without that same composition being necessarily formed in our intellect. This conformity of knowledge to the object is what confers its evidence on the apprehension of the first principles. Moreover, this is why the contrary of these principles is literally inconceivable: "it cannot enter anyone's mind," *non potest venire in intellectu alicujus*. To think that being is not or that the whole is not larger than the part is to fail to think of being and nonbeing or of whole and part. To tell the truth, it is to fail to think, and as the perfect syllogism deduces consequences with certainty starting from first principles, we can affirm against the Academics that science is possible by virtue of the certainty of the principles and evidence of the reasoning.[83]

But if the senses, by which alone we know terms, are all mistaken in apprehending the terms, will not our intellect in its turn be mistaken in the knowledge of principles and of the conclusions that the senses draw from the principles?—Not necessarily, because the sense is not the cause of this kind of knowledge; it is only the occasion. When the intellect conceives two terms thanks to sensation, it can compose them of itself, and if it sees that the combination of these terms forms an evidently true proposition, it will give its assent to it by virtue of its own light, not only the testimony of the senses. I say, "Socrates is white," because, when I see Socrates, I observe that these two terms are united in reality. But this is not a principle. In order to say, "The whole is greater than the part," I do not need to see a part included in a whole. It is enough for me to have formed the notions of whole or part from

any sensations to know that one implies the other. The whole can only be what includes parts, the part can only be what is included in a whole. If all the senses from which we take these terms deceived us, or even worse, if some deceived us and others did not, our intellect would not be mistaken regarding these principles, because it would dispose of necessary terms to form them. Someone born blind who miraculously received the sensible species of white and black while dreaming and still had them awake could form this proposition by abstraction of the intellect: “white is not black.” However the terms of this negative were received, it would be known to be true, because the formal reason, as the intellect apprehends it, is the cause of truth.[84]

Assured of the validity of the first principles and of their rationally deduced consequences, let us turn toward the second source of our knowledge, which is the experience of singulars. To draw sure conclusions from our experience, the latter does not have to attain all singulars nor do so always. It is enough for us to know from experience that some beings behave most of the time in a certain way to know infallibly that this is always so in all the beings of the species. This certainty rests upon a proposition that is latent in our soul: every thing that happens most of the time *through a cause that is not free is the natural effect of this cause*. The proposition is evident to the intellect, and it would be the same if the intellect had received the terms erroneously, because it would be contradictory for a cause that is not free to produce most of the time effects contrary to those to which its nature binds it. To maintain the opposite is to destroy the very notion of *natural cause* and to reduce it to the concept of *accidental cause*, which precisely because it does not exercise the determined causality of a *nature*, can produce by chance an effect or its opposite, and even produce one of them and not produce any.

But how can we know that a given particular effect proceeds most of the time from a given cause? Experience teaches it. Let us suppose that we found a certain nature sometimes with a certain accident, other times with another, and that despite this diversity in the accidents, the same effect always resulted from the same nature. We would be able to conclude with certainty that the

cause of this effect is the nature itself and not any one of these accidents.[85]

In this kind of knowledge, furthermore, experience can be concerned with either a conclusion or a principle. For example, it is a fact of experience that the moon is frequently eclipsed. Let us take as our conclusion that there are eclipses of the moon and ask what their cause is. To find the cause of this conclusion, the method to follow is analysis (*via divisionis*). In some cases, starting from this conclusion of experience, we end up at principles that are immediately evident by virtue of their terms, from which we will go back toward the conclusion in order to justify it starting from these principles. Thus, the conclusion that was first known only empirically will hereafter be known with higher certainty, as deduced from a principle known by itself. To take a more specific example, it is an evident principle that an opaque body interposed between a luminous body and a transparent body will prevent the light from reaching this transparent body. If we have discovered by analysis that the earth is an opaque body interposed between the sun and the moon, we will know with complete certainty, from this cause, the reason of the previously empirically known fact that there are eclipses

But it can also happen that experience delivers a principle. In that case, instead of working back toward an evident principle, we will appeal to a kind of general evidence. In such cases, experience assures us that two terms are frequently united in reality, for example, “A given species of herb is hot.” As we see no way of going back beyond the fact by way of analysis and consequently no way of finding a middle term to tie the fact to a principle from which we can then deduce it, it is really necessary to appeal to the fact itself as to a first principle based on experience. How, then, can we justify its certainty and guarantee it against any risk of error? We must invoke this other proposition: the effect regularly produced by a non-free cause is this cause’s natural effect. Guaranteed by this rule, our empirical principle becomes a truth of science, but we are then at the lowest degree of scientific knowledge. Perhaps we do not even have the necessary knowledge of the actual union of these terms, because we do not know why an herb of the species in question is necessarily hot. We only know that it is capable of being hot. Indeed, a

property of this kind is an absolute, something other than its subject and separable from it. There are species of herbs that we classify among the cold herbs, and there are causes of heat that are not herbs. In such a case, we can separate the property from its subject without contradiction, and someone who only knows the fact of their union by experience only knows that it is thus by virtue of their nature, not from what cause it must be so in the precise case of these terms.[86]

Having assured the validity of sense knowledge, Duns Scotus goes on to what will subsequently be called internal experience, whose certainty seems at least as firm to him. We have already met it in the context of the singular immaterial, buttressed by the authority of St. Augustine. So as not to distort the perspective, it is interesting to note that this time Duns Scotus is supported by Aristotle's authority. Speaking against Protagoras in *Metaphysics*, book IV, chapter 6, the Philosopher reproaches his adversary for seeking demonstrations of everything, even principles, whose nature, however, excludes them from being objects of demonstration. Discussing this remark and applying it to the knowledge we possess of our acts, Duns Scotus observes that many of them are principles known intrinsically. He uses the word *principle* in the Aristotelian sense in which sensation is a principle, since it is the *first point of departure* for the acquisition of other knowledge. If that is so, the fact that *I am awake* is a principle, because it is immediately evident and can become the origin of a demonstration.

It is true that it is a contingent fact, but not all contingents are of the same order. Some of them are first in the sense that starting from them we can establish others, and in some way they play the role of first principles in the order of contingents.[87] Moreover, it is necessary that certain contingents should be first. Otherwise, we would go on to infinity in the order of contingents, or a contingent would follow a necessary case, both equally impossible suppositions.[88]

These internal intuitions are innumerable. I know that I know, that I understand, and so on. Each time I know by an act that is complete in itself, because it is its own term for itself. It is not certain that I see a white body

situated outside me at a given distance, because cases of illusion can enter into play in the medium, in the organ, and in many other ways, but it is absolutely certain that I see. Even in the case where the illusion is most complete, that is, when the act that is produced in the absence of the object is as it would be when caused by the object, there is still really vision. If, instead of the illusion being produced in the optic nerves, it were produced in the eye itself, provided that the impression caused by the species was just like one caused by the object, there would still be vision.[89] The act's certainty is absolute in case of this kind, even if the certainty does not guarantee the existence of their objects.

This conclusion itself poses another problem: what certainty do we have that a white body or a hot body really exists outside of us just as it appears to us? That depends on the case. If this object can be known by different sense, and the judgments of these different senses agree, we can be sure of the veracity of their testimony. Not only is the testimony of the senses sufficient in cases like these, but also we can confirm it by the proposition we have already invoked: "That which a cause produces regularly is the natural effect, if the cause is not free." The only reasonable way of explaining that the sense is regularly modified by a species that is always the same in presence of the same object is to admit that outside of the sense exists a body whose nature is to produce such a species.[90] The same does not hold when the testimony of our different senses are not in agreement, as when touch judges a stick that is partially submerged in water to be straight, although sight judges it to be bent. In a general fashion, all faraway objects including the sun appear smaller than they are. But here precisely we have a general proposition known by the intellect that permits this last error to be rectified, a proposition that says that the sense is not the *cause* but only the *occasion*. If my intellect knows that it is true, my sight will not deceive me about the dimensions of the sun. In the case of the stick that seems bent in the water, the intellect likewise does not leave us defenseless. It knows that *a hard body is never broken by contact with a soft body*. Is not this proposition more certain than the testimony of any sense? The opposite proposition is in fact contradictory.

It is absurd to think that the stick is harder than water and that, however, mere contact with water can break it. Our senses make us see the opposite, and on this point at least their testimony is in agreement, because the eye and the hand alike testify that wood is harder than water. Consequently, if one of the two senses is mistaken in any particular case, the intellect has the means to judge it with a more certain judgment than the act of any sense.[91]

In conclusion, empirical knowledge possesses a proper certainty that can be transformed into actual certainty thanks to a general principle posited by the intellect. We then obtain the following hierarchy of the different orders of knowledge by going from less to more perfect: immediate sensible certainty, in the case of agreement of testimonies of the senses; certainty of experimental science, when the intellect guarantees the testimony of the sense by the general principle of the constancy of natural causal actions; perfect scientific certainty *a priori* by the cause, when the intellect is able to discover a middle term that lets us say why the effect produced must necessarily be produced as it is produced. Accordingly, Duns Scotus places great confidence in the sensible. This is not surprising, because without denying the essential mutability of its objects, he maintains the stability of their *natures*. In a word, Avicenna comes to balance St. Augustine, because what acts upon the senses is not the Augustinian mutability, *mutabilitas*, of the sensible object, but its Avicennist nature,[92] offering the intellect an *occasion* made for it to exercise its judgment upon this datum of sensibility.

Having thus proved that certain knowledge is possible from purely natural things, *ex puris naturalibus*, Duns Scotus is still faced with a final problem: how does the eternal light intervene in the operations of the intellect that knows truth? Everyone agrees that the uncreated light is necessarily required as a remote cause, which, with intellect and object, produces true knowledge is something in which. On the other hand, on account of Augustine's words, *propter verba Augustini*, it is certainly necessary to grant that the eternal truths are seen, known, and apprehended by the intellect, *in regulis aeternis*, in the divine ideas. Lastly, Duns Scotus is so far from intending to avoid the problem that he begins by denying that we can see the truth in the divine idea

without seeing the divine idea itself: “what is set out in the opinion is false, namely that the eternal exemplar is an unknown reason of knowing.”[93] The point is to know how the uncreated light can be the remote cause of our true knowledge and how we can see the truth in the eternal rules, while seeing them, but without seeing God.

Duns Scotus finds valuable assistance in his own interpretation of the nature of divine ideas. In expounding it, we have already announced what a decisive role this interpretation would play at the moment of resolving the problem of illumination, but it is helpful now to add that the role itself sheds the clearest light on the exact meaning of the formal distinction that Duns Scotus introduces between God and his ideas. This distinction must certainly be more than verbal or more even than a distinction of reason for it to be able to furnish the solution to our problem.

All intelligibles owe their intelligible being to the act of the divine intellect and all truths shine forth there of themselves because, by knowing them, God knows all their possible relations. As we said in its place, divine knowledge is thereby expended to all necessary truths, which it sees in the ideas as in the objects of its intellect. Why do we speak of *truths* here? We do so because the ideas are the second objects of the intellect, and they in fact are *truths* insofar as they conform to the model, which is the divine intellect itself. These ideas are light, because they reveal their proper quiddities. Furthermore, they are necessary, like the divine essence and divine intellection that produce them. Lastly, and for the same reason, they are eternal. However, they are only eternal relatively, because eternity is a condition of being, and that which has only relative existence can only have a relative being’s eternity: “but those things are eternal in a limited sense, since eternity is a condition of an something existing and those things do not have existence except in a limited sense.”[94] In a first sense, we can respond that we see in the eternal light, that is, in the *second object of the divine intellect*, which is truth and the *eternal light* in the sense that has just been defined.

Again, Augustine says that we see the eternal rules “written in the book of this light that is called truth.”[95] He is completely right again, because these

truths are inscribed in the divine intellect insofar as it contains them. The book itself is not seen, but we see the quiddities or truths that are written there, and we can say that our own intellect sees the truths in the eternal light, in this book as containing its object. We can even say that our intellect sees them in these truths themselves, which are the second or relative eternal light, as its objects. Indeed, the divine ideas are really eternal light in a limited sense, *lux aeterna secundum quid*, and to see in them is to see them. Moreover, it seems that Augustine has both explanations in mind, because he says, "The concept of a square body remains incorruptible and immutable."[96] We have this concept, and yet it can only remain incorruptible and immutable as the second object of the divine intellect.

To that it will be objected that if we do not see the ideas in the divine intellect because we do not see the divine understanding itself, how can we see them in *uncreated light*? After all, we see them only in this *lux aeterna secundum quid* that only exists in the uncreated light of the divine intellect that knows it. In other words, we must not deny that we have a vision of the divine intellect, yet grant ourselves a vision of the uncreated life, because the two names designate the same thing.

The third way of defining divine illumination responds to this objection. First, let us return to the fundamental thesis that the divine ideas have no being (*esse*) other than as a second object of the divine intellect, the completely relative being that consists in *being known*. A relative (*secundum quid*) being cannot exercise any action that comes from itself. If it exercises one, it will not be in virtue of its being but in virtue of the being from which it has its being. Accordingly, it only pertains to these second objects of the divine understanding to move an intellect by virtue of the absolute being of the divine understanding from which they have their relative being. Consequently, we see in the relative eternal light as in our proximate object, but we see in the uncreated light as in the proximate cause by virtue of which the proximate object moves our intellect. Moreover, we see the same thing differently by remaining in this third sense. We see in the uncreated light as "in the proximate cause of the object in itself." For, the divine understanding

gives this object its intelligible being by its act. The divine understanding makes it be *this* intelligible object. In short, it gives it its very nature as object, which permits it to move our intellect to a given determined sure knowledge. This third manner of speaking amounts to saying that we see a cause when we see its effect, because we see its cause in the effect. It is as when we say: "we know in the light of the agent intellect." That does not mean that we know this light itself, or that the light is an object of knowledge for us, but rather that it is the active cause that makes the object intelligible in act or by virtue of which the object moves our intellect or both at once. It is precisely the case that the divine intellect exercises this dual causality in regard to us. An authentic *uncreated light*, it first produces second objects to intelligible being by producing the ideas and all the necessary truths that stem from them. Therefore, it is certainly the divine intellect that produces the intelligible objects, but in addition once produced, these second objects move our intellect, and these two combined causalities constitute the third reason on account of which we can say that we really see in the *eternal light* of the divine understanding.[97]

Duns Scotus is now in a terrain he has completely explored. His thinking is complete and capable of receiving exhaustive justification. When it is objected that, if God causes our intellectual knowledge (i.e., God is the cause of an object that is a production *ad ex*tra for him), it must be God's will that causes our knowledge, then all the core theses of Scotist theology enter into play to refute this inference. In some way it is prior to God's will (prior with a priority of nature) that the divine intellect produces these objects into intelligible being. Accordingly, the divine intellect is a purely natural cause in what concerns them, because God is only a free cause in regard to what supposes some act of his will. This is why the cooperation of the eternal truths in our knowledge produces a natural effect. In other words, since the divine causality that produces them is the causality of a nature, they in turn act upon our intellect in the manner of a natural cause in order to produce a natural effect. Apprehended and composed, the eternal truths cause the intellect that apprehends and composes them to conform itself to its models.

It depends on God's will that our intellect composes or does not compose the terms of a proposition. But, if our intellect composes those terms, the divine will has nothing to do with their composition, which is just as the terms of the proposition require. The composition of these terms only depends on the terms. It results necessarily from their intelligible being just as God has naturally produced it by his intellect.

There can be no question of any special influence of God. We do not see that Augustine himself held it to be necessary, because when he talks about *seeing in the eternal rules*, these examples always involve truths that are necessarily evident by virtue of their terms. Moreover, in cases of this kind, the action of both remote and proximate causes is maximally necessary for the effect to be produced. God's intellect must move ours to these objects, and in their term these objects, proximate causes of intellection, must move our intellect to unite them. Obviously, it is not necessary that we should perceive these terms, but if we perceive them, it is necessary that we compose them as their nature demands.

Perhaps we could discuss the question of finding out whether the general influence of God cooperating in apprehension and composition of the terms is necessary by *natural necessity*. Duns Scotus does not seem to think so, but whether it is simply general or general and necessary, we are not dealing with a *special* illumination.[98]

That means the divine light shines equally upon every human coming into this world. It is true that certain passages in Augustine would make us think that few humans attain these intelligible reasons and that pure souls alone are capable of being elevated to that height.[99] These passages are difficult to assimilate for anyone less ingenious than Duns Scotus. He is truly at a Platonic impasse, but his Arisotelianism finds a means to escape it. It is an extraordinary means, because since Augustine affirms that the rational soul alone can see ideas, and again "not every and any soul, but that which is holy and pure," *non omnis et quaelibet sed quae sancta et pura fuerit*, Duns Scotus calmly declares that the point is not about a soul free from vices but about an intellect experienced enough in metaphysical reflection to be capable of

apprehending essences in themselves and separated from all their accidents. Few minds are capable of that. Say that the whole is greater than the part. Most people will think of the whole as a pile of stones or a piece of wood. But it is accidental to the proposition that the whole should be made of stone or wood or something else, and to grasp general truths under any of its accidental forms is only to apprehend a truth by accident. To apprehend a pure truth, this *sincera veritas* of which Augustine speaks, we must first conceive pure terms. For, pure truths are such precisely by reason of pure terms, that is to say, insofar as the terms are abstracted from everything that is united to them by accident. “Few people attain the eternal reasons, because few have intellections intrinsically, but many have these concepts accidentally.” Still we should not believe that this small number is distinguished from others because they receive special illumination. They are simply better endowed. Their intellect is more capable of abstraction or more perspicacious. Or, these people search more than others, because of two equally gifted minds, the one who seeks more will end by grasping those quiddities that another will never know.[100]

There is still a fourth way of understanding the vision of necessary truths in the eternal rules. It marks the far limit that, given Duns Scotus’s principles, he could grant to meet Augustine. In this last sense, “the pure truths are known in the eternal light as in a remote, known object.” This remote object is the *uncreated light*, first principle of all objects of knowledge and last end of all operations or actions. Consequently, speculative as well as practical principles flow from it. Also, the knowledge of everything that there may be in the order of speculation or of action is more perfect and purer when it owes its principles to the knowledge of the eternal light (*a luce aeterna cognita*) than when the knowledge flows from principles of the same kind as its objects. Then, it is superior to all other knowledge, and this is precisely the way theologians know everything. The mathematician knows that the triangle has three angles because he knows that such is its nature, but the theologian knows that the triangle has three angles, because it is a certain participation in God, and because its reason for being in the general order of the universe is

to express divine perfection in some way. Accordingly, the theologian knows the triangle in a more noble way than the mathematician. What is true of speculative knowledge is also true of practical knowledge, because the moralist knows that we must live temperately on account of the moral rule that we must always do what is honorable. But the theologian knows that we must practice this virtue to win supreme beatitude, that is to say, to attain God's essence itself. That is what Augustine wants to make us understand when he speaks "about created light as known," *de luce creata ut cognita*, and when, inviting us to raise our eyes toward it, he explains to us why we cannot see it face to face. "Therefore, what is the cause on account of which you cannot see with a fixed gaze except sickness?"[101]

The text has been identified. Duns Scotus regularly invokes, discusses, and interprets it, when the problem is to say why the human intellect in its present state must be satisfied with abstractive knowledge of the intelligible, of which it has temporarily lost its intuition. This is an extraordinary panorama, and it would be difficult to find a more favorable observation point to measure the distance that separates Patristics from Scholasticism. In Augustine, in the same passages that Duns Scotus cites, the issue is merely the soul burdened by a body that itself is burdened by sin, but that strives with the grace of God and heroic asceticism to recapture for rare instants the pure intuition of the intelligible light. Augustine does not doubt that Plotinus himself reached it sometimes. Here, theological science replaces the intuition of the true in the eternal truths. Theological science takes its principle from the *eternal light*, and connecting all beings to the first cause whose symbol they are, permits our intellect to attain the *uncreated l*ight as a distant object. The abstraction of quiddities, purified of their accidents by an intellect experienced in metaphysical asceticism, is inserted in phrases of *De Trinitate*. The fine point of thought attempts to pierce a thick crust of images whose hardness hides it and has slowly accumulated over thought, while it employs its own substance with mad prodigality to form them. Sickness, weakness, *infirmitas*, *iniquitas*, says Augustine, but he speaks of his own history. Repeated by Duns Scotus, the same words sum up the present state of humanity in general and recall

one of its principal causes. They say why, *pro statu isto*, the metaphysician finds it so difficult to at least attain abstractly pure essences in the absence of intelligible intuitions that are now denied it. But the theologian climbs the mountain and in the purer light of the summit, he has a premonition of the secret presence of the Cause of the essences beyond them. Why would he still think about philosophers in this high place? If we could know how St. Augustine's spirituality, without losing any of the faith that inspired it or the charity that animated it, has been reincarnated in the impassioned theology of intellection, we would be very close to comprehending Blessed Duns Scotus. Perhaps we would also end by giving definite meaning to the word *Scholastic*. But we would hardly interest historians and not at all philosophers by telling them that, at bottom, all the great intellectual constructions that the Middle Ages left us were inventions of love.

Notes

1 On the overall problem, see the texts assembled by Parthenius Minges, O. F. M., in *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. I, pp. 146–81.—Karl Werner, *Die Pschologie und Erkenntnislehre des Johann Duns Scotus* (Vienna: Karl Gerold's Sohn and K. Akademie der Wisssenschaften, 1877). (Werner accepts *De Rerum Principio* as authentic.)—Paulo Tochowicz, *Johannis Duns Scoti de Cognitionis Doctrina* (Freiburg, Switzerland: Studia Freiburgensis, 1926). (Tochowicz also accepts *De Rerum* Principio.)—Olivier Lacombe, "La critique des théories de la connaissance chez Duns Scot," *Revue thomiste* 35 (1930), pp. 24–27, 144–57, 217–35. See also the reply by Seraphin Belmond, "Le mécanisme de la connaisance d'après Duns Scot," *La France Franciscaine* XIII (1930), pp. 285–323.

2 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 1, vol. I, p. 398 [CE III, p. 201].—On intellectual knowledge, see the well-documented book by Reinhold Messner, O. F. M., *Schauendes und begriffliches Erkennen nach Duns Skotus, mit kritischer Gegenüberstellung zur Erkenntnislehrer von Kant und Aristoteles* (Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1942).

3 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, number 8 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 214–15, numbers 108–09]. *Memoria* can have three meanings: first, the faculty that preserves past species *qua* past; second, the faculty that preserves the species of objects in themselves, whether they exist or not; third, the same faculty as the principle of an act of actual knowledge, that is, of a second act as Avicenna understands it. Here we are dealing with memory understood in the second sense. The third sense will be examined next.

4 Godfrey of Fontaines answers that we cannot explain intellection without admitting the existence of the intelligible species, *Quodlibet* IX, question 19, pp. 273–74, *Le huitième, neuvième et dixième Quodlibet de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Jean Hoffmans: "Immo est dicendum quod nihil fit in intellectu possibili nisi ipsa intellectio . . ." The *ipsum intelligere* is what can be called *species sine forma*, p. 275. Cf. *Quodlibet* X, article 12.

5 Present to be known and real to be knowable. Naturally, we are dealing with reality of being understood in the Scotus sense. Since every formality is a really distinct entity (by the distinction that is found between formal realties, *realiter*, *formaliter*) one and the same real object can cause several distinct concepts, each one of which expresses a distinctive real object. Accordingly, the concept of the genus has the genus as its object, that of the species the species, and so on. If these distinct concepts did not correspond to distinct objects they would be fictions, and our metaphysics would amount to logic. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 19, numbers 6 and 5 [EW II, p. 317, number 32, and p. 316, number 29]: "Esssentia una specie, quantumque simplex, ut albedo, nata est ex se diversa objecta facere praesentia intellectui possibili." Indeed: "Omnis differentia prior naturaliter omni actu rationis, videtur differentia realis; objecta naturaliter praecedunt actus, et distinctio objectorum distinctionem actuum, maxime quando haec illam causat, ut hic sumitur; ergo differentia intentionis, quae est in conceptibus, concludit priorem in objectis, quae erit realis."

6 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, numbers 1 and 4 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 210, number 96, p. 213 number 203, and possibly p. 218 number 118]: "Objectum secundum per se conditionem objecti praecedit actum, universale vero est per se conditio objecti intellectus." "Universale est conditio objecti precedens actum intelligendi." "Requiritur quod objectum secundum propriam rationem objecti praecedat actum." The latter duplicates *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 5, vol. I, p. 402 c [CE III, pp. 209–12].—On the universal in the logical sense, see Joaquin Carreras y Artau, *La doctrina de los universales en Juan Duns Scot*, Vich: Seráfica, 1931, and Stefan Swiézawaski, "Les intentions premières et les intentions secondes chez Jean Duns Scot" *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* , directed by Étienne Gilson and G. Théry, O.P. (Paris: Vrin, 1934), pp. 205–60. The universal in the real sense is the common nature taken absolutely, determinable to universality by this intellect. See *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 6 [EW II, pp. 298–99, numbers 39–43].

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 2, vol. I, p. 399, and number 5, p. 402a [CE III, pp. 204–05 and 209–12].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 10, vol. I, p. 407 [CE III, p. 364 gives this as part of an interpolated passage]: "Objectum non est praesens intellectui possibili in cognitione abstractiva ante actum elicitum, nisi per aliquod repraesentativum, quod voco speciem, et sic habeo propositum."

8 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, number 4 [possibly *Reportatio 1-A* I, pp. 212–13, number 103].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 8, vol. I, p. 404 [CE III, pp. 216–17]: "Omnis autem actio realis habet aliquem terminum realem; ille autem terminus realis non est in phantasmate, quia intellectus agens nihil causat in phantasmatibus, quia illud receptum esset extensum, et ita intellectus non transferret objectum ab ordine in ordinem, nec illud esset magis proportionatum intellectui possibili quam phantasma; ergo est in intellectu possibili, quia nihil recipitur in intellectu agente; illud autem primum causatum non potest poni actus intelligendi, quia primus terminus actionis intellectus agentis est universale in actu; universale autem in actu praecedit actum intelligendi, sicut praedictum est in antecedente, quia objectum sub ratione objecti praecedit actum." [CE differs in wording].

9 Averroes, *De Anima*, book III, comm. 18, Venice, 1574, folio 161, where the commentator insists on the transference from one order to another required by the act of intellection.

10 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 8, vol. I, p. 405 [CE III, p. 216–20].—See also *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, number 4 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 213, number 105]. In number 6, [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 214, number 107]. Scotus observes that if the agent intellect itself did not possess a proper object, like the intelligible species, it would not have proper being: "Unde non diceret [Aristoteles] intellectum posse separari, nisi concederet cum

habere operationem sibi propriam, in qua non dependeret essentialiter a parte sensitiva.”—These arguments are general in scope. It seems that they ought to suffice to deflect the claim that Scotus does not admit an intelligible species in the intuition of a present object. Whatever we may say about that, Ockham is the antithesis of Duns Scotus on this point.

11 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 22, vol. I, p. 417 [CE III, pp. 224–45, gives number 22, where the sentences quoted above occur, as canceled by Scotus]. Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book, VII, question 18, number 7 [EW II, pp. 299–301, numbers 44–45].

12 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 10, vol. I, p. 406 [CE III, p. 364, gives this as part of an interpolated passage].

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 11, vol. I, p. 409 [CE III, p. 224]: “in operatione sua dependet ab illa potentia cui contingenter conjungitur.” —The union is contingent *in ratione potentiae* because, precisely *qua* power of intellectual operation, the intellect of itself does not imply union with the sensitive power.

14 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 8, vol. I, p. 404 [CE III, p. 217, has *nec aliquid* instead of *nihil*]: “Intellectus agens nihil causat in phantasmatibus.”

15 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 14, vol. I, p. 409 [CE III, p. 228].

16 This is true *pro statu isto*, let us recall. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 19, vol. I, p. 414 [CE III, p. 239]. Therefore, it is clear that our present condition does not prejudge at all either the structure or the powers of our intellect precisely *qua* intellect. This is why the famous *conversio ad phantasmata* maintained by Duns Scotus is no longer required by our intellect as such, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 19, vol. I, p. 414 [CE III, p. 239]: “Talis est connexio istarum potentiarum, scilicet phantasiae et intellectus, pro statu isto, quod nihil intelligimus in universali nisi cujus singulare phantasiamur; nec est alia conversio ad phantasmata, nisi quod intelligens universale imaginatur singulare ejus; nec intelligens quod quid est relucens in specie intelligibili videt illud in suo singulari viso per virtutem phantasticam in phantasmate.”—Consequently, the *colligantia virtutum* is reduced to this, that these two faculties of the soul, always simultaneously exercise essentially distinct acts. —For the repercussions of this doctrine on the knowledge exercised by the separated soul, see *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 45, question 2, numbers 16 ff, where Duns Scotus talks about a certain doctor “qui ponit vilificationem animae et intellectus.” The *vilificatio* is completely philosophical, of course.

17 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 15, vol. I, pp. 410–11 [CE III, pp. 231–32].

18 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 21, vol. I, p. 416 [CE III, pp. 242–44].

19 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 16, vol. I, p. 411 [CE III, p. 233 for all three Latin phrases, *in primo*, *in secundo* . . .].—This is what explains that a whole *science* could be one by the unity of its first object as metaphysics is by the unity of being *qua* being. If there were only imaginable phantasms, no science would be included in the intelligible unity of a single object, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 21, vol. I, p. 415–16 [CE III, p. 242].

20 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 25, vol. I, p. 420 [I do not find the Latin phrase at CE III, pp. 300–02. It sounds as though it should come from the end of question 4].—Cf. *Reportata Parisienisia*, book I, distinction 3, question 5, number 5 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 225, number 138]: “Et istum duplicem modum intelligendi ponunt etiam ipsi, qui multum

nituntur improbare opinionem praedictam Avicennae, Ponunt enim quod intellectus conjunctus intelligit per conversionem ad inferiora et sensibilia a quibus recipit species, sed intelligit per conversionem ad superiora, a quibus recipit species intelligibiles."

21 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 28, vol. I, p. 423 [I do not find mention of common nature either at CE III, pp. 305–06 or Vivès IX, p. 375].—Of course, this does not keep the intellect from being the cause of the universal as such, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 8 [EW II, pp. 302–03, numbers 48–49].

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 28, vol. I, p. 423 [I do not find mention of abstraction at CE III, pp. 305–06].—Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 5, number 12 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 230, number 154]: "Ideo intellectus convertitur ad phantasma, non sicut ad objectum, nec sicut ad aliquid repraesentativum sui objecti; sed convertitur ad illud sicut passivum (so we are dealing with the possible intellect) ad activum, a quo recipit suam perfectionem. Si enim intellectus de novo recipit speciem per abstractionem a phantasmate, tunc convertitur ad phantasma sicut passivum ad activum. Si vero intellectus habet speciem, tunc phantasia coagit ad intensionem ejus, et tunc intellectus convertit se in intelligendo ad phantasma, non sicut ad activum suae speciei de novo, sed sicut ad intendens suam speciem." Consequently, to be accurate, there is a dual *conversio ad phantasma*. One consists in the conformity of the operations of intellect and imagination, when they operate on the same object; the other one, the conversion of the possible intellect to the sensible species whose action it undergoes, is a *conversio passivi ad activum*.

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 8, number 32, vol. I, p. 427 (Translator: this should probably be question 7, CE III, pp. 311–14).—The four commonly recognized species of quality were, first, *habitus et dispositio*; second *potentia et impotentia*; third, *passio et passibilis qualitas*; fourth, *forma et figura*. Intellection cannot fall within the fourth or third species of qualities, because they are exclusively corporeal, or into the second, which only includes the natural powers (which the will is not) and their contraries. Consequently, it can only belong to the first.

24 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 8, number 34, vol. I, p. 429 [I do not find this at CE III, pp. 316–18].—See Seraphin Belmond, O. F. M., "L'intellect actif d'après Jean Duns Scot," *Revue de philosophie* (1930), pp. 31–54.

25 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 432 [CE III, p. 247]: "In ista quaestione est una opinio quae attribuit totam activitatem respecta intellectionis ipsi animae, et imponitur Augustino."—Duns Scotus responds that Augustine maintains it, and finds it easy to quote the passages where he says, for example, number 3, p. 434, [CE III, p. 250]: "res . . . congenerat in nobis notiam sui."—That is true in the general sense that in order to deny it, it would be necessary to deny the existence of things with Berkeley. The generality of the clearly Augustinian tendency to reduce the object's active quality to a minimum (a causality, moreover, that is indispensable) is seen in the names of the different witnesses cited by historians in this regard. Belmond, "L'intellect actif." p. 231 [translator, *sic*], thinks of Pierre Olieu, called Peter Olivi. Cf. *France Franciscaine*, vol. XII, pp. 312–18. He also points to Petrus de Trabibus. The passage is in Ephrem Longpré, O. F. M., "Pietro de Trabibus, un disceplo de Pier Giovanni Olivi," in *Studi Franciscani*, July–September, 1922. Pietro de Trabibus also maintains, pp. 277–78, that the agent intellect produces everything and undergoes nothing in the presence of the object and without a possible intellect. Cf. Olivier Lacombe, "La critique," in *Revue thomiste* 1930, pp. 145–50.—On the other hand, Faustino Prezioso, O. F. M., "L'attivitá del soggetto pensante nella gnoseologia di Matteo d'Aquasparta e di Ruggiero Marston," *Antonianum* XXV (1950), quotes, pp. 10–12, an interesting passage from Thomas of York, *Sapientiale*, book VI,

chapter 26, and also Roger Bacon in *De Multiplicatione Specierum*.

26 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 1, number 3, vol. I, p. 434 [CE, pp. 250–51].—Matthew of Aquasparta already discusses the thesis of "*excitatio sive occasio formandarum in se specierum*," without giving the name of its author, *Quaestiones de Cognitione*, III, Quaracchi, 1903, p. 282. Matthew remarks, p. 284, "Ista positio magnorum magistrorum est et multum sublimium, tamen hanc videtur sequi aliqua inconvenientia." Nor does Matthew admit that the phantasm is only the *objectum excitativum*, p. 289. It is the *objectum motivum*.—By contrast, Roger Marston, *Quaestiones Disputatae*, Quaracchi, 1932, question 7 *De Anima*, p. 396, maintained: "quod in anima sensitiva non fit aliqua species quae multiplicetur ab objecto in eam." As for the intellectual soul, he discusses the opinion of that *solemnis modernus doctor*, Henry of Ghent, *Quodlibet* IV, question 21, and *Quodlibet* V, question 14, which denies the existence of intelligible species, basing himself on Avicenna, Marston, question 9, p. 413, but mistakenly according to Marston, question 9, p. 415. He next discusses the theory of the species' *instrumentality*, Giles of Rome, *Quodlibet* V, question 21. Duns Scotus will discuss the theory in his turn, which we pass over (with some uneasiness) in order to be brief. Marston rejects it, question 9, p. 418, and then criticizes the thesis of the illumination of the phantasm, p. 420, a thesis likewise criticized by Duns Scotus. This shows that the discussion of the Subtle Doctor is situated within an existing framework. Marston's deeply Augustinian solution, p. 422, helps us to understand how much Augustinian inspiration enters into Duns Scotus's Aristotelian approach.

27 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 1, number 6, vol. I, pp. 436–37 [CE III, pp. 258–360].—Cf. Lacombe, "La critique," pp. 150–57.

28 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 1, number 7, p. 437 [CE III, pp. 260–52].—See Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* V, question 10. Along with Thomas, Godfrey locates the passage from the sensible to the intelligible in the phantasm. But how does this passage take place? That is not *bene manifestum*, p. 36. In any case the "actio vel operatio intellectus agentis non est positiva sic quod faciat aliquam dispositionem positivam et subjectivam in phantasmate," p. 37. At most we can speak of a certain kind of *remotio*, *abstractio*, or *sequestratio*, which consists in the light of the intellect illuminating the only quiddity enclosed in the phantasm. If someone discards the individuating conditions from the phantasm, pp. 37–38, "potentia intelligibile faceret actu intelligibile, absque hoc quod aliquam dispositionem formalem in ipsa quidditate substantiale efficert, et prohibens quodam modo removeret. . . . Hoc autem fit quodam contactu spirituali et virtuali luminis intellectus agentis . . ." We find the same terms as in Duns Scotus's summary that closely follows Godfrey.—For a comparison with Thomas Aquinas, see Paul Fleig, "Thomistische und skotistische Erkenntnislehre," *Franziskanische Studien* XXXII (1935), pp. 149–57. Fleig situates the principal source of differences in the opposition between analogy and univocity. We agree, but at the level of epistemology rather than noetics.

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 1, numbers 9–11, vol. I, pp. 437–40 [CE III, pp. 264–71].

30 For Henry of Ghent's intermediate position and Duns Scotus's discussion of it, see Lacombe, "La critique," pp. 217–19.

31 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 3 [CE III, p. 292]: "Si ergo nec anima sola, nec objectum solum sit causa totalis intellectionis actualis, et ista sola videntur requiri ad intellectionem, sequitur, quod ista duo sunt una causa integra respectu notitiae genitae."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 2, number 20, vol. I, p. 447 [CE III, pp. 289–93], and *Quodlibet* XV, 8–9 [AW, pp. 351–53].—The Augustinian tradition tells us, *De Trinitate*, book IX, chapter 12, number 18, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 970: "Unde liquido tenendum est quod omnis res, quamcumque cognoscimus, congenerat in nobis notitiam

sui; ab utroque enim pariter notitia, a cognoscente scilicet et cognito." The internal organization of the two causal actions is clear. First, the intellect exercises two acts, the intelligible species and the actual intellection, and it exercises them without undergoing anything from the sensible species. Second, the intellect perceives the first *qua* principal cause; when the species is present, the intellect and the species form an integral cause. Third, the intellect exercises the second, always *qua* principal cause, with the intelligible species. The intellect and the species then form two partial causes that cooperate in the same effort. See Messner, *Schauendes und begriffliches*, pp. 5–28.

32 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 14, vol. I, pp. 444–45 [CE III, number 275–76]. These arguments are found in the refutation of the fifth position discussed by Duns Scotus. He remits to it in the exposition of his own solution. This consists in maintaining: "Ipse intellectus tantummodo se habet tanquam materiale, vel informatus illa specie, vel per objectum supplens vicem speciei."—The sixth position, traditionally attributed to Giles of Rome amounts to the same thing because it confuses knowledge with the species, something Duns Scotus denies regarding the common sense as well as the intellect, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 15, vol. I, p. 445 [CE III, pp. 277–79]. None of the positions discussed by Duns Scotus seems to be exactly the position of Thomas Aquinas.

33 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 2, number 21, vol. I, p. 447 [CE III. p. 295]: "una est. simpliciter perfectior altera, ita tamen quod utraque in sua partiali causalitate est perfecta, non dependens ab alia."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 12 [CE VII, pp. 532–33]. The thesis is general in scope and extents to all partial causes, *In Metaphysicam*, book VIII, question 4, number 6 [EW II, pp. 445–46, numbers 31–37].

34 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 2, number 23, vol. I, p. 450 [CE III, p. 298]. The two causes form *una causa totalis*, whose unity is the unity of parts ordered to a whole, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 12, vol. II, p. 296 [CE VII, pp. 531–33]. Cf. *Quodlibet* XV, 10 [AW, pp. 353–54].

35 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 3, number 25, vol. I, p. 451 [CE III, pp. 300–01].—On Duns Scotus's residual Augustinianism, see the measured comments of Belmond, "Le mecanisme," p. 295.

36 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 3, number 26, p. 452 [CE III, pp. 302–03].

37 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 3, number 31, p. 457 [CE III, pp. 309–11].

38 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, number 37, p. 461 [CE III, p. 321]: "Philosophus loquens sic de intellectu [scilicet, *De Anima*, III, 4], necesse habuit dicere eum esse passivum, et quod intelligere est quoddam pati, hoc est, quod intellectio, in quantum est quoddam quo formaliter intelligimus, est forma quaedam recepta in intellectu; non autem intelligimus ea in quantum est quid causatum ab intellectu si causatur ab eo, nam si Deus causaret et eam in intellectu nostro imprimeret, non minus ea intelligeremus."—Duns Scotus adds that we can, furthermore, label the possible intellect *passive*, although even the possible intellect is not bereft of all activity. In any case, it is only *possible* in relation to the intelligible about which it is not in act at all before having received the intellection. But in itself, it is an actual being. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7 number 38, p. 463 [CE III, p. 324]: "Ideo sic intelligendum est ipsum non esse aliquid eorum quae sunt ante intelligere, scilicet intelligibilium: non quia antequam intelligat nihil sit in actu, sed quia non est aliquid quod possit potentia propinqua intelligi a nobis ante intelligere alterius, propter intellectionem nostram naturalem incipientem a

phantasmatibus modo [CE does not have *modo*].”—Cf. *Quodlibet* XV, number 12 [AW, p. 355], “Ad secundum Aristoteles videtur loqui frequentius pro activitate objecti . . .,” and Messner, *Schauendes und begriffliches*, pp. 23–27.

39 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 1, number 14, vol. I, p. 443 [CE III, pp. 275–77].—It is even what allows the phantasm to act upon the intellect because, on the one hand, the sensible is pregnant with the intelligible, and on the other hand, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 45, question 2, number 8, “tantummodo per hoc agit phantasma in intellectu, quia est repraesentativum objecti.”

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 3, number 39, vol. I, p. 464 [CE III, p. 326]: “Ita in proposito, indeterminatio intellectus non est indeterminatio potentialis passivae in ordine causalitatis, sed et indeterminatio actualitas quasi illimitatae; et ideo non determinatur per formam quae sit sibi ratio determinate agendi, sed tantummodo per praesentiam objeti, circa quod determinatum nata est esse determinata intellectio.—The number of cooperating causes plays no role here, except to make evident the intellect’s actuality. The more actuality there is, the more its activity bursts forth before our eyes, Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 10, number 1, vol. I, p. 467 [CE III, pp. 330–32]. Indeed, even before any second act of knowing, the intellect, taken in itself and as first act, is one of the intelligibles. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 15: “Quia licet ante intelligere nihil sit de numero intellectorum, est tamen aliquid de numero intelligibilium.”

41 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 7, article 3, number 39, p. 464 [CE III, p. 326]: “Vel aliter posset dici, quod sicut causa superior determinatur ad agendum, concurrente aliqua particulari causa inferiori, sicut sol ad generandum hominem concurrente homine agente, et bovem concurrente bove, non autem per aliqua formam sibi in se receptam, ita intellectus, qui est causa superior et causa illuminata, determinatur ad hoc objectum concurrente causa particulari determinata, puta ad agendum circa hoc objectum concurrente hac specie. Non enim istud determinans determinat effective causam superiorem indeterminatam, neque formaliter sicut ratio agendi, sed sic determinat, hoc est, virtus activa superior indeterminata, potest in determinatum effectum, tali virtute inferiori determinata concurrente.” [CE has *causa autem inferior non* instead of *non enim istud determinans*].—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 11, vol. II, p. 295 [CE VII, p. 530]: “Hoc modo [*scilicet*, quando prima causa dat virtutem secundae] non est in proposito, quia nec intellectus ut agens causalitate sua partiali dat specie objecti istum actum quo operatur ad intellectionem, nec multo magis e converso, quia species nullam activatem dat intellectui pertinentem ad causalitatem ejus.”

42 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 8, number 2, p. 468 [CE, pp. 333–34].—Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 10, vol. II, pp. 294–95 [CE VII, p. 530]: “Intellectus habet activitatem suam propriam, sive objecto praesente in se, sive in specie sua concurrente secum ad causandum effectum communem amborum, ita quod sufficit unio et approximatio istarum partialium causarum; nec tamen requiritur quod altera alteram informet, quia neutra dat alteri actum pertinentem ad suam causalitatem partialem.”

43 “Intellectus igitur agens, concurrens aliquo modo cum natura indeterminata ex se, est causa integra factiva objecti in intellectu possibili secundum completam indeterminationem universalis.” He continues, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 8 [EW II, p. 302, numbers 48–49]: “nec est alia causa, quod intellectus cum natura fecit objectum sic esse, nisi quia est talis potentia, sicut nec quare calidum calefacit; est ergo natura in potentia remota ad determinationem singularitatis et ad indeterminationem universalis, et sicut a producente conjungitur singularitati, ita a re agente et simul ab intellectu agenti conjungitur univeralitati. Et isto modo bene intelligitur illud dictum Avicennae V *Metaphysica*, capitulo 1, quod natura de se non est universalis, nec

particularis, sed tantum natura." Note the correspondence in this text: the cause confers singularity on nature as the intellect confers intelligibility on it.—The universal in the broad sense, which designates the common nature, must be distinguished from the universal in the strict sense, which includes predictability in regard to every individual. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 6 [EW II, pp. 298–99, number 41]: "Primo modo dicitur natura, absolute sumpta, universalem quia non est de se haec, et ita non repugnat sibi ex se dici de multis. Secundo modo non est universale, nisi sit actu indeterminatum, ita quod intelligibile numero sit dicibile de omni supposito, et illud est complete universale."

44 Duns Scotus himself says that *abstraction* is not a real operation, which permits him to justify Avicenna in a certain way. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 9 [EW II, pp. 303–04, number 51]: "Abstractio objecti non est aliqua actio realis sed causatur species intelligibilis a phantasmate et intellectu agente simul qua causata in intellectu possibili formaliter, sicut causatur objectum abstractum ibi, non formaliter sed objective, et sic bene salvatur Avicenna V *Metaphysicae*, capitulo 2 de forma intelligibili."—Number 8 has just remitted to Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate V, chapter 1, on the nature's indetermination, but here Scotus envisages the thesis of Avicenna according to which the phantasm and the separated intellect suffice to make the sensible species intelligible. It is enough to integrate this separated intellect with the intellectual soul to obtain the truth [EW II contains the reference to Avicenna, but relegates the citation to a note, p. 302, note 98].

45 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 8, vol. II, pp. 230–31 [CE VII, pp. 406–07]: "Universale in actu est illud quod aliquam unitatem habet indifferentem, secundum quam ipsum idem est in potentia proximam ut dicatur de quolibet supposito. . . . Nihil enim secundum quamlibet unitatem in re est tale, quod secundum ipsam unitatem praecisam sit in potentia proxima ad quodlibet suppositum, ut dicatur de quolibet supposito praedicatione dicente hoc est hoc; quia licet alicui existenti in re non repugnet esse in alia singularitate ab illa in qua est, non tamen illud vere dici potest de quolibet inferiori, quod quodlibet est ipsum; hoc est enim solum possibile de objecto eodem indifferenti actu considerato ab intellectu; quod quidem, ut intellectum, habet unitatem et etiam numeralem objecti, secundum quam ipsum idem est praedicabile de omni singulari, dicendo quod hoc est hoc."—This is why Duns Scotus is opposed to doctrines where, according to him, the intellect does not make universals. See, for example, *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 4, numbers 20–21 [EW I, pp. 31–33], and compare it with Hocedez, *Richard de Middleton*, pp. 147–48. Olivier Lacombe, "La critique," pp. 220–22, seems to be completely right in pointedly emphasizing an important point of divergence between the two doctrines. According to St. Thomas illumination by the agent does something in phantasms. It makes them "apt to undergo the abstraction of intelligible species," *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 85, article 1, reply to objection 4. Lacombe, p. 220, is far from denying the overall agreement of the two doctrines, but like Scotus himself he seizes upon the doctrines' individuating differences to distinguish them. How could he do otherwise? The historian has no other function than to describe each of the doctrines as it is. Philosophers choose which is true, that is their business. In the measure that doctrines differ, they cannot both be true at once. Fr. Belmond is impressed that Lacombe appreciated Duns Scotus from the standpoint of Thomas Aquinas, but he protests from the standpoint of Duns Scotus, who himself could only criticize the position of Thomas Aquinas from his own point of view. Historical objectivity and doctrinal indifference must be carefully distinguished. In any case, it is clear that for Duns Scotus the modification required for intellection does not take place in the phantasm; *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 9 [EW II, p. 303, number 51]: "sed illa non in phantasmate patet."

46 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 1, number 9, vol. II, p. 231 [CE VII, pp.

407–08]: “Ex hoc apparet improbatio illius dicti, quod intellectus agens facit universalitatem in rebus, per hoc quod denudat ipsum quod quid est in phantasmate existens; nam ubicumque est antequam in intellectu possibili habeat esse objective sive in re sive in phantasmate, sive habeat esse certum sive deductum per rationem, et si sit non per aliquod lumen, sed semper sit talis natura ex se cui non repugnet esse in alio, non tamen est tale cui potentia proxima conveniat dici de quolibet, sed tantum est in potentia proxima ut est in intellectu possibili; est ergo in re commune quod est de se hoc, et per consequens ei non repugnat esse non hoc. Sed tale commune non est universale in actu, quia deficit ei illa indifferentia secundum quam completive universale est universale, secundum quam scilicet ipsum idem aliqua identitate est praedicabile de quolibet individuo, ita quod quodlibet sit ipsum.”—Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 10 [EW II, pp. 305–08]. It is a general rule that the causality of any cause never replaces the proper causality of another cause. Even God’s intellect does nothing in the divine essence that it knows, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 14, number 5 [EW II, pp. 248–49].

47 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 6, number 7 [EW I, p. 127, number 39]: “Intellectus agens non causat universale, sed intellectus posssibilis, considerans illam quidditatem illimitatam causat in eo universale; ita quod universale non est per se objectum intellectus sed consequitur etiam actionem primam intellectus possibilis; ita quod quidditas secundum se, sicut est objectum sensus, secundum praecedentem responsionem, ita etiam et intellectus.” The universal is not intrinsically the object of the intellect, because it only becomes that after being made.—We have not succeeded in obtaining details on this *unlimited consideration of the quiddity*, which leads the possible intellect to universalize the indifferent *nature*. Perhaps we are dealing with an abstraction according to the tradition of the Franciscan masters, *conferendo et comparando*, but we know no text on this point —[Addendum by Gilson]. This remark on the role of the possible intellect surely does not express Duns Scotus’s thinking but rather that of one of his predecessors. In reality, since the possible intellect is not really distinct from the agent intellect, and since abstractive intellection is not required by the nature of the intellect, but only in the present human state, the problem has secondary importance within Duns Scotus’s doctrine.

48 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XV, numbers 13–20 [AW, pp. 355–63], contains a long development on the question of finding out whether, in the active part of the soul, the intellective cause of intellection is the agent intellect or the possible intellect. Unfortunately, after setting out the two theses, Duns Scotus does not choose. In his commentary, Lychet says that the Subtle Doctor “videtur declinare magis ad hoc, quod intellectus agens sit activus notitiae objecti, quam possibilis,” Wadding edition, vol. XII, p. 431. But what interests Duns Scotus primarily is to know how the definition of *imago* given by St. Augustine can be safeguarded in either hypothesis. The pro and con is similarly contrasted in *Collationes* VIII. Hugo Cavellus notes the fact, Wadding edition, vol. III, p. 365: “Scotus in hac quaestione, an intellectus possibilis sit activus necne, problematicus est.” In fact, as Messner correctly observes, *Schauendes und begriffliches*, pp. 45–46, the distinction of the two intellects loses much of its significance in Duns Scotus’s doctrine.

49 Scotus *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 1, vol. II, p. 287 [CE VII, pp. 517–18].—The problem splits in two. Is the singular intelligible of itself?—This is a metaphysical problem. Do we know the intelligible in fact?—This is a psychological problem, falling under *De Anim*a. The first of these two problems is settled after we have resolved the problem of the principle of individuation. Since the singular is supremely real, it is supremely intelligible, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 4 [EW II, pp. 256–58, numbers 14–18]. The issue is mainly the second problem.

50 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 3, question 5, number 11 [*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 339. numbers 151–52].—Scotus’s answer is interesting for its own sake: “Unde minor rationis

eorum falsa est; quamvis enim quidditas materialis non sit nisi in aliquo singulari, tamen existere in aliquo singulari non est de ratione ejus. Ideo intellectus, qui est abstractus, potest intelligere quidditatem, non intelligendo eam ut existit in aliquo singulari." Therefore, it is certain in any case that the abstract knowledge of an essence taken without its singular determination is always possible for an intellect.

51 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 10.—Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 4 [EW II, pp. 256–58, especial number 15]. Let us recall that this does not exclude the possibility in the angel of abstractive knowledge of its own essence, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 12.—Regarding the problems that follow, it is useful to consult Day, *Intuitive Knowledge*, who vigorously defends interpretations that differ from ours.

52 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 12, question 8, number 10.

53 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 14, sole question, number 8. See the entire passage in note 60 of this chapter.

54 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 12, question 8, number 10: "Et cum allegatur Philosophus, dico quod non est ejus intentio quod singulare non sit intelligibile. Sed intellectus noster non intelligit nisi per sensum, et dictum est quod per sensum non cognoscenti hoc singulare at hoc, sed solum ut natura, et sic potest intellectus noster intelligere singulare. Unde Philosophus vult quod intellectus noster potest in duo, sensus autem tantum in unum, quia non potest in universale, ut universale; et intellectus potest in singulare, sicut sensus."—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 3, question 3, number 15: "Ideo dico quod in nulla specie, inquantum talis, perfecte potest cognosci objectum suum singulare, quia aliquid includit quod non species, et quantum ad hoc non dicit species in ejus cognitionem. Et ideo dico quod singulare non est per se intelligibile sub propria ratione perfecte."—With even more reason, the senses do not know the individuating singularity even though they perceive the singular. "Haecceitas non sentitur," says an objection that Duns Scotus does not contradict on this point, *In Metaphy*sicam, book VII, question 13, number 26 [EW II, p. 241, number 176].—See Antonius Andreas, *Quaestiones supra Metaphysicam*, book I, question 9, body of answer, Venice, 1514, folio 9 verso: "Singulare sub ratione singularitate non est objectum per se ipsius sensus."

55 This is also why, although the real is completely intelligible, our knowledge never knows anything in its compete knowability, because the nature of the object only acts upon the intellect at the level of nature and not at the level of singularity. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 5 [EW II, p. 259, number 22]: "Nulla potentia cognoscitiva in nobis cognoscit rem secundum suam absolutam cognoscibilitatem, in quantum scilicet est in se manifesta, sed solum inquantum est motiva potentiae, quia potentiae cognitivae hic moverentur ab oppositis; natura autem non movet secundum gradum singularitatis."—In fact, our most perfect science pushes up to the most determined species and stops there. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 13, number 26 [EW II, p. 241, number 178]: "Perfectissima scientia nunc nobis possibilis est de specie specialissima, ibi status."

56 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 14, question 3, number 6. We cannot insist enough on this point, Day, *Intuitive Cognition*, p. 107, quotes the statement of Lychetus, "Omnis cognitio per speciem intelligibilem est tantum abstractiva," which accurately expresses Duns Scotus's thinking. But if the intuition has the proper character of being partially caused by the presence of a given existent, being caused in this way is really what distinguishes it from abstractive knowledge. Accordingly, every intuition is intuition of an existent *seen* as such, but whose *nature* is abstractly known by an intelligible species. Evidently, the intellectual knowledge of a nature can only be abstract, because this nature only reaches the intellect by the phantasm, *pro*

statu isto. It is significant that Duns Scotus always defines intuitive knowledge as knowledge of the *existent as existent*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 2, article 2, number 3, vol. I, p. 137 [CE II, p. 23]: "Visio est existentis ut existens est, et ut praesens est videnti secundum existentiam suam." If there is intuition of the nature, it is insofar as, being the cause of the intellection, it is known as existent. For the rest, the content of the two acts must be the same, because once the intuition ends, the intelligible species survives, ready to take the intuition's place. Consequently, the intuition is not *visio essentiae ut essentiae est*, but *visio essentiae ut existens*. That is so true that, as Duns Scotus has just said, even the intuitive knowledge of the singular as such, if we possessed it, would not deliver its existence to us. The intuitive character of knowledge bears upon existence, because its object causes it, insofar as existent, and it only bears upon that. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 8, question 4, article 2, number 15, vol. I, p. 631 [CE IV, p. 257]: "Praeterea, intellectus intuitivus nullam habet distinctionem in objecto, nisi secundum quod existens est; quia sicut non cognoscit aliquod objectum nisi secundum quod existens, ita non cognoscit aliqua distincta formaliter in objecto nisi ut existens."—Whether the issue is the whole or the parts, the intuition bears upon the object as existing, and it only bears upon that. We do not say, *on the existence in general*, which does not exist separately, but upon the *objectum secundum quod existens est*.

57 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 4 [EW II, probably p. 258, number 18].

58 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 45, question 3, number 13: "Ad propositum tamen dico, quod cognitio intuitiva non est tantum singularis, inquantum est cognitio intuitiva, sed essentialiter est ipsius naturae existentis, et ut existens est, quia prius competit esse naturae, quam sit ut haec, sive ut singulare, eo quod essentia sit ejusdem rations in omnibus singularibus, non autem singularitas ipsa sit ejusdem rationis in omnibus, sed diversa in quolibet singulari unius esentiae, ex quo sequitur quod essentia potest cognosci, non tamen singularitas ejus."—Cf. *Quodlibet* XIII, number 11 [AW, pp. 292–93].

59 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 14, question 3, number 12: "Contradictio est igitur quod sit cognitio intuitiva in genere proprio, et quod res non sit, quia species non potest sufficere ad cognitionem intutivam sine praesentia rei, quia species aequaliter potest repraesentare objectum re existente et non existente; igitur non sufficienter causat cognitionem intuitivam existentiae rei."—In this connection, may we be excused for specifying that we have never "found in Ockham's teaching on intuitive knowledge, one of the principal reasons for the ruination of scholasticism and for skepticism," which would infect "all modern philosophy and nearly all medieval philosophy," Day, *Intuitive Cognition*, p. xiii. In any case, in what concerns intuition, our critique of Ockham has dealt with the intuition of *what does not exist*. Ockham holds this intuition to be possible *de potentia Dei absoluta*. Duns Scotus holds it to be contradictory. Certainly, Duns Scotus admits that, if God wishes, he can impress a species upon our intellect or even in our eyes, in which case our intellect, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 11 [EW II, p. 307, number 69]: "eodem modo ferretur in objectum, sicut modo, et objectum ita esset objectum." We would imagine we had an intuition, but, to our knowledge, neither here nor elsewhere, does Duns Scotus say it would be one. Since he says elsewhere that an intuition without object would be a contradiction, nothing authorizes us to attribute this doctrine to him.

60 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 14, question 3, number 8: "Item, quodlibet est intelligibile ab intellectu Deo, ita singulare sicut universale; igitur et a quocumque intellectu, absolute loquendo, cum quantum est ex se, sit totius entis, licet impediatur secundum statum istum lapsum. Ideo [*scilicet*, for this last reason] de potentia ordinata non potest dici singulare per se intelligibile a quocumque intellectu, non quia objectum non sit in potentia propinqua quantum ex parte sui, sed quia intellectus non movetur nisi a phantasmate, vel a natura quae gignit phantasma,

quorum neutrum [*scilicet*, not even the phantasm] est hoc ut hoc: natura enim est prius natura quam sit haec ut haec. Ideo singularitas non movet intellectum nostrum, quia illud est principium movendi, quod assimilat sibi effectum. Ideo singularitas se habet tantum concomitanter ex parte moventis intellectum, quia nihil movet intellectum nostrum nisi natura vel phantasma, et ideo intellectus, qui sic movetur a re, non capit hoc ut hoc; sed respectu intellectus Dei, non sic est, quia ab illo immediate cognoscitur haec ut haec."—*In patria*, this will not hold for us; cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 14, question 3, number 9.

61 Quoted by Day, *Intuitive Cognition*, p. 123, note 1.—In this life, for humans, there is not direct knowledge of the singular as such, *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 5 [EW II, p. 259, number 22]: "Intellectus noster, in hoc statu, non intelligit per se singulare, nec sensus sentit."—Obviously, intuition directly perceives existence, but we must not forget that, if the singular alone exists, existence is not singularity. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 4 [EW II, p. 258, number 18]: "Non enim singulare ex se determinatur ad existentiam, quia abstrahit, sicut et universale."

62 The problem is connected to the status of existence in Duns Scotus. As we know, existence in Scotus is not an act of the essence but is distinguished from it as a modality. As such, existence is not a nothing, and insofar as it *is*, it is a cause. To be exact, it is the proper cause of the kind of intellection that is called intuition or vision. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 15, number 6 [EW II, p. 260, number, 25]: "Probatur de existentia, quae est alterius rationis ab entitate quidditativa et individuali, quae tamen movet ad intellectionem, quae est visio."—Since existence is the cause of the intuition, existence is certainly its object, *and not quiddity or singularity*. However, as we see in the same place, the existing individual being does not exercise distinct natural action upon the intellect. It does not make itself known separately as existing. (This would be purely sensible knowledge, connected to quality.) The object makes itself seen existing in the intellectual intelligibility itself. The intellect then knows both that it is object and that it is. Here below, this is impossible without sensation, but the intuition of existence remains an act of the intellect.

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 13, vol. I, p. 13 [CE I, pp. 21–22]: "Ad secundum concedo quod non habetur modo cognitio de anima vel de aliqua ejus potentia ita distincta, quod ex ipsa possit cognosci quod aliquod objectum tale intelligibile sibi correspondeat; sed ex ipso actu quem experimur concludimus potentiam et naturam cujus iste actus, illud respicere pro objecto quod percipimus attingi per actum: ita quod objectum potentiae non concluditur ex cognitione potentiae, sed ex cognitione actus quem experimur."—This passage has direct bearing on the possibility of knowing the natural or supernatural object starting from the power, but we see what it implies touching the possibility of knowing the act starting from the power and from the nature.

64 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 13, vol. II, p. 297 [CE VII, p. 534]: "anima de se actu intelligibilis est et prasens sibi; et ex hac sequitur quod possit intelligere se, si non esset impedita."

65 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 13, vol. II, p. 298 [CE VII, p. 535]: "intellectus noster pro statu isto non est natus moveri immediate, nisi ab aliquo imaginabili vel sensibili extra prius moveatur."

66 On the possible causes of the *impedimentum*, see above chapter 1, pp. 62–65 [check internal reference]. Here Duns Scotus specifies that they are both "ex peccato et non solum ex peccato, sed etiam ex natura potentiarum pro statu isto." The soul is both fallen and pilgrim, wounded in the exercise of its acts and naturally united to the body. See *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 3, question 8, number 14, vol. II, p. 298 [CE VII, p. 537]: "In anima sunt impedimenta, in angelo

non."

67 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, article 2, number 11, vol. I, p. 11 [CE I, p. 17]: "Non enim cognoscitur anima nostra a nobis, nec natura nostra pro statu isto, nisi sub aliqua ratione generali abstrahibili a sensibus."

68 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 3, article 4, number 24, vol. I, p. 351 [CE III, pp. 112–14].—It is true of all immaterial or material substances that, in our present state, "non concipiuntur in aliquo conceptu quidditativo nisi in conceptu entis." This does not define the nature of the intellectual soul, just as we do not define the eye by the fact that it can see the light of a candle. We are dealing with the present conditions of the intellectual soul's exercise.

69 Duns Scotus explicitly recalls this at the moment he affirms that we have intuitive experience of the acts of our soul. The soul, he says, intuitively knows what the senses know, and moreover, it knows the senses themselves, but here is the proof he gives, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 45, question 3, number 17: "et utrumque probatur per hoc quod cognoscit propositiones contingenter veras, et ex eis syllogizat; formare autem propositiones et syllogizare proprium est intellectui; illarum autem veritas est de objectis ut intuitive cognitis, sub ratione scilicet existentiae, sub qua cognoscuntur a sensu."—In other words, "the intellect intuitively knows what the senses know," because the contingent truths that it knows concern objects whose existence is intuitively known by the senses. If I intuitively know my sense perception of the existence of an object, I intuitively know the existence this perception knows. What intuition there is in intellectual knowledge bears directly upon the sensation, not the object.

70 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, number 11: "quodam sensu, id est perceptione interiori, experimur." Duns Scotus defines it in relation to the intellection that the angel possesses of his own intellection, in the interesting development in *Quodlibet* VI, number 8 [AW, pp. 136–37].

71 It has been held that intuitive knowledge is directly produced, with no interposed species. Father Day has gathered texts that seem to him to give evidence, some decisive, in this direction, *Intuitive Cognition*, pp. 108–09. We are not certain that they are decisive. Duns Scotus certainly thought that the object moves the soul to knowledge more efficaciously and more perfectly than the species, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 11, number 9, but he does not say in this passage that the cooperation provided to intellection by the object dispenses with the cooperation of the species. In seeking Scotus's position on this point it is necessary to limit oneself to the passages that are applied to humans (not angels), taken *pro statu isto* (and not to the state of the separated soul). The fact that when a higher angel knows a lower angel, *ista cognitio non est per aliquam speciem*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, number 19, vol. II, p. 460 [CE VIII, p. 165], proves nothing as to our intuitions *pro statu isto*.—By contrast, the next formula holds for intuition in general, Day, *Cognitive Intuition*, p. 109; *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, number 29, vol. II, p. 469 [CE VIII, p. 183]: "Ista autem [*scilicet*, cognitio intuitiva] non potest haberi per speciem objecti, quae manere potest, objecto absente." However, to say that the species is not enough to cause intuition does not imply that it is absent from it. Cf. the passage from *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 45, question 2, number 12, quoted by Day, *Cognitive Intuition*, p. 108: "Solum phantasma non sufficit ad cognitionem intuitivam objecti."—The passage from *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 17, question 3, article 4, number 36, vol. I, p. 831 [CE V, p. 231], is decisive as quoted by Day, *Cognitive Intuition*, p. 109: "Objectum in se praesens . . . sufficit absque omni informatione [i.e., by a *species*], ad causandum visionem *vel ex se solo* cum intellectu." But here is Duns Scotus's text: "Tamen secundum illam viam quam dixi distinctione 3 hujus primi, quod objectum, sive in se sive in specie, est sicut causa partiale concurrens cum intellecto ad causandum intellectionem, non facit

aliquam difficultatem, quia objectum in se praesens, quomodo erit in Patria, sufficit, absque omni informatione ad causandum visionem, vel ex se solo cum intellectu." Accordingly, he is dealing with beatific vision from which we cannot draw conclusions *pro statu isto*. Moreover, Duns Scotus refers us to *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 7, vol. I, p. 404 [CE III, pp. 215–16], where he says: "Phantasma, in eodem instanti in quo intelligent universale, secundum totam virtutem suam repraesentat objectum ut singulare virtuti phantasticae, quia tunc est actualis imaginatio illius objecti in singulari." [CE omits *in eodem instanti*]. Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, vol. IV, distinction 45, question 2, number 20, where Scotus deals with the separated soul.—If it is objected that the issue is abstractive knowledge, we must answer precisely that intellectual knowledge is always abstractive *pro statu isto*, even in the presence of the object; hence the necessity of the species. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 14, vol. I, p. 409 [CE III, p. 228]: "Sed negando speciem intelligibilem, tota pars intellectiva non habet, ante actum intelligendi, objectum sibi praesens in se, nec in aliquo repraesentante." Without the intelligible species, the object would not be present to the intellect, either in itself or in a species that represents it. The oddest thing is that, by maintaining the contrary, we would attribute to Duns Scotus a position he refuted, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 1, vol. I, p. 398 [CE III, p. 202]: "Praesentia objecti est causa praesentiae speciei . . . ergo superflue ponitur species propter praesentiam objecti." To this Scotus responds, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 6, number 16, p. 411 [CE III, p. 232]: "Ad secundum de praesentia, dico quod objectum respectu potentiae habet primo praesentiam realem, scilicet, approximationem talem, ut possit gignere speciem talem in intellectu, quae est ratio formalis intellelectionis. Secundo, per istam speciem genitam, quae est imago gignentis, est objectum praesens sub ratione cognoscibilis sive repraesentati."—Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 10, question 8, number 5: ". . . in aliqua similitudine quae potest esse existentis et etiam non existentis, sive praesentis, sive non."

72 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 43, question 2, numbers 9–11. This passage is entirely reproduced in Day, *Intuitive Cognition*, pp. 136–37.

73 In principle, the totality of created being could be known by our intellect, either intuitively or abstractly. Therefore, the two kinds of knowledge do not differ by their content. Everything that can be known one way can be known in the other. The difference stems from their objects' mode of presence, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 10, question 8, number 5. For the object's part, its actual existence is the mode of presence that determines intuitive knowledge. This is why the object is only intuitively known *qua* existent, *Quodlibet* XIII, number 10 [AW, p. 292]: "In cognitione intuitiva res in propria existentia est per se motiva objective." Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 9, question 2, number 29, vol. II, p. 469 [CE VIII, p. 183]: "Hoc autem est contra rationem cognitions intuitivae, quod sit de re non actualiter existente et praesentialiter."—Furthermore, when we emphasize the importance of intuitive knowledge in Duns Scotus, we must not forget that the object of sense still remains the essence for him, *Quodlibet* VII, number 9 [AW, p. 168]: "Cum ratio in anima possit manere non manente existentia actuali objecti, sequitur quod existentia non est per se ratio objecti ut scibile est, quia ratio scientifica non potest manere eadem in anima, non manente illo eodem quod est per se ratio scibilis, ut scibile est; sive autem scibile possit existere in re, sive non, saltem ratione ejus, ut scibile est, potest manere eadem in anima, non manente existentia: abstrahit ergo scientia ab existentia, ita quod non includit eam in ratione scibilis."

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, vol. I, p. 357 [CE III, p. 123].—We can obtain a general view of the problem's history in the interesting collection: *De Humanae Cognitionis Ratione Anecdota Quaedam Seraphici Doctoris Sancti Bonaventurae et Nonnullorum*

Ipsius Discipulorum, Quaracchi: Typographia Collegii Sancti Bonaventurae, 1883. See particularly, St. Bonaventure, *Utrum rationes aeternae sint rationes cognoscendi in omni certitudinali cognitione*, p. 49 ff; Matthew of Aquasparta, *Utrum quidquid certitudinaliter cognoscitur cognitione intellectuali, cognoscatur in rationibus aeternis vel in luminae primae veritatis*, p. 87 ff; John Peckham, *Quaesitum est de ipsa Dei sapientia vel luce aeterna, utrum sit ratio cognoscendi quidquid intellectualiter cognoscitur in via*, p. 179 ff; Roger Marston, *Utrum anima omnia quae cognoscit cognoscat in luce aeterna, an sibi sufficiat lux naturalis, et propria ad cetera cognoscendum*, pp. 197 ff. If Henry of Ghent, Vital du Four, and Duns Scotus were added to this list, not to mention others, we would see how difficult it is to maintain that it is the historians who, out of concern for modernity, have introduced the problem of knowledge in the theology of the Middle Ages.

75 St. Augustine, *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 9, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, column 13.

76 This was the only point disputed among theologians, but even within the Franciscan school it was disputed. See the quandary of Peter John Olivi, *Quaestiones in II Librum Sententiarum* (Quaracchi: Typographia Collegii Sancti Bonaventurae, 1922–1926), vol. III, p. 500: “An rationes aeternae sint nostro intellectui ratio intelligendi omnia, et an lux increata irradiet intellectum nostrum quadam speciali irradiatione in omni actu intelligendi seu quandocumque aliquid actu intelligit.” Cf. particularly pp. 512–13.

77 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, number 2, vol. I, p. 358 [CE III, pp. 126–28].

78 Henry of Ghent, *Summa Theologica*, part I, article 1, questions 2 and 3, whose text is found in Vital du Four, “Huit questions disputées sur le problème de la connaisssance,” ed. by Ferdinand Delorme, O. F. M., in *Archives d’histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* II (1927), pp. 322–36.

79 Augustine, *De Vera Religione*, chapter 30, 54, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XXXIV, column 146; and Henry of Ghent in Vital du Four, *Huit questions*, p. 326.

80 Augustine, *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 9, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, columns 13–14. Cf. Henry of Ghent in Vital du Four, *Huit questiones*, pp. 326–27.

81 Henry of Ghent in Vital du Four, *Huit questions*, pp. 334–36; summed up by Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, number 4, vol. I, p. 361 [CE III, pp. 130–33].

82 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 1, number 6, vol. II, pp. 362–64 [CE III, pp. 136–37].—Cf. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XV, chapter 12, 21, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 1075: Do we not know that there is an ocean, lands, towns, and so on? Column 1074: I know from within what I want, and I know that I know. *De Trinitate*, book XV, chapter 15, 25, column 1078: Because the soul is always present by itself, it can always know what belongs to its proper nature.—Regarding sense knowledge properly speaking, Augustine does not teach that it fatally leads the intellect into error, but only that it is not capable by itself alone of distinguishing true from false, *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 9, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, column 13: “Si igitur sunt imagines sensibilium falsae, quae discerni ipsis sensibus nequeunt, et nihil percipi potest nisi quod a falso discernitur, non est judicium veritatis constitutum in sensibus.”—Duns Scotus agrees with Augustine on this point, but he only concludes from it that an illumination must be added to the intellect’s natural light for scientific knowledge to be possible. As for a *protervus* who denies that any proposition is evidently certain, for him Scotus suggests a rather good definition: one who argues against that of which he is at bottom convinced, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 3, number 15, p. 373: “Si contendis

mecum nullam propositionem esse veram, nolo disputare tecum; constat enim quod tu es protervus, sicut patet in actibus tuis." [In CE III, pp. 154–55 the *protervus* denies rather that there is any self-evident proposition].

83 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 3, numbers 7–8, vol. I, pp. 365–66 [CE III, pp. 138–41].

84 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 3, numbers 7–8, vol. I, pp. 366–67 [CE III, pp. 138–41]. *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 4, numbers 4, 5, 13, and 16, [EW I, pp. 86–89, 96–97, 99–100] quoted in Gilson, "Avicenne et le point de départ de Duns Scot," pp. 121–23.

85 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 3, numbers 7–8, vol. I, p. 367: "Quod autem . . ." [I have not found *quod autem* in CE III, pp. 138–41] Here we follow *Opus Oxonienese*. For a more detailed exposition of the same thesis, based on other texts, see Gilson, "Avicenne et le point," pp. 126–29, or P. Raymond, "La théorie de l'induction: Duns Scot précurseur de Bacon," *Études Franciscaines* XXI (1909), pp. 271–78.

86 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 3, number 9, vol. I, pp. 367–68 [CE III, pp. 141–44]. See *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 4, number 6 [EW I, pp. 89–90]; the passage is quoted in Gilson "Duns Scot et le point," p. 124, note 2.

87 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 3, article 5, number 13, vol. I, pp. 56–57 [CE III. pp. 94–95]. This knowledge is intuitive, because even in the case of an internal sense, we are dealing with sense knowledge: "Quia primum notum in contingentibus non est nisi per intuitionem extremorum; ergo primum intuibile cui insit primum praedicatum primae veritatis contingentis, est primum subjectum omnium veritatum contingentium ordinatorum." Let us recall that even the intuition of an internal sense presupposes a phantasm.

88 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 2, number 10, vol. I, p. 368 [CE III, pp. 144–45].

89 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 2, number 10, vol. I, p. 369 [CE III, pp. 145–46]. Here Duns Scotus affirms that, even without a corresponding real object, we would have the internal experience of an act of vision, or as we would say today, of a visual sensation. He cites as an example those *verae visiones*, the fires that we see with closed eyes if we abruptly press upward. Unlike Ockham, Scotus is not speaking of a vision that would be intuitive knowledge despite the fact that its object *nihil sit*. Cf. Philotheus Böhner, "The *Notitia Intuiva* of Non-Existents According to William of Ockham," *Traditio* I (1943), p. 249. In this same passage, we see that William of Ockham opposes Duns Scotus point by point: "Et ideo differentiae quas dat Johannes inter cognitionem intuitivam et abstractivam: quod cognitio intuitiva est praesentis et existentis ut praesens et existens est, intelliguntur de cognitione intuitiva naturaliter causata, non autem quando supernaturaliter. Unde absolute loquendo non requiritur necessario ad cognitionenm intuitivam alia praesentia, nisi quod possit actum intutivam terminare."—As Day, *Intuitive Cognition*, p. 104, correctly states, Duns Scotus's consistent thesis is "Non oportet objectum in se esse praesens propter terminationem actus, sed tantum propter causationem." We see why, in Duns Scotus, there is always an intelligible species to terminate the act. This is why the object's presence is required in order to distinguish abstraction from intuition. In Ockham, there are no longer intelligible species to terminate the act, whether abstractive or intuitive. Therefore, the object's existence is not absolutely required to distinguish them. The concept of an intuition of what does not exist, which is *contradictory* in Duns Scotus, is no longer contradictory in Ockham.

90 It will be observed that in this case, where we are dealing with a sensation, Duns Scotus maintains that the present object engenders a sensible species. *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3,

question 4, article 2, number 11, vol. I, pp. 369–70 [CE III, pp. 146–48].

91 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 2, number 11, vol. I, p. 370 [CE III, pp. 146–48]. It is always the intellect that judges in the last instance. If the senses disagree, the intellect has the role of arbiter. Even if their testimony agrees, the intellect confirms the agreement with a more certain light than theirs: "Etiam ubi sensus percipit conjunctionem singularium terminorum in re, adhuc certius adhaeretur principio complexo per naturale lumen intellectus quam propter aliquam apprehensionem sensus." (Translator: *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 4. Vivès VII, p. 54; EW I, p. 88, number 17). See the texts quoted in Gilson, "Avicenne et le point," pp. 123–24. Experimental knowledge has its proper value and certainty. It is never "sufficiens causa ad generandam artem vel scientiam . . . sed tantum coadjuvans et occasiio" (*In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 4, number 6, [EW I, p. 89].—Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book I, question 4, number 13 [EW I, p. 96, number 49] in "Avicenne et le point," p. 123: "Intellectus judicat de actu sensus per notitiam ab actu sensus acceptam occasonaliter, vel quoad apprehensionem simplicem, vel quoad compositionem principiorum et conclusionem."—We are not dealing with occasionalism of sense knowledge here. Duns Scotus does not say that the presence of the object is only the occasion of sensation. On the contrary, we know that in his doctrine the object acts directly upon the soul through the phantasm of which the object is the natural case. If we want to speak of occasionalism in this matter, it could only involve the occasionalism of sensible knowledge in regard to the judgment of the intellect. This amounts to saying that the term would then designate something completely different from its normal sense.

92 Of course, the perspective of a historian is not Duns Scotus's own perspective. He could object that even in Augustine the object does not act by its *mutabilitas*, and to attribute this position to Augustine is to confuse him with Heraclitus, whom Aristotle already refutes in *Metaphysics*, book IV, chapter 5, 1010 a. Duns Scotus would be right, but he reinforces Augustine by Avicenna, when he adds that the active cause of knowledge in the sensible realm is the immutable nature of the unchanging object, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 3, number 13, vol. I, p. 371 [CE III, pp. 150–52]: "Non sequitur ergo; si objectum est mutabile, ergo quod gignitur ab eo non est repraesentativum alicujus sub ratione immutabilis, quia mutabilitas in objecto non est ratio gignendi, sed natura ipsius objecti quod est mutabile; genitum igitur ab ipso repraesentat naturam per se; quia est per se ratio gignendi ipsum; igitur si natura unde natura habeat aliquam immutabilem habitudinem ad aliud, illud aliud per suum exemplar, et illa natura per suum exemplar repraesentantur ut immutabiliter unita, et ita per duo exemplaria [*scilicet*, species] genita a duobus mutabilibus, non in quantum mutabilia sed in quantum naturae, potest haberi notitia immutabilis unionis eorum. Patet etiam quod per repraesentativum in se mutabile potest repraesentari aliquid sub ratione immutabilis, quia essentia Dei sub ratione immutabilis repraesentatur intellectui per aliquid omnino mutabile, sive illud sit species, sive actus." [Between *unionis eorum* and *patet etiam* there should be an ellipsis indicting 16 lines according to CE].

93 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 4, number 16, vol. I, p. 374 [CE III, p. 157]: "falsum est quod ponitur in opinione, scilicet exemplar aeternum esse rationem cognoscendi, non cognitum."

94 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 18, vol. I, p. 376 [CE III, p. 160]: "sed aeternae sunt secundum quid, quia aeternitas est conditio existentis, et illa non habent existentiam nisi secundum quid."

95 Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XIV, chapter 15, 21, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 1052.

96 Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XII, chapter 14, 23, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 1011.

97 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 19, vol. I, pp. 377–78

[CE III, pp. 161–63].

98 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 20, vol. I, pp. 378–79 [CE III, pp. 164–66].—In number 21, p. 379 [CE III, pp. 165–66], Scotus engages in the exegesis of Augustinian texts to establish that the eternal rules do not make Christians see the articles of faith but make the pagans see natural truths, *De Trinitate*, book IV, chapter 15, 20, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, columns 901–02. Furthermore, the eternal rules do not make any contingent truth be seen but always necessary truths, *De Trinitate*, book IV, chapter 16, 21, column 902, and book IX, chapter 6, 9, column 966. If, in the case of faith and of contingents, where a special illumination would seem to be required, there is no illumination, it follows that there is none at all.

99 Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XII, chapter 14, 23, *Patrologia Latina* XLII, column 1010, and *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 46, number 2, *Patrologia Latina* XL, column 30.

100 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 22, vol. I, p. 380 [CE III, p. 168].—Following this text, see the bold exegesis of the passage from Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book IX, chapter 6, 11, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 966, where he who sees what is true is like one who is on a high mountain, with the pure light of the sun above him and the clouds below his feet. It is true, says Duns Scotus, that he who only has concepts by accident is in the fog of the valley, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 3, question 4, article 5, number 22, vol. I, p. 381 [CE III, pp. 168–69]: “Sed qui separat quidditates intelligendo praecise eas conceptu per se, quae tamen relucent in phantasmate cum multis aliis accidentibus adjunctis, ipse habet phantasia inferius, scilicet aerem nebulosum, et ipse est in monte in quantum cognoscit illam veritatem, et videt verum supra, ut istam veritaten superiorem in virtute intellectus increati, quae est lux aeterna.”—Scotus’s Augustinianism has limits. So does his Aristotelianism, because he judges that if Aristotle has proved that the Ideas are not *necessary* to explain generation, he has not proved that they are impossible. Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 11, number 4 [EW II, p. 163, number 22].

101 St. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XV, chapter 27, 50, *Patrologia Latina*, XLII, column 1097: “Quae igitur causa est cur acie fixa ipsam videre non possis, nisi infirmitas?” The continuation of the passage is well known: “Et quid tibi eam [*scilicet* infirmitatem] fecit, nisi unique infirmitas? Quis ergo sanat omens languores tuos, nisi qui propitius fit omnibus iniquitatibus tuis?”—Quis ergo sanat omnes languores tuos, nisi qui propitius fit omnibus iniquitatibus tuis?—The thesis according to which the theologian knows the triangle better than the geometer is akin to another, that in a sense, theology treats everything “quantum ad aliquas relationes quas habent omnia ad Deum,” *Reportata Parisiensia*, prologue, question 3, *quaestiuncula* 5, number 18 [KR 1-A, p. 71, lines 124–25; *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 88, number 251].

9

The Will

Two forces dominate the realm of being and divide its empire: nature and will. In the realm of nature, everything is permanence, stability, and necessity. In the domain of will, everything is life, becoming, movement, and contingency. Yet, they are not two juxtaposed forces and still less are they opposed by irreducible antagonism. One of them comes from the other, and remarkably, freedom is born from nature in the unique case of divine being, but they are distinguished in everything else.[1]

What is a natural motion? It is every motion that precedes an act of the will, and there is no intermediary. "Every act preceding the act of the will is merely natural" *Omnis actus praecedens actum voluntatis est mere naturalis*. Or again: "The will's motion is non-natural in the highest degree." *Maxime motio voluntatis est non naturalis*.[2] It is impossible that a voluntary motion should be absolutely first. The absolutely first motion can only be natural because, from its tending toward an object, every voluntary motion supposes at least another motion, the completely natural motion of the object that moves the intellect. Consequently, if a motion exists that presupposes no other, it can only be a natural motion. Lastly, if we ask what can be this object, it will be necessary to reply that it can only be infinite, finite, or an infinite object that includes something finite. The finite presupposes the infinite, and not at all the reverse. Accordingly, it is impossible that the first of all natural motions has a finite object or one mixed with the finite. The first

of all natural motions can only have as its object the infinite pure and simple, *simpliciter infinitum*.

For the present, let us suppose that by applying the distinction to God we improperly extend the term *motion*, *motio*. We will obtain the following consequences:

The first mover, the absolutely first source of any motion, is the divine essence. Since God's essence is the first object of his intellect, the motion that is absolutely first of all is the natural motion of the divine intellect by its first effect. What is the effect of this motion? Since it is natural, it infallibly exerts its effect upon the mobile. Accordingly, we will necessarily have a Person, the principle of an immanent operation that consists in knowing his own essence by perfect, eternal knowledge and in engendering it as Word. This production is not immanent as to its term but, insofar as operation, it is completely immanent. Such is the first purely natural operation, since this generation of the Verb by the Father is an *actio mere naturalis*, and its term is absolutely the first, because it is infinite. If we remember that to exercise an act of intellection is to say, to speak, we can conclude that "the absolutely first motion consists of evoking the intellection of the Father's intelligence, and that the second motion is to engender the Word."[3] To exercise an act of intellection and to express it in a Word (*intelligere et dicere*) are both purely natural motions, which precede all others. If there is some element of *voluntarism* in Duns Scotus, it cannot be in God, and if we think that in Scotus's doctrine it is contradictory for a movement to be absolutely first, we even ask whether this voluntarism could exist. The wisest thing is not to consider it.[4]

Only then does the will intervene with a posterity of nature. Since the voluntary is opposed to the natural, this new motion is not exercised in the manner of a nature. Like the intellect's motion, it is dual. Where the intellect understands, *intelligit*, the will loves, *amat*. To the Word expressed by the Father's intellect corresponds the Love that proceeds from both divine persons. Still, in this unique case, we do not emerge from necessity. As was said in regard to the problem of the Ideas, divine intellection immediately

extends to the totality of intelligibles and the infinity of their necessary relations, but it stops there, precisely because the truth of contingents presupposes a voluntary, free choice, without which no propositions dealing with contingents can be true.[5] However voluntary it is, the procession of the Holy Spirit, who is love, is equally necessary, but its necessity results from a supremely free act, which it simply follows. What makes an act fail to be free is not that it is necessary, but the fact that it is necessary in virtue of constraint exercised from outside. Nature exercises such constraint. This is why an act of nature is never free. But even a necessary action remains free when its necessity flows from a will irrevocably fixed on its object. Someone voluntarily hurls himself from the top of a tower. He falls necessarily with the necessity of natural weight. Yet, if he continues to fall voluntarily while he falls, he just as freely wills his fall. Likewise, although God necessarily lives with the life natural to him, and although this necessity of living excludes all freedom, he fully wills to live this life. Accordingly, there is no diminution of freedom in the necessity of the love with which God eternally lives this necessary life.[6] The perfection of the infinite essence is such that God's infinite will cannot fail to love it freely. What is necessary in this act results from its freedom.[7]

Duns Scotus's whole theology is marked by this key thesis, that the first free act found in all being is an act of love. By the demonstration of God's existence we already know that the first is will. We could also establish this by proving that he is blessed, because there is no beatitude without an act of the will. Finally, we could prove it by showing that he is a productive cause, because we know only two principles of production and action, *nature* and *will*, "because between these modes of producing, there is no intermediate mode," *quia inter modos istos producendi non est aliquis modus medius*. If there is will in God, it can only be as the principle of the desire of a good and consequently, of a free act that is an act of love. Produced by an infinite will, the love of an infinite good is necessarily proportionate to its object, necessarily infinite itself. But we should not forget the dialectic of identity that Aristotle did not know, because it does not apply to creature: in the

infinite, even what is formally distinct is really identical by virtue of its very infinity. This mode of predication is applied only to God.[8] But it applies to him always. The infinite love of the divine essence offered by God's infinite intellect to his infinite will is the divine life itself.[9] Accordingly, by the very fact that God is formally will, he is essentially love: *Deus caritas est.*

Humans are in a completely different situation. As finite beings, their will is not identical to their essence and in this life only encounters finite goods. This is why the will's decisions are free, like every act proceeding from the will, and not even necessary. Their nature needs to be analyzed.

A The cause of willing

The will is the peculiarly human form of appetition. In a general way, the appetite, *appetitus* is the faculty of the soul that exercises the act of moving itself by tending toward an object to be acquired. Accordingly, it is the cause of a moment tending to obtain an end. In the hierarchy of beings, appetition begins before the soul does. Material nature already tends toward the term of its act, as heavy bodies tend toward the earth's center, their natural resting place. However, since they do not know that they do so, we can only speak of appetition in a metaphorical sense. Even if we admit that the heavy inherently moves toward the center, it does not prove any desire to do so or any conscious inclination to reach it. When it finally is there, it does not enjoy it. Saying that iron attracted by a magnet rests when it reaches the magnet is a metaphor. We see there nothing that resembles conscious enjoyment of a freely pursued and felicitously achieved end. There is no perfect appetite without some freedom.[10]

The sensitive appetite does not satisfy this last condition. Still, this time we are dealing with an *appetitus* properly so-called: first, because there is knowledge of the end and conscious desire to attain it; second, because in the case of humans, who are rational beings, the appetite can obey the authority of reason, and without itself being rational or free, indirectly participate in the order of rational knowledge and freedom.[11] However, intrinsically, the

appetite's act naturally and necessarily follows the act of sensitive knowledge, because there is nothing in appetite that might turn it away.[12] Two important consequences follow: *Qua* active but natural power, the sensitive appetite is inherently and entirely determined by the knowledge of its object. It does not lead, it is led. Moreover, because it is a natural faculty, the appetite does not dispose of any means of controlling itself, so that it points toward is object with all its strength.[13]

These two characteristics of *appetitus* must be kept in mind if we are to understand Duns Scotus's peculiar position regarding the problem of will. Ordinarily, will is defined as rational appetite, *appetitus rationalis*.[14]Duns Scotus is not opposed to that, but he only admits the definition with an important reservation that stems from the will's nature. Employing against Thomas Aquinas a phrase from St. Augustine, Duns Scotus declares in principle that will and freedom are identified. Either the will is free, or there is no will.[15] We can say that the will is free by its essence, *liber per essentiam*.[16]

If that is the case, if, in other words, the very essence of the will is to be free, the will must first be defined by freedom rather than by *appetitus*. Obviously, the will is an *appetitus*, but others exist from which it is distinguished precisely by being free. Consequently, in the will, *libertas* is a more formal reason than *appetitus*, and the will is formally will *qua free*, not *qua appetitus*.[17]

This way of defining an essence by its most formal element is connected to Duns Scotus's principles, and it shows where he sees the heart of the problem. The existence of the will implies that a faculty exists that is the ultimate cause of its own determination. From that comes the way in which Scotus formulates his problem: does something other than the will effectively cause the act of willing?[18] Since freedom is the essence of the will, Duns Scotus necessarily is going to maintain the negative, but it is interesting to note that here, as usual, he is going to appeal to Augustine to keep the spontaneity of willing intact. Moreover, in equal circumstances, two humans may act in two different ways. Why is this true, except because they are free?

[19] Besides, what is more in our power than willing? Otherwise, we could not praise, blame, or even warn anyone. Someone so completely inert would have to be excluded from the ranks of humans.[20]

Evidently, no theologian would have disputed this conclusion, but justifying it is another matter. In fact, the way in which some who accept the conclusion justify it amounts to rejecting it. To follow the discussion at all, we must remember that all the doctors of this period admit the coexistence of twin perspectives on the will. In itself, the will is a nature, in which capacity is determined to want the good in general. This is why we see Duns Scotus hold that God's infinite will loves the infinite good that is God with a will both necessary and free. By contrast, considered in relation to its act, the will poses problems about which the masters are divided. Since no particular object is good in general, it is not clear why this faculty would choose to want one good rather than another one. In its turn, the second problem is divided into two: what is it that determines the will to exercise an act of volition and, in exercising it, what determines the will to decide in favor of some particular act? Accordingly, we can ask what moves the will *quantum ad exercitium actus* (in regard to the exercise of the act) or else *quantum ad determinationem actus* (as to the determination of the act). In both cases, we undertake to say what cause determines the will.

One modern professor, *doctor modernus*, maintains that the cause of volition is the phantasm because, since nothing moves itself, the motor and moved must be in two subjects. Since the will is an intellectual appetite, *appetitus intellectivus*, it is impossible to find a subject for it in the intellectual soul different from the soul. Consequently, the motor cause of the will must be sought outside the intellectual soul in sensible knowledge and precisely in the phantasm.[21]

A second, slightly older opinion (*alia est opinio doctoris antiquioris*) agrees with the first in admitting that the will is moved by something other than itself, but this opinion does not invoke the phantasm as motor cause. That something is the known object. The latter moves our sensitive faculties as an efficient cause. Known by the soul, it next moves the will. Therefore, we can

say that the object, insofar as it is known effectively, moves the intellectual appetite, which is the will. Just as the sensitive appetite is moved by the sensible desirable, the intellectual appetite is moved by the intellectual desirable. If it is objected that the known object cannot be cause of volition, because it is not a being and because what is nothing cannot be a cause, the answer will be that the intellect through its intellection causes the volition. Although the abstract quiddity does not exist outside the intellect, it exists in the intellect, and since it is not nothing, it can be a cause.[22]

For the phantasm to be the volition's cause, it would first have to be the intellection's cause, which is impossible. If it were, intellection would have an *equivocal* cause, namely, a cause of an order different from the order of intellection. When a cause of this kind totally produces an effect, the cause is nobler than the effect. Accordingly, it would be necessary to admit that the phantasm by itself is nobler than any intellection or any volition, that is to say, nobler than the happiness that the philosophers taught consists precisely in intellection and volition. We should add that the author of this position contradicts himself, since he starts by requiring that the motor and the moved correspond to different subjects; then he poses the phantasm, insofar as illuminated by the agent intellect, as the motor cause of the will. But in this capacity how could the phantasm be in a subject other than the intellectual soul?[23] As such, the phantasm cannot act on the will, but only on the sensible appetite. Stripped of its sensible characteristics, it is no longer distinguished from the intellect as its subject. In short, the hypothesis is void in every case.

Moreover, positing the phantasm or the object as the cause of the will's act destroys freedom of the will and consequently the will itself. Whatever cause is invoked, if it is extrinsic to the will, the will can only undergo its efficacy passively. In fact, it is not within the power of the patient, as such, to undergo or not undergo the agent's efficacy. As long as the agent is not there or does not move, the patient remains inert. On the other hand, once the agent exercises its action upon the patient, it is no longer in the patient's power not to undergo the action. Therefore, if the agent moves the patient to an act, this act itself will be determined. This is precisely what Duns Scotus opposes in

the name of St. Augustine and St. Anselm and of what he himself holds to be true.[24]

Taking Duns Scotus's criticisms literally, we would have to conclude that he imputes total psychological determinism to his adversaries. But perhaps Duns Scotus would respond here, as he does elsewhere concerning Aristotle and Avicenna, "I am not concerned with their intentions." What Godfrey and Thomas say interests him, along with the consequences that follow from it. It must be admitted that, taking him literally, *ut littera sonat*, Godfrey of Fontaines pushes the determination of will by object as far as possible. It is certain that in his mind, freedom is safeguarded despite this determination. Furthermore, he says so. But it is understandable that Duns Scotus should interpret Godfrey's position as equivalent in fact to pure and simple determinism.[25] The same observation explains his attitude to Thomas Aquinas. Obviously, Thomas does not deny that spontaneity of the will, even less so if it were possible than Godfrey. We would never finish quoting the passages where he affirms it, because if the will *ut natura* is necessarily determined to want good in general, *ut voluntas*, as will, it is undetermined *ad utrumlibet*. In both cases, the will is an *inclinatio* toward its object, a nature that no object can necessarily move as to the exercise of this act, not even as to the determination of its object, unless we are dealing with good in general, its natural end.[26] All that is true, but it is not enough to satisfy Duns Scotus because, even if it is denied that the object moves the will necessarily, it is admitted that the object moves the will. This is Aristotle's doctrine: "the appetitive power is a passive power, whose nature is to be moved by what is apprehended," *potentia enim appetitiva est potentia passiva quae nata est moveri ab apprehenso*. The known desirable is an unmoved mover. The desire is a moved mover.[27] In Duns Scotus's view, the last point is troubling, because the will can only be moved by its object, that is, by something external whose action is exercised upon the will from the outside.[28]

We arrive at the juncture where the two doctrines become irreconcilable, because both want to lead humans to beatitude, but one through knowledge, the primacy of intellection, and freedom based upon rational judgment about

means; the other through love, the primacy of will, and freedom based on the will's radical indetermination. If we designate the overall Thomist position by the term *intellectualism*, we can characterize Duns Scotus's position as *voluntarism*, provided only that, in both cases, the label indicates the emphasis in the doctrine and does not try to suggest that Thomas Aquinas wants to lead humans to God without love or that Duns Scotus wants to do that without the light of intellect.

We see how Duns Scotus's thesis proceeds to justify itself. Initially, it does not rest upon any general principle like the one we ourselves have posed. Scotus's adversaries affirm that to be moved, the will must be moved by its object. To this factual claim, Duns Scotus opposes another fact: if we can explain that the object causes volition, how are we to explain that it causes *nolition*? We are able to want, but also not want, or rather *want that not*. Let us take an example from Augustine: one man succumbs to the sight of feminine beauty and another resists the sight of the same beauty. Does the same object cause two different and even contrary acts? Someone will say it does because one of these men will apprehend it as a good, the other as an evil. Let us admit that. It remains for us to discover how this object, precisely as evil, can cause an act. Evil is the privation of good, which is being. How can a privation be the cause of an act like *nolle*? Since the decision to not want is an act as positive as the act of wanting, it can have no other effective cause than the will.[29] Furthermore, the same goes for *velle*, because if the act of wanting depends on a natural agent like the object, this agent will cause it; since the object will cause it in the manner of a nature, the volition will not be within the will's power. That will entail the elimination of any merit or demerit, which Augustine has already discussed. In truth, there will no longer be will at all.

To avoid this consequence, it is pointed out that since the will can turn the intellect toward a certain object or turn it away at pleasure, the volition ultimately remains within the will's power, except, of course, for the first act, which the object necessarily determines. In other words, an object catches my sight and provokes a first movement of which I am not the master. Since I am

free to fix my mind upon this object or to turn it away, I remain master of my act, because I am master of my object.[30]

Duns Scotus does not deny that the object first acts on us without our contributing anything. Augustine already said that to be touched or not by objects is not in our power. Let us admit that. The problem, however, remains intact. If, after the first impression, I can determine my intellect to fix itself upon this or that object, or not, it will be asked, by virtue of what act?[31] It could not be by virtue of the first, which is not in our power. Accordingly, it must be by another. Where does this other come from? The answer is that the cause can only have the will, the object, or the phantasm. If it comes from the will, we have our conclusion, because this volition is then in the power of the same will that causes it. Not only that but, since the previous movement is caused by the object, it is natural and consequently not voluntary. The act by which the will fixes itself upon the object or turns away from it becomes the first voluntary act from which it follows, to the contrary of what was affirmed, that the first voluntary act is within the power of the will. As to holding that the will fixes itself upon this or that object under the efficacy of the phantasm or of the object, that would make this act purely natural and no longer voluntary. The second act by which we command the intellect to consider this or that object would then be no freer than the first.[32]

Duns Scotus is inspired above all by concern for the nobility of the intellectual soul in general and the will in particular. The soul is obviously a nature, but a spiritual nature. It is an error to speak as if volition and even intellection are acts completely comparable to the act of feeling in animals or the act of heating in fire. We say that two distinct actions presuppose two distinct subjects. This is the case in sensation, for example, where the feeling subject is different from the felt subject. Again, it is the case in heating, where fire is different from the wood that it heats. This is why, in all cases of this kind, nature only exercises its act after having been moved from the outside. But this is not the case of the soul and its will. We should not forget that the will is not *really* distinct from the soul. On the contrary, this noble perfection belongs to the soul in its first act, and in this special case it is

reasonable to admit that the will, which perfects the soul in the first act, can inherently exercise its operation that perfects the soul in the second act without any external cause being required for this effect.[33]

Duns Scotus reacts against the naturalism of philosophers ignorant of the soul's nobility, because they do not know its end, and against theologians who imprudently think they will safeguard the Christian destiny of a soul whose structure is still more or less pagan. There is no question of denying that sensation, and intellectual knowledge play a role in the exercise and determination of the voluntary act. We only want what we know. The point is to maintain that, once the object of the voluntary act is present, the will remains the total cause of volition: *nihil aliud a voluntate est causa totalis volitionis in voluntate*.

We thus better understand the privileges that Duns Scotus acknowledges in the free act. Firstly, volition is free *ad oppositos actus*, to want or reject the same object. As we were saying, that distinguishes it radically from the causality of *natures*. This first freedom permits a second, which is *libertas ad opposita objecta*. The power the will has of exercising two opposite acts in regard to any object allows it to tend toward opposite objects. From that comes the freedom of the will in regard to opposite effects that it can produce. This third freedom is not identified with the first because, if by an impossibility no effect resulted from the opposite acts of volition that the will can exercise, *qua* will it could still tend toward opposite acts. While this third form of freedom is not identified with the first, it flows from it by way of the second, since to choose between opposite acts is to choose between opposite objects, and therefore also to produce opposite effects. So *libertas ad oppositos actus* is the foundation of *libertas ad opposita objecta* and, through the latter, of *libertas ad oppositos effectus*.

Various contingencies accompany this threefold freedom. To begin with, it is possible to exercise opposite acts *successively*, to want after not wanting or the reverse. To do both at once would be contradictory and impossible, but one can do sequentially what cannot be done simultaneously. Therefore, there is a first contingency, which is that of the existence of opposite acts

succeeding each other over time.

Though it is less obvious, the second freedom is no less real. Let us suppose that there is a created will whose existence only lasts for a single instance. Let us further imagine that in the single instant it exercises a determined volition (*hanc volitionem*). It is completely evident that this freedom of choice would be exhausted in this single act, which can be said to fill its whole existence. Yet, the single volition would not be necessary: if the will necessarily exercised this single volition, since it would only cause in this single existent, it would be a necessary cause, and therefore a *nature*, which is the opposite of a will. It is unimportant here that the volition existed or not in a prior instant where it could have willed the contrary. The present instant, the only one in which it exists, is when we must take it. Just as in each prior instant of any duration, a being is either contingent or necessary, so also in the present instant in which a cause exercises its causality, it does so either contingently or necessarily. Since, by hypothesis, we are dealing with a will, it does not cause in a necessary, but a contingent way. Consequently, a will is capable of wanting the contrary of what it wants and of causing the contrary of what it causes at the same time it wants or causes. Obviously, it cannot want or cause contraries simultaneously, but at the same time it wants and causes one, it also retains its essential aptitude to will and cause the other: there is the simultaneous potential of this cause to the opposite of what it causes, *est ergo potentia hujus causae ad oppositum ejus quod causat, sine successione*.

One final illusion is possible, to say that the will remains free because it *could have* chosen the other part. Even at present, while it wants what it wants, its volition retains the radical contingency of the voluntary as such. Accordingly, at the same time the will brings a contingent act into existence, it could exercise the opposite act. It is not contradictory to say that the will that exercises and act, even while it exercises the act, remains capable of producing the opposite act. The will’s intrinsic freedom does not diminished by the fact that it uses it. How could the cause be contingent in relation to its effect if it were contradictory that it should produce the contrary effect? But

if it is not contradictory, it is possible. Our will's freedom *ad oppositos*, therefore, implies the contingency of the opposites, not only successively, but also in the same instant.

Important consequences for the logic of propositions follow from these psychological considerations. They express the contingency of opposite acts.

Take the proposition, "The will that wants A can want other than A." In the composite sense "The will that wants A does not want A" is an absurd and impossible proposition. In the divided sense, taken in the order of succession, the proposition is valid, because the will can want the object at moment A and not want it at B. But even at a given instant the proposition remains true in the divided sense, because, although the will that wants A cannot not want it, this will that wants A is such that it could fail to want it. Even wanting it at moment A, it is capable of not wanting it at moment A. Duns Scotus acknowledges that this distinction is difficult to grasp, *obscurior*, but it has a basis, since in the divided sense, it justifies the possibility of two different affirmative propositions. One says what the will wants at moment A. The other says what it is possible that the will might want at moment A. Both deal with the same moment, but not the same object. They can be true simultaneously and, in fact, they are, because it is true that at the very moment when the will does not want, it can want, and that, while wanting an object, it could want another.[34]

We can ask why Duns Scotus is certain of the irreducible contingency of volition at this point. The answer is simple. Necessity and contingency are irreducible data themselves, disjunctive passions of being, one of which, contingency, even if it is not demonstrable *a priori*, is demonstrable a posteriori. Starting from necessary being, it cannot be proven that there must be contingent being, but it is a fact that there is.[35] There is contingency in things, that is to say, avoidability, because if there were only inevitability, nobody would worry about anything. Still, since the avoidable and the contingent happen, they must have a cause, and not a cause determined to the production of a particular event (otherwise it would be inevitable), but a cause that is undetermined to either of two opposite effects). This cause

cannot determine itself to two opposite effects at the same time, because it would be contradictory. Accordingly, we are left with the cause either being able to determine itself to one of these two or, if it cannot do so, being determined externally. If the cause can determine itself even in a contingent and non-inevitable way, we get our conclusion. If, by contrast, it is determined from the outside, it must be either that this is a contingent and non-inevitable way (i.e., by a will), in which case, we get our conclusion; otherwise, it is determined in a necessary way, in which case the effect would not be contingent.[36] The same argument that obliges a free cause to be situated at the origin of contingency obliges that others be inserted in the web of second causes and their effects. In both cases, they can only be wills.

The debate takes on cosmic scope, and if we are attentive, it reproduces at the limited level of the voluntary act, what had already unfolded in regard to the world's origin and God's freedom *ad extra*. The dialogue between Duns Scotus and Avicenna finds its replica in the dialogue that the Subtle Doctor maintains with the partisans of determination of the will by the intellect. Obviously, we are dealing with Christians this time, none of whom are determinists in the strict sense of the term, but thinkers who, in Duns Scotus's view, jeopardize freedom by submitting it to the understanding's determinism.

Accordingly, we return to the same problem. The divine intellect knows every possible, and does so by necessary, natural knowledge. All future contingents are eternally before its view as eternally necessary alternatives, but they would remain eternally alternatives, if the divine will did not freely raise up some among them by deciding that one of two contradictory events will be brought to pass. *Mutatis mutandis*, the same holds in the case of human actions. We will never explain how contingency could emerge from understanding because, in order to demonstrate to the will that one of the two future *contingents* must necessarily exist, our intellect must use a sophistical argument. In other words, the only determination that can be expected from the intellect in such cases is the result of a paralogism. That is how the comparison with divine freedom clarifies the problem of human freedom.

God at least commits no paralogism. There is no chance that his understanding makes his will believe that one of two future contingents is necessary. Therefore, if we can only count on the divine understanding as the source of contingency, there is none. The same holds in the case of humans. The first reason for contingency is always in the will.[37]

Duns Scotus seems never to have wavered on this point, but we may wonder whether he did not hesitate on the previous one, namely, whether the will is the *total* cause of its act. We do not know of any passage where Duns Scotus revised this position, which moreover seems essential to his doctrine. However, it is perhaps necessary to distinguish two problems, one dealing with the will as such, and the other with volition included in election and even in the total voluntary act. From the first point of view, Duns Scotus never reversed himself. However many conditions we may imagine are required for volition to be possible, once they are possible it is still true that "nothing other than the will can be the total cause of volition in the will, according to how the will freely determines itself to cause the act of wanting."[38] From the second point of view, Duns Scotus has examined two possible responses: the object is the necessary, *sine qua non*, cause of volition or the object is *partial cause* of volition.

In the *Opus Oxoniense*, Duns Scotus attributes the first response to another Master: "And so he posits that intellection is the necessary of volition itself."[39] Even if this answer is true, it is indifferent to Scotus because, since a *sine qua non* cause is not the *causa effectiva* in any way, the will would remain the total effective cause of its own volition. From that point, he maintains that even if knowledge of the object is necessarily *pre-required* for there to be volition, the volition is still not the *effect* of knowledge or of the object in any sense. It depends only on the efficacy of its own causality.[40] In the *Additio Magna*, Duns Scotus wonders what kind of causality to attribute to the understanding in the complex that is the volition of a definite object. It is no longer enough, then, to say that the object and the knowledge we have of it are the *sine qua non* cause of volition. First, the *causa sine qua non* is a fifth kind of cause, unknown to Aristotle, about which we can ask whether it

exists, or rather whether it ought not be reduced to one of the four kinds of causes already known. Next, and above all, integrated into the total act, object and phantasm are more than *sine qua non* causes. They are partial causes that cooperate with the will in the total effect.

It is not clear that by adding this specification Duns Scotus retracts anything. He could never have thought that, even if there were no intellection, volition would be possible. When he explicitly poses the question of deciding between the respective contributions of intellect and will in the production of total acts, Duns Scotus is again in faced with a problem analogous to the one he already had to resolve, when he asked what part is due to the phantasm and what part is due to the intellect in intellection. It would not be necessary to scrutinize the texts closely to come to the conclusion that, at bottom, the problem is the same, which would explain that this is the same solution. There are two coordinated causes, neither of which owes its proper causality to the other in any way, but each of which in its order cooperates in the same effect. The object does not owe its being as known to the will, because it would be known even if there were no will, and where the will exists, the object is not object on account of the will. Likewise, the will does not get its causality from the object, and especially not its freedom, since the will is the principal agent here. Accordingly, we should say that intellect and will cooperate, each according to its proper virtue, to cause the same effect, not as two tugs pull a ship, but rather as father and mother cooperate in the birth of a child. Both are active causes. Moreover, neither has its proper causality of itself. Both contribute to the production of the effect, but one does so as the principal active cause, and it is the will.[41]

The last point is crucial, because the proper causality Duns Scotus reserves for the will, even in this division of roles, is precisely the freedom that makes the will the total cause of its whole volition. There are many partial causes of the effect, if we wish to analyze all of them: the known object (present in itself or through its species), the intellection by which the intellect knows the object, the intellect that exercises the intellection, and lastly the will capable of wanting and also exercising its act. All this is total cause of volition:

“Rather than all that cooperating with the will to cause the act of willing, the act is no less freely caused because it is within the will’s power to act or not act. If it acts, the others are obliged to cooperate. If it does not act, the others do not act.”[42] Accordingly, Duns Scotus does not concede or retract anything on the only point he takes seriously. Free at its root, the whole action is free: *tota actio est libera*. That is exactly what Scotus proposes to demonstrate.

We get tangled up in this doctrine and even risk getting lost if we forget the concern to distinguish formal orders that always inspires the Subtle Doctor. Within a complex act like election, the intellect does its proper task,[43] which is to present the object, just as the will does its task, which is to want or refuse the object. Consequently, we can describe the intellect’s whole work in detail, show that it conceives, judges, compares, deliberates, and add that, if it did not, there would be no volition, because the will would have nothing to want. Ultimately, though, only the will wants, and the decision ultimately springs from it alone. Duns Scotus goes as far as possible in this direction, because he maintains the indetermination of willing in the presence of any object. “From the fact that the will is perfectly free, it does not follow that it plunges itself with all its strength into its object. On the contrary, whatever the force with which the will tends toward its object, it has still more force to dominate itself. Regardless of the object toward which the will tends, it does so freely and by virtue of its absolute freedom it could refrain from tending toward it in this way.”[44] Even the angels did not all tend toward good with all their strength, nor conversely did they all embrace evil completely, with all their strength.[45] Even the blessed, in the beatific vision remain free to want God in the sense that they want him freely. It is true that the root of freedom is intrinsic to the will or rather coincides with it, but we cannot clarify this point completely without positing the question of fruition.

B The term of the voluntary act

A conclusion emerges from these analyses. When Duns Scotus does not attack a question rigorously, the reason is that another question interests him.

Not only does the voluntary decision ultimately depend only on the will, but also in whatever complexity the will involves it, the will always dominates. Duns Scotus refers to it with a kind of speculative affection: *tam nobilis causa*. When present, the will informs everything, directs everything, and qualifies everything. Duns Scotus acknowledges a primacy of the will precisely in the order of excellence.

Here is an excellent opportunity to recover Duns Scotus's view about Thomas Aquinas and behind him the philosophers by whom Aquinas the theologian is inspired. According to St. Thomas Aquinas, the intellect is a passive power,[46] and nevertheless he considers it superior to the will. It is surprising for Duns Scotus that Thomas puts the intellect before the will, because the mover goes before the movable, and the agent before the patient.[47] We are not going to search for how Thomas Aquinas reestablishes the equilibrium in his fashion by other paths.[48] Rather, let us look with Duns Scotus's eyes at a claim that he finds disconcerting: "If intellect and will are considered in themselves, the intellect is found to be more eminent." Again: "Therefore, since the proper reason of the power is according to its order to its object, it follows that the intellect in itself and intrinsically is higher and more noble than the will."[49] Precisely there, we see Duns Scotus immediately react with vigor for *theologian's* reasons. St. Paul in 1 Cor. 13:13 teaches that charity is the greatest of faith, hope, and charity. Charity resides in the will. Justice and injustice, sin and grace are certainly in the will. Lastly, the will already possesses the objects and enjoys them as it will enjoy God *in Patria*.[50] Unless *fruitio* is specifically different in this life from what it will be in the other, the power of the soul that one day must grasp the highest good is the most noble of all, and it is the will.

Enjoyment of its object (*fruitio*) is the form of the voluntary act. Considered in a general way, this *fruitio* can be applied to any object, good or bad. Some delight in good, others in bad. There are even those who sink into the supreme perversity so often denounced by St. Augustine of enjoying what should only be used and using what should not be enjoyed.[51] In this sense, the will is not determined to any particular act, and its choice is entirely free.

The same does not hold for ordered enjoyment, *fruitio ordinata*, which unlike enjoyment in general, *fruitio in communi*, is restricted to the conditions required or the moral act's rectitude. Accordingly, enjoyment or fruition that is called *ordered* is that which intends to be morally right. There is only one object that can be said to be the object of fruition for itself and in itself. It is the last end, which is God.

This is not Avicenna's opinion. He seems to think that for a finite subject, whose capacity of enjoyment is finite, a finite object suffices to give perfect enjoyment and consequently to fulfill it. In that case, fruition can be ordered without thereby attaining the last end. At least this is what a famous passage in Avicenna's metaphysics implies,[52] stating that the higher intelligence produces the lower intelligence by its intellection. If we admit the thirty-fifth proposition of Proclus in *Elementatio Theologica*, "Everything rational returns to that from which it proceeds," it is clear that once produced, the lower intelligence must return toward the higher intelligence and, by this complete return to its origin, find perfect joy in perfect rest.

Duns Scotus objects that the conclusion does not agree with another principle admitted by Avicenna himself: that the intellect's object is being in general.[53] In the case of a Separated Intelligence, perfect enjoyment can only be enjoyment of intellection. Since to satisfy an intellect capable of all being, all being is necessary, nothing can satisfy a Separated Intelligence except the supreme and absolutely perfect Being. We should add, in a general way, that a power that tends toward multiple objects can only find perfect satisfaction in one of them if it includes all the beings toward which the power can tend. There is only one in which all beings are eminently included: Infinite Being. Consequently, in it alone, a power of the soul can find the supreme calming of its desire. At bottom, Duns Scotus intends to deny philosophers the right to assign humans any other last end than the *ens infinitum* of *our* theology.[54] "The ordered fruition has only the last end as its object, because just as the First Truth is the only end to which the intellect must consent for its own sake, so also the First Good is the only end to which the will must consent for its own sake."[55] Once more, we are faced with one of those cases where the

theologian, by becoming more aware of the philosophers' proper principles than the philosophers are capable of doing, extends the ideal line that encounters the truth for philosophers.

Comparing these two conclusions, we see that *ordered fruition* represents the case where *common fruition* is what it ought to be, or at least tends toward where it ought to tend. In this sense, we can say that the object of fruition in general (*fruitio communis*) is nothing but the last end, whether the authentic or a false last end that erroneous reason presents to the will, or even a last end arbitrarily chosen by the will using its freedom. The first two cases are clear. As for the third, it is explained by the will's radical indetermination, because just as the will can want or not want, it can exercise its act in the manner it pleases. We are dealing with the act's *mode* in that case. Accordingly, from this point of view, it is within the will's power to decide that it wants a certain good for itself without relating it to another, to want it as an end.

This does not imply that the will enjoys its object *qua* end. The will enjoys its object insofar as it is *good*, because it is end only as good. For the good, being an end is a relation of reason, and it is not clear that such a relation could be the object of fruition. Consequently, even *fruitio ordinata* cannot be directed toward the Supreme Good insofar as the Supreme Good is its end, but insofar as it is the good itself. As for *fruitio communis*, the conclusion is the same. If apprehension of the object presents it as desirable, its appearance as good makes it be taken for an end. If the will decides to assign the object to itself as end, the object chosen has the reason of end only in consequence of the voluntary decision.[56] In all cases, fruition tends to the enjoyable, *fruibile*, as such, not to the relation of end in which the *fruibile* stands in regard to the will.

But what is it to *enjoy* an object? It is an act of a perfect will, which consists in wanting a good *for itself*.[57] Enjoying, therefore, is distinguished from using an object (*uti*), an imperfect act of the will that consists in wanting a good with a view to another. The same distinction is found again in the order of the intellect that can assert to a true proposition whether for itself, if it is a

principle, or on account of another, if it is a consequence that is accepted by reason of a principle. Similarly, the will can want a good for itself, with an act that we call perfect because it finds its total reason for being in its object, or it can want a good because of and with a view to something else, an act we call imperfect because the will finds neither its end nor repose in the object.[58]

Despite this parallelism, we should note two differences between the assent of intellect and that of will. First, there is the distinction of objects that determines the distinction of acts in the intellect, while the distinction of two free acts determines the distinction of objects in the case of the will. What the intellect sees is either a principle or a consequence. If it is a principle, the intellect consents to it by reason of its evidence. If it is a consequence, the intellect has no other choice than to consent to it by reason of the principle's evidence. In the case of the will, by contrast, since it is always free to act differently from the way it does act, it is always in its power to enjoy an object or to use it, to want it either for itself or in relation to another end. Consequently, there are no longer distinct objects corresponding to distinct acts, because the will can always want any object in the manner it pleases.

The second difference is subtler. In the case of the intellect, the two modes of assent that we have distinguished cover all possible causes. One can only accept a truth as a principle or as a consequence. There is no possible intermediate between the two ways of assent. By contrast, in the case of the will, an intermediate position is possible; we can either enjoy a good or use it or do neither and still want it. These *neutral* acts happen and they are not necessarily disordered. The will can be faced with an object that the intellect presents to it under an aspect that is absolute in some way, neither as an intrinsically desirable good nor as a good desirable for something else, but purely and simply as a desirable good. In the presence of a good of this kind, the will wants it *absolutely*, so to speak, neither for itself nor for another, without enjoying it as an end in itself (*frui*) nor using it as a means (*uti*): "there can be some act of willing that absolutely, without relation to another, or without enjoyment account of itself"; *potest habere aliquem actum volendi illud absolute, absque relatione ad aliud, aut absque fruitione propter se*.

Moreover, the will can command the intellect to inform itself about the object in order to tell the will how it is appropriate to want the object. After this, the will, according to its choice, can either *use* or *enjoy* it. Duns Scotus concludes that the whole reason for this difference is, on the one hand, freedom on the will's part and, on the other hand, natural necessity on the intellect's part: "And the whole reason of the difference here is, therefore, freedom of the will and natural necessity on the intellect's side."[59]

We might think that, with these magisterial determinations, the voluntary act's term is completely defined. That would be to fail to know Duns Scotus. In regard to the will's term, it remains for him to settle a problem that its cause already presented. Without exaggeration we can say that of all the questions that the will poses to Scotus, none interests him more. Once the will apprehends its end, the problem of knowing whether it is necessary that the will should want to enjoy it corresponds to the problem of knowing whether another total cause of volition exists besides the will itself. It is easy to anticipate Duns Scotus's answer, and it leads us once more to the great separation of orders that divides his whole doctrine: even when the intellect grasps an end, it is not necessitated to want it, because natural necessity and will exclude each other *Necessitas naturalis non stat cum libertate*.

However, let us distinguish different cases. We might be dealing with the will apprehended obscurely and in general. Some claim that the will cannot fail to consent to it because, just as the intellect necessarily asserts to the speculative first principles, so also the will must necessarily consent to the last end in the practical order. They add that, since the will only wants any particular good as it participates in the last end, it must want this end necessarily. In other words, if the will does not want the good in general necessarily, it would not want any good in particular.[60] But Duns Scotus admits neither these arguments nor their conclusion. First, we already know that we cannot base conclusions about the will on the intellect, the intellect being a nature, the will freedom. Next and above all, our will can only want the end if an intellect conceives it first. It is within the will's power to turn the intellect away from considering the end. In that case, the will can no

longer want it, because the unknown cannot be wanted, so it is always within the will's power not to want the end.[61] Accordingly, the will no more wants necessarily the end confusedly grasped under the aspect of good in general than it necessarily fixes upon the means ordered to this end in order to enjoy it.

The same reason holds for all other conceivable cases. The will is not more necessitated to enjoy the last end as obscurely apprehended in the particular. This conclusion is even more remarkable, but exactly in the general line of Scotus's doctrine. He judges that in the presence of the last end clearly seen and when the will is elevated by charity, it is not necessitated to want it. For things to be otherwise, the will would have to change its nature. Before being swept up to heaven, Paul had or could have had the same charity as during his rapture. He had the same will, capable of producing the same free act and of fixing himself upon the good to enjoy it. Nothing changed, at least in what concerns Paul. Consequently, he is under no more necessity to want the last end clearly seen than he had been to produce any act. During his rapture, Paul was free.[62]

It would have been difficult to suggest a purer metaphysical position because it is clear that, by pushing a little further on, we end in the conclusion that even in the beatific vision, the *vision* does not necessarily cause *fruition*. Vision naturally precedes fruition, and since the two acts are two absolute natures, there is no contradiction in the first existing without the second. There can be vision without fruition, which amounts to saying that one does not necessarily cause the other.[63] There can be little doubt about the impact of this conclusion. Duns Scotus intends to maintain that even in the presence of the Supreme Good, the act by which the will enjoys the Supreme Good remains *its* own act and springs from it as its source. There is no question of denying the divine cooperation required for such an act to be possible, but considering the will *ex parte sua* and in itself, once placed in the state of wanting, it is certainly the will that wants. It cannot do so without charity, but the charity does not act for it. This is why, pushing on to the extreme limit of his thesis, Duns Scotus affirms that the will is intrinsically capable of

enjoying the Supreme Good, even without being elevated by a supernatural habit, *habitus*. We should not be scandalized, because this only holds always for the will considered *ex parte sua*, for its part. From this precise point of view the consequence is inevitable; we can also convince ourselves of this by trying to imagine the contrary. Let us suppose that the will, *ex naturalibus suis*, by its natural powers could not exercise any act regarding the last end clearly seen. By what device can we explain that God himself could make it capable of exercising such an act? If the will is not naturally capable of that, it is not capable at all, and nothing will ever make it become capable. Not even charity, which is neither the will nor part of the will.[64] By maintaining that the will that is not supernaturally elevated can enjoy that end (*quod voluntas non elevata supernaturaliter potest frui illo fine*), Duns Scotus does not intend to say that the will could raise itself to the beatific vision by its natural powers alone. (In fact, the whole prologue to the *Opus Oxoniense* refutes this kind of interpretation.) But he certainly thinks that unless the will changes nature at the moment of enjoying the Supreme Good, it must be capable of wanting the Supreme Good itself. Is not the natural will identical to the nature of the will, that is, the will itself? Accordingly, if the will itself is not capable of enjoying the Supreme Good, nothing will ever make it enjoy the Supreme Good.

Therefore, it is understandable that Duns Scotus situates the final term of Beatitude in voluntary fruition rather than intellection. He has to do so. Since the human will is nobler than the intellect, Duns Scotus must make humans attain God by that which is most noble in them. Moreover, we cannot doubt that the will is what is most noble in humans, because that which is most perfect is that whose corruption is worst. Corruption of the intellect is only a natural evil, not a moral one, while corruption of the will is sin itself.[65] As we have already stated at length, only the will moves itself. Consequently, the will can turn toward the intelligibles that transcend humans, while the intellect is subject to the action of those things that move it and can only undergo them.[66] Therefore, beatitude must be said to reside essentially and formally in the act of the will, the only way humans can absolutely and

uniquely attain the Supreme Good in order to enjoy it.[67]

We are far removed from the *philosophers* here and yet at the heart of our subject. Nature, necessity, and intellect go together, and their logical coronation is speculative beatitude founded upon the primacy of wisdom. By revealing to humans the primacy of charity, Christianity opens a world to them that is no longer the *philosophers*' world. Duns Scotus will grant a great deal to Aristotle and even to Avicenna, but yields nothing about the one thing necessary, *unum necessarium*. Between wisdom and charity, *sapientia* and *caritas*, certain theologians award the prize to wisdom, and that is why they regard the intellect as more noble than the will. Furthermore, they appeal to Aristotle in this. "But another philosopher of ours, namely Paul, argues the opposite, saying that charity is more excellent."[68] That is what settles and at the same time explains the spirit of Scotism, because from the primacy of charity over vision flows the primacy of will over intellect and of freedom over finite nature, and therefore also the rejection of the *philosophers'* necessitarianism. It is objected that the doctrine contradicts Aristotle, and in effect, we could search in vain in the Philosopher for the idea that the will exceeds the intellect in dignity, "since the will is of greater capacity absolutely speaking, here and hereafter," *quia majoris capacitatis simpliciter est voluntas quam intellectus, hic et in patria*. But does this really contradict Aristotle? We should rather say that Aristotle never thinks about these problems. He never specifically distinguishes the principles of intellectual operation from the principles of voluntary operation, to such an extent that he sometimes seems to confuse them. In fact, Aristotle speaks more often of intellection than volition, because the intellect's act is more manifest than the will's. But we cannot conclude anything from his silence. Instructed by St. Paul, how could Christians be mistaken about the importance of the power of the soul in which charity, the source of our beatitude, takes root? "The Saints and our Doctors in fact searched beyond this."[69] What characterizes the theologians is not refuting the philosopher, but going beyond him.

C Will and morality

From the point of view of their morality, voluntary acts are divided into good, bad, and indifferent. Their moral goodness is distinguished from natural goodness, which is different. The natural goodness of a voluntary act belongs to it inherently, precisely insofar as it is a positive being. Volition is one of them, and like all that is, volition possesses a degree of goodness equal to its degree of being. As for the act's moral goodness, it is divided into three, according to whether it belongs to the act *qua* moral act in general, virtuous act, and meritorious act. For example, to give alms is a moral act. To do it with one's own money to a poor person in need, in an appropriate situation, and for the love of God is a virtuous act. To do the same thing not only by natural inclination, as would have been the case in the state of innocence and as an unrepentant sinner can still do it, but for that charity that transforms the charitable person into a friend of God is a meritorious act, acceptable to God.[70]

Let us take up the first two members of this division separately. Considered in a general way (that is to say, in what gives the voluntary act its *moral* character), the act owes being *morally good* to the fact that it involves an object proposed as suitable by a right judgment of reason. Here the issue is something other than the act's natural goodness, like the goodness of vision as such, and even other than the natural goodness of the object, as we say that light is good for sight. Rather, the issue is the act's goodness precisely as moral. It is the first moral goodness, *prima bonitas moralis*, the basis of all the others in each of which it is included. Accordingly, we can say that volition is moral, generally speaking insofar as it involves an object judged suitable by reason.[71]

At the level of morality, judgment and rational knowledge regain the role that Duns Scotus denies them at the level of voluntary freedom properly speaking. The will always draws its freedom from itself and itself alone, but if the judgment of reason is not what makes this act a volition, it is what makes it a moral act. Consequently, there is no reason to see the slightest retraction in what Duns Scotus attributes to the intellect's influence in moral matters. The formal distinction of orders prevents our situating the proper

cause of volition other than in the will, but we can regard that point as established. Now the issue is different. The peculiarly moral order begins at the moment when the intellect's judgment offers an object of the will.

We see that still better by examining what gives the moral act its virtuous character.[72] The virtuous act could be described as a *circumstantiated* act. The word means, firstly, that its relation to a single term, such as the end, cannot define the act's morality, for example. Morality stems from what more accurately would be called a coincidence, adding, however, that in the case of the moral act this coincidence is not fortuitous. On the contrary, an act's morality consists in its free decision to satisfy all the conditions required by the practical judgment of reason. This means that the moral act's *goodness* is extremely complex. This is true for goodness, as it is for the beauty of a body, made of height, form, color, and proportion. If we were dealing with the beauty of a face, we would have to add expression.[73] Dionysius says in chapter four of *De Divinis Nominibus*: "Goodness is from a perfect and integral cause," *Bonum est ex perfecta et causa integra*. The act's natural goodness, as being, we should recall, is not in question. If all the required circumstances for the act to be morally good are absent, it can be naturally good *qua* act, but it is perfectly bad *qua* moral act. To be naturally good, it is enough that an act fulfills all the conditions necessary for its perfection under the different relations to its efficient cause, its object, its end, and its form. To be morally good, it is necessary that an act should also satisfy all the conditions required by right reason. First, in regard to its efficient cause, which must be a free will, since there is not good or bad and therefore no morality without freedom. Next in regard to the object, because the act is morally good only when it involves an object approved by right reason. Thirdly, in regard to the end, because although the end alone is not enough to constitute the act's whole good, it qualifies it completely.[74] Fourthly, it is necessary to take the act's form into account, that is to say that it is done as reason says it must be. Finally, we should add other more external circumstances, such a time, place, and others of the same kind. Taken together, those elements form a sort of integral cause of the moral good. All

are required, says Duns Scotus, that there may be goodness, *ut bonitas sit*.[75]

The object that the judgment of reason proposes to the will is found at the center of this complex. We cannot insist enough on this point if we want to avoid breaking the doctrine's equilibrium. The first circumstance is that the act belongs to a free will. Otherwise, all morality would be impossible. But, since all voluntary acts are free, the bad as well as the good, freedom cannot be what qualifies some of them as good or bad or even as morally indifferent. The intellect alone can distinguish among objects and judge them, so much so that even Duns Scotus, who jealously safeguards the will's autonomy in order to guarantee the act's freedom, immediately requires agreement of the will with the intellect's judgment in order to confer the act's *moral* character on it. This is why Duns Scotus, every time he encounters a problem of this kind, proceeds to two complementary operations to show that the circumstances that qualify an act morally are not its *cause*, and to prove that the real cause of the act does not suffice to describe its *morality*. *Bonitas moralis* is added to the voluntary act's substance as beauty is added to the body's substance. However, it is certainly free choice's deference to reason (however *circumstantiated* it may be in relation to the volition's being) that makes moral good appear and with it the whole order of morality. Therefore, if we wanted to label this doctrine, at least two labels would have to be used for the single order of human acts. Even if the doctrine is *voluntarism* in regard to volition, it is *intellectualism* in regard to establishing the voluntary act as *moral*. An act's moral goodness is not its *active* principle. The moral goodness of a virtuous *habitus* is not at all the efficient cause of the voluntary acts that result from the *habitus*. Inversely, the voluntary act's substance is not what confers its peculiarly moral goodness on it, but its relation of conformity to right reason: "The correspondence of the act to write reason is what makes the act good . . . therefore, principally the conformity of the act to right reason fully dictating all the suitable conditions of that act is the act's moral goodness."[76]

We will have to ask what the principles are in whose name the intellect itself categorizes objects or, if we prefer, what is the basis of rectitude in

recta ratio. But the problem is only posed in the clear case in which the act is either morally good or morally bad. Many acts exist that can be called morally indifferent, that is to say acts that deserve no moral qualification, good or bad. The complexity of circumstances required for the act's goodness is such that, if one of them is missing, the act that could be morally good is not. For example, someone sees a beggar and automatically gives him money. The act is certainly not bad, but is it good? Giving money to someone poor without even asking to what end one does it is doing something that could be moral but that lacks the circumstances required for the morality of an act.[77] We are not yet in the order where rectitude of reason enters to establish morality.

Moreover, in this dialogue the will does not present itself as a bare power, reduced to the simple ability to consent or refuse. The will is equipped with those habits, *habitus* that are called virtues and are so many stable dispositions by which it conforms itself to the intellect's moral judgment, just as their opposites, the vices, are stable positions not to conform itself so. In a doctrine where the will is inherently determined to the known good, it would be absurd to situate the moral virtues in the will as their subject. In that case, they would be placed rather in the sensitive appetite, where the will's natural inclination to good clashes with resistance.[78] By contrast, Duns Scotus insists on situating the moral virtues in the will as their subject, and we can easily see why. Undetermined by essence, the will (as Duns Scotus conceives it) can always refuse, in what concerns itself, to follow the judgment of reason. Consequently, it is appropriate that the virtuous *habitus* be added to it, not in order to determine it to act or to cause the substance of its act, but to make it easier for it to delight in the accomplishment of good.

This is exactly the point at which virtue intervenes. Before the right judgment of prudence, the will is always free to determine itself and, precisely insofar as voluntary and therefore free, the judgment will ultimately remain the total cause of its act. But, precisely as will, it is not the total cause of choosing its act with equal ease and equal pleasure. If it were, it would be enough for reason to propose the opposite for the will to choose as easily and

with the same pleasure. That is not the case. Therefore, the virtues certainly must be located in the will in order to explain how it happens that the will can ally itself with the counsels of prudence more or less easily, to the point of no longer finding pleasure anywhere but there.[79] Perhaps someone will say that, since delectation resides in the sensitive appetite, virtue also does. That would not be correct, because we do not say that virtue consists in the habit of choosing what is most pleasant, but in taking pleasure in choosing what reason prescribes. Virtue is a stable disposition that the will can acquire by the repeated exercise of acts that conform to right reason and that, since the will is their free cause, reinforces the will's natural inclination toward the good without ever necessitating it.[80] Accordingly, we can say that in Duns Scotus's position, the radical freedom enjoyed by the will in the exercise and determination of its act calls forth a corresponding doctrine that situates virtue in the will to incline it toward the suitable determination. The question is not posed in regard to natural agents, whose nature suffices to determine their acts. However, in the case of a free agent, which is inherently undetermined to choose one or the other of two parts, it must gradually acquire greater inclination to choose well, that is acquire the kind of *habitus* that is a virtue thanks to the exercise of certain acts.[81]

Accordingly, we come back to reason's judgment as the source of morality, but this also poses problems. We talk about *recta ratio*. In what does its rectitude consist? If right reason judges the will morally in order for it to be *right*, does reason itself not need a judge of its rectitude? If there is one, what is it?

Aristotle is not a sure guide here, because he takes the state of fallen nature for the state of nature itself. Consequently, he considers the present rebellion of the flesh to be natural[82] and the natural law of reason to be sufficient to overcome this revolt. We are no longer in that ignorance, because God has promulgated his law. In the theologian's vision, this is something unquestionable, but Duns Scotus also knows that a natural law of reason exists and that, however much sin clouds it, it is not completely erased. The difficulty is to find out what remains of it, especially because we may wonder

in what measure Duns Scotus is really concerned with it. After all, for a theologian teaching in 1300, the problem had lost its relevance long ago. The living question is salvation. If Duns Scotus takes care to note that morally indifferent acts exist, perhaps it is because many morally good acts from the standpoint of simple ethics are effectively indifferent as to *merit*. Let us go further. Even in the Christian's world, where humans are creatures, they would have to be held to the will of God in everything they do. God himself does not ask so much. He leaves humans free in many respects. In fact, God simply requires that humans observe the precepts of the Decalogue. This seems difficult enough to humans, but it is not impossible.[83] In any case, it is very little in comparison with what God could ask of us.

This is also the point of view from which we must view what Duns Scotus says about the moral law. He is often reproached, sometimes bitterly, for subjecting morality to the whim of the divine will. The accusation would be valid if we were dealing with his thinking on what we call natural ethics, but Scotus himself is thinking about the laws that it pleased God to promulgate as necessary and sufficient conditions of our salvation. On this point, God is entirely free. It depends only on him to demand more or less, or something else. All that the theologian can look for is what, within the whole Decalogue, coincides with the natural law of conscience and what is added to it. Duns Scotus does this in terms that resolutely clarify his general attitude toward what is usually called *natural ethics*. Still, to understand him, it is necessary to interpret his replies in function of the problem he poses.

The intellect knows first principles in the practical order just as it knows first principles in the speculative order. They are known of themselves, *per se nota*. Their evidence springs directly from knowledge of their terms and can no more be reduced to principles of speculative knowledge than the latter can be reduced to principles of practical knowledge. Therefore, their truth is necessary, and God himself cannot make what they prescribe become bad or what they forbid become good. These first principles and their necessary consequences constitute what is called natural law. Knowledge of them and of their consequences falls under conscience,[84] which resides in the intellect.

Consequently, *qua* conscience, the intellect orders the will, without ever diminishing its freedom. The intellect cannot show any good in this life such that the will might not fail to want it, nor consequently any bad such that the will might not fail to want it. This is precisely why conscience does not reside in the will but in the intellect, because the intellect cannot withhold its assent to the first principles or to the necessary conclusions that flow from them, while the will can also fail to consent to what these conclusions or these principles prescribe for it. As the necessary rule for contingent volitions, conscience is necessarily distinct from them.

It is true that the will itself as nature, *ut natura*, in other words as appetite alone, *ut tantum appetitus*, necessarily wants good in general. In this capacity, it simply follows a natural inclination, and we can say that it does not lead; it is led. However, considered as free choice, which includes intellect and will, the will is free, because it is always within its power to tend toward this or that particular object, or to reject what the intellect presents to it. It might be difficult for the will to reject the good in particular that it wants in general, but it is always possible, as we see in the virtuous person and in the saint who freely deny themselves the enjoyments of many goods and choose to want certain others. Inversely, the bad person refuses to want what his conscience tells him to want. *Qua* conscience, the intellect then maintains the practical rules or their necessary conclusions. In this sense, it accuses, judges, condemns, or even, if we can use the expression, murmurs, because by maintaining its judgment against the rebel will, the intellect provokes the will to murmur.[85] Free choice's decision, therefore, presupposes the practical conscience.[86] There remains the question of the nature of the precepts that this conscience prescribes for the will.

Those precepts all derive from the general principle that good must be wanted and evil rejected. But the great difficulty for the intellect is to know in each case what is good, less good, or best, and what is bad, less bad, or worst. Naturally, such judgments depend on the nature of the subject that makes them, our human nature: what is good or evil for beings like humans? However, these judgments also depend on the nature of things: given what an

object is, should humans want it or reject it? To this remark we should append the well-known passages where Duns Scotus affirms that good and evil depend on God's will.

Insofar as our judgments are modeled on the natures of things, the manner in which God created these natures is one of the bases of natural law. *De potentia absoluta*, by his power absolutely speaking, God could want everything that does not imply contradiction. Speaking by his ordinate power, *de potentia ordinata*, God can only want what agrees with the natures he has chosen to create and with the rules of his justice or his wisdom as he has established those rules. His will is not what makes natures be what they are, but his will has freely chosen which ones would be created from an infinity of possible essences. If God had created other essences, there would still be good and evil, but it would not be the same. If God's will had established other natural laws or God's justice had established other moral laws that were in agreement with the essences created by him or with those he could have created in their stead, there would be another natural or moral order, no less just and wise than the one we know, and yet different. So, Duns Scotus simultaneously teaches that there can be no irrational arbitrariness in God's works, but that the choice (not the essence) of each rational order depends on his will. This is the sense in which we must understand Scotus's declarations concerning good and evil that seem to subject them to the whim of the divine will. Accordingly, the natural law must be understood in this sense. There is a natural law inscribed in the very essence of things; it is absolute starting from them, and precisely for this reason it is relative to the choice God made about the natures he wanted to create. Once we presuppose this original conditional character, another condition is added: God can always want, *de potentia ordinata*, anything that is not incompossible with the natures he created and the order he established.[87]

That said, it is difficult to enumerate the principles or conclusions that fall under natural law in Duns Scotus. What are these first practical principles known by their terms or the conclusions that necessarily follow from them, *prima principia practica, nota ex terminis, vel conclusiones necessario*

sequentes ex eis, which belong to the natural law in the strict sense (*et haec dicuntur esse strictissime de lege naturae*)? We are unable to establish that, but Duns Scotus's interpretation of the commandments of God sheds some light on the whole disputed question. The problem becomes to discover which mandates of moral conscience are those that God himself said bind humans in achieving their salvation. It is understandable why Duns Scotus's discussion concerns the Decalogue above all. The deduction of consequences necessarily included in the principles of natural law would be the work of philosophers. But God may have refrained from obligating humans to everything strictly belonging to natural law and, inversely, he may have obligated humans by some commandments that do not strictly belong to natural law. That to which God, in fact, binds humans is just what must capture the theologian's attention. To the contrary of what Thomas Aquinas teaches, Duns Scotus maintains several times that God dispensed certain commandments of the *Decalogue*.[88] Therefore, Scotus concludes, these commandments cannot strictly belong to the natural law. Accordingly, the two doctors agree that God himself could never dispense us from observing the natural law, but Thomas Aquinas concludes that, despite appearances, God never dispenses anyone, while Duns Scotus concludes that certain commandments of the Decalogue are not part of the natural law, because God dispensed from some of them on occasion.

The very essence of the natural law makes this second conclusion necessary. Evident propositions, known to be true by virtue of their own terms like their consequences, are true intrinsically and prior to any act of the will. If all commandments of the Decalogue, or practical propositions that flow from it, belonged to natural law, God's will itself could not fail to consent to these commandments as they are grasped by his intellect. God could not prescribe that any human should either take another's goods or kill his neighbor. He often does that. Consequently, the commandments of the Decalogue do not belong to the natural law. Nothing shows better how imprudent it is to designate a doctrine by a label. Duns Scotus is often called *voluntarist*, because he subjects part of the Decalogue to God's will and for

that reason part of the natural moral law. In fact, Duns Scotus refuses to include in the natural law that from which God has often dispensed humans, precisely because the natural moral law depends on God's understanding alone, not his will. In the strict sense, what belongs to the natural law are precepts whose truth is apprehended by the divine intellect before any act of God's will. The quarrel between Scotists and Thomists can only deal with what *in fact* is included in the natural law. As for the concept of this law, it is no less intellectualist in Duns Scotus than in Thomas Aquinas. Duns Scotus does not waste time arguing about words. We are speaking about *natural law* here in the strict sense of the expression: *prima principia practica nota ex terminis, vel conclusiones necessario sequentes ex eis*. If we want to extend the expression to all rules of action that agree or harmonize with the first principles or the necessary consequences, it will be necessary to say that all God's commandments without exception belong to the natural law. The area of the reasonable is always broader than that of strict rational necessity. Nearly all possible laws are simple reasonable dispositions, but not necessary. This is why what a legislator establishes, he or another can revoke. All God's commandments belong to the natural law in the second sense, which is the broad sense. That all should belong in the strict sense is another question.

Duns Scotus's reflection on the content of the Decalogue is guided by a constant, general rule: a commandment belongs to the natural law when a necessary relation connects the good it prescribes to the good of the last end. A prohibition belongs to the natural law when the evil it forbids is intrinsically incompatible with the good of the last end.[89] Therefore, the point is to found out which among God's commandments are those that prescribe acts necessary to attain the last end and those whose relation to the end is such that the divine legislator could sometimes dispense from them.

The first two commandments of the first table of the law are "Thou shalt not have strange Gods before me" and "Thou shalt not take the name of thy God in vain." Do they belong to strict natural law? Yes, because humans cannot attain their last end, which is the Supreme Good, without loving it. If

there is a God, we must love him. That is the rule of rules, which simply derives from the most general of all the practical applications of the natural law: do good and avoid evil. From this comes a series of necessary consequences: we must love good; we must love God; we must worship God alone; we must not fail to respect God. God himself cannot dispense us from these commandments or permit any to violate them.[90]

The third commandment of the first table is positive: “Remember to keep holy the Sabbath day.” It is divided into two parts. The first, it is necessary to worship God, belongs to the natural law. The other, this worship will be given on a certain day of the week, belongs to the positive laws. All prescriptions regarding the manner in which this worship will be done, for example, abstention from servile work on the Lord’s Day, likewise belong to the positive law. However, let us specify that we can ask whether it does not belong to natural law that a certain day (whatever it is) is set for the exercise of certain worship. If the obligation to actually worship God at some particular time does not strictly speaking belong to the natural law, God, absolutely speaking, could dispense from it, so much so that a person could spend his whole life without exercising a single act of adoration toward God. This option is hardly likely, because we cannot want the end without wanting what is necessarily related to it. If it does not belong to natural law that humans should worship God either on Saturday or Sunday or any other day, humans are not obliged to do so at all, because when we are not bound to an act at any determined time, we are not bound at all. To say that humans are bound torender some worship to God, while adding that they are not bound to it at any precise moment, would amount to saying that nothing ever obliges them to do so. But is it not contradictory that humans must love their last end and that they might never exercise any act to obtain it. However we answer, it is certain that the obligation to worship God belongs to strict natural law. It is probable that the obligation to do this worship on a fixed day also belongs to the natural law. It is certain that the election of the day belongs to positive law. Lastly, if we doubt these conclusions, we would still say that the third commandment at least belongs to the natural law in the broad sense, like

those of the second table.[91]

Against this last thesis Duns Scotus recurs to the formidable authority of St. Paul, Rom. 13:19: "*Thou shalt not commit adultery. Thou shalt not kill. Thou shalt not steal. Thou shalt not covet*; and if there is any other commandment, it is summed up in this saying, *Thou shall love thy neighbor as thyself*." Someone who loves his neighbor fulfills the whole Law. The whole Law and Prophets are contained in that (Mt. 22:40). But we know that love of neighbor necessarily follows this other commandment: *Thou shall love the Lord thy God* (Mt. 22:37). Since all the commandments of the second table necessarily follow from the first commandment of the first table, which belongs to the natural law, all the commandments of the second table belong to the natural law in the strict sense.[92]

It is absolutely certain that one who loves his neighbor has fulfilled the Law. But this must be understood in the sense that he who loves his neighbor has fulfilled the law as the Legislator said it ought to be observed when he explained it by the commandments of the second table. It does not follow that these commandments necessarily flow from the first commandment, *Thou shall love the Lord thy God*. As we have said, this commandment belongs to the natural law in the strict sense, but here we need to specify in what sense. It is in the sense that the opposite could not be either prescribed by God or permitted by him or consequently be good. This amounts to saying that the first commandment taken strictly forbids us to hate God. Accordingly, in its negative sense, it belongs to the natural law. As for finding out whether it also belongs in the positive sense, it is not certain. In regard to the third commandment, we noted that it does not evidently belong to the natural law that humans must love God at this or that determined time. "To refrain from hating belongs strictly to the natural law, but on occasion, it is to be doubted whether to love falls within the third commandment."[93] What follows necessarily from this commandment taken in the negative sense? For each of us, loving our neighbor is wanting that our neighbor should love God. This necessarily follows from the first commandment taken in the positive sense, but does not necessarily follow from its negative sense. Let us add that it

would be contradictory to desire that the common good was only loved by a single person, but it is not contradictory to want this or that person not to love it. The proof is that in predestining this person and not that one, God certainly wants the predestined person's good, without wanting the other's good. Lastly, even if it were of strict natural law that we ought to love our neighbor and want him to love God, the commandments of the second table do not necessarily follow from that. Indeed, I can want my neighbor to love God without wanting him to keep on living or wanting him to maintain marital fidelity, and so on. Even if I love God and I want my neighbor to love him as I love him myself, it does not follow necessarily that I want for him the goods that the commandments of the second table bid me to want for him. Consequently, what is the meaning of St. Paul's statement? It is that God understands love of neighbor beyond what strictly follows from the principles of the natural law properly speaking, so that we are now bound not only to want him to love God but bound to want all the goods for him that he will possess if we abstain from murder, adultery, theft, and all the misdeeds that God forbids us to make him undergo.[94]

Always careful to define what revelation adds to natural law, as he was at the beginning of his Prologue, Duns Scotus intends to situate our love of neighbor within the limits it would have if God had not extended them. It is not *contradictory* to want to love God without wanting to love a particular person, because no human is in a necessary relation of means to end in regard to God. It is not even *contradictory* (although now it is impossible in fact) to love God and hate one's neighbor.[95] Nor is it *contradictory* that I should want my neighbor to love God without wanting him to abstain from murder robbery, or adultery. It is not contradictory that I should love God without wanting anyone to be protected from the wrongs that the second table forbids inflicting on him.[96] So, the commandments of the second table do not belong to the natural law.[97] Furthermore, this is why Scripture records so many cases where God himself suspends the laws he had promulgated. He never does so without a reason, but since he does so, we must conclude that the morally rational goes beyond the morally necessary, and this is all that Duns Scotus

wants to demonstrate.

It is easy to see what dialectical battles took place around such passages. For some commentators Duns Scotus's God is a despot who can dispense us from the moral at his pleasure without consulting anything but his will. But, first of all, this despot's will is love. Next, he does not dispense us of the moral law as such at his pleasure. Completely to the contrary, Duns Scotus always specifies that no command of God can go against the just principles of practical reason or against their necessary consequences. For example, in the case of marriage, he even adds that God sometimes parallels the precept of natural law with a commandment, because at stake was a consequence so remote from the principle that human legislators risk not discerning it.[98] The arbitrariness for which Duns Scotus's God is sometimes reproached is not exercised at the level of natural morality, but on that of supernatural merit. Since everything is gratuitous here, everything is free. This is why the Decalogue primarily defines which commandments God prescribes for humans as necessary conditions of their salvation. Theologies different from that of Duns Scotus are possible, and in them the Decalogue becomes a simple confirmation or promulgation of the precepts of the natural moral law. From this point of view, Duns Scotus sometimes leaves the impression of an oriental despot who lends God his own tastes, but this is not Duns Scotus's point of view. He surely would ask whether it is not we who end by believing that we have promulgated the Decalogue and that the philosophers' commandments dispense us from God's commandments. The meticulous dissection to which Scotus subjects God's commandments has exactly the object of making it clear how much difficulty natural reason, reduced to its own resources, would have in discovering God's commandments. The Prologue of the *Opus Oxoniense* continues: the point is to confirm the necessity of revelation.

Other interpreters insist on the opposite. All that Duns Scotus wants to do, they assure us, is to show that the precepts of the second table are not as necessary as those of the first.[99] Perhaps that is to say too little. The same scholars who propose this interpretation would certainly admit, because they

know Duns Scotus admirably, that the two tables are equally necessary in the order of merit, which is the order of salvation. Therefore they want to say that between the commandments of the two tables, at bottom there is only a difference of degree in the orders of natural necessity, and here the difficulty is to keep from denying what is true in this idea without emphasizing it to the detriment of a still more important Scotist truth.

From the outset of our investigation, we have seen Duns Scotus in a completely apologetic approach present precepts, counsels of perfection, and even sacraments as a kind of explication of the natural law: “once as an explanation of the natural law, which according to the Apostle is written in our hearts,” *quasi quondam explicatio legis naturae quae, secundum Apostolum scripta est in cordibus nostris*. In the same sense, we have seen him insist indefatigably on the harmony between God’s commandments and the requirements of natural law. Can we be surprised? Did we expect that, after giving us a moral conscience, Duns Scotus’s God imposes commands upon us without relation to our conscience or even opposed to it? In any case, Duns Scotus never thought so. On the contrary, we perceive him full of admiration for the astonishing harmony of nature and grace, of moral conscience and the Decalogue, of practical reason and revelation. In the face of this spectacle, taking the natural law with all it includes or all that is in harmony with it, Duns Scotus makes all of the commandments of the Decalogue enter into it: “since their rightness is very much in keeping with the first natural principles known necessarily,” *quia eorum rectitudo valde consonat primis principiis practicis necessario notis*. But is it necessary to conclude that the commandments of the second table are simply less absolutely necessary for Scotus than those of the first table? That is another question.

To admit that, it would be necessary to suppose that Duns Scotus admitted degrees of necessity in deduction. This is not what he does. When he observes that the sacrament of marriage consecrates a contract of natural law, Duns Scotus does not claim that the contract’s natural character was not intrinsically necessary, but that such a chain of consequences was required to

make its necessity apparent, that the Supreme Legislator wanted to promulgate it. In the most frequent cases by far, where commandments, counsels, and sacraments are in harmony with the natural law, it is not enough to say that the necessity is less; there is no necessity at all.

Duns Scotus sees an example that makes this fairly clear.[100] Let us suppose this principle of positive law: *one must love peace within the community of the body politic*. From that it does not necessarily follow: *therefore everyone must possess property distinct from his neighbor's property*. Peace could subsist in common life, even if all goods were common. This consequence is not necessary, even if we take into account the weakness of nature in humans living together. Nevertheless, weak humans are more careful of their own material goods than of those that are common, because they would rather appropriate common goods than leave them to the community and its guardians, from which controversy and trouble arise. In this way, in almost every legal system, although it includes a principle that could serve to be the basis of other laws or other rights, the positive laws do not simply flow from this principle, but they clarify it and develop it in regard to certain details. These developments agree marvelously with the universal natural principle.

Who does not see that here Duns Scotus speaks about something different from a lesser necessity? In his mind, the point is to have an art of attaining a certain goal by choosing more appropriate means, although they are not always absolutely the best. Duns Scotus has read the Acts of the Apostles. He knows that community of property is not incompatible with the social order. This Friar Minor himself lives in a community that, as poor it is, does not lack what is necessary without anyone possessing anything as his own. What would make Scotus believe that from the principle, *pace is necessary for life in common*, we can deduce with any degree of rigor the consequence, *therefore private property is necessary*? Since not all religious are heroes of spiritual life, Duns Scotus knows that even the weak can live in peace without any private property. From the principle in question, it is impossible to deduce necessity of either the community of goods or private property. Both solutions are possible, although the second obviously agrees better with

the weakness of the laity and the first with the state of perfection in which religious live.

That, it seems, is what Duns Scotus means, *mutatis mutandis*, when he speaks of the harmony of divine and natural laws. The Supreme Legislator works less as a keen logical jurist than as the Father of the city he created in order to lead it to its highest end. What moves him is neither the despotism of will nor the mechanism of deduction, but the vigilance of charity that knows how to adapt means to ends. In this order, and provided precisely that no necessity is violated, everything is possible. When the logically necessary inferences are safeguarded once and for all, we can say that, *logically speaking*, everything is equally possible, absolutely everything, even the Incarnation.

Perhaps the difficulty we feel in trying to follow Duns Scotus here stems in part from our reducing the problem to two elements, when there are at least three. Scotus thinks that not all the commandments of the Decalogue are deduced in the mode of rational necessity. If this is the case, he certainly also thinks that their promulgation by God is free. But it would be a mistake to conclude that in Scotus's mind, the promulgation is arbitrary. The only object God wants necessarily is God. The only good that must necessarily be wanted by humans with moral necessity is consequently God. Outside the supreme and absolute desirable, *volibile*, there is no other. What contradicts this volition is absolutely evil in itself, but since in relation to the absolute good all the rest is contingent, the will for that *rest* in God's vision cannot be more necessary in itself than its existence is in relation to the infinity of the divine essence. The necessity of wanting something other than God can, therefore, only be conditional and hypothetical, *ex hypothesis*.

This however does not imply that the necessity is irrational, because God is intelligence with a priority of nature, even before he is will. Everything that is not contradictory is possible for God. For Duns Scotus, we are not in Leibniz's world that is subject to the choice of the supreme Algebraist by virtue of the principle of sufficient reason. Whatever it might have been, the world would have been good, because its creator is perfect. Accordingly,

what he created is good. Although it cannot be deduced from the divine essence with any natural necessity, whether logical or mathematical, the intellect unhesitatingly discerns what, in fact, was the end that the creator freely proposed. Through love, God produced intellectual creatures from nothing, creatures for this reason capable of all being and even of God himself. To say *intellect* is to say. Therefore, these intellectual creatures are naturally endowed with first principles inseparable from reason, and it would contradict the end freely chosen by God if his commandments contradicted the natural law. It is even certain that in a world created by perfect wisdom, there must be an intimate relation, a profound harmony, between this law and the commandments. In this sense, all God's commandments belong to the natural law. The only question is to find out whether the whole Decalogue is included in the natural law as an immediate or mediate consequence of the first practical principles of reason, telling the will what it must necessarily want or not want in view of the Supreme Good.[101]

Duns Scotus does not think so for the simple reason that, if it were so included, God himself could not dispense any of his precepts, as we see that he has done. Theology about *divina* grounds moral theology here. In the hypothesis in which either the principles of the Decalogue or practical propositions like *Thou shalt not kill* and *Thou shalt not steal* were necessary with natural necessity, the divine intellect would grasp them as necessarily true. God's will could never dispense us from them, because it would be necessitated to want them. In fact this is not the case, and in principle it cannot be the case: "It would be to posit that his will is determined with strict necessity about some desirable things different from himself, the opposite of which is said in the first [book] where it is established that the divine will only tends contingently to things other than God."[102] Duns Scotus could not go further in the metaphysical justification of his ethics. Admitting that the finite good of the commandments is connected to the Sovereign Good by a necessary relation would be to say that the divine intellect knows it as necessary before any act of the divine will, and therefore that the divine will would necessarily have to want it and consequently have to create it. The

consequence's absurdity is evident and enough to settle the matter, but we still do not find ourselves in the presence of an authority whose capricious despotism would be unjustifiable. Everything God commands is good, because it is he who prescribes it as the suitable manner for the end he has chosen. If God dispenses us from what he has commanded, it is not that what he commanded fails to be good, but that what he substitutes is better *hic et nunc* in view of same end. In short, all the Decalogue's commandments belong to the natural law in the broad sense, and every infraction against any one among them violates this law inscribed by God in our hearts.[103] The first two commandments alone are necessarily linked to the only necessary thing: "No act is generically good by its object alone except loving God, which is the love of an object desirable of itself and of the infinite good."[104] The others are not linked necessarily, but they are linked in fact by divine wisdom, which is the exact opposite of arbitrariness. The radical convergence of all finite good in relation to the infinite good can admit no exception or no doctrine where not only nature but the whole supernatural order and the order of grace had been made necessary. By crowning his work with another doctrine of the moral law, at the last moment Duns Scotus concedes the victory to the necessitarianism of the philosophers, which he has always fought.

Notes

1 In the broad sense, *nature* is taken as extending to everything that is. In this sense, even the will is a nature, and if it is found to want an object necessarily, it wants it by *natural* necessity. Such is the case of God himself, who, being perfect, cannot fail to will something; he cannot fail to will the Sovereign Good and so on.—By contrast, in the strict sense, *natura* and *libertas* are opposed as the first two divisions of the efficient cause. Duns Scotus understands them in this sense here, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 13 [AW, pp. 327–29].—Cf. Aristotle, *Physics*, book II, chapter 5, 196 b 18–22, which in Duns Scotus's mind is similar to Augustine, *De Civitate Dei*, book V, chapter 9. Chance (*fortuna*) is what happens without the intervention of either nature or will. Catholics attribute it to Providence in fact, *Quodlibet* XXI, numbers 3 and 8 [AW, pp. 470–71 and 477].—On the *vital* character of the voluntary act, see *Quodlbet* XVI, number 18 [AW, pp. 386–87].

2 Scotus, *In Metaphysicam*, book IX, question 15, number 4 [EW II. p. 608, number 22]: "Iste autem modus eliciendi operationem propriam non potest esse in genera nisi duplex. Aut enim potentia ex se est determinata ad agendum ita quod, quantum est ex se, non potest non agere quando non impeditur ab extrinseco; aut non est ex se determinata, sed potest agere hunc actum vel oppositum

actum, agere etiam vel non agere. Prima potentia communiter dicitur natura, secunda dicitur voluntas. Unde prima divisio principiorum activorum est in naturam et voluntatem." Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book IX, question 15, number 6 [EW I, pp. 611–12]. In this sense *In Metaphysicam*, book IX, question 15, number 8 [EW II, p. 614, number 43], "Voluntas est principium activum distinctum contra totum genus principiorum activorum quae non sunt voluntas, per oppositum modum agendi." This distinction, which is emphatic to the point of being an opposition, does not prevent the first motion necessarily belonging to a nature, not to a will. *Quodlibet* XIV, number 14 [AW, p. 329, has *first*, i.e., *prima* instead of *propria*]: "Motio omnino propria in entibus est necessario naturalis, quia omni motionis voluntatis est alia praesupposita. Et si aliqua motio in entibus est non naturalis, maxima motio voluntatis est non naturalis."

3 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 14 [AW, pp. 329–30]: "Primum motivum motione naturali est essentia divina, ut est primum objectum intellectus sui . . .; motio omnino prima est elicere, vel quasi elicere intellectionem in intelligentia paterna, et huic proxima est gignere Verbum."

4 It is difficult to believe that Catholic as well as Protestant theologians have spread the legend that has circulated at least since Ferdinand Christian Baur, *Die christliche Lehre von der Dreieinigkeit und Menschwerdung Gottes* (Tübingen: C. F. Oslander 1842), vol. II, pp. 642–56 (reproduced Hildesheim and New York: Olms, 2005). Baur makes Duns Scotus hold that the essence of God, absolute spirit, is not thought as Thomas Aquinas taught, but absolute will, the pure arbitrary. A list of authors in favor of this opinion is found in Parthenius Minges, O.F.M., *Der Gottesbegriff des Duns Scotus auf seinen angeblich Exzessiven Indeterminismus* (Vienna: Verlag von Mayer, 1907), pp. 1–4. One of the most charming opinions is that of Vacant: "Scotus, therefore, will not say with St. Thomas that God is because he must be, following the understanding he has of himself. Scotus would say that God must be because he wills to be," *Compte rendu du IV*e *Congrès scientifique international des Catholiques tenu à Fribourg*, third section (Freiburg, 1898), p. 642. This is to slight both St. Thomas and Duns Scotus at once. Fr. Minges has definitively refuted this error, which we can certainly call inexplicable, since we are dealing with a theology whose very foundation is the absolute primacy of essence in God. Let us recall a single text, which suffices, *Quodlibet* I, number 3 [AW, p. 8]: "Recte ergo in divinis, in comparatione ad essentiam tamquam ad entitatem simpliciter primam et absolutam, consideratur omnis ordo cujuscumque sive quorumcumque, quae in divinis sunt." After that, it is difficult to explain that as noteworthy a historian as Reinhold Seeburg could write, "Duns hat Gott als den absoluten geistigen Willen verstanden," *Die Theologie de J. Duns Scotus*, p. 654.

5 The first intelligible, Duns Scotus says, *Quodlibet* XIV, number 16 [AW, p. 331]: "Naturaliter movet et per consequens necessario ad cognitionem cujuscumque quod est possibile naturaliter et necessario cognosci; hujusmodi est quodcumque objectum simplex, et etiam quodcumque complexum verum necessarium; non autem tale est aliquod complexum de existentia contingentis, quia non est natum esse determinatum ad veritatem."—Let us recall that contingent motion occurs according to the following order: First, the divine will determines itself *ad intra* to will one of the two parts of a contingent alternative. Second, "ex hoc intellectus videns istam determinationem voluntatis infallibilem, novit hoc esse futurum." Third and lastly, the *motio ad extra* follows. Since it depends on the free divine choice, it is completely contingent and immediately dependent on the will as its principle, *Quodlibet* XIV, 16 [AW, pp. 331–32]. Moreover this is the profound reason that our knowledge of God, if its cause is not the nature of things, cannot be caused by God's nature, but only by his will. *Quodlibet* XIV, number 16 [AW, p. 332]: "Nullum igitur intellectum creatum movet essentia [*scilicet*, divina] tanquam motivum per modum naturae, sed omnem intellectionem illius essentiae, quam non causat aliquid creatum, causat immediate voluntas divina."—God's will alone can make his necessary essence known to our contingent intellect.

Quodlibet XIV, number 17 [AW, p. 332]: “Essentia divina est motiva immediate sui intellectus, sed non intellectus creati, quia intellectus divinus est primum mobile omnino, et ideo primo movetur a prima forma motiva, et nihil aliud est immediate mobile a prima forma motiva.” From there comes the necessity of revelation as the point of departure of the theologian’s work. The gap that runs between God’s essence and humans is there, drawn by God’s free will.—On the overall problem of the will, see Joaquin Carreras y Artau, *Ensayo sobre el voluntarismo de J. Duns Scot*, Girona: Tipografía Carreras, 1923. Parthenius Minges, “Ist Duns Skotus Indeterminist?” in *Beiträge sur Geschichte der Philosophie des Mittelalters*, vol. IV, Münster im Westphalia, 1905.

6 Scotus, *Quodlibet* XVI, number 18 [AW, p. 387].—Cf. *Quodlibet* XVI, number 2 [AW, p. 370]: “In actu voluntatis divinae est necessitas simpliciter, et hoc tam in actu diligendi se, quam in actu spirandi amorem procedentem, scilicet Spiritum Sanctum.”

7 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 10, sole question, number 11, vol. I, p. 686 [CE IV, pp. 359–61]. See number 4, p. 681 [CE IV, pp. 333–34]. This act’s naturalness does not prevent its freedom: “Hoc enim esset omnino contra ipsam libertatem, sed potius ut sit consecutiva et annexa libertati.” Cf. *Quodlibet*, XVI, number 8 [AW, pp. 377–79].

8 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 8, question 5, number 6: “Respondeo quod praedicatio per identitatem non habet locum in creaturis. Unde et Philosophus non determinavit de hujusmodi praedicatione, sed tantum habet locum in divinis, et ratio hujus patet ex praecedenti quaestione, quia enim in divinis, facta abstractione, remanet identititas propositionis in praedicando abstractum de abstracto, dicendo sic: sapientia est bonitas.” (Seems to be *Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 369, number 127, but only the first eight and last three words are the same.)

9 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 10, sole question, number 1, vol. I, p. 679 [CE IV, p. 340]. God’s power, connected to the infinity of his essence, is the principle in another and necessarily second order, because it is a power of execution.

10 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 22, and book I, distinction 1, question 5, number 6, vol. I, pp. 171–72 [Probably CE II, pp. 120–24].

11 Reason cannot even *persuade* the sensitive appetite, because only a free being can be persuaded. But reason can command the sensitive appetite, and the appetite can obey. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 33, number 13.

12 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 18, question 3, number 11: “Actus appetitus sensitivi sequitur naturaliter et necessario actum sensus apprehensivum, quia non habet appetitus sensitivus aliquid unde impediatur quia feratur concorditer in apprehensum per sensum et conveniens.”

13 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 29, sole question, number 3, vol. II, p. 739 [CE VIII, p. 309]: “Naturale est unicuique appetitui ferri in suum appetibile et si est appetitus non liber, naturale est ei summe ferre quantum potest.”

14 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 17, question 2, number 3: “Dico quod communiter voluntas accipitur pro appetitu cum ratione.” Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 19 for *appetitus intellectivus*. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 33, sole question, number 9, for *appetitus rationalis*.

15 Augustine, *Enchiridion*, chapter 105, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, column 282: “Neque enim culpanda veritas . . .” This is quoted in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 10, question 2 number 3. (*Reportatio 1-A* I, p. 36 does not include the quoted words, and remits to *Enchiridion*, chapters 73 and 80. Footnote 14 remits rather to chapter 28, number 105.)

16 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 17, question 3, number 5, vol. I, p. 798 [CE V, p. 169].

17 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 16, vol. II, p. 695 [CE has no book II, distinction 25]: “Hoc non bene capio . . .”

18 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 1, vol. II, p. 685 [CE has no book II, distinction 25]; *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 1. Cf. the interesting *additio magna* published by Balić, *Les Commentaires de Jean Duns Scot*, pp. 265–301.

19 Augustine, *De Civitate Dei*, book XII, chapter 6, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLI, column 354: “Si enim aliqui duo aequaliter affecti animo et corpore videant unius corporis pulchritudinem . . .” The passage is quoted in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 3. It is quoted in Opus Oxoniense, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 2, vol. II, p. 686 [CE has no book II, distinction 25], and in the *Additio Magna*, p. 266.

20 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 2, vol. II, p. 686. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.] We do not say that Augustine exclusively inspires Duns Scotus here, but principally in the spirit of his doctrine.

21 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 3, vol. II, p. 687. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 5, vol. II, pp. 688–89. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.] *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, numbers 9–18, meticulously refutes the same doctrine, Cavellus has no hesitation about its author. He is Godfrey of Fontaines. We would not dare contradict that, since our author knew the theologians of his time better than we do. However, the *phantasma* does not play this role in the texts of Godfrey that we have read, for example, *Quodlibet* I, question 7, pp. 18–21, *Les quatre premiers Quodlibets de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Maurice de Wulf and Auguste Pelzer, which seems to us to be the place to talk about the issue.

23 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 6, vol. II, p. 689 [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]

24 St. Augustine, *Retractationes*, book I, chapter 22, 3, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XXXII, column 620: “nihil tam in potestate quam ipsa voluntas est.” Quoted in Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 2, vol. II, p. 686 [CE has no book II, distinction 25], where Duns Scotus also cites St. Anselm, *De Conceptu Virginali*, chapters 4 and 8.—The same passage from Augustine in quoted in *Quodlibet* XVI, number 4 [AW, p. 373].

25 Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* VI, question 11, p. 220: “Et sic oportet ponere quod, cum potentia ad actum determinetur per objectum, voluntas direct et in omni actu suo determinatur ab intellectu, id est ab objecto apprehenso prius ab intellectu, ut dictum est, et quod absque derogatione libertatis voluntatis non potest velle nisi secundum quod apprehendit et judicat intellectus.”

26 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 82 article 1, body of article and reply to objection 2.—The will moves itself, insofar as it inclines toward its end. Cf. *Summa Theologiae*, Ia IIae, question 9, article 3, body of article.

27 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 80, article 2, body of article.

28 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 9, article 4, body of article: “Repondeo dicendum quod secundum quod voluntas movetur ab objecto, manifestum est quod moveri potest ab aliquo exteriori; sed eo modo quo movetur ad exercitium actus, adhuc necesse est ponere voluntatem ab aliquo principio exteriori moveri.”

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 5, vol. II, p. 689. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]—*Additio Magna*, p. 266, ties this argument closely to Augustine’s

authority cited above: “Contra Augustinus XIII *De Civitate D*ei, capitulo 6: Si duo sint aequaliter affecti anima et corpore, unde est quod unus cadit et alius non? Dicit quod hoc solum est a voluntate; igitur, etc. Ex hoc potest sic argui: objectum apprehensum apud intellectum utriusque est idem et passa sunt eodem disposita, ut ponit Augustinus, ut voluntas et appetitus sensitivus; igitur aequaliter agit objectum apprehensum in voluntatem istius sicut illius, et tamen unus cadit peccando et alius non; ergo oportet voluntatem esse causam effectivam volitionis et nihil aliud, quia omnia alia sunt aequalia per positionem Augustini.”—We see the difference between Augustine’s personal experience and the argument that the *Additio* draws from it. Its perfect technical formulation, thanks to the conception of *nolle* as a *positive act*, is common to *Opus Oxoniense* and *Additio Magna*, p. 267: “Sed objectum cognitum est naturale agens; ergo non potest causare velle et nolle in voluntate eodem modo disposita ad recipiendum, qui sunt actus contrarii respectu ejusdem objecti.”

30 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 17, article 5, reply to objection 2: “Et ideo homo imperat sibi ipsi actum voluntatis inquantum est intelligens et volens.”—Ia IIae, question 9, article 4, reply to objection 1: “De ratione voluntatis est quod principium ejus sit intra: sed non oportet quod hoc principium instrinsecum sit primum principium non motum ab alto; unde motus voluntarius, etsi habeat principum proximum intrinsecum, tamen principium primum est ab extra: sicut et primum principium motus naturalis est ab extra, quod scilicet movet naturam.”—Above all, Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* XV, question 2, p. 11, *Le Quodlibet XV et trois questions ordinaires de Godefroid de Fontaines*, ed. Odon Lottin: “Voluntas in primo actu non movetur a se nec quantum ad determinationem actus nec quantum ad exercitium, quia voluntas antequam velit non potest applicare sum objectum sibi nec mediate nec immediate nec impellere vires apprehensivas ad proponendum objectum, sed facta in actu potest movere se ad alios actus quantum ad exercitum ipsius actus, non quidem immediate, sed mediante motione facta in viribus apprehensivis, in quantum facta in actu potest, impellere dictas vires ad considerandum aliquid fugiendum vel prosequendum a quo postea voluntas movetur.”

31 Moreover, Duns Scotus wonders how the will can turn the intellect from one object to another because, since the will itself does not know, it can only turn the intellect toward some object that it already knows. Yet, he maintains this is possible. First, it is a fact. I can pass from the idea of soul to that of stone simply because I want to and without my intellect comparing the two in order to offer the choice to my will. Next, because the perfect intellection of an object is accompanied by many confused and imperfect intellections of other objects; consequently, it is enough for the will to fix itself upon one of them to stop thinking about the others. Cf. *Collationes*, III, 4; *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 42, question 4, number 11, vol. II, p. 888 [CE VIII has a sole question for distinction 42, corresponding to Vivès question 5]. It is like the eye that confusedly perceives the points of a visual field situated around what it sees clearly.—On the overall question, see Philotheus Böhner, “Die Ethik des Erkennens nach Duns Scotus,” *Wissenschaft und Weisheit* II, 1, (1937), pp. 1–17.

32 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 7, vol. II, p. 690. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]—Scotus next mentions a reply (which he considers an evasion) that chance plays a role in the presentation or the first object, or that the will, by acting upon the understanding, can immediately prefer something else to its object, same question, number 8, p. 690. He responds that chance indeed plays a role, but that, if the will yields to the first object, it is not free and that it is no freer if it prefers the second to it. An ox sees grass and sets out to graze. On the way, it encounters water and stops to drink. It is no freer in the second case than in the first. —Cf. Godfrey of Fontaines, *Quodlibet* XV, question 2, p. 11, where a similar hypothesis is sketched; but there must be other passages or another author behind the discussion.

33 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 20, vol. II, p. 699. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.] Here we are dealing with an immanent operation whose principle and term both are the intellectual soul, same question, number 20, p. 700. The observation also holds for intellection.

34 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 15–17, vol. I, pp. 1216–19 [CE VI, pp. 417–420 in appendix].

35 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 39, sole question, article 3, number 13, vol. I, pp. 1214–15 [CE VI, pp. 414–15]. Perhaps this explains why the principle of causality upon which modern Scholasticism insists so strongly is not even mentioned by Duns Scotus or by Thomas Aquinas. For them, being is the first principle, from which the principles of identity and noncontradiction flow. But it is not necessary that every being should have a cause. The proof is that God does not have to have one, and it is not necessary that a being should be a cause. The proof is that God would be identically what he is even if he had not exercised any causality *ad extra*. Since causality is not necessarily linked to being as being, it does not occur to Scotus or Aquinas to make it a first principle. Their thinking works differently. Starting from experience, they use the concept of cause to explain it as long as the datum's nature demands. Since they do not make causality a first principle, nothing prevents them from positing a cause without a cause at the origin of the series of causes. The reproach often directed at their successors of using the principle of causality in order to establish, against this very principle, the existence of an uncaused cause, does not touch Scotus and Aquinas at all.

36 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 22, vol. II, pp. 701–02. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 20.

37 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 23, vol. II, p. 702. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]—*Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 20.

38 The *Additio Magna* published by Carolus Balić explicitly reaffirms this, *Le Commentaires de J. Duns Scot*, p. 299: "Respondeo ergo ad quaestionem, quod nihil aliud a voluntate potest esse totalis causa volitionis in voluntate secundum quod voluntas determinat se libere ad actum volendi causandum."—It should be observed how precise the scope of this operation is. Moreover, it is like *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 18, vol. II, p. 697 [CE has no book II, distinction 25], which raises the question of the cause of the *actum volendi in voluntate*. Duns Scotus would go so far in this direction that he extends the conclusion to causality of nature: "Nam ego semper dicam quod cuicumque combustibili applicetur ignis, si illud comburatur, hoc erit per actionem suam propriam in seipsum necessitate naturali; tamen non sine igne praesente, sicut causa sine qua non solum." In other words, fire is necessary to light wood, but it is certainly the wood that burns. Another conciliatory move has been proposed: Duns Scotus would be satisfied with establishing that, in any case, the intellect is not *totalis causa* of volition. But the text itself says that "nothing other than the will can be its total cause," which is different.

39 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 19, vol. II, p. 698 [CE has no book II, distinction 25]: "Et ita ponit intellectionem esse causam sine qua non ipsius volitionis."

40 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 25, sole question, number 20, pp. 699–700. [CE has no book II, distinction 25.]—Cf. *In Metaphysicam*, book VII, question 18, number 11 [EW II, p. 308, number 69]: "Similiter voluntas nostra nihil agit in objectum, etiam secundum ponentes ipsam activam, sed tantum actione sua intendit in objectum."

41 Scotus, *Additio Magna*, in Balić, *Les Commentaires de J. Duns Scot*, p. 282. Duns Scotus compares the problem to that of intellection, p. 283, when he recalls that he proved that "the intellect receives nothing from the object to cause its intellection, provided that the object is present." Note that in order to be *total*, it is not necessary that the cause suffice by itself to produce the effect. It is enough that, once the required matter is ready and at a suitable distance, the cause suffices by itself to produce its effect. In *Collationes*, III, number 1, Duns Scotus situates our problem precisely, and the point upon which his conclusion bears: "Ergo nullo modo concurrit [*scilicet*, intellectus] dicendo tanquam per se causa respectu electionis, sed vel tanquam occasio et causa sine qua non est electio, quia electio est cum ratione et intellectu." This *Collatio*, like the others, does not resolve the problem it poses. It confines itself to comparing the *sic et non*.

42 Scotus, *Additio Magna* in Balić, *Commentaires*, pp. 282–83.

43 The fact that there is distinction of orders does not keep them from cooperating. This cooperation rather supposes their distinction. Intellectual knowledge is required for there to be volition. Intellection is exclusively an act of the intellect, and it precedes *natura* the volition to which intellect presents the object. Nevertheless, the will can command thought and turn the intellect away from an object to turn it toward another. Duns Scotus analyzes this operation's structure in detail in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 42, question 4, numbers 13–16. Even then, he only admits an indirect action of the will on the intellect: "non quod voluntas causat immediate aliquem actum, vel aliquem gradus actus in intellectu." Then he adds, number 16: "Aliter vero posset dici, quod voluntas habet immediatam actionem super intellectum; sed hoc est difficilius videre."—Cf. *Collationes*, II, number 7, where Duns Scotus argues in favor of the thesis that the will exercises no causality upon any intellection. The will can only turn the intellect to consider another object, but even then the *total* cause of intellection is composed of agent intellect, possible intellect, and of object. The will is not involved at all.—Regarding the will's influence on the intellect, see Philotheus Böhnner, O.F.M., "Die Ethik der Erkennens nach Duns Scotus."

44 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 7, sole question, article 1, number 9, volume II, pp. 412–13 [CE VIII, p. 85]. The basis of this position is established in book I in terms that henceforth must be read in the critical edition, vol. II, p. 66, number 92 [Vivès, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 3]. Duns Scotus now posits two decisive conclusions, CE II, p. 96, number 143 [Vivès, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 15]: "sicut voluntas fruitur non necessario his quae sunt ad finem, sic nec fine obscure apprehenso et in universali." Also, CE II, p. 97, number 145: "dico quod voluntas elevata non necessario *quantum est ex parte sui* fruitur fine sic viso." (The italics are ours.)

45 See Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 7, question 3, number 9, where Scotus argues against the determination of will by understanding in Thomas Aquinas.

46 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 79, article 2, body of article.

47 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 82, article 3, body of article.

48 The intellect moves all the powers of the soul as to the determination of acts. The will moves them all as to the exercise of acts, Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 17, article 1, body of article. Particularly in the practical order, the two positions become quite close. According to St. Thomas, the virtue of religion, which resides in the will, orders the soul's other powers, while *devotion*, which also depends on the will, sweeps along prayer, which stems from the intellect. Here, the intellect is the noblest power of the soul, because it is the one closest to the will, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 83, article 3, reply to objection 1.

49 Summa Theologiae, part I, question 82, article 3, body of article: "Si ergo intellectus et voluntas considerentur secundum se, sic intellectus eminentior invenitur." "Cum ergo propria ratio

potentiae sit secundum ordinem ad objectum, sequitur quod secundum se et simpliciter intellectus sit altior et nobilior voluntate."

50 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 26, sole question, number 4. Cf. Seeburg, *Die Theologie de J. Duns Scotus*, pp. 87–89. (Reproduced Aalen: Scientia Veri, 1971.) Of course, we are dealing with a primacy of dignity in humans. God is not the issue here.

51 Augustine, *De Diversis Quaestionibus LXXXIII*, question 30, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XL, column 19: "Omnis itaque humana perversio est, quod etiam vitium vocatur, fruendis uti velle atque utendis frui." Cited in *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 1, number 2, vol. I, p. 128. [CE II, p. 4, note F. The text of the critical edition reflects this passage but does not transcribe it literally.]

52 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate IX, chapter 4, numbers 104–05.

53 Avicenna, *Metaphysica*, tractate I, chapter 5, number 72.

54 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 1, number 3, vol. I, pp. 128–29 [CE II, pp. 5–7]. Among other arguments, Duns Scotus mentions this one, which some doctors offer against Avicenna. The soul is the image of God and therefore *capable* of God. Cf. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book XIV, chapter 8, 11, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 1044. But this argument does not seem usable against a philosopher: "quia praemissa assumpta de imagine est tantum credita, non naturali ratione cognita." In fact, the *reason* of image is in the soul insofar as it imitates the Trinity. Avicenna, likewise and for the same reason, refuses to argue against the philosophers "quia anima immediate creatur a Deo; igitur in Deo immediate quietatur." Indeed, "hujus antecedens est tantum creditum, et negaretur ab eis, quia ipse [scilicet, Avicenna] ponit eam immediate creari ab ultima intelligentia et infima," *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 1, number 4, vol. I, p. 130 [CE II. pp. 8–9].

55 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, number 5, vol. I, p. 130 [CE II, pp. 9–10].

56 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 1, number 5, vol. I, p. 131 [CE II, pp. 9–10].

57 Augustine, *De Doctrina Christiana*, book IV, chapter 4, 4, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XXXIV, column 30: "Frui enim est amore alicui re inhaerere propter seipsam."

58 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I distinction 1, question 3, number 2, vol. I, p. 150 [CE II, pp. 49–51].—As a perfect act, consent to the good wanted for itself (*fruitio*) is accompanied by pleasure (*delectatio*). *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 3, number 2, vol. I, p. 151 [CE II, p. 51]: "Habemus igitur quantum ad propositum quatuor distincta: actum imperfectum volendi bonum propter aliud, qui vocatur *usus*; et actum perfectum volendi bonum propter se, qui vocatur *fruitio*; et actum *neutrum*; et *delectationem* sequentem actum." In short, there are three types of voluntary acts plus a passion that is added to them. Only one of these acts corresponds to the term *frui*. As for pleasure, certain passages in Augustine seem to identify fruition with pleasure and even reduce it to pleasure, while others include in fruition the act and the pleasure that accompany it. Accordingly, it must either be acknowledged that the term *frui* is equivocal or we must reduce certain passages in Augustine to just one of the two senses by interpreting them, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 3, number 5, vol. I, pp. 152–53 [CE II, pp. 52, where this section is given as canceled].

59 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 1, p. 154 [CE II, p. 60]: "Et tota ratio differentiae hic inde est libertas voluntatis et necessitas naturalis ex parte intellectus." Scotus adds: "Quod probo: quia natura et voluntas sunt principia activa habentia oppositum modum principiandi; ergo cum modo principiandi voluntatis non stat modus principiandi naturae; sed libere voluntas vult finem; ergo non potest necessitate naturali velle finem, nec per consequens

aliquo modo necessario."

60 Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 82, article 1, body of article.

61 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 3, vol. I, p. 157 [CE II, pp. 51–53].—We should recall the following argument based on experience in number 9, p. 157 [Vivès VIII, p. 359; I have not found this in CE II, pp. 78–80]: "Item, omne necessario agens de necessitate agit secundum ultimum suae potentiae, quia sicut non est in potestate ejus actio, ita nec intensio ejus; ergo voluntas de necessitate volet finem intensissime, cujus oppositum experimur."

62 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 13, vol. I, pp. 158–59 [CE II, p. 91].

63 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 14, vol. I, p. 159 [CE II, p. 94].

64 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, question 4, number 15, pp. 160–61 [CE II, p. 96].—Cf. *Collations*, question 15, number 3, which shows that even if the blessed cannot fail to want God clearly seen, they do not want him by virtue of any necessity that does violence to their will. On the contrary, the immutability of wanting would stem from the free act by which the will is fixed upon it immutably contemplated object.

65 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 18. The argument has Thomas Aquinas in mind, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 8, article 3. We do not think we need to enter into the details of this controversy, which is essentially theological. It is enough to indicate Duns Scotus's position insofar as it is connected to his overall doctrine.—Note *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 3: "Et ponit ad hoc duas rationes de quibus miror quod inter eas multa verba miscet, quia alibi sic non facit."

66 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 18.

67 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 20: "Dico igitur ad quaestionem, quod beatitudo simpliciter est essentialiter et formaliter in actu voluntatis, quo simpliciter et solum attingitur bonum optimum, quo perfruatur."—This conclusion, of course, does not exclude the intellect's cooperation, without which we would not talk about beatific *vision*. On the contrary, the fruition of the last end requires the cooperation of all the soul's powers tending simultaneously toward the beatifying object. Nevertheless, at its root there is a single operation since, however many faculties there are, the soul can only be united to its end in an *immediate* and absolutely *ultimate* way by one of the faculties. If we wish to join the intellect to the will, we must say that the will is the principal faculty of beatitude. If we wish to retain only one faculty of the soul, we must say that the will is the only one *ultimately* beatified. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 3, number 7: "Si autem ambae potentiae concurrunt ad beatitudinem, sic illa, quae est principalior potentia, habet principaliter beatitudinem, et sic voluntas magis quam intellectus. Si autem accipias secundum aliam ultimationem, sic tantum voluntas ultimate beatificatur."

68 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 11: "Sed contra hoc arguit alius philosophus noster, scilicet Paulus, qui dicit quod caritas excellentior est." Cf. St. Paul, 1 Cor. 13:13. Duns Scotus also cites *De Trinitate*, book XV, chapter 19, 37, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 1086, where it states that if "Deus caritas est," we must conclude that "in donis Dei nihil majus est caritate." Note the impact of the doctrine of the gifts of the Holy Spirit upon the thesis of the primacy of the will, which is usually considered *philosophical*.—Duns Scotus has just argued against Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 82, article 3, body of article, whose doctrine is more nuanced than it seems in its refutation. Duns Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 7, sets his sights on it exactly. As for the superiority of wisdom to charity, nothing proves that Duns Scotus is thinking of Thomas Aquinas

in denying it. After all, St. Thomas was also interested in theology, and it is difficult to believe that, after Duns Scotus read the beginning of this article, he did not read the end. In any case the fact is that Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 68, article 8, reply to objection 1, places the theological virtue of charity above the gift of wisdom. Perhaps Duns Scotus could object that on the strength of Aquinas's own principles, he does not have the right to do so, but we do not see that he reproaches St. Thomas for having done so.

69 Reportata Parisiensia, book IV, distinction 49, question 3, number 12: "Sancti vero et Doctores nostri ultra hoc exquisierunt."—In what concerns Aristotle, Scotus seems to have in mind *Ethica Nicomachea*, book VI, chapter 7, which puts wisdom above prudence, and book VI, chapter 8, where he raises wisdom above all human things. Cf. Thomas Aquinas's commentary on the *Nicomachean Ethics*, *In Decem Libros Ethicorum Aristotelis ad Nicomachum Expositio*, ed. Angelo Pirotta (Turin: Marietti, new edition, 1934), number 1195. As for the accusation directed against the Philosopher, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 2, number 12, that he distinguishes volition and intellection badly, it is difficult to know exactly what passage Scotus has in mind. Perhaps he is simply thinking of the fact that in Aristotle, as in Thomas Aquinas, election is an *appetitus consiliativus* or *an intellectus appetitivus*, which amounts to assigning it a cause that confuses intellect and will without being either, *Ethica Nicomachea*, book III, chapter 4, 1111 b 20 ff, Cf. book VI, chapter 2, 1139 a 22–23 and 31–35.

70 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 7, sole question, article 2, number 11, vol. II, p. 415 [CE VIII, p. 89]: "Tertia bonitas convenit actui ex hoc quod, praesupposita duplici bonitate jam dicta, ipsa elicitur conformiter principio merendi, quod est gratia vel caritas, sive secundum inclinationem caritatis."—Number 12 [CE VIII, pp. 90–92] of this question contrasts this triple good with the corresponding triple malice: general malice when the act, although good by nature, turns toward an object that is not appropriate (e.g., when the act of *hating* is directed toward *God*); next, malice of the act that, though dealing with a suitable object, is vitiated by a circumstance that makes it disordered; lastly, malice of demerit, when the acts wounds charity. We will return to indifferent acts below.—On the distinction between moral good and meritorious good (*bonitas caritativa*), see *Quodlibet* XVII, numbers 5–9 [AW, pp. 390–94].

71 On moral good as *convenientia* or *conformitas actus ad rationem*, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 17, questions 1–3, article 3, number 3, vol. I, pp. 797–98 [CE V, p. 164].

72 Duns Scotus first introduces his second kind or moral goodness under the name of *bonitas virtuosa*. He briefly describes it in these terms, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 7, sole question, number 11, vol. II, p. 415 [CE VIII, p. 88–89]: "Secunda potest dici bonitas virtuosa sive ex circumstantia . . . secunda bonitas convenit volitioni ex hoc, quod ipsa elicitur a voluntate cum omnibus circumstantiis dictatis a recta ratione debere sibi competere in eliciendo ipsam." It is moral good, properly speaking, because it possesses all the requisite moral determinations. See number 12, p. 416 in this question [CE VIII, p. 92 contains the first nine words and p. 91 explains the necessity of the right conditions]: "Iste quidem actus non est bonus vel virtuosus moraliter, quia non est circumstantionatus." The external act possesses its proper moral goodness distinct from that of the internal act and added to it, *Quodlibet* XVIII, numbers 12 and 14 [AW, pp. 408–09 and 410–11].

73 He refers to St. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, book VIII, chapter 3, 4, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 949.

74 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 40 sole question, number 4, vol. II, pp. 866–67 [CE VIII, pp. 470–71]. We are dealing with the act's *moral* goodness, not its *meritorious* goodness in view of a supernatural end. In the later case, *bonitas meritoria est a fine*. Therefore the end becomes the principal cause of the act, on whose complete moral goodness it is superposed by

making it an act of charity.

75 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II distinction 40, sole question, number 2, vol. II, p. 866 [CE VIII, pp. 468–69].—The circumstances are enumerated in the famous verse recalled in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 39, sole question, number 1, *scholium*: "Quis, quibus auxiliis, quid, ubi, cur, quomodo, quando." In this last passage, the end remains in the same place in the *order* of circumstances, although it seems to receive a kind of primacy of nobility: "Bonitas igitur moralis completa est ex correspondentia ad actionem rectam secundum omnes circumstantias, et prima bonitas ex circumstantia est ex fine, quod actus sit circa talem finem, et quod finis recte intendatur circa quem natus est esse bonus actus. Secunda bonitas est ex eo modo, videlicet, quod agens habeat actum convenientem tali agenti. Modus enim qui convenit nobiliori non convenit nobili. Tamen prima bonitas simpliciter in actu morali est a causa efficiente. Secunda ex objecto, quae est bonitas ex genere, deinde bonitas ex circumstantia finis. Quarta bonitas ex modo, sed completa est ex omnibus circumstantiis." Cf. number 4 of this question: "Ad aliud dico . . ." and *Quodlibet* XVIII, number 6 [AW, pp. 403–04].

76 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 17, question 3, article 3, number 3, vol. I, pp. 797–98 [CE V, p. 164]: "Ita quod pro omnibus possumus dicere quod convenientia actus ad rationem rectam est qua posita actus est bonus, qua non posita, quibuscumque aliis conveniat, non est bonus; quia quantumcumque actus sit circa objectum qualecumque, si non sit secundum rationem rectam in operante, puta si ille non habeat rationem rectam in operando, non est bonus actus. Principaliter igitur conformitas actus ad rationem rectam plene dictantem de circumstaniis omnibus debitis illius actus est bonitas moralis actus. Haec autem bonitas nullum habet principium activum, sicut nec aliquis respectus, maxime cum ille respectus consequatur extrema posita ex natura extremorum; impossibile enim est actum aliquem poni in esse, et rationem rectam in esse, quin ex natura extremorum consequatur in actu talis conformitas ad rationem rectam: relatio autem consequens extrema necessario non habet causam propriam aliam ab extremis."—What is true of the voluntary act evidently applies to the moral *habitus*, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 17, question 3, article 3, number 4, p. 798 [CE V, p. 167]: "Virtus moralis non addit super substantiam habitus, ut est forma de genere qualitatis, nisi conformitatem habitualem ad rationem rectam."

77 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 41, sole question, number 2, vol. II, pp. 872–73 [CE VIII, pp. 474–76]. There is a more explicit answer in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 41, sole question, number 2. In both cases, Duns Scotus extends his conclusions, with nuances, from the moral act to the *meritorious* act.

78 Contrary to what has been claimed, we do not believe that Thomas Aquinas is the issue here. Cf. *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 56, article 6, body of article and reply to objection 2. The author or authors of the thesis attacked here probably stayed much closer to Aristotle on this point than Thomas Aquinas does. Naturally, Duns Scotus argues vigorously to establish that Aristotle is nonetheless on his side, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 33, sole question, numbers 5–6.

79 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 33, sole question, number 7. Cf. numbers 24–25 on the respective nobility of prudence and of the will: "Prudentia . . . est nobilissima virtus moralis, comparando ad virtutes in voluntate inquantum regulans eas."

80 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 33, sole question, number 8. Cf. number 23 in the same question: "Sed tamen hoc non tollit ejus [*scilicet* voluntatis] libertatem, quia sicut voluntarie causat habitum virtuosum, ita potest agendo corrumpere habitum contrarium, vel potest libere neutrum causare," and further on, "Virtus fundatur in voluntate ut libera est."

81 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 33, sole question, number 10. Cf. number 24

of the same question, where Duns Scotus admits that the will indirectly generates a moral virtue in the appetite: “Potest autem ulterius dici, quod non tantum in voluntate sit virtutes moralis, sive habitus, ex multis electionibus rectis generatus; sed ex hoc reliquitur quaedam impressio in appetitu inferiori, qui potest dici virtus moralis; sicut adductum est in exemplo Philosophi, quod ad bonum regimen requiritur virtus in principe ut bene imperet, et in subdito ut bene obediat. Sic in appetitu superior ut bene imperet, et in inferiori ut bene obediat.” Duns Scotus in no way reverses himself, since the virtue that is in the sensitive appetite is born from the virtue whose seat is the will.

82 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 33, sole question, number 25: “Ad aliud *Politica* dicitur quod Philosophus ibi erravit. Credidit Philosophus legem membrorum esse naturae verae institutae, et ideo cum appetitus sensitivus sit potens revellare, credidit sic esse a natura instituta, sed hoc est falsum. Etenim in natura instituta quilibet appetitus tendebat delectabliter in objectum proprium, et si aliter fuit moderatum, tunc fuit per justitiam originalem, quia omnes potentiae obediebant rationi.”

83 Duns Scotus often affirms God’s indulgence or condescension. For example, in *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 6, question 4, number 4 [CE does not contain number 4 for this question]. Cf. *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 15, question 1, number 7, and *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 15, question 1, number 9. God does not want to oblige humans to do the impossible, not even what is very difficult.

84 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 39, question 2, number 4: “Ideo dico quod conscientia est in intellectu, et si est actualis, est dictamen actuale in intellectu, et si est habitualis, est dictament habituale, et ideo est concors scientiae rectae.”

85 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 39, question 2, number 5. As a free power, the will *tends to want* an end (*intentio*) through an overall act that includes the means, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 38, question 1, numbers 2–3. The will is guided by the conscience, whose judgment binds the will each time conscience agrees with the divine law, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 39, question 2, number 10. This is what provokes the will’s *murmuring*, number 5 in the same question.

86 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 39, question 2, number 6.

87 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 44, question 1, number 2, vol. I, pp. 1286–87 [CE VI, p. 366]. The passage directly concerns the laws freely established by God in the order of good and of merit, but it holds for the whole order of the contingent: “Ideo potest [Deus] aliter agere, ita potest aliam legem statuere rectam, quae si statueretur a Deo, recta esset, quia nulla lex est recta nisi quatenus a voluntate divina acceptante statuta.” Things would then occur differently, but according to another order: “Non quidem fieret ordinate secundum istum ordinem, sed fieret ordinate secundum alium ordinem; quem alium ordinem ita posset voluntate divina statuere, sicut aliter potest agere.”

88 Exodus 20:1-7, Deut. 5:6-21. The first three commandments, which define duties toward God, form the first table. The last seven, which define duties toward our neighbor, form the second table.—According to Thomas Aquinas, as correctly summed up by Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 2: “Omnia quaecumque sunt in Decalogo sunt talis [*id est*, de lege naturae], vel immediate vel mediate.” Cf. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 100, articles 1 and 8. In other words, everything God’s commandments prescribe has formal goodness that intrinsically orders it to our last end. Everything they forbid has formal malice that intrinsically turns us away from this end. On the Thomist position, see Pedro Lumbreras, “Theologia Moralis ad Decalogum,” *Angelicum* XX (1943), pp. 265–99. Duns Scotus

discusses this position. His fundamental objection is that, if all the Decalogue's precepts belonged to natural law, God himself could never dispense anyone from these commandments in any circumstance. Duns Scotus's fundamental agreement with Thomas Aquinas on the basic concept of natural law is affirmed in *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 5: "Et rationes contra primam opinionem probant quod in talibus non potest esse dispensatio, quas concedo." The term *dispense* must be taken strictly. *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 3: "Dispensat quicumque legislator simpliciter quando revocat praeceptum juris positivi facti ab eo." For example, under the Old Law, God prohibited killing. Under the same law, he commanded Abraham to kill. He can only do this by revoking the Old Law in this case.—See the same question, number 4, for the basic intellectualism of the doctrine regarding natural moral law.—For the strict and broad senses of *lex naturalis*, see *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 8.

89 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 6.—Loving God is the only act that is good in virtue of its object alone. Hating God is the only act that is bad in virtue of its object alone, and no circumstance can make it good, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 28, question 1, number 6.

90 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 37, sole question, number 7 [CE VIII, pp. 386–88].

91 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 8.

92 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 9.

93 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 10: "Non odire enim est simpliciter de lege naturae sed an aliquando amare, dubitatum est in tertio praecepto."

94 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, numbers 11–12. Naturally, this does not mean that the precepts of the second table are less binding than if they belonged to strict natural law. Even if God can suspend certain of them, he alone has the power to do so, and we are not authorized to revoke them for any motive whatsoever. When someone in the Old Testament lies, Duns Scotus condemns him, insofar as he lies, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 38, question 1, number 13. His position in moral theology is ultimately bound up with his theology *in divinis*, and more precisely with his fundamental doctrine of the finite's essential contingency in relation to the infinite. Cf. CE II, pp. 72 number 95, p. 80, number 111, and p. 82, number 115 [Vivès *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 1, part 2, question 2, numbers 5, 10 and 10 again.] Our necessity to want an object in view of its end cannot exceed the necessity of its proper relation of means to end. What is not *intrinsically* a necessary means for God cannot *intrinsically* be necessarily wanted by us with a view to God. But if it pleases God's reasonable wish, the means can become necessary in fact, *qua* positive law.

95 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 28, question 2, number 3: "Itaque non est contradictio quod aliquid haberet caritatem cum odio proximi; tamen necessarium est de potentia ordinata Dei, quia in illo praecepto prohibetur ille actus malus, scilicet odire poximum; nam simpliciter necessarium est non odire de potentia ordinata et intellectu praecepti. Unde tantum est necessarium ex praecepto et ordinatione, quia de facto transgressionem praecepti cessat caritas in anima, quia tunc annihilat eam Deus."—The hypothesis of someone who gained salvation without ever loving his neighbor with a positive act of love is not contradictory. *Ibidem*: "De actu affirmativo, dico quod non oportet semper inesse, sed debet inesse quando occurrit necessitas. Ideo licet semper praeceptum obliget ut nunquam odiat, non est necessarium alicui habere actum affirmativum respectu proximi, nec esset necessarium considerare proximum, ideo neque sic diligere illum. Et ideo si esset aliquis solitarius et devotus, nihil cogitans de proximo, non est necessarium elicere actum diligendi circa ipsum, sed necessarium non odire."

96 This does not mean that I would positively want the death of another, unless it pleases God to take his life away for his own good. There are two cases when someone can want the death of an enemy without sinning. If we are dealing with a criminal that the judge wants to punish or with a public persecutor of the Church whose evil life prevents divine worship and harms the common good, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 30, sole question, number 6.—To situate these particular problems in their doctrinal context, see Joseph Klein, *Die Charitaslehre des Johannes Duns Scotus*, Münster im Westfalia: Aschendorff, 1926 and also Klein's remarkable *Der Gottesbegriff des Johannes Duns Scotus vor allem nach seiner ethischen Seile betrachtet* (Paderborn: Schöningh, 1913), particularly sections V and VI.

97 In the absolutely strict sense defined above, the commandments of natural law are first practical principles or their consequences, so that it would be contradictory for God to wish to dispense us from them. Duns Scotus simply maintains that the commandments of the second table are not among those *principia practica* or their *conclusiones necessariae*. They prescribe nothing whose goodness is *necessarily* required by the goodness of the last end. They forbid nothing whose evil is *necessarily* opposed to this end. In other words, it is not contradictory in itself that the last end could be achieved without one doing this good or avoiding this evil, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 5.—Let us recall once more that all God's commandments, even those of the second table, belong to the natural law in the broad sense, see number 8 in the question cited: "Quia eorum rectitudo valde consonat primis principiis practica necessario notis." It would be a mistake to regard this attitude as a theological innovation or a characteristic of the incipient fourteenth century. Cf. Bernard of Clairvaux, *De Praecepto et Dispensatione*, III, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. CLXXXII, column 684: "Necessarium deinde quod inviolabile nominavi, illud intelligo, quod non ab homine traditum, sed divinitus promulgatum, nisi a Deo qui tradidit, mutari omnino non patitur; ut exempli causa. *Non occides*, *Non moechaberis*, *Non furtum facies* (Exod. 20:13-15), et reliqua tabulae legiscita, quae, etsi nullam prorsus humanam dispensationem admittunt, nec cuiquam hominum ex his aliquid aliquo modo solvere, aut licuit, aut licebit, Dominus tamen horum quod volutit, quando voluit solvit, sive cum ab Hebraeis Aegyptios spoliari (Exod. 3:22), sive quando prophetam cum muliere fornicaria misceri praeceptit (Osee 1:2), etc."—Samson, who committed suicide, certainly did so according to a counsel personally received from God. Duns Scotus discusses each scriptural case according to its own data, and he sometimes admits that there was sin, other times that there was dispensation, or even a mixture of the two. There are cases where one can kill, but not as punishment for theft, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 15, question 4, number 15. This case is interesting, because Duns Scotus absolutely forbids the death penalty for theft, since God forbids homicide. God alone (not the prince), Scotus says, can dispense from his own positive law, but he can do so. *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 15, question 3, number 7: "Excipit autem multos [casus], ut patet in Exodo, scilicet blasphemum, homicidam, adulterium, et multos alios." Cf. Lychetus in Vivès, vol. XV, p. 787.

98 Thus in *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 28, sole question, number 15, marriage is firmly described a *contractum secundum legem naturae*. Scotus then adds that since it is not a first practical principle, this contract needs to be approved by legislation, and even, however natural it is, to be instituted by God: "Quia illa quae sunt remota a principiis practicis non apparent esse de lege naturae sicut ipsa principia practica quae sunt nota omnibus ex terminis, nisi explicarentur termini, quod non nobit aliquis legislator particularis. Ergo congruum est hoc explicare per legislatorem universalem, qui est auctor humanae naturae et totius entis creati." Accordingly, marriage is a natural contract, a legal contract, and a sacrament. Moreover, it is such a difficult contract to respect that grace is necessary for it. However, God could authorize polygamy, and although only the supreme legislator could do so, he did it, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV,

distinction 33, question 2, number 5. Therefore, marriage does not strictly belong to natural law, although it is *multum consona*. In cases of this kind, which do not put in doubt either first principles of moral conscience or necessary consequences of those principles, but only harmonious agreement, consonant with the principles or consequences, God can dispense. See the same question, number 7.

99 See the chapter, excellent in itself, by Parthenius Minges in *Der Gottesbegriff des* Duns Scotus, pp. 101–19.

100 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 8.—Certain historians of Duns Scotus see a secret intention behind these positions, which would deprecate nature even in its aptitude for morality. More accurately, some see a kind of *theological humanism*, in the sense that, thanks to revelation, it unveils an excellence of human nature "that philosophy did not know and could not know," Paul Vignaux, "Humanisme et théologie chez Jean Duns Scot," *La France Franciscaine* XIX (1936), pp. 209–25.

101 Cf. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part Ia IIae, question 100, articles 5 and 8.

102 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 37, sole question, number 4: "Esset etiam ponere, quod voluntas ejus simpliciter necessario determinatur circa aliqua volibilia alia a se, cujus oppositum dictum est in primo [libro], ubi tractum est, quod voluntas divina in nihil aliud a se tendit nisi contingenter."

103 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 27, sole question, number 2. Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 22, sole question, number 3.

104 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 28, sole question, number 6: "Nullus actus est bonus in genere ex solo objecto nisi amare Deum, qui amor est objecti per se volibilis et boni infiniti."

10

Duns Scotus and the Philosophers

General conclusions about Duns Scotus can only follow from a complete study of his doctrine, which is itself situated within the doctrinal history of his time. We have not attempted this in the present work, and our conclusions are valid only in function of the limited results we have reached, if indeed we have reached any. We are dealing rather with impressions here, which other historians will compare to their own conclusions in order to rectify them.

Renan did not reap only pleasant impressions from his dealings with Duns Scotus. As Renan pictures Scotus from his work, the Subtle Doctor "generally is shown as possessing a violent temperament, with an uncultivated and neglected genius. He is not as moderate as St. Thomas. His tone is severe, rude, and cutting. He lets himself be swept into invective. He is generally very intolerant."[1] This judgment is easy to understand. In order not to be intolerant in Renan's eyes, Scotus would have had to be sure of few things. But invective? One must read hundreds of pages of Duns Scotus to find a single example of invective, and they are much more easily encountered in the writings of Henry of Ghent or even of the seraphic St. Bonaventure. In fact, although there may be others, we remember only one, against Muslims. Less moderate than St. Thomas? Yes, perhaps, but then we are dealing much more with two different theological styles than with the two men.

Again, one must distinguish, even within the concept of style. St. Thomas's

career was too short. Duns Scotus's was still shorter. We have before us works that have been altered and revised, composed in technical language that is abrupt, uninterested in giving pleasure, entirely at the service of demonstration. We have to judge a philosophical and theological style, not in relation to others, but in itself. At least once, in *De Primo Principio*, Duns Scotus is capable of attending to the perfection of his style. A firm, plain language, that adheres directly to his thought without a shadow of ornamentation, freed from any controversy and thereby possessing a kind of sober dialectical inebriation, as if the order, connection, and very rigor of the arguments gushed from a warm desire for light, and to speak the whole truth, from insatiable love. A summa of theology, completely written by Duns Scotus, would have been of the same cast: the proof that he could have written it stands before us; for instance the questions are there in the *Quodlibets*, where the same mastery of thought and language reigns unfailingly. Sometimes, even in the most obscure detours of Scotus's dialectic, a bold turn of phrase stands out, flashes before our eyes and before our minds with commanding energy, as if the perfect adaptation of the words to the intellect completely suppressed the distance between reader and teacher.[2] These austere delights are not infrequent in Duns Scotus, and they wrench a cry of admiration from us, but one must be more structured than Renan to experience them.

That said, Duns Scotus remains difficult for others because he was so for himself.[3] Severe but not without humor, abrupt rather than rude, precise rather than cutting, he guides his reader through dialectical labyrinths at the end of which he unties rather than cuts. Certainly his style does not have the lucid ease that we find in St. Thomas Aquinas or St. Bonaventure. Scotland is not Italy. Again, to get to the heart of the problem, we would have to compare styles of thinking rather than of language. These theologians do not do exactly the same thing. They do not conceive theology in completely the same fashion. When we examine St. Thomas closely, he has his personal theology that he does not doubt any more than Duns Scotus doubts his, but he does not impose it. No one is more careful than Aquinas to leave all doors

open through which different minds can reach the same truth. No less firm than John Duns Scotus in excluding error, Aquinas carefully cultivates the seeds of truth wherever he finds them. Thomas gives every expression, even one alien to his personal thought, a true meaning, provided only that it is capable of admitting one. Aquinas has the gift of joining extreme flexibility to unbreakable firmness. It seems that Aquinas negotiates and arbitrates, but those who know him well are not misled: he never concedes a half-truth as a step toward the whole truth. Still, one can be misled there. In Duns Scotus, misunderstanding is more difficult. Because Scotus's thought in some measure moves on just one level, we are less exposed than in St. Thomas Aquinas to stopping on the way and taking as the profound truth what is only completely true in its own order, which is not necessarily the highest one. When the history of the schools is written, if we observe that Scotism overall has remained more homogeneous, something that is not certain but probable, perhaps it will have to be explained in this way.

This is not to say that Duns Scotus left us a system.[4] The word of God, which Scotus seeks to understand, is not a datum that may be reconstructed in deductive fashion, above all when divine freedom is at the origin of God's work. Still, the philosophy Scotus uses is composed of fundamental theses to which he returns constantly in order to clarify the depths of faith. Like all his contemporaries, Duns Scotus speaks Aristotle's language, but there is hardly more relation between his personal thought and that of the Stagirite than there is in our own time between our contemporaries and the thought of Kant or Hegel, whose language our contemporaries borrow. For our theologian, St. Augustine remains a higher doctrinal authority and, above all, one of a different order. The ascent of Aristotelianism in the thirteenth century did not allow one to keep to the letter of Augustine, but without fear of error, one could hew to the spirit of Augustine's doctrine while perfecting his technique and clarifying solutions that Augustine had only sketched. Does Duns Scotus owe Augustine his identification of being with *essentia*? That is improbable, because the position was common, and so to speak, went without saying. In any case, positing God as the archetypical *essentia* was not an innovation, but

Duns Scotus had to innovate to construct his theology with the help of a metaphysics of essence. In profound agreement with the spirit of Platonism, that is to say, not with Plato's writings but with the requirements to which Plato's thought itself had deferred, Duns Scotus translates the essences as concepts and their relations as a dialectic of concepts. Certainly, judgment and reason have major importance in Scotus, but are important to link or divide concepts according to the real connection or division of essences. Against what St. Thomas thought, in Duns Scotus the truth of judgment is ultimately grounded on essence more than on existence.

From that stems what is called Scotus's formalism.[5] The consequence is unavoidable, because if being is essence, as long as there are essences, there will be beings; and as there are as many distinct essences as distinct concepts, every distinct concept of an essence is the concept of an actual or possible being. Duns Scotus's formal distinction says no more, and it is uncompromising because, in a doctrine where essence is the very stuff of which being is made, to reduce formalities would be to annihilate being. Here the problem is not to reduce them but to unite them. The solution for that is easy, because essences form a hierarchy such that the higher essences include the lower, and by the very fact that they include them, they unite them. Here again, through Dionysius and Plotinus, Duns Scotus spontaneously returns to the unifying conclusion and metaphysical energy of the One. The world of essence has a structure where the essences come to be included in unities that really contain them without undergoing loss of being that would be the loss of formalities.

Metaphysical being is only the most universal of these quiddities. As such, it is only being, and that is why everywhere being is found, it is univocal, as, moreover, are all essences taken one by one, all their properties, and all their modes taken one by one, since each one is always and everywhere what it is and nothing but what it is. But we need not represent the real as a mosaic of pieces cut from the block of univocal being. Firstly, the entity of univocal being is that of a quiddity, not of an existent. There is this being in everything that exists, but, if it is true to say that all that is participates in its formal

entity, we would be completely mistaken about Duns Scotus's thinking if we inferred that all that exists is by virtue of the same existence. In so far as they are being, all beings have it in the same sense, but they do not have the same being. They would have it, if reality were only being instead of including the formal perfections and modes by which each being is distinguished from others. It is thus understandable why this metaphysics of univocity elsewhere stresses the principle of individuation so heavily. For beings to be irreducibly distinguished from each other in a doctrine of essence, it is necessary that each defined structure should in some way be closed upon itself, beyond the specific form, but in the same line, by this ultimate individuating determination that Duns Scotus's disciples call whatness, *haecceitas*. This ultimate actuality of the form, *ultima actualitas formae*, and not univocal being, is what perfects being's individuality and makes it capable of actual existence. It is the extreme point of being, the supreme metaphysical energy that by making it be itself *ut hic*, at the same time forbids it to be confused with any other. Formalities and *haecceitas* separate what univocity unites.

God is being *qua* being, separated from everything else by the individuating modality of infinity. Therefore, all the rest is infinitely separated from him, because there is no infinite being but him. If creatures were not also being, our understanding could know nothing about their cause, not even its existence. But there is existent being, it is a fact, and starting from it, we can demonstrate that an infinite being exists. On the other hand, although finite beings can only have an infinite being as their cause, it would be contradictory to claim to deduce them from it. Holy Scripture alone can teach about the love that willed to surmount for us the infinite abyss that separates our being from God's. Ontological contingency, which is also absolute, forbids any deduction that would claim to bind the finite world of beings to the absolute transcendence of being. In relation to his works outside himself, God's infinity is freedom itself. The general view of the world that emerges from Duns Scotus's work is, therefore, that of an Infinite Being that is sufficient unto itself, but who in fact has created finite being by a free will whose only intelligible motive is love. This universe is entirely different from

that of the philosophers whose language Duns Scotus borrows. How can we be surprised that Scotus is so different from the philosophers in his whole tendency of thinking?

However, this universe of essences is not a static universe because the forms are active. There is no difficulty in understanding that they exercise formal causality. It is more difficult to conceive of their exercising efficient causality, and Duns Scotus knew the force of the objections that Aristotle directed against the Platonic ideas too well not to have become aware of the problem. For Scotus it is a question of existence. It is a fact that being exists and, through the metaphysical examination of the contingent that we know, we can demonstrate necessarily the existence of a being so perfect that its existence is necessary. The perfection of the being implies omnipotence, the foundation of all causal efficacy. By way of creation, each second being receives from the First Being causal efficacy proportional to its degree of being, and just as God's infinite perfection accounts for his aptitude to create, the finite perfection of each creature grounds the aptitude to cause other beings. Accordingly, Duns Scotus resolves the problem in his fashion, without recurring to the efficacy of an act of being whose existential energy would confer efficacy on its operational power, because it completed the form's perfection from within. Conceived as the perfection required to account for an operation, every first passive power is grounded on the substance *qua* matter. Every first active power is grounded on the substance as form. The Scotist world thus maintains its dynamism of its forms. The essence defined by the formality of certain forms explains why they are active and others are not. Strictly speaking, one could posit as the first action of a form the one by which it actualizes the corresponding power: quantity "quantifies," duration endures, and so forth. But this would be an abuse of language, because acting in the strict sense is making a being other than it was by exercising a causal influence upon it. In this sense, efficient causes are always substances or qualities. Certain first acts are of such nature that they can act or make by exercising second acts. The perfection of their natures itself is not at issue: the elements, which are very imperfect, do

produce; inanimate compounds [translator: medieval Latin *mixta*] do not produce; "so that it does not seem that some greatest universal can be assigned, to which being producing corresponds," *ita quod non videtur aliqua posse maxima universalis assignari, cui enti conveniat producere*. When a form is active, its nature demands it be so. In any case, the apparition of any new quantity or quality has as its prerequisite an efficient cause. In that, the Scotist world remains the same as Aristotle's, where the apparition of a new substance presupposes the existence of another substance that causes it, that is to say of a being in act producing what was only a being in potency.

The natural light of the intellect disposes of three real sciences in order to know this universe of essences. Setting aside logic, whose object is not real, three sciences are concerned with everything that exists. First, as we have said from the beginning, is metaphysics, whose proper object is being *qua* being, immaterial or material. It is an eminently speculative science, not a practical science, because, since being is the highest object of the sciences, it would be contradictory that metaphysics should be necessary to direct the operations of the sciences and that it should come last. The goal of metaphysics is pure knowledge that concerns all the quiddities as such, although it does not concern all their accidents. Indeed, the quiddity is prior to everything: to knowledge, to definition, to time, to movement, and to quantity. Therefore, a science of quiddity as such is necessary, and it is metaphysics. Next comes mathematics, whose object is the quantified, natural substance taken in so far as *quanta*. Lastly, there is physics whose object is material substance as changeable: the *mobilia*. Metaphysics does not directly know objects below being, but we cannot completely know the nature of the elements or petrography or botany without being capable of reaching back to their ultimate explanations by the general metaphysical nations of cause, substance, and being. Thus, the chemist (*elementicus*), the geologist (*lapidicus*), and the botanist (*planticus* or *plantista*) only possess the ultimate reason of their knowledge, if each is also a *metaphysicus*. Such are the three real sciences, and there are no others that are naturally accessible to humans, but there remains a supernatural science, theology, which is the

science of God as infinite being, creator of humans destined to beatitude, in other words, their principle and end.

Theology is totally different; it is a practical science, which in no way means that it is less *science* than metaphysics. Like every quiddity, a science cannot be more or less a science or a science differently from another. A body of knowledge is science or not. Whatever may be theology's intrinsic perfection as knowledge and whatever the perfection of its object, it is a science whose proper goal is to serve as a rule for human operations with a view to salvation. The philosopher seeks to know the universe as it is, and it is accidental to its essence that this science is the rule of practical action. Above all, the theologian pursues knowledge that the word of God has revealed expressly with a view to lead humans to their salvation. The difference is considerable, because even when they pursue their metaphysics as far as theology, the Ancients had no other ambition than to know, whereas, after the Gospels, theologians are not simply philosophers who are interested in divine matters. Theologians and philosophers no longer do the same thing, and they really do not even speak of exactly the same object.

Overall, if we set aside Duns Scotus's writings on the philosophical questions that are preliminary to theology, his work is the work of a theologian. He himself probably would have been surprised by being placed among the *philosophers*. During his short twelve-year career, Duns Scotus appears to us as a professor in the line of so many others, with the responsibility of teaching theology in his turn and commenting on the text of Peter Lombard. This is what explains the order Scotus follows.[6] Duns Scotus is what is called a *Scholastic* theologian today. He places knowledge Christians get by reading the Bible above any other knowledge. Everything the Bible says is true, and the Christian knows by faith that it is true. To know that, he does not even need to prove the truth of one part of the Bible by another part. No proof, even a Scriptural one, is required to satisfy the *habitus* of faith, whose assent is granted immediately to everything there is in Holy Scripture, globally, and in each proposition taken one by one, in itself and for itself, and *non uni propter aliud*. That is so true that when Scripture

argues and demonstrates, we do not believe because of the demonstration, we believe the demonstration. In 1 Cor. 15:16, St. Paul says: “If the dead do not rise, neither has Christ risen,” *Si mortui non resurgent, nec Christus resurrexit*, and it is true. But if he had merely said *mortui resurgent*, that would also be quite true. All Christians are at the same point in the above: properly speaking, they do not know, they believe.

We can do something else, that is to say, explain Scripture. First, we can explain Scripture by itself, one passage by another passage, the obscure by what is clearer. This is extremely useful. However, as in the obscure by the clearer, the text that clarifies and the text clarified are simply objects of belief. The truth of the explanation is always not that of science properly speaking, but of faith.

But the masters finally arrived at another mode of explanation of the Bible, also very valuable, which consisted of mixing philosophy, particularly metaphysics, with Holy Scripture to achieve understanding of the truth of Scripture regarding the Trinity, the Separated Intelligences, and other abstract matters. Although the theologian uses philosophy to establish his conclusions, here again, the conclusions have no other certainty than that of faith. On this point, Duns Scotus is aware that he is describing a late development in the history of theology: “finally, the Doctors have come mixing philosophy with holy scripture, which clearly is very worthwhile and especially in metaphysical matters,” *ultimo devenerunt Doctores immiscendo philosophiam scripturae sacrae, quod sine dubio multum valet et praecipue metaphysicalia*. He approves this development, which we think natural, but it was not a necessary one. Not all the theologians of his time approved this mixture of philosophy and Holy Scripture. Some even judged it dangerous. Duns Scotus, by contrast, is among those who judged it useful, while maintaining firmly that the truth of the conclusions thus obtained remains a truth of faith. Nobody pushed this rigorous distinction of orders further than Duns Scotus. Science, which rests upon the evidence of the terms, is incompatible with faith regarding one and the same object. *Cum fide stare non potest scientia proprie dicta, quia termini non apprehenduntur in*

particulari sub propriis rationibus.[7]

Here we reach one of the standpoints from which the work's unity appears most clearly. From the beginning of the prologue, Duns Scotus poses the fundamental question of finding out whether philosophy suffices to provide humans with the knowledge necessary for salvation. His answer is negative, and it controls his attitude in regard to philosophers. He nowhere seeks to diminish philosophy as such but to signal its insufficiency with regard to human salvation. What Scotus intends to demonstrate is not the uselessness of philosophy, but the necessity of revelation. Hence his attitude in regard to Avicenna. If, like Averroes, Duns Scotus reproaches Avicenna for having mixed elements taken from religious belief with his philosophy, it is precisely because as a philosopher in intention and profession, Avicenna did not have the right to do that. On this point Duns Scotus holds that the Commentator is right, when, having resolved to be only a philosopher, he denies himself conclusions, perhaps true in themselves, but that cannot be justified by any rational conclusion. We should not say that Duns Scotus held that all of Averroes's conclusions were philosophically demonstrated. That would be false because, on the contrary, Scotus judges that he can demonstrate that all Averroes's conclusions that contradict faith are false or lack necessity. But in Duns Scotus's eyes, Averroes and his master Aristotle represent the predicament or insufficiency that *philosophers* suffer every time they approach a problem whose correct and full solution matters for the task of salvation. Avicenna is a more complex case for Duns Scotus. Avicenna believes he can demonstrate by reason alone that humans are capable of naturally attaining natural beatitude. He is a philosopher, who without knowing it assumes theologian's garb. Moreover, in a certain way, Avicenna is useful in this respect, because his metaphysics is a kind of valuable *praeparatio theologica* for a Christian Doctor. Avicenna thinks he knows by pure metaphysical knowledge that the human intellect is naturally capable of being everything. He is mistaken in believing that he knows it without the help of any religion, but his position is no less true. The most remarkable thing is that this principle, which is unknown to the philosopher Aristotle in

its absolute sense, is true for the theologian Duns Scotus. The theologian has the right and duty to do what the philosopher's own methods forbids him to do. The philosopher as such does not have the right to mix Holy Scripture with philosophy. On the contrary, and Duns Scotus himself has just told us this, the Doctors were fully right ultimately to come to mix philosophy with Holy Scripture, which is extremely useful, especially when this philosophy is metaphysics. Therefore, the theology master is right to do what he forbids the philosopher, precisely as philosopher, to do, and this is also why all the *metaphysicalia* in Duns Scotus's work, in its content and its very existence, is intelligible only from the theologian's perspective. Aristotle and Averroes are good philosophers. Avicenna is better only when he is a theologian without knowing it. To be a better philosopher than Aristotle, Averroes, and Avicenna, it is enough for the master in theology to be a theologian completely.

Metaphysics' instrumental character explains the apparent philosophical disorder that reigns in the *Opus Oxoniense*. Duns Scotus might have first established a metaphysics, as is done nowadays, and then employed it in theology. He did not do that and does not even seem to have thought about it, except in regard to the art of logic. We see him introduce metaphysical theses when the theologian needs to use them. Even while he uses them, he pursues a theological truth, not a philosophical truth. The *Quodlibetal Questions* and *De Primo Principio* are of the same kind. If we want to expound a philosophy of Duns Scotus according to a more or less philosophical work, we would be reduced to the *Questions on Metaphysics*, where theology is far from being absent. Not much is left! The bulk of what today is called Duns Scotus's philosophy is composed of elements taken from his theology. These are metaphysical theses that interest him in so far as he can attain a certain intellection of faith through them.

From there to conclude that there is no philosophy in Duns Scotus's work is a short distance, but it is imprudent to cross it. Things are not so simple. Let us note that in every subject that depends entirely on faith and on it alone, Duns Scotus does not hesitate to argue as a dialectician, not in order to

demonstrate that that the truths of faith are true, but to establish that they cannot be proven false. This is what he calls “to make it clear that faith is not impossible.” The undertaking is certainly eminently theological, but it is going to lead the theologian to the philosopher. For, if faith is not impossible, it is possible. Against whom is he demonstrating that? Against philosophers who claim that faith is impossible. By what means do they presume to demonstrate that? By natural reason. The theologian can only refute them on their own ground, which is that of our natural lights, by opposing reasons to their reasons. By the mere fact that he engages in dialogue with a philosopher, the theologian is constrained to behave like a philosopher, if not to establish a philosophical truth, at least to assure himself and to convince his adversary that there exists no rational demonstration of the falsehood of faith.[8] From there, particularly in Duns Scotus, comes a sort of philosophical critique of philosophers, undertaken on behalf of theology, which would benefit the history of philosophy itself in addition to the history of theology.

The quandary into which this problem plunges historians is not peculiar to Duns Scotus. It is likewise found when we study St. Thomas Aquinas, but it stems from an error of perspective. In our time, we tend to identify the distinction between theology and philosophy with the distinction that exists between faith and reason. According to this approach to the problem, every conclusion, one of whose premises comes from faith, is theological by that very fact, and every conclusion whose premises depend on natural reason alone is philosophical by that very fact. In the Middle Ages, the masters admitted the first point, but not the second. In their eyes, a conclusion deduced from purely rational premises could be theological. For them, the distinction between two sciences was found elsewhere, and it was simple. As St. Thomas says at the beginning of his prologue to book II of the *Sentences*: “The study of creatures belongs to theologians and to philosophers, but in different ways. Indeed, philosophers consider creatures taken in their proper nature, while theologians consider creatures in so far as they come from the first principle and are ordered to their last end, which is God.” There is no question of reason or faith here. Since both are necessary to theology thus

conceived, their division will not be the division of philosophy and theology. To prove the existence of God starting from beings whose existence would be impossible without his existence is to do the work of a theologian, even if we proceed by merely rational arguments.

The issue of knowing and saying what must be done does not depend on history, and that is not what we are examining. Our purely historical observation is that we place ourselves in inextricable difficulties by trying, as we ourselves did for a long time, to find a distinction between *natural theolo*gy and *revealed theology* in the classical theologies of the Middle Ages, thus modeled on the patter of the distinction between faith and reason. The latter distinction was familiar to our theologians and after Albert the Great was very clear in their minds. But, however they believed they ought to define its object—God, Jesus Christ, the infinite being, or otherwise—none of them to our knowledge, distinguished two theologies. We cannot do so in their name without introducing the distinction into their doctrines or overturning the order they follow in their works, as if the order is not inseparable from the science, inscribed in its nature and imposed upon it. There can be advantages and disadvantages often in different domains and points of view, which vary according to the times, in choosing one or the other method. The problems here are not simple. For a historian, one thing is sure: everything in a commentary on the *Sentences* or in a *summa theologica* of the thirteenth or fourteenth centuries, at least up to Duns Scotus and William of Ockham, was theology pure and simple in the eyes of the authors. The theologian uses philosophy as he uses many other disciplines, and it must be genuine philosophy to be usable, but he always uses it as a theologian.

No doubt, it will be asked why we are interested in this nonphilosophical use of philosophy. Are we not outside philosophy by the mere fact of this heteronomy? No, since the adversary claims to be there. If it is philosophical to demonstrate rationally that the notion of one God in three persons is absurd, it is no less philosophical to demonstrate rationally that it is not absurd. There is room to demonstrate that because, even if it is true that such a concept is rationally possible, it is not evident.[9] But to demonstrate a

conclusion in the full sense of the word is to prove that it is necessary. Therefore, the theologian here starts to establish a necessary possible, *possibile necessarium*, that is to say, by refuting his philosophical adversary, to prove that a certain article of faith is possible using necessary philosophical reasons.

From there come the well-known *rationes necessariae* in Duns Scotus, which he uses in theology, and about which a great deal of ink has been spilled. St. Anselm had already spoken about them, but it is remarkable that Duns Scotus takes up this concept despite the objections St. Thomas Aquinas raised against it. Like the Angelic Doctor, the Subtle Doctor does not allow us to invoke sophistical arguments in favor of faith. That would be to expose faith to the mockery of unbelievers. It would be more serious instance of a fault from which one should abstain even in religiously indifferent areas, geometry for example, where it is better to confess ignorance than to sustain a conclusion by sophistical reasons. But this is not the case for necessary reasons because, as we have said in its place, demonstrating the credibility of the object of faith does not eliminate faith, and it does not harm unbelievers to make them see that an article of faith is believable. It still remains for them to believe it, but perhaps they were turned away from it by the intellect's natural repugnance to believe something absurd, in which case at least that obstacle is set aside.[10]

Let us confront the theology that makes use of philosophy with the philosophy that is only philosophy, including metaphysics that is only metaphysics. When Duns Scotus defines philosophy in itself and by its essence, he gives it the highest praise. As the science of being *qua* being, first philosophy demonstrates its conclusions by necessary demonstrations, *a priori* and by the cause. Of course, the principles that first philosophy puts to work are immediately evident to pure natural reason, and as being is the first common nature from which all other natures derive, the science of the first knowable is also the first science: *scientia prima scibilis primi*. When Duns Scotus speaks of metaphysics in these terms, he intends to speak of what metaphysics is inherently.

What relations can be established by theology that speaks of God according to revelation without proving anything but God's possibility and metaphysics that speculates upon being as being? This was one of our initial questions, and the clearest finding of our investigation, after having heard Duns Scotus for so long, is that we have not yet received an answer. Perhaps it is that we have not yet been capable of understanding the answer, because we imagined it beforehand to be different from what it is. Perhaps we expected to encounter somewhere, as we followed a response to some objection, the ideal passage that would trace once and for all the watershed from which on one side the waters flowed toward theology and on the other toward metaphysics. Perhaps this mistaken attempt ought not to surprise us too much, but what have we found instead of what we sought?

In this vast theological structure, philosophy is everywhere, not only on every occasion, but also at the slightest pretext. When there is no pretext, Duns Scotus sometimes enjoys creating one. There is nothing new in this method, which, at bottom, is simply that of St. Augustine in his *De Genesi ad Litteram*, and which puts the principle of *De Doctrina Christiana* into practice. Every commentary on the *Sentences* has an *In Hexameron*, and we see Duns Scotus pouring a physics of place and movement into his commentary while discussing angels; a metaphysics of individuation in the context of matter; a physics of mixture when dealing with bodies; a psychology and an epistemology while treating of human beings; in short, all kinds of rational knowledge that Scotus desired to marshal in the service of revealed truth. Still, it is a waste of effort to extract their rational content from the *Sentences* or even the *Questions on Metaphysics* in order to reconstruct a *philosophy* of Duns Scotus. It would be riddled with holes and even made out of pieces that never belonged to a philosophy but a theology. Anyone can assure himself of this, for example, by taking the trouble to compare how Duns Scotus uses the writings of philosophers, of Aristotle and Avicenna with those writings. Scotus never comments on the letter of a single one of them, as St. Thomas Aquinas does. For Scotus, they are mines of questions to pose or of materials to utilize to construct a new work in a different style

from that of the philosophers: namely, one of those *Scholastic Theologians* from the period between 1200 and 1400 when Christian faith freely uses the human knowledge at its disposal to deepen its understanding of its own object. No one has done this more freely than Duns Scotus, or more exactly in the spirit of *Crede ut intelligas* of Christian tradition. For the rest, we can achieve certainty, to quote with Scotus the beautiful words of his teacher Augustine: “Let them believe in Holy Scripture with unshakeable faith. Let them seek understanding by praying, studying, and right living. That is let the mind see as much as faith believes.”[11] Duns Scotus always had the same project.

It would be incorrect to say that Duns Scotus never thought of the problem in terms of the pair theology-metaphysics, *theologia-metaphysica*. He did so several times, principally in the prologues to the *Opus Oxoniense* and the *Reportata Parisiensia*. We took note of that in its moment, and it is easy enough to refer to these passages to see that *our theology* and *metaphysics as we have* it are defined and distinguished from the point of view of their objects. Yet, even there, the issue is their objects as we can attain them in our present state, with an intellect wounded by original sin. In principle, such an intellect is capable of intelligible intuition, but in fact it is no longer capable of more than abstract knowledge. The state of the knowing subject matters as much here as the nature of the object known.

This is probably why, once these elements have been acquired, Duns Scotus no longer speaks of *metaphysica* and *theologia* but of philosophers and theologians, *philosophi* and *theologi*. Scotus might have started from a concept of metaphysics taken in itself and, so to speak, in the absolute, definable in function of a human intellect identical in its operations after the fall just as before, centered upon an object adapted to the intellectual faculties of the subject that knows it. If he had, Duns Scotus could have concluded like Thomas Aquinas, that what natural reason does not suffice to demonstrate escapes philosophy as a matter of principle. In Scotus’s view, things transpired differently. Everything was clear for the theologian. He knew what God revealed about himself and that humans can only learn about God from

God. In Scotus's view, it was even the proper function of the theologian to say and teach this in all its forms, but Scotus had no fixed criterion to define *a priori* how far natural reason can get before revelation. The theologian is not faced with *philosophy* but *philosophers*, unaware of the present state of the intellect and of its cause. Such people achieve admirable results that are useful to the theologians each time they interpret nature as such, but they are quite unaware of the danger of taking a false path without knowing it, when by metaphysics they go beyond physics to penetrate into the realm of the theologian, which is the science of God.

We cannot say that they get nowhere. Yet, even when they happen to advance rather far along the right road, they take as an absolute goal what is only the goal of their competence: a being in itself, that is to say, the First Being; a being infinite in power, not in being; a first cause, but in the manner of a nature; a sort of creator, but determined by its own necessity and not free. Will we ask them whether *philosophy* could, in principle, go beyond the conclusions actually achieved by the philosophers? This is a pointless question, because, in fact, the philosophers have not gone beyond them, and the only ones who have gone beyond them are theologians. Moreover there are reasons for that. The philosophers' conclusions are functions of the object that they set out to know and therefore, of their methods, or if we prefer, of their initial attitude. For Duns Scotus, or for old doctor Bonaventure, the philosopher is a man who *looks down* and only sees what is high from below. He does not look up first, because he would stop being a philosopher and would become a theologian.

The Scotist critique of the philosophers springs from the same source. Duns Scotus attributed no common theses to them except naturalistic necessitarianism, which in his view is less a philosophical conclusion than an inevitable consequence of the philosophers' attitude. Scotus refuses to attribute to philosophers theses that are alleged to be theirs on the grounds that they necessarily flow from their principles, unless the theses do genuinely flow from those principles For Scotus, each case is a case of this sort: what did Aristotle or Avicenna say on such and such a particular point?

Is it prudent to introduce into theology such and such a thesis of philosophical origin, when the theologian speaks about a different topic than the philosopher and when one of them, to speak of his own case, disposes of lights that the other lacks? Duns Scotus knows his trade, and what is called his critical spirit, or sometimes his *criticism*, is to be explained quite differently from Kant's, with whom Scotus, strictly speaking, has nothing in common. At the beginning of the fourteenth century, a theologian is no longer in William of Auvergne's situation. Before Scotus, others have done a great deal of Scholastic theology, mixing a great deal of philosophy into it. When Duns Scotus attacks a problem in his turn, he asks whether so much philosophy is really necessary, and above all, whether the right philosophy has been chosen. From the theologians who preceded him or who surround him he goes back to the philosophers. If he seeks to clarify the sense of their conclusions, it is often to make it apparent that certain theologians have failed to justify their own conclusions starting from principles imprudently taken from philosophers. His critique of philosophers is generally motivated by the use that certain theologians made of them.

On the other hand, and we have seen this as we went along, opposition to the *theologi* by *philosophi* was familiar to Duns Scotus. From this, it has sometimes been concluded that Duns Scotus admitted a kind of double truth, as if in his mind the same conclusion could be true in philosophy and false in theology or inversely. But Duns Scotus's disciples do not understand him thus, and to cleanse his memory of such an accusation, some reduce his attitude to that of a theologian for whom Catholic teaching might well have opposed this or that doctrine of this or that philosopher, Aristotle, Avicenna, or Averroes, for example, but not opposed philosophy itself. Under a different form, this poses the previous problem again, and the truth could be in this attack or this defense, because there is no trace of a doctrine of double truth in Duns Scotus, a doctrine, moreover, that to our knowledge no one has ever maintained. However, in his criticism of philosophers, our theologian does something other than reproach this or that philosopher for having been wrong on some particular point.

As we have said, philosophers are not philosophy, but, for Duns Scotus, our philosophy is what the philosophers have made it.[12] Moreover, there has to be a reason why philosophy has come to be what it is in their hands. Duns Scotus has no ill will toward philosophers. If he ever directs an insult against them, the occurrence is unusual, and speaks less to them than to their errors. Nor, let us recall, does Scotus attribute a common doctrine to the philosophers, which would be *philosophy*, and which Scotus would denounce as false or dedicate himself to refuting. A great abstractor of essences in metaphysics, where essences are at home, Duns Scotus thinks concretely about the particular. We perceive that historical scrupulosity pierces him, something rather rare in the Middle Ages. We see it at work in his very personal, very meticulous way of interpreting the thought of others. But he also does not compromise either with a metaphysics of determinism and universal necessity, or with a psychology and epistemology holding that the intellect in principle can only grasp being through sensation. Duns Scotus does not say that this is the error of *philosophy*, but neither is he content to say that it is a particular error of this or that philosopher. It is an error of *the philosophers*. When the theologian meets them on this ground, conflict does not fail to break out: *hic est controversia inter philosphos et theologos*. Why, therefore, are there, if not two doctrines, at least two camps?

The answer is simple regarding the first point, and several historians of Duns Scotus have seen it clearly. Around 1300, a theologian was in almost the same situation with regard to the decree of 1277 as those of the early twentieth century after the condemnation of modernism. Indeed, Étienne Tempier's decree had been a summons back to tradition. A large number of the condemned propositions were taken from the philosophical doctrines of Aristotle and his Arab interpreters. They might be understood as a list of *errores philosophorum*. Consequently, a characteristic constituted the group of *philosophers* in a very recognizable way, though, in fact, a bit loosely: they all admitted, in one way or another, that the First Cause acted by necessity of nature and that its necessity was propagated step by step starting from the first created Intelligence down to our sublunar world. Certainly, the

presence of matter that was itself eternal introduced an element of *deformity* into the world, something accidental and by chance, but any freedom was excluded from it, and along with that freedom the kind of contingency that freedom introduces into the world. This is how the *philosophers* thought, and they were recognized, first of all, by this sign. Duns Scotus took too much from them himself to believe that there was nothing true in their work, and we have just recalled with what scrupulous attention he refused to attribute errors to them that nothing proved they committed. But they had committed this serious error, and their whole vision of the world was warped.[13]

It is worth noting that Duns Scotus does not designate them by a philosophical label, for example the *necessitarians*, which would distinguish them from other philosophers. For him they are simply *philosophers*, and those who collectively oppose their attitude call themselves *theologians*. Is it arbitrary to conclude that Duns Scotus thought theologians view the universe in a different light than the philosophers? Since what comes between the former and the latter is Christian revelation, everything indicates that in Scotus's mind the Scriptural revelation had entailed an important shift of perspective on the world, its origins, and its structure for one who sought understanding of faith. The theologians' view of the universe is set against that of the philosophers. We have observed this several times, but for our reflections to be supported by a particular fact, let us add to what we have already said a case that we have not had the occasion to mention.

This is a well-known case, frequently employed against Duns Scotus by those who attribute a theory of *double truth* to him. We are dealing with a purely theologian problem: can nature be the efficient cause of the resurrection? In other words, can the resurrection be produced by a purely natural cause? Put in technical terms, the problem amounts to knowing whether an active power in nature corresponds to the passive power that the body to be resurrected possesses. If we answer *yes*, nature is capable of resurrecting the dead on the last day. If we answer *no*, it will not be.

Duns Scotus himself does not answer yes or no initially. Some believe themselves able to answer *yes* in the name of philosophical reason by basing

themselves on the following proposition of Aristotle: in nature, a particular active potency corresponds to every passive potency. Therefore, if the body is resurrectable, there is a force in nature capable of resurrecting it. To this, Duns Scotus responds once again: “I say that philosophers answer one way and theologians another,” *dico quod aliter huic respondetur secundum philosophos et aliter secundum theologos*. Among philosophers it would not be absolutely true that a natural active potency corresponds to each natural passive potency, because beings that have achieved their natural perfection are correctly ordered to receive still more perfection than they have, but there is no active natural potency to give it to them. This does not entail the consequence that such a passive potency exists vainly in nature because if no natural agent can make the passive potency pass into act, it can at least dispose it to receive such an act. This is not to denigrate nature but rather to honor it, as we said at the beginning of this work. Therefore, the proposition is true according to the philosophers only in the sense that a *natural* active potency corresponds to every passive potency. There is no question among philosophers about what a supernatural cause could add to nature. That does not enter within their perspective, but it is important to see exactly why.

If philosophers never imagine that even in beings where nature achieves its perfection, nature can be raised to a still higher state, it is precisely because in their eyes the very perfection of nature is an insurmountable limit. A perfect nature is all it can be, not only in virtue of itself, but by virtue of its cause; if the cause could give it more, since it is natural itself, it could not fail to do so; therefore, it would do so.

Here we reach the crucial point, on which it is impossible to dwell too often, because it clarifies Duns Scotus’s constant attitude in these matters. According to the philosophers, nature is all that it can be, “because according to them God causes naturally and by natural necessity in his order of causes just as a created agent,” *quia secundum eos ita causat Deus naturaliter et necessitate naturali in suo ordine causandi sicut agens creatum*. This point settles everything. For minds that see the whole universe including its first cause, as submitted to necessity, everything that can be has been, is, or will

be, and will always be exactly what it can be. To put it differently, no passive potency that is actualizable by a natural cause will remain without being actualized. But what about *secundum theologos*?

> According to the theologians, to say that a natural active potency corresponds to every natural power is a false proposition, because in higher beings, nature is capable of more perfection than that to which the power of the natural active potency extends.

And let us pay close attention to what follows:

> This passive power does not exist in vain, because it can be reduced to act by a free agent as well as by a natural agent. If the issue is acting outside of itself, the free agent is even more efficacious and more powerful than the natural agent, because it is infinite, which the natural agent is not. Accordingly, this proposition ought to be understood as follows: potency, whether natural or free, corresponds to every passive natural potency, which reduces the passive natural potency to act, and I grant that.[14]

Let us start by trying to sum up that commentary: First, there is a position of the *theologians*, different from that of the *philosophers*. Second, it consists in positing the first cause as a free agent. Third, this agent is free, because it is infinite. Inversely: first, there is a position of the *philosophers* different from that of the *theologians*. Second, it consists in positing the first cause as a necessary agent. Third, the agent is necessary, because it is not infinite.

Unless we give up interpreting an author's thought through his texts, this doctrine is all the more certainly Scotist in that the Subtle Doctor, who appears as direct, simple, and clear here as it is possible to be, affirmed it several times. In fact, he did so each time he had to define the position proper to the theologians in the context of that of the philosophers. Let us only recall as a reminder that the philosophers have certainly achieved the notion of a God who is infinite in power, but not to that of a God infinite in being, which is the point at issue.

From here on, interpretation is unavoidable, and since this interpretation will decide the overall meaning of Duns Scotus's doctrine or, if we prefer, the

spirit of Scotism, the historian will need to make an important decision. We hope that the historians will be excused for justifying that decision as clearly as possible in order to permit others to see more clearly where he is mistaken, if he is mistaken. In turn, the historian himself has the right to expect something from them. For us, the problem is to find out, not what we would like Duns Scotus to have thought, but what he actually thought according to the texts at our disposition. A different interpretation, even one preferable for other reasons, will have to agree with the texts as well or better in order to be preferred.

Barring misunderstanding on our part, our first interpretation of Duns Scotus simply consists of repeating what he said*: to posit God as a free, infinite being is a theologian's position*. Such is the principle of principles, it seems to us, and it decides everything. It is even why the detail of its consequences defies analysis for us, but it already defied analysis for Duns Scotus.

A dazzling confirmation that this point of departure is right is to be found in the absolutely certain fact that, according to Duns Scotus, *ens infinitum* is the theologian's proper object. Consequently, everything we say about the infinite being is properly theological. Inversely, we can observe that in fact philosophers have never spoken about the infinite being, and the fact agrees with the principle because the subject of their science is not being *qua* infinite, but being *qua* being. The first is a singular being; the second is common being. Accordingly, we will not attain the first simply by going more deeply into the second. They are not objects of the same nature or of the same order, and this is precisely why Duns Scotus sees a radical distinction between the philosopher's knowledge and the theologian's.

If the First's infinity is the immediate foundation of its freedom, every conclusion based upon God's freedom is itself theological. The consequence seems inevitable, and it finds a dazzling confirmation in the overall doctrine: since infinity presides over all God's operations *ad extra*, outside himself, the freedom that flows from infinity presides over all God's operations ad intra, the freedom that flows from infinity presides over all God's operations *ad*

extra. Inversely, we can observe that, in fact, philosophers have always submitted divine actions to necessity. If they had spoken of the First as infinite in being and free in its action, they would not have spoken as *philosophers,* but as *theologians*.[15]

These two great vectors are simple, clear, and unquestionable, but we must make an effort not to prolong them further than Duns Scotus himself did. It is arbitrary to infer from this that for Duns Scotus the same proposition could be true in philosophy and false in theology or inversely. He himself never said such a thing, and we can easily see the reason why he did not think so. The *philosophers* to whom Duns Scotus contrasts the *theologians* are not bad philosophers but the best philosophers, Aristotle and Avicenna, the ones Scotus most admires. These men went as far as possible on the path of philosophy: they proved the existence of the First; they established that it is the first cause, and that its power is infinite. All that, which is true for the philosopher, is also true for the theologian. No doubt the philosophers did not know that the First is infinite in being and that it is free. From this limitation comes their conclusion that it the First is determined in its action, but this is not a philosophical truth, it is an error born of ignorance about something theologians know. To avoid any philosophical error, the philosophers should simply have said that the First is the infinitely powerful efficient cause of everything that is, and kept to that.

On the other hand, we defend Duns Scotus poorly by responding to this accusation: “He only said that there is a contradiction regarding God’s power and his mode of action between theologians and certain ancient philosophers who were not Christians.”[16] This is not the style of advocacy that interests us —to defend Duns Scotus matters less than to understand him. But it is regrettable that under the pretext of justifying his position on this central point, we should eliminate the position. That the ancient philosophers were not Christian is a tautology. What caught Duns Scotus’s attention is the fact that the common position of these pagans is different from the Christians’ common position. Why does he call them *philosophers*? Because after Christianity there are no more philosophers who were simply philosophers. A

Christian who speculates about the universe no longer does so as a philosopher, even when he uses philosophy, but as a theologian. This is why Duns Scotus watches Avicenna so closely when he claims to justify as a philosophy conclusions that are inaccessible to philosophy as such. Averroes harshly reproaches his predecessor for mixing theology in his philosophy. Duns Scotus directs the same reproach against Avicenna, but in an entirely different spirit. For Averroes anything from theology mixed with philosophy turns it into rhetoric. For Duns Scotus, the theology Avicenna had mixed with his philosophy could sometimes be true, but he is mistaken and risks misleading others when he makes it pass for philosophy. A real theologian does not tolerate a philosopher's claiming to have discovered by himself what he would never have known had he not learned it from religion.[17] Therefore, it is not enough to respond that we have a contradiction here between the theologian and Aristotle or certain of his disciples, "but not between theology and philosophy as such."[18] The more we insist on the fact that Duns Scotus here does not oppose philosophy and theology, the stranger it becomes that the theses he sets in opposition so often are those of the *philosophers* and those of the *theologians*.

Although Duns Scotus himself make no bones about naming the opposition,[19] there is no need to draw up a list of the problems falling under *philosophy* in opposition to *theology*. From the point of view of method, this is evident, since the technique of demonstration is the same everywhere. From the perspective of the questions themselves, the problem is extremely complex, because Duns Scotus's thought moves within a framework where the arguments of his defenders do not always fit better than the reproaches of his critics. By asking whether a philosophy of Duns Scotus exists, we bring up a problem alien to the thought of Duns Scotus.[20] For us, everything that can be rationally demonstrated without appealing to revelation falls in principle within what we call *philosophy*. Therefore, it must be possible to extract from the *Opus Oxoniense*, as we have done, what Duns Scotus says about infinite being as such and attribute it to *the philosophy of Duns Scotus*. However, things are done quite differently in Scotus, and the principal

elements of the positions he has adopted himself can be arranged thus: first, the proof of the existence of an *infinite being*, who therefore is free, is the work of the theologian; second, the proof is carried out by natural reason using the methods of the metaphysician; third, therefore, there are rationally demonstrable proofs, unknown to philosophers, that the theologian can establish metaphysically. This last point is not an inference. We have found the assertion emanating from Duns Scotus's own pen, and the moment has come to take it in its full meaning, that is to say, simply to take it literally: the philosophers have said many things that cannot be proven by natural reason, and much can be proven by natural reason that they have not said.[21] This point is certain, but it is to depart from the strict Scotist path to conclude that since the theologian alone proves these truths, they are not rationally demonstrable. The opposite is true. Duns Scotus proves the existence of the infinite being by natural reason alone, but it is a theological conclusion unknown to philosophers because had they known it, they would have known that God is free. Inversely, "the philosophers could not conclude by natural reason that God can cause contingently,"[22] but that does not keep the theologian from offering the demonstration. We could wish for a less complex situation, but such it is, and the historian can only accept it in its complexity.

Besides, it is laudable to wish to clarify the expression today or even to elaborate upon it. But, we do so under the condition of leaving history behind and running the risk of leaving Scotus's Scotism behind. In order to attempt it while avoiding this last pitfall, the following points, at least, must be examined. Why have these purely rational truths been discovered by Christian theologians? Although naturally knowable, why do they remain the key to *our* theology? If the evidence of an infinite, free being is rationally demonstrable, how does it come to pass that the philosophers did not know it and that we owe the proof to the theologians, while it is so difficult to cite a scriptural text where the divine being is explicitly and directly designated infinite *qua* being? Needless to say, here we are only dealing with Scotist conclusions that presuppose no article of faith. We simply ask how it happens

that these conclusions arise in a Christian theology and that our theologian has maintained them. History can only give us the elements of the problem. It is for philosophers to resolve it, and also for theologians, if they please.

To situate the problem within the framework established by Duns Scotus, we must first recall that, as he conceived the sciences, they formed a series of superposed levels that are not connected by any passageway. If he had merely taught that the same truths cannot be the object of faith and science at the same time and under the same respect, Duns Scotus would be indistinguishable from St. Thomas. But he goes further because he refuses to admit that our theology is subalternated to the theology of the blessed in heaven, and that our philosophy is subalternated to our theology, so that we might believe something in a subalternated science that is regarded as known in another. Not only does Duns Scotus judge that Thomas Aquinas contradicts himself in this,[23] but, more importantly for us, he rejects this position in the name of the distinction of sciences, as he himself understands it.

To understand Scotus's distinction, it suffices to recall the prologue to the *Opus Oxoniense*, where the sciences are divided and subdivided by reason of their objects. They are distinguished from each other less by the causes that make us know them than by the object proper to each of them and the mode of thought of the intellect that knows it. The blessed have their theology, whose object is God known intuitively: their knowledge of God is not the essential cause of our theology, whose object is infinite being and thus different from the divine essence, which moreover is not attained without faith. In its turn, our theology in no way causes our metaphysics, because the latter's object is not infinite being, but being as such, which our intellect attain in its present state. From this standpoint, the Thomist subalternation of sciences is only a device or else it is false. It is a device, if by it we merely say that intellects situated in different states in the presence of different objects can have different knowledge. It is false, if we conclude that one of these bodies of knowledge can be the cause of any of the others. A theologian does not know theology because the blessed know its principles, or else

somebody could maintain that he knows geometry because he believes that geometers know it.[24]

It follows necessarily from there that in this life humans cannot have a science, in the strict sense, about revealed objects of faith,[25] but it also follows from this that our metaphysics as such cannot receive its light from our theology. The theology that is intruded into it remains theology without ever becoming metaphysics. In the end, from this completely general point of view, it is understandable that Duns Scotus should conceive the problem in terms of the disjunction *philosophi-theologi*. It is impossible to be both at the same time and in the same respect, nor even to beon both levels simultaneously. How would one who seeks to know being *qua* infinite learn anything from someone whose very vocation is only to study being *qua* being? They do not talk about the same thing, and even if they did, it would not be in the same way.

These factors would be incomplete if we neglected those that appear at the other pole of the problem, when it is posed from the standpoint of metaphysics. Let us briefly recall the main ones. To humans, who are the union of a soul and a body, it is natural to know only by concepts abstracted from the sensible or by intuitions of these abstractions. What is not natural is that humans should additionally dispose of direct intuitions of the intelligible. There we have two facts of experience, both equally certain. The first is explained by human nature and the natural solidarity of intellect and sensibility in a being of this species. The second remains inexplicable from the viewpoint of the intellect itself, which, precisely *qua* intellect, is inherently capable of direct intuitions of the intelligible. Consequently, we ask why, if the intellect is capable in principle, it is not capable in fact. Duns Scotus has suggested these answers several times: because God willed it thus, no doubt as punishment for original sin.

Whatever the explanation may be, the fact remains, and it entails important philosophical consequences. Firstly, indeed, our natural knowledge is mutilated. If we imagine what metaphysics would be for an intellect exercising intelligible intuitions, we will see how much *our* metaphysics a

posteriori differs from the science that metaphysics could be *a priori* and by its cause. Next, and this is more serious, we know nothing about that knowledge. Let us say, at least, that everything cooperates to hide it from us, because no living human being has experienced a different state from that in which we are: we do not even think that another one could be natural for us. That is why Aristotle himself, "who knew no other state," *qui nullum alium statum expertum erat*, always taught that the abstract quiddity of the sensible is our intellect's object. Many philosophers followed him on this point, and even Christian theologians, who were ill advised in doing so.[26]

For, it is not true. Although our intellect must now abstract its whole intelligible from sensible data, as an intellect, it remains in principle capable of intelligible intuition. This is even why its proper object, which is that of metaphysics, is not common being starting from the sensible, but being pure and simple and in total indifference to the common sensible just as to the intelligible. Thus conceived, being has a name: it is univocal being, the first object of the intellect, and consequently also of First Philosophy. Therefore, the univocity of being subsists in our metaphysics as the mark of an aptitude for intelligible intuition that we can no longer exercise. The whole Scotist conception of metaphysics, with the doctrine of being, soul, intellect, and human knowledge that are linked to the conception, is inseparable from the certainty that certain powers of our intellect are currently mutilated, and that humans are capable of a better state than that in which we live today.

How does Duns Scotus know that? Because as a Christian, he knows that humans were freely called by God to a state where it was necessary for them to intuit the intelligible, whereas that would be impossible for them if they were essentially incapable of it. Whether they have exercised it or not, humans will exercise it someday, and if it is indeed desired that humans should exercise it, it must already be inscribed in their nature. Accordingly, it is the theologian who knows this. Could a pure philosopher know it in principle? No doubt at all that he could, because it would be enough for that philosopher to understand that the intellect, precisely as intellect, is in principle open to all being, *capax totius entis*. Aristotle might have suspected

that an intellect, precisely *qua* intellect, could not have a more restricted object than that of the Separated Intellects. If he had seen that, he would have said so, but he did not see it. However, a philosopher did see it, and that was Avicenna, precisely because he mixed religion into his metaphysics. Wanting humans to be capable of intellectual contemplation after the body's death, Avicenna saw clearly that for this to be so, an intellect had to be essentially capable of all being, intelligible as well as sensible. Here we return to the same problem, but with this difference: this time all philosophical knowledge is at issue within and through metaphysics. What should we call this rational knowledge that only becomes aware of this truth through the understanding of a theologian and in the context of a theology? Whatever name we please to give it, the name is not what matters but the thing. As for Duns Scotus himself, why did he name it? He knows too well that all his words on the subject were the words of a theologian.

It seems to us that this was John Duns Scotus's general attitude toward philosophy. Or rather it was an attitude toward the philosophers themselves. An encouraging sign that this interpretation is not far from the truth is found in the contradictions into which Duns Scotus is accused of falling, when the accusers lose sight of the interpretation. The Subtle Doctor often would have confused philosophy and theology, but also separated them irremediably. The same theologian who claimed to demonstrate the possibility of one God in three persons by necessary reasons disputes that metaphysics is competent to demonstrate the omnipotence of the infinite being and even, strictly speaking, its existence. Yet, he immediately hastens to demonstrate the existence by principles of natural reason, precisely because he poses the problem as a theologian. As long as we seek to resolve the problem by a distinction of the objects of metaphysics and theology, contradictions spring up everywhere along with controversies or replies that are hardly worth more than the objections. Duns Scotus himself stayed on a different level. In harmony with his notion of theology conceived as an essentially practical science, what matters is the particular situation of the philosopher or theologian. Scotus sees that, from this standpoint, the privileged situation belongs to the

theologian in relation to the philosopher, even in questions of reason. No one but Scotus could have originated this remarkable phrase: “many Catholic doctors had a more perfect concept of God on purely natural grounds than some philosopher or other.”[27] We may label as we wish the knowledge of God by which the Catholic doctor excels over this or that philosopher on purely natural grounds, *ex puris naturalibus*. If this is natural theology, we wonder why it is the prerogative of the theologian. If it is theology pure and simple, unqualifiedly, it is unclear how this knowledge can be *ex puris naturalibus*. It is preferable once again to recognize that Duns Scotus’s thinking does not move in this area. Someone who shifts Scotus’s authority to that realm will no longer get an answer from him. Perhaps he will even lose sight of the real meaning of the gigantic undertaking about which we have only obtained partial and disconnected visions: the striving of a theologian whose reason does not deny its cooperation to faith and is not surprised to see better in the light of faith. Our descendants will be better informed than we are and will say whether the real Duns Scotus was this or someone else, but unless Cavellus, Mauritius a Portu, and Wadding are completely mistaken about their master’s deep meaning, we would be surprised if the Subtle Doctor appears very different to our descendants from Duns Scotus whom the great interpreters of yesteryear faithfully served and knew intimately.

It is true that we do not know how the great interpreters themselves posed the problems. That is important, because if events depend on the time when they occur, their history depends on the time when it is written. From Descartes to our day, it has been thought that the works of the medieval doctors contained no philosophy because they were theologians. This was an error because philosophy continued to live and be transformed thanks to their theological speculation. The fact that in the seventeenth century Descartes and Leibniz decided to regard as philosophical theses that until then were judged theological did not change the nature of those theses. Either they did not become philosophical then, or they were so already. Every metaphysics where God is no longer Greek but Christian will have to be disqualified under the same conception as are the medieval theologians, if we want to regard as

philosophical only the doctrines that do not suffer from having been germinated in Christian soil. How much of the doctrines will remain? Those who hold this thesis must do the accounting. It is a bit surprising that they continue to hold the thesis without having tried to count the doctrines.

Inversely, the requirements of apologetics in our time have somewhat modified this perspective. In a time when so many philosophies keep themselves away from any theology, theologians desired to dialogue with them. From that comes an interesting effort to extract the philosophical elements that each medieval theology contains, this time not in order to recount the history of what had become the philosophical ideas of the thirteenth century, but to make *philosophies* out of them. We are confronted by this curious paradox: the philosophies thus obtained only appear original, alive, and creative at the points where they were really enmeshed in a theology. It is easy to make this clear for Thomas Aquinas, and it is no less evident for Duns Scotus. Both use borrowed philosophical techniques, but Thomas Aquinas's thought is not that of Averroes nor is Duns Scotus's thought that of Avicenna. They conceived neither God, nor the origin of the world, nor the nature of being, nor human nature, nor intellectual knowledge, nor voluntary act, nor the moral law as those philosophers did. Taking Averroes's and Avicenna's language Aquinas and Scotus use it to say something different, and one of the surprises of history is to see so many conclusions reached in the thirteenth century by theologians, who never wanted to be anything else, parade before us in seventeenth century philosophies in revolt against theology. From Descartes to certain atheist existentialisms in our days, philosophical rationalism has lived comfortably off the metaphysical capital accumulated by medieval theologians. No doubt, that is why certain Christians in our time, playing the same game, believe it useful to speak as if the philosophies they invoke have no essential relation to the Christian climate in which they were born. It is not surprising that our present attitude washes back upon the Christian past, whose history we write, but that phenomenon produces anachronisms that it would be preferable to avoid.

More than one contemporary theologian would feel hurt, if he were declared not to be a philosopher. Duns Scotus would have been surprised, at least, to be told that he was one. Not that he felt the least scruple about being informed about the doctrines taught by philosophers, or even putting them to use, he simply was not one of them. It can even be said that he was completely unwilling to let himself to be possessed by one of them, because his doctrine is entirely dominated by the problem of salvation. If Scotus becomes involved in the metaphysics of Aristotle or Avicenna, it is not to create a better metaphysics, but to prove that reason refutes them each time that their conclusions are opposed to Christian faith, which alone can save us.

This is why even Scotus's own theology was always defined not as speculative, but as practical science.[28] Duns Scotus calls all knowledge *practical* that pushes speculation no further than is necessary to determine the conditions of action. The *Opus Oxoniense* opens with a prologue entirely dominated by this concern. What is the end of human beings? Can philosophy alone let us discover it? The answer is *no*, for the reasons we have seen. Consequently, theology is necessary to inform us about this; that is why this knowledge is necessary. But, on the other hand, theology is justified only as the knowledge of our own last end and of the means of which we dispose to attain it. Therefore, Duns Scotus's theology is practical science first and foremost.

From there, in the last analysis comes the primacy of the will that can be observed in Duns Scotus's doctrine. This is not completely true of God, where essence, intellection, and love are much more than equals, because, since one is the other in virtue of the dialectic of the infinite, they are really identical. But since humans are born of a free decree that produced them with a view to an end, attaining that end is Christians' sole reason for being than to, and being informed about the paths that can lead to the end is the sole reason for knowing. Also, as we have seen clearly, this by itself requires much speculation, but such speculation remains practical, first in that it determines this single object that is in conformity to right volition; next, it is practical in that it prescribes the rules our action must obey in order to lead to

salvation. In short, the relations of conformity and of priority, *relatio conformitatis et prioritatis*, are the two characteristics of the science that proposes the will's ultimate end to it and precedes our volitions on the road that leads us to salvation.

On this issue we see the two basic errors of the philosophers converge. Philosophers teach that the happy human being is the one who loves God with all his strength, but they conceive the happiness that stems from that love as speculative, and they conceive it this way because, in their view, the creature is linked to the creator by a bond of necessity. It is inevitable that what stems from a necessary act of intellection should return to its origin by the intellect. But let us even admit that the Philosopher's Intelligence springs from the love of God and returns to him by love; the Philosopher would attribute the love that God puts into the will of the Intelligence to natural necessity, so that the Intelligence would have no choice between good and evil. Even in this case, the knowledge of good remains strictly speculative, and so to speak *ostensive*, because what the intellect would show to the will, the will would want necessarily. The intellect would not show it what it ought to want.

The Christian's situation is quite different. He does not merely need to know what the end is of humans in general, something metaphysics would suffice to make him see.[29] The Christian needs to know what his particular end is, *Deus ut hic*, and how he must act in each particular case if he wants to attain it. Above all, the Christian must want to attain it by a succession of free acts, for each of which he is personally responsible, until God himself raises him by grace to glory. Did Aristotle ever imagine anything of the sort? Duns Scotus poses the question, and his response marvelously illustrates his general attitude in regard to the *philosophers*. Indeed, Scotus does not believe it. When other theologians object to him that according to the Philosopher beatifying knowledge is speculative rather than practical, Duns Scotus does not dispute it. Besides, how could he deny it, he who sees the system's logic laid bare? An intellect-God is therefore nature, and hence necessity and the father of Intelligences whose natural beatitude is to know themselves as

necessary through him—such is certainly the Greco-Arabic universe, where nature, necessity, and intellection join hands. Duns Scotus does not throw the stone at the Philosopher. “The Philosopher posited speculative not practical happiness,” *Felicitatem ponit Philosophus speculativam, non practicam*: this is only too certain, but

> if he had agreed with us that the end must be capable of being loved freely, whether well or badly, and that it can only be well loved by a love in conformity with right reason, which does not simply show him his object but orders him to choose it, perhaps he would have admitted that such knowledge of the end remain practical. Therefore, it is better, if theologians must reject the Philosopher’s minor premise, to be logical enough to reject his conclusion also, than to grant him a conclusion that he himself would not draw, if he rejected the minor premise as the theologian does.[30]

If Aristotle had agreed with the theologians that human beatitude is to enjoy God eternally, and that, even with grace, humans can only attain it by a free act of their own will, perhaps he would indeed have admitted that *our theology* is a practical science. But he certainly would have admitted many other things that would make his doctrine strangely similar to that of Duns Scotus. This marvelous encounter did not happen because Aristotle did not know the Gospel. We may respect Aristotle enough to render him this justice, that if he had changed his minor premise, he would have changed his conclusion. What surprises Friar John Duns is that other theologians were so illogical as to maintain Aristotle’s conclusion while rejecting his minor premise. It is certainly true that this time they and he had the Gospel in common, but there were other differences between them. When Friar John Duns imagines an Aristotle who agreed that beatitude lies not ultimately in knowledge but in love, he does not for a moment picture that, having become Christian, Aristotle could have inadvertently been swept up in the Order of Preachers. Scotus does not even wonder whether Friar Thomas whose curious maneuvers Scotus cannot approve, might not have precisely found a way to receive the Philosopher into St. Dominic’s Order. In order to do so much as

convert Aristotle, Duns Scotus prefers to enroll him immediately among the sons of the Poverello of Assisi. It can be said that this is a great miracle, but the dreams of intelligence reveal the love that feeds them better than his logic.

After Duns Scotus summoned the philosophers to appear before the theologian's tribunal, other theologians have judged Scotus himself over the course of time, and his great surprise would have been to see his theology criticized so often for philosophical reasons. The historian does not have to take part in this debate, but he can understand its nature. A theology's truth is the truth of an understanding of faith, *intellectus fidei*. Accordingly, it must satisfy two conditions: the truth of faith and that of understanding. Hence, there are two possible orders of theological criticism. Does the doctrine in question respect the integrity of the faith and, on the other hand, is it philosophically true from the standpoint of reason?

From the first point of view, the judgment belongs exclusively to the magisterium of the Church, which alone possesses the deposit of faith for a Catholic theologian. Any theology that contradicts revelation or dogma is false in so far as it does so. The authority of the Church judges whether a theology does contradict revelation or dogma. There is no appeal from this judgment, and, since it may be made with a delay of years or even centuries that is required to put a doctrine to the test, doctrines that one was free to hold may cease to be so at any moment. Rome has spoken; the case is closed.

The theologians know it, and that is why that they anticipate the judgment of the Church on the doctrines they criticize. If it can be demonstrated that a certain theology contradicts revelation or dogma, that is the simplest way of getting rid of this theology. Inversely, to get the Church to guarantee the complete orthodoxy of a theology would be a sure way for its adherents to shelter it from any rejection on the grounds of faith. The disciples of Duns Scotus think that Duns Scotus's doctrine was in fact guaranteed by such a document, but that is a sad tale.[31] Under Pope Paul V, the Sacred Congregation reportedly declared Duns Scotus's doctrine immune to censure and forbade the censors to oppose the printing of any authentic work of Duns

Scotus. This occurred a little before 1620, and seemed perfect. However, when Fr. Bonaventure Baron, Luke Wadding's nephew, finally found the collection containing this document and the article and the page, disappointment awaited him: "two sheets were missing, stolen with pincers it seemed," *duo folia deferent, forcibus clepsa, ut videbatur*. No doubt they were Thomist scissors! But Fr. Wilibrord Lampen O. F. M., to whom we owe the narrative, abstains from any hypothesis about who did it, *qui fecit*, to limit himself to what did it, *quid fecit*. His wisdom is all the more praiseworthy, since it would still pose a subtle problem of discernment of spirits even if we knew the agent.

The fact is that with or without such a document, Duns Scotus's theology has traversed the centuries without any ecclesiastical censure and that the more time passes, the less plausible it becomes that any heretofore unsuspected opposition between the doctrine and Catholic dogma could be discovered at this late date after the doctrine has been searched, scrutinized, and discussed in every sense by so many theologians, many of whom did not share Scotus's views. It would be surprising that Rome should take six centuries to notice that opposition in such an important subject. The situation is different. The Church magisterium has recommended the theology of St. Thomas Aquinas as the surest. In the encyclical *Aeterni Patris* Pope Leo XIII did not want to separate that theology from St. Bonaventure's, but Duns Scotus's theology was not excluded. On July 23, 1568, Pope Pius V approved the constitutions of the Conventual Franciscans in the brief *Illa Nos Cura*. The brief provides for two regents in theology, one following Peter Lombard or St. Bonaventure, the other Duns Scotus's speculative theology.[32] Even today, the different families of the Franciscan order, the heir to an ancient and proven theological tradition, sometimes seek their education in St. Bonaventure, sometimes in Duns Scotus, with a marked preference for the latter, but without excluding any theology that has not been deemed unacceptable by the magisterium of the Church and with greater reason a theology that it recommends. One can be Franciscan and Thomist. That even occurs. In any case, no one so far has cited a judgment, whether directly

emanating from the Holy See or not, against teaching Scotist theology. What is true is that Rome dispenses no theologian from its directives, "especially in what concerns the teaching of the Common Doctor, St. Thomas Aquinas."[33] There can only be one common doctor, and it is not Duns Scotus, but the Church can have reasons to recommend in other respects a doctor who is not the common doctor, as it has done for St. Bonaventure. The Church can have still other reasons not to find a theologian unacceptable, when it sees how he has been followed for centuries by a great religious order whose preferred master he is. Would so much science and Christian virtue be nourished by a poisonous theology? Rather than living upon that theology, the science and virtue ought to have died a long time ago. The history of the Church has not ended, and if Rome one day were to pronounce itself against this theology, the only Scotist reply would be that of Duns Scotus himself regarding the sacraments of the Church: "One should judge about Scotus's philosophy as the Roman Church judges," *Sentiendum est de theologia Scoti, sicut sentit Romana Ecclesia*.[34] That day has not come and, although it is not impossible that it could come, as of 1950 it is extremely improbable.

Accordingly, the debate ought to be carried out in the terrain of understanding, not of faith. Their nature is completely different since the issue is no longer the truth of revelation, but the truth of the philosophy the theologian utilizes to reach the understanding of the faith that the doctrine presupposes. Not only respect for the magisterium of the Church, but also the very essence of theology demands the unconditional respect for revealed truth and for the dogmas that define it; an *intellectus fidei* that is mistaken about faith is a contradictory notion. Insofar as a doctrine is philosophical, it is called *true* according to the judgment of natural reason, so that the coexistence of different theologies, for example, those of St Bonaventure and St. Thomas Aquinas, is explained in the last analysis by two different uses of natural reason in search of an understanding of faith.

What is the nature of this difference? Some explain it by the absolute transcendence of faith in respect to all its rational interpretations. This transcendence is real, but it explains that even the best theology is inadequate

to its object. The transcendence does not justify the conclusion that several theologies can be equally valid, as if all their differences were insignificant, given their distance from their object. Strictly speaking, it can be held that two different theologies practically amount to the same thing, provided that they satisfy the demands of faith equally. Even that is not sure, and it cannot be maintained at the speculative level in any case. We would have to choose between different philosophical positions, sometimes so openly contradictory that they cannot both be true at the same time and in the same regard. The certainty of scientific knowledge requires an illuminating of the human intellect distinct from the general influence of God, as St. Bonaventure would have it, or else the general influence is enough, given the intellect, as St. Thomas would have it. We must choose: if one of the two positions is true, the other is false. The implications of such a choice are numerous, but the two positions cannot be true at the same time. The same remark applies to Duns Scotus: being is analogous or it is univocal. In the measure in which Scotus's theology and that of St. Thomas use a metaphysical notion of being, if their ways of conceiving being contradict each other, their theologies contradict each other, not from the point of view of faith, which is the same, but from that of understanding, which is not. When a theologian uses philosophy, it remains integrally philosophy, or his theology could not use it. Consequently, what it says is philosophically true or false, and in the measure in which a true or false philosophy is integrated into his theology, his theology becomes true or false in the same measure. It is therefore an illusion to believe that, because several different theologies exist, they are equivalent. On the points where they are complementary, their differences present no problem, but the problem is posed when they contradict each other. If Gaunilo speaks the truth, St. Anselm is mistaken. If the theology of univocity is true, that of analogy is false, and inversely.

Some see a scandal here, but wrongly. Firstly, the truth of faith remains outside these differences; its unity transcends the plurality of these theologies, and because faith belongs to a different order, it is no way affected.[35] Besides, if there were a scandal here, it would be philosophical

and not theological. Fully aware that we are approaching an area full of pitfalls, we enter it with fear and trembling. But for others to exercise their function, which is to denounce error, it is certainly necessary that some should try to speak the truth. This is less easy. It is a fact that there are different philosophies; that these philosophies, precisely as philosophies, fall directly under natural reason; and that, however, in order to have only one philosophy of the type called *Scholastic*, it would be necessary for theologians to agree unanimously about philosophy as they do about faith. It follows from this that if the Church imposes a single Scholastic theology, St. Thomas Aquinas's for example, she imposes, in the name of the deposit of faith of which she is the guardian, a single philosophy, that of St. Thomas Aquinas. The Church could do so, for reasons of discipline for example, but she has not, and we do not have to speculate about a situation that does not exist.

The situation that exists is enough to feed our reflection, and its nature is such that in the measure of their possibilities, some aspire to suppress it. For those who attach no importance to philosophy or those who believe that philosophy is marred by essential relativity, there is no problem. Unfortunately, among those for whom metaphysics is capable of attaining apodictic certainty based on the evidence of first principles of natural reason, some do not comprehend that the only effective weapons in philosophy are philosophical themselves, and that the only way to guarantee the undisputed victory of a single metaphysics is to demonstrate rationally that it is true. The fact that the dispute exists ought to make the solution obvious but, in their passionate pleas for the rights of pure natural reason, they do not suspect the degree to which they show themselves to be theologians.

The very nature of Scholastic theology explains the problem's existence and complexity. All theologians without exception agree on three fundamental positions: the certainty of faith, which rests upon God's word, is superior to that of science, which only depends upon reason; in order to achieve a certain understanding of faith, it is useful for theology to appeal to natural reason, notably to metaphysics; the metaphysician's vision turns out

to be weakest at the moment when his natural reason is concerned with the highest objects, among them, the objects of the theologian. Thus, the Scholastic theologians call upon a knowledge, that of science, which *qua* knowledge is superior, to serve a knowledge that is inferior *qua* knowledge but superior in certainty, that of faith, Where the less certain cooperates in the task of the more certain, we cannot be surprised if some de facto pluralism appears? The contradictions of the philosophers are a theme familiar to the Church Fathers, who have always contrasted them with the unity of faith. The quickest glance at contemporary philosophy lets one see clearly that this continues to be true. It was always so, even in the Middle Ages, but the situation remained simple as long as basically the Christian religion was on one side, and philosophy on the other. It became complex at the instant when Scholastic theologians consciously introduced philosophy into their exposition of faith, *inmiscendo philosophiam Scripturae Sacrae et praecipue metaphysicalia*. Metaphysics entered its Christian state at this moment but, although it gained a great deal in stability and unity, it did not thereby cease to be metaphysics. Its nature stayed the same, whether in Albert the Great, Bonaventure, Thomas, or Duns Scotus. This philosophical pluralism is neither necessary, nor good, but it exists. In order to reduce it, we only dispose of philosophical methods, all of which have revealed themselves to be ineffective from the thirteenth century to our times. The existence of failure does not make it legitimate for us to resign ourselves to it. The unity that the past did not create may be ahead of us in the future, but at least two things are certain: it is imprudent to expect a philosophical unity equal to the unity of faith, because the light is not the same in the two areas. In order to obtain the unity of reason in the measure that is possible, it is necessary to have confidence in reason.

This is what Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus did after and before many others, but with outstanding gifts. To such a degree were they eminent theologians that the more one is studied, the better the other is understood. Moreover, their very differences teach us about the factual conditions that influence philosophical reflections. The true is necessary, but there is much

that is contingent in the circumstances amid which the philosopher seeks the true and expresses it. A thirteenth-century Augustine would have written works different from the ones we know. No doubt he would greatly resemble Thomas Aquinas, because his education would not have been as a reader of Plotinus, but as a reader of Aristotle. Thomas Aquinas himself explained very well the historical reasons for the differences between his peculiar language and that of the Bishop of Hippo. Since their philosophical techniques are not thesame, their understanding of faith is no longer identical: “And therefore Augustine, who was imbued with the doctrines of the Platonists, if he found anything adapted to faith in their sayings, took it up. The things he found opposed to our faith, he changed for the better.”[36] A doctrine is affected no less by what it improves than by what it accepts unchanged. Writing after the condemnation of 1277, which was a foregone conclusion for him, Duns Scotus no longer encounters philosophers in the same situation as Thomas Aquinas. Confronted by the offensive of philosophical naturalism, the task of defending theology seems more urgent to Scotus than that of taking up philosophy. With a different intellectual formation, Scotus’s mind has trouble seeing the astonishing way in which Thomas Aquinas’s Aristotelian expressions transcend Aristotelianism. We have been misled about this often enough to have no taste for reproaching Scotus. Let us add to the fact that, by his whole intellectual bent, Duns Scotus belongs to the philosophical family of metaphysicians of essence, and also that the act of being, without which nothing remains of Thomism but the name, is radically alien to Scotus. From that comes the quasi-permanent misunderstanding between him and Aquinas. To this misunderstanding we owe the most elevated metaphysical dialogue of history, in which *entitas* is sought after and its necessary determinations are found without recurring to the act of esse *even* once. Here again, the better one interlocutor is understood, the better the other is too, and understanding both is useful for someone who, in the last analysis, wants to know why his judgment says yes and why his judgment says no. The issue is more or less about light here, but it is the same light clarifying the same object at different degrees of depth.

In principle, all intellects rightly using the same light ought to coincide in their conclusions, but it is all too evident that they do not. It can be hoped, with different amounts of optimism, that they may do so someday. The old theological argument *by the contradictions of the philosophers* is perhaps not close to fading away in the face of the argument *by the common affirmation of the philosophers*. No science will be able to prove the evidence of the first principles. As the light of the intellect, the first principles are the conditions of all knowledge, even metaphysical knowledge. In respect to their evidence, First Philosophy does nothing but take note of it and defend it against those who dispute it. That it can be disputed is a problem all by itself, but it certainly can be established against those who reject these principles that the deniers employ them in order to deny them. The real difficulty lies elsewhere. If metaphysics limited itself to taking note of the first principles and to bringing out their evidence from the objectors that dispute them, its work would be simple. It is not difficult to show that in fact the human intellect cannot fail to hold the real to be intelligible and only conceives it as made of substances linked by relations of efficient causality, which are controlled by teleological relations. Even when the most fervent advocates of scientistic positivism criticize these notions, they do not cease for an instant to use them. After our learned scientistic positivist has established that he acknowledges neither efficient nor final causes, when he worries about his health, he consults a physician about the cause of his illness and asks him for a remedy in order to be cured. The evidence of the first principles can be defended effectively by showing that, otherwise, the intellect cannot think.

This is not all of metaphysics, even regarding principles, because once their formal necessity is acknowledged and assured, metaphysics tries to penetrate its meaning, and the question changes character. Let us take for example the principle of principles, the nature of being, that which first comes before the intellect *id quod primum cadit in intellectu*. Every human intellect, the crudest and most highly abstract alike, can only conceive something as a being, in and by being. The metaphysician enjoys no privilege in this regard, except that, by going beyond implicit common sense knowledge of being, he

becomes aware how the concept of being plays the role of first principle and makes it the object of a wisdom, which is the science of being as being. It is a real science, if there is one, and its object is to delve into the very content of the notions whose formal necessity governs our thought. This task imposes itself inescapably upon our thought, because the formal necessity of the principle is only the sign of the intelligible necessity of being itself, as it is in itself, independently of the knowledge we have of it. Because being is what it is, it is identical to itself and excludes all contradiction. Being is not itself conformed to the first principles; the first principles say what it is.

What is being? Aristotle already observed that this is an old question, and more than twenty centuries have slipped by without rejuvenating it. Given that the first principle of knowledge is evident and necessary, it might be asked why so many metaphysicians are still unable to reach agreement about the reality that grounds being. The surprise we feel perhaps comes from a misunderstanding about the object of metaphysics. Once agreement is established regarding the number, meaning, and order of the first principles of metaphysical science, once their evidence, their necessity, and their value as real knowledge has been established, it will still remain for us to delve into its content. Here metaphysics must pay the price of its noble rank, and metaphysics has known that for a long time. We know everything in the first evidence of being, which is itself a mystery, and though known by every intellect, still reveals everything it is to none. Moreover, this is why the history of metaphysics is a quest for being, a quest that had already been going on for a long time in Aristotle's day, as book I of the *Metaphysics* testifies. After Aristotle, it was taken up again by Plotinus, Augustine, Thomas Aquinas, Duns Scotus, Ockham, and so many more, whose lineage has not been extinguished. Historicism is an error, but denying history is another, because it happened, and if we trust the principle of sufficient reason, there must be intelligible reasons for it to have happened one way rather than another. They are subjective in great measure, and Thomas Aquinas enumerated them explicitly. Intellectual shortcomings, family responsibilities, laziness, and so many causes leave only a few persons free

for the great work of seeking the truth, especially the truth of metaphysics, the highest and last science that the human intellect can naturally tackle. But there are also objective reasons that are due to the fact that the more we approach a pure intelligible, the less capable our eye is of fixing its gaze upon it. Like a nocturnal bird, humans only see in the light of dusk or rather of dawn, in this kind of *intellectual chiaroscuro* that is rightly mentioned and that is our normal condition in regard to intelligible. Being does not escape this rule. Grasped by the intellect, whose judgments it grounds, we immediately see how mysterious it is in the fact that the word that designates it is a verb.[37] This is why, however evident and necessary it is, our first knowledge of real being does not attain it in its totality or in its ultimate depth. Being contains something obscure along with what is very clear about it, and not just by the nature of the terms it unites. Like the clarity of every true mystery, being's obscurity is in its very clarity. We can only think in it and by it, but the act of judging is carried out in a light whose evidence, because it transcends the order of essence, does not let itself be completely included in the definition of a concept.

Therein, it seems, is the deepest reason explaining the coexistence of several metaphysics. If our vision of the first principles exhausted its content, or simple penetrated into it to its depth, there would only be one metaphysics. However, we find St. Thomas, who holds that being is analogous, and Scotus, who holds that being is univocal. When one has spent each day of his life in wonderment at the act of being, how could he conceive the possibility of breathing in another metaphysical climate? From the outset we communicate with the existents in this world as one among them. We touch them and we see them by our bodily eyes and by the vision of the intellect. We know they are all created from nothing, maintained in their duration out of nothing, and inhabited from within by Him Who Is their cause and their end. How can we fail to affirm the evidence unshakably once we have seen it? It is not a problem of evidence, but of communication of evidence, and it is certainly necessary to seek the reason for our failure to communicate the evidence in our manner of attaining the object of metaphysics.

By definition, the first principle has no principle. It is not even its own principle, so much so that we can only see it and show it or not see it and not possess it. This is not a scandal but the human condition, because the objects that are most certain by nature are least certain by the weakness of our intellect.[38] Our intellect's first principles are eminently like this. The intellect judges by them, but none of them, being, causality, or teleology, gives up its whole mystery to the intellect when shedding its light on the intellect. When we attempt to delve into its nature, we no longer view being precisely as a principle but as an object, because its character of first principle does not constitute its nature. It flows from its nature. Because it is being, it is principle, not inversely. Consequently, we should not be surprised that by entering into the light from which metaphysical knowledge springs, even minds that see being clearly enough to see it as first principle, hesitate and sometimes distance themselves when they come to say what being is. This is what happened to Duns Scotus coming after Thomas Aquinas. Both of them looked at being, the same being but they did not see exactly the same thing, and the dialogue continues among their disciples because what one sees and would like to make the others see, he cannot demonstrate to him but only show.

What attitude we should adopt in the face of this situation? We should certainly regard as an error that which we see is an error. Otherwise we would have the strict duty to change our metaphysics, and consequently change our theology. But what good is it to denounce as false that which we cannot demonstrate to be false, even if we see it that way? In this particular case, what profit would result for truth? The only effective way of serving the truth in such matters is for each intellect in turn to try to see what any other one shows him, while confining himself to show what he sees. The great metaphysical peace of being will do its task at these heights, not in indifference but rather in fraternity in a common effort to see the source of all certainties at the extreme limit to which sight can be forced. The point is simply to acknowledge that, in the presence of its highest object, the intellect that is surest about the truth, lacking weapons to impose it on others, is

situated in an order where denouncing does not serve truth in any way, a unique case. Why do we not carry our certainties in peace? “There are some who presume of their wits so that they esteem that they can measure the whole nature of things with their intellect, namely judging true whatever that appears to them and false what does not appear to them.”[39] St. Thomas does not like this presumption very much. He prefers “a modest search for truth.” To follow him by recommending this modesty is not to yield to skepticism or to renounce the unity of minds in truth, but to recall the source of the truths. St. Thomas himself specifies this source in the same place, and it is not metaphysics. To cure the human mind of its presumption, “it was necessary for human beings that something be divinely set forth that completely exceeds the human intellect,” *necessarium fuit homini proponi quaedam divinitus quae omnino intellectum ejus excederent.* We do not denigrate philosophy by preferring revelation to it as the source of harmony in certainty. Perhaps this is why the Church, under its vigilant magisterium, allows theologians to scrutinize freely the mystery of being, in the unity of a faith whose peace their noble emulation does not perturb. They themselves will never work too much at knowing each other better in order to understand each other, and this is before they will be joined in the light if no human word dares to divide those whom the light of God has united.

Notes

1 Ernest Renan, *Histoire littéraire de la France*, vol. 25, p. 424.—Seeberg, *Die Theologie de Johannes Duns Scotus*, p. 54, note 1, judges that Renan exaggerates about intolerance, but that overall his judgment faithfully reflects the impression left by Duns Scotus’s writings.

2 Mauritius a Portu, Epistola Proemialis, *In Metaphysicam*, Wadding edition, vol. IV, p. 508: “Verba ipsa Scotica habent nescio quid latentis energiae, quo fit ut qui se hujus viri discipulum appelari cupit, is ejus scripta legat necesse sit.”

3 Fr. Balić, who is interested in nothing but the truth and who speaks here from experience, is amused by those who claim that Duns Scotus is obscure only by dint of being too clear. Such is not Fr. Balić’s opinion, nor ours. With him, we would say rather: “Fatendum tamen est duriusculum esse Scoti sermonem,” or with William of Vaurouillon: “ejus dicta communem transcendunt facultatem,” in Balić, *Annua Relatio Commisionis Scotisticae* Quaracchi, vol. IX (1949), p. 24.

4 By that we understand in the modern sense, a linear dialectical systematization like those of Spinoza or Hegel, for example. Scotus’s theology is still more hostile to that than the theology of

Thomas Aquinas. The latter, which sought to be a science of the relations of the creation to God and of nature to grace, still had to make room for the story of the Incarnation and the Redemption, Marie-Dominique Chenu, *Introduction à l'étude de saint Thomas d'Aquin* (Paris: J. Vrin, 1950), pp. 269–70; *Towards Understanding Saint Thomas*, trans. A. M. Landry and D. Hughes (Chicago: Henry Regnery, 1964). Duns Scotus remains faithful to the Augustinian theology of *states*, which is a theology of history. That is why the *Opus Oxoniense* begins by posing the question of the last end, not that of *sacra doctrina* in itself, and, in this context, defines the status of human beings, of their intellect, of *our* philosophy, and of *our* theology. This difference of initial positions affects the content of the two theologies. Duns Scotus also wants to construct his theology as a science, but the science of a history can only be a science of the contingent. This is why, by building his whole work on the Incarnation, instead of inserting the Incarnation within the work, Duns Scotus is naturally led to emphasize, in everything that concerns *actio ad extra*, the notions of life, will, freedom, and omnipotence. In such a theology they must pass into the foreground. Scotus's special adversary, consequently, becomes Greek necessitarianism, represented by the *philosophers*. As Fr. Chenu, *Introduction*, pp. 272–73, has profoundly seen, it is the essential difference in content that makes it impossible to compose a Scotist "summa" according to the formula and plan of St. Thomas's *Summa*.

5 At first sight this seems to bring Duns Scotus close to Thomas Aquinas: *Formalissime semper loquitur*. . . . But a great deal of Scotism has been poured into Thomism. Duns Scotus criticized Thomas Aquinas for having maintained that the *habitus* of science is one and indivisible, notwithstanding the specific difference of objects and acts. Scotus himself, by contrast, maintained that there are as many specifically distinct formal sciences as there are specifically distinct formal conclusions. See *In Metaphysicam*, book VI question 1, numbers 3–7 [EW II, pp. 6–13]. Therefore, in Duns Scotus we are dealing with a formalism that is not only more thorough but different.

6 We cannot resist citing the little known passage in Fr. Carolus Balić, where, with his keen historical sense he describes how the texts have been gathered, which the Scotist Commission strives to put in order. Balić, *Solemnis Inauguratio anni 1943–44 Studiorum Commissionis Scotistica*e (Quaracchi, 1944), p. 32: "Disciples and masters, supporters and adversaries, Friars Minor and Friars of the Order of Preachers, members of different religious orders and secular priests sought to obtain everything that Duns Scotus was reputed to have said or written. While the Subtle Doctor composed his *Opus Oxoniense*, where he wanted to tell posterity what he thought about different problems that the *Book of Sentences* poses, copybooks, notes, and various writings circulated almost everywhere. They more or less faithfully and more or less clearly reproduced his teaching. All that was done partly from what Duns Scotus had said in his course, partly from his own workbooks and his own notes, partly from talks he gave his colleagues or his confrères, and even from remarks that he managed to make to his friends."—This is the exact truth.

7 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 24, sole question, numbers 15–18.

8 Duns Scotus, *Collationes* X, number 4: "Quodlibet theologus fatetur quod potest ostendere naturaliter fidem suam non esse impossibilem, ne illa esse impossibilia quae credimus, dum potest solvere rationes in contrarium fidem impugantes; sed quod non est impossiblile, est possibile; ergo theologus potest ostendere per rationem naturalem et probare omnia credibilia esse possibilia, ut Deum esse trinuus . . . ergo per rationem naturalem potest concludere quod Deum esse trinum et unum est possibile necessarium, et sic de aliis."—Cf. A.-M. Vellico, O.F.M., "De Charactere Scientifico Theologiae apud Doctorem Subtilem," *Antonianum* 16 (1941), pp. 3–30: bibliography, p. 4, note 1.

9 Duns Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book I, distinction 42, question 2, article 6: "Licet

secundum rei veritatem non concludatur contradictio, tamen non est evidens nobis quod non includatur, sicut de aliis articulis fidei."

10 Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense* book II, distinction 1, question 3, number 10, volume II, pp. 40–41 [CE VII, pp. 69–71]. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book II, distinction 1 question 4, number 18.

11 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 24, sole question, number 20: "Cum inconcusse crediderint scripturis sanctis tamquam veracissimis testibus, agant orando, quaerendo, et bene vivendo, ut intelligant, id est ut quantum videri potest, videatur mente, quod teneatur fide."—St. Augustine, *De Trinitate* XV, chapter 27, 49, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. XLII, column 1096.

12 This is only an inference on our part, but it seems useful and justified. Fr. Parthenius Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. I, p. 582, responding to Erdmann's remarks that, "Saepe *philosophi* et *Catholici* uni aliis opponuntur apud Scotum," declares, "Absque dubio, sed non Philosophia et Catholica fides." (Translator: This exchanged has guided my translation of the very obscure sentence in the text contrasting opposition to philosophers and philosophy.) To this, we in turn add, "absque dubio," but Duns Scotus does not speak even to say that there is not opposition between them. In other words, Duns Scotus does not say either that philosophy and faith are opposed or that they are not opposed. He does not talk about it at all. It is just that, when he wants "to prove" that natural reason cannot know something, he regularly gives as "proof" of this that philosophers did not know it. This does not prove that natural reason in itself could not know it, but since it cannot do so starting from the principles of the philosophers, in practice it cannot. It will be said: let the philosophers change principles. Certainly, but outside of the principles of the *philosophers*, there are only the principles of the *theologians*. Inversely, in the case in which philosophy is not mixed with theology and remains within the limits of its competence, Duns Scotus is ready to listen to it. If the philosopher in question meddles with medicine, which is another manner of exceeding his competence, Duns Scotus prefers to hear the physician. Let Aristotle give way to Galen then! Cf. *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 4, question 2, number 7.—Duns Scotus was not the first to use this disjunction. Marie-Dominque Chenu, "Les 'philosophes' dans la philosophie chrétienne médiévale," *Revue des sciences philosophiques et théologiques* 26 (1937), pp. 27–40. See by the same author, *Introduction à l'étude de saint Thomas d'Aquin*, p. 264. But this distinction does not play the same role in the two doctrines and in reality it only partly means the same thing. In Thomas Aquinas, *In II Sententiarum* (prologue), the philosophers consider natures in themselves; the theologian considers them as having issued from God and going to return to him: a simple distinction of two sciences by their objects. In Duns Scotus, the philosophers are those who, since they only consider natures in themselves, naturally tend to think only in terms of necessity to the detriment of freedom.

13 We do not claim that Duns Scotus was unaware of the abstract terms *philosophia* and *theologia*. We have already encountered them, and we are going to read particular texts where he contrasts them, but in his eyes they represent rather the work of philosophers and the work of theologians than abstract essences.

14 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 43, question 3, number 18.

15 In his *Ensayo sobre el voluntarismo de J. Duns Escoto*, p. 57, Joaquin Carreras y Artau makes the following astute observation: "The distinction we have noted between the two orders of truths, philosophical and theological, also constitutes the dividing line between two very pronounced tendencies in Scotus's doctrine, rationalism and voluntarism." No formula—whether our own or of others—can exactly define a position that Duns Scotus has not defined, but, although the preceding is also open to discussion, it certainly comes from a sound intuition. In Duns Scotus's own view, the *philosophers* are certainly intellectualists and the *theologian* is certainly a defender of freedom of the will.

16 Parthenius Minges, *J.D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 581. Minges argues against Erdmann's remarks in *Theologische Studien und Kritken*, 1863, p. 413.

17 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book IV, distinction 49, question 5, number 6: "Tales igitur, qui sic dicunt, miscent philosophiam cum theologia."—Cf. the parallel text already quoted, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 1, number 12 [CE I, pp. 19–20], where Avicenna is directly challenged. Duns Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book III, distinction 24, sole question, number 16, does not contradict him at all by praising the Doctors who ultimately explained Scripture "immiscendo philosophiam Scripturae Sacrae; quod sine dubio multum valet, et praecipue metaphysicalia, ut veritas Scripturae de Trinitate et Intelligentiis abstractis intelligatur." He has not ceased doing this himself, but "immiscendo" here means "to introduce into" and not "to mix with." Furthermore, Scotus immediately specifies that when a premise is the object of faith, the conclusion remains a conclusion of faith, whatever the amount of philosophy that is introduced into the argument. With greater reason, the totality remains theological.

18 Minges, *J. D. Scoti Doctrina*, vol. II, p. 582.

19 See chapter I, pp. 72–84 in Gilson, *Jean Duns Scot* (check internal reference).

20 We do not claim in any way to deny that it is legitimate to speak today of *Scotist* philosophy. We simply say that, except for logic, almost all that would appear there would be extracted from writings where Duns Scotus expressed himself as a theologian with complete awareness of the distinction that this label introduced between him and the *philosophers*. We do not deny that there is a right to divide his doctrine into *philosophy* and *theology*, but we deny that this division is his.

21 See the first two texts inscribed as the epigraph of this book.

22 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book I, distinction 42, sole question, number 3, volume I, p. 1267 [CE VI, pp. 344–45]: "philosophi non potuerunt per rationem naturalem concludere Deum posse contingenter causare." See also notably: "Praeterea si philosophi posuerunt Deum esse necessario agentem, sicut videntur multi eorum sensisse et posuisse . . ."

23 Duns Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia* book III, distinction 24, sole question, number 4.—Cf. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* part I, question 1, article 2, body of article, and *Summa Theologiae* IIa IIae, question 1, article 5.

24 Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 24, sole question, number 6.—Cf. number 22: "Ad secundum dicendum quod non sequitur quod perspectivus . . ."

25 It would be contradictory to maintain the opposite, Scotus, *Reportata Parisiensia*, book III, distinction 24, sole question, number 22: "Secundo patet ex parte impossibilitatis habituum: nam ad scientiam proprie dictam requiritur evidentia objecti; evidentia autem objecti repugnat fidei, quae est de non visis. Ideo dico quod scientia et fides non possunt simul esse in eodem et hoc respectu ejusdem."—This distinction poses no problem in the case of the dogma of the Trinity, which evidently falls under the theologian's competence alone. There are truths "quae videntur maxime theologicae, et non metaphysicae, ut Deus *trinus* et *Pater generat* Filium," *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 4, article 5, number 32, volume I, p. 105 [CE I, p. 210]. But what should we make of things that are not *maxime theologicae*. For there are some things, notably God's *essentialia*, about which we can know a great deal in metaphysics. It is necessary to respond to this question with what Duns Scotus has already told us and that we recall: sciences are distinguished by their objects. Therefore, even if "essentialia plurima possunt a nobis in metaphysica cognosci," *ibidem*, our knowledge of them remains relatively metaphysical but it is absolutely theological because it bears upon God. The same proposition cannot simultaneously belong to two sciences, *because they are not the same thing*.

26 We allow ourselves to insist on this point, because it is central to the interpretation of Scotism:

humans are no longer in their natural state, and the example of the greatest philosophers suggests that natural reason alone could never know that. Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book II, distinction 29, sole question, number 3, vol. II, p. 739: “Praeterea tunc posset cognosci et rationem naturalem hunc statum non esse naturalem; quia manifestum est nunc esse rebellionem in potentiis inferioribus, et, per te, non potest esse, nisi corrumpatur rectitudo voluntatis: consequens est inconveniens, quia praeclarissimi philosophi ad hoc pertingere non potuerunt.”

27 We say, “originate” but not that Duns Scotus himself wrote it. This expression is found in the apocryphal collection *Quaestiones Miscellaniae de Formalitatibus*, question 5, number 34, Vivès, volume V, p. 402: “ex puris naturalibus multi catholici doctores perfectiorem conceptum habuerunt de Deo quam aliquis philosophus.”

28 This does not mean approximative and less rigorous speculative knowledge, but knowledge naturally capable of serving as a guide to action. Here as elsewhere, *notitia est notitia tantum*. What cannot serve as a rule for action is speculative; what can is practical.—On the important concept of praxis, see Marianus Müller, O. F. M., “Theologie als Weisheit nach Scotus,” in *Sechste und siebte Lektorenkonferenz der deutschen Franziskaner für Philosophie und Theologie* (Werl im Westfalia, 1934), pp. 33–51.

29 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 4, article 5, number 17, volume I, p. 92 [CE I, pp. 185–86]: “Ostensio autem finis in theologia est finis non in universali, sed in particulari, quia ad metaphysicum pertinet illa ostensio in universali.”

30 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, prologue, question 4, article 5, number 23, vol. I, p. 99. [CE I, p. 196 for the Latin. I cannot find the translated passage either there or at Vivès, vol. VIII, p. 250.]

31 The documents are put forward by Hugo Cavellus, *Vita Joannis Duns Scoti, Doctoris Subtilis*, Antwerp, 1620, chapter 5, no page.—Cf. Hurter, *Nomenclator litterarius*, vol. V, Oeniponte [Innsbruck]: 1899, col. 369, and the whole narrative of Willibrord Lampen, O.F.M., *Beatus Joannes Duns Scotus et Sancta Sedes* (Quaracchi, 1929), pp. 26–28.

32 Lampen, *Scotus et Sancta Sedes*, p. 29. Concerning St. Bonaventure, see Leo XIII’s letter of December 13, 1885, pp. 39–42, and Benedict XV’s letter of June 25, 1921, p. 51. Rome’s preference among Franciscan masters is visibly given to the Seraphic Doctor rather than to Duns Scotus.

33 Letter of Cardinal Gasparri on the twenty-fifth anniversary of *Études franciscaines*, May 28, 1925, Lampen, *Scotus et Sancta Sedes*, p. 55.

34 Scotus, *Opus Oxoniense*, book IV, distinction 6, question 9, number 14 [CE XI, p. 370]: “Sentiendum est de sacramentis ecclesiae, sicut sentit Romana Ecclesia.”

35 This implies no reservation about the concept of *philosophia perennis* that Leibniz made famous in his letter of August 26, 1714, to Rémond, Gerhardt ed., *Leibniz: Philosophische Schriften*, vol. III, p. 424 f. But this *perennis quaedam philosophia* is not a particular philosophy in Leibniz. It is the continued effort of philosophers to save what is true in all their predecessors. No one has practiced this method more consciously than the Scholastic theologians, and Leibniz knew it. As has been correctly observed, *philosophia perennis* thus conceived is “deeply rooted in religion” and “only religious faith allows it to be constructed and grounded.”—Cf. Engert, “Ueber den Gedanken einer *philosophia perennis*,” *Philosophische Jahrbuch* XLIX (1926), p. 127.

36 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, part I, question 84, article 5, body of the article.

37 Reginald Garrigou-Lagrange, *Le sense du mystère et le clair-obscur intellectuel*, Paris: Desclée de Brouwer, 1934, pp. 74–76, see p. 95.

38 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentes*, book I, chapter 5.

39 Ibid.: “Sunt enim quidam tantum de suo ingenio praesumentes ut totam rerum naturam se reputent suo intellectu posse metiri, aestimantes scilicet totum esse verum quod eis videtur, et falsum quod eis non videtur.”

Appendices

The following notes merely attempt to sum up the current state of our knowledge about the life and works of Duns Scotus. They contain nothing original. We cannot even claim that they are complete, because studies on Duns Scotus are widely scattered and doubtless many have escaped our notice. We do not pretend that they are up to date, because the bibliography on the work of the Subtle Doctor is not remained, and we move in quicksand in this area.

A Bibliographical information

Almost nonexistent in the time of Ernest Renan, the Subtle Doctor's biography has been enriched recently, thanks particularly to the patient insights of Fr. Ephrem Longpré, O. F. M., with whom we must associate Fr. André Callebaut, O. F. M.

John Duns Scotus was not English or even Irish, but Scottish. He was born in Maxton, County Roxburgh, which the River Tweed separates from the County of Berwick, where there is a village called Duns that may have been the cradle of the family. Berwick County has always been such a bone of contention between Scotland and England that even today it is officially regarded as neutral territory, not assigned to either country. Perhaps this explains that, by connecting Duns Scotus to the village of Duns, some have turned Duns Scotus into an Englishman, but besides the fact that he was called *Scotus* early on, the area of Littledean and the village of Maxton, where he was born, are as unquestionably Scottish as the county of Roxburgh to which they belong. Scotus's date of birth, 1266, and his Scottish roots are now certain.[1]

The little Roxburgh town had a Franciscan convent, to which the Duns family gave a plot of land in 1234 that served as the convent cemetery. John Duns was educated in the schools of Haddington in the County of the same name, located to the north of Berwick County. In 1277 at the age of eleven, his uncle Friar Helias Duns brought the boy to the Franciscan convent of Dumfries of which he was the guardian. There, around 1281, John Duns Scotus took the Franciscan habit.[2]

Fourteen years later, on March 17, 1291, at Lincoln, Bishop Oliver Sutton ordained Duns Scotus a priest at the age of twenty-five. Since Scotus's name does not appear on the list of the three ordinations that took place in the diocese during 1290, it can be admitted that he had been there for a short time, but we do not know that, nor do we know about his life between 1277 and 1291. Here it would be very easy to imagine what is likely and furthermore may be true but that would be to write footnotes to history. The date, at least, is certain, and we must be content with it.[3]

It is possible, and even probable, that Duns Scotus then went to the University of Paris in 1292. In any case, it is very possible that Duns Scotus studied there from 1293 to 1296.[4] Indeed, he commented on the *Sentences* in Paris in 1302. For that, the University regulations required nine years of prior theological study of which the Mendicants had to do at least four years in Paris; the other five could be spent in a *studium generale* of their order. To be able to comment on the *Sentences* in 1302, Duns Scotus had to have studied at Paris at least from 1293 to 1296, although he might have begun in 1292. During those years our young Franciscan's professor is believed to have been Gonzalo de Balboa,[5] whose *Conclusiones Metaphysicae* were to be included later within those of Duns Scotus.[6] Another professor was William of Ware,[7] whose thought is insufficiently known for us to be able to say exactly what influence it may have exercised upon the formation of the Subtle Doctor.

After Duns Scotus's first four-year stay in Paris, he returns to Oxford University to give his first commentary on the *Sentences*, his famous *Opus Oxoniense*. The work is quite long, and although it has been traditionally agreed that its composition should be placed in the years that follow Scotus's

stay in Paris (therefore between 1297 and 1302), we do not know exactly how to situate it within this period. The Prologue, question II, number 9, gives its date as 1300 (if our text is correct, and we are not dealing with a subsequent addition). Book IV, distinction 15, number 1, cites a bull issued by Pope Benedict XI in 1302, consequently after Scotus's teaching stint at Oxford. But here again, we cannot count on the text available to us. Since the custom was to comment on the *Sentences* over a two-year period (certain commentators were satisfied with just one year), it is probably that Duns Scotus did so during the last two years of his stay in Oxford, that is 1300–1301.

In 1302, we encounter a date that is certain, because during the two years 1302–1303 Duns Scotus commented on the *Sentences* for the second time in the role of a sentential bachelor, but this time at the University of Paris.[8] The *Reportata Parisiensia* derive from this teaching assignment. This second stay in Paris was interrupted in June 1303, when Duns Scotus refused to sign Philip the Fair's appeal to the Council against Pope Boniface VIII. That excellent historian of Scotus, Fr. Ephrem Longpré, awards the highest honor to that refusal, and we do not intend to diminish Scotus's merit,[9] but the refusal was less unusual among foreign than French religious. However that may be, the foreigners who refused to sign the appeal to the council had "to vacate the realm," which Duns Scotus probably did between June 25 and June 28, 1303.[10] He did so, if the degree expelling foreigners uncooperative with the appeal was immediately applied to all without exception.

Here the Subtle Doctor disappears for some time, but he reappears from 1304 on, when he is sent back to Paris, where he almost certainly won the rank of Master of Theology during 1305.[11] This is not absolutely sure. By contrast, we know that Scotus was sent to the Cologne *studium generale*[12] in 1307, where he died on November 8, 1308. His very fruitful literary career thus lasted for almost ten years.

Duns Scotus is given the title of "Blessed" in virtue of an immemorial cult, whose existence was officially reported by the Bishop of Nola in 1710.[13] His solemn beatification has not yet taken place. (Translator: Pope John Paul II

beatified Scotus on March 20, 1993.)

B Biographical information

The most frequently used edition is the *Opera Omnia, Quaestiones in Libro Sententiarum*, Lyon, 1639, in 12 folio volumes, commonly designated the *Wadding edition*, although others cooperated in it. It is often quoted according to the re-edition of Vivès, Paris: 1891–1895, which contains additionally the *De Perfectione Statuum*.

Some remarks follow on the 12 volumes of the Wadding edition.

Volume I

1. *Grammatica Speculativa Scoti*—Apocryphal. The real author is Thomas of Erfurt, O. F. M. See Martin Grabmann, "De Thoma Erfordiensi Auctore *Grammaticae* quae Joanni Duns Scoto Adscribitur *Speculativae*," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* 15 (1922), pp. 273–77.
2. *In Universam Logicam Quaestiones*

   Wadding, vol. I, p. 79: "Scripsit autem Scotus ista adolescientiori aetate; unde nihil mirum quod provectiori et maturiori studio quaedam correxit et in libris praesertim *Sententiarum* aliter tradidit." Consequently, there is an issue of internal criticism. However, at present the following are considered authentic:

   A. *In Porphyrium Quaestiones*, vol. I, p. 87.
   B. *Praedicamentorum Aristotelis*, vol. I, p. 124.
   C. *Quaestiones in I Perihermeneias*, vol. I, p. 186.
   D. *Quaestiones in II Perihermeneias*, vol. I, p. 204.
   E. *Questiones Octo in Duos Libros Perihermeneias operis secundi*, vol. I, p. 211 (see Wadding, *censura*).
   F. *Quaestiones super librum Elenchorum Aristotelis*, vol I, p. 224.

The questions *In Librum I et II Priorum Analiticorum Aristotelis* and *In Librum I et II Posteriorum Analyticorum Aristotelis* ought to be considered

inauthentic. Smeets, *Lineamenta*, pp. 15–16 attributes the latter to Johannes de Cornubia. Cf. Uriel Smeets, O. F. M., *Lineamenta Bibliographiae Scotisticae* (Rome: Commissio Scotistica, 1943), pp. 8–9.—On Peter Thomas's *De Distinctione Praedicamentorum*, see Victorin Doucet, "Maîtres franciscains de Paris," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XXVI (1935), p. 31.

Volume II

1. *In VIII Libros Physicorum*—Apocryphal. Wadding already regarded it as such: "Spurium puto; genuinum ipsum opus, si aliquando occurrerit, hoc amoto substituetur." Augustinus Daniels, *Quellenbeiträge zur Geschichte der Gottesbeweise im dreizehnten Jahrhundert* (Münster: Aschendorf, 1909), pp. 162–64, establishes that this commentary utilizes Thomas Bradwardine's *De Causa Dei*, which dates from around 1338–1346. It has long been attributed to Marsilius of Inghen, *circa* 1494.

   Cf. Smeets, *Lineamenta*, p. 13.

2. *Quaestiones super libros Aristotelis de Anima*, vol. II, pp. 479–562. Generally held to be authentic, at least substantially, but it may proceed from the pen of Antonius Andreas, Duns Scotus's pupil. In any case, it is enough to read what Hugo Cavellus, its editor, makes of it to see that in the present state of the text we cannot reach a judgment about it, even as to internal criticism: "Textum innumeris quibus ubique scatebat, mendis correxi . . . quae videbantur a placitis Doctoris alibi dissentire, cum iis quae in theologia habet pro modulo meo concordavi . . ." and so on. In any case, only the first twenty-three questions would be from Duns Scotus.

   Uriel Smeets classified it among the *authentica*, *Lineamenta*, pp. 9–10. Cf. Carolus Balić, *De Critica Textuali: Scholasticorum Scriptis Accomodata* (Rome: Antonianum, 1945), p. 286, and note 2, and *Opera Omnia*, vol. I, p. 152*, note 1.

3. *Quaestiones Meteorologicae, Libri IV*—Apocryphal. Wadding hesitated here. His principal scruple came from the fact that Thomas Bradwardine is

cited here, although his *Tractatus de Proportionibus* dates from 1328. Pierre Duhem returned to this argument, which he regards as decisive in his article “Sur les *Meteorologicorum Libri IV* faussement attribués à Jean Duns Scot,” *Archivum franciscanum historicum* 3 (1910), pp. 626–32.

Volume III

1. *De Rerum Principio Quaestiones* XXVI—Apocryphal. Collection of questions taken mainly from Vital du Four, O. F. M. Cf. F. Delorme O. F. M., “Autour d’un apocryphe scotiste,” *La France Franciscaine* 8 (1925), pp. 279–95; Palémon Glorieux, “Pour en finir avec le *De Rerum Principio*,” *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XXVI (1938), pp. 225–34.
2. *Tractatus de Primo Principio*—The content is authentic, sometimes an extract or summary of Duns Scotus, but perhaps it is not from his own hand. Cf. Marianus Müller’s edition, Joannis Duns Scoti *Tractatus de Primo Principio* (Freiburg im Breisgau, 1941); also Carolus Balić’s notes in *De Critica Textuali*, p. 25.
3. *Theoremata*—This is the apple of discord among the interpreters of Duns Scotus. Déodat Marie de Basly, O. F. M., regards it as apocryphal, “Les *Theoremata* de Scot,” *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XI, pp. 3–31, as does Ephrem Longpré, O. F. M., *La philosophie du B. Duns Scot*, pp. 29–48. The two main arguments are that no manuscript attributes this work to Duns Scotus and that it contradicts Scotus’s doctrine, since its inspiration is Ockhamist.—By contrast Fr. Carolus Balić, O. F. M., *Theologiae Marianae Elementa* (Sibenik, Yugoslavia: Kacic, 1933), pp. CXXI–CXLV, made it clear that a manuscript tradition exists in favor of the attribution of this writing and that this work agrees with the doctrine of Duns Scotus on important points. Later, when we ourselves set out to demonstrate the *Theoremata*’s Ockhamist character, we had to observe that they directly contradicted Ockham’s epistemology: “Les Seize premiers *Theoremata* et la pensée de Duns Scot,” in *Archive d’histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge* (Paris, 1938), pp. 5–86.—Cf. Carolus

Balić, “La questione scotista,” *Rivista de filosofia neo-scolastica* XXI (1938), pp. 235–45. From the same author: “*Tractatus De Primo Principio* et *Theoremeta*, nihil aliud sunt quam duo excerpta ex *Opere Oxoniensi*, quae Scotus delineavit, et alii perfecerunt,” *De Critica textuali*, pp. 288–89 and 293–97. Cf. *Opera Omnia*, vol. I, p. 154*. Allowing for what literary history may still discover, we can say that, from the point of view of internal criticism, the general interpretation of Duns Scotus’s doctrine is at issue here and that it alone will permit agreement on the question.—The work is presently classified among the *Authentica* in Uriel Smeets, *Lineamenta*, p. 11.

4. *Collationes Parisienses*—Authentic. Cf. Uriel Smeets, *Lineamenta*, p. 7. See Carolus Balić, O. F. M., “De *Collationibus* Joannis Duns Scoti Doctoris Subtilis ac Mariani,” *Bogoslovni Vestnik* IX (1929). It contains the text of three unpublished questions, pp. 200–17, notably on pp. 212–17: “Utrum conceptus entis sit simpliciter univocus Deo et creaturis.”
5. *Tractatus de Cognitione Dei*—Apocryphal. Cf. Uriel Smeets, *Lineamenta*, p. 16.
6. *Quaestiones Miscellaneae de Formalitatibus*—Apocryphal. Composed of several treatises proceeding from different Scotists. See Carolus Balić, “À propos de quelques ouvrages faussement attribués à J. Duns Scot,” *Récherches de théologie ancienne et médiévale* II (1930), pp. 161–70.

Volume IV

1. *Expositiones in Metaphysicam Aristotelis*, or *In XII Libros Metaphysicae*—Apocryphal. Mattheus Ferchius already challenged it in *Discussiones Scoticae* (Patavii, 1638), pp. 46–50, and proposed Antonius Andreas as the author. Likewise Ernest Renan in *Histoire littéraire de la France*, vol. XXV, p. 434; also Reinhold Seeberg, *Die Theologie des Duns Scotus* (Leipzig: Dietrich, 1900), p. 60. Carolus Balić, *De Critica Textuali*, p. 286, attributes it to Antonius Andreas.
2. *Conclusiones Utilissimae Metaphysicae*—Apocryphal. It is a work of

Gonzalo de Balboa, O. F. M. See André Callebaut, “Le B. Jean Duns Scot étudiant à Paris,” *Archivum franciscanum historicum* (1924), pp. 5–6. Cf. Uriel Smeets, *Lineamenta*, p. 12; Smeets attributes them to Gonsalvus Hispanus, that is to say, Gonzalo de Balboa.

3. *Quaestiones Subtilissimae in Metaphysicam Aristotelis*.—Authentic, except perhaps the last two books. Cf. Ephrem Longpré, *La philosophie du B. Duns Scot*, pp. 28–29.

Volumes V–X

Opus Oxoniense—Authentic. Regarding the manuscript tradition and the method to be followed in the new edition in progress, see Carolus Balić (the work was published without the author’s name), *Les Commentaires de Jean Duns Scot sur les quatre livres des Sentences, Étude historique et critique* (Louvain, 1927). In this inexhaustible work, Fr. Balić, pp. 58–67, establishes the existence of an unpublished commentary on book I of the *Sentences*, fundamentally in agreement with the *Opus Oxoniense*, but a different redaction. This would be the first version of the *Opus Oxoniense*: “We do not encounter the *Opus Oxoniense’s* mention of ‘anno 1300’ here. Furthermore, we would have the point of departure of the development of the Subtle Doctor’s thought” (p. 86). A sample of this “inaugural commentary” is given, pp. 254–63.

Regarding *Opus Oxoniense*, see Carolus Balić, “Die Frage der Authentizität und Ausgabe der Werke des J. Duns Scotus,” *Wissenschaft und Weisheit* II (1935), pp. 144–58.—*Annua relatio commissionis scotisicae* (1939–1940).—“De Critica Textuali Scholasticorum Scriptis Accommodata,” *Antonianum* XX (1945), pp. 275–80 and 297–307.—“Segne e note critique nelle opere di Giovanni Duns Scoto,” in *Miscellanea Giovanni Mercati*, six vols. (Vatican City, 1946), vol. VI, pp. 7–21.

Concerning the still unpublished *Lectura Oxoniensis* (or *Inaugural Commentary*), which the Subtle Doctor would have used to write or dictate the *Opus Oxoniense*, see Carolus Balić, *Solemnis Inauguratio 1943–44 Studiorum Commissionis Scotisticae* (Quaracchi, 1944), pp.10–31.

N.B. After this note was composed, a major Scotist event took place, namely, the publication of the first two volumes of the critical edition *Joannis Duns Scoti, O. F. M., Opera Omnia*, published by the Scotist Commission under the leadership of Fr. Carolus Balić, Civitas Vaticana, 1950. Volume I includes the critical introduction and the whole text of the prologue to the *Opus Oxoniense* (called *Ordinatio*). Volume II contains the beginning of Book I up to distinction 2, part 2, questions 1–4 inclusive. Henceforth this admirable edition will be the accepted text.

Volume XI

Reportata Parisiensia.—Authentic. Initially, Wadding, *Vita*, ch. VII, vol. I, p. 9, was very uncertain. Consequently, Ernest Renan was also uncertain, *Histoire littéraire de la France*, vol. XXV, pp. 442–43. But Wadding completely changed his opinion while editing the *Reportata* and today nobody doubts their authenticity. Regarding the Wadding edition's value, see Msgr. Pelzer, "Le premier livre des *Reportata Parisiensia* de J. Duns Scot," in *Annales de l'Institut supérieur de philosophie*, Louvain, vol. VII (1923), pp. 449–91: the edition of book I is "an arbitrary rearrangement of the course given at Paris . . . based in part on the summary William of Alnwick had made of the great r*eportatio*, in part on the bad *reportatio* whose publication in Paris was carried out by two young bachelor's degree holders in 1517, thanks to John Major," p. 490.—Cf. Franz Pelster, "Duns Scotus nach englischen Handschriften," in *Zeitschrift für katholische Theologie*, vol. LI (1927), pp. 65–80. Carolus Balić reaches different conclusions in *Les commentaires de Jean Duns Scot*, pp. 25–33; see also pp. 44–45, especially the important conclusion on p. 56. "We will always be obligated to anyone who can quote to us a single page of Wadding's edition reproducing the first book of the *Reportatio* and can prove at the same time that the manuscript tradition of the first half of the fourteenth century does not attribute it to Duns Scotus."

Furthermore, there exists a still unpublished *Lectura Parisisiensis*, which will be published through the efforts of the Scotist Commission, vol. VII.

Volume XII

1. *Quaestiones Quodlibetales*—Authentic, undisputed, in perfect agreement with the *Opus Oxoniense*. The *Questions* would have been disputed at Paris. Heinrich Denifle and Émile Chatelain, *Inventarium Codicum mss. Capituli Dertuensis* (Paris: 1899), p. 88.

   It is found in volume XXVI, pp. 501–61 of the Vivès edition.

2. *De Perfectione Statuum*—Doubtful and probably apocryphal. Here is Wadding's criticism: "Opusculum hoc ex Anglica amici ope summo gaudio recepi, sed dum lego, haereo et judicium suspendo an Scoto sit asserendus. Aliqua continet, quae multorum conflent invidiam, prudentissimi viri doctrinae et modestiae penitus adversa."—Against its authenticity, see Ephrem Longpré, *La philosophie du B. Duns Scot* (Paris: Societé et Librairie S. François d'Assise, 1924), pp. 20–21.

   A general bibliography of publications devoted to Duns Scotus would be an undertaking comparable to that of establishing a Thomist bibliography. A first attempt is found in the valuable work of Fr. Uriel Smeets, O. F. M., *Lineamenta Bibliographica Scotisticae*, with an introduction by Fr. Carolus Balić, O. F. M., published *pro manuscripto* according to the practice of the Scotist Commission, Rome, 1942, 1312 entries.—Another bibliography, naturally more restricted but already quite extensive, is found in C. R. S. Harris, *Duns Scotus* (Oxford, 1927), vol. II, pp. 313–60. It is all the more useful to consult Harris, since not all of his bibliography is included in the *Lineamenta* by Fr. Smeets.—Efrem Bettoni, O. F. M., *Vent'anni di studi scotisti* (1920–1940), Milan: *Quaderni della Rivista di Filosofia Neoscolastica*, 1943. It first of all indicates several other critical bibliographies in Germany, Italy, and France, pp. 1–2. It then comments on a very large number of recent studies, pp. 2–105.

1. Entity (*entitas*) is the property of everything that possesses being in whatever sense and whatever degree.
2. Intelligibility always accompanies entity; entity is fully intelligible.
3. Being is first in reality and therefore also the first notion known by our intellect. All knowledge is knowledge of variously modified being.
4. Being is divided into real being and being of reason. Being of reason, which is real being insofar as it is object of knowledge, only exists in the intellect. It is the proper object of logic. All other sciences deal with real being taken in different degrees of abstraction.
5. Real being is divided into quidditative being and being of existence. Quidditative being is the object of metaphysical science.
6. Quidditative being is real being, but, of itself, it is not a being of existence. Quidditative entity is that of essence. Its reality consists in conformity to an exemplar, which is its idea in God.
7. All quidditative entity possesses unity corresponding to the unity of the exemplar and circumscribed by its definition.
8. Two quidditatively distinct entities are really distinct. The reality of their distinction is that of their being, which is not the being of existence but quidditative being.
9. In so far as the quidditative distinction is based on the quidditative entity itself, it is prior in nature to any act of intellect. The real distinction between quiddities, essences, or forms is ordinarily called “formal distinction.” Formal distinction is thus between two or more quidditatively different quidditative beings.
10. Since quidditative being is not being of existence, several formalities which are really distinct in the order of quiddditative being can enter into the composition of an existent being without destroying the unity of its being of existence.
11. Two quidditatively distinct entities are unequal. The set of quidditatively distinct entities forms a hierarchy of quidditatively ordered entities.
12. Every quidditative entity possesses the same order of unity as of being: that is to say, quidditative unity. This unity is that of the essence. It is less

than that of the individual but more than that of the universal. Its unity is that of nature indeterminate as to individuality or universality but determinable to both.

13. The quidditative being of common nature never loses its unity under any of its determinations.
14. To predicate quidditative being, or essence as essence, is to predicate *in quid*. And, since essence or quiddity is common in virtue of its very indetermination, the predication of essence as such is always univocal.
15. The most formal essence of all is being. Therefore its predication is always univocal. This univocity is understood strictly in the order of quidditative being. Quidditative realities are the real being of which metaphysicians speak.
16. Every essence has the objective possibility of existence, provided only that it is not contradictory in itself. In order to have the possibility of subjective existence, it must also be individualized. Individuation does not confer existence, but is the last formal condition of its possibility.
17. The individuating act (*haecceitas*) thus belongs to the order of quidditative and formal being, but it is not a form itself. Otherwise, it would determine a new species. In the form, the individuating act is the last actuality.
18. Being of existence only belongs to individuals. It is complete being in the full sense of the word and belongs either to the essence whose very perfection includes existence or to essences whose cause places them in actual existence by virtue of its efficacy.
19. Every existent endowed with an active form can cause the being of other existents that are its effects. Its form quidditatively determines the essential causality of an existent. Certain forms are active; others are not. That is a primary fact that must be accepted as such.
20. Since every existent has quidditative being of a determinate degree, the hierarchy of these beings is accompanied by a corresponding hierarchy of causes. The causes are essentially ordered within that hierarchy, and the act of lower cause presupposes that of a higher cause. A series of

essentially ordered causes is necessarily finite and entails a first cause whose causality is itself unconditioned.

21. Philosophy of nature deals with existents. The natural philosopher determines the causes by which existence is given. Since metaphysics deals with essences whose being is quidditative, the metaphysician abstracts from actual existence and only considers being in the essential conditions of all causality.
22. The existence of physical causes and effects implies that being is capable of causality and effectability, which are metaphysical properties of beings.
23. The possibility that effects be produced (effectability) presupposes the possibility of a first cause whose causality excludes any effectability by reason of its very primacy. A cause that is first and of itself is therefore possible.
24. If the causality in question is that of being, the possibility of the first cause is that of a being that is of itself and uncaused. Now its very possibility presupposes its existence. Therefore it exists.
25. The being per se whose actual existence can be inferred starting from the quidditative properties of actually given causes and effects is what we call "God."
26. A first being *qua* being is all that it is possible to be, because in it the actuality of being is the source of its possibility. Thus, it is being in its absolute intensity, that is to say, infinite being.
27. Infinite being is the being that excludes any finite being by more than any conceivable proportion.
28. Infinity is the proper modality of divine being. Thus it is its *haecceitas*, that is, according to the definition of the latter term, its last actuality.
29. Theology is the science of the singular being whose essence is individualized by the mode of infinity.
30. Since the modes of being are its intrinsic determinations, everything is first in the First; everything is infinite in the Infinite.
31. Everything in the Infinite, which is infinite like it, is really identical.
32. Because it is infinite, the First includes in itself the infinity of possible

quidditative beings. These beings are quidditatively distinct in it, but the reality of their quidditative distinctions introduces no distinction of actual existence in it. On the contrary, formally distinct quidditative entities exist in God by the existence, identically the same in all of them, of the actually existent Infinite.

33. The infinite being, in which quidditatively distinct entities are identically one and the same existent, is absolutely simple. Infinity entails simplicity; finitude entails composition.
34. The metaphysical univocity of being as such does not extend from finite and composed being to infinite and simple being. There is no real community, either of quidditative being or of being of existence, between finite being and infinite being.
35. In God essence is absolutely first, and everything in divinity is situated in relation to it.
36. The first divine motion is that by which God's essence moves itself, so to speak, to know itself as intellect. Because he is infinite, God is infinite intellection of the infinity of quidditative beings eternally present to his intellect as known objects.
37. These quidditative beings are called "Ideas." As object of a formal distinct act of intellection each divine Idea possesses distinct quidditative being, but none of them has its own distinct essence. All together they exist by the simple existence of the actually existent Infinite.
38. The act by which the infinite being knows the Ideas only stems in it from the essence and intellect knowing the infinity of possible quidditative being with all their possible relations. Natural and necessary, this act precedes any movement of will.
39. Since it is infinite in being and hence perfect, the First is will, just as it is intellect. The infinite being is the only infinite good, therefore also the only necessary object of the divine will. Since no finite object is linked to the infinite being by a necessary relation, in God any volition for a finite being is a gratuitous, free act of love.
40. The possibles only depend on God's essence and his intellect; but in

freely choosing which of them will be created, his will transforms them into creatables. Therefore, a creature is an individualized, quidditative entity of which the divine intellect knows that the divine will has chosen it to be created.

41. The divine will can only choose among the infinity of objects of the divine intellect. The free choice of creatables has no effect on the quidditative being of possibles. It only causes creatability in them.
42. The initial contingency of any willing by God *ad extra* is the cause of all that is contingent in the world. Just as at the beginning the radical contingency of finite being in relation to infinite being could only be overcome by love, it will only be overcome by love at the end. Theology, a practical science, teaches man the means that God himself has put at our disposition to overcome it.
43. The execution of divine volition *ad extra* is called "creation." It is the work of the divine essence as power. The power of the infinite being is infinite. We call it "omnipotence." Omnipotence is the power of producing from nonbeing any possible finite being, immediately and without the accompaniment of any interposed secondary cause.
44. Linked to the infinity of being, this mode of production is God's exclusive prerogative. That is why only God can create.
45. Chosen by God among all possible combinations of intelligible entities, the universe is intelligible in its essences and in all the relations that unite them. Divine freedom of choice entails no irrationality.
46. The most perfect creatures are the angels, that is, subsistent intellectual forms.
47. The most perfect creatures after angels are humans. The species "human" includes beings composed of an intellectual soul and organized living body. The soul is act and form of the body.
48. As the constituent part of the human species, the soul itself does not constitute a species. Therefore it is not a Subsistent Intellect like the angel. The human is the substance here, not intellect alone.
49. In placing this composite being in being of existence, the creating act

places in being all the quidditative beings that enter into its composition at the same time. In the individual, which is the totality, the composing formalities conserve their distinct quidditative being. But they have no other being of existence than that of the totality of which they are part. The being of existence of each part is its part in the being of the whole.

50. After its fashion the composition of finite beings thus imitates the divine being's simplicity, but whereas in the divine being the quidditative entities are identically infinite existence, in the finite, the quidditative entities only take their place in the existence of the totality of which they are part. Once again, the finite is by definition composite.
51. Thus each existence possesses a dual entity, one quidditative and the other of existence. Its quidditative unity includes all the distinct forms that enter into its composition, from the form of corporality to the intellectual soul, without these formalities either losing their distinction or enjoying distinct existence. Its unity of being of existence is that of the being of existence of the totality, which entails the simultaneous coexistence of all the distinct quidditative entities which enter into its structure.
52. Since every being is only what it is by its substantial form, it is by the substantial form that every being is such and such a being and that it is an actual existent being.
53. The unity of the human composite depends on one of the virtues of the form, which is to include by unifying. Every higher form includes and unifies the lower forms. The complete substantial form, including its highest actuality, which is *haecceitas*, includes and unifies all forms or quidditative entities necessary for the composition of the human being.
54. Since the individual alone exists, everything in an individual is individualized.
55. *Haecceitas* eludes knowledge in the measure in which it eludes definition.
56. Although it is only part of the human species, the intellectual soul has the quiddity of intellect, which is of a being capable by nature of knowing everything that is.
57. The natural, adequate, first object of such a being is thus being taken in

total indetermination as to sensibility or intelligibility. It is capable by nature of intelligible intuition as well as of abstraction based on the sensible.

58. In fact, the human intellect exercises no act of intuition of quidditative intelligibles. In their present state, whatever the cause may be, humans only know the intelligible by the mode of abstraction.
59. The only intuitive intellection by humans in their present state is that of the existent perceived by sense knowledge. It is knowledge of the existent precisely insofar as existent.
60. Abstractive knowledge is made possible by the fact that the quidditative sensible, although individualized in the known object, conserves of itself its indetermination open with regard to individuality or to generality. It can therefore be universalized by intellect.
61. The act of intellection consists in the production by the agent intellect of an intelligible species corresponding to the common nature whose quidditative being is included in the sensible species. This intelligible species is received in the possible intellect.
62. The agent intellect is the total efficient cause of intellection. The thing known cooperates in the role of formal cause and determines its concept.
63. Proceeding at the same time from two natures, that of the knowing intellect and that of the known object, intellection is a natural operation and consequently a necessary one. As the intelligible always precedes intellection, whether in humans or in God, its content depends necessarily on its object.
64. Every act that does not proceed from a nature proceeds from a will. The act of a nature is determined by what it is. The act of a will is free.
65. Taken in the broad sense, will itself is a nature. As such it necessarily desires good in general. But it is free in regard to any particular good whose relation to the absolute Good is not necessary in itself. There is not a necessary link between the absolute, infinite, Good and any particular good.
66. Therefore, the will can always want or not want finite goods in wishing

for one rather than another and cease to will them after having willed them. This fact is expressed by saying that it is free in regard to the exercise of its acts and in regard to their specification.

67. Freedom of the will consists in the fact that nothing but it is the total efficient cause of volition.
68. The intellect cooperates in volition as partial cause by offering to will objects of possible volitions, but because it is always in the will's power either to refuse or to prefer others to them, will remains the sole efficient cause of volition.
69. As cause of the act of fruition by which alone humans will be able to enjoy their last end, which is God, the will is the noblest power of the soul.
70. The will's primacy of nobility over the intellect entails the primacy of charity over wisdom.
71. Free and responsible for their choices, humans know they must choose to attain their last end thanks to their knowledge of two laws: natural law and divine law.
72. Natural law contains the first principles of practical reason and the necessary consequences that derive from it. This law is necessary and cannot be changed even by God, because it stems only from intellect, not from will.
73. Knowledge of the natural law belongs to the practical intellect; moral conscience, which prescribes this law, resides in the intellect.
74. The first principle of the natural law is that one must want good and avoid evil.
75. Since no particular good is linked to the absolute Good by a necessary relation of means to end, God himself had to promulgate the commandments to say what humans ought to want or not want with a view to attaining their last end. These commandments constitute the divine law.
76. The commandments of God are contained in the Decalogue, which is itself differentiated into two tables: the commandments regarding God and the commandments regarding our neighbor. All the commandments regarding God, who is absolute Good, are necessary like him. Therefore

they belong to the natural law and cannot be revoked or suspended. The commandments regarding our neighbor, who is a particular good, only belongs to the positive law. They are not necessary and can be revoked by the Legislator or suspended by him.

77. Only God, supreme legislator, can revoke or suspend the commandments he has promulgated.

78. Since all volitions of God *ad extra* are free, the promulgation of divine law is free, and its content could have been different from what it is. But since all divine knowledge is supremely reasonable, all the commandments of God, even if they only belong to the positive law, are eminently rational and intimately harmonized with natural law. Therefore, they belong to natural law in the broad sense of the term.

Notes

1 Ephrem Longpré, "Nouveau documents d'Écosse," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XXII (1929), pp. 588–89. A summary by Longpré is contained in *Le B. Jean Duns Scot, O. F. M., pour le Saint-Siège et contre le Gallicanisme* (Paris, June 25–28), Quaracchi, 1930, p. 28, note 2.—Cf. André Callebaut's earlier study, "La patrie du B. Jean Duns Scot," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* X (1917), pp. 3–16. Also by Callebaut see, "L'Écosse patrie de Jean Duns Scot," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XIII (1920), pp. 78–88. Likewise by Callebaut see, "À propos de B. Jean Duns Scot de Littledean, notes et recherches historiques de 1265 à 1292," in *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XXIV (1931), pp. 305–29.

2 Ephrem Longpré, *Le B. Jean Duns Scot pour la Saint-Siège*, p. 28, note 2. The County of Dumphries is adjacent to Roxburgh County to the southwest. The whole region in which young Duns Scotus moved is intensively Scottish. John Knox was born at Giffordgate, on the outskirts of Haddington, and the unhappy Jane Welsh (Mrs. Thomas Carlyle) was a native of Haddington and is buried in the town cemetery. Burns died at Dumphries, where the Franciscan monastery can still be recognized in the church in which Bruce killed Red Comyn in 1306.

3 Ephrem Longpré, "L'ordination sacerdotale de Jean Duns Scot," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XXII (1929), p. 10.

4 Franz Pelster, "Handschriftliches zu Scotus mit neuen Angaben über sein Leben," *Franziskanische Studien* X (1923), pp. 1–32.—André Callebaut takes several pieces of information from Pelster in "Jean Duns Scot étudiant à Paris vers 1293–1296," *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XVII (1924), pp. 3–12.—Ephrem Longpré, "Gonzalve de Balboa et le B. Duns Scotus," *Études franciscaines* XXXV (1924), pp. 640–46. Again by Longpré, "Le primat de la volunté, Question inédite de Gonzalve de Balboa, O.F.M.," *Études Franciscaines* XXXVII (1925), pp. 170–81. Also by Longpré, "Le séjours de Jean Duns Scot à Paris," *La France Franciscaine*, Paris, XII (1929), pp. 353–73.—Efrem Callebaut, " Le B. Jean Duns Scot bachelier des Sentences à Paris en 1302–1303," *La France Franciscaine*, Paris, IX (1926), pp. 293–319.

5 André Callebaut, “Jean Duns Scot étudiant,” pp. 9–11. (Translator, Gonzalo de Balboa, born Lugo, Spain, died Paris, April 13, 1313, is also known as Gonsalvus Hispanus.)

6 Callebaut, “Jean Duns Scot étudiant,” p. 5.—See Scotus *Opera Omnia* (Paris: Vivès, 1891), vol. VI, pp. 601–07.

7 Callebaut, “Jean Duns Scot étudiant,” p. 12.—Cf. Daniels O.S.B., “Zu den Beziehungen zwischen Wilhelm von Ware und Iohannes Duns Scotus,” *Franziskanische Studien* IV (1917), pp. 221–38; see also Hubert Klug, “Zur Biographie der Minderbrüder Johannes Duns Scotus und Wilhelm von Ware,” *Franziskanische Studien* II (1915), pp. 377–85.—Of all their arguments, Pelster, “Handschriftliches,” retains only the testimony of Bartholomew of Pisa.—Ephrem Longpré, “Guillaume de Ware, O.F.M.,” *La France Franciscaine* 5 (1922), pp. 1–12, especially, pp. 5–6.—Balić, *Les Commentaires de Jean Duns Scot*, p. 59, note 5.

8 André Callebaut, “Le B. Jean Duns Scot, bachelier.”—Carolus M. Balić, “Die Frage der Authentizität und Ausgabe der Werke des J. Duns Scotus,” *Wissenschaft und Weisheit* II (1935), p. 145.

9 Longpré, *Le B. Jean Duns Scot, O.F.M., pour le Saint-Siège*, pp. 36–38.

10 Ibid., p. 36.

11 From that period would date a new course on the *Sentences*, different from the 1302–1302 course. Cf. Carolus Balić *Les commentaires de J. Duns Scot*, p. 31.

12 André Callebaut, “Le maîtresse de B. Jean Duns Scot en 1305, son départ de Paris en 1307 durant la préparation du procès de Templières,” *Archivum franciscanum historicum* XXI (1928), pp. 206–39.

13 On this point see Fr. Prosper de Martigné, O.M.C., *La scolastique et les traditions franciscaines* (Paris: Lethielleux, 1888), p. 305.

Afterword: The Dissolution of Divine Government: Gilson and the "Scotus Story"

John Milbank

A Acquiring perspective

Any consideration today of the work of Étienne Gilson requires, above all, a sense of perspective. He left behind a dual legacy: historical and philosophical. As a historian of medieval thought, his work can appear now somewhat outdated: limited both in its textual scholarship and in its taxonomies of intellectual tendencies, not to mention its overwhelming bias toward the importance of Thomas Aquinas—even though it was Gilson himself who was one of the first to go beyond neo-scholasticism in making us aware of the multiple currents of medieval thought and the greater dominance of Scotus over Aquinas in the later Middle Ages and even long afterward.

Yet Gilson was not unaware that his continued bias toward Aquinas was for him more philosophically than historically justified, and his ultimate concerns were both philosophical and cultural. As a philosopher and philosophical theologian, however, he would also seem to be now out of fashion. He is associated with neo-Thomism, metaphysics, and abstract rather than symbolic approaches to theology in an epoch (at least until very recently) more attentive to the critique of metaphysics, to phenomenology, to linguistic theory, and to a Patristic *ressourcement* that encourage an

integrated approach to theology, philosophy, and history.

Yet to consider Gilson's historical scholarship as surpassed would be to forget that he laid the groundwork for so much of the contemporary approach to medieval philosophy. Above all, it was largely Gilson who first called into question the corralling of this period from the early modern one and realized that one cannot make sense of Descartes without considering his relationship to the second scholasticism and its powerful continuities with the first one.[1] With Jacques Maritain (even though the latter had far more time—not without all good reason—for Cajetan and Poinsot), Gilson was the first to intimate that the crucial *caesura* in the history of Western thought might not coincide with what is regarded as the "early modern." Instead, the characteristic attitudes of modern thought, and above all its "conceptualism," has deep roots in the Middle Ages themselves. If Gilson appealed to Aquinas against these attitudes, in the name of his supposed "existentialism," then he was not totally without awareness that Aquinas represented an increasingly minority report in the Middle Ages themselves, while, still more than Maritain, he regarded the later "Thomistic" revivals as much contaminated by typically modern attitudes after all.[2]

With respect to the attributed "existentialism" of Thomas, Gilson has also bequeathed a strongly persisting scholarly legacy. Again alongside Maritain, Gilson rightly perceived (whatever one may think about his "existential Aquinas") that the nineteenth-century Thomistic revival, in its positivistic obsession with opposing idealism, was overly focused upon questions of the proofs of God's existence and on divine causality, regarded (in the wake of Suárez and others) as issues belonging to a regional domain of "special metaphysics" or of "natural theology," subordinate to a "general metaphysic" defined by "ontology," or a dealing with being taken apart from a consideration of God and reduced to the terms of an existence that is conceptually graspable. Instead, Gilson and Maritain correctly recognized that medieval Latin theologians (who were never professional philosophers) were as much or more concerned with the nature of being as with the identification of causes, and that the question of being was for them far more

immediately and problematically tied up with the question of God, in a way that ensued from the *Metaphysics* of Aristotle itself, before its *aporiae* were ironed out in the late-medieval and early-modern eras. When it came to the question of the nature of God's being, then the issue, after Augustine, besides Dionysius, of "how God is to be named," or of what concepts we are to use of him, held at least equality with, and sometimes priority over, the issue of how God operates as cause and how his existence and causality might be demonstrable by us. And this question of the names of God opens a cognitive region where rational theology cannot be so readily segregated from a revealed one. Here Gilson acknowledged a kinship with exponents of the *nouvelle théologie* like Henri de Lubac, and even though Maritain distanced himself from their theses regarding nature and grace, in reality his own philosophy built up toward a Trinitarian vision.[3]

So both Maritain and Gilson were distanced from the "official" neo-Thomists by stressing the unity of philosophy with theology twice over: first, in terms of the recovery of a metaphysics not just reducible to ontology but equally concerned with God—in such a way that, strictly speaking, they were not really advocates of a "natural theology" at all. Second, in terms of a powerful (however disputed) sense of a "Christian philosophy" aware that the biblically derived doctrine of creation ex nihilo had transfigured the entire philosophical field for three traditions: Islamic, Jewish, and Christian. For Gilson a new attention given to being *qua* being and to the contingency of things arose from this alteration. And additionally, monotheistic doctrines of the image of God in Man and of grace and salvation were seen as having shaped, in the Middle Ages, notions of human psychology.[4]

All this awareness continues strongly to resonate in the best scholarship of medieval thought. Indeed, Gilson and Maritain's new attention to *being* was already paralleled, as they were well aware, by that of Martin Heidegger. To a large extent a lot of French research into medieval philosophy has become Gilsonian-Heideggerean, with the Gilsonian desire both to trace and root out the drift of metaphysics toward pure ontology being complicated by a Heideggerean desire to divorce ontology from theology, though also to

"deconceptualize" it, or end the thinking of Being in terms of a graspable individual being, on the debatable assumption that this ontic occlusion had to do with contamination by theology. To the degree that "the forgetting of being" is today traced back, not to a metaphysics that was directed as much toward the knowledge of God as to the knowledge of being, but to a later and inauthentic positioning of God himself within an ontological field flattened enough to contain him, one could say that Gilson is now, after all, starting to win out over Heidegger.[5] For the latter, all Western thought and Catholic theology since Aristotle had been trapped in an onto-theological circle, such that God is thought of within a Being itself ontically reduced to every individual instance of being, by reference to God as the "supreme being." Yet prior to the influence of Avicenna, Christian thought had not located God within Being in general and Aquinas only consummates the tradition by and naming him as the ineffable "to be" which is the eminent source both of being "in common" and of beings in particular. Very many scholars and thinkers would now agree with the French historian against the German master-thinker that Aquinas is not guilty of "onto-theology" and that an ultimate deriving of being from God respects the "ontological difference" between beings and Being just as much as Heidegger's immanent and temporal solution. It is equally true that contemporary scholars are still more preoccupied than were Gilson and Maritain with the question of "the names of God" and of the integration between the theology proper to metaphysics and theology as *sacra doctrina* based upon revelation.[6]

In any genuine historical perspective upon his historical work therefore, Gilson remains a major presence. This is obviously far less true for his work as a philosopher, and yet the perspective one needs here is a reminder of his *contemporaneity*, both in the early to mid-twentieth century and even to a degree today. Here, once again, one can see a notable rupture with the older neo-Thomism.[7] That was predicated on a conceptualizing distance between the knower and the known, out of a predominating desire to ward off a perceived subjectivizing and Prometheanism of the idealists. But Gilson and Maritain were at one with their contemporaries in refusing a sense of

alienation between subject and object, as much in its empiricist as in its Kantian or idealist form. Along with Bergson, Blondel and Berdaev proclaimed the connaturality of human knowers to the given world of nature, and in this respect they lie in continuity with "French spiritualism" from Maine de Biran onward, which was realist in a totally non-empiricist fashion, since it emphasized the inner resonance of our minds with external realities through the shared media of corporeality, temporality, and habit. Gilson's *penchant* for existentialism belongs just here—he wants a realism not of evidenced and accurate concept, but of "living with" reality, in such a way as to render our spiritual and emotive responses informative of judgments that disclose the world, rather than being locked into estrangement within it. The proximity to Heidegger is here manifest.

B The Cartesian ambivalence

Yet to mention French spiritualism is already to invoke an ambiguity, whose ultimate name is "Descartes." In this tradition, as Jacob Schmutz underlines, there is a desire above all to close or to deny the gulf between knowing subject and known object.[8] But how to close this gap?

The legacy of de Biran and Félix Ravaisson is in a sense ambiguous. On the one hand, as already mentioned, one can speak of the way we are in continuity with the surface of the world through our embodiment, subjection to habit, and belonging within the flow of time. On the other hand, one can emphasize how, as natural creatures, we know reality "from within," always through being affected and self-affected. In the case of Ravaisson and later Maurice Merleau-Ponty, these two things are mediated by an entanglement and interplay: we know things from within, yes, but other things by mere analogy to how we know ourselves "directly." Even this directness is qualified by a reflexive mediation of things apprehended without—not by a cold evidence-gathering gaze (as for Kant) but through a real relationality and participative sharing in a received identity, somewhat as for the Aristotelian-Thomist *species* theory.[9]

But in the case of Henri Bergson, by contrast, the inward grasp of the flow of time in its passing ecstasy is more authentic and truthful than its external measurement. Much later, for Michel Henry, things are truthfully manifest to us when compounded with our own intimate self-presence as spiritual-material "flesh" and somewhat betrayed when regarded intentionally, as displayed "corporeally" outside ourselves.[10] In either case, one sees in different ways an intensification of the Cartesian component in the French spiritualist legacy, of which its early-twentieth-century exponents like Louis Lavelle were often well aware. And one could argue that the post–Second World War turn to phenomenology has exacerbated this recension. This has occurred in two moments: in a first, Husserlian one, there was a drift to a more German subjective idealism and conceptualizing account of intentionality; in a second, Levinasian one, the refusal of intentionality (so understood) and renewed concern for a non-alienated inhabitation of the world produced the "theological turn" in French phenomenology, which, as Schmutz suggests, for all its "anti-metaphysical" bias, has engendered a phenomenology itself become metaphysical if not (covertly) speculative in terms of its claims to probe the depths of reality and even to approach the courts of heaven. In such a way, as he further suggests, the trajectories of the prewar era have been resumed. However, one can add to his analysis that the phenomenological and thereby redoubled Cartesian influence ensured for a while a triumph for the moment of "inward" version of closing the subject-object gap in the French spiritualist tradition.[11]

What has all this to do with Gilson? Well clearly his desired way to close the gap would be rather that of inward-outward entanglement and interplay, though in a specifically Thomistic mode, which (as more elaborated by Maritain) sees a continuity of form between known and knower. On the other hand, for all this firm and ultimate preference, he is aware and respectful of the Cartesian alternative, which he knows has medieval roots. What are the salient features of Descartes in this respect? (1) His realism and non-phenomenalism about the external world of which we are intuitively aware and which trust in the presence of the infinite confirms; (2) His allowing of a

certain integral reality to anything which we can clearly and distinctly think; (3) The co-priority he gives to the infinite in our knowledge of being, along with the *cogito*; (4) The figure of "distance" from the infinite as contrasted with participation in *esse* to characterize our relationship to God; (5) The importance he gives to the will and its independence; (6) The equality of the will with the intellect in God (which for Descartes amounts to indiscernible identity in an ineffable simplicity).[12] In all six instances, Gilson will note how these themes are anticipated and even established by Duns Scotus.

Of course, Gilson does not exhibit the degree of strong sympathy (besides strong critique) of Descartes shown by Michel Henry or Jean-Luc Marion. However, the increased sympathy of the latter is opened up along a research trajectory established by Gilson, as he clearly acknowledges. Gilson might well have felt more amenable to Descartes in the wake of Marion's careful demonstration that he rejected Suarez's account of the analogy of attribution as too idolatrously univocal, and his more recent scholarly deepening of Lavalle and Henry's demonstration that the *cogito* embraces also the affective and the "eminent" presence of the sensible, which we do *not* for him primarily know in the external and representational manner of Lockean ideas, but intimately through a union of soul with flesh (as opposed to externally sensed corporeal extension).[13] As Marion also shows, in the end Descartes substitutes his own prevailing univocity around cause (which includes God as *causa sui*) and will.[14] For this reason he fails to embrace a more authentic account of analogy that Pierre de Bérulle might have held out to him and instead abandons the "names of God" tradition altogether.

Marion suggests that this means he has to "begin Christian thought again," yet if he does so, it is partially because he has rightly rejected, out of concern for the ineffability of God, some important aspects *of* the modern conceptualizing *episteme* as found in Suárez. In this sense, there is already something "postmodern," albeit inadequately so, about Descartes's thought, if not always Cartesianism, insofar as he is dubious about typically theologically rationalist modernity—and the same consideration applies in a not totally dissimilar way to both Hume and Kant. Thus for Marion, despite

the univocity of cause, the Cartesian way of “distance” toward the infinite holds for him a more than considerable attraction, along with the unilateral besides univocal reach of will beyond reason in the mode of gift and charity.[15]

Such an ambivalence is also shown by Marion, and then by some other French historians of philosophy toward Descartes’s precursor in some regards, Duns Scotus. Does the latter begin an idolatrous onto-theology, or does he “complete” it as something always lurking within the already conceptualizing bias of scholasticism, and then surpass it by the way of charity? God may now be contained within what would much later be called “ontology,” but this is only because it has been thinned-out to a proto-Kantian transcendental indeterminism, falling short of the real, and so opening more emphatically to view the reality of God as both infinite and free, properly known to us only through revelation. For this perspective, “infinity” may disturbingly limit God to a mode of univocal being, yet the modal primacy of the infinite within being can be regarded as *in reality* exceeding it, thereby permitting the infinite to most authentically express itself, beyond any “given” to which knowledge is subservient as the ungrounded free gift of charity, the true subject matter of Christian theology.[16]

But here again, is there not more continuity with Gilson than one might suspect, if one retains perspective? Is not Gilson already significantly ambivalent about Duns Scotus? Why did he write such a huge tome about him if he did not resonate with him to a degree, besides considering him the exponent of an “essentialist” path to which he wished to oppose the Thomist “existential” one? I would suggest that his Scotus book is best read if one bears this double stance always in mind. On the one hand, Gilson is implying that the Subtle Doctor has fatally reduced being to essence regarded in terms of concepts graspable by us, thereby over-privileging reason and its lack of situation. On the other hand, he indicates that the option for essence and for the univocity of being is *itself*, and paradoxically, a valid existential option, to the degree that, between this and analogy, pure reason alone can scarcely

adjudicate.[17] Moreover, again and again he suggests that, while Scotus offers solutions that are the polar opposites to those of Aquinas, they nevertheless do the *equivalent* job of metaphysically orientating us on the same Christian cognitive globe. Thus infinity does the work of *esse*, haecceity that of existential participation, the divine will that of the Thomist real distinction—and so forth. In either case the imperative of the Exodus naming of God is respected, along with the contingency of the Creation and God's unconstrained freedom.[18] The key differences between the two thinkers are in part explained by Scotus's far greater Avicennian formalism and in part by his historical situation after the condemnations of 1277. It is implied that, unlike in the case of William of Ockham, Scotus at once tried to respect the new ecclesial demand to remove any tincture of divine necessitation, and yet to repeat, albeit in an altogether different mode, the authentic theological and especially Augustinian tradition.

Our question should then be, regarding the present book, does everything quite add up? How can Gilson entertain two equally valid Christian philosophies without trivializing the importance of philosophy for Christian theology? How can he reconcile a need somewhat to respect 1277 and his evident preference for Aquinas's pre-1277 thought, much more receptive both of Averroes and of Proclean neo-Platonism? Or does he secretly envisage an eventual new synthesis of Thomism with Scotism and, thereby, even with certain elements of Cartesianism, important to the legacy of French spiritualism which was, to some degree, his inherited *milieu*?

C Gilson on Scotus

Étienne Gilson's 1952 book *Jean Duns Scot: Introduction à ses positions fondamentales* must also be considered in perspective. It is true that textual scholarship and textual attribution in relation to Scotus has advanced considerably since it was written—and this can even make it hard for most readers to follow through on his references in the original French edition.[19] However, the degree to which this invalidates his work or renders it outdated

can be exaggerated. It is also possible to take him to task for mainly contrasting Scotus with Thomas Aquinas. Yet Gilson is perfectly aware that, in context, Scotus is more often explicitly engaging with Henry of Ghent (and sometimes Giles of Rome, Thomas Sutton, etc.) than with Aquinas, whose positions he nonetheless sometimes deals with, attributively or otherwise. However, Gilson's interests are ultimately more philosophical than historical and he wishes to contrast what he considers to be the two major ways—essentialist and existentialist—open to the Christian philosopher.

When it comes to historical concerns, then his point is really that Scotus steered a path away from the mainline, Platonically informed theological legacy, toward something new which nonetheless built upon the existing Franciscan reception of Avicenna and a rereading of Augustine through Avicennian eyes. If Aquinas forms a contrast to this, then it is at once as a spokesman for a more traditional exemplarist, analogical and participatory perspective and for a rethinking of this in more materially grounded Aristotelian terms, taking account of Averroes, and beyond Aristotle in terms of a new "Exodus metaphysic" of Being. The angelic doctor quite rightly does *not* figure here as the old path now partially abandoned, but more as a way of rival novelty (if somewhat greater traditional rootedness) that is destined (unlike that of Scotism) in general *not* to be taken. This attitude is characteristically the mark of the new interwar Thomism; on either side of the channel and to a degree in Germany and Italy also it was seen as a radical, even avant-garde retrieval, naturally able to debate with the modernist philosophy of Bergson and to inform reflection on modernist art and writing, besides inspiring it.[20]

Thus Gilson is here predominantly concerned to contrast essence and existence, and in some consequence, univocity with analogy. All the same, he did not think that the univocity of being was the most original feature of Scotus's perspective—it is found, after all, in thinkers preceding him, including, obliquely, Avicenna.[21] For Gilson it was rather the formal distinction which, quite rightly, had been held most of all to characterize the Scotist school.

But the formal distinction rests upon Avicenna's doctrine of the plurality of forms. Gilson saw this as an echo of the Platonic ideas, without realizing that the echo is much distorted. The ideas as Avicennian forms are now always self-identical "atomic" units, indifferent at once to universal as to individual exemplification. *Equinitas est equinitas tantum*—the same horse whether really ridden or dreamt about in general. Just by reason of this indifference, such an objective form hovers obscurely above both real and intellectual being. It concerns directly neither the form of the hylomorphic real compound, nor the form merely entertained by logic. Precisely for that reason, several subordinate forms may be virtually lurking and ready to burst out on their own account, within a substantive unity that has one governing form. For this governance cannot override the remaining atomic and ideal independence of the formal units, underwritten by their presence in the eternal divine mind itself.[22]

Scotus further conceptualizes form by identifying it, in a proto-Cartesian way, as Gilson stresses, with whatever can be clearly and distinctly thought about something in such a way that this property is not necessarily dependent on something else.[23] In this manner, formal distinctness has become more emphatically definable by its thinkability. One might say that metaphysics is thereby already yielding to epistemology, but it is more that the metaphysical is becoming more epistemologically and logically determined. For just as Avicenna's form is indifferent to reality and logic, so also Scotus's formal distinction hovers, as Gilson likes to emphasize, between the real distinctions and motions handled by physics on the one hand and the merely cognitive distinctions and processes handled by logic on the other.[24] Thus the thinkability of separation does not, for Scotus, mean that the separability is sheerly mental; on the contrary, it rather indicates an unsuspected void in the real. The formal distinction, as Gilson says, is not a mere distinction of reason, and not even one with a *fundamentum in re,* as sometimes for Aquinas; it rather concerns an aspect of reality integrally united to a substantive unity and yet not absolutely and in all conceivable circumstances bound to it. Thus to give an example mentioned by Gilson, matter for Scotus

is thinkable without form, therefore there is a (paradoxical in pure Aristotelian terms) form of matter and this implies that it lay within the divine power to create matter without form, even though God has not in fact willed to do so.[25]

Despite the primacy as to originality and method ascribed by Gilson to the formal distinction, he nevertheless considers the univocity of being to be primarily determinative of Scotus's metaphysics and theology, in part because it eventually requires the crucial complementarity of *haecceitas.* But the most crucial hermeneutic move made by Gilson is to read the univocity of being in terms of what he debatably calls Avicenna's "essentialism," or his doctrine of the priority of quiddity as "form," as just considered, which in Duns Scotus mutated into the formal distinction.[26]

This move is complex because it has two discernible aspects, if one attends carefully. First, Gilson thinks that Scotus considers being under the mode of quiddity or essence. Just as form is neutral as between real and logical form, so metaphysics is neither physics nor logic, just because it is about *ens* insofar as it is taken as form or quiddity. It is this "indifference" which renders metaphysics for Scotus a *scientia transcendens,* as today brought out by Ludger Honnefelder, such that the meaning of "transcendental" has shifted from its usual medieval sense of coincidence with all of reality, to mean already a proto-Kantian coincidence only with the dimension of reality that is always conceivably the same. This does not, as yet, betoken in an epistemological fashion, as with Kant, merely perceivable reality in its thinkability, but still, in keeping with an Aristotelian philosophy of form as shared between real things and the understanding of those things, a common formal dimension of the real, besides its conceivability by us. This shift in the meaning of "transcendental" was overlooked by Gilson, for all the support which it gives to his "formalist" reading, although this continuity is in turn not really noted by Honnefelder.[27]

It is in these formalist-transcendentalist terms that Scotus at one point says that, insofar as metaphysics deals with the *quid,* it is indifferent to the actual existence of the *quid.*[28] If the mark of the univocity of being is that it is self-

identical and does not transgress the law of noncontradiction, then this mark is as much to be found in possible as in actual existence, though in the sense of really and not just logically possible existence[29]—which for Scotus (in contrast to Aquinas's more teleological and participatory sense of potential) amounts to logical possibility with the addition of possible actualization by an adequate efficient cause.

Thus as Gilson realizes, Scotus does not, as later Scotists will, go very far with this equating and leveling of the actual with the possible, which would tend toward a "tinology" rather than an "ontology."[30] As for Avicenna, fully fledged *essentia*(sometimes distinguished from quiddity as mere formal possibility)[31] is always conjoined with existence, just as form is, after all (for all its mooted "indifference") more fully found in a real substance rather than in a being of reason. Just because neither thinker *does* really divide *essentia* from *esse* (or even allow, like Henry of Ghent an *esse essentiae* for conceivable being),[32] essence always remains for them the core aspect of nonetheless existent reality. This is crucial for understanding that, while Scotus indeed "logicizes" his metaphysics, he is never, in treatises explicitly dealing with the *res* of reality offering pure logical or grammatical considerations.[33] (Whereas the logical treatment of mere beings of reason was always, in the Middle Ages, clearly signaled, and generally contained in separate works.)

Yet it seems that, for Scotus and for Gilson's Scotus especially, being is primarily thought of as essence and even as the still more indifferent "quiddity." This, in part, gives Gilson the lead for the second aspect of his hermeneutic move which, unlike the first, he admits has no direct textual support—though that does not mean that it is false. Whereas the first gave priority to the essence aspect of existence, the second reads *existence as such*, in Scotus, as a kind of form. Hence, most crucially, Gilson considers that the key to univocity of being in the Subtle Doctor is the way in which he treats being like a kind of super-form and so regards it both as supremely indifferent and as, in effect, formally distinguishable from essence and other irreducible marks of difference.[34]

How else, thinks Gilson, is one to account for the fact that it is *ens* as studied by metaphysics and not by logic that is to be considered as univocal? Indeed he argues that Scotus thinks that logic is overwhelmingly preoccupied with the equivocal, since what is "common" to logical differences and implications being so thin as to be almost nugatory.[35] By contrast, univocity belongs more naturally to metaphysics just because, in this case, continuities are weightier. Being is always said in the same way just because it always occurs in the same way, in the same fashion that horseness is always horseness, which amounts to considerably more than the logical *a* always being *a* or every syllogism obeying the same diagrammatic formula.

It would seem, however, that Gilson is scarcely quite right here. Recent scholarship shows that, to the contrary, Scotus began by agreeing with Henry of Ghent that, in logical terms, being is univocal, albeit in a "confused" manner, whereas in reality finite and infinite are analogically different in so extreme a fashion as to amount to univocity. Later, he came to see the logical univocity of being as precise (since governed by the law of identity) and construed metaphysical being on this logical model, yet without reducing it to the merely logical.[36] In Gilsonian terms, this means that the formal indifference of being to logical universality or real instantiation (for Honnefelder its "transcendality") is more strongly regarded in terms of logical identity, although this quite naturally reinforces the Avicennian *tantum.* One could choose to consider this "meaning" of being, like the meaning of "horse" as sheerly "semantic" in the sense of its priority to either logical or physical usage. However, this then *cannot* mean that the semantic lies at a further vacuous remove from the real than does the logical, after the manner of Richard Cross's construal, which equivalently tends to reduce the formal distinction to a purely mental one.[37] To the contrary, to read the univocity of being as "semantic" (a description never given by Scotus himself) must in Scotist terms imply that it occupies a kind of middle ground, exactly that of the formal or transcendental. It is on the middle ground that Scotus has indeed logicized and conceptualized metaphysics, in a revolutionary fashion, but that does not mean that he has replaced it with

logic, far less with grammar.

Nor are the implications of Gilson's error here all that drastic. It is true that metaphysical unity gives more weight to sheer identity than does logical unity: a horse is more *significantly* like another horse than the algebraic *a* is like another *a*. And Gilson does not make the mistake of supposing that the formal univocity dealt with by metaphysics is a fully real one, in terms of the realities handles either by physics or by theology.[38] He is indeed at pains to deny that there is anything exactly "real" in connecting realities that share only the transcendental "being" (besides the other transcendentals) in common and are not united by any genus. Thus both substance and accident exist in the same way, but they have absolutely nothing "really" in common. A fortiori the infinite God and finite creatures have nothing really in common whatsoever.[39] Does this then mean that univocal predication is just a necessary way of speaking, as some later Scotists indeed thought and Gilson attributes (perhaps wrongly) to William of Ockham?[40] But that would reduce the univocity of being to a thesis in logic or grammar, and Scotus (along with more or less everyone else at the time) does not think of these disciplines as adequately able to approach either real being or God. Instead, according to a third path that defines Scotus's fabled subtlety, there is a shared formality or formal object in these instances. Substance and accident, God and creatures really exist in absolutely incommensurable ways, but they share, with complete independence, the same neutral existential ground that allows this sheer difference to arise. Gilles Deleuze's famous gloss is at this point accurate: "the essential in univocity is not that Being is said in a single and same sense, but that it is said, in a single and same sense, of all its individuating differences and intrinsic modalities."[41] Radical sameness and radical alterity are naturally paradoxical allies.

Gilson therefore thinks that the metaphysics of form offers Scotus a double model for construing the univocity of being. But this does not, for him, account for Scotus's motives in adopting it. These motives are, for Gilson, overwhelmingly theological, though linked to a more rigorous rationalism and conceptualism.[42] In the first place, Scotus explicitly rejects Aquinas's

view that the first and natural object of the human intellect is being embodied in a materialized form.[43] This is certainly true for human beings in *statu lapsus*, but how can human beings according to their nature then be destined to see the beatific vision purely with the eye of the soul, if this was also their unfallen condition? It must rather be the case that the human intellect is naturally oriented to the indifference of being that can be both materially and spiritually instantiated. Gilson later indicates just how static a concept of nature this involves on Scotus's part: there is for him so restricted a real participation in the supernatural, even under grace, that a sheerly natural and self-derived consent of the will is required even for the human reception of the beatific vision.[44] In the case of the intellect also, it seems that the human being must already be in the same formal *milieu* of being as God, if he is to be commensurate enough with him as to eventually be able to see him. There is no sense here then, of a mediating realm where our nature might be transfigured, as nature, beyond itself.

And this is all of a piece with Scotus's failure to see that we might be able to transcend through judgment and spiritual elevation our sensorily and imaginatively mediated understandings, while inversely God is able symbolically to accommodate himself to their restrictions. Gilson stresses that this failure of vision is linked to his thinking of analogy not in terms of judgment, but of the concept.[45] If a name or concept can be analogically extended to God, then Scotus argues that this must be so on the basis of a minimal clear agreement as to just what we are talking about, as defined by the stipulation of self-identity and noncontradiction. On that basis it would seem—to supplement Gilson here—that analogy reduces to a non-analogical blend of degrees of intensity of a univocal quality along with ineffable equivocal difference, just as the divine infinity is for Scotus at once the degree maximum of "the same" being and a mode of being incommensurably different from the finite.[46] But for Thomas, as Gilson rightly says, being is identified not in terms of detached concept but of a more inwardly resonating judgment, which does not regard analogy in terms of a potentially measurable mimetic likeness (requiring a basis of univocal agreement) but of a

speculative, if mystically apprehended proportion of contingent and limited perfection to its supremely perfect causal origin.

Gilson, like Erich Przywara, seems wrongly to think of this in terms of a priority of "proper proportion" or "proportionality" in analogy (as for Aquinas's earlier position)[47] which renders, for example, God's goodness taken in proportionate ratio to himself as our goodness is to ours, rather too sheerly unknown and thereby equivocal in substantive terms—precisely *on account of* the excessive formal similarity of shared *ratio*—resulting in a somewhat empty judgment. In order for the judgment of analogy to have real content, it must be (as for the mature Aquinas)[48] primarily attributive, thereby ascribing some degree, after all, of substantive resemblance of created thing to creative source, but not in such a way that, as for Scotus, one is talking about a resemblance that requires a third assumed term taken univocally in common. Instead, for Thomistic analogy, God, as the terminus of attribution, is himself also, so to speak, the third term of being, the only thing that renders a remote comparison possible, since he is the coincidence of transcendence in height and the transcendental in scope. Thus creatures are only like God because they derive from him and "as it were" take parts from him, even if inversely, they only participate in God by being remotely like him.[49]

It is to a degree because of his rather diluted grasp of analogy and participation that Gilson is able somewhat to play down the contrast between Aquinas and Scotus and to see their metaphysical machinery as carrying out equivalent jobs, as we shall further see below. But all the same he is fundamentally right about the correlation of the subjectively judgmental and the actively existential, in line with the concerns of his French contemporaries, which I outlined at the outset. Just as judgment fluctuates without rules and is self-guided and differentiating, so also, for Aquinas, as Gilson brings out, being *of itself* and without any formal check or constant norm is endlessly and unpredictably various, and naturally manifest in different *degrees* of instantiation.

This follows, because only the differentiated and individuated fully exists

and for Aquinas it is participation in being itself (as Gilson well emphasizes) that individuates (even if, in the material realm, this is mediated by "signed" or quantified matter).[50] Since, for Aquinas, self-standing, individuated difference coincides with existence, there is no residue of pure being that escapes this real instantiation. The formal thinkability of such a residue provides no warrant for imagining it to be formally rather than just rationally distinguished, while insofar as being is really distinguished from the individual thing taken in its essence, it denotes not something abstract but the actual and dynamic realm of the participation of that thing in the divine *esse*, whereby it is constantly in excess of itself. Inversely, form is not, for Aquinas, formally separable from the act of being but only exists through it, just as we have no empirical or phenomenological warrant for supposing that matter, accidents or subordinate forms can really exist outside their relational subsumption by the architectonically unifying principle of substantive form and individuated actuality.

With Scotus it is altogether otherwise. Given that, according to Gilson's plausible account, he thinks of being on the model of Avicennian constant form, then it follows that difference must be rather extraneous to being and not resulting from it as an *aliquid* with which it is transcendentally convertible, as for Aquinas.[51] Univocal being, one might say, is given, inert, immune to causality and thereby somewhat infertile. Thus, as Gilson emphasizes, for Scotus it extends to being *in quid*, but not *in quale*—not, at least immediately, to ultimate, defining differences and to the other *passiones* or transcendentals besides being.[52]

And yet, one could elaborate here, these restrictions are somewhat paradoxical. For the more that there is a clear formal difference, then the more there is univocity. Matter is in the "same" being as form, as are accident and substance, and creature and creator. Since the mark of the divine "thisness" is his infinity,[53] then one must assume that every unique *haecceitas* is in the same, univocal being also. Just *because* being as such does not differentiate or individuate, and differentiating and individuating are mysteriously locked within their own self-authenticating, self-identical circle,

in a manner that is totally "additional" to univocal being, they are still governed by the univocal principle. By contrast, in a way that Olivier Boulnois brings out, the transcendentals and last specifying differences are not directly covered by univocity, *just because they are too close to being*, since their degree of formal differentiation is weaker and more overruled by a real, simple unity which *cannot* virtually fly apart.[54] Thus to say "unity" or "truth" or "goodness" is but tautologously to say being again, according to the rule of convertibility among the *passiones*, and so if being is said of them in just the same way it is said of being itself, then all the transcendentals seems to collapse back into, or as we might now say, "disquote themselves" as being. Thus a minimal formal distinction remains, but this very minimality in its nondetachable integrity is guarded by the impossibility of predicating univocity *in quid* of the other transcendentals. For Aquinas, by contrast, to say "true" or something similar is only to say "being," but disquotation is not possible for us, since the transcendentals are differentiated according to our *modus cognoscendi*, but not, even formally, in reality.[55]

A similar consideration applies to the specifying differences. Since the defining quality of a species is what allows it really to be existentially instantiated, as "rational" allows there to be human beings, to declare that being is predicated in the same univocal way of, for example, "rational" as it is of the quidditative base "animal," is somewhat to suppress the real requirement for a final specification in order that anything finite exist at all. Only in the case of God is his quiddity and haecceity sufficient for his existence, which is omni-qualitative. For everything else, the danger would be of implying that, for example, "rational" is *entirely* at one with the existence which it alone allows. By contrast haecceity, one might interpretatively suggest, although necessary for real being and thereby allowing of it, so *ineffably* and uncharacterizably coincides with it as to be, by contrast, predicable univocally, in accordance with Deleuze's insight. Every instantiating absolute uniqueness is "the same" entirely unique uniqueness, at one with real being, whereas a quality like "reason" adds something formally general to being and so different from it. Qualities are so

close to being they must be different from it; haecceities are so distant from being that they absolutely coincide with it. As Gilson stresses, even *haecceitas* is for Scotus a quiddity, indifferent to actual existence (which comes about through causal force, created or divine), but all the same no being exists without ultimate distinguishing.[56]

Nonetheless, Scotus does not wish to allow some kind of equivocally "other" being in the case of qualities, in denial of real, simple unity: thus, he says that both the transcendentals and the last specifying differences are "virtually" included in the *quid* which is formally univocal.[57] This concurs with the way in which Scotus dilutes the full convertibility of the transcendentals by regarding them, also, as formally distinct from each other, even within God.[58]

Gilson noted that Ockham, by contrast, extended univocity even to the instances of ultimate differences and the transcendentals.[59] He ascribed this to the way in which, for Ockham, unlike, as he supposed, Scotus, univocity was first at home in logic, and he further considered that univocity was, in Ockham, wholly a logical doctrine. Nominalism, Gilson considered, had been encouraged by the influence on logic of grammar turned speculative for which, by a natural disciplinary bent, all suppositing by signs might be reduced to naming. As a doctrine it then comes about through the effective usurpation of the place of metaphysics by that of such a speculatively grammatized logic. Yet, as Boulnois now points out, against both Marilyn McCord Adams and Pierre Alferi, Ockham also continues to deal metaphysically with real *res,* and nominalism indeed remains a metaphysics.[60] In Ockham's case it is less the result of the total displacement of the ontological by the logical as of a kind of generalization of the principle of univocity of being to all formal universals. Formal resemblance now acquires the kind of minimality of common likeness stripped of any real participatory continuity, such that, for instance, trees are all alone in their similar possession of a coincidentally resembling "treeness," registered by mind as the minimal universality of resemblance and not, by the mature Ockham, reduced to a pure fiction or *flatus vocis.* Nonetheless, given the

consequent erosion of any sort of inherent “belonging” or “affinity” out there in the world, the formal distinction must itself collapse into a real one. It follows that qualities do not really “stick” to their substances and are really different from them, such that “rational” is completely detachable from animal, even in the case of man, and so no longer at risk of naming fully determinate being twice over. It is for this reason that univocity is, with Ockham, directly predicable of ultimate differences and not—contra Gilson—because this predication concerning being is merely logical. It is rather that the disconnecting power of a more sheerly Formal Logic has, with Ockham, yet further entered the metaphysical terrain. Equivalently, the convertibility of the transcendentals is further weakened, and univocal being can now be directly predicated of “truth,” “goodness,” and so forth because they no longer denote attributes that really coincide with being, but are truly distinct from it.

But somewhat ironically, for Ockham the abandonment of the formal distinction means that in the case of God there is a purer simplicity than for Scotus, including between intellect and will: in God all the transcendentals are really identical—even though for him the Trinitarian persons alone inconsistently remain formally distinct from the divine essence, just because a nominalist metaphysic cannot really accommodate either substantive relations or their real unity with the simplicity of the divine substance.[61]

Gilson stresses equally Scotus’s second theological motive in endorsing univocity. This concerns the rational coherence of both our speech about God and our ability to demonstrate his existence.[62] In either instance Scotus takes the criterion of rational coherence to be the principle of noncontradiction and concludes that anything that cannot be the opposite of itself possesses a univocally specifiable identity. Being is not said in analogically diverse ways according to attribution *ad unum* as Aristotle seems to suggest and neo-Platonism endorsed; instead it is said in always the same way and yet cannot be differentially specified like a true genus. It only varies according to modal degrees of intensity of the formally same thing, like the color white, and can be more or less formally self-standing, or substantial, according to the

divinely willed contingency of the ontological arrangements of creation, or more or less necessary or more or less actual.[63] Its supreme degree of intensity, which is nonetheless incommensurably beyond any finitely graspable scale, is the infinite.[64]

It follows that in naming God we ascribe to him an infinite and unknown degree of a transcendental perfection whose essence we do perfectly know in itself—as being, goodness, truth, wisdom, love, and so forth. Scotus, in sidelining the priority of judgment, will not allow that our most basically available axiological meanings might be inherently vague and subject to speculative projection: thus, we can elaborate beyond Gilson, he will not grant that in predicating an excellence of God we are ourselves growing further into the meaning of that excellence, if the context of our naming is liturgical, as it was for Dionysius the Areopagite.[65] Instead, the priority which he gives to the grasped concept means that all our judgments and projections have to be foundationally based. In this way our reaching for transcendent height depends upon locating it within a transcendental breadth, pre-given in independence of any causal derivation, even from the Creator God. By contrast, analogically to attribute any perfection of God is to seek to rediscover the eminent causal source of that excellence, such that transcendental breadth only splays out here below as a consequence of its descent from an eminent transcendent height.

In this manner, as Gilson underlines, Scotus thinks that the status of rational theology as a science depends upon univocity of being. For otherwise syllogistic demonstration, upon which science depends, lapses for lack of a stable middle term. And indeed neo-Platonism had openly denied to theology a fully apodictic status, just because it seemed that analogical ascent can be at once only dialectical and mystical. Seeking to understand just how Aquinas thought that he could locate fully scientific demonstrations within an analogical framework that governs all his theology is difficult: perhaps one can gloss this to mean that his notably “physical” proofs, pivoted upon motion and actualization, gradually become fully demonstrative as we more and more ascend analogically to the divine point of view in our seeking of an

ultimate basis for the always relative series of finite causal conditionings.[66] This ultimate basis would lie in the divine being as such, but since Aquinas disallows the situation of God within a univocal *ens commune*, his "five ways" cannot require any shared univocal consistency of meaning as between finite and infinite being. It is surely for this reason that they are not in any sense at all "ontological" proofs, as an absolutely demonstrative "scientific" proof would arguably have to be, as Kant claimed. The "third way" does involve the reduction of contingent possibility to actual necessity, but this is the reverse upward tracing of a divine "moving" descent, since for Aquinas potentiality is something that is participatively on its way to full being.

But for Scotus, by contrast, all proofs, as Gilson underlines, are semi-ontological; as for Thomas fully ontological only from the divine perspective (for which reason Scotus "hybridizes" them with a posteriori reasonings), yet partially ontological for us insofar as we begin with finite beings *fully determined* in their quiddity by their possible being (as in Aquinas's both more Aristotelian and more neo-Platonic metaphysics they could not be).[67] We can account for their actualization by appeal to an infinite being able efficiently to cause the existence of finite being, precisely because its infinite consistency of identity is compatible with, and lies as it were on the same causal plane, as all the finite consistencies of identity. So with Scotus the ontological moment of linkage between God and creatures is divorced from the causal moment, whereas in Aquinas they are combined as emanative descent which is at once a creaturely sharing in the divine Being and the divine power of transmission.

Viewed in this way once can then further underscore Gilson's insistence that the Thomist and Scotist perspectives are not directly nor even very readily comparable.[68] This means that one cannot simply see Scotus as supplying a missing univocal basis for Thomist analogical predication or for Thomist demonstration of divine existence. For in either case the very nature of analogy and of proving is of a very different kind to that which we find in Duns Scotus. As Gilson tirelessly reiterates, the realization of essence by existence itself through individuating act is barely comparable with the

realization of quiddity and haecceity as essential existence through contingent causal eventuation and ultimately the divine will—which alone brings about being from nothing, though for Scotus finite creatures (as not in Aquinas) can of themselves and non-participatively bring about being from something.[69] The one operation assumes analogy of being, the other, univocity.

Gilson is rightly at pains to emphasize that despite, or even because of shared formal univocity, a genuine and full divine transcendence is retained in Scotus through the emphasis on infinity, at once incommensurably distant and boundless, as the key divine property. He appears, more debatably, also to defend the Scotist formal differences within God as compatible with his real simplicity.[70] And he even appears to allow Scotus's kataphatic qualification of Thomist "agnosticism" which construes infinity positively as a somewhat knowable divine distinction, since it can be grasped as the ultimately intense degree of univocally grasped being.[71]

He does however note, though without further remark, the strangeness of Scotus's ordering of an atemporal sequence of formally prior and posterior moments in the divine self-understanding.[72] Precisely because infinity, and not simplicity, is the key divine property for Scotus, infinity comes formally first, since other, formally distinguishable divine properties do not precisely coincide with it, as they would in the case of a supreme simplicity (as for Aquinas), by definition. Hence what God knows first is his infinite essence; then the quiddities of all the infinite possibilities in their latent knowability; then their actualized knowability.[73] Scotus here stresses that the quiddities do not of themselves cause this actual knowing, but rather God's infinite knowledge itself does, just as a second sunny field adjacent to a first one is not caused to be sunny by the first, but by the sun itself which shines on both. Nonetheless, one could add to Gilson, in accord with Boulnois, that a certain "representational" interlude seems to intrude here in God himself between what is known—the infinite, the slumbering quiddities—and the knower.[74]

It is just in terms of this priority of knowable quiddities and God's actual knowledge of them "prior" to the intervention of his will, that Gilson rightly insists that Duns Scotus was not a "voluntarist" in any straightforward

sense.[75] To the contrary, infinite truths are for him decided by a purely intelligent representation of the infinite sea of merely rational combinatorial possibilities, in a way that remotely foreshadows Leibniz. What is more, God freely but necessarily wills this knowledge as the good; for this reason, as Gilson remarks, it is not for Scotus that the divine will first wills to love, but that the divine will arises in the first place as inevitable love. This will only assumes the idiom of free choice, purely instigated by the will itself, though under the guidance of reason and charity, when it comes to the divine decision as to which finite possibilities to actualize and in what combination. Of these created actualities, God is then no longer (as Boulnois brings out) the eternal ideal exemplar, as for Aquinas; instead the divine ideas arise only at the stage of his "representation" of the actualization of this set of possibilities.

The created order in consequence for Scotus consists of certain selected formalities, ordered as to genus and species and actualized as substantive forms, purely spiritual in the case of angels and combined with the formality of matter in the case of the sublunary order. Ludger Honnefelder is here correct to say that Gilson is not quite right to call this "essentialism," since essence itself is but the secondary upshot in the created ontological order of a particular and contingent free divine selection of some quiddative possibilities (possessed of a logical "non-repugnance" to being, or a *ratitudo*) rather than others, and in some combinations rather than others.[76]

Arising within form and of it and yet not as form nor by form, nor as a further formalization, as Gilson underlines, is the principle of individuation, which is a different principle in every unique thing, finally sealing its possibility of being, which is however actually instigated by an effective external power, created or uncreated (in the case of the totality of finite existences arising from nothing).[77] Gilson points out that Scotus shares with Aquinas a rejection of Bonaventure and others' universal hylomorphism, which made the form-matter distinction coincide with the Creator-created one, thereby Platonically confusing materiality with finitude as such and ascribing to all the angels (where Augustine allowed this only for some of

them) a rarefied corporeality[78]. Both thinkers exhibit a better grasp of the more transcendent and ontologically deeper and more drastic character of the Creator-created divide. If Aquinas renders it coincident with the ontological difference between Being and beings or between Act and partial act still in potency to full actuality, then Scotus expresses it in terms of the gulf between the simplicity of the infinite and the always composed character of the finite and, like Aquinas, realizes that purely spiritual beings can also be composed —in his case of a limited substantive grouping of formalities.

Yet for all that, Gilson also realizes that much more is shared for Scotus between infinite and finite than is shared for Aquinas between *esse* and but partially actual creatures who alone share with him the "same" (since created) *ens commune.* The meaning and so the formality of being, unity, truth, and goodness is the same for Scotus in either case as it is not for the angelic doctor. Also the same is the division between the aspect of determined nature on the one hand and of freedom and love on the other.[79]

The great French scholar here notes first that Scotus seeks to defend and secure contingency by a rigid contrast between it and anything determinate (either determining or determinated). Second, that Scotus entirely assigns reason to this natural realm. In consequence, the natural and rational contribution to truth is, as Gilson well brings out, if anything more drastically "intellectualist" than with Thomas: God knows in three "signs" his infinity, the possible essences and their truths *entirely before* the intervention of the will, even though, in God's case alone that inevitably follows, though as the entirely free supplement of love—thereby ensuring that love also, is formally separate from the understanding.[80] One can add here that Scotus distinguishes the Trinitarian persons (whose existence in God is somewhat secondary to the three momentary "signs") in the same terms: the Father is infinite origin, the Son is reason, the Spirit is love.[81] Even in the case of the Trinity, Scotus applies his rule that things are self-determined in essence and never relationally: "for no entity does a relation constitute its ratification (or that by which something is a sold being or a true or certain being)."[82] As we have seen, the divine loving will becomes a freedom of pure choice in the

Creation of the world. And in the angelic and human instances, the will is entirely defined by this freedom, which is univocally the same in formal terms as the divine creative freedom (and can indeed, bring about being). As a result, the human mind imitates the Trinity in a somewhat literal fashion, given that Scotus has already "psychologized" the Trinity in God by much more directly and non-relationally identifying persons with faculties, in a way avoided by either Augustine or Aquinas.[83]

This is not discussed by Gilson, but he does consider how, for Scotus, the freedom of created spirits, like that of God's, entirely arises from the will. Though the intellect decides as to truth on its own, the will is entirely free to accept or reject its wisdom, in a way that refuses the determination of the will by the judgment after Plato, Aristotle, Augustine (despite Gilson's apparent endorsement of Scotus's invocation of him), and Aquinas. Equally it is the will on its own that decided whether to seek for this or that understanding of such and such a reality.[84]

The same strict division between natural reason and the will informs Scotus's approach to law and ethics, as Gilson contends. Scotus, as Boulnois today emphasizes, rejected the Aristotelian and Thomist distinction between theoretical and practical reason which understands the latter in terms of thinking toward a rationally known goal which is to be approximated toward by action.[85] Instead, for Scotus it is the intervention of the deciding will that renders reason active. Therefore, the role of reason in the case of either theoretical or practical reason is the rational grasp of possibilities, whether of their actual instantiation, or their possible instantiation. In this way the divine understanding is not, as for Aquinas, the absolute simple coincidence of the theoretical and the practical, of simultaneous realization and expression both in the Trinitarian *Logos* and in the externally creative act, but is initially and overwhelmingly, solely intellectual—before the will intervenes both as necessary confirmation (of the infinite) and as contingent instigation (of the finite). It is highly significant here that Scotus rejects the Trinitarian "expressivism" of Aquinas's understanding of all cognition, divine, and human; instead, for him, it is kind of pure, if already (and dubiously and

again contrast to Thomas) reflexive self-presence, in continuity with the unmediated understanding of Avicenna's "flying man" and in some anticipation of the Cartesian *cogito*.[86]

The Scotist division of intellect and will is mirrored in spiritual creatures. In refuting or nuancing the usual description before 1950 of Scotus as a "voluntarist," Gilson points out that, for the Subtle Doctor, conscience is an *entirely* intellectual matter, whereas for Aquinas's stronger account of practical reason as teleological, the will is intrinsically involved from the outset; if the will is guided by judgment, practical judgment is in part to do with the lure of right desire by a genuine *telos*. It is then for Scotus reason that apprehends the natural law and the precepts of the "first table" of the Decalogue to love God and God alone. Scotus, as Gilson indicates, believes that he is offering a true exegesis of Christ's assertion that the whole of the law is contained in the gospel commandment to love God and one's neighbor as oneself. But Scotus reads this to mean that a natural and rational obedience to God requires one to follow his commandments. These concern how one should treat one's neighbor, as set out in the "second table" of the law, and these do *not* belong to the natural law, as they arise from the contingent willing of God.[87] Scotus concludes this on the basis of the fact that, in the Old Testament, God sometimes suspends his commandments in emergencies and permits or even orders killing, stealing, adultery, and neglect of parents.

Gilson here wrongly asserts that Aquinas denies these suspensions; in fact he does not, but still allows that the second table proclaims the natural law, precisely because he thinks of this as amenable to equitable or "miraculous" exceptions, since he construes the natural law for human beings as accessible through the exercise of prudential judgment and discernment of the divine will and not through theoretical precept—a contrast of which Gilson might have been aware, in parallel to the case of analogy.[88] He is nonetheless right to emphasize that Scotus is not endorsing a divine arbitrariness: the God we should rationally obey is also the God who is love and whom we should naturally and rightly love. His willed commandments are offered out of this love. Nevertheless, they have more of the character for him of a convenient

constitution for the postlapsarian human polity than they do for Aquinas, for whom they are more intrinsic to our human nature. This goes along with the Dominican ascription of property, lordship, rulership, and legal *connubium* to the paradisal state. This was denied by the Franciscans, in an exacerbation of the position of St. Augustine.[89]

D Assessing Gilson on Scotus

How should one characterize Gilson's rendering of Duns Scotus? As we have seen, it is marked, above all, by a contrast between Scotus as a philosopher of essence and Aquinas as a philosopher of existence. The former is seen as failing to make the real distinction between essence and existence that is made by the angelic doctor. Nevertheless, as we have also seen, Scotus is read, and not without justification, as consistently offering compensations or equivalents for this failure in term of the ineffability and absolute difference and distance of the infinite (equivalent to *esse*), the excess of individuation over form (equivalent to the excess of act over form) and the independence of the divine will (equivalence to the divine act of being as bringing contingent things about). In this way, both scholastic masters are regarded as theologians of Exodus and of creation ex nihilo, beyond the pre-biblical limitations of the Greeks.

There is therefore a tension in Gilson's construal. On the one hand he already thinks, somewhat *sotto voce,* that Scotus marks a key Western *caesura*. Before him, in a general way, theology was governed by an analogical and participatory construal of the divine names linked with the primacy of a mystical judgment, resonant with being as such. After him, theology increasingly tends to be dominated by a univocal naming of God under the *aegis* of a more distant and conceptualizing relation to being. Albeit allowing for the already rationalizing contributions of Abelard and Gilbert Porreta, this shift in Scotus builds upon the massive difference made to Latin thought by the translations of Avicenna, and his "atomically Platonic" construal of form as static and indifferent, even across the uncreated-created,

infinite-finite divides.[90] On the other hand, Scotus is also read by Gilson as offering, after 1270, another valid path, which now more strongly guards against Arabic necessitarianism than the older theology of mystical reason, while providing certain new guarantees of the impenetrable mystery both of God and of creatures, and considerably qualifying the range open either to the divine or to the human will.

Just how stable is this tensional balance? One can argue that it is less stable than Gilson supposed or perhaps wishfully thought, maybe in deference to magisterial history and a desired ultimate harmony of the diverse Catholic intellectual legacy.

In describing Scotus as the supreme metaphysician of essence and Aquinas of existence, Gilson did not simply wish to favor the latter, though clearly he did so to a great and even an overwhelming degree. Instead, despite Scotus's failure to register the essence-existence real distinction, his very essentializing of existence (as described in the previous section) can be read by Gilson as a one-sided account of a true metaphysics; almost as offering exactly half the truth. Thus what he says about the realm of possibility and intellect need not (it is implied) be seen as entirely wrong; it is just that he does not realize the leading role of existential actualization in achieving a fully concrete reality. However, to some degree, his wholly novel view of the realm of quiddity as extending to the possibility of the unaccountably unique (*haecceitas*) phenomenologically manifest and yet ontologically unsoundable, plus the more independent role he grants to the will compensates for this deficiency. Gilson therefore concedes some similarity and equivalence between the Thomist act of existence on the one hand and Scotist individuation and willing on the other.[91] This may even for him even open up the prospect of a new scholastic synthesis in which haecceity supplies a certain bridge between form and act, while the link of the existential with choice and free-directedness confirms the link between Aquinas and a post-Kierkegaardian stance toward the subjective.

This sounds agreeable enough, but why might it not work? The problem lies with a too simple characterization of the different stance of the two

thinkers toward essence and existence. Arguably it is not that Aquinas strongly divides them and Scotus fails to do so; to the contrary, but that Aquinas ultimately unites them, whereas Scotus keeps them ultimately too much apart. Or to put this another, and paradoxical way: it would seem that the formal distinction is less of a distinction than is a real distinction but more than is a rational one, whereas, more deeply considered, the formal divide is more of a rupture than the real one.

How can this be so? On Gilson's reading of Aquinas, existence is presented somewhat as a dimension "beyond" essence, which still remains sovereign in its own domain.[92] In the case of God, though he knows all essences as possibilities of participation in him, his own essence is uniquely "to be." While Gilson naturally realizes that God is not unstructured or disordered, he still writes as if the divine essence was his existence, in a sense going beyond a rhetorical expression of the truth that, in God, essence and existence absolutely coincide. This means that, curiously enough and even counterintuitively, one might start to argue that Gilson's Aquinas is presented slightly too much in terms that already favor a negotiable comparison with Scotus. Thus the suggested excess of pure existence over essence looks a little like the formal primacy of the infinite in the later thinker. Equally, and alternatively, it looks a little like the formal excess of the will over the essence-bound intellect of the Scotist account of God. In the case of the structure of created existence, Gilson thought somewhat too simplistically in terms of "another metaphysical layer"—just as form actualizes matter, so act in turn actualizes form. Yet if, for Thomas, *forma dat esse,* it is more as if form has been existentially enriched and is consequently regarded as more open-ended.[93] It is not then, after all, so obvious that, after Avicenna, Aquinas goes any further than the Boethian distinction between being and essence in terms of a distinction between the *quo est* and the *quid est.* For Boethius, that in virtue of which something exists (such as "the soul") contains also an existential, actualizing factor.[94] Thus despite much ambiguity of formulation in his texts, one can read the angelic doctor to be saying that form, precisely as form, participates in a fullness of being which

is also, in God, a fullness of form or of essence. The latter is rhetorically regarded as the more "receiving" factor, merely because, in the case of a creature, one can specify its essence, without its existence necessarily following. That is because its essence is, unlike the divine essence, limited. Yet if its essence is limited, then so is its existence, being merely contingent and participated and tied to a specific formal mode of being. On this rendering, Aquinas's strong doctrine of the absolute divine simplicity over-determines even the centrality of *esse*, and his "natural" (as opposed to his Trinitarian) metaphysics remains after all a metaphysics of "the One" (not beyond being, though significantly beyond quasi-generic, created *ens commune*). When Aquinas adds to the Greek ontological legacy the biblical, Philonian, and Patristic concern with "divine politics" or governance, then one could say the central concept of his thought is *ordo*—indivisibly united in God, economically unified in diversity in the creation.

Interpreted in this fashion, the Thomist "real distinction" of being and essence in creatures does not mean any absolute separation; rather a dilution of their intrinsic, absolute connection in God. The "reality" of their divide is not like that between one physical object and another, but is rather the mark of contingency in the sense that any creature only exists as *this* thing through its dependent realization on an *esse* which is everything. Thus it is really divided within itself between its own nature, that might not be, and a deeper ultimate ground of its very own being, which yet does not belong to it at all, since it is the being as such and omni-essentiality of God. It is for this reason that, in his commentary on Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, Aquinas clearly refuses the more extreme versions of the real distinction espoused by his later followers which would involve both an "existence of essence" and an "essence of existence."[95] For Aquinas, by contrast, essence is only real, even as essence, when somewhat possessed of an actually inherent potential for (as opposed to abstract possibility of) further existence, and existence is only real, even as existence, when it is essentially structured. It is, rather, the univocal account of being that reduces it to the pure fact of "being there" or of "possibly being there." In this crucial fashion it is *Scotus* who is the more

existentialist, just because he makes (in effect and despite immediate appearances) more of an Avicennian essence-existence divide, though again, without going so far as to divide them entirely (with the paradoxical consequence of "existing essence" and "essential existence") as his own later followers sometimes did.[96] But for Aquinas, since being is also the expansion and hidden dimension of form, the act of being is linked at once to a further potential of something for becoming while yet remaining the same thing or person, and yet also to its unique individuation which alone allows it to exist at all.

Although Scotus, like Avicenna (but unlike certain Latin Avicennians), does not allow essence to be fully real on its own, even in God, he nonetheless effectively thinks of essences as formally distinct from existence, in terms of their eternal logical possibility—providing an infinite repertoire from which God selects. Since, as already argued, fully fledged "essence" means in Scotus "quiddity plus willed causal instigation," it is not quite right to view him, with Gilson, as an "essentialist," or as an "anti-existentialist." Yet this qualification only renders the sundering of the conceptualizable and modally possible moment of the real all the more separable from the existential.

And although, again, there is for Scotus no purely indeterminate existence, being can, as Gilson argues, be for him separably thought of a distinct formality, just because it correlates with the purest and most abstractable expression of the law of noncontradiction according to which any real thing, finite or infinite, cannot both be and not be at the same time and in the same manner. It follows that we do not, as for Aquinas, *judge* such and such an individual to be present with such and such restrictions and such and such potential, but instead we *assert* (according to sensory intuition) that such and such an ineffable individual is present and that it falls under such and such formal and common concepts, including the formality of being, itself indifferent to particularity or universality, but present as this particular thing and universally thinkable.

In consequence, the formal distinction implies more separability than the

real one. For Aquinas, just as matter exists through form, accidents exist through substance and subforms through the dominant one (the form of the hand through the form of the body) by perfected participation, so also limited form exists through perfecting act, through imperfect and always ongoing participation. It is the latter alone that is the mark of a real distinction, which asymptotically tends toward a real unification. But by exact contrast, the inherent bias of the formal distinction is toward a drifting away, precisely because it has been adopted in order to divide something where one might have chosen not to do so—in seeing the hand as not fully subsumed, as still to a degree possessing its own form, one regards it as virtually separable, as already no more than a prosthesis.[97] Similarly, if, in effect, on Gilson's reading (which I basically affirm) existence is formally distinct from essence, then essence, especially as the more prior quiddity, tends toward an independent "existence" of abstract conceptual possibility and existence toward an independent "essence" of predicability as "there or not" in an almost proto-Tarskian sense.

From all, this one can suggest that Gilson was not quite right to see Aquinas as the metaphysician of existence and Scotus as the metaphysician of essence. As we have seen, this way of viewing their contrast *both* allows Gilson to indicate Aquinas's superiority, *and* to seek a certain correlation of their philosophies and resolution of their differences. But if the point is rather that, in a suitably "subtle" fashion, it is Scotus who more *divides* essence from existence, then the contrast remains, but the correlation and half-mooted synthesis become more difficult, if not impossible. As to the question of respective superiority, that issue will be left for the moment in abeyance.

Before eventually tackling it, it is important to see that this same revision of contrast can be made with respect to Gilson's account of Aquinas as intellectualist and Scotus as voluntarist. For once more, Gilson (here somewhat vaguely) implies the superiority of Aquinas's perspective and yet also suggests a certain complementarity, or even advance, on Scotus's part, in affirming the autonomy of freedom as an inherently Christian value. And again also, a somewhat questionable difference from Boethius is ascribed to

Aquinas in terms of an accentuated role for the independence of the will in human deciding—whereas it would seem that both thinkers allow that guiding judgment involves some dimension of purged affectivity, in the tradition of the Platonic *eros*.[98]

The complementarity arises for Gilson in two respects: first, insofar as Scotus is himself largely an intellectualist. As we have seen, human conscience is for him wholly guided by reason, and the divine understanding is wholly guided by the preceding nature of essence and not at all by choice or desire. Second, insofar as Gilson says that the divine will in Scotus plays something of the role of participation in the divine act in Aquinas. For Gilson then, the Scotist fault might be to raise will above intellect, but the Scotist advance might be to better grasp the self-sufficiency and ultimate primacy of the domain of will and charity, while fully granting to intellect its due. The parallel with essence and existence here is complex: Scotus is seen by Gilson as newly allowing to the will its full significance, as he does with essence; at the same time, it is just the increased allowance given to will which permits Scotus somewhat to compensate for his lack of a metaphysics of existence.

But again, what Gilson has arguably failed to see is that the difference between the two thinkers lies not with the one stress or the other, but with a metaphysical separation—a point precisely grasped by Jean-Luc Marion.[99] Even if Thomas's integration of intellect and will was somewhat inferior to that of Augustine's, it remains more genuinely Augustinian than Scotus's post-Avicennian division of the two.[100] Here Gilson rather overrated the contrast between Avicenna's neo-Platonic necessitarianism and Scotus's increased buttressing of divine creative freedom.[101] It is true that Avicenna failed to see God as unique creator of all that is, restricting him to emanative source of the intelligences, and true also that Avicenna was reluctant to use any anthropomorphizing talk of "will" or "intention" or "motivation" in relation to God. Yet the frequent wrestling of the great Persian philosopher with the *aporia* of how God as perfect can give rise to anything other than himself, yet how anything can be at all without ultimately arising from God, results in the conclusion that there is some sort of inexplicable *caesura* in the

divine which divides the possible quiddities from the actualized ones.[102] Even though this rupture cannot be neo-Platonically named as "decision," it still arises from the Islamic dimension in Avicenna's thought, which concerns a monotheism of pure, solitary sovereignty over the cosmos. In Scotus this perspective on divine government is emphasized and the rupture is unambiguously baptized "will."

It is also, arguably, Avicenna's Islamic monotheism which pushes him toward thinking of forms in the mode of the "atomized Platonism" which we have already considered. As neutral and fixed essences they become entirely subject to the divine sieving, which somewhat interferes with and complicates the apparent emanative structure. In the case of Scotus the latter is just got rid of, to leave behind a mix of the monotheistic and the "Platonic" purged of any authentic neo-Platonism, including that of Augustine. Now we have a duality of the infinite quiddities as understood by God on the one hand, and the infinite divine love and willed creative decisions on the other.

But it seems odd that Gilson did not call into question this duality. For after all, it depends upon just that reduction of thought to conceptualizing which he half-objects to in Scotus elsewhere. With no initial desire, God's thinking must, for Scotus, ineluctably "represent" first the infinite, then the quiddities and eventually, in their possibility, all those created realities which the divine will has selected. Does this not undo inherited Philonian and Patristic notions of divine government, as consummated by Aquinas?[103] For these notions, being and ordering, understanding and will, are all "simply" at one in the godhead, such that what, in the cosmos, *achieves* order, also symbolically *reveals* the truth. The economy of governance and the economy of disclosure are here at one. Yet the Avicennian current, as consummated philosophically, not within Islam, but by Scotus, starts to undo this epochal synthesis. Now being as being and primarily being as infinite are just "given," outside the causal order—whether as causing or caused, such that Scotus can shockingly say that it is not true that "because God is God, therefore man is man."[104] God creates through actualization the various "terms" of our existence and this existence itself, yet not the possible combination "man" since this is not

exemplarily rooted in his eternal actuality as eternally bestowed and inherently governing gift, but is rather transcendentally "given," before and outside a creative ordering.

Infinite being is of course not caused, but nor, for Scotus, is finite being *qua* being, rather than as specifically finite being, since it is a transcendental placeholder, not something fully real and yet a "formal" dimension of reality that escapes even divine control, since, for Scotus, it is its real transcendental precondition. In a similar fashion, the quiddities of possibility just lie floating in the infinite sea, ready to be representationally spotted by the divine helicoptering patrol. Therefore, both divine being and divine understanding occur momentarily "prior" to his self-affirming and cosmic governance. Even God's internal personal ordering as Trinity is secondary, and the *Logos* merely conveys rather than relationally constitutes the Paternal understanding. And this understanding does not, from all eternity, express in his Son the ideas of those things he has decided to create.[105] Gilson fails to note that this, by contrast, is the case for Aquinas, such that, even though creation is for him the free decision of the divine will, this decision *coincides* with the eternal divine being and essence, ensuring a strong parallelism (as recent commentators have brought out) between the internal expression of the Trinity and the external expression of this expression, which reveals God *to be* expression.[106] In overlooking this, Gilson underplays the difference between Aquinas and Scotus on the divine ideas.[107] For both, indeed, they are ideas as the divine thoughts of created things, but for Aquinas they are fully exemplary and God was never without them, whereas for Scotus they arise "later" in God and are secondary "representations" or mimetic copies and no longer exemplars at all.

E Gilson and the "Scotus story"

The implications of all this are very considerable. It means that Scotus has taken over and even played up a certain blend of the philosophically Platonic and the orthodox Muslim Kalamic emphasis on God as one in the sense of

solitary, individual, and all-commanding. And that by doing so, the inherited deep structure of Christian thought has been so subtly subverted as to have become speedily indiscernible. For this subversion is *not* simply or even primarily to do with voluntarism. Instead, it is to do with too sharp a *divide* between essence and being, and intellect and will, and so between being and providential government.

The irony involved here is very extreme indeed. For undoubtedly the condemnations of 1270 and Scotus's sincere and profound attempt to pay heed to them were to do with trying to further purge Christian theology of pagan fatalism and dogmatism. The excessive result of this, as so many twentieth-century theologians (Catholic, Orthodox, and Anglican) have argued, was a wholesale loss of "symbolic realism" or the view that the cosmos mysteriously discloses God, as the Bible itself declares, thereby allowing the book of the scriptures and the book of nature mutually to illuminate each other. Everything—liturgy, exegesis, architecture, politics, and theology—had hitherto depended on that. Recently, this account has come to be known as "the Scotus story."

For many other modern theologians (both Catholic and Protestant) the loss of symbolic realism was, however, a price worth paying: a more contingent and mysterious cosmos at once more proclaims the hidden majesty of God and opens a more empirical and experimental investigation of nature. In the human sphere, pride is downgraded and we come more to depend upon the divine mercy. Finally, in the case of both God and man the formality of freedom comes to prevail over substantive content—setting the human will free to more love at will, reshape reality and construct economic and political orders based upon contractual mutual respect for liberty, rather than any consensus as to, or imposition of an order whose truth must, for us, remain elusive.[108]

However, irony arises if one can point out that this alternative, "modern Christianity" (much of the Christianity which we know today), is itself *yet more pagan* than what it displaced—to a considerable degree, if by no means wholly, in the wake of Scotus. The charge is cogent, because, whereas for the

Fathers and Aquinas, necessity had become infused with will, love, and beauty to become the economically *conveniens,* not strictly necessary, yet "obliging" in its very objective desirability, what is brought to a head in Duns Scotus is that will can only guarantee itself as will if it is placed in an *absolute* contrast with the necessary as its backdrop and counterpoint. But this inevitably means that a purer, and more purely "pagan" necessity must be granted a firmer ontological place. It would then seem that, in a rather Chestertonian way, a desire to extirpate pagan wisdom altogether can only lead to a stronger debased dose of it. There is it seems, no more Christian choice to be had than the transfiguration of the pagan—as is natural, if Christianity is a religion of salvation and not escape nor abandonment.

Thus in the case of Scotus, the primary divine existence and the divine understanding seem too much depersonalized, even over-subject to fate. And if, in the infinite, will follows love rather than the other way round, then even that, at first sight so attractive a proposal, seems to suggest that freedom is over-necessitated by a good that is but the translation into an active register of the imperatives of truth. Beyond that point, all it would seem that is left for will to value is free will itself, in its very distinction from the natural as most fully shown in the power of God to choose this created order or that, according to *fiat.*

To be sure, God's decision is guided by both infinite reason and infinite love. But if he thereby chooses the *conveniens,* this would now appear to be more, as with the regulations of the second table of the Decalogue, by way of instrumental rather than aesthetic convenience. For if reason does not from the outset operate with a teleological judgment and in fused company with right desiring, then the governance of will by reason is likely to reduce to something like a respect for the regular, inevitable, and utilitarian. Thus a modern duality of fact and value and even of nature and culture is here in sight. As with Newton's Laws of Motion, there is ineluctable necessity on the one hand, constraining even God, and on the other, the aberrant, including, finally, the self-instigation of the will. Gilson is entirely right that Scotus cannot be accused of an exultation of the arbitrary, but that is just because for

him the will must be half-guided by a *still more* necessitated order than with Aquinas.

It is therefore not an accident that Scotus, like other Franciscan theologians, had begun to downgrade the centrality of "the common good." This now started to reduce on the one hand to "what objectively works" and, on the other, to an aggregated good which is the compounded goods of separate beings, individually reducible to their pragmatic well-being on the one hand and their liberty on the other. Hence a certain beginning of contractualism and subjective rights in Scotus, which contemporary Franciscans sometimes celebrate.[109] And if will must be defined as the opposite of necessity as its counterpoint, then the same thing is tended to be true (as Pierre Rousselot pointed out long ago) for the Franciscans, of gift in relation to contract.[110] Contract must be purged of all shared substantive good (as opposed to mutual convenience) in order for gift to stand out in pure unilateral freedom, innocent of any hope for return—in a manner already envisaged by Avicenna.[111] One can here interpret Scotus to mean that, if will is self-instigating, then charity as propelled by will and not intellect must be self-controlling and so independent of any reaction by others. Charity ceases, then, to be as it was for the early to high Middle Ages a state of mutual being and becomes instead a one-way deed, paradoxically "owned" by the very one who gives away.[112] Sheer disinterest then becomes the crucial mark of love, by implicitly applying the underlying principle of Scotus's formal reasoning as stressed by Gilson: what defines a thing is what is clearly unique to it and capable of existing without the other things to which it is attached. Our free loving must be most authentically disinterested as to response (which is different from a preparedness for disinterest *in extremis*), else for its fulfillment it would require the other's reception. But to thereby define charity non-relationally, as independent of friendship which was, for Aquinas, its core, is clearly questionable, along with the operative, conceptual, and not judgment-biased principle of Scotus's entire philosophy.

It also engenders a splitting of love itself into the *affectio commodi,* more compelled by the pragmatically convenient and self-serving on the one hand

and the *affectio iustitiae*, respectful of the will, rights, and just commodious demands of the neighbor, taken in isolation, on the other.[113] In refusing traditional eudaemonism, and dividing happiness from value, the Scotist split of nature and will would seem also to foreshadow the division of modern ethics between consequentialism and deontology. But to trace this division to its Scotist root is to reveal their complicity rather than rivalry, in the same way that pertains between intellectualism and voluntarism.

It is also to demonstrate that "the way of charity" in no way *exceeds* Scotus's onto-theological distortion of metaphysics, but to the contrary confirms it, since charity redefined as unilateral freedom of donation is but the residual reverse face of a de-eroticized reason, whose conceptualism both follows upon and supports the reduction of nature to pure determinism. This reduction compromises the ineffable order intrinsic to form and living form, and then in consequence the bond of form between being and understanding. Thus while for Scotus *species* theory still held, it was overridden by the view that, for both God and created spirits, what defines subjective knowledge is the grasp of an "object" which mimetically "represents" an original reality external to it.[114]

In one respect, all this analysis abundantly confirms Gilson's view that the formal distinction and a formalist bias underlay Scotus's thought. But in another respect it questions whether he took this far enough. The point is not that Scotus stressed form at the expense of actuality, but more that he viewed form in a particular way. This, as we have seen, was on an Avicennian model: *equinitas est equinitas tantum.* By contrast, one can trace in Aquinas, faintly but surely, the presence of an alternative, Proclean, model of form as *fluxus*, more strongly present in his teacher Albert the Great. Here, as for Scotus, form in a substantive thing is individual, in the comprehending mind is universal; but, unlike Scotus, "before" the mind it is not an indifferent "atomic" quiddity but is dynamically at one with the descending divine presence itself, only tending to differentiation as it gradually "splays out" through all the ranks of being, into differentiated things.[115] This concurs with the primacy in Aquinas of notions of divine unity, simplicity, and order. The

key difference from Scotus is neither existence over essence nor intellect over will, but the original unity of these things only arriving at difference through an emanative process that at once mystically discloses and economically rules (as with the understanding of hierarchy in Dionysius), as compared with an original and eternal duality of fixed form and elective will, expressed in the Creation not as symbolic emanation, but as incidental or efficient combination.

As to historical scholarship, this contrast amounts to the point that, for all his discovery of "Avicennian Augustinianism," Gilson still underrated the extent to which Avicenna had made a difference and resulted in an "Augustine" construed more essentialistically, subjectively, and voluntaristically than was warranted. This in turn tends to undermine Gilson's overemphasis on an Aristotelian-Augustinian contrast for the later high Middle Ages, since it was possible to construe Augustine, as Aquinas did, through more Proclean and even through purged Aristotelian lenses, after Averroes. Whether the resulting "Augustine" is less "Augustinian" than the Avicennian, one begs many questions that Gilson simply did not raise.

Equally, if Boulnois is right that late-medieval nominalism is a kind of generalized univocity, assuming also Scotus's sharp nature-will divide, then Gilson's continued adherence to the notion that the essential medieval gulf is between the *via antiqua* and the *via moderna* must also come into question. Realism about universals or its lack does not appear to have been the main line of cleavage, but rather different construals of metaphysics, to which Gilson first inaugurated our attention and yet, in the end, was insufficiently attentive.[116] For Aquinas, metaphysics was about being as its subject matter and pointed but remotely to God as cause of being, in such a way as finally to hand theology over to *sacra doctrina* and to allow a revealed theological revision even of the ontological domain, with the discourse of "the names of God" mediating the metaphysical, rational, and revealed theologies[117] Scotus largely saw metaphysics as concerning being, and as including God as infinite within the range of its newly "transcendental" subject matter. And yet, as recent researchers have shown, at times toyed uneasily with the idea

that it was finally about God and an analogical ascent to him—albeit on a univocal basis which, as I have argued, renders radical analogy untenable.[118] What this prevarication fascinatingly shows is Scotus's unease about the implications of his own approach and an implicit fear that he is danger of overly "containing" God. Yet the model that influenced posterity, both immediately and long afterward, was the one that not merely made metaphysics to be emphatically about being, but also included God within its subject matter, to the degree that he is formally contained under univocal being. Eventually, as many scholars have now traced, this leads to a conception of metaphysics as pure "ontology" and a displacement of the other aspect of Aristotle's metaphysics onto another science, variously named "special metaphysics" or "natural theology."[119] The latter has become regional within a transcendental field, which means that rational, and in its wake revealed theology can no longer be determinative or revisionary of our entire perception of reality. As no longer belonging to our most fundamental layer of assumptions, its claims will eventually seem debatable or dismissable, as by Kant. But to render the study of God a specialism within a broader field is surely an idolatry, for if God is all in all, then he contains breadth as well as height and the only way to dilate the heart outward is simultaneously to dilate it upward.

As we saw at the outset, it was just this prioritizing of the transcendental over the transcendent that Gilson and Maritain sought to contest. Those who imagine that they had somehow missed the point of Kant have themselves altogether missed the point of what they were so radically contending in both historical and conceptual terms. In this respect they deserve still to be considered part of a Christian avant-garde. Yet it would seem that Gilson did not quite carry through on his own insights to the degree that he sought to reconcile Scotus with Aquinas. To put this more positively, those who have taken his scholarly legacy further have tended to locate a bigger and perhaps the decisive rupture as occurring with the thought of the Subtle Doctor.

Yet Gilson's hesitation still continues to a degree with some of these thinkers, not to mention those, like Ludger Honnefelder, who wish

unequivocally to celebrate this rupture as eventually ushering in the thought of modernity, which is thereby rendered more unproblematically compatible with a Catholic outlook. For those who instead see Scotus as inaugurating onto-theology, there remains the question of whether his more consistent rationalism was inevitable, completing metaphysics and yet surpassing it in a way that opens eventually to view a post-Cartesian, more genuine access to God in terms of an inward presence that is at once given and gift, at once saturated form and donation of love, in a manner that attempts, on a subjective foundation, to collapse together the Scotist and modern dualities of nature and freedom, object and subject.[120] Perhaps, for this vision, a metaphysics already divided from physics as the study of motion was destined to fade back into ontology and then epistemology and logic, leaving the field clear for a more subjective and direct mode of disclosure, immediately resonating with the hidden real.

However, as already intimated, it might seem that this philosophical path restores in a new way the Scotist and so unexpectedly "pagan" duality: with all of the external and observable handed over to science, necessity, the political, and the pragmatic—as if some region of our existence was doomed to the relatively barbaric. Nor do the accompanying figures of donated "distance" and inexpressible "saturation" seem truly to escape, when exalted, as they inevitably are, into something like "metaphysics" (a vision of how everything is as manifest) the Scotist problems of locating God in merely ontic terms and correspondingly leaving our finite understanding of things and their relative perfections "as they were," since God's difference can now be but equivocally respected in a mysticism that has lost what for Dionysius remained an essential kataphatic moment. In these critical respects, there seems to persist a merely ontic divide between God and creatures, infinite and finite, subjective gift and the externally apparent, that would disallow God's overriding and subsuming rather than merely partial causality on a *concursus* model to which Scotus already succumbed. The same merely ontic divide ensures that the finite, external and initially apparent, must be drastically and non-disclosively random, contingent in the Scotist sense of

being possibly otherwise, rather than contingent in the Thomist sense of being radically dependent on the absolute God, yet not possible to be otherwise, since disclosive of his "aesthetically necessary" decree. It is this model which allows the external to us also to be revelatory, along with the internally self-present.

The figure of "distance" would seem one-sidedly to suppress the equal truth of proximity and non-alterity germane to the radical transcendence of the ontologically different God. Equivalently, the figure of a transcendental "passivity" for our known and willed reception of distance and of all realities in pure self-presence[121] would seem to suppress the equally active and synergic character of creaturely reception of God and of other creatures: paradoxically, the lack of any receiving base in their original nullity requires that they are, from the outset, actively self-instigating in the very radicalness of their degree of absolute derivation. The doctrine of Creation is not then hospitable even to a transcendental residue of given being outside cause, as for Scotus, but not even to the much more subtle transposition of this givenness into donatedness exposed as still independently transcendental just to the degree that it is predominantly characterized in spatialized terms as the "passive" pole of an inconceivable gulf whose other, wholly active pole is the far, unreachable end of "distance." This *schema* remains more like the Scotist or Cartesian one of the priority of the infinite over the finite within a transcendentally shared domain than it is like the Dionysian and Thomist analogical relation between Being and that which participates in it.

On this analysis it would appear that the only way to challenge Scotist onto-theology is through another, alternative metaphysics and not through anything vauntedly post-metaphysical which inevitably builds upon the very slide of metaphysics into foundational epistemology, logic, and phenomenology that is the upshot of the onto-theological turn itself. It would seem, therefore, that supposedly post-metaphysical discourses are ironically liable to reproduce ultimate ontic dualities in the mode of inner over-against outer, distance over-against passivity, sublime saturation over against the non-numinous particular and disinterested, anonymous unilateral gift over

merely functional exchange and reciprocity.

All these dualities can be summed up as a duality between the manifestatory on the one hand and the externally and relationally ordering on the other. In consequence, the former is viewed *apolitically*. Scotus, as we have seen, splits divine government into an impersonal "pagan" ontological given on the one hand, and divine willing that is both unilaterally loving and randomly selecting on the other. The theological turn in phenomenology equivalently tends to divide mundane ordering from sacral disclosure, even if it may properly wish to temper the former with the latter. Thus Marion says that "[hierarchical] order . . . does not give orders to be executed but lays out 'sacred things.'"[122] Of course he is fundamentally right to restore the true meaning of hierarchy, which is by no means modern hegemonic domination by élites,[123] yet its "laying out" is also surely the real divine way of persuasively yet ineluctably giving orders? As we saw with Aquinas, for the Christian politicization of metaphysics, to disclose is to govern, just as to govern is to disclose. Equivalently, liturgical reception and naming is not merely passive reception and praise, but active theurgic utterance and performance, which, as for Dionysius, can only receive God, by creatively working with him and transmitting his disclosive rule, in such a way that liturgy can "magically" transform the world to provide true government, through its attunement to the divine presence, which of course God ultimately commands and brings about.

In a similar fashion, the post-Cartesian route of pure phenomenology would seem to continue to require foundations in terms of a search for a basic principle "irreducible" to anything else, and on which everything else depends in a still Scotist idiom. Thus the fundamentally given as gift is still problematically the gift reduced to the sheerly and originally given, and so inevitably to the bipolar rather than to the mutual and spiraling (such that the Trinitarian reciprocity gives itself to us by endlessly brining us within this circle). Yet this drive to reduce to pure manifestation ever since Husserl begins with a bias against the relational and the temporally and spatially untraceable. Nor does readmitting these factors in terms of an "unending

task" of reduction assist, since it necessarily requires a now surpassed reduction to lapse back into a measure of merely natural "appearance" insufficiently regarded and so not really comprehended and thereby somewhat delusory.[124] The asymptotic trajectory toward the ineffable and yet (supposedly) fully given was therefore on the phenomenological agenda from the outset. And yet, as Derrida in essence once asked, if natural attitudes (toward people, things, words, and numbers) are always required at the sequential outset and can never be definitively surpassed and so must always be returned to, then should we not allow that it is equally foundational, in an anti-foundational manner?[125] In consequence, a necessarily speculative attitude toward the real, beyond phenomenology, is phenomenologically given. For our speculations and reading of given presences not to be arbitrary (beyond Derridean deconstruction), they must be interpretative construals of divine symbols that participate in his reality, as does our responding judgment, construing them.

The only alternative is to sustain phenomenology as all of philosophy in a manner that involves a kind of endless asymptotic progress toward idealism, as if realism always remained only as something ideally to be purged away, even though it never can be. But such a trajectory requires, as much as realism, a speculative trust, if it is not to be indistinguishable from a skeptical phenomenalism. It then becomes more natural to trust *both* our judgment and the appearances of things, together with their connatural affinity. And both, by speculative trust, can only be secured against phenomenal dissolution by the affirmation of non-appearing "substance" and "subjective substance" as the ground of appearing, just as Leibniz belatedly realized he would have to add the *vinculum substantiale* to his monads if they were not to dissolve into dream-like phantoms. It is significant that Maurice Blondel deployed this doctrine in support of the realist undergirding of his spiritualism.[126]

F Beyond Gilson

In the wake of recent critiques of phenomenology, therefore, Gilson and

Maritain look once more highly relevant.[127]

Since Gilson, there have been at least two responses to his legacy—discounting the minority who deny that he represents an epistemic rupture, for dubious reasons, already dealt with.[128] One response agrees with and accentuates his historical verdict, but reverses the philosophical, since Scotus is embraced as the inaugurator of univocity, representation, possibilism, and political liberalism. Another response, of the French philosopher-historians, also accentuates his historical verdict and ambiguously sustains while mutating his historical one: Scotus as both subtle disaster and subtle promise. But the third response, sometimes associated with the "radically orthodox" theologians, but actually much more widespread, would both accentuate the historical verdict (which is scarcely then controversial) and purge the philosophical one of all ambiguity. The "Cartesian hesitation" here vanishes.[129]

This direction then desires a return to the primacy of the analogy of attribution and Proclean participation—as apparently envisaged as *one* possibility by Jean-Luc Marion in his earlier work on Descartes.[130] But does that mean simply a return to Aquinas and authentic Thomism in Gilson's wake, however much, beyond Gilson, the neo-Platonic dimension of his thought is more accentuated, on the lines indicated above? That is far too large a question for this afterword. Nevertheless, I would suggest that one does not best respect the avant-garde nature of Gilson's true inspiration, nor his resonance with French spiritualism, by merely turning in that direction. Indeed, what is valid in the Cartesian and radically phenomenological sense of a resonance with reality from within needs to be respected and incorporated, even if a better reconciliation of inner and outer requires a more "speculatively realist" character.[131] But what is more, one has to allow that Scotus realized a certain inconsistency in Aquinas between his rationalist approach (dependent on the ultimacy of the law of identity) and his analogical vision. Neither Gilson nor Maritain were able to see that the Renaissance turn to mystical paradox, as supremely with Cusanus, may well have been a post-Scotist and post-nominalist response to this tension.[132]

What is more, Cusa, like Eriugena and Dionysius, himself was able to allow that perfectly concrete things could also be enigmatically "like" God in their very apparent unsuitability. The Thomist gulf between analogy and metaphor starts properly to collapse here, which again can be seen as a response to Scotist objection. If analogy requires a paradoxical resemblance of things to God in their very unlikeness, without a shared, mediating commonality then why, as Scotus validly asked, should not a "stone" also present an analogy to God?[133] The response of a more alchemically informed sensibility was, of course, that it could: if God is the creator of matter, then is he not eminently matter also, especially if the negative simplicity and vanishing density of matter in a way uniquely mirrors him? How else ultimately to render the sacraments more than instrumental, or to avoid a "pagan" placing of the "given" inexorable character of matter subtly outside God's creative and providential sway? The Scotist response is to worsen this "paganism" by replacing a non-causally "given" matter that divides us from God with a non-causally given "being" that unites us to him, for Scotus in fulfillment of the Exodus naming.[134] But the counterresponse to Scotus requires, beyond Aquinas, a fuller incorporation of the material into the analogical and participatory outlook, as some Renaissance and Baroque thinkers undertook.

In the same way, even what we take to be the more "occult" and more emphatically neo-Platonic aspects of the Renaissance idiom may have been a response to the crisis of scholastic metaphysical thought, whose dilemmas Gilson did not sufficiently define. As already mentioned, Aristotle had separated "physics" from "metaphysics" in a way that risks handing over the study of the real to physics (as has transpired today) and reducing metaphysics, already concerned with static categories, to categories of logic and perception. But for Plotinus, by contrast, both motion and rest belong to the finite, and rest or halting in fact more so.[135] In consequence, substances and ultimate forms are intrinsically in kinetic motion, as constantly being affected and affecting, down to their core being, and are not at this core merely in intransitive act. Intellect is as much infinite circular motion (*kinesis* and not just *energeia*) as it is *stasis*, and the One is the ineffable source of

both—inconceivably dynamic as much as it is inconceivably still. (One could indeed say that neo-Platonism already accommodates what is valid in Whiteheadian "process" and refuses what is invalid.)

What is more, Plotinus construed the transgeneric *pros hen* resemblance across categories in terms of their dynamic generation from the One, thereby supplying an account of transcendent "vertical" becoming to complement Aristotle's physical account of the temporal, "horizontal" one.[136] Because of the dynamic character of analogy, as both vertical and horizontal resemblance and loose affinity (apparent to judgment), and its unthinkable, translogical third way between identity and nonidentity, Renaissance thought not unreasonably, and following Proclus, saw these affinities as operating and operable upon by natural magic—allowance of which encouraged later recognition of various "actions at a distance" (like magnetism, gravity, electricity, and subatomic coordination), vital spontaneities and circular organic cohesions, resembling those of the cosmos at large (as with the circulation of the blood) against the mechanizing bias of the Scotist-nominalist legacy, with its duality of pure necessity and pure will.[137]

In our current drastic plight, is not this "para-physical" mode of metaphysics more promising for us than the pure Aristotelian tradition which, not altogether accidentally, has historically devolved into a transcendental doctrine of the "conditions of possibility" for our "scientific" and aesthetic understandings, themselves dualistically separated? Significantly, the renowned Catholic scholar Antoine Faivre argues that what actually *defines* Renaissance esotericism, besides its syncretic invention of a "perennial" tradition, is not secrecy nor *gnosis,* but rather the attempt to close the widening modern gap between metaphysics and cosmology, which includes that between psychology and corporeal medicine.[138]

For all his counter-impulses to this Renaissance, in fear once more, as with Scotus, of a pagan automatism and restriction of the divine freedom, it is significant that Descartes rejected a univocalist legacy that rendered causality secondary to given being. Instead, as already mentioned, he erected a different univocity around cause itself. This, as Marion argues, impaired his

otherwise extremely pure account of the divine simplicity with the divisive notion of a "self-causing."[139] But at least he was thereby making the dynamically moving ontologically ultimate, and somewhat healing the metaphysics-physics divide. It is also the case that the unnamed revisionary metaphysics which Aquinas clearly articulates after and within *sacra doctrina* is a Trinitarian one, partly after Augustine, which classifies reality in terms of rising and ever more perfect degrees of transitive motion—thereby, beyond, or in an intensification of the neo-Platonic vision, "saving" the significance of horizontal motion at the ultimate vertical level.[140]

To take up Gilson's speculative lead today would then require reading Aquinas in a certain way and then looking beyond Aquinas. Thus if Gilson after all played down the difference from Aquinas of Scotus and the difference the latter made, he also did not observe the degree to which not all the difference made by Scotus can be ignored.

Yet one should not wish to perpetuate, in whatever guise, the Scotist undoing of divine government by sundering essence from existence, intellect from will and freedom from mutuality. The deep structure of Scotus's thought concerns, because of its formalism, the "self-bounded" in a way that is unrealistically allergic to both relation and causal linkage. Being here rests within itself, but so does a positive infinity, so do natures, so do individuals and so does the will, in a fashion that almost reduces their efficient causal instigation to a mere occasioning. Government, whether divine, angelic, or human, is thereby undone, because it becomes subservient to a given ontology, without gift, inherent meaning or love. All it can add to this is cold command which is at best formal regulation if it does not descend into the arbitrary for the sake of minimum order, palliated by acts of disinterested love, indifferent to the formation of reciprocal community.

By contrast, a maximum order, ordering by attraction, would be throughout a coincidence of ordering with being, but also of being with ordering. This would be best expressed by a metaphysics that understood "to be" as also the Platonic *dynamis*—as "to be affecting" and "to be affected," or "to be moving" and "to be moved." Such a metaphysics would no longer allow, as

even Aquinas did, that the divine *potentia absoluta* was not entirely coincident with his *potentia ordinata*, on pain of impairing his simplicity, the convertibility of his expressed *Logos* with his essence, or the infinity of his justice.[141] And it would no longer risk even minutely any impersonal, static and unmoving (in an eminent sense) and therefore "ungoverning," apolitical essence or being. The Trinitarian God is internally governance and distribution, even though he is not, thereby, self-governing or self-controlling, any more than he is self-causing, since the Trinitarian relations do not compromise divine simplicity through a reflexive doubling, just because this relationality is irreducibly substantial and thereby transcendentally singular. Beyond Aquinas, such a still more distinctly Christian metaphysics would thereby be more immune to a Scotist rationalist critique and a Scotist dissolution of true divine order.

Notes

1 Étienne Gilson, *Études sur le role de la pensée médiévale dans la formation du système cartésien* (Paris: Vrin, 1967).

2 See Jacob Schmutz, "Escaping the Aristotelian Bond: The Critique of Metaphysics in Twentieth-Century French Philosophy," *Dionysius* XVII (December 1999), pp. 169–200. The shape and content of this afterword is much influenced by this essay. See also Étienne Gilson, *The Spirit of Medieval Philosophy*, trans. A. H. C. Downes (Notre Dame, IN: Notre Dame University Press, 1991); *Being and Some Philosophers* (Toronto: PIMS, 2016).

3 Jacques Maritain, *The Degrees of Knowledge*, trans. Gerard B. Phelan (Notre Dame, IN: Notre Dame University Press, 1995): see also John Milbank, *The Suspended Middle: Henri de Lubac and the Renewed Split in Modern Catholic Theology*, second edition (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2014).

4 Étienne Gilson, *History of Christian Philosophy in the Middle Ages* (London: Sheed and Ward, 1980).

5 See, for a summary and further development, Olivier Boulnois, *Métaphysiques rebelles: Genèse et structures d'une science au Moyen Ăge* (Paris: PUF, 2013).

6 See Jean-Luc Marion, *Sur la théologie blanche de Descartes*, second edition (Paris: PUF, 1991).

7 See again Schmutz, "Escaping the Aristotelian Bond."

8 Schmutz, "Escaping the Aristotelian Bond."

9 See Dominique Janicaud, *Ravaisson et la Métaphysique: Une Généalogie Du Spiritualisme Français* (Paris: Vrin, 1969).

10 Henri Bergson, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, trans. T. E. Hulme (London: Palgrave-MacMillan, 2007); Michel Henry, *Incarnation: A Philosophy of Flesh*, trans. Karl Hefty (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 2015). It is difficult to justify in exegetical terms a

Christian reading of incarnation as “flesh” rather than “body” as Henry sought to do.

11 See John Milbank, *Beyond Secular Order: The Representation of Being and the Representation of the People* (Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell, 2013), pp. 66–72.

12 On divine simplicity in Descartes, see Marion, *Sur la théologie blanche,* p. 285.

13 Marion, *Sur la théologie blanche,* pp. 27–159; *Sur la pensée passive de Descartes* (Paris: PUF, 2013), pp. 51, 264.

14 Marion, *Sur la théologie blanche,* pp. 427–54.

15 Ibid., pp. 455–56.

16 Jean-Luc Marion, “Une époque de métaphysique,” in *Jean Duns Scot ou la revolution subtile* ed. Christine Goémé (Paris; FAC, 1982), pp. 87–95; Olivier Boulnois, *Duns Scot: La Rigueur de la charité* (Paris: Cerf, 1998). But Boulnois’ later works would seem to insist more strongly upon Scotus’s metaphysical perspective and on the onto-theological character of this perspective.

17 Étienne Gilson, *Jean Duns Scot: Introduction à ses positions fondamentales* [1952] (Paris: Vrin, 2013), pp. 624–69.

18 Gilson, *Jean Duns Scot,* pp. 84–278.

19 Gilson here always cites the first version of Scotus’s Sentence Commentary, or at any rate under its first title, the *Opus Oxoniense.* Today this is usually cited in its second, Parisian recension, the *Ordinatio.* The two texts usually coincide, but not entirely.

20 See Rowan Williams, *Grace and Necessity: Reflections on Art and Love* (London: Continuum, 2006).

21 Gilson, *Jean Duns Scot,* 87 n. 1.

22 Ibid., pp. 84–115.

23 Ibid., p. 92.

24 Gilson, *History of Christian Philosophy,* p. 456.

25 Gilson, *Jean Duns Scot,* pp. 432–54.

26 Ibid., pp. 84–115.

27 Ludger Honnefelder, *Johannes Duns Scotus* (Munich: C.H. Beck, 2005) and *La métaphysisque comme science transcendentale,* trans. Isabelle Mandrela (Paris: PUF, 2002). Honnefelder may underplay a continuity with Gilson here because he has some valid reservations about viewing Scotus as an “essentialist.” See further below.

28 Scotus, *In Met* VI, q. 4 n. 2; cited by Gilson in *Jean Duns Scot,* p. 80.

29 See Honnefelder, *Johannes Duns Scotus,* p. 77.

30 See Jean-François Courtine, *Suarez et le système de la métaphysique* (Paris: PUF, 1990), pp. 376–458; Olivier Boulnois, *Ětre et representation: une généalogie de la métaphysique modern à l’époque de Duns Scot (XIIIe – XIVe siècle)* (Paris: PUF, 1999), pp. 444–504.

31 Scotus, *Ordinatio,* Prologue, III, q. 3, p. 200; *Jean Duns Scot,* 48 n. 1.

32 Henry of Ghent, *Ordinatio* I, d.36 q. un. no. 48; Honnefelder, *Johannes Duns Scot,* p. 79. But Henry does not accept Aquinas’s real distinction of existence and essence for actual being, the subject of metaphysics.

33 It is for this reason that contemporary logical or semantic readings of univocity in Scotus are anachronistic with respect to Scotus himself, even if by no means incoherent as one rendering of possibilities opened up by the Scotist trajectory. Yet for this reason there is no warrant whatsoever for thinking the dominant scholarly metaphysical interpretation of univocity in Scotus as metaphysical (albeit in a newly “formal” or else “transcendental” fashion) to be manifestly

deluded. The Subtle Doctor is traceably the forerunner of Kant; to see him as the forerunner of Frege is more debatable; and while he prepares the ground for Kant, in shifting the meaning of "transcendental" in an epistemological direction (see main text above) he does not travel all the way. It is ironic that scholars scornful of "genealogical" claims themselves appear to endorse an excessive genealogy that roots much later contingent theoretical consequence back into its long-term conceptual germ. And to call his thesis about the univocity of being "semantic" rather than logical might seem a little strange, though it is hermeneutically allowable, as indeed Scotus would seem to think that the illogical is meaningless. It is, however, coherent, if the point is that, for the Avicennian-Scotist viewpoint the meaning of, for example, "horse" is transcendentally prior to either its logical or its real instantiation. But in that case, the argument that "semantic" means totally removed from the real, nearer to logical universality than to real particularity or metaphysical, categorial generality, collapses. For a summary of this current in recent Anglo-Saxon understanding of his thought, see Daniel P. Horan OFM, *Postmodernity and Univocity: A Critical Account of Radical Orthodoxy and John Duns Scotus* (Minneapolis, MI: Fortress, 2014).

34 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 44–115.

35 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 107–08.

36 Boulnois, *Ětre et representation,* p. 290.

37 Richard Cross, *Duns Scotus* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999). And see note 32 above.

38 Jean Duns Scot, p. 237.

39 Ibid., 84–115.

40 Gilson, *History of Christian Philosophy,* pp. 496, 788.

41 Gilles Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition,* trans. Paul Patton (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), p. 36.

42 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 44–115, 120–28, 149–57,

43 Scotus, *Ordinatio,* I. d. 3. p. I qq. 1-3. For the fundamental accounts of univocity of being, human knowledge of God and human cognition in general in Duns Scotus, see the immensely useful editions in English of *Ordinatio* 1. p.1 d.3 *in toto* and in French of *Ordinatio* I d.3 p. I and d. 8 p. I. Respectively, John van den Bercken, ed., *On Being and Cognition* (New York: Fordham, 2016); Olivier Boulnois, *Sur la connaissance de Dieu et l'univocité de l'étant* (Paris: PUF, 1988). Boulnois' introduction and extensive notes are particularly illuminating.

44 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 574–624; see also Milbank, *The Suspended Middle*, pp. 85–87.

45 Jean Duns Scot, p. 101.

46 Scotus, *Quodlibetal Questions,* q. 5 a. 1, 5:10; a. 3, 5:55-56. And see Anne Ashley Davenport, *Measure of a Different Greatness; The Intensive Infinite, 1250–1650* (Leiden: Brill, 1999), pp. 165–239.

47 Aquinas, *De Veritate,* q. 2 a. 11 resp.

48 ST I q. 13.

49 Aquinas, *In 2 De Caelo* 18g; *In Boeth de Hebdom* 2:26: *Participare est quasi partem capere.*

50 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 317–55, 460–77.

51 Aquinas, *De Veritate,* q.1 a. 1 *resp.*

52 Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d.3 p. I q. 3 a.1, 131–36 a. 2, 137–51; a. 3, 167–84.

53 Jean Duns Scot, p. 465.

54 Boulnois, *Sur la connaissance de Dieu,* footnotes to sections 147–51 of *Ordinatio* I. d. 3 p.1 q. 3, pp. 367–68.

55 Aquinas, *De Veritate*, q. 1 a.1.

56 Jean Duns Scot, p. 465.

57 However, the other transcendentals like truth and goodness are not equivalently the subjects of virtual inclusion. Only being is virtually inclusive: *Ordinatio* I d. 3. P.1 q. 3 a. 3, 167–84.

58 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 228–54.

59 Gilson, *History of Christian Philosophy*, pp. 489–99.

60 Boulnois, *Métaphysiques rebelles*, pp. 343–79.

61 Marion points out how, in the case of Ockham as with Descartes, this extreme simplicity makes their description as "voluntarists" inaccurate—even if our lack of analogical insight into divine preference produces a kind of voluntarism in practice, as far as humans are concerned. See Marion, *Sur la théologie blanche de Descartes*, pp. 283–86.

62 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 101–05.

63 Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d. 3. p.1 q. 1 a.2, 26–55; a. 3, 56–57; a. 4, 58–62; q. 3 a.1, 131–36; a. 2, 137–51; a. 3, 152–66.

64 Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d.8 p. 1 q. 3, 139–56.

65 See Timothy D. Knepper, *Negating Negation: Against the Apophatic Abandonment of the Dionysian Corpus* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2014).

66 ST I q. 2 a.3.

67 Scotus, *Ordinatio*, d. 2 p. 1 qq 1–3; *De Primo Principio*, cc 3–4; *Jean Duns Scot*, pp. 177–215; Honnefelder, *Johannes Duns Scotus*, pp. 95–103.

68 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 625–69.

69 Ibid., 343–55.

70 Ibid., 228–54.

71 Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d. 3 p. 1 q. 2 a. 4, 58–60.

72 Jean Duns Scot, 279–306; Scotus, *Quodlibetal Questions* q. 5 a. 3, 55–56.

73 Scotus, *Ordinatio* Prol. q. 3 [200].

74 Olivier Boulnois, "Jean Duns Scot," Chapter X of *Sur La Science Divine*, trans. and ed. J.-C. Bardout and O. Boulnois (Paris: PUF, 2002) [a collection of mediaeval texts on God's knowledge], pp. 244–52 and the texts translated here: Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d. 36, 1–3, 27–31, 34–35, 39–45, 48–53; *Reportata* I d. 36 q. 2, 26–38, 50–64; q. 3, 18–31, 46–69.

75 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 306–43, 574–624.

76 Honnefelder, *Johannes Duns Scot*, p. 102. It is in this respect not clear to me, as Boulnois claims, that Gilson continued to think, as he seems to have done in his earlier researches, of univocal being in Scotus as a "substitute for the idea of God in us" which would at once regard our notion of being as an *a priori* sense of the wholly indeterminate possible (as opposed to the real metaphysical entity) and as an *a priori* presence of God, thereby assimilating Scotus to Henry of Ghent's belief in the primacy of our knowledge of God through direct divine illumination. But Gilson seems clear in his later book that Scotus does not wholly detach metaphysical essence from existence (since it is "formality"). Thus his attribution to Scotus of an "essentialism" is vulnerable insofar as he *plays down*, as Honnefelder argues, the dissolution of essence into quiddity plus will, and not insofar as he makes is a pure possibility wholly prior to existence, as Boulnois seems here to suggest. Gilson is equally clear that Scotus reduces divine Illumination to a minimum which amounts to God's causation of our natural understanding, without Aquinas's account of a constant participation in the divine light, which is arguably more truly Augustinian than the Avicennian

Franciscan and Ghentian glosses which render this light too directly present either as an *a priori*, or an alienation of our mind to the divine realm. See *Jean Duns Scot*, pp. 215–300; Boulnois, *La Rigueur*, pp. 19–20; *Ětre et representation*, pp. 289–90; Milbank, *The Suspended Middle*, pp. 102–03.

77 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 460–66; Scotus *Ordinatio* II d. 3 p. 1 q. 1, 42; q. 2, 58; q. 3, 61–65; q. 4, 111. And see Bruno Pinchard, "L'individuation dans la Tradition Aristotélicienne" and Olivier Boulnois, "Genèse de la Théorie Scotiste de L'Individuation," in *Le Probleme de L'Individuation*, ed. Pierre-Noël Mayaud (Paris: Vrin, 1991), pp. 27–50, 51–77.

78 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 232, 391–431.

79 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 307–10, 574–75.

80 Scotus, *Ordinatio*, Prol q. 3, [200].

81 Scotus, *Quodlibetal Questions*, q. 1 a. 3, 57–77; q. 3 a. 2, 19–33; q. 4 a. 3, 48–52, 61–63; q. 5 a. 1, 5–60.

82 Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d.3 p.2 q. un., 323.

83 Scotus, *Ordinatio* I d.3 p. 2 q. un. See John Milbank, *Beyond Secular Order*, pp. 61–64.

84 Jean Duns Scot, pp. 574–624.

85 Scotus, *Reportata* I d. 36 q. 3 18; Boulnois, "Jean Duns Scot," Chapter X of Bardout and Boulnois, *Sur La Science Divine*, p. 249.

86 Avicenna, *De Anima* I 1.

87 Scotus, *Ordinatio* III suppl. d. 37; IV d. 15 q.2; d. 17; d.33 q.1; q. 3.

88 ST II.II q.154 a.2 ad 2.

89 See John Milbank, "The Franciscan Conundrum," Communio 42 (Fall 2015), pp. 466–92.

90 For the anticipations of the Avicennian shift in the Latin west, see Adrian Pabst, Metaphysics: The Creation of Hierarchy (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2012), pp. 155–200.

91 Besides *Jean Duns Scot, passim*, see Étienne Gilson, *Ětre et L'Essence* (Paris: Vrin, 2015), pp. 124–43.

92 Étienne Gilson, *Being and Some Philosophers*, pp. 154–89.

93 See Milbank and Pickstock, *Truth in Aquinas* (London: Routledge, 2001), pp. 19–59.

94 Gilson, *History of Christian Philosophy*, pp. 104–05.

95 Aquinas, *In Met* L 2: C 556–60. See also John Milbank, "Manifestation and Procedure: Trinitarian Metaphysics after Albert the Great and Thomas Aquinas," in *Tomismo Creativo: Letture Contemporannee del* Doctor Commune d. Marco Salvioli OP (Bologna ESD, 2015), 33–117.

96 Olivier Boulnois notes that Scotus can just as well be regarded as an existentialist as he can an essentialist in *Duns Scot; La Rigueur de la Charité*, 14–22.

97 See Catherine Pickstock, *After Writing: On the Liturgical Consummation of Philosophy* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1999), pp. 121–40.

98 Étienne Gilson, *The Spirit of Mediaeval Philosophy*, trans. A. H. C. Downes (Notre Dame, IN: Notre Dame University Press, 1991), pp. 304–23.

99 Marion, *La théologie blanche*, p. 285, n. 21: [to translate] "Descartes does not break any less with nominalist 'voluntarism' than with the 'intellectualism' of Suarez; these two tendencies, far from contradicting each other, already support each other with Duns Scotus." Marion points that that Descartes's doctrine of the creation of eternal truths (of maths and logic, including the law of identity), far from being an ultra-voluntarism, is a refusal of the voluntarist-intellectualist complicity since the Subtle Doctor. Yet divine government is not thereby restored to the degree

that the divine essence thereby becomes ineffably inscrutable. Nicholas of Cusa's paradoxical mediations of the infinite and finite, likewise allowing that "eternal truths" are bound to finitude, would seem to offer here an alternative.

100 Although, as Marion stresses (*La théologie blanche*, p. 283) will "follows upon" intellect for Aquinas, he also makes it clear that teleological appetition of the good and so will, is not extrinsic to intellect as such: "[The] aptitude to good in things without natural knowledge is called natural appetite. Whence also intellectual natures have alike aptitude to good as apprehended through intellectual form; so as to rest therein when possessed, and when not possessed to seek to possess it, both of which pertain to the will."

101 Gilson, *The Spirit of Mediaeval Philosophy*, pp. 248–68.

102 Avicenna, *Metaphysics* (from the *Al-Shifā'*), VIII, 6, (5), (16), 7, IX, 1, 2 (4–6).

103 ST I qq 103–19 ["Treatise on the Divine Government"]. And see Giorgio Agamben, *The Kingdom and the Glory*, trans. L. Chiesa and M. Mandarini (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2011). This book is an inspiration, even if one must dissent from many of its readings, which are sometimes corrected by Dotan Leshem in his *The Origins of Neoliberalism: Modeling the Economy from Jesus to Foucault* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2016).

104 Scotus, *Quest. in Met* I q. 1, 109.

105 Scotus, *Quodlibetal Questions*, q.1 a. 3, 59, 70–71.

106 Gilles Emery, *La Trinité Creatrice: Trinité et création dans les commentaires aux* Sentences de Thomas d'Aquin et de ses précurseurs Albert le Grand et Bonaventure (Paris: Vrin, 1995).

107 Gilson, *Being and Some Philosophers*, p. 182.

108 This is broadly the perspective of Ludger Honnefelder, but also of many modern Franciscan thinkers. See also Emmanuel Falque, *Dieu, la chair et l'autre; D'Irénée à Duns Scot* (Paris: PUF, 2008), pp. 429–69. For a critique of such an outlook, see Pickstock, "Duns Scotus: His Historical and Contemporary Significance."

109 See John Milbank, "Against Human Rights: Liberty in the Western Tradition," *The Oxford Journal of Law and Theology* (January 2012), pp. 1–32.

110 Pierre Rousselot, *The Problem of Love in the Middle Ages: A Historical Contribution*, trans. Alan Vincelette (Milwaukee, WI: Milwaukee University Press, 2001).

111 Avicenna, *Metaphysica* (from *The Book of Scientific Knowledge*), p. 36.

112 See Milbank, "The Franciscan Conundrum."

113 Scotus, *Ordinatio* IV Suppl. d. 49 qq. 9–10. Allan B. Wolter OFM significantly describes the affection of justice in totally Kantian terms of a "freedom *from* nature and a freedom *for* values" in his *The Philosophical Theology of John Duns Scotus* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1990), p. 151.

114 Scotus, *Quodlibetal Questions*, q.13; Boulnois, *Être et representation*, p. 405–56; Milbank, *Beyond Secular Order*, pp. 31–34, 57–66.

115 See Alain de Libera, *Métaphysique et noétique: Albert le Grand* (Paris: Vrin, 2005); John Milbank, "Manifestation and Procedure," pp. 68–69.

116 Boulnois, *Métaphysiques rebelles, passim.*

117 Métaphysiques rebelles, pp. 191–226.

118 Boulnois sums up and elaborates the conclusions of G. Pini, D. Demange and R. Wood in *Métaphysiques rebelles*, pp. 291–303.

119 Boulnois, *Métaphysiques rebelles*, pp. 313–41.

120 Jean-Luc Marion, *Being Given: Towards a Phenomenology of Givenness*, trans. Jeffrey L. Kossky (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002).

121 Marion, *Sur la pensée passive de Descartes*, pp. 217–60.

122 Jean-Luc Marion, *The Idol and Distance*, trans. Thomas A. Carlson (New York: Fordham University Press, 2001), p. 164.

123 The late English poet Geoffrey Hill was fond of making this crucial distinction.

124 I am grateful to Ryan Haecker, my Masters student at Nottingham University for this insight.

125 Jacques Derrida, *Voice and Phenomenon: Introduction to the Problem of the Sign in Husserl's Phenomenology* (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 2010).

126 See David Grummett, "Blondel, Modern Catholic Theology and the Leibnizian Eucharistic Bond," *Modern Theology* 23, no. 4 (2007), pp. 618–44.

127 See Tom Sparrow, *The End of Phenomenology: Metaphysics and the New Realism* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2014).

128 This denial rests essentially upon a rationalistic misconstrual of Thomist analogy which imagines that Scotist univocity could act as a foundation for it; on a denial that univocity in Scotus is metaphysical and related to an understanding of metaphysics fundamentally unlike that of Aquinas, which is, in a new way, consistent with the Patristic vision and on the erroneous view that Thomist participation reduces to "imitation," as it does for Scotus. See Daniel Horan, O.F.M., *Postmodernity and Univocity.*

129 For the most detailed summary, see Catherine Pickstock, "Duns Scotus: His Historical and Contemporary Significance." Horan's claims that RO has largely invented "the Scotus story" do it far too much credit. Its contribution lies far more in its extension of a growing unease about the Scotist legacy.

130 Marion, *La théologie blanche, passim.*

131 Nevertheless, the speculative realist approaches of Badiou, Meillassoux, Garcia, Harman et al. can exhibit the opposite danger of closing the subject-object gap purely on the side of "the thing," even if one welcomes the drift, in Tristan Garcia especially, away from materialism toward realism. A balanced mediation of subject and object would undoubtedly require a philosophy/theology of participated transcendence, in contrast both to philosophies of the transcendent "other" and to philosophies of immanence.

132 See John Milbank, "From *Mathesis to Methexis:* Nicholas of Cusa's Post-Nominalist Realism," in *Relire Cusanus*, ed. Isabelle Moulin (Paris: Vrin, 2017).

133 Scotus, *Ordinatio,* I d. 3 a. 2, 40.

134 Scotus, *De Primo Principio,* Cap I.

135 Plotinus, *Enneads*, II, VI.

136 Enneads, VI, I, 3, 10–20; Milbank, "Manifestation and Procedure."

137 See Ernst Benz, *The Theology of Electricity: On the Encounter and Explanation of Theology and Science in the 17th and 18th Centuries,* trans. Wolfgang Taraba (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2014); Walter Pagel, *William Harvey's Biological Ideas* (New York: Karger, 1967); Stephen Gaukroger, *The Collapse of Mechanism and the Rise of Sensibility: Science and the Shaping of Modernity 1680–1760* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2010).

138 Antoine Faivre, *Access to Western Esotericism* (New York: SUNY, 1994), pp. 3–47. I am grateful here for the discussions I had with Laura McCormack, my doctoral student at Nottingham.

139 Marion, *La théologie blanche*, pp. 427–44.

140 Milbank, “Manifestation and Procedure.”

141 See John Hughes, “*Creatio ex nihilo* and the Divine Ideas in Aquinas: How Fair is Bulgakov’s Critique,” in *Graced Life: The Writings of John Hughes*, ed. Matthew Bullimore (London: SCM, 2016), pp. 35–50.

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[Translator: Gilson sometimes does not cite the edition of a classic and occasionally cites via another author. I have completed such references where I could.]

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here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here,
here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here,
here, here, here, here
communissima here, here–here, here
composite here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here,
here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here
composition here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here,
here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here
concept here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here,

here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here
concordia potentiarum here, here, here
concrete here, here, here, here
condemnation of 1277 here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
conscience here–here, here–here, here, here, here
contingency here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here
contingent here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
contradictory here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here
controversies here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here
coordination here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here
correlatives here, here
creatable here, here, here, here, here, here, here
creation here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
creature here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here

Decalogue here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
definition here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here,

deity here, here, here
desire here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here
differences, Ultimate here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here
dispensation here–here
distinction here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
divine attributes here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
divine essence here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here
divine freedom here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here
divine illumination here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here
divine names here–here, here, here, here, here
divine persons here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here
divine simplicity here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here
divine substance here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here

election here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
elements here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here
eminence here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
end here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here,

essence here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
evil here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here
existence here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
existence of God here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here

finitude here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here
first, the here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here
form here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here
formality here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
fortune here
freedom here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here

fruition here, here–here, here

generation here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
genus here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here
God here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–

individuation here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here
inferior here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here
infinite here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here
infinity here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here
intellect here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here
intellection here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here
intellectuality here, here, here, here, here, here
intelligible here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here
intensity here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
intuition here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here

knowledge here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here,

here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here
known of itself here–here, here–here

law here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here
light here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here
logic here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here
love here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here

materialists here
matter here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here

measure here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here
memory here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here
merit here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here
metaphysics here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here,

here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here
movement here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here
natural here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here,

nothing here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here

object here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here

omnipotence here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here

one here, here, here–here, here, here–here

order here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here,

here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here
place here–here, here–here, here, here
plurality here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
polytheism here, here
possible here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here
potency here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here
power here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here
practical principles here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here
predestination here
predication here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
primacy here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
primo modo here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
principles here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here
private property here
privation here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here
protervus here, here
prudence here, here

quality here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here
quantity here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here
quiddity here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here,

here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here

reason here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here
relation here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here
revelation here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here
rhetoric here, here, here, here, here–here

sacraments here, here, here, here
salvation here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here
science here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here
Scotism here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here
scripture here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
semen here–here
seminal reasons here–here, here, here–here
sensation here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here
sensible here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here,

here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
separated intelligences here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
separated substance here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here
signum here, here
size here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here
soul here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
species here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here
substance here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here
suchness here, here–here
supernatural here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here
state here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here
synonym here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here

talitas. *See* suchness
theologian here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here
theology here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here,

here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here
time here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here
transubstantiation here, here, here
triangle here, here, here, here
trinity here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
true here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here
unicity here–here, here
unitive containment here, here, here–here
unity here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
universal here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here
univocity here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here
vice here, here
virtue here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here
volition here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here
voluntarism here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here
will, divine here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here
will, human here, here, here–here, here–here, here
wisdom here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here
world here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here–here, here, here, here, here, here, here, here–here, here, here, here

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